Seacat

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Seacat

by Starfox5

Summary

Life was good for Seacat. Sure, losing your memory in a Horde attack a few years ago wasn't exactly easy, but she had rolled with the punch and rebuilt her life. She's got a name, a spot on a ship - as long as she could keep it from burning - and a sort of family. But now, just when she was trying to chill in one of Sea Hawk's favourite dives, some blonde weirdo was hugging her and babbling about having thought her dead years ago.

Notes

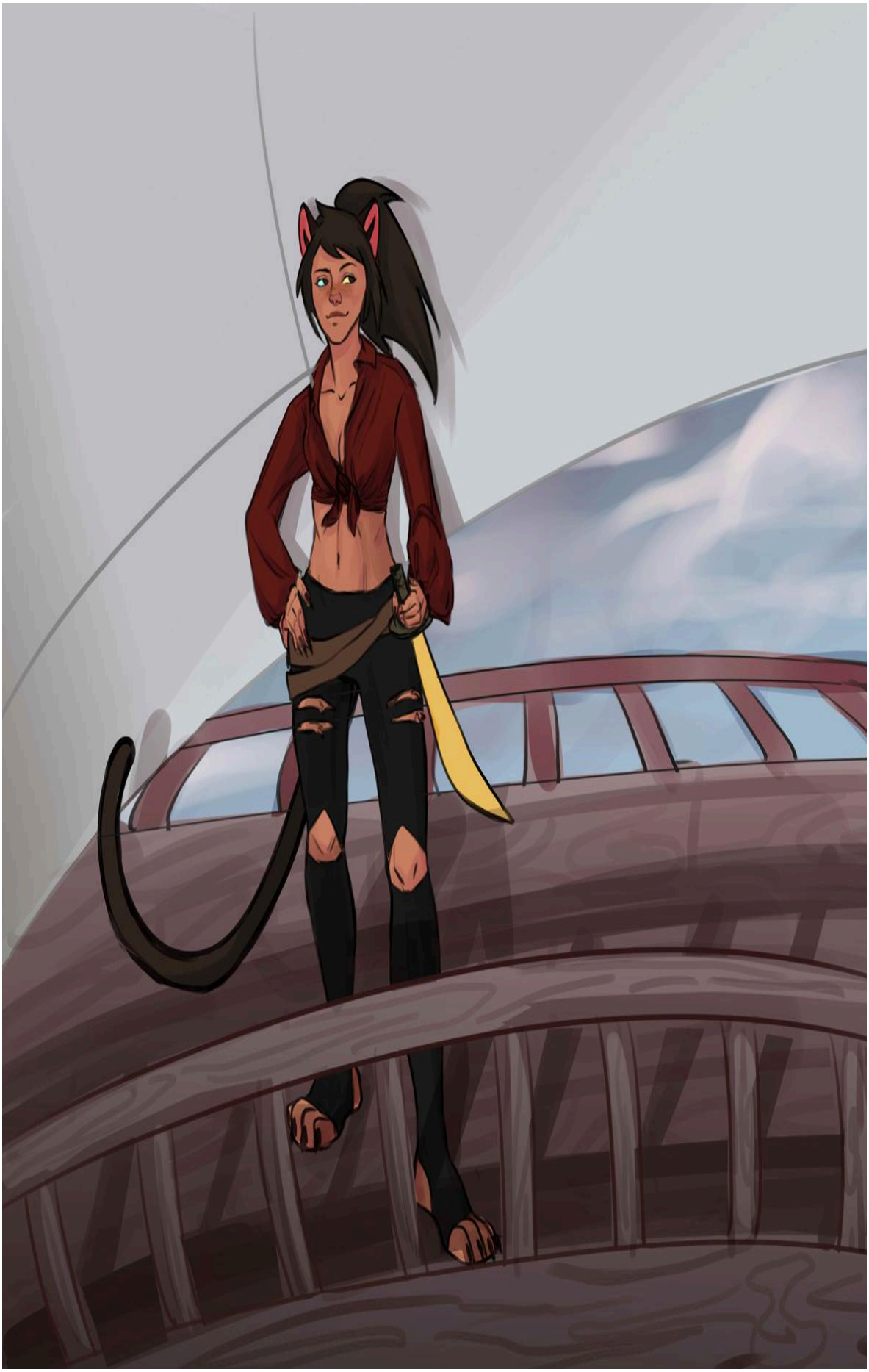
This story is set in an Alternate Universe. A number of canon events didn't happen or happened differently in the series.

I'd like to thank elpenor for his help with this chapter.

I commissioned a picture of Seacat by Carnivalkitten.

Prologue & Chapter 1: The Weird Girl





Prologue: Four Years Ago

She was the first who heard it, even over the screams and explosions. A whine that made her sensitive ears hurt and her fur stand up. She turned around, hissing, her hands pressed on her ears, as she tried to find the source of the noise.

It didn't take her long. The weird bot in the middle of the village was the source - the whine came from it. She hissed again as the whining grew louder. This was unbearable! She turned, growling, and started to run away.

Horde Soldiers with weird helmets tried to grab her, but she ducked, sprinting on all fours, her claws digging into stone and soil as she raced through the village, not knowing, not caring where she was running as long as it was away. Away from the noise. Away. Away. Away.

Gasping, she drew to a stop on the beach. The sea was there. She couldn't run further. But the noise was still in her ears. And she was boxed in by cliffs.

No choice. She dashed forward, jumped into the sea, tried to dive into the shallow water. Anything to get away from the noise.

Until everything went black.

*****

She woke up with a gasp, her fur drenched with sweat. Shaking and panting, she wrapped her thin blanket around herself. She had to calm down. It was just a dream. A nightmare. She wasn't there. Not anymore. She wasn't surrounded by the corpses of Horde soldiers and villagers, fallen where they had fought.

She wasn't alone in a dead village.

"Hey, kid!"

She gasped again, scrambling back, away from whoever had startled her, pressing herself against the wall behind her mattress, one hand raised with her claws out.

The man bared his teeth - no, he smiled at her. “Hey! It’s me! Sea Hawk! The one and only! You had another nightmare?”

She shakingly nodded. “Y-yes.”

“Don’t worry, that’ll get better.” He kept smiling but didn’t approach her. She saw the bandage over his nose and winced. She hadn’t meant to hurt him. He had found her in the village. Had taken her on his ship. Taken her away from that horrible place.

“We’ll be in Seaworthy soon. Don’t worry, we’ll find help there.”

Once more, she nodded. More firmly this time.

“So, ah… do you remember your name now?”

Her ears dropped, and she swallowed as she shook her head. “N-no.” She didn’t. Didn’t remember any part of her life before the Horde soldiers attacked her village and killed everyone she knew.

“Ah.” His face fell for a moment. Then he perked up. “Well, until you do, I’ll be calling you… Seacat!”

She blinked. “Seacat?”

“Yes!” He beamed at her. “Because I fished you out of the sea and you’re a cat!”

She stared at him. Then she slowly nodded. And tried to smile.

He patted her shoulder, and she barely flinched. “Don’t you worry, once we’re in Seaworthy everything will be fine! There are no Horde soldiers there - you’ll be safe!”

Safe. She nodded. “Yes.”

But she gripped his hand with hers, and when he tried to pull it away, her claws dug into his skin, forcing him to stay.

Safe.

*****

Chapter 1: The Weird Girl

"...and then I said: 'Damn the blockade! Onward!' and we smashed through their blockade!"

"Wow! Really?"

"Yes, really! Left them drifting with broken oars and ruined rigging as we sailed off into the sunset!"

Seacat rolled her eyes at the silly waitress listening to Sea Hawk's boasting. Sure, they had broken through the blockade put up by those deserters from Mermista's kingdom, but it had left the Dragon's Daughter III with a damaged stern. And that had cost more to fix than breaking the blockade had earned them. Which meant they were broke again and looking for a cargo in Seaworthy. Preferably one by desperate people who needed the best ship on the sea. Or gullible idiots with more money than sense who could be fleeced for all their worth - Seacat wasn't picky. She couldn't afford to. Not with a captain like Sea Hawk doing his best - or worst - to sink their ship to ruin whenever he got a chance.

She clenched her teeth, suppressed the urge to growl, and took a deep breath. And a large swallow from her ale. Sea Hawk was a decent man. He had taken her in after her… well, after the attack. Taught her to sail the seas. Gave her a home.

If only he wouldn't keep trying to set her home on fire. And were a little more responsible.

She took another swallow before her mouth could decide whether it was meant to frown or smile. That hit the spot. But now her

tankard was empty. Sighing, she set it down and stared at the waitress. The silly wench was still looking at Sea Hawk as if her eyeballs were glued to the man's lips.

Seacat cleared her throat. Neither reacted. She did it again. And again.

"Are you well, first mate? You're not coming down with something, are you?" Sea Hawk asked. "Or are you coughing up a hairball?" He laughed at his own joke.

She groaned - briefly - at his old, stupid joke. Then she flashed a toothy grin at him that had him wince. "Just wondering what Mermista would think about you flirting with another woman."

He gasped in his exaggerated manner, jumping up and holding a hand to his heart. "What? Me, flirting? Never! My heart belongs to my dear Princess Mermista!"

She snorted in return. "Sure, sure." And tried not to feel guilty about the way his eyes had looked at her for just an instant. It wasn't her fault that the prissy princess didn't return his feelings. Not that Mermista would be a good match for Sea Hawk, anyway. Far too straight-laced. Sea Hawk would be good for her, of course - people like Memista needed some fun in their lives or they'd bore themselves to death 'doing their duty'.

Sea Hawk snorted as well and sat down again. "Perhaps you're a little grumpy because you aren't flirting?"

That made her roll her eyes. "No, I'm just grumpy 'cause my tankard's empty and the waitress has run off." And was now busy with another table.

He made a dismissive gesture with his hand. The hand that wasn't suddenly gripping his own tankard tightly before she had managed to grab it. Drat. "That's your own fault."

"Yeah, yeah." She stood. If the Maelstrom didn't come to the ship, the ship had to go to the Maelstrom.

She made her way to the bar - carefully. Her bare feet were perfect for the deck of a ship in heavy seas, and her claw marks just added character to the ship, no matter what Sea Hawk claimed, but there was nothing worse than stepping into spilt ale. Well, except for stepping into vomit. That just felt icky on her feet and fur and was hell to get out of her leggings. Even if the stains didn't easily show on the black fabric.

Some low-life nobody - looked like a sailor down on his luck - stared at her. Or rather, at her blood red tied-off shirt. She tossed her mane back and put a hand on the hilt of her cutlass, then bared her teeth with a growl. The man paled and looked away, hunching over.

Good. She neither wanted nor needed such attention. Nor did she need another attempt of Sea Hawk to play 'protective captain'. Or, worse, prospective matchmaker. She wasn't looking for a relationship. Or love.

The bartender was talking to a trio of landlubbers. Rich landlubbers, she thought - the little girl wore expensive clothes. Probably worth more than she was paying her two bodyguards.

Seacat smirked. Time to show the visitors who was at the top of the pecking order here. She deliberately stepped between the shrimp and the blonde bodyguard, forcing them out of the way. Ignoring their surprised protests, she leaned over the bar top and flashed two coins at the bartender. "Two more ales! And hurry!!"

"Hey! Who do you think you are?"

Oh! The shrimp just handed her the perfect opening. Seacat turned, leaned against the bar and grinned. "Me?" She laughed. "You've never heard of me? I am…"

"...Catra? Catra?"

What? Seacat blinked. That wasn't how this was supposed to go! The blonde guard she had elbowed to the side was staring at her

and... Were those tears in her eyes? What in the Ocean's name was going…

"Catra! I thought you were dead!"

The blonde lunged, quicker than Seacat had expected, and tackled her. Pressed her against the bar with enough force to drive the air out of her lungs, actually.

"I thought you were dead! For years! They said you were lost! Oh, Catra!"

Yes, she was crying - on Seacat's shoulder. That would get her shirt wet. And her hair.

"You're alive! You're alive!"

Not for much longer if the crazy woman kept trying to crush her ribs. Seacat managed to force out: "Need to breathe!"

"Adora! You're hurting her!"

"Adora!"

"Oh! I'm so sorry! I still don't know my new strength, I mean… sorry!"

The woman finally released her and Seacat took a deep breath. A few deep breaths. Air had never tasted sweeter than right now. Not since her first swimming lesson with Sea Hawk. She flashed the woman a toothy smile that usually served her well to keep grabby sailors away before she had to claw their faces off and make another bartender mad.

It didn't, not today. The woman - or girl, she looked much younger with a watery smile - beamed at her. "Catra!"

"The name's *Seacat*," she corrected the girl. Unless… No. Her village had been wiped out. She had been the only survivor. If

anyone had known her, they'd have found her. Sea Hawk had asked around in every port for months after he had taken her in.

"Seacat?" A dumb expression made the girl look even more… well, dumb.

"Yes, Seacat," she repeated herself.

"Like sea and cat?" the guy asked.

She glared at him. It was a perfectly fine name. Sea Hawk's choice, but still. It might not be the most original name, but it was hers. She had earned it.

The blonde was shaking her head. "No, no… it's been years, but I wouldn't mistake… it's you! Catra! My best friend!"

What?

"Don't you recognise me? It's me, Adora!" The girl gripped her shoulders. "We grew up together! You used to sleep on my bed!"

What?

"What?"

"Adora?"

Seacat winced and shook herself free while the shrimp and the other guard stared at the blonde. She suppressed the urge to rub her shoulders - the girl had a grip of iron. Could probably weigh a frigate's anchor by herself.

But… Seacat wet her lips and took a deep breath. This was just a misunderstanding. It must be. Neither she nor Sea Hawk, not even Mermista had ever found any other survivor from her village. On the other hand… "You're from... Gullpeak?" Her voice faltered a little saying the name, and Seacat clenched her teeth in frustration. She was stronger than that.

“Uh… Gullpeak?” The blonde blinked at her with her mouth half-open.

“Our... *my* home village,” Seacat said, doing her best not to show any disappointment. Not that she’d have actually harboured any real hope. It was just a misunderstanding, as she had thought. Or… was this a con? Some scummy lowlife trying to trick the amnesiac girl? It wasn’t as if Seacat’s past was a secret. Not with Sea Hawk having made up a shanty about it.

“Home village?” The blonde was still staring at her.

But the other guard was rubbing his chin. “Gullpeak… I think I’ve heard the name before.”

Seacat sighed. Loudly. If they were con men, they weren’t good at it. At all. “Yes, my home village. The place I was born and raised, you know?”

She pushed off the bar and got into the blonde’s face. You had to get up and personal if someone crowded you - it threw them off balance. And you were close enough to sucker-punch them - or gut them - if you had to. Few people who didn’t know her expected her claws to be able to cut through leather and light armour.

But Blondie didn’t look off her game. She looked confused. “But… we were raised in the Fright Zone. Together.”

What? Seacat leapt back, somersaulting, and landed on the bar top, hissing. “You’re Horde soldiers!” It was a trap! The blonde flinched - Seacat knew it! She drew her cutlass and lit the blade.

The other guests flinched, and the closest bunch moved away. Seacat ignored them, growling at the Horde soldiers with flat ears. They had wiped out her village!

“Nonononono!” The boy stepped in between them, waving his arms as if he were capsizing in a skiff. “She isn’t a Horde soldier! We aren’t Horde soldiers!”

The shrimp joined him. “We’re members of the Rebellion. I’m Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon.”

What?

“Are you in trouble, first mate?” Great. Now Sea Hawk had to butt in. And he struck a pose. “Don’t worry, your captain has your back! The sacred laws of the sea bind captain and crew together!”

Flashing his teeth, the captain stepped closer to her and mumbled. “What’s this all about, anyway? Friends of yours?”

“I’ve never seen them before!” Seacat hissed in reply, crouching on the bar top and keeping her cutlass pointed at the group.

“What? Catra! Did you lose your memory or something?” The blonde pushed through her friends and stepped so close, Seacat would just have to lean forward to pierce her stupid face.

“Of course not!” she growled, unfortunately at the same time Sea Hawk blurted out: “Why, yes, she did, in fact. Didn’t you know that?”

She glared at the captain as the three newcomers gasped. As usual when he was in full form - and slightly drunk - he ignored it.

He took a deep breath, struck another dramatic pose, hand on his cheek, and said: “She lost her memory in the same attack in which she lost her family. A poor orphan, the sole survivor of her village! When I first saw her, I knew I could not abandon her to a life in an orphanage and decided to take her in and raise her as the second-best sailor in all the seas!”

He had planned to find her a foster family until Mermista had commented that she wouldn’t have expected him to be so caring, but that was neither here nor there. “Don’t tell my life history to strangers,” she spat. At least, he wasn’t singing.

“But it’s dramatic!” he retorted. “Besides, it makes me look good. And it makes you more likeable.”

She growled at him - she didn’t need nor wanted pity. “Yeah, yeah. It’s ancient history.”

“It’s been four years,” he said. “Although time flies when you’re on an adventure! And life’s an adventure!”

“That makes… no sense,” the male guard commented. “Wouldn’t it…”

“Four years ago? That’s when you disappeared!” Blondie blurted out.

Seacat snorted. “What a coincidence!” Even a dumbass con man would’ve known to say that.

And yet, the blonde nodded with an earnest expression that almost looked convincing. “Yes! There was a mistake during a field exercise! You were sent to the wrong coordinates and never returned!”

“Mistake?” Seacat snarled. “Field exercise? Are you trying to claim that I was a Horde soldier?” She hopped down from the bar top and landed in front of the girl. If she dared to...

“Yes!” Blondie blurted out. “Well, a cadet - like me!”

Blondie was a Horde soldier? Hadn’t they just denied that? “You’re a Horde soldier?”

“She deserted!” the other guard butted in. “Before her first mission!”

That seemed to finally make the idiot realise that Seacat was about to claw her stupid face off and she took a few steps back, shaking her head. “I’m fighting for the Rebellion.”

“Anyone can say that!” Seacat snapped back.

“Indeed,” Sea Hawk added. “Taking on a fake identity is quite common on adventures. While I prefer to solve my problems with

blade and bravery, guile and trickery are not without merit."

"I'm Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon," the shrimp repeated herself. "A member of the Princess Alliance."

"The future Princess Alliance. Or the reborn Princess Alliance," the guy added.

"You don't look much like a Princess," Seacat told her.

"And you've seen many Princesses, have you?" the shrimp shot back with a scowl.

"Oh, I'm very familiar, practically family, with Princess Mermista!" Sea Hawk blurted out, as Seacat had known he would. "And as my trusted first mate, she's also very familiar with Princess Mermista."

Too familiar, for Seacat's taste.

The shrimp made a frustrated noise - and disappeared in a cloud of sparkles to reappear in the booth Sea Hawk had vacated. A moment later, she returned to her guards' side in the same way. "There!"

"Oh...a demonstration of a Princess's power!" Sea Hawk hit the palm of his hand with his fist and nodded several times. "Impressive!"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Yes, yes, impressive. But it doesn't prove anything else at all." It probably didn't prove that the shrimp was a princess, either, but Seacat didn't know enough about magic to know if a sorceress could do the same.

And it certainly didn't prove Blondie's story! Seacat wasn't a Horde soldier!

"Catra!" Blondie tried again as if she had read Seacat's mind. "You've lost your memory! At the same time, my best friend disappeared! Doesn't that tell you something?"

“Yes, it does,” Seacat replied. She waited until the girl’s expression brightened before she added: “It tells me that you didn’t think your story through. Not even the Horde sends children into battle!” Mostly because they had more than enough bots and soldiers already, but that was neither here nor there. The girl looked more hurt than foiled, though. And that made Seacat feel… nothing. Certainly not guilty.

Blondie shook her head, sending her silly ponytail flying. “It was a mistake! You weren’t supposed to be there - you were supposed to go to a safe outpost like me and get some field experience!”

“Gullpeak!” Guard guy slapped his fist like a miniature Sea Hawk. “I remember now! That was a village that was totally wiped out by some secret Horde weapon four years ago! Yes!”

She was about to claw his face off for his stupid smile - that was her family’s death that he was smiling about! - but Sea Hawk’s hand on her shoulder held her back.

The guy had the grace to flinch. “Uh… sorry. I got carried away. History is kind of… not my thing, but one thing of mine.”

“I am not a Horde soldier,” Seacat repeated herself through clenched teeth.

“No one here is a Horde soldier,” the guy said quickly, clapping his hand. “So… how about we continue this very informative talk with a little more privacy?”

Right. Half the tavern was staring at them. Seacat groaned - she should’ve known better than to hash things out at the bar. She would never live this down.

*****

“So! Introductions!” the shrimp said as they sat down - with the three strangers on one side, and Seacat and the captain on the other side. “I’m Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon. This is my best friend, Bow, and our best friend, Adora.”

And they made fun of her name? Seacat clenched her teeth. A deep breath later, she snorted. That made the shrimp frown at her and Blondie look… she couldn't place the expression. "The Horde cadet."

Blondie winced at that before rallying. "I'm not with the Horde. I mean, I was - but not anymore." She sighed. "It's complicated."

"She deserted," the shrimp said, "and joined the Rebellion." There had to be more to the story, going by the glance she shot at the other two.

Seacat made a mental note of looking into that. You could never know enough about potential friends and enemies.

"And you were looking for your long-lost best friend after you heard the famous shanty of Seacat!" Sea Hawk clasped his hands to his chest and beamed at the three.

Bow-guy smiled, rather weakly. "Actually, we never heard that shanty."

"If we had, we would've come at once!" Blondie added.

Sea Hawk's eyes widened, as did his smile. "Ah, it's really...Ow!"

Seacat glared at him and pulled her claws from his thigh. This wasn't the time. Actually, it never was the time to sing that particular shanty.

The princess cleared her throat. "We came here because we need a passage to Salineas."

"To see Princess Mermista," Bow-Boy added.

"And you naturally chose me! The best and bravest captain sailing the sea! And the one whom Princess Mermista holds so dear in her generous heart!" Sea Hawk flashed his teeth at them in what he thought was a dazzling smile.

Seacat smirked when she saw the slightly embarrassed expressions on the three.

"Uh, actually, we ever heard of you, either." Bow-Boy looked like he wanted to apologise for that. As if a landlubber would have heard of Sea Hawk. Well, a bounty hunter probably had.

Which was why they couldn't trust any stranger. Though… these guys weren't bounty hunters. And Seacat didn't think that the captain had ever set a princess's boat on fire. Apart from Mermista's, of course.

"Oh." Sea Hawk's face fell - but only for a moment. "In any case, you came to the right people! I and my first mate are the crew to hire for a trip to Salineas. Or to anywhere, actually. As long as it's on a coast." He stood, put one boot on the table and pushed his chest out. "No matter the danger, no matter the odds, the Dragon's Daughter III will always reach her destination!"

"What happened to the Dragon's Daughters I and II?" Bow-boy asked.

"They went down in flames," Seacat replied.

"*After* reaching their destinations!" Sea Hawk was quick to add.

"*While* reaching their destinations," Seacat corrected him. She ignored his confused glance. They needed money, but they didn't need those weirdos' money. And if the shrimp was desperate enough to hire them anyway, that meant they could charge more money - enough to make it worth travelling with Blondie. The way the girl was staring at her made Seacat's skin… crawl. Definitely crawl. Not shiver.

"You're hired!" Blondie declared.

"Perfect!" Sea Hawk replied at the same time that the shrimp blurted out: "Adora! We haven't made a decision yet!"

"But they have a ship, they know the princess, and it's Catra!"

“Seacat,” she corrected Blondie through clenched teeth.

Instead of being taken aback, the girl’s smile grew. “That’s the same hissing I remember!”

“Uh, we can’t agree on hiring them before we know how much this will cost,” Bow-Guy cut in. He seemed to be the least stupid of the three. Not that that would make him smart, of course - Blondie was obviously dumb, and the princess was, well, a princess. And anyone who knew princesses knew that they weren’t smart. Mermista was the best example of that.

But this gave her another opening. Seacat smiled, showing her fangs - which, unfortunately, made Blondie’s smile grow even more sappy - and quickly noted a number down on a scrap of paper. “Here’s our fee, Brain!” she announced as she held it out to the boy.

It was very satisfying to see their mouths drop after they read the note. Guess your allowance doesn’t cover this, huh?

“Those are… many zeroes. Very many zeroes,” Brain managed to say.

Seacat grinned at him. “Operating a ship isn’t cheap.” Especially if your captain had the habit of setting it on fire whenever he had the chance.

“Oh, yes,” Sea Hawk agreed - for once.

“But… this much?” Shrimp held up the paper, and Seacat winced.

She reached out to grab it, but the captain had already seen the number. “What? Oh, that must have been a mistake. That’s two zeroes too many, actually,” he said. “You must forgive my first mate - I was the one who taught her maths.”

Seacat slapped her face and growled while the three weirdos blinked in surprise.

“Uh… OK… so, we can definitely pay the fee then,” the shrimp told the captain.

“Marvellous! To adventure!” Sea Hawk declared, holding out his hand.

Seacat sighed while the two shook on it. Now she was stuck travelling with a weirdo - a Horde cadet - who thought she was their long-lost best friend or something. And a princess, but that particular pain in the buttt paled compared to travelling with Blondie. Besides, the shrimp couldn’t be as bad as Mermista, could she?

*****

After having their three passengers pay their bar tab - they actually believed Seacat that this was how things were done! - they made their way to the harbour. Seacat led the way, next to the captain, with the three members of the Rebellion trailing behind them. She wasn’t actually trying to lose them, but if they couldn’t keep up…

Not that she was losing them, anyway - she could hear them talk behind her.

“Are you sure that she’s your friend, Adora? She doesn’t seem to like you at all.”

“That’s just how she is. You have to know her better to, uh, know her.”

Seacat rolled her eyes and clenched her teeth again as she felt her ears twitch. She didn’t have to glance over her shoulder to know the stupid expression Blondie had.

“Well, she is firmly set against the Horde. That’s a good thing,” Brain said.

“Except that she is so firmly set against the Horde, she doesn’t like that Adora was part of the Horde.”

“Right. That’s not a good thing.”

“But we both left. Why won’t she accept that?”

Because it wasn’t true! Seacat balled her hands into fists, almost piercing her palms with her claws.

“She will. Once we can talk about this, once I can tell her all about our friendship, she will understand!” Shrimp said.

No, she won’t. “I can hear you,” Seacat sing-songed through clenched teeth without looking back.

“Uh…”

“Right, I forgot all about her hearing! I mean… sorry?”

Seacat huffed and stepped up her pace. Fortunately, the trio remained silent until they reached the Dragon’s Daughter III.

*****

“Alright,” Seacat said, loudly, as soon as they had boarded the ship, “stay on this deck and don’t touch anything but the railing. Especially don’t meddle with the rigging - we don’t want to capsize because you unfurl the sail in the middle of a gale.”

“Indeed, we don’t. Losing a ship to capsizing is one of the worst ways to lose a ship,” Sea Hawk added. “I should know, for I have experienced them all!”

Seacat closed her eyes, then blinked. If the weirdos reconsidered...

“What?”

“Are we sure about this guy?”

“I trust Catra! She loathes water. She would never board a ship that’s at risk of sinking!”

What? She laughed. “Your Catra hated water?”

Blondie looked confused. “You hate getting wet.”

“What?” Seacat glared at the girl. “I don’t! I like to swim! I *love* to swim!”

“You can swim?”

“What sailor can’t swim?” Seacat retorted. Swimming was an important skill for a sailor - especially for a member of Sea Hawk’s crew.

She felt the captain’s hand on her shoulder - he had snuck up on her again, somehow - before she was pulled into his side. “I taught her personally! It was an adventure! I’ve been bloodied less fighting pirates, but after a long, hard and painful struggle, I succeeded!”

She rolled her eyes and shrugged his arm off. “Yes. I can and like to swim.” As long as she could clean the saltwater off her fur before it dried.

“Really?” Sea Hawk blinked. “You like it?”

“When I’m not forced to because our ship’s on fire,” she quickly clarified.

“Oh.” Sea Hawk looked sad for a moment - but Seacat wasn’t fooled. She knew him too well. “My first mate likes swimming!” Yes, there he went, hanging on the rigging and all but singing.

“Are we *really* sure about these guys?” Brain asked.

“They just need to get us there,” Shrimp replied.

Blondie, though, was staring at her. Seacat met her gaze with narrowed eyes, cocking her hip. Maybe now the girl had realised that she was Seacat, not Catra.

But the girl beamed at her. “That’s exactly how you used to stand when we were cadets!”

Oh, for Maelstrom’s sake! She growled at the idiot and turned away. “I’ll cast off the lines.”

“And I’ll set course for Salineas!”

*****

“Ahem…”

Seacat hissed as she turned her head to glare at Blondie. “Don’t disturb me while I’m working. Do you want us to capsize?”

“Uh… I thought you were just storing ropes…”

Seacat scoffed. She had managed to keep Blondie at bay by busying herself while they left port, but it seemed that the annoying girl didn’t get the message. She just had to meddle, had she? “The lines control the sails. And the sails are what drives the ship - uncontrolled, they can wreck a ship.”

“Oh.” The blonde took a step back with a dejected expression. Seacat briefly felt the urge to apologise but suppressed it.

“Even a ship as advanced as the Dragon’s Daughter III doesn’t sail herself,” she said instead. “Do you think sailors spend their time doing nothing between ports?”

“No, no, of course not! I just… wanted to talk…” Blondie’s shy smile was a pitiful sight.

Seacat pressed her lips together as she finished tying up the spare lines. “Are you going to try to talk about your missing friend again? The Horde soldier?”

“No? Yes? Maybe?” The girl’s smile grew forced.

“Save it!” Seacat snapped. “I’m not her. I’m not a Horde soldier. I never was a Horde soldier. I’m not your friend. And I don’t want to be your friend!” she hissed in the idiot’s face.

Blondie gasped. “But…” Seacat saw her swallow and blink - and were those tears in the blonde’s eyes? “Sorry…”

Once more, Seacat had to suppress the weird urge to apologise as the blonde turned and walked away. She scoffed at her own weakness. She hadn’t done anything wrong. She wasn’t this ‘Catra’. She wasn’t a Horde soldier. The sooner Blondie accepted that, the better. For both of them.

*****

Seacat liked being the lookout. Climbing the rigging was fun - and no one was as fast at the top of the main-mast as she was. No one not cheating by using magic like the shrimp, that was. She scowled at the show-off, but not for long.

Here, she felt on top of things. On top of the world. At peace. Just her and the sky and the sea. If the wind was blowing strongly enough, she wouldn’t even hear the captain’s shanties. She took a deep breath, enjoying the smell of the ocean. Soon, they would be arriving at Salineas, and the three passengers would go and annoy Mermista. And Seacat and Sea Hawk could set out again, and leave all this… stupidity behind.

She grinned. After all, the three hadn’t hired them for a round trip.

“Oof.”

What? Seacat quickly glanced around. The sea was calm. They were still a good way off the reefs that dominated the straits of Salineas and made the Sea Gate the key to controlling sea trade. So…

She glanced down and growled. Blondie was climbing the rigging. And smiling widely at her.

“Ahem. Sorry… I just felt the urge to climb.”

Oh for Maelstrom’s sake! “Really?” she replied, putting all the doubt she could muster into it.

“I used to climb a lot in, ah, the Fright Zone.”

Seacat growled, and the girl winced.

“Usually to follow, uh… my friend.”

Of course. Seacat smiled. “So, you’re used to high places and strong winds?”

Blondie nodded enthusiastically. “Yes!”

“Good. You can take over lookout duty until dinner.” Seacat bared her teeth at the idiot. “And don’t slack off, or we might hit a reef and sink!” she snapped as she slid down the other side.

As soon as she hit the deck, she chuckled. That should keep Blondie out of her hair for a few hours - the girl wouldn’t slack off. She was far too serious for that, Seacat knew. Always doing her duty…

She frowned, then scoffed. The girl was an open book. Everyone would’ve known that after spending a few hours with her. Yes.

“Uh… what’s Adora doing?” Brain asked,

Seacat rolled her eyes. She didn’t want to talk about the annoying girl. “She relieved me from lookout duty so I could do my other jobs on the ship.”

“Really?”

Honest and gullible. No wonder he was a friend of Blondie. “Yes, really,” she replied.

“And what does a lookout do?”

“Looks out for ships, reefs and other dangers,” she explained.

“Reefs?”

“Yes, reefs,” she repeated herself.

“But… the ship flies.”

She sighed. Landlubber, yes. “It sails over the sea,” she told him. “It doesn’t really fly. Steer it over land - or a rock, or a too shallow sea - and it’ll crash. The magic holding it afloat over the water doesn’t work over land.”

“Oh. That’s why we only have small skiffs on land, not big huge cargo ships.”

“Exactly. That’s a completely different magic.” Honest, gullible but smart. She flashed a smile at him. “You’re the brains of your group, aren’t you?” A little more information about the trio wouldn’t hurt at all.

He blushed a little. Adorable. “Ah, well… I’m a master bowman and a tech master. Well, working on the latter, but I’m close.”

“Ah.” She cocked her head and looked at his quiver. Men loved to talk about their weapons. “You made the arrows yourself?”

“Ah, right.” He beamed. “I’ve got a wide range of arrows for all occasions! Whatever we’ll face, I’ll have an arrow for it!”

She snorted. “Really?”

“Oh, yes!” He pulled out a shaft with a hefty arrowhead. “This one shoots glue!”

“Glue?” She took a step back. Glue and fur didn’t go well together. Not at all. “Don’t point it at me!” she hissed. She didn’t want to have to shave off her fur ever again!

“Uh, sorry.” He smiled weakly. “Didn’t want to scare you.”

“I am not scared,” she growled. She wasn’t scared, She hadn’t had nightmares in months. Huffing, she turned away. “I’ll be busy doing… stuff.”

“Stuff?”

“Important stuff.”

Like napping in her hammock. Away from bothersome passengers.

Seacat couldn’t wait until Blondie and her friends were gone from her ship.

*****

The Battle of Salineas

"Hey, Adora! Look what I found!"

"Catra?"

She raised her hands, gripping the struggling mouse tightly. "I caught it!"

"Oh! How?"

"I was faster!" She smiled, showing her fangs. She had caught the stupid mouse! It would never eat her rations again. Or Adora's.

"Great!" Adora scrunched up her nose - she was thinking. "Now what do we do with it?"

"Uh…" She hadn't thought about that. "Eat it?"

"Ew!" Adora made her icky face.

"Kill it?"

"Kill it?" Adora looked scared.

She shrugged. Wasn't the mouse bad? And it ate their food! But to kill it…

Suddenly, the mouse twisted in her grip - and bit her!

She yelled and threw the bad mouse away - at the wall. It hit with a crunch and fell down. And she was bleeding! "I'm bleeding!" she sobbed.

"Oh, no!" Adora was there, gripping her hand. "We need to go to the infirmary!"

She shied away. That was a bad place!

"Come on!"

"No!" She shook her head.

But Adora didn't listen. She dragged her away!

*****

Seacat blinked. What a weird… what dream? She squinted at the porthole in her cabin. Was the sun setting already? Dinner time, and no one had woken her up? Between that and Blondie being dumb, no wonder she was having stupid dreams that made no sense!

Shaking her head, she climbed out of her hammock and went out on the main deck. Everything looked to be fine. Blondie was still up in the rigging - how long had she stayed up there? It had been hours! - the other two passengers were staring at the sunset, and the captain was at the wheel.

She blinked. Wait! They had set out from Seaworthy to Salineas. The sun shouldn't be setting that close to their bow - not if they were on course...

She pressed her lips together and quickly climbed up the stairs to the conn. "Captain!"

Seacat saw him flinch, as she had known he would - he knew her tone. "Yes?" And she knew the too-wide smile. "Isn't it a brilliant day for adventure?" He spread his arms and puffed up his chest, briefly letting go of the rudder. "I mean, it's now a brilliant evening, but you know what I mean."

Oh no! She sighed as she frowned at him. So that was why he hadn't set a course directly for Salineas. As if she wouldn't notice - she knew the local seas as well as the back of her hand! "We're not on an adventure - we're transporting passengers to Salineas," she reminded him.

"It can be both! Instead of a boring cruise our passengers could have a harrowing adventure!"

She closed her eyes while Sea Hawk posed, flexed her claws, then grabbed the captain by his bandana. “We’re not being paid for adventure! We’re being paid for transporting the Shrimp and her friends to Mermista. And we need the money!”

“Ah… now that you mention it...” His smile widened. “Offering them an adventure should liven up the voyage and make them hire us for the trip back as well, don’t you agree?”

“No, I do not.” she spat. “Change course to Salineas!”

“Hey! Who’s the captain of this ship?”

“And who handles the money?”

“That’s a good point!” He raised his index finger in her face. “However, I have a counterpoint!”

“What?” she growled.

“Reef ahead!” Blondie’s voice rang out - she had strong lungs. “And wrecks! Many wrecks!”

“See? We’ve already arrived! Adventure!” Sea Hawk yelled. He let go of the wheel and pointed to the sky.

“Shipwrecker’s Reef? Turn about!” she snapped back, grabbing the wheel herself. Then she saw the sea serpent emerge from the water. “No…” Too late. Now they had to fight a monster. And with a bunch of useless passengers on board. Damn Sea Hawk!

“It’s a monster!”

“It’s a sea serpent!”

“It’s an adventure!”

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

“Everyone, hold...what?” Seacat tore her eyes from the approaching monster and saw an impossibly tall blonde woman in

shining - literally shining - armour rush towards the railing. And she was wielding Blondie's sword.

She kept staring as the woman jumped incredibly high - as if she had grown wings - and came down on the serpent's head, shattering teeth with her sword. "Maelstrom's maw!" Seacat cursed as both disappeared underwater. "She's crazy!" And damned… She forced that thought away.

"Oh, no - she does that all the time," Shrimp said in a rather smug voice.

"Don't worry, she's got this," Brain Boy added, leaning against the railing as if he had no care in the world.

"Got it!" the blonde yelled from the water as if she had heard them. "Wait, no!"

And she was pulled under - or dived, Seacat couldn't tell.

Fighting a sea serpent by herself? With just a sword? Seacat shook her head.

Then Blondie surfaced. "Now I've got it!" she announced with a beaming smile. Blondie? The weird girl had slain a sea serpent? And had changed into a giantess for it??

Behind Seacat, Sea Hawk dropped the harpoons he had taken out of storage. "I guess my brilliant plan to impress our passengers didn't account for that twist," he said.

Seacat couldn't help it - she laughed. "But your plan to entertain them so they'll hire us again might've worked," she said as Blondie, helped by her friends, climbed back on board, babbling excitedly about her fight.

Wait - that was a bad thing, Seacat reminded herself. Then her eyes widened as she realised what she had seen. There was only one explanation for this.

Blondie was a princess! A bloody princess! A former Horde soldier was a princess? How was that possible? Princesses were born to royalty! Did they lose her as a baby? No, that only happened in stories. Stupid stories for little girls who hadn't yet learned that the world wasn't a tale, and that no one would be coming to claim them as their lost grandchild and take them away to a life in safety and luxury.

Seacat shook her head. "How can you be a princess?" she yelled, claws digging into the railing where she stood.

Blondie blinked at her. "I'm She-Ra, Princess of Power."

"I don't care about your title," Seacat growled as she handed the conn over to Sea Hawk. "*How* can a *Horde soldier* be a *princess*?"

"Former Horde soldier," Brain Boy cut in.

Seacat ignored him as she jumped down to the deck and stalked towards Blondie. The girl had shrunk to a more normal size, and her clothes covered her arms and legs again, hiding those toned muscles. Well, being all wet, they didn't hide them completely. A white undersuit wasn't the best choice for swimming or diving, and her ponytail was limply hanging down her back. Not that Seacat cared.

"Ah, well…" Blondie grimaced as she tugged on her jacket. "I found this…"

"That's a secret," Shrimp interrupted her, teleporting between them with her arms spread. Did she think Seacat would attack a woman - a princess! - who could take out a sea serpent with just a sword? Well, they *were* rebels...

"Really?" Seacat narrowed her eyes at the shorter princess. "A secret?"

"Yes, a secret." The princess frowned at her - and then at Blondie. "Crucially important information for the Rebellion that cannot get out."

Blondie looked surprised and then guilty. Catra almost laughed at her expression.

Instead, she nodded. That something was a secret was valuable information by itself. But it was obvious, of course - everyone knew that the power of the princesses had kept the Horde away, even when they were just defending their own realms. And it wasn't as if anyone but the Horde would profit from spilling the secret. She still wanted to know the secret, of course. But this wasn't the time. So she scoffed. "Two princesses. We should've charged more for this trip."

"Hey! Just because I'm a princess doesn't mean I've got money!" Blondie protested. "We didn't have any money in the Horde! I actually don't have any money now." She blinked in that stupid manner of hers. "I don't need money, do I?" she asked her friends.

"Bright Moon will cover all your expenses," Shrimp replied.

Seacat huffed. Some people had all the luck while others struggled and earned their keep. "Whatever," she spat and turned around to find something to be busy with. Anything to take her mind of stupid impossibly tall and toned blonde princesses straight out of a children's tale!

"What is this place, anyway?" Shrimp yelled after her. "I didn't read about a ship's graveyard on the way to Salineas when I planned this mission!"

Seacat stopped and grinned without facing them. "The Captain set the course," she told the princess. "Ask him."

"What?"

She hid her smile and climbed the rigging while the three passengers went to question Sea Hawk. It wouldn't teach her captain a lesson - she knew him too well to hope for that - but it would at least be amusing to watch.

*****

They reached Salineas without too much delay, but the captain wouldn't be bragging about this trip when he next claimed the Dragon's Daughter III was the fastest ship on all the seas. Which was more or less correct, of course. Though she was also one of the smallest ocean-going vessels.

Salineas's port was emptier than usual, Seacat noticed as they approached the breakwater - which would also break any ships that foundered on it, of course. Instead of the dozen ships usually waiting to pass through the gate after reprovisioning, she could only see two - and those were ships of Salineas's navy. And the guards on the mole outnumbered the people fishing there.

"Something's not right," she muttered.

"Hm?"

Seacat felt her fur bristle, but she managed not to jump. How had Blondie snuck up on her? She turned around especially slowly to face the princess. "What?"

"What's not right?"

"Eavesdropping," Seacat answered with a toothy grin.

"What?"

Blondie just had to ruin her quip, didn't she? "Eavesdropping isn't right," Seacat explained.

"Oh." Blondie blinked. "I wasn't. Eavesdropping, that is. Not intentional, I mean." She bit her lip, then smiled again. "I just wanted to talk to you."

But Seacat didn't want to talk to her. She frowned. "We're about to make landfall - I'm busy here."

"Oh."

That should've been obvious. Seacat cocked her head, pointedly looked at where the other princess and Brain Boy were standing at the railing, and nodded. "So, can I go back to keeping us from ramming the pier?"

"Oh. Of course! Sorry! We can talk later!"

Seacat sighed. She should've told the girl to get lost. But then Blondie would've cried or something. And that would have made a bad impression on the other princess, who still had to pay them. And on Mermista as well. Probably - it was hard to tell with the Princess of Salineas.

The Dragon's Daughter III came to a stop right at the pier, leaving less than a handwidth between the hull and the wall. It was a perfect example of great seamanship by Sea Hawk - not that the landlubbers would have realised that. But Seacat did, of course.

She jumped over to the pier and secured the ship with the lines hanging there. "She's tied up, captain!" she yelled with a smile.

"Good work, first mate!" Sea Hawk replied before swinging on a line to land next to her. "Ah! The shores of Salineas! Fairest port on all the seas, and home to the fairest princess in the world!"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Yeah, yeah." Of course, the man had done this just to impress the princess. Who wasn't at the pier, anyway. Ah well. She turned to their passengers. "I'll have the gangplank ready in a moment so you can disembark!"

"No need!" Blondie yelled back and jumped herself, followed by her friends teleporting directly on to the pier.

Seacat frowned - they didn't have to act as if they couldn't wait to leave the ship, did they? Before she could say anything, though, Blondie was in her face. "So… the ship's all secured now, no danger of sinking? So, can we talk now?"

Maelstrom's mother! Seacat clenched her teeth. She couldn't blow up at the idiot - they hadn't paid their fare yet.

“Adora! We need to speak to the princess first. We can’t leave her waiting, or she might be offended,” the shrimp called out.

“Oh…”

“And we have to deal with customs,” Seacat said. “Sorry,” she added with a toothy smile. The harbourmaster of Salineas was usually a pain in the butt with all her required paperwork, but today they only had three passengers to declare, so it shouldn’t take long at all. Just long enough to see the trio well on their way to the palace.

“That can wait!” Sea Hawk declared. “Mermista can’t wait!” Before she could stop him, he turned to the approaching guards. “Ho! Dear fellows! We require an audience with the princess! Tell her Sea Hawk has arrived with a diplomatic delegation from Bright Moon!”

Seacat shook her head as the guards snapped to attention. Well, even if that meant Sea Hawk wouldn’t be here to help her deal with customs, it would also stop Blondie from bothering her.

But Sea Hawk slapped her on the back. “Come on, first mate! Dear Mermista will be overjoyed to see you as well!”

Oh, no.

*****

The city wasn’t as lively as usual, either, Seacat noted on the way to the palace. She saw fewer guards about, and fewer merchants boasting about their wares. Very few merchants, actually - most of the shops she saw were closed.

Something was wrong. They hadn’t been to Salineas in some time - enough time to let Mermista cool down after the latest ‘unfortunate misunderstanding’, as Sea Hawk called it - but the last time they had visited, the city had been buzzing.

Even so, Blondie seemed impressed, Seacat noted - the girl was looking around as if she'd never seen a port town other than Seaworthy, and she was probably not listening to what Shrimp and Brain Boy tried to tell her about Mermista and about making a good impression.

Well, that was none of her business. Seacat stepped up her pace until she was walking right next to Sea Hawk. "Captain," she said in a low voice, "do you know where all the people are?"

"Oh?" He blinked, then looked around. "No, can't say I do!"

She sighed, but it wasn't as if she had expected anything else.

At least the palace looked the same, and the majordomo had the usual frown on his face when he saw Sea Hawk and Seacat. "Princess Glimmer!" the arrogant prick sad, beaming at Shrimp before he bowed. "Princess Mermista will be receiving you and your friends. If you'll follow me?"

"Thank you," the shrimp replied.

Seacat frowned, then stepped closer to Blondie. "Shouldn't you rate a welcome as well?" she asked in a whisper, "being a princess and all?"

"Ah… It's complicated." Blondie smiled at her. "But I don't mind."

Yeah, right. A princess not minding not being treated as a princess? Seacat snorted. On the other hand, perhaps Blondie wasn't used yet to being a princess. The way she acted, she must have been a recent pick or however you became a princess.

"So… you've been here before, right? Sea Hawk told us about your visits." Blondie beamed at her.

Seriously? Was she trying to get information like that? Or was she trying to chat? Seacat narrowed her eyes. "We've visited before," she said carefully.

“Oh. So...”

Fortunately, they reached the throne room, and Blondie fell silent as the majordomo announced them. “Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon. And friends.”

“And the one and only Sea Hawk!” the captain added in a loud voice.

Seacat grinned at the way the prick’s frown deepened.

But then Mermista loudly sighed. “Ew. Who let him in?”

Seacat winced - it seemed they hadn’t been away long enough.

“Guards!” the majordomo bellowed at once. “Remove the captain at once!”

“No, no!” Mermista raised one hand, the other still propping up her head where she was slouching on her throne, “if he’s already here he might as well stay.”

“My dearest Mermista! It’s been too long! I’ve dreamed of you...” Sea Hawk stepped forward with a wide smile.

“For now,” the princess added with a frown, which shut him up.

Seacat frowned - that was typical of the princess; stringing Sea Hawk along with mixed signals.

“And look what the cat dragged in.” Mermista nodded towards her.

“They’re a diplomatic delegation,” Seacat replied, deliberately misunderstanding the princess’s intent. “From Bright Moon.”

“I know that. I didn’t mean them.” Mermista’s glare was lacking her usual intensity, Seacat noticed.

“I’m Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon,” the shrimp announced, taking a step forward. “Our parents fought in the Rebellion together.”

The Princess wasn't impressed, though. "Yes, that particular disaster is well known in Salineas. Let me guess: You want to renew the alliance and fight the Horde together." She sighed.

Shrimp was taken aback, and before she could say anything in response, Mermista stood and walked over the wall behind her. A wave of her trident turned it into a window showing the Sea Gate. "We could've used help before the Sea Gate started crumbling right when Horde flotillas increased the pressure on my kingdom."

Seacat felt her ears perk up. That was news. Very unwelcome news. "Is that why the port's deserted?" she blurted out.

Mermista glared at her for a moment, then shrugged. "People don't want to stay in a city that will fall as soon as the Sea Gate stops working. Who would have guessed?" she added with a cynical smile.

That was more like the Mermista Seacat knew. But her attitude was… she wasn't giving up, was she?

"My dearest Mermista! As long as my ship is sailing the waves, no Horde vessel will reach your shores!" Sea Hawk declared, pointing at the ceiling.

"So… that'll be for about half an hour until it's burned to the waterline?" Mermista shot back with a wry smile.

"Make it an hour," Sea Hawk replied with a grin.

Mermista chuckled with a wry smile. "Thank you."

This was very alarming. She had never seen Mermista like this. And Seacat very much didn't want to die in a futile charge against an enemy fleet that only served to prolong the battle for half an hour. No, she didn't want to die, period, she reminded herself.

"That's why we're here - to rebuild the Princess Alliance," Princess Shrimp declared. "Together, we can beat the Horde!"

“Sure, like our parents beat them, right?” Mermista sighed again. “Without the Sea Gate protecting us, we’re pretty much dead.”

And if the Horde controlled Salineas, they’d control the sea routes - the Sea Gate protected the only safe passage between the Maelstrom and the Eastern Reefs. That would spell disaster for any independent captain.

“We’re here to help you!” the shrimp tried again. She was stubborn, Seacat had to admit. Of course, that stubbornness might get her killed here. Well, she’d be in good company - it wasn’t as if Seacat would abandon Sea Hawk, and her captain would never abandon Mermista. Not when she was fighting for her life.

“This is First Ones’ writing…”

Seacat turned - she had almost forgotten about Blondie. The girl was staring at a colourful display with… runes?

“Who’s she again?” Mermista asked.

“She’s Adora. She’s got a magic sword,” Brain Boy said.

Seacat really needed to reconsider his nickname. On the other hand, Shrimp and Blondie were even worse, weren’t they?

*****

As it turned out, Blondie could read the lost language of the First Ones. Which supposedly meant she could repair the Sea Gate, which apparently somehow had lost or was losing its connection to the runestone.

It didn’t make much sense to Seacat, but she wasn’t a sorceress. She wasn’t really interested in knowing details. This was just a way to pass the time until Mermista either sent the three weirdos away or made an alliance and then spent a few days encouraging Sea Hawk before blowing up at him and driving him away again.

Sea Hawk would never change. The sooner Mermista realised that, the better for both of them.

On the other hand, she needed something to keep her from being bored while waiting for the inevitable breakup. “So, you can do magic?” she asked as the group walked over towards the Sea Gate, to check if Blondie was correct.

“Ah… yes?”

“That didn’t sound very confident.”

“It’s a theory,” Blondie replied, frowning a little. “But a sound one.”

“Yes,” Shrimp butted in, “Magic is connected to the runestones.”

“And how are you going to repair it? Hit it with your magic sword?” Seacat joked.

“Uh…”

“Seriously?” She started at the girl. “You’re planning to hit to repair it?” That wasn’t how repairing anything worked.

“Not directly. But I will use my sword.” Now Blondie was pouting. She looked almost adorable like that. Seacat snickered.

“What’s so funny?” Blondie asked, frowning at her.

“Nothing,” Seacat chuckled again, “I’m just imagining how you’ll repair the gate with your sword.”

“Hmph.”

Before the other girl could think of a response - or Shrimp could butt in again - they reached the Sea Gate. “Up close it does look different,” Seacat remarked.

“Oh? Are you an expert?” Shrimp asked.

Seacat rolled her eyes. She didn't like the princess's tone. Or expression. Or attitude. At least when it was aimed at herself. "Any sailor passing through the gate as often as we do would notice such changes," she said.

Mermista cleared her throat, glaring at her as if it was Seacat's fault that the princess's gate was failing. "As I was about to say, the gate's magic has grown weaker since my father's time, and the process goes on. If you think you can restore its power, feel free to try."

Blondie nodded with a determined expression. Seacat was tempted to ask if they had agreed on a reward yet, but it was none of her business if Mermista decided to get some free help without committing herself to an alliance. And if the princess had decided to do that, she'd be angry at Seacat for spoiling her plan. Which would put Sea Hawk into a bad spot.

"For the Honour of Grayskull!"

Seacat didn't gasp as she watched Blondie turning into some seven-foot warrior with coiled muscles and legs that didn't seem to end. She just took a deep breath. And stared. So, that was a princess's magic at work.

"Uh... now… how best to do this…" Blondie said as she eyed the barrier.

"Don't ask me - you're the one with the magic repairing sword," Seacat replied with a smirk.

"I wasn't asking you!"

Hah, she got a rise out of Blondie! Seacat chuckled. "You didn't exclude me, either."

"She didn't have to," Shrimp added, "this is serious. If you don't have anything helpful to add, you're not supposed to interrupt!"

Seacat sighed and rolled her eyes. "I was just joking."

“And this is no joking matter! The Horde will conquer the kingdom if we can’t restore the gate!”

“I know that!” Seacat snarled at the shrimp.

“Just… point it at the barrier, or the runestone, and direct the magic like that?” Brain Boy suggested as he stepped between Seacat and his friends.

Obviously, the princess didn’t mind *him* interrupting. Seacat scoffed and walked over to where Mermista and Sea Hawk were standing.

“She’s going to use her magic sword to repair the gate by hitting it,” she told them.

“I know! Isn’t it impressive?” The captain was always too optimistic.

“I’ll believe it when I see it.” Mermista, of course, was more realistic. “Sea Hawk told me that Adora claims to be a childhood friend of yours.”

Oh that damned… Seacat pressed her lips together. She wouldn’t insult her captain in front of Mermista. Not now, at least. “She also claims that we both are former Horde soldiers,” she said after a moment.

“Why would she lie about that?”

That was a good question, but Seacat didn’t have to answer any question if she didn’t want to. And she very much didn’t want to answer this question.

Fortunately, Blondie finally did something right and distracted the Princess by pointing her sword at the gate and… pushing some light through it? Magic? Seacat felt her fur bristle again and quickly ran her hand over her tail - no need to let everyone know she was a little… impressed. Certainly not worried. Or afraid.

“It’s working. The leaks are closing!” Sea Hawk yelled.

“That’s the least of the gate’s problems,” Mermista replied.

Well, it seemed that Blondie wasn’t just good for beating up monsters, but could also restore ancient magical artifacts to their original power. Well, she couldn’t sail a skiff through a storm!

Brain Boy joined them. “Adora’s at it, but fully repairing the gate will take some time,” he told them. “I hope it won’t take too long, though - even She-Ra gets tired.”

“She can always take a break,” Seacat said, shrugging.

“Ah… that might be problematic,” the boy replied. “She’s kind of stuck.”

“Stuck?” Seacat looked at the blonde again. “What do you mean, ‘stuck’?”

“Uh…” Brain Boy’s smile grew a little forced. “She can’t pull out. The, uh, magic is too strong.”

Seacat took a step back. That was bad. Pretty bad. On the other hand, it was also a little funny. More than a little. To see Blondie - She-Ra - stuck like this, unable to pull out… She chuckled before she reminded herself that this was important. “I hope she slept plenty, then,” she said.

“Oh, yes. Don’t worry about it! As long as no one bothers her, she will be fine.”

That was asking for trouble, in Seacat’s opinion and experience. Just as she was about to point that out to the fool - perhaps with the help of her claws to make a point or three - a bell started ringing.

The bell from the lighthouse.

An enemy fleet had been sighted.

Mermista took off towards the lighthouse, with Sea Hawk in tow. Seacat glanced at Blondie, who was still standing there, pouring or pushing magic or whatever into the gate, then ran after her captain.

She couldn't do anything here, anyway.

"What's the enemy's position and composition?" Mermista barked as soon as a commander of her guard came into view.

"They're approaching from the south and are about half an hour out. Six frigates, half a dozen troop transports," the woman replied, "and one bomb vessel."

Mermista cursed, as did Seacat. A bomb vessel was useless in naval combat, but it could shell fortifications into rubble - or crack the Sea Gate. That was an invasion fleet, not a raiding fleet. "And with most of our fleet escorting the evacuation convoy…"

"Fear not, my love! We will stop them! No matter the cost!" Sea Hawk declared.

"And how?" the princess shot back, apparently unimpressed. "We have one frigate and a sloop available."

"And the Dragon's Daughter III!"

"Which is a fast courier," Mermista pointed out. "Not a warship."

"Every ship is a warship if you know how to use it!"

Seacat groaned. "You're going to set her on fire and ram the enemy, aren't you?"

"Exactly! I might have missed out on a harrowing adventure on the way here, but I shall not shy away from this one!" Sea Hawk put his foot on the nearest railing and pointed to the sky. "The sea is my witness: They shall not pass while I still draw breath!"

The captain was entirely serious, Seacat could tell. As could Mermista - she wasn't scowling any more. In fact, she was smiling at him.

Seacat sighed. "I'll get her ready to sail, then."

Sea Hawk blinked, turning his head away from Mermista - who had probably been about to kiss him - and looked at Seacat. "I think you should better…"

She gave him her best glare. They were a crew! If he actually told her to stay here...

His smile turned a little forced. "...uh, hurry, then."

Satisfied, she nodded, then started running towards her ship. The evacuation of the civilians proved to be quite handy - if she'd had to deal with a terrified mob of people trying to escape…

"Hey! Seacat!" Princess Shrimp appeared in front of her in a shower of sparkly lights.

"No time!" Seacat yelled as she jumped over the girl, landing on all four and continuing to dash like that towards the pier. Getting the Dragon's Daughter III ready to sail - ready for battle - would take some time. Time they didn't have.

"Wait!" Once more, Shrimp appeared in front of her.

"No time!" Seacat took the next corner.

"Wait! What are you doing?"

"Getting ready to fight!" she yelled back as she once more had to dodge the stubborn princess. Wasn't it obvious?

"We can help!"

No, they couldn't. They weren't sailors. They didn't know how to sail a ship into battle. On the other hand, they could fight.

Probably.

“What about Blondie?” Seacat reached the ship and jumped on board, not bothering with the gangplank.

The shrimp appeared on deck, panting even though she hadn’t actually run. “She can’t join us; she tried - she’s stuck there until the Gate is restored.”

“So, she can’t pull out until the Gate’s satisfied?” Seacat’s joke went over the shrimp’s head. It wasn’t really funny, anyway - if they ever needed a bloodthirsty, slightly insane giant warrior with a magic sword on their ship, it would be now. “Who’s watching her?” If the fool was stuck, she was pretty much helpless, after all. And she would be an easy target for Horde scum hiding in the city...

“Uh… drat!” Shrimp disappeared.

Seacat quickly started to set sails. The wind was, fortunately, in their favour - the Horde would have to tack against it to approach them. As she pulled on the line with all her strength, she saw the sloop was also setting sails, but the frigate was lagging behind. Great.

“Here we are! Set sails! Onward!”

The captain had arrived. “I’m already setting sails,” Seacat replied.

“I know, but it was the thing to say!” He flashed her a smile as he scrambled up to the conn.

Seacat shook her head, not bothering to hide her smile, as she tied the line, fixing the mainsail. The captain would never change. And she didn’t want him to. Even if he was about to get her killed alongside himself - the odds of pushing through half a dozen Horde frigates, even with the Salinean vessel helping, were bad. Very bad. And the odds of surviving the battle...

A column of water shot up in the air next to the ship, startling her. What the…? She flinched and dodged to the side as the water arched towards here, then hit the deck, splashing her. What… no, who?

Mermista stood there, trident in hand, smirking at the drenched Seacat.

"You aimed for me!" Seacat yelled.

"I didn't see you," the princess lied with a grin. "Sorry."

Seacat huffed but was smiling herself.

With the princess on board, their odds had just improved. Greatly.

They might actually survive this.

*****

As expected, they were the first out of port. With the wind blowing steadily, Sea Hawk then slowed down to let the others catch up. Well, at least the sloop; the frigate was still setting sails. If that were her ship, Seacat would keelhaul half the crew. Or all of them.

"Raise the Princess's flag!"

"What?" Seacat turned from watching the Salinean ships to stare at her captain.

"We're the flagship; it's only proper that we announce that fact," Sea Hawk replied. "You wouldn't want to enter battle improperly dressed, would you? That's the same for ships."

Seacat hissed in annoyance at the reminder of a particularly embarrassing incident in Crimson Port. "We don't have a flag like that!"

“We do, actually! I commissioned one for exactly such a moment!” he announced with a wide smile.

“For sailing to face an enemy fleet that outnumbers us four to one in a desperate battle to the death?” Mermista asked.

“Well… I was more thinking of a honeymoon cruise, but this also works! Adventure!”

Seacat opened the chest with their spare flags with a kick and started going through them. And yes, there it was: A Salinean flag with a crown. Huffing, she scaled the rigging and raised it on the mainmast.

She slid down a line to land next to the captain and the princess. “This will draw the attention of the entire Horde flotilla.”

“Good!”

She rolled her eyes. As if Sea Hawk would have it any other way. “So, what’s the plan?”

“We’ll go after the bomb vessel,” Sea Hawk said.

“Yes,” Mermista agreed. “The troop transports and escorts don’t matter as long as the Sea Gate stands. The real threat is the bomb vessel. With She-Ra restoring the Sea Gate, we just need to keep the Horde from destroying it before it’s repaired, and that requires taking out that ship.” She pointed at the horizon, where the enemy fleet was rapidly advancing.

Sea Hawk nodded with a smile, and Seacat couldn’t tell if he had come to the same conclusions or if he simply had wanted to hit the enemy flagship. It didn’t matter, anyway - this was a solid plan. Or, as solid as they could get in their position. “So, we just need to evade the six frigates already manoeuvring to cut us off, and then sink a ship about… five times our size?”

“Exactly!”

Well, she'd faced worse odds. While playing cards, mostly. And she had lost most of the time.

Glancing back, she saw that the sloop had caught up, but the frigate was just leaving port. "What a bunch of layabouts!"

"The ship's performance so far is lacking," Mermista agreed. "I'll have to rectify that after the battle."

"First, we have to make it through the battle," Seacat reminded her.

"Naturally." The princess scoffed as if that had been too obvious to mention.

"You're suddenly…" Seacat trailed off, glancing at Sea Hawk. She bit her lower lips. Pointing out that the princess wasn't as gloomy any more, even though they faced death in battle, would only cause problems. Perhaps even sink what small chance they had to survive this.

But, oh, she wanted to rub it in the princess's face. Or not - that would give her more ideas about Sea Hawk.

Scoffing herself, she jumped over the railing, landing lightly on the main deck, and ran towards the bow. They'd soon be in range of the screening frigates, which had formed up in a line now, still headed to intercept them. She ran a quick calculation in her mind. It would be close, but if they timed it right, and if the Horde was unprepared for their actual speed…

"Signal the Salinean Shark to change course and head east, then south!" Sea Hawk yelled.

She quickly grabbed twe flags and started signalling. That would force the enemy to split up their ships. If only the dumb frigate were here. Then the sloop could draw two away, the frigate would keep two more busy, and they would only have to outsail two enemy ships Instead of...

She watched as the flags on the Horde's lead ship changed. She didn't know their code, but it wasn't as if they had too many options. There! The last two ships in the line changed course, tacking as they did so, and were on the way to intercept the sloop.

That left four frigates still bearing down on them. Four to one. Not good odds. Definitely not good odds. The only thing that would give them a chance to pull this off was Mermista's magic.

Seacat was sure the princess would never let them forget it, either.

If they survived.

A loud explosion made her jerk and her tail puff up before she realised what had happened.

The bombardment had begun. She turned and watched the Sea Gate. How long would a shell take to hit it? Oh. That long.

The explosion covered the Sea Gat in smoke, but the steady wind quickly cleared it. And the gate had held!

Seacat's smile vanished as she remembered that Blondie was stuck to the gate. If the gate blew up with her right next to it…

They had to hurry and sink the bomb vessel!

But there were four ships between them and the - now anchored - bomb vessel. Four frigates, every one of them carrying enough cannons to blow the Dragon's Daughter III out of the water if they managed to get close enough.

The Dragon's Daughter III was faster and had the wind at her back, but that wouldn't be enough to break through. Not if the Horde commander was even somewhat competent. The cannons on Horde frigates had a reach of about one mile. Effective range was about half that, but if they put out enough shots, some were bound to hit anyway.

So far, both the Horde ships and the Dragon's Daughter III were headed almost straight towards each other, bow facing bow. That meant only the lead frigate could fire, and only their chase guns - and with the wind directly at their back, Sea Hawk could easily swerve enough to throw off their aim. The Horde flotilla was tacking against the wind, which slowed them down, but they could always turn away and present their broadsides.

The Dragon's Daughter III could outrun them - but they couldn't outrun them and get close to the bomb vessel. Which fired again, making Seacat flinch. That was a huge gun on that damn ship.

They were still closing. Now there were about four miles left between them and the Horde lead ship. She licked her lips as she estimated their speed. A few more minutes, and they would be in range.

She spotted two small flashes at the bow of the Horde ship. They were firing already? Had they improved the range of their guns? Then she saw the splashes, far ahead of them, and grinned. No, just an overeager crew. Or an impatient captain.

Mermista joined her, gripping the railing with one hand. "How competent is the enemy?"

"Hard to say," Seacat replied. "Unless they are trying to bluff us, they aren't the best sailors on the seas." She glanced at the princess. "You wouldn't happen to be able to conjure a huge wave to sweep them away, would you?"

Mermista snorted. "Sure. I'm just waiting to use my power to make it more dramatic."

Seacat had to chuckle herself at the joke. "Pity," she said.

"But I can raise waves powerful enough to reach the decks of the enemy. That should throw off their aim. And some of them overboard."

That would help, but it wouldn't decide the battle. And... "On all four frigates?" Seacat asked. The leading frigate fired again. This time, the shells hit closer to them, but still about a mile short.

Mermista winced. "Not unless I make the wave weaker."

"Great." Seacat clenched her teeth. "You told the captain."

"Yes."

The bomb vessel fired again. Now they were going head to head with the frigates. If the enemy started to turn away from the wind now to present their broadsides, the Dragon's Daughter III would be able to quickly turn the other direction, evading their field of fire - and the Horde leader would block the other ships. And if the enemy turned into the wind… well, that would slow them down so much, they would be able to sail around them.

But the closer they got, the more dangerous it would be to try and evade them. The enemy would be able to close the distance quickly enough to catch them with a broadside, and that would be the end of it. And of them.

"What's his plan?" Seacat asked the princess. He better have a plan!

"We'll fly past them."

"What?" She whipped her head around and almost missed the next salvo from the leading horde ship. This time, they fell short a few dozen yards.

Mermista grinned at her like Sea Hawk used to when he was pulling off a stupid stunt that might get them killed - or become the talk in all the ports.

They were about a mile out, and at their speed, that was shrinking rapidly. Soon, the enemy would turn. And Seacat realised what the captain was planning. "If we survive this, I'm

going to kill him," she spat as she quickly wrapped a line around her arm, tying herself to the ship.

Mermista laughed as she copied her. "Not before I get him!"

Less than three quarters of a mile left. The Dragon's Daughter II was now swerving back and forth rapidly, and the chase guns spoke again. One shell went wide, but the other shell hit the sea so close, a column of water drenched both Seacat and Mermista.

And the enemy was turning away from the wind.

"There they go!" Seacat yelled as the guns of the enemy came into view.

"Hold fast! This will be our finest adventure!" Sea Hawk yelled back.

Seacat held her breath as she saw the full broadsides of four frigates turn their way. They were about six hundred yards away from the leading ship. What was the captain waiting for?

"What's he waiting for?" Mermista echoed her thoughts.

Then the guns started to fire, and Sea Hawk yelled: "NOW!"

Mermista waved her trident, and the Dragon's Daughter III was lifted up, far above the sea, by a huge wave, and propelled forward.

"Yes!" the captain shouted as the first frigate's broadside passed beneath them, the shells harmlessly punching through the wave.

The second frigate fired her own broadside, with the same result. And the third and fourth were rapidly trying to turn away from the wind to bring the flying Dragon's Daughter III into the arcs of their guns - without success.

They were shooting past the bow of the first frigate, so close that Seacat could see the Horde sailors struggling to bring the chase

guns to bear without success. As soon as they cleared the bow, the enemy captain had the other broadside fire - but they were too close and too high for the cannons to get a bead on them, and the magical wave wasn't affected by mere shells.

The second frigate had still been turning away from the wind and was now turning back into the wind to bring her other broadside into play - but they were too slow; the Dragon's Daughter III was opening the distance too quickly for them. And the other two ships were still too far away.

Yes, they had…

"Ugh!" Seacat heard Mermista say.

A moment later, the wave crashed, and with it their ship. They hit the water hard - Seacat could hear wood cracking and splintering even over the roar of water splashing around them - and if not for the lines wrapped around her limbs, she would have been thrown overboard. Even the mainmast seemed to sway far more than it should be able to.

But they were still going fast. Still had the wind at their back. And there was no enemy ship left between them and their target. No warship, at least - even damaged, the Dragon's Daughter III could outsail a troop transport.

Guns fired behind them - the three trailing frigates finally having been able to aim their cannons - but they were too far away. And too slow to catch up.

Seacat untied herself and dove for the hold. If that cracking had been any indication…

She dropped into the hold and cursed. Cracks ran along the hull, centred on the keel. Sooner or later, the keel would break - or the ship would snap in two.

She jumped, grabbed the lid of the hold, and pulled herself out. "She's done for, captain!" she yelled. "Keel's cracking!"

“She’ll hold on for a few more minutes!” the captain yelled back. “Long enough! Set her on fire!”

“What?” Mermista all it shrieked. “Now?”

“Yes, now!” Seacat snapped, running towards the oil barrels. Next to them, a splash showed that the enemy was now firing their chase guns.

It wouldn’t do them any good, though - they were eating up the distance to the bomb vessel. Seacat barely registered that the sloop was fighting two frigates now as she started to splash oil around the hold and deck.

“Where’s the dinghy?” Mermista asked.

“We don’t have one,” Seacat told her.

“What? Where will we be going once all this is on fire?”

“Overboard, of course!” Seacat replied, pouring the last of the oil on the spare sails in the bow. Hadn’t Mermista expected this?

“Sea Hawk failed to mention that part!” the Princess confirmed her suspicion.

“He tends to do that.” Seacat drew her cutlass, the blade glowing as she stuck it into the deck. Flames erupted from the tip at once, rapidly spreading over the oil-soaked deck.

Seacat was already scrambling up to the captain, who was still handling the rudder. “Ship’s set on fire!” she reported, sketching a salute.

“Noted!” he replied, laughing loudly.

With the wind at their back, they didn’t have to deal with smoke reaching them, but between the sails and the smoke, steering the ship would be difficult. Not that that would be a problem - the enemy ship was still anchored and hadn’t set any sails yet.

“First Mate, prepare to abandon ship.”

“Aye aye, Captain!”

They were about four hundred yards out now. Seacat saw the horde soldiers running around in apparent panic. Still no sails going up, but someone must have cut the anchors loose.

It wouldn’t save them, though it meant they had to steer the ship even closer to ensure they’d hit it.

And that would be cutting it a little closely.

Two hundred yards. More creaking and cracking filled the air - did the mainmast just shift?

“Abandon ship! Abandon ship! Adventure!”

Seacat cursed and flung herself over the railing. She hit the water, going under, then swam for the surface. Treading water, she glanced around. Where was… there! Sea Hawk broke the surface, followed by Mermista!

“I was supposed to be the last one to leave the ship!” Sea Hawk complained.

“I wasn’t about to leave you there!” the princess retorted.

“Look!” Seacat shouted, interrupting the argument.

The Dragon’s Daughter III, now fully ablaze, rammed into the bomb vessel. Her bow crumpled, stuck in the enemy’s iron-plated hull. Then the mainmast fell - onto the Horde ship, scattering crew and burning pieces of rigging all over the deck.

“It’s beautiful!” Sea Hawk yelled. “What an adventure! Look at her burning!”

The fire was indeed spreading quickly - very quickly. Half the enemy deck seemed on fire, and the crew was already jumping

overboard, which was… Oh no!

The first explosion ripped the ship's forecastle apart and toppled one mast. Another blew part of the main deck away.

Then the entire ship vanished in a fireball, and everything went dark.

*****

She woke up sopping wet and retching, coughing out water from her lungs. And she was on a deck - she could feel hardwood beneath her.

"Are you alright?"

Some sailor - Salinean; she could tell from the uniform - was staring at her. She nodded and waved him away. She was fine.

"...did my duty! I came as fast as possible, Princess!"

"You arrived when the Salinean Shark was still fighting two enemy frigates! And you ran from the enemy!"

That was the princess chewing out someone. Seacat was very familiar with that tone thanks to Sea Hawk.

Sea Hawk! She gasped, jumping up and almost falling down as she slid over the wet deck until her claws found purchase. Where was the captain? Oh. There he was. Standing next to and slightly behind Mermista as she was snarling at a Salinean captain.

"I had to save you, Princess! That was the only reason I retreated behind the Sea Gate. Besides, the Shark was beyond hope."

And that was Captain Slowpoke. Or Captain Coward.

"It was beyond hope because you couldn't get your ship out of the port in time!"

“Indeed - that was among the sloppiest feats of seamanship I’ve ever seen,” Sea Hawk chimed in.

“But princess! This is a frigate, not a sloop, or a courier ship! Getting ready to sail takes some time!”

“And why weren’t you ready already?”

Seacat chuckled, then coughed some more, spitting out salty seawater. Blergh. So, they were safely behind the Sea Gate, which apparently - she checked; yes, it shone as if new - was restored completely. That meant the invasion had failed.

They had managed to beat a Horde fleet with a fast courier! And a princess and a sloop, but who was counting?

People would hear about this for weeks!

*****

“Catra! There you are! I was so worried!”

Seacat closed her eyes and clenched her teeth in frustration. Blondie. Of course she had to be at the pier to welcome them back! Sighing, Seacat turned to face the girl. “I told you before, my name is… Maelstrom’s mother! What happened to you?”

Blondie looked like she had fought an entire tavern in a brawl - and lost. One eye swollen shut, multiple bruises - and those were just the visible ones - and she was limping. Seacat took a few steps towards the blonde, reaching out to her before she realised what she was doing and stopped, snapping her arm down.

But Blondie was beaming at her. “Oh! I’m fine. Some Horde spies attacked us, but we fought them off. Well, Glimmer and Bow did - I was stuck while I restored the Sea Gate, so I couldn’t defend myself. But I’m fine!”

“Those bloody cowards!” Seacat spat.

“But what about you? You look like…”

“Yes, I look like a drenched cat,” Seacat replied, rolling her eyes.

“No! I mean, yes, you do, but… you look hurt!”

She was hurt, but like hell would she tell Blondie that. “I was a little too close to the enemy flagship when it blew up, and the shockwave hit me.”

“Oh, no!”

“But I’m fine - it doesn’t even hurt anymore.”

“Oh.” Blondie nodded, as if she believed her. Maybe she did. “Sorry about your ship.”

Seacat shrugged. The Dragon’s Daughter III had lasted longer than she had expected. “You get used to it.”

“And you sunk the bomb ship and saved the Sea Gate! And all of us!” Blondie flashed a stupid smile at her. “This was so brave!”

And Blondie was far too close for comfort. If she hugged Seacat’s aching ribs… “I didn’t do it for you!” she snarled at Blondie.

“That’s exactly what Catra would say!”

Seacat clenched her teeth and fought the sudden urge to claw the blonde’s face off.

*****

The Outposts

She was facing her enemy with her staff raised across her body. Ready to strike and ready to parry a strike. Just like the trainer had said. And shown.

And her enemy was doing the same, blue eyes staring at her over bared teeth and under a blonde lock of hair.

She licked her lips in response, flashing her fangs. Stay cool. Cool. Her tail flicked back and forth behind her, but there was nothing she could do about that.

The blonde took a step towards her, staff held ready, still baring her teeth. Threatening her.

She started circling the blonde, her claws scratching the padding on the floor as she sped up. She was faster and quicker on her feet. She just had to wait until her enemy stumbled and then she could…

The blonde attacked! Striking with her staff. Fast!

She parried, and almost got her staff hit out of her hands. And there came another blow! Once more she parried, as she had learned, but she was driven back anyway - and she stumbled! The blonde thrust her staff at her, and she jumped to the side, her top almost getting caught on the tip.

Close. Close! Closer!

She darted forward, her staff sliding over the blonde's, but before she could strike, her enemy twisted her grip, lifted - and her staff went flying.

But she had claws! She ducked under the staff and jumped, headfirst, into the blonde. Both of them fell down, and she started scratching.

Until the trainer pulled her away, holding her at the neck. It hurt, but all her hissing wouldn't make him let go.

"I said staff training, not… biting and scratching like an animal!"

"But you also said anything goes in a fight!" Adora piped up as she rubbed her scratched arm.

She cringed - talking back to a trainer meant getting punished. But the man nodded, even if he growled, then dropped her on the ground. "Again. And this time, staves only!"

Adora's beaming smile turned into a smirk as she gripped her staff again.

"This time I'll beat you, Catra!"

She snorted in return, and then it was on.

At the end of the training, they were covered in bruises - and some scratches for Adora - but they were friends.

*****

Seacat shook her as she woke up. Another stupid dream. Stupid Blondie. Even when she was half a world away, the girl managed to bother Seacat.

She stretched, resisting the urge to dig her claws into her mattress - Mermista didn't like it if her guests left holes in the bedding. Or scratches in the furniture, no matter how fragile they were built. Then she rolled off her bed and went to get dressed. Breakfast waited.

She left her room, still retying her hair into a ponytail, and made her way to the kitchen. She didn't bother knocking on the captain's room - he hadn't slept a single night there since the Battle of Salineas. At the big doors that separated the princess's quarters from the rest of the palace, she stopped and cocked her head, her ears twitching.

She couldn’t hear any yelling or furniture breaking, so Mermista hadn’t lost her temper yet with Sea Hawk. Which was, for a change, a good thing - they were still waiting for the ship the princess had promised them to replace the Dragon’s Daughter III, and while Mermista probably wouldn’t go back on her word, you never knew with princesses.

“The princess is resting,” one of the two guards Seacat had ignored so far told her.

“Just checking.” She grinned in return and went on towards the kitchen. She was hungry, and the kitchen staff, even with half of them not yet having returned after the evacuation, made the best breakfast, ever: lots of fresh roasted fish!

She felt her nostrils flare as she approached the kitchen - yes, that was the heavenly smell of fish covered with the special palace sauce. She licked her lips, then wiped her chin, just in case she might’ve been drooling, and entered. She’d risked her life for the whole kingdom, so she deserved a special breakfast!

The kitchen staff agreed with her - they were smiling at her and even had a plate already ready.

She thanked them - always be polite to those who make your food, as Sea Hawk had taught her - and left again, carrying a plate and a pitcher of some red fruit juice she’d claim was blood if someone bothered her.

Life was good for a hero!

*****

“And this is the Dragon’s Daughter IV!” Sea Hawk said, spreading his arms wide. “A marvel of shipbuilding, the crown achievement of the Salinean Royal Yards!” He stood at the princess’s private pier, staring at the small ship tied up there.

“It’s a refurbished courier ship,” Mermista said in a flat voice. “Originally built in Seaworthy.”

“But rebuilt here!” Sea Hawk wasn’t going to let a small thing like reality dim his enthusiasm, Seacat knew. “A token of your love for me!”

“I couldn’t exactly let you get stranded here, could I? I’d never be rid of you.”

Seacat frowned. The princess was smiling as she spoke, but this sounded as if Mermista was already getting sick of the captain. “It certainly looks fast enough,” Seacat said. “Though it’s a little wider in the beam unless I’m mistaken.” She wasn’t, of course - she had checked the ship last night.

“It is, but it also has a bigger cargo hold!” Sea Hawk confirmed it.

“So, we’re going to make good money shipping cargo,” Seacat said. If the ship was nearly as fast as the late Dragon’s Daughter III but could hold about a fourth more cargo, then that would result in good profit margins. They just needed a few easy runs from Seaworthy to the Kingdom of Snows, for example.

“Not just any cargo, but important cargo! Crucial supplies for the Rebellion!” The captain beamed at her. “Delivered straight to the soldiers fighting the Horde on the frontlines! It’ll be an adventure!”

There went Seacat’s profit margins. “Usually, dangerous deliveries pay extra-well,” she commented, glancing at Mermista.

“Exploiting the fact that my love’s kingdom is at war would be extremely gauche, first mate! Especially after Mermista gave us such an excellent ship as a gift.”

“As a replacement for the ship we sank saving her kingdom,” Seacat corrected him.

“We saved her kingdom together with my dear Mermista!”

“Without my powers, you’d have ended on the bottom of the sea without getting to ram the Horde bomb vessel first,” the princess

commented with a grin. Seacat bared her teeth in a matching grin and was about to enter negotiations when the princess grew serious. “I hate to ask this of you, but almost all Salinean ships are currently busy transporting our evacuated people back to the kingdom - or guarding the transports. And what ships we have available would take too long to supply our forward posts.”

Which would mean they would have to be abandoned - or they’d fall to the Horde. Seacat suppressed a growl. That would be unacceptable. The Horde couldn’t be allowed to advance further into Salineas - or anywhere else. So, as much as it grated, they would have to do this. Afterwards, though, they could return to making money.

“Rest assured, my love, we will fly to supply the Salinean eye!”

“‘Salinean Eye’?” Mermista sounded confused.

“Aren’t your outposts the eyes of your fleet, looking for Horde ships?” Sea Hawk beamed.

“In a manner of speaking, yes. But there’s more than one such post.”

“But that wouldn’t rhyme!”

Seacat sighed. The captain was about to sing. “I’ll check the ship,” she said. “See if there are any issues that need to be corrected before we can sail.” Trying to plug a leak in a hold full with cargo was a nightmare.

“Duty calls, evening falls, out we sail into the squalls…”

Seacat jumped down, grabbing the rigging to slow her fall, as a shanty started behind her. The captain was a great man, but he was a much better sailor than singer.

*****

True to Sea Hawk's shanty, they were leaving port in the evening - to better hide from Horde spies, or so Seacat had been told. It made sense - she was sure that the cowards who had attacked Blondie and her friends hadn't been the only traitors in port. On the other hand, anyone would have noticed the cargo delivered to their new ship, and it wouldn't take a genius to realise where they might be going. Now, whether the Horde had any ships left to try and catch them was another question. The Horde generally weren't the best sailors, to say the least. And the favoured firepower over maneuverability.

"Ah! Adventure! As much as I love my dear Mermista, I cannot resist the call of the sea!" Sea Hawk declared, pointing at the horizon.

Seacat made some noncommittal noise as she scaled the rigging. The basic build of their new ship was the same as that of the Dragon's Daughter III, but there were a few differences. It wouldn't do to miss a line in the middle of a storm - or a battle. And her eyes saw perfectly fine in the dim light of the moons. Perks of being a cat. Like claws and superior balance. Blondie would be half-blind in her place.

She froze for a moment, growling with anger at herself. Blondie was gone. Back to Bright Moon. Far away from the sea. Why was she still thinking of the idiot? She had a task to do! An important task!

*****

"About ship!"

Sea Hawk's command rang out over the deck, and Seacat moved to get ready for the turn into the wind. "Ready!" she yelled.

In response, the ship began to turn into the wind, losing speed as the sail stopped moving her forward and the wind started to push back on the bow. But they were fast enough to complete the turn without having to pull the lines to help the turn along, and soon

the Dragon’s Daughter IV was sailing along the next leg of their course as they tacked towards their first destination.

Seacat checked that the lines were fastened and everything else was in order, then dropped by the cabins, grabbing a bite to eat - dried fish - from the pantry before joining the captain on the afterdeck.

“She’s a beauty, isn’t she?” Sea Hawk exclaimed with a beaming smile.

“Our new ship or the princess?” Seacat asked with a grin.

“I was talking about the ship, although, of course, my dear Mermista is a beauty without equal on all the seas!”

Seacat reached out to hold the steering wheel in place as the captain put one boot on the chest nearby and pointed towards the sky.

“I guess so,” she said. “She runs well enough,” she added - they had put the ship through her paces all morning after a rather quiet night, “but she could be a little faster.”

“You only have to be fast enough to evade dangers and catch your enemies! The closer you shave it, the better the adventure!”

“And the more dangerous,” she replied before swallowing the rest of the dried fish.

“That’s what I said!”

“Just don’t set this ship on fire until we’ve got enough saved up for the next.” Wait! That wouldn’t stop him. “And remember that people - Mermista’s soldiers - depend on us delivering them their supplies.”

He blinked as if he’d forgotten this. Then he nodded. “You’re right! The love of my life would never forgive me, at least not for months, if I let her down!”

She couldn’t resist. “Unless you do it gently,” she mumbled.

“Huh?”

“Nothing.” She bared her teeth in a grin, but he wasn’t deterred.

“Ah!” He beamed at her again. “You shouldn’t be jealous of our relationship! As I’ve told you a hundred times, love will find you, too! One day.”

“Yeah, sure.” She snorted, almost turning it into a scoff. “I don’t need that kind of stress in my life.” Just watching Sea Hawk and Mermista wrecking their relationship every few weeks was enough to know that.

“Ah! Shying away from a challenge, first mate? I wouldn’t have thought you were a scaredy…”

She growled at him in return, making a point of flexing her claws next to his hand on the wheel.

He coughed, holding a fist before his mouth. “Although, seriously, romance is nothing to be afraid of. Romance is the spice of life! The soul of adventure!”

“I’m not afraid,” she hissed. “And I’ve got plenty of adventures.” Especially with Sea Hawk.

“Of course! But there could always be more! More passion! More adventure! More life!”

“More food,” she retorted. It wasn’t her fault that she hadn’t found anyone interesting - interesting and interested - yet. “I’m going to grab some more fish. Do you want any?” He wouldn’t - he didn’t like fish as much as she did - but she always asked.

“I’ll get some hardtack later.”

She made a face at that. “Bleargh.”

“A sailor’s stomach can easily handle hardtack!”

“But a sailor’s tongue shouldn’t!” she shot back before jumping over the railing and landing on the deck below.

Unfortunately, by the time she returned with some hardtack for the captain and more fish for her, Sea Hawk had found a new subject that Seacat hated even more than her love life.

“So!” He nodded at her. “That passenger claimed to know you.”

“She’s stupid. And a princess. And a former Horde soldier!”

“Well, why would she lie about you being a missing friend of hers?”

“Just because she thinks something is true doesn’t make it true!” Not even princesses could do that. “You know how I was found - I wasn’t wearing a Horde uniform. And not even the Horde uses child soldiers, anyway!”

“Oh! Now you admit that you were a child?” He grinned at her.

She snorted in return.”I was young and stupid.” And she had wanted a berth on a ship. His ship. To wait on land, not knowing if he’d return…

“And now you’re old and wise?”

“Just wise,” she shot back.

“Disillusionment isn’t wisdom,” he told her.

“Close enough,” she replied, eating another fish.

He hummed in return and focused on his own ration.

She knew he’d bring it up again - he had that annoying habit of not letting things drop - but not for the next few days. Probably. Longer if they ended up in an adventure.

She snorted again - hell, she was almost looking forward to one!

*****

“I don’t think they’ll need our supplies any more. Or anything else.” Seacat forced herself to sound flippant, almost joking, as they approached the pier. The alternative was hissing and growling with anger. The Salinean outpost had been razed. Half the top of the lookout tower was gone, the ramparts broken. But those could be repaired. The soldiers, though… She couldn’t see anyone, but she could smell a hint of rotting meat. Rotting flesh.

Sea Hawk nodded slowly. “Ahoy!” he suddenly yelled. “The Princess sent us!”

No one moved, though - and the rock upon which the outpost had been built was small enough for the captain’s voice to carry to every corner.

They stopped at the pier - flanked by the reefs that kept larger ships away. “They were informed about our trip,” Seacat said. “Whoever attacked them must have struck after we set out.”

“Two nights ago. Perhaps one,” the captain agreed. “And they didn’t warn Salineas - they must have been surprised. A direct hit from a bomb vessel’s mortar would do that, but...”

She nodded. The whole outpost would’ve been flattened by such a shell. “But if they managed that, why would they still bombard the outpost?” She growled under her breath. The answer was obvious. “Treason. Sabotage.”

“Sabotage the communications, then shell the outpost at your leisure,” Sea Hawk said. “Not much of an adventure.”

“But effective,” she retorted before she jumped over the railing and landed on all fours on the pier. She checked the lines hanging. They were cut. “Someone left in a hurry,” she yelled as she tied up the Dragon’s Daughter IV.

Sea Hawk joined her. “The crew might have fled after they realised their communications had been sabotaged.”

Seacat nodded. It was possible. The outposts couldn’t be held against a determined attack. That was why they had a fast cutter, after all. Smart sailors knew when to cut and run.

But the stench… it was more than a hint now. She clenched her teeth. “Or whoever sabotaged communications took the cutter as well.”

“Let’s check the outpost’s interior.” Sea Hawk drew his sword and started up the stairs leading to the outpost proper.

He wasn’t charging ahead and he wasn’t yelling about adventure. That was a bad sign. She clenched her teeth as she followed him.

By the time they reached the outpost’s gate, she was pinching her nose shut and didn’t need to look at the centre of the courtyard to know what had happened to the crew.

She did it anyway. The attackers had piled up the stripped bodies of the defenders there, forming a large heap.

“Horde scum!” she hissed. They had taken everything! Murdered everyone!

“But why would Horde soldiers take the uniforms and weapons of Salineans?” Sea Hawk asked. “They have ample supplies of the latter, and no use for the former.”

Seacat blinked and almost breathed through her nose - which would have been a very bad experience. “Pirates?” But pirates knew better than to massacre their victims. Especially Salinean sailors. There would be no mercy, nor any way to finagle a pardon after turning privateer against the Horde for a while. And pirates would know that, so why… She gasped. “Horde scum turning pirates?”

“After losing their bomb vessel, the surviving officers might have decided to turn pirate rather than face the consequences of failing.” Sea Hawk looked around. “They had traitors in Salineas. Perhaps they had traitors here as well.”

“Someone must have shown them the way through the reefs,” Seacat agreed. “So... now we’ve got Horde scum roaming the seas as pirates.”

“Not for long, if I have anything to say about it!” Sea Hawk raised his sword. “We shall hunt them down and bring them to justice!”

Just the two of them? Against at least a frigate, probably more than one? Seacat snorted. She should’ve known better than to wish for adventure. But to let Horde scum get away with this?

They’d make them pay. Somehow. Probably involving another burning ship.

*****

Thick smoke was rising from the outpost’s courtyard when they set sails again. They had turned the heap of bodies into a funeral pyre. A burial at sea might’ve been more appropriate, but to lug two dozen bodies around with them? Seacat shuddered at the mere thought of it. The stench would’ve been unbearable. Better to burn them.

“Let’s hope the second outpost hasn’t suffered the same fate,” she said as they passed the last reefs and Sea Hawk changed the course.

“They would’ve had to be in much faster ships than frigates to cover the distance in the time they had,” Sea Hawk said. “Of course, that doesn’t mean they can’t be attacking right now - with the stolen cutter, they might even attempt a coup de main.”

Seacat scoffed and bared her fangs. “Then let’s find out just how fast our new ship can go!”

“Indeed! Adventure!”

*****

The second outpost was two days worth of sailing from the first with average winds and an average ship. Or a ship with a crew who had to grow familiar with her. But with a fast ship and a great crew taking all reasonable risk? One day was doable - barely.

Seacat grinned when the outpost’s top appeared on the horizon, the Salinean flag flying above it. Then she licked the back of her hand - which tasted salty - and rubbed it against her cheek. She hated it when saltwater dried on her fur, but there hadn’t been time to groom herself properly. And she would’ve ended up being drenched twice more, anyway.

“Huzzah! We are on time!” Sea Hawk cheered. “What an adventure! We’ve got the fastest ship on the sea!”

“And the craziest captain!” Seacat yelled back as she collapsed the telescope.

“I didn’t hear you protesting on the way here!”

She snorted. “Would you have listened?”

“Listened? Yes. Followed your advice? No!”

She snorted again and scaled the rigging. Time to get a closer look from up top. She grabbed on the mast with one hand, pulled the telescope out of her belt with the other and snapped it open one-handedly with a practised motion.

There was the outpost. She could see soldiers on the ramparts, and… two cutters in the sea? One at the pier, and another approaching.

She couldn’t see the people on the deck of the second cutter, but she was sure that this was the one the Horde-pirates had taken.

Sliding down the line, she landed gracefully on the deck. “Captain! The Horde scum’s about to storm the outpost!”

And they were still about half an hour away unless the wind turned. And yet… “I’ll signal them!” she shouted. She rushed to the chest with the signal flags, kicked it open and grabbed them. A moment later, she was rushing up the rigging again, flags held in her mouth. Now the idiots in the outpost better be having their eyes on them!

She wrapped her leg around a line, dug the claws of one foot into the mast - it could do with some scratches, anyway - and leaned out, waving the flags to signal ‘danger’ and ‘trap’.

She kept repeating the signals, squinting as she tried to see if there was a reaction from the outpost. Was that a soldier running? The second cutter was almost at the pier! What were those idiots doing?

Right before the cutter reached the pier, the cannons on the outpost fired. She dropped the flags and grabbed the telescope again.

The soldiers had reacted too late, despite Seacat’s best effort - the horde scum was already on the pier. She saw two soldiers running up the ramp leading to the outpost’s gate, but both fell before they reached the halfway point.

The cannons on the rampart spoke again, and she saw the cutter’s mast fall. But it was too late - there were dozens of the scum already on the pier. Why hadn’t they used cannister shot? That could’ve swept the pier clear!

And now the horde rushed forward, storming the ramp. Seacat held her breath. If the Salineans were quick enough to reload, they could out a shell right into the horde… but they weren’t. The pirates reached the wall, where the cannons couldn’t fire.

Seacat cursed. “They are at the walls,” she yelled to the captain. “The idiots didn’t manage to stop them!”

“Then it falls to us to save them!”

“Without setting us on fire!” she shouted.

“No promises!”

Seacat cursed again. She had liked their new ship.

“Find us a route through the reefs!”

“Aye aye, Captain!”

She grabbed the telescope again. She had seen the route - part of it - that the cutter had taken. But the entrance… Her fangs dug into her lower lip as she studied the rocks jutting up from the sea ahead of them. The real danger were the ones that didn’t break the surface, of course. The ones that were just deep enough to escape notice, but high enough to rip open the hull of any ship that sailed over them.

This or that passage? Was that a shadow, or a reef in the middle? She squinted. That was… a reef. Which meant it was the other. “Starboard!” she yelled.

“Starboard!” Sea Hawk confirmed. “Huzzah!”

They entered the reefs, and Seacat climbed on the very top of the mast, to get the best angle possible to guide them as Sea Hawk slowed down - a little, at least. There was another reef lurking beneath the surface. “Port!”

“Port!”

The ship turned, in time.

“Starboard!”

“Starboard!”

“Port!”

“Port”

Turn by turn, they sailed through the reef.

Until they suddenly had a clear path to the pier. And the pirate cutter there. The ship’s mainmast had fallen, but part of the rigging had kept it from ending up in the sea. Still, that cutter wouldn’t sail anytime soon. The other cutter, though, the one stationed at this outpost, looked whole - and there were people on it. Enemies! Seacat counted half a dozen Horde soldiers.

And two to three dozens assaulting the walls of the outpost, but who was counting? “Let’s board them!”

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk replied, and the Dragon’s Daughter IV turned, barely avoiding the first cutter, before it scraped alongside the second, bumping into the other ship with enough force to send half the Horde scum stumbling.

But not her. Seacat had grabbed a line a moment before the ships touched and was already swinging over to the cutter. She drew her cutlass with her free hand, slashing with the glowing blade as she flew past one of the pirates still standing.

The man went down, screaming, hands gripping a ruined face, and Seacat let the rope carry her onward. Another horde soldier stepped into her path, and she let go, slamming into the merman with her feet, digging her claws into his protruding belly, leaving long gashes when she jumped off.

He screamed, dropping his weapons to keep his guts in, and Seacat howled, landing on the still moving deck with one hand and both feet down, claws scratching the wood as she slid to a stop and swung her blade with the other hand.

The remaining four of the scum turned to face her, wielding stun batons and knives, and she laughed in their faces. The biggest of them, a lizardman, hissed and charged her while the rest spread out, trying to encircle her.

Pathetic. She met the lizard blade to blade, then let herself fall down on her back when he swung the baton, kicking out with her feet before raking her claws over the horde scum's legs.

He screamed but didn't fall, stabbing at her in a frenzy with both blade and baton. She rolled to the side, evading the first attacks, then back, dodging the second, before she deflected the blade with her cutlass and cut the baton off with the backhand stroke.

A roll over her shoulder saw her back on her feet, and the lizard swung again. She forced his blade down, then jumped, lashing out with one leg after the other, kicking him in the chest and face.

He stumbled back, reeling, his head thrown back, and Seacat lunged, whirled and slashed his throat with her blade, almost decapitating him.

"Finally done? You've been getting slow!"

She growled at Sea Hawk, who had jumped on the deck as well and was standing over the bodies of the other tree enemies. "He was their leader!"

"Just because he was the biggest doesn't make him their leader."

"I also got two on the way in!"

"Then we're even!"

She snorted and looked around. The pirates attacking the outpost had noticed them by now, and a dozen of them were rushing towards them. Bad odds without surprise.

"Another challenge! Adventure!"

Not for Sea Hawk, of course.

But she wasn't looking forward to fighting outnumbered six to one. Not without an advantage, preferably an unfair one. "We need to secure the cutter!" she yelled.

“Not quite!” Sea Hawk shouted back. He was running towards the cannon in the bow. But he wouldn’t get it loaded and aimed in time, even with her helping!

She rushed towards him anyway, but he waved her off. “Get our ship clear!”

She gasped - he was crazy! - but obeyed, dashing towards the railing, then jumping off, throwing herself towards the Dragon’s Daughter IV, which had started to drift away.

She missed the deck and railing, but her claws found purchase in the hull, and she quickly scrambled up on deck, then rushed to the wheel. The wind hadn’t changed, so she threw the ship into a turn towards the wind, slowly starting to gather speed as the bow swung around.

Then she glanced back. The pirates had almost reached the cutter. What was Sea Hawk doing? “Captain!” she yelled, then held her breath. The first pirate jumped on the cutter’s deck, and…

There went Sea Hawk, jumping on the railing, grabbing the rigging and swinging his sword - and cutting through the rigging.

The mast swayed at once, and the rigging ripped, pulling him up as if he had been fired from a cannon. He flew in an arc, narrowly missing the cutter’s falling spar, before splashing into the water.

Seacat released her breath.

But the pirates rushed to the railing, one of them climbing on the bow, peering at the water, eager to shoot at the captain as soon as he surfaced

And the cutter’s powder store blew up, the ship’s entire bow section vanishing in an explosion.

For a terrible moment, Seacat saw the bomb vessel blowing up. The explosion travelling underwater, killing all the Horde sailors in

the water and almost killing her despite the distance.

But this wasn't a bomb vessel's powder magazine going up, well below the waterline. This was a powder storage chest for a cutter's pivot gun blowing up on the deck. Granted, a big one - the navy rarely skimped on ammunition - but even so, it shouldn't have… The captain had been thrown almost clear - at least away from the bow…

She clenched her teeth. Sea Hawk couldn't be…

"Huzzah!"

Her eyes darted to the side. There was a head visible in the sea, an arm waving… She sighed with relief, sagging for a moment, then growled and yelled: "You idiot cut it too close!"

"The only good call is a close call!"

She glanced back at the pier as she turned the ship into the wind so Sea Hawk could catch up. There were no pirates on it. No, she couldn't see any pirates, she corrected herself. But there were about a dozen or more pirates still left at the outpost's gates. Caught between the Dragon's Daughter IV and the outpost's walls. Or, rather, caught between the walls and the rocky shore, with a damaged cutter their only way to escape.

"Ooof!" Sea Hawk pulled himself over the railing, groaning.

She dug a fang into her lower lip. So he had been hurt by the explosion. "That was too close," she told him as she helped him up.

"But it was a beautiful explosion!"

"You didn't even see it."

"I felt it!"

That made her growl again as she shook her head. “Stick to setting ships on fire.”

He laughed at that, then turned to point at the outpost. “A dozen more notches for our belts!” he exclaimed, tapping his buckle.

She didn’t miss how his hand strayed upwards, rubbing his belly, afterwards. “I think the garrison can handle them.” If they didn’t, then Mermista needed to deal with whoever set up those outposts.

“Perhaps. But we still are needed to keep the pirates from escaping!”

“We need to treat your wounds,” she spat. Explosions could damage the inside of your body. Sea Hawk could be bleeding out inside, or something - the Healers at Salineas had been concerned about that, after the last battle. “And that cutter won’t be sailing anywhere with a broken mainmast!”

“I’m good for another harrowing battle against impossible odds!” He pointed at the outpost. “And look! They’re retreating - they’re coming straight at us!”

“We don’t need to fight them. We can set the cutter on fire and trap them on the island,” Seacat pointed out. Or set the cutter on fire with the pirates on it.

“Or we could blow the cutter up. In a big beautiful explosion!”

Fortunately, the garrison finally developed a spine and sallied, a dozen soldiers chasing the pirates down to the pier. By the time the Dragon’s Daughter IV had turned away from the wind and was sailing towards the cutter, half the pirates had been overtaken and killed, and the other half was battling the soldiers on the damaged cutter.

And the captain was in the rigging, brandishing his sword. “Get us closer! I want to rush them from behind!”

“You just want to beat my score!” she yelled as she brought their ship closer.

“I already beat it with my explosion!”

She blinked, then scoffed. “That doesn’t count!”

They reached the cutter, bumping against it, and Sea Hawk jumped on the other deck before the ships separated again. Seacat saw him cut down the last pirate standing, then face the soldiers with a flourish.

“I’m the one and only Sea Hawk!” she heard him yell. “Feel free to thank me for the timely rescue!”

The officer leading the ragged troop looked as if she had bitten into a rotting lemon.

Seacat was still chuckling at the sight as she guided the ship to a gentle stop near the pier - close enough to use it as an anchor.

*****

The officer commanding the soldiers wasn’t really grateful, Seacat found out quickly. It was clear that she had to force herself to be polite to them. Granted, they had blown up her cutter, but that had been necessary. And they had another cutter anyway, only slightly damaged.

Seacat waited to point out that, of course. As long as the woman was busy ordering the soldiers around she was already stressed enough. Though Seacat did need answers to a few questions. “Did you find out where the rest of the pirates are hiding?”

“We haven’t even started questioning the survivors!”

“I meant, did they say anything? Offered you a deal? Named their patron?

“No, they didn’t. They just attacked - if not for your warning, we might’ve lost half our troops before we realised what was going on.”

Seacat grinned widely. “So, I saved the entire outpost?”

The woman froze for a moment. Then she pressed her lips together in a frown. “We could have held out until relief forces arrived.”

“Sure.” Seacat flashed her fangs. “You had them right where you wanted them. After we killed half of them for you. And sunk their ship.”

“That was my cutter!”

“Not any longer - they had taken it,” Sea Hawk cut in. “According to the law of the sea, that means it was an enemy ship and a legitimate target for us.”

“And we didn’t even blow it up completely - half the ship you could probably raise and repair,” Seacat added. She looked round. “Well, if you had wood to repair them.” The rock didn’t look like it would grow trees anytime soon.

The officer - what was her name again? Seacat hadn’t really paid attention - looked even more annoyed now.

“The Salinean Navy thanks you for your assistance.”

“Anything for my dear Mermista!” Sea Hawk beamed. “Now we just need to find the pirate frigate.”

“Pirate frigate?”

Seacat sighed. “The pirates are former Horde scum. And they stole the cutter from the other outpost in the area. That means they must have had a ship to reach the outpost before stealing this one. And the last Horde ships we saw in the area were

frigates.” And troop transports, but those wouldn’t make plausible pirate ships.

“A frigate.”

“Possibly more - we didn’t sink them. Oh, by the way, could you send a few men to unload the supplies for the outpost?” Sea Hawk asked.

“You’ve brought supplies?” She wasn’t the smartest officer, in Seacat’s opinion.

“We did indeed! We braved pirates and monsters and Horde patrols to supply you!” Sea Hawk raised his fist to the sky again. “And we let no one stop us!”

“I’ll send a crew to unload the ship.”

“Thank you, my dear!”

“And please share everything that the prisoners say,” Seacat added.

*****

A few hours later, the officer’s attitude still hadn’t improved - apparently, she was the commander of the outpost which explained a lot, in Seacat’s opinion. But the hold of the Dragon’s Daughter IV was empty and they knew the name of the Horde captain who had taken her ship and turned pirate rather than returning to the Fright Zone and answer for her failure.

Octavia.

It was a dumb name, in Seacat’s opinion.

*****

The Serpent's Maw

"Hey, furball!"

She turned, her eyes narrowing. Furball. She hated that word. When she saw who had yelled, she hissed.

It was a Horde soldier - an adult, not a cadet. Some fishwoman with tentacles on her back. And a frown on her noseless face. "My name's not furball!" she hissed.

"Who cares. You're a furball."

"And you're a dumb face!" she spat.

"What did you say, you ugly little piece of…"

The fishwoman stomped towards her, but she wasn't scared. She knew she was faster than anyone else in this place. "I said you're a dumb face!" she repeated herself. "You don't have a nose and no ears?"

"Oh, you!" The fishwoman lunged, webbed hands reaching for her, but she was already dodging, dropping to the floor and rolling against the woman's knees. As dumb face stumbled, she jumped up, grabbed the flailing arm and pulled herself up like in the training hall. "Dumb face!" she snarled, lashing out with her claws at the woman's face.

She grinned when she heard the screams. Call her furball, would she? With her hands clutching her bleeding face and one eye covered, the dumb face couldn't do any…

She was flying through the air. Something had hit her.

She crashed against the wall, her breath knocked out of her, and fell to the ground. She'd been hit, but what could've… Blinking, she saw the tentacles flailing around the stumbling woman. Oh. That had.

Blinking, she tried to clear her head when the fishwoman suddenly glared at her, showing razor sharp teeth. "I'm going to kill you, furball!"

She gasped, which made her ribs hurt, and jumped to her feet, which made everything else hurt, and scrambled away on all fours. This time, she avoided all the tentacles and the woman's legs, and she was up the stairs, heading for the vents, before the dumb face could recover.

*****

Seacat woke up in the middle of… well, morning. What a weird dream. She tried to recall what she had dreamt, but she only remembered tentacles and some monster. Probably the fault of Sea Hawk singing weird shanties about Kraken and mermaids again.

And speaking of faults… She rolled out of her hammock and checked up on the captain. She found him sleeping in his bunk. No fever, no clammy skin, no paleness. She sniffed the air. Probably a little too much rum.

Well, if he had a headache today, it was no fur off her butt. It was a beautiful day, no cloud in the sky, a calm sea and a steady wind blowing on their back. Perfect for sailing - or hunting.

Perfect for leaving this dump of a rock. Or something. Looking at the outpost above the pier, then at the cutter, where the mainmast still hadn't been fixed, she scoffed. No wonder the outpost had almost been taken by three dozen pirates - the garrison must be the dregs of the service, as the captain would call it. Had called it, actually, after the third glass of rum.

Well, if the sailors didn't get their act together, then that was their problem. Sea Hawk and Seacat had saved them once, which should be enough. She grabbed some dried fish for breakfast, mixed milk powder with water to wash it down, then started preparing the Dragon's Daughter IV to set sail.

The captain appeared on deck sometime around noon, groaning and rubbing his stomach. For a moment, she was concerned, but then he shook his head. “I think that fish was bad.”

She narrowed her eyes at him. “It wasn’t!” She’d had four of them!

“Well, perhaps mine was bad.” He grabbed some hardtack and jerky for himself - neither of them would have wanted to dip into the outpost’s supplies, not after checking the cargo - and started munching while he walked towards her. “Everything set?”

“Except for you, everything’s shipshape,” she replied.

“Hey!” He glared at her for a moment before laughing. “Sailors giving you trouble?”

“Haven’t seen them today at all, other than from afar,” she replied, nodding towards the ramparts. “Probably too scared to come out from behind the walls.”

Both had a laugh at that. “My dear Mermista won’t be happy about our evaluation of this garrison’s performance.”

And neither would be the garrison commander, Seacat thought. “So… we’re returning to Salineas, then?” They hadn’t received a new mission, after all, nor new cargo.

“Not quite!” Sea Hawk grinned at her. “How could we face ourselves if we left while some pirate frigate roamed the seas?”

Quite easily - it wasn’t as if Seacat needed a mirror. “You want to take on a Horde frigate with her?” she asked, making a sweeping motion with her hand.

“I prefer to think of it as looking for an adventure! All we need is the right opportunity, and even a frigate won’t stand a chance!”

“You really don’t like the number four, do you?” she asked, shaking her head.

He blinked. “Well, three is the better number, you know, but four can be nice.”

She rolled her eyes. “You know what I mean,” she scolded him.

“Yes, but do you know what I mean?” He grinned at her.

“I don’t want to know,” she replied with a toothy smile. “But I’ll ask Mermista about it.”

“Ah… I mean… perhaps we should focus on our mission!” Sea Hawk smiled weakly and went towards the wheel.

Seacat smiled. Eight times out of ten, if she didn’t understand one of the captain’s joke, threatening to ask Mermista shut him up.

*****

As they sailed past the cutter, Seacat took the time to wave at the handful of Salinean sailors working on the broken mainmast before she scaled the rigging, once again taking up a lookout position on top of the mast. She had to focus on the reefs guarding the outpost. Fortunately, she was an old hand at that - and her sharp eyes were perfect for this duty.

Half an hour later, they were on the open seas, quickly picking up speed after setting full sails. She tied up the last line, then climbed up the stairs to the conn. “Everything’s set,” she reported.

“Good.” Sea Hawk adjusted their course a tiny little bit towards the wind, almost past the point where the sail would start to slacken.

“So… how long are we going to roam the sea, looking for a pirate frigate?” she asked as she leaned against the railing, her hands resting on her hip and the hilt of her cutlass.

He grinned at her. “Oh, I was thinking of about a week.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes as she made a quick calculation. They could cover quite a lot in a week, but blindly roaming the seas wasn't Sea Hawk's style - or hers. So… Ah! "Serpent's Maw?"

He nodded with a smile. "Exactly! Where else would a Horde turned pirate go? They cannot use Horde ports, and with Salineas standing proud, they cannot reach the northern coast.

Seacat nodded. The ports of the northern coast were closed to pirates, but there were always some smaller villages where pirates could do trade. It wasn't as if a fishing village had much of a choice, anyway - if they didn't trade, the pirates would just plunder. But south of Salineas, the Horde controlled the coast - and a village caught trading with pirates would be wiped out. Like Gullpeak had been...

She shook her head. "There's a little problem with your plan, though."

"Oh?" He looked at her with exaggerated surprise.

"We're kind of wanted in Serpent's Maw." Setting their port ablaze tended to make people mad at you.

"Oh, the one and only Sea Hawk and his trusty first mate certainly would be crazy to even consider sailing into a pirate haven like Serpent's Maw. However, no one is mad at a mysterious and handsome pirate and his trusty first mate!" Hit bumped his chest with a fist. "It's a perfect plan! A daring adventure!"

She blinked. "There's a flaw in that plan as well."

"How so?"

She pointed at herself with her thumb. "I'm a little distinctive. There aren't many sailors who share my looks."

"Ah, but that's nothing a good disguise cannot handle!"

“I hope you don’t think that a hooded cloak will do,” she retorted with narrowed eyes.

“Err… of course not! Perish the thought! I have something much more sophisticated in mind!”

“Really.” She kept glaring at him, but he didn’t waver.

“Really!”

Seacat sighed. It would be a hooded cloak. She knew it already.

*****

Three days later - the winds had been favourable - they were approaching Serpent’s Maw. Seacat pressed her lips together as she looked round the ship. They had changed the sails, even painted a garish skull on the mainsail with some leftover paint in the hold, but… “I don’t think this will fool anyone who saw us in Salineas,” she said.

“Oh, but the Horde spies in Salineas wouldn’t have been able to reach this pirate haven even if they had set sails the same night we left the port. So, don’t worry, our disguise is foolproof. Remember: No one will expect the famous Sea Hawk to sail a ship with such an ugly figurehead!”

She glared at him. She was no carver, but she had done her best. It wasn’t her fault that claws that could easily cut steel didn’t make her a master carver. “Time to put on our disguises, then,” she said.

“Oh, yes!” He beamed. “This will be fun! Exciting! A tale to tell our friends and enemies!”

“Yeah, yeah, yeah…” she sighed as she went below decks to change. It would be hot. Unbearably hot. At least for her.

She stared at the disguise hanging on a hook next to her hammock. In hindsight, a simple hooded cloak would have been

better. But that would mean admitting that Sea Hawk's first half-baked plan was good. And that she had been wrong to criticise it.

And she could bear the heat for one day - it would be cooler in the evening, anyway. Still...

"Why do we actually have a full-body leather suit on board?" she complained as she returned to the main deck, fiddling with the many ties and clasps that lined its front. Handling those was almost as much a pain as wrapping her tail around her waist and stuffing her feet into boots.

"Ah." Sea Hawk, who had taken the time to change into black leather pants, black shirt, bandana and a black cloak, actually blushed. "That was supposed to be a gift for Mermista, but there never seemed to be the right opportunity to give it to her."

She closed her eyes. She shouldn't have asked.

"But it's perfect for hiding your fur, and, ah, everything else!"

"Let's just get this over with," she hissed through clenched teeth.

"Right! But not before we add the crowning touches!"

"'Crowning touches'?" Seacat knew that the captain was spending too much time with princesses.

"Our faces are quite distinctive. Who else has a naturally shiny moustache?" He cocked his head at her, and she growled back. She had fur, not a moustache! "So, I'll be wearing a dashing but not quite as handsome full beard, and you…"

She recoiled from the black face mask he presented to her, baring her fangs, then blinked. Why had she done that?

He frowned at her. "It's made from light wood. You'll hardly feel the weight."

He was correct, of course. And it made a lot of sense - the mask would hide her face, only leaving the eyes exposed. And while her mismatched eyes were distinctive as well, not too many knew about them. Still, why did the thought of wearing the mask make her feel so disgusted? And angry? It made no sense! But she wouldn't let some stupid feelings stop her. So she shook her head and grabbed the mask. "Alright."

"And the bandana, to hide your ears!"

She growled again. That wouldn't be comfortable at all - she had tried that before. And the heat would be murder. And with the mask, she wouldn't be able to easily drink.

But it would be a cold day in hell before she'd let Sea Hawk alone in a pirate port. Not again. "Alright," she snarled.

The things she did for the captain!

*****

"Remember: We're the Red Beard and his right hand, the Black Death!" Sea Hawk said as they entered the port.

"Yeah, yeah." Rookie pirates with a stupid name - they would fit right in with the scum here. "Why did you pick a red beard, anyway?"

"It's supposed to be blood red," he replied. "You know, menacing in that gauche pirate-y way. And it was easy to paint on our flag!"

That made her snort, which in turn made him smile.

Then they had to focus on the next turn as they turned towards a free berth among the ships in the harbour. About half a dozen pirate ships, and a few merchantmen. She tried to identify them - Mermista would love to know who was trading with pirates here.

Seacat couldn't spot a Horde frigate, but that didn't have to mean anything - the pirate crew wouldn't sail their ship into the

Serpent's Maw without feeling out the port beforehand; the Horde had a reputation for brutally dealing with pirates, after all, and if the pirates thought they were under attack, they would fight. Well, those who couldn't run from a frigate. But at least one of the merchantmen had a damaged rigging and hull - not a greedy scumbag, then, but a victim of pirates. Perhaps the Horde's?

A bunch of dockworkers were already gathering at the berth they were steering to. Armed dockworkers. Seacat grinned behind her mask. If they planned to board them, they were welcome to try - cutting down pirates was almost as satisfying as cutting down Horde scum.

But the captain was already yelling: "Ahoy! 'Tis the Red Beard! Most dangerous pirate captain on all the seas!"

"Never heard of you!" one of the workers, a lanky goat woman, yelled back.

"Really? I shall have to rectify that! I and my trusty first mate, Black Death, have made our way here through hordes of Horde frigates, to prey upon the fat merchantmen of the northern coast!"

"You mean you'll end up dangling from a Salinean spar, dancing the noose dance!" the woman yelled back. "Do you have cargo to unload?"

"Not yet!" the captain announced as they drew alongside the pier. "We're here for supplies, first. A prepared pirate is a successful pirate!"

Seacat didn't like the laughter that followed his comment. Her snarl hidden by her stupid mask, she jumped over the railing and landed on the pier. And almost stumbled - with her tail wrapped around her waist and trapped there by the stupid suit, she wasn't as balanced as she should be. Still, she made enough of an impression even landing on both feet - in stupid boots - and one

gloved hand to send the workers back a step or two. “You think you’re funny?” she growled.

Most shrank away - if they were pirates, then they were smart ones. Or cowardly ones. The goat woman, though, stood her ground. “Wrapped in leather as if you were sailing the Frost Sea? Here in Serpent’s Maw? *That* is funny!”

When the idiot turned to call the others of her group, Seacat moved. She closed the distance in the blink of an eye, the glowing blade of her cutlass singeing the fur on the goat woman’s throat.

“Don’t kill her!” the captain yelled. “We’re here to resupply, not to sate your bloodlust!”

No one would miss pirate scum - not that Seacat actually was bloodthirsty; she simply didn’t hold back when fighting the kind of people who needed killing, and this was an act anyway. So she took a step back, not taking her eyes off the group, as she sheathed her blade. “You’re in luck,” she growled. “Next time, I’ll cut your throat.”

The goat woman swallowed, rubbing her neck. “You’re mad!”

“That’s what I keep telling her!” Sea Hawk butted in. “Makes most port visits exciting, but you should see her in a fight!”

Even though Sea Hawk was merely acting as a pirate would, Seacat liked hearing such praise.

And she liked seeing the goat woman retreat at a pace just shy of actually running.

This hare-brained mission was starting out better than she had expected. But even now that the sun had set, it was still far too hot in the tight leathers, and Seacat had to struggle with the urge to lift the mask to feel cooler air on her face, at least. But that would be stupid. “Captain?”

“Onward, first mate! Onward to… the tavern!”

Where she wouldn't be able to drink and where the air would be hotter than outside and filled with smoke and the stench of unwashed pirates. Sometimes, having a better nose than the captain - or most anyone else she had ever met - wasn't a good thing.

They walked towards the waterfront, a pair of drunk pirates staggering out of their way after a glare from Seacat, and soon were faced with a row of taverns and brothels. "They're not even trying to be discreet," she muttered.

"It's a pirate port, my dear first mate! This is what pirates come for - this, and the opportunity to sell their loot and stock up on supplies!"

Which was their cover as well. "Let's go," she muttered. "The sooner we find them, the sooner I can get out of this."

They entered the first tavern, Sea Hawk heading straight to the bar while Seacat looked round. Lots of lowlives, but she didn't see many wearing parts of Horde uniforms. Fresh deserters wouldn't have many spare clothes, would they? She also didn't see anyone who knew Sea Hawk or had a grudge against him - which usually went with each other, at least among pirates - either.

At the bar, Sea Hawk was already drinking beer and telling stories. "And then, we crossed her bow - you know how slow those frigates turn - and were past the reef before she could come about again, her cannons unable to reach us!"

The bartender, some burly fishman without a nose, nodded with polite but fake interest, but the three pirates nearby openly scoffed. "What a load of seal piss!" the largest told Sea Hawk. "You don't outrun Horde frigates so easily!"

"Perhaps you don't!" Sea Hawk shot back with a laugh. "But the Red Beard? Greatest pirate of all the seas? Outwitting and outsailing Horde scum is child's play!"

The pirate sneered in response. "No one's ever heard of you!"

“You just did, didn’t you? Hah!”

Seacat rolled her eyes behind her mask as she reached the bar behind the captain. He was overdoing it. Again.

But the pirate facing the captain was now staring at her. Had he missed them entering together? That would make him even stupider than he looked.

“And who’re you supposed to be? ‘Black Leather’? ‘Black Mask’? ‘Leatherface’?”

“This, my dear fellow, is Black Death, my first mate!” Sea Hawk announced. “Please do not annoy her - I’d like to finish my beer without blood splattering all over the bar.”

Seacat wanted a beer as well, but that wasn’t in the cards for now. So she shifted her stance a little, hand on the hilt of her cutlass. Perhaps the idiot would get the message.

He didn’t. The pirate scoffed, glancing over his shoulder as he talked to his mates. “Friends! Are we going to let a pair of idiots talk to us like this?”

“You just did, didn’t you?” Sea Hawk laughed loudly.

Not for the first time, Seacat was impressed by how quickly the captain made enemies. Of course, she had been expecting that, and by the time the pirate started to draw his sabre, she was already moving. Her foot hit his groin with enough force to drive her claws into the reinforced leather of her stupid boot, and the idiot fell to his knees with a stunned whimper.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk lunged past her, his sword piercing the closest pirate’s thigh. That man shrieked as he fell down, gripping his bleeding leg.

Seacat, meanwhile, kicked the kneeling idiot into the head and sent him into the path of two of his friends. All three went down in a heap, and he wasted no time kicking the other two in the

head as well. It was obvious, after all, that they weren't using them.

Whirling, she brandished her blade, looking for the next opponent, but the rest of the tavern's patrons were laughing and jeering, not looking for a fight.

A pity - but they had half a dozen more taverns to visit. She grabbed the untouched beer of the first pirate and started for the door. The shadows of the side alley next to this dive should allow her to drink it without anyone seeing her face.

Seacat certainly needed a drink if she had to stomach more of those lowlives. She could only hope that they'd find the Horde scum quickly.

*****

Three taverns and two more barfights later, they finally got lucky. Seacat saw a largish group - about a dozen - sitting in a corner, and all of them were wearing at least one piece of the Horde naval uniform. More telling, though, the apparent leader, a large fishwoman, matched the description that the captured pirates had given: Eyepatch, tentacles on the back, and a surly attitude even when she was drinking.

Seacat grinned as she followed Sea Hawk to the bar. "Saw them?" she whispered as she leaned against the bartop next to him.

"Of course!" Sea Hawk stage-whispered back. "And there's a table free next to them!"

While the captain ordered two beers, Seacat studied the room. There was a sort of tension present. The table next to the Horde pirates was the only one free, and the way the rest of the patrons kept eyeing the new guests… She smiled. The Horde scum wasn't welcome here, not even among pirate scum.

Even scum had standards.

“Come on, first mate!” Sea Hawk lifted two tankards with one hand. “To our table!”

They hadn’t even reached the table yet when they drew the attention of the Horde. A burly human wearing the ripped remains of a Horde jacket as a vest rose from his seat. “This table is taken!” he told them.

Sea Hawk stopped and stared at the pirate. “Are you blind? It’s empty. Well, now it’s taken since I’ve staked my claim on it! The Red Beard’s claim!”

“We’ve got more crew coming. Get lost!” the pirate snapped as he walked towards them. Behind him, the others laughed - but a few were pushing their chairs back and gripping weapons.

“They can take it up with us, then!” Sea Hawk said, baring his teeth at the man. “Red Beard and his trusty first mate, Black Death! We’ve been outsailing and outfighting Horde scum for years!”

“What?” The man took another step towards them, hand on his weapon now.

Seacat noticed that the other pirates nearby, who had been watching with interest, probably hoping for a fight, had fallen silent. And the Horde pirates at the table had lost all humour.

The captain, of course, ignored everything. “I said we’ve been outsailing and outfighting Horde scum for years, so we aren’t to be intimidated by the threat of more of you.”

“Did you just call us Horde scum?” That had been their leader. Octavia. Her dumb face matched her dumb name.

“Why, yes, I did, didn’t I?” Sea Hawk snorted. “After all, either you are so fond of the Horde, you decided to raid their laundry and steal their uniforms, or you are Horde soldiers.”

That sent whispers and mutters through the room as everyone was now watching.

The fishwoman stood, slowly walking over to them. “We’re not Horde. Were pirates. Like you.”

“Not like us,” Sea Hawk said at once. “For I am the one and only Red Beard, and this is the mysterious and bloodthirsty Black Death! And you are Horde scum.”

Octavia looked around, narrowing her single eye. She must not like the glares from the others in the tavern. “We deserted,” she spat. “Decided to turn pirates - like, I wager, many others here.” She grinned at the rest of the room.

“Deserted? All of you? Including a captain?” Sea Hawk scoffed again. “Did you take your ship as well?”

“And what if we did?” Octavia replied.

“Oldest trick in the book,” The captain flashed her a smile. “You claim to be deserters, to check out the port before you come with your ship, and gain the port’s trust. And then, when your ship arrives, it’s let into the harbour since you’re known - and, suddenly, Boom! Boom! Broadsides into the ships anchored here! Down goes the pirate flag, up goes the Horde flag, and the battle is over. For such a feat, the Horde would probably forgive a lot, wouldn’t it? Even desertion?”

“What?” “I knew it!” “Traitors!” The other pirates got up as well now, brandishing weapons.

The fishhead looked so surprised, Seacat bet that the idiot probably hadn’t even thought about such a ruse.

“Oldest trick in the book!” Sea Hawk declared. “And you’ve used a false flag before, haven’t you? Horde Scum.”

Seacat drew a hissing breath. The captain was again a little too clever for his own good.

“How would you know that?” Octavia snapped.

“I found your handiwork,” Sea Hawk replied. “Massacred the entire garrison, did you? A whole Salinean outpost.”

The mutterings grew louder, but the pirates also looked more nervous now. Less willing to deal with Horde scum in their port.

And the deserters from the Horde looked spitting mad. At Sea Hawk and Seacat.

She took a step away from the captain so they could cover each other better in the fight that was coming and raised her chin. “Bet I can cut up more Horde scum than you can, captain,” she said loud enough to carry through the room.

“Just ensure that they are recognisable,” Sea Hawk replied. He sounded unconcerned, but she saw he was tense. “We might cash them in for the bounty the Salineans are undoubtedly placing on the ‘pirates’ who massacred an entire outpost of theirs.”

A number of the other pirates took a step forward upon hearing that, but not too many. The cowards must be baulking at the thought of facing Horde scum.

The Horde leader scoffed loudly and took a step forward. “You call yourself a pirate, yet talk of bounties? Are you a lapdog of the princesses? Or a traitor?”

Seacat bared her teeth behind her mask. This could get very ugly if the other pirates followed up on that.

“Hah!” Sea Hawk sounded undaunted by the prospect of fighting an entire tavern of pirates. “Trying to accuse me of being a spy to distract from your own plan? Predictable! Tell me, did you disguise yourselves as pirates to massacre the Salineans so the princess would blame the real pirates? Have them hunt down the pirates who survive your upcoming attack? Such a fiendish plan fits the Horde!”

“Lies! We are pirates!”

“Of course you would say that!” Sea Hawk shook his head, then glanced over his shoulder at the other pirates in the tavern. “I say they are Horde spies! Who is with me?”

For a moment, Seacat was sure it would work. The pirates were angry. Angry and drunk. And they outnumbered the Horde scum. But most importantly, Sea Hawk now had them listening like a good captain would.

But then another voice cut through the angry murmurs. “Wait! I know that voice! That’s… You’re Sea Hawk!”

And Seacat knew that voice. When had Scurvy entered the tavern? Or how had she missed him?

“Preposterous!” Sea Hawk yelled. “I’m the one and only Red Beard the Pirate!”

“You are Sea Hawk! Lads, this is a Salinean spy!”

Seacat had known Sea Hawk’s relationship with Mermista would be the death of her one day!

She drew her cutlass and turned the move into a slash at the Horde Scum in front of her. The bullheaded pirate stumbled back, avoiding her blade, but crashed into the pirates behind him, stopping their advance. That gave Seacat enough room to whirl around, cutting down the pirate trying to sneak up on her from behind.

“Have at you, Horde scum!” Sea Hawk yelled next to her, and a charging Horde fishman impaled himself on his sword. Seacat ducked under a wild swing from a pirate with a blade as long as she was tall, then swept his feet with her legs while she dodged a thrown knife from another. Rolling to the side, then over her shoulder, she came up in a crouch. A quick lunge later, the taller pirate sunk to his knees with his hands trying to stem the blood from his slashed throat.

She slid past him, jumping to the side to avoid a sword as she parried an axe, and sunk the claws of her free hands into the sword wielder's arm. Whirling, she parried the axe again and again, guiding it towards the floor until the pirate wielding it got it stuck in the boards. Her cutlass opened his belly before he could recover or retreat.

Nearby Sea Hawk had dropped two Horde deserters and one pirate. But there were too many, and they were caught between the Horde scum and the pirates.

"A pouch of gold for whoever brings me Sea Hawk's head!" Scurvy yelled.

"What did I ever do to you, Scurvy?" Sea Hawk yelled back as Seacat frantically parried thrusts and slashes from two pirates working together, yielding ground as she was driven towards her captain.

"You set my ship on fire!"

"That doesn't count! I do that all the time to my own!"

Seacat would have laughed if she hadn't been about to die. Those pirates were too skilled. She sidestepped another lunge, parried a slash at her belly, deflected the next attempt to stab her, then whirled to riposte - and a blade flashed towards her face. She jerked back, but she was too slow, stupid boots and suit! Something tugged at her face, and something broke, and she fell on her back, rolling over her shoulder without thinking, pushed herself to stand… and her broken mask fell to the floor.

Well, she never liked the thing anyway. Here the two pirates came again at her, and she was with her back to Sea Hawk, out of room to retreat. This would not…

"YOU!"

Despite herself, Seacat turned her head towards the guttural scream. She wasn't the only one - the two pirates about to cut her

to pieces did the same.

The Horde fishwoman, Octavia, was screaming with rage and coming straight at… Seacat? And the stocky fishwoman was barrelling through her own crew to reach her! Seacat moved to the side without thinking, placing the two skilled pirates between her and the madwoman. Octavia ran into them before they could react, flinging one of them away with her tentacles and the shoulder-checking the other to the side. "I'LL KILL YOU!"

Seacat ran at her, then jumped, flipping over the stupid pirate, her cutlass lashing out - but tentacles snared her sword arm, and she was pulled to the side and smashed into the ground.

That knocked her breath out of her, but as she was lifted into the air again, she recovered in time to swing her free arm at the tentacle holding her, her claws cutting straight through it. Instead of hitting the ground again, she was thrown clear and rolled over a table and a bench before she came to a stop under the next table.

The Horde scum howled even louder than she had screamed, tentacles flailing wildly around her and braining one of the two deadly pirates. His partner yelled something and dashed forward, his blade cutting off another tentacle in what looked like a parry.

Couldn't happen to a nicer Horde scum! Seacat thought as she rolled out from under the table and jumped to her feet, ramming her cutlass into the belly of an approaching fat fishman. She dodged his wild swing by jumping backwards onto the table, then backflipped onto the next.

Where was Sea Hawk? There! Back to a wall, he was fending off three goons.

And Octavia had gone berserk! Seacat saw the Horde scum cutting apart one of the pirates held in her remaining two tentacles before beheading the other on the ground.

“Hey! Horde scum!” Seacat yelled, waving her blade at the pirate. “Got a haircut?”

Octavia screamed with rage and charged through another group of pirates to get the Seacat. As planned!

Seacat jumped off the table, landed next to a swinging pirate, ducked under his blade and rammed her claws into his groin. She didn’t let go but used his body as a battering ram to press through more pirates as she headed towards her captain.

By the time she reached the captain, her human battering ram had also served a human shield several times and was bleeding all over the place. She dropped him and cut one of the two pirates Sea Hawk hadn’t killed yet down from behind. Then she glanced over her shoulder.

Octavia was, again, coming straight for her. And her crew had started fighting the pirates trying to stop her! It was now or never!

“Captain!” Seacat yelled again, pointing at the door.

“Huzzah!”

She took that as agreement and grabbed the groaning pirate her captain had just cut down. A quick throw and the scumbag hit Octavia’s legs just when she was already reaching for Seacat. The fishwoman couldn’t compensate and stumbled, falling to the floor, and Seacat danced away from her.

Sea Hawk jumped over the pirate, somehow avoiding the tentacles, and landed next to her. “To the ship!” he yelled, pointing with his blade at the door. “Adventure!”

Seacat ran straight at the closest pirate - they had been giving them more room - howling and hissing. He broke and tied to get away, turning his back to her. Perfect. She rammed her cutlass into his kidney from behind, grabbed his neck, and charged ahead, straight into a cluster of pirates between her and the door.

They scattered, and she kept going. At the door, she pulled her blade out of the dying pirate and kicked him to the side.

Sea Hawk passed her, pulling the door open. “Freedom! Huzzah!” And he had something wrapped in his cape.

She followed him outside, pulling the door closed behind her, then ran after the captain on all fours.

They were close to their pier and had a small lead. Long enough so the clumsy pirates wouldn’t be catching up to them before they reached their ship. But not long enough to set sails and get away before they stormed the Dragon’s Daughter IV.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk snapped his arm, and something - a bottle - arced through the air, landing on the deck of the pirate ship next to them. And broke into flames.

“Burning oil?”

“Rum, actually. What a tragic waste!”

Another burning rum bottle flew towards the next pirate ship as they ate up the distance to their ship. Screams started to be heard from the first ship Sea Hawk had set on fire.

“You plundered the bar?” When had he done this?

“I recovered stolen loot!” he yelled back as he set another ship on fire.

There was the Dragon’s Daughter IV! Seacat jumped on her deck and started cutting the lines tying her to the pier.

Sea Hawk kicked a stack of crates over, then set them on fire with his last bottle, forming a burning barricade. That would hold the pirates off long enough for them to set sail.

She would never criticise his arsonist mind. Not for another week, at least!

But as she pulled on the mainsail's line, Sea Hawk already steering the ship away from the pier, she heard Octavia cry out again.

"CATRA!"

*****

The Princess Prom Part 1

Chapter Notes

I commissioned a picture of Seacat by Carnivalkitten:
https://i.imgur.com/WdT3O45.jpg
I've added it to the first chapter as well.

Chapter 5: The Princess Prom Part 1

The guards passed below her - dumb and clumsy guards; they didn't ever look up on their patrols. Grinning, she watched them turn the corner, then twitched her ears until she heard the automated doors close behind them.

Releasing the breath she had been holding, she gripped the pipe upon which she had perching and swung around it, letting go when she was below. She landed lightly on her feet, as always, and crouched, then froze for a moment - that had been a little louder than expected. Claws on steel weren't sneaky.

But she heard nothing, no footsteps, no alarm. Whew!

Smiling, she padded ahead to the corner. The guards had gone right, but her goal was left. The food storage! Stupid trainers never gave them enough food, and she was hungry. And so was Adora, but the idiot would never complain, much less do something.

Unlike her! She was doing something. She was being decissisis-something! She was sneaking food!

Lowering her head, she peered around the corner. Clear! All the way to the food locker! Wetting her lips, she took care to keep her claws from digging into the floor and making noise, and quickly moved to the door. Still no one. She looked left and right, then listened at the door. It would be bad if someone else was sneaking food right now.

But she didn’t hear anything. Taking a deep breath, she opened the door. Or tried to. It was locked, and the code that had worked last time didn’t work any more. She would go hungry! And Adora would go hungry, too.

Growling, she glared at the stupid door. Why didn’t the code work any more? It had worked before. She wanted food! She drew her leg back to kick the stupid door then gasped. That would make noise! And her claws would… damage... the door…

Beaming, she raised her hand, flexing her claws. It was just a metal door. And her claws could cut metal!

A few swipes later, the door was open, and she had food! Plenty of food! Enough for her and Adora!

She pulled her top off and filled it with the tastiest ration bars before leaving again. Adora would be so happy!

At the door, she peered left and right again. Nothing, just shadows. Shadows that moved - no, there was a mask moving through the shadows… Oh, no! Not her. Not...

*****

Seacat woke up with a gasp, then blinked. Why wasn’t the ship moving… Right. She was in Salineas. In the palace, not on the Dragon’s Daughter IV. She shook her head, then stretched extensively, wincing at the pain she still felt in her bruised side. It was getting better, though.

But she’d had another weird dream. Something about food and whatever. She probably shouldn’t have made a trip to the palace kitchen before bed. On the other hand, going to bed while still being hungry made for weird dreams as well.

Yawning, she went to the bathroom for a long, luxurious shower. Mermista wasn’t good enough for Sea Hawk and also a prissy princess, but she had the best shampoo in her guest rooms. And she hadn’t yet realised that Seacat only ever used half a bottle per

day and swiped the rest for the next trip. And this being her second day back in the palace, she could hide a whole bottle in her pack.

Showered and dressed in her usual, comfortable clothes - no sweaty leather suit for her ever again - she headed to the kitchen for breakfast. The sun was already… hm… midmorning, she noted after a quick glance out the window. And Mermista and Sea Hawk had been 'celebrating' late last night, so they wouldn't be up already.

Which meant Seacat wouldn't be bothered by anyone until noon or something. The guards certainly wouldn't annoy one of the heroes who had set Serpent's Maw ablaze and sunk half a dozen pirate ships. And brought back vital information about the defectors.

It was perfect! Breakfast, then napping!

*****

"Seacat? There you are!"

She frowned as she squeezed her eyes closed. "I'm asleep," she said.

"No, you aren't! And you shouldn't be! Adventure awaits! Or, in this case, lunch! With my dearest Mermista!"

"I'm on a diet." She still had her eyes closed. The sun felt warm on her fur, and there was just the nicest breeze of air through the open window to keep her from sweating.

"There'll be salad too."

"Salad isn't food."

"That's perfect for a diet! Come on, first mate! You don't let royalty wait!"

She raised her head and glared at him. “Shouldn’t you have breakfast first?”

“We skipped it. Come on!”

She sighed. When he was like this, the captain wouldn’t take no for an answer. And since he usually didn’t bother her like that unless it was important, it probably was important. If not, she’d scratch something or someone. “Alright, alright,” she muttered, stretching and poking her claws into a pillow as she got up. “Let’s go eat.”

*****

“...and after reviewing your report, it’s clear that I’ll have to reevaluate Commander Krila’s posting,” Mermista said as she cut a smoked salmon on her plate.

“Well, she wasn’t as bad as the commander of the other outpost,” Sea Hawk said before taking a bite from his own meal. “She didn’t lose the entire outpost and get her troops killed.”

So, that was the stuck-up officer’s name. Seacat made some agreeing noise while she reached for her second serving. Mermista might insist on turning a perfectly fine meal in the royal dining room into some bothersome planning session, but Seacat had her priorities straight. And she wasn’t responsible for the Salinean sailors.

“Only because you arrived just in time to save them,” the princess replied. “Without your warning, they would have suffered the same fate.”

“That’s what we do - and why you love me!”

Seacat didn’t have to look up to know her captain would be flashing his best ‘roguish smile’ at Mermista.

“That’s why I tolerate you,” the princess corrected him, and Seacat frowned for a moment before swallowing the rest of the

salmon on her plate.

Sea Hawk laughed. “That’s what you say now - but last night told a different story!”

Ugh. Seacat cleared her throat before things could get sappy. “So, will you replace her then?”

Mermista frowned. “That’s a complicated decision. She was sent to the outpost because she didn’t perform adequately as the first officer of a Salinean frigate.”

“And you don’t want to reward her for almost losing the outpost.” Seacat nodded. “Will Captain Slowpoke be sent to the other outpost?” That idiot didn’t deserve to command a ship.

“He would deserve it, but then - we can’t let pirates and Horde ships roam the Southern Sea undetected. We do need competent soldiers there, as your recent adventure has proved.”

“And it was an adventure! We outfought an entire tavern filled with pirates and Horde scum, cut our way clear to our ship while setting fire to all the pirate ships in the harbour and sailed away faster than anyone could catch up!” Sea Hawk jumped up and pointed at the window. “No one but the one and only Sea Hawk could’ve pulled this off!”

“Seacat’s report isn’t quite as optimistic about the number of burned ships,” Mermista remarked.

“That’s because she worries too much!”

“That’s because I can count,” Seacat retorted. “We set fire to half a dozen ships, and at least two managed to control the fire before the ships were beyond saving.” She scooped up the last of the cream sauce with a boiled potato. Excellent!

“Details, details! What is important is that we had another harrowing adventure!”

“We also failed to kill the Horde scum captain,” Seacat added.

“Ah, yes. Octavia.” Mermista nodded, then glanced at Sea Hawk as the captain sat down again.

Seacat felt the hairs of her neck rise and narrowed her eyes. “What?” she spat.

“She went berserk when she recognised you. And she called you ‘Catra’,” Sea Hawk said.

Seacat forced herself to shrug. “She probably saw me at the Battle for Salineas and mistook me for this ‘Catra’. I doubt that she could tell me from another cat.” Seacat wasn’t a Horde scumbag. She was a victim of the Horde.

Mermista glanced at Sea Hawk again, then cleared her throat. “But She-Ra grew up with this Catra.”

“And Blondie last saw her friend years ago,” Catra said through clenched teeth.

“Four years ago,” Sea Hawk added.

She glared at him. “Coincidence.” It was. Just coincidence. “What’s more likely: That I’m the only cat in Etheria, or that there are more of us around to the East? Occupied by the Horde?” She snorted. “I didn’t appear out of thin air, did I?”

“Well, no, but…” Sea Hawk started. “Don’t you think this ‘coincidence’ is worth investigating?” He smiled at her.

“No!” She spat back. “We’ve got more important things to worry about. Like the war against the Horde. And the pirate attacks.”

“Speaking of the war…” Mermista held up a scroll. “Bright Moon is working on expanding the Princess Alliance. So far it’s just Bright Moon, Salineas and Plumeria.”

Seacat shrugged. She wasn't a princess. This was politics. On the other hand, it was also a distraction. "So recruit more. That's how you joined, right?" The shrimp had been busy, last Seacat had heard. Not that she cared about Bright Moon or Blondie.

"Exactly. And there's a perfect opportunity coming up for such." Mermista smiled in a way that told Seacat she wouldn't like what came next.

"We've been invited to the Princess Prom, which will be held in the Snow Kingdom."

Seacat frowned. That meant a trip through the Northern Sea. Which was cold, as the name suggested. They'd have to worry about icebergs in the sea, too. All in all, it would take about two weeks to reach the kingdom - and that was with average wind. And all so a bunch of princesses could dance and eat for an evening!

She noticed that Mermista was holding out a letter to her. "What's this?" she asked as she took it.

Mermista shrugged. "Bright Moon sent a letter to you."

Bright Moon? Blondie, of course! Seacat frowned and stared at the envelope as she held it up. No glitter. That was the Bright Moon seal, though. She noticed the princess and the captain staring at her and huffed. She broke the seal by sliding a claw under it and cutting, then opened the envelope and pulled the letter out.

And blinked.

"What is it?" Mermista asked, leaning forward. Sea Hawk was leaning to the side, too, as if he could stretch his neck two yards to read over Seacat's shoulder.

She shook her head. "It's an invitation. To the prom. From *Blondie*."

What the hell? Couldn't the woman find another date? It wasn't as if she were ugly. Ah.

"Oh!" The captain nodded. "Bold of her."

"Bold?" She scoffed at him. "Transparent is what it is! She just wants to bother me the whole evening about her missing friend!" She scowled - she wouldn't have thought Blondie would be so underhanded! The woman had seemed to be far more straight-forward. Too honest for her own good, actually.

Seacat blinked again. "I bet this was the shrimp's idea!"

"I do hope you won't call her that at the prom," Mermista commented.

"Who says I'm going?" Seacat shot back.

"Well… we'll be sailing to the Snow Kingdom - my dear Mermista has invited me along, and what better ship to take than the fastest on all the Seas?," Sea Hawk said with a beaming smile. "So, since you'll be in the kingdom anyway, why would you want to spend the night in some tavern drinking cheap cold beer if you could enjoy the biggest event of the decade? Think of all the food!"

She definitely wasn't thinking about all the food the princesses would eat, even though the buffet would be stocked with the finest selection from all of Etheria. "At least I won't be bothered there!" she spat.

"Really?" Mermista snorted in that eye-rolling manner of hers. "So, you think Adora invited you to the prom just so she can nag you, yet you also expect her not to look for you if you decline her invitation?"

She didn't have to make it sound stupid. Seacat scowled at her. "I can hide." Or she could wear a disguise. Not a leather suit, though. A cloak would suffice.

Sea Hawk frowned at her. “That doesn’t sound like much of an adventure. You should meet any challenge head-on! With bravery and guts! Or with a cunning plan!”

“This isn’t a challenge. Or an adventure. This is just an annoyance,” Seacat retorted.

“Such an annoyance, you’d rather hide?” Mermista shook her head with a pointed sigh. “Well, if you don’t think you can handle a princess…”

Now Seacat was the one to roll her eyes. She knew what Mermista was trying to do, and she wasn’t falling for it. She wasn’t Sea Hawk who could be baited into anything with a challenge. “I could handle her - or anyone else - just fine. I just don’t want to.” She pressed her lips together as soon as she had spoken - she shouldn’t have said that. It sounded like whining. And Seacat didn’t whine. The most she did was complain - perfectly justified, mind you - about some things like the weather, the food, or, or some stupid princess.

But Mermista was smirking at her, and Sea Hawk was giving her that disappointed look as if she had failed to set sails in time.

So what? She hadn’t done anything wrong. She didn’t need or want to go to that stupid prom. Least of all with Blondie.

“Well, if it annoys you so much, I’ll talk to Adora and ask her to cut you some slack. Can’t have my first mate get annoyed into hiding, after all.”

“I’ll tell her myself!” Seacat snarled. She could fight her own battles.

“No, no, if the thought of spending time with her annoys you so much, you’d go into hiding, then it’s clearly my duty as your captain to step in. The sacred law of the sea that binds captain and crew together would demand no less!” He stood and raised his hand to point at the ceiling. “No need to be afraid, my dear Seacat, I shall protect you!”

Seacat growled. She didn't need protection. Not from Blondie. Or from anyone. And she wasn't afraid of her, either. She saw Mermista smirking and clenched her teeth. This could not stand! She wasn't some… whatever. "No," she spat, "I can deal with this myself! I'll go with her to the stupid Prom, and she'll realise she's got the wrong person!"

*****

Leaning against the railing as they entered the harbour, Seacat shivered despite her fur and the heavy jacket and pants she was wearing. The Kingdom of Snow was as cold as she remembered from her last trip. Snow and ice everywhere. Why would people actually live here? Well, apart from the Northern Sea having the best fishing grounds of Etheria. And the crystal mines that supplied most other kingdoms. The Dragon's Daughter IV would be taking a cargo of crystals back to Salineas. And enough dried fish for months. Mh.

"Ah! The Shining Star of the North! The Mysterious Jewel of the Northern Sea!" Sea Hawk announced, pointing at the glittering houses forming the capital of the kingdom.

"We've been here before. It's about as mysterious as a melted iceberg. They have travel brochures with suggested tours," Mermista drawled. "And the light being reflected by all the snow and ice hurts my eyes."

"Oh, but think of the night of mysteries that awaits us in the palace there! Dancing! Eating! Plotting and politics! Adventure awaits!"

"Making nice with people who barely know where my kingdom is located and don't give a damn about the war we're fighting. Fun."

"Indeed, fun! What tales could they tell that would measure up to our daring deeds and harrowing adventures? We will be the life of the party!"

"Unless we freeze to death first."

Seacat shook her head. The captain and the princess's relationship had weathered the trip much better than she had expected - they weren't fighting, yet - but she wasn't looking forward to the trip back. Two more weeks on the Dragon's Daughter IV would see the couple at each other's throats. Fun indeed.

On the other hand, perhaps this would convince Sea Hawk that Mermista wasn't the best woman for him? The captain deserved someone who could stand him for longer than a month. Although finding a woman who could stand him for a few weeks in the first place had proven difficult so far.

They reached the pier, and Seacat went to secure the ship and to haul down the mainsail. By the time she had finished, Sea Hawk and Mermista had handled the port master's paperwork - not that there would be much, not when travelling with a princess. One of the few advantages of transporting Mermista.

"Are you done?" the princess asked, sounding more than a little impatient. Or annoyed.

"Aye," Seacat replied in her best drawl. Mermista knew exactly how long it took to tie up a ship, and she knew that Seact had been fast.

"Finally! Then let's go to the palace!"

"I thought the prom wouldn't start until the evening," Seacat said, making a point of looking at the afternoon sun. They would've arrived two days earlier, if not for an unfortunate encounter with one of Sea Hawk's exes. Fortunately, they had still arrived in time.

"It does," Mermista replied. "But you didn't plan to get ready for the social event of the decade on your ship, did you?"

"Hey!" Sea Hawk protested at once. "The Dragon's Daughter IV is the best ship to sail all the seas!"

"But it's not the best closet or changing room," Mermista retorted. "Onward, I say! To the palace!"

“Onward! To Adventure!” Sea Hawk jumped over the railing and landed on the pier, fist raised high.

“To the Princess Prom! If you dare set the buffet on fire, I’ll gut you like a fish!” Mermista followed him with slightly less grace - in Seacat’s opinion.

She took a last look around the deck. Everything was shipshape. Too bad.

Then she followed the couple.

*****

By the time they reached the palace, Seacat wished she’d worn boots. Her feet were, if a little chilly, perfectly fine for a ship’s deck, properly swept clear of snow and chipped ice, but the Snow Kingdom apparently thought that a few inches of snow covering their streets was acceptable.

It wasn’t. She took some relief in digging her claws into the polished floor of the palace in retaliation as they entered. At least it was warm here, even though the walls looked as if they were made of gleaming ice.

She caught Mermista glancing over her shoulder at her and dug her claws in extra-deep on the next step.

“Are you claws frozen stiff?” the princess asked. “You’re usually not that clumsy.”

“They’re fine,” Seacat spat back, clenching her teeth.

“Really? That’s good to hear. I still remember when you froze to the railing on our first trip to the Snow Kingdom,” Sea Hawk cut in.

Seacat wasn’t cold any more at all - she felt positively warm at the embarrassing memory. “That was three years ago!” And she had been young and stupid then!

Mermista giggled, but, fortunately, didn't rub it in. "Let's go to our quarters to get ready."

Finally! That should keep everyone busy for some…

"Cat-Seacat! There you are!"

Catsycat? Oh, no! Seacat turned and felt her tail poof up. Blondie was coming straight at her.

"Blondie." She glared at the woman.

"It's Adora, actually." Apparently, Blondie couldn't read moods since she was beaming at her. "You came! I wasn't sure - Glimmer said you would, but Bow was sceptical, and… oh! Hi, Sea Hawk! Hello, Mermista!"

"She-Ra," Mermista nodded at her with her polite smile. The same smile she usually gave to Seacat when Sea Hawk had overstayed his welcome, and they were leaving.

"Hello!" Sea Hawk himself was beaming.

"It's Adora, actually," Blondie repeated herself. As if Mermista would have missed ehr the first time. "It wouldn't be appropriate to attend a ball as She-Ra, I was told. Swords aren't allowed at the Prom. Or any other weapons." She nodded.

Seacat frowned. No weapons? Well, she had her claws if anything happened. And if the other guests didn't have any weapons, that would put her at an advantage. And… "So, She-Ra won't be attending the prom?" she asked.

"Uh," Blondie looked confused for a moment. "Technically, I'm She-Ra even if I'm not, you know, being She-Ra. Transformed, I mean. But I was planning to attend like this." She ran a hand down her front. "Only in a dress, of course. Uniforms aren't suitable for the Prom, either."

"Unless you're a soldier," Sea Hawk replied.

“Well, I am a soldier. Kind of.”

“You’re a princess,” Seacat told her. “But more importantly… why are you wearing a Horde Uniform?” They must have had more than enough time to get her better clothes than… that.

“Err…” Blondie rubbed the back of her head. “They’re comfortable? I didn’t really think about it since I always change clothes when I change into She-Ra, so…” She shrugged. “And they’re sturdier than civilian clothes!”

“How pragmatic,” Mermista drawled.

“Yes!” Blondie nodded with a smile. “Anyway, Glimmer is still in a meeting with Frosta, and Bow’s checking out the local crafters or something, but I heard you were expected to arrive today, so I decided to look for you.”

Well, today was the last day they could’ve arrived without missing the event. Still… “You waited for us?”

“I guess?” Blondie smiled at her. “I’m not a crafting or diplomatic type, so it wasn’t as if I had anything else to do.”

“I’m flattered,” Seacat said, making a point of showing what she really meant with her expression.

The other woman gasped. “Oh! No, I didn’t mean it like that…”

“Then how did you mean it?”

“I mean... I just… I didn’t want to, uh, stalk you.”

“Ah.” Seacat nodded. “I can see how waiting hours for our arrival and then jumping me as soon as we enter will avoid that, yes.”

Blondie blushed at that. “It didn’t seem like that when I thought about it.”

The woman was either very stupid or a very good liar, in Seacat's opinion. "Well, you saw that we have arrived. I'd love to stay and chat, but unfortunately, we'll have to spend the next few hours getting ready for the Prom, so… I guess we'll meet up at the prom?"

"Before the prom, of course," Mermista butted in. "You're her plus one, remember?"

As if Seacat could forget that.

The princess turned to Blondie. "Forgive her; she was raised on a ship. By Sea Hawk. The prom is an entirely new challenge for her."

Blondie perked up. "Oh, I'm the same! Glimmer was so surprised - and a little shocked - at what I didn't know about the prom. I had to redo all my plans every time she corrected a mistake!"

Seacat blinked. She shouldn't ask, shouldn't give the woman another opening, but… she had to know. "Plans?"

"Oh, yes - this is a diplomatic mission, after all. For the Princess Alliance!" Blondie nodded enthusiastically. "We need to convince Princess Frosta to join the Alliance. So, I planned for every eventuality."

Ah. Seacat nodded. That made sense - she knew better than most that having a plan or two ready helped when things turned bad. Which often happened with the captain in charge. Though diplomatic missions were a little beyond her. Seacat was a sailor, not a princess. Diplomacy was Memista's business; not that she was very diplomatic in Seacat's experience.

But she probably would hold back her attitude when talking to other princesses.

"So… do you need help getting ready? For the prom?" Blondie asked.

"We should manage," Seacat replied.

“Come by our quarters an hour before the prom starts,” Mermista said.

“Why so early?” Seacat asked as they left Blondie.

“We need to coordinate outfits, of course.”

Seacat had a bad feeling about that.

*****

As it turned out, Seacat’s fears had been unfounded. Mostly. The shampoo in the bath hadn’t wrecked her fur, for one. Apparently, Sea Hawk hadn’t forgotten that particularly embarrassing incident in Seaworthy and must have informed the palace’s staff. ‘Best shampoo in Bright Moon’, indeed! More likely, of course, Sea Hawk had mentioned it to Mermista, and the princess had organised things.

In any case, Seacat’s fur was soft and *shiny*. Not poofy. And her hair had been styled without turning it into some absolutely impractical construct that wouldn’t survive a strong gale, much less a storm. And her claws were polished and painted in shiny black. She had rarely looked better, if she was honest. And the bathrobe was soft and fluffy - it would be perfect if it had a hole for her tail. As it was, each time her tail moved, the hem was lifted a little, from her knees to her thighs, though that wasn’t a problem. It wasn’t as if she were going out in it.

But the clothes lined up for her… “Most of those dresses don’t even have a hole for my tail!” she protested.

“That’s normal - the hole will be added once you’ve chosen your dress,” Mermista said.

Seacat shot her a frown. That didn’t match her own experiences. And shouldn’t the princess be worried about her own dress?

“I picked out my dress before we set out for the Kingdom of Snow,” Mermista told her with a smirk as if she had read Seacat’s

mind.

Seacat huffed, but didn't push further. Instead, she pointed at the other row of clothes, smaller, but apparently heavier. "And what's with the uniforms? I'm not a member of the Navy, much less an officer!"

"Those are styled after officers' uniforms, they aren't actual uniforms," Mermista explained. "As I've been told, after our victory at sea, naval uniforms became fashionable in Salineas."

Seacat snorted. "Would've been better if actually serving in the navy would've become fashionable," she muttered.

"What a noble sentiment! You and Sea Hawk could have commissions but for asking," the princess replied as she walked over to the row of dresses.

"No, thanks," Seacat shot back. "I like being able to choose my own fate." And it went without saying that Sea Hawk wouldn't fit into the Navy. Setting frigates on fire would quickly grow too expensive for any kingdom.

"That's an incentive to rise through the ranks," Mermista replies, pulling out a white dress and holding it up, eyes flicking back and forth between it and Seacat. "I think not."

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Don't tell me that you haven't planned my outfit already, and this is just for show."

The princess's grin told Seacat that she was right. "We still have time to try on a few dresses."

Seacat glared at Mermista. "Shouldn't we wait until Blondie arrives so we can 'coordinate' outfits?

"I already know what she's wearing," Mermista replied, peering at another dress. One that looked like it was made out of plants. "And I know what you'll be wearing."

Seacat blinked. “And what’s this, then?” She pointed at the dresses and suits.

“That’s Sea Hawk’s doing.” Mermista’s grin made her look like a shark. “This is your first ball, after all, and he wanted to be prepared for all eventualities.”

“Ah.” Seacat swallowed her first comment. Of course the captain would do such a thing. And it explained the capes on half the dresses and all of the uniforms. She glared at Mermista, but only half-heartedly. It was hard to stop the captain when he got going; Seacat knew that better than anyone else.

But she was also pretty sure that Mermista hadn’t even tried to stop him. Though she was less sure about the princess’s reason for that.

A knock at the door interrupted the sudden silence.

“Enter!” Mermista said, loud enough to be heard through the door, but not yelling.

Seacat told herself that a sailor didn’t need to be able to do that. A sailor needed to be able to yell as loud as possible so they’d be heard in the worst of storms.

Then she blinked. Blondie entered with a weak, shy smile. Dressed in… oh. That was a nice dress. Simple but stylish. Red - and a darker red, almost like Seacat’s preferred shirt, to set it off. It reached mid-calf. No cleavage, but most of the shoulders and arms were bare. Toned arms.

She resisted the urge to whistle. Instead, she said: “I expected more ruffles and lace.”

Blondie actually blushed, looking at the floor near Seacat’s feet. “Ah… that’s an interesting...”

“Please excuse her; she’s got some strange ideas about princesses,” Mermista said. “Beats me where she’d got it from -

the only princess she knows is me."

"Exactly," Seacat said, flashing her fangs.

Blondie smiled, even chuckled at that. "So… what are you wearing?" She peered at the dresses, almost ignoring Seacat and Mermista.

"Err…" Seacat licked her lips, turning to the clothes. She only had to…

"This one!" A bundle of clothes hit her in the chest before she had turned completely to face Mermista, and only her fast reaction allowed her to catch it before it hit the ground. "Go and try it on!"

Seacat frowned - this was exactly why she didn't want to join the navy! - but she wasn't about to argue in front of Blondie.

She glared at the princess anyway, then walked into the bathroom. At least the princess had gotten her favourite colours - black and red - right.

But when she unfolded the bundle, she knew at once that this had been Sea Hawk's pick. It was a suit with a cape. A half-cape, so it wouldn't exactly make her trip up or hamper her tail's movements, but still!

On the other hand, she had to admit once she had put the clothes on and checked herself in the mirror, it looked dashing. Black leggings and jacket, red shirt - with a higher collar than she usually wore - and black half-cape covering her left shoulder. Fingerless half-gloves that matched her leggings. No shoes, of course.

All in all, not bad at all, if she did say so…

"Seacat! Did you get tangled up in the fabric again?"

She rolled her eyes as she opened the door. The princess made it sound as if she had trouble dressing herself. "That was a cargo of

silk, ropes and linen," she said, "and I had to jump into the hold or get crushed by the mainmast when that cannonball smashed its base."

"And then you got stuck!" Mermista said, laughing.

Not for long, and only because she hadn't wanted to destroy part of the cargo! But before Seacat could come up with a comeback - probably involving the princess's on/off relationship with her captain - Blondie started laughing as well.

It wasn't that funny, in Seacat's opinion. But the other woman kept laughing for almost half a minute before she finally stopped. "Oh! Oh, no - I'm sorry. I just…" she shrugged, blushing again. "But you look very nice."

Seacat huffed, even though the princess sounded honest. Then again, of course she looked nice - she always did! She nodded. "Thank you. So, do we pass muster?" she added, looking at Mermista.

The princess made a point of studying her with a frown on her face and making humming noises. "Let's hope you'll do."

"You picked out the clothes," Seacat told her.

"But you're wearing them."

She rolled her eyes. "Shouldn't you get ready as well? You've got half an hour left."

Hearing Mermista gasp was very satisfying. Seacat smirked and stuck out her tongue as the princess positively rushed out of the room and into her own quarters.

"Catra used to have the same expression when she managed to pull a prank on, well...!"

And there went her good mood. She turned to face Blondie. "I'm not her."

“Sorry, I forgot.”

“‘Forgot’? What do you mean?”

“Ah…” The other woman grimaced. “It’s like… you know…”

Blondie was a pathetic liar. Seacat narrowed her eyes, flattened her ears and leaned closer. “What do you mean, you ‘forgot’?”

“Well, ah, I know you don’t like it when I tell you about Catra. So I didn’t want to.”

“When you call me Catra, you mean.” She showed her fangs.

Instead of being intimidated, Blondie blushed again. “Sorry. But...”

Seacat frowned. Best to nip that in the bud. Mermista wouldn’t like it if they made a scene in the middle of the prom, and Sea Hawk had been looking forward to this. “It’s an instinct. I’m sure that every cat like me does the same thing. Ears moving, tail swishing, claws scratching…” she raised her hand and flexed her claws.

Blondie nodded with a smile. “That makes sense.”

She sighed. “But you still think I’m your missing friend.”

The other woman blushed again. “Well… yes?” She laughed, but it sounded a bit forced. “But I know you don’t like being reminded of that, so I shouldn’t do it.”

“Yes, you shouldn’t.”

Blondie nodded several times with a very earnest and hopeful expression.

Seacat clenched her teeth. This was more awkward than she had feared. And it was all Blondie’s fault. “Let’s go.”

Once more, the princess nodded with a stupidly happy expression. This was probably a mistake, but Seacat wasn’t a quitter. Sea

Hawk and Mermista would never let her forget it if she fled, anyway. And she could always hide at the buffet.

*****

"Adora! And Seacat."

Right. The shrimp was there as well. Seacat nodded at the princess as they joined them in the line waiting for the prom to open. She, at least, was wearing a properly ruffled dress. Very princessy.

"Hey!" And Brain Boy was there as well. Although he was with another girl… princess. "Perfuma, this is Seacat. Seacat - Princess Perfuma of Plumeria"

"Hello," Seacat replied. At least he got her name right.

"Oh! I've heard of you!" The princess beamed at her.

Seacat narrowed her eyes. That wasn't always a good thing. "You have?"

"Yes! Adora told me so much about you!"

Blondie's smile looked very forced when Seacat glanced at her. "Ah… Perfuma is a very good listener. If you ever have some problems and want to talk about them…"

"Oh, yes. It's the least I can do."

"What exactly did she…"

"Hi!"

Seacat didn't jump back. She merely straightened very fast. Another princess? With… moving *hair*?

"Ah. Entrapta, this is Seacat. Seacat, Princess Entrapta of Dryl."

“Hello.” Seacat was meeting too many princesses for her taste. Then again, this was the Princess Prom.

“I’ve heard about you.”

Seacat glared at Blondie, but the other woman was looking at the wall.

And then the princess was in her face. “You’ve lost your memory, right? I can help with that! Probably. Possibly. I’ve got some ideas, at least. Interesting ideas. Hardly more dangerous than any other experiment. What do you think about neurological stimulation? The brain is basically running on electricity, and so are bots! And I’m very good at making bots. Unless some First Ones’ Tech gets out of control, but that hardly happens. About once a month, which is a very good and safe ratio! So, what do you say? Mind a little brain scan? It won’t hurt. I think. Or not much.”

Seacat felt her tail puff out again as she took a step back. She hadn’t understood half the princess’s words, but she recognised danger when it was staring her in the face. “No. I’m here to dance, eat and enjoy the evening. No time for anything else.” She grabbed Blondie’s arm, lightly dug her claws into it to make her point, and bared her fangs at her. “Right?”

“Oh, right, of course. Ow.”

“Oh, and there are our friends! See you later!” Seacat ignored the protests and dragged Blondie over to Sea Hawk and Mermista, who had finally made an appearance. The princess wore - surprise! - a dress in dark green and blue colours that made her look a little like a mermaid. Sea Hawk was dressed in a matching suit. With a cape, of course.

“Hello!”

“You’ve met Blondie already today,” Seacat snapped, glancing over her shoulder. The other princesses were still a little away. Perfect. “Did you know she has a friend who wants to carve open my skull?”

“What?”

Seacat smiled, showing her teeth, as both Mermista and Sea Hawk stared at Blondie. Turnabout was fair.

*****

The Princess Prom Part 2

“Your friend wants to cut open Seacat’s skull?” Sea Hawk, his back to the still closed door to the palace’s ballroom, gasped before his eyes narrowed and he started glaring.

“No, no! It’s a misunderstanding!” Blondie protested. She shook her head.

Seacat grinned. That was the reaction she had been hoping for.

Mermista, though, sighed. “Ugh. Entrapta got enthusiastic, right?”

Spoilsport.

Blondie nodded, visibly relieved. “Yes, but she doesn’t want to cut into anyone’s skull. She just wants to do a brain scan.”

“She can scan your brain,” Seacat muttered. It was obvious that Blondie’s brain needed more help than Seacat’s.

“Hey!” The other woman frowned at her. Seacat bared her teeth in return.

“Did you ask her to do this?” Sea Hawk was still frowning.

“I, ah, well…” Blondie fidgeted with her fingers. “It’s like... She overheard me talking to Glimmer, and when I mentioned amnesia, she was all fired up about finding out how to treat it - she said something about memory leaks.”

“I’m not a ship that’s leaking,” Seacat told her. “And I’m fine.” She didn’t actually need her missing memory. She had been doing fine for years without it!

“But…” Blondie pressed her lips together.

“We’re here for the Princess Prom, not to get into my head,” she told the other woman. “Right?”

“Of course!” Blondie nodded rapidly. She really was a bad liar.

“Just keep Entrapta away from me,” Seacat snapped. “I like my brain where it is.” And how it was.

“But it… Right! No brainy talk! I mean, no talking about brains!” Blondie once nodded several times with a serious expression.

“Good.”

“Hello!”

And there was Princess Brain Scan. Seacat took a step back, moving closer to her friends, as the group exchanged polite but pointless greetings. She wasn’t afraid or nervous. She was merely concerned. A little. Which was completely justified. On the other hand, she wasn’t about to let a princess scare her. She straightened and stepped forward again. She still kept Blondie between her and the weird princess.

“Mermista! You’ve missed the meeting before the prom!” the shrimp complained.

“Unfortunately, I arrived too late to take part.” Mermista sighed as if she weren’t lying through her teeth. “Our ship was slower than planned.”

“We had to take a small detour,” Sea Hawk corrected the princess. “It was an adventure, actually!”

The story that followed had not much to do with what had happened, but it kept everyone entertained - though Mermista was rolling her eyes a lot - until the prom finally opened and they could enter.

Or could wait in front of the open door, as it turned out, since there was a special order for the guests to enter. “Can you imagine that?” Seacat whispered to Blondie. “You arrive first, and then have to wait until some slowpokes arrive just because they

are supposed to be in front of you. If anyone ran a harbour like this…"

"Technically, you were the last to arrive," the shrimp cut in.

Seacat frowned at the princess. "Who enters the harbour first is not important. Who gets their cargo unloaded and delivered first is the winner. We were among the first to wait here."

"Because Mermista skipped the meeting and so could finish getting ready earlier than everyone else," the shrimp retorted.

"If I had attended, I'd have made everyone late," Mermista defended herself. "Besides, you were probably gossipping about the prom anyway.

"We were not! We were discussing alliances!"

"And dates," the plant princess added with a beaming smile.

The shrimp blushed a little - but it seemed she was more angry than embarrassed. "That's part of alliances," she all but spat out. "Something anyone taking alliances seriously would be aware of!"

"But we weren't talking about engagements or marriages," the other princess retorted with a frown.

"Guys, guys!" Brain Boy - perhaps she needed a better nickname for him, seeing that he had just stepped between two angry princesses - smiled. "Let's just enjoy the prom, right? We can talk politics in the morning."

"And nurse our hangover," Mermista muttered. "Because I'll need a few drinks."

Seacat nodded in agreement. She had a feeling she'd need some drinks as well.

*****

She-Ra, and with her Seacat, was among the last of the princesses to be called in. Whether that was because she was the youngest princess or the most famous, Seacat couldn't tell. Blondie certainly made an impression - everyone was looking at them as the servant announced her.

"She-Ra, Princess of Power. And her date."

Seacat shot the man a glare - she had a name! A very good name! - but he ignored her. And Blondie was all but dragging her towards the host, Princess Frosta. Who looked almost as bored as Seacat probably would have been in her place. And was about ten years old.

Well, at least a princess her age would have a good dessert buffet at her party.

But first, they had to introduce themselves. Even though Seacat was sure that the princess had met Blondie before and didn't really care about a sailor.

"Bow, hold it for three seconds," she heard Blondie mumble under her breath. It probably hadn't been aimed at Seacat. Not that she needed it, anyway - she'd been drilled about all the rules of this ball by Mermista for half the trip here.

"So, they didn't trust you to behave, either?" Seacat whispered as they slowly walked towards the Snow Throne or however it was called.

"What? No, no, I planned this out for weeks. Rules for presenting yourself, rules for dancing, rules for eating."

There were rules for eating? Other than 'no snatching food from others' plates', as Mermista had put it? Seacat clenched her teeth. No, this was easy - she just had to watch how others ate, and then do the same.

Oh, there they were!

“Princess Frosta!” Blondie bowed, Seacat following her a fraction of a second later. One, Two. Three. Smile! Without flashing your fangs. And no giggling at the ten-year-old princess trying to look serious and grown-up. Mermista had been quite firm about that.

“Princess She-Ra. Seacat. Welcome to the All-Princess Ball.” Frosta nodded without changing her expression. And she knew Seacat!

“Thank you.”

“Yes, thank you.” Seacat nodded. That should be it. She pulled on Blondie’s arm, and they made their escape.

“Whew!” Seacat exclaimed as soon as they were out of earshot. “The hard part is over! It’s party time now!”

“Ah…”

“What?” Seacat frowned at Blondie. “You’ve had weeks for your diplomacy! You don’t need to work now, do you?”

“No, no. I was just… surprised.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Let me guess: Your friend was all serious and never did anything for fun, huh?”

“What? No, no. Cat… My friend actually liked, ah, goofing off. But you were always so serious when we were travelling together.”

Of course, she had been serious! Someone had to be serious in the crew, and Sea Hawk wouldn’t be serious even when faced with a mob of deadly pirates or Horde Scum. “I’m a sailor,” she told the blonde. “We’re serious when working. We have to be on the open sea.”

“That rhymes!” Blondie coughed. “Sorry.”

Seacat huffed. At least she didn’t mention Sea Hawk. “Let’s get something to eat.”

“Alright!” The way Blondie perked up, she must have been starving herself for this evening. She looked more eager to sample the food than sailors who hadn’t eaten anything but hardtack and salted meat for weeks, washed down with lemon juice.

They made their way through the crowd - some of them were still staring at Blondie as if she were… well, she actually was ‘a legendary princess returned in Etheria’s hour of need’, as Mermista’s head servant had put it, but still! Such staring should be against the rules - it made Seacat want to check her clothes for stains and run her hand through her hair, and that would definitely make matters worse.

But, fortunately for her temper and stomach, they reached the buffet without anyone actually bothering them. She sniffed the air - ah, so many delicious smells!

“Are you purring?”

Really? She glared at Blondie. “That’s not something you ask a cat! It’s rude!”

The other woman gasped. “Oh, I’m terribly sorry - I had no idea!”

Blondie looked so honestly sorry, Seacat almost told her that she had been joking. “Let’s eat!” she said instead and grabbed the biggest plate she could find. Blondie followed her example, she noted with a glance. Well, she was a fighting Princess, not some dainty useless princess who hid in their palace and didn’t do anything. She would need the food to keep in shape. Those muscles…

Seacat huffed and focused on the dishes, licking her lips at the selection of seafood. Oh!

“You really like fish, huh?”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. “Like your friend?”

“What? No, no. We never, uh, ate anything but rations. I was just noticing your selection.”

“Only rations? Horde rations?” Seacat gaped. She had tried those… things… in the past. To be raised on that…

Blondie frowned. “It wasn’t that bad. They don’t taste very good, but they provide you with everything you need. And the taste keeps you from overeating.”

“The taste keeps you from eating,” Seacat replied before sticking out her tongue and making gagging noises. “I’ve tried them before.”

“Oh? When?”

“That was on the Dragon’s Daughter I. We’d raided a Horde outpost but then sailed into an enduring calm and ran out of actual food waiting for the wind to pick up.”

“Oh! Couldn’t you fish?”

“I didn’t catch enough to feed everyone.” Not after Sea Hawk had eaten the good bait, leaving them with bits of rations

“Ah.”

They spent the next few minutes shovelling food into their mouths and making satisfied noises. Then the shrimp decided to join them. “There you are! I’ve been looking for you.”

Seacat swallowed a particularly tasty morsel of fried Ice Fish, and nodded at the princess. “And you found us.” She didn’t add ‘good for you!’, but the face the shrimp made looked as if she heard it anyway.

“It’s really good!” Blondie said, nodding happily, then coughing a little. Swallowing a fistful of roasted meat would do that to you.

“I told you, didn’t I?” The princess grinned, then sighed, “If only Bow would be here.”

Huh? “Did he leave?” Seacat scanned the crowd. Why would anyone leave the ball so early? Unless… oh.

“I meant ‘here’ as in ‘here with us’,” the princess explained with a pout that made her look barely older than Princess Frosta.

But he was at the party, wasn’t he? There he was, about to dance with his date, the plant princess… Oh. Seacat grinned. “You’re jealous!” she said, pointing at the princess’s face.

“What?” The shrimp glared at her. And Blondie grimaced behind her friend’s back, shaking her head at Seacat.

She ignored it. If they meddled with her private life, it was only fair to meddle with theirs. “You wanted him to come as your date, not… who did you come with, anyway?”

“I am technically here with Entrapta,” she replied. “But she went to gather data on social interaction’ or something before we even formally greeted Frosta!”

Oh! So, even princesses broke the rules. Wait - of course, princesses got to break the rules.

“And Bow is perfectly fine to go with anyone he wants to this ball!”

Seacat snorted. “As long as he’s with you, you mean.”

The shrimp’s glare grew even hotter. “That’s none of your business.”

“So? It’s amusing.” Seacat bared her teeth in a wide smile. “You should just take your heart in hand and charge full speed ahead!”

“What?” Both the shrimp and Blondie looked confused.

Seacat frowned. That was what Sea Hawk would say. Had said, when she asked him about his relationship with Mermista after a particularly loud breakup. But they didn't know the captain as well as she did. "You should tell him that you want him."

And now the shrimp was blushing. As was Blondie.

"I don't… I mean, not... " The shrimp shook her head. "He's my best friend. We were supposed to attend this ball together, I've been waiting for this for years, and now…"

'Best friend', huh? That didn't look like a best friendship to Seacat. "Did he know that?"

"What? Well, of course! We are best friends, we always go to parties together!"

Seacat shrugged. "Should've asked him out, then. Before your rival did it."

"She's not my rival!"

Seacat smirked. The princess was fooling herself. "Anyway, seems you didn't know your friend as well as you thought you did." She speared the last piece of fried shark with one claw and popped it into her mouth. Mhhh. Delicious!

"You're purring?" the shrimp blurted out.

"UH! Glimmer, it's rude to say that to a cat!" Blondie whispered into her friend's ear. Seacat's ears caught it, of course. "She's sorry; she didn't know about that," the woman went on, a little louder.

"I've never heard of this!" the shrimp protested.

"See? She's telling the truth." Blondie beamed at her.

"This sounds fishy!" the shrimp said, glaring at them.

“No, this *smells* fishy. Deliciously fishy!” Seacat retorted. “I’m getting seconds.” She sauntered the few steps back to the buffet, tail swinging back and forth. Blondie was staring at her, she noticed with a subtle glance over her shoulder. Then she caught herself purring again and frowned. She really needed to get a handle on that.

When she had finished filling her plate and returned to her supposed date for the evening, the shrimp was gone.

“She went to ask Bow for a dance,” Blondie explained.

“Cool.” She started eating the tasty morsels again. “Do you think they’ll fight over him?”

“What? No, no. They’re friends. Well, Bow and Glimmer, but Perfuma is, at least, an ally. Probably a friend, too - well, I think of her as a friend.” Seacat found herself frowning for some reason, but Blondie’s eyes widened. “Oh, no! What if they do end up fighting? This could tear the alliance apart! I didn’t consider that possibility when I laid down the relationship web!”

“The ‘relationship web’?”

“Yes! I marked out all known relationships, so we’d know who was dating whom and who can’t stand each other.” Blondie bit her lower lip for a moment. “But I didn’t consider this. Not at all. Oh, no…”

Tsk. Seacat pierced another morsel with her claw - roasted Ice Fish, one of the best and most expensive fishes she knew - and waved it in front of Blondie’s nose until she looked at it with crossed eyes.

“Uh… what?”

“Roasted Ice Fish. Try it. And stop worrying about a lover’s spat. Sea Hawk and Mermista fight each other all the time, but still love each other.”

Blondie opened her mouth and blinked. “But…”

Seacat silenced her by pushing the morsel into her mouth. Blondie closed her mouth reflexively, and she withdrew her finger and claw with a grin. “It’s good, hm?”

The other woman swallowed, blinked again, then nodded and stared at Seacat’s plate.

She shook her head. “Nu-uh. Go get your own fish! I’m not hand-feeding you without you returning the favour.” Then she blinked. That had sounded less… something… in her head.

Fortunately, Blondie laughed and went to fill her own plate, and neither of them spoke much until more fish had been eaten.

“So… ah… What do you do when you’re not being serious on a ship?” Blondie asked once they had put their empty plates down.

Was she trying to compare her to her friend again? Seacat snorted. She had the answer to that. “I carouse.”

“You what?”

She grinned. Blondie didn’t know the word. Well, she hadn’t been raised by the captain. “I go out drinking and partying,” she explained. Like every sailor worth their salt.

“Oh.” The other woman looked surprised - and a little taken aback.

“Never done it yourself?”

“I, ah, don’t drink much.” Blondie looked embarrassed. Justly so, of course.

“I bet you’re a fun drunk,” Seacat told her, smirking.

“I wouldn’t know.” But the woman was blushing far too much for that to be true.

Seacat grinned and leaned a little closer. “Really? You’ve never been drunk?”

Blondie shook her head vehemently. “We, ah, didn’t really have much alcohol as cadets in the Horde, and after I became She-Ra, well… I can’t drink and fight, can I?”

“Of course you can!” Seacat objected. “Drunken brawls are great!”

“I’m not talking about brawling,” Blondie retorted with a frown. “I’m talking about fighting a war!”

Seacat frowned in return. Blondie was correct - trying to fight a naval battle while drunk would be stupid. Very stupid. Sea Hawk had tried it, once, and never again, or so he’d told her. But that didn’t mean she had to admit it. She sniffed. “Well, I was talking about brawling. You know, having a fun fight. Not a serious one.”

“Oh, like sparring?”

Seacat blinked, then nodded, “Kind of. Just drunk, too.” She grinned. “That’s important.”

“I guess so…” But Blondie didn’t look convinced. More worried, actually.

She huffed. “I’m not going to start a brawl here.” Mermista had made both Seacat and Sea Hawk promise, after all. Several times. And it would be stupid with all the princesses around. On the other hand… She suddenly noticed Blondie was all tense and glaring. “What’s wrong?”

“Horde,” Blondie spat.

What? Seacat whirled, hand going to her hip - where the hilt of her cutlass would have been, if she’d been allowed to carry it. A Horde attack? Here?

“The woman there, with the claws and tail,” Blondie said. “That’s a Horde Force Captain.”

Claws and tail… Oh. Not a cat. A bug. A huge bug. And that armour… fighting her would be tricky, but a woman so big couldn't be quick. Certainly not as quick as Seacat. And Seacat wouldn't let Horde Scum get away. Not here. Not anywhere. "Someone must have smuggled her inside! Let's get her before she reaches Frosta!" She dashed across the dance floor, almost sending some stupid couple stumbling, and jumped on the stairs leading up to the Snow Throne, landing between the kid and the Horde scum. "Watch out! She's a Horde spy!"

The bug woman blinked, frozen by surprise. "What?"

Seacat hissed. All she had to do was to keep the scum from the princess before the guards would dogpile the spy. She blinked. Why were the guards pointing their weapons at *her*?

"This is Princess Scorpia. She's a guest," Frosta said behind her.

"Uh…" She glanced around. Mermista was glaring at her while holding back Sea Hawk. Blondie was standing at the foot of the stairs, faced with two guards, and looking lost and stupid. Shrimp was glaring as well. And everyone else was staring at her. Damn.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I was told she was a spy." She looked pointedly at Blondie. This was all her fault!

"She's a princess, and therefore invited," Frosta said as if that was obvious. "I won't tolerate violence against any guest - by anyone. And I won't break with centuries of tradition and abolish the neutrality of this event!"

"I haven't attacked her!" Seacat protested. It was true.

But it was obvious that the princess didn't see it that way. And Mermista was gesturing towards her. And frowning, as if they had just set something on fire.

Seacat pouted and moved to the side, letting the Horde Scum pass before heading down to Blondie.

“Why didn’t you tell me that she was a guest?” she hissed to the other woman.

“I didn’t know!” Blondie protested.

“I thought you had a plan for everything!” That was what she had said, at least.

“Obviously, I hadn’t planned for the Horde attending this event!”

“‘Obviously’.” Seacat glared at her.

“Obviously!”

“Seacat! What the hell were you thinking?”

Seacat closed her eyes. Just what she needed - Mermista was furious. At her. That wouldn’t do - it wasn’t Seacat’s fault. Not this time. “It’s her fault!” she said, pointing at Blondie. “She told me the bug woman was a Horde spy! I only tried to help!”

“And you did!” Sea Hawk said with a smile. “Selflessly jumping between an enemy and a princess is what we do! Adventure!”

“Causing a diplomatic incident is what you did!” Mermista snapped. But she was glaring at both of them, now!

“I never said she was a spy!” Blondie protested. “I said she was Horde!”

“That’s the same thing!” Seacat shot back.

“It’s not!”

“Well, what was I supposed to think?” Seacat replied.

“What were you thinking!”

Oh, great. The shrimp had arrived as well to yell at her.

And at Blondie, apparently, since she shook her head. “I wasn’t thinking anything - I just recognised the Force Captain and pointed her out to Ca-Seacat!”

“Ugh! You weren’t thinking - you got that right!” Mermista scoffed. “Seacat was raised by Sea Hawk! You don’t point out Horde scum to them without keeping them on a leash!”

Seacat glared at the princess. Everyone knew that in a fight, you needed to be quick and decisive. You couldn’t stop to overthink every action!

“A leash?” Blondie was staring again.

“I wasn’t talking about a literal leash!”

“You better were not!” Seacat snapped.

“Not outside the bedroom, at least!” The Captain nodded, rubbing his chin.

Seacat stared at him, blinking. She wasn’t the only one.

“Uh… do you mean…?” Blondie started.

“No, he didn’t!” Mermista snarled, flushed with anger or embarrassment. “Besides, we have a diplomatic crisis to fix here! Focus on that!”

“I’m no diplomat,” Seacat retorted. “Besides, shouldn’t me trying to protect the princess score us some goodwill?”

The shrimp winced a little. Not a good sign. “Ah… Princess Frosta is a little… sensitive about her age. And about not being taken seriously.”

Blondie nodded. “Oh, yes! Totally!”

Seacat sighed. Typical. “It still isn’t my fault. I was only trying to help!”

“Well, stop trying,” Mermista told her. “We’ll fix this… somehow. Just go and… dance or something. Without fighting anyone! Both of you!”

Seacat glanced at Blondie, who frowned. “We can’t just let a Horde Force Captain wander around here, doing who knows what!” she protested.

Seacat nodded in agreement. The woman had a very good point. “You can’t trust Horde scum!”

“We’ll keep an eye on her,” the shrimp said. “I’ll set Bow and Perfuma on her. You just enjoy the party. Without fighting. We’ll handle Frosta.”

“But…” Blondie started to say, yet everyone else was leaving already. She sighed. “It wasn’t my fault.”

“It certainly wasn’t my fault!” Seacat told her.

They stared at each other for a moment, frowning and glaring.

“Let’s blame the Horde?” Blondie said, smiling weakly.

Seacat huffed. It was still Blondie’s fault. On the other hand, she wouldn’t have said anything without the Horde scum visiting the prom. She nodded curtly.

“Great!” Blondie beamed at her as if things were perfectly well again. “So, uh… should we dance?”

Dancing? Seacat looked at the dance floor. Couples turned around each other. Hm. Perhaps… then she blinked.

The Horde Bug was walking straight towards them! And she was smiling. Smiling far too widely and friendly for Horde Scum. Probably gloating that she had managed to trick them into making a scene. “There you are!”

Seacat took a step to the side, just as Blondie did the same. One more, and it would be easy to flank the woman.

"Whoa!" The Horde Bug raised her pincers. "I'm not here to fight! I'm just here to say hello and play nice."

Seacat blinked. "'*Play* nice'?"

"Yes!" The tall woman beamed at her. "That's what I was told to do: Be friendly and play nice. Show the princesses that the Horde isn't evil."

The Bug Woman was either the worst spy in Etheria or the best, Seacat thought. This was… She actually didn't know what it was. Weird, in any case.

"Well, you can try, but we know that the Horde is evil!" Blondie bristled. "We were, I mean, I was raised there!"

"Oh, yeah - you're the Force Captain who deserted on her first mission." The Horde Bug nodded, apparently not fazed at all. "Adora, right? I'm Scorpia. But you probably knew that already."

"She also answers to Blondie," Seacat added, then grinned at the shocked look that earned her from Blondie.

"Blondie?" The bug woman sounded confused. "Ah, a nickname. Cute!"

She frowned at the Horde scum. It wasn't meant to be cute. It wasn't cute, period.

Blondie had to ruin it, of course. "Ah, I guess so," the woman said, with a faint smile, before frowning again. "So you were sent to deceive us about your intentions!"

"Uh…" The Horde Bug was frowning, though more in a confused rather than angry way. "I guess so? Though can you really call it deception if everyone knows about it?"

Seacat still couldn't tell if this was an act or if the woman was that naive. But why would the Horde send such a naive spy? Wait, Bug Woman was a princess, so they probably didn't have any choice.

"Not everyone knows just how evil you are, or they'd already be fighting you!"

Well, Blondie wasn't any less naive, it seemed. Seacat sighed and rolled her eyes.

The Horde Bug laughed, one pincer behind her head. "Ah, I guess so. Though we're just doing what other kingdoms did before." She shrugged, and Seacat briefly wondered how her black dress had survived that. "It's just, well, war, I guess?"

"War against civilians! I was at Thaymor and Plumeria!" You attacked peaceful, harmless civilians!"

"And you wiped out my home village!" Seacat added.

The bug woman looked actually taken aback. "Really? But that makes no sense. Why would we destroy a village? The goal is to conquer it, not to destroy it. On the other hand, things don't always go according to plan. You know, first casualty in war and all."

"I think that's meant to be 'truth is the first casualty in any war," Blondie corrected her. "And that no plan survives contact with the enemy."

"Right! I guess you really paid attention at Force Captain orientation."

"We studied that as cadets." Blondie looked even angrier.

"Right!" More nodding. "Anyway - I also got a message for you. From Shadow Weaver."

Seacat felt the fur on her back rise for no reason. Shadow Weaver… She shook her head. There was no reason to be

frightened of someone she had never met. And yet… She felt a shiver run down her spine. What the...

Blondie spat: “I don’t want to hear it.”

The bug woman blinked, then nodded. “She said you’d say that. That’s why she gave it in writing.” The woman craned her neck and stuffed one of her pincers down the front of her dress, then pulled it out with a letter held in it. How she managed that without tearing the envelope or the letter, Seacat had no idea. “Here!” She held the letter out to Blondie.

After a moment of more glaring, Blondie reached out to take it, and Seacat had to step in, grabbing her hand. “Seriously? It could be poisoned! Or cursed!”

“What?” Bug woman looked at the letter, tilting her head. “No, it isn’t!”

Blondie looked torn for a moment before she raised her chin slightly, jaw set. “I know Shadow Weaver. And I don’t trust her.”

“Well… That’s, ah, a problem.” The bug woman moved the letter around a little. “But I am really supposed to give you this message.”

“I’m sure,” Seacat said. “Just drop it on the floor.”

“Really?” The Horde scum perked up. “Alright!”

“No, she was joking,” Blondie interrupted. “If the letter is a trap, then that would endanger others. You can’t just drop it on the floor.” After a moment, she added: “And if it’s no trap, then that’s a private message on the floor. Which is also not OK.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Let’s get your friend Princess Shrimp to look at it.”

“Princess Shrimp?” Bug woman blinked. “I don’t think I’ve met her. Or heard of her. And I was briefed on all the princesses for

this night."

Blondie sighed. Loudly. "It's Seacat's nickname for Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon."

"Oh." The horde scum beamed at Seacat. "You give everyone nicknames? That's cute! What's mine?"

"It's 'Horde Scum'," Seacat replied, baring her fangs.

It got the far too cheery woman to frown, finally - Seacat had wondered what it took to get under that chitin skin. But she'd… "That's a little generic, isn't it?"

Seriously? That was what the Horde Scum took offence to? 'A little generic'? "What about Horde Bug?"

The woman kept frowning as if she took that seriously. Then she nodded. "I'll call you Wildcat, I think. Because, you know, you're all wild and hissing. And a cat."

Seacat scoffed. Who cared what Horde Scum called her?

Blondie, though, looked very much confused. "Uh… so… about the letter?"

"Right! Can I give it to your friend?"

"No! We can't just drop this on her." Blondie shook her head. "But we can go ask Princess Frosta. She's the host, so she's responsible for everyone's safety."

"And she invited you, so you're her problem," Seacat added, baring her fangs again as she took a step closer to Blondie.

"Good! Let's go, then!" And the bug woman turned and walked across the dance floor. The couples dancing moved out of her way like sardines parted before a killer whale.

Seacat looked at Blondie, but the woman was already following the Horde spy. Typical.

*****

Princess Frosta, for all her young age and brattiness, got things done, though. One of her underlings took the letter - Seacat took a step away, just in case - and didn't drop dead or started screaming. Then the letter was taken away to be examined by a sorceress or something. Presumably in an explosive-proof room.

And Bug Woman turned to them. "So… with that done…"

"We're done, yes," Seacat said, baring her teeth. "Enjoy the rest of your evening!"

"Ah, right, uh…"

But Seacat had already grabbed Blondie's arm and led her away. After they were out of earshot - she checked with a glance over her shoulder - Seacat scoffed. "The nerve of the Horde scum! Acting all nice while plotting our deaths!"

"Uh, yes."

That wasn't the firmest agreement Seacat had ever heard. By far. "So… you know Shadow Weaver?" She felt her tail starting bristle and suppressed the urge. She was stronger than this.

"Ah, yes. She, ah… kind of raised me and my friend."

"Oh." She shouldn't have asked. Now the woman would assume… something.

"But she was the worst m...parent. Always taking favourites and manipulating us, and…"

Seacat raised her hand. "No need to go into details. I get the picture. I do."

“You do? Uh, that’s good, I guess.” Blondie’s smile wasn’t the brightest Seacat had ever seen, either. She looked pretty shaken up - for a woman who attacked sea monsters for fun.

So Seacat nodded towards the dance floor. “Well, while we wait for Princess Frosta’s expendable minions to test your letter for traps, wanna dance?”

A smile lit up Blondie’s face. “Yes!” She blushed and ducked her head a little. “I mean, yes, I would like to.”

Seacat grinned and stepped on the dance floor, then held out her hand. “Come on, Princess!”

Blondie took it, and they started dancing. Fortunately, it wasn’t formal ballroom dancing, even if they were in a ballroom. Seacat would have been lost if she had to fit into some big production where every step had to be perfect as you traded partners multiple times while moving like a ship in formation.

But she knew, from several visits to the Grotto and some lessons from Sea Hawk and Mermista, how to dance. She met Blondie’s eyes, then started to circle in step with the music.

Blondie matched her. She was surprisingly graceful, what with how toned she was. That her dress was cut on one side almost to the hip helped, of course - she could move easily like that, and it also showed her...

Seacat blinked, then focused on Blondie’s face instead of her legs. Releasing her hand, she whirled, then switched hands, circling again. Then they drew close, arms rising, letting Blondie twirl beneath their locked hands before they separated again.

And once more they circled, switching hands, drawing close and apart, eyes meeting every time. On and on…

The song ended, and Seacat took a deep breath. That had been… fun. Blondie blinked, her bright smile dimming a little. She looked almost as if she were shy. “So, shall we…”

The orchestra started a new song, and Seacat grinned widely. She knew this song. And this dance. Lighting-quick, she grabbed Blondie's hand again. "Not so fast!"

The other woman gasped in obvious surprise as Seacat drew her in close, one hand on her bare back. She could feel her tense for a moment as her claws touched her skin, then she relaxed.

And they danced. Closely. Seacat could almost feel Blondie's heart beating as they turned, and she felt her own beat a little faster when the woman put her muscular arm around her waist.

Turning, twisting, legs moving so close, but not quite touching - but their chests did. And then she dipped Blondie, and for a moment, time seemed to freeze. The others on the dance floor faded into the background. Their faces were so close, all Seacat would have to do to touch, to kiss her would be tilting her head just a little. Just a little...

She blinked, almost gasped, and drew back, pulling Blondie up with her until both were upright again. A deep breath brought her shivering under control. And her fur kept Blondie from noticing how flushed she felt.

Not that the woman was looking at her right now - she was looking anywhere but at Seacat. They kept dancing, but more sedately. Seacat could breathe without her chest pressing into Blondie's. And she needed to breathe. That had been… weird. Very weird. That sudden urge to… Seacat wasn't Sea Hawk, but she had flirted and danced before. But she hadn't lost - almost lost - control like that. Never. It had always been… different.

"That's a good orchestra," she said. "Really catchy song, too."

"Yes." Blondie started to nod, then stopped. "Really catchy."

They turned twice around each other without either saying another word. Then the song ended, and they were left standing on the dance floor looking stupid.

Seacat straightened and looked at the buffet. “I could do with dessert,” she said.

“Dessert sounds good, yes,” Blondie replied.

“Good.”

They were halfway to the buffet when Seacat noticed that she was still holding Blondie’s hand. Her first impulse was to release it at once. But that would’ve made her look as if she were scared or hadn’t noticed what she was doing. So she gripped the hand a little harder and only released it once they were at the buffet and she had an excuse.

*****

Seacat was halfway through an ice cream dish for which she’d have cheerfully fought Admiral Scurvy’s best ship in a rowboat when Princess Shrimp arrived in front of her and Blondie.

“There you are!”

“Yes, here we are,” Seacat replied in the kind of tone reserved for little children who had managed to tie their shoes or something. Hadn’t they gone through this before?

The shrimp narrowed her eyes, but Blondie managed to swallow the mouthful of ice cream that she had just shovelled into her mouth in time to cut her friend off: “Glimmer! What’s going on?”

The princess shifted her glare to Blondie as a result. “What is going on? I’ll tell you what is going on!”

“Good.” Seacat grinned, then grabbed another spoonful of that heavenly ice cream.

“Oh, you!”

“Glimmer!”

“Alright. What’s going is that Horde scum fake princess! She’s been making the rounds and talking to everyone! And I’m the only one keeping an eye on her because Entrapta is stuck ‘analysing’ what ‘data’ she collected. Mermista and Sea Hawk are off somewhere ‘private’, and you two were flirting on the dance floor for ages!”

Wow. Someone was jealous. Seacat smirked and stepped closer to Blondie just to rub it in. As Sea Hawk always said: Never miss out on an opportunity to show off!

“Oh. What about Bow and Perfuma?” Blondie asked.

“What about them?” the shrimp snarled. “They’re busy having fun! I’m the only one doing my duty for the Rebellion!”

“I’m not a member of the Rebellion,” Seacat pointed out.

“What?” Blondie gasped.

“You aren’t? But Sea Hawk and Mermista are!”

“I’m just Sea Hawk’s first mate,” she told them. “I never formally joined anything.” She was fighting the Horde for her own reasons.

“But your ship belongs to him,” Glimmer said. “And he’s a rebel, so that makes it a rebel ship.”

“So?” Seacat shrugged. “Besides, if I were a member of the Rebellion, I would be under Sea Hawk’s command. Just as I am, actually. And he hasn’t given me any orders other than to enjoy myself and not start a diplomatic incident.” Which she had, but that hadn’t been her fault.

“But…” The princess was gaping at them.

“You’re on your own here, shrimp.”

“That’s… You know what? Fine! I’ll handle this myself!”

And she disappeared in a sparkly cloud of glitter.

“That wasn’t very nice,” Blondie said a moment later.

Seacat glanced at her. The other woman was frowning. She sniffed in return. “You don’t seem to be very concerned about the Horde Bug either.”

“Uh…” Blondie blushed with embarrassment. “Diplomacy and surveillance aren’t my strengths.”

“You don’t need to sneak around here,” Seacat said. “You can just walk up and talk to whoever she’s talking to.”

“I’m sure that’s against some rules. Or impolite.”

“So?” Seacat grinned widely.

“That’s exactly what my friend would say,” Blondie replied. Then she gasped. “Sorry!”

Seacat couldn’t tell if she had slipped or if she had used this to get back at Sea Cat for driving her annoying friend away. She waved her hand. “Forget it.”

“Glimmer is right, though - we need to keep an eye on Scorpia.” Blondie nodded with a firm expression.

Seacat sighed.

*****

“...and that is why it’s so important that everyone considers how their actions affect others. We’re all part of the same world. Interconnected. A small plant growing in one place might change the weather patterns in another region.” The plant princess was oozing concern as she talked.

“But you can’t always consider that. Sometimes you have to act right now. I mean, not right now as in here at the prom, but

hypothetically.” The Horde bug blinked. “A plant can affect the weather? Seriously?”

“Oh, yes. Not easily and not at once, but if they grow and multiply, plants can change the climate. The Crimson Waste was once a lush forest, people say. Until the plants died and the climate changed.”

“Interesting. But back to the main topic: Sometimes you need to act, or react, without being able to plan for hours.”

“But that doesn’t mean you can’t consider your actions and their consequences afterwards.”

Seacat stepped to the side, next to Brain Boy, and whispered: “How long ago did they start talking?”

“About a quarter-hour,” the boy replied.

And the two princesses didn’t seem planning to stop anytime soon. “I don’t like this,” Seacat muttered.

“It’s very suspicious,” Blondie agreed. “Horde Force Captains aren’t that nice.”

“Hey!” Brain Boy spoke up. “You’ve never met her before, right? Maybe she is that nice?”

“It’s an act,” Seacat insisted. No one was that nice talking to their enemies.

“And perhaps seeing that we’re nice, talking with us, celebrating with us, will show her that she’s on the wrong side.”

Seacat stared at Brain Boy. He really needed a new nickname since that was the biggest load of whale shit she had ever heard. Well, outside of a tavern where Sea Hawk had a tiny little bit too much to drink.

Horde scum didn’t change sides. And they weren’t nice.

*****

The Princess Prom Part 3

“Come on! You can’t keep defending! That’s not how you win a fight!”

“You can’t keep evading, that’s *not how you win a fight!”*

She wasn’t evading - she was circling her opponent, probing for an opening. Forcing her to keep turning until she stumbled or something. Her opponent was stronger, but she was faster.

She twirled her staff, then stepped to the side. There! She lunged, bringing her staff down then thrusting it forward, straight at the other’s stomach, driving her breath out of...

But her opponent parried it, guiding it away and up in a far too smooth move, and she found herself corps-a-corps with her opponent - struggling against her superior strength. She clenched her teeth as she found herself being forced back. If she could redirect… no, the other was too skilled for that. Too familiar with her own moves.

And she had pulled that trick in the round before this one.

Snarling, she pushed back anyway. She wasn’t a quitter. She wasn’t going to lose like some… some loser. But she was committed - if she retreated now, she’d get with the staff. Damn. Damn. Oh! She grinned. She had an ace up her sleeve. Or rather, up her toes. Sort of.

She pushed back again, as much as she could, with a hiss, then dropped on her back, letting the other’s staff pass over her head while she struck with her feet at…

And something heavy fell on her, knocking the breath out of her. Her opponent hadn’t gone with a blow - she had dropped her staff and dropped on her!

She gasped for breath, twisting her body, but her opponent was stronger and heavier, and on top of her. One arm was across her throat, fixing her in place, the other sneaking around her neck for a full chokehold, her hips pinned by hers.

But she wasn't helpless - she still had her claws. She could drive them in the neck of her opponent, and… NO! This was just a sparring match. And they were friends. But she hated losing. Especially to her. On the other hand, this was… wasn't so bad. Even if she had trouble breathing, what with the other's heave body pressed against her, pinning her on the ground, and…

"Yield?"

"Yield," she agreed, taking deep breaths as soon as the other withdrew her arms. "Good fight."

"Yes, good fight." Her friend smiled at her. The stupid hair poof had survived the match, too - it was always a treat when she managed to mess it up.

For a moment, they smiled at each other, breathing heavily. Her friend still hadn't gotten up. Was still lying on her.

And she didn't want her to move. "Well…"

"Adora! Catra!"

She froze, a shudder running down her spine. Shadow Weaver! This was going to hurt.

*****

Seacat shook her head and resisted the temptation to accidentally shred a pillow or two. What a stupid dream! It was all Blondie's fault - she hadn't had such stupid dreams until she'd met the woman. The only dreams she'd had were nightmares about her destroyed village. And her own death.

And while those had been bad and had her wake up shivering more often than not, they had been based in reality. She remembered staggering through her village, seeing corpses strewn around everywhere, having no clue what had happened, or who she was.

She hadn't woken up afraid of someone she had never heard of before. Or, even worse, all hot and… bothered about Blondie.

She scoffed and shook her head. They'd just danced. That was all. Besides, it would be very stupid to start anything with a woman who still thought Seacat was her missing horde scum friend.

She stretched, yawned, stretched some more, and rolled out of bed. A glance at the sky outside told her that it was… wait, this was the Kingdom of Snows; the sun rose much earlier in summer. So… it was mid-morning.

She blinked. Why was she awake already? Sea Hawk and Mermista wouldn't wake up until noon. They had drunk too much during the ball, and Seacat was sure that they, unlike her, hadn't gone straight to sleep after the ball ended.

Not that she wanted to know for sure, anyway. On the other hand, with all the princesses in probably the same state, this was a good occasion of getting something to eat without getting bothered. Princesses weren't hard-working sailors, so they wouldn't be used to getting up early to set sail with the tide after a night of carousing.

Right! She yawned again and walked over to the bathroom. Time to get presentable.

*****

"...and we have another meeting with Princess Frosta in the evening, which we all will attend," Princess Shrimp said glaring at Mermista.

Seacat sighed after swallowing another bite of Ice Fish stew. What was it with Princesses and turning mealtimes into planning sessions? Lunch shouldn't be work. Hell, she'd like to see a princess try and set sails while eating! No, Sea Hawk might think it was a good idea.

"Not you, though," the shrimp went on.

Seacat blinked. The princess was looking at her? "Not that I mind getting out of a boring meeting where I would be out of place anyway, but why so specific?"

"We, ah, kinda blamed you for the whole incident with the Horde princess," Brain Boy said, smiling in a rather embarrassed way.

"What?" Seacat glared at him, then pointed at Blondie. "It was her fault!" And the woman hadn't said anything other than a greeting to her today so far. It wasn't exactly as if Seacat wanted to, well… and they hadn't done anything, anyway, but... It was rude.

"I didn't call her a spy!" Blondie protested.

"So what? Any Horde scum is the enemy! Why would you call her out to me if you didn't want to fight her?" Seacat retorted.

"Because we were at the Princess Prom and not on the battlefield?" the shrimp cut in.

"So? The enemy is supposed to respect that?" Seacat scoffed in return.

"Well, they did," Princess Plant said. "They didn't attack anyone. They didn't even spy on anyone."

"As far as we know," Brain Boy said with a slight frown.

"I think Scorpia was honest. I didn't spot any lie," the plant princess went on. "She didn't seem like a good liar, anyway."

“That’s what she wanted you to think!” the shrimp said. “She almost sabotaged the alliance just by showing up!”

“She benefited from Seacat almost starting a fight in front of our host,” Mermista added.

Seacat glared at the princess. “I was defending our host! Better safe than sorry!”

Sea Hawk, of course, nodded in agreement. “Indeed! When the enemy suddenly emerges out of the fog, best act swiftly and decisively! That’s the hallmark of a hero!”

“No, that’s the hallmark of an idiot,” Mermista shot back.

Sea Hawk gasped. “But dear! What if this had been an assassination attempt?”

“It wasn’t!” Princess Plant objected. “Scorpia might be Horde, but she seems quite decent and honourable to me. We talked a lot, and I’m a good judge of character.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. That was Brain Boy’s fault. If he had kept the princess entertained, she wouldn’t have fallen for the Horde ploy. Really. “If she were a decent woman, bug, whatever, she would have deserted!” she said. “Like Blondie.”

“She might still see the light,” Plant Princess said. “I talked to her about all the evil the Horde is doing, and she was quite shocked.”

Ugh! Seacat made a point of rolling her eyes. “Really? She didn’t notice what the Horde was doing? While fighting for the Horde? Did she think all those villages were accidentally wiped out? Yeah, right!” Hell, the princess’s own kingdom had been invaded a bit ago, hadn’t it?

Blondie must have gotten something down the wrong pipe since she started coughing. “Anyway… if she deserts, we’ll know. Shouldn’t we focus on, ah, recruiting Frosta?”

“Yes,” the shrimp agreed. “And that’s what we’ll be doing at our meeting in the evening, which everyone except Seacat will attend. Especially you, Mermista.”

“Ugh. Why me?” Mermista complained between eating her roasted shark steak.

“You’re a key member of the Princess Alliance!” shrimp retorted. “What kind of example would you set if you wouldn’t attend a crucial diplomatic meeting?”

“The kind of example that tells a ten-year-old princess that we’re a cool group who doesn’t, like, waste their time on mandatory meetings?” Mermista asked with a grin.

“But you do,” Seacat blurted out. After everyone turned to look or, in the shrimp’s case, glare at her, she pointed at Sea Hawk. “He told me.”

“I didn’t. I just said I’d rather have an adventure than a meeting,” her captain replied.

“We all knew that already,” Mermista said. She sighed and rolled her eyes. “But if it makes you happy, I’ll attend the meeting. Hell, the kid might think it’s very grown-up and be flattered.”

Seacat chuckled at that.

“Ahem.” Brain Boy clearing his throat drew the attention of the room to himself. “Did the Horde envoy actually succeed in making people think they’re not evil?”

“Well… the data I gathered about that is inconclusive!” The Hair Princess spoke up for the first time. Apparently, she had finished her tiny fishes. “I was mostly focused on observing and collecting data on interpersonal relationships and public displays of affection - hidden and in public - so I didn’t gather enough data on politics and diplomacy to draw valid conclusions.”

“I think she showed that there are decent people on both sides of the war,” Princess Plant said.

Seacat sighed. There was proof that the Horde’s plan had had some success.

The rest of the meeting was just bickering and blame-shifting. At least that was what Seacat took from it. And none of it was her fault, anyway. No matter what the princesses thought. And who would trust anyone who fell for a Horde ploy, anyway?

As soon as Seacat had finished dessert - which wasn’t leftovers from the prom’s buffet, as she had expected - she stood. “I’ll check the ship, Captain,” she announced and left without waiting for an answer.

There was even more snow in the streets - and this was summer! - but this time, Seacat had come prepared - she was wearing oversized boots. They were uncomfortable and felt unnatural, and they would ruin her footwork should a fight break out - unless her claws ripped them apart, at least - but they kept her feet warm. It was still a bad trade-off. How people managed to live in this kingdom beat her.

The Dragon’s Daughter IV was covered in snow as well, and ice had started to cover some of the more exposed parts. She sighed - it would take her some time to get it shipshape. There was no way around it, though - Sea Hawk had taught her that their ship had to be ready to sail at a moment’s notice. If a mob was pursuing you, you couldn’t spend half an hour sorting out the rigging before setting sail.

But it meant she would be chipping ice and sweeping - or, worse, shovelling snow for some time.

*****

Seacat had dealt with the ice on the rigging and most of the snow when Blondie arrived. “Hey!” the woman said as she stepped close to the railing but stayed on the pier.

She briefly paused, nodded at the princess, then heaved the next load of snow off the deck and into the water. “Finally done with the pre-meeting?”

“Uh… sort of? I think?”

“You think?” Seacat cocked her head.

“Well… Mermista and Sea Hawk left, and Glimmer and Perfuma were starting to repeat the same arguments about Scorpia, so Bow and I slipped out. I don’t know if they noticed.” Blondie grinned, almost mischievously, for a moment.

Seacat approved. She chuckled. “Won’t the shrimp be mad?”

And that was a wince. A guilty wince. “So… what are you doing?” the woman asked.

Seacat rolled her eyes, both at the blatant attempt to change the subject and at the stupid question. What did it look like she was doing? Dancing? “I’m shovelling snow off the deck.”

“Uh, right. Right.” Blondie nodded. “So…”

“So?” It came out a little sharper than she had intended, but Seacat had things to do.

“What are you going to do now?” Blondie blurted out.

“Now?”

“Please don’t say something about checking the ship or chipping ice or whatever. You know what I mean!” Blondie said, frowning.

“I actually don’t know,” Seacat told her. “It depends on Sea Hawk.” And Mermista, but that was a subject they didn’t need to get into.

“Oh. Because it’s his ship, right.”

Seacat nodded. “And I’m his first mate.”

“Right! And you’re not a member of the Alliance.”

“I’m not a princess,” Seacat said. Unlike Blondie.

“Bow’s not a princess, either.”

So what? Brain Boy followed the shrimp. She scoffed. “Are you trying to recruit me?”

Blondie blinked. “Ah… No? I mean, I’m not trying to recruit you, like, begging you to join.”

“Unlike you all do with Frosta,” Seacat mumbled.

Blondie blushed in return. “The Kingdom of Snows is the largest and one of the most powerful kingdoms of Etheria.”

“You’re still begging.”

“We’ve got a meeting in the evening.”

“And you’ll beg her then.”

Another frown - even a glare - followed. “Do you have to make it sound like…”

“Like calling it what it is? Yes.” Seacat scoffed. “You shouldn’ lie to yourself. That never helps.”

Blondie opened her mouth but didn’t say anything for a moment. Then she closed it and glared at Seacat some more.

She grinned at the woman in return. Score! “So, why did you come here? Too cosy and warm in the palace?”

“No. I wanted to talk to you.”

Uh. “Ah.” Seacat tensed, then forced herself to relax. Somewhat. “About your missing friend?” Who was definitely dead if she hadn’t resurfaced in four years.

“Only if you want to. I was...”

“Well, I don’t!” Seacat interrupted her.

“... yes, I expected that.”

“Good.” She nodded. Firmly.

“But I, ah, liked talking to you. At the prom. When you weren’t all serious and...”

“So you came to talk to me while I’m working.” Seacat nodded in a slightly exaggerated manner. “That makes sense.”

Blondie flushed again. “I can wait until you’re finished.”

“I might take the whole afternoon,” Seacat retorted.

“I’ve got nothing else planned.”

She clenched her teeth. She could busy herself all afternoon, of course. But that would mean staying out in the cold all afternoon. She sighed, then pointed at the broom leaning against the railing. “If you’re going to stay here, at least help me finish faster, then.”

Blondie beamed at her.

*****

With the woman helping - putting her strength to good use - they finished in good time. All the rigging clear of ice, the whole deck free of snow. As it should be.

“So…”

Seacat clenched her teeth. Of course, having finished their work meant that Blondie expected to talk now. “Not here. I’m freezing.”

“Oh, right!” Blondie nodded, sending her slightly frazzled ponytail bouncing. “Back to the palace, then?”

It would be warm and it had free food. On the other hand, it was at the other end of the city, on top of the hill. And people - princesses - would be bothering Seacat there. “No.” She shook her head. “Let’s hit a tavern here in the harbour.”

“Alright.”

Seacat took them to her favourite tavern in the kingdom - well, her second-favourite, but her favourite one had banned her after a brawl had gone a little out of control during her last visit. “Hot wine for two,” Seacat ordered at the bar, then headed towards a free table in the back.

“Hot wine?” Blondie asked.

“Best cheap drink in town,” Seacat explained. It wasn’t as if anyone would want cold drinks with this weather. “Would you prefer hot tea?”

“Well…” Blondie smiled a little weakly.

Seacat groaned. Was she for real?

“Trying hot wine sounds fine!” the other woman blurted out. “I haven’t drunk much wine, actually.”

Oh! Seacat grinned. Time to see if she could get the princess drunk!

*****

“...and then she shaid ‘idiot’ and left me. ‘Aven’t sheen her since - she never returned.” Blondie wrapped her arm around Seacat’s waist and pulled her into her side. “Until I’ve mesh you!”

“I’m not your friend,” Seacat spat, trying to wriggle out of the woman’s grasp. But Blondie was too strong, even when she wasn’t seven foot tall and killing sea monsters for fun. She couldn’t hold her drinks, either - Seacat had matched her glass for glass and was only slightly tipsy.

“You’re not my friend? But… You hate me!” Blondie wailed. “It’s all my fault! I shouldn’t have lesh you go!”

“That wasn’t what I meant!” Seacat protested.

“I’m never leshing you go again! Never!” Blondie declared as she pulled Seacat into her lap.

Getting the princess drunk hadn’t really been one of Seacat’s better ideas. She was trapped with some drunk princess who still thought Seacat was her long-lost Horde friend.

Once more, she tried to wriggle out of Blondie’s grasp but stopped after a moment. Trying that in the woman’s lap was… weird. Very weird. “I’m not Catra,” she hissed. She didn’t want to claw the woman, but she didn’t want to spend the rest of the day here. Not really. No, really not!

“I know! You’re Sheacat! You’ve losht your memory! And itsh all my faulsh! I shouldn’t have lesh Shadow Weaver shend you away!” Blondie hugged her with so much force, Seacat thought for a moment that she’d transformed into She-Ra without Seacat noticing.

She should call for help… no! That would be too embarrassing. Everyone would know, and Mermista would never let her forget it. “I wasn’t sent away. I wasn’t in the Horde to begin with!” she hissed. She wasn’t Horde. Couldn’t be Horde. She was a victim of the Horde! What would her friends think if she were actually Horde? And had posed as a victim for years?

Growling, she grabbed the offending arm that trapped her on Blondie’s lap and dug her claws into the skin - not breaking through. Not yet.

“Ow!” Blondie stared at her.

Yes!

“That hurt!” The woman pouted.

Just a little, Seacat told herself. She hadn't even drawn blood. Hell, Mermista and Sea Hawk had had rougher nights. Or something. Not that she wanted to know such things.

Then Blondie beamed at her. "But itsh a good hurt. Tellsh me you're shtill alive!"

Oh, no! Once more, the arms tightened around Seacat's poor body, and she struggled to breathe. "You're hurting me," she complained. "Can't breathe!"

"Oh, no! I hursh you. Yesh. You left! Left me alone!" Blondie sniffled. "Itsh all my fault!"

Seacat agreed with that. Why would the woman drink so much wine if she couldn't hold her liquor nearly as well as she could hold Seacat? Wait! That was an idea that would solve this - or get her maimed. But at this point, she was willing to risk it as long as she could escape this… situation. She forced herself to smile. "Hey, Blondie!"

"And you call me Blondie! I'm Adora! You even forgot my name!" More sniffling followed.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Hey, Adora!"

"Yesh?"

"Can you change into She-Ra?"

"Yesh!" Blondie happily nodded. "I can."

Seacat waited. Blondie kept smiling. Oh, right. "Could you change into She-Ra? Right now?"

"Oh, that'sh what shou meant!"

Blondie reached for her sword, and Seacat used the opportunity and jumped straight out of the woman's lap, putting the table between her and the princess.

“For the Honour of Greyshkull!”

Seacat had to squint as light enveloped Blondie and the woman suddenly grew a foot or two. In height. And a few pounds in hair. She didn’t quite stare as the clothes changed into a shining white outfit - dry this time. That was… She swallowed. It was a sight, yes. She-Ra was… impressive. Tall. Toned. And…

“Oh no, what have I done?”

...wailing?

She-Ra shook her head. “What have I done?”

Seacat blinked, then shrugged and shifted on the bench, acting as casually as she could manage. “You got drunk.”

“I got drunk!”

“Yes.” And now she was sober.

“But… I called you Catra! Even though I know you don’t like it and told myself a dozen times not to do it! And I grabbed you!” She-Ra shook her head, sending her wild yet still perfectly styled mane flying. “I did exactly what I shouldn’t have done!”

“Well, you were drunk.” Seacat shrugged again. As she had hoped, the transformation had sobered up the woman. Which was really unfair - Blondie probably never had a hangover. She could drink as much as she wanted, then change - and everything was fixed without having to drink Sea Hawk’s special anti-hangover cure.

“Yes. I…” She-Ra’s eyes narrowed. “You got me drunk!”

Seacat grinned. “No. I got myself nicely tipsy. You got yourself drunk when you tried to keep up with me.”

The princess blinked. “But… you knew…”

“I didn’t know you were such a lightweight,” Seacat said. She had hoped to get the woman drunk, but she hadn’t known it would be that easy. “You’re much heavier than I am, after all.”

“Hey!”

Seacat raised her brows at the woman. “Who had trapped who in their lap?”

So She-Ra could blush, she noticed. Quite noticeably. “Uh… sorry. That was… the hot wine!”

“Sure,” Seacat drawled.

“Sorry. I didn’t know… I mean, I never got drunk before. There was this First One artefact with the virus, but… We never had alcohol in the Horde.”

“What?” She stared at She-Ra. “No booze?”

“It was against regulations!”

“So?” As if that would stop a sailor - or soldier.

“It was against the rules,” She-Ra repeated herself.

Seacat sighed. “And you’re all about following the rules, huh?”

The other woman blinked, opened her mouth, then closed it with a snap, grimacing.

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Don’t say it.” She didn’t need to hear how that was just what Blondie’s missing friend had always told her.

She-Ra mimed pinching her lips shut with her fingers. “I’m not saying it.”

But she was thinking it. Seacat knew it. At least the woman wasn’t hugging her any more. Seacat could do without getting squished against Blondie’s chest. Or squirming in her lap, getting all weird.

She really could do without all of that. Nodding firmly, she ordered another glass of hot wine. She needed a drink after all of this.

*****

When Seacat woke up, her head hurt. A lot. And the sun was busy trying to kill her by driving daggers through her eyes. Or something. She groaned and threw an arm over her eyes, shielding them from the evil sun. It wasn't enough, though. So she rolled on her side, curled up, and pulled the blankets over her head.

Or rather, she tried to - they refused to cooperate.

Without opening her eyes - the sun was just waiting for such a mistake - she pulled again. Harder. Still without success.

Growling - her headache was getting worse - she grabbed the sheet with both hands and heaved with all her strength.

The blanket finally settled on her, shielding her from the sun, with a startled yelp.

She blinked. A yelp? Blankets didn't yelp! People yelped. No, no… She couldn't have... Sea Hawk had taught her better than that. Mostly by showing what not to do, but still!

She kept her eyes firmly squeezed shut and patted herself down. Top and bottom - she was in her sleep clothes. That was a good sign. She sighed with some relief.

"Why did you do that?

And Seacat froze again. That was… She pulled the blanket off her and rolled on her other side. "Blondie!" Then she hissed, as the sun shone straight into her sensitive eyes, and her head hurt like one of Sea Hawk's first attempts at baking. Through squinted eyes, she stared at Blondie, who was just getting up from the floor. Fully clothed, Seacat noted.

“Why did you kick me out of your bed?”

“I didn’t see you,” Seacat replied, then blinked and shook her head - no, no, that hurt. “Wait. Why were you in my bed?”

“I wasn’t!” the woman replied. But she was blushing, “Well, not in, uh, *that* sense. I was just… I’ve fallen asleep on your bed.”

“Why were you on my bed, then?” Seacat asked through clenched teeth.

“That was your fault.” Blondie nodded with a slight grin.

“What?” Seacat felt her ears flatten. “What do you mean?”

The woman recoiled a little. “Uh… you were drunk and, well… you had fallen asleep while clinging to me. With your claws!”

Seacat blinked and quickly inspected her claws. “No blood…” She hadn’t licked it off, had she? That would be gross.

Blondie held up her jacket. Two sets of rips were visible on its back. Familiar sets.

“Ah.” Well, that wasn’t Seacat’s fault. Blondie should have kept her out of her lap. Or worn a tougher jacket. “Obviously, you managed to free yourself, though.”

“Ah, yes, but by then it was late, and… well… I fell asleep.” Blondie blushed again. “Sorry.”

“You fell asleep on my bed.” That was her explanation?

“Yes. Obviously.” Blondie nodded in that earnest manner of his. “I’m sorry. I just… I was tired, and, well…”

“Too tired to head to your room.”

“Yes.”

Seacat sighed. That was a very stupid excuse. If the woman didn't look so… whatever, then Seacat would kick her out of her room. With claws. Although Blondie also had taken Seacat back after she'd gotten stone-drunk. And she was looking at Seacat with such a hopeful expression… "Whatever. My head hurts too much to think this through."

"Oh."

"Not everyone can transform into She-Ra to cure a hangover," she pointed out.

"I didn't know that would work. I never got drunk before."

"Well, good thing I thought of it," Seacat said with a grin. "What time is it, anyway?"

"Uh…"

Of course she wouldn't know it. Seacat squinted and looked outside, braving the glaring sun. "Close to noon."

"Ah."

Well, it was time to get up and get ready for lunch. Seacat pulled the covers away and slid out of bed. Her headache didn't like it, but she managed not to flinch as she rolled her shoulders before stretching her arms and legs.

"Well, I'm gonna get a shower. You should probably do the same, you've slept in your clothes." And she could smell a few taverns and drinks on them. She glanced over her shoulder and noticed that Blondie was staring. That felt good, she realised, and she put a little sway into her walk - not much; her head was still hurting, but enough to be noticeable. Seacat did cut a nice figure, after all, especially… She blinked, a few steps from the bathroom, and turned. "Wait. Did you strip me before I fell asleep?"

Blondie blushed but shook her head. "No, no! When I finally got you loose - I mean, got you to stop clinging to me - you started to

strip off your clothes and complained that you were too hot!”

“Oh.” Seacat winced, and not just because of her headache. That sounded… well, she could imagine herself saying that. It was still embarrassing. She curtly nodded - which made her wince again - and walked into the bathroom.

As soon as the door closed behind her, she sighed. As far as carousing went, last evening obviously had run into some trouble.

*****

A long shower and several gulps of water directly from the tap later, Seacat was ready to face the rest of the world - and Blondie - again. She pulled the bathrobe, a far too soft, slightly too short thing with far too many decorative snow and ice motives, on and opened the door.

“...and we were all worried about you! You didn’t show up for the meeting! It was a miracle that Frosta still decided to join the alliance!”

Great. The shrimp was here. And Brain Boy. Berating Blondie.

“But Glimmer! I couldn’t leave Cat-Seacat alone! She was far too drunk!”

“You could’ve told us! We would’ve sent someone to look after her! Probably Sea Hawk to keep him from setting the palace on fire!”

What? Seacat frowned. No one talked bad about her captain in her presence. “Hey!” she snapped.

All three whipped their heads around and stared at her. Had they forgotten that they were in Seacat’s room?

“Oh, you’re finished,” Blondie stated the obvious with a weak smile that twisted a little as her eyes wandered down to Seacat’s legs.

Brain Boy looked away, but the Shrimp was glaring at her, Seacat noticed. Then the princess's eyes widened, and she turned back to stare at Blondie. "What did you… Did you skip the meeting for.. this?"

Seacat was tempted to run with this - it was the perfect opening. Walk slowly and with her hips swaying over to Blondie, sit in her lap and run a hand over her face, and let the princess's imagination run amok. But she still had a headache, and a screaming princess would only make it worse. "Simmer down, shrimp," she said instead. "If we had been doing what you're thinking, we would have taken the shower together."

That's what Sea Hawk and Mermista did, in any case.

"I wasn't!" the shrimp blurted out, but she was blushing. As was Blondie. And Brain Boy.

"Wow!" Seacat shook her head, then struggled not to wince and ruin the effect - that had been a stupid move. "You need to get out more."

"I get out plenty!" the shrimp spat. "But I don't get so drunk, I can't find my room."

"That's her fault," Seacat said, pointing at Blondie. "She got me drunk."

"You got me drunk first!" the woman protested.

"I also got you sober again, so that doesn't count," Seacat told her with a grin.

"What? I changed into She-Ra."

"I asked you to."

"But…"

“Oh, shut up! Both of you! You can sort out who got who drunk later!” the shrimp interrupted them. “We’ve got more important things to worry about!”

“Shouldn’t you have said that first, then? Instead of worrying about what we did while we slept together?” Seacat cocked her head. Slowly so it wouldn’t hurt.

“Oh, you!” The princess snarled at her. “This doesn’t concern you. This is Princess Alliance business. And as you told us, you aren’t a member of the alliance.”

“I’m not a princess,” Seacat replied. “But this is my room, so if you want to talk about ‘Princess Alliance business’, you should leave.” She made a face as she imitated the shrimp.

“And we will!”

“Though you might let Blondie take a shower first.”

The shrimp clenched her teeth in a very impressive - and funny - way as she growled at Seacat.

“What? It’s not my fault,” Blondie complained. “You barged in here before I could get ready, and she was in the bathroom.”

“Well, I’m not any more, so feel free to use the bath while I change,” Seacat said.

“Enough!” The shrimp grabbed both Brain Boy and Blondie, and all three disappeared with a pop and a cloud of glitter.

Seacat closed her eyes and sighed. Her head really hurt.

*****

Blondie, shrimp and Brain Boy were absent when Seacat reached the mess - dining hall, she reminded herself - of the palace. But Sea Hawk and Mermista were there. Grinning. Well, Sea Hawk was grinning. Mermista was smirking or something.

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Nothing happened,” she told them as she took a seat across the table.

“That’s not what we heard!” the captain exclaimed. “You were last seen cradled in the arms of She-Ra, who carried you to your room as gently as if you were a bride on her wedding night!”

“I was drunk,” Seacat replied.

“Stone drunk,” Mermista added.

Crap. Had the princess seen her? “I had a little too much to drink,” Seacat admitted.

“I’ve paid your tab at the tavern.” The smirk grew worse.

“Most of that was Blondie’s!” Seacat protested. It could be true, anyway. She reached for some bread and smoked fish - she better start with a light meal. Her stomach still felt a little queasy.

“I would hope so, or you’d be dead,” the princess retorted.

“Now, now - my trusty first mate wouldn’t die from a little booze!” Sea Hawk shook his head. “Though it was an impressive tab, I have to admit. Almost as impressive as when I won a drinking competition against Scurvy!”

“You needed a Healer afterwards,” Mermista told him with a frown. “And it was a near thing.”

The captain nodded, beaming at her. “As I said, impressive!”

“Ugh.” The princess sighed and turned to Seacat. “Be more careful in the future. And don’t get She-Ra drunk.”

“She can’t get drunk,” Seacat told her. “Trust me, we’ve tested it.” She did remember that. And that explained her tab, too!

“Whatever. Just be more…” Mermista gestured with her right hand. “...be less like Sea Hawk.”

“Aw!” The captain pouted. “But how can she be happy if she doesn’t pursue her love with all the passion she can muster?”

“My love?” Seacat narrowed her eyes, putting down the mug of milk she had been sipping from. Her headache was down to some easily ignored dull throbbing, but if this continued...

“Please!” Mermista rolled her eyes. “You’ve got the hots for each other. We saw you dancing, remember? If the song had gone on, you’d have started making out on the dance floor!”

“We wouldn’t have!” Seacat shook her head, then winced.

“Sure you wouldn’t have.”

“There’s no shame in love, no matter what,” Sea Hawk said, standing up. He pointed to the ceiling. “Be true to your feelings! Love is the ultimate adventure!”

“There is nothing like that between us!” Seacat snapped. Yes, her headache was back. “Yes, she’s attractive. And I’m hot. But that’s all. Hell, we slept together, and nothing happened!” She blinked. That had sounded better in her head. “I mean…”

Mermista blinked as well. “You tried it? Well, you were too drunk, I guess…”

“Oh, no! How awful! You must be so disappointed!” Sea Hawk said. “And poor Adora…”

“No! It wasn’t because I was too drunk! We didn’t even try!” Seacat glared at both of them until they started to laugh. Then she glared even harder at them. This wasn’t how things were supposed to go - Sea Hawk and Mermista were the ones with the weird relationship! Seacat didn’t have a relationship. And she didn’t want any, anyway!

Huffing, she focused on eating her fish.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat, covering his mouth - and probably his grin - with his fist. “I’m sorry, Seacat. We shouldn’t have made fun of you.”

“Of course we had to!” Mermista cut in.

“No.” The captain even frowned at the princess. “This might be her first serious relationship. This is a very delicate affair. I should’ve realised this much sooner, and taken steps to help her.”

What? Seacat stared at him, her fish forgotten. “‘Help me’? With what? And how, exactly?”

“Why, with relationships, of course. While I wouldn’t call myself an expert…”

“All your exes want to kill you,” Seacat pointed out. “You’re hardly a good example to follow.”

He gasped. “Not all of them! My dear Mermista here doesn’t want to kill me!”

“Not yet, at least,” Mermista said.

“Not this week, yet.” Seacat scoffed.

“Ah, you wound me!” The captain put a hand on his chest for a moment, then withdrew it. “In any case, as your captain, the sacred bond forged between us compels me to help you in this difficult moment!”

“It’s not a difficult moment!” Seacat snarled. “We drank together, and we slept together - we just slept in the same bed. She didn’t even pull her clothes off! End of discussion!”

“You slipped twice in one conversation,” Mermista said, smirking again. “That’s a clear clue!”

“A clue?”

“Yes! Like in a Mermaid Mystery. You might try to lie to the detective, but such clues betray you!” The princess nodded in what she probably thought was a smart, superior manner.

Seacat scoffed again. “This isn’t a novel. This was just a shore leave.”

“We’re still here,” Sea Hawk said.

“But we’re leaving, right? With the next tide?” Seacat leaned forward. “You settled matters with Princess Frosta, so there’s no need to dwell, and Mermista, you really need to return to Salineas before it falls to the Horde in your absence.”

“Ah… Yes. In theory. But I was told that there’s another matter to discuss with the alliance. Which couldn’t be discussed last evening thanks to someone dragging She-Ra through all the taverns of the harbour.” Mermista glared at her.

“Hey! I didn’t drag her through every tavern in the kingdom.” Seacat hadn’t entered the ones where she was banned, of course.

“Just most of them?”Sea Hawk grinned.

“Really. This is…”

“There they are!” Seacat interrupted the princess, pointing at the trio who had just entered the dining hall. Shrimp, Brain Boy and Blondie. And they looked angry - or annoyed. Whatever. Important was that they were here and could serve as a distraction. “Hey!” Seacat yelled, waving. “We saved you a spot!”

Blondie looked relieved as she approached them, and, for a moment, Seaca felt guilty for using her like this. Then she remembered that this was all Blondie’s fault. If she hadn’t carried Seacat to her room last night, the captain and Mermista wouldn’t have heard anything about it.

So she waited until they were seated and blurted out: “So, what was in that Horde letter?”

Blondie's smile vanished at once. "Not you too! I already told Glimmer and Bow that it's just a personal message of no importance. Shadow Weaver is trying to manipulate me, that's all. And she won't succeed. Now, that's all."

"And we keep telling you that it's important information that concerns the entire Alliance!" The shrimp replied. "If she's trying to blackmail you…"

"She won't succeed. She has no hold over me any more," Blondie said. "End of discussion."

It was quite obvious that that wasn't true - otherwise, the woman wouldn't be so worked up. Then again, it was her business, not Seacat's.

Of course the shrimp didn't see it that way. "But…"

"Glimmer." Brain Boy finally acted like he had a brain and stopped the princess. "We have to trust Adora."

"Yes!" Blondie agreed. "Have I given you any reason to distrust my judgement?"

Seacat really didn't like the glance the shrimp pointedly sent her way. Not at all! She might not want or need a relationship, but that didn't mean being interested in her was a mistake or anything!

*****

The New Frigates

"Psst! Adora!" She peeked down from her bunk. The blonde was asleep. "Hey, Adora!"

Without opening her eyes, the girl below briefly groaned. She didn't really sound awake. It didn't matter.

She whispered: "I can't sleep. Can I sleep in your bed?"

Another groan.

"I'll take that as a yes."

Grinning, she pushed herself off the bed and landed lightly on the floor without making a sound. Well, without making much of a sound - her claws hit the concrete. She tilted her head and listened, her eyes twitching. The others in the barracks didn't react. Good.

A moment later, she was on the bed. It wasn't big, but it was big enough for two. Especially if one of them was as nimble as herself. With a satisfied sigh, she made herself comfortable, stretching out at the foot of the bed - Adora's legs were perfect as a pillow. Much more comfortable than her own, empty bed. Warmer, too.

Curling up, she purred and closed her eyes.

But before she managed to fall asleep, her pillow moved. "Hey! What the… Catra!"

She didn't open her eyes and growled in response.

"What are you doing here?"

She scoffed. Wasn't it obvious? "Sleeping."

"But you've got your own bunk! You were ready to fight for it!"

"And?" She still had her own bunk. That didn't mean she had to sleep in it. It was hers either way. She'd claw anyone who tried to take it.

"'And'?" She heard Adora sigh. "Never mind. But don't use my legs as pillows."

"But they're comfy." And warm. Like Adora.

"And they'll fall asleep if you spend the night on them."

Huh? "Should they stay awake?"

"Not that kind of asleep. They'll be all tingly and numb and stuff in the morning!" Adora came close to hissing - she must be mad.

But she couldn't just give in. That would make her look weak. And you couldn't look weak. To anyone. Not in the Horde. What could she do? Oh! "Alright," she whispered back. "I'll change."

"Good! I really need… what are you doing?"

That was closer to a shriek than a hiss, she noted with a grin as she snuggled up to her friend, placing her head on Adora's tummy. "That's not a leg," she whispered.

"But… ah, alright."

She heard and felt the blonde sigh and smiled. That was even better. She took a deep breath, basking in Adora's scent, and fell asleep.

*****

Seacat woke up with a frown. Another weird dream. Very weird. If she had to dream of sleeping in Blondie's bed, why couldn't she dream of something more… exciting? But no, instead she dreamt of some Horde children sleepover.

She made a gagging noise and rolled out of her hammock. It was Blondie's fault, anyway. If the woman had come by to see them off, instead of avoiding her and going off with the shrimp and Brain Boy for another 'Important Meeting of the Princess Alliance' - Seacat made a face - then she wouldn't be dreaming of her. They would've settled things. Made it clear that nothing happened or would happen. Just two women drinking together. Like crew.

She nodded to herself and stretched, then rolled her neck, taking deep breaths of the cool - but not cold - morning air at sea. The sun was rising - she was on time. A week out from the Kingdom of Snows, the temperature had much improved. No need to watch out for drifting ice any more, either. That had been a pain - a fast ship like the Dragon's Daughter IV could wreck itself if it ran into even a small patch of drifting ice, and if there was fog, you often barely saw the things in time to avoid them.

After grabbing some hardtack and a dried fish, she climbed up to the bridge, where the captain was manning the conn. "Ah, there you are! Just in time!"

"Of course," she replied with a slight frown. It wasn't as if she'd oversleep at sea. That was limited to shore leave, when it didn't matter.

He yawned. "Just keep us steady - the wind doesn't look like it'll change."

She nodded. "Aye-Aye, captain."

"I assume my dear Mermista is still asleep."

She grunted in response. Of course, the princess was still asleep - she never got up in time.

"Slept well?" the captain asked.

She shrugged. "Can't complain." She wasn't about to discuss her weird dreams with Sea Hawk. He'd either think she was pining for

Blondie, or that it was a sign for an adventure or something. And dreams were just dreams. Weird or not.

"You know, we left without properly saying goodbye to our allies…"

Seacat glared at him. "We have a mission, and they have a meeting. Everyone's doing their part."

He chuckled. "Don't let Princess Glimmer hear that!"

Ah? Seacat grinned. Of course, she'd do exactly that! Once they met again.

*****

An hour later, the captain was asleep, and Mermista was awake - well, the princess was up, but she was still yawning and looking half-asleep as she stumbled on deck.

"Morning!" Seacat yelled.

Mermista grumbled a response that didn't seem to consist of any words, then spent a minute leaning over the railing and staring at the sea. Finally, she turned and climbed the stairs leading to the bridge.

"We're on course, and there haven't been any problems," Seacat told her.

"Ah, good."

Seacat narrowed her eyes a little behind the wheel. She expected some snarky or grouchy comment, not some half-hearted agreement. Something wasn't right.

The princess took a step to the railing here and looked out over the sea again. As if there was anything interesting out there that Seacat hadn't seen. Well, perhaps Mermista was sensing something in the water…

But then the woman turned and smiled at her. “So… did you enjoy the Princess Prom?”

Definitely something afoot. “The food was great. The company was a little too princess-y. And it would have been a lot better if we’d have kicked Horde Bug’s butt.”

“That’s diplomacy for you,” Mermista replied. “Everyone lies and plays nice while trying to get one over the other.”

Seacat huffed in response. “Doing what’s expected is a recipe for defeat,” she quoted the captain.

“We made a powerful ally, so it’s not as the whole thing was a failure.”

“And a lot of princesses got the completely wrong impression of the Horde,” Seacat retorted. “They’ll be harder to recruit.”

“Only until they see the Horde’s work first-hand.”

“By then it’ll be too late,” she replied. “But that’s a problem for you and your friends. I’m just a sailor.”

Mermista snorted at that - but once again, no follow-up comment appeared. Nor did she blame Seacat for the Horde spy’s reception. “So… you liked spending time with Adora?”

Oh, no! “I couldn’t exactly tell She-Ra to get lost, could I?”

Now Mermista’s expression turned into that frown Seacat was so familiar with. Although it was usually aimed at the captain. “Of course you could. And you did that often enough to me. And to other princesses.”

“Well, you’re…” Seacat trailed off. A friend? Not like the others? Familiar? “You’re you,” she said instead.

“Why, thank you.” Mermista bared her teeth. “I feel so proud.”

Seacat shrugged in response, baring her fangs. “You helped blame me for the whole Horde thing,” she told her. “And the shrimp really needs to be told more often that she doesn’t get to order everyone around.”

Mermista started to nod, then sighed. “Ugh. That was supposed to go differently.” She shook her head and sighed again. “Anyway, let’s restart.” An almost creepy smile appeared on her face. “Do you like Adora?”

“What?” Seacat stared at the princess. What kind of question was that?

“You spent a day drinking with her and the night in the same bed.” Mermista grinned. “If you don’t like her, then something went really wrong.”

“That’s called getting drunk,” Seacat shot back. She didn’t hiss, but she growled a little. This was getting too personal, and what relationship she had was no one’s business but her own. Not that she had any relationship, anyway!

To her surprise, Mermista looked concerned. “Do you regret what happened?”

Ugh. “Nothing happened, which I told you already. Several times!” She almost turned the wheel because of the stupid question.

“Ugh.” Mermista looked to the side. “I should’ve expected that. I’m no good at this.”

“Then don’t do it!” Seacat snapped. That should’ve been obvious.

“Someone has to, and Sea Hawk isn’t exactly…”

“Exactly what?” Seacat glared at the princess. If she was bad-mouthing the captain…

“What? No, he’s not… Ugh. Look, he’s convinced you are in love with Adora. That kind of colours his advice to you.”

Love? What the…? She shook her head. “There’s nothing between us! She thinks I’m her dead friend, that’s all.” Really.

“Alright.” Mermista nodded, but Seacat couldn’t help feeling that the princess wasn’t completely convinced of the truth of her words. “Anyway, if you want to talk about whatever happened or didn’t happen or should have happened, you can come to me, OK?” She grinned. “No teasing, promise!”

“You already teased me,” Seacat replied with a growl.

“Ah, I guess I - we - did. But we didn’t realise just how complicated things had become, back then.”

“What? Complicated?” Seacat blinked. Was her and Blondie’s… tavern tour the talk of the alliance or what?

“Yes. We thought it was just a drunken fling, you know? Drinking, dancing, dallying?”

“Dallying?”

The princess gave her a flat stare. “Sex.”

“Oh.” She blinked and tried to remember the word. It sounded like something to use when talking to princesses. “Anyway, we just drank and danced, and didn’t dally. It’s not complicated at all.”

Seacat smiled, but Mermista gave her another of those stares that she usually reserved for Sea Hawk when he did something stupid.

“What?”

*****

“Well, we found the Horde squadron roaming the Southern Seas!” Sea Hawk, standing at the steering wheel, beamed. “Success! And it took us only three days after setting out from Salineas!”

“It looks more as if they found us,” Seacat corrected her captain. Then she flinched when another shot from the closest Horde frigate chasing them fell a little too close to the Dragon’s Daughter IV. Not close enough to damage them, or splash them, but too close for her liking.

“Nonsense!” The captain, of course, was unflappable. “Our mission was to verify its presence before Mermista’s navy starts their own operations, and that’s exactly what we did!”

“We still need to escape to actually report in,” Seacat pointed out. And that was proving a little harder than expected. “We should’ve left them behind already,” she added. “Instead, they’ve kept up.” Granted, that was because of the wind blowing straight from their aft. If they were tacking against the wind, the Dragon’s Daughter IV would’ve outpaced the frigates easily - but even so, the much larger Horde ships shouldn’t have been able to keep up.

“That is quite odd, yes,” Sea Hawk said, rubbing his moustache.

“Quite dangerous too,” Seacat pointed out as she pulled on a line to straighten the mainsail just a little bit more, to edge out a tiny bit of additional speed. They had set every square inch of sail they could, and it still didn’t seem to be enough. If they couldn’t sail away, they would have to fight. Ram the closest frigate, then board it… Seacat would fight to the death before she’d let herself be taken by the Horde scum.

“Indeed!” He sounded cheerful. “It’s a harrowing adventure! Imagine the tale we will be able to tell my dear Mermista after this!”

“We need to escape them first before we can boast about it.” And it didn’t look like the Horde would let them escape. Even worse, they still had no clue how the damn frigates were so damn fast. Usually, Salinean ships were faster and handled better than their Horde counterparts, and the Dragon’s Daughter IV outsailed either easily. But if the Horde suddenly had improved so much, then that changed the whole balance. And not in the Alliance’s favour. “How

are they doing this?" she spat. Then she gasped. "Did they manage to finally get a skiff's magic to work over water?" And on a ship the size of a frigate? That would… the Horde would dominate the seas!

Even Sea Hawk looked worried now. For a moment, then he shook his head. "I doubt that. They would've sent out skiffs to harass us in that case. No, it has to be something else. Some added propulsion, indeed, but not like a skiff." He pulled his telescope out and handed it to her. "See if you can spot something that's different about these frigates."

"But…" She glanced at the sails. If she didn't keep adjusting them, they would lose speed. And even the slightest loss of speed could prove fatal in this situation.

"We need the information. Salineas needs it," he told her.

She clenched her teeth and nodded, then raised the telescope.

The sails of the frigates, billowing with the wind, hampered her view, of course - she couldn't spot much. And even with the Horde scum spread out, she barely caught glimpses of the decks. Yet… "Their wakes! Their wakes are different!"

"Oh?"

"Yes!" Seacat had seen the wakes of Horde frigates before. The difference was small, but it was there."

"Perhaps a new hull shape?" Sea Hawk speculated as another shot hit the water a few dozen yards off their stern.

"I'm no shipbuilder," she retorted. "But whatever it is, it has to be what makes the Horde Scum so damn fast."

"But not fast enough to catch us!" Sea Hawk yelled.

"Not so far…" Seacat started to say, then looked at where he was pointing.

And smiled. “A squall!” There was a medium-sized rain cloud in the distance - once they reached it, they’d be all but invisible to the Horde scum.

“Yes! Just in time to save us from relentless pursuit, a squall appears! That’s what I call a harrowing adventure!”

“Don’t sing the shanty before we actually make our escape,” she muttered. But it looked like they would make it out of this mess.

The next shot was so close, part of the water thrown up was carried by the wind to the Dragon’s Daughter IV.

Seacat raced down to the main deck and started adjusting the mainsail again. They only needed a smidgen more speed.

Another shot - no, two. And the ship bucked from the force of the blast behind it. The sails fluttered for a moment, and Seacat pulled with all her weight to correct that. They only had to hold out a little longer.

The Dragon’s Daughter IV swung a little to starboard - Seacat gasped, then realised that the captain was adjusting the course since the wind was changing a little. If it kept changing…

The next shots fell further behind them. And the wind was still turning. And she could feel the first drops of rain on her fur as she raced to the foresail.

Yes! Seacat bared her teeth in a fierce smile as more and more drops hit her face and upper body and splashed against her leggings. They would make their escape!

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“...and as soon as we disappeared in the squall, we changed course, and by the time we were out of the rain, the Horde scum was far off the course, unable to catch up any more as we tacked back!” Sea Hawk finished with a wide smile, arms spread.

“Uh.” Mermista didn’t look impressed - she was slouching on her throne, Seacat noticed. She wasn’t bored, though - she looked annoyed. “We already knew you escaped, since you made it back here.”

“But not how! A feat of daring seamanship, a harrowing adventure, an escape in the last second, before mysterious foes caught up…”

“Speaking of catching up,” the princess interrupted the captain. “How exactly did they manage that?”

“That’s a very good question.” Sea Hawk nodded with a serious expression. After a moment, he added: “We don’t know, though.”

“Ugh.” Mermista rolled her eyes, even more annoyed now. Frustrated. And not in the Sea Hawk way.

“They had a different wake,” Seacat said before the princess could start an argument. “We don’t know if they have a different hull, or if there’s something else.”

“We wondered if they managed to get a skiff’s magic working on water, but they would’ve used skiffs against us in that case,” Sea Hawk said. “And they didn’t. So…” He shrugged.

“The Horde frigates were always slower than our own frigates. The Horde’s yards were focusing on quantity, not quality,” Mermista said. “And their designs showed a lack of experience. Salineas, however, has a naval tradition reaching back centuries.”

As expected of an island kingdom, of course. Yet… “That doesn’t mean they’ll stay behind forever. With all their weird magic and tech, they could’ve found a way to, ah, even things out,” Seacat said.

“More than even things out,” Sea Hawk said. “If they can almost catch the Dragon’s Daughter IV, the fastest ship on all the seas, then they will outsail any frigate.”

Which meant the Salinean fleet would be horribly outmatched. Even the best skill and experience wouldn't help if the other side had such an advantage.

Mermista's expression showed that she was fully aware of this. "We need to know what they did to their ships."

"Exactly!" Sea Hawk beamed. "And I have a plan for finding out!"

And Seacat had a sinking feeling in her stomach.

*****

Splitshard, once a thriving port according to Sea Hawk, now the largest Horde naval base in the Southern Sea, looked busy. At least as far as Seacat could tell looking through a telescope from a mountaintop a few miles away, across the bay. The Horde scum was filling the piers, a few marching in formation, most running this and that way, like ants on an anthill, carrying sacks of supplies back and forth between warehouses and piers.

Warehouses that had the typical look of horde buildings - massive, flat-roofed and ugly, with lots of pipes running up and down the walls and across the roof. Warehouses that had replaced whatever buildings had stood there before the conquest. There wasn't much left of the original town - the walls had been turned into massive fortifications, earthworks dotted with turrets and barbed wire and most of the town had been remodelled, Horde style. A few older houses still stood, forming a small quarter in the landwards part of it, but they looked run-down as well.

She clenched her teeth. Whatever the Horde touched, it ruined. Like her own home.

Seacat took a deep breath and forced herself to focus on the harbour. They couldn't do anything about the town, not yet. They were here to find out what made the new frigates of the Horde fleet so damn fast.

“Hm…” she heard Sea Hawk next to her. “All the ships look the same.”

They did. Typical Horde frigates, utterly exchangeable. They didn’t even have proper names, as far as Seacat knew. Just numbers. But that was enough to identify the frigates they sought - or, rather, their absence. “I don’t see the ships that chased us,” she said.

“Must be still at sea,” the captain replied. “But I doubt that those were the only of their class.”

“Yes.” That wouldn’t be the Horde’s style - they were big on uniformity, as Mermista called it. But the Horde frigates in port did look like the old, familiar ones. Sails, cannons, decks… She narrowed her eyes. That frigate in the corner was sporting additional portholes in the hull, at the stern. Large ones. Or… air intakes?

She pointed it out to Sea Hawk.

“Well-spotted!” He praised her. “And most of the frigates have them, or so it seems - that must be a sign of the new modification.”

“Yes.”

“Now all we need is to sneak in and find out what exactly was done to them!”

Sneak into the largest Horde naval base in the area. And out again.

Great. “No disguises!” she said.

“Of course not!” Sea Hawk scoffed. “We already used that plan to infiltrate Serpent’s Maw. We can’t use the same trick twice. Not in close succession, at least!”

That was good to hear. But… Seacat frowned. “What’s your plan, then?”

“We’ll swim, of course!” The captain beamed at her. “We need to inspect the hull of the Horde frigates anyway, so we might as well start in the water already! And they’ll never expect that!”

“It’s a naval base,” Seacat pointed out. “They’ll be watching the sea.”

“For ships and boats. But not for people in the water. And we’ll be diving!”

“Diving.” She felt her ears flatten against her head. Diving. “You said swimming.”

“It’s the same, just underwater.”

In theory. “We should have Mermista to help with that.” Without the princess’s power, Seacat didn’t think they would have an easy time swimming that far underwater.

“She’s needed at home - with rumours of new Horde ships spreading, the Salinean people need her. But don’t worry - I’ve got a perfect plan!” Sea Hawk almost stood up and pointed to the sky, but she managed to drag him down before he exposed them.

“Not here,” she hissed.

“Sorry.” He grinned in return. “But you’ll love it!”

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She didn’t, in fact, love it. “Snorkelling?” She asked, looking at the devices the captain had laid out on the deck of the Dragon’s Daughter IV, which was currently hidden in a small cove further down the coast.

“Yes! With snorkels, we can stay underwater as long as we need to - long enough to pass the entrance to the harbour!” Sea Hawk

raised his arm and pointed towards the sky, which was darkening already as the sun was setting.

"Unless they have patrols underwater - they have fishpeople in the Horde," Seacat reminded him.

"Fishpeople might be able to breathe underwater, but they cannot see in the darkness - unlike you. As long as we wait until the sun has set, we shall be like ghosts in the night, floating past them with no Horde soldier the wiser!" Sea Hawk nodded to his own words. "Although some fishpeople have very good noses, so we're in need of a small distraction. Just in case."

"A distraction?" Seacat frowned. Then her eyes widened as she remembered what else the captain had brought with them. Fish oil. Concentrated fish oil. "No! I have a good sense of smell as well!" And she couldn't stand the stench.

"You'll be underwater, and unless you suddenly start breathing water, your nose will be fine," the captain retorted.

"I won't stay underwater," she said. "And the stuff reeks. You want us to coat ourselves with it?" Her lovely fur… She shuddered.

"Only a little, to dampen our own scent." He nodded, "I learned that when I was sneaking into the Underwater Grotto after I was banned for the first time. They have fishmen bouncers."

"I know - I've been there, remember?" Seacat reminded him. She hadn't been banned, after all.

"Yes, of course. Anyway - just a cup of oil, spread over your skin - your fur - will fool the best noses in the sea. Although it won't fool sharks if you happen to be bleeding."

He was looking at her expectantly, but she didn't ask how he had found out that tidbit - they would be here all night if he launched into another tale. And they had a mission. "If this doesn't come out of my fur, I'll keep dousing you in it until it's gone."

He laughed.

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An hour later, they were ready. And stinking. Seacat had to plug her nostrils; the fish oil stench was so bad, it had even put her off of having fish for dinner. At least when snorkelling, she wouldn't smell it.

And they wouldn't have to swim the whole distance - they could use planks disguised as driftwood as floaters to approach with the rising tide most of the way. In theory at least.

She checked her belt and cutlass again so she was sure she wouldn't lose it in the water. Without her leggings, it rubbed her thigh a little, but that wouldn't be a problem in the water. "I'm ready."

"So am I!" Sea Hawk struck a pose and flexed his muscles.

"Save that for Mermista," she replied.

He pouted for a moment, then smiled. "I will! I might tell her of this adventure when we're in her private bath!"

"You should also use the fish oil so she can get a better impression," Seacat told him with a smirk.

"That's a…" He blinked, then frowned at her. "That's a nasty trick you tried to pull on me!"

Seacat giggled and grabbed her plank. It was time to start their mission.

*****

Even with the planks, and the rising tide dragging them along, it was a long way to the base. By the time they were approaching the entrance to the Horde harbour, Seacat wasn't worried about the state of her fur any more - she wished she had slathered

more grease and oil on her. The water wasn't very cold here in the south, but she was still feeling it.

"Aright!" she heard Sea Hawk whisper from ahead of her. "Now we'll have to snorkel. Follow my lead!"

"Yes," she replied, more loudly - he didn't have her ears. A moment later, she saw him mount his snorkel and slide under the water, though still holding on to the plank. She followed his example, biting into the mouthpiece when the cold water covered her head and entered her ears. That was one reason she preferred swimming to diving - her ears weren't made for underwater.

She realised quickly that the snorkel must have come into contact with the fish oil; she could taste the oil with every breath. But they were already committed - even underwater, she could see the lights of the base's garrison sweep over the sea ahead of them. It wouldn't help them, though. Not to spot two divers.

She told herself that a few more times as the tide carried them closer and closer to the harbour entrance. Then she spotted something ahead, underwater - something massive and long. She held her breath for a moment before she realised that it was the chain that secured the harbour's entrance. The links were as large her entire torso, she noticed as she slipped above it. There was no way even a Salinean frigate would be able to force her way through that. Smaller boats, though, might work, she noted.

But they were now inside the harbour - and no alert had been sounded. As far as she could tell, at least. And Sea Hawk was still ahead of her. Things were going well. All they had to do now was to find one of the modified frigates and inspect their stern and hulls.

The captain had stopped moving, letting her catch up. "That one," she whispered as soon as she reached him, pointing at the second frigate at the pier ahead.

He nodded in response and went under again, only the snorkel peeking out of the water. Time to lose the planks - they wouldn't make it out of the harbour with them anyway; not against the tide.

Sea Hawk was a good swimmer, better than her, she had to admit, but he was pacing himself - she could easily keep up as they swam towards their target.

The Horde frigate quickly loomed over them - she had to crane her neck to look at the masts with the reefed sails for a last check before she focused on the hull. Sixteen gunports on one side; that hadn't changed. She couldn't check the cannons themselves, since the ports were closed, but the chase guns on the foredeck looked like the same guns she was familiar with. There was no one on the foredeck, as far as she could tell, but there would be a watch on the bridge; the Horde wasn't incompetent.

And indeed - as they swam along the hull to the stern, she could see two figures on the bridge, leaning against the railing. Damn! If they looked down… She quickly reached out to Sea Hawk and tugged on his arm until he looked at her. Then she pointed down.

He didn't argue - he simply dived down. She followed. If they swam under the keel of the ship, they could surface for air on the other side, and then start diving to inspect the stern.

As she dived, she ran her hand over the hull - it was plated, but with a different material than usual. That alone wouldn't explain the higher speed, though. All the Salinean ships had sheaths on their hulls as well, and the Dragon's Daughter IV's hull was kept immaculately clean thanks to its construction.

She glanced towards the stern as she cleared the keel - there was something sticking out of the keel at the aft… And there was something moving there! Someone - a fishman!

If the Horde scum raised the alarm, Seacat and Sea Hawk were dead - they couldn't escape the harbour. Not with everyone

looking for them.

No time to resurface - if the enemy had spotted them, it would be too late. She clenched her teeth and swam towards the figure, drawing her cutlass halfway to her mark.

Seacat hated fighting underwater - she couldn't use most fencing techniques Sea Hawk had taught her, and the water's resistance made her feel sluggish and slow. But she knew how to fight - be it against sea monsters or Horde scum. Same difference, anyway.

The fishman - she couldn't make out his exact type, but he didn't have tentacles and wasn't a shark - was doing some work on the thing protruding from the keel. Fixing a hole or something? It didn't matter right now. What mattered was that he was so focused on his work, he didn't notice her until she was almost on top of him. But when he saw her, he didn't hesitate - he immediately tried to flee.

And the man was fast - if she hadn't been about to strike, he would've escaped. But as it was, her energy blade caught him in the chest as he whirled, and he bent over, clutching his ribs.

That gave her enough time to grab onto his flailing arm with her free hand, digging her claws into his flesh. He tried to shake her off as she drew her cutlass back for another stab at him, but without success - she wrapped her legs around his waist before he managed to free his arm at the cost of her claws carving deep gouges into it.

Blood started to colour the water around them, yet the fishman was still fighting - he struck at her with his good arm, and she only managed to deflect the blow so it hit her shoulder. That also stopped her from stabbing him - her thrust went wide.

At least he had stopped trying to drag her to the surface with him, but her air was starting to run out. Damn. She had to finish this quickly! He hit her in her side, hard enough to make her lose air

but not hard enough to dislodge her, and she lashed out with her left hand, slashing across his face.

He recoiled - a familiar reaction, somehow - and hit her with both flailing arms. If not for the water softening the blows, she would've been doomed. But she needed air!

She struck again, this time going for his gills. Her claws sliced through the soft flesh there and tore into his throat. They got stuck on something, almost entangled, but then he hit her again, and as the force of his frantic blow finally forced her away from him and dislodged her snorkel, it also forced her claws to come free - taking half his throat with them.

Seacat lunged again, holding on to the thrashing, dying Horde scum. He couldn't surface. Not alive, not dead - that would alert the watch on deck. But she needed air. Damn, she needed to breathe.

She pushed herself up, using her legs to push the fishman down herself towards the surface, grabbing frantically for her snorkel. If she stayed underwater she should be safe. But the snorkel was full of water - and she didn't have the breath left to blow it clear.

She had to risk it. She surfaced and gulped down air, chest heaving, then quickly emptied the snorkel and dived below the water again. If anyone had seen her… But no lights came searching for her. And she could breathe again - although the air faintly tasted like blood through the snorkel.

Blood… damn, any shark within miles would soon smell the blood in the water. And any fishman with a sensitive nose, too. Where was Sea Hawk? And where was the Horde scum?

She took a deep breath and dived again, swimming downwards as fast as she could. Where was… Oh! Sea Hawk was there, sticking the fishman's corpse to the hull? She should've thought of that! That way, it wouldn't surface and tip off the Horde sailors on watch.

She swam to him, then pointed at the pipe the Horde scum had been fixing. It was large - and aimed straight at the rudder. And open. That must be what made the frigates faster! But how did it work?

She gripped it - metal, and quite thick - and peered inside. There was something glowing dimly, very dimly, inside. But even her sharp eyes couldn't make out what it was. And she needed to breathe again.

She had enough air left to clear her snorkel, so she didn't have to actually surface, but it was still too close for comfort. How long would it be until the fishman would be missed? Did he have a schedule to report in? An upcoming shift change? She didn't know how the Horde ran things. She should have asked Blondie about such things.

No - this wasn't the time to think about what she should've done. She had a mission to finish. If only she knew…

Sea Hawk surfacing next to her interrupted her thoughts. He pointed forward, towards the bow of the frigate. Oh! She nodded and sank a little, then swam along the hull towards the bow.

Yes! Below the waterline - way below - there was an opening in the middle, protected by a grate. The same width of the pipe in the back. So…. water would go in here, and out in the back. Somehow pushing the ship ahead.

The captain pointed up again, then swam up. Seacat followed him. This time, he surfaced, so she did the same, resisting the urge to shake the water out of her ears.

"We've got it," he announced. "Now it's time for a distraction!"

Distraction? Her eyes widened as she saw him pulling a bottle from his belt. What was he trying to do with his spare fish oil...? No, that wasn't fish oil! Of course, Sea Hawk wouldn't sneak into a Horde base without planning to set something on fire!

As she realised this, the captain quickly pulled the cap off the bottle, revealing a wick stuffed into the top part. He pulled it out, then activated his energy sword and set it on fire.

Seacat dived under the water - just in case he missed his throw. When she resurfaced, she saw flickering lights above her, on the frigate's foredeck. And she could hear cries from the watch.

It was past time to get the hell out of the harbour. As fast as she could, Seacat swam towards the exit at snorkel depth. Which wasn't as fast as she liked, what with the tide still rising. But she was still faster than Sea Hawk, if not by far.

And as much as she didn't like to admit it, the distraction was working - everyone seemed to be headed towards the frigate, instead of hunting for them. Then again, it wouldn't take them long to realise that saboteurs were in the water, and start searching. They had to hurry and get out of the harbour so they could go with the tide, further into the bay, away from the base.

She kept swimming, expecting searchlights to go off at any moment. But they didn't. Not until they had passed over the chain again and entered the bay proper, where the tide pulled them away from prying eyes, to the floaters they had stashed in advance to help them cross the bay to the Dragon's Daughter IV.

*****

The Milk Run

"Cadets! Fall in line!"

She growled as she started moving - the instructor was screaming loud enough to hurt her ears. Were they deaf or something? It wasn't uncommon in the Horde, especially among former artillerymen. Or sailors. The big cannons were incredibly loud.

But they didn't need to yell that loud, she thought as she jogged towards the wall across the square. She didn't need to be the fastest, she only needed to beat Kyle, who was still limping from his mishap on the obstacle course, to not be the last cadet of the formation. And she could beat him in her sleep even when he wasn't hurt.

Then she saw Adora, already at parade rest at the head of the line, glaring at her. Scoffing, she sped up. Her friend was always on her case about not making an effort - as if you needed to. She'd seen the actual soldiers - they never gave their all in drills. As long as she did enough to succeed, everything was fine.

She grinned as she took up position next to Adora, elbowing Lonnie out of the way. "Hey, Adora," she whispered.

"Catra!" her friend hissed back. "You need to be quicker! The instructor knows you can do better."

She was about to retort, but then Kyle finally arrived, and the instructor started screaming again, and her ears hurt once more. As if they would win the war by standing extra-straight in formation! All that would do was to present the princesses with better targets! She suppressed a chuckle at her thought.

"Cadet Catra! Did I say something funny?"

She froze and clenched her teeth. Damn. The Instructor had noticed. "No, Force Sergeant!" she yelled.

"Then why were you grinning like a demented rebel? Huh?"

She stood ram-rod straight, as their first instructor - who had been a deaf former artillerywoman - had called it. "I don't know, Force Sergeant!"

"If you can grin like an idiot, you can do pushups - all of you! Give me thirty, everyone!"

She hissed as she dropped down and started doing pushups. This was bad. And so unfair - everyone would be on her case for this as if it was her fault that the instructor was an arse.

"I told you!" Adora whispered next to her.

"Shut up!" she hissed back.

"If you can still whisper, you can do ten more!"

She suppressed a growl. This was Adora's fault! Not hers!

*****

In her hammock on the Dragon's Daughter IV, on the way back to Salineas, Seacat sighed without opening her eyes. Another weird, stupid dream. She had never been a soldier, much less a Horde soldier. And she'd never been drilled like this - the closest she had come to such exercises was observing some Horde scum walking in formation in the naval base they had left yesterday. It was better than dreaming of the dead Horde fishman, but still...

It was all Blondie's fault. If the woman hadn't insisted, even drunk, that Seacat was her missing, dead friend, she wouldn't keep having such weird nonsense dreams. She'd give the princess a piece of her mind next time they met - and not the piece of her mind that kept dreaming of her!

*****

“And this is how the propulsion mechanism looked, yes? Yes! Oh, I see! They must have managed to find a solution for the fouling. Something to prevent the impurities found in seawater from building up inside a crystal-laced matrix when the water’s partially steamed while being funnelled through it. How ingenious! I’m almost jealous! Field trip log, day seven: First results have appeared but require further examination and research!”

Seacat glanced at the others in Mermista’s throne room while the hair princess was talking to herself - or to the thing in her hand. Mermista was closely paying attention but trying not to look like it, lounging on the throne - but the way she tightly held her trident betrayed her. Sea Hawk was smiling at the princess and acting as if he didn’t notice.

Brain Boy was nodding along with the hair princess, but the shrimp looked lost yet trying to fake it. And Blondie…

...was looking at Seacat with a smile on her face.

Seacat quickly looked away, then clenched her teeth for her stupid reaction. People could look and smile at her how much they wanted to; that was no skin off her butt. She felt her cheeks heat up a little and drew a hissing breath as she stood straighter, pushing her chest out.

Seacat had no reason to be embarrassed - she had every reason to be proud, instead! They had returned with vital information for the Princess Alliance! A harrowing adventure, indeed, as Sea Hawk had told it - even if the frigate he had set on fire probably hadn’t burned down to the waterline.

Then she realised that she was standing ramrod straight - just as she had been standing in line in her dream.

She forced herself to slouch a little and shifted her weight, then put one foot in front. “So… what can we do about those ships? As they are, they’ll sail circles around the Salinean frigates.”

“Oh…” The Hair Princess looked as if she hadn’t even considered that. That wasn’t a good sign. “Well, I guess… the mechanism that provides propulsion by pumping water through the ship requires both a sort of fuel and air - the additional air intakes at the stern lead to that conclusion. Otherwise, they wouldn’t really be necessary. Although I wonder why they didn’t add the air intakes on the front of the ship.”

“That’s called the bow,” Seacat told her.

“Right, the bow.” The princess blinked. “Did you ever think of putting a giant bow there? To shoot giant arrows at the enemy? I just did, and it sounds like a fun thing!”

“That’s called chase guns, and we’ve had them for a while,” Mermista cut in. “Back on topic: How can we counter those ships?”

“Well, as I said, they need some sort of fuel and air, according to my preliminary calculations and deductions. And, as the grate on the water intake on the front - the bow, sorry - shows, the pump mechanism is also susceptible to foreign objects. Whether they could damage the mechanism or would merely reduce its efficiency remains to be discovered. In any case, clogging the intake should greatly hamper the whole propulsion system,” the Hair Princess rambled on. “As would, presumably, clogging up the air intakes. They probably are quite close to the actual mechanism, by the way, and must be rather voluminous - otherwise, from an efficiency point of view, it would’ve been much better to add intakes in the front as well.”

“Clogging up the intakes, hmm?” Sea Hawk was rubbing his moustache, Seacat noticed. “That sounds like a daring plan!”

“You’d need to get very, very close,” Seacat pointed out.

“Exactly! A harrowing adventure!”

“I don’t think that we’re that desperate yet,” Mermista said.

“Coulda fooled me,” the shrimp mumbled under her breath - Seacat overheard her, of course - which prompted Brain Boy and Blondie to frown at their friend.

“Not to mention that we’d have to face their guns to get close enough to clog their pipes,” Seacat added. “Best case, that’s two chase guns handled by their best gunners. Worst case, they turn and give us a broadside.” And even average Horde gunners wouldn’t miss too much at point-blank range.

Sea Hawk, of course, looked even more eager.

“And even if you can manage, you’re just one crew. We’d need at least one ship per enemy frigate,” Mermista said. “Small ships with expert sailors willing to face such odds…”

“Exactly!”

“Well, I could help with that!” Hair Princess piped up.

“You could?” Mermista looked surprised.

“Sure I could! A catapult to deliver the payload, and you won’t have to go near the enemy at all!” The princess’s hair tentacles were moving rapidly as she started sketching things on a whiteboard nearby. And on the wall next to it. Mermista wouldn’t be pleased.

“A catapult! That could be used with different payloads, right?” Sea Hawk asked, beaming at the princess.

“Sure, I guess,” the Hair Princess replied without looking up from her scribbled notes.

“Perfect! This might revolutionise boarding tactics!”

“No!” Seacat blurted out - together with half the people in the room.

*****

An hour later, the meeting had broken up. Officially, at least - it had become a research and development session, as the Hair Princess called it, long before that, of course. Seacat didn't care either way. As long as the Alliance found a way to stop the Horde frigates - preferably without sending brave sailors, like Seacat herself, to their doom - she was fine with it. Although she wasn't looking forward to having a catapult installed on the Dragon's Daughter IV. That was as bad as hiring Sea Hawk to transport a cargo full of oil drums.

"That was very brave of you," Blondie interrupted Seacat's thoughts. "Sneaking into the naval base like that…"

Seacat narrowed her eyes a little, then grinned and shrugged. "What can I say? We're the best!" They had done well, after all.

The shrimp frowned a little at her boasting, Seacat noted, but Blondie smiled. "Though now it's our turn. We'll have to find out what fuel those frigates need."

Seacat hid her frown. If she had paid more attention to the warehouses in the base, she might've found out that information as well. She should have, in any case, but she had been too focused on the ships. Sloppy. And now Blondie would have to do a spy mission. "I still say we could sneak into the naval base again."

"You probably could," Blondie admitted, "but then who would fetch the materials Entrapta needs?"

Someone with a slower boat. Which might mean the princess's devices wouldn't be ready in time for the next battle. If they were too slow, a possible Horde blockade might stop them entirely. There were good reasons for Sea Hawk and Seacat not doing the spy mission, but she didn't like them anyway. "Well, don't get caught. Wouldn't want to have all our work be ruined."

Blondie snorted. "We won't!"

"And if we are, I'll get us out," the shrimp butted in. "I can move us across the entire Fright Zone in a single teleport," she boasted.

“Yes, you’re really good at running away,” Seacat told her with a wide smile that grew even wider when she saw the princess scowl.

*****

Seacat spotted Blondie before the other woman reached the pier that the Dragon’s Daughter IV was tied to and sighed. She knew that walk: All determination and stubbornness. Like Mermista when she was angry. No, actually it was different. And she hadn’t seen Blondie like that before, had she? So why...

“Hello.”

And there she was. Seacat forced her stupid thoughts away. “Ahoy,” she replied with a grin.

“Permission to come aboard?”

Oh? Had she been reading up on sailing? “We’re no fancy navy ship with all that stuff. Hop on deck.”

Blondie did. She wasn’t jumping as easily as Seacat, or with as much style as Sea Hawk, but it was still impressive. Sort of.

“I thought you were planning your spy mission,” Seacat said. Just as she was preparing the ship for their own mission.”

“Well, I told them all I knew. I was never actually in the Horde Supply Corps, so that wasn’t all that much,” Blondie said. “Glimmer and Mermista will be sorting it out.”

That made sense. Mermista knew all about the Horde supply routes by sea, and the shrimp would know about the landlubber side of the war. Or should - Bright Moon had been on the frontlines for years, after all, and the shrimp apparently was the commander of their army.

“So you came to help me get the ship ready because you were bored.” Seacat nodded as if that was obvious.

“No!” Blondie blinked. “I mean… not that I won’t help, but I wasn’t bored.”

“You weren’t? Those were some of the most boring meetings I had ever seen,” Seacat lied. She had seen and attended far worse.

“Really?” Blondie looked surprised, and, for a moment, Seacat thought she would call her on her claim. Then the other woman shook her head. “No, I came for another reason.” She stood a little straighter and narrowed her blue eyes slightly, facing Seacat. “Why are you needling Glimmer?”

Oh. Seacat narrowed her eyes in turn. Defending her best friend, was she? “Someone has to, to keep her head from getting too big.” And it was fun to see her all worked up, of course.

“She isn’t like that!” Blondie protested. “She works very hard. And she cares about everyone.”

This time, Seacat huffed. “She’s a princess and thinks she knows best.”

“Well…” Blondie looked quite cute with that scrunched-up expression, but she couldn’t deny this, could she? “But that’s still no reason to make her mad!”

“It’s also funny.” Seacat bared her fangs at Blondie. “And she needs to learn how to control her temper before she becomes queen. I’m actually helping her.”

Blondie opened her mouth, then closed it before opening it again. “That’s… That’s…” Suddenly, she frowned at Seacat. “You’re just doing this because you think it’s fun, aren’t you?”

Rats. Seacat took care to shrug in an especially bored-looking way. “You can have more than one reason for doing something, can’t you?”

The frown didn’t vanish. “Yes. But you’re doing it because you think it’s funny.”

Seacat was frowning herself now. “Well, it is funny. You should try it yourself,” she added with a slightly forced grin. She had no reason to feel bad - it was funny, but also needed. Two birds, one stone or something.

Once more, Blondie gaped at her. Then the woman sighed and closed her eyes, rubbing the bridge of her nose. “Glimmer doesn’t think it’s funny.”

“That’s part of why it’s funny,” Seacat retorted. “Don’t you think it’s at least a little funny?”

Blondie shook her head with a stern expression. Still, Seacat had seen a hint of a smile and a little red blush appear for a moment before vanishing again. So she smiled widely at the other woman until Blondie sighed.

“I didn’t actually come here to talk about you and Glimmer, you know?”

“No, I didn’t,” Seacat replied. “Why did you do it, then?”

“I thought it was a good opener.”

Seacat snorted. “You should’ve opened with ‘Hey, can I help you?’ instead.”

“Then you’d have me sweep the deck for an hour.”

Seacat smirked. Of course she’d have done that - who would turn down free help? “So, why did you come then?”

Blondie sighed again. That was a bad sign. “What you did was very dangerous.”

Seacat shrugged. “Someone had to do it. Might as well send the best, so it actually gets done.”

“Yes, but… Look, we’ve got a good plan, but we might be a little too late to stop the Horde frigates.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. “We’ll try anyway!” The Horde would take the kingdom over her dead, floating - or sinking - body.

“Yes, but… What I meant was that you’re doing dangerous missions. You might…” Blondie took a deep breath. “...you might die on one of your missions.”

“Yes,” Seacat said, nodding. She tried to appear confident and casual. She didn’t want to die, but war was dangerous. Of course, so was she. And anyway… “The same goes for you,” she pointed out.

“Oh, I’m She-Ra, I’m very hard to kill. It’s you I’m worried about.”

Did she just…? Seacat felt her tail poof up as she clenched her teeth and growled at the idiot. “Worry about yourself, first!”

“But…” Blondie looked confused. “I didn’t mean you’re helpless or weak…”

“Of course not!” Seacat scoffed. The woman just had to double down on the insult, had she?

“But… you’re usually alone out there, with no one except Sea Hawk, and in a small ship. I’m fighting with Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, Netossa, Spinderella and sometimes Frosta. And Bright Moon’s army, of course. If I should get hurt - which I haven’t yet, not really - there are lots of people to help and save me.”

“And you’re facing the entire Horde,” Seacat shot back.

“Not the entire Horde - they have to garrison a lot of territory, and we keep them off-balance with raids all along the border, so they need to use even more soldiers to guard their supply lines.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “And they don’t raid your supply lines?” The Horde soldiers were scum, but they weren’t stupid.

Blondie grinned. “They try, but they don’t have princesses. They need a lot more troops to stop one of our raids than we need to

stop one of theirs."

"They have the bug woman," Seacat retorted. And that woman looked like she could take on an army by herself.

"Ah… Scorpia rarely appears on the frontlines."

"Then she must be up to something worse."

"Well, we'll see. Scorpia isn't your typical Horde soldier."

"Of course she isn't. If she were, we'd have lost the war already. At least on land." Seacat bared her fangs at the other woman in a sneer.

"Hey!" Blondie frowned at her in return. "Anyway, I'm just saying you're taking bigger risks than we do. Especially with those super-ships the Horde has now."

"So? We've taken even worse risks." Hell, Blondie had been there - well, present - in the Battle of Salineas!

"What? But…" The other woman pressed her lips together for a moment, visibly trying to calm down. "Look, I'm worried about you."

"Worried about me? Or about your friend?" Seacat huffed and crossed her arms.

"I'm worried about you no matter what." Blondie glared back.

Which meant she still thought Seacat was her former Horde cadet friend. "Well, you don't have to be. We're going on a milk run. Even with cargo, we can outsail the Horde frigates."

"You were saved by a raincloud last time," Blondie retorted.

"We were caught in a bad spot with the wind blowing from the wrong direction," Seacat told her. "But even then, we could've escaped if we had known how fast the Horde frigates were. Now

that we know, they won't catch us downwind like that again." The Dragon's Daughter IV would start evading much sooner, and they'd pick a route that wouldn't let the Horde ships use their sails to best effect.

"And what if the wind turns?" Blondie shook her head. "It's still more dangerous than what we're doing on land."

"Yeah, because ships can so easily hide in the brush or in a building and ambush you."

"We've turned the last such ambush back on them," Blondie said, glaring. "I doubt that they'll try that again anytime soon."

"Why not? They've got soldiers to spare, and they only need to get lucky once."

"That also goes for you!"

"It's not the same on the sea." It was different. A different war.

"Why not?"

"We're fighting ships, not soldiers." Unless they were fighting a boarding action, of course.

"So? One unlucky hit and your mast goes down, and you're helpless!"

So, Blondie had been studying naval warfare or something. Or she had paid more attention to Seacat's stories at the Princess Prom than Seacat had expected.

"One unlucky hit and you're out. Or one of your friends."

"I'm very tough."

"Tough enough to bounce a cannon shell off your hair poof?" Shells that could wreck ships didn't care about tiaras.

“Well… I’ve never tried that. I mean, I’ve never had to try. Wait! Are you making fun of my hairstyle?”

“Is this a serious question?” Seacat cocked her head with a grin.

“My hairstyle is perfectly fine!” Was Blondie finally getting angry?

“Perhaps in the Horde.”

“Hey! No one else had my hairstyle!”

“I think I’ll have to raise my estimation of our enemies’ intelligence, then.” She bared her fangs at the stupid, stubborn woman.

Suddenly, Blondie was laughing. After a moment, Seacat joined in. She couldn’t help it, for some weird reason.

“I’m just worried about you,” Blondie said after both of them had calmed down again, leaning against the railing.

“But you expect everyone else not to worry about you?”

“I’m She-Ra. I’m supposed to protect everyone else. That’s my destiny.”

“Who said that?”

“Li… that’s not important.” The woman shook her head. “I’ll fight, and we’ll win.”

“Yes, of course.” They had no choice, after all.

“But I worry that, well…” Blondie trailed off. “If we couldn’t…”

“Couldn’t what?” Seacat narrowed her eyes again. Couldn’t have sex? Or couldn’t ‘remember’? If this was just another attempt to make her believe that she was a former Horde scum...

Blondie stared at her for a moment, wetting her lips. Then she sighed. “Just don’t die.”

Seacat scoffed. “Don’t worry.”

Blondie’s chuckle sounded very forced.

*****

One of the worst parts of a milk run was the boredom. Seacat was reminded of that fact a few days into their cargo trip. The wind was blowing steady and from behind them, the course was easy to keep, and there were no enemies on the horizon. Which meant there was nothing to do. Well, not nothing - you could always clean or fix something on a ship, so she was currently splicing rope - but nothing that really required her concentration.

Or Sea Hawk’s. Which was worse.

She suppressed a sigh when she saw the captain approach her on the foredeck. “Hey! Everything shipshape?”

“Of course,” she replied. As if she’d accept anything else.

“Good, good!” He leaned against the railing across from her, then looked at the horizon, then at the top of the mast.

“What?” Seacat asked, rolling her eyes.

“What?”

“What do you want?” she asked again. It wouldn’t be a good thing - Sea Hawk rarely needed to work up to a talk with her. He was more the ‘blurt it out’ type.

“Ah.” He beamed at her. “Since the sea and the wind are currently favouring us, I thought we could have a talk or something!”

“The weather can change in a heartbeat,” she reminded himself.

“If it does, we’ll be at our posts in a heartbeat as well!”

“Right.”

“Anyway!” He took a deep breath, then coughed into his fist. “I was wondering about your relationship to Adora - She-Ra.”

“There is no relationship,” she replied at once.

He raised his eyebrows at her but didn’t say anything.

Frowning - and clenching her teeth - she added: “She’s talking to her missing friend, not to me.”

“Are you sure?”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. What exactly did he mean? Was this a hint that he believed Blondie’s absolutely stupid claims? Or was he just asking if Blondie might be talking to Seacat instead of this ‘Catra’? “She still thinks I’m her missing friend. And she’s oh so afraid I’ll die before I ‘remember’.”

“Well…” The captain drew the word out. “She’s been sticking to her story.”

“Which makes no sense.” Seacat scoffed. “You know the Horde - they don’t send cadets into battle.” The scum had no honour, but some lines they didn’t cross. If only because sending children into battle meant fewer adult soldiers in the long run.

“Mistakes do happen.”

“So, this Catra mistakenly arrives at a force that’s about to attack a village, and instead of, well, sending her back, they let her join them?” Seacat scoffed. She wouldn’t have joined butchers about to massacre a village. Cadet or not. “I think the girl deserted and got killed by some monster, and they covered it up so her fellow cadets wouldn’t get any ideas.”

Sea Hawk nodded, but she could tell that he wasn’t convinced.

“I’m not Catra,” she said, baring her fangs at him. “I’m Seacat.”

“Of course!” He flashed her a smile. A genuine one. “But… are you worried about her?”

“She’s She-Ra. Legendary Princess of Power.” Seacat rolled her eyes. “She can throw some of those Horde bots.”

“And bounce shells off her face,” Sea Hawk said. “Or so the legends claim.”

Seacat snorted. She’d believe that if she saw it - not that she wanted to see Blondie get hit by a shell. A boot to the head, on the other hand…

“I just noticed that you’ve been spending more time with her than with anyone - except for me and Mermista, of course.”

She scoffed. “She’s the one following me around.”

“When she’s not carrying you to bed.” The captain grinned at her.

She glared at him in return. “You won’t ever let me forget that, huh?”

“Of course not!” He chuckled, then shook his head and sighed. “Although you should consider that the war’s growing worse. In the last year, the Horde has made more headway than in the decade before.”

Since the Princess Alliance had fallen apart, in other words. “Is it really that bad?”

“Yes. They’ve been building up. New and more weapons. The frigates are just one part of that. Bright Moon’s been hit by more of those giant walking bots they have, and they’ve been fielding mobile cannons.”

“Mobile cannons?”

“Yes.”

“But… the recoil would wreck any skiff they mounted it on!” It had been tried before, after all.

“They don’t shoot while flying - they set down for that.”

“Oh.” That would be… ugh. She winced.

“Yes. So… perhaps… think about not being too stubborn to miss out on something…” He tilted his head in a not-quite-shrug. “...beautiful?”

He patted her head and left to return to the bridge before she could think of an answer.

*****

Perched on the top of the mast, Seacat narrowed her eyes. Was that…? She squinted, then nodded. The Sea Gate’s slight glow was unmistakable. “Salineas ahead!” she yelled down to the captain.

“As expected!” he yelled back. “We’ve made good time!”

They had - despite the heavy cargo they were transporting back to Salineas. But they weren’t in port, yet. They hadn’t spotted any Horde ships on their trip, so the new frigates had to be somewhere - and blockading Salineas was an obvious move. The enemy ships would be able to intercept arriving ships easily - or, at the very least, drive them away - and sooner or later, the Salinean navy would have to give them battle or see the kingdom starve.

But if there was a blockade, they should’ve seen the pickets guarding the western approaches of the kingdom already. This was the obvious route to take, most of the other routes locked by reefs and the Maelstrom, so where were the Horde sailors?

“Do you see any sails?” Sea Hawk, of course, knew this as well.

“No!” she yelled back, clenching her teeth. She used her telescope to scan the horizon - none. Wait… “There’s one!” She adjusted the telescope, which was a little tricky doing one-handed, and got a clearer view of the sail. “It’s a Salinean sloop.”

“Alright.” He didn’t ask if she were sure, of course.

Seacat felt relieved - trying to outrun a new Horde frigate with a cargo hold full of metal and other materials would have been a little difficult, even with the wind blowing from a favourable direction. But she couldn’t help worrying, either.

If the Horde frigates weren’t blockading Salineas then where were they?

*****

“Landing operations?”

“Yes.” Mermista wasn’t happy. She was very unhappy, in fact. And not at Sea Hawk, for a change. “The Horde has launched a campaign up the Northern Coast, supported by several landing operations to encircle and take port after port. If they aren’t stopped, they’ll soon control the coast up to the Northern Sea.”

And cutting off Salineas from support by the Alliance - with so many ports, the Horde could easily control the sea up to the Kingdom of Snows.

“We didn’t know - we were at sea for the last few days,” Sea Hawk said. “But surely, we can stop them before they advance too far! If they conduct landing operations, they are vulnerable to a naval attack!”

“We can’t face their frigates and hope to defeat them,” Mermista said. “We lost two frigates on patrol already. I’ve called back the entire fleet until we can counter their advantages.” She smiled for the first time since they had arrived in the throne room. “Which is why your cargo was so essential.”

“Princess Entrapta must be glad to finally have the materials to finish her work,” Sea Hawk said, smiling himself.

Mermista grimaced for a moment before she nodded. “I suppose so.”

*****

“Oh! This is just perfect! The density is in the green range, too! And there’s enough for several tests! Oh, and this! What’s this?”

‘Glad’ wasn’t the right word to describe the Hair Princess’s reaction. ‘Ecstatic’ would be better. Or ‘hyper’. The princess was all but bouncing around in the room she had obviously transformed into a laboratory or workshop… Wait, now she had taken a leap and bounced off the wall to get behind a stack of metal plates.

“Hello, Entrapta. You’ve got the cargo, I see,” Mermista said.

“Yes, yes, I did! Thank you so much!” The princess used her hair to jump over another stack and land next to Sea Hawk, wrapping him up in purple tentacles. Like a demented squid. “And you!”

Before Seacat could react, the princess moved over to her, and Seacat found herself wrapped in hair. Tightly wrapped. “Hey!”

“Thank you!” The princess whirled, moving back towards her bench. Seacat felt herself dragged along and was about to use her claws to get free when she was suddenly dumped on the floor - which was littered with parts, one of which dug painfully in her rump.

“Ow!” she complained, but it wasn’t like the princess even heard her.

“Those are the last high-tensile components I needed!”

“So you can build your countermeasures, then?” Mermista asked.

“What?” The princess looked up but didn’t remove her mask, which made her look like one of her creepy bots. “Oh, yeah, sure. That’s easy, just have to use the chemical converter over there. Shouldn’t take more than a day to convert the base material.”

“So you’re working on the catapults?” Sea Hawk asked.

“No. Should I? Those are easy, anyway, and a mature technology.” This time, the mask slid up, and the princess’s confused expression was clearly visible. “Your yard workers should be able to build as many as you need.”

Seacat wasn’t the only one who blinked. “You’ve already finished the countermeasures?”

“The design, yes. Others can build it - it’s not First One’s tech. Oh, did you know that if you do everything yourself, you hurt the economy of your kingdom? People need work or they’ll leave, which reduces the amount of taxes and customs you receive, which reduces your research and development budget!”

“Err, yes,” Mermista replied. Sea Hawk nodded.

“I had to learn that for myself.” The princess pouted, then beamed. “But that’s all in the past now that I have the new materials!”

“So…” Sea Hawk spoke up. “If you’re not working on the counteragent or catapults, what are you working on?”

“Happy you asked!” The princess jumped up and landed next to a covered board. Her hairs grabbed the cover and ripped it away, revealing a whiteboard with…

“You’re working on a propulsion system?” Seacat asked.

“Yes!” The smile widened even more. “With this - once it works - your frigate will be the fastest on the seas again!” Then she frowned. “Well, for about half an hour so far.”

Oh.

*****

A few days later, the Salineans were still working on the catapults. Apparently, it was a little harder than the Hair Princess had claimed. Especially since the 'mature technology' actually meant that no one had constructed catapults in a century or so, what with everyone using guns on ships and for sieges instead.

"Should we go seek cover?" Seacat asked as she watched three sailors handle a catapult on a small platform on the shore near the Sea Gate.

Mermista glared at her. "This catapult was built exactly to Entrapta's specifications."

"I thought all the others were built to her specs as well," Seacat replied.

"They were supposed to," Mermista admitted. "But there were a few problems with the building process."

And with quality control. Like sinking the boat the first catapult had been mounted on. Seacat was very happy that she had managed to stop Sea Hawk from volunteering their ship for testing.

"But it's all fine now," the princess went on. More loudly, she added: "Fire when ready!"

"Aye, aye!" the commander of the catapult crew replied before turning to his men. "Alright, you scallywags! The princess herself is watching! If you mess up, she'll have us all keelhauled!"

Seacat snickered at that - and at Mermista's expression. "Great discipline, princess."

"Keelhauling isn't actually practised any more in the Salinean Navy," Mermista replied with a deep frown.

“But do they know that?” Sea Hawk asked.

“Yes. They should, at least.”

In Seacat’s opinion, some of the Salinean sailors would deserve to get keelhauled, if only to encourage the others. Like the crew on the slow frigate in the Battle of Salineas. The catapult crew there, though, threw their backs into it. Two used a crank to pull the arm down, and the third carried the payload - a dummy cask - to load it.

This time, the arm didn’t break, and the catapult didn’t flip over either. It worked as advertised, sending the cask flying in a high arc.

But it didn’t come near the target. Not even close.

“They need more training at aiming,” Sea Hawk commented. “It’s not like aiming a cannon.”

Mermista frowned.

Seacat did so as well. It took weeks to train a gunner so they could hit anything from a ship at sea. She didn’t think it would take less time to train a catapult crew - quite the contrary, actually.

And they didn’t have the time. Not with the Horde rolling up the coast.

*****

It took the princesses a little longer to realise what Seacat already knew, but after a day’s worth of training - which resulted in another catapult self-destructing and one botched shot almost hitting the Sea Gate - Mermista announced that the catapult project would be abandoned. “We won’t be ready in time. We need to use our current weapons instead of new ones,” she said in her throne room after dinner.

“Technically, it’s not a new weapon at all, but a very old one. Salineas was once protected by numerous catapults covering the approaches,” the Hair Princess retorted. “Catapults of various sizes, even! And installed on ships.”

“Very old or new, the thing is, our sailors aren’t trained to use catapults. And I cannot send them into battle with weapons they don’t understand. That would be murder,” Mermista told her.

“Well, actually… Oh. You were using hyperbole, weren’t you?”

“Yes,* Mermista replied through clenched teeth.

“Thanks! Socialising log day thirty-one: I correctly identified hyperbole.”

Seacat didn’t know if she should laugh at the princess or pity her. There were more important concerns, anyway. “What are you planning then? Shoot the casks out of cannons?”

“That won’t work,” Mermista replied.

“Have you tried it?” Seacat asked.

“Yes! The pressure from the cannon’s charge is too much for the cask!” The Hair Princess made a gesture with her hands that indicated an explosion. “I constructed a cask that was tough enough to withstand the pressure, but that meant it was tough enough not to break up upon hitting the water, which kinda defeated the purpose of shooting it in the first place. I’m trying to calculate the right structural strength so the cask will only just survive the shooting and will be so damaged, it’ll break as soon as it hits the water, but it’s a very fine line - and the standardisation of Salinean cannons leaves a lot to be desired!”

“At least our cannons don’t blow up if they’re handled a little roughly,” Mermista shot back.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “As much as I like explosions and catapults, what are our plans now to battle the Horde frigates? Is

your new method of propulsion ready to be tested?”

“Yes! It is!” The princess beamed at them. “I just need a volunteer!”

“Not the Dragon’s Daughter IV,” Mermista snapped.

“But it’s ideal for my tests! Light enough so the propulsion booster will show its true potential!”

That sounded worrying. And the gleam in Sea Hawk’s eyes was even more worrying.

“No.” The Salinean princess looked grim. “We’ll need the ship in top shape to lead the battle against the Horde.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. She knew what that meant. “You’re going to swarm the frigates and pour the stuff into the sea at close range.” So close, the Horde frigates would have an easy time aiming their guns.

Mermista nodded. “I don’t like it, but it’s our only chance.”

Seacat didn’t like it either. Not at all. But the princess was right - they had no choice.

“But… I just need a little more time to finish my device!” the Hair Princess protested. “Your chances of survival would be much improved with it!”

“We don’t have the time. If we don’t stop the Horde now, they’ll take Seaworthy, and with that port in their power, they’ll cut the alliance in half. There’s not much north of Seaworthy that could stop them.”

“But…” The Hair princess shook her head, her tentacles flailing around, “That’s… your chances of survival are far too low! It’s irrational!”

“Our chances of survival might be low, but our chances of success are better. And it’s our only option,” Seacat said, chuckling without any humour. Even the weird princess who was often more like a bot than a person knew how bad this was.

Sea Hawk, though, was beaming. “Huzzah! A daring, desperate gambit awaits us! Adventure!”

*****

The Battle of Seaworthy

She sniffed the air and made a face. There was that smell again. She had the best nose of all the cadets, and the smell was really noticeable among the usual smells of the Fright Zone. No smoke, no stink of whatever materials the factories used, but… weird. Wrong, kind of.

"What's wrong?" Adora asked, looking up from where she was watching the formation drills on the square below them.

"Something stinks," she replied. "Very much."

"It's probably you," Lonnie butted in with a sneer. "You 'forgot' to wash again?"

She snarled at the stupid girl. "I didn't forget - I didn't need to!" It wasn't her fault that the others couldn't smell how bad the water stank. She didn't smell bad, anyway - she had hardly made an effort at the exercises. She didn't need to, anyway - it was easy to tag the clumsy and slow practice bots.

"Ew."

"Catra! You can't neglect your hygiene!" Adora blurted out.

"I didn't!" she protested. "Lonnie's stinky, anyway. I'm fine."

"Really?" Before she could react, Adora had stepped up to her and started sniffing her.

"What are you doing?" She gasped - Adora was far too close - her stupid hair poof was almost tickling her chin!

"Checking. A good officer always checks and verifies reports," Adora replied, twisting her neck in an attempt to smell her arms.

She moved back, crossing her arms over her chest, and felt her cheeks heat up. "Don't do that! I'm fine!"

Adora frowned. "You always say you're fine. Even when you aren't!"

"I am fine!" she snarled. "And I don't smell!"

But Adora sniffed the air. "No. That's a bad smell!"

"That's not me - that's the stench I smelt before!" she told her friend.

"Of course you'd say that! Stinker!" Lonnie said.

She glared at the girl, noticing that Rogelio was snickering in that lizard way of his, and even Kyle dared to smile - though the wimp paled quickly when she narrowed her eyes at him. He'd pay for that! "You don't believe me? I'll prove it! Follow me!"

She took off before the others could say anything. They didn't matter anyway - only her friend mattered, and Adora would follow her, as usual.

"Catra! Wait!"

She knew it! She grinned and smelt the air - the stench came from the direction of the disposal site. Where the wrecked gear was disposed of. That made sense.

And she knew the way - you could find useful stuff there, sometimes.

She dropped down on the catwalk below them, dashed forward past the stairs and grabbed the water pipe at the edge. She swung over the railing, slid down the pipe and hit the ground running. No one was as fast as she was when she went all-out!

She had to slow down a little to get through the maze of supply depots and pipework, but she reached her goal far ahead of the others - and not even out of breath. Which was a good thing - the stench was much worse here.

It was so bad, she had to pinch her nose closed. Really bad. And with her nose closed, she couldn't track the stench any more.

"Catra! There you are… ew!"

"See?" She turned towards Adora, who was panting. "That's where the smell came from."

"Ew!"

She nodded. "Yes, it's bad. Especially for me." No sign of Lonnie and the others. They probably hadn't had the guts to follow her. Stupid idiots, anyway.

"But what is it? I've never smelt this before," Adora asked.

"I don't know. It smells weird. Like the mess hall, once."

"Rotten, you mean." Adora nodded. "Let's find out! If someone's left food out to spoil that needs to be reported!"

She made a gagging noise - easy with the stench. "Adora! You're such a goody-shoe!"

"I'm going to be a good officer - and good officers don't look away when something's wrong!"

She rolled her eyes - that was Shadow Weaver talking. Adora was such a fool when it came to the witch. But she followed her friend - someone had to keep her out of trouble.

They moved past some wrecked bots and some destroyed cannons, turning around a corner - and stopped. And stared.

Before them were two rows of somethings, covered with tarps. Bodies, she realised after a moment - she could see some limbs and some tails sticking from under tarps.

Dead bodies. Dead Horde bodies - she could easily see the uniforms. Or their bloody remains.

"Bodies…" Adora said.

"Yes," she agreed. "Lot's of them." Almost two dozen. And they were here to be disposed of.

Without saying anything else, they both turned away and left. At a brisk pace.

And she tried to remember how often she had noticed that smell before. Then she tried to forget it.

*****

Seacat woke up in her hammock and snorted a few times - she could still smell the stench of rotting bodies. Just like on the outpost the Horde pirates had taken. But the Horde didn't do that to their own soldiers. They certainly wouldn't just dispose of their dead like broken cannons or skimmers, would they?

No, they wouldn't. This was just her worrying in her dreams about the upcoming battle. And her possible death.

*****

"Admiral! Admiral Sea Hawk! Hah! I can't wait until Scurvy hears of his!" The captain - Seacat wasn't about to call him admiral just because Mermista had said so - rubbed his moustache for the umpteenth time since they had set out from Salineas. "And we're leading the entire Salinean fleet! People will talk and sing of this battle forever!"

"As long as we're among them," Seacat muttered. She'd rather be alive and a hero than dead and a hero. Who knew what kind of lies they'd tell about her if she wasn't around to correct people? And Blondie would be crushed. And she'd also proven right about her worries. Both were unacceptable to Seacat.

"Oh, we will! The Dragon's Daughter IV is the fastest ship on all the seas. And if the wind doesn't change, we'll have the advantage we need against the Horde."

If. The wind could change. Of course, even if the wind changed unexpectedly, and in the worst moment, they probably could still pull off their attack. Hell, they could get sunk and would still be able to make a decent attempt - they carried so much of Entrapta's Solution, it was probably enough to cover the entire area around Seaworthy.

It was the getting away part that worried her. Unlike in other, slightly similar situations, they wouldn't have to swim away from a burning Horde ship with a crew that was too busy trying to fight a fire than to hunt them down - they would be facing a fleet, and even with their magic engines shut down and the crews the usual collection of scum and the dregs of the Horde, they would be able to catch up to a couple of swimmers before the rest of the Salinean fleet descended upon them.

They would have to hope that the Horde would be too preoccupied with their failing propulsion and the approaching fleet to take revenge against them. And that the 'automatic flotation devices' the Hair Princess had developed worked as advertised.

She glanced at the necklace. The princess had explained how it worked, but other than 'like inflatable, but not," it had gone over Seacat's head. She hadn't even understood half the words the princess used.

Then again, neither had the others.

"We'll see," she said. "As long as we take down the Horde fleet, we'll have done our... " She trailed off. It wasn't their duty - they were volunteers. Although Sea Hawk's promotion to admiral might have changed that, at least for him. Not for Seacat, though, She was an independent sailor. "...task," she finished lamely.

"Indeed! However, I aim to do a little bit more than what is expected of us!" Sea Hawk pointed to the horizon, where, if you squinted and had a telescope, the first peaks of the inland mountains would become visible soon. "We will make the Horde rue the day they challenged Admiral Sea Hawk's fleet!"

Well, that was something Seacat could get behind. Although… "You want to ram one of them?"

"Once they're helpless and engaged in battle, I want to board it, then set it on fire," the captain confirmed what she had already known.

"They'll be expecting that once they see our flotilla," Seacat pointed out. After the Battle of Salineas, even the Horde would have realised the danger of smaller ships ramming their warships. And worked on countering it.

"They won't expect us to board them, which will be their undoing!"

Well, that was true - for a simple reason: Two people boarding a frigate was generally suicide.

On the other hand, a panicking crew, torn between the propulsion failing, fire starting and the Salinean frigates bearing down on them… It was still damn dangerous, but they might have a chance. A better chance, in Seacat's opinion, than swimming for it.

She sighed, and Sea Hawk beamed at her.

He knew her as well as she knew him, after all. He hadn't even tried to make her stay behind, or serve as 'liaison' on a regular frigate. Even though she knew he had wanted to.

But they were crew. He was the captain, and she was the first mate. If he was leading a flotilla of volunteers in small ships, some barely more than boats, then her place was at his side.

No matter what Blondie might think.

Seacat clenched her teeth. This wasn't the time to be thinking of the woman and her weird views. She had to focus, not wonder how Blondie would react to however this might turn out.

*****

They reached Seaworthy a day later, in the afternoon. The Horde hadn't yet launched their attack, but Seacat saw several columns of smoke rising from the port. "The Horde has started their bombardment!" she told the captain.

He frowned, then checked himself with his telescope. "That doesn't look like a bombardment. Not a siege bombardment. It's probably just a few guns - mobile ones - to unnerve the defenders and possibly lure them out."

Ah. "Those mobile guns we've heard about?"

"Most likely." He grinned. "That means they don't have too many of them yet. And their fleet should be around as well. Just as planned!"

"I must have missed that planning session," she said, as sarcastically as she could manage.

"Probably," he replied with a shameless grin. "In any case, they'll have their landing troops on their ships already, so they won't be able to run from us."

"They've sunk two Salinean frigates already; I don't think they'll run anyway." Seacat wouldn't, not with such an advantage. "And they'll fear that we'll go after the transports with our flotilla." Like they had gone after the bomb vessel in the Battle of Salineas.

Sea Hawk's grin widened, and he rubbed his moustache. "They will be surprised when we go after their frigates instead! A perfect feint!"

"They'll also do their worst to sink us," she pointed out.

"They'll do that anyway!"

He had a point, though she didn't like admitting it. "Orders?" she asked instead.

“Signal the flotilla to follow us southwards! We’ll search and engage the enemy!”

“Aye aye, Captain!”

“It’s Admiral!”

She chuckled as she climbed the mast, signal flags held in her teeth.

*****

A night battle would’ve been perfect, but the Horde fleet was already closing in on Seaworthy when they found it - with enough daylight left to land the troops if left undisturbed.

“So much for great planning,” Seacat muttered under her breath as she adjusted the sails. The wind was blowing towards the coast, so neither side had an advantage. She clung to the mast with her legs, one wrapped around a line, and quickly counted the enemy fleet. Thirteen frigates. One bomb vessel, falling back - they had learned their lesson at Salineas. And half a dozen troop transports even further back - turning towards the coast. Were they trying to land troops there now?

It didn’t matter much. They were here for the frigates. “Thirteen frigates!” she called out to Sea Hawk. “One bomb vessel, six transports.”

“Signal the flotilla to pair up and pick their targets. The Dragon’s Daughter IV will go for the enemy flagship! And signal to the main fleet that we’re engaging.”

She checked the horizon - the leading ship of the Salinean main fleet, another courier, was just barely visible from her position. She signalled it first, then started relaying commands to the flotilla. A few of them were already spreading out - no discipline amongst the volunteers.

Then again, she thought as she slid down the mast, they needed bravery more than discipline for this attack.

"Prepare the cargo for dispersal!" Sea Hawk yelled as he adjusted course, lining up their ship with the leading frigate.

"Aye aye, Captain!" she replied, then moved towards the casks tied to the deck, next to improvised rails which would let them slide into the sea with little effort. And the other casks. A last check of the 'quick-release stopper' the Hair Princess had provided, then she turned towards the bridge. "Ready!"

"Alright!" Sea Hawk was grinning widely - she could see his white teeth catching the sunlight for a moment.

Then the first shells from the enemy hit the water ahead of them, followed by dozens more - the enemy battleline was firing the chase guns.

"Turn about!" Sea Hawk announced, and Seacat jumped to tighten the lines as the ship turned towards the wind, away from the coast. She craned her head to look at the enemy line. If they didn't take the bait… But they did. Fearing that the flotilla would circle around them and hit the transports, the entire battleline turned towards the wind as well.

But the Horde frigates were fastest with the wind at their back - tacking against the wind, they couldn't keep up with the fast ships following Sea Hawk. They wouldn't have to, of course, if the flotilla were going after the transports - the Horde frigates would still be able to intercept them thanks to their relative positions.

But that wasn't the goal.

The enemy had stopped firing - at their current course, the angle was wrong for either broadside or chase guns. But that would change soon - the trailing ships of the flotilla would soon be in the line of fire of the leading ships of the enemy. Still out of range, though.

Seacat clenched her teeth. They had cut it very close - possibly too close. If the wind let off just a little, they would be caught in range of the enemy broadsides before they were in position.

Minutes passed as they held course, slowly outpacing the enemy. Slowly reaching the point where the wind would be just right for the final part of their attack.

Too slowly - the enemy started firing again. Broadsides. And the trailing ships were in range. Barely, but with the sheer number of shells thrown their way…

Water columns appeared all around the last two ships. And then the second to last ship suddenly seemed to stop, dipping and listing. Hit below the waterline, Seacat realised. Keel was probably shattered, too - the mast was swaying, and the ship was already sinking.

It didn't matter, the next volley smashed the entire ship to pieces. The Horde gunners had the range, now.

She looked at Sea Hawk.

"All ships - deploy smoke and close with the enemy!"

Instead of using the signal flags to alert the ship behind them to deploy smoke and charge, Seacat simply lit the prepared smoke charge in the bow. Everyone knew the plan anyway. Then she had to jump to adjust the mainsail as the Dragon's Daughter IV turned until the wind was almost at her back and she was racing at the enemy.

The smoke was quickly blown towards the enemy line by the wind, obscuring them from view - and concealing the Salinean flotilla from the enemy gunners. Except for the enemy flagship, which was too far ahead relative to the wind's direction. That meant it had a clear line of fire at the Dragon's Daughter IV.

The enemy guns roared again, sending shells at the charging ships. Columns of water were thrown up all around them - their

sudden turn must have thrown off the gunners' aim. They would quickly adjust, though. Seacat hissed through clenched teeth, trying to estimate the rapidly closing range and the rate of fire of the enemy. At their current speed, the enemy would get off three volleys before they were close enough to dump the casks overboard.

But if the enemy was competent, they would save the last volley until point-blank range - they would expect a ramming attack and would want to sink them at the last moment. They could only hope that the enemy flagship was crewed by a competent captain - but not too skilled gunners.

"Turn about!" Sea Hawk yelled, and Seacat threw herself to pull the mainsail back as the ship swerved, turning a little into the wind. A moment later, the Horde flagship fired her broadside. Most shells went wide, missing with a good margin. A few were close enough to throw water over the decks. And one shell went through the mainsail, ripping a hole into it, before detonating in the water on the other side.

Sea Hawk quickly turned back, returning to a collision course. Seacat checked the mainsail - it was holding so far, not tearing up, but any sharp manoeuvre could change that. Any manoeuvre such as another hard turn to avoid the next salvo.

She cursed under her breath then looked to starboard. She couldn't see any of the other ships - the smoke hid them. But that meant they wouldn't be able to see much, either. They could only hope the other crews were good enough to correctly judge the distance.

Shaking her head, she looked at the enemy flagship again. The Horde used breechloaders, so there was no way to tell when the guns were ready to fire other than timing the volleys and guessing, but any moment, they'd spat more shells at them.

"Turn about!"

Once more, the Dragon's Daughter IV turned away, towards the wind, slowing down. And once again, the enemy fired a few seconds afterwards. Seacat saw the shells hit the sea, one impact closer than the other. Water washed over the deck, drenching her, but her claws anchored her to the planks - she wouldn't slip.

Then the bowsprit vanished in an explosion. The Dragon's Daughter IV shook as if it had struck a reef, and Seacat barely managed to dive behind the casks before splinters shredded her. The ship was rolling, almost stalling - without the bowsprit, the foresail was uselessly flapping.

Seacat jumped up and drew her cutlass. Two slashes, and the foresail was cut free, dropping into the sea next to them. She whirled, dashing back to her post. They were close enough that she could almost make out the expression on the Horde Sailors on deck. The water had extinguished the smoke charge - not that they needed it right now, anyway.

This was it. The Dragon's Daughter IV was damaged, but she was still sailing. Still going directly at the enemy ship. What would the enemy do? Hold their fire until they were too close to miss? If they fired now, all it would take was one hit. If they turned away to get a better angle, the Dragon's Daughter IV could turn from the wind to avoid their broadside and strike their stern - not that they wanted to.

The enemy held their fire and held their course. Seacat yelled, baring her teeth, as Sea Hawk turned the ship away again. "Release the cargo!" he yelled.

Once more, Seacat whipped her cutlass around, slashing the ropes holding the casks in place. The first cask rolled over the rails, hitting the water - and breaking up. As planned.

The enemy was now trying to change course, but a frigate wasn't as nimble as their own ship. The next cask hit the sea. And they were almost out of the firing angle of the enemy broadside. The Horde captain tried to turn to keep up, but they had missed their

moment - with each cask hitting the water, the ship grew lighter and gained more speed. The guns of the enemy broadside couldn't reach them now. And as soon as they were in front of the enemy, Sea Hawk was turning into the wind again as the last few casks hit the water - the Horde frigate wouldn't be able to avoid them.

Then the chase guns fired. One shell missed, throwing water into the air on the port side of the ship. The other shell struck the Dragon's Daughter IV's stern. The impact threw Seacat forward, sending her to crash into the rails mounted there and sliding across the deck before a rolled-up line stopped her. Despite the pain in her side, she jumped up.

She whirled and gasped - the entire afterdeck of the Dragon's Daughter IV was wrecked. The Captain! Sea Hawk! She rushed back, claws digging into the slowly tilting deck, as she tried to find him amongst the debris and smoke.

The keel must have held - they hadn't capsized already - but without the rudder, the wind hitting the mainsail was pushing the ship off course and would soon push it over. If it didn't sink or got blown before that.

"Sea Hawk!" she yelled, climbing over the remains of the stairs leading up to the wrecked afterdeck. "Captain!" Had he been blown into the water? Or... No! He couldn't have! She clenched her teeth and reached the top - the entire afterdeck was gone. She could see the keel through the empty space.

"Captain!" Where was he? Why couldn't she… There! She saw a speck of orange, down in the water, surrounded by floating debris. The flotation device had worked!

She dived into the sea without hesitation, narrowly missing a particularly large splintered beam, but instead of diving, she was pulled to the surface as her own flotation device pulled her up - the amulet had released some balloon-like swimmers around her neck. She couldn't swim like this! Or fight! Her claws made short

work of the flotation things and she pulled the device off her neck, then quickly swam towards Captain. He wasn't moving. Clenching her teeth, she grabbed him under the shoulders. "Captain!"

He wasn't answering. Was he breathing? She couldn't tell. And the Dragon's Daughter IV had turned away from the wind and was slowly rolling over. If she reached it…

The roar of another broadside almost deafened her. Eyes widening, she slashed Sea Hawk's floatation device and pulled him underwater, trying to get as deep as possible before…

She was thrown around as if hit by a minotaur, multiple times, when the shells exploded. She felt her breath being driven out of her lungs by the shockwave and almost lost her grip on the captain before she managed to claw her way back to the surface.

She gasped for air, then pulled Sea Hawk's head up as well. The Dragon's Daughter IV was gone - blown up by several shells hitting it. But there was floating debris around. On her back, she swam towards the largest, a piece of the deck, dragging Sea Hawk behind her, his head pressed to her chest, above the water. It was all she could do, and if the damned Horde wanted to finish them, she would be helpless.

But they weren't finishing them off - even with her ringing ears, she could hear the sudden screams from the flagship. They must have spotted the main fleet of the Salineans, sailing at them with the wind at their back, their approach hidden by the smoke so far.

She pulled Sea Hawk on to the floating wood and finally could check him. He was bleeding from a cut in his forehead, but his heart was beating - and he was still breathing. Coughing up foul-smelling water, tainted by the solution they had poured into the sea, but breathing.

Laughing - and coughing herself - she looked around. The smoke was mostly gone, so she could see the rest of the Horde fleet -

and what was left of the flotilla.

There weren't many ships left of them, she realised. She counted six burning wrecks, and who knew how many of the small ships had just vanished, like their own? But a few had made it through the enemy lines and were sailing away as fast as they could while the Horde ships were trying to form a line to receive the Salienan main attack.

Trying - and failing. She bared her teeth as the first shots from the Salinean chase guns rang out, shells splashing the water near the frantically turning Horde ships - and hitting them.

"Seacat?"

"Captain!" She gasped. He was awake!

"Did we ram the ship?" Sea Haw tried to push himself up on his elbows.

"No, we got sunk," she told him. "But we did wreck their ships." She wasn't lying - the Horde frigates were sailing far slower than before - slower than they had before being upgraded, even. All those water intakes must have added drag to the designs.

And the Salineans were placed in a perfect position to exploit it. They were now sailing parallel to the Horde line, exchanging broadsides - but they were easily outpacing the Horde ships and would be able to cross the enemy's T before long.

If the Horde scum lasted that long - she saw one frigate's main mast fall, dragging most of her rigging down and slowing the ship so much, the following frigate couldn't turn away in time and rammed it from behind. Two Salinean frigates lost no time swerving and raking the Horde ship's sterns with heavy volleys. The rest of the battle line stayed on course, though - and was now about to pass Seacat and Sea Hawk's position.

Which meant they were about to find themselves smack in the middle between two battle lines - and too close to the Horde ship.

“Dive!” she yelled, sliding off the piece of deck. A moment later, Sea Hawk followed.

Seacat remained underwater as long as she could hold her breath. The chance of getting hit by splinters was low, but with the number of shells a broadside threw at the enemy… When she resurfaced, gasping for air, the Horde frigate was burning and had lost one mast. Her cannons were still firing, though - and the Salinean frigate had taken several hits as well, though none of them crippling, as far as Seacat could tell.

“Huzzah! That’s the enemy flagship! Give it to them!”

“Dive!”

She turned underwater, trying to spot a glimpse of the enemy’s hull underwater, but they weren’t close enough for that. She could hear the muted explosions, though. If the enemy frigate’s magazine went up…

The next time they resurfaced, the Horde flagship had been completely demasted and she was dead in the water. Seacat could spot several horde sailors jumping into the sea. She didn’t see anyone lowering dinghies into the water - but judging by the damage she could see, they hadn’t survived the fight anyway. And the smoke rising from the hulk...

An explosion shook the frigate, sending spouts of water up in the air - not the main magazine; probably propellant left on the gun deck - and the frigate slowly started to turn turtle.

“And down she goes! Hah! Another heroic adventure successfully concluded!” Sea Hawk yelled, pointing at the sinking ship.

“Thanks to the Salinean fleet,” Seacat muttered as she pulled herself up on the piece of deck from the Dragon’s Daughter IV that had remained nearby.

“They helped, of course, as was the plan!” the captain exclaimed as he followed her.

Seacat was too busy watching the enemy's hull as it completely turned over to reply. There was the water intake - and the pipe at the stern.

"Hm. With the water pushed straight at the rudder, the frigate should've been more responsive. I think there's more to the engine than what we assumed," Sea Hawk said.

She glanced at him and saw that he was squeezing water out of his moustache. "I think we've got more things to worry about than that," she said.

"On the contrary! Until we're picked up by our valiant allies, we have nothing else to do than wait and watch!"

Well, he had a point. She looked around. The enemy's numbers had been reduced to about half, from what she could see, what with smoke from burning ships blocking her view in some areas. And all the Horde frigates she could spot were in bad shape, engaged by at least one Salinean ship.

A not so distant explosion sent smoke and fire high in the air - that had been a magazine going up. A Horde frigate's, or so Seacat hoped. The Salineans hadn't escaped unscathed either - she could only count nine frigates still sailing, and what might be a burning hulk in the distance. But the outcome wasn't in doubt any more.

She saw two Salinean frigates finish off the closest Horde frigate. Good! That meant… She blinked. They were turning away? Oh. "They're going after the transports."

"Of course! With the enemy fleet defeated, this is the best opportunity to end the threat of another landing!" the captain said.

"It also means we won't get picked up until the last enemy has been sunk," Seacat told him.

He blinked, then beamed at her. “Indeed! This will be another captivating part of our tale!”

“Really.” She frowned. She didn’t hate swimming, unlike Blondie’s friend, but sitting on a floating piece of deck, soaked to the bone, her fur already getting crusty with salt? She could do without all of that, heroic adventure or not. On the other hand, they had survived the battle, and that was… She blinked. “Horde!” she hissed.

“What?” Sea Hawk was at her side in a moment. “Where?”

She pointed at a figure in the water swimming towards them. They were coming from the position where the enemy flagship had sunk. No allied ship had been near there. Other than the Dragon’s Daughter IV.

She drew her cutlass. What was the Horde scum thinking, coming at them? She almost wanted to jump into the water and slice the scum up before it could try to capsize their raft!

“They seem to be alone,” Sea Hawk commented.

“Gutsy bastard,” she spat.

“Maybe not.”

“What?” She glanced at him. “What do you mean?”

Then the enemy reached their raft and gripped its edge. “Made it!” the man gasped, panting. “A hand, mate?”

She saw him look up, his eyes widening as he got a look at them. And at her cutlass.

But next to her, the captain was kneeling down and reaching out to the enemy. “Welcome to what remains of the Dragon’s Daughter IV. I believe you are our prisoner!”

The Horde sailor coughed, then gripped the captain's hand and let himself get pulled onto the raft. "Thank you," he said as he sat down, slumping over. He was barefoot, only wearing the Horde uniform pants and shirt, and his dark hair was plastered to his head.

Seacat glared at him, her cutlass pointed at him. If he made the slightest move…

"We're just doing what any sailor would in our position. The law of the sea is clear about this," Sea Hawk said. "And, we're kind of in the same boat. Or on the same raft."

The Horde scum weakly chuckled, coughed again, and groaned. "You were the ones in the small ship trying to ram us, then?"

"No!" Seacat spat. "If we had wanted to ram you, we would have done so!"

He shied away from her.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. "Not exactly. Suffice to say that we completed our mission before your chase gunners got lucky."

The man nodded but didn't take his eyes off Seacat's blade. She kept it pointed at him for a few more seconds, then sheathed it. He wasn't armed. And even without her blade, she could disembowel him with her claws if he tried anything.

Sea Hawk smiled and struck a pose. "You are twice fortunate. Not only did you survive the sinking of your ship, but you were rescued by the one and only Sea Hawk, and my first mate, Seacat!"

She was about to remind the captain that there was a time and place for such boasting, and it wasn't when they were on the floating remains of their ship, but their prisoners gasped and stared at her with wide eyes.

"Seacat? Catra?"

Not again! She grabbed the scum by his throat and held him up. "Why do you know that name?"

"Ah, Seacat…"

She ignored the captain. She had almost been killed by the Horde, she could feel the seawater drying on her fur, leaving salt crusts and whatever the princess had put into those casks, and now this Horde scum was insulting her? "Talk!"

The man coughed, feeble hands gripping her wrist.

"He can't talk if he can't breathe."

She glared at the captain, then released the scum. "Talk!"

He coughed instead of talking, rubbing his throat. "Just heard the names… general orders."

"'General orders'?" Sea Hawk asked.

"What orders?" she spat.

"Just that…" The scum coughed again. "That should we capture, ah, Seacat or Catra, we should deliver her to the Fright Zone."

What? She blinked.

"What? Seacat? Are you sure they didn't mean *Sea Hawk*?" the captain asked. "The one and only Sea Hawk? Scourge of the Horde fleet? Love of Princess Mermista's life? Captain of the fastest ship on all the seas? Most wanted man on Etheria? The Sea Hawk?"

She glared at him. This wasn't the time to worry about your fame!

"Uh… yes? We got a description, too. Ears and tails. They, uh, match…?" The Horde sailor grimaced, then cowered when she glared at him.

"And you had no other special orders?" Seacat asked.

He shook his head wildly.

She frowned. “Why would the Horde single me out?”

“Indeed! You are the best first mate one could wish for, but I’m the captain of our crew! How could they mistake you for me?”

She couldn’t tell if Sea Hawk was joking or not.

*****

It took another hour before Seacat saw a dinghy heading their way from one of the two damaged Salinean frigates that had stayed in the area - all the others had sailed off to hunt down the bomb vessel, the transports and what other Horde ships hadn’t been smart enough to flee in time.

“Ah! Relief at last!”

“Yeah,” she muttered, glancing at the Horde sailor. He hadn’t looked up. He hadn’t said anything since the interrogation, either. Which was just fine with her.

“Ahoy!” Sea Hawk yelled, waving.

“Took you long enough!” Seacat added, then smirked when she saw the Salinean midshipman in charge of the boat flinch. Yes, leaving the lover of your princess in the water for hours might not have been the best decision.

Not that the captain would abuse his relationship for that. Not when drifting on the sea for hours made a much more compelling tale. By the time they hit Seaworthy, Sea Hawk might have added nearly dying from hunger and thirst to the tale.

“Captain Sea Hawk?”

“Admiral Sea Hawk, if you please! My flotilla might be gone, and my ship most definitely was sunk - we’re standing on the last remaining piece of her that’s still afloat - but I still have my rank!”

“Until Mermista decommissions you,” Seacat added, smirking when he frowned at her.

But he smiled again in a heartbeat. “In any case, this was a splendid victory! My compliments to Admiral Gharn - she hit them right when they were the most vulnerable.”

“Ah, thank you, Admiral,” the young midshipman managed to reply as she gestured at her boat. “If you’d like to board…?”

“Certainly! Also, this is our prisoner - Sailor... “ Sa Hawk frowned. “I actually didn’t get your name in all the excitement. But he served on the enemy flagship and has vital information about the enemy plans!”

“Oh?” The officer perked up and looked at the Horde scum.

“I what?” The sailor looked confused in return.

“Captain!” Seacat hissed. This wasn’t anyone else’s business!

But Sea Hawk wasn’t listening to her. “Indeed! There was a very interesting general order given to the Horde fleet! The Princesses have to hear about this at once!”

“No, they don’t!” she snapped. Especially not Blondie!

But everyone was ignoring her.

*****

The Bounty

"You could've done better, Adora."

She didn't like the voice. Not at all. She pulled back a little more, pushing herself into the corner behind the pillar that was a little off, near the door to their quarters. No one would find her there, and she could still hear everything - her ears were much better than anyone else's - she knew that!

"We passed the exercise."

"Adora…"

She clenched her teeth, hissing under her breath as she felt her fur rise. She hated that tone, especially!

A sigh.

Fake. Fake. Fake.

"Passing is not enough. Not for someone with as much potential as you. You're letting others hold you back. Stifle you."

She wanted to spit. 'Potential'. Bah! She was faster and she had claws! And she could see and hear things better than anyone else. But no one, ever, said she had potential.

"But it was a group exercise. We had to work together" Adora said.

"You were the leader, and they let you down."

"They didn't! We passed," Adora protested.

"You could've done better. You were distracted, Adora. You can't allow yourself to be distracted. As a Force Captain, everyone will depend on you."

Yeah, yeah - Adora would be a Force Captain. She knew this already. Everyone knew this. Feh!

"And I won't let them down!"

"You can't let them drag you down - even if they are your friends, you have to be better than that."

"This is about Catra, isn't it? She took down the main bot from ambush!"

"After hiding for the entire exercise. She's dragging you down. And you let it happen."

"She's my friend!"

"And what will you do when her laziness and mistakes cause the death of others under your command? And that will happen, Adora! She's a liability. A soldier of the Horde has to always give their best. You have to trust them to obey your orders, or your plans will fail. She is a distraction - no, she's a danger to you and everyone else."

"She's my friend! She won't drag me down!"

Yes! Tell her, Adora!" She hissed again. Stupid… stupid…

*****

Seacat woke up shivering. Again that stupid, hateful voice. Again a stupid dream - she didn't even know how the face the voice belonged to looked like. If that didn't prove that she wasn't this 'Catra', then nothing would.

She stared at the ceiling. Solid wooden beams - but she wasn't on a ship. She was in Seaworthy, in an inn. The best inn of the port, actually. Sea Hawk might not have been an admiral for longer than a week, and he might not remain an admiral for much longer, now that their work was done, but the people in

Seaworthy didn’t know that and had been very grateful for being saved from the Horde invasion.

Sea Hawk’s latest shanty hadn’t hurt, of course. How the captain had found the time to compose it she didn’t know - he had been handling his report and looking into the survivors of the flotilla on the way to Seaworthy, and she didn’t think he had invented it on the spot.

Not that there had been many survivors. She sighed as she got out of bed and splashed some cold water on her face, then rubbed it dry with a towel. As they had expected - and as Sea Hawk had told them - the Horde had been prepared for ramming attacks by fast boats. They had installed carronades on their frigates. Those guns had a pitiful range but were devastating close up. Grapeshot at point-blank range…

She shivered once more as she pulled her clothes on. A single carronade could destroy a boat and kill her crew at once. If the Dragon’s Daughter IV had just sailed a little closer, or if the Horde scum hadn’t been patient and skilled enough to wait a little longer…

Only three ships of their flotilla had survived. And one of them had been sunk attacking a transport later. Fools - all they should have done was shadowing the transports and leading the rest of the fleet to them. Which the other two had managed, at least.

She bared her teeth. All transports sunk, most of them with the landing forces still on them - the Horde scum would feel this loss for a long time!

Well, it was time for breakfast. Seacat hoped that she was early enough to eat without getting bothered by anyone. Like a princess.

She took a deep breath as she stepped into the hallway, her nostrils flaring. Oh, fresh milk bread! That was something you

didn’t get to eat on a ship. Licking her lips, she went down to the inn’s dining room, taking two steps a time.

And came to a stop at the bottom of the stairs. Blondie and her friends were there, sitting at the closest table.

Looking at her. Damn.

“Cat-Seacat!” And Blondie made a beeline towards her, almost shoving the waitress out of her way.

Seacat smiled at her. “So, you made it as well. How did…” Before she could finish, she found herself interrupted by the woman grabbing her in a hug strong enough to push her breath out of her - and she wasn’t even transformed! “Ack!”

Blondie released her, only to grab her by her arms instead. “What were you thinking? We’ve heard about what you did! Who had this… this *plan*?”

Uh-oh. “What plan?” She had to delay. Distract the woman. She just had to stall and… why weren’t the shrimp and Brain Boy interrupting them?

“What plan? The plan to rush at a Horde battle line in small boats and get sunk!”

“Ah, *that* plan.” Seacat forced herself to smile. Stalling didn’t work very well. And the shrimp and Brain Boy were glaring at her as well - as if this was her fault!

“Yes, *that* plan!” Blondie looked really angry. Were those tears in the corner of her eyes? For her? Or had she tried the hot fish stew for breakfast?

“Hey, it worked, didn’t it?” As Sea Hawk had taught her, it was hard to argue with success. Not impossible, but hard.

“It also caused over fifty per cent casualties among the soldiers involved,” the shrimp said. As if that was her business!

“Sailors,” Seacat corrected the princess, “not soldiers.”

“Who cares? You almost died!” Blondie blurted out. “And after you said…” She shook her head - shaking Seacat a little as well since Blondie still kept vice-like grips on Seacat’s upper arms. “Whose plan was it?”

Blondie was really mad. There was only one answer. “The Salinean Navy’s!” Seacat replied. They could take the casualties better than Seacat’s crew could. She had only one captain, and the Salineans had officers to spare, many of them useless anyway.

“Oh! I’m going to give Mermista a piece of my mind!”

Ugh. If Blondie went after Mermista, Sea Hawk would step in to protect the princess. “We volunteered! We knew how dangerous it was, but it was the only way to save Seaworthy!” Seacat told Blondie. “We tried catapults to deploy the mixture, but they didn’t work, cannons wouldn’t work either, and the Hair Princess’s new invention to make our ships faster wasn’t ready yet.”

“Sea Hawk volunteered you?” Blondie had no fangs, but up close, her teeth looked quite impressive when clenched.

“*We* volunteered,” Seacat spat.

“What were you thinking? You almost died!”

She finally managed to wriggle out of the woman’s grip. “But we didn’t! And we had it all planned out - attacking with the wind, smoke to hide us and hinder their gunners, turning outside the point-blank range of the enemy… We even had new flotation devices the princess made for us.” Which hadn’t really been that helpful - quite the contrary, actually - but there was no need to mention that.

“And you got sunk!”

“One of the Horde gunners got lucky,” Seacat spat with a frown. But Blondie was still glaring at her. And those were definitely tears

in her eyes. Damn. Seacat forced a weak smile on her face. “Look, I know the general order the Horde got to capture me looks bad, but…”

“‘General order’? They want to capture you?”

Seacat winced at the volume. “So… you hadn’t heard about it, yet?” And she was still so worked up?

“We arrived late at night,” Brain Boy said. “And we convinced Adora that you needed your sleep after your, ah, ordeal.”

Was that a fancy word for battle?

“I wasn’t about to wake her up!” Blondie protested.

“You were about to transform and break through her door,” the shrimp retorted.

“Never mind!” Blondie turned back to Seacat and glared at her. “What did you say about a general order to capture you?”

That was an intense glare the woman had. Seacat felt her fur bristle a little in response. Even though she wasn’t afraid or even impressed. She huffed and sneered a little. “We captured a sailor. He told us that if they captured me or Catra, they should bring us to the Fright Zone. So, you see - it’s an order to capture me, but just an order what to do should they capture me. Which they won’t, anyway!” She flashed her teeth in a smile. A confident smile.

But Blondie wasn’t looking at her - she was frowning at the floor or something, and biting her thumb. “Shadow Weaver! She’s behind this! I should’ve expected that after her letter!”

Shadow Weaver… Seacat felt a shiver run down her spine. She didn’t like that name. At all. Wait! She blinked. “What letter?”

“The letter Scorpia delivered to you at the Princess Prom?” the shrimp was suddenly at their side. “That letter?”

“Yes,” Blondie replied, grimacing. “She tried to use my old comrades in the Horde against me. As if I’d fall for that! But I should’ve expected that she wouldn’t give up.”

“Wait! You’re the reason the Horde wants to capture me?” Seacat blurted out. “They think I’m your friend? Your missing friend?”

Everyone was staring at her again.

“Err…” Blondie coughed. “Yes?”

“Why?” Seacat snapped. “Why, damn it?” This couldn’t be true!

“Uh…” Brain Boy spoke up. “Are you asking why Shadow Weaver wants to kidnap you, or why she thinks that you’re Catra?”

Before Seacat could answer the stupid question, the shrimp spoke up. “What kind of question is that? Everyone knows that she’s Catra! The dates match, she looks like her, she acts like her…”

“I don’t act like her at all!” Seacat protested. “I like to swim! And I hate the Horde!”

“Big deal!” the shrimp retorted. “I didn’t like to swim when I was younger, either! And Adora hates the Horde, too!”

That stupid princess! Seacat hissed. This wasn’t true!

“And, ah… Shadow Weaver wants you because you’re my… friend,” Blondie added, with a glance towards her friends.

“One of her friends,” the shrimp added before she was elbowed by Brain Boy.

“So… this Shadow Weaver…” Seacat felt her fur bristle again just saying the name. “...she wants me as a hostage?”

“Yes.” Blondie nodded. “She must have found out about you at the Princess Prom, from Scorpia. And when I didn’t react to the threats to the cadets in my former squad…”

Seacat shook her head with clenched teeth. This wasn't true! This couldn't be true! She wasn't just some hostage! She wasn't just *leverage* against *She-Ra*! She was Seacat! She had fought the Horde! She had beaten the Horde - with Sea Hawk. She had done much more things that mattered than… dancing with a princess at a ball!

"No!" she spat and whirled around.

"Ca-Seacat! Wait!"

"Leave me alone!" she hissed at Blondie. "This is all your fault!"

Then she leapt to the door, ripped it open and rushed out of the inn. Away from… away from everyone.

"Wait!"

Blondie was coming after her. Of course!

"Wait! Seacat, wait!"

But the woman didn't know Seaworthy as well as Seacat did. And she wasn't as fast as Seacat. Not by a long shot.

Seacat sprinted down the main street on all fours, dodging around the passers-by and easily outdistancing the Blondie, until she reached a particular intersection. She bared her fangs as she took the corner, dashing down a side alley, then took the next corner, and another and one more.

Then she slowed down. Here, the alleys were so narrow, sometimes you couldn't even see the sky above you. There was no way Blondie - or any princess - would find her here.

Sighing, she sat down and leaned against the wall.

And cursed the Horde, Blondie, the princesses. Everyone.

She wasn’t Catra! She was Seacat! The damn best first mate of the fastest ship in Etheria! She mattered!

And she wasn’t crying!

*****

Seacat sniffed the air and grinned. She could smell the roasted fish around two corners - her third-favourite food stall in Seaworthy was open! She could finally get breakfast. Scoffing, she reminded herself that this, too, was all Blondie’s fault. If not for the princess and her stupid friends, she could’ve eaten in the inn. Milk bread!

But now she could eat in peace. And it was late enough so she could order breakfast and lunch together. Perhaps one order of roasted fish and one of fried fish? Yeah, that would do. Running from a stupid princess had made her work up an appetite, too!

She was licking her lips as she rounded the last corner. There was the stall - and that was a piece of arctic shark on the spit in the corner! And there was…

…Sea Hawk sitting at the counter.

She froze for a moment, almost turning and dashing back around the corner. Then she scoffed and straightened. She wasn’t going to run away from her captain.

Instead, she continued walking and sat down on the seat next to him. “Morning,” she grumbled.

“Morning, first mate!” he replied with a smile.

She didn’t ask how he had found her - he had shown her the back alleys of Seaworthy, after all. But she looked around.

“No one else is here,” he told her.

She huffed in response. But she was glad he hadn't brought Blondie here. Not that she had really expected him to.

"I'll have the fried fish and the roasted shark," she told the cook.

"Good choice," Sea Hawk told her. "The shark's delicious - fresh from the Kingdom of Snows. I had it myself."

That was good news. She nodded, licking her lips as she watched the cook put the fish pieces into the boiling oil before cutting off a generous portion from the shark. She had been here often enough, so the man knew better than to ask if she wanted some greasy side dishes with her fish.

And the shark was delicious. She gobbled it down while the cook finished frying her next order.

Sea Hawk didn't say anything while she ate, but as soon as she swallowed the last piece of fried fish, he cleared his throat.

And Seacat suppressed the urge to wince. "It's all Blondie's fault!" she spat before he could say anything.

"Is it?"

"Yes!" Of course it was!

"That the Horde wants to capture you?"

She clenched her teeth for a moment, almost hissing, before she answered: "Yes. They want me as a hostage. Because she thinks I'm her missing friend."

"I think dancing and sleeping with her in the Kingdom of Snows also played a role there." He nodded slowly and took a sip from his ale.

This time, she did hiss. "I didn't sleep with her - we just slept in the same bed!" she corrected him.

“Well, you know gossip and rumour.” He chuckled softly. “I think people were already talking about your passionate night with Adora before we left port.”

“You mean She-Ra.” She scoffed. “No one would care about her if she were just a Horde deserter fighting against them. The Horde.”

“Ah.” He frowned and tilted his head. “Are you angry that the Horde didn’t put a bounty on your head for being the best first mate on all the seas?”

She clenched her teeth again. She didn’t want to sound arrogant, but…

She had taken too long to answer since he patted her shoulder before she could say anything and told her. “I understand completely, Seacat. I, too, know how it feels when your accomplishments haven’t been appreciated as they should’ve been.”

“They made you an admiral,” she replied in a flat voice.

“And it was completely justified, as we proved during the battle, yes!” He smiled widely. “However, it took me a long time to develop my reputation as the best captain on all the seas. Oh, the years of doing heroic deed after heroic deed, surviving adventures that would have left others dead and destroyed…”

“Such as setting your own ship on fire,” she interrupted him.

He ignored her jab. “...without being recognised for it. Well, except for the bounty hunters and the jealous captains. Or their jealous lovers.” He nodded to his own words. “But in the end, Mermista acknowledged my heroic and dashing nature and my pure love for her!” He reached over and grabbed her by both shoulders, looking into her eyes. “You, too, will achieve your dreams, as long as you persevere and never give up!”

“I don’t want a relationship with Blondie,” she retorted.

“Did I say that?” he asked - far too innocently to be innocent.

She narrowed her eyes and growled at him.

He released her shoulders in response and coughed into his fist. “Trust me, you too will soon be hunted by the Horde for your own merits - they’re just a little slow to realise what we’ve done to them, together. Part of the reason for this is that Mermista has forbidden me to sing shanties about our spy missions for ‘operational security’.”

“That’s so we won’t run into a trap the next time we do such a mission,” she told him.

“Probably, yes.” He grinned. “My dear Mermista is a little too cautious. I’ve told her that we wouldn’t use the same plan twice, so letting the Horde know what we did would only make them focus on the wrong areas, but she remains unconvinced.”

She scoffed in return.

“Exactly! But I might yet convince her. Anyway, you shouldn’t blame our friends for the Horde’s actions.”

“It was their actions that led to this,” Seacat told him. “If she hadn’t mistaken me for her missing friend, none of this would’ve happened.”

“Are you certain?” He cocked his head. “She didn’t force you to spend so much time with her, did she? If she did, I’ll have a word with her - as your captain, the law of the sea compels me to protect you from such… advances.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. She was tempted to lie - it would serve Blondie well to have the captain come after her - but… She wasn’t the kind of sailor who had a lover in every port, nor was she a rake like some of Sea Hawk’s friends, but she, well… If Blondie weren’t a princess, not a former Horde soldier, and not such a pain in the stern about her missing friend, she wouldn’t be the worst choice to spend an evening carousing with.

“Ah!” The captain was smiling widely - she had taken too long to answer. Again.

“It’s not like that!” she spat.

He chuckled in return. “Of course not. But it could be, couldn’t it?”

She glared at him instead of answering.

He sighed and put his hand on her shoulder again. “Seacat, I know this isn’t easy for you. But remember: This isn’t your fault, nor hers. Nor anyone’s except the Horde’s. Adora and the others mean well.”

“She still thinks I’m Catra.”

“She’ll come around.” He squeezed her shoulder. “Now, shall we head back to the inn to discuss our next step in the war?”

She scoffed again but nodded.

*****

“So… what about our ship?” she asked on the way back to the inn - where, apparently, the Alliance would be planning the next step of the war. “Did you check the harbour if there’s a nice courier ship for sale? With Mermista bankrolling us, you should be able to outbid anyone else who lost theirs in the battle.”

“Ah, no. Actually, our new ship is waiting - or so I hope - in Salineas for us.” The captain smiled at her, flashing his teeth.

That was the sort of foreplanning Seacat wouldn’t have expected of Sea Hawk. He didn’t believe that preparing for misfortune would ensure it would befall you, as some superstitious - and stupid - sailors thought, but he was a great believer in improvising. Although this had been a very dangerous mission, and it wasn’t out of the question that Sea Hawk would have taken steps to… No. He hadn’t been planning ahead like this even when he had been planning to wreck his ship ramming the Horde bomb

vessel in the Battle of Salineas. That meant… No. "You didn't… you didn't pick the Princess' test ship!"

He nodded with a wide grin. "Of course I did! Princess Entrapta said that it would be the fastest ship on all the seas once she has perfected the design. Imagine if someone else would get to sail her instead of us! The shame! We have a reputation to defend - now more than ever!"

She felt her ears flatten against her head as she stopped walking and glared at him. "Are you seriously trying to use this mess about Blondie's friend to… to justify risking our lives with the Hair Princess's project?"

Sea Hawk beamed at her and cocked his head sideways. "Yes. Is it working?"

She growled, shook her head and turned to continue to walk briskly towards the inn. Even dealing with Blondie and her stupid friends was better than trying to talk sense into Sea Hawk right now.

*****

"Seacat!" Blondie jumped up as soon as Seacat and Sea Hawk entered the inn. "I'm sorry!"

Seacat glared at her. "What are you sorry for?"

"Uh…" The woman blinked with a particularly stupid expression. "Everything?"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "It's the Horde's fault, you idiot!"

Blondie started nodding and smiling. It didn't make her look smarter in any way.

"Are we really doing our planning here?" Seacat pointedly looked around and eyed the waitresses and the innkeeper, all of whom were staring at them. The Horde must have spies in Seaworthy,

and who knew who they were? They hadn't revealed themselves during the battle, unlike the ones in Salineas.

"Of course not," the shrimp spoke up. "We've got a secure room prepared. Upstairs." She stood. "Let's go! The admiral is waiting," she added with a frown at Seacat.

As if that was Seacat's fault! She stuck out her tongue at the shrimp's back as they climbed the stairs.

"The *other* admiral," Sea Hawk said. "I'm also an admiral."

Admiral Gharn was already in a large room on the first floor - with two marines standing guard outside - but it didn't look like she had been waiting for them; she was at a long table scribbling on sheets.

"Admiral Gharn! How's my fellow flag officer doing?" Sea Hawk blurted out as soon as the door opened.

"Doing paperwork," the woman replied with a frown.

"Ah!" Sea Hawk nodded sagely before sitting down and putting his boots on the table. "My own, sadly, sank with my ship. Very unfortunate."

"Not as unfortunate as our casualties," the admiral retorted.

"Yes." Sea Hawk nodded again. "I've lost my ship as well."

"And most of your command."

Seacat clenched her teeth and glared at the officer. "Everyone knew the risks," she spat. "We did better than expected."

"Yes. A few ships survived, actually," Sea Hawk added with another nod.

"And replacing those that didn't will take a long time," Gharn said. "Until then, our ability to keep up lines of communication with

headquarters as well as keeping eyes on the enemy fleet will be restricted."

"What enemy fleet?" Blondie asked. "You sank the Horde ships in the area, didn't you?"

"The Horde will be sending more ships. And my own fleet is in dire need of repairs and resupply. Our victory was bought with blood."

"As was the victory in the land battle," the shrimp said. "And we have to keep fighting. The Horde's reeling - this is the best time to hit them. Hard."

"Half my ships won't be hitting anything until they've been patched up. If I sent them out in their current state, I might as well sink them myself."

"That still leaves the other half of your ships, my fellow admiral," Sea Hawk said. "And you should still have two couriers to serve as the eyes of your fleet. More than enough to push down the coast and take a port or two back."

"Yes!" Blondie said. "We can land troops, too! If you take a force down the coast, we can hit them before they know what's coming."

"I cannot risk the Salinean fleet without approval from Princess Mermista."

Seacat hissed. Bloody coward.

"Well, unless I bungled my admiral orientation," Sea Hawk said with a sly grin, "which was given to me by the princess in person, mind you, then our standing orders are that absent other orders, we're to hunt down fleeing Horde ships. And I'm reasonably sure that some Horde ships are fleeing south. Although we're bound for Salineas, to take possession of our new ship, so I can ask if your different orders take precedence."

Gharn looked like she wanted nothing more than shooting Sea Hawk out of a cannon right now. "I'll send out scouts to recon the southern coast."

"Great!"

"And we'll send out scouts as well," the shrimp said. "To clear the coast down to the closest enemy naval base."

Well, it looked like matters were settled. Of course, that would mean that people would now spend far too much time talking about stupid details. Seacat made a point of closing her eyes and leaning back, though she didn't put her feet on the table.

*****

"I can't believe you fell asleep in the briefing!" Blondie, sounding both shocked and annoyed, cornered Seacat as soon as they had left the briefing room.

Seacat made a point of yawning and stretching, craning her neck for good measure, before replying. "Why?"

The other woman blinked. "Huh… I mean: What were you thinking?" She was flushed now, too. She must really care about rules and expectations.

"I was thinking that I said my piece and had no need to listen to all the logistical details. I don't need to know about who supplied whom and who gets to order whom around on the move south since I'm not going to head south for a while." Seacat grinned.

"But…"

"Also, me listening would've been a bad idea since such information is need to know, and since I won't be taking part in the operation, I don't have a need to know. So, you see, me taking a nap - which was quite challenging with all the whispering from you - was actually just me doing my duty for the Alliance."

Blondie was gaping again. “But… but…”

Of course, the shrimp just had to butt in. “So you acknowledge that you’re a member of the Alliance now?”

Seacat frowned at the princess. That was… well, she was correct. Kind of. But not really. “I’m Sea Hawk’s first mate,” she said. “And he’s an admiral of the Salinean Navy.”

“A soon to be decorated admiral!” the captain said from further ahead, looking over his shoulder at them.

She rolled her eyes. “But I didn’t join the Navy,” she went on. She would remember that. Even if others assumed so.

“But…” Blondie tried again.

Seacat interrupted her with a raised claw. “No buts. There’s only one man who can give me orders, and that is Sea Hawk.” And as long as she didn’t join the Navy, that wouldn’t change - she knew better than letting all the idiot officers in the Salinean fleet order her around.

“That’s… incredibly…” The shrimp seemed at a loss for words.

“...smart?” Seacat prompted her, flashing her fangs in a grin.

“...Selfish! And disruptive!” the princess tried.

“No. Even if we were both in the Navy, I’d be directly under him, with no one between us. No one else would be in my chain of command,” Seacat told her.

“Mermista could give you orders!” The shrimp obviously didn’t like to lose an argument.

“That’s different,” Seacat replied, “and not related to the Navy at all.” And she wasn’t going into the reasons she - sometimes, only - listened to Mermista.

“But…” The shrimp finally huffed - and clenched her teeth, which made her look more like a child than the commander of Bright Moon’s army she was. “Fine! Whatever! You’re not in the stupid Navy!” She turned to her friends. “Let’s go and talk to our troops! We’ve lost enough time here!” She whirled and walked - stomped - down the hallway towards the stairs.

Brain Boy, who had stayed silent so far, glanced at Seacat before following the princess.

Blondie, though, hesitated. “Uh… if you’re not going to join the attack down the coast, where are you going?” she asked.

“Back to Salineas,” Seacat told her. “We need to get our new ship and get it sea-ready.” Which could take a while even if she didn’t blow up the first time they pushed her.

“Oh.” The woman looked almost disappointed for a moment before smiling at Seacat. “That’s great!”

“We’ll see,” Seacat said. She wasn’t exactly looking forward to testing the inventions of the Hair Princess, but Sea Hawk was correct that they couldn’t let others have a shot at the fastest ship on the seas, even if it was a little dangerous.

“Is something wrong?” Blondie frowned at her.

“Nothing,” Seacat lied and stretched again. “It’s just been a long day, and a troublesome morning.”

Blondie had the grace to blush in response. “Again, sorry about that.”

“Don’t worry, it’s not your fault. It’s the Horde’s.” Like so much else.

“But still… you’re now in even more danger!”

Seacat scoffed. “More danger than charging at a Horde battle line in a courier?”

“Well…” The woman looked confused for a second, then frowned again and leaned towards her. “You won’t do that again, right?”

Seacat leaned back before she realised what she was doing. That was an intense glare - worse than Mermista’s in a bad mood. But she was Seacat, not some Alliance soldier or whatever. She raised her chin. “Not until it’s needed. You won’t be charging Horde artillery, will you?”

Blondie opened her mouth, then closed it again, her frown turning into a pout before she smiled - weakly, but it was there. “Not until it’s needed.”

Seacat chuckled, and, a moment later, both of them were laughing.

*****

Seaworthy might have been under siege less than two days ago - although not for long, all things considered, and the port hadn’t been completely surrounded on the land side - but the seedy underbelly of the port, as Mermista would have called it, hadn’t been affected much. The tavern Seacat had just entered - the same where she had met Blondie for the first time - proved that beyond a doubt. It was as busy as ever, and the patrons as shady and untrustworthy as they came. As usual.

She walked up to the bar, glaring at a drunken sailor who stared too openly at her butt, and flipped a coin to the fishwoman behind the counter. “Ale,” she ordered. “Cold. Keep the change.”

The woman caught the coin without looking at her and quickly filled a mug. “Here.”

Seacat took a sip and blinked. The ale was stronger than usual. She turned to address the bartender and lifted her mug. “Is this a new brew?”

“To celebrate the victory against the Horde.” The woman’s smile was a little forced, but the surrounding patrons lifted their glasses

and mugs. “To victory!”

Seacat joined in - it was her victory, after all. Well, hers and Sea Hawk’s. And their flotilla. And the Salinean Fleet had helped, too.

She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and resisted the urge to lick it clean right away. That was strong ale, though the aftertaste was a little off. “Need to go over the recipe again,” she told the bartender, wrinkling her nose. “There’s some aftertaste.”

“Huh?” The drunken sailor - a goatman - next to her grunted. “Whatcha talkin’ ‘bout? It’s fine!”

She scoffed. “Just because you have no taste…” She blinked. The man looked a little… hazy. Seacat hadn’t drunk that much. And it was ale, not liquor!

She pushed off the bar and felt her legs wobble for a moment. Damn - the ale! She whirled around with a hiss. The bartender was at the other end of the bar, headed towards the door there.

Growling, Seacat jumped on the bar and dashed along it on all fours. The fishwoman yelped and started to run, but she was too slow. Seacat smashed into her just as she reached the door and tackled her to the floor. A quick blow to the chest stopped the scumbag’s attempt to fend her off. While the woman clutched her ribs, Seacat kicked her in the other side, flipping her on her back. “What did you put into my ale?”

“Nothing! I swear!”

“Then why did you try to run?” She kicked the liar again and flashed her claws. “Talk or I’ll gut you like a… a fish!”

“Help! Help!”

Damn. Seacat placed a foot on the woman’s belly and looked over her shoulder. Four people, including the goatman, were moving towards her, weapons drawn. “Stay back! She poisoned me!”

Seacat snapped. She had to blink again - things were getting hazy once more. “Call the guards!” she added.

But the four kept dancing - and fanning out.

“Ah! That was your plan! Horde scum!” Seacat snarled. She drew her cutlass and ignited it, waving it towards the closest attacker. The man shied away, and Seacat jumped forward, to the door the bartender had tried to reach.

It wasn’t locked! She kicked it open and swung her blade again, almost catching the goatman in the stomach, but the nimble bastard managed to jump back in time. Then Seacat dashed through the open door - and found herself in the tavern’s kitchen. The cook, a fat woman, shrieked and moved into the corner, but Seacat had only eyes for the exit - the backdoor. There!

She took a step, but her leg almost buckled. Damn! And everything was now hazy.

She steadied herself with one hand on the big table in the centre of the kitchen and turned just in time to meet a burly man jumping at her, hands outstretched. Seacat snarled and ducked, then pushed herself up, sending the fool flying headfirst into the huge pot of soup on the stove behind her.

He smashed into it, spilling boiling hot, greasy broth all over himself and the floor. While he screamed like a stuck pig, Seacat jumped on the table - she didn’t fancy getting her feet scolded.

But her legs gave out, and she ended up on her back on the table, sending spices and bread flying. And the goatman was charging at her, wielding a sap.

Seacat rolled to her side and raised her blade, but before she could stick it through the scum’s chest, his hooves slipped on the greasy floor, and he fell down, hard.

Seacat rolled on her belly and stabbed down, catching him in the shoulder. He screamed and rolled away, and before she could

recover and cut his flailing legs, a fishman jumped on top of her with a high-pitched yell.

The impact drove the breath out of her lungs, and she almost dropped her cutlass. Before she could react, she felt hands around her throat - he was choking her.

Snarling, she lashed out over her shoulder, burying the claws of her free hand deep into his lower arm, then ripped them out again.

The fishman howled and released her neck, and she felt blood drop down on her back. Hissing, she reversed her grip on her cutlass and drove the blade back - into the fool's stomach. His screams cut off, and she twisted, pushing the dying bastard off her.

That left the goatman and the fourth, a lizard. She rolled off the table and faced them. Just two left, and she could flee out the back…

She blinked. The goatman had doubled. As had the lizard. And they were growing taller. No, floating.

No, Seacat's legs were collapsing - she was sinking to the floor.

Everything went black before she hit the ground.

*****

The Witch

"Oh, look at this!"

"It's a skiff, Catra."

"Yes - but look at it! It's flying!" She cocked her head, smiling.

"It's hovering, actually. It can't really fly."

Adora was being a killjoy again.

"It doesn't have to be touching the ground to move and it can go higher than a tall trooper stands. That's flying!" Anyone could see that the skiff was flying - to demonstrate, she quickly passed underneath it. "See? Flying!"

Adora frowned at her. "It's not really flying. It needs the ground to work."

"So?" Who cared? As long as it could soar above everyone else on the ground? And could go fast!

"That means that it won't work over water." Adora huffed at her.

"What? That makes no sense!" She stared at her friend. Why wouldn't the skiff be able to fly over water? If you could fly over rocks and grass, why not water?

"It's magic, duh." Adora shook her head. "It doesn't make sense."

"Magic?" That couldn't be true!

"Yes, magic." Adora nodded with that overly serious expression of hers.

"But… why are we using magic?" She took a step back. Magic. Only princesses used magic. The Horde used technology! Like the cannons. And the bots. And the shock weapons.

"We aren't - we're using the skiffs," Adora explained. "Making them needs magic, but anyone can use them."

"So we've got princesses in the Horde making them?" That sounded wrong, too - everyone knew princesses were the enemy of the Horde.

Adora blinked. "I don't think you need to be a princess to do magic. Shadow Weaver isn't a princess, and she can do magic."

She felt her fur bristle at the name, and she hissed, then looked away. "Well, if it's from Shadow Weaver I don't want to have anything to do with it!"

"Catra! It's not from Shadow Weaver. I think, at least." Adora blinked. "Someone else probably worked on it. Or we took the magic thingies from the princesses and built the skiffs around them."

"'Magic thingies'?" She raised her eyebrows with a grin.

Adora scowled at her. "You know what I meant. The magic…"

"...thing?" She flashed her fangs, chuckling.

"...device that makes things fly."

"'Things'!"

"Oh, you!" Adora glared at her, huffing.

"Whatever - let's check it out!" She jumped, grabbed onto the railing, and swung herself onto the skiff. "Whoa…" She could feel it shift slightly under her feet as she walked. That wasn't a solid wagon. It was more like… a boat. She shuddered, remembering the 'amphibious training' they had gone through. She wasn't made for water!

"Catra! Come down! We're not supposed to touch the skiffs - we aren't even supposed to be here!"

“Feh!” She scoffed. She could also feel something vibrate. Softly, but it was there. Was that the magic? She cocked her head, trying to get a feeling for it.

“Hey! What are you doing here? This is off-limits to cadets!”

Uh-Oh!

*****

The vibrations were the first thing Seacat noticed when waking up. Like in her dream - she was on a skiff. Then she gasped - she was bound. And she remembered. She had been attacked. Poisoned! She looked around - it was dark, but not completely dark. She was in… in a crate. A wooden crate - a little light came through the gaps between the boards.

She had been kidnapped! And hogtied! Clenching her teeth, she tried to break her bonds, but no matter how much she flexed and strained, the bands holding her wrists and ankles together - behind her back - didn’t budge. And she couldn’t use her claws on the bonds.

Damn! She settled for slamming her body against the boards. If she rocked the crate, perhaps...

“The cat woke up!”

“So?”

“She’s banging around in the crate.”

“So? Let her.”

“What if she brains herself? We won’t get the reward if she’s dead!”

“‘Brains herself’?”

Seacat hissed. She knew that voice - the goatman from the tavern! The other must be the lizard.

"Killing herself by hitting her head against the wall. People do that."

"In your damned Mermaid Mysteries, perhaps."

"Oi! They're good books!"

"They're trash!"

"Don't say that!"

"I'll say what I want! I got us this windfall!"

"And you got Juke and Oli killed!"

"I didn't get them killed - they got themselves killed attacking the cat. I fought her and lived!"

"You almost died - she cut your shoulder."

"And I'll heal. Unlike Juke and Oli. Now shut up and let the cat tire herself out. No one can hear us out here anyway."

Seacat hissed again. That was important information. Important but not very promising. At least she had killed two of the Horde scum who had poisoned her. But they must be far inland if there wasn't anyone around. And they were headed to the Horde territory.

Damn.

She threw herself at the crate again. That didn't do anything. But she could use the claws on the boards, couldn't she? Of course she could!

She twisted until she was lying on her back and tried her claws on the board below her. They easily went through the wood. Good. But how to escape? She was on a skiff, that much she knew.

Perhaps if she dug through the board and the deck below, she could damage the skiff and cause it to crash?

They weren't flying high, so she would survive. So would the two scumbags, though - but if they crashed, there was the hope that others would find them. Sea Hawk would know about the kidnapping - everyone in the tavern had seen the fight. And Blondie would probably charge after them on foot and without any directions…

Seacat chuckled under her breath at the thought. That would be… She frowned. She didn't need a rescue by Blondie. She could escape herself. All she needed was a little luck. Like the goatman and the lizard crushing their skulls in a crash.

Clenching her teeth, she started scratching through the board. She couldn't see her work, and just using her fingers as leverage made it far harder than usual, but this was wood used for crates; far from the hardwood used for the decks of ships or their hulls. After a little while, she had made a hole big enough so she could easily reach the deck below.

That was made of metal - and harder than she remembered… had dreamt of. Still, she could feel her claws cut it. Little by little. Her fingers hurt, but she'd hurt her kidnappers more. All she needed to do was to crash the skiff, then get out of the crate and roll onto them until she could dig her claws into their flesh.

But first, she needed to get through the skiff's deck. She just needed to be patient. Revenge would be hers. And she would get the key to her bonds.

After a good while, she finally broke through the deck. But as much as she twisted, she couldn't reach anything below it with her hands. Damn it. That meant, she would have to widen the holes in the crate and the deck. Probably large enough so she could fall through them.

That would take a long time, but it wasn't as if she had better things to do. As long as she managed before they reached Horde territory…

She heard steps approaching the crate and froze. Had the kidnappers heard her? No, she hadn't been loud enough; she'd know. So…

The steps stopped, and, for a moment, she felt relief. But then, the lid of the crate was removed, and she was blinded by sunlight, hissing as she squeezed her eyes shut.

"Here's some water, you…" The lizard gasped. "Brad!"

She snarled and threw herself upward, fangs bared. The lizard raised his arms, and she bit him, sinking her fangs into his lower arm.

"Ah! Help! Help!"

He recoiled, but she didn't let him go - she clenched her jaws and hung on. All she needed was a little leverage, a twist, and she could use her claws on him.

But he shook her too hard for that - she could barely hang on.

"What are you doing?"

"Trying to get her off!"

"Well, just hit her, idiot!"

She hissed and let go, landing a few yards away and rolling until she hit the railing. She shook her head, then glanced around. They were in some kind of forest. The goatman was at the helm, clutching the steering wheel. And the lizard...

"Look at my arm!"

...was wailing and clutching his barely-bleeding warm.

“Get her! She’s about to escape!”

“But my…”

“Get her!” The goatman was screeching.

Escaping was a good idea, but hogtied as she was, she couldn’t exactly move well. She couldn’t even get up. This wasn’t going as planned.

The lizard approached her, and she hissed and snapped, driving him back.

“Get her, you fool! She’s tied up, you worthless, useless idiot!”

“Oli! You saw what she did to my arm! What if her fangs are poisoned?”

“Just grab her - she can’t really hurt you!”

“She hurt me already!”

But the lizard was advancing on her again. Seacat lunged - as much as she could, bound as she was - but he sidestepped her attack and grabbed her by the neck. She managed to slam her knees into his shin, but except for forcing him to take a step back, it didn’t do anything.

And he hadn’t released her. Instead, he held her up. “Got her!”

She hissed again, but he barely flinched.

“Finally! Now poison her! I’m not going to have her escape again!”

“But…”

“Do it!”

Seacat struggled as much as she was able to, shaking and growling. “You’ll pay for this! They’ll come for you! They’ll already have your names!”

“Oli…?”

“Shut her up, damn it. We’ll be fine in the Horde!”

Despite her resistance, the lizard forced a piece of wood into her mouth. She tried to bite through it, but that was hardwood. She wouldn’t… wouldn’t…

Everything went dark again.

*****

The smell was the first thing that hit her when she woke up. She knew it. A bit of smoke - coal, not wood - and oil or other stuff. And no hint of the scent of the sea. None at all. Yet, it was… familiar. She had smelt it before. It was… it was… Horde!

She gasped, opening her eyes and looking around. She was in Horde territory! Blinking, she looked around. She was in a cell. A metal cell, with dimly glowing bars instead of a door. Horde style. Green, dim light filled the room. She wasn’t hogtied anymore. And her hands were in cuffs, but in front of her, not on her back. Good.

But her throat hurt. As did her stomach. The kidnappers hadn’t fed her much during the rest of the trip - she only remembered waking up a few times, and getting water and some dried meat. The scum had kept her drugged for the entire time!

And it hadn’t done her any favours - her head hurt, and standing up was… well, she managed. On the third try. But she was parched and hungry. Didn’t the Horde feed their prisoners?

She looked around again. In front of the bars there was a tray, and on it… Water! She stumbled towards it, almost falling down, and grabbed the bottle with both hands. Water!

She gulped down most of it, sighing as it soothed her throat. Sweet, sweet… well, the water had a metallic aftertaste. Like

drinking from a metal can after a month at sea. Seacat made a face but drank the rest of the water anyway.

There were a grey and a brown bar on the tray as well. Horde ration bars. She wrinkled her nose - even the supposedly good ones tasted bad. But it was food. Sort of.

And she needed food. She couldn't escape while starving. She sniffed the bars, then took a cautious bite.

Bleargh. She shuddered at the taste but kept eating. She had eaten worse, after all. And the taste was kind of familiar. Like...

She blinked, then clenched her teeth. She had eaten Horde ration bars before, at sea. That was why they tasted familiar. No other reason. None!

Growling, she finished both bars, tried to lick the last drops of water from the bottle, then scuttled back and leaned against the wall.

She was in a Horde cell. Probably in the Fright Zone - the Horde Heartland. And the Horde had a bounty on her head. They wanted to use her as a hostage against Blondie.

She needed to escape, and quickly.

*****

She met the first Horde scum about an hour later - it was hard to tell the time without seeing the sky. She heard them, first - steps on metal grates. Those were rather uncomfortable for bare feet and claws could get stuck in them. Or would. Before she could consider the stray thought, a figure in Horde armour stepped into the hallway outside her cell. They looked female, but with the chest plate and helmet, it was hard to tell.

Seacat glared at them, but they didn't even stop - they just walked past the cell. That wouldn't do. "Hey!"

That made them stop and turn around. “What?”

So, there was a man under that armour.

“I’m hungry.” She kicked her tray towards the bars. She could jump the scum when they opened the cell to feed her.

“You’ll get food in the evening.” He turned away.

Damn. “And when will that be?”

“In the evening.”

“What time is it?” she spat.

He snorted. “Noon.”

She couldn’t tell if he was lying or not. “And where am I?”

A scoff was her only answer, and the scum walked away, ignoring the curses she sent after him.

“Scum,” she muttered one last time, then sat down, leaning against the wall again. With the guard gone, she was alone again - there wasn’t even anyone in the cells nearby. No one she could hear or smell, in any case.

Though that was an opportunity as well. She grinned and looked at the wall. Metal - but that wouldn’t stop her claws. And she had, unless the scum had lied to her, a few hours to bust out of this cell before they came to feed her.

That should be more than enough to get through the metal wall. She raised her hands - slightly awkward, since they were still cuffed together - and started scratching the wall.

It was much, much harder than she’d expected. She was just scratching the wall, instead of leaving deep gouges in it. And her claws started to hurt. As did her wrists - the cuffs dug into her wrists with each swipe.

This might not work as she had planned. Whoever had built this cell had been prepared for her.

And wasn't that worrying? First the general order - and a bounty on her had - and now this. All the work of this 'Shadow Weaver'?

She shuddered against her will and clenched her teeth. She was better than this. She had fought and beaten the Horde scum - sank their ships. She wasn't about to be scared by anyone. She…

Footsteps. She cocked her head, her ears twitching. Several people - three. Coming towards her. Coming for her.

She had run out of time.

But.. Seacat's ears perked up. They were talking!

"Should we be doing this?"

"Yes."

"Are you really sure? This is a restricted area. Like, really restricted. Not normal restricted."

"Yes, Kyle. Now shut up."

That didn't sound like a goon squad here to fetch her to whoever - Shadow Weaver - had wanted to capture her. She shifted a little, stretching out and crossing her legs as she was lounging on a deck in the sun. She wouldn't appear weak to anyone.

Three Horde scum stepped in front of her cell. A wimpy looking blond man, a tall lizard - not the bounty hunter scum, though - and a tough-looking woman with a stupid haircut. All wearing Horde uniforms, but no armour. And all looked a little surprised when they saw her.

Seacat flashed her fangs at them with a smirk. "Hello, there."

The woman pressed her lips together for a moment, frowning. "Catra."

Oh, no! Seacat hissed and glared at her. "Not another one! I'm Seacat, not 'Catra'. You dumbasses need to get it right!"

The blonde looked surprised. "Really? Oh, that would…"

"Kyle!" the woman snapped. "She's lying - of course, that's Catra!"

"I'm not," Seacat retorted.

The lizard hissed something in return, and the woman nodded. "Yes, Rogelio. See, Kyle? She has the same markings. And the same attitude."

Attitude? She'd give the idiot attitude! Seacat growled. "You just don't want to admit that a pair of loser bounty hunters fooled you and got the reward!"

"Loser bounty hunters who managed to capture you. What does that make you?" The woman scoffed at her.

She bared her teeth at them and felt her tail tap the ground as her ears flattened a little. "They poisoned me before they attacked, and I still killed half of them!" The idiots had been lucky, that was all.

"Oh." The blond took a step back.

"And yet you were captured." The woman scoffed again. "How does that feel, Catra?"

"I'm not Catra!" Why couldn't the scum see that?

"Try to tell that to someone who doesn't know you." The woman leaned forward, touching the bars. "You haven't really changed, have you? Still mouthing off and screwing up, huh?"

“Screwing up?” Seacat got up and walked to the bars, snarling at the woman. “I fought you scum for years! I’ve sunk your ships and killed your soldiers!”

All of them gasped - even the lizard. “You… you traitor!” the blond blurted out.

“Of course she’s a traitor, Kyle,” the woman said, glaring at her. “She’s joined up with Adora, remember?”

“I didn’t!” Was there something in the water that made everyone in the Horde stupid? “I’m Admiral Sea Hawk’s first mate!”

“Who?” the blond asked.

“Sea Hawk! The best captain on all the seas!”

“Some rebel,” the woman said. “Like you, huh?”

Seacat hissed at her. “Says the Horde scum.”

“You were one of us until you deserted!” the other woman spat. Then she raised her chin a little and sneered at her. “But you never really were one of us, were you? Always hanging out with Adora, looking down on us, lazying around while we did all the work… I bet you only deserted because it got too hard for you to shirk your duties. Too much work.”

“‘Too much work’?” Seacat growled. She was the best first mate - she worked damn hard! “For the last time: I didn’t desert - I never was in the Horde! You scum destroyed my village and killed my family!” she hissed at the scum in front of her.

“Uh…” The blond seemed to hunch over a little and shy away from her. “But we didn’t…”

“Kyle! She’s lying. That’s Catra.” The woman scoffed. “We wanted to talk to you, for old time’s sake, but if you’re being like this… Rot in here for all I care!” She turned around and walked away.

The lizard hissed something and followed her. The blond, though, looked at them, then at Seacat. “You really aren’t Catra?”

“Why doesn’t anyone listen? I’m Seacat!”

“Uh… sorry…” He trailed off. “You know, Lonnie’s been under a lot of pressure after Adora deserted.”

Seacat huffed. “So?” Who cared about Horde scum?

“Just saying. She isn’t usually like this.”

“That’s what they all say.” She bared her teeth at him.

“You really don’t, uh remember me?”

“I haven’t seen you before in my life.” Only in some weird dreams, she realised. No, that couldn’t have been them. Or her.

She turned away, tail swishing against the bars, and ignored him until he had left.

She had to escape. She was going mad in here.

She looked at the bars. They were thicker than she expected. And made from the same metal as the walls - just covered with a different coat of paint, as she found after scratching one. Damn. She clenched her teeth. Horde scum trying to keep up this farce… And it was a farce. And it was all Blondie’s fault. She wasn’t Catra. She was Seacat. She wasn’t Horde scum.

No matter what anyone else claimed.

She took a few deep breaths. She had been stupid to chase the Horde soldier away. She might have convinced him to let her out...no, no one was that dumb. But fool him into coming into her cell? Fake an illness? That probably could’ve worked. Could still work - they had to feed her, after all.

That was a plan. Wait for the evening, then jump the scum serving her dinner. Easy. She just had to wait. For hours.

She cursed again and kicked the bars. She hated waiting. Unable to do anything. Just waiting. For others. Helpless… no, not helpless. Even with her hands in cuffs, she could still fight. An average Horde soldier? No contest. She could outfight one of those with both hands tied behind her back.

She scoffed, then sighed and sat down again, leaning her head back against the wall and staring at the ceiling above her. There was a grate covering the air duct. If she could climb up, she should be able to remove it and slip into the ducts. She could disappear there - they were narrow, but she was slim and flexible. She would be able to pass through them. Get to the outside, then disappear in the Fright Zone's labyrinth of factories and refineries…

...well, the supposed factories and refineries. She had only heard of them. Though she could smell them. Burning coal and other stuff. That meant the ducts had no filtration. A logical deduction, as Mermista would call it.

She snorted at the weak joke. A deduction. She didn't - couldn't! - know the ducts, or the area, but she could deduce how it looked. Mostly.

Not that it mattered - she couldn't climb the walls. They were too hard, too smooth. Her claws couldn't find any purchase.

That left plan 'jump the Horde soldier'. She liked that plan - she needed to fight someone. Break something. Anything. Teach the Horde that she wasn't helpless. That she was dangerous. That she wasn't just a stupid hostage, but a threat to them!

But she had to wait until someone came visiting her. She hated that part of the plan. She needed to move, to do something.

She sighed again. Perhaps a nap would help. Though she doubted that she would be able to sleep easily with all the noise and the

stench from the Fright Zone. And who knew what kind of stupid dream she'd have? More stupid Horde soldier dreams? Perhaps with the three idiots from before?

She'd rather have a nightmare. Or another weird dream with Blondie.

Damn. She really needed to escape. Before she started feeling as if…

She growled at her own stupidity. She was Seacat. Not Catra. Never Catra.

Huffing, she lay down on the floor, squirming a little to find a comfortable position. With her hands cuffed together, it wasn't as easy as usual, and the stupid metal floor didn't help, either. But she managed, using her arms as a pillow.

But she couldn't sleep. She was in the Fright Zone. The Horde wanted to use her as a hostage against Blondie. She couldn't let them do that. Not that Blondie would give in - she wasn't that stupid - but it would… well, she couldn't let the Horde do this. No matter what.

She found herself gnawing on her lower lip, almost piercing her skin with her fangs. Could she kill herself, if everything else failed? Would serve them right, mistaking her for Catra. But it wouldn't work - the Horde could lie about her death.

And killing herself would have been stupid, anyway. There was always hope as long as you were alive, no matter how bad things looked. Sea Hawk had taught her that. And experience. She just had to be ready to take any opportunity that might appear.

She sighed. Sea Hawk. He would be so worried about her. Probably trying to sail their ship… no, he didn't have a ship. She clenched her teeth. He would come for her. Probably with Blondie. And the Horde would be expecting them.

No! She growled again. She couldn't let anyone get killed for her. This was her fault - she shouldn't have let herself get caught by some stupid bounty hunter scum. So she had to fix it. She had to escape. Where was the stupid Horde scum with her dinner, so she could jump him?

Where was…

She froze. Someone was… something…

A figure stepped - no, glided - into view outside her cell. Red robes, moving by themselves. A mask hiding her entire face. Wild dark hair peeking out… Seacat drew a hissing breath.

She knew this woman. She knew her.

"Shadow Weaver."

The woman tilted her head. It looked… off, somehow. But that might've been the way she seemed to glide and float, instead of walking. "You remember me, then." Her voice was… raspier than expected.

Seacat knew that the woman was smiling, even though she couldn't see her face. But the attitude… the arrogance. The way she held herself showed it. And the tone of her voice, always so… "No, Blondie told me about you," Seacat spat.

"Really?" The woman's voice dripped with condescension. "Did she try to jog your shaken brain into remembering your past?"

"No." Seacat hissed at the woman. "She told me that you were the worst parent. That you were trying to manipulate her - and failed." She bared her teeth.

"Oh? I guess even Adora thought that it wasn't worth trying to recover your memories." Shadow Weaver shrugged. "Perhaps she prefers your current personality. You certainly weren't a prize while growing up, Catra."

“I’m not Catra!” Seacat spat.

“Really? You deny it, even at this point? I knew you were remarkably stubborn and simple-minded, but this is…” The woman shook her head with a sigh. “...ridiculous.”

“It’s not! I’m not Catra.”

The Horde scum ignored her. “Your denial is understandable, of course - I wouldn’t want to be Catra myself. No one would. She was always in trouble. Skiving off, failing to follow orders, making a nuisance out of her, trying to distract and drag down her fellow cadets… She was a pest, to be honest. Worthless.”

Seacat growled, her tail lashing as her ears flattened themselves against her head. This was… this was… not true! “Wrong!”

“‘Wrong’?” Shadow Weaver laughed. “Didn’t Adora tell you about ‘her friend’? How she always had to cover for the pest?” She scoffed. “Or did she lie to you, perhaps?”

“She didn’t lie to me!” Adora couldn’t lie worth anything!

“So you say.” The Horde witch shook her head. “But deep down, you know the truth. You are worthless.”

“So worthless, you put a bounty on me! General orders!” Seacat sneered at the witch.

“You’re nothing. Your only worth is as a means to convince Adora to return to me.”

“No!” She jumped to her feet and moved to the bars, glaring at the arrogant Horde scum. “I’m Seacat. I sunk your ships and foiled your invasions!”

“You? Don’t make me laugh! Still riding the coattails of your betters, I see, and claiming their success as your own. Just as you did as a cadet!” The woman leaned forward - but not close enough for Seacat’s claws to reach her. The gap between the bars

was too narrow to allow her to stick her arm through. "A nuisance. A distraction. A pest. That is what your existence amounts to."

"For the Horde," Seacat shot back. "But my friends know better."

"Your friends are fools as well. Their stubborn refusal to admit defeat is all that keeps this war going."

"We just defeated your invasion of Seaworthy! And we sunk your fleet! We'll push you back into the Fright Zone, and then we'll finish you!"

Once more, the woman laughed. "You have no idea. This war won't be decided at sea. You could sink every ship that the Horde fields, occupy every port, and you'd still lose."

"*You're* delusional!" Seacat spat. "The Kingdom of Snows joined the alliance. It's the biggest kingdom in Etheria. The Horde hasn't managed to defeat Bright Moon when it stood alone, and now you want to defeat the entire alliance? You're even more stupid than your sailors!" She scoffed. The woman was mad. Unless… No. This had to be a ruse. An attempt to make her lose hope and give up. And she wouldn't! She'd rather die!

"Of course someone as shortsighted and ignorant as you would think so."

"We'll see who's right soon enough." She bared her teeth again and gripped the bars.

Shadow Weaver scoffed again. "We? You'll rot in this cell. You won't see anything ever again except these walls."

Seacat scoffed in return. "Really? You want to use me as a hostage to make Adora switch sides, don't you? How well do you think that'll work with me isolated here?" She forced herself to laugh before she imitated the woman's voice. "'Oh, yes, Adora - I have Seacat in a cell, trust me! I would never lie to you! Now do what I say!' No wonder Adora deserted as soon as she could."

She saw the witch freeze for a moment before Shadow Weaver's hands rose and *something* hit Seacat, through the bars, throwing her back a yard.

Magic.

Seacat managed not to rub her aching chest and face as she got up. "Feh! I've been hit harder in friendly tavern brawls!"

"Do not test my patience. I only need you alive, not unhurt." Shadow Weaver told her in a clipped tone - she was mad! Good!

"And that will make Adora see the error of her ways, right?" Seacat laughed again. "You really are bad at this, aren't you?"

The witch grew still again, and Seacat wondered if she had pushed the Horde scum too far.

But the witch didn't lash out again. "You haven't changed at all. I had wondered if your… experiences… had changed you. For the better. But you're as insolent as ever," Shadow Weaver spat. "You haven't grown up at all. You're still the useless brat I knew."

"Takes one to know one," Seacat shot back. "Not that you'd know me since I'm not Catra!"

But instead of getting angrier, the woman seemed to relax. She even snorted at Seacat, cocking her head. "Really? How long will you keep up this useless charade? Or do you honestly think you aren't Catra? No, not even you could be so stupid. Not in the face of all the evidence. Adora recognised you, after all. As did your former comrades. As did I."

"They're mistaken!" Seacat snarled. They had to be. She wasn't Horde scum!

Shadow Weaver laughed in response, and Seacat cringed. That was… that sound… She knew it… No!

"Oh, I understand now. You don't want to accept the truth. You are so desperate to be someone else, anyone else but the failure that was Catra, you'll ignore the truth staring you in the face." She laughed again and leaned forward until her eyes were on the same level as Seacat's. "Poor, naive Catra. So desperate to succeed, to be more than a fool and a distraction! You tried, but your base nature and your mental limits betrayed you every time, and now all that is left is mindless denial. But no matter how often you repeat it, it won't come true. You *are* Catra. A former Horde cadet too weak and inept to make it. Not even Adora, for all her efforts, could salvage you. Vanishing was the best thing you did."

"You lie!" Seacat threw herself against the bars, tried to jam her arms, even bound as they were, through to reach the woman and claw her mask and face off. "It's not true!" She didn't care about the pain - she was hurting anyway. "I'm not a failure!" She hated the witch. Hated her more than anyone else.

Once more, the woman laughed. "But you are! A complete failure. No discipline. No intelligence. You're barely more than a wild animal, always acting on your whims. Spoiled rotten by Adora. And how did you thank her? By dragging her down! You're a hindrance, nothing more!"

"No! I'm the best first mate on all the seas!" Sea Hawk's first mate. Seacat.

"Did they tell you that? Probably to avoid hurting your poor feelings. But you know the truth - you aren't good enough. You'll never be good enough. You are and remain a failure. Your only worth is that Adora, out of mistaken loyalty, still cares for you. Probably out of pity for her pet."

No. No! NO!

Seacat growled and hissed: "No!" Not pity! She managed to refrain from throwing herself at the bars again. That was what Shadow Weaver wanted - a stupid girl hurting herself while trying to claw her. Seacat wasn't stupid. She forced herself to laugh. It

was a choked laugh, but the best she could manage. “You are blind,” she added with a scoff. “And stupid.”

Shadow Weaver snorted in response. “I know you. Better than you know yourself - if your claims of having lost your memories are true and not some pathetic attempt to hide from your past.”

“They are!” Seacat snarled. No - she couldn’t lose her temper. That would let the witch win. And that couldn’t be allowed! That would be… like in her dreams. No. She raised her chin and sneered at Shadow Weaver. “But you *don’t* know me. You just see what you want to see. That’s worse than being blind. I’m Seacat. I’m the first mate of the fastest ship on all the seas. I’ve outsailed, outfought and out-thought the best of your fleet. I’ve spied on your ships, I set them on fire - and I crippled them in the Battle of Seaworthy. My captain, Admiral Sea Hawk, trusts me with his life.” And she him with hers, of course.

“He must be a bigger fool than I had heard, then,” the witch replied.

She snarled at the witch once more. No one insulted her captain! Well, except Mermista. And Seacat herself- but only if he deserved it. The stray thought allowed her to snort, even chuckle. “Again, you only see what you want to see. He led the Salinean fleet against your ships - and his tactics saw the Horde frigates sunk. He’s been sailing circles around your ships for years. If he’s a fool, then what does that make you?”

“He was lucky so far. But luck runs out sooner or later.” Shadow Weaver’s hand rose, then fell again. “He’ll reap what he sowed soon enough.”

“Keep dreaming!” Seacat spat. “He’ll sink the pathetic rest of your fleet, then the Salienans will take your ports and wreck your supplies! And then Adora will lead the alliance into the Fright Zone and crush the Horde once and for all!”

“Adora will do no such thing! Once she’s separated from the rebellion and back in her proper place, she’ll…”

“...cut you down with her magic sword!” Seacat interrupted her, baring her teeth. “You really think hurting and threatening her friends will work? I haven’t known her for long, but even I can tell you that this won’t end well - for you.” She scoffed, shaking her head. “She said you raised her, but I can’t believe that. Not when she deserted the Horde as soon as she could and spent all her time since then fighting you. If you really raised her, then you were a total failure. A complete screwup! An utter fool! A moron of such...”

“Enough!” Shadow Weaver screeched and pushed her hands towards her.

Seacat saw something sparkle between the clawed fingers of the witch, then lightning struck her.

And she screamed. Her body felt as if she were burning. Her muscles were frozen - and hurting. She was clenching her jaws so hard, she thought she could hear her teeth crack. This was like when she had been hit with one of the shock rods. No. This was worse. Much worse. And different.

But familiar. She’d suffered like this before. No!

She thrashed on the metal floor, convulsing as her limbs flailed around, still screaming. No! She hadn’t been here before. Hadn’t suffered this before.

It couldn’t be. It couldn’t be true. She didn’t… she wasn’t…

She arched her back, against her will, as pain filled her. Overwhelmed her. Reduced her to a screaming, trembling wreck.

But she didn’t care any more.

She *remembered*.

*****

The Return Part 1

"A field exercise?" Adora gasped. "We're going to be deployed in the field?"

Catra rolled her eyes. Her friend was far too naive. This was just another exercise, only in a different location. They probably wouldn't even leave the Fright Zone. Really, Adora shouldn't get so excited. It wasn't as if they'd let her command actual soldiers.

"Indeed. For one week, starting tomorrow, you will be working with units in the field." Shadow Weaver nodded.

"On the frontlines?" Adora asked.

"No, you'll be training with formations which are working up for deployment at the front."

As Catra had expected. Training as usual, just with different instructors. She snorted - silently.

"Oh. New formations?" Adora asked. Always the teacher's pet. Or Shadow Weaver's pet.

"No. You'll be assigned to combat formations that are integrating replacement soldiers. You'll be able to profit from the experience the veteran soldiers will impart on the new soldiers."

"Ah." Adora nodded with the most serious expression. "That makes sense."

"Indeed, Adora. Perceptive as usual."

Catra clenched her teeth. If she had said that, Shadow Weaver would have called her out for being insolent. But Adora got praise. Typical.

"So, which unit will we be assigned to?"

"You'll be split up," the witch told them.

"What?" Catra blurted out. Split up?

"An entire squad would be too much for the formations. By splitting you up, you'll also be forced to interact with experienced soldiers instead of sticking with each other," Shadow Weaver added.

And Catra knew exactly to whom this was addressed. She bared her fangs in response, but the witch didn't even twitch.

Damn.

"Report to your assigned units tomorrow. Dismissed, cadets!"

And the witch glided away. Oh, if only Catra could see her stumble once…

"Wow! We're going to be working with actual soldiers!" Adora gushed.

Catra sighed loudly. "Come on, Adora - she's left. No need to act all eager. It's just training."

"But training as soldiers, not cadets! This is a major step for us - if we do well, we'll be so much closer to becoming soldiers ourselves!"

The others were nodding in agreement. No surprise there - Catra was surrounded by morons and naive Adora. "We're going to be training with them. Big deal." She scoffed. "And we might learn a trick or two from a veteran. Cleaning boots without polish - life-changing."

"I'd love to be able to clean boots without having to replenish my polish can every week."

"Shut up, Kyle!" Catra spat. She scoffed. "Anyway, I'm going to take a nap."

"But we should prepare for the exercise!"

Catra stretched and looked over her shoulder at Adora, who blinked at her. "You can do that. I'm best when I'm improvising." And it was just training, anyway - Catra could do that in her sleep.

*****

"We're deploying?" Catra asked, frowning.

The officer in charge of the company she had been assigned to, Second Company, glared at her. "Are you hard of hearing, cadet? Yes, we're deploying. We're about to take a rebel village. Now get on that skiff there!"

Catra's eyes widened. This had to be a mistake - they weren't supposed to be at the front. They were supposed to be assigned to units in training. She opened her mouth to complain, then blinked. She didn't know that this was a mistake, did she? She was supposed to follow orders from the officer in charge, wasn't she?

Grinning, she saluted, then sped away to the closest skiff. Hah! She'd get actual combat experience! The others would be so jealous! And the best thing, it was Shadow Weaver's fault! The witch had personally handed her her orders!

Hah!

She jumped and grabbed the railing of the skiff, then pulled herself up and slid over it. "Cadet Catra, reporting as ordered!" she snapped, saluting again.

The gruff-looking man at the helm snorted. "None of that here, cadet - we're a recon unit for the main force. We don't salute in the field."

Now that was nice to know. Catra nodded. "Got it."

"So, you're the hotshot cadet who's good for recon, huh?"

Hotshot cadet? Had Shadow Weaver mixed up her orders with Adora's? Catra flinched a little. The witch would blame her, then. But… Adora was slated for command, not recon. She was very good at almost everything, but she wasn't a scout.

Catra, on the other hand, was the best at skulking and sneaking, and getting into places she shouldn't be in. And Shadow Weaver knew that. What if… What if this wasn't a mistake? What if Shadow Weaver had picked her for this operation? A trial by fire? A test to see how she worked with actual soldiers, in her speciality? She smiled, almost against her will. An opportunity for her to prove herself!

"Yes." She nodded. "That's me - the best scout of all the cadets!"

The man snorted again. "Don't get a big head, you're still a cadet. But command said you were good enough for a field mission."

Yes! She knew it! This was her chance! She nodded again.

"So… it's an easy one - Gullpeak, that's the village, shouldn't be fortified. All we have to do is scout out what forces the alliance has in the village. Then we take it, push the enemy out, and go home."

"Sounds easy enough," Catra said. It did.

He shook his head. "It's never easy. But it's simple enough."

She nodded again, then frowned as she spotted an unfamiliar bot walking in formation with the rest of the bots supporting them. "What's that?"

"That? Oh, some new bot. Only the captain knows what it's supposed to do."

"Ah."

Nothing to worry about, then.

Catra picked a spot on the skiff's bow and sat down. They'd take some time until they'd hit the rebel village.

*****

She came to panting and shivering. Her body felt as if she had been dipped in fire. Groaning, she rolled over on the metal floor. She was in a cell - standard Horde prison, she remembered. No, not standard. Reinforced. Had to be. Standard, she could scratch. She had proved that, once.

And she'd been punished for it. By Shadow Weaver. Just like before. Now. She'd tried to explain that now they knew the cells weren't enough for someone like her, but… the witch hadn't listened. Hadn't wanted to listen.

She remembered that day. And she remembered every other day. In the Horde. She was Catra. Horde cadet. Horde scum. Blondie - Adora - had been right. Damn. Damn. Damn!

She wiped her eyes. She couldn't cry. Not with Shadow Weaver watching. No matter how much it hurt.

She took a deep breath. That hurt too - but she could handle that kind of pain. She was used to it. Had been used to it. Damn. Damn. So much… so many memories. She couldn't… she had to focus. She was in a cell. She needed to escape. She had to. This was…

She blinked. Her last memory before… No. It couldn't be. It couldn't!

She clenched her teeth. It couldn't… no, of course, it could be. This was Shadow Weaver.

"Have you learned your lesson?"

She hated that voice. Hated that woman. Clenching her teeth, she opened her eyes and turned her head, staring at the witch. "It wasn't a mistake, was it?" Every word hurt.

Shadow Weaver slightly tilted her head to the side. “What are you talking about?”

“My ’training exercise’. You didn’t make a mistake and assigned me to a frontline unit. You wanted me to go to Gullpeak. As a scout - first into the fray, and all. You wanted me to die.” She shuddered as she tried to sit up without losing eye contact with the witch.

The other woman stared at her for a few seconds before scoffing. “Figured it out, did you? Took you long enough.”

No hint of remorse. No hatred. Just disdain. And that hurt the most.

She should have known better, back then and now. But she had hoped…Of course it had been a pipe dream. A stupid fantasy.

She scoffed in return. “Why did you go to that trouble? Why didn’t you kill me yourself?”

And the other woman laughed. “I see your mental facilities haven’t improved despite your memory returning. I needed to get rid of you before you ruined my dear Adora. But if I had killed you, she would have blamed me. She wouldn’t have understood that it was for the best. That it was better for her. She would have resented me for doing what was needed. What she needed.”

“Hell, yeah, she would have,” she spat.

“So, I had to arrange an accident. I thought about a training accident. Tragic, but it happens.”

She shouldn’t ask, but… she couldn’t help it. “Why didn’t you?”

“In hindsight, I should have. The risk of Adora finding out the truth was minimal. And even though losing a cadet would have reflected badly on me, I could’ve handled the consequences.”

The witch was talking about her death as if it was a footnote. Some banal task - necessary but boring. She found herself hissing under her breath.

"But… I saw an opportunity. If you died at the hands of the enemy - or close enough - Adora would've been even more motivated. Driven by the need to avenge you. And I would be able to console her, and help her through those trying times."

Oh, yes, she could imagine that. Shadow Weaver, playing nicely, being oh so understanding and helpful… She growled. "Too bad that the new bot malfunctioned and killed everyone."

"Oh, yes, too bad."

Wait. That sounded smug, not annoyed. But why would… no. That couldn't be true. It was… not even Shadow Weaver would've been cruel enough to…

"Oh. What are you thinking now?"

"Nothing," she spat. Don't tell the enemy anything. Information was a weapon. But… "You never used that weapon again." She had checked, fearing more such massacres. But no other village had been wiped out like Gullpeak.

"The weapon wasn't reliable. An expensive and costly mistake. Fielded too soon, without appropriate refining."

"It wasn't your weapon." She felt her stomach sinking.

"Of course not. Although I was involved in the development in a peripheral role. Interaction of magical components."

Which would've given her ample opportunities for sabotage. One less rival. One less nuisance. No witnesses.

"You look shocked. Have you started to fool yourself again? Perhaps told yourself that you were so important, someone sacrificed an entire company to get rid of you? Don't flatter

yourself. You weren't worth anything back then, just as you're worthless now."

The crazy women had done it. She stared at Shadow Weaver, baring her teeth. "You failed. I survived. And I even met Adora again while you lost her."

The witch raised her hands again.

This time, she managed to close her eyes just before the spell struck her.

*****

She didn't immediately open her eyes when she woke up next. Instead, she listened - making sure that her ears didn't twitch and gave her away. She couldn't hear anyone or anything but the familiar faint sounds of the Fright Zone's machines. She opened her eyes just a sliver and glanced at the bars of her cell. No one was there, either. Shadow Weaver was gone, then.

Good.

She groaned as she sat up. The witch had been really mad. And Catra… Seacat… had been really stupid. Taunting someone who had admitted that she wanted you dead? That was a desperation move in a fight, not something to do while you were locked up in a cell. The Captain would not be happy with her.

But he'd be happy to be able to scold her for it. She smiled at the thought, then frowned. For that, she needed to escape the prison. Before the others tried to save her and got captured themselves - or worse. Shadow Weaver would be expecting them. Hell, this was probably her plan. Not even Adora would be as stupid as to surrender herself to *Shadow Weaver* for Catr… Seacat.

She blinked. She remembered her life now. Both her lives. Both her names. Both of her very different lives. Damn. She was Horde scum. Had been Horde scum. Watever. Damn. Adora had been right. Again. What would they think of her, once they found out

she hadn’t been a victim of the Horde, but one of the scum wiping out Gullpeak? What would Mermista say? What would the Captain think? She didn’t want to know. Not after… not after...

Sighing, she leaned against the wall. She had no time for this. She had to escape. She could sort this out later. Much, much later.

For now, she had to focus. Escape the cell. Escape the Fright Zone. Return to the others. To Sea Hawk. And Adora.

Adora… Her best friend. Her only friend, not counting Sea Hawk and Mermista, who were… well, something different. So very unlike…

She clenched her teeth. She wasn’t a cadet. Not any more. Nor was she a stupid little girl still dreaming of… whatever.

Except for bashing in Shadow Weaver’s face. Shattering her stupid mask. Paying her back for everything she had done. The witch had tried to kill her. Get her killed. And so many others. Gullpeak. And the entire Second Company. Which had been Horde scum. Like Catra.

She hissed under her breath. Well, Seacat wasn’t Horde scum any more. But the Second Company had trusted Shadow Weaver. And had been… She still couldn’t believe the woman had gone so far. And had she, really? Or was that just another attempt to confuse and manipulate her? Would she really sacrifice a whole company just to get rid of Catra?

No. That was… just no.

But if Shadow Weaver could get rid of a rival, or get more power? Catra didn’t know what exactly Shadow Weaver was doing, other than favouring Adora and getting on her case, but she was a witch. And the second in command of the Horde. She was doing magic, in any case. And the bots weren’t magic. Even if you couldn’t see how they worked.

In any case, Shadow Weaver didn't build bots. Hordak wasn't building them, either. Not that she'd know, anyway. At least she couldn't imagine the Horde leader getting his hands dirty. So, someone else would've built the bot Catra remembered. A potential rival? She couldn't think of anyone. But then, she had been a stupid little girl and hadn't cared about stuff like that.

She shook her head, growling. She had no time to dwell on this. She had to escape. Before her friends did something stupid. More stupid than usual, she added with a snort. Which turned into a sob. Sea Hawk would do whatever he thought would help her, no matter how stupid. Mermista would rein him in - but Mermista hadn't been at Seaworthy. She was days away in her kingdom. And Adora… Adora would also do whatever it took, no matter how stupid or dangerous, to save her. To save Horde - former Horde scum.

She growled again. She had to hope the shrimp and Brain Boy would be enough to keep the others alive.

Great.

She really needed to escape as soon as possible!

Fortunately, for all the pain Shadow Weaver had caused her, Seacat had finally remembered her life as Catra. And that meant she remembered everything she knew about the Horde and the Fright Zone.

And that was a lot. The witch might call her a failure and a nuisance, but Catra had paid attention to their lessons, even if she hadn't shown it. She looked up. If she could get into the air ducts, she could get out. She knew her way around them - all of them were laid out the same way. And while she couldn't reach the air ducts from her cell, out in the hallways, the air ducts were easily accessible for maintenance.

All she had to do was to get out of the cell, first. And now that she remembered Horde rules and procedures, that shouldn't be

too hard…

Well, it wouldn't be easy, either. This was the Fright Zone - and a personal project of Shadow Weaver. The witch wouldn't be using the dregs of the Horde. And if she thought you were slacking off, instead of taking a well-deserved break after doing everything you were told to, then she tended to get testy. And nasty.

She clenched her teeth at the memories that thought brought up. Yes, she couldn't count on the Horde soldiers handling her being sloppy. And she probably couldn't count on Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio returning, either. Not that they would help her, anyway - Lonnie was almost as much a hardass for rules and regs as Adora had been at her worst, and the woman didn't like Catra. Kyle might be gullible enough to get talked into letting her out of the cell.

She frowned. No. It had been four years. Even Kyle would've wised up in that time - he was a Horde soldier now, wasn't he? If he were still as prone to screwing up as he had been as a cadet, he would've been in the cell next to her. Probably.

She snorted at the thought, then sighed. As Sea Hawk had taught her: While she should always be ready to exploit any mistake an enemy made, she couldn't count on them making mistakes in the first place. Any plan that relied on enemy mistakes was a bad plan.

Of course, sometimes, a bad plan was all you had, and, often, a bad plan was better than no plan at all. Sea Hawk disagreed with that, of course, but Mermista was on Seacat's side there.

In any case, she had a decent plan. All she needed was a little luck. And Shadow Weaver being her usual self and ignoring her.

She curled up and shivered, letting her fur ripple a little. Then she moaned and groaned. It wouldn't fool Sea Hawk or Adora, but she was very sure that whoever was guarding her cell and coming to feed her wouldn't know her well enough to tell. And it had worked

on that guard in Seventower, after that misunderstanding about their cargo. It would work here as well. It had to.

All she had to do was look pitiful and wait.

*****

Hours - at least! It was hard to tell the time here - later, she was wondering if they even planned to feed her. Shadow Weaver had tried to kill her, letting her starve wouldn't be beyond her. But it would be stupid - she needed Catra as leverage against Adora. And for that, she needed Catra alive. And reasonably healthy. Or so Seacat hoped. And she had been fed before already.

But she was getting hungry enough so she didn't have to fake her groaning. Perhaps that was Shadow Weaver's plan? Weaken her enough so she couldn't do anything? No. The witch thought Catra was useless; she wouldn't go to such lengths to weaken a 'nuisance'.

She growled under her breath. She'd show the witch who was a nuisance! She was Seacat, scourge of the Horde fleet! She'd show her! Show them all!

As soon as she got out of this cell. And got something to eat. Rations, probably. She gagged at the thought. Hell, if the others knew about how much better people had it outside the Horde, they would… Steps! Someone was coming!

She curled up tighter, holding her stomach - or tried to, with her hands in cuffs, it was a little difficult. And she moaned.

"Here's your dinner."

She opened her eyes, groaning as if it hurt, and blinked. There was a guard, in full Horde armour. And they had dropped a ration bar in her cell, and a water bottle.

"Water?" she asked. After not saying anything for a few hours, and not drinking much, her voice croaked.

But the guard scoffed and turned away.

She almost cried out after them but managed to control herself. When they returned in the morning, her act would look more convincing. Especially if she hadn't touched the food.

Which wasn't really hard, anyway - it wasn't one of the good rations.

Then her stomach rumbled. Damn. She never slept well on an empty stomach. And she needed the rest. As much as she needed the food. Which she couldn't eat.

She crawled forward, in case someone was watching, and grabbed the water bottle. Opening it was awkward with her cuffed hands, but she managed. Drinking helped a little.

She curled up again. The guard would return in the morning.

And then she would escape.

*****

"Catra! Catra!"

Adora was running towards her, waving. And smiling. And behind her were Sea Hawk and Mermista. And the shrimp and Brain Boy. All of them were here, for her!

All of them were walking into a trap. She wanted to warn them - but Shadow Weaver had tied her to a pole and gagged her, and no matter how she struggled, she couldn't break free.

"We'll have you free in a moment!" Adora yelled.

She frantically shook her head. No! No! Don't approach! She tried to yell, but the gag silenced her. No!

Then the trap was sprung - Adora's friends suddenly vanished in a big hole. And Shadow Weaver appeared next to her, holding a

knife to her throat.

"Surrender, or the nuisance dies!"

No! She struggled even harder, but couldn't move even a finger. No! Adora was wavering. Her big sword was pointing at the ground. No! Don't do it, Adora! You stupid idiot!

There was just one way to save her and her friends: She had to remove herself as a hostage. Crying, she pushed her head down, trying to cut her own throat on Shadow Weaver's blade...

*****

She woke up with a gasp, cuffed hands going for her throat. No blood. No pain. It had been a nightmare. A stupid nightmare - as if Shadow Weaver would use such a blatant trap! Or a knife. Just a stupid nightmare.

She forced herself to calm her breathing. A stupid nightmare, nothing more. She was still shivering, though. Her friends were coming for her. She knew it. And if she didn't escape as soon as possible, it would be her fault if anything happened to them. She had let herself be captured by some stupid bounty hunters.

But she had a plan. A good plan. She just had to wait for the guard to return with breakfast. Breakfast… She glanced at the ration bar near the bars. Against her will, her nostrils flared. Food. She was hungry. She needed to eat. Even if it was just a ration bar. And the water… Her throat felt parched. She needed water.

But if she ate or drank, the guard wouldn't fall for her ruse. Clenching her teeth, she curled up, groaning and holding her stomach. If only the stupid Horde scum would arrive already!

It took another eternity - at least an hour - until she finally heard steps. Booted steps. The Horde! She tucked her head into her arms some more and kept her eyes closed.

"Breakfast."

In response, she groaned. Softly.

“Are you trying to starve yourself?”

She groaned again. “Water…”

“There’s water, traitor.”

This was it. This had to work. She slowly uncurled, groaning and holding her stomach. Which was aching for real. “Water?” her voice sounded weak and rough. She blinked at the guard, hoping her face looked as bad as her fur felt. “Go away!”

“I will.”

“Go away!” she repeated herself, then groaned and curled up again. “Leave me alone!” She shuddered and trembled.

“As you want, you… ah, screw it.”

Yes! She hid her grin. Now he would step into her cell, and she would jump him, grabbing his keys and weapons…

“Hey, Lern! I need you - the prisoner seems sick.”

Damn! He was bringing another guard. Well, she could take two Horde scumbags at once. She had done it before.

But the steps she could hear approaching weren’t just from one guard.

“Alright. You two stay outside. Lock up after us. We’re going in.”

“Do we have to?”

“Shadow Weaver wants the traitor alive. If she’s dying from some infection or illness, and we didn’t do anything…”

“Right!”

Damn. At least four, then. And they were smart about it. That meant she had to strike as soon as the bars were pulled up. She clenched her teeth and moaned again as she waited, her heart beating faster in her chest. Any moment now…

Then she heard the sound of metal grinding against metal - the bars were being raised. And then she heard footsteps.

Now!

She uncurled and whirled as she rose into a crouch, then pounced on the two guards standing right beneath the bars with a hiss.

"Whoa!"

"Ah!"

One of them tried to hit her with a shock rod, but he was too slow - he had been aiming at the floor, where she had been, and she was already above him when he started to raise the rod.

She slammed her hands on his helmet and raked her feet, claws out, across his arm and chest, before jumping off him. The one guard next to him was turning towards her, but a kick to the woman's visor sent her stumbling back and further into the cell.

Seacat twisted in mid-air, feet hitting the doorframe, and propelled herself at the guards outside the cell. Both had their shock rods out already, but they still underestimated her. She hit the ground and rolled over her shoulder, under the swing of the closest one. She came up inside his guard with her hands raised above his head and her fangs bared.

Then she raked her claws down his front, shattering his visor and leaving deep gouges in his chest plate - and in his stomach below it. He collapsed, screaming, while she pivoted on the ground, legs sweeping out and catching the second guard in the shins. He, too, fell down with his muscles shredded.

But the first one was already coming at her. She tried to evade, but his boot caught her in the stomach and slammed her back, into the gutted guard.

Seacat had her breath knocked out of her, but she managed to recover before the guard could follow up. Snarling, she jumped straight at him, aiming for his ruined arm. Her knee dug into his stomach, where the armour was flexible, and she hit him in the neck with both hands, digging her claws into his helmet.

Then she twisted until she heard a satisfying crack.

One left. The female guard she had kicked in the head had recovered and rushed her - but, once more, was too slow. Seacat grinned as she hit the door controls and the bars slammed into the woman from above, knocking her down. That gave Seacat rough time to pick up one of the shock rods and drop her for good, then do the same to the guard on the ground who was holding his shredded shins.

Hah!

Now she had to get rid of the cuffs. Didn't one of the guards have a key? They should, shouldn't they? She quickly searched the one who had brought her breakfast - he had ordered the others around. Horde cuffs were standard, anyway, and… there! She grinned as she pulled out the key from the pocket in the back of the guard's belt.

Unlocking her cuffs was child's play. Now she had to get away. The guards hadn't managed to sound the alarm, but that wouldn't last. She pushed the guards still outside the cell into it, then locked the bars in place and wrecked the door controls. Those wouldn't come after her. Well, the one she gutted wouldn't, anyway - he had died in the meantime.

No big loss. Just another Horde scum. She clenched her teeth and grabbed another shock rod - hers would have lost some charges - and one spare.

Then she dashed down the hallway. The doors would be locked with a code, and with all the prison guards knocked out - or dead - she couldn't get the codes out of them. But she only needed access to the air ducts.

The next room was a small room for the guard shift. Four cots, a small table, an armoury - just shock rods, though, and she already had two. Nothing else that would be of use - there were playing cards left on the table, but they had played for bottle caps, not valuables.

But there was food! Well, rations. But the good ones! She grabbed one and wolfed it down while stuffing two more down her shirt - supplies for her escape. Another followed.

And there was the grate covering the air ducts! She was tempted to rip the grate off, but she still had some time - and if she didn't make it obvious how she had escaped, the Horde soldiers would take longer to realise that she was in the air ducts.

She used a small knife to pull out the screws, then removed the grate and crawled inside. Pulling the grate back in place behind her took some squirming and heaving, and putting the screws in was even more of a pain - she didn't manage it, but she managed to get the grate stuck in place by using the screws to wedge it closed.

"So long, suckers!" she whispered, sticking her tongue out, before she twisted around in the narrow duct and started crawling.

She didn't know exactly where she was - there were several holding areas, and this wasn't one of those Catra had seen before - but that didn't matter. She could follow the flow of fresh air.

Sort of fresh, she amended her thoughts with a grimace - the stench of the Fright Zone's factories would never smell fresh to anyone who knew the open sea. Hell, even Seaworthy's harbour at its worst smelled better!

She came to a t-junction. The air current - almost like a soft breeze barely strong enough to fill a sail - came from the right. Following it, she came to a narrow shaft. Up or down? No question. Up. You had to climb up in the Fright Zone.

She entered the shaft. The metal wasn't as hard as the material in her cell, so she could easily climb it using her claws. She passed several ducts branching out from the shaft, but ignored them, following the air current. All the way to the top.

Just like before.

Here, the air currents were stronger, but still no problem. Not for her. She crawled through the air duct until she reached the big fan at the end.

That was a problem. Not the fan itself - she could wreck it and get past it easily enough. But that would also show the guards where she went.

On the other hand, they wouldn't take too long to find the route she had taken - there were not many alternatives.

She scoffed and started slashing at the fans. She needed to get out of the building. Then it would be easy to get away.

She had to duck to avoid one blade spinning as it tore itself off, and another hit her hand hard enough to bruise, but less than a minute later, she was squeezing through the remains. Now only another grate stood before her and freedom! She could see the roof and the sky through the metal mesh! She was almost out of the prison! Just one grate left!

But it resisted her claws. Hissing in frustration, she tried the walls, but they were reinforced as well.

Damn. She tried to reach the screws, but she couldn't get her hand through the grate.

No choice - she had to backtrack and try another way.

Cursing under her breath, she scrambled back. The guards could be detected at any moment, which would trigger the alarm. She needed to be outside when that happened.

She squeezed through the wrecked remains of the fan again, resulting in a tear in her shirt's sleeve, then climbed down the shaft. Still no alert. Good. She took the first air duct from the top. The higher the better - they would be watching the ground entrances. And the underground ones. Few guards ever watched the topmost balconies, as Sea Hawk had taught Seacat.

Granted, he had been talking about sneaking into a palace - Mermista's, to be exact - but it held true. At least in her experience.

She reached a grate and peered through it. Even in the dim light, her eyes had no trouble making out a storage room - no, a janitorial closet. That would be perfect; those were never locked. Now to open the grate…

It was impossible to reach the screws from the inside, but this grate wasn't reinforced metal. She grinned as she started cutting through it. The Horde always went for the cheapest possible solution, as Catra knew. Well, Shadow Weaver probably had luxury quarters, and she doubted that Hordak cut any corners when it came to his, but the Horde couldn't afford to make everything too tough for her claws.

Grinning, she gripped the grate she had cut before it dropped on the floor, then lowered it gently down. It still made a sound - stupid metal floor; a ship's deck would've masked it. She listened for a moment, but couldn't hear anything. Good. And still no alert. How often did they check the cells? Or the guard shifts?

She slid through the opening - no more tears in her clothes this time! - and landed lightly on the floor below. The closet was filled with cleaning supplies, and She frowned. She knew that smell. Catra had been forced to clean the hallways often enough. Too

often. If there were some janitor's uniforms, she could disguise herself and pass as one easily enough, but in her own clothes...

Scoffing, she opened the door a gap wide. Still nothing and no one outside. Still no alert. How many soldiers were in the building, anyway? Shouldn't there be a regular check-in? Or were secret special prisons exempt from that?

It didn't matter; she was getting out of here. She stepped into the hallway and looked around. Left or right? She frowned, recalling the direction. Right it was.

She padded softly through the hallway, ears twitching as she listened for footsteps, or any other signs of Horde soldiers. But she didn't hear anything. Was the prison actually mostly empty? What a waste. Like sending a ship with half the cargo hold empty.

Well, that was the Horde for you…

Snorting, she approached the doors ahead of her. A storage room - paper and ink and stamps; nothing useful - and an office. Not one in use - there was a fine coating of dust on the desk. No windows, though she hadn't expected any - she was, by her reckoning, still not at the outer walls.

There was a checkpoint ahead, but it wasn't manned. This was starting to get weird. Where were the other guards? And the prison staff? Was this prison so secret, only a handful of guards had the needed clearance?

Well, never complain about the enemy making mistakes, as Sea Hawk liked to say. She passed through the checkpoint and reached the stairs. Finally! All she needed was to get to the roof and she would be clear!

Once more, she listened for footsteps. Or talking. Nothing. Was the whole damn building empty? Or was it constructed so the sound didn't carry? Not everyone liked to hear screaming prisoners.

She shook her head as she dashed up the stairs. Escape now, think later.

The door to the roof was locked, but that had never stopped Catra before - well, not since she learned how to manipulate the controls. And the door controls were on the inside, as was standard for Horde buildings.

She grinned as she cut into the side of the panel with her claws, peeling away the cover. Yes - they hadn't changed the setup! She cut the green wire, and the door slid open. Yes!

And the alarm sounded. She blinked, gasping. What the…? Had they changed the door controls? Of course they would have - this was a prison, not the barracks or a factory! Doors to the outside opening would sound an alert!

Cursing her own stupidity, she dashed across the roof to the railing. And froze for a moment. The entire Fright Zone - well, the part of it that she could see from her spot through the smoke - was on alert. She could hear multiple alarm sirens going off - general alert. And she could see soldiers scrambling out of barracks.

Shadow Weaver really didn't want her to escape.

Pressing her lips together, she grabbed the railing and peered down. Yes, there were plenty of hand- and footholds to climb down. But she couldn't take her time. Not with every damn Horde scum looking for her.

She climbed over the railing and started her descent, jumping from ledge to ledge whenever possible. Once she used her claws as a brake to slide down a gutter. More than once she almost fell, only catching herself in the last moment.

And for the whole time, she expected to be detected, soldiers scrambling on the ground to cut off her escape route. Why weren't they gathering? They had to know she wouldn't stay on the roof!

But against all hope, she reached the ground without getting shot at. Good. Now she could disappear in the maze of buildings and channels. The junkyards and factory feeders would be her best bet; no one ever patrolled there unless on punishment detail. And from what she had seen from the roof, she just had to…

"Wow! You're the intruder?"

Seacat froze. A huge figure stepped around the corner, blocking her escape route. Massive claws cracked as she flexed and a giant stinger dangled over her head from an armoured tail.

The Bug Princess of the Horde was barring her way.

*****

The Return Part 2

Seacat hissed. This was bad. Very bad. The Bug Princess was huge - almost as big as a bot, at least it looked like that right now - and unless those bug parts of hers - shoulders, pincers and tail, mainly - were much weaker than they looked, she was tougher than a bot, too. And Seacat didn't have her cutlass, only two shock rods. This wouldn't be… Wait. "Intruder?"

The Horde scum laughed. "You're good - I would have never expected you to reach the prison."

Seacat blinked. 'Reach the prison'? "What?"

"You broke through our perimeter, didn't you?"

Seacat didn't have the time to spend talking. But if she could distract the brute, she might be able to dash past her and make her way to the scrap parts. A huge woman like the Bug Princess wouldn't be able to follow her there.

So she put her best sneer on her face and laughed. "No. I broke *out* of prison. Guess Shadow Weaver lied to you, as usual. She tends to do that."

"What? No, we got the alert from the perimeter patrols." The Horde scum frowned. "You're trying to trick me!"

Seacat's eyes widened. If the Bug Princess was telling the truth - and she wasn't smart enough to lie, that was obvious - then someone else had triggered the alarm by breaking through the… Oh, no! Sea Hawk was already in the Fright Zone! And with Adora!

Damn! Now Seacat would have to find them before fleeing. She would…

…dodge! Now!

Seacat threw herself to the side, narrowly avoiding the charge of the Bug Princess. She rolled over the concrete floor and came up in a crouch on all fours. And gasped. That woman was a monster! Her blows had cracked the concrete and powdered enough of it to throw up a cloud of dust!

And there she came again! This time, though, Seacat was ready. She avoided the pincers by diving to the ground, rolled over her shoulder and dodged to the side, leaving the woman's stinger to pierce the ground.

It didn't get stuck, alas.

"You're fast!"

The woman was a talker, too. "Faster than you," Seacat spat, baring her fangs. Why hadn't the princess sounded the alarm, yet? Not that Seacat was complaining, but… if there were more Horde scum, she'd be easy prey. A single squad would be enough to corner her, with that brute pressing her.

"Hah!"

Another charge. Seacat jumped back, scrambling up the wall, then pushed off when the Bug Princess slammed into it, jumping over the woman. But the stinger shot up as well, and she was forced to parry it with her shock rod. It threw her off some - this monster woman was *strong*.

Seacat twisted in the air and landed on both feet. And with the Bug Princess at the wall, the way out was clear! She whirled and dashed down the passageway. There was no way the Horde scum would catch up to her n…

Something struck her shoulder and sent her flying. She hit the wall to her left, sliding along it and scraping her left arm before she ended up on the ground. What the…? She jumped to the side, avoiding the second chunk of concrete the Bug Princess hurled at her. "That's destruction of Horde property!"

The Bug Princess actually stopped for a moment, blinking. Then she grinned. “I’ll blame it on you!”

Seacat rolled to her feet, then winced - her shoulder hurt like hell. Her right arm was almost useless. She certainly wouldn’t be able to run on all fours like this. Damn. And the woman was charging at her again.

Seacat growled and jumped over the pincers, then struck out with her shock rod at the Bug Princess’s face. There was no bug shell there!

But the Horde scum managed to raise one of her pincers in time to block her. The charge still went off, but the woman wasn’t even fazed. Seacat slammed her feet, claws out, into the shell and pushed off - just in time to avoid the stinger.

And her claws, too, had barely scratched the woman’s pincers. That was so unfair!

“You should surrender - you’ve got no chance!” the woman yelled.

“I’m not going back into prison, Horde scum!” she yelled - and threw the shock rod at the stupid woman’s face. You weren’t supposed to do it - Catra had caught hell for doing it in training - but as expected, the Bug Princess blocked the rod with both pincers. And that meant she blocked her own field of vision, too.

Seacat dashed ahead, drawing her second shock rod, and struck at the woman’s legs. This time, she heard the brute cry out - but the princess didn’t go down, even if she favoured her leg when she turned to face Seacat.

“Nice blow.” The way the woman bared her teeth at her sent a cold shiver down Seacat’s spine.

“Not good enough,” she spat.

“Like you!”

Oh! Seacat snarled. She'd pay for that. This time, she charged at the brute herself. "I've killed worse scum than you!" she yelled, raising the shock rod above her head. And as soon as the woman's eyes followed the rod, Seacat threw it up and jumped forward. She rolled over her good shoulder, and dived between the woman's legs, lashing out with her claws, ignoring the pain in her shoulder.

As the Bug Princess screamed, Seacat dashed forward, whirling to strike at her back - just in time to see the stinger come down and strike her chest.

The impact was surprisingly gentle - all she felt was a slight bump. No sting. No pain. But when she jumped back, she heard her shirt rip as the stinger was lifted.

"And it's over! You fought well, wildcat, but…" The Bug Princess trailed off, blinking. There was a ration bar stuck on her stinger.

Seacat patted her front - just in time to catch the second ration bar she'd had stuffed down her shirt when it slid out of the torn remains of her top. She grinned, baring her teeth, and tried not to wince. Her shoulder was hurting - everytime she moved her arm, it flared up with pain.

"That's… You were carrying ration bars in your shirt?" The Bug Princess seemed more shocked by that than by the fact that her legs were bleeding, and she was propping herself up with one pincer on the wall. She swung her stinger around - but the ration bar remained stuck on it. As anyone who'd had to eat the things would expect.

"They didn't leave me with bags in the cell, you know," Seacat shot back. "I had to make do. And now my shirt's ruined." She was studying the woman. The princess was leaning against the wall, which meant there was an opening on her other side. Seacat could rush forward and go past her before she could react with her wounded legs.

“Your... cell?”

“Yes, my cell.” Seacat moved to the side a little. If she ran straight for the opening, the Bug Princess would intercept her. She needed to trick her again. And with both her shock rods already on the ground, she hadn’t much else left to do so. Well, another ration bar, but that wouldn’t do anything. The Bug Princess’s eyes tracked her. And… “Are you blushing?” What?

“Can’t you, like… fix your shirt?” The woman bit out.

Oh. Oh! Seacat grinned. She could use that. “Why? You did that.”

“That’s not the issue!”

Yes, definitely blushing. She pulled her good shoulder back, and her shirt fell completely open. The hulking brute gasped - and Seacat moved. She dashed, running straight at the woman, claw and ration bar raised.

The Horde scum gasped again, pushing off from the wall to raise her pincers in defence.

Seacat had expected that. She dived again, going down on all three, protecting her wounded shoulder, as if she were going for the other’s legs again.

The Bug Princess fell for it. She slammed her pincers down, trying to catch her - but Seacat had changed course already, sidestepping the attack as she slid around the woman, into the passage behind her. The Horde princess lashed out with her stinger, but Seacat had expected that as well and dodged easily.

“Hey!”

“See you, sucker!” Seacat yelled a moment before she dashed into the narrow side passage around the corner. She might not run and climb as well as she usually could, not with her shoulder hurting like that - but she could outrun the Bug Princess easily even when the Horde scum wasn’t bleeding from both legs.

Of course, the woman still tried to come after her. But by the time she reached the entrance to the narrow passage, Seacat was already leaving it on the other side - by scrambling up a pipe feeding a factory.

"Wildcat!" she heard the Horde scum scream before the sound was drowned out by heavy machinery.

She grinned even as she changed direction - the Horde scum would inform the rest of the Horde. Which was why she grabbed another pipe and slid down to the ground and doubled back a bit - they wouldn't expect that. Certainly not the Bug Princess.

But she still needed to get away for good. And while she knew more or less where she was, she couldn't afford another encounter with Horde scum. And she knew that somewhere in the Fright Zone, Adora and her friends were trying to come for her. Probably stumbling into a Horde ambush at this moment.

So she dashed through two more passages, one underground, then scaled the next factory. All the smoke from boilers and the fog from steam pipes made it very hard to spot anyone on its roof - Catra knew that from experience. But it didn't keep anyone on the roof from spotting guards on the ground. Which she also knew from experience.

On the roof, she quickly moved to the other side, tying her shirt closed - there was no need to give anyone a show any more.

"Now… if I were a stubborn, dumb idiot trying to save me, where would I be?" she muttered as she studied the area between her and the Whispering Woods.

Well… Adora had never explored the Fright Zone as much as Catra had done. Always too much of a good little soldier. They had their secret places - she smiled, remembering that particular ledge - and Catra had dragged her on a few excursions, but Adora wouldn't be very familiar with the back routes out of the Fright Zone - or into it.

Granted, Catra hadn't been exactly roaming the Whispering Woods, either. But she knew her way around the Fright Zone. Unless the Horde had been rearranging entire factories and barracks in the last four years. Which they hadn't, as far as she could tell from here.

So, Adora would be taking the secret passages she knew about. Which Catra also knew. And that meant, assuming she came in from the Whispering Woods, which were the closest area held by the Alliance…

A plume of smoke rose in the middle of the Fright Zone.

"...or the idiot decided on a frontal assault," she muttered under her breath. That had been the main road linking the small arms factory with the arsenal. Adora couldn't really be trying to tackle the Horde head-on, could she? Not even Sea Hawk would do that. They'd be fighting the entire Home Force - Horde garrison, she corrected herself. This wasn't home.

She blinked. Yes, an apparent attack on either the factory complex or the arsenal would draw the attention of all the Horde scum in the Fright Zone. Which meant this was a *diversion*!

She grinned, flashing her fangs. Adora was an idiot, but she wasn't stupid - she knew how the Horde operated. And Sea Hawk knew all about distractions. And blowing things up. If the shrimp was here, she could teleport around and set things up all over the place to blow up or burn!

But if that was a distraction, then where would Adora lead the others? Catra hadn't known about the prison she had been held in. She didn't even know if it was a new building, repurposed or had been there all along. Adora might have known, though - she had been Shadow Weaver's pet cadet, and the damn witch would have shared such secrets with her to make her feel important. Or she might have kept it a secret anyway.

Damn. Decisions, decisions. You didn't have to worry about that on the sea. No, wait - this was exactly like trying to guess which route Scurvy would take to escape a trap. If Scurvy wasn't an ugly bastard who couldn't outsail a Horde tub, but a smart, tough and… whatever.

She clenched her teeth. She had to think like Adora. And Sea Hawk. But Sea Hawk would be trusting Adora to lead them. So… think like Adora. "Oh, I'm such a good cadet, I'll follow orders blindly! Jumping into that hole? Why, at once!"

No, not that. She chuckled. But if this were an exercise, how would Adora run it? Catra's plan would have been rejected for cheating or something. Lonnie would be waiting for orders. Rogelio never said anything, anyway. And Kyle would be useless. But Adora… she'd come up with a plan that wasn't too obvious, but not too complicated either. She'd feint once, then she'd strike. And she'd avoid the obvious route - usually.

That meant… Hm. The normal prison was over there. And Adora didn't know about Shadow Weavers real plans. So, she wouldn't be looking for a secret prison.

She closed her eyes for a moment. Catra knew the area around the prison - Shadow Weaver had threatened her with it often enough so anyone would take a few precautions. Apart from the obvious route, there were two more routes. But the faster one required climbing over a building. Adora wouldn't be doing that - too easy to get caught in the middle of the climb if you weren't as nimble as Seacat. So, the hidden route past the reprocessing plant, it was. Or would be.

Seacat grinned as she dashed across the roof and slid down the largest pipe, before jumping off and landing on a catwalk two floors down, halfway to the ground.

Then she started to run.

Fifteen minutes later, she was leaning against a shabby concrete wall with flaking paint. And coughing. Damn, she had forgotten about the filthy air in the Fright Zone. It was like breathing next to a bonfire when the wind turned and blew the smoke into your face. After Sea Hawks old socks had fallen into the flames.

At least she had reached the passage. Now she just had to wait until Adora passed through. Just as…

An explosion interrupted her thoughts. She blinked, That had come…

...from the prison! But how…? Seacat had gone past the prison on the way here! Had Adora infiltrated the prison already when Seacat had passed through? Without her noticing? Had Adora managed to become sneaky? Well, she would've been with Sea Hawk, but…

She turned and dashed back towards the prison. She checked the sky - the smoke from the explosion was fading, so it wasn't on fire. Yet. But she had to hurry - even cadet Kyle would have noticed the explosion. That meant the Horde was coming. Or, at least, some of them - what with part of the Fright Zone still on fire from Adora's distraction. Which probably had been Sea Hawk's idea.

Her shoulder was getting worse, she noticed. The stupid Bug Princess must have hit her harder than she had thought with that piece of concrete. But she could still fight even if it hurt - she was used to that. Now.

She approached the last corner before the prison and carefully peered around it. There was a huge hole in the prison's walls. Smoke was still coming out of it. There was Brain Boy covering a few Horde scum on the ground. The shrimp was standing on top of a cart, looking down the main road. And there were Sea Hawk and… Adora. Interrogating a prisoner. A Horde prisoner, not a prisoner of the Horde.

At least it looked like an interrogation to Seacat - Adora, in her princess form, was shaking the scum back and forth and shouting: "Where is she? Where did you take her? Stop lying! I know you have her!"

"I'll keelhaul you! On land! After gelding you! Talk, you scum!" Sea Hawk added, flashing his blade.

She found herself smiling. They had come for her, the idiots! Then she smirked and stepped around the corner. "Hey, Adora."

The idiot didn't even notice.

Brain Boy noticed her first. She saw his eyes widening, and she sent him a glare when he opened his mouth, putting a finger across her lips. He fell silent, flashing her a smile. Good boy!

Shaking her head, Seacat started walking towards them. "Hey, Adora."

She was halfway across the road when the Shrimp noticed. To Seacat's surprise, the princess looked at her with wide eyes, then at Adora And Sea Hawk, then at Brain Boy before she giggled. So, the shrimp had a sense of humour. Just hidden most of the time.

"Tell me where she is, or I'll tear off your head!"

"Your other head," Sea Hawk added.

"Hey, Adora."

This time she noticed - Seacat saw her freeze up for a moment before her head snapped around. And her eyes went wide. "Cat-Seacat!"

"Seacat!" Sea Hawk exclaimed. "There you are!"

"Captain." She smiled at him. They had come for her. But now…

"Catra!"

And she found herself lifted off her feet, caught in a hug that would probably put a Kraken to shame.

“You’re alive! You’re here! I was so worried!”

Damn, she was big. And strong. Very strong. It actually hurt. “Ow!” she hissed - that was her woulded shoulder.

“Oh, no! You’re hurt! I hurt you - I’m so sorry! I didn’t mean to… Ack! You need help!”

Catra laughed despite the pain. For all her magic and bulk and muscles, this was still Adora the dummy, overreacting. “Im fine,” she lied. “Just hurt my shoulder a little.”

“Oh, no, and I made it worse!”

“Where were you?” Sea Hawk asked.

“Special prison,” she told him. “So secret, it had only a handful of guards in it. Easy to escape.”

He nodded, then smiled - though she could tell it was a little forced. “I expected no less from my first mate! An adventure we shall sing about!”

“They poisoned my drink,” she told him, “or they would’ve never caught me.”

“We know - we found out, but only after they had left already. What a dastardly plot! But the fiends will pay for it!”

“Bow! We need bandages to treat her wound!” Adora yelled.

“We can do that later,” Seacat told her. “It’s just a bruised shoulder.”

“Your entire shirt is torn! And you’re covered in blood!”

“It’s not my blood,” she told her. “But we need to get out. Half the Horde is hunting you.”

“They’re busy dealing with our distraction,” Sea Hawk said. “We set their factories on fire!”

“I did that,” the shrimp cut in.

“It was my idea!” the captain retorted.

And there came Brain Boy with enough bandages to treat an entire crew after a boarding action.

“I’m fine,” she spat. “We need to go - now. They’re mobilising everyone, and they’ll have noticed the explosion. We need to move before they lock down the area and cut us off from the scrapyard. Come on!”

She started towards the side alley that led to the scrapyard area.

“Wait… how do you know that’s what we... “ Adora blinked.

Now she had to get a clue. Seacat sighed. “I remembered in prison. Everything.”

“Oh.” Adora gasped “So...”

“We need to go. Now!” She bared clenched her teeth, This wasn’t the time to talk about… everything.

The shrimp appeared next to them. “Guys! There’s a squad coming!”

They started running. Finally.

They dashed down the side passage, towards the scrapyard, until they reached a particular t-junction, just as Catra remembered it. “Follow me!” she told the others, starting down the smaller, darker passage.

“But that’s not leading to the scrapyard!” Adora protested. “Are you sure you’re OK? Do you remember everything correctly?”

“Of course I do!” Seacat blinked. “Why do you think we’d be going to the scrapyard?”

“You said so. Just before!”

“Of course I said so - right next to the Horde scum on the ground,” Seacat replied. “They’ll expect us to go to the scrapyard area.”

“Oh.”

Oh, Adora… Seacat shook her head. Still all the subtlety of a particularly dense brick. “Now let’s go!”

“Are you sure we’re not overestimating them?” Brain Boy asked as they sprinted down the passage to make up for the time lost - they still had at least a squad on their heels and needed to be well out of sight by the time the Horde reached the t-junction.

“What do you mean?” Seacat glanced back at him; the man was covering their rear.

“What if they don’t tell them where we’re going?”

“Oh, they will,” Seacat replied. “They’ll fall all over themselves to share such information. Especially after not only losing us, but getting captured by you guys. That won’t look good for them.”

“Oh, yes. Shadow Weaver won’t be happy,” Adora agreed.

Shadow Weaver. Seacat clenched her teeth. The witch would be very unhappy, indeed, if Seacat had any say.

But Sea Hawk agreed. “Oh, yes. It’s an old but very reliable trick. Many ruses work best when the enemy thinks he caught you making a mistake. Sometimes, they even work best when you do make a mistake since it makes it more convincing!”

“Also known as ‘improvising’,” Seacat added. And claiming after the fact that it had all been part of the plan. She snorted and

smiled at Sea Hawk, who beamed at her and raised his sword in salute. While running.

Adora came to a stop in front of another t-junction. “Uh...left or right?”

“Neither,” Seacat told her, pointing at a manhole cover. “Down.”

Her friend gasped. “The sewers?”

The shrimp, predictably, protested as well. “Ew!”

Sea Hawk, though beamed. “A classic escape! We might even get to fight a monster in the darkness!”

“Let’s hope not,” Seacat told him as Adora lifted the manhole cover - with one hand, easily. “Fighting the Bug Princess was enough for one day.”

“You fought Scorpia?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Seacat peered down the shaft and wrinkled her nose. This wouldn’t be fun. But it was their best shot to reach the river docks undetected. No one ever was in the sewers, unless they were on punishment detail. Catra knew that very well.

“Double-Ew!”

Seacat scoffed at the shrimp. “What’s wrong, princess? Afraid to get your shiny clothes dirty?”

“As if!” the princess retorted. A moment later, she vanished with a soft popping sound.

And Seacat heard a splashing sound. The following yelp and cursing that would put Scurvy to shame everyone heard.

She nodded. “Now we know there’s water down there, so be careful you don’t slip off the raised passages on the side of the

sewers.” She gripped the ladder and slid down the shaft, breathing through her mouth.

“Wait, Cat-seacat! You’re wounded - you shouldn’t take point!”

Seacat grinned as she lightly landed on her feet in the sewers, next to a dripping-wet princess.

“That was… that’s… disgusting!” the shrimp told her with clenched teeth.

“Welcome to the sewers,” Seacat replied before plucking a piece of debris out of the princess’s hair. “And you got lucky - this is mostly water used to cool the factories. The barracks are on the other side of the zone.”

“Ew!”

“Wait!” Adora landed next to her. “Let me take the lead.”

“Oh, please!” Seacat retorted. “Who here has the best eyes to see in the dark? And who here has spent the most time down here?” If Adora the great had been sent to patrol the sewers even once, Seacat would...well, Adora hadn’t been.

“But you’re wounded!”

“I can still move and fight.”

“Guys! We should move!” Brain Boy butted in.

“Yes.” Seacat pushed past Adora and headed down the main sewer. The ‘River Route’, as Catra had called it. They wouldn’t have to walk too far.

“Ew!”

“I think I just stepped into something... Something.”

“Are you sure you’re OK?”

"Onward!"

Seacat sighed. They wouldn't have to walk too far, but it would still be a long trip to the river port.

And yet, she was smiling as they made their way through the sewers.

*****

A few minutes and a lot of whining later - really, Seacat was walking barefoot, and did she complain? No, she didn't! Not much, anyway - they reached the river docks. Well, the manhole closest to the piers. "Alright," Seacat told them. "Now we need to sneak into the docks and on to a river barge."

"A river barge?" Sea Hawk frowned. "I think we should board and commandeer a river gunboat, at the least! Fight our way free of the port, then sink the boat to block pursuit and make our way to the sea!"

Well, she should've expected that plan.

"What? No!" Adora protested. "We need to head to the Whispering Woods; it's closest, and we will be able to easily lose the Horde soldiers in there. We'll also be able to reach Bright Moon easily."

The shrimp and Brain Boy agreed with her, of course. Seacat should've expected that as well.

She sighed. "We can't crew a river gunboat. Not if we want to use the guns. And we're on the opposite side of the Whispering Woods border. Not to mention that the Horde will expect us to go back to the woods." Rebels had been using the woods to shelter and infiltrate the Fright Zone for a while, after all. Catra remembered hearing reports of that.

"We could set a few boats on fire and sneak back to the woods," Adora suggested. "Glimmer can drop a few more firebombs, like

before."

Sea Hawk looked torn, Seacat noticed. He liked setting ships on fire, but to abandon the river plan for a trip through the woods? And he enjoyed starting the fires himself. On the other hand…. Oh.

Seacat shook her head. "They'll expect another diversion."

"They'll have to react anyway," Adora retorted. "And Glimmer can teleport us half of the way. Right?"

The shrimp didn't look as confident as Adora but she set her jaw and nodded firmly. "Yes, I've got enough left for that."

So, that was how they had gotten the climbing part done, Seacat noted. But she still didn't like the plan. And not just because she didn't want to go back to the woods. "They'll expect a diversion. And they have enough troops to cover the borders to the woods anyway. I doubt that they withdrew the pickets and patrols."

"They haven't," Adora admitted.

Seacat nodded. "So… we can set a few barges and boats on fire, and sneak away on another barge escaping the attack."

Sea Hawk nodded in agreement. "That's a cunning plan worthy of adventure! Unless we manage to take a gunboat, of course."

Seacat resolved to have the shrimp prioritise gunboats when it came to burning ships.

"Still… if we're caught on the barge…" Adora worried.

"Glimmer can get us out then," Brain Boy replied. "Provided you don't overdo it in the port."

"I won't."

Adora frowned, but Catra could tell that she was just holding out because it hadn't been her idea. She would give in anyway.

Seacat grinned. This wasn't a military exercise - this was perfect for Catra's skills. Seacat's, she corrected herself with a frown. "I'll take a look," she told the others and started climbing.

Holding up the manhole cover with one hand, using a foot to brace herself so she could let her hurting shoulder rest, Seacat peered out at the river docks. "The guards are on alert," she said. "And there are more of them than normal." At least what Catra remembered as normal.

"We can take a few more guards!" Adora said below her.

"As long as we're quick enough to get away before reinforcements arrive."

"Yes, I think…" Seacat trailed off and hissed. There was a bot walking around as well. That definitely wasn't normal.

"What? Is something wrong?" Adora whispered.

"They've got a bot too," Seacat replied. And tried not to think of Gullpeak.

"Ah. No problem."

Seacat nodded. No problem at all. She had to believe that. She could handle a bot, anyway. Had done so before. Before she had remembered her life as… whatever. She peered around. "We can't get out here without being seen," she said. There's a guard keeping an eye on the area."

"Where are they?" the shrimp asked. "I can take them down easily."

"Corner post," Seacat told her. "Come get a look." She was getting a little tired bracing herself and keeping the manhole cover propped open, anyway.

"Jump, I'll catch you!" Adora told her.

Letting Adora catch her? Like a… She forced the weird feelings down. Anyway, she wasn't an invalid. She could handle herself. "No need," she said, then started sliding down the ladder, jumping the last few yards and landing in a crouch in front of Adora.

And barely splattered her with murky water from the puddle in which she landed.

"Hey!"

Seacat chuckled. "What, are you afraid of a little water?"

"No!" Adora lied. Then she grinned. "It'll vanish anyway once I change back."

Seacat gasped. That was cheating!

But the shrimp was already climbing up. She probably was running low on her magic, Seacat thought, or she'd have teleported. That meant escaping might not be as easy as they assumed.

She heard the princess grunt and looked up. The shrimp was struggling with the cover. Seacat turned to Adora. "Can you lift the lid with your sword or something?" Adora was tall enough, as She-Ra, and the shrimp small enough, for this to work. Without cutting anyone by accident. Probably.

"I don't need help." The shrimp grunted even louder and made a funny grimace as she kept pushing up.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Don't be stupid."

"I'm not!"

Too stubborn to admit she needed help. Really, Seacat had expected better from Bright Moon's princess. "Adora…" she started.

But before she could tell her friend to help the shrimp, she heard a popping sound - the princess had vanished. Had she teleported blindly? No, there was the sound of the manhole cover falling closed again. "Never mind. She got it. Finally."

"Glimmer's stronger than most think," Adora said with a smile.

And more stubborn and stupid, too, Seacat added to herself. Not that she cared unless the princess got them killed.

Which was a real possibility if the shrimp screwed up taking out the guards. If the bot sounded an alarm… They would have to flee. Either on the ground or down below. They'd be more mobile, but more exposed up there - down here, they were limited and cut off more easily - if the Horde was quick enough. And if they realised that they were fleeing through the sewers.

Decisions, decisions. Wait. If the princess screwed up, Adora would charge in to save her anyway. She wouldn't abandon her friends. And that would make trying to sneak away undetected much harder. Heh, she was already waiting right at the top of the shaft, ready to jump out. No, sneaking away through the sewers was probably impossible.

"Let's go!"

And here we go, Seacat thought as Adora pushed the cover away and jumped out.

"Adventure!" Sea Hawk was next up the shaft.

Seacat looked at Brain Boy.

"After you," he said.

She grinned and scrambled up the ladder herself. Time to sink more Horde ships!

She reached the top of the ladder and climbed out, then froze for a moment. There was the bot - and it was glowing. Before she

could react, though, the bot collapsed, and Adora appeared behind it, pulling her sword out of it. “Hah!” she yelled, grinning widely.

And there was the guard - on the ground in a growing pool of blood. Glimmer must have killed them from behind, as planned.

“Huzzah!”

The captain! Seacat whirled, then cursed. Sea Hawk was charging down the pier, towards the largest gunboat moored there. The gunboat with the crew scrambling to man the guns. She looked around - Adora was mowing down a squad of soldiers and about to break through into the gun emplacements guarding the port. The shrimp was too far away, dropping firebombs on more gunboats. “Brain Boy! Support the captain!” she yelled, already charging after Sea Hawk.

If only her shoulder were whole! She dashed across the pier, jumping on top and then down from an overturned cart full of rations. The first Horde gun crew was already loading their carronades - and Sea Hawk was too far away to…

An arrow hit the gun, and both it and its crew vanished in a… splatter of glue? What was Brain Boy doing?

But stuck to the gun, the Horde scum couldn’t bring it to bear - and there was Sea Hawk!

“For the Alliance! Adventure!” he yelled as he jumped, landing on the deck of the gunboat. His blade flashed, and a Horde sailor fell. But more were coming.

Seacat pressed on. She was almost there. Half a dozen sailors charged the captain - one fell with an arrow in his chest - but Sea Hawk could handle that.

The gun crew trying to bring the swivel gun to bear on him, on the other hand… Seacat snarled and jumped on a crate on the pier, then pushed off, landing feet first on the loader of the gun.

Her claws slashed across the woman's back, sending the Horde scum down onto the deck in a shower of blood. Seacat dropped and rolled over the deck, grunting with pain when her wounded shoulder struck something, then came up in a crouch, claws out and rushed the gunner.

The fishwoman shrieked and drew her cutlass, but she was too slow. Seacat grabbed the gun barrel and threw it to the side - which rammed the breech into the fishwoman's side, sending her staggering to the side. Before the Horde scum could recover, Seacat vaulted over the gun and struck out with her feet, raking the sailor's arm.

The fishwoman dropped her cutlass and fell down, clutching her ruined arm. Seacat snatched up the blade and slashed the Horde scum's throat, then whirled. Sea Hawk was finishing off the last two sailors fighting him, and… the helmsman on the bridge was on the ground, an arrow stuck in his head.

But the officer on deck was already gripping the wheel, and more sailors were casting off the lines that kept the boat moored. Seacat snarled, ignored the pain in her shoulder and rushed the bridge.

The officer - the captain; up close, Catra recognised the rank tabs - let go of the wheel and met her with her sword. "Rebel scum!" she yelled, slashing with the blade.

"That's alliance scum!" Seacat retorted, deflecting the blow and riposting with her new cutlass.

But the enemy was good - she fell back as she parried, keeping Seacat at a distance so she couldn't use her claws.

"And former Horde scum!" Seacat yelled as she repeatedly lunged at the Horde captain, trying to land a blow.

"Traitor!" the Horde scum snarled as she parried each blow - though with mounting difficulty, Seacat noticed.

Grinning, she sidestepped a counter-lunge, then attacked again, driving the enemy captain further back - until the woman stepped into the pool of blood left by the helmsman, and her next parry sent her stumbling when she lost her footing or a moment.

Long enough for Seacat to bat her blade aside and bury her cutlass in the woman's gut. Whatever the Horde scum had been about to say was drowned in the blood gushing from her mouth.

Seacat kicked the enemy's blade away and turned. The remaining Horde sailors had been killed or driven to jump overboard by Sea Hawk. Time to look for a barge to hide on while Adora and the others finished off the Horde garrison of the river port.

She blinked, then cursed. Brain Boy was running towards the gunboat they had just taken, carrying the shrimp in his arms. And Adora was holding back what looked like an entire assault company trying to storm the pier.

With the shrimp knocked out, there was no way they'd make it on a barge without getting spotted.

Seacat cursed and gripped the steering wheel. They had no choice, now. "Captain! Cut the lines as soon as Brain Boy is on board!" she yelled.

"Huzzah! Another daring plan comes together!"

The captain slashed the last two lines, and Seacat felt the ship starting to drift as the river's current dragged it away.

Brain Boy made the jump before they left the pier, landing in a heap on the deck. But Adora…

Seacat clenched her teeth. Her friend was still fighting - mowing down half a dozen Horde scum. But a dozen had her surrounded, shock rods out. And even more were coming.

"Adora! Jump!" Seacat yelled, turning the wheel to keep the boat alongside the pier for a little longer. "Jump!"

The idiot wasn't listening!

"Adora! Jump!"

She saw Adora's head snap towards her as the blonde parried a blow from a huge minotaur.

"Jump!"

Then Adora raised her blade, then brought it down and drove it into the ground - and the pier broke apart.

As Seacat stared, Adora jumped off, landed on a chunk of the pier as it slid onto the water, and jumped off again - to land on the deck next to Brain Boy and the shrimp.

"Huzzah!"

Seacat started breathing again and threw the wheel, turning the gunboat away from the collapsing pier.

They needed to get away before the Horde brought artillery to bear on them.

Which would be damned hard, what with the Horde's fortifications dotting the river - even the witch was aware that they had to protect one of the Horde's most important supply lines.

They needed a new plan, and they needed it right now.

*****

The Return Part 3

Without sails, the gunboat was slowly going - the current pushed it, which made steering it a little tricky, but they couldn't go any faster. "We need to set sails!" Seacat yelled - the wind was blowing from a favourable direction. One piece of good luck so far.

That would change at the first bend - but with their current speed, they wouldn't reach the first bend, not with the Horde giving chase.

"I've dismantled the guns in the fortification," Adora yelled. "But there's another gun emplacement further down the river."

Seacat knew that already. The captain was rushing to the mainmast, but he wouldn't be able to set the mainsail by himself. "Help Seahawk!" she yelled. Brain Boy was treating whatever wounds the princess had suffered, but Adora was so strong - at least as She-Ra - she could probably *carry* the sail up the mast if she tried to. Not that it would be of any use.

But they needed to pick up speed. As slow as they were, the Horde scum could keep pace with them on foot, and if they… She drew a hissing breath through clenched teeth. Skiffs! Horde skiffs had appeared on the banks of the river.

Worse - those were the artillery skiffs she had heard of. "Watch out!" she yelled. "Artillery!"

"What?" Adora whirled.

The skiffs were already setting down to deploy the guns. And the Horde soldiers with them didn't look like the dregs of the service. At this distance, and with how slow the gunboat was going, they wouldn't miss.

"An artillery duel! Huzzah!" Sea Hawk was rushing towards the gun that hadn't been immobilised by Horde scum stuck to it. "Follow me!"

“Can you even shoot the gun?” Adora yelled - but she was running after the captain anyway.

Seacat hoped her friend had received some training in gunnery in the last four years - she knew they hadn’t received any while she had been a cadet in the Horde.

She corrected the course a little - she wanted to hug the river bank opposite the Horde guns, but she couldn’t get too close, or she might end up running aground - and clenched her teeth as she watched the four guns set up. A few more minutes, tops, and they would be under fire. And Sea Hawk was talking Adora through loading the gun. Apparently, she had stayed on the command course. Damn!

“Don’t worry, it’s really easy! Just open the breech like this, put the shell in, then the powder charge… yes like this! Slam the breech closed, aim and… FIRE!”

The gun bellowed. Dirt was thrown up in front of the Horde guns - they had missed.

But at least part of the crew looked rattled. Oh, one soldier was down, too - must have caught some shrapnel. Seacat hoped that they had been the main gunner.

Then she saw the guns move. The Horde gunners were aiming!. Cursing, she pulled on the wheel, pulling away from the river bank - and slowing down. If she timed it right…

The guns fired - smoke and flames shot out of their muzzles, followed by the sound of the shots rolling over the river.

Two missed, throwing up water in front of the slowed gunboat. The third didn’t, hitting the foredeck - and wrecking the gun there, with the Horde scum still stuck to it. Seacat winced as she saw the mangled, bloody mess left - that could’ve been her friends! Or herself.

But Sea Hawk was unfazed - and Adora, stubborn as always, had already reloaded the gun. Once more, the captain returned fire. Seacat tried to track the shot with her eyes - but this gun fired too fast.

One of the horde gun emplacements blew up in a giant explosion, throwing pieces and body parts all over the other guns and wrecking the skiff behind the gun.

"Huzzah! We hit their ammunition!" Sea Hawk cheered.

"Yes!" Seacat hissed.

One gun down, and the explosion had hurt two more crews - including the slower one. They fired, but their shot went wide - Seacat had steered the gunboat back on the fastest course.

Now it was a race between their gun and the remaining ones. And Sea Hawk and Adora beat the Horde - their next shot wrecked the fastest gun remaining on the river bank, toppling it and shredding the crew with shrapnel.

That left two wounded, shaken crews. And the distance was opening. The Horde fired before Adora managed to reload, but both shots missed - the near-misses must have thrown their aim off.

Sea Hawk missed in turn, but close enough to kill a few more soldiers - and one skiff was smoking. The Horde scum had had enough and started falling back - or fleeing.

Seacat took a deep breath. They had gained a little time. She hoped it was enough to find a way to escape - they couldn't stay on the river. The next gun emplacement would be ready for them. And those guns wouldn't be artillery meant for the field, but rifles meant to sink ships.

But they couldn't get off the river either - not without getting spotted and run down by half the Horde. There were skiffs following them on both sides now - fortunately, there were no

artillery skiffs among them, but the scouting skiffs would ensure they couldn't slip away, not without the shrimp teleporting them.

Seacat glanced down at the deck and clenched her teeth. The princess was awake now, but she didn't look in any shape to stand, much less use magic. Damn. Although… She grinned. They could set the gunboat on fire - make it look like the shot that hit them had caused it - and then escape by diving. They could probably scrounge up makeshift snorkels to stay underwater longer… with all the smoke and fire, the Horde soldiers would be unlikely to spot them, and then all they needed was a good spot to sneak up the riverbanks unseen. And Catra remembered such a spot from a past exercise as a cadet.

She nodded. Yes, this was a doable plan. All they needed was a little luck and some…

She blinked. Down on the deck, Adora was glowing. And pointing her sword at the shrimp. What the…? She almost hit a sandbank in the river.

In front of her eyes, a glowing beam shot out from the tip of Adora's sword and hit the shrimp. And the princess shuddered, then stood, smiling and hugging Brain Boy and Adora - who had shrunk down to her normal size, too.

Well, using magic to heal their teleporting princess worked as well, Seacat had to admit. And they wouldn't need to cobble together snorkels. But they still needed a distraction - even the Horde scouts wouldn't miss the sparkles if they teleported from the deck.

"Hey, princess!" she yelled. "Can you teleport us to the riverbank in a few minutes? Or do you need to nap a little?"

"I can teleport you right now!" the shrimp yelled back.

Yes, she was back to normal. "No need - we need to pass the right spot, yet," Seacat told her. "Remember the exercise where we dunked Lonnie in the river?" she asked Adora.

“You did that!” Adora replied. Then she nodded. “Yes, I do.”

“Good. That’s where we’ll get off this boat.”

“Yes!” Sea Hawk yelled. “I’ll prepare the distraction!”

“The distraction?” the shrimp asked Adora in a low voice - she probably didn’t intend Seacat to hear her.

“We’ll set the ship on fire so the smoke will mask our exit,” Seacat yelled down. “So, get ready.”

“He’ll set the ship on fire?” Brain Boy looked shocked. He really should’ve expected that. This was Sea Hawk, after all.

“No, of course not!” Sea Hawk’s head popped up in the open hatch in the middle of the deck. “I’ve already done that!” he added as he climbed out, followed by the first wisps of smoke. “Huzzah! This will be our most dramatic rescue, yet!”

Which meant he had cut the fuse a little short - so to speak. Seacat steered the gunboat a bit closer to the riverbank as the next bend appeared. They would need all the speed they could get to reach the exit spot before the fire reached the magazine.

“Why exactly did *we* have to rescue her again?” Seacat heard the shrimp complain to Brain Boy. She better not be serious!

“Because Adora and Sea Hawk were rushing off with or without us and someone had to be sensible here?” Brain Boy replied.

Hey! Seacat was the most sensible of the group!

By now, steering had become a little tricky since smoke was covering most of the foredeck. In fact, Seacat couldn’t see much of the river any more - but she could see the first flames licking the deck from below. And the spot with the bushes and dense underbrush leading into a patch of woods was still about a minute away.

Adora climbed up to the bridge. “Are you sure about this?” she asked in a low voice.

“Do you have a better idea?” Seacat briefly turned her head to flash a grin at her friend.

“I had a better idea - before we ended up on this…” Adora shook her head as Sea Hawk started to throw bags of powder over the railing. Yes, the captain had cut it a little close.

“Hey! My plan was to sneak onto a river barge.” And that had been a much better plan than using the same route that you used to get in to get out again.

She turned the wheel - it was getting a little hard now, in this current - and winced when pain flared up in her shoulder as a result.

“You’re hurt worse than you said!” Adora sounded aghast.

“I can still walk, run and steer the ship. A little pain is nothing compared to Shadow Weaver’s punishment.”

She heard Adora gasp and felt guilty about the low blow - but they really couldn’t afford to talk right now. “Alright! See the green bush there? We need to teleport right behind that one!” she yelled.

“What bush?”

Oh for…! “Get up here and take a look!”

“Glimmer!”

But the shrimp was already climbing the stairs. And she managed to catch a glance before the billowing smoke blocked their view.

“Alright! Everyone off the ship now!” Sea Hawk yelled, running towards the bridge.

Seacat cursed. That meant they had a few seconds left, tops. She grabbed the shrimp's arm. "Let's go! Now!"

They scrambled down the ladder to the deck, where Sea Hawk and Brain Boy were waiting, coughing in the smoke.

"Go now! Now!"

Seacat saw the flames in the hatch suddenly grow much brighter - and then the whole boat vanished.

*****

She landed on a steep slope and barely managed to grab the closest branch to keep from falling down and into the river. Looking around, she held her breath, then relaxed - everyone was with her, too: Adora, Sea Hawk and Brain Boy. And the shrimp, but that was a given seeing that the princess had teleported them. In the last second, actually.

Seacat hadn't heard an explosion, though - had the boat…? Turning around, she saw the smoking remains spread over the river, a number of smaller fragments still in the air. No, the gunboat definitely had blown up. Completely. That must have been a big powder magazine. But why weren't her ears ringing? Had the ship exploded in mid-teleport?

"A harrowing adventure, indeed!" Sea Hawk commented as he got up and brushed off some dirt from his pants. "But well-timed!"

"You cut that far too close!" Adora protested. "We almost died!"

"I had faith in Princess Glimmer," the captain retorted, unfazed. "And the closer, the better - the Horde will surely assume we died with our brave little boat."

The gunboat had been larger than the Dragon's Daughter IV. But with everyone glaring at Sea Hawk, Seacat wouldn't point that out.

“Guys? We need to move. They’ll cover the riverbanks!” Brain Boy said.

He was right, of course. “Are you strong enough for another teleport?” Seacat asked the shrimp. She did look a little under the weather. Not as bad as before Adora healed her, but not well either.

“No, she isn’t,” Adora replied.

“Hey!”

“Glimmer…” Brain Boy’s hand on her shoulder apparently shut the princess up.

“Let’s go, then. We need to be deeper in the forest when the Horde starts searching the riverbanks,” Seacat said. The skiffs couldn’t navigate the forest here, but there would be squads on foot coming - or by barge.

She started climbing up the rest of the slope. The soft soil made it a little tricky, especially with one arm - her claws weren’t as useful as usual.

“Ca-Seacat! How badly hurt is your shoulder?”

Damn. “I’ll manage,” she replied to Adora without looking back.

“I can carry you.”

Like hell she would let Adora carry her! This time, she glared over her shoulder at her friend. She wasn’t an invalid - she had escaped from prison by herself, hadn’t she?

Her friend flinched for a moment, then that stubborn expression set in. “I can carry you.”

“I’m fine,” Seacat spat, clearing the last part of the slope before the more even part of the forest.

“But you’re hurting!”

“A little pain never hurt anyone,” she retorted.

“What? That makes no sense! Catra!”

It made perfect sense! Seacat huffed and quickly moved ahead. There was a road cutting through the forest near the river - they had to cross it unseen.

“Don’t be so stubborn! We’re here to help you!”

She turned and hissed. “I don’t need your help! I am fine!”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “We’ll treat all our wounds once we’re safe - relatively safe.”

She glared at him, but the captain simply smiled at her. Huffing, she turned around and continued towards the road.

“Why is she listening to you? She never listens to me!”

Really, had Adora forgotten how good her ears were? And it wasn’t true - Catra listened to Adora, as long as Adora wasn’t being dumb. Or no fun. Or needed to get taken down a peg or two.

“Why, she’s my first mate, and I’m her captain, of course.”

That, too, of course.

“But… I was a force captain, too!”

Seacat rolled her eyes.

*****

They reached the road a few minutes later, at which point Adora stopped complaining in a not-low-enough voice to Sea Hawk. Unfortunately, as Seacat could see from a bush overlooking most of the road, Horde soldiers were already deploying there - and

they would start sweeping the forest between the road and the river soon.

“We can take them,” the shrimp muttered next to her.

“That would alert them to our survival - and to our escape route,” Adora, on Seacat’s other side, replied.

It was getting a little crowded here.

“Letting them find us will do the same, anyway,” the princess retorted. “And we can’t exactly hide.”

“We could, actually,” Seacat informed the shrimp. “We could dig holes and hide there. But we don’t have the time to do that.” Catra had managed to hide like that a few times as a cadet.

“That makes no difference then,” the princess told her.

“We could take out the soldiers and take a skiff!” Sea Hawk suggested. “A fast skiff - fast enough to escape their net!”

“And we’d need two skiffs,” Seacat pointed out, “unless there’s a cargo skiff around. Or an artillery skiff.” And no Horde commander would send either into the woods.

“We could ambush a patrol and take their uniforms,” Adora said.

“They would still miss the patrol.” Seacat would prefer a method that wouldn’t let the Horde figure out that they hadn’t died in the gunboat’s explosion.

“Do you have a better idea?”

Seacat didn’t need to look at Adora to know that she was frowning at her. Like she used to frown at Catra when they disagreed about a plan of action.

She scowled. “No,” she admitted. “Unless the shrimp can teleport us across the road.”

“Uh…”

“I’ll take that as a no,” Seacat said. “I guess plan ‘strip the guards’ it is.”

“And then we can commandeer a skiff or two!”

Sea Hawk wasn’t one to drop a plan easily; Seacat knew that very well.

“It’s not ‘plan: strip the guards’!” Adora shook her head. “You make it sound as if we want to see them naked!”

Seacat grinned at her. “But we do want their uniforms, don’t we?”

“Yes, but…” Adora shook her head, then suddenly smiled. “I’ve almost forgotten how you…” She trailed off.

But Seacat knew what she meant. Catra had loved needling her like that. “Let’s get into position,” she said with a grin.

“Position?” Brain Boy asked.

“Standard Horde tactics are to start at one end of the forest, not both. It cuts down on friendly fire. They’ll keep the road secure with the main force and send a smaller force in to sweep the forest to flush us out,” Adora explained.

Seacat wouldn’t do it like that, but Catra had learned long ago that unless it came from the top, the Horde wasn’t very keen on new ideas. “So, we’ll set up a little towards the middle,” she said. Far enough so the patrol won’t be as sharp as at the start.

“It’ll also give us time to camouflage us,” Adora added as she rushed through the underbrush.

“But we’ll be further from the skiffs,” Sea Hawk protested.

“That won’t matter,” Seacat told him. “We can fake having wounded who need to be evacuated.” At least, she hoped they

would have to fake the wounded.

“Ah, yes, that would work - very cunning!” Sea Hawk nodded as he ducked under a thick branch.

*****

When the Horde patrol finally showed up, they weren’t as sloppy as Seacat had hoped, but they certainly weren’t sharp. They had been at this for the better part of half an hour, and it showed - they had split up a little too much, which would make them lose sight of each other frequently.

Good. That meant they had a chance to take out the patrol without the rest noticing. That would allow them to change into the uniforms to fool the Horde forces outside the forest.

Perched on a branch, she grinned as she saw them come closer. And they weren’t looking up - they never looked up.

“This is a waste of time,” she heard one of the Horde scum grumble. “You saw the explosion. No way anyone could’ve survived that. Magazine went up.”

“I didn’t know that you were a sailor, Jens. Got lost on the way to the sea and followed us into the woods?”

“Friend of mine is in the fleet, arse!”

“Cut the bloody chatter! The rebels could be hiding behind the next bush!”

Seacat mentally marked the apparent leader of the group. His position - second behind the point man - matched the Horde tactics, too. Predictable, really. Which meant that this patrol would be made up of five soldiers. They could take five Horde soldiers without splitting them up - but Seacat would take any advantage she would get. Especially with her hurt shoulder.

She looked to her right, where Brain Boy was in another tree, then down to the others and signalled five enemies, wedge formation.

Adora nodded - but then had to explain to the others, who didn't recognise Horde signs. Great. Seacat made eye contact with Brain Boy and tried to communicate the plan to him. After two repetitions, he nodded.

She hoped he had understood, or they would have to improvise - Sea Hawk style.

But then the patrol was too close to say anything, and Seacat took a deep breath before moving a little further ahead on her branch. She and Brain Boy would take the two Horde soldiers on this side. And since she didn't have a trick bow, she had to do it the hard way.

The semi-hard way, she corrected herself as her target - the complainer she had heard before - started to make his way around the trunk of her tree. And he wasn't looking up at all!

Perfect. She glanced towards Brain Boy and snapped her hand downwards. Then she pushed off and pounced.

She hit the idiot's helmet with her feet - heels first - and drove him face-first into the soil. Before he could react or even cry out, she sneaked her good hand under his chin guard and opened the strap. He started to groan as she pulled the helmet off, but she grabbed his hair and slammed his face into the closest root a few times until he stopped moving.

And her shoulder only hurt a little more.

Then she looked up. Brain Boy had shot an arrow through the faceplate of his target. Messy - but then, they planned to fake a wounded or two, right?

And Adora, Sea Hawk and the shrimp were already moving towards the three remaining Horde soldiers. Seacat jumped up

and followed the shrimp - Adora and Sea Hawk wouldn't need any help dealing with a single soldier each.

"I don't need help," the shrimp whispered.

"I don't care," she hissed back. "You can't teleport, can you?"

The princess huffed, then fell silent as they crawled through a dense bush.

"Hey, Jens, did you drown?"

"I said cut the chatter!"

"Jens?"

Damn. Time was running out. Seacat dug her claws into the soil, getting traction. Good.

"Sibon, go check on Jens and Lori!"

"Alright."

Adora and Sea Hawk should be close enough now. Seacat licked her lips. Almost…

The Horde scum stumbled over a root, and Seacat shot forward, ramming her good shoulder into his gut, and tackled him to the ground. With his breath knocked out of him, he couldn't yell - and there was the shrimp, hitting his helmet with a staff. Again and again. With enthusiasm.

The soldier didn't recover until he was out. Or dead - there were a few dents in the helmet.

Adora and Sea Hawk had finished their soldiers more quickly, though Sea Hawk had run his target through.

Well, good enough for a second wounded.

“Hurry! We need to change!” Adora snapped. “Pick a soldier close to your size and strip them!”

Seacat snorted, which earned her a glare.

“You know what I mean!” Adora told her.

Of course she did. But teasing Adora was fun.

Stuffing your tail down the leg of an already uncomfortable uniform wasn’t fun, though. Nor was squishing your ears flat with a helmet not made for you. But the worst was the smell. “I don’t think that their commander enforced the hygiene regulations,” she spat while trying to breathe through her mouth.

“They are loosened in the field,” Adora told her. “Don’t you… oh.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. Catra hadn’t really cared much about regulations on her first and last field deployment.

“I look ridiculous,” the shrimp complained.

She did, actually - the uniform really didn’t fit her body. “You can be one of the wounded, then,” Seacat told her.

“What?”

“And you’re the other one,” Adora said. “You’re already wounded.”

“I’m also the only one who knows how to act as a Horde soldier,” Seacat replied.

“Except for me.”

“No. You know how to act as a Horde captain, not a soldier.” Seacat grinned.

Adora opened her mouth, but closed it again, obviously trying to find a counter-argument. “That’s…”

“You can be a walking wounded,” Sea Hawk said. “That means we have three wounded. Princess Glimmer, Bow and you.”

“Why us?”

“You would stick out with your height,” the captain told the princess.

“Or lack of height,” Seacat added.

“And Bow perfectly fits the damaged uniform, but not the others,” Sea Hawk went on.

“Ah.” Brain Boy nodded.

“But…” The shrimp wasn’t giving in easily.

“Glimmer!” Adora interrupted her. “Sea Hawk’s right. I’ll carry you.”

The commander of the patrol wouldn’t carry a wounded, Seacat thought. On the other hand, some officers might - at least if everyone else was already wounded or carrying a wounded. “Let’s go, then!” she said.

Time to nab a skiff.

*****

A few minutes later, they were nearing the road and Seacat started screaming: “Help! Help! We need help!”

“Ambush! Rebel ambush!”

“Help!”

“We need support!”

The first squads were already entering the forest when the group stumbled onto the road. A huge minotaur - a squad leader

according to the rank tabs - confronted them. “What happened? Report!”

Adora actually straightened, saluting with the shrimp still hanging on her shoulder. “We were ambushed in the area straight behind us with overwhelming force. We managed to retreat with our wounded, but they were right behind us.” She gestured at Brain Boy, who was leaning on Sea Hawk, faking a gut wound.

Seacat tensed. If the Horde scum knew the patrol leader…

But the minotaur nodded. “Get the wounded to the skiffs. We’ll hunt the rebels down!” He started bellowing orders to the Horde soldiers gathered around them, and Seacat relaxed. A little - they still had to overpower the guards at the skiffs and escape. And then lose the inevitable pursuit.

But for now, they had fooled the Horde soldiers. As the Horde scum broke into squads and entered the forest to the screaming orders from the Minotaur, Seacat and the others staggered towards the skiffs parked further back, towards the edge of the forest.

“We need two,” Adora mumbled. “One won’t carry all of us.”

“Even if it could, we’d be too slow,” Seacat agreed.

“Three would be better,” Sea Hawk said.

“That would leave one of us alone on a skiff,” Adora pointed out. “And how many of you know how to handle a skiff?”

“I do,” Seacat said. Catra had paid attention. Mostly. It couldn’t be too hard.

“I can steer everything!” Sea Hawk added.

“We’ve been testing some captured Horde vehicles,” Brain Boy said.

Adora, once more, closed her mouth and pouted for a moment. “Still, two are better than three - we can protect each other better.” She turned towards Seacat. “And you’re still wounded!”

“I can handle it,” Seacat retorted. Of course she could - she had steered the gunboat, after all!

Then they were too close to the skiffs to keep talking. There were three skiffs, with two squads standing guard. But Seacat couldn’t see the crews - were the soldiers both guards and crew?

“Hey!” Adora snapped. “Some help here! We’ve got wounded!”

The soldiers standing guard - some of them sitting - started moving towards them. Only one guard stayed behind - the squad leader, Seacat noted.

Good.

“What happened?” the first Horde scum asked as they reached the group.

“Rebel Ambush,” Adora replied. “In the woods.”

“Really? The rebels survived?”

“Hah! I told you! Pay up, Hana!”

“But…”

All the soldiers were now there, two reaching for Brain Boy. Seacat drew the shock rod dangling at her hip and buried the tip in the stomach of the closest soldier, straight under her chest plate.

She collapsed with a scream, and Seacat jumped over her, sprinting towards the leader at the skiffs.

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

A Horde soldier flew past Seacat, crashing against a nearby boulder. Adora was showing off again.

More screams sounded behind her, but Seacat had only eyes for the horde leader in front of her. He was climbing onto a skiff! He was trying to escape! And alert the others!

Snarling, Seacat pushed herself. Not on her watch! Her shoulder started hurting from the movement, but she wouldn't let the bastard escape! She was almost…

The Horde leader suddenly jerked and screamed. As he slowly turned on the ladder and started to fall, Seaca saw an arrow sticking out of his back. Brain Boy.

She huffed as she turned. "I would have had him!"

The others had subdued the Horde squads and were already rushing towards her. "Get on the skiff!" Adora yelled.

Well, what did she think Seacat was about to do, take a nap?

Seacat had barely begun to start up the skiff when Sea Hawk climbed on board. "I'll handle the skiff," he told her. "Keep an eye out for trouble."

She nodded, stepping away from the controls, and looked around. Adora was wrecking the third skiff, while the shrimp and Brain Boy were boarding the other skiff they were taking. The Horde… Damn! It seemed that the Horde soldiers had noticed something amiss - they were moving towards the bodies on the ground. Even with the Horde uniforms the group was still wearing, they wouldn't take much time to connect the dots.

"Hurry!" Seacat spat. "They'll be coming at any moment!"

"We'll be moving in a moment!" the captain replied.

Adora looked at her, then rushed to the second skiff, *jumping* on board - Seacat could almost hear the deck crack as She-Ra landed

on it with all the grace of a falling mast. Just how heavy was Adora in that form?

Something to tease her about later, Seacat decided - the Horde soldiers had reached the skiff guards. And one of them was pointing at the body of the skiff commander Brain Bow had shot.

Their cover was blown. And Adora was just starting up the other skiff. Damn.

But Sea Hawk was already moving theirs. "Hold on tight!" he yelled. "Huzzah!"

Seacat gasped and grabbed the railing as the skiff turned and raced towards the Horde soldiers, scattering them. And sending one scum who was too slow flying into a tree.

But more were coming out of the woods. Seacat ducked as the minotaur threw a pike at them which struck the skiff's hull with a dull thud. Others brought crossbows up. No guns, fortunately - if the Horde had deployed artillery, they would be done for already. But she could see grappling hooks in the hands of other Horde soldiers. If they managed to board the skiff… it wouldn't take many hanging onto it to drag it down.

She looked back to Adora. The other skiff was finally starting to move. "Let's get out of here!"

"Adventure!"

Their own skiff took a sharp turn, scattered the minotaur's squad - and sent the burly leader flying into the forest when he tried to grab the vessel. Then it shot down the road, following Adora's skiff.

A few more Horde scum took potshots at them, but most didn't even come close to hitting the hull before they were out of the woods and racing over the plains.

It didn’t take long to catch up to Adora. Not only was the other skiff carrying three people - and one of them was She-Ra - but Sea Hawk was handling the skiff expertly. The captain could pilot any vessel, after all.

Seacat sat down and rubbed her aching shoulder. While keeping watch for pursuit - or Horde ambushes. It was a long way to the mountains.

*****

“That’s the Cold Peak!” Adora announced.

“Are you sure?” The shrimp looked a little sceptical.

Adora nodded. “Yes. I remember it clearly - this was one of the last field exercises I did with… Ah.”

Seacat, leaning against the railing of her and Sea Hawk’s skiff, rolled her eyes at her friend. “Damn it, Adora, I’m not going to break down if you mention ‘field exercises’.!”

“Sorry.” Adora looked sheepish. “Anyway - yes, I’m sure. We can reach the pass west of the peak in a few hours from here.”

“Good.” Seacat nodded. “We’ve been lucky so far, but the faster we’re out of Horde territory, the better.”

“Occupied territory,” the shrimp told her. “We’ll liberate it.”

Seacat snorted. The Horde held it, and it would be Horde territory until they were driven out of it. A storm didn’t suddenly turn into a squall if you refused to accept reality. Any sailor knew this.

“And our ruse fooled the enemy!” Sea Hawk announced.

Seacat snorted again. It wasn’t much of a ruse. They had headed straight for the eastern passes at the start until they had left pursuit behind. Then they had taken a wide turn towards the

northern mountains, in the hope of throwing off the Horde soldiers searching for them. At least that had been the plan.

Travelling through what passed for plains this close to the Fright Zone, they'd had to balance speed and safety. The more open they travelled, the faster they were - but the greater the risk of being seen by some field worker or patrol. The uniforms helped - Adora had shrunk down so she could wear hers again - but sooner or later, an officer would compare reports and sightings with deployment orders and find an unaccounted for skiff patrol.

Seacat hoped that this wouldn't happen until they were past the pass. They had decent odds - with the Alliance pushing down along the Eastern Coast, going east would be the obvious route to take. And any forces covering the mountains to the east would be too far away to block their escape up north. Though the Horde had enough soldiers to send substantial forces to both mountain ranges. Perhaps they should've tried to double back, cross the enemy lines, and make directly for the Whispering Forest?

No. They were committed now, anyway.

She rubbed her shoulder.

"Cat-Seacat! Does your shoulder hurt again? I can transform and…"

"It's fine," she told her friend before Adora could climb over the railing and hop onto their skiff. "Just an itch," she lied - during one of their breaks, Adora had transformed and healed Seacat's shoulder, but she still felt a twinge now and then.

Adora looked suspicious but nodded.

She really needed to understand that Seacat could take care of herself. "Let's go - the longer we stand here and chat, the more time the Horde has to catch us," she said.

"Hah! Even if they tried, we'd beat them in a daring chase up and down the pass!" Sea Hawk announced.

Seacat would rather sneak out of Horde territory than be chased out, but either way sounded fine as long as they made it out.

She leaned back as the skiffs started to pick up speed again and headed towards the mountain pass Adora had discovered as a cadet.

*****

The pass was, as Adora had said, too narrow and too steep to be of much use. Even the skiffs had trouble navigating it - Sea Hawk had scraped the paint off the left side in a particularly tight bend. Seacat couldn't imagine the Horde transporting supplies through it. Perhaps with lots of skiffs, but that would gut the screening and scout forces of the Horde - they didn't have enough of the things to keep up with demand as it was, what with the Horde fighting on all fronts.

But… "The Horde could've been inserting small groups easily through this pass," she said, standing next to Sea Hawk.

"That's not their style," the captain replied.

"That doesn't mean they haven't done it. Or won't do it,"

"If they had, we would have heard of more acts of sabotage and attacks behind the lines," Sea Hawk told her. "And we already know they have spies in our ranks."

And traitors like the bounty hunters who had come after Seacat. She pressed her lips together, not wanting to remember the fight. She almost had them!

"But you are correct - we should use the pass ourselves to infiltrate the Fright Zone!"

"We can always sneak in through the Whispering Woods," Seacat pointed out. "Or land forces at the coast." Not even the Horde had enough soldiers to guard the entire border against infiltrators.

“Indeed! But having more options is always better!”

She couldn’t argue with that. Certainly not when making their way up a narrow pass. “I just wish we were over the pass already,” she muttered. “We’re hemmed in here. If Adora’s skiff breaks down, we’ll have to walk since we can’t pass it.” She wouldn’t risk flying over a wreck. Not with a chasm to their right and a cliff to their left. Unless Adora could push the wreck over the side of the road, down the chasm. “It’s an ideal spot for an ambush.”

“Of course it is,” Sea Hawk agreed. “But they’ll be waiting on the top of the pass, where they can keep an eye on both sides. And we’ll scout it out on foot, so they won’t spot us.”

That was the plan, at least. But Seacat still hated their position.

*****

“As expected, the Horde reinforced the pass,” Seacat said, hiding on a ledge on the cliff, and looking at the top of the pass. “They didn’t forget about it.”

“Those are field fortifications - and rather shabby ones, at that,” Adora, also hiding on the narrow ledge after managing - with help, of course - to scale the cliff, protested. “They can’t be old. So, the Horde had forgotten about the pass.”

“Until we were about to use it?” Seacat raised her eyebrows at her.

“Uh… yes?” Adora blinked.

“It’s a trap. They’re probably already moving to block the exit behind us,” Seacat said. Which meant the Horde forces would be rolling up the road soon enough.

“Oh.” Adora frowned. Then she set her jaw. “That won’t help them - we can push through the line there.”

“They’ll be expecting us,” Seacat pointed out.

“But they can’t have enough troops up there to stop us. The fortifications would be better,” Adora retorted, “so they can concentrate their forces behind us to catch us between the fortification and them.”

She was probably correct. That didn’t mean that Seacat had to acknowledge it - or like it. “Well, we either turn around and go back, and hope there’s no blocking force, or we push on.” And hope it wasn’t a more complicated trap.

“We push on!” Adora said at once.

“I knew you’d say that.”

“Hey!”

Seacat snorted, shaking her head. To be honest, she preferred to push on herself. Smash through the line, and show the scum that they couldn’t hold or stop her. And she really couldn’t see many troops. Perhaps one, two dozen. Nor were there traces of a larger force - which would have had to rush up the pass, and the dust thrown up by their marching would have been visible from afar. But why would the Horde send so few troops… She blinked as she spotted a Horde squad leader at the gate.

“Lonnie.”

*****

The Escape

"It's Lonnie," Seacat said.

"What?" Adora replied.

"There. The squad leader at the gate. Still has the same stupid hairstyle."

"I need binocs for that." Adora pulled a pair of binoculars out of her pocket.

"Give me a good telescope any day of the week," Seacat mumbled. Better magnification - and you could use one as a club in a pinch. And the Horde used binocs a lot.

"I like them… wow, you're right - it's Lonnie!"

"And there's Kyle, which means Rogelio can't be far," Seacat pointed out.

"Yes… look at the gun pit on the left. My left."

Seacat narrowed her eyes. The loader did look like the lizardman. "Right. I didn't know he went into the artillery."

"He didn't. But we cross-trained a lot," Adora said. "I, uh, wanted to have the best squad in the Horde."

That was a rather low bar, in Seacat's opinion. And pretty much impossible if she kept Kyle on.

As if Adora had read her thoughts, she continued: "And we were the best cadet squad - I checked the results of all tests."

"And now we're fighting them," Seacat replied.

"Uh… yes?" Adora laughed in that forced manner of hers that showed she was embarrassed. "But we'll beat them!"

“Of course we’ll beat them.” Seacat snorted. Adora could probably just fling them over the side on her way through the pass. “So… hit the gate or the wall?” Though it was questionable if the flimsy barricade deserved that title.

“Hmm…”

Seacat glanced over. Adora was wrinkling her forehead - she was thinking. “The gate’s the obvious weak spot. Lonnie will expect us to hit it. She’ll have something prepared there. So we’ll hit the weaker wall between the gate and the cliff.”

“Sounds good.” Catra would have prepared a trap at the wall, expecting Adora to avoid the obvious weak spot - but Lonnie had all the imagination of a particularly dense brick. Even worse than Adora. “Let’s get back to the others; we can’t wait much longer, or we’ll be caught between the camp ahead and whatever forces are coming up the pass now.”

“Right.”

They crawled back until they reached the end of the ledge - out of sight of the Horde fortifications - and climbed down the cliff to where the rest of their group was waiting with the skiffs. Or, in Adora’s case, failed to climb, slid down and jumped the rest. But she stuck the landing.

“Alright!” Adora cleared her throat as Seacat touched down behind her. “The Horde has been fortifying the pass, but they couldn’t do much so far. It’s just standard prefab barriers - and not many of them - with barbed wire. We can break through there; I can cut either with my sword.”

“Can we fly over them?” Brain Boy asked.

“Not really - they’re high enough to block skiffs, and they’ve got two cannons in the camp,” Seacat pointed out. “So, even if you managed to jump over the wall, you’d have to hope they won’t hit you. And Lonnie will have grapple hooks ready as well.”

“So, we’ll attack on foot,” Adora continued, “then either go back for our skiffs or take theirs.”

“Huzzah!”

“And we’ll be so quick, the Horde forces coming up the pass behind us won’t catch up before we’re gone,” Seacat said.

“Uh…” The shrimp stared at her.

“Ah! A cunning if simple trap!” Sea Hawk nodded as he pounded his palm with his fist. “And we’ll turn the tables on them!”

“Right!” Adora spoke up again. “So, Bow - cover fire. Take out the gun emplacements. I’ll charge the fortification and cut a hole into it. Then the rest of you follow, and we take out their centre on the way to the skiffs. We board them and get away. Straightforward.”

“And what about me?” Brain Boy asked.

“You rush after us,” Seacat told him. “And make sure you’re not too far behind.”

“You can jump and hold on to the aft of the skiff, getting dragged behind as the Horde shoots at us and we barely manage to pull you in before you fall off!” Sea Hawk beamed at Brain Boy. “It’ll be an adventure you will tell your grandchildren at the hearth!”

“That sounds exciting indeed,” Brain Boy replied with a grimace.

The captain, of course, ignored this and nodded. “Yes, it does! Huzzah!”

Seacat snorted. “Let’s go! We need to sneak close enough so we can rush them before they start shelling us from afar.”

Or their charge would end in a bloody mess - Seacat doubted that even She-Ra could shrug off cannon shells.

“Oh, I’ve just thought of a better plan! A perfect plan!”

Sea Hawk beamed at them.

Seacat suddenly knew they wouldn't be going back for their skiffs.

*****

"This is crazy. This won't work."

Seacat scoffed at Adora's comment. "This will work." The captain knew what he was doing. Well, most of the time. But when it came to handling ships - or setting them on fire - he was the best. She leaned into the controls as her skiff took the next narrow turn at high speed, hot on the heels of Sea Hawk's.

"If you're so convinced, why aren't you on the other skiff?" the shrimp asked from where she was holding tight on the railing.

"Someone has to steer this skiff," Seacat replied, not taking her eyes off the narrow path. Two more turns, and then they would be headed straight towards the fortifications.

"Adora could do it!"

"She's got another task." And Seacat was better at steering skiffs. Or handling any ship.

The next turn was even tighter. And Sea Hawk hadn't slowed down at all. Seacat clenched her teeth as her skiff moved a little too far towards the cliffside, bouncing off after scraping the paint off the left side. She cursed as she fought to keep it on the path, away from the chasm on the right side.

"AHHH!"

"NOOO!"

"CATRA!"

Seacat ignored the screaming and tilted the skiff to the side. That was enough to make the turn. After a few seconds, she let the

vehicle right itself again. One more turn.

"*You* are crazy!"

No, she wasn't. And she was focusing on the next turn. That one was to the right, so they didn't run the risk of tumbling into the chasm - but they could ram the cliffside.

Well, the skiff could handle a few more bumps. Add some character. And she had to catch up to Sea Hawk.

She accelerated.

"Catra!"

"No!"

This time she tilted the skiff to the other side, and they went up the cliffside a few yards, tilted sideways, like a sledge in some of the races the Kingdom of Snows loved so much.

More screaming.

"Pipe down! We're almost there!" Seacat snapped, flashing her fangs.

"You're crazy!" the shrimp repeated herself.

Then they were on the last leg, headed straight towards the Horde camp. And straight towards the two field guns the Horde forces had. Seacat moved behind Sea Hawk, using the other skiff as a shield, but she could still see the gun crews struggling with the piece on the right as a siren sounded in the background.

"Huzzah!" Sea Hawk yelled and pushed his skiff even more.

"Adora!"

"On it!"

Adora, in her She-Ra form, rushed to the bow of the skiff. ”Sea Hawk!”

“Watch out!” Sea Hawk yelled, and his skiff suddenly veered to the left.

Seacat pulled to the right at once.

And one, then another shell flew between the two skiffs, detonating behind them. “Hah!”

“Watch the chasm!”

“Catra!”

“No!”

Seacat was already turning to the left - really! As if she’d forget this!

And a few seconds later, they were behind Sea Hawk again. “Jump!” Adora yelled.

“Huzzah!”

Sea Hawk released the Skiff’s controls and ran towards its aft. Towards Seacat’s skiff. “Adventure!” He jumped on the railing, then off, towards the waiting arms of Adora. She-Ra had to reach - but she managed to grab his hand and reel him in as Seacat slowed the skiff down.

And, lightened a little more, Sea Hawk’s skiff, its controls fixed, shot towards the enemy gate. If Lonnie had prepared a trap there… The vehicle hit the gate, crashing through it - and the gate and skiff vanished in a fireball as Sea Hawk’s fuse reached the powder stashed in the bow.

Seacat sped up again, heading straight into the smoke cloud. The gun crews had been shaken by the explosion and were just

getting up again from where they had dived for cover when the skiff entered the smoke - too slow to bring their guns to bear.

"Everyone out!" Seacat yelled as they left the smoke and dust cloud, and she tilted the skiff to the side, sliding over the ground as she braked.

"For the Honour of Grayskull!" Adora had already jumped off, racing towards the gun on the chasm side.

"For adventure!" Sea Hawk jumped off as well, followed by the shrimp and Brain Boy.

Seacat sped up again - and turned the skiff towards the second gun emplacement. The crew was struggling to turn the gun around - it hadn't meant to fire into the camp - and scattered as she rammed the gun, toppling it.

She jumped off before the skiff ground to a halt in the remains of the gun emplacement, the cutlass she had taken from the horde flashing. It wasn't magical, but it was enough. She cut down the gun chief before the goatman could get up, then kicked the soldier next to him in the head before the man could draw his own blade.

Stepping on the fallen, struggling man, she stuck her blade into his mouth, then turned to the four remaining gunners on the other side of the skiff.

They had managed to form a shaky line, blades and shock rods drawn, and seemed torn between charging and fleeing.

Seacat hissed and charged them. One broke, turning to run away. Another counter-charged her. She met his blade with her own, twisting it to the side, then buried her free hand in his stomach - with her claws out.

The man collapsed, bleeding and screaming, and she pounced on the two remaining gunners. Ducking under the wild swipe from the one on the left, she kicked out with her foot and raked her

claws over the legs of the other. He went down yelling and holding his ruined legs as she rolled over her healed shoulder, avoiding the other horde scum's stab.

She came up behind the man and slashed his back with her cutlass, then rammed its pommel into the man's head. He collapsed, knocked out. A quick cut to the throat finished the other, and she turned around. There would be infantry in the camp - if they hadn't been killed at the gate.

"Traitor!"

And there was Lonnie. Charging straight at her with a shock rod.

Seacat side-stepped the first lunge - the woman still telegraphed her moves - and took a swipe at the rod with her blade.

Lonnie blocked it. That wouldn't have worked against Seacat's old cutlass, of course. The Horde soldier followed up with a riposte. Or tried to - Seacat jumped back before Lonnie managed to align her rod. But her own strike was blocked as well.

She scoffed. Time to distract and rile up the Horde scum. "Fancy to see you here. Is that punishment detail, or did Shadow Weaver give you special orders?" She flashed her fangs at the other.

Lonnie clenched her teeth in return and struck at her again, trying to hit her arm with the shock rod.

Seacat parried the first two strikes, then riposted. Lonnie twisted her body out of the way, but the blade still nicked her upper arm.

"Oh, did that hurt?" Seacat chuckled and cocked her head. "Why are you using a shock rod, anyway? You always were better with a polearm." She glanced around. No one else was near them - the cloud of smoke from the burning skiff was blocking the rest of the camp.

Good. Dealing with an entire squad and Lonnie would be a little tricky. Not really dangerous, though.

Lonnie growled, gripping her biceps for a moment before withdrawing her hand, trailing blood.

"On the other hand, you need both hands and arms for a polearm, and that might be a little difficult right now." Seacat laughed again as she looked for an opening. Lonnie was a decent fighter - or a good one, now - and guarded herself well, but she couldn't avoid Seacat's cutlass forever.

But she could avoid it for a while longer, Seacat found out as she closed with the Horde soldier. She forced Lonnie back with a few lightning-quick strikes that broke through her guard, but the woman managed to dodge at the last moment, and what should've opened the artery in her inner thigh merely nicked her leg.

And not deep enough to make her fall. "You damn traitor!" Lonnie spat.

Seacat scoffed in return. "Me, a traitor? I wasn't the one who got an entire company killed to get rid of me!" Lonnie's bleeding leg slowed the woman down now. If Seacat started circling her, then sooner or later she would slip up - or slip.

"I'm not listening to your lies! I'm not Adora!"

Seacat's eyes widened. "What?" Lonnie couldn't mean… She laughed. "Oh, that's rich! Shadow Weaver decided that it must have been me who made Adora desert? And you believed it? Did you ever know her, really?"

Lonnie growled and attacked again, wildly swinging her rod, followed by lunges. But she was tiring - and making mistakes. Seacat drew her into a corps-a-corps, then lashed out with her free arm when Lonnie tried to overpower her.

This time, she saw blood fly as her claws slashed into the woman's shoulder, barely missing her throat. Lonnie stumbled back, swinging her rod back and forth to keep Seacat at a distance.

But she was done for. She couldn't use that arm any more, and she couldn't stop the bleeding without dropping her weapon - at which point Seacat would finish her off.

And she knew it. "Damn you!" Lonnie spat, hefting her rod.

A last, hopeless charge? That sounded like the Lonnie Catra knew from training. Had known. She grinned as she raised her blade in turn. This time, she wouldn't miss the vitals.

"Lonnie!"

Damn! Seacat glanced to the side, towards the smoke, and cursed. There was the rest of the squad - Rogelio and Kyle. Only, Kyle was propping up Rogelio, who looked even worse than Lonnie.

Seacat could handle this. Could handle them.

"Kyle, run!"

Seacat whirled to face Lonnie. The woman wasn't even trying to guard herself, any more - she was coming at Seacat with the shock rod raised high above her head, screaming like a stuck pig.

"No! Lonnie!"

Kyle's shout made Seacat glance to her side. If the other soldier charged her… but Kyle wasn't. He was standing there.

Snarling, Seacat dodged to the side, avoiding Lonie's blow, then kicked her, sending her sprawling - and making her drop her weapon.

A moment later, Seacat's blade was at Lonnie's throat. The other woman froze, caught in the middle of trying to get up, and stared at her.

"No!" Kyle yelled.

A little push, and it was done. Would be done. Just a flick of her wrist, and the Horde scum would be dead. Dying. Bleeding out.

Lonnie bared her teeth and didn't look away. "Kyle, Rogelio, run!"

"No!"

Seacat glanced to her side. Kyle was lowering Rogelio to the ground. The lizardman all but collapsed, groaning.

And Kyle was drawing his own shock rod. Idiot.

"Kyle, run!" Lonnie spat.

"No!"

And the idiot took a step towards Seacat, brandishing his weapon.

Seacat clenched her teeth. Did the idiot think he had a chance of beating her? He was shaking in his boots - literally, actually; the boots were a little too large for his scrawny figure. "Surrender," she said with a glance, keeping her attention on Lonnie.

"N-no!"

"Surrender or Lonnie dies."

"Traitor!" The woman spat through clenched teeth.

Kyle gasped.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Hey - what do you think happens if you attack me? I kill her so I can kill you without having to worry about getting stabbed in the back." She bared her teeth. "Something of a thing in the Horde, you know? Shadow Weaver sabotaged a weapon test to kill me. Get rid of me and a rival with one blow. Lose an entire company, but the Horde has more, right?"

A glance showed her that Kyle was gaping, the shock rod pointed at the ground. "No!"

“Liar!” Lonnie said.

Seacat snorted. “Why should I lie?”

“To get more of us to desert.”

She rolled her eyes again. “I couldn’t care less whether or not you desert. I didn’t even remember you until Shadow Weaver used me as a lightning rod.” She scoffed. “You surrender, or I kill you all. I don’t care.” It wasn’t as if Lonnie had too much time left anyway, the way she was bleeding.

“Seacat! Seacat!”

That was Adora!

Seacat cursed herself under her breath - she had gotten caught up in this stupid banter while there was a battle going on! Stupid! Best to end this now.

“Seacat! There you… Lonnie?”

Oh. Adora stepped out of the smoke and stopped.

“Hey, Adora,” Seacat told her. “We had a little reunion here. Lonnie thought she could stop me, and Kyle doesn’t want to surrender.”

“Traitor!” Lonnie glared at Adora.

“I’m not…” Adora cut herself off and set her jaw. “Surrender!”

Kyle dropped his shock rod to the ground and raised his hands.

“Kyle!” Lonnie snapped.

He shook his head. “Lonnie! This is Adora; she won’t kill us.”

“You thought I would kill you?” Seacat shook her head at the idiot.

“You said so!”

“I said I’d kill you if you didn’t surrender!” That was how things were done - the law of the sea was clear on that. “Idiots!” She scoffed and took a step back and turned to face Adora. “Did you secure the other skiffs?”

“Yes! But we need to leave - more Horde troops are coming!” her friend replied.

“Let’s go then!” She took a step towards the smoke, which hid the rest of the camp.

“But…” Kyle was still staring at them.

“What?” She glared at the idiot.

“What about us? We surrendered!”

Seacat scoffed. “Yes, you did. And we’re leaving.”

“Cat-Seacat!” Adora gasped.

“What? We can’t take any prisoners with us. They’d slow us down too much.”

“That’s not the point!” Adora knelt down next to the still breathing and bleeding Lonnie.

Oh. Seacat sighed. That was so like Adora. Even though Lonnie and the others were probably the reason that the Horde was even here to stop them. “Just stop the bleeding. The Horde will soon be here.”

“How can you be so…” Kyle shook his head. He looked as if he was about to cry. Like when Catra had eaten the ration he had been hoarding, “We were your friends!”

“And now you’re our enemies,” Seacat replied. “Fighting for the Horde - who tried to kill us. Fighting for *Shadow Weaver*!” she

spat the last words.

“You deserted!” he replied.

“Technically, I was left for dead - after Shadow Weaver tried to get me killed.” She flashed her fangs at the idiot. “Don’t worry, as long as you blindly obey her, you’ll be fine. Unless she needs a few expendable troops for a plot or so.”

He gaped.

“Alright, you’ll be fine, Lonnie.” Adora got up.

“Traitor!” the woman on the ground spat, holding her shoulder.

“You need to learn more words than ‘traitor’, ‘run’ and ‘Yes, Shadow Weaver’,” Seacat told them. “Let’s go.”

Rogelio groaned something as they passed him, but Seacat was sick of listening to Horde scum.

*****

“Get on board!” Sea Hawk yelled as soon as they approached the skiffs. “A harrowing escape awaits us!” He beamed at them from the controls of the first skiff, next to the shrimp and Brain Boy. All of them looked unhurt, Seacat noted.

“That means the Horde reinforcements will be here any moment,” she told Adora before she grabbed the ladder hanging down from the second skiff and started climbing.

“I’m aware of that!” her friend replied. “That’s why I was looking for you!”

“Oh, not because you were worried about me?” Seacat laughed and quickly started the skiff moving.

“Of course I was worried!”

Seacat smiled, then reminded herself that Adora didn't need to worry about her - she could take care of herself.

"Hold on!" she snapped, then accelerated. As she neared the first turn, she just caught a glance of the Horde skiffs behind them. Damn.

Seacat took the turn while still accelerating, but didn't scrape the paint off this time. Nor did she come too close. At least the paint wasn't in any danger of getting scraped off. Nor did she have to pull a stunt to avoid going over the edge and into the chasm in the next turn. Adora had no reason to complain, really.

But she wasn't gaining on Sea Hawk, either. The Captain handled his skiff too well. He was probably even holding back a little.

Seacat growled and accelerated a little more - she wouldn't slow the group down!

"Uh…"

"What?" she snapped without taking her eyes off the road.

"That was a little close," Adora said.

"We didn't crash," Seacat replied. She watched how Sea Hawk's skiff took the next turn, then copied him. She had to quickly compensate for the difference in weight, but otherwise, it worked well. Decently well.

"Oh!"

"What?" They hadn't even come close to ramming the cliffside, this time!

"Pursuit. Looks like… one, no, two scout skiffs."

So they had pushed through instead of stopping to check on the Horde remains in the camp.

“How many crew per skiff?”

“Looks like… watch it!” Adora complained as they took the next turn. “...standard complement. Two,” Adora added.

“I know the standard complement,” Seacat told her. “Just the two skiffs?” They could handle two skiffs with two Horde scum each. Hell, Seacat could handle them all by herself!

“They’re scouts.”

Which meant the Horde scum would shadow them, leading the rest to them. They couldn’t have that - they had a long way before them once they were through the pass. And they couldn’t have a Horde force chasing them all the way to Bright Moon.

“Can you lose them?” Adora asked.

“I’m trying,” Seacat yelled. This time, she did hit the cliff a little as she took a turn.

“It’s not working!”

“I know!” It wasn’t as if she had driven this particular skiff before. Or this road. And the Horde hadn’t caught up either, yet. But what could they do? Use the skiff to block the pass? Sea Hawk’s skiff would be slowed down, and the Horde could just push the remains off the cliff into the chasm.

“I’ve got an idea,” Adora suddenly said.

“You’re not going to jump off and hold them off while we escape!” Seacat snapped. If the stupid idiot did this, she’d run her over with the skiff herself!

“What? No, no. But I need to get off the skiff.”

“No!”

“Just slow down at the next turn - it won’t take long!”

On the next straight part of the road, Seacat glanced over her shoulder. Adora was smiling at her. Confidently. She didn't look like she was about to sacrifice herself, but…

"Alright," Seacat spat and slowed down.

"Thanks!" Adora jumped off as soon as they weren't travelling at a breakneck speed any more.

And Seacat kept braking until the skiff came to a stop. Then she jumped off and ran back.

Her friend was already climbing the cliff rising above the road. What would she… "Oh, no!" Seacat blurted out.

Adora looked down. "What are you doing here?"

"Helping you." And keeping you honest.

"You can't help here. Get back!"

Seacat looked at the cliff, then at Adora. She was the better climber. But she wasn't as strong as Adora. On the other hand, Adora was an idiot. "Shut up!" she yelled, dashing towards the cliff.

"What are you doing? Get back!"

"No," Seacat spat, quickly catching up to the idiot. "I know what you're planning!"

"Then you know you can't help!"

"I can help by saving you from your own stupidity!" She passed Adora on the right side and eyed the protrusion Adora was going for. If her friend the idiot wanted to cut that off, she'd have to… there!

"Get away!"

"No!"

Adora glared at her, but Seacat wasn't budging. Huffing, Adora cleared the protrusion and started to swing her sword, slashing and stabbing at the rock next to her.

After a few blows and swings, the sword got stuck - and Adora grabbed it. Then she suddenly glowed and groaned.

The next moment, the cliffside exploded. Seacat managed to lunge and grab Adora's belt before a cloud of dust engulfed them as an avalanche of rocks and rubble buried the road below. She held her breath and clung to the cliff, digging her claws into the rock, a moment before Adora lost her hold on the crumbling cliffside.

If the whole face crumbled… but it didn't. One of her feet lost purchase, but Seacat kept her grip with her hand and the remaining foot, and not even Adora dangling from her hand was enough to make her lose her grip.

It was a close call, though - Seacat's arms and shoulders hurt. "You need to eat less!" she spat as she did all she could to keep her friend from falling into the cloud below.

"Hey!"

But they were alive. The idiot was alive.

At least until they got down and Seacat could talk to her about how incredibly stupid she had been. With her claws!

As soon as they'd reached the road again - Adora slid the cliffside down more than she climbed, which was the only reason she was first - Seacat rounded on her. "You stupid idiot! What were you thinking? If I hadn't been there, you'd have fallen down! Can you survive a rock avalanche, huh?" She grabbed Adora's shoulder and shook her. Well, she tried - as She-Ra, her friend was too tall and too heavy to be shaken. Which was so unfair.

"Uh… yes? I think so. Most of the rocks were below me…"

Seacat narrowed her eyes and growled. "'Most of the rocks'? There was enough left to bury you! And can you survive without air, huh?"

"Uh… I haven't really tried…"

Oh, no! "If you even think of trying that, I'll kill you myself!" Seacat spat.

"Hey! I had to do something! And it worked out!"

"You almost got killed, you idiot!" Couldn't Adora understand how stupid she had been? "You…" She shook her head.

"Sorry," Adora said in a small voice. Then she gripped Seacat's shoulders. "I just thought…" She trailed off.

Seacat stared at her. For some reason, she remembered the Princess Prom. The dancing. They were almost as close. She would have to move her hands, though. And Adora was taller in this form. And buffers. Her eyes wandered down for a moment, against her will, before she looked at her friend's face again.

Which didn't help.

"So…" she licked her lips, swallowing.

"So…"

"Adora!"

"Seacat!"

She released Adora's shoulders and whirled. The Captain, the shrimp and Brain Boy were running towards them. "What?"

"We noticed you weren't behind us any more and came back to check! What happened?" the shrimp blurted out.

"Oh! You caused a landslide!" Sea Hawk beamed at her. "Ingenious! What a great idea - it could've been one of mine!"

Seacat glared at the captain. That was the completely wrong thing to say! He shouldn't encourage Adora!

Huffing, she walked past him. "Let's go before the Horde scum decides to send infantry climbing over the rubble!"

"But…"

"Let's go!" she spat.

They boarded their skiffs again and continued to drive down the pass - though not at a breakneck pace any more. Which cut down on the complaints and shrieks as well. In fact, neither Seacat nor Adora had said anything since they had started following Sea Hawk again.

Well, Seacat had to focus on piloting the skiff. Idle chit-chat - or a deserved chewing out, in this case - would only distract her.

Yes.

*****

"Leaving behind perfectly good skiffs…" The shrimp sighed, looking at the two skiffs in the clearing.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "They're not perfectly good. They've got no fuel left."

"Actually, the fuel cells are good - the engine's damaged from overheating," Adora told her.

Seacat sent her a glare. "It doesn't matter what broke them - the point is, they're broken and won't work anymore."

"I'm just saying that with a little more care…"

Seacat cut her off. "When you're chased by the Horde isn't the time to be careful with your stolen skiff. It's time to push it as far as it can go!"

“Which,” Brain Boy said, “seems to be this clearing and no further.”

She narrowed her eyes at him. The man sounded a little too bland. “Yes, this clearing - so far away from the pass that the Horde will have to spread out over a huge plot of land to find us.”

“Indeed! And now we can evade their search parties on foot by sticking to trails and paths where no skiff can pass - all according to plan!” Sea Hawk said, nodding.

“Exactly.” Seacat smiled at the captain. He knew the score.

Then she noticed the others exchanging rather doubtful glances.

“I vote that next time we steal skiffs, they don’t get to drive them,” Brain Boy said.

“Seconded!” Adora said.

“We’re not voting on things!” Seacat told them. “What do you think we are, a pirate crew?”

“What?” Adora stared at her.

“Pirate crews vote on their officers and captains,” Seacat explained. And that wasn’t how you ran things. The captain was the captain. You didn’t command a ship by asking the crew.

“That’s…” the shrimp shook her head.

“But we’re not voting on officers,” Adora pointed out.

“Same thing,” Seacat said,

“I don’t think so,” Brain Boy retorted. She glared at him, but he didn’t lose his stupid smile.

“Anyway, let’s set the skiffs on fire and set off!” Sea Hawk announced.

“No! The smoke will tell the Horde where we went!” Adora snapped.

“Ah, but they would know that we know, and expect it to be a diversion!” the captain retorted.

Seacat winced. “The Horde officers are generally not smart enough to fall into that trap.” Catra was well-aware of that. “And they have enough troops to still send a group to check.” It was the perfect punishment detail, too - something Catra also familiar with.

“Ah…” Sea Hawk slowly nodded. Then he coughed. “I’ll be right back, then!”

He ran towards the skiffs, pulling out a flask of water.

Seacat sighed and didn’t look at the others.

*****

After hours of walking, they finally set up camp in another clearing with a small pond. Seacat groaned and sat down, rubbing her legs. Sailors weren’t meant to hike.

“Are you alright?”

She glared up at Adora, who was standing next to her, smiling weakly at her. “I’m fine.”

“I mean… you were kidnapped, and you had to fight, and you starved yourself to get away, and Shadow Weaver... “ Adora bit her lip as she trailed off.

Seacat scoffed. “I’m fine. Just a little tired. Like all of us.”

“Right.” Adora nodded.

She didn’t look tired at all, Seacat noted. So unfair. “I’m fine,” she repeated herself.

“Of course.”

“Alright, let’s get a fire going - a smokeless fire,” Brain Boy said. “I’ve seen suitable wood nearby.”

“And we can hunt!” Sea Hawk said. “Or fish in the pond.”

“Fishing!” Seacat snapped. After eating Horde rations for so long, she needed fresh fish!

“Are there fishes in this pond? Big enough so we can actually eat them?” The shrimp looked doubtful

Seacat scoffed. “If there are only small ones we can make soup. Wait… we don’t have a pot.” Damn.

“I can rig something up,” Brain Boy said. It figured that the bowman would be a woodsman as well.

Not that Seacat was complaining - having someone who knew how to survive in the forest was a good thing, in her book. At least if you were unlucky enough to end up in a forest. Which a sailor shouldn’t have happen to her often, if at all. Stupid Horde.

She leaned against the trunk of the tree behind her and closed her eyes. A little rest would do her good. And the Alliance territory couldn’t be too far now.

Taking a deep breath, she listened to the others work.

“You carry bait with you?”

“Always, my friend! You never know when you might end up stranded on an island and fishing is the only way to feed yourself!”

“Oh.”

“And you can eat the bait in a pinch.”

“Ew!”

“Would you rather starve, Glimmer?”

“Yes!”

Laughter followed. Seacat grinned.

“Is this the right wood?”

“Adora! Did you rip out the entire tree?”

“Uh….”

Seacat chuckled as the voices faded.

*****

“Seacat?”

She opened her eyes. “What?” Then she gasped. “I fell asleep!”

“Uh… yes.”

Adora was standing in front of her, bent over, smiling down at her. And behind her, Seacat could see two tents and a fire.

“You let me sleep while you set up camp?” Seacat clenched her teeth. Why would they do this?

“You looked exhausted.”

“I was just napping,” she snapped. Everyone else had been working? She was about to complain when she smelled fish. Roasted fish.

“Fake trout, according to Sea Hawk.” Adora was smiling at her as if this was amusing.

Seacat growled and got up, fast enough to startle Adora and sent her stumbling back to avoid knocking their heads together.

“Hey!”

“What?” Seacat cocked her head and smirked. It was a small, petty victory, but she’d take what she could get. “Getting a little tired yourself?”

Adora huffed.

“This wouldn’t have happened if you hadn’t let me nap while you worked,” Seacat told her with a sniff. The fish smelled really good.

Adora frowned in return and looked at her weirdly for a moment, before grinning. “You looked too cute to wake up.”

What? Seacat stared at her friend. That wasn’t how things were supposed to go. No comment about how the poor prisoner needed her rest? Or how she couldn’t be expected to work after her ordeal? Or how she was too weak to help? She was at a loss for words.

So was Adora, apparently. The woman cleared her throat. “Uh…” She trailed off again, blushing slightly.

Seacat felt herself blush as well. “So…”

“Come on! Dinner’s ready!” Sea Hawk yelled.

Seacat turned and stalked towards her captain. She could think of a comeback when she had her fill.

The others were already sitting around the campfire - which was mostly smokeless, as Brain Boy had promised. And there was a… “How is that bag not burning? Or melting?” Seacat pointed at the bag hanging over the flames from a piece of wood.

“The liquid inside is the key,” Brain Boy, looking far too smug, replied.

“Does that mean that you don’t know the actual answer, either?” she shot back.

“What?”

The shrimp started giggling.

“Glimmer!” Brain Boy shook his head. “It’s a simple trick.”

Seacat snorted, grabbed a spit with a fish on it from the fire and sat down on a free rock. She took a deep breath to savour the smell, and, with her mouth watering, bit into it. It tasted as good as it smelled, and she moaned a little as she chewed and swallowed. “This is great!”

“Thank you,” the captain said with a smile.

“I didn’t know this fish lived in a pond,” Seacat added.

“They don’t - but we found a stream a little further ahead.”

“Oh.” She smiled before taking another big bite. That meant fresh water, instead of pond water. And a possibility to wash without ending up with algae and pond scum on your fur.

Fresh fish, fresh water, and a comfy… She looked at the tent behind her. No mattress, but someone had gathered a lot of moss. It wasn’t a hammock, but it would do.

Things were looking up.

*****

The Queen

"...and then, the princesses, realising that Hordak wouldn't surrender and that the Horde was too strong to be defeated by any one of them, banded together to once and for all wipe out the threat to their unjust rule. Half a dozen of the closest kingdoms allied under one banner - the banner of the Rebellion."

Catra rolled her eyes. They had heard this before. Many times. She elbowed Adora. "Hey, Adora," she whispered, "do you think they'd notice if we sneaked out?"

Her friend gasped. "Catra! This is a mandatory training lesson!"

She snorted in return. Adora always took things so seriously. She knew the lesson by heart already - had learned it after the first lesson, Catra knew - and yet paid attention as if it was the first time and there would be a test.

Not that Adora would fail the test, anyway. Catra snorted.

"..so the war started in… Catra? Do you think this is somehow amusing?"

Uh-oh. The instructor was glaring at her. Well, that was nothing new - all of them hated her anyway. Shadow Weaver probably told them to. Although… well, if she already had caught the instructor's attention, might as well go for broke. "I have a question, actually."

"Catra! No!" Adora whispered.

She smiled and ignored her friend.

"Really?"

"Yes, sir! I was wondering why the Alliance was called 'Rebellion'. They're the attackers, aren't they? We never controlled their territory before the war, did we?"

To her surprise, the instructor laughed. "Actually, no one knows why they're calling themselves that." He shrugged. "I think they don't know either."

Adora raised her arm.

"Yes, cadet?" Of course the man would smile at Adora.

Catra's friend stood and assumed the parade rest position. "Could it be propaganda? To make it appear as if the Horde's the aggressor in this conflict?"

"That's a good hypothesis. The Alliance certainly lies to their people, keeping the true state of the war from them and using only loyal troops and their evil princesses in battle."

"Unlike us, where everyone fights!" Adora parrotted the usual propaganda.

"Exactly! Very good, cadet!"

"Thank you, sir."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Suck-up," she whispered as Adora sat down.

"Catra!" Adora whispered back. "Be glad I distracted him!"

She scoffed in return. She didn't need a distraction. And it was useless, anyway - she'd get punished anyway.

"...the first battles at the then-borders of the Fright Zone soon showed that…"

*****

Seacat woke up warm and comfy. Much warmer and comfier, actually, than she had expected - the moss mattresses weren't as soft as Brain Boy had claimed, and the tents barely more than pieces of sail cloth draped over sticks.

But she was warm, and her head was resting on soft pillows that... Wait. She hadn't had pillows when she'd gone to bed. And her mattress seemed to move… She blinked. Oh.

She was lying on top of Adora. And her head had been resting on… Oh. Seacat must have moved in her sleep, and climbed on top of her friend as if they were still Horde Cadets sleeping in the barracks. No wonder she'd had such a weird dream. Or was the dream the reason for her sleep-moving?

She took a deep breath. Did it matter? Probably not. But she really should remove herself from Adora's bed. The shrimp - she glanced at the third bed in the tent - was still asleep, as was Adora, so this would be best to avoid awkward explanations. That morning in the Kingdom of Snows after the Princess Prom had been bad enough.

Taking another breath, she carefully raised her head and started to crawl back - only to feel a strong arm wrap around her back and pin her in place. What the…?

"Hmm," Adora moaned. In her sleep. Before she wrapped her other arm around Seacat.

Well, she hadn't changed into She-Ra, so it wasn't as if Seacat was really trapped. She just needed to carefully wriggle out of Adora's grasp. No sweat.

But the moment she tried to get some leverage, Adora clamped down as if she were a barnacle on a wooden post. And moaned again. Twice. First in apparent protest, then in that satisfied manner of hers she usually did when she got the good rations.

Damn. It didn't look like Seacat would escape without being noticed. Plan b, then. "Hey, Adora," she whispered.

"Mhhh."

"Hey, Adora! Wake up, Dummy!"

“Hrngh.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. Really. Well, she had other means at her disposal. She might not be able to move her arms without getting crushed against Adora’s chest, but her tail was free - and Adora’s face was close.

A little wriggling and she was rubbing the tip of her tail right against Adora’s nose. Now she just had to keep this up until…

Adora sniffed. And sniffed again. Yes! A little more, and…

Her friend sneezed. Right into Seacat’s face.

“Ack! Gross!” Seacat tried to scramble back, shaking her head while her hands sought purchase to push against Adora’s arms. One of her palms ended up in Adora’s face.

“Huh? What?”

Seacat pushed Adora’s face to the side. “Release me!”

“What? Oh… what are you doing?” Adora grabbed her hand, which allowed Seacat to slip out of her embrace.

“What am *I* doing? *You* grabbed me! And when I tried to get away, you sneezed in my face!” She furiously rubbed her fur. Gross!

“What were you doing in my bed?”

“What? You grabbed me!” She needed a wet cloth and soap or something.

“I grabbed you and dragged you into my bed?” Adora got up on her elbows.

“I woke up like this!” Seacat retorted. This was all Adora’s fault.

“I don’t remember grabbing you!” Adora blinked. “Wait - you used to sneak into my bed!”

“What? There was no sneaking involved! I didn’t go to bed in my bunk and woke up in yours!” Seacat wouldn’t let Adora blame her.

“Can you shut up? People are trying to sleep here!”

Oh. The shrimp had woken up.

“Sorry, Glimmer,” Adora said.

“It was her fault,” Seacat added.

“Was not!” Adora protested.

“Well, if I grabbed you, you would have woken up, wouldn’t you?” Seacat pointed out.

“I’m a deep sleeper!”

“So am I.”

“See? You were probably sleep-grabbing!” Adora huffed.

“Ngh! If I could teleport, I’d drop you both in the pond right now! Shut up and let me *sleep*!” The shrimp yelled at them. The princess had a good set of lungs, at least - she would make a good bosun.

“Glimmer? Adora? Seacat? Are you awake? I’ll prepare breakfast!”

Brain Boy. Seacat sighed. So much for sleeping a little longer. She glared at Adora. “That’s your fault.”

“What? No, it isn’t!”

“Both of you are at fault!”

“No!”

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“Let’s take a break here,” Brain Boy told them.

Seacat groaned and sat down where she stood. Sailors weren't meant to walk. "Stupid Horde and their stupid cheap and flimsy skiffs," she mumbled.

"They're actually quite durable - if you don't push them over their limits."

She raised her head, glaring at Adora. "People who use magic to cheat don't get to talk. Besides, we had to push the skiffs to escape the Horde."

"Exactly!" Sea Hawk nodded from where he was sitting on a rock. "It was a necessary sacrifice. I know everything about necessary sacrifices, trust me - they're an integral part of any harrowing adventure!"

"I'm not cheating!" Adora claimed. "Besides, you never had trouble on marches as a cadet."

"We didn't march halfway to the end of the world as cadets," Seacat retorted.

"And you haven't kept up marching since you became a sailor," the Captain added.

"How much longer?" the shrimp asked - she was on the ground, spread-eagled, staring at the blue sky above them. She probably never walked in her kingdom but always teleported.

"We're about a day from Bright Moon's borders," Brain Boy told them. "So… unless we march through the night…"

"We won't!" the shrimp snapped. "I'm not going to stumble blindly through the forest at night."

"And light would give us away," Sea Hawk pointed out.

"Seacat can guide us - she can see perfectly well in the dark," Adora said.

That was true. On the other hand, Seacat wasn't looking forward to marching for another day without rest. She would probably fall asleep walking and end up leading the others in circles, or something.

Or, worse, Adora would carry her. So how to avoid that without looking weak? Ah!

Seacat pushed herself up. "Well, we can do it - and then we all collapse upon arriving. Fine by me - I'm not the one having to report to the Queen."

"Ugh…" The shrimp groaned. "No, let's spend another night in the forest, then arrive at Bright Moon fresh and awake!"

That sounded a little too easy to Seacat. She looked at Adora and frowned, signalling a question.

"Queen Angella doesn't know about our mission," Adora replied in a voice so low, only Seacat could hear her. "There was no time to contact her, and…"

"Ah." Seacat started to grin, then frowned. It wasn't her fault, was it? Or, rather, they wouldn't blame her for this? Seacat had let herself be captured by second-rate bounty hunters, after all.

Damn.

She groaned. This wouldn't be a fun visit. And Bright Moon was landlocked. If you didn't count the river. But no sailor worth their salt would count rivers, of course. In any case, there wouldn't be decent harbour taverns to hi... visit.

She blinked. The last time she had visited a tavern, she had been kidnapped. On the other hand, she hadn't been to Bright Moon before, so no one would be able to know her favourite taverns, anyway. Although… "Does Bright Moon have decent taverns?" she asked.

Why was everyone but the Captain looking at her as if she had gone insane? It was a perfectly logical question. After all of this, she really needed a drink or three!

*****

"So… You remember your former life."

Seacat didn't wince when she heard the Captain speak up. But she kept staring into the smokeless fire. Well, almost smokeless - she could still smell the smoke, and had to move around twice so far on her watch to avoid it when the wind turned. "You should rest. Your watch is coming up soon."

"I can sleep in Bright Moon," he replied, sitting down next to her.

"If Mermista isn't there to have words with you." It was a cheap shot - without the Captain and the others, Seacat might not have escaped the Fright Zone. Might - she'd already been on her way out, after all, when she heard about their intrusion.

He laughed. "Oh, that's just because she cares."

Seacat made an agreeing noise and kept staring into the flames.

And he waited in silence. Damn.

After a while, she sighed. "Yes, I remember my whole life."

"Mhhh."

"And it sucks!" she hissed.

"Really?"

"Yes! I was a stupid Horde cadet! Happy to serve! I'm Horde scum!" she spat, looking up for the first time.

He smiled at her. "You certainly are no Horde scum - I would say everyone agrees about that."

She scoffed in return. “I’m a fake. I wasn’t a victim - I was a murderer. I was glad to be sent to the frontlines!” She bared her teeth at him. “I wanted to attack the village!”

“You were a kid,” he replied. “Doing what you were told to.”

“I knew the Horde wasn’t… was evil. But I didn’t even think of defecting.” She clenched her teeth. Afterwards, everyone had fawned over her, thinking she had lost her family in the attack. If they had known she was a Horde soldier…

“Neither did Adora for four more years.”

She scoffed. “Adora’s great, the best friend you could want, but she’s not the brightest lantern on a ship. She trusted Shadow Weaver. I should’ve known better.”

“Really? You knew how things were in the Alliance?”

“No, but…” She scoffed again. “I should’ve known that the Horde was lying about that as well. And it’s all my fault! Shadow Weaver wanted me dead - and she sacrificed an entire village for it!”

“That’s her fault, not yours,” he corrected her. “And I think she had other motives as well - the second in command of the Horde doesn’t strike as someone who has simple plans.”

She snorted. “She’s twisted, yes.” She knew that better than anyone else. “But I knew that as well!”

“But you never actually *did* anything wrong, did you?”

She opened her mouth to contradict him, then closed it again and glared at him. “I didn’t have the opportunity! I would have!”

“But you didn’t. And now you wouldn’t, would you?” He smiled and wrapped his arm around her shoulders. In a lower voice, he added: “No one’s going to blame you. We understand. Trust me.”

She drew a shuddering breath, then hugged him. Hard.

And cried.

*****

Brain Boy had lied - it took more than half a day to reach Bright Moon. It was mid-afternoon - according to the sun - when they finally reached the kingdom. By literally stumbling out of the woods and onto a field from which the spires and palace on top of the cliff were visible.

And, as Seacat had expected, a dinky riverport. Well, it was a clean and shiny riverport, but rather tiny. But it was not on top of a cliff, but very close by to their position - which meant there were no endless stairs to climb to reach it. And there wouldn't be a Queen waiting in the port. "Alright!" she said, trying not to sound as exhausted as she felt, "I'll find a tavern in the port while you go and explain things to the Queen."

"What? No!" Adora protested. "You'll be lodging in the palace with m... us!"

"I don't want to be a bother." Nor did Seacat want to explain to the Queen how she had been captured.

"You can't stay in a tavern while we sleep in the palace!" Adora insisted.

"Of course I can! People do it all the time!"

"That's not what I mean! You know what I mean!"

"All I know is that I want the closest bed so I can rest after my ordeal!" Seacat shot back.

Adora stared at her. Then she set her jaw. And grinned.

"What?" Seacat asked. "You…"

"For the Honour of Grayskull!"

Seacat gasped. “Oh, no, you’re not going to…”

But Adora scooped her up before Seacat could say anything else. “I’ll carry you to the palace!”

“Let me down! I’m not entering Bright Moon like this!”

“Seems to me that you are!”

“I’ll claw you!”

“Just relax, Ca-Seacat!”

“I’m not kidding!”

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“You clawed me!”

“I told you I would!” Seacat scoffed. Adora was being a baby - she had barely scratched her. And she had warned her! Twice!

“I was just trying to help!”

“You were embarrassing me!” As if Seacat would allow herself to be carried into Bright Moon as if she were helpless. Or a baby.

Adora huffed. “See if I care next time!”

“I will!” She turned away.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “Now that we’ve arrived, shall we go meet the Queen?”

Ugh. Seacat clenched her teeth, then forced herself to smile as she turned back to face the others. “Of course, Captain.”

At least the shrimp seemed to be as looking forward to the meeting as Seacat herself. Shared misery was halved misery or something.

Unless the Queen would blame Seacat for this.

Great.

At least the street leading to Bright Moon was broad and sloped up the hill; it would take them a while. A stay of execution, so to speak.

And the city was looking nice. Far too clean to be taken seriously, and full of landlubbers, but nice. “This city needs a proper harbour,” Seacat said as they passed a bakery.

“We’ve got a harbour,” the shrimp replied.

“No, you’ve got a pier trying to pass as a port. That’s no harbour.”

“Well, Bright Moon isn’t on the coast,” Brain Boy cut in.

“Exactly!” Seacat nodded. “A major fault.”

“It’s a very nice city. And they have horses!” Adora apparently had finally gotten over her scratch. She could heal herself, anyway, by transforming.

Horses. “Pf!” Seacat shook her head. Four-legged farm animals. Who needed them? A skiff was better, faster, didn’t tire, could transport more, and didn’t need feed and other care, and it could…

“Adora!”

She blinked. “Since when can horses fly? And talk?”

“Swift Wind!” Adora waved at the beast.

Seacat took a step back when the great beast landed - and she still had to dodge the wings before they folded. “Hey!”

“You went on an adventure without me!” the horse complained.

“I’m sorry - there was no time to call you!”

Seacat turned to Sea Hawk and pointed at the beast. "What is that?"

"Swift Wind, stalwart mount and comrade of She-Ra!" the Captain told her.

"And *what* is it? Horses don't have wings. And they don't talk."

"Ah… I don't exactly know, actually." Sea Hawk rubbed his chin. "I assume he's like the sword, part of She-Ra's magic."

"Actually, when Adora was experimenting with the sword, she accidentally turned a horse into Swift Wind," Brain Boy explained.

And Seacat had let her friend heal her with her sword? She stared at the… at Swift Wind.

"And this is Ca-Seacat!" Adora said, pointing at her. "Seacat. This is Swift Wind."

"So, you're Adora's old friend with the brain damage."

What? "My brain's fine!" Seacat spat.

"Seacat remembers everything now!" Adora said with a beaming smile.

"Ah." Swift Wind sniffed.

Seacat narrowed her eyes. What was this… mount thinking? She took a step closer to Adora. The horse sneered at her - behind Adora's back. Hmph.

Then it turned to Adora: "So, come on, I'll fly you up!"

"Oh, but…" Adora glanced at Seacat.

She forced herself to smile. "Go on!" she told her friend. Go on your dumb horse and fly!

She wasn’t jealous. Not of Adora getting to fly, and certainly not of a stupid animal.

*****

“So, this is Bright Moon’s palace!”

“Ah.” Seacat didn’t really pay attention to the shrimp as she looked around. Tall rooms - very tall. Wide hallways. Everything was clean and bright. “Looks a little bigger than Mermista’s, but not as big as the Snow Kingdom’s palace.”

“It’s older than both,” the princess told her with a frown.

“It’s not a competition,” Brain Boy added.

“Of course not.” Seacat smirked.

“Princess Glimmer? The Queen’s expecting you in the throne room.” A guard - or a guard captain; Seacat didn’t know the rank markings - told them. The shrimp winced, and Seacat was about to wish the shrimp luck when the guard continued: “With all your companions.”

Which, fortunately, didn’t include the flying horse, as Seacat found out. It wasn’t much, but it was something. “Hey, Adora.”

“Yes?”

“You’ve met the Queen before, right?”

“Yes.”

“How is she?”

“Oh, she’s nice!”

That would’ve been reassuring - if the shrimp didn’t look like a prisoner headed to the gallows. After all, Adora wasn’t exactly the best judge of character.

Before Seacat could ask for details, they reached a huge door - almost a gate, which was already opening for them.

And there was the throne room of Bright Moon. And the Queen.

She was tall, even seated on the throne that was obvious. Seacat couldn't help but wonder how the king had looked, seeing that the princess had a rather stocky build. She knew who'd she trust not to lose their balance and get blown overboard in a storm.

Then again, she doubted that the Queen would ever be on a ship in a storm. She looked rather… well, 'airy' or whatever. That the throne was floating in the air, with hovering steps leading up to it, reinforced the impression. As did the fact that the throne room was open to the air behind her. Must be using magic to keep the rain out, Seacat thought as they approached.

The shrimp knelt down. Seacat quickly followed her and the others' example. She was very much aware that she was still in the now rather worn clothes she had been wearing at the time of her kidnapping. Not the best way to make a good impression. On the other hand, her torn top might garner some sympathy for an escaped prisoner. If the Queen felt like giving any.

"My Queen. We've returned successfully from our mission."

Did they really speak so formally to each oth…?

"That would be the mission you undertook without my leave, right? Glimmer?" The Queen wasn't amused. At all. She made Shadow Weaver sound downright friendly.

"Your majesty, there was no time to send for your leave," Adora, always ready to protect others, spoke up, her hand on her chest. "We had to act quickly to pursue the kidnappers before they could escape."

The Queen wasn't impressed, though. "Yet, that's exactly what they did - they did escape, didn't they?"

“Yes, but we were close - and we managed to rescue Seacat from the Fright Zone,” the princess added, smiling.

“So I see.”

Seacat didn’t flinch when the Queen stared at her. She even managed to smile. “That’s me.”

“I know.”

This time, Seacat winced.

“So, what happened? Adora?”

Seacat saw the shrimp close her mouth and frown as Adora stood at parade rest and spoke up: “We heard about the kidnapping in Seaworthy about two hours after it had happened. Despite immediate action being taken, the culprits had already left the town on a skiff. Charting their probable course, we set out in pursuit while sending forces down alternative routes. We were correct in our assumptions, but since we had to track the kidnappers and they had a lead on us, we didn’t manage to catch up to them in before they reached the Fright Zone, at which point we switched from pursuit to infiltration, using my knowledge of the location to sneak undetected into the Fright Zone. When we were detected inside the Zone, we set fire to several factories as a distraction and breached the prison. We subdued the guards and were about to interrogate them to find out where Seacat was kept prisoner when Seacat arrived on the scene, having escaped a secret prison. We regrouped and moved to the main river port of the Fright Zone. We took the port and a gunboat and escaped downriver, where we destroyed the gunboat, stole two skiffs and escaped into the Eastern Plains, then to the mountains, where we broke through a Horde fortification on a small pass before using a rockslide to hinder pursuit. The skiffs broke down afterwards, so we had to walk through the woods to Bright Moon.”

“See, Mom? Everything went as planned.” The shrimp beamed at the Queen.

But the Queen wasn't amused. "Princess Glimmer. I know a redacted report when I hear one - I've heard enough from you." That caused the princess to flinch. And Adora as well. "Now, tell me again what happened - and don't skip the details this time."

Seacat saw Adora swallow. That was a bad sign. She cleared her throat. "I was ambushed and poisoned by four bounty hunters in a tavern," she said. "I tried to get away, but they followed me, and we fought in the kitchen. I got two of them, but the poison took me out before I could finish the other two."

The Queen looked at her. "I meant She-Ra's report. I already heard about your kidnapping from trusted sources."

"Ah, sorry…" Seacat forced herself to smile.

The Queen seemed to return the smile for a moment before turning back to Adora. "She-Ra?"

"Uh.." Adora took a deep breath and started again. "As soon as we heard about a commotion in Seacat's favourite tavern, we moved there, but when we arrived, it was already over, and the witnesses told us that she had been kidnapped. There were two bodies in the kitchen, which were identified by others as bounty hunters, so we deduced that…"

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"...and then we arrived in Bright Moon." Adora hadn't relaxed during her report - the perfect soldier.

"Thank you, Adora." The Queen, though, had leaned to the side and propped herself up with one elbow on her throne's armrest during Adora's very detailed report. The idiot hadn't even left out getting scratched by Seacat!

Not that Seacat had dared to protest - the Queen's smile had slipped quickly into Adora's recount. Obviously, Bright Moon's Queen wasn't as fond of 'harrowing adventures' as her daughter. Especially if it involved her daughter.

“To sum it up: You went on this mission without permission, support or proper preparation. You achieved your objective only because Seacat here realised you had infiltrated the Fright Zone and decided to look for you instead of fleeing to safety on her own.”

Seacat bit her lower lip. That sounded… well, it wasn’t exactly wrong, but it wasn’t exactly fair to the others, either.

“But Mom!”

“Glimmer! This is your Queen speaking to her commander!”

“But… Fine! We did have a plan, and we adapted it to changing circumstances! We weren’t stupid!”

“I didn’t say you were stupid - I said you were lucky. If Seacat hadn’t found you, you would’ve been caught looking for her. Caught, possibly killed, because you rushed into a mission without thinking. A mission that had turned out to not have been needed in the first place, as your report shows!”

Alright. That was going too far - this had been the Captain and Adora’s mission, after all. Seacat couldn’t let them suffer the Queen’s wrath. Certainly not for saving her. She cleared her throat. “But that’s not true, err, your Majesty...”

“Yes?”

That wasn’t a friendly look. Not at all. Mermista’s frown had nothing on the Queen’s. Seacat swallowed and took a deep breath. “They acted according to the best information they had, and I might not have escaped on my own, since I was wounded in my battle with the bug princess.”

The Queen’s eyebrows rose a little. “Your wound didn’t seem to have slowed you down much in the subsequent fighting, did it?”

“I would’ve done much better if I hadn’t been wounded.” Seacat blinked and clenched her teeth. That was, well, true, but not

helping. “And I might’ve succumbed to my wounds on the way out of the Fright Zone,” she quickly added, forcing herself to keep smiling. Might’ve - she was tough. She had escaped on her own, after all.

“Ah.” The Queen slowly nodded. “That doesn’t change the fact that the rescue mission was rushed and done without either support or planning.”

“Your Majesty!” the Captain - finally - spoke up. “In war, there are times for planning and preparing - and there are times when time is of the essence, and one can but rush ahead and trust one’s wits and blade since any delay will mean doom!” He raised his chin and pointed at the sky behind the Queen. “This was the latter - there was no time to plan; the enemy escaped, this is true, but only by chance. With a little luck, we would’ve caught them before they reached the shelter of their cowardly employers. And when we reached the enemy borders, we had to press on since any time lost waiting for reinforcements would’ve put the life of my brave first mate at risk and would have given the enemy commander more time to prepare a trap. It was only by rushing in, far swifter and more daring than the despicable creature calling herself Shadow Weaver would’ve thought possible, that we were able to foil her dastardly plans!”

He pushed his chest out.

“And foil them we did! We set their factories on fire! We wrecked their main river port, we sunk their barges and gunboats, destroyed their gun emplacements and fortifications, and lured them into a futile chase, exhausting both soldiers and materiel! This was a great victory for the Alliance! And a great adventure!” he yelled.

The Queen winced - and she wasn’t the only one who winced, Seacat noticed. She shook her head. Really - it was as if the others had never heard someone speak passionately. They would be useless in a storm, their voices lost in the wind. She nodded emphatically. “Yes, your Majesty. We hurt the Horde - and we

recovered valuable information as well. I remember how Shadow Weaver sacrificed an entire company to kill me and sabotage a rival."

The Queen was still frowning. What did it take to make her see reason? Should they blame everything on the shrimp? She wouldn't really punish her daughter, would she?

"I see. You make some good points." The Queen slowly nodded with obvious reluctance. "But you did take considerable risks. Risks I cautioned you against. And while I cannot fault you for rushing to rescue your friend, I can and must fault the commander of my forces for rushing in as if she had no other, important and crucial duties to the Alliance."

Oh. So, no need to blame everything on the shrimp. The Queen was already singling out the princess. Seacat blinked. Well, that was an acceptable loss. Whatever light punishment princesses suffered would probably build character, anyway.

"But Mom!"

"I'm talking as your Queen, not as your mother, Glimmer!"

"No, you're not!"

And it seemed that the shrimp really needed that character building, too.

*****

"So… is that normal?" Seacat asked as soon as they, except for the shrimp and Brain Boy, had left the throne room.

"What?" Adora frowned at her.

Instead of answering, Seacat nodded towards the closed doors behind them.

“Oh. No, not really. I mean… it’s rare. Pretty rare. Queen Angella is a nice leader, and she means well, and Glimmer does her best, but…”

“The Queen’s a little overprotective,” the Captain cut in. “And Princess Glimmer is passionate for adventure!”

Seacat glanced around, but the guards standing at the gate hadn’t reacted to Sea Hawk’s outburst. Either the Captain had been here before, or people yelling in the palace was normal.

She would’ve known if the Captain had been a frequent visitor to Bright Moon. So, this was normal - well, if she cocked her head and moved her ears just right, she could faintly hear fragments of a row from the throne room.

That sounded familiar. Smiling, she folded her hands behind the back of her head. “So… tavern now? I really need a drink.” And a rest.

“‘Tavern’? Don’t be stupid!” Adora blurted out. “You’re staying at the palace, of course!”

“What?” Seacat narrowed her eyes at her friend. “Do you think I’ll get kidnapped again?”

“What? No, the palace is great! You need to see my room!” Adora beamed at her before frowning. “And it’s also safer than a tavern.”

Aha! Seacat scoffed. “I’ve been in palaces before.” Hell, Mermista’s palace almost felt like home - not that anything other than a ship could ever feel like home!

“But not in this one! Come!”

Before Seacat could respond, Adora grabbed her hand and started dragging her away. It was a good thing her shoulder had been healed, or this would have hurt. And short of scratching Adora’s hand again, there was no escaping this grip.

She looked over her shoulder at the Captain, but Sea Hawk was smiling while following them at a slower pace.

Fortunately, they didn't have to go far, so Seacat's arm was still attached to her shoulder when Adora stopped in front of a large door - without guards, Seacat noted. "This is my room!"

And the room was huge! Almost as big - no, not close to the throne room. But it had huge open windows - didn't Bright Moon ever get any storms? - and a bed bigger than Mermista's. Hell, the entire room was about as big as Mermista's bedroom! And… "You've got a waterfall in your room?"

"Yes?"

"What for?"

"Uh… I don't exactly know? It's not for bathing; that's this room."

Ah. Well, it wasn't as if Seacat couldn't understand the desire to have a waterfall in your room if you were stuck on land. At least the sound of the water would help you relax as you fell asleep - it wasn't as if in Bright Moon, you'd ever be tired enough from a day's work on a ship. At least not in the palace. They probably used magic to serve the food, too.

"That's a very nice room. Almost too big for one person."

"I know, right?" Adora beamed at Sea Hawk. "I couldn't believe it when they gave it to me!"

Seacat narrowed her eyes at the Captain behind her friend's back. He wasn't half as subtle as he thought he was. "And where will we be staying?" she asked.

"Uh…" Adora blinked. Then she smiled at Seacat, though it looked a little forced. "Well… you could stay here. I can get another bed - I know where to get one since I had to replace mine; it was so soft, I almost drowned in it!"

That sounded ridiculous. The drowning, at least.

“I mean… we have a lot to talk about, don’t we?” Adora started fidgeting. She was twiddling her thumbs and avoided looking at Seacat. “It’s, well… on the way here, we didn’t really have any opportunity to talk about, you know…”

“My past.”

“Yes, exactly!” Adora nodded so rapidly, her ponytail whipped around her face. Unfortunately, her stupid poof didn’t even budge. “And, well… It’s more private here. Except for Glimmer and Bow, no one comes here, and Glimmer won’t be allowed to leave her room for tonight, maybe longer, which means Bow will be with her, and…”

“Wait - the princess’s being sent to her room as punishment?” Seacat had heard of such customs from Mermista, but to hear that this actually happened, and to a princess?

“Err… probably?”

“You mean this isn’t the first time this happened,” Seacat said with a frown.

“Glimmer’s very brave,” Adora replied.

“And her thirst for adventure cannot be quenched without adventure!” Sea Hawk added, raising his hand to point at the ceiling. “Speaking of, I shall take my leave to secure transportation back to Seaworthy for us. I’ll be back later! You stay and rest, First Mate! Captain’s orders!”

And he was gone - through the door, not the window, at least. Then again, they were a little too high up above the cliff for the Captain’s favourite exit. Well, his orders were clear.

“So… you’re going to leave again?”

Adora looked as if someone had told her that her favourite rations were banned. “I’m a sailor - I need to get back to the sea,” Seacat told her. “We need to get our new ship and take it on a shakedown cruise.” And, unlike other times, this would likely be quite the adventure, what with the new ship using an engine built by the Purple Princess.

“But so soon?” Adora looked crestfallen. “You just remembered your - our - past, and now you’re leaving again…” She sat down on her bed and looked at the floor.

“Oh for…” Seacat rubbed the bridge of her nose and sighed before sitting down on the bed as well - though behind her friend. “I’m not leaving right now, dummy. But we need to keep the pressure on the Horde. And I am a sailor - I need to get back on a ship.”

“But…”

“That I remember my past life doesn’t change that.” She was the best damn first mate on all the Seas, and no one could take that from her!

“I hoped that you’d… you remember what we planned when we were kids?” Adora turned to look at her.

“Yes.” Seacat was tempted to add: ‘fight for the Horde’, but that would’ve been... She wasn’t like that. “But things changed.”

“I know, just…” Adora sighed. “It’s like losing you again.” She gasped. “I don’t want to sound as if I meant… it’s not your fault. I totally understand that you want to get back on a ship. You don’t need to feel guilty for that!”

Adora looked like a kicked puppy. “I’m not feeling guilty,” Seacat lied.

“Ah, good. I mean… you went through so much! And I’m being so selfish, wishing that…”

“Wishing what?” Seacat leaned forward.

“Err…” Once more, Seacat’s friend looked away. “To stay with me for a while. Catch up, you know? I really missed you,” she added in a whisper so low, Seacat almost missed it despite her keen ears.

“I missed you as well,” she told Adora.

“You did? But you didn’t remember before!”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “I mean, I missed being together like this, you know? Now that I remember.”

“Oh.” Adora didn’t look like she understood what Seacat had said.

That was fine. Seacat wasn’t sure that she did, either.

But sitting here, talking… it felt good. Really good. She leaned forward and put her hand on Adora’s thigh, squeezing it reassuringly. Just like old times.

*****

The Broken Bot

Seacat squeezed Adora's thigh again. Just like old times. The two of them, in Adora's bed, together, about to take a nap, she'd curl up with her and…

OK, it wasn't like old times. She pulled back and cleared her throat. "So…"

"So?" Adora stared at her.

We need to talk. But Seacat didn't say that. "You heard the Captain. I need to rest."

Adora blinked, then nodded. "Yes. Of course. We did a long march. And dinner's a few hours away. Resting is… good."

Seacat nodded in return.

Neither she nor Adora moved, though. Seacat really should go to her room for a nap in peace. But Adora would, well, she'd look crushed again. Seacat reached out and patted the woman's shoulder. "So… you mentioned a second bed?"

"Oh! Yes, of course!" Adora jumped up. "I'll be right back!"

And she was out of the door before Seacat could say anything. Snorting, Seacat shook her head and looked around the room. You could fit a courier boat in here with room to spare. And there was ample storage room, too. Certainly far more than Seacat was used to on a ship. Hmmm…

She could go and take a peek at Adora's things. Her friend was bound to have more stuff now than before.

Or she could just lie here a little longer, relax and…

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“Hey! Seacat! Dinner time!”

“What?” She blinked, propping herself up on her elbows and turned her head. Oh, no - she must have fallen asleep. On Adora’s bed. And she had drooled on the pillows. Fortunately, actual pillows, this time. But…

“It’s dinner time - well, it’ll be dinner time in a bit.” Adora was standing there, next to the bed, smiling at her. “I thought you wanted to, ah, ‘freshen up’ a little? Glimmer said that’s how you call it when you clean up for an inspection before meals. Only, there’s no inspection.”

Seacat closed her eyes and sighed. “I know what ‘freshen up’ means, Adora. I’ve spent four years outside the Fright Zone, remember?”

“Oh…”

Snorting, Seacat rolled on her back and looked at the ceiling. “I’m not the cadet you knew any more. I’m a sailor, you…” She blinked. It felt a little drafty. Oh. Her battered top had ripped completely during her nap. “Oh, bother. You wouldn’t have a spare shirt?” She blinked again.

Adora was blushing furiously. And, apparently, caught between staring at Seacat’s chest and looking anywhere but at her chest.

Oh. Seacat started blushing as well. That was… no! This wasn’t embarrassing. She was a sailor. You couldn’t live on a ship without such things happening. “So, can I borrow a shirt from you?”

“Uh… sure?”

“Thank you.” Seacat rolled off the bed and pulled the remains of her shirt off. “I think that is beyond hope - unless you can magically repair it?” She held it out to Adora, who was now looking as if all her blood had ran to her head.

“Ah… I’ve never… I mean, I never tried… err...”

Seacat started smirking. “Well, see if you can manage it? I’ll go take a bath.”

She dropped the torn shirt on the floor and walked to the bathroom. A glance over her shoulder at the door told her that Adora hadn’t moved a finger since she had left her there. She grinned when she closed the door behind her. This was fun! Just like old times - or not like old times. Adora was more susceptible to teasing about her performance in training, back then. Not about...

And now Seacat was blushing. For some reason.

*****

The bathroom was great - roomy, warm, with as much hot water as you wanted, and a bathtub large enough to float a dinghy in it. Seacat purred when she dried herself with a towel large enough to double as a spare sail. Did Bright Moon have anything that was normal-sized?

Not that she didn’t appreciate it, anyway - her fur certainly needed all the care she could give. “I’ve used up your shampoo,” she yelled as she wrapped herself in a smaller towel and opened the door. “You should get more bottles… Oh. Hi, Brain Boy.”

“Hi, Seacat.” The guy was standing next to Adora at the small table, looking at something.

“What’s up?” she asked, walking over and peering at the table herself. Just some letters. “Did the shrimp send for help? Do we need to break her out of her room?”

“No!” Adora sounded scandalised.

Brain Boy, though, laughed. “Glimmer will be joining us for dinner. With Queen Angella.”

She felt her stomach drop. “Oh, how nice.” So much for a peaceful dinner.

*****

“This is very good,” Seacat commented. It was true - the steak was perfect; just how she liked it. And the spicy butter on it… Mhhh!

“Yes, indeed!” Sea Hawk agreed. “Our compliments to the cook!”

“I will tell her,” Queen Angella said with about as much honest emotion as a frozen ice shark.

No one else said anything. Seacat glanced to Adora as she cut another slice off her steak. Her friend was sitting slightly hunched over and focusing on her food. Brain Boy mirrored her. And the shrimp was silently steaming in her own seat and attacking her steak as if it was an enemy to be dismembered. Or the Queen.

Seacat had to suppress a snort at the thought. The food was the only good thing about this meal. It was also the only thing anyone had talked about so far - and they were on the main course! She looked at her Captain. Usually, he’d entertain the entire table - or tavern - with a tale or three. She didn’t know why he wasn’t his usual self, but he probably had a good reason for it.

Which meant she’d better keep her head down, too. Damn. No, that couldn’t stand. “Do you have news from the war? About the offensive south of Seaworthy?”

“The offensive is progressing according to plan, last I heard,” the Queen replied after a moment.

That didn’t tell Seacat anything about the war - she didn’t know the plans, after all. But she nodded with a smile anyway. “Thank you.” Princesses were prickly about respect, and Queens, from what Seacat could tell, doubly so.

“At least something’s going according to plan,” the shrimp mumbled - rather loudly.

Seacat drew a hissing breath through clenched teeth and resisted the urge to duck.

“It’s impressive that the offensive is continuing despite the fact that our commander left her troops to go on an unauthorised rescue mission,” the Queen replied with as much warmth as an arctic storm.

“It shows that I made the right decision!” the shrimp snarled, putting down her cutlery.

“It shows that you were lucky - twice over.”

“We weren’t just lucky! We struck hard at the enemy! And we need to keep striking until they break down!” The princess hit the table.

“Rushed and sloppily planned attacks are an invitation for a devastating counterattack. We cannot afford to underestimate the Horde. We did, once - and paid the price.” The Queen remained unmoved - almost like a statue.

“We cannot afford to cower in fear - we just struck at their heartland and escaped without any losses! If you had your way, we would only defend our borders - but nobody ever won a war by sticking to defence!” the shrimp retorted.

“Too many lost a war by overextending their forces.”

“But we aren’t! We have the strongest alliance, ever! Troops are massing, and we control the sea! It’s time to strike on multiple fronts! The Horde can’t be everywhere!”

“You won’t strike until you’ve shown that you understand your duty as a commander!”

“Mom! I understand my duty perfectly! I need to win this war!”

“That proves you don’t understand your duty at all!”

Seacat hastily swallowed the last of her steak and glanced at Adora. Her friend was staring at her empty plate. “Hey, Adora!” she whispered.

No reaction.

Frowning, Seacat repeated herself: “Hey, Adora!”

Still no reaction. She scoffed, checked if anyone was looking, then kicked out with her foot.

Adora jerked and gasped, then turned to glare at her. “Why did you kick me?” she whispered.

“You were ignoring me!” Seacat whispered back.

“What? I wasn’t!”

“Anyway, can we leave the table without offending the Queen? I don’t want to watch this.”

Adora blinked. “Oh…” Seacat could almost see her thinking. Then Adora’s eyes widened, and she started smiling. “Your Majesty!”

“Yes, Adora?”

“Ca-Seacat is still tired from her ordeal. Can I escort her to her room to rest?”

Seacat opened her mouth to protest that she was fine and didn’t need any rest, but her friend had kicked her in the shin, and all that left her lips was a gasp.

“Payback,” the traitor whispered.

“Of course! Please - you need your rest.”

“Thank you, your Majesty!”

Seacat stood up before Adora could reach her - she didn’t need help to walk!

Adora offered her her arm anyway. “Take it, or the Queen will notice that we’re lying.”

That was… Seacat huffed and took the arm. And ignored Adora’s triumphant smile.

“Rest well,” the Captain called after her. Brain Boy probably said something as well, but the Queen and the Princess were already going at each other again, so not even Seacat’s ears caught the boy’s words.

How did Bright Moon manage to defend itself against the Horde with such leaders? “They seem to fight each other more than the Horde,” she commented - after checking that no guard was near who might overhear her.

“What?”

“The Queen and the Princess,” Seacat explained.

“No! They’re just… they just have a disagreement,” Adora said. But she didn’t look at Seacat as she replied.

“Well, it’s not exactly filling me with confidence in the Alliance’s leadership,” Seacat said after a moment. Although Mermista wasn’t too bad. The princess knew how to wage war on the sea, at least - even though that was mostly Sea Hawk’s doing. But the Snow Princess was a kid and what Seacat had seen of the Plant Princess hadn’t impressed her. And the Purple Princess… no, that was no leader at all. Unless you were talking about bots.

“They’re doing their best,” Adora replied as they reached her room and she opened the door.

Seacat stopped. “Aren’t you supposed to show me to my room?”

Adora’s face fell. “Uh… I thought… you know…”

Seacat laughed and elbowed the idiot. “I’m joking, you dummy.” She sauntered inside.

“Oh, you!” Adora closed the door. “That was mean!”

“Was it?” Seacat grinned and sat down on the bed, then leaned back and stretched a little, arching her back.

“Yes, it…”

“Hmmm?” Seacat glanced at her friend. Adora was so cute when she was flustered.

And when she huffed, like she just did. “Oh, you!” Adora stalked over to the bed and let herself fall on it. “They’ll work it out.”

“Do you think that or do you hope that?” Seacat asked, then pressed her lips together. That was a quote from one of their old instructors.

Adora thankfully didn’t comment on her slip. “Bow said so.”

“And he’s the expert?” Or had Brain Boy just been trying to reassure Adora?

“He’s Glimmer’s best friend. They’ve known each other for a long time.”

“Ah.” Which doesn’t mean that he was truthful. On the other hand, Brain Boy was about as good a liar as Adora was, in Seacat’s opinion. Meaning, he sucked at it.

For a few moments, neither of them spoke. They just lay there, staring at the ceiling. If the mattress had been harder and the ceiling duller, lower and dirtier, it would’ve been like back in the barracks.

She pushed the thought away. She wasn’t… She was Seacat, not Catra. “I’m Seacat,” she mumbled. Not Catra. Not Horde scum.

“Hmmm?” Adora shifted around next to her, Seacat could hear her.

“I’m Seacat. Not Catra,” she repeated herself.

“Oh. But…”

She turned her head. Adora was on her side, looking at her with her mouth stuck half-open.

Seacat closed her eyes and suppressed a curse. “I’m not Catra any more.”

“Oh. But you…”

“What?” Couldn’t Adora just say what she wanted to?

“You do remember, right?”

“Of course I do! I told you so, didn’t I?” Seacat rolled her eyes.

Adora sighed. After a moment, she said: “I kept telling myself that, you know. That you’d remember, and you’d turn back to…” She shrugged. “Back to the Catra I knew.”

“Fourteen years old and dumb?” Seacat raised her eyebrows at her.

Adora snorted, which seemed to surprise her. “No! Yes? I don’t know!” She raised her arms and let them fall on the bed. “This is complicated.”

And there was no manual for her to read about it. Seacat pushed that nasty comment away before she could blurt it out. Her friend was already feeling bad enough. “It’s not complicated,” she replied. “I was Catra. Then I left the Horde and became Seacat. Just like you became She-Ra.” Well, in principle. And with memory loss. And a few years spent at sea, living a lie. Alright, it was mostly the same.

“But… I’m still Adora when I’m She-Ra. I’m just stronger, tougher and can do magic.”

Yes, rub it in. Seacat sighed. “But you’re not Force Captain Adora any more, are you?”

“Of course not!”

“See?”

“Uh… no?”

“I’m not Cadet Catra any more. I remember being her, but I’m a sailor now. Seacat. That’s who I am.”

“Ah.” Adora slowly nodded. “I knew that already.”

“Really?”

“Well... “ Her friend grimaced. “I knew it after you told me?”

“Oh, you…” Seacat rolled her eyes again.

Adora wasn’t looking at her, though. She was staring at the wall. “I wasn’t talking about Cadet Catra. I meant Catra. My friend.”

Oh. Seacat blinked. Then frowned. “I’m still your friend, you dummy. Hell, I was your friend when I was Seacat. Or do you think I would go carousing with just everyone?”

Adora broke out in a wide smile, and her eyes grew wet.

And then she tried to break Seacat’s ribs by crushing her chest in her arms.

“Ack!”

*****

A little later, they were both sprawled on Adora’s bed, and Seacat had stopped rubbing her ribs to make a point.

“You know, I was wondering…” Adora trailed off.

“I bet you are,” Seacat replied.

Adora started to nod, then frowned for a moment before shaking her head. “Anyway, do you have any sailor friends? I mean, except for Sea Hawk and Mermista.”

Sea Hawk was her Captain. And Mermista was… his girlfriend. Neither was a friend, not in the sense Adora probably meant. Not like the shrimp and Brain Boy were for her. “What do you mean?” Seacat asked.

“I mean, a friend… like me.”

“I doubt that there’s another one like you in Etheria,” Seacat smirked.

Adora blushed a little, “Thanks! I was just wondering…”

“I didn’t replace you if that’s what you mean.”

“I didn’t mean it like that!” Adora protested. “But… hadn’t you forgotten all about me?”

“Yes.” Seacat shrugged. She hadn’t made any friends, but that was normal. Sailors roamed the sea. “So, you don’t need to be jealous.”

“I’m not jealous!”

Seacat snickered in return. “Gotcha!”

“Oh, you!” And now came the pout. Just like old times.

“You’re too easy to rile up,” she told Adora with a grin.

“And you’re impossible!”

“I know.”

Her friend sighed. “I just… I feel guilty. I thought you were dead, and I just accepted Shadow Weaver’s lies. I should’ve

investigated! If I had, I might have...”

Seacat rolled her eyes and interrupted her friend. “Don’t be stupid. A cadet, investigating a battle? What would you have done? You weren’t there, anyway - by the time you could’ve reached the village, I was already gone.” And the dead had been taken care of.

“I know that, but… I can’t help feeling guilty for not doing anything.”

Seacat sighed. That, too, was typical for her friend. “You dummy. Not everything is your fault.” She reached over and grabbed Adora’s chin, pushing it up so their eyes met. “And you can’t save everyone.”

Adora looked into her eyes, blushing slightly. Then she pulled back. “But I’m She-Ra. It’s my duty to save everyone.”

“What?”

“Yes. Light Hope told me so.”

“Light Hope?” Was that a new friend of Adora? Why hadn’t she met her yet? And was that why Adora had asked about friends of Seacat? Had she been checking if Seacat had replaced her because she had replaced Seacat?

“Oh… She’s, like… this hologram program.”

“A what?”

“That’s how she explained it. She’s like… a bot, but very smart, and she doesn’t have a body, but she can project an image. Like a ghost. And she knows all about She-Ra.”

“A bot?”

“Sort of… not a bot from the Horde.” Adora sighed. “It’s… complicated.”

“And she knows everything about She-Ra?” Seacat had heard such claims before. Usually by con-men.

“Yes.” Adora nodded emphatically. “But she’s a little damaged, so she can’t tell me everything.”

How convenient! “I think I need to meet her,” Seacat said with a tight smile.

“I can take you to her tomorrow.”

“Good.” And if Seacat didn’t like what she saw, there would be consequences.

“So… you weren’t like the sailors we hear about?” Adora’s comment interrupted Seacat’s thoughts.

“What?” She frowned. “What do you mean?”

“You know, a lover in every port.”

“Really?” She narrowed her eyes at Adora. “Where did you hear that?”

“Uh… I read it somewhere. When I was researching.” Adora was looking quite embarrassed now.

“Researching?”

“I, uh, wanted to know more about ships and other nautical things. After, you know, we had met again, but you didn’t remember.”

“And you focused on lurid stories about sailors?”

“No! That was just… well, I didn’t want to read them, but I didn’t know they were, well… like that.” Adora looked like someone had painted her head red.

Seacat laughed as she shook her head. “And how many such stories did you read?”

“Only a couple.”

“Do you have some here? I’d love to know what landlubbers write about sailors.”

“No! That is, I don’t have any here.”

“Really?” Seacat narrowed her eyes at her.

“Really!”

“Ah, well.” She sighed with fake disappointment. “In any case, I don’t have a lover in every port. That only leads to trouble.” As the Captain’s past perfectly demonstrated - not that Seacat would discuss that with anyone, not even with Adora.

“Ah.” Adora nodded emphatically.

“Disappointed that I’m not the kind of sailor you read about?” Seacat raised her eyebrows at Adora and grinned at her.

“What? No, no! I like you just fine as you are!”

“Well, you better!” Because Seacat wasn’t about to change. Certainly not back into Catra.

*****

Seacat woke up half-sprawled over Adora again. How the… Oh, right. They had fallen asleep talking last night. On Adora’s bed. Though she wasn’t caught in her friend’s grip again. And she hadn’t drooled on Adora. Not much, at least.

Sliding off her friend, then off the bed, she looked around. The sun had gone up a couple hours ago, judging by its position on the sky. That meant it was soon time for breakfast. Or would be in an inn - in a palace, it was always time for whatever the princess wanted, after all. And She-Ra was a princess, wasn’t she?

But Seacat needed to freshen up. She couldn't really head to breakfast looking like she had just kicked off her pants and slept in her clothes - which she had. Which reminded her to get proper clothes. Adora's taste in clothing had improved, but her style was still… not Seacat. She needed proper clothes for sailing. Not for running around in the woods.

And clean clothes, a sniff informed her. Well, Adora had a few more clothes she could borrow until she got her own.

"Ngh."

Ah. Of course the woman in question would wake up just now. "Morning, sleepyhead."

Adora blinked, then stared at her. "You're up already?"

"I slept half the day yesterday," she reminded her friend.

"Crazy…" Adora sat up and started stretching. Which stretched the fabric of her top, Seacat noticed.

"Ca-Seacat?"

"What?"

"I asked if you want to use the bathroom first, since you're already out of bed." Adora frowned slightly.

She had missed that? Perhaps it was a little early, still. But she was up, and heading back to bed would make her look weak. Or lazy. "Yes," Seacat replied, heading to the bath. She could always nap later, after all. When the rest had a meeting or so.

*****

Breakfast wasn't as awkward as dinner had been, but that was a low bar to clear. The food was great, though - fried and grilled

fish! Seacat filled her plate for the second time with choice pieces. Bright Moon might be a kingdom of landlubbers, but they knew how to eat.

"I thought you'd love that," Adora told her. "So I told the kitchen staff yesterday to make some."

This was a special treat for her? Seacat stared at her plate, then at Adora. That was… sweet, she decided. And thoughtful. She beamed at her friend. "Thank you."

Adora nodded, a little blush on her cheeks, Seacat noted.

"So, what's the plan for today?" she asked after a moment, looking at Sea Hawk.

"We have a meeting in the afternoon concerning the next phase of the war," the Queen informed her.

"Indeed! As the ranking naval officer, I'll represent my dear Mermista! Oh, how I long to see her again, hold her in my arms!" He stood, pointing to the ceiling. "But duty is a harsh mistress, keeping us apart a little longer!"

The queen looked a little nonplussed, Seacat saw. She wasn't used to the Captain, yet - unlike the others.

"I planned to show Seacat the Whispering Forest," Adora said.

She hadn't mentioned Light Hope. Was that a secret? Or implied? Adora wasn't the type to keep secrets from her friends, but Seacat would have to ask to be sure she wouldn't accidentally reveal anything that was supposed to be secret. And it was good policy to keep secrets - loose lips sank ships, after all.

"The Whispering Forest?" Brain Bow looked confused. "Ah!" He nodded.

Well, it seemed he knew about Light Hope. But did the Queen?

“Be careful. Those Horde forces who chased you might still be in the area,” Queen Angella cautioned them.

Adora grinned. “In the Whispering Forest? They won’t last!”

Seacat frowned. That sounded… concerning. Catra had been told about the forest, but those had sounded like the usual tales to scare recruits who didn’t know better. Just how dangerous was the forest?

*****

As Seacat found out an hour later, quite dangerous - if you weren’t familiar with it. Or had a guide. Or She-Ra.

“Hah!”

Her friend was currently enthusiastically hacking a bug the size of a courier ship into dinghy-sized bits.

“Hah!”

Very enthusiastically.

Seacat shook her head as she leaned against the closest tree - after checking for more dangerous wildlife, of course. “Having fun?”

“Uh…” Adora jumped back when the bug lashed out with one of its huge limbs. “I’m almost done!” She charged in again.

“You know, if you kill every monster in the forest, the Horde can simply walk through,” Seacat pointed out.

“I’m… Hah! … just driving it off!”

“Really?”

“It’s being stubborn!” Adora planted a kick in the head of the bug which flipped it over on its back. The monster quickly recovered but seemed warier now.

“Hah!” Seacat’s friend moved in again, this time hitting the bug’s head. That seemed to do the job - the bug turned and started to flee.

Panting but smiling wildly, Adora turned back to Seacat. “See? No sweat!”

Seacat shook her head with a grin. “And how far is it to Light Hope’s den again?”

“It’s not a den!”

“Then what is it? A dungeon?”

“Not a dungeon either! It’s… a bunker?”

“That’s like a dungeon,” Seacat retorted. “See, I was correct.”

“No, you weren’t!”

*****

“A friend?” Light Hope sounded very doubtful for a bot. And a little insulting. Not that bots could talk, anyway. But this one could, and it sounded far too condescending for Seacat’s taste. Not quite like Shadow Weaver - Seacat clenched her teeth at the memory - but it was far too calm and polite to be honest.

“Yes. My best friend, Ca-Seacat!” Adora repeated herself.

Seacat waved at the spooky ‘projection’. “That’s me.”

The thing ignored her. “You’ve mentioned her before. She has defective memory.”

That definitely sounded like an insult. Seacat frowned at the thing. “Not any more. I recovered my memories.”

“Yes!” Adora nodded with a smile. “She remembers me!”

“I see.”

Seacat doubted that. “And what about your memories? I heard you can’t access most of them.”

The projection glanced at her. “That is irrelevant. I fulfil my duties to the best of my abilities.”

“And what are your duties?” Seacat asked with narrowed eyes.

“Supporting She-Ra in her duties.”

“Yes,” Adora nodded. “She’s been very helpful in figuring out what I can do!”

“With your personal problems solved, I presume that we can resume your training without further distractions, then.”

“Uh…” Adora sounded taken aback. “I was kinda hoping you could show her what you showed me, about She-Ra. And that we could have a nice talk.”

“The information in my memory is classified,” Light Hope replied. “Only She-Ra has the right to access it.”

“But if I have the right to access it, I have the right to share, right?”

“Negative.”

“Negative?” Adora looked surprised. “But… if it’s my information - I’m She-Ra, after all - I can share it!”

“That would be ill-advised,” Light Hope retorted. “She-Ra’s secrets need to be kept safe from everyone, for your own safety.”

“I trust Ca-Seacat with my life!” Adora declared, raising her chin in that stubborn way of hers.

Seacat smiled at the display - that was her best friend.

“Irrelevant. She-Ra’s duty takes precedence.”

Seacat really didn’t like Light Hope.

“What does my duty have to do with this?” Adora asked.

“You have to restore balance to Etheria.”

“I know. I have to beat the Horde.” Adora shook her head. “But I can’t do that without my friends!”

Light Hope didn’t reply to that. Which, Seacat thought, was answer enough.

She really didn’t like the thing.

*****

Light Hope’s training was surprisingly - and suspiciously - similar to the training used by the Horde: Lots of bots to be defeated. Light Hope’s bots were magical, though, not mechanical. That probably saved on maintenance, Seacat thought as she took a seat on a smashed bug the size of the bug princess and watched Adora.

Her friend was having fun smashing bug after bug. It was an impressive display, too. But… Seacat shook her head. That wasn’t a topic to be discussed in Light Hope’s base. Dungeon, she corrected herself with a smirk.

And watching Adora go all-out was nice as well. Her friend looked very impressive as She-Ra. She probably could smash the bugs without her sword, too. So much power…

A movement to the side drew Seacat’s attention, and she reacted without thinking, jumping off the broken bug a moment before another bug crashed into it. “Hey! Watch it! I’m not She-Ra!”

But the bug didn’t react - it turned its head towards Seacat, and clicked its mandibles. Then it charged at her.

“Hey!” Seacat snarled as she dodged the charge. “She-Ra’s that way!” This was Adora’s training session, not hers.

But the bug turned around, ignoring Adora to focus on Seacat. Well, if the damn thing insisted, Seacat would oblige her, as the Captain called it.

Then she noticed more bugs coming towards her. Encircling her.

Damn!

“Hey, Adora! Some help!” she yelled as she backed away from the first bug.

“What?”

“Those bugs are after me!” Seacat added a curse as the closest took a swipe at her, and she had to duck under the blow. If only she had her old cutlass… Well, you fought with the weapons you had, not the weapons you wished you had.

She drew her blade and parried the next blow - but the force behind it sent her back a few steps.

“No parrying, got it,” she told herself, then somersaulted over a charging bug and slashed at its back. Its armoured back, which her blade didn’t damage much if at all. Great.

“I’m coming!” Adora yelled. “Just a… oh, no!”

That didn’t sound good. Seacat risked a glance as she ducked under another swipe - Adora was getting swarmed herself. “Light Hope! Stop the session!” Adora called out.

No answer. Damn and damn!

Seacat rolled over the floor, away from the two closest bugs, but her new shirt caught on the debris left by Adora earlier, and instead of gracefully coming up in a crouch, she was suddenly in a dead-stop on the floor. Looking up at a pouncing bug.

Cursing, she rolled to the side, tearing her shirt, as the pincers barely missed. Scrambling away on all fours, she darted towards Adora, but two more bugs blocked her way.

"Light Hope, stop the session!"

Seacat scoffed as she glanced around. Two bugs in front of her. Two behind her. Fanning out. If those were bots… She faked a lunge at the bugs in front, then fell back - and a glance told her that the other two were charging her.

Perfect. She dashed towards the two in front of her, waited a moment, then jumped up and to the side, landing on all fours while the bugs crashed into each other behind her. "Hah!"

She moved in, slashing at the flailing limbs, but her cutlass was standard Horde issue - almost worthless against a well-armoured enemy. And the bugs were already recovering!

This wasn't good. She glanced over her shoulder and gasped. Adora had vanished under a mound of twitching bugs!

"No!" She froze for a moment - what could she do? Then cursed and sprinted towards her friend. She couldn't do nothing!

But before she reached Adora, the mound of bugs suddenly exploded, bugs and parts of bugs flying in all directions - one almost squashing her like a… well… bug if she hadn't dodged.

And Adora stood there, glowing brightly, sword raised above her head and a pissed-off expression on her face.

She looked… Seacat shook her head after freezing for a moment. They were in the middle of a battle. And there were half a dozen bugs after her!

She quickly dashed towards her friend, jumping over a twitching bug, and landed next to Adora. "Hey, Adora! There's more behind me."

Her friend didn't reply. Adora merely turned, lowered her sword, and charged the remaining bugs.

Her sword had no trouble cutting through their armour, of course. Seacat frowned - she really needed a better cutlass. Perhaps the smith in Seaworthy had a good one in stock. Otherwise, she would have to ask Mermista; the Salinean Royal Armoury contained several excellent blades.

"Ngh…" Adora snarled before kicking the last bug into a pillar hard enough to break both. "Light Hope! End training session! Now!"

A moment later, the room lit up, and they could see the broken bugs - bots - starting to vanish one by one. Like Magic.

Seacat clenched her teeth together. "What was that?" she asked, scowling. "Why did the bugs attack me? This was supposed to be a training session for Adora!"

"And why didn't you stop the session when I asked you to?"

"I don't have any memory of the incident." Light Hope's voice rang out from the ceiling. "It must have been a malfunction of the security system. This area is restricted to She-Ra, and your friend might have been mistaken for an intruder."

Yeah, right. That was totally convincing - not! "Really? A malfunction?" Seacat scoffed. And memory loss? How convenient!

"How could that happen?" Adora asked.

"My data banks and systems are damaged," Light Hope replied in that annoyingly calm voice of hers. "It has been a thousand years since I was last maintained."

"Please ensure that it doesn't happen again," Adora said.

"I cannot guarantee this. The best way to avoid a similar incident is to refrain from bringing others with you."

Ah, that was her game! Seacat scowled. The damn bot wanted Adora alone with her! She blinked. That sounded a little… whatever. She shook her head. "Well, I'll say we leave now before another 'malfunction' happens," she said, staring at Adora.

"Uh... good idea," her friend replied, though looking like she wasn't sure about it.

"That would mean leaving your training session unfinished. This will hamper your efficiency as She-Ra," Light Hope objected.

"Bah! She can smash bugs perfectly well already," Seacat said. "It won't hurt to cut that one short." It wasn't as if the Horde employed such bugs. "Let's go, Adora."

For a moment, her friend looked torn. Then she nodded, her jaw set. "Yes, let's go."

Seacat smiled, then, behind Adora's back, stuck out her tongue at the ceiling.

*****

"'Malfunction' my ass!" Seacat spat as soon as they had left the clearing in which the entrance to Light Hope's bunker was hidden.

"What?"

"That wasn't a malfunction," she explained to her friend. "That was an attempt to get me!"

"What?" Adora repeated herself, gasping this time. "Light Hope wouldn't do that!"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Really? A mysterious bot that is supposedly a thousand years old wouldn't do that?"

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "She taught me so much about being She-Ra - she wouldn't do such a thing."

Her friend's logic hadn't improved, Seacat realised. Well, what else could've been expected, with Shadow Weaver training her? "It was a very convenient malfunction, wasn't it? Light Hope doesn't like me, and suddenly, her bugs attack me."

Adora gaped at her. "She wouldn't try to kill you! And why wouldn't she like you? You're my best friend!"

"Exactly!" Seacat replied.

Her friend frowned. "What do you mean?"

"She's jealous, duh." Seacat scoffed.

"Jealous? But… She's a teacher, not..." Adora shook her head. "You're wrong."

"I didn't mean jealous in *that* sense," Seacat said, rolling her eyes. "But she wants you to be alone with her."

"Well… she's there to train and help She-Ra…"

"So? Is there a rule that says She-Ra can't have friends?"

"Not exactly, but…"

Seacat cut her off. "She wants you alone, so no one can contradict her. Sound familiar?"

Adora blinked, looking confused, then frowned as she worked it out. And scowled deeply at Seacat. "Light Hope isn't like Shadow Weaver! She's helping me!"

"So she says," Seacat retorted. "But she doesn't want anyone to know what she's teaching you."

"She never told me to keep my training secret!" Adora shook her head. "She's been nothing but helpful. You're wrong - not every teacher is like… her."

Seacat scowled at her. “She tried to get me killed in an accident. Looks very similar to me.”

“That was an accident!”

“So she says.” Seacat didn’t believe the damn bot. And Adora really needed to wise up. “I don’t believe her.”

They stared at each other for a moment. Then Adora sighed. “Let’s return to Bright Moon.”

“Yes.”

They didn’t talk on the way back.

*****

“Ah, there you are!”

Seacat didn’t cringe, not really, upon hearing the Captain’s voice. But she didn’ turn around and kept staring down at Bright Moon from where she was sitting on the tallest tower’s roof.

That didn’t stop Sea Hawk, of course. She heard him approach, then saw him sit down next to her on the edge of the roof. “Great view,” he said. Apparently, the planning meeting had ended already.

She made a noncommittal noise.

“I looked at the pier first, then the taverns,” he went on. “Then I was told to look on the roofs.”

By Adora. She clenched her teeth. Stupid Adora.

“She seemed a little… off.”

Seacat sighed. Unless the Horde decided to invade right this moment, she wouldn’t get out of this. “We had a disagreement about her choice of mentor.”

“Oh?”

“She’s listening to some stupid broken bot who tried to get me killed in an ‘accident’!” Seacat snapped, turning her head to glare at him. “And she’s falling for its lies!”

“Ah.” Sea Hawk nodded. “And you’re absolutely sure that it wasn’t an accident?”

“Yes!” She spat, then sighed again. “Mostly. I’ve got a gut feeling.” Light Hope might be broken, but she was still too smooth.

“Ah.”

She rolled her eyes at his tone. “It’s a good gut feeling.”

“Well, I’ve always trusted my gut - it told me to pursue my dear Mermista, and that was the best thing that ever happened to me - but… Are you sure it’s your gut feeling, and not… Catra’s?”

She pressed her lips together and glared at him. He met her eyes with a smile. A far too understanding smile for her mood.

“If you’d have met the bot you’d think the same,” she said.

But she couldn’t help wondering, now, if this was Catra’s doing and feeling.

Damn.

*****

The New Engine

“You’re leaving?” Adora sounded surprised. Perhaps even shocked. ”Today?”

“Sea Hawk secured passage on a river barge leaving today,” Seacat told her. It wasn’t much of a ship, but it would take them to the sea. They could take a real ship there.

“You could get another, though - a little later! You could spend more time here.” Adora’s smile looked rather forced.

Seacat shook her head. “We need to get back to Seaworthy, and then to Salineas. The Horde’s going to recover soon from their defeat unless we keep up the pressure.”

“But… we’re also going to do that in Bright Moon. We’re already stepping up the raids through the Whispering Woods, and Perfuma’s about to advance as well in Plumeria.” Adora nodded. “We’ll be fighting the Horde on this front, too. And we would be very glad to have you with us.” She suddenly frowned. “This isn’t about Light Hope, is it?”

Seacat suppressed a wince. “No,” she lied. “I’m a sailor - I belong on a ship. I can do much more on the sea.” They hadn’t talked about the stupid bot since yesterday. They hadn’t talked much at all, actually, since yesterday.

“Oh. I thought...”

Seacat clenched her teeth - Adora looked crushed. “Sorry,” she said.

“It’s OK.”

Seacat almost snorted. Adora still couldn’t lie worth a damn. Perhaps if she asked the Captain… No! She needed to get back on a ship. Back on the sea. She wasn’t needed here. And if she stayed, she’d just have another dispute with Adora over the damn

bot. And that would… She shook her head. Maybe she was seeing things. Maybe this was Catra messing things up, seeing Shadow Weaver everywhere. And she wasn't Catra any more. She was Seacat - the best first mate on all the seas! She belonged on the seas, not in the woods. Or in dungeons ran by bots.

She took a deep breath and nodded. "So…"

"Uh… so…" Adora grimaced.

Both fell silent. Seacat sighed. "It's not as if we'll never see each other again."

"Yes. We'll have meetings and stuff..."

But they would be separated. For quite some time - She-Ra was crucial for the war, after all, but she'd be on land. And Sea Hawk and Seacat would be roaming the seas and coastlines. Seacat knew that. And so did Adora.

"So…" Seacat bit her lower lip - almost piercing it with her fangs. It hurt. But it kept her from blurting out some stupid comment that would only hurt Adora. Or Seacat.

"So…"

This time, she snorted. After a moment, so did Adora. Then she tried to crush Seacat's chest again. Seacat didn't complain, though - not when she felt her friend heave and heard her sniffle. And, maybe, caught some wind in her eyes herself that made them leak a little.

*****

Sitting on the railing and watching the landscape move past as the river barge slowly, oh so slowly, made her way downriver towards the sea, Seacat sighed. She was on a ship again, but she didn't feel any better. The barge barely qualified as a ship, anyway - even a small storm would sink it on the open sea. Far too slow, too. It didn't smell right, either. Neither did the river. And you

weren't supposed to be so close to the shore, anyway - far too easy to run aground.

She leaned back and grabbed the railing with one hand, then let her leg swing down until her toes touched the water. Then she sighed again. There wasn't even a decent mast to climb. Not that she wanted to climb up a mast anyway - she'd be able to see Bright Moon from up there, and that would...

"Missing the sea? Or missing Adora?"

She narrowed her eyes before she turned her head to look at Sea Hawk.

He was, as expected, not impressed and stepped up to the railing himself, leaning against it and making a point of looking at the light woods lining the river bank.

"I'm fine," she spat.

"Really?" He raised his eyebrows at her.

She scoffed in return. "We're needed on the coast - and in Salineas."

"So, you're missing Adora."

"I'm fine," she repeated herself.

"It's perfectly natural to miss her - we did leave rather shortly after we arrived."

Seacat pressed her lips together. She didn't want a lecture about… whatever the Captain meant.

"But it's not the end of things. You'll meet again. Some distance can also be a boon - absence makes the heart grow fonder, as the saying goes. Why, it was just like that for my dear Mermista and me - without our frequent separations, who knows if we would have become the couple we are today?" He beamed at her.

She stared at him. Was he implying what she thought he was implying? "It's not the same!" she spat through clenched teeth. Sea Hawk and Mermista had had an affair. Seacat and Adora hadn't even kissed. Hell, she didn't even know if Adora liked her!

"I think that was obvious," the Captain said.

Apparently, she had said that last part out loud. "Well, I don't think it's obvious!" she replied. Her friend hadn't changed that much, after all, and they hadn't had anything like a relationship - the kind of relationship that wasn't friendship - back in the Horde. Even if Catra might have had some ideas.

And the Captain didn't have to look so surprised!

*****

Seaworthy hadn't changed since Seacat had - unwillingly - left it, except that it was busier than it had been in a long time. Ships of all kinds filled the harbour - she could see four Salinean frigates among them - and the piers were almost overflowing with crates, barrels and bags being moved around.

"Someone's been busy," she commented as the barge steered towards one of the few free piers.

"The Alliance is pushing down the coast," Sea Hawk replied. "That's a lot of supplies being shipped - though I don't see many troops."

"They're probably already fighting." Seacat hoped so, at least - she hadn't been lying when she told Adora that they had to keep attacking while the Horde was reeling from their recent defeats. "But where are they getting so many supplies from?" The Kingdom of Snows wasn't exactly farmland, though they had dried fish aplenty - but fish wasn't shipped in bags or crates, but barrels.

"The Kingdom of Plumeria, mostly, or so I was told by Queen Angella." The Captain grinned. "It seems that Princess Perfuma's

powers allow for near-instant growth of any plant - including food."

"Oh." Seacat blinked. That was a very powerful, well, power. And it meant that the alliance could field and supply a lot of troops, but… "The other kingdoms won't be happy to be undercut and outproduced like that."

"I don't think Princess Perfuma will keep this up after the war - it must be tiresome."

Seacat snorted. The knowledge that the Plant Princess could do this - could undercut any other realm with her produce - would be enough to make other realms wary of her. If the Alliance dissolved after the Horde's defeat, Plumeria would need a strong ally or two to keep from becoming a target. Hell, she thought, here I go, thinking the war's won already. Nothing would matter if they didn't beat the Horde.

She straightened as the barge was moored at the pier. "Let's find the next ship headed to Salineas." They needed a new ship. As soon as possible.

"Let's find out who's in charge here, first. I might be an Admiral, but Mermista doesn't like it if I ruffle too many feathers among her officers," Sea Hawk told her.

Seacat snorted. Most of the Salinean officers could do with having their feathers ruffled, in her opinion.

*****

"Of course you can board the next courier to Salineas, Captain." Judging by her sneer, Admiral Gham obviously wanted to have them gone as soon as possible.

"It's Admiral," the Captain corrected her with a beaming smile. "Surely you haven't forgotten me - the one and only Sea Hawk! Victor of the Battle of Salineas and the Battle of Seaworthy!"

And now Gham looked like she had eaten an entire barrel of salt. “I don’t think anyone could forget you if they tried.”

“How kind of you! Thank you!” Sea Hawk nodded. “That’s my fellow admiral!”

Seacat noted that Gham was gripping the handle of her sword with enough force to turn her knuckles white. She was tempted to ask about a replacement sword or further rub in the Captain’s rank, but… they really needed to get to Salineas as soon as possible. She’d rather not make Gham mad enough to sabotage them - no matter how stupid doing that to Mermista’s lover would be. Enraged people made mistakes, as she knew very well from fighting pirates and Horde scum. So she cleared her throat and asked: “Which ship is that?”

“The Flying Swallow,” Gham replied with a glare at her.

That was a decent ship. Not quite as fast as the Dragon’s Daughter III and IV had been, but fast enough to qualify as a courier. “Who’s her captain?”

“That would be Captain Leren.”

The name didn’t ring any bells for Seacat, but Sea Hawk perked up. “Leren? He’s finally been promoted? Good for him! I told him that he’d make the list when he was a young ensign!”

“He was promoted after the loss of so many captains under your command,” Gham said.

“Ah, those brave heroes volunteering to risk their lives for Salineas!” Sea Hawk put his hand on his heart. “Their sacrifice won’t ever be forgotten!”

The other Admiral glared at him. Seacat could see her jaw muscles bulge as Gham clenched her teeth. “So, unless there’s anything else,” she quickly said, “we should be off to meet up with Captain Leren - wouldn’t want to miss the ship, after all, would we?”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk agreed. “Have a nice day, my fellow Admiral. I’m needed back on Salineas, with my dear Mermista!” He struck a salute, which Gham half-heartedly returned, glaring at him all the way until they left her office.

Well, it could’ve gone worse. They had a passage, and Gham hadn’t tried to strangle the Captain.

*****

“...and then we boarded their biggest gunboat, shot up their pier, and sailed downriver, destroying their field artillery in a running gunbattle! It was a grand adventure!”

Seacat rolled her eyes at the Captain’s tale. Discreetly - things had happened more or less like he told it, but he was exaggerating. They hadn’t been quite so close to certain death so often. At least not after she had found them in the prison.

Captain Leren, though, nodded with an impressed expression. Almost awed, actually. “Unbelievable! This must have hurt the Horde even more than the defeats on the coast!”

Seacat frowned - that was far too humble for a Salinean officer, in her experience. Even for someone who knew the Captain since they had been a fresh ensign. Of course, Sea Hawk was a great captain - the best on all the seas - but this was a little too much.

“What did you do after that?”

“Blew up the gunboat to cover our escape, stole a pair of skiffs, led the Horde on a wild goose chase and escaped through the mountains - after destroying another base of theirs!” Sea Hawk grinned. “Oh, the shanties I’ll sing of this!”

And Leren beamed. “I’m looking forward to listening to them!”

“You will - it’s what, three more days to Salineas?”

“If the wind keeps, yes,” Leren replied.

“Three more days until I can finally embrace my dear Mermista again!” Sea Hawk sighed with his eyes closed. “How I long for her! But duty is a harsh mistress, keeping us apart!”

And now Leren was frowning. Seacat narrowed her eyes. Was he one of the officers who didn’t like Mermista being with Sea Hawk? But those would usually be more openly hostile - or smarter about it. Or…

Sea Hawk slapped the man on the shoulder. “But I trust in you, and your ship! You’ll see us there swiftly and safely! Not that I’d mind another harrowing adventure, of course!”

“Of course!” And Leren was beaming again. At Sea Hawk.

Oh. That was it. The man didn’t like Sea Hawk being with Mermista because he was jealous - of Mermista!

Seacat shook her head. Whatever had been between the Captain and Leren in the past - and she doubted that there had been anything; the captain was usually not shy about his past affairs - was over now. Mermista was far from perfect - she had a number of faults, actually, of which Seacat was very well aware - and she was a princess, which caused even more issues, but Sea Hawk loved her. Losing her would hurt him deeply.

And Seacat wouldn’t let anyone hurt the Captain. Not now, not ever. No matter their motives.

She just had to figure out how to step in, should Leren make trouble.

*****

“Ah! Salineas! The jewel of the Eastern Sea! Home of my dear Mermista, love of my life! Hold out, my love! I’m coming!” Sea Hawk declared, boot on the railing, pointing at the barely visible Sea Gate ahead of them.

Leren made some choked noise under his breath - Seacat's keen ears picked it up, but no one else noticed. She sighed - the Salinean captain had been pining after Sea Hawk for days. At least he hadn't made a scene, but he really should've accepted that the Captain was spoken for. Firmly spoken for.

But they were finally back in Salineas, which meant Leren would soon find himself sent on another mission - courier ships such as his were in constant demand, after all. Especially after losing so many fast ships in the Battle of Seaworthy. A navy lived and died on fast cutters carrying messages and scouting for enemies.

Now they… She frowned and narrowed her eyes. That was smoke there, on the water. A burning ship? If so, it had just begun to burn - Seacat was very familiar with how quickly ships burned and how they looked ablaze, although usually from a much closer distance. "Hey! Someone might need assistance there!" she said.

"Oh?" Sea Hawk shaded his eyes with his hand and took a look, but that was just for show - he knew her eyes were much better than his.

Leren, on the other hand, pulled out a telescope. "Let me check… Oh. It's the Princess's new ship! That's supposed to burn. I think."

"What? Mermista has a new… Oh. The *other* princess's ship," Seacat said. That was the Hair Princess's ship? The one intended for Sea Hawk and Seacat? The fastest ship on the seas? "Let's take a look!" she said.

Leren frowned. "We're expected to head directly into the harbour…"

"Oh, yes - it's best to observe a ship when she's sailing," Sea Hawk said, still trying to see more than some smoke.

"...but a little detour won't hurt - they might need assistance, anyway," Leren smoothly continued.

"You think so?"

“Well… I was present when the first trials started.” Leren smiled rather weakly. “And they did need assistance then. Often.”

Seacat sighed. If Leren was correct, then not only would they be visible from afar thanks to the smoke, but the ship was apparently prone to stop working - or stop floating.

Great.

But whatever her other faults, the ship’s hull looked good. Seacat could tell from a glance that she was a fast one.

“Good lines,” Sea Hawk agreed.

“Indeed,” Leren commented. Not that Seacat cared what he had to say - she was studying the ship.

And she didn’t like what else she saw. The mast and rigging… they looked as if they were meant for a sailing yacht half the ship’s size. And the pipe sticking up from the afterdeck… smoking like a chimney. She could smell it from a hundred yards away.

“Why is it smoking?” she asked. The Horde frigates didn’t smoke.

“It’s burning wood, I think, to propel the ship,” Leren replied.

“Oh?” Sea Hawk perked up.

Seacat groaned. Of course, the Captain would be interested in that. “If we have to carry wood for burning, then that will cut down on what cargo we can transport.”

“But imagine: A ship driven by fire!” Sea Hawk beamed. “Fire and wind! The shanty practically writes itself!”

But Seacat was imagining something else. Tending to a fire was busy work. Even a small fire needed regular attention and more wood, or it would burn out. If the ship ran on fire, someone would have to keep putting logs into it.

She clenched her teeth. That wasn't what sailing should be like.

"Kleo! Signal them - ask if they require assistance!" Leren yelled.

"Aye aye, sir!"

A sailor stepped up to the railing and started waving flags, which were answered by the other ship. They didn't require assistance.

The Flying Swallow still closed in. Seacat couldn't see the princess among the crew. But she could see the blackened faces on half the sailors waving at them as they sailed past.

That looked worse than she had feared! Soot like that would stick to her fur like… She shuddered. "I don't like the looks of this," she muttered.

"Hm?" Sea Hawk turned to look at her.

"Nothing," she replied.

She wouldn't talk about this with Leren around. That would make her look bad.

*****

"Mermista! My love!" Sea Hawk opened his arms wide and quickly strode forward.

"Admiral Sea Hawk." Mermista, sitting on her throne, nodded slowly at him. "You're back."

"Indeed, I am - and victorious! Twice victorious!"

"So I've heard. Although…"

The Captain wasn't deterred by her cool manner and picked her up in his arms. "I've missed you so much!"

The princess yelped, but she didn't try to hit him. Nor did she actually struggle to escape his embrace, Seacat noted with a

snort.

While the two embraced - and kissed - she looked around. Some of the guards were frowning, others trying to pretend nothing was happening, and a few were smiling.

She scoffed and walked over to a small table with some refreshments, where she poured herself a glass of water while she grabbed a piece of roasted fish.

Sea Hawk set Mermista down but didn't release her. "I've so much to tell you! It was a glorious - albeit bloody - battle! And then Seacat got kidnapped, and we had to push into the very heart of the Horde to save her!" Sea Hawk

Hey! "I was on my way out when you arrived," she corrected the Captain.

"Really?" Mermista raised her eyebrows at her.

"Yes."

Not that that would stop the Captain. "It was a harrowing adventure! We almost missed her, but pulled through - and set half the factories on fire as we fought our way out! Indeed, it was only by the skin of our necks that..."

*****

"...and then we made our way to Bright Moon."

"I see." Mermista nodded, then looked at Seacat.

Seacat looked away and focused on her third toast with roasted fish.

"You've recovered your memory, then."

Seacat winced. "Yes," she pressed through clenched teeth. She'd been a Horde cadet. Horde scum. An idiot looking forward to

attacking a village - the village she had mistaken for her home for four years.

“That must have been a shock.” Mermista sounded… not like herself. Far too soft.

Seacat shrugged. “I managed.” She grabbed another toast. And a glass of ale. “You’re pushing down the coast.”

“We’re in control of the coast, but the Horde is recovering - their troops are digging in,” Mermista said. “Their fleet is still unable to challenge us, but scouts reported that they are rebuilding in their main base.”

“My fellow admiral told us that already,” Sea Hawk said. “What about the planned raids on the fuel sources for the Horde frigates?”

Mermista sighed. “They were not as successful as we hoped. We captured several ships, but the Horde switched to river- and even road-based transport, and we can’t currently reach the production sites.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. “That’s rubbish. We managed to raid their capital!”

They had to destroy that fuel, or they’d lose the battle on the sea.

Sea Hawk nodded. “Indeed! We shall strike at them again!”

“Once you have a new ship,” Mermista commented. “Which could take a little while.”

*****

“So, you see, while the engines the Horde uses are great - not perfect, but quite interesting; I’ve improved the efficiency and made them less bulky, but they’re still basically the same engines from the frigates we captured - the fuel’s a problem. They need special crystals which are, as far as we know, only found in Horde

territory. And running our ships on captured crystals isn't really sustainable, or so I've been told, so I'm looking for alternative fuel sources and alternative engines. I first tried to use the same engine that powers bots, but - well, they, too, depend on those crystals. In fact, I think the Horde scientists - who are quite smart, I have to admit - adapted the engines from the bots' engines, not the other way around. Though the bots' engines are more sophisticated, albeit they are much smaller and provide much less power - which also means the crystals last much longer, which would explain why we didn't notice their dependency on those crystals yet, you know?"

Seacat actually didn't know - she could barely follow the gist of the Hair Princess's words. That the woman's purple hair was currently imitating a Kraken's tentacles and dismantling what looked like a harpoon gun didn't help with her focus either, of course. Nor did the fact that they were standing in what looked like a cavern full of broken bots and wrecks.

But it didn't look like the princess expected an answer - she continued right away: "So, I'm testing a few alternatives. I first tried to adapt a skiff's engine, but that didn't work out. At all. Something about the water and the kind of magic they use. But Mermista managed to refloat the skiff every time it sank, so that's a good thing. Anyway, I then thought of alternative engines, like an engine that runs on wood. We've got lots of trees, and Perfuma can always make more, so that would be a very sustainable alternative." She frowned. "Only, the efficiency is kind of substandard. The energy density of wood is simply not good enough to achieve comparable power ratios as the Horde engines have. Also, I've been told that the ships need to fill their cargo holds with wood to burn for longer voyages, so that probably isn't a good thing, either, though I think it wouldn't affect couriers much, would it? They mostly carry messages, right?"

"They also deliver cargo," Sea Hawk replied, "And passengers."

"Right." The princess nodded, but it sounded dismissive. "Anyway, I'm still working on that - I think I could find a way to increase the

energy density of wood. That would make the engine more efficient without a redesign, you know?"

Seacat nodded, trusting the princess's explanation. At least about this. "And how is that going?"

"Uh…" The hair princess winced. "I'm working on it."

That wasn't good news. "The Horde's working on rebuilding their fleet."

"I know! But science can't be rushed - well, it can, but that tends to end up in explosions. And I'm told that's a bad thing."

"Yes, it is," Seacat said, firmly and quickly, before Sea Hawk might get ideas. "But we need a new ship now." And if the new design wasn't ready, they'd simply take an older design. Without a stinking wood-burning engine.

"I know! And I've had an idea!"

Seacat felt her stomach drop a little.

"Oh?" Sea Hawk, of course, wasn't fazed in the least.

"Yes! I mean, we don't have enough fuel crystals to supply a fleet, which is why I'm looking into alternatives. But for a single fast, small ship?" The princess beamed. "More than enough! And the efficiency would be better too, since the engine wouldn't have to push a frigate."

"So… you installed a frigate's engine in a courier's hull?" Seacat asked. That sounded… less than safe. If you did that with a sail, you'd end up capsized in a light breeze.

"No." The princess shook her head, her hair waving around her. "I installed an *improved* engine in a courier ship!"

Seacat forced herself to smile.

That sounded worse.

“Oh! What a great idea! We’ll have the fastest ship on all the seas - again! And by a great margin! Scurvy will be green with envy!” We’ll be able to sail rings around every other ship! And we’ll be able to raid their transports at impunity!”

Sea Hawk, of course, saw nothing wrong with it - on the contrary.

“Mermista told us that they are using river- and road-based transport for their supplies,” Seacat pointed out.

“So? With a small, fast ship we can sail up any river - we’ll be past a fortress so quickly, they won’t even wake up in time to stop us! And we can land raiding parties!”

She frowned. That might actually work - the raiding parties; not the sailing past artillery emplacements. But… “Just how stable is your improved engine?”

The princess beamed at her. “Very stable! It hardly explodes any more!”

“Excellent!” Sea Hawk beamed back at the princess.

Seacat didn’t. ‘Hardly explodes anymore’ wasn’t what she liked to hear about any ship, least of all one she would be crewing. “I’d prefer it to not explode at all,” she said, struggling not to sneer.

“Oh, that’s the goal!” The princess nodded eagerly. “Otherwise, it would be a little hard on the ship, yes?”

Seacat stared at her. “...yes.”

“But if there’s the option to set the ship to explode on command, that would be great!” Sea Hawk added.

“Oh. Like a self-destruct?”

“Yes, exactly! But with a more powerful explosion that will sink other ships nearby!”

“Oh! You want a bigger explosion?” The princess looked surprised. “No one asked me for that, yet! They always want no explosions - from engines.”

“Yes. Ramming your ship into the enemy flagship and having her explode is a very effective tactic,” Sea Hawk said. “But you need a big explosion for that.”

“Of course!” The princess repeatedly nodded. “I can do that - I can make it so it’ll blow up in the biggest explosion, ever, if I connect the fuel crystals to each other! Oh! I could use the engine to amplify the shockwave…”

The hair tentacles dropped whatever they had been doing and started sketching stuff on a whiteboard.

“All I need is a guided array of crystals, and an amplificator… and a way to seal the pressure chamber until the explosion…” Seacat heard the princess mumble under her breath as she worked.

Sea Hawk rubbed his moustache and nodded, watching her.

“You don’t have any idea what she’s doing, do you?” Seacat hissed next to him.

“I know she’s going to build the greatest ship ever!” he replied.

“She’s going to build the greatest bomb ever,” Seacat retorted. A bomb they would be crewing.

“Exactly! And imagine how we’ll use it!”

She shuddered at the thought. And yet… imagining blowing up the Horde fleet, preferably at anchor in their biggest base… that would be a coup indeed.

Provided they didn't blow up testing the ship. Or sailing it. Or just looking at it. Oh.

"Mermista might not be happy about such a ship being built in her palace," she commented.

Sea Hawk blinked for a moment, then grimaced. "Ah… I think I'll have to break the good news to her gently."

Seacat nodded. "Very gently."

She would stay down here. Next to a maniac working on a ship-sized bomb was still safer than being near Sea Hawk when he told Mermista about this.

*****

Two days later, Sea Hawk was still sleeping in the guest quarters Seacat usually had to herself, but he hadn't been exiled, and Mermista hadn't broken up with him. So, things were going well on that front, at least.

Whether things were going well with their new ship, Seacat couldn't tell - but she would find out soon since the Hair Princess had announced the 'third prototype of the improved bomb engine' ready for testing.

Seacat assumed that the first and second were behind the two explosions that had shaken the palace yesterday. She hoped very, very much that the third wouldn't follow in their footsteps.

"...and this is TD-14, which will steer the ship on her first trial! Wave to the nice people, TD!" the princess in question finished her explanation on the pier.

Seacat tried not to shudder when the bot on the deck of the prototype waved one arm at them. This was… It wasn't a Horde bot, but the parallels couldn't be missed.

"'TD-14'?" Mermista asked.

“It stands for ‘Training Dummy Number Fourteen,” the other princess explained.

“What about Training Dummies one through thirteen?” Seacat asked.

“Oh… they suffered total construction losses during testing.”

Seacat looked at the ship again and tried to figure out if she needed a longer safe distance. “How much fuel does the ship have?”

“Oh, only the amount needed for a short test cruise,” the princess replied. That was reassuring. “It gets a little too tedious, or so I’ve been told, to recover large numbers of crystals from the seabed. Even though Mermista can get them easily by doing her thing.”

And that wasn’t.

“I have more important duties than recovering fuel crystals from the seabed,” Mermista told them in a flat voice.

“Anyway!” the Hair Princess said. “Now let’s start the testing! TD-14, sail away!”

The bot waved again and then operated something near the wheel. A moment later, the ship started to move. Slowly at first, but she was quickly picking up speed.

“I’ve also improved the power of the engine,” the Hair Princess said as she studied the ship through her visor - which, Seacat assumed, included some form of telescope or binoculars. “It’s more compact, but also more powerful than a Horde frigate’s engine!”

“Splendid!” Sea Hawk exclaimed. “Look at that speed!”

Indeed, the ship was now running faster than any ship Seacat had ever seen on the sea. Faster than a skiff, even. So fast, actually, that… “What exactly is the ship’s turning circle?” she asked.

The way the princess blinked was really concerning. “Uh… that depends on the speed. Lemme make a quick calculation…”

But while the princess calculated, Training Dummy Fourteen demonstrated that the turning circle at the ship’s current speed was too big to avoid the mole coming up ahead.

An impressive demonstration of the engine’s explosive power followed.

The bits of stone and wood didn’t quite reach Seacat and the others, but they came a little too close for comfort.

“Oh, no! Poor TD-14!” the Hair Princess commented. “He miscalculated the speed and turning radius.”

“Poor mole,” Mermista replied. “You know how long it’ll take to repair that?” She pointed at the hole blown into the pier. “We’re lucky if we finish before a storm hits the port.

Seacat winced. That would be bad - without the mole sheltering the harbour, ships would be in danger if there was a nasty storm at the wrong moment. Coupled with the tides, it could wreck a lot of ships.

“Sorry,” the other princess said. “I guess we’ll have to test the next model on the open sea. Even though that will make recovering fuel harder.”

Was she expecting the next test ship to sink as well? “I would suggest not testing the explosive forces,” Seacat said as dryly as she could.

“Good idea!” The princess smiled at her. “That will make testing take longer, though.”

“We can spare the time,” Mermista said. “We can’t spare more pieces of my kingdom. Or my people.”

“Oh, right. I keep forgetting you can’t just repair stuff as easily as we do at home.”

“But it was a marvellous explosion! Imagine doing this to a Horde harbour!” Sea Hawk spoke up. “And the speed! If we had ships like this, the Horde wouldn’t have hit any of ours in the Battle of Seaworthy!”

“Sorry,” the Hair Princess replied, frowning and slumping slightly. “But I wasn’t ready then - if I had focused on engines instead of launching the payload…”

“No!” Sea Hawk smiled at her. “You did well - you couldn’t know in advance what would work and what wouldn’t. We’re treading new ground here, after all!”

That perked the princess up. “You’re right! That’s how science works! With trial and error!”

“And explosions?” Seacat asked.

“Exactly! And explosions!”

Seacat really needed to work on her sarcasm,

“Anyway - back to the lab! I need to construct a new ship and a new testing dummy! And a new engine!”

Apparently back in high spirits, the princess took off before anyone else could reply.

Mermista sighed. “And I will need to adjust our budget for repairs.”

Sea Hawk reached out to wrap an arm around her shoulders. She leaned into him for a moment before starting to scowl and pushing off.

“She’s coming around,” Sea Hawk said after Mermista had stalked off.

Seacat nodded in agreement. At least something wasn't blowing up in her face today.

*****

"Alright! This is the Improved Engine Mark 3 Testbed Ship, piloted by TD-16!" the hair princess announced.

Seacat eyed the ship with some suspicion. She did look like a courier ship, just without any mast or rigging. And as her unfortunate predecessor, she was crewed by a single bot. Wait… "TD-16? What happened to TD-15?"

The princess sighed, and the huge bot standing behind her made a weird noise. "TD-15, unfortunately, had a lab accident - the integrated stabilisation system to improve its ability to stay standing during a storm needed additional fine-tuning. But it's fixed now - no more ripping bots apart from the inside!"

Seacat winced.

"I trust that this engine won't explode like a bomb," Mermista stated rather than asked.

"Well, not like a bomb - but due to its nature, it'll still explode if damaged severely enough. Like, say, by a cannonball striking it," the Hair Princess said. "But the explosion won't be amplified, so it'll only destroy the ship itself. Mostly."

And with the ship her crew. It was like transporting a cargo full of powder. Seacat had done that before, but she wasn't looking forward to doing it all the time. Especially not in battle. She knew very well what magazine explosions did to ships.

"That's very good for testing, but I hope the final engine will not be so limited!" Sea Hawk said, smiling at the princess.

Seacat glared at him. So did Mermista, she noticed. The captain hadn't spent last night in the guest quarters, but judging by the princess's expression, that might change again.

They really needed to work out how their relationship was supposed to work.

“Oh, no, of course not - your requirements will be met and potentially exceeded by my design!” the Hair Princess replied.

“Great!”

“Great;” Seacat echoed the Captain, though in a much dryer tone.

“If you blow up anything else in my realm, I’ll have words with you,” Mermista added. The way she clutched her trident, Seacat wasn’t sure she would be limiting herself to actual words.

“Uh… do lab prototypes count? Cause I kind of need to blow them up when testing bombs.” The Hair Princess looked concerned - she was biting her lower lip.

“Unless you blow up something else with it - something that belongs to me or mine - no,” Mermista told her.

“Goodie! Then it’s OK. And now, let’s test the new engine! TD-16, start the test!”

The modified courier ship started to move - and rapidly accelerated. Much faster than a sailing ship would have, outside a storm. It was soon sailing in a wide circle on the open sea, though coming close to the repaired mole, on which they were standing, with every lap.

“You’re doing good, TD-16!” the Princess yelled. “Now start stress testing!”

“Stress testing?” Seacat asked.

“Oh, you know, how tight you can turn, how long the hull can take the vibrations at top speed, how long the engine will hold up when redlined.”

“Redlined?” Seacat asked.

“Pushed past safe limits,” the princess replied. “Look at that!”

Seacat snapped her head back in time to catch the courier ship capsizing, with the bot being thrown off as if launched by a catapult.

The Hair princess didn’t seem to be fazed, though - she made some notes on her ever-present tech thingie, then turned to Mermista. “Uh… could you straighten out the ship before it sinks completely?”

The princess sighed. “I guess I have to, if I want this test to end sometime reasonable, don’t I?”

The Hair Princess nodded in agreement. “Exactly!”

Mermista sighed again, then jumped into the water. She disappeared for a moment, then resurfaced - with a Mermaid’s tail - and swam towards the sinking ship.

Unlike other times, Seacat wasn’t jealous about Mermista’s magic. Not at all. It looked like the princess would be doing this very often.

*****

The Genius

"Oh, Seacat…" Adora bent down, her hands gripping Seacat's, pushing them into the mattress on both sides of her head.

Seacat arched her back, squirming - but the blonde was straddling her, and her hips were trapped between Adora's thighs. She couldn't move. She couldn't escape. But… did she even want to? She squirmed some more, unsure. Not that it mattered - Adora was too strong to be pushed off, and with her hands caught in hers, Seacat couldn't get any leverage anyway. And her tail was caught as well, pinned down beneath one of Adora's knees. Seacat moaned with frustration and with...

"Oh…" Adora grinned, then licked her lips, lowering her head down towards Seacat's. "You like this, don't you?" she whispered, her breath tickling Seacat's sensitive ear. Then their lips met, and...

*****

Seacat woke up with a gasp, taking a few deep breaths. That had been… a weird dream. Very weird. Adora wasn't like that. And Seacat wasn't like that, either. Helpless, trapped like a merchant vessel caught leewards - and liking it?

No! She sat up and noticed that she had been entangled in her bedsheets. That must have been the trigger of her weird dream. And why she was soaked with sweat - she sniffed her arm, then wrinkled her nose.

Kicking the remains of the sheets off - she must have used her claws in her dream - she slid off the bed and walked towards the bathroom. She definitely needed to freshen up before breakfast.

A glance to her right, towards the open door of Sea Hawk's room, confirmed that the Captain had slept elsewhere again. Good. At least something was going well this week.

She entered the bathroom and pulled off her top, dropping it on the floor, followed by her bottoms. She was a little unfair, she knew that - the Hair Princess was working hard and faster than any shipyard thought possible; Seacat had asked around how long new ships usually took to be built. But all the magical speed didn't mean anything if every day, a stress test ended with another sunk 'prototype'. At least none of them had blown up - so far.

Seacat tested the water in the tub - Mermista hadn't repeated her ice water prank in years, and Seacat doubted that the princess would do anything when she was with Sea Hawk, but old habits died hard.

But the water was warm, just like she liked it, and she poured in some shampoo-soap nicked from Mermista's private stash, then climbed in herself. Ah! She sighed and closed her eyes. A little soaking would do her good.

*****

"...and so this is the Mark 8 engine - technically the Mark 9, if you count the Mark 5 that we never tested since it broke before I could install it in the ship. But! It's working five per cent more efficiently than the Mark 7, at the same output. I think we've nailed the limits of this design, though you can always tweak it a little more, and I've got a few ideas to improve the screw by adding..."

"But you could do this with a new test ship, right?" Seacat interrupted the princess. "Fiddle with it while we take this one on a shakedown cruise?" And finally get back into the war! A week was far too long to spend on land when there was a Horde fleet gathering.

"Uh…" The princess frowned. "That would be possible, though I'd need another test ship…"

Mermista sighed, rolling her eyes. "I guess we can scrunch up another courier."

“Oh, nice! Can I have two? I could test double the designs that way!”

“We currently lack enough courier ships,” Mermista told her. In a lower voice, which only Seacat caught, she added: “And I don’t want to recover two ships per day.”

“Oh. Ah, well - I’ll have to make do! TD-21, start the next stress test!”

Seacat watched as the courier ship accelerated in the familiar area outside the mole. She moved a little faster than yesterday, in her opinion. And she had a slightly tighter turning circle. But otherwise, there wasn’t much of a difference. The princess was probably correct.

Which meant it was time to test the ship with an actual crew. Such as herself and the Captain.

Provided she survived today’s testing. Which, given how much she listed in the first curve, wasn’t sure.

“Watch it, TD-21! The capsizing test is scheduled for the end of the run!”

Seacat didn’t hear any reply from the bot, but the princess seemed satisfied - and the ship slowed down a little as she took the next turn.

And she was still faster than any ship Seacat had been on in her life. It might be dangerous and prone to blowing up, but she really wanted to sail that ship. Very much.

*****

“Huzzah! This is incredible! Magnificent!”

Seacat was bound to agree with the Captain. The “Test Ship IV” cut through the waves like a hot knife through butter. They were

going at a speed she hadn’t imagined would be possible before the tests - faster than any skiff.

“Faster than a cannonball!”

Not quite as fast. Fortunately - they would probably not survive it, otherwise. Even so it was a little dicey when Sea Hawk took a sharp turn. Once they had almost capsized - if the timing had been off a little, the waves would have swept over the railing.

She looked up at the bare mast. Any sail would just slow the ship down. And probably rip it apart as it broke the mast.

That didn’t mean they didn’t have a sail, of course - no matter what the Hair Princess thought, neither Sea Hawk nor Seacat would be trusting their new ship to an engine that needed Horde-produced crystals to work. Sails only needed wind.

The ship listed to the side as Sea Hawk took another turn, but he slowed down a little. Seacat gripped the mast and dug her claws into the deck to keep standing. She grinned, though - that felt familiar. Like sailing against a very strong wind. And, very importantly, the crystal engine didn’t stink or smoke. It just needed to be cooled, and seawater worked for that.

She took a deep breath, savouring the smell of the sea. Clean, fresh air - far from the stench of a city or busy harbour.

The ship levelled out as Sea Hawk finished the turn, and Seacat went down into the hold - or to the ‘engine room’, as the princess called it - to check on the engine.

It was humming, as usual. And glowing slightly - that meant they would have to cover up all portholes or the light would give them away in a night raid. But it wasn’t running hot or vibrating too much, both of which were signs that the engine was overloading according to the princess. And the crystal in the engine’s chamber was still half-intact - no need to replace it.

She returned to the deck and called out to the Captain: “Still good - the last crystal’s at half!”

“Great! And we’re going full speed!”

She could tell that by the wind and the sound of the engine. This was a truly great ship. They could literally sail circles around any Horde ship.

Sea Hawk took another turn, whooping with glee. “Come on, First Mate! Take over!”

Seacat gasped and scrambled up the stairs to the afterdeck. She had known she would - after all, she would have to steer the ship as much as the Captain would since they were the only crew - but so soon? In Sea Hawk’s place, she would have kept going for an hour longer!

But she wasn’t complaining. Not at all. She grinned widely as she took the wheel, her eyes widening at the way it pushed against her grip.

“Yes, it takes quite the strength to keep it on course - at least at this speed,” Sea Hawk told her.

She nodded in return, tightly gripping the wheel. She could handle it. She would handle it. It wasn’t worse than when you were tacking in rough seas. Rough seas… “We need to see how she handles in a storm,” she said.

“That’s what the shakedown cruise is for!” he replied. “I think we’ll have rougher weather up the coast.”

Seacat should point out that they would be far from friendly shores on that occasion - not the best place or time to test how your ship fared in rougher weather. But she was enjoying the speed too much to care.

She grinned, revealing her teeth, as she took the first turn, leaning against the list. The power and speed the ship had...

This was great!

*****

“How was it? What do you think? Is it a good ship?” The Hair Princess blurted out as soon as they had moored the ship on the pier. She was bouncing on… well, not her feet, her hair with obvious excitement.

“*She* is the best ship,” Seacat corrected, but she was smiling widely.

“Indeed! We took her through her paces, and she passed every test we could think of - except for the ramming and explosion ones!”

“Which we won’t test,” Seacat growled.

“Quite. But she is truly the fastest ship on all the seas.”

“Oh, yes! Although if you keep going at top speed all the time, you’ll burn through the fuel reserves very quickly. And the vibrations might damage the structural integrity of the hull so much, it might spontaneously fail.” The princess nodded. “I made some charts to show what’s the most efficient speed.” She pulled out a book thicker than most logs.

“Great!” The Captain beamed at her. “This will be very useful. However, one thing needs to be fixed.”

“Oh? What? Is it the insulation? Or has the hull sprung some leaks? It does that sometimes.”

“No, no!” Sea Hawk grinned. “We need to rename the ship properly.”

“Oh.”

Seacat nodded. A ship as fast as her deserved a much better name.

*****

“And we hereby dub you ‘Dragon’s Daughter V!” Sea Hawk declared, smashing a bottle of rum against the ships’ hull. “May you live up to your predecessors’ legacy!”

“I’d rather she didn’t blow up or burn down,” Mermista commented dryly.

Seacat nodded in agreement. Even though she knew that odds were, it would happen sooner or later.

“But that’s the point of the explosion amplification function I incorporated in the engine!” the Hair Princess protested.

“Exactly!” Sea Hawk said. “It would be craven and criminal not to use it should an opportunity present itself to make a crucial difference!”

“Only as long as there’s no other choice,” Seacat added. “We can’t sacrifice such an excellent ship for anything but a decisive blow against the Horde.”

Mermista frowned and grabbed Sea Hawk. “And only if you can safely get away beforehand,” she hissed into his face. “Understood?”

Seacat saw the Captain swallow. “Uh, of course - we’re not suicidal.”

“Could’ve fooled me,” the princess replied. “But you won’t get Seacat killed.”

“Of course not!”

Seacat agreed with that, but this was getting a little too… personal or something. So she cleared her throat. “Speaking of not getting me killed…” She tapped the hilt of the cutlass at her side. “I still need a better blade. This literally won’t cut it.”

The Hair Princess looked confused. “Do you mean it has a dull blade? I found that with sufficient force, even dull blades cut.”

“Err, no, I meant it won’t cut well enough against armoured enemies,” Seacat explained. “I need a better blade - preferably a magic one.” She beamed at Mermista.

The princess sighed. “That’s why you’ve been in the Armoury, right?”

Seacat’s smile deepened. “I’ve picked out two blades that would be adequate.”

“Only adequate?” the other princess cut in. “I could make you a superior blade. I think. Cutting through armour should be easy with the right tools. What exactly are your specifications?”

“Uh…” Seacat didn’t think ‘It should cut really well’ would be enough - that would probably inspire the princess to create a monstrous thing rather than a useful blade.

“Something like this!” Sea Hawk said, drawing and igniting his own blade.

“Oh, a magic sword! I can do those!” The hair tentacles reached out for the Captain’s sword, but he quickly withdrew it, cradling it against his chest.

“I need this!” he exclaimed.

“I would just borrow it.”

“A man parted from his blade is no man at all,” Sea Hawk retorted.

“That’s not about these kinds of swords, and you know it,” Mermista told him with a smirk.

He stared at her for a moment, then grinned back.

Seacat cleared her throat. “Anyway, what about my new cutlass?”

“I’ll see what I can do - do you prefer vibrating blades or heated blades? Or perhaps energy blades?”

“My last sword was an energy blade,” Seacat told her. “I’d like another.” She’d rather not wield a heavy contraption after being used to her own blade for so long - she would have to change her fighting style otherwise, and that wasn’t a good idea, especially not in the middle of a war.

“I can do that!”

The Hair Princess rushed off, followed by three of her bots, and Seacat wondered if she had just made a mistake.

Judging by Mermista’s smirk, she might have, but then again, Mermista might just be happy she wouldn’t have to part with one of her own swords. Even though she only used her trident, anyway.

*****

“So… when do we set sail? I mean, leave,” Seacat asked as she stowed another line in the chests on deck. Not that they would actually set sails until they were out of the harbour - if the wind was favourable.

“Once you have your new sword,” the Captain told her with a smile. “Can’t leave you unarmed when we’re going to war, can we?”

She snorted and raised her hand, showing off her claws. “I’m never unarmed.”

He chuckled, then grew serious. “But you need a good blade. It’s hard to parry a sword with your claws, isn’t it?”

She pouted and patted her cutlass. “I could parry with this.”

The Captain frowned in return. “Are you arguing that we should set sail without waiting for your new sword?”

“If we need to, yes. We’ve already wasted enough time.” It was bad enough that she was former Horde scum- she didn’t want to be responsible for holding up the next offensive. Or, at the very least, delaying the deployment of the Dragon’s Daughter V.

“We didn’t waste time,” he retorted. “We tested the ship until we were sure she could be trusted.” He patted the railing. “And she’s a good ship. Fast and eager.”

“Yes, but we can’t wait another week until the princess builds a blade that won’t explode when it breaks or strikes a rock,” she told him

“But we can wait a few days - we haven’t finished outfitting the ship, anyway.”

That was true. She nodded, and he reached over and squeezed her shoulder. “See? It’s all coming together just as planned!”

Seacat narrowed her eyes - the Captain usually claimed that when they got lucky.

But Sea Hawk smiled and then went to check the charts and logs again.

*****

“And this is the improved energy sword!” the princess announced, holding up a slim cutlass - more like a sabre, actually.

“What can it do?” Seacat asked.

“I’m glad you asked!” the princess replied as if that hadn’t been an obvious question. “Watch!”

She walked over to the corner of her lab filled with broken-down machinery. A bot turned to face her, and, for a moment, Seacat

wondered if she'd use it for a demonstration. But the princess waved the bot to the side before she ignited the sword.

It looked like Sea Hawk's sword, just with a slightly curved blade.

"I tried making a complete energy blade - just growing from the hilt when activated - but it didn't have the cutting power needed," the princess explained. "I just couldn't stabilise the matrix at that thickness - or lack thereof. But I made something better!" She grinned widely. "I made a sword with a monomolecular edge stabilised by the energy sheath!"

"A monomolecular edge?" Seacat had no idea what that was, but it sounded cool.

"Well, not a true theorised monomolecular edge - that would've been impossible, though, technically, every edge has a single molecule at its, uh, edge, but people generally assume a far wider monomolecular area when they talk about the concept. However, the blade is so thin, it comes close enough for most practical purposes. That's why it needs the energy sheath - it would break really easily if you use it without it."

Seacat only caught half of that. "So… I shouldn't use it without the energy part?"

"Exactly!" The princess beamed at her. "Now let me demonstrate how it works!" She took a step towards a thick piece of metal - it looked like the bottom of a frigate's main mast if it were made of metal - and swung the blade.

Seacat whistled as a part of the metal slid off and crashed to the ground. That was impressive - even Sea Hawk's sword would have had trouble cutting it so easily. Her old sword wouldn't have done much at all.

"Now, the blade will have more trouble with dedicated armour, of course - this was just aluminium," the princess explained. "But it'll cut through most body armour we know."

“Most?” The sword looked like it could bisect the bug princess without trying.

“Well… I couldn’t test it against every piece of armour; only the samples I had,” the princess told her. “Some organic compound armour will resist it.”

“Like the bug princess?” Seacat asked.

“Uh… I don’t know her armour’s composition. Sorry. But I don’t think she’d donate part of it for science, anyway.”

Seacat snorted. She would have to test that personally. “What about bots?”

“It should cut bots just fine. I think…” The princess was interrupted by sudden, urgent-sounding beeps coming from the other corner. “Oh, no, Emily! I would never test it on you! And neither would Seacat - she’s a friend!”

Was the princess trying to calm down a Horde bot? A panicking Horde bot? Seacat laughed at the sheer weirdness of it.

“See? She’s laughing. That means she’s friendly.”

Seacat blinked. That wasn’t how things worked. A lot of people laughed before hurting you - or trying to. Mostly pirates and other scum, of course. But this was probably not the time to explain that to a bot who was apparently scared of her. A former Horde bot. Just like… She scoffed. “No, I’m not going to hurt your bots, but I’d like to test the sword myself against some targets.”

“Oh, we have those! Let’s set up some targets!”

Another bot started putting up metal targets vaguely people-shaped while the princess kept talking. “First, I got targets from the training yards, but they broke too easily and were quite difficult to repair - and the straw got everywhere! So I made my own. Aren’t they cute?”

“Uh, yes, they are,” Seacat said. As cute as metal statues of Horde soldiers could be, at least. Not that she cared, anyway.

“So… here’s the blade. That’s the button to activate the energy sheath. I wanted to hide it so only you could use it, but that would’ve made it awkward to use. I found that people find adequate security bothersome, you know?”

Seacat nodded. People were lazy. Then she took the blade. It did feel a little unbalanced in her hand - well, it was still decent enough, better than her current cutlass, actually, but her old sword had been perfectly balanced for her. The princess might be a genius, but she wasn’t a swordsmith. But it would do. And it looked very sharp and very thin. Flimsy, even.

Then she pushed the button, and energy covered the blade. And… “Is it humming?”

“Oh, yes. That’s the effect of the sheath pressing down on the blade to stabilise it. It’s usually not audible, though.”

“I’ve got good ears,” she replied.

“Oh, that would explain it!”

Seacat wasn’t really listening. She sized up the closest target and swung.

And a metal head rolled over the floor. She hadn’t felt any real resistance.

Seacat’s grin widened. She could fight with this. Very well, indeed. “This is great,” she said. “Thank you!”

The princess beamed at her again.

*****

“...and don’t forget, if you want the engine to explode, you need to flip the big red switch to adjust the containment field,” the

princess said. “It’ll need some time to build up, too, so you need to give it a few minutes.”

That wasn’t ideal, in Seacat’s opinion. It would’ve been better, and much safer, relatively - preparing to ram an enemy was never safe - if they could’ve flipped the switch a moment before impact or something. A few minutes meant a lot of shots fired at them.

Seacat suppressed a shudder as she remembered how her last ship had been sunk in the Battle of Seaworthy. Any Horde gunner could get lucky. She considered pointing it out, but… It wasn’t as if there was anything to be done, not now, at least, and the princess had worked very hard for them. Complaining would be… well, petty.

Sea Hawk, of course, had no objections - on the contrary. “Perfect! The Horde will rue the day they decided to challenge us on the seas!”

“They’ve been doing that for a while,” Mermista said.

“Then they’ll rue the day even more!” the Captain declared, raising his fist to the sky. “For we are back to hound and hurt them!”

Seacat nodded in agreement - it was past time to get back into the war. The Horde was getting cocky enough after rebuilding their forces.

Mermista, though, rolled her eyes. “Whatever.” But then she took a step closer and stared into Sea Hawk’s eyes. “Don’t you dare to blow yourself up, you hear?”

He smiled in return and hugged her, making her squeak in surprise. “No worry, my love! Thanks to Entrapta’s superb work, we’ll be far too fast for the sluggish Horde ships to catch us!”

The princess beamed again. “Yes! You should be as safe as possible since the ship’s too fast for the Horde firing solutions according to my calculations. Although there’s always the chance

that they manage to hit you by mistake, I guess," she added with a frown. "That would be bad."

"Yes," Seacat told her with a smile. "But we'll be careful. And we'll be raiding more crystals for you."

She found herself wrapped in the woman's hair. "Oh, thank you! That would be great! And tell me everything about the ship and sword's performance, yes?"

Seacat wriggled a little, but the hair didn't let her go. Well, she could endure that - Adora hugged way harder, especially in her sleep. "Of course."

"Thank you!"

The princess acted as if this was unusual and not common sense, Seacat noted as she was released.

Sea Hawk and Mermista were just pulling apart as well, both staring at each other. "Don't get killed," the princess said.

"Never!" Sea Hawk put his hand on his chest. "I shall return victorious to you!"

Mermista nodded, rather curtly, then turned to look at Seacat.

She knew that look and what it meant. "We'll do our best," she told the princess.

"You better."

Seacat nodded, though she knew as well as Mermista did that, sometimes, things didn't go your way no matter what you did. Every sailor knew that there was always a risk you'd stay at sea.

Not that she would be foolish enough to tempt fate and mention it, of course.

“Then let’s go! Next stop: Seaworthy!” Sea Hawk announced as he jumped from the pier to the deck of the Dragon’s Daughter V. “Adventure awaits!”

Seacat snorted and followed him, landing lightly next to the mast, then went belowdecks to start the engine.

When she returned to the deck, they were already pulling away from the pier. Mermista was watching them with crossed arms and a stern expression, but Entrapta was waving at them with arms and hair.

Seacat waved back, then moved to the bow to serve as lookout until they had left the harbour.

This was another change caused by the engine - larger ships wouldn’t have to wait for the tides anymore, or have some rowers tug them out to sea when there was no or no favourable wind. Hell, even a single boat with such an engine could probably tow a squadron of frigates out of a harbour in the same time it would take a single of them to leave the old way.

Another advantage the Horde frigates had. They really needed to take the crystals needed for the engines away from the Horde, or their frigates would take control of the seas - the shock from their defeat in the Battle of Seaworthy wouldn’t last long.

*****

Seacat pulled on the line, adjusting the mainsail some more. The Dragon’s Daughter V leaned a little more to the side as the sail caught a little more of the wind. Before testing Entrapta’s engine, she would’ve considered her going decently fast. Not as fast as the Dragon’s Daughter IV or III would’ve been going in the same wind, but fast enough for a courier ship.

But compared to the speed they could make with the engine going full-out, it was slow. And they weren’t even tacking against the wind.

It didn’t help that the ship wasn’t the best sailing ship. It was good enough, of course - it was a former Salinean Courier, and Mermista’s people did build the best ships. Fast lines and a solid design. Much better than anything the Horde put out. But when the engine wasn’t running, it was a heavy weight, and the water intakes did add some drag in either case. Probably some additional wear and strain on the hull, too.

“That’s as fast as she will go, Captain,” she reported as she climbed the stairs to the afterdeck.

“So I see,” Sea Hawk replied. “It’s a decent pace, I guess.” He laughed. “And it feels slow! Who would’ve thought things would change like that?”

“Not me,” Seacat told him. She was just a sailor. “But we need this.” She gestured towards the deck. If the Horde were the only one with engines, they’d win the war on the seas - and then the war on land.

“Indeed - and it was very fortunate that Princess Entrapta joined the Alliance in time to construct this marvel of science!”

“And that she came to Salineas and started building ships,” Seacat added.

“Oh, I think that was assured as soon as she heard of the Horde frigates,” the Captain said. “I doubt that she could’ve resisted the lure of a new field of inventions like that.”

That was probably true, Seacat had to admit. But the princess could’ve stuck to Seaworthy, or some other port, building small boats that kept sinking or blowing up. Without the Salinean yards’ experience, she wouldn’t have been able to create a ship like the Dragon’s Daughter V in such a short time. She nodded in agreement.

“But still - we could cut through the waves much faster, should we start up the engine;” Sea Hawk said. “We might be missing a crucial battle.”

“We still have no source of crystals for the engine,” she pointed out. Apart from raiding the Horde supply lines - which wasn’t exactly easy. “So we can’t waste them like this.” Not if there wasn’t an emergency.

“Another reason to deprive the Horde of fuel crystals!” Sea Hawk raised his fist in the air. “We need them for our own ships! And we shall take them!”

“As long as we’ve got a decent plan,” she replied.

“Oh, don’t worry! I’ve got the perfect plan in mind!”

She narrowed her eyes at him. “You don’t mean sneaking up a river and raiding barges, do you?”

His frown told her enough even before he replied: “It’s a good plan - with this ship, we can sail past the blocking forts at night and outpace any pursuit. And we can both fill our hold and tow barges with us.”

“Past forts that are now on alert? And with skiffs patrolling the riverbanks?” This didn’t sound like a good idea.

“We’ll sacrifice the barges, if needed, to shield us from artillery.” The Captain grinned. “With this ship, we can outrun their cannons easily. They’ll get off one, two volleys. Three, at most.”

“They only need to hit once,” she pointed out. “And if they hit the engine…”

“It won’t blow up without the amplifier switched on,” Sea Hawk said. “Entrapta was quite clear about that.”

“It won’t blow up like a giant bomb, but it’ll still blow up,” she corrected him. “We saw that during testing, didn’t we?”

“That was an earlier model; this ship’s engine is far more advanced.” he shook his head. “Don’t underestimate the Dragon’s Daughter V! She’s a fighter!”

“We can’t underestimate the Horde, either,” Seacat retorted. “And what if the blockade the river? Or block it?”

Sea Hawk blinked, then smiled. “That’s where the land forces come in.”

“Land forces?”

“Of course! For such an important mission, we’ll have to work with our allies and strike from the sea and from the land! We can carry a landing force to take the forts while the Horde soldiers focus on us.”

She narrowed her eyes further. “You just thought of that, didn’t you?”

“Would I do that?”

“In a heartbeat.”

“I’ll have you know that refining a few details of a plan is the hallmark of a successful strategist.” He struck a pose, one fist on his chest.

“Adding a landing operation isn’t a small detail,” Seacat told him, hands on her hips.

“Details, details… important is that we’ll succeed!”

*****

“Seaworthy! We’ve made good time!” Sea Hawk announced as they approached the port.

Seacat nodded. They could’ve been faster, of course. Either by using the engine or if the ship had been a proper sailing ship and rigged for it. But as expected, the engine was weighing them down when it wasn’t running. And the hull was already leaking a little more than was usual for such a ship - all the testing must

have weakened it, and the intakes for the engine didn't help either.

"We'll sail in so the Horde spies won't be tipped off about our new ship's true capability," the Captain told her.

"Aye aye, Captain," she replied. They hadn't been too discreet in Salineas - you couldn't really hide such 'destructive tests' or 'stress tests', as Entrapta called it, anyway, not if you wanted to conduct them in parts where the sea was shallow enough for Mermista to recover the wreckage and fuel crystals. But a spy would take time to get anything from Salineas to the Horde. There was no trade between the kingdom and the Horde territory, and the Salinean ships were patrolling aggressively to avoid another invasion surprising them, so any spy would have to first sail to another location and then find a way to the Horde. Which would slow them down long enough for the Dragon's Daughter V to surprise the Horde.

Seaworthy, on the other hand, was much better for Horde spies. All they had to do was get out of the port, and they could hook up with Horde scouts. The Alliance ran patrols, but catching a single scout - or even a skiff - was hard. Seacat knew that from experience. Just as she knew there were traitors taking Horde coin in the port. And cowards not stepping up when the traitors attacked others.

Scowling at the memory, she started adjusting the sail as Sea Hawk changed course to enter the port. At least the wind was fair, so they wouldn't have to manoeuvre too much - or, worse, row the ship in.

But they were back in the war and would soon hit the Horde again. Harder than before. She grinned, showing her fangs, at the thought and looked at the port. Three Salinean frigates, four - five - transport ships from the Kingdom of Snow, a dozen independent merchants, three couriers - or smugglers… busy as usual.

“No battle damage,” Sea Hawk commented as they passed the Salinean frigates moored inside the harbour.

“I hope they haven’t sat on their asses while we were in Salineas,” Seacat said, scowling again.

“I doubt my fellow Admiral would have let them,” Sea Hawk told her. “I think she would have pushed her fleet hard to impress my dear Mermista.”

That would fit the woman, Seacat had to admit. Gham was probably more likely to seek battle even when it wasn’t a good idea than to pull back and hide.

Which meant, she added as she took a closer look at the next frigate, that the Horde hadn’t taken to the seas. “The Horde must be preparing something,” she said. “They had enough time to repair and resume operations. And they need to contest our control of the seas to defend the coast.”

“Exactly. And I don’t believe the current raids have caused a shortage of fuel crystals bad enough to present further operations.” Sea Hawk nodded. “They’re preparing something. Either they are just gathering every ship they can for another pitched battle, or they’re planning something more devious.” He stroked his moustache and grinned. “Either way, we will beat them and foil their plans!”

Seacat nodded. They had to.

*****

“My fellow Admiral! I bring news from Salineas!” Sea Hawk greeted Gham with exaggerated cordiality - Seacat could tell easily.

The scowl from the admiral showed that she either saw through Sea Hawk’s act or just loathed him anyway. “You have a dispatch for me?”

“Indeed. In addition to the usual missives, I also have orders for you directly from Princess Mermista - my dear Mermista - herself!” He reached into his shirt and pulled out a sealed envelope. “Here!”

Gham glared at him and took the envelope with a look of loathing. She sliced it open, then quickly read the orders inside.

Seacat used the opportunity to put the package with the rest of the mail on the admiral’s desk and step back again. She felt safer with her hands free - in Seaworthy or in Gham’s office.

Her keen ears didn’t miss the slight gasp of the woman when she reached the critical passage. “I’m to support you,” she spat through clenched teeth.

“To your best ability,” Sea Hawk added, nodding. “This is truly a crucial mission - should we fail, we might yet lose control of the seas. Both my dear Mermista and Princess Entrapta are fully behind this!”

“Behind this folly?” Gham scoffed. “A landing operation behind the enemy lines? With a single courier ship? That’s suicidal! Even worse than your forlorn charge against the Horde’s line of battle!”

“A successful charge, I have to point out - which also was agreed upon by Princess Mermista.”

“A charge that cost us most of our courier ships!”

“That all the ships taking part were at risk was known in advance as well. All of the crews were volunteers,” Sea Hawk retorted. “Very brave. Of course, I would never ask anything of the men and women under my command that I wouldn’t risk myself - and I lost my ship as well. The Dragon’s Daughter IV, sunk by the Horde flagship even after I crippled her!”

“You got another ship already,” Gham replied. “And you knew you would get a new ship.”

“As did all other survivors, I believe.” Sea Hawk smiled. “Princess Mermista knows how to reward her sailors.”

Gham scowled. “I won’t support another suicidal and wasteful plan! There’s no need for it - the Horde scum hasn’t dared to take to the sea in weeks against our ships! We have them all but blockaded in their ports!”

Seacat snorted. “They’re preparing something. Something big. Which is why we need to strike now - and cut off their fuel supply.”

Gham glared at her, but Seacat met her eyes with a smile. She wasn’t some cowed Salinean sailor trembling before an admiral - she was Seacat, best First Mate on all the seas. And not in Gham’s chain of command.

She waited until Gham turned to face the big map of the local sea behind her desk to stick out her tongue at the admiral’s back, though.

“Look at this!” Gham slapped the middle of the map. “We control the entire coast! And we need every courier to screen our forces and scout for the enemy! Now you want to take not just a perfectly fine courier, but also our best marines, behind the enemy lines?”

“Before they finish rearming and rebuilding their forces, yes.” Sea Hawk shrugged. “If it makes you feel better, assume we’re scouting the enemy? And, as before: volunteers only, of course.”

It didn’t make the Admiral feel better, Seacat could tell. But orders were orders.

This mission wouldn’t be delayed.

*****

The Storm

"Let me be honest with you: Our mission is crucial for the Alliance - decisive, even! - but it's also very, very dangerous," Sea Hawk announced, standing on his seat with one boot on the table, facing the two dozen marines, soldiers and sailors gathered in the repurposed dining hall. "You will be braving deadly dangers and facing the best of the Horde should you decide to volunteer for this! A mission reserved for the bravest of the brave!"

Seacat looked the men and women over. None of them looked afraid - but then, after such a speech, who would dare to show fear? In front of the other volunteers?

"I know you've all volunteered for a dangerous mission without knowing more than it would put you into peril, but I'll have to say it again: Only join me if you are willing to lay down your life for the Alliance!" Sea Hawk went on. "You can serve the Alliance perfectly well on the frontlines otherwise!"

One burly goatman scoffed. "Are you trying to scare us away? If so, it's not working!"

A few more chuckled. Two female 'privateers' Seacat was sure were actually pirates, at best former pirates, both decked out with many blades, one minotaur with a battleaxe slung over his shoulder that looked like it could cut through a frigate's mainmast, and a lizardwoman that matched the minotaur in height and bulk and had a huge harpoon in her hands.

The Salinean marines didn't laugh. They didn't look afraid, either, of course - but they were standing apart from the others.

The rest of their group was made up of three soldiers in Bright Moon armour and four from the Kingdom of Snows - Seacat didn't think anyone else would be wearing furred armour in Seaworthy. But they were at least familiar with the sea; Seacat didn't know if

the Bright Mooners could be trusted not to spend the trip bent over the railing puking their guts out.

"If I thought you were easily scared you wouldn't be here," Sea Hawk retorted. He flashed his teeth. "But I'm serious - you all know how many of my crews returned from the Battle of Seaworthy. This will be as dangerous."

That reached some of the cocky scoundrels. But with the marines not budging at all, only nodding with grim expressions, none of them backed out either. The goatman hit his chest. "I've been on raids before."

Sea Hawk waited a moment, looking at everyone else, then nodded. "Splendid! Then let's board our ship - you'll be briefed once we're underway."

That was her cue. Seacat cleared her throat and took a step forward, placing herself at the Captain's side. "Alright you lot - follow me to the Dragon's Daughter V. I'll get you sorted out there." She showed her fangs. "I'm the first mate, Seacat."

Once more, the marines merely nodded, as did the other soldiers, but the lizardwoman sniffed. "I've heard of you. You were Horde scum, weren't you?"

Seacat stared at her. How dare that bastard… She forced herself to grin. "I was raised in the Fright Zone. And I've spent the last four years fighting the Horde."

But the other woman didn't want to back down. "I don't trust Horde scum."

Seacat clenched her fist, barely managing to avoid digging her claws into the palms of her hands. A number of the others were eyeing her with guarded expressions as well. "So you don't trust She-Ra, huh?"

"What?"

“We were in the same cadet squad in the Fright Zone. Bunk mates,” Seacat told the idiot. She took a step forward, keeping eye contact with her. “That makes her Horde scum, doesn’t it? So, she can’t be trusted, right?”

“She’s She-Ra,” the lizardwoman said.

“And I’m Seacat.” She took a few more steps until she was right in the woman’s face. The other scoundrels moved away, giving them space.

The lizardwoman held her gaze, her jaw set. Perhaps Seacat would have to beat her down to make her point. One less scoundrel wouldn’t endanger the mission. Might even help impress on the rest not to mess with her.

But then the lizardwoman looked away. “Feh!”

Seacat scoffed and deliberately turned her back to the woman. “Enough of that. We’ve got a mission. Everyone follow me to the harbour!”

Most of the scoundrels agreed, the two ‘privateers’ chuckling as they glanced at the lizardwoman. The woman glared at them, gripping her harpoon harder.

Seacat sighed silently. The woman obviously was trouble. She knew the type.

*****

As expected, Svetana, which was the lizardwoman’s name, not that Seacat cared, complained as soon as they were on the Dragon’s Daughter V. “What do you mean, we can’t go belowdecks?”

“I meant exactly what I said,” Seacat told the woman. “You can’t go belowdecks without my or the Captain’s permission. Which you haven’t, in case you’re confused about that.” She tilted her head.

“Are we supposed to sleep on deck?”

Seacat wasn’t the only one to stare at the lizardwoman. Any sailor would rather sleep on deck, in the fresh air, than belowdecks in a stick cabin - at least in these waters, where it was warm. And it would only get warmer as they sailed south.

“Are you daft?” one of the ‘former’ pirates, Alcy, told her. “You want to sleep in the hold?”

Her friend Licy - and Seacat bet those weren’t their real names - snorted. “Of course she is, starting trouble on *Sea Hawk’s* ship.”

The way the scoundrel said that made Seacat think she and her friend might be trouble, too - if of a different sort. Some of the sailors and pirates hadn’t gotten the message yet that Sea Hawk was taken.

Whatever, she’d tackle one problem at a time. “You’re not allowed belowdecks,” she repeated herself. “Sergeant Bry.”

The tallest woman of the Salinean marines raised her head. “Yes?”

If Seacat had been a member of the Salinean Navy like Sea Hawk, she would have taken offence at the lack of respect, but since she wasn’t, she’d let it slide - as long as the woman did what was expected of her. “Ensure that no one except for the Admiral or I go belowdecks. We’ve got delicate cargo.”

“Delicate cargo? On a raid?” Svetana narrowed her eyes at Seacat.

“Yes.” Seacat flashed her fangs in a tooth grin at the troublemaker. “And that’s all you need to know.”

The other woman growled but slowly nodded, then went to the railing. “Whatever.”

Seacat shook her head and wondered if they could get rid of the woman on the way.

“Where’s the Admiral, anyway?” Licy asked.

“He’s got a meeting with Admiral Gham regarding the mission,” Seacat told her. It wasn’t a secret - half the port would know it before the Captain was back on the Dragon’s Daughter V.

“Ah.” The woman looked around on deck, where the two dozen volunteers were now spreading out. “The ship’s riding high in the water for a full cargo hold.”

Of course a pirate would notice that right away. “Yes,” Seacat replied, showing her fangs again.

For a moment, Licy pouted. Then she grinned and went to join her friend.

Seacat suppressed a sigh. Passengers often were the worst cargo. You couldn’t even fight them if they were too annoying. Not usually, at least.

*****

“Alright!” Sea Hawk announced as soon as he stepped on deck. “Prepare to sail!”

“Aye aye, Captain!” Seacat replied, heading to the mast. “Cast off!” she yelled at the Minotaur standing closest to the bow mooring lines. The brute looked confused. “Pull the line in!” she clarified - the closest dockworker had already untied it.

He finally got the idea and reeled the line in. Licy was doing the same aft. The wind wasn’t ideal - they would have to tack once to leave the harbour, Seacat knew - but it was good enough. A tugboat with an engine would be really handy, actually. No need to use a Horde engine, either - a tugboat could stock up on wood anytime and wouldn’t need to carry cargo…

But then they were underway, and she was busy adjusting the sails - and keeping an eye on Svetana and the other scoundrels - until they were past the mole.

Sea Hawk turned south at once. That was a surprise, actually. Frowning slightly, Seacat tied the line down and then joined the captain on the afterdeck. "I expected to sail towards Salineas until we were out of sight of the harbour," she commented in a low voice.

"Oh, but any Horde spy would expect that. By turning south directly after clearing the harbour, they'll suspect this is a ruse!" Sea Hawk replied with a grin.

Seacat frowned. That might be overestimating the intelligence of a Horde Spy. On the other hand, the Horde would be expecting operations in the south anyway. Especially with… She looked around - no volunteer was close enough to overhear them. "What about the landing force?"

"They'll be boarding a transport in a smaller village to the south before meeting us at the Dolphin Cape," Sea Hawk told her.

"Ah." That made sense - any force large enough to take a Horde port would have sent the spies in Seaworthy flying. And there weren't that many targets for such a force.

*****

The Dolphin Cape didn't look like a dolphin nor did dolphin's live there. It was named after the explorer who had first found the closest route around it - through the reefs dotting the sea nearby. Seacat remembered Sea Hawk telling her the story when they first sailed through, years ago. And she remembered telling the same story to others on their first visit to the cape.

"...and that's why it's named Dolphin Cape," 'Alcy' finished telling the story - or *a story* about it - to the soldiers from Bright Moon.

"Ah." Their leader nodded.

"That's also why dolphins are called dolphins," the scoundrel went on. "They were discovered here first, but migrated afterwards."

The snickering from the rest of the experienced marines and assorted scourges of the sea clued the Bright Mooner in that this was about as close to the truth as his kingdom was to the sea. He didn't make a fuss, though, but chuckled - having been stationed in Seaworthy must have made him get used to sailors' tales.

Or shanties, Seacat added with a glance to the Captain who was at the wheel. The other scoundrel, 'Licy', had been encouraging Sea Hawk to sing at every opportunity. It was a transparent attempt to get closer to him, and the Captain should've told her off already.

But this was Sea Hawk's business… he wouldn't cheat on Mermista, anyway. On the other hand, if rumours about an affair went around… She clenched her teeth. She knew this would be trouble.

And speaking - or thinking - of trouble… Seacat looked at the bow, where the lizardwoman was standing, watching the sea. The other troublemaker. She hadn't tried to get into the hold for a while now, but Seacat was sure she hadn't abandoned the idea. But was that because she was simply too curious to let things lie, or because she was a spy? Or was she simply a pirate looking for loot? Did she think they were transporting a war chest to pay the Alliance forces fighting on the coast?

Seacat looked at the rest of the scoundrels. If that rumour started going around, it would be very bad. How many of the cutthroats would be tempted to go after such a price? At least half of them, in Seacat's opinion. Perhaps all of them.

Perhaps they should let the lizardwoman catch a glimpse of the empty hold to prevent this...No, that wouldn't work. The woman would only assume the rear cargo was hidden somewhere else. And once she found the engine… Hell, if she realised how valuable the crystals were, things would be even worse.

No, they couldn't let her do this. All they could do was to watch the troublemaker - and drop her overboard as soon as she tried

something.

Seacat was looking forward to it.

*****

“Ship ahead!” the scoundrel - ‘Alcy’ - on lookout duty yelled. Seacat quickly scrambled up the mast to check herself with a telescope.

“Kingdom of Snows cog!” she yelled to the Captain. “Looks like the ‘Ice Spear’!” That was the transport ship they were supposed to meet.

“A transport?” The woman’s eyes lit up. Definitely a pirate, Seacat thought.

“One of ours,” she told her. “We’re going to escort it.”

Not quite a lie.

“Us? Escort a transport?” The scoundrel scoffed. “How? We don’t have guns!” With narrowed eyes, she added: “Unless you’ve got a secret weapon in the hold.”

“We will serve as a guide and scout for them,” Seacat told her. “With the Horde ships still blockaded, we won’t have to deal with any hostile ships.” At least nothing like frigates - the chances of the Horde to slip a frigate past the Salinean patrols was nil. And the Dragon’s Daughter V could deal with smaller ships - the Horde sailors would be no match for the marines and scoundrels on the ship.

She slid down the mast, jumping the last few yards and landed lightly on her feet.

“Ah, they made it!” Sea Hawk announced. “Great!”

“So, it’s not going to be a raid but a landing operation!” the Salinean Sergeant spoke up.

“A combination of both, actually,” Sea Hawk retorted. “We’ll need to take a fortress to conduct a proper raid.

“What?” That was the lizardwoman. “You… you’re going to raid a river!”

Sea Hawk, despite knowing about Seacat’s misgivings, nodded with a smile. “Indeed! Not only will we raid their supply barges, but we’ll block them from the sea!”

The soldiers cheered. The scoundrels were probably calculating their cuts from such a raid. Or the sack of a fortress-town.

“So, that’s why the hold is off-limits - you’ve got some secret weapon down there!” The lizardwoman grinned.

Seacat didn’t know if that was worse than the rumour that they had a chest full of gold in the hold. But, she reminded herself as she looked at the sky, which was darkening, it might just have become moot anyway. If a storm was brewing…

*****

At least they knew now that the Dragon’s Daughter V was handling well in rough seas. Seacat snorted at the stray thought as she pulled on a stubborn line to secure the scrap of sail they were still flying. Anything bigger would’ve been torn to shreds by the wind battering the ship, and she was giving the remaining sail fifty/fifty odds of surviving the storm that had developed in a few hours.

It was already bad - rain was pouring down, soaking her, and the waves were tall enough to capsize the ship, should they hit it from the side. She had a feeling it was going to become worse, though.

After finally tying down the line, she made her way across the heaving deck to the Captain, claws digging into slick, wet wood to keep her from sliding into the railing - or even going overboard. “All’s tied down, Captain!” she yelled over the roaring winds.

“Good, First Mate!” Sea Hawk yelled back. He was soaked to the bone, just as Seacat was. At least it was rainwater, not seawater - she wouldn’t have salt crusts in her fur tomorrow.

Provided they managed to keep the Dragon’s Daughter V afloat through the storm. “How’s she holding up?” Seacat asked, gripping the railing with both hands to steady herself as they crested another wave.

“Leaking, but the pumps are being worked!”

That wasn’t anything new. Seacat held her breath as the ship started to plunge down the wave. “We’ll have to ride it out!”

Not as if they had a choice. They had lost sight of the transport hours ago, though in this storm, even the larger ship might have serious trouble. It depended on their crew - and the sailors of the Kingdom of Snows were a mixed breed. Some of them were amongst the best you could find while others were worse than Horde scum pressed into service.

She shook her head - she had to focus on surviving this storm. Not on wondering about how others fared.

Another tall wave, taller than the rest. She gritted her teeth as they rose higher than before, and plunged deeper afterwards. This time, the mast creaked ominously, and Sea Hawk grunted as he struggled with the wheel to keep the bow pointed at the waves.

She reached out to help him, but he shook his head. “Start the engine and lower all the sails!”

She’d expected that - the winds were too strong even for the scraps still flying from the mast, but they needed some sort of propulsion to steer the ship. “Aye aye, Captain!”

She stuck to the railing, making her way to the hold hand over hand. If she lost her grip, she would be thrown overboard and…

She hissed at the wind and the waves. She wouldn’t lose her grip. She wouldn’t lose. She was Seacat!

On the main deck, she grabbed the line leading to the hold, resisting the urge to run. Slow and steady. One hand always on the line. As Sea Hawk had taught her.

She reached the hold and ripped the trapdoor open with one hand, then slid inside. Rain doused the stairs before she closed the trapdoor again.

Down below, the marines and scoundrels were looking at her with scared expressions. Even the ones manning the pumps. “Keep pumping!” she yelled. If they stopped, the ship would sink. Another plunge surprised her, but she managed to keep her grip on the stair’s railing and avoid getting thrown into the hold - unlike the lizardwoman, she noticed, who slid all the way down to smack into the hull.

The marines were still in front of the door to the engine room. Good. That would keep the rest out. She dashed over to them, gripping a hanging line to steady herself just in time to ride out another wave. As soon as the ship was steady - if you could call it - again - she rushed inside.

There were puddles of water on the floor, but Entrapta had assured her that water wouldn’t damage the engine - and the drains were working. Probably. As long as the pumps were kept working.

She approached the engine, then slid back as the ship took another plunge, crashing into the hull next to the door with a curse despite her claws leaving deep gouges in the deck. Damn - this hadn’t been a straight plunge! They needed the engine to start!

Clenching her teeth and cursing the damned storm every way she knew, she scrambled forward on all fours, claws ripping into the wood, until she reached the engine. There was the activation

switch, as Entrapta had called it. She flipped it, then checked the crystal feeder as the engine started to come alive. The crystal started glowing as the engine started running.

Good. She rode out another plunge by gripping the engine, banging her thigh against a coolant pipe, before moving back to the door - she was needed on deck.

*****

When the sky finally cleared up, just in time to see the sun rising, Seacat almost collapsed against the railing to which she had tied herself. That had been one of the worst storms she had ever lived through. Not as bad as the storm during her third trip to the Kingdom of Snows, which had been a nightmare of ice, hail and water that froze on her fur, but it had matched it in sheer power and rage.

She hurt as well - she had been smashed into the deck and against the railing far too often while riding out the storm. But, as a quick check showed, nothing seemed to be broken. Just far too many painful bruises. And her fur was covered in salt crusts and itched like crazy.

Nothing she couldn’t handle.

She glanced up. The mast had held, which was a miracle - but even the small scraps of sail they’ve had running had been ripped off by the wind. She’d gotten the engine up and running just in time.

“Whew! This was a little more harrowing than I would have preferred.”

Even Sea Hawk sounded subdued. Then again, he didn’t look any better than Seacat felt. He had tied himself to the wheel, and she could see the bruises on his chest through the torn remains of his shirt.

“A little?” She scoffed.

“Oh, we made it, didn’t we?” His familiar grin appeared, teeth gleaming. “This will be a story to tell many times.” Then his smile faded. “But I fear that the storm will have claimed more than a few ships, and while our own has come through, she suffered from the experience.”

Seacat nodded as she tried to untie the line securing her to the railing, then gave up and slashed the knot with her claws. The ship had been battered. The mast was still standing, but the rigging had been torn. The railing had been damaged as well in some spots. And… She looked down at the sea and cursed. “We’re lower in the water than before.” Either the pumps had failed, or the water had been too much for them. “I’ll check the hold.”

Sea Hawk, struggling to untie himself, nodded. She saw him grab his sword before she opened the hold.

Then she winced. She had been thrown around on deck, but it had been as bad - or worse - belowdecks. Most of the marines and scoundrels looked hurt. But the sergeant was still blocking the door to the engine room, and the minotaur was manning the pumps. One of them, at least. The two former pirates were struggling with the other, barely managing to work it. And everyone was staring at her with exhausted, even haunted expressions.

“The storm’s over!” she yelled, forcing herself to smile. “We’ve made it.”

A ragged cheer mixed with painful groans answered her. She looked around. The lizardwoman looked like she was just waking up - had she slept through the storm? Or collapsed from exhaustion?

It didn’t matter right now. “Keep the pumps going!” she yelled. “And get the wounded up on deck so we can look you over.”

“We’ve sprung at least two leaks,” the minotaur told her. “I can’t keep up with just one pump for much longer.”

"Noted," she replied. They'd have to fix that. At least enough to reach the coast so they could do proper repairs.

It wouldn't do to have the ship sink now after the storm was over.

*****

"Land ahead!"

Seacat breathed a sigh of relief. She hadn't been sure that the repairs would hold - they had done their best to plug the leaks and shore up the hull, but there was only so much you could do at sea. They really needed to get the Dragon's Daughter on a beach somewhere and repair the hull properly. Before the pumps gave out - or the people manning them collapsed.

The minotaur was already dead to the world - he had worked himself into exhaustion. The goatman had taken over but was struggling. And the second pump… well, the lizardwoman was keeping it going, but Seacat hadn't had the impression that she was giving her all.

Which was the reason Seacat had kept an eye on the woman for the last few hours - and had the marines guard the engine room despite the situation on deck, where all the wounded were resting. It was really too bad that the lizardwoman hadn't worked herself into exhaustion in time for making landfall. That would've been very convenient.

Well, she'd just have to help with beaching the ship, which should be enough to exhaust her - Seacat wouldn't let her slack off in any case.

She suppressed a yawn. She should've slept a little longer than a few hours. Probably. But with the ship in constant danger of sinking, and so many of their passengers unable to pitch in - the Bright Moon soldiers all had broken bones, and Seacat still couldn't understand how they hadn't managed to secure themselves in time - she had been needed.

And she was still needed. The Captain hadn't slept any longer than Seacat, after all.

Beaching the ship would be a bitch, indeed.

*****

As it turned out a few hours later, beaching the ship was far easier than Seacat had assumed. Sea Hawk simply had her push the engine to max power and drove the Dragon's Daughter V straight up the beach. Only the aft was left in the water, and shallow water at that - the screw was turning in the air.

Of course that meant getting it back into the sea would be a bitch. Seacat snorted as she jumped down onto the still cold sand, landing in a crouch, and looked around.

They were in a small inlet of sorts - a sandy beach flanked by reefs and rocks, with a forest bordering the beach. Unless someone was sailing straight past the mouth of the inlet, they wouldn't spot the ship from the sea. But anyone could be hiding in the forest.

"Sergeant, take your men for a sweep of the area!" Sea Hawk had come to the same conclusion, of course.

"Aye aye, sir! Come on, you lot! We've got work to do!"

The marines climbed down the hull with the help of a rope ladder and trotted off towards the forest's edge. Sea Hawk swung down on a line and landed next to Seacat, then turned to look the hull over.

There were two spots where the planks had been caved in, which they already knew about, but now, out of the water, Seacat could see that the hull had more if smaller holes and spots where the planks looked slightly loose.

"We should've expected that," she muttered. All the stress testing wasn't good for any ship.

“It’s the storm’s fault. She was fine before that.” Sea Hawk shook his head. “It doesn’t matter - we will rebuild her! Better than ever!” He looked up at the ship’s main deck and yelled: “Everyone who can, come on down - we’ve got work to do!”

“Everyone?” she whispered.

“I’ve left a guard in the hold,” he told her, flashing a grin.

Good. She nodded, then stepped forward to face the scoundrels climbing down on to the beach. They needed to hurry - there was a war going on. And the storm would have hit the Salinean ships on station for blockade and patrol duty much worse than the Horde ships pinned down in their ports. The alliance ships would’ve been blown off-course. Some might’ve even been lost altogether.

Seacat frowned as she started giving orders to the ragged group of people. She could only hope that the transport hadn’t sunk - it had been full of soldiers.

*****

“We found no sign of any enemy troops - or anyone else - in the woods,” the sergeant reported an hour later.

“Good,” Sea Hawk replied. “Now go rest with your men; you’ve earned it.”

The burly woman nodded. “In the hold.”

“Exactly, my good fellow!”

Seacat nodded as well - everyone had realised what was in the guarded room, especially with the screw visible, but the exact details of the engine were still a secret, and it would stay a secret. She glanced at the lizardwoman, yawning. They had her digging sand, but now that they knew the forest was safe, they could send her to do some lumbering; you would need seasoned wood for repairs, which was why they had planks with them, but fresh

logs would be perfect for propping the ship up while they prepared to float it.

As long as someone kept an eye on her. She suppressed another yawn.

“Seacat, I think you should take a rest as well,” Sea Hawk said.

Damn. He had noticed. “I can’t,” she told him, nodding at the ship. The repairs were still going on.

“If you don’t take a nap now, you’ll collapse,” he retorted. “And so will I.”

She glared at him. That was unfair!. “You can take a nap now, then!”

“I’m the Captain; I rest after my crew. That’s the sacred code we live by!”

“I’ve got the feeling that the sacred code of the sea gets frequent additions,” she said, narrowing her eyes at him.

“It’s a pragmatic code,” he replied with a smile Growing more serious, he added: “You really need sleep. You’re driving yourself ragged. That’s an order.”

She growled through clenched teeth. “Aye aye, sir!” she snapped. “I’ll sleep in front of the engine room.” That way, she would at least be a little useful.

And she wouldn’t be easy prey for the lizardwoman.

*****

“Svetana’s gone?” That wasn’t what Seacat wanted to hear right after she was woken up from a nap that had been far longer than agreed according to the position of the sun in the sky.

“Yes.” Sea Hawk yawned. “She was lumbering and stepped deeper into the forest - and didn’t come out.” He nodded at a Brightmoon soldier with a splinted arm. “Tevos tracked her, but returned when it was obvious she was heading straight inland.”

“Damn. She must have been a spy!” Seacat cursed.

The Captain nodded as he yawned again. “As we suspected. Perhaps we should’ve locked her up, but without any proof...” He shook his head. “That’s Horde style, not us.”

“But why would she run now?” The Marine Sergeant was shaking her head as well. “There’s no port nearby, and the enemy front is a day’s worth of walking south of us.”

Seacat scoffed. “She probably knew we were onto her and used the opportunity to escape.”

“Or the front’s not as far,” Sea Hawk said, blinking a few times.

Hell. If there were Horde troops in the area… “Go get some rest, Captain. We’ll do our best to complete the repairs as quickly as possible.”

“Alright. You’re in command, First Mate!”

He didn’t argue, she noted with a frown. And she’d been all ready to throw his own words back at him.

Damn.

But things weren’t beyond hope. The spy had been in Seaworthy for a while - she couldn’t know the latest troop movements of the Horde. She was probably just trying to escape to the Horde. That would take her a day - more than enough time to finish the repairs and sail away.

Seacat blinked. Unless… “We need to check the ship for sabotage,” she hissed. “And the lumber she cut.”

*****

While Sea Hawk finally took a nap, she did exactly that. And as she had feared - the struts the lizardwoman had brought in were useless - cut in some places so they'd break as soon as the ship's weight rested on them. "We need more lumber," she said. That would throw off their timetable. The Horde still wouldn't reach them, not even if they sent a force on skiffs - but it would be closer than Seacat liked.

"I'll get my men on it," the sergeant replied, nodding sharply.

Seacat nodded in return, then climbed up to the deck. She had to check the rest of the ship for more sabotage. The mast and rigging looked OK - not that there had been much of an opportunity to sabotage either - but the rigging was still torn from the storm.

She climbed down into the hold, wrinkling her nose at the smell of puke. She hadn't noticed that earlier. Perhaps she had been a little too tired. But then, what else had she missed?

The hull was fine - they had checked it after the lizardwoman had been sent away to lumber. That left the engine and steering.

The engine was OK. Seacat ran it through all tests Entrapta had taught them, and it worked. As did the steering - the cables connecting the wheel to the rudder were fine.

She sighed with relief. If they had been stranded here…

She was about to return to the main deck, wrinkling her nose at the smell of vomit again. Landlubbers just couldn't handle rougher seas without getting sick.

She paused, blinking. They had kept an eye on the spy. Kept her from the engine room and other sensitive parts. But the lizardwoman had spent the voyage and the storm in the hold. Where they stored their water and food.

Damn. She rushed over to the barrels with their fresh water, opening the first. She scooped up some water and sniffed it. There was something… she licked it, then spit on the floor. There was something in the water. Faint, but she could taste it - if only because they had just left Seaworthy and the water hadn't taken on an aftertaste yet. If the lizardwoman had waited a little longer… Seacat snorted. The storm might have saved them all, actually.

But they still need to replace the water. Which meant they needed a source of fresh water - and they needed to clean the barrels. Thoroughly.

That would take time. Quite a bit. Maybe enough for the Horde troops to reach them.

Damn.

They could sail without water - but they would have to get fresh water from somewhere within a few days, at most. That would delay the whole mission - and give the Horde enough time to react and fortify the target.

Unless… No, The sky was clear. No chance of rain. She shook her head as she climbed out of the hold. Half a day ago, she'd been worried the ship would sink in a storm, and now she'd be ecstatic if it were raining so they could catch the water.

And she would have to wake up the Captain. Damn.

*****

"There's a small spring, but it's half an hour into the woods," the Bright Mooner told her. "And the stream it feeds doesn't lead anywhere near here."

"Great." Seacat shook her head. Poisoned water. And now the only source of fresh water was half an hour away in the middle of the forest - transporting enough water for a sea voyage would be a

pain. She looked at the people washing the barrels in the sea and sighed. “No way around it. We need that water.”

“Indeed,” Sea Hawk said, stifling a yawn. “Without water we cannot continue our mission. We have to send a party to gather water.”

“And how do we transport it?” the soldier asked. “Lugging the empty barrels around is bad enough, but full?”

Seacat looked at the minotaur, who was busy digging into the sand so they could float the ship back out as soon as the repairs were done. He could probably carry a full barrel by himself. As for the rest… four per barrel, if they could rig a pack frame or something. The Salinean marines could do it. A dozen people - three casks, a fourth with the minotaur. That would see them through for a while.

At least the repairs were progressing nicely - in a pinch, they would be able to sail away and rush back up north. They should be able to reach the frontlines before dying from thirst.

Yells and screams made her whirl. Someone had fallen from the deck! She rushed over and found the goatman on the ground, groaning. The scoundrel probably had spent too much time in the sun without a head covering.

The goatman rolled over and vomited on the beach. And among the bile on the sound was blood as well. Seacat hissed. The lizardwoman must have poisoned the water earlier than they had assumed!

“Is anyone else feeling ill?” she yelled?

One of the Salineans raised his hand. He looked queasy - and clammy. And one of the soldiers from the Kingdom of Snows did so as well. His comrades didn’t look healthy either - if that wasn’t just the southern heat...

Damn.

“It seems the spy was more effective than we assumed.” Sea Hawk looked grim.

Seacat nodded. As did the sergeant. With people starting to get sick, work would slow down. And they would have to send out the water party now - they needed fresh water urgently.

“Make sure that no one who drank water within the last twelve hours is coming with you,” Sea Hawk told the sergeant. “You can’t afford to carry the wounded as well as the water.”

“Aye aye, sir,” the Salinean replied. “But that will cut down on our number.”

“There’s no way around it,” Sea Hawk told her.

Seacat clenched her teeth. If she ever caught that spy…

But first, she had to focus on ensuring that this wasn’t the end of their voyage. No matter what.

*****

The Beach

Seacat frowned, watching the group of soldiers and sailors disappear in the forest. With half their number - and their strongest people - sent to collect water, and half of the remaining people being sick, the repairs slowed to a crawl. It was a good thing that the hull was already mostly fixed - but they still needed to move a lot of sand to float the ship and get it back into the sea. And they needed lumber to prop the ship up until the water filled the channel dug around it. The damn spy's sabotage had hit them twice there: Poisoning the men and sabotaging the lumber.

"Go with the lumbering party," Sea Hawk told her. He suppressed another yawn. "I'll oversee the repairs here."

"You need to take another nap," she replied in a low voice - it wouldn't do to let the remaining people see them bicker. Morale was down already.

"I can nap once we're at sea. Now it's all hands on deck," he retorted. Then he blinked. "In the sand, actually, but you know what I mean."

She did. And he was, unfortunately, right. "We need you at the helm. Don't overdo it," she hissed.

He smiled in return. "We need that lumber."

Clenching her teeth, she walked over to the group digging the channel. The two female pirates, or former pirates, as they claimed, looked healthy, but they weren't the strongest. The two remaining soldiers from the Kingdom of Snows looked strong, but they kept glancing towards the tent they had put up for the poisoned crew, where the other half of their group was groaning and suffering.

It couldn't be helped. She pointed at the two men. "I need you two. Lumbering party."

Once more, one of them glanced at their friends. Seacat suppressed the urge to snap at them. "We need to get the ship back into the water. If we're still stuck here when the Horde arrives, your friends are doomed."

"Are we supposed to dig alone?" Licy complained.

"Until we've got enough lumber, yes. Keep digging as if your life depends on it. It does." She flashed her fangs at them,

The pirates snorted at her feeble joke but kept shovelling sand. Good.

She turned to the others. "Alright, lose the coats and come with me."

"We'll get sunburned without our coats!"

"Not in the forest. But you'll collapse in the heat." It was early afternoon, after all - and the heat wouldn't go down until the evening. "Come on!"

She led them to the edge of the forest. "The spy cut down the best trees already, so we'll have to go further in," she explained. "Don't try to move the logs - we'll cut them into lumber in place. Easier to move."

"We're just three people," one of the men complained.

"Once the water party is back, we'll be more," she replied. "Now start cutting down trees!"

She drew her sword as she approached the first not overly crooked tree. Trying to cut through the trunk with one swing would risk wrecking the sword. It could cut through the trunk, she knew that, but with all the weight on top… She'd rather not risk it. But if she angled the blows and whittled the trunk down… Not quite as fast, but fast enough. Or so she hoped.

She swung her cutlass, carving a slice out of the trunk. And another. And another. Until the tree started to topple.

"Watch out!" she yelled as the tree fell, crushing a small bush underneath it. Good. She started on cutting it into lumber. Rough, uneven lumber - but they didn't need precise planks to prop up the ship. Just enough logs and planks.

She wiped sweat from her face. This would be hot and tiring work. But if she could keep the pace up, they could do this.

"Ugh."

"Mirko! Not you too!"

Seacat closed her eyes.

Damn it to hell!

She looked around - one of the men was leaning against a tree with his eyes closed. "Did you drink from the water?" she snapped.

"No, no. I haven't drunk any water since the storm started."

Seacat sighed. "Great. Go soak your head in the sea. It might help cool you down." She glared at the other. "You! Keep cutting. And if you feel like you're about to collapse, tell me."

Really, if this continued, she'd have to do everything by herself!

And she was feeling pretty parched as well. That water party better hurry back - she doubted that the others would last much longer without water.

She should've asked Entrapta for something that turned salt water into fresh water and taken a sword from Mermista's vaults.

*****

An hour later, she was just cutting up another trunk, she finally heard cursing from further into the forest. Familiar cursing - that was the Marine sergeant. They were bringing water!

Smiling, she finished cutting the log into struts, then looked towards in the direction of the cursing. Soon, she could spot movement in the underbrush. Then the minotaur appeared, carrying an entire barrel on his back. A dozen soldiers in three groups of four followed, struggling with three barrels.

She waved. “Hey!”

The minotaur grunted in reply and seemed to pick up his pace - then almost stumbled and dropped the barrel. He managed to catch it, but it was clear he was exhausted.

“Go help him!” she told the Kingdom of Snows soldier. “Your friend needs water.”

So did Seacat - her mouth felt parched, and she had been sweating too much, but the others needed it more urgently. As Sea Hawk had taught her: A captain never drank before his sailors had their fill. She wasn’t a captain, but the principle applied to first mates as well.

She approached the sergeant while the soldiers and the minotaur dropped to the ground for a - hopefully short - rest. “Any trouble?”

The woman scoffed. “Moving through the forest with a heavy load is much more difficult than we expected.”

“Told you,” the minotaur said, chest heaving as he lay there, all limbs stretched out.

“We do what we’re ordered to,” the sergeant retorted before turning back to Seacat. “We’ll take another hour to reach the ship, I reckon.”

Seacat nodded. “Yes.” That fit in with her experience transporting the logs. And since they were behind with the logs, they couldn’t send the party back to fetch more water - not without risking the Horde catching them. “I expect you’ll be reassigned to transporting the lumber,” she told her.

The tall woman snorted. “The reward for one job done is another.” In a lower voice, she added: “We’ll be on water rations, though - this is only half of what we need.”

“I know,” Seacat replied in a whisper. “But we can’t risk waiting too long. If the Horde arrives with half our crew in the forest…” That would be a massacre. Tired, exhausted sailors and marines, caught in the forest, spread out, against a Horde force who knew what they were facing thanks to that damned spy? Who probably would lead them straight through the forest?

Those weren’t good odds at all.

“Then I guess we better speed up,” the sergeant said. She took a deep breath, then bellowed: “Alright you sorry lot! Up and away with you - we have water to deliver to our comrades!”

“If they’re still alive,” one soldier grumbled.

“Dead or alive, we’ll deliver the water!” The sergeant growled at the soldier. “That goes for you, too - I don’t care if you kill yourself; you’ll carry this load to the ship! Understood?”

“Aye aye, sir!”

The marines got up, groaning and with obvious difficulty, but they gripped the pack frames and started walking. The minotaur took the lead again, stumbling but moving forward.

Seacat watched them go. And wished she had taken a drink herself.

Sighing - sometimes, the sacred code of the sea really sucked - she started cutting up the next log.

*****

Two hours later, Seacat was *really* regretting not having drunk some water. What was taking the marines so long? There were lots of struts to transport back now - and it was already late in the afternoon.

She wiped more sweat from her face and tried not to gag at the smell. Fur and the tropics didn't agree. Well, not when you had to do heavy labour. But that wasn't a problem - the problem was that time was running out. They had to prop up the ship, then finish digging the channel and flood it. If the spy managed to find a Horde advance force today, they would be here in the morning.

"Where are the lazy bastards?" the first Kingdom of Snows complained, again.

"Shut up and swing your axe," she snapped. "They're coming." The Captain would ensure that. "And when they arrive, we'll be done with our work here."

"Great. Then we can kill ourselves carrying the wood back."

She hissed. The idiot should *shut up*. A leap over the staple of logs took her right in his face. "What was that?" she asked, fangs bared.

He recoiled, stumbling back two steps - and tripped over a root, falling down. His friend pretended not to notice either of them.

She scoffed. "Don't complain - work! Or do you want to fight off a Horde force on the beach?"

He breathed heavily as he stared at her. For a moment, it looked like he would keep complaining. But then he looked away and got up. Slowly and trembling.

She scoffed and turned back to her work. Damn, she really needed water - her whole throat hurt from the little exchange.

*****

When Seacat reached the ship, she dropped the struts she had carried and went to the barrel near the tents without bothering to report to the Captain or even check the state of the Dragon's Daughter V. All she wanted, all she cared about was water.

She grabbed the cup and started drinking. Stopping after two cups took far more than she had expected, but she managed. She really should've taken a drink instead of talking to the sergeant. Or after talking to her. And sod the 'Captains don't drink or eat before the crew's had their fill' rule!

But with her throat not hurting so much anymore, she turned to check the tents. The sick lingering there seemed to be still alive, but they hadn't really improved, either.

And the ship was pretty much patched up - all that was left now was to finish digging the channel and float her back into the sea.

"We've got some work left, but we'll manage before nightfall."

She turned to the Captain, who had managed to sneak up on her. He looked… well, not exhausted, but he was still tired. She could tell. He certainly looked better than she felt.

"You need to rest," he went on.

Rest? Now, with the work almost done? She looked at him.

He smiled at her. "We have the situation in hand, and you've been lumbering for hours. Rest. After eating."

"I'm telling Mermista," she mumbled. But she grabbed the piece of jerky and the biscuit he handed her and started chewing.

"She would have my hide if I let you work yourself into exhaustion."

She scoffed - a bit late for that - but sat down in the shade of the tent anyway, finishing the food. Just a little nap to recover her strength. Perhaps she could sneak off afterwards, or help with the sick.

Yawning, she put her head on her arms. Just a little nap. Half an hour or so…

*****

"Oh, Seacat!"

Leaning against the railing, watching the sea, she felt the strong arms wrap around her. Felt the head resting on her shoulder, felt the chest pressed into her back. Her tail wrapped around toned legs.

"It's beautiful."

She nodded. Of course it was beautiful. The sea was beautiful. Especially on a warm sunny day with a gentle breeze, just enough to let the ship travel at a decent pace and keep the heat off. And yet… "Not as beautiful as you," she whispered, turning her head to the side to look at Adora.

Her friend was blushing, but not looking away. And her arms tightened around Seacat's body. And her hands moved. Up.

Oh… Seacat gasped. That was… that was… She moaned.

"You like that, huh?" Adora said, teasing. Then she rubbed her cheek against Seacat's. And nipped at her ear.

Seacat hissed. That felt… Oh. She closed her eyes and moaned again, enjoying the sensation. The sun on her fur, the wind in their sails, the hands on her body. Adora being so close…

*****

"First Mate!"

Seacat's eyes shot open, and she jumped to her feet. "Captain?"

Sea Hawk was standing there, looking more tired than she remembered. And the sun… was setting. She had slept through the afternoon!

"We're almost ready to float the ship," he told her. "It's time to load the sick back on the Dragon's Daughter V!"

Already? When the ship wasn't floating yet? That would add weight, and make it more… "Bad news?" she asked in a low voice?

"Something's disturbing the birds in the forest," he replied. "We still have time, and it could be a predator hunting, but…"

She clenched her teeth. The Horde was coming. The spy must have found an advance party. "Let's go, then." She turned to the sick resting in the tent. "Up, you lot! It's time to leave this place!"

She grabbed the first to move under her shoulders and helped her out of the tent. "Hey!" she yelled. "Rig a gurney for the sick!"

They were slow to get a gurney together from leftover struts and some torn sails, and the first woman to be lifted up to the main deck almost fell off the contraption, only held back by straps when it tilted too much, but the next one went better, and soon they had a routine going.

Meanwhile, the sergeant was screaming at the marines to dig harder - they were about to break the dam keeping the water from filling the channel they had dug around the ship.

As the last of the sick crew was being strapped down on the gurney, Seacat turned to watch the forest's edge. More birds rose - right at the edge.

She narrowed her eyes. Something was moving there, in the forest.

No, she realised. Not something. Someone.

Horde troops!

“They’re here!” she yelled as she drew her blade. “Get the ship moving!”

“Get the sick on board! Hurry!”

“Dig you bastards! Dig!”

She clenched her teeth, moving in front of the bow. The Horde would try to board or burn the ship before they could make their getaway. And where was the Captain?

“Huzzah!”

There he was! Sea Hawk jumped down from the main deck, landing next to her in the sand. “Sergeant! We need half a dozen soldiers to hold the line!”

They needed more than that - Seacat could see at least a dozen Horde scum at the edge of the forest now, and she doubted that they would expose themselves like that if they hadn’t more troops lining up behind them. The damned spy would’ve told them all about the crew’s numbers, too.

“We’ll face them close to the ship! Drop some lines so we can climb back up as soon as the Dragon’s Daughter V is moving.”

“Who’s on the helm if you’re here?” Seacat asked, watching as the Horde troops started to form a line.

“Licy.”

She huffed. The pirate better not mess this up. Then again, all she had to do was to keep the rudder straight as the ship slid back into the sea. The engine was already running - she could see the screw moving. That must have been what had delayed Sea Hawk.

Half a dozen marines joined them, looking grim. They were facing at least two dozen Horde infantry - and more behind them. No skiffs, at least - they wouldn't have been able to pass through the dense forest. That meant no artillery, either, which was very fortunate - the ship wouldn't have lasted against artillery.

"Dig! Dig! Damn you wastes of air!"

How much longer until the channel started to fill?

Too long. Someone shouted an order - 'Advance!' - and the Horde line started moving. They were ragged-looking - they had probably done a forced march, with the last bit through the jungle.

Seacat grinned. She knew how that would tire people out. On the other hand, their own crew was tired as well. And outnumbered four to one just by the first ave.

'Charge!' the apparent commander yelled halfway to them, and the Horde troops started running.

That broke up their line, though - and the sand made running more difficult as well.

"Here they come! Give them hell, marines!" Sea Hawk yelled.

She activated her blade.

"We're through! We're through! Knock those struts away and join the line!"

That was the sergeant! The channel was filling now!

But Seacat couldn't check behind her - the Horde line reached them. One burly lizardman came straight for her, raising a staff above his head. She dashed forward, claws digging into the sand, then slid to the side, avoiding his blow, and swung. Her blade cut through his chest plate and into his belly. He collapsed with a scream, blood and guts pouring on the sand.

But two more were behind him - and another attacked her from the side. She rolled away from a wild swing, and Sea Hawk cut the man down, but Seacat barely avoided the spears from the two Horde scum with a quick backflip. Back on her feet and lunging, she cut off one spearhead before they could recover, then had to fall back again when they pressed the attack anyway.

Damn.

She fell back a few more steps, looking for an opening to counterattack, but before she could lunge, she had to parry a stun rod from a soldier who had almost managed to get behind her.

The man stumbled and was left wide open, but the other soldiers pressed on before she could exploit it. She managed to drive the soldier back anyway, but only temporarily. And more were coming from all sides. Sea Hawk was standing his ground, but two marines were down already, and more about to be surrounded and cut down.

“Stop the ship! Stop the ship!”

The Horde commander’s order had the Horde soldiers freeze for a moment, and Seacat saw their heads move as they instinctively looked at the ship. Hah! She bared her fangs and charged, jumping over the jerky attempt to stab her with the spear, kicking the staff the other soldier was wielding away with her feet, then slid through the sand on her back between the two.

Before they could react, she spun, sword flashing, and both collapsed, blood shooting out from where her cutlass had cut their legs.

Seacat jumped to her feet, finished one of them off with her blade while jumping on the other, claws raking his head, then flipped over the stun rod wielder as he tried to stop her.

She reversed the grip on her cutlass while she was in the air and jabbed behind her with both hands as soon as she touched the

ground, then spun around. The Horde soldier fell with a torn lung and a sliced back, and Seacat looked at the battle.

Sea Hawk was still fighting, three marines at his side. The rest had fallen. Half a dozen Horde soldiers were surrounding them, the rest of the scum was charging at the ship, but the sergeant had gathered the other marines and was meeting them head-on on both sides of the Dragon's Daughter V.

Before she could check the forest line, the Horde commander charged her - with a glowing blade.

"That's not standard issue!" she yelled as she parried it, causing a shower of sparks to erupt from their blades.

"Traitor!" the man spat, attacking her with rapid, well-aimed blows. Trying to herd her into some of his men.

She whirled, blade flashing, and the two soldiers behind her jumped back. She completed the turn and parried the commander's next attack, then kicked out with her left foot to wreck his knee, but he was fast enough to dodge - and almost cut her foot with his counter-attack.

Damn, the scum was good with his blade. Not as good as she was, but Seacat was still outnumbered and surrounded. Sooner or later, either the commander or his soldiers would land a hit, and then it'd be over.

She wouldn't let them. Hissing at the man, she parried his next blow, batting it to the side, then stepped inside his guard, reaching for his arm with her free hand. Her claws dug into his armour and his flesh - not deep enough to cripple him. But deep enough to grab hold and trap his sword arm.

He kicked at her, but she twisted away - and swung her blade in the same motion, slashing him from belt to shoulder.

He fell, almost dragging her down with him when her claws got stuck for a moment, but she rolled over his corpse and came up

facing the two soldiers behind her.

The Horde scum fell back again, and she saw them look around for help. Grinning, she picked up the commander's sword and stuck it through her belt, then advanced on them. One turned to flee, the other met her with wild swings of his staff.

She easily avoided them, then cut his staff in half. While he froze for a moment, presumably staring at the two halves, she drove her cutlass into his stomach, and he fell to his knees with a grunt.

That left… She turned and cursed. More Horde scum were coming - they had formed a second line at the forest and were advancing. And the lizardwoman was with them!

Seacat had taken a few steps towards the traitor before she could control herself. Charging at the spy would be suicide; the lizardwoman had two dozen Horde scum with her.

But she could get her. Seacat would die, but she could get the traitor.

No. She glanced behind her. Sea Hawk had finished his opponents and led his group against one of the remaining Horde forces trying to get to the ship. Which was slowly sliding back towards the sea.

Time to go.

Seacat tuned and dashed towards the other group of Horde soldiers, those facing the Salinean sergeant. Four of them left - and half a dozen Horde scum.

One of them noticed her charging at them and managed to turn in time to face her, but she wasn't fast enough to stop her. Seacat dived under her shock rod and slashed through the arm holding it, then drove her blade straight through the helmet's visor.

"Get on the ship!" she yelled as she jumped up and cut the next Horde scum down from behind. "More are coming!"

“Get on the ship!” the sergeant repeated. Probably to her men.

Seacat stabbed another from behind, and the burly Salinean killed her own enemy when the Horde scum turned to face the new threat.

That left two more, who broke ranks and tried to flee. The Marines gave chase, but the sergeant screamed at them. “Back to the ship, you idiots! We’re leaving!”

That finally got them moving, and they started running to the Dragon’s Daughter V - which was now almost in the sea.

The scoundrel on deck threw down lines to climb up, and Seacat saw that Sea Hawk and the other Marines were already at the ship.

But the second line of Horde troops was now charging, running at them as fast as they could. If they caught them while climbing...

Damn.

The first marines were climbing up already. The Captain, though, was turning around. She ran towards him. “Get on the ship!” she yelled, panting.

“Once everyone else is on it!” Sea Hawk replied as the sergeant joined them, their backs against the retreating bow of the Dragon’s Daughter V, where a few marines were still climbing the ropes.

Three against two dozen.

Seacat clenched her teeth. “Let’s take the spy at least!” she snapped.

“No, stand your ground!” Sea Hawk yelled.

What?

Then the Horde line reached them, and Seacat had to fend off a spear thrust and a sword slash, falling back to cover Sea Hawk's right side. She lunged as the Horde soldier - a minotaur - withdrew his spear, aiming low.

The huge soldier collapsed, holding his bleeding groin, and Seacat twisted, parrying the next blade.

"Huzzah!" Sea Hawk yelled, and a headless lizardman fell down next to her.

But they were surrounded now. No way out. At least the ship was out of the Horde's reach - they wouldn't be able to board or burn it in the surf, much less the deeper water behind it.

But it was out of their reach as well. They'd die here. Cut down by Horde scum.

Seacat snarled, panting, and parried two more blows, her foot wrecking a knee in return, then slit the throat of the wounded scum as he fell down with a scream.

But there were too many. A cutlass nicked her left arm, drawing blood, and a spear sliced along her calf.

She tried to ignore the wounds and killed the cutlass-wielder in return, but she was slowing down - and the blood loss would quickly weaken her.

Where was the damn spy? Seacat would take her with her if it was the last thing she did.

There! Facing the sergeant! Seacat bared her fangs, dodging another blow. She had to swap places somehow...

"Horas, now!" Sea Hawk yelled.

What? Horas?

A moment later, a harpoon flew over their heads and pierced the lizardwoman's back, the tip erupting out of her chest. She stumbled, then fell to her knees, her own harpoon dropping to the floor.

"Grab on!" Sea Hawk yelled, whirling with his sword flashing to drive the Horde back.

On to… oh! There was a line tied to the harpoon! And tied to the ship!

Seacat jumped on the dying spy and grabbed the line, her claws raking the traitor's back. Sea Hawk followed her example, kicking the lizardwoman's face in. The sergeant turned to do the same, but one of the Horde scum used the opportunity to stab her in the leg with a spear.

Seacat gasped as the Salinean marine collapsed. She had to…

But Sea Hawk's hand clamped down on her own. "It's too late."

What?

Then the line went taut, and they were dragged into the surf. Into the water. Away from the sergeant just as the rest of the horde fell upon her.

They'd bowled over some of the Horde scum who had been behind them and by the time the Horde ranks had reformed, Seacat and Sea Hawk - and the dying spy - were almost at the ship. The saltwater burned in her wounds, but Seacat ignored it, staring at the beach where the sergeant had fallen until they bumped into the hull of the Dragon's Daughter V.

"Pull them up!" she heard a command on the deck, followed by grunts - and the line went taut again.

Snarling, she started to climb up the rope herself. She wouldn't be lifted onto the deck like some invalid - or cargo.

The minotaur - Horas - was doing most of the pulling, she noticed when she climbed over the railing. He was grinning at her. As was the other scoundrel, Alcy.

“That was close,” the former pirate said.

“Too close,” Seacat replied.

“Indeed.” Sea Hawk followed her on deck. “Sergeant Amis fell,” he said in a sombre voice.”

The marines on deck grumbled and cursed at that. Then the spy was dragged over the railing and dropped on the deck. The marines advanced on her, but it was obvious that she was dead already.

“Although we lost one of our own, we managed to avenge her already - and our poisoned comrades,” Sea Hawk put his foot on the corpse. “A fitting end for a cowardly saboteur!”

The marines grumbled some more - probably about the death having been too quick or something. Seacat ignored them and started taking charge of the deck. “Secure the wounded and set the sails!”

“Why? The Horde knows about the engine now; the traitor will have told them all about it,” one of the marines complained.

“She didn’t know everything,” Seacat retorted. “Not how it works, nor for how long. The more misinformation we can spread, the better.” They still had a mission, after all.

“Indeed!” Sea Haw smiled as he passed them on his way to the conn. “I’ll take the wheel and turn us around. The wind’s favourable.”

They should’ve had a gun, Seacat thought, looking at the beach as the ship turned and the scoundrels started to set sail. A light cannon might not do anything against a frigate or large merchantman, but loaded with canister shot, it would have swept

the beach clear of the Horde. Hell, the Horde probably wouldn't have tried attacking them if they'd had even a single gun.

Once they were underway and her wounds bound, she joined the Captain at the helm and said so.

He nodded, looking grim for a moment. "You're right. I didn't consider that we'd have a larger crew and it wouldn't do anything against a ship large enough to threaten us, but it has its uses. It'll slow us down, but we'll get a gun next time we're in Salineas. Swivel gun, I think. Light, and you only need one sailor to handle it.

Seacat nodded. In a pinch, she could handle the gun while Sea Hawk steered the ship. It wouldn't have been very practicable with a sailing ship, but the engine might allow her to provide somewhat effective fire, instead of having to adjust the sails constantly. After all, a courier that sailed straight in a battle was a courier that begged to be sunk; Horde gunners weren't the best, but they could hit a ship sailing straight after a few tries.

But for now, they would have to make do without. And they had a bigger problem. "Where do you think the troop transport is?" she asked in a low voice.

"If her captain's as good as I was told she is, she should be on the way to the river mouth," Sea Hawk told her. "Unless her ship was damaged even worse than ours."

Sailing a transport unescorted into enemy waters? In the hope that the Dragon's Daughter V had survived the storm and would catch up? That took guts. Especially for a merchantman from the Kingdom of Snows - they didn't really know these waters.

"Let's hope that the Horde frigates didn't use the storm to break out of their ports," she said.

Sea Hawk nodded grimly again.

He probably shared Seacat's opinion of how likely that was. The Horde wasn't stupid, after all.

*****

"Sail ahead!"

Seacat narrowed her eyes at the yell from their lookout - once more Licy - and climbed the rigging. Her arm twinged a little, but she easily ignored it. Just a scratch already healed. Mostly. Like her leg.

A quick check with her telescope confirmed the sighting - and that this was their missing transport; the lines of a Kingdom of Snows cog were unmistakable. She had weathered the storm better than the Dragon's Daughter V if she had reached the area before them, but the storm hadn't left her unscathed. Seacat could easily tell that her foremast had been damaged and repaired.

Still, she was sailing - they could continue their mission!

Seacat stashed the telescope and climbed down, jumping the last few yards, to report to the Captain.

"Transport's sighted. It's the Ice Spear," she told him.

Sea Hawk nodded. "Perfect! And it looks like she came through the storm just fine. We can proceed with our mission, then."

"The Horde spy will have warned them," Horas the minotaur told them.

"Indeed. But it will take them some time to warn our target - and more time to reinforce it," Sea Hawk said. "As quick as their response to our presence was, they must have been an advance party - and they would have to send a courier back to their base, first. It'll be more difficult, but we can do it!"

Seacat nodded loyally, though she had her misgivings. The Horde wasn't stupid - not completely; Catra knew this better than most.

Far from perfect, and with a lot of stupid people, but the Horde's basic organisation was sound. "We have to scout ahead, though, so we don't stumble into a trap."

"Of course. First, though, we need to meet with the Ice Spear and Captain Faris. And whoever commands the landing force," Sea Hawk said. "Although I'm certain that they will agree that we've come too far to abandon our mission."

They didn't know about the spy, though. But first, they had to meet up with them.

As the Captain adjusted their course, Seacat went and adjusted the sails. They had a reputation to maintain, after all.

A few minutes later, they were sailing smoothly towards the transport, and Seacat was taking a closer look at it. "Those are Salinean Marines on the deck," she said. Or at least people wearing their uniforms.

"And that must be Captain Faris," Sea Hawk replied, studying the ship through his telescope. "And the fellow next to her with the glittering brass on his coat must be the commander of the marine forces."

Seacat nodded. She hoped that the officer in charge would be reasonable. They wouldn't pick a commander who hated Sea Hawk, would they? She sighed. That was exactly what Gham would do, just to spite Sea Hawk - or to let someone else claim most of the glory of a decisive victory.

"That's the Seahorses!"

She blinked at the yell from one of the marines on deck. They knew the other forces? Well, duh, they were marines, and Salineas didn't have too many soldiers. And, as she noted, there was a banner with a seahorse on it visible on the deck. Snorting, she jumped down onto the main deck and walked to the salinean marines. "The Seahorses?"

“Yes. Second Royal Marines,” he closest marine told her. “My old regiment.”

“Before you found a better posting!” his friend told him with a chuckle.

The man snorted. “Says you.”

Seacat cleared her throat. “Who’s in command of them?”

“Unless he fell in battle, that would be Colonel Kilian,” the marine replied.

“Kill-Kill-Kilian,” his friend added.

“He’s not like that!” the first protested. “He’s just not as timid as the rest of the Colonels. The Seahorses are a fighting regiment.”

Seacat nodded. That would explain why they had been picked for this mission - it was, after all, a very dangerous operation. If it succeeded, the Horde would’ve suffered a blow it wouldn’t easily recover from. If it failed… well, odds were none of them would live to see the consequences. “So, how’s he to work with?”

Both marines eyed her for a moment. “I never worked with him; just under him,” the first one said.

“He’s brash, loud and likes to have his way,” his friend added. “Or so I’ve heard.”

Seacat nodded again. So… the Colonel and the Captain would either be best friends or worst enemies. At least on the Colonel’s side - Sea Hawk was a little too generous towards his enemies, in her opinion. “Thanks.”

She returned to Sea Hawk’s side.

“So, what did they have to say about our good allies?” he asked.

She suppressed a sigh. Of course he'd realise what she had been doing. "I haven't heard anything about Faris. About Colonel Kilian… Loud, brash and likes to have his way," she quoted the other marine.

"Great! Just the man we need!"

Seacat snorted. That remained to be seen. Fortunately, if Sea Hawk was asking after an officer, he didn't know them - which meant the odds of anyone being an old lover of the Captain were low. Not nil, alas, as some memorable consequences of drunken carousing had proved in the past. "We'll see," she said. "Bu…"

"Ship ahead!"

She blinked. That wasn't…

Cursing, she jumped down and scrambled up the mast. "Where?"

The lookout pointed ahead. Indeed, there was a ship. But… Seacat grabbed her telescope.

It was a Horde frigate. Headed straight towards the transport.

The Horde had managed to break out after - or even during - the storm. And even an old Horde frigate was faster than a Kingdom of Snows cog. Especially a cog full of marines.

Damn.

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The Ruse

“Horde frigate ahead!” Seacat yelled to the Captain without taking her eyes off the enemy ship.

The frigate was still too far away to make out many details, but it was obvious that she was running under her engine - she was going straight against the wind without any sails set. Unless the wind changed, the cog wouldn’t have any chance to outrun the frigate. Hell, even if the wind changed Seacat didn’t think the transport would be able to outrun the frigate - the Horde ship could just set sails as well and run them down.

“The transport’s turning,” Licy told her.

Seacat scoffed. It wouldn’t do her any good. The frigate could outsail a Salinean frigate - a cog stood no chance at all. And the marines on board would be useless, too - the enemy would just use her guns to sink it from a safe distance.

In a few hours, at the latest, the cog would be at the bottom of the sea, and an entire regiment of marines would be drowning. She drew a deep breath. Perhaps this was a good time to test the bomb part of Entrapta’s engine. The Dragon’s Daughter V could easily outsail the Horde frigate, wind or no wind, and come at it from a blind spot not covered by more than one or two guns. And the Ice Spear could pick them up - if they survived.

She looked for the Captain. He had left the wheel to Alcy and was studying the Horde frigate as well. Seacat slid down a line, then pushed off the mast and dropped down on the afterdeck next to Sea Hawk. “It’s looking bad,” she said as she straightened. “If we don’t do anything, the frigate will sink the transport.”

“And that would ruin our mission,” he agreed. “So, we need to do something about the frigate.” He turned to her and flashed his teeth at her. “And I have the perfect plan!”

“Ram it?” She bared her fangs in return. She didn’t like losing a ship, but a courier ship was a cheap price to pay to save a regiment of marines. And the crew of the cog.

“Not quite, First Mate!” he replied. “Signal to the Ice Spear: Keep your distance and prepare to board an immobilised vessel!”

Seacat almost gasped. Immobilised vessel? That would mean…

Sea Hawk nodded. “We’ve got a barrel of Entrapta’s solution. That should clog up the enemy’s engine - and then we’ll have the wind at our back.”

“Unless they’ve found a way to protect their engines from this,” she said. Their spies would’ve told the Horde about it.

“That’s a risk, yes.” Sea Hawk’s confident smile didn’t waver. “But it’s worth a try. If they have managed to protect themselves against it, we’ll ram them.”

Seacat nodded, lips pressed together, then ran to the chest with the signal flags. It was possible that the Horde had found a way to protect their engines - but was it likely? Not according to Catra’s memories. It took a long way for anything to get fixed in the Horde, in her experience. And some stuff never got fixed. Like the tent stakes that broke on hard ground far too easily.

But those were annoyances. This was the core of the Horde fleet. Wouldn’t that have taken priority? Shadow Weaver would know how important control of the seas was - whoever ruled the seas ruled Etheria.

Well, Seacat thought as she started signalling the Ice Spear, they would find out soon.

She had to signal the order twice for the cog to acknowledge it, and Seacat suspected that if the order hadn’t been essentially telling the Ice Spear to get away for now, they still wouldn’t have acknowledged it.

But they had, and now it was up to the Dragon's Daughter V. She stashed the flags and returned to Sea Hawk to report.

He nodded. "Good. Let's do this!" He turned the wheel, and the Dragon's Daughter V lined up perfectly with the enemy frigate.

"Shouldn't we transfer the marines to the transport?" Alcy asked. "There's still time!"

Seacat frowned at the scoundrel. That sounded like she didn't believe they could pull this off.

Sea Hawk, though, shook his head. "Transferring the sick would take too long, and if we get everyone off but for us, then we couldn't save the sick should we have to abandon ship."

"Ah." Alcy slowly nodded.

Seacat snorted. The sick were recovering - but they were far from healthy. If they were left to fend for themselves, they'd all drown.

"And we wouldn't want to deprive them of the glory of this! They are part of our crew and share both the dangers and the victories!" He turned to address the people gathered on the deck - who were mostly staring at the enemy frigate coming at them. "My crew! We'll cripple the enemy ship so the marines from the Ice Spear can board them! Glory and fame await us! Huzzah!"

The cheer that followed was rather ragged, but at least the crew wasn't looking like they were doomed any more.

Even though there was a good chance they were.

Seacat raised her telescope again and studied the frigate. "They've got carronades," she reported.

"I expected that. It's good news," Sea Hawk told her.

"Good news?" She glanced at him for a moment before returning her attention to the enemy.

“If they hadn’t added carronades but had sortied, then they might have found another way to protect themselves against our tactic,” the Captain explained.

“They might have managed that anyway,” she retorted. On the frigate, the guns were being loaded. She could see the crew rush around on the forecastle, where the chase guns were.

“They might. We will soon find out.”

“We need to get close to deploy the stuff,” she said. Too close, as they knew from experience.

“We’re much too fast for them - and they don’t know that yet.” Sea Hawk remained unflappable.

He was correct there - the frigate must have left port before the spy managed to get away. Not that the spy would’ve managed to warn them anyway, not with the distances involved. But… “They’ll expect us.”

“They won’t expect our speed. Nor Horas.”

“Horas?” The minotaur? Seacat blinked.

“Horas! Fetch the barrel marked ‘glue’!” Sea Hawk yelled.

“Aye aye, Captain!”

“Oh. You’ll have him throw the barrel.”

“Exactly!” She didn’t have to look at the Captain to know he was beaming at her.

Horas throwing the barrel would give them a little more room to manoeuvre. Not much, though - but every little bit might help. “The enemy’s ready for battle, “ she reported.

“A little slow, I think. Good news.”

“Or they’re being extra-careful since they can spare the time,” Seacat pointed out. Once the battle started, the Horde gunners wouldn’t be able to take their time loading carefully. It was all about speed then. Something that tended to bite them in the back when facing small, fast ships.

Every little bit helped, Seacat told herself again as she stowed her telescope and jumped down onto the main deck to adjust the sails. The Captain would start to change courses soon.

A few minutes later, Seacat didn’t need the telescope any more. Almost in range of the Horde guns. How good was the enemy captain’s nerve? How close would they let the Dragon’s Daughter V go before they turned and fired a broadside? As always, if they waited too long, they wouldn’t be able to reload in time for a third - or even a second - volley before Sea Hawk crossed their T. But to waste the first, carefully loaded and aimed volley…

She gasped - the enemy was already turning!

“Turn about!” Sea Hawk yelled.

Seacat grabbed the line and pulled as hard as she could as the Dragon’s Daughter V swung around, changing course. Would they be fast enough? The damned Horde engine changed the whole battle.

The Dragon’s Daughter V was still slowly, far too slowly gathering speed again when the enemy frigate’s broadside went off. Most of the shells fell short, throwing up water spouts as they detonated. Seacat saw one of the shells skip over the water, bouncing three times before it vanished in the water. And two shells flew past, one detonating so close, she could feel the ship getting pushed off-course by the explosion.

Sea Hawk compensated easily, of course. But this had been too close. If they had sprung a leak in the weakened hull…

“Start the engine!” the Captain yelled.

Seacat jumped down into the hold, racing past the guard at the door to the engine room. She flipped the activation switch, then pushed the throttle, as Entrapta called it, all the way up. They needed all the speed they could get.

She checked the feeder - all good - and stepped into the hold again. Where a leak had sprung.

“Man the pumps and plug this!” she yelled as she climbed up on deck.

As the corporal now in charge of the Salinean marines yelled orders, she joined Sea Hawk at the wheel. They were racing across the waves now, going faster than she had ever thought possible with the wind at their back.

And the Horde crew was scrambling - she could see the captain on the afterdeck flailing their arms.

Sea Hawk changed course again, a moment before one of the carronades of the frigate fired. The Horde scum must be panicking, Seacat realised - they were far out of range of the carronade. But closing quickly. Too quickly for them to reload.

But they had the chase guns, still - and the enemy frigate was turning towards them. That would bring the chase guns into play - and then the other broadside.

She drew a deep breath. This would be close. Damn close.

Sea Hawk adjusted the course again. Minimally. Just as she had known he would - shortening the route they would take to cross the enemy’s T.

“Horas! Get ready!” the Captain yelled.

The minotaur grunted and hefted the barrel higher, then moved to the railing.

Seacat prepared to adjust the sails once more - any moment, Sea Hawk would turn to present their bow to the enemy, making them a smaller target.

“Turn about!”

Here it came! Seacat pulled as the Dragon’s Daughter V swung around, pointing her bow at the frigate’s. A moment later, first one then the other chase gun fired. The first shot went wide, the shell detonating near the ship and showering them in seawater. The second went high, ripping through their sail without exploding.

“Huzzah! Turn about!”

Once more, the Dragon’s Daughter V turned - into the wind this time. Much faster than would’ve been possible without the engine.

“Throw as soon as you can!”

“Aye aye, Captain!” Horas bellowed, then roared - and the barrel flew towards the enemy frigate, landing in the water close to their bow and breaking apart.

Seacat clenched her teeth. If the enemy just kept turning… Hah! The frigate stopped for a moment, reversing course - the worst thing they could’ve done. This way, the ship stayed in the affected area for longer, and the second broadside wouldn’t come into play. The Horde captain must have panicked.

Good for the Dragon’s Daughter V, of course - they were opening the distance as fast as the engine allowed. By the time the frigate had trend enough to present the first broadside, they were almost out of range.

The Horde fired anyway - it wasn’t as if they had anything to lose - and the water aft of the Dragon’s Daughter V erupted in a dozen waterspouts.

“The frigate’s stopped,” the lookout yelled.

“Huzzah! We’ve ruined their engine!” Sea Hawk yelled.

That meant that the transport now had a good chance to escape, Seacat knew. But Sea Hawk had more in mind than merely escaping - he wanted to board the enemy. Or sink it. And that meant they had to disable the sails that the Horde scum was now setting as well.

Which meant they needed to expose themselves to the enemy guns again.

“What’s the status of the leak?” she yelled.

“There’s another, but the pumps can handle it!” one of the marines yelled back.

No surprise there - even a shell that missed a ship could sink it if it detonated too close to the hull.

“Prepare the harpoons!” Sea Hawk yelled. “We’re going to set fire to their rigging!”

Seacat took a deep breath. Fire was bad on a ship. Dry wood and tar burned easily and quickly. She knew that better than most, what with her experience on the Dragon’s Daughter V’s predecessors. But it was their best shot - unless they wanted to board the enemy frigate themselves, with two dozen crew.

She busied herself adjusting the sails as the ship turned for another go at the Horde frigate and four marines carried a bunch of harpoons up from the hold. And a big chest containing a small barrel.

There were various ways to set fire to an enemy ship. Heated shot had fallen out of use as solid shot had been replaced by shells. Seacat only knew about that from Sea Hawk’s tales. Catapults lobbing barrels of pitch were even older, and, as the testing in Salineas had proven, had been abandoned for a reason. Fire ships worked best but were costly. If Brain Boy were here, he could probably use some of his trick arrows.

“Hold it steady!” she yelled to the Captain as the marines started to fill the harpoons with the dense liquid from the barrel. If that stuff spilled on deck, then all it took was one spark, and they were gone.

Fortunately, one of the Kingdom of Snows soldiers had been a whaler and knew how to load harpoons with explosive charges. Or incendiary charges, in this case. She doubted that the man had ever used them before, but he kept calm. And he kept the marines from messing up.

She still breathed a sigh of heartfelt relief when the harpoons were ready and the barrel back in the hold, inside the sturdy chest.

“Ship’s ready for action!” she reported to Sea Hawk.

He beamed at her. “Very good. Let’s cripple the enemy!” He raised his fist to the sky. “Huzzah! For the Alliance! For Glory! Adventure!”

This time, the cheer that went up was loud and full of spirit.

The damn fools hadn’t realised that things would be even more dangerous now, Seacat knew. The enemy had lost their engine - but they knew now just how fast the Dragon’s Daughter V could go.

On the Horde frigate, sailors were climbing the rigging to set sails. Seacat bit her lower lip. They were slow, far slower than Salinean sailors, but the Dragon’s Daughter V had to cover quite the distance to reach the frigate again, and she couldn’t tell if they would manage it before the enemy frigate could manoeuvre under sails.

“Fools didn’t have the sails set, yet!” a marine next to Seacat said.

“They counted on manoeuvring better against the wind without sails,” she told him. A mistake, and - she hoped so, at least - a costly one. The frigate would’ve been harder to sail with the sails -

but she wouldn’t have been dead in the water after the engine failed.

Sea Hawk yelled commands as the Dragon’s Daughter V turned again, lining up with the enemy ship’s bow once more. That was the safest course to get close - they couldn’t face the carronades on the broadsides, and they didn’t have time to sail around to approach from the stern.

But it meant they would come under fire again. And with the wind blowing from straight behind now, any evasive action would mean they had to jibe a lot. She took a deep breath - this would be exhausting.

She threw herself into pulling on her line as they jibed for the first time right before entering the range of the chase guns. One of the guns fired, the shell going wide, but the other held its fire.

They had learned, damn it.

Sea Hawk changed course again, and as the Dragon’s Daughter V swung around, and they had to pull the sail back against the wind, the second gun fired. Another detonation, too close for comfort, shook the ship. Two marines slipped and let go of the line. For a moment, it looked like they would botch the jibe. But not on Seacat’s watch! She dug her claws into the deck and growled as she pulled as hard as she could. “Pull you mangy curs!” she yelled through clenched teeth. “Pull!”

And they did. The sail swung around, then slammed forward, and the ship took up more speed again.

But they couldn’t relax - Sea Hawk turned the ship again. Another jibe. Seacat pulled again. The first gun fired once more, missing again by a wide margin. Not the best gun crew, either. But the sails of the frigate were almost set - she would be moving and manoeuvring soon. One more jibe. And one more shot.

Sea Hawk turned, then swung the ship back. Then the Horde gun fired, missing by what looked like inches, the shell detonating aft

of them - and lifting the ship lightly as Sea Hawk resumed the turn and headed straight for the enemy ship.

"Fire!"

Horas, at the bow, threw the first harpoon. It hit the mainsail in the centre, going straight through it to hit the deck behind it. Seacat could hear screaming from the enemy ship.

They were close now. More harpoons flew, one hitting the enemy bow and splashing liquid over it. A moment later, it was burning.

More screams followed. Smoke started to rise. And then one harpoon hit the mainsail just right, getting stuck in it before lighting up.

Moments later, the sail was on fire.

And Sea Hawk turned the Dragon's Daughter V away, into the wind.

But they weren't clear yet. Like in the Battle for Seaworthy, they were in the field of fire for the enemy's chase guns. And the second chase gun - the good gunners - had finished reloading. Seacat saw the cannon line up. "Incoming!" she yelled.

Sea Hawk was already turning back to throw their aim off, but they were too close. Too slow.

A few more harpoons flew - most of them falling short, but one landed on the gun. And a fireball erupted on the frigate's bow as the powder stashed next to the guns there blew up.

Cheers went up as the Dragon's Daughter V sped away, Sea Hawk skillfully keeping her in front of the enemy frigate, outside the field of fire of either broadside.

Seacat closed her eyes for a moment, sighing.

“We really need a gun,” she mumbled. Relying on luck and a strong minotaur wasn’t a good solution.

“There comes the Ice Spear!”

She looked up. Indeed, there was the cog sailing towards the enemy frigate. They were adjusting their course - they must have planned to approach from the stern, but with the bow cleared now, they didn’t have to sail around the enemy. The marines were already gathering on deck.

Seacat saw the Horde sailors drop two longboats into the water. Were they abandoning ship? No, she realised a moment later, they were trying to use the longboats to tow the frigate - turn it so she could present her broadsides to the approaching cog.

But it was too little too late - the sailors in the boats had barely started to row before the cog reached the frigate, all but ramming the bow.

Grapple hooks flew, and, a moment later, marines started boarding the frigate.

There was no doubt about the outcome now. A whole regiment versus a frigate’s crew. If the Horde captain wasn’t a complete fool… There! Seacat bared her teeth in a smile as she looked through her telescope, watching as the fighting stopped on the deck. “The Horde scum surrendered.”

“Good!” Sea Hawk raised his fist to the air. “Victory!”

This time, Seacat joined the others in cheering. They had beaten a frigate with a courier and a transport. That was no small feat. And the prize money would… actually not be much. Not with an entire regiment sharing it.

Damn.

And they’d need a prize crew for the ship to take it back to Salineas or Seaworthy. That would cut into their number. Even

with the marines and the cog's crew providing most of the prize crew, the Dragon's Daughter V might lose their three remaining scoundrels. But they had no choice - they had no space for the prisoners on the cog, so sinking the frigate was out of the question. Even though… She blinked, then grinned and turned to Sea Hawk.

"Captain! I've got an idea!"

*****

The Horde fortress securing the mouth of the main river of the Fright Zone had a port attached to it, of course. But it looked mostly-empty as Seacat studied it through her telescope. "A few small transports, a slew of river barges, and one sloop," she reported to Sea Hawk. "No frigates."

"Good. I didn't expect any to be stationed here, not with their main port north of us, but it's good to have confirmation," he replied.

Seacat nodded in agreement. As they had heard from the prisoners, most of the enemy frigates had escaped the blockaded port after the storm and were now, presumably, making trouble for the Salinean fleet and the Alliance in general. That was a big problem.

But having a frigate or two in the port ahead would've been a bigger problem. Their guns would've made taking the port and fortress very difficult. Even the sloop could make trouble if handled correctly. She looked it over and saw movement on deck. "They've seen us."

"Took them long enough," Sea Hawk commented. "Are they falling for our ruse?"

"No movement on the gun emplacements at the seawall," she replied.

“Good.” Sea Hawk smiled. “Everything is proceeding according to plan.”

My plan, Seacat thought as she looked ahead, at the frigate sailing in front of them and the transport, flying the Horde flag. A frigate returning to the closest Horde port with two prizes. Nothing suspicious here.

Or so she hoped.

They hadn’t managed to get the frigate’s engine running again - Entrapta’s concoction had done too much damage, as it had been created to do - but they had managed to save enough sails so the frigate could make a decent speed. And they had plugged the leaks on the Dragon’s Daughter V.

Now they were passing under the guns of the fortress. If the Horde realised what they were doing… Well, the Dragon’s Daughter V might be able to escape while everyone focused on the transport and the frigate.

But no alarm was raised. No guns manned and aimed. No challenge shouted, either - not even signal flags waved. That wouldn’t have been a problem, anyway - they knew the Horde code, just as the Horde knew the Salinean code.

They passed the mole and entered the harbour proper. The sloop still hadn’t cast off her lines - it didn’t look as if her crew were preparing to sail, either. The sailors were crowding on deck to watch the frigate sail into port, Seacat realised. They were cheering.

She almost felt bad for them. Almost.

“Be ready to turn about; we’ll take the mole;” Sea Hawk said.

Seacat nodded. The mole had few soldiers on it, but a few guns. If the Horde scum managed to turn them around, they could fire into the harbour.

But they couldn’t change course yet. That would look suspicious. Not that they had to keep up the charade for much longer - the frigate had almost reached the sloop. Any moment now, they would…

She heard a yelling command, and the Horde flag flying from the frigate’s mast was replaced by the Salinean flag. From her point of view, she could see a ripple go through the sloop’s crew.

But before the Horde sailors could react, the frigate’s gun ports flew open, and the cannons were pushed out, into firing position. A moment later, the frigate fired her broadside directly into the smaller ship. At point-blank range. And the sloop’s deck turned into an abattoir. Canister shot from the guns. And the Carronades. Seacat saw blood run down the sloop’s hull before the Dragon’s Daughter V turned and started racing back towards the mole.

All around the harbour, people started running and screaming. And the alarms were finally raised. Too late, though. As a glance over her shoulder told Seacat, the marines hidden on the frigate were already swarming over the sloop. And the cog had changed course and was headed straight towards the waterfront.

Then the Dragon’s Daughter V reached the mole, and Seacat drew her cutlass.

“At them, crew!” Sea Hawk yelled as he grabbed a line and jumped, swinging over to the mole. “For Salineas! For the Alliance! Huzzah!”

Seacat cursed as her Captain landed straight in the middle of a group of Horde soldiers. “Tie her up!” she yelled to the two scoundrels next to her, then dashed forward, jumping on the railing and then over on the mole.

A soldier faced her with a spear - no, a harpoon - but she parried his first thrust, then cut the harpoon’s head off with a flick of her wrist before ramming the blade into his belly.

A lizardman came at her, but before she could face him, a thrown axe split his head in half. Horas pulled himself onto the mole a moment later, grinning, and recovered his axe.

Seacat returned the grin, then turned and started to cut her way to the Captain. They had a fortress to take.

When Seacat reached him half a minute and two dead Horde scum later, Sea Hawk was just finishing off the last Horde soldier in the gun emplacement in this part of the mole. He was bleeding from a cut on his arm, she noted, but it was a shallow cut - it wasn't slowing him down. The closest Horde soldiers were retreating towards the waterfront.

Behind their group, half a dozen marines were fighting in the gun emplacement at the end of the mole.

"There you are, First Mate!" Sea Hawk yelled. "And Horas! Let's take this mole! Huzzah!" He raised his glowing sword and charged towards the gun emplacement between them and the pier, Seacat and Horas at his side.

The Horde scum there had formed a line - two rows of half a dozen soldiers each. But they were trembling, still shocked from the sudden attack. Behind them, four gunners struggled to turn the guns around - whether to bring them to bear on the mole or the ships inside the harbour, Seacat couldn't say.

She didn't need to, anyway. Shells from the captured frigate tore into the gun emplacement, the explosions throwing one cannon through the air and into the sea while shredding the back row of the Horde infantry with shrapnel and splinters.

That broke the soldiers, and they turned to flee - one of them even climbing the outer wall to jump into the sea.

"Don't get too close!" Seacat snapped as they climbed over the crater the frigate's shells had left. "I don't trust our gunners that much!"

“Hah!” Sea Hawk laughed, but Horas slowed down some.

She glanced to her side. The marines were clearing the other side of the harbour while their main force was rushing the fortress’s gates. A company was forming up to cover their rear against an attack from the waterfront, but Seacat doubted any such would happen - not with half the regiment landing directly at the waterfront.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk yelled as he jumped over a mangled corpse of a fishman. They were close to the small tower overlooking the mole where it reached the waterfront. A Horde officer was trying to rally the fleeing soldiers there - but as much as he waved his blade around, the Horde scum kept running past him.

“At them!” Sea Hawk screamed, followed by Horas’s roar.

The officer took a look at them and turned to flee himself. But the marines were already clearing the waterfront, and the fleeing Horde scum were forced into the alleys behind it - which were too narrow for the mass of fleeing soldiers.

Even before their group reached the scum, the first of the Horde forces were throwing their weapons away and surrendering. The rest quickly followed their example when the marines started cutting down anyone who resisted. And probably some who didn’t.

“To the fortress!” Sea Hawk yelled, raising his sword like a standard. “Follow me!”

It took almost longer to make their way through the marines crowding the waterfront than it would have taken them to cut through Horde soldiers. The gates were already secure when they entered, though there was still fighting on the ramparts. And the fortress’s citadel still flew the Horde flag - and its gates still stood.

As Seacat watched, three marines turning a captured gun on the citadel’s walls were blown apart from the artillery mounted there.

“Ladders! Bring the ladders!” someone yelled. “Storm the walls!”

“Get those guns turned around and sweep the walls!”

Ladders? Seacat scoffed. That would be a damn costly attack.

“We don’t need ladders - blast the gates away!” Sea Hawk yelled. “With me!”

The Captain rushed to the other side of the ramparts, where a gun had been captured. Seacat, Horas and half a dozen marines followed him. “Forget the walls!” he snapped at the marines there. “We need to aim it at the gates!”

Horas and a huge lizardman all but carried the cannon down into the yard. Seacat and the others grabbed shells and powder.

“Cover them!” someone yelled.

She glanced up and saw that the enemy gunners were struggling to aim their own cannon down at them. The gun emplacement wasn’t designed for that, but they could improvise - if they had the time.

But the Seahorses were a crack regiment - their gunners managed to set up the captured piece before the Horde was ready. And the gate was a really easy target. Seacat covered her ears just in time for the shot - and the explosion that wrecked the gate.

Or not totally. That was some solid workmanship.

But the second shell blew it to splinters, and the waiting marines rushed inside. The first of them were blown apart by a gun the Horde apparently had managed to move - but that didn’t stop the Salineans.

A few minutes later, the Horde flag fell, and a ragged cheer started up.

They had taken the fortress.

*****

“We’ve secured the barges. Unfortunately, they were mostly empty,” Licy reported. “Most of their cargo was already unloaded.”

Seacat frowned. She had expected that. The marines had secured the warehouses at the waterfront, so it wasn’t as if the Horde had managed to escape with supplies or destroy them, but unlike for captured ships, there was no prize money for captured warehouses. And it had been the Seahorses who had secured them, anyway.

Sea Hawk wasn’t fazed. “And we secured a sizable amount of fuel crystals!” he announced. “That’s our main objective.”

Colonel Kilian nodded. “With the fortress in our hands, we control the river transports. The Horde won’t be able to send more to the other ports. They will run out of fuel sooner or later.”

“That will take some time,” Captain Faris of the Ice Spear pointed out. “And they’ll try to ship them overland.”

And the Horde fleet could wreak havoc with the fuel they already had until then, Seacat knew. Especially with half a dozen of their frigates - five now, what with one captured - loose at sea. They would have to be hunted down, which would be very difficult. If the Horde captains were smart, they would save the engine fuel for combat and just sail. That way, they could stay at sea for a long time.

“Nothing we can do about that,” Kilian replied. “At least they didn’t keep their frigates together. A squadron of half a dozen frigates could’ve taken control of the coast off our front. And blockade us in here.”

“But five frigates hunting for our transports means we’ll have to use escorts and convoys,” Faris retorted. “That will slow us down - and any transport sailing alone will be lost. You can’t outrun these frigates.”

Not in a slow-ass cog, of course. A courier would manage, even without an engine. But a courier wouldn't transport many supplies. Seacat suppressed a sigh.

"We've won a battle - a glorious and important victory! - but not yet the war!" Sea Hawk said. "But this won't stop us! With the provisions secured here, you can hold out for months, can't you, Colonel?"

"I'll run out of soldiers before I run out of food," the officer replied with a grin.

That was a rather callous stance about casualties, Seacat thought. Perhaps the man deserved his 'Kill-Kill-Kilian' moniker. She wouldn't like to serve under him, in any case.

But he wasn't her problem, either.

"The Horde will attack," Captain Faris said. "They can't afford to lose this port - their front up north is cut off."

"Let them come! We took the fortress almost intact - we can hold against ten times our number here!" Kilian boasted.

"An attitude worthy of this mission!" Sea Hawk agreed enthusiastically. "And we will continue upriver, to burn as many barges as we can find! That will cripple the Horde supply system in this area! It'll be a great adventure!"

It would also be very dangerous. But it had to be done - they had to stop the fuel crystal deliveries; the Horde yards in the west could still build more frigates.

"There are several forts lining the river," the Colonel pointed out.

"Yes." Sea Hawk smiled widely.

The officer snorted in return. "Good luck then, Admiral."

“Thank you, Colonel. Although before we leave, I’d like to ask for volunteers among your soldiers to replace our sick and wounded.”

Seacat saw the officer scowl at once. “I’ll need every man to hold the fortress.”

“They will heal up,” Sea Hawk retorted. “Eventually. And our actions upriver will help you - if we disrupt the supply lines, any move against you will be hampered as a result.”

“If you succeed.”

Seacat refrained from hissing at the Colonel. How dare he question their mission!

Sea Hawk tilted his head and bared his teeth. “We did take both the frigate and the fortress, didn’t we?”

Kilian kept frowning for a few seconds, then suddenly chuckled. “I guess you did. It’s a daring plan - but who dares wins, as the saying goes. Although I won’t let you take more than half a dozen. Only the best will volunteer, and I need them to lead the rest of my regiment. And no officers!”

“Deal!” Sea Hawk grinned. “Although I’ll need one senior noncommissioned officer.”

“I’ve heard how you lost your first one.” Kilian nodded. “Don’t get them killed.”

“I’ll endeavour to avoid that.”

*****

The marines had restored and manned most guns, as far as Seacat could tell, by the time they had replenished their ranks, left the sick in a tavern until there was room for them in the fortress’s infirmary, which was currently stuffed with the wounded from the battle, and had restocked water - sweet, fresh water! - and other provisions for the Dragon’s Daughter V.

“What about all the prisoners?” Lucy asked as they started to set sail.

“I guess the Ice Spear will transport them up north,” Seacat replied. The frontlines were no place for prisoners, a fortress surrounded by the enemy even less. She watched a team of fishpeople surface and report - presumably - to an officer from the Seahorses; they were patrolling the harbour intensively; no one wanted Horde fishpeople saboteurs to sneak in.

“Let’s hope they don’t encounter another Horde frigate, then,” the scoundrel said.

Seacat nodded in agreement, though she couldn’t tell if Licy was worried about losing the ship, or that the Horde might sink the transport before realising that there were prisoners on board. Or whether she was worried at all, and not just making idle conversation.

It didn’t matter anyway - this was out of their hands. They had to focus on their own mission now. Which would be dangerous as well. She eyed the setting sun. Travelling at night would mean they would be safer from the Horde - they would be hard to spot at a distance, or in time to ready the cannons. But it would also be more dangerous since it was harder to spot sandbanks and other obstacles.

Seacat would have to be on her toes as a lookout.

*****

The Raid

They were making great speed up the river. With the number of fuel crystals secured in the fortress, they didn't have to save them for emergencies and could have the Dragon's Daughter V run at full speed all day. With a little luck, they would even outrun the news of the fortress falling before they reached the first fort on the river - they were almost as fast as a skiff on a road.

And if they ran into a sandbank or underwater obstacle, they'd crash as badly as a skiff flying into a rock at full speed. Which was why they weren't going at full speed now that night had fallen and why Seacat was currently crouched at the bow and looking ahead into the water - she was the only one able to see well enough in the darkness to spot such obstacles quick enough to avoid them.

Without using lanterns that would give their position away to any Horde patrol on the riverbanks, that was. Out here, the river was still wide enough that they had a good chance of avoiding being spotted if they kept to the middle of the stream.

"We're still a day away from the fort," she heard Licy whisper behind her. "At least according to the directions we got from the prisoners."

"You don't need to whisper," Seacat replied in a low voice. "We're not that close to the riverbanks." And whispers carried further than low voices.

"But that might change, and I don't want to give us away - I can't tell how far away we are from the shore," the former pirate replied.

"Far enough for now - the river doesn't really narrow until past the main inland port for the fuel crystals." At least according to their maps. Unfortunately, none among their force had actually been upriver that far, yet - and those amongst the Horde prisoner who had couldn't be trusted.

Licy scoffed. “It’s already narrow enough. We can’t manoeuvre here. Not properly.”

“We can manoeuvre well enough,” Seacat retorted. Thanks to the engine, at least.

“Right. I forgot,” Licy said. Sighing, she sat down on the railing next to Seacat. “This will change sailing. The engine, I mean.”

Seacat made an agreeing noise without taking her eyes off the river’s surface. Anyone could tell that - naval combat had been changed already. In a few years, any warship without an engine would be obsolete. Hell, the Salinean frigates might already be obsolete if they didn’t have Entrapta’s concoction to wreck the Horde engines.

“Used to be, all you needed was a fast ship and a crew. Now you need a princess to make an engine for you. And crystals to feed to it,” Licy went on.

Seacat nodded. “If you want to fight. Engines might be too expensive for most transport ships.” She was well aware how expensive running a ship was - or replacing it, but she didn’t know how much an engine and fuel would cost if you didn’t get them for free from a princess.

Licy snorted again. “But good luck running from a frigate with a sailing ship.”

Ah. That was what concerned the scoundrel. “Good thing you won’t have to do that,” Seacat said, chuckling a little.

“Sailing on a merchantman isn’t much fun, though,” Licy replied. “Would you want to spend your days ferrying cargo?”

“We did that before we joined the war full-time.”

“No, you didn’t - we’ve all heard the stories and the shanties. We’ve seen you in action. You and Sea Hawk. You’re not some

boring merchant captain transporting dried fish or ore from port to port.” Licy snorted again. “You have adventures.”

“A lot of adventures,” Seacat agreed. Mostly because of Sea Hawk.

“And you will need a bigger crew even after the war. You want at least one gun, or so I heard. And someone to handle the engine. And a lookout. And you’ll need enough to cover all watches.”

Ah. That was why Licy was talking to her here. “That’s up to Sea Hawk,” she said. He was the Captain.

“He listens to you.”

Seacat grunted. Sometimes, at least.

“So… think about it, hm? We - Alcy, I and Horas - worked well with you, didn’t we?”

“Yes.”

She didn’t have to look at the scoundrel to know Licy was smiling when she left the bow.

But the former pirate was correct. If they wanted to keep sailing with the Dragon’s Daughter V - or her successors - they would need more crew. Trustworthy crew who could handle Sea Hawk.

Without trying to kill him, like most of his old friends.

Seacat blinked. There was something ahead of them. Not a sandbank. Not an island. It was… She gasped. “It’s a barge!” she whispered. “Barge ahead!” she said in a low voice. “Course clear.”

Licy picked it up and whispered it to Alcy, who informed the Captain.

A moment later, Sea Hawk jumped down to the main deck and moved to the bow.

“It’s deep in the water - loaded,” she informed him.

“Do you see any escorts?” he asked.

She shook her head. “None. But they could have troops on the riverbank.” She couldn’t see through the bushes and trees there.

“Unlikely,” the new sergeant - Clovis or something - said, joining them. She wasn’t built as bulky as her predecessor, but lean. And mean, in Seacat’s impression. “They wouldn’t be able to protect the barge from there.”

“And the barge would be anchored at the riverbank, not in the middle of the stream.” Sea Hawk chuckled. “No, I think we happened upon a single barge without escorts and a crew who hasn’t heard about our recent victory.”

“A fully-loaded barge - a prize!” Licy whispered.

That was true. A barge full of supplies would fetch a good price at the admiralty courts. Even if she wasn’t transporting fuel crystals, but normal supplies. Kilian’s troops could use the supplies, anyway. But could they spare a prize crew? And risk sending the barge downriver without an escort?

Well, first they had to take the barge.

“Prepare to board the barge!” Sea Hawk ordered - a little too loudly, Seacat thought, but the barge was still quite a distance away. The Captain was already headed back to the helm while the sergeant woke up her marines.

A minute later, they picked up speed, and Seacat was too busy checking for obstacles in the river to pay attention to anything else. At this speed, she would have to shout her warnings - there wouldn’t be time to manoeuvre otherwise.

But there were no obstacles. They were rushing towards the barge as if they were planning to ram them. Seacat clenched her teeth - the Captain was cutting it a little too close; she could tell.

On the other hand, it meant they surprised the enemy - they were almost upon the barge when she heard a yell from the barge's watch. Far too late to do the Horde scum any good.

At almost the last second, Sea Haw turned, and the Dragon's Daughter V started to slow down. A moment later, they bumped against the barge, hard enough to rock the larger vessel. More screams rang out - but they were drowned out by the yelling from the marines as they went over the railing and jumped on the barge's main deck, brandishing their blades.

"Not going to board them?" Licy asked As Seacat used a line to secure the bow of the Dragon's Daughter V against the barge.

"No need," Seacat replied. "The marines will have finished any moment." She cocked her head. "You didn't board them, either."

The scoundrel shrugged. "I was told to stay near you to relay orders. That wasn't countermanded."

There wasn't any need for such a relay now, not with two dozen marines and half a dozen Horde scum screaming and fighting. But it spoke for the former pirate that she hadn't left her post in search of loot.

Of course, the woman might just be trying to make a good impression. Either way, it was the correct decision. "Let's check out the cargo," she said.

"Alright!"

They climbed over the railing and dropped on the barge, next to a dead Horde sailor and a cursing marine holding her hurt arm. "I'm fine," the woman snapped when Seacat looked at her. "Bastard got lucky."

Seacat nodded, then went ahead to the hold. She didn't need a lantern - the moonlight was enough to show that the hold was full of crates and bags. Food supplies - she recognised the tags on the crates.

She still searched through the whole hold while the marines cleared the rest of the barge, both to check for a hiding Horde scum, leaks or hidden fuel crystals. She found nothing of the sort. Just enough supplies for a regiment.

She jumped, grabbing the edge of the deck, and pulled herself up.

"No fuel crystals?" Alcy asked.

"No. Food, mostly. Powder and shells, too. Some weapons," Seacat said, looking at Sea Hawk.

"Ah! Kilian will put all of it to good use, I bet!" the Captain declared. "Though now we need a prize crew."

Seacat grinned as both scoundrels suddenly looked away and even Horas the minotaur turned to inspect the barge's bow. No one wanted to leave the Dragon's Daughter V right in the middle of the mission.

*****

An hour later, they were on their way again, with more supplies in the hold - mostly gunpowder - while the Salinean corporal and four marines had taken over the barge. Unfortunately, none of them could see in the dark, so they couldn't head downriver right away. Well, even with a slow barge, they would be able to reach the fortress the next day. And five fewer soldiers was a dent in their crew complement, but they could still storm an outpost or so. Quality before quantity.

Still, Seacat couldn't help thinking that they should've taken more marines with them. If they found another barge or two, they would have to burn it - or lose most of their marines.

She snorted and shook her head. She had a task to do, and it wasn't planning the next boarding action, but looking out for obstacles at night. They could tackle the question of what to do with a captured barge once they captured another. And that wasn't sure, anyway - the Horde would be spreading the news,

and they would expect the Alliance to raid the river after blocking it. That was just common sense. If Seacat were commanding the Horde, she'd unload and sink some of the barges to block the river. Or skip the unloading, if the enemy was too fast, Better to deny them resources.

Sure, it would also block traffic for a counterattack downriver, but she doubted that the Horde had the forces ready for such a counterattack anyway - they were under pressure on all fronts, after all, according to what she had heard in Seaworthy.

Damn, she was doing it again. She had to focus on the river, not on planning. All her plans would be for nought, anyway, if she let the Dragon's Daughter V run aground.

*****

There she was. Adora. Looking up at her with a smile.

One foot on the railing of her ship, Seacat smiled back.

"Permission to come aboard?" the blonde asked.

"Permission granted!" Seacat replied, throwing back the admiral's jacket she had hung over her shoulders.

Adora, wearing a flowing silk robe that clung to her body, outlining every muscle and curve, came up the gangway. "So this is your ship."

"Yes." Seacat spread her arms. "All mine! I took her from the Horde in a pitched boarding action, then had it remodelled by Entrapta to become the fastest frigate on all the seas!"

"That's great! And they made you admiral!" Adora gushed.

"They did!"

"And they gave you a crew of the finest bots Entrpata could make!"

"Yes…" She blinked. "What?" Turning around, she saw that it was true. Bots were crowding the deck, trying to pull on lines. One bot was crushed when another fell on it from the rigging. What the…

"Enemy ship ahead!"

Seacat whirled. The Horde was attacking! And her bot crew couldn't run the frigate! And Adora was watching! She had to...

*****

"Enemies ahead! Barge and gunboat!"

"Battle stations!"

"Move, you sorry excuses for marines! Move!"

Seacat gasped as she woke, dropping out of her hammock and grabbing her cutlass before she realised what was happening. They were on a river and had just found another barge. And a gunboat - an escort!

She checked whether the engine room was manned - it was - and went up on deck.

Alcy and Licy were in the bow and Marines were running everywhere, being yelled at by the sergeant, so Seacat climbed the rigging for a quick look. Indeed, a few turns of the river ahead, there was a gunboat escorting a barge. And judging by the tiny figures swarming over the gunboat's bow, they had seen them as well.

She grinned. If they let supply barges sail unescorted, but escorted this barge… Fuel Crystals. Or soldiers. But she couldn't see any soldiers on the barge, other than the handful of crew she was supposed to have, so the safe bet was fuel crystals. Or something else important for the Horde. A good prize - provided they could deal with the escort.

She jumped down and joined the captain "It's a small gunboat - two guns, bow and aft."

"Like the one we took in the Fright Zone?"

"A little smaller. Probably shallower draft as well," she replied.

"Not enough crew to be a problem, then." The Captain grinned.

"Enough to man both guns," she reminded him. And a single shell could sink or cripple them if it hit at the right spot.

"True. So we need to ensure that they won't hit us. And I have just the plan for that! Sergeant Clovis!"

*****

The water was colder than Seacat had expected this far south of the continent. Not really cold, like up north, much less freezing like in the Kingdom of Snows, but just this side of uncomfortable if you weren't swimming.

Which, she thought as she pushed off the Dragon's Daughter V's hull and grabbed the log floating nearby - large enough to hide her head behind it, as well as the heads of the marines already there - means this will be uncomfortable.

"Everyone's here!" she heard the sergeant snap. "Now shut up and don't move!"

Seacat turned her head and watched the Dragon's Daughter V sail away, further downriver. Running from the gunboat, or so it would - hopeful - look to the Horde. A smart captain would keep the escort with the barge. Send it back and report the encounter. Cautiously pursue the enemy, with the wind at their back.

But the odds of encountering such a captain here were low. Not impossibly low, but low. Good sailors were needed on the Horde frigates, not on some - until now - backwater river.

Seacat still worried until she saw the bow of the gunboat appear at the turn ahead of them - at a speed that meant they didn't fear a trap or ambush.

Well, they'd get both. Seacat grinned, then ducked a little lower behind the 'stuck' log, gauging the gunboat's speed and distance. Yes, they could make it. But it would be close.

Well, that was why she was with the marines. "I'm going!" she hissed, then grabbed the line tied to the log and dived.

She could see the hull of the gunboat - flat bottomed - coming towards her and adjusted her angle. She had to time this right, and she only had one chance. She pushed on, swimming as fast as she managed, dragging the line with her. If she had miscalculated and the line ran out of slack…

But it didn't. And there was the gunboat. The bow passed her, close enough so she could touch it, and she surfaced, already swinging the line with the grapple. Once, twice - she let it fly and watched with bated breath as it flew up, then came down behind the railing - and hooked on to it.

Yes!

Seacat didn't wait for the line to run taut and drag the log with it - she started climbing as fast as possible. Any moment, someone would notice her.

They didn't. Focused on the 'fleeing' Dragon's Daughter V, they didn't spot her until she climbed over the railing and rushed towards the gun in the aft. Her blade ignited, and she ran the officer commanding the gun through before he could react.

The half a dozen sailors yelled and screamed, grabbing weapons and tools to defend themselves, but she was too close and too quick for them. She gutted the closest sailor with her claws, parried a shaky blow with a boathook with her blade, then kicked the fool into another sailor moving towards her, sending both of them falling on the deck.

Snarling, she faced the remaining Horde scum, deflecting a thrust from one sailor before ducking under a wild swing from another. She rolled forward, slashing the legs of the brute, and jumped to land next to the two sailors she had kicked. They were trying to get up, but two quick thrusts put an end to that.

She whirled, but the Horde scum with the boathook was already falling back. That left… Her eyes widened as the last Horde sailor swung the gun around. She dived to the side, and the shot went through railing and Horde sailor without detonating.

Hissing, she jumped over the barrel and cut the gunner down. What a fool!

Behind her, the marines had reached the railing just before the rest of the Horde crew reached them, and blades crossed in a fierce melee battle. Salinean marines versus Horde scum? Seacat had no doubt about the outcome of that fight. She skipped them and headed towards the bridge of the gunboat, where the captain and two sailors were trying to guard the helmsman.

She wouldn't let them stop her, of course. They were covering the stairs leading up to the bridge, but she jumped up, grabbing the railing with one hand and pulling herself up. By the time the Horde scum had turned to face her, she was crouching on the railing, flashing her fangs at them.

After a moment's hesitation, the two sailors rushed her, screaming and waving their weapons. She jumped over them, flipped over, landed on her feet and lunged, driving her cutlass through the ribs of the captain before the woman managed to react.

The Horde scum collapsed, blood running from her mouth, and Seacat whirled. The two sailors hesitated again, one of them trembling. The other one charged, and Seacat met the goatman head-on, parrying his swings once, twice, three times until he left himself wide open and her blade cut his throat.

That was too much for the second sailor, who turned and jumped overboard. Which meant the helmsman - or helmswoman, in this case - was left. But the lizardwoman was already running towards the railing as well.

Which meant the bridge was theirs. That only left…

Something hit her, throwing her in the air, and everything went dark.

*****

Seacat woke up with a gasp - and started choking on water. She was underwater! And she was drowning! She started swimming, then stopped, trying to reorient herself. Where was up? And Down? Coughing and feeling her lungs hurting, she finally managed to figure out which way to the surface, then frantically swam up.

She broke the surface with burning lungs and splashed around, caught between trying to breathe as much air as she could and coughing out all the water. Then she realised the pain in her left arm. And that she couldn’t move it very well.

And that gripping it hurt even more. Hissing with pain, she saw that there was a splinter in her upper arm. She couldn’t tell how deep, but it felt as if it was almost all the way through.

Damn.

But the others! She looked around. She could see the gunboat, smoking, in the distance. Upriver. The Dragon’s Daughter V was alongside it. Good. That meant they had taken the gunboat.

But Seacat was drifting away from them - caught in the river’s current, around the next turn. She waved - with her good arm - and screamed, but she couldn‘t make out any reaction - had they missed her? Did they think she had been killed?

She had been blown into the water when the Horde scum had fired on their bridge, she realised. Had anyone seen it happen? Was anyone looking for her? They would be looking; the Captain would never abandon her. But they couldn't do that before they had secured the gunboat. And probably the barge.

Clenching her teeth, she started to swim towards the riverbank. She had to get out of the water and signal the others. Somehow.

With only one arm, it was harder than she had expected, and she was dragged downriver for quite a stretch, past another turn, before she finally reached the riverbank and managed to pull herself out of the water.

Panting and heaving - there was still water inside her, somehow - she collapsed on the grassy slope, hurting all over. And bleeding. She really needed to get that splinter out. Not right now, though - she would probably bleed out if she removed it. Splinters were tricky.

She rolled over, then hissed at the sudden pain in her left leg. A quick check revealed another wound - a cut this time. And some small splinters. She hadn't even noticed in the water. But it would slow her down some more. And it was bleeding.

She needed to bandage it. She had lost her cutlass - again - but with her claws, it was easy to tear the sleeve off of her left arm and use it to bandage her leg. Good. Time to get back to the Captain. And the others.

She took a deep breath, resisted the urge to cough again, and started up the slope - it would be easier to walk on even ground. Or sort of even ground.

Unfortunately, there was no road on the riverbank. Not even a dirt track. Just light forest. With underbrush.

Gritting her teeth, she walked on, keeping an eye on the river through the trees. It wasn't far. Just one, maybe two turns of the

river. Her leg hurt, and her arm kept bleeding, but she kept going. Limping, to be precise.

Every few yards, she peered through the forest. It wouldn't do to walk past the Dragon's Daughter V. Not that the Captain would leave without her. Unless staying would doom everyone. But that was almost impossible. The Horde would have to send a second gunboat at them - or two, now that they had taken one themselves.

Still… She clenched her teeth and forced herself to step up the pace, which worsened her limp. There was the first turn. No sign of a boat or the Dragon's Daughter V.

For a moment, she hesitated. She could wait here. The ship would come downriver. Even if they took the barge, they would come back. Or send the barge back. Unless they pushed on and burned the barge.

She marched on, hissing with pain when a dense brush rubbed against her arm. Just a little longer. Another turn. She could see the smoke from the battle, still.

Seacat stumbled and almost fell. Her leg twisted, and she felt liquid - blood - run down her thigh. And down her arm.

Damn.

Baring her fangs, she wanted to scream. Yell. Hiss. But she couldn't. Not in Horde country. Some of the Horde scum who had fled into the water might be around. And she was unarmed - but for her claws - and wounded.

She leaned against a tree, taking deep breaths. And blinked. This was exhausting. She needed to adjust the bandage, too. She tied it tighter, then almost lost her balance when she straightened.

Damn and damn.

She limped on. Just another turn. She could almost see the… there was something on the water. A boat. A longboat. And those were Salinean marines on it. Looking at the water. Looking for her.

She stumbled down the riverbank, waving. Yelling.

The last thing she saw before things went dark again was the boat heading her way.

*****

Seacat woke up in pain. Her arm and leg hurt. And she couldn't move her arm. But she wasn't wet or cold. And lying on something softer than earth. And she was on a ship - she could feel the slight rocking movement from the waves. And hear a familiar engine.

She opened her eyes. She was in a cabin. The Captain's cabin on the Dragon's Daughter V. Sea Hawk had given her his bed. Damn. Time to get up.

Her left arm was tied in a sling, but she didn't need the arm to walk. She sat up, pushed the blanket off, then turned to let her legs dangle over the bed - and hissed at the pain from her leg. But she wouldn't let that stop her. She had been able to walk on that leg before it was… bandaged and treated.

She could walk on it again.

"Stay in bed!"

That was the Captain's voice! She looked around. He wasn't in his carbon, the voice had come from outside - the helm - so how had he…

There was a thread tied to the blanket she had pushed away.

"I mean it, stay in bed, First Mate!"

And that had come from the door.

The door opened, and Sea Hawk walked in, frowning at her. “You’re not leaving the bed until you’re well.”

She wanted to tell him that she was fine, but she wouldn’t be able to fool the Captain. “What happened? We took the gunboat. Did we get the barge as well?”

“You were almost killed by a shell - the Horde gunners fired on their bridge,” the Captain replied as he walked up to her and grabbed her right shoulder. “Blasted you into the water, fortunately.” He turned her around and pushed her down. “Gave me a scare,” he added in a whisper.

She clenched her teeth. She hadn’t wanted to make him worry. He probably thought she was dead after that explosion. And if the gun had been loaded with canister instead of a shell... “Sorry,” she mumbled.

“Wasn’t your fault,” he replied softly as he pulled the blanket up.

“I should’ve seen the gun turning towards me.” The Horde scum must have noticed - or given the orders.

“You can’t see everything in a battle.”

She could - she had the best eyes of the crew. And the best ears. She pressed her lips together and looked away.

Sea Hawk sighed. “It wasn’t your fault,” he repeated himself.

But it was. She sighed. “Did you get the barge?”

“Of course we did!” He smiled at her. “And it’s full of fuel crystals! Enough to run a squadron of frigates for a month!”

She smiled, then frowned. “And how many such barges can they fill per month?”

“Two, according to our prisoners,” he told her. “And they depend on the river. We’ve got them locked down.”

“They’ll move the crystals overland.” That’s what Seacat would do. And Catra agreed. They would use carts and skiffs.

“They’ll try - it’s not nearly as efficient. And the Alliance will cut their supply lines.” Sea Hawk’s smile grew a little more toothy. “The Horde will have to fortify the mines and the entire road against raiders. And those soldiers will be missing from the other frontlines.”

That was good news - provided they could hold the fortress and keep up the pressure on the Horde on all fronts. She nodded. “So… we’re going to press on to the mine?”

He shook his head. “No. We already got this month’s production when we took the barge, and it seems the Horde garrison at the mine has been reinforced. And the fort ahead, of course.”

“Oh.” Well, the Horde wasn’t stupid. Not that stupid, at least - Catra knew that better than anyone else. “So, we’re escorting the barge back to the fortress.”

“With our new and slightly burned gunboat, yes.”

She sighed again. Then there was really no point in getting up and back on deck.

“You just rest and heal up,” the Captain told her. “I would rather not face Mermista with you still hurt. Or, worse, Adora.”

She blinked. “Face Mermista?”

“We’ll return to Seaworthy. With the Horde’s fleet now cut off from resupply thanks to our glorious attack, we need to plan our next offensive.”

“They still have five frigates out preying on our ships,” she reminded him.

He grinned. “They shouldn’t be a problem. We now know that they have the same engine as before - and I’m certain that my

dear Mermista and the plucky Entrapta haven't been sitting on their hands while we fought a pitched battle and took a key fortress from the Horde."

"You think they adapted the Salinean frigates," Seacat said.

"Or built a bigger, faster ship to hunt the Horde frigates down." He shrugged. "And even if they had more important problems to solve, I'm confident the Salinean Navy can handle five Horde frigates."

Seacat hoped that he was correct. Trying to conduct landing operations and supplying an army from the sea would be almost impossible otherwise.

"Now you stay in bed and heal up, you hear me?" He patted her head.

She growled in return, but with her eyes closed. And she smiled when he had left the cabin.

Then drew a deep breath through clenched teeth. This had been close. Far too close. And it was all her fault. She shouldn't have been so reckless.

*****

"Fortress ahead!"

As Seacat heard the lookout - Alcy this time - yelling, she suppressed the urge to get up so she could take a look herself. Sea Hawk didn't have a bell tied to her blanket any more, but his orders had been clear: She was to stay in bed. In his bed, not even her hammock. He was really pampering her. He wouldn't have given up his bed for any other wounded, would he?

Sighing, she closed her eyes. But he was the Captain, and his word was law on the sea. Or on the river, this time. Even if she felt guilty for being so spoiled. And guilty for liking it.

He cared for her. A lot.

She caught herself smiling.

He probably would've given his bed to her even if he were travelling with Mermista. And the princess probably wouldn't have protested, either. Even if it meant that they wouldn't be able to…

She grimaced and forced the thought away. At least she knew that Sea Hawk and Mermista hadn't done it in this bed. Not yet. That would've been very awkward, otherwise.

*****

"Freedom!" Seacat exclaimed as she stepped on deck. She took a deep, deep breath to reinforce her point, enjoying the fresh air - well, relatively fresh; they were still in the former Horde fortress's port, but the wind was blowing from the sea, so she wasn't smelling a whole regiment's worth of sweat from reinforcing the defences with sandbags and everything else they could get their hands on.

And from unloading the fuel crystals from the barge and loading them onto the Ice Spear at a frantic pace that would have the dock workers in any port shake their heads at them. Even so, it would take another day for the cog to be ready for the trip to Seaworthy.

There the transport could get an escort for the voyage to Salineas. A real escort - the Dragon's Daughter V wasn't a warship. And the small cannon they were currently installing on the foredeck wouldn't change that.

"You've been busy," she commented. While she had mostly slept.

Sea Hawk, standing next to her, looking as if he were ready to catch her at any moment - smiled. "If we were in Seaworthy, I probably would still be trying to get the cannon. But we're on the frontlines, and Kilian knows what he's doing."

“And he isn’t a jealous admiral,” she added.

“That, too.” The Captain chuckled.

“Mermista needs to clean up her officer corps,” Seacat mumbled.

“I expect that she will reevaluate a number of flag officers before the next offensive.” He still was hovering behind her.

She scowled - she wasn’t an invalid. Her leg was healing just fine. And she wouldn’t stumble and fall just because she had an arm in a sling.

“What’s wrong?”

“Nothing,” she replied. “I just feel useless.”

“You aren’t useless. We’re just waiting for the Ice Spear to finish loading their cargo so we can set sails.”

“I lost my new sword.” Which meant she was carrying a looted Horde sabre again.

“That happens. Mermista will get you a new one.”

“I know.” That didn’t mean she liked it. To beg the princesses for another blade, after having lost her new sword because she hadn’t paid attention to the enemy… it grated.

“And you’ve earned your new sword - that was a brilliant plan if I do say so myself. And you fought bravely.”

“But I’m the only one who lost her sword.” And almost got killed getting blown into the water.

“And you’re the one and only Seacat!” He patted her good shoulder. Gently.

She had to laugh at that. Genuinely, even.

Though that didn't change how she felt about her performance. She could do better. And she had to do better. They had a war to win, after all.

*****

"Sails ahead!" Licy yelled.

Seacat was moving towards the mainmast before she realised it, then stopped with a scowl. Her arm still hadn't healed up - she wouldn't be of any use in the rigging. Instead of climbing up, she moved to the helm. The added height of the afterdeck should let her spot the ships soon enough.

"Two ships! Frigates!" Licy reported.

Seacat pulled her telescope out. Two frigates…. The Horde scum were supposed to have split up. But they might've joined up again. And while the Dragon's Daughter V could easily evade them the Ice Spear couldn't. They would have to sink her themselves, to avoid the Horde capturing the cargo.

If those were Horde ships. She peered through her telescope at the horizon. There! She could spot the tops of the mass. And the Salinean flag. That looked like a Salinean rigging, too… Yes. Definitely a Salinean frigate. But the one behind was a Horde frigate. Under a Salinean flag, but that could be a ruse.

"Salinean frigate followed by a Horde frigate under Salinean flag," she reported.

"Indeed," Sea Hawk agreed. "And signs of battle. Now, who took whom?"

That was the question.

Seacat studied the frigate in the lead as they sailed closer. Salinean uniforms on the marines on board - at least as far as she could tell. No Horde uniforms visible. Obvious battle damage,

patched up - still missing a few parts in the rigging. But that would be there no matter who had won the battle.

She switched to the Horde frigate. No Horde uniforms were visible on deck. Mostly Salinean marines. Extensive battle damage. No way to tell.

"It looks like the Salineans are in charge," she said.

"Indeed." Sea Hawk nodded. "That could be a ruse, of course - but why would they attempt such a ruse on the open sea?"

"To catch couriers and transports unaware," Seacat replied.

"Possible - but this close to Seaworthy? And headed towards the port? Two frigates, even crammed full of soldiers - and the ships aren't riding that low in the water - won't be enough to take that port."

"Could be a raid. Wreck the port. Land a small force to plunder and set afire the supplies in the warehouses, and leave again."

Sea Hawk shook his head again. "Not the Horde style. We know the Horde frigates' orders. They are to raid the transport ships, not the ports. And Horde captains aren't really known for taking the initiative."

"There's always the exception," Seacat pointed out.

"Indeed. But I doubt this is one. We'll find out soon, anyway - we'll sail closer to see if we recognise the Captain. Damaged as they are, I think even the Ice Spear could escape them - provided that the Horde frigate's engine was wrecked."

If it was, then odds were the Salineans had won anyway. But Seacat held her tongue as the Dragon's Daughter V sped up and closed the distance to the two frigates.

"Ah! I do recognise Captain Isabel. Great sailor - no wonder she managed to best a Horde frigate. A bit of a temper, too."

Seacat closed her eyes. Another of Sea Hawk's past lovers. Great.

*****

The Reunion

Unlike the troops in the Horde fortress that they had taken with their - with Seacat's! - ruse, Seaworthy's garrison didn't let an enemy ship sail into port just because they were flying an Alliance flag. Seacat, still stuck on deck since her arm hadn't healed yet and she couldn't climb the rigging - well, she could, but the Captain had ordered her not to - watched as the cannons on the seawall were trained on their small flotilla and the four Salinean frigates in port set sail.

She frowned. Four frigates in port, together? With four Horde frigates still prowling the seas? She blinked. That meant…

"Mermista! My dear Mermista is in port!" Sea Hawk yelled loud enough for everyone on board to hear.

Right. If Mermista was visiting Seaworthy, the Salinean Navy would send a squadron of ships with her. Even though Mermista's power meant that any ship she was travelling on would outsail a Horde frigate even in a full lull. Couldn't let their ruler take even the slightest risk. Or, more likely, couldn't have Mermista show that she didn't need the Navy to be safe.

Sea Hawk was waving at the port - as if Mermista would be able to see him. Well, with a telescope, she might. Seacat snorted and took a closer look at the seawall. Soldiers. Marines. No scoundrels, of course - they would be preparing to flee, in case this turned out to be a Horde attack. But no Mermista. Not on the mole. Perhaps on the ships…

Seacat froze and turned back to the mole. There! On the tower at the end of it, which doubled as a lighthouse. She knew that blonde hair. Adora. That would make the other two the shrimp and Brain Boy. And the blonde was waving.

Seacat smiled and shook her head. Well, if Mermista was present, then odds were Adora was too - you couldn't plan an offensive

without She-Ra, after all. Or the shrimp.

She grinned - things were about to turn even worse for the Horde scum!

*****

“Cat-Seacat!”

They hadn’t even tied up the Dragon’s Daughter V, and Adora was already jumping on board. After rushing down the pier at full speed.

Seacat grinned as she shook her head. “Hey, Adora.”

But Adora had stopped moving and stared at her. “Your arm!”

“Caught a splinter in a boarding action,” Seacat replied. She wanted to pat the arm, but that would hurt too much not to wince. “It’s healing well.”

Adora looked towards the Horde frigate which was being tied up down the pier. “You boarded the frigate?”

“Oh, no.” Seacat shrugged her good shoulder. “That was the ‘Dolphin’s Grace’.” She nodded at the Salinean ship tying up two berths down the pier. “We met them after they had taken the frigate. We boarded a gunboat.”

“Oh.” Adora blinked.

In a shover of sparkles, the shrimp and Brain Boy appeared on the pier. “Adora! We were just waiting for the ship to stop!” the princess said with a frown.

And Adora ignored her. That would usually be amusing, but she was staring at Seacat in a way that was…

“A river gunboat? I haven’t heard of the Horde using gunboats on the coast. They aren’t made for the sea.”

“Yes. Escort for a barge. We were raiding upriver after taking the fortress.”

“That must have been…” Adora blinked again. “And it’s still not healed? How bad was it?”

Uh, oh. “Nothing life-threatening,” Seacat told her. “It was just a little bigger than the ones in my leg, and my leg’s fine.” She reached down to pat her left thigh with her right hand. “See?”

“You were hit in the thigh as well? By more splinters?” Adora’s voice was rising higher than Seacat remembered hearing before. Obviously, her friend didn’t see. And Adora’s friends looked taken aback as well.

“Just small ones,” Seacat told her.

“What happened?”

“My First Mate was taking on the captain of the gunboat when the dastardly Horde sailors decided to fire on their own bridge.” Sea Hawk had arrived at her side. “She was blown clear into the water by the explosion.”

“Ca-Seacat!”

Seacat rubbed the bridge of her nose and growled at her captain’s warped sense of timing. “I managed to get to the shore by myself, bound my wounds and was picked up by a longboat.”

Sea Hawk wrapped his arm around her. “And we were so relieved - we had feared the worst!”

Adora gasped. “No!”

Seacat pulled away from Sea Hawk. “I’m fine. I wasn’t seriously hurt - I could walk just fine. I was just out for a moment or so, and if the river hadn’t carried me away, I would’ve climbed back onto the ship.” And she would have, too!

Unfortunately, Adora didn't agree. "You almost died!"

And then Seacat gasped when Adora hugged her way too hard. "Ow!"

"Oh, no!" Adora released her, almost sending her stumbling back. "I'm sorry! I'm so sorry - I wasn't thinking! I made your wound worse!"

"No, those were my ribs you were crushing," Seacat replied with a wry grin. "My arm is fine."

"Your arm isn't fine!" the shrimp exclaimed. "Or it wouldn't be in a sling!"

"Glimmer!" Brain Boy whispered.

"What?" The princess whirled to glare at him. "It's true! She's as bad as Adora about her wounds! The two deserve each other!"

Seacat blinked. That was…

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. "In any case, no one died. Other than the enemies. But we should continue this discussion in a more comfortable place instead of on our ship." With a wide smile, he added: "I think my dear Mermista's quarters would be perfect!"

"Ah, uh… right," Adora said, nodding. "Should I carry you?"

"I can walk just fine," Seacat snapped. "My leg's healed." She demonstrated that by jumping on to the pier. And barely winced after landing. "Coming?" she asked, looking over her shoulder.

"Uh… do you know where Mermista is staying?" Brain Boy asked.

Seacat suppressed a hiss. "In the best inn of the town?" That was where the Navy's headquarters was, after all.

"Right!"

Seacat took care to avoid even giving a hint of limping as she marched off. She wasn't an invalid.

She also ignored the shrimp's muttered "Damn, they really act the same."

And Adora's reply: "No, we don't!"

*****

"Mermista!"

"Sea Hawk!"

Seacat looked away as the princess and the Captain embraced each other. And kissed each other. Passionately. And, apparently, without planning to stop any time soon. After a few minutes of not watching them kissing, and overhearing mumbled things she didn't need to know or hear, she cleared her throat.

And was ignored.

She cleared her throat again.

"Oh for…!" The shrimp stamped towards the couple. "Can we discuss the strategic situation before you two make love on the table?"

"Glimmer!" Brain Boy sounded scandalised.

"What?" the princess turned to frown at him. "They were acting as if they were about to do it!"

"Mermista has more decorum than this," Seacat pointed out. The Captain, though…

Sea Hawk used the distraction to release Mermista and clear his own throat. "Ah, right. Strategy! My dear Mermista, we return victorious! Not only have we taken the fortress guarding the main supply line, we also raided their supply line, securing two barges

full of supplies - including fuel crystals - and we boarded and took an enemy frigate!”

“And Ca-Seacat almost died!” Adora added.

“What?” Mermista glared at Seacat as if she was at fault. Well, she was, sort of, but...

“I got blown into the water and hurt my arm,” Seacat explained, pointing at her sling. “But it’s healing nicely.”

“And you got splinters in your leg!”

She glared at Adora. “Not any more, and my leg’s fine.”

“They thought you were dead!”

That was technically true, but Adora made it sound much more dramatic than it had been. “Look, I’m not dead. I’m healing fine - the wounds aren’t infected or anything,” Seacat said, forcing herself to smile. “So… let’s talk about beating the Horde!”

But no one was listening.

“What exactly happened?” Mermista asked Sea Hawk even though Seacat was standing right there.

“When we boarded a river gunboat, she took out the captain, but the enemy fired on their own bridge,” Sea Hawk said. “She was blown into the water by the explosion.”

Adora didn’t have to gasp like that. Or stare at her like that - she already knew that. Most of the story, at least. “I had already reached the shore and was walking back when I saw the boat looking for me.”

“What?” Mermista gasped as well. “You mean… no one noticed you being blown into the water?”

“They had to take out the gun, first!” Seacat protested. “And I think I was blown clear off the boat on the portside while we were boarding them from the starboard side. And Sea Hawk wasn’t even there, yet - our boarding party had hidden behind a floating log in the water, and the Dragon’s Daughter V had lured them into the trap by retreating downriver.” It was all very logical.

“They sailed past you?” Mermista looked angrier than Seacat remembered her being in quite some time.

“I was underwater until I woke up again - there was no way for them to spot me,” she explained.

“Unconscious… underwater… out of sight… wounded…” The princess was shaking her head.

“You almost died! Twice! Three times if we count the bleeding!” And Adora was yelling. Again.

Seacat took a step back. She was fine! Why wasn’t anyone focusing on the war?

“That does it! I’m healing you right now! For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Seacat gasped. Adora had transformed into She-Ra - and the blonde was pointing her sword at her. “Now wait…” she started to say. Then the sword glowed, and something glowy and sparkly washed over her. She blinked. Her arm didn’t hurt any more. Even poking the biceps didn’t hurt.

“Did it work? Are you feeling better? Are you still in pain? Do I need to redo it?”

“You mean this could’ve gone wrong?” Seacat blurted out.

“What? No! I’ve healed lots of people, and nothing ever went wrong. Well… once I got the hang of it,” Adora said.

“And you didn’t sprout wings, so that’s a good sign,” the shrimp added with a smirk.

“Wings?” Seacat blinked. “I could’ve been turned into a bird?”

“No!” Adora was glaring at her friends. “That was an accident, and I wasn’t trying to heal Swiftwind!”

Seacat quickly checked her body for anything missing or added party. Her tail was fine, her claws as well, no wings on her back…

“I don’t see any wings or fins,” Mermista said. “Is your arm healed?”

“I think so… Don’t!” Seacat snapped at Adora before the blonde could point her sword at her again. “I’m fine!”

“I only wanted to make sure!”

Seacat tried to ignore her as she pulled her arm out of the sling and rolled her shoulder - carefully. No pain. She started pulling the bandage off. There was dried blood on her fur around the wound, but no actual wound left. And her fur had grown back.

And Adora was way too close, staring at her arm.

Seacat pulled back with a frown. “I’m fine.”

“Trust, but verify,” Adora replied. “You almost died! Thrice!”

“That’s not what the saying means… I think,” Brain Boy said.

“I think that’s exactly what it means!” Adora countered.

“And I think you’re all crazy,” Seacat muttered. “Can we focus on the war now?” she added in a louder voice.

“Yes! Let us focus on a plan to beat the foul Horde once and for all!” Sea Hawk agreed. “We can focus on my first mate’s health afterwards.”

The grudging nods Seacat saw didn't bode well for her evening.

Sea Hawk seemed to ignore it, though, as he stepped up to the big map on the wall of Mermista's quarters. "Now, the priority should be cutting the Horde's supply lines so we can resume the blockade of their ports…"

*****

Half an hour later, Seacat was leaning against the wall in the back while Sea Hawk, Mermista, Adora, the shrimp and half a dozen high-ranking officers were arguing about strategy, tactics and everything else. Opening the planning session to the alliance staff hadn't done much to help, in Seacat's opinion. Quite the contrary.

"What a mess," She muttered under her breath.

"Hm?" Brain Boy, who was standing next to her, glanced at her.

"Nothing," she said, then sighed. "Just commenting on our 'strategy meeting'." She nodded towards the map, where Captain Isabel was outlining how she had fought the Horde frigate and why that meant they should focus on hunting down the rest of the frigates. Under her command.

"Ah." Brain Boy nodded. "Do you think they're talking too much about tactics?"

She snorted. "It's not that."

"Oh?"

The man looked genuinely curious, so she explained: "Knowing how Isabel has beaten a Horde frigate with a sailing frigate is important for planning how to deal with the remaining four frigates." He nodded. "But," she went on, "this isn't about that. Isabel is angry that we beat a Horde frigate in a courier ship, showing her up."

"Oh."

“Yes.” Seacat snorted again. “It’s pure jealousy.” In more than one way - Isabel also obviously didn’t like that Sea Hawk was Mermista’s lover. And not because she thought that the Princess shouldn’t dally with a ‘mere smuggler’, as one particularly stupid admiral had put it. No, Captain Isabel - soon to be Admiral Isabel, if scuttlebutt was correct - still hadn’t gotten over her own breakup with Sea Hawk. And it hadn’t even been a bad breakup - her ship hadn’t burned down, after all.

Seacat was about to explain a little more - but not everything; the Captain’s past was his secret to share, which he did, often and enthusiastically, but rules were rules - when the door was slammed open.

“Sorry for being late! But I was working on the latest iteration of my improved frigate-rated engine mark V, and I really needed to finish the power chamber so an accidental activation wouldn’t result in an explosion. And I’ve been told that that would’ve been bad here, since my workshop isn’t as fortified as in Salineas, so I have to be a little bit more careful.” Entrapta marched in, using her hair to move. “So... What did I miss?”

Seacat didn’t bother to hide her amusement at the reactions from the assembled admirals. Entrapta was a princess so they couldn’t sneer at her like they wanted to. And the officers wanted to sneer at the princess. Seacat could tell by how they stiffened, how they pressed their lips together, and how they mumbled their greetings. Others noticed as well - Mermista was already scowling at her staff. Even Adora looked slightly puzzled and would probably realise what was happening in an hour or two.

It was obvious to everyone except Entrapta, who beamed at the entire room, then focused on Seacat. “Seacat! I heard you were wounded! It wasn’t the fault of my engine, was it? Or the sword I built?”

Before Seacat could reply, the princess was at her side, waving hair and some tools around. “Oh! You’re not wounded. Was I mistaken?”

“Adora, ah, healed me,” Seacat explained.

“You almost died!” Adora yelled.

“What?” Entrapta gasped. “How did that happen?”

Seacat growled. “It happened during a boarding action in the south. I was already almost healed when we arrived in port.”

“You couldn’t use your arm!”

She wasn’t doing this again. Ignoring the blonde, she forced herself to smile at Entrapta. “But I lost your sword, I’m so sorry. It was great - cut through almost anything - but I got blown into the water, and when I woke up, I was already downriver.”

“Oh! The sword fell into the river?”

“Yes.”

“Was it active when it happened?”

“Yes.”

“Hm. I could probably locate it, tracking the battery… but… it’s not meant to be constantly in use. It’ll probably run out of power before I can find it.” Entrapta bit her lower lip.

“It’s also quite a distance away in a contested river,” Seacat pointed out.

“Right. That would complicate matters. I think.” The princess frowned. “But I can build you a new one! And one with a retrieval feature, so you won’t lose it!”

“A ‘retrieval feature’?” What did she mean? Some line to tie it to a scabbard? That would catch on to everything, especially during a fight.

“I’m thinking of making a bot to home in on it and retrieve it. If you lose it, you tell the bot, and he goes and fetches it.

“Ah.” Seacat’s smile froze a little. She didn’t want a bot. And she certainly didn’t want a bot following her just to pick up her sword for her - people would laugh at her. “I think I can do that myself. What about a tracker or something?”

“Oh! Great idea! I’ll build it into the scabbard! I could...”

Mermista clearing her throat - loudly - interrupted the princess. “Can we, like, focus on the offensive against the Horde?”

“Oh, right! Sorry!” Entrapta didn’t look sorry as she turned to face the other princess, Seacat noted.

And she chuckled when she overheard Adora whispering “You could’ve said that sooner,” to Mermista.

But then, the staff started bickering about tactics and positions again. And, of course, promotions.

Seacat sighed and closed her eyes. This would be a long afternoon.

*****

“...so, we’re in agreement. We’ll reinforce the fortress - which shall be named ‘Fortress Freedom’ - and stage our forces there. Our naval superiority will allow us to attack along two axes: Up north along the coast, and along the river. That way, we’ll be able to trap the entire Horde forces on the coast while we can supply our troops by ship.” The shrimp looked around as if daring anyone to disagree.

None of the officers did. A couple might have, but Mermista’s expression promised that the next idiot who annoyed her would be thrown into the sea. And, as Sea Hawk could attest to from past experience, it wasn’t an empty threat.

“Good!” The shrimp nodded. “Then this planning and strategy session is officially over.”

“Dismissed,” Mermista added.

Finally! Seacat pushed off the wall she had been leaning against and strode towards the door. It was almost dinner time, and she was starving!

“Seacat!”

And she was trying to escape Adora. But the door was blocked by a gaggle of admirals.

Sighing, she turned. “Yes?”

“Uh…” Adora closed her mouth for a moment. “Are you…”

Not again. “Yes, I’m fine,” Seacat spat. “No pain, no twitching, no tingling. Fine!”

Adora looked startled. “Uh… I wanted to ask if you were hungry.”

“Oh.”

“Of course she’s hungry. Everyone is hungry - we spent hours bickering here!” Mermista exclaimed - loud enough for some of the leaving officers to wince.

“We could’ve had the inn’s staff serve us some food and drink,” Sea Hawk pointed out.

“And drag this session out even longer?” Mermista scoffed. “Without the threat of starving, they wouldn’t ever have stopped trying to one-up each other.”

“You’re the princesses, you could’ve ordered them around,” Seacat pointed out. That was how the chain of command worked. On a ship and in the Horde.

“That wouldn’t have worked,” Mermista said - after checking that the door was closed. “They would’ve resented it. And we need everyone to be fully behind this.”

“You can’t order admirals around as if they were sailors. Well, you could, but they tend to resent it and become irrational,” Sea Hawk added, nodding slowly.

“Yeah, yeah, yeah.” Mermista scoffed. “Enough talking. I’ve ordered dinner for all of us to be served in the dining room.”

That sounded great! Seacat smiled. Adora, for some reason, though, looked disappointed.

*****

The food was great if a little late - the cooks apparently had expected the planning session to run a little longer. Well, that was only to be expected if they were used to Salinean admirals. But Seacat was now pleasantly full. Almost stuffed - sailors knew to appreciate good food after weeks at sea eating rations from the hold.

And her arm was healed, so she didn’t have to eat one-handed any more. Speaking of… “Hey, Adora.” Seacat leaned towards the blonde, who was finishing dessert with great enthusiasm - Adora had quickly gotten over her funk once the food had started to arrive.

Adora swallowed hastily, then nodded. “Yes?”

“About your healing. We left our wounded in the Fortress No. 3 - Fortress Freedom - but we should’ve brought them back with us, instead.” If Adora could heal the wounded, then that would greatly reduce the time they were out of action.

“Uh.” Adora blushed slightly and looked down at her now empty plate. “I don’t do much healing, actually.”

“Why not?” Seacat frowned. That sounded like an incredibly useful magic power.

“Well, it takes something out of me - I mean, it’s tiring,” Adora explained. “It’s fine if there’s a small wound to heal, but if it’s

serious…” She bit her lower lip.

“It exhausts her,” the shrimp cut in. “And we can’t risk She-Ra being exhausted near the frontlines. Which cuts down on the healing she can do.”

Because most seriously wounded would either die or recover enough to heal up on their own before they reached She-Ra.

“Yes. We found out the hard way,” Brain Boy added. “The Horde attacked after Adora had spent the day healing.”

“We had more wounded at the end of the day than before Adora started healing,” the shrimp explained. “And more dead as well since we couldn’t take out their troops quickly enough.

“Fascinating! You could probably find a formula to optimise healing using distance and severity of the wounds,” Entrapta said, looking up from her own tiny but numerous desserts.

“We’re working on that,” the shrimp told her. Seacat couldn’t tell if she was lying or not.

But Adora lowered her head further, not looking at anyone. “I acted without thinking.”

Oh, damn. Seacat reached out and squeezed Adora’s thigh. “You tried to help people.” That was more than most could say. Of course, that didn’t help the ones who died due to the mistake.

Adora relaxed a little, Seacat could feel it. “I heal when I can, but… there aren’t many wounded in Seaworthy,” the blonde said. “And most will heal up just fine without me.”

“Yes. So, we can save your healing for when it’s really needed,” the shrimp said.

“Like healing my arm?” Seacat grinned, then had to suppress a frown when she felt Adora’s muscles tense again. She hadn’t meant to guilt her.

“You’re… I had to heal you!” Adora blurted out.

“Thank you,” Seacat said with a smile. “It was a pain to do everything one-handed.”

Adora smiled back.

The shrimp grumbled something that Seacat ignored.

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk added. “Where would we be without the best first mate on all the seas ready for action?”

“We’d still be here, eating,” Mermista said in a flat tone. “Seacat just wouldn’t have finished eating yet.”

Seacat snorted in return.

Adora, tough, was frowning. She was about to say something, Seacat realised.

So she squeezed Adora’s leg a little tighter and let her claws dig in just a tiny bit, then smirked at the offended look the other woman turned her way.

“I had to heal you,” Adora mumbled.

Seacat didn’t think anyone else overheard her.

“I know,” she silently mouthed back. Just like Catra used to during certain lessons, safely behind the back of an instructor.

Adora’s smile grew, and she put her own hand on Seacat’s. It felt calloused, even through her fur. Warm. Familiar.

“Oh for… Get a room,” the shrimp mumbled. Loud enough for Adora to hear, who then withdrew her hand.

Seacat glared at the shrimp, who was glaring at Adora in turn.

*****

An hour later, Seacat was peering at the window to Adora's room. She could've knocked on the door, but with her arm finally healed, she had felt like climbing - she hadn't been able to for far too long and couldn't allow herself to grow rusty, after all. And she didn't like the thought of every guard knowing where she went. Not that she had anything to hide.

So instead of using the door, she had slipped out of the window without any of the guards noticing. That wasn't hard - the inn they were staying at was the best in Seaworthy, but it was still an inn in a port catering to scoundrels and 'reformed' pirates. And those people liked having ways to come and go - mostly go - without being seen by bounty hunters and other enemies. Which meant the building had lots of nooks and crannies to obscure such trips.

And while the Salinean guards had found a workaround about that by simply sealing off the entire area around the inn, it meant Seacat could probably enter any room unseen. Not that she planned to enter any room other than Adora's.

Hanging upside down, she knocked on the window.

Adora reacted at once - Seacat saw her jerk on the bed, then get up and grab her sword.

She waved at the blonde, still hanging upside down and saw her blink in surprise before Adora opened the window.

"Hey, Adora!" Seacat said as she gripped the window's frame and flipped down and into Adora's room.

"Uh. Why were you on the roof?" Adora asked. "I mean, there's nothing wrong with climbing in through the window! I'm just curious."

Seacat laughed. "I just felt like climbing." She rolled her left shoulder. "I couldn't climb well with my arm in a sling."

"Oh, right." Adora nodded, then smiled.

“Thank you, by the way.” Seacat looked around. Except for Adora’s sword and a small backpack, she didn’t see any luggage. “Traveling light?”

“I don’t need much.” Adora put her sword down next to her bed. “Anything you take with you you have to carry all the way and back,” she quoted one of Catra’s old instructors.

“Unless you stash it in the hold,” Seacat retorted as she leaned against the small desk in the room. It was a rather small room, for a princess, she realised. A bed, a desk, an armoire. Which would be empty.

“Well, we don’t have a hold when we’re travelling overland.” Adora picked up her backpack, which had been leaning against the bed, and put it into the armoire. Which had been empty as expected.

“That’s why you travel by sea, duh.” Seacat grinned.

“Not every place is on the coast. Or at a river.”

“All the places worth visiting are,” she shot back, crossing her arms over her chest.

“Not…” Adora closed her mouth and pouted at her.

Seacat smirked in return, then laughed.

After a moment, Adora joined in.

“So…” Adora trailed off, then licked her lips.

“So…?” Seacat tilted her head slightly.

That made Adora frown. “Did you just visit to inspect my room?”

‘I just wanted to see you’ would sound dumb. They had seen each other half an hour before, after all. “Well, you’re a princess now. Who else could check up on you?” Seacat dragged a finger over the desk, then held it up, checking for dust.

Her friend scowled. “I didn’t clean the room.”

“I can see that.” She nodded slowly, then acted as if she was blowing dust away from her finger.

“Hey! That wasn’t what I meant! I meant people clean the room!”

“Isn’t the officer responsible for their troops?”

Adora’s frown deepened. “The maids of the inn aren’t my troops!”

Seacat laughed at her friend. “I’m just teasing you.” She hopped up on the desk and let her legs dangle. “And you’re so easy to tease.”

Her friend’s frown turned into a pout. “That’s so…” She trailed off with a huff.

“Yes?” Seacat cocked her head and wriggled her ears for effect.

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again. “You!”

“Me?”

Suddenly, Adora smirked. Seacat’s eyes widened at the sight. That was… unexpected.

The blonde kept smirking as she walked up to Seacat. “So… why did you come, if not to inspect my room. Just to tease me?” the blonde asked in a low voice, putting one hand on the table next to Seacat’s thigh as she leaned in - close enough so her breath tickled Seacat’s ear.

Seacat swallowed and wet her lips before she realised what she was doing. This wasn’t going according to plan. Not that she’d had a plan. “Someone has to tease you,” she replied, sniffing.

“Oh, really?” Adora tilted her head, smiling rather… something. Something quite un-Adora-ish. “That’s dangerous. Teasing, that is.” She leaned in even more, her nose - her lips - almost brushing

against Seacat's right ear. "Someone might think you're not just teasing."

Seacat swallowed again. Adora wasn't supposed to be so… smooth. She was supposed to be the flustered one. What was… She blinked, then sniffed again. "Rum?"

Adora's smile became a little strained, and she pulled her head back a little. "Ah, I, uh… You know, Mermista loaned me some books. About sailors." Was she blushing? "And they mentioned drinking rum. So, I was curious…"

"What kind of books did you read?" Certainly not the official history of the Salinean Navy. Although rum featured there as well.

Adora blushed even more. "Uh…"

"Ah. About the adventures of dashing sailors? Like those you've read before?" Seacat was the one smirking now. She shifted around, trapping Adora's hand beneath her thigh, and leaned forward. "Did you like them?"

Adora pulled her head back a little more, which pushed her chest out towards Seacat. She didn't pull her hand out, though. "That's…" Suddenly, she frowned. "You talk like you've read them as well!"

"I didn't." Seacat snapped.

"Then how do you know what's written in them?" Adora grinned, a little hesitatingly at first, then more confidently. "And you spend a lot of time in Salineas. In Mermista's palace. I bet you read them all!"

"No!" Only a few, to see if Dread Captain Rolan was really based on Sea Hawk. And a few more, about the dashing rogue Siren.

"Are you lying? Your tail is twitching!"

She bared her fangs. “My tail doesn’t twitch when I lie!” It hadn’t done that since they had been eight.

“It wasn’t twitching.” There was that smirk again. Adora wasn’t supposed to be smirking. Not when they were talking about…

She licked her lips, then narrowed her eyes. She wouldn’t let Adora have the upper hand. She was Seacat! *She* was the dashing sailor here! And Adora was the fumbling naval officer! “But you’ve read them. And you liked them.”

“Did you like them?” Adora asked.

Their noses were almost touching now. She could smell the hint of rum on Adora’s breath. And the familiar scent of Adora.

“You’re purring.”

What? She wasn’t. She was. Seacat swallowed, then smiled. Toothly. “Yes;” she whispered, staring at Adora’s eyes. Daring her to… do something. To look away and admit defeat. She was Seacat. She licked her lips again. Not nervously. Slowly. Like she’d seen that Siren do, in the Enchanted Grotto.

Adora didn’t look away. She narrowed her eyes, huffed, then leaned forward, and their lips touched.

Seacat gasped. Adora’s lips were soft. Barely touching hers. And her eyes were wide. Surprised. At herself? But she was kissing Seacat. Her breath was tickling Seacat’s fur. This was...

Adora started to pull back, and Seacat growled. Pressed her own lips against Adora’s. Grabbed her head with one hand to hold her in place, claws lightly pricking her scalp. Her other arm went around Adora’s back. Grabbing her waist.

And when the blonde gasped, Seacat slipped her tongue in. Kissed her properly. She closed her eyes and moaned.

Seacat was panting when she pulled back, licking her lips. She didn't release her grip on Adora, though.

Her friend was staring at her, mouth still open. Chest heaving. Eyes, wide with surprise, meeting hers. "That was…"

Seacat grinned. "A proper kiss. Just like in the…"

She couldn't finish since Adora suddenly growled and grabbed her. Pulled her in and kissed her again. Harder this time.

When they broke the kiss again, both were moaning. And Seacat wasn't sitting on the desk anymore -- she was pressed against Adora, standing in the middle of the room. And her claws had almost ripped off her friend's shirt. Oh.

She looked into Adora's eyes. This was… this was…

Damn it!

Growling again, she pushed her friend back, towards the bed.

Adora didn't resist - she pulled Seacat on the bed. On top of her.

*****

Seacat woke up to the unfamiliar sensation of her pillow moving beneath her. Growling, she held on closer to it. She could feel the sun on her fur, and it was much too comfortable to move, much less to get up. Sighing contentedly, she snuggled into the pillow a little more. It smelled so very familiar, too. Perfect.

"Uh, Ca-Seacat."

And now Adora was trying to wake her up. What was wrong with these people? She huffed and squeezed her eyes shut in a clear sign of her disapproval.

"Seacat?"

Wait. Her pillow was still moving. Up and down. Slowly and not by much, but... And Adora's voice had sounded from…

She opened her eyes. Oh. This wasn't a pillow. This was Adora. Who was smiling at her.

"Morning."

Seacat blinked. "Morning." She started to take stock of their situation. They were in bed. In Adora's room. Both of them naked. And they had… She didn't blush. And if she did, her fur hid it.

Adora, though, blushed. And her smile looked… shy. Almost vulnerable.

They looked at each other for a moment. "So…" Adora said.

"So…" Seacat replied, then clenched her teeth. No, she wouldn't do this again. She was Seacat, not some blushing… whatever. She forced herself to grin. "Was it like in those novels?"

Adora's blush grew even worse. "Uh… I guess so?"

Seacat snorted. "You guess so?" She hadn't drunk that much rum, had she? Seacat knew how drunk Adora looked like - until she cheated and transformed into She-Ra, at least.

"Well… I mean, it's very different, reading about, uh, stuff, and, uh, doing it."

Adora was still blushing. And she was looking away. And Seacat felt her arms lift, then lower again - her friend would've tried to twiddle her fingers nervously if Seacat weren't occupying her chest right now.

This wouldn't do. Adora wasn't meant to look so vulnerable and shy. Seacat shifted until she was straddling her friend, both hands planted beside her friend's head. Her lover's head.

Adora swallowed in return, staring up at her. "Uh…"

Seacat bent down, silencing her with a kiss.

Adora didn't stay silenced for long, but she wasn't making those meek sounds any more. For some time, at least.

*****

This time, Seacat didn't fall asleep afterwards. But she still stayed on top of Adora, her head on the other woman's chest. Resting. Basking in the sun and Adora.

"We, uh, should probably get up."

Or Seacat would be basking in the sun and Adora if Adora were being good and enjoying the moment. "No. I want to stay like this," she told her without opening her eyes.

"Oh." Seacat could feel Adora taking a deep breath. "So… for how long?"

Seacat snorted. If you weren't at sea, you didn't plan out your basking and napping in the sun time. You took them whenever you could.

"It's just… I'm a little hungry."

Seacat resisted the impulse to make a crude joke in return. "A little longer," she said instead. She was getting hungry as well. Or was hungry. But… cuddling or eating… Her stomach growled.

Sighing, she rolled off of Adora and sat up to stretch. "I guess we should eat something."

When Adora didn't answer, she glanced to her side. Her friend was still in bed, looking at her with a smile. "I've missed this so much."

"Hm?" Seacat cocked her head.

“Waking up like this, you know? Back in…” Adora trailed off. “Sorry!”

Seacat chuckled and grinned at her lover. “We didn’t exactly wake up like this, did we?”

Adora blushed again. “No, but…”

“But?”

“Nothing.” Adora shook her head and slid out of bed. “Let’s get dress… Oh.” She held up her shredded shirt and pouted at Seacat.

Seacat chuckled and shrugged. “It was in the way. Besides, you ripped off my shirt.”

“What?”

“You don’t remember? You sent the buttons flying across the room!”

“You don’t use the buttons!” Adora protested. “You just tie it off!”

Seacat held up her shirt. “See?”

Adora opened her mouth then closed it again. “Well, you can still tie it together under, you know…”

“And you can wear your jacket just fine,” Seacat retorted.

“Fine!”

Seacat grinned. Victory!

Then Adora found what was left of her pants, and she was glaring at Seacat as if it wasn’t her own fault that her pants had refused to come off quickly enough!

*****

The New Clothes

"You ripped my pants to shreds!" Adora complained. Again.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "So? Get a new pair."

"I don't have a new pair!" The blonde dropped the remains on the bed.

"What?" Seacat turned to look at the pack in Adora's room at the inn. "You don't have spare pants with you?" Horde regulations had been to always carry a spare set of uniforms in your pack, as Catra knew.

"I do!" Adora replied.

Seacat raised her eyebrows at her lover as she tied her own, damaged shirt close. Who needed buttons, anyway?

"They're currently in the laundry." Adora grimaced. "I wanted to meet you with a freshly cleaned uniform, I mean, set of clothes, so I changed, and the maid must have taken them to get cleaned. While I was in the bath."

"Ah." Seacat chuckled. That was what happened if you didn't do your own laundry. "So, what about a skirt?"

"I don't have a skirt."

"You wore a dress at the Princess Prom," Seacat pointed out.

"I don't carry that dress with me when we're in the field. It's back in Bright Moon." Adora sighed and sat down on the bed, picking up her ruined pants as if she hoped that they would have been magically repaired…

Seacat blinked, then laughed. "Just change into She-Ra! You get a new outfit with the transformation, don't you?"

“Oh! I’m so stupid!” Adora beamed at her. Then she frowned. “That’s where you tell me that I’m not stupid.”

“What? I would never disagree with you about this!” Seacat laughed and patted her shoulder.

“Oh, you…” Adora glared at her, then suddenly smirked and grabbed her sword. “For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Seacat watched as her lover transformed. Adora was tall and strong and muscular. She-Ra was… all that, just more. If they did… She swallowed, then licked her lips before forcing herself to smile confidently. “See? You have pants now. And a skirt!”

Adora smiled back. No, that was a smirk. “Do you have spare pants?”

What the… Uh-oh. Seacat took a step back, then out the bed between Adora and herself. “In my room.” Unless the maids grabbed them as well for cleaning.

“Mhh.” Adora took a step closer to the bed and cocked her head sideways.

Catra knew that expression from several tussles usually in the barracks. Seacat made a dash for the window. She-Ra was tall, strong and a princess, but she couldn’t climb as well. And Seacat was still faster.

But not fast enough, as it turned out - just as Seacat reached the window, a hand grabbed her tail. “Ow!” she yelled, but her traitorous friend didn’t let go.

“Gotcha!” Another hand grabbed the collar of her shirt, lifting her up. “So…”

Seacat snarled and sliced through the knot with her claws. She slipped out of the shirt and dropped to the floor, then rolled to the side. “Hah!” She flashes her fangs to Adora.

“Oh, you…” Adora dropped the shirt and went after her again.

Seacat dodged to the side, then jumped over the bed. “Too slow!”

“I’ll show you slow!”

Instead of going over or around the bed, Adora cheated and pushed the bed towards Seacat. She jumped up and onto the bed before she was stuck between it and the wall, but Adora had been expecting that and dropped on her. “Gotcha!”

Seacat hissed and squirmed, but as She-Ra, Adora was too large and too heavy to get away. “Cheater!”

“Hah! Now let’s see how you like it when your pants are destroyed!”

“Adora?”

Seacat froze. As did Adora. That was… She turned her head and looked at the door. In the middle of the room stood the shrimp.

“Uh… This is not what it looks like?” Adora’s smile wouldn’t have convinced a drunk and blind sailor.

“You’re not trying to rip Seacat’s pants off?”

“Uh… well, I am, but not for what reason you think I’m doing this, I mean…” Adora blushed like a ripe tomato.

Seacat grinned. “We already did what you think we’re doing!”

Adora gasped. “Ca-Seacat!”

“What? It’s true!” Seacat frowned. Adora wasn’t ashamed of that, was she?

“Well, yes, but…” Adora trailed off.

The shrimp was grinning. No, she was gloating. “See? I told you to take the initiative! Hah! Bow was wrong!”

“What? I came to Adora’s room!” Seacat was the one who had taken the initiative!

“I kissed you first!” Adora protested.

“I kissed you first properly!” Seacat shot back. “And I destroyed your pants, first!”

The shrimp coughed. “Anyway… I just wanted to let you know that we’ve got a briefing after lunch. Or breakfast for you. See you!”

She disappeared in a shower of sparkles.

“So…” Adora, still flushed, looked at Seacat. “Lunch?”

She wasn’t getting away that easily. Seacat flashed her fangs in a wide grin. “So, you asked your friends for advice to seduce me?”

And there was Adora’s blush, back again with double the force. “I didn’t ask for help seducing you!” she replied. “I just… I asked for advice.”

“Advice about what?” Seacat asked.

“Advice about romance.” Adora looked away. “I didn’t… I mean, I haven’t had…”

Once more, Seacat had to suppress the urge to make a crude joke. “...a relationship?” she asked instead.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “And you had, well…” She shrugged. “I needed advice.”

Seacat nodded. “Well, it worked.”

Adora’s lips twisted into a smile that slowly grew wider. “Right!” She nodded again, more firmly. “So, we’re…”

“Lovers.”

“Lovers,” Adora repeated. “Good.”

“Good.” Seacat nodded. A moment passed. “We still need to find you replacement clothes, though,” she said.

“Right. Uh. In Bright Moon, I’d go to the tailor in the palace, but... there’s no tailor in the inn, is there?”

“No, there isn’t. The staff can mend clothes, I think, but…” Seacat held up the remains of Adora’s pants and shirt. “That’s a bit beyond mending.”

“The books never mentioned that problem.” Seacat’s friend - lover - pouted.

Seacat chuckled. “They also never mention hardtack and foul water. Or nasty weather. But we can get you a shirt and pants, easily.”

“Oh. I can borrow some from you?”

Seacat grinned. “They wouldn’t fit you. But don’t worry. I’ll get you some clothes that’ll fit you.”

*****

“Is that an admiral’s uniform?” Brain Boy blurted out as Adora and Seacat entered the dining room Mermista had commandeered.

Adora opened her mouth. “Uh…”

Seacat grinned and cut her off. “Of course not! Do you see any epaulettes or rank insignia on it?”

“We can see where you ripped them off,” the shrimp said, frowning.

“I didn’t rip them off!” Adora protested. “I mean…” she looked at Seacat. “You brought them!”

Seacat gasped. “I didn’t cut anything off! I found them like that.” In the quarters of the freshly promoted Admiral Isabel, ready for the admiral’s insignia to be sewn on, but that was a technicality. Grinning, she took her seat at the table, sniffing the air. Mhhh. Roasted fish!

“You didn’t really rip off rank insignia, did you?” Adora whispered as she sat down next to her.

“Would I do that?”

“Yes, you would.”

“Well, I didn’t!”

“But you took the uniform from one of my officers,” Mermista cut in, shaking her head.

“Well, they can get a new one. Adora needed new clothes, and they were her size.”

“Why did you need new clothes? Did you have an accident? I once burned my clothes off, but I’ve replaced them with fire-resistant ones and haven’t had a problem since. Do you want me to make you a fire-resistant set as well?” Entrapta leaned to the side, staring at Adora’s pants. “I could make leather pants that are treated against flames!”

The shrimp snorted. “Adora’s clothes had an accident with Seacat’s claws.”

Adora blushed again. “Well…”

“Retaliation after Adora tore my shirt off,” Seacat said. “Twice!”

“Oh!” Mermista smirked. “Like in ‘The Tale of the Daring Rogue’, right?”

Adora’s blush intensified.

“Were you sparring?” Entrapta asked, blinking. “Isn’t that dangerous without protective clothes or armour?”

“Oh, no!” The captain beamed at them. “They finally gave in to their passion for each other, and spent the night together! Ah, my best first mate had her heart stolen!”

Entrapta looked confused for a few moments while Adora babbled something no one understood. Then the princess’s eyes widened. “Oh, you had sex!”

Adora closed her mouth.

“Yes,” Seacat replied. The best way to deal with potential embarrassment was to out-embarrass the other side. So she grinned and said: “And if anyone is interested, I can tell you exactly how…”

Obviously, no one had ever taught Adora that - her lover slapped her hands over Seacat’s mouth. “And we should really talk about the war!”

Seacat pushed Adora’s hand away. “Really?”

Adora nodded, her jaw set, though she was still blushing fiercely. “Yes, we really should talk about the war.”

“We can discuss your relationship later, Seacat,” Sea Hawk said, still beaming at them. “I’d be happy to give you advice - I’ve got extensive experience with relationships!”

“And that’s exactly why you shouldn’t give them advice,” Mermista said. Judging by the Captain’s grimace, she was pinching his thigh. The Princess’s slightly forced smile changed into a genuine one when she turned to Seacat and Adora. “However, I’m available if you’ve got any questions.”

“So am I!” the shrimp piped up. “And who was it who told you how to approach Seacat, hm?”

“I’ve got some questions!” Entrapta raised her hand. “Relationships are a fascinating field of study. A confusing one, too, though. I’ve got so many questions! Or is the offer limited to Seacat and Adora?” she asked, frowning a little.

“Mermista will be happy to explain everything to you,” Seacat said before anyone else could answer the princess.

“Oh, thank you, Mermista!”

Mermista was again forcing herself to smile, but it didn’t seem as if Entrapta noticed.

*****

“We’ll visit a tailor!” Adora announced as soon as dessert was done. “Come!”

Seacat found herself dragged towards the door before she could say anything. And with Adora having a death grip on her arm, there wasn’t much she could do, anyway. “Right! We’ll be back in time for the meeting!” she said, waving with her free arm.

“I can’t be seen by Isabel in her uniform!” Adora whispered as they left the dining room.

“It’s not her uniform,” Seacat told her. “It lacks her insignias.”

“Oh, you - you know what I mean! She’ll know it’s hers!”

Was hers. And what could the new admiral do, anyway? On the other hand, Mermista would probably appreciate it if they didn’t rub it in in front of the new admiral. And she had sent a glare at them when they left. Probably because Entrapta had already started asking questions. Well, Mermista was a princess. Handling other princesses was her duty. And she certainly had more experience about that topic than Seacat had.

“Well, let’s see if we can find clothes in your size,” she told Adora. “We’ll make you look like a proper sailor!”

Adora grinned at that. “You think?”

“This is Seaworthy,” Seacat explained as they stepped out of the inn, “Any spare clothes the tailors have will probably be from a sailor who didn’t pick up their order.” Or made for a tavern wench, but Adora couldn’t wear such a dress - well, she could, and it would look great on her, but it wouldn’t work for a military meeting.

“Ah. I didn’t consider that,” Adora said, nodding with a serious expression. “That makes sense.”

“There might also be uniforms,” Seacat added. The closest tailor, and the best in town, wasn’t far from the inn. “What with the Salineans having been stationed here for months now.” The Navy and the marines were kind of fixated on uniforms being mended.

“Ah. But I can’t really wear Salinean uniforms, can I? I’m not a Salinean sailor.”

“Well… we could remove the rank insignia.” She grinned. “Or we just say we bought this uniform from a tailor!”

That earned her a deep frown. “No, we won’t!”

Seacat chuckled in return. Seeing Adora in proper sailor’s clothes should be a treat.

*****

“Oh! Look, Seacat!”

Seacat swallowed a curse when she saw what Adora was holding. How on Etheria had she found a Horde top in the shop? Why was the tailor stocking Horde uniforms?

“It’s just like the one you destroyed!”

Seacat could see that.

“And matching pants!”

Damn. Perhaps they weren’t her size…

“And they fit!”

Damn again.

“And the Horde insignias have already been removed!”

“Is there actually a demand for Horde clothes?”Seacat asked the tailor while Adora went to change. They were lightweight and sturdy, but… they were Horde uniforms.

“Not a big demand,” the fishwoman replied, the tentacles on her back folding towels and napkins. “But there aren’t many such uniforms in pristine condition, so it’s a novelty item.”

That might change once they brought in a supply ship full of the stuff, Seacat thought. “Not exactly pristine, without the symbols,” she said.

The woman winced. “Some people take offence at the insignia.”

“Ah.” Of course they would. Who wouldn’t? Hell, Seacat had liked shredding the damned things, last night.

“Look!” Adora actually twirled after stepping out of the changing room. “Better than new!”

Seacat forced herself to smile. That sight brought up memories.

“I think there are some in your size, too!” Adora went on, peering at the small stack of Horde uniforms. “We could match!”

Seacat didn’t quite hiss. But her expression must have given her reaction away since Adora’s smile vanished as soon as she turned to look at Seacat. “Oh, no! I’m sorry - I didn’t think.”

Seacat scoffed. “Heh, if you want to match, we’ll get proper sailors’ clothes!” She made a point of eyeing Adora’s body. “You’re

much too hot for a uniform."

That made her lover blush again - and forget about her gaffe.

And Seacat used the time spent looking around in the shop for decent clothes to calm down. Wearing a Horde uniform! Really?

*****

"I should've changed," Adora said, not for the first time, as they approached the inn again.

"No, you shouldn't," Seacat replied with a grin.

"This is highly inappropriate for a planning session."

"I wear the same clothes," Seacat pointed out.

Adora didn't have an answer for that. She didn't like that, either - Seacat could see her frown at her in the corner of her eyes. "Just enjoy looking hot," she told her lover.

"I could transform…"

"Not before your friends have seen you, I bet they prefer this look to your uniform, too!"

"What? No!"

"Wanna bet?"

Adora pouted, then nodded. "Yes!"

Seacat's grin widened.

*****

"Oh, Adora! You look great! Doesn't she look great, Bow?" The shrimp started to gush over Adora's sailors' clothes as soon as Adora and Seacat had entered her room. "And you match!"

“I approve.” Brain Boy grinned at her bare midriff.

“Uh… don’t you think my regular clothes look better?” Adora asked.

“What? No, no! These look much better,” the shrimp told her. “Less…” She trailed off and shrugged.

“Less Horde-ish?” Seacat suggested with a grin aimed at Adora.

“Well… Horde uniforms aren’t very fashionable,” the shrimp said with a nod.

Adora pouted. “They’re functional. Lightweight and protective. And very comfortable.”

“Protective? Not in my experience.” Seacat raised one finger and flexed her claw. “They rip and tear very easily.”

“You can tear through body armour with your claws,” Adora pointed out with a frown.

“Exactly!” Seacat’s grin widened.

“That’s not the point,” the shrimp said. “These clothes look much better than a Horde uniform. Much, much better.”

Seacat took a step closer to Adora. “Yes. And you don’t run the risk of being mistaken for a Horde soldier.”

“I never run that risk,” Adora replied. “I fight as She-Ra.”

“But you don’t socialise as She-Ra,” Brain Boy interjected. “And, well… Some people did mistake you for a Horde soldier.”

“That was only right after my defection, when I still wore the insignias!” Adora protested.

“Uh…” The shrimp grimaced.

“She didn’t notice, hmm?” Seacat asked. Of course people would recognise the uniform. At least those who had fought the Horde.

“What?” Adora blurted out.

“People realise quickly that she’s no Horde soldier,” Brain Boy said.

“But…” Adora shook her head. “Why didn’t you tell me? I thought it was fine!”

“It is fine. It wasn’t a real problem. It rarely happened. And we didn’t think you wanted to change your clothes. But now that you did…” The princess smiled. “And they look much better on you.”

“See?” Seacat smirked.

Adora pouted, then glared at her friends.

“Uh… is something wrong?” the shrimp asked.

“If you really like your old uniform, then you can, of course, keep wearing it,” Brain Boy said.

“We had a bet,” Seacat explained. “And I just won it.”

“Thanks to you two,” Adora grumbled.

“Oh.” The shrimp blinked. “You bet? What did you bet?”

Seacat grinned. “Oh, that’s…”

“Private!” Adora blurted out, “*Very* private! And nothing. Almost nothing!”

“Oh.” The shrimp’s smirk looked like it belonged on a cover of Mermaid Mysteries - as a villain.

Brain Boy looked a little lost.

And Adora cleared her throat. Loudly. “So! Let’s prepare for the strategy meeting!” She all but stomped over to the desk and

spread out a map.

Seacat nodded and joined her, putting both hands on the desk's edge and leaning forward.

And let her tail gently wrap around Adora's right leg and move up.

Adora stiffened - Seacat could see she was suppressing a gasp - then started to blush a little. But she stubbornly stared at the map, clenching her teeth.

Seacat grinned and made a point of looking at the spot Adora was staring at. "What's so important in the Crimson Wastes?"

"Nothing! I mean… Argh! Let's study the Horde defences! They've lost Fortress No 3, but still have troops guarding the passes and the edge of the Whispering Woods. Once we have destroyed their forces north of the river along the coast, we will need to..."

Seacat only listened with half an ear - striking through the woods or passes was landlubber work - and kept teasing Adora with her tail. She wondered how long it would take for her lover to crack. Just a little bit more...

"...and then we can envelope the remaining Horde forces guarding the river and the mines." Adora tapped the map with her left index finger.

Ah. The mine for the fuel crystals. If they took it, they would rule the seas uncontested. That would… Seacat tensed, then glanced down. Adora was gripping the tip of Seacat's tail with her right hand. Well, that was cheating. She started to pull her tail back.

And Adora squeezed. And kept talking as if she wasn't doing anything "Once we control the river here, the Fright lands are wide open for attacks from the north and the east." Turning to look at Seacat with a wide grin, she added: "What about landing operations along the coast?"

Oh, she… Seacat ground her teeth and leaned over. “The Salinean fleet can land any force where you want, as long as the Horde frigates are taken care of. Supplying them inland will need a river, though-oh.” She almost hissed when Adora kept squeezing her tail.

That wasn’t how this was supposed to go!

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Seacat was almost relieved when they moved to the meeting room for the planning session and Adora had to release her tail. Damn cheating Adora, abusing her greater strength like that!

But Seacat would get her revenge - she had won their bet, after all! The thought made her grin - and her grin widened when she noticed the sudden frown and uncertainty on Adora’s face. Stew on that!

But first, Seacat had to endure another hour or two full of posturing, bickering, and boring plans. How Mermista hadn’t drowned her admirals yet, and how the shrimp hadn’t teleported with her generals high enough to let them go splat on the ground, she didn’t know. Well, in the case of the shrimp, her mother probably frowned on that.

Sighing, leaned against the wall and looked at the ceiling. A dozen beams kept it up.

“Hey!”

She blinked. Entrapta stood in front of her, head and upper torso tilted as she smiled up at Seacat. How had the princess managed to sneak up on her? “Yes?”

“We haven’t yet talked about your new sword. And how your ship performed!”

“You want to talk about that now?” Seacat blinked again. It wasn’t as if anyone else was paying attention to them - the officers were

all focused on their power plays while Mermista and the others tried to keep them from tearing each other apart. Well, Adora looked like she was trying to keep herself from tearing them apart.

"Yes! I already said my piece, so they don't need me any more." She frowned. "And they didn't seem to be interested in my observations."

That sounded a little… "Observations?"

Entrapta nodded with a wide smile. "I'm observing the social dynamics of this meeting. It's fascinating how different people react to the same stimuli." Frowning again, she added: "But some reacted rather hostile to me observing them."

"Admirals are often like that," Seacat told her. "It's part of becoming Admiral."

"Yes! Mermista told me the same. But she didn't want to let me study the transformation, even though Isabel just went through it! The loss of data for science!"

"Ah." Time to change the subject - the rearmost Admirals were now glaring at them. "So… did Sea Hawk tell you about our adventures yet?"

"Oh, he did, but it never hurts to get more data. A second accounting would be very useful. Any tale is biased, after all, so you need as much data as possible to find the facts."

That made sense. The Captain had a tendency to… exaggerate. "Alright. What do you want to know?"

"Everything! Start from the beginning!" A strand of hair pushed a small device in front of her. "Speak into the recorder, please!"

Oh. Well, the meeting looked like it would go on for a while. "So, we set out from Salineas. The engine was a great help in getting

out of the harbour quickly and efficiently. It would be even more useful for larger ships," Seacat told the princess.

"Oh, yes - Sea Hawk mentioned a tugboat with an engine! A great idea! So, did you use the engine to travel faster?"

"No, we saved the fuel for battles."

"Hmm." Entrapta scrunched her nose. "That's an external factor related to logistical concerns. This makes it hard to actually test how the engine holds up in the long run. We might have to prioritise capturing the crystal mines so we can properly run those tests."

Well, they had to capture the fuel crystal mines to deprive the Horde of their use, but the result was the same. Seacat nodded in agreement. "But it performed very well in battle. It allowed us to capture a Horde frigate - together with your special solution."

"Special solution? Oh, that solution!" Entrapta mumbled some more lines into her device. Then it was held in front of Seacat's face again. "Sorry! Continue! Please."

Seacat cleared her throat. "Alright. So, after reaching Seaworthy, we sailed south along the coast, to meet up with the Ice Spear, when we encountered a storm…"

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"...and then we returned to Seaworthy."

"Fascinating! I wouldn't have thought that the engine would be so crucial during a storm! "

Seacat nodded. "Saved our ship and our lives."

"Perhaps every ship should have one installed for emergencies. A small one." Entrapta mumbled into her 'recorder' again. Something about testing tiny engines. "And there was no

noticeable change of efficiency in the river as opposed to the ocean?”

“Not that I would’ve noticed,” Seacat replied. “Although I couldn’t observe the ship going all-out in the river.”

“Why not?”

“Going upriver, we had to slow down to watch out for obstacles, and going back I was, uh, wounded and stuck belowdecks,” Seacat explained.

“Right! And speaking of wounded and rivers... How did the sword perform?”

“It performed very well - until I lost it,” she replied. ”Sorry about that.”

“That happens. Do you know how many prototype engines blew up in testing?” Entrapta frowned. “Wait, you do, you helped test them. Some of them.”

“They didn’t blow up when I tested them,” Seacat said.

“Right! That was the preliminary testing phase, not the field test.” The princess nodded. “So, any details about the sword’s performance?”

Once more, the recorder was almost shoved into Seacat’s face. “Well, parrying worked, and no armour withstood it. And I cut wood with it when we needed logs.”

“Oh! Woodworking! I didn’t even think of that application! I should make some saws using the same technology - that should speed up shipyard construction!”

Once more, the princess started muttering into her recorder. And once again, Seacat only caught about half of it. But faster shipbuilding was always a good thing - especially in war.

"...though the projected building rates would be bottlenecked by the rate at which engines can be produced, which, despite my efforts, is still lagging behind due to lack of trained personnel."

"Not every ship needs an engine," Seacat pointed out. "More transports would help as well." Especially with four Horde frigates still roaming the seas - a number of transports were overdue and presumed lost according to Mermista, and while some of them might've been lost in that storm that had almost sunk the Dragon's Daughter V, a number hadn't even been in the area at the time.

"I guess so… though they'd be slow."

Seacat shrugged. "We won't have the crystals for them, anyway, until we take the mines."

"Right!" Entrapta nodded enthusiastically, her hair bopping along. "Another reason to secure those mines!"

That had been mentioned before, but Seacat didn't say that. "Yes."

"So… your new sword. Do you want the same model? Or something with a little more functionality? I could probably build a saw-sword! You'd be able to cut even more wood with it!"

A saw-sword? That sounded rather unwieldy. "I'd prefer a cutlass," Seacat said. She wasn't a weakling, but she needed a lightweight, fast blade. Not something a minotaur would have trouble swinging around. And a saw-sword sounded a little too much like what a drunk pirate would buy because it looked dangerous.

"But with a fetching bot, right?"

"Uh… on a ship, space is limited. How about just a way to find it?"

"Oh. I guess that would be possible…" Entrapta sounded rather disappointed.

Seacat searched for something to cheer her up. “Did you check our ship’s engine yet?”

“Oh! No, I didn’t yet! Good thinking! Let’s go!”

As Seacat found out, Entrapta’s hair was still far too strong to get away once it had a hold on her. Well, at least it got her out of the planning session.

*****

“Oh… almost no sign of material fatigue! Although you didn’t use the engine constantly, so it was more like intermittent use… though you pushed it to its limits in the battle, which would have a stronger effect on the frame and driveshaft… and the fuel chamber is perfectly clean, though that was to be expected with the quality of the crystals used…”

Seacat, leaning against the wall next to the door of the engine room in the Dragon’s Daughter V, smiled, shaking her head as the princess got lost in her examination of the engine. At least the verdict sounded good so far. No risk - or no increased risk - of blowing up in the middle of a trip.

After a few more minutes and increasingly incomprehensible comments from Entrapta, the princess straightened, wiped some smudge of what looked like green liquid from her face, and nodded emphatically. “The engine’s performing within expected parameters.”

“I guess that’s good,” Seacat replied, a little snarkier than she had intended.

“Oh, yes! I mean, it’s not as good as discovering that your work is actually much better than you thought - although that could also mean that you didn’t understand your own work as well as you thought you did, which is generally a bad thing until you do understand what you did - but it means the engine is working as intended and my calculations don’t have to be redone. Which means my suggested table for maintenance doesn’t need to be

altered.” She frowned. “I hope that will convince the admirals to stop criticising my table, now that it has been experimentally validated. They didn’t trust my calculations, you know.”

Seacat snorted. “I wouldn’t count on that. The admirals - at least all I know - generally don’t like anything they didn’t think of.”

Entrapta gasped. “But… Why wouldn’t they accept facts? Data doesn’t lie!”

“People lie, though,” Seacat said.

“They think I’m lying? But I’ve never lied to them! Or to anyone!” The princess trembled a little as she shook her head.

Seacat bit her lower lip, then forced herself to smile. “It’s not your fault. The admirals are just used to everyone lying and trying to replace them.”

“But we’re all on the same side! That doesn’t make sense.”

Seacat suppressed another frown. Entrapta was, in some ways, the most naive woman she had ever met. She made Adora look like a cunning schemer. “People are like that. Not everyone, but many don’t care about anyone but themselves. Or they think that they know best.” She shrugged. “There’s not much you can do about it, other than outranking them or finding someone who outranks them and believes you.”

“Like Mermista?”

“For admirals, yes.”

Entrapta set her jaw and nodded firmly. “Then I’ll go and tell her to tell the admirals to trust me!”

Seacat winced. “Ah… not right now! They’re in the middle of a planning session.”

“That’s exactly why I need to tell Mermista that! Planning should be based on facts, not lies!” Entrapta rushed out of the engine room.

“Uh…” Seacat quickly locked the door, told Licy to keep guarding the ship, and hurried after the princess. She had to stop her before she caused a mess or possibly a rift in the alliance.

“Entrapta!” she yelled. “Wait!”

The princess stopped in the middle of the gangway. “Wait?”

Seacat pressed her lips together as she reached her. “Let’s walk slowly, OK?”

“But…”

“Please.”

Frowning, the princess nodded.

Seacat sighed. “Look, Mermista knows about this. And she trusts you. You know her, and you know that, right?” she said as they stepped onto the pier.

“But why doesn’t she tell them, then? They would have to believe me!”

“Ah…” Seacat trailed off. How to explain this? “She could tell them - and will tell them - that you’re right. She trusts you, after all. We all do.”

“Not the admirals! They don’t, or they wouldn’t treat me like they do!”

Seacat needed to have a word with Mermista about this. “I meant Mermista. Sea Hawk, Adora and her friends, and me.”

“Oh.” Entrapta nodded with a slightly puzzled expression.

“Yes. Anyway. Mermista knows that her admirals are being stupid. But she can’t just order them around. Well, she can give them orders, but not just any order.”

“What?” Entrapta looked confused.

Seacat sighed again. They had reached the waterfront. “It’s like… Some orders won’t be followed. And Mermista knows that. So she has to be, ah, diplomatic about it.”

“But she’s the princess, and they are her subordinates!”

“Yes. But if they all united, Mermista would have lots of problems. And if she treated them like…” Seacat trailed off again. She couldn’t say ‘like bots’; Entrapta treated her bots better than some captains treated their crew. “...As if they were stupid and didn’t deserve respect, then they would mutiny.”

“But telling them the truth isn’t treating them as if they’re stupid!”

“It isn’t, but they think so. Most of them, anyway.”

“That’s stupid.”

“They are stupid.” Seacat shrugged. “But that’s how it works.”

“It shouldn’t be like that! Data should matter!”

“Yes,” Seacat agreed. “But… it takes time to fix this. To find the right people and make them admirals. And get rid of the stupid admirals. Without making all of them mutiny.”

“She should promote you! Like Sea Hawk!”

Seacat snorted. “I’m a first mate, not an admiral. And I wouldn’t want to be an admiral.”

“Why not?” Entrapta walked with her hair and turned her body to look directly at Seacat without breaking stride.

“It’s…” Seacat clenched her teeth for a moment. “I don’t want to deal with stupid admirals.”

“You would be good at it, though. You understand this.”

She snorted. Not enough to deal with a room full of backstabbing officers. Well, not unless she had Mermista backing her to the hilt, maybe literally. It would be fun, of course, to take down the admirals a peg or two. On the other hand… “I just want to sail a ship and be with my friends.”

“And with Adora!” Entrapta smiled widely at her.

“Yes.” Seacat couldn’t help smiling. Adora. Her friend. Her lover. Oh...

“So, are you going to take her with you when you sail?”

Once more, Seacat clenched her teeth. “We’re fighting a war. She’s needed at the front. And I’m needed at sea.”

“And after the war?”

Well, that was a question Seacat didn’t really want to think about.

Fortunately, she didn’t have to - they had arrived at the inn, and Entrapta was distracted by a bot waiting for her. “Emily!”

The bot beeped - which made Seacat’s fur ruffle. It sounded a little like… She buried that thought. Entrapta’s bots were safe. Mostly.

“Oh? My supplies have arrived? Yes!” Entrapta turned to Seacat. “My supplies have arrived! I can now work on your sword!”

“I thought you had your workshop set up here already,” Seacat said.

“Yes. But I didn’t have all the materials I needed to make your new sword.”

“Ah.” That made sense. Entrapta would have prioritised materials for the engines - they were crucial, after all, for the war at sea. And who ruled the seas ruled Etheria.

“The materials I need to make the improvements for your new sword are a little temperamental, so they couldn’t be transported with the rest of my workshop. The interference from an engine - or a bot running at full capacity - might set up a chain reaction in the crystals if the frequencies should match.”

That sounded… concerning. “A ‘chain reaction’?” Seacat asked, trying not to sound concerned.

“Once the first crystal matrix absorbs too much energy, it collapses and discharges all of it - which tends to overload the closest matrixes, which in turn overload, collapse, and…”

“I get the picture,” Seacat interrupted her with a wince. “So… my new sword will also be a bomb?”

“Oh, no - once the crystal bonds with steel, the matrixes stop being able to store enough energy to overload since the metal will absorb the energy in the form of heat and vibration.” Entrapta blinked and then wrinkled her nose. “Although I could block that process, and allow the sword to explode like a bomb, I guess.” She perked up. “That would allow you to blow up your sword and most of the area if you can’t recover it! Mermista said that we need to be extra careful not to let the Horde get any of my inventions! This will work perfectly for that - great idea, Seacat!” Entrapta beamed at her, then whirled around. “Come on, Emily! We need to get started on Project: Bomb Sword!”

As the princess sped away, half-riding the bot, half dragging it with her air - Seacat couldn’t tell which was the case - Seacat couldn’t help wondering if Entrapta crashing the planning session and causing a mutiny among the admirals wouldn’t have been the better option. Or the lesser evil.

Entrapta had been talking about a bomb that would destroy not only the sword, but also the area around it, hadn't she? And she expected Seacat to carry it around and hit their enemies with it. That sounded suicidal.

But telling Entrapta that she didn't want the new sword, after the princess showed such enthusiasm… She would be so disappointed.

Seacat sighed. "The things I do for my friends…"

*****

The Night Out

"You sneaked out of the planning session," Adora said as the last admirals had left the room. She had crossed her arms and stood in front of the table. And she sounded… not mad. Not annoyed, either, like when Catra sneaked away in the Horde and left Adora with some stupid task. But she most certainly wasn't happy.

Seacat shrugged. "I came back."

"After staying away for most of the afternoon."

"Technically, I was dragged out by Entrapta."

"I saw that."

Yes, definitely unhappy. Something was bothering her.

"She wanted to check the engine of the Dragon's Daughter V so it won't suddenly explode out on the ocean," Seacat went on.

"Ah." Adora nodded. She sounded… relieved?

Seacat blinked, then grinned. "What did you think we were doing?"

"Uh… I don't know. I was just… curious." Adora grimaced.

"Were you worried?" Seacat joined her at the table, picking up a model of a Salinean frigate.

"Why would I be worried?" Adora asked. "I'm not worried."

"Well, I was kidnapped here before." Seacat added a fake pout.

Adora gasped. "Oh, I… I mean, I knew that, but I didn't think… I'm sorry!"

Seacat laughed, interrupting Adora's babble. Holding up a hand, she said: "I was just teasing you."

“Oh, you…” Adora’s chest moved nicely in her new shirt when she moved, Seacat noticed.

“Yes, me!” she replied with a toothy grin. That was payback for the tail-grabbing. “Anyway, the engine’s fine and Entrapta’s working on a new cutlass for me.” She patted the hilt of her current one. “I’ll be back to cutting ships in half soon enough.”

“You cut ships in half?” Adora stared at her.

“No, that was just joking,” Seacat replied. “I can’t actually cut ships in half - well, I could probably saw some of the smaller ones in half.”

“Oh.” Adora frowned. “I wonder if I could cut a ship in half.”

“Well, don’t try it on one of our ships. Or on a ship we’re about to take as a prize.” No sailor liked people who sank their prize money like that.

“A prize?” Adora sounded surprised.

“If we capture an enemy ship, she’s getting sold, including cargo, at the prize court in Salineas. And the money’s divided among the crew who took her.

“You get money for boarding Horde ships?” Adora sounded surprised.

“For capturing them, yes.”

“We don’t get money for capturing Horde whatevers.”

Seacat shrugged again. “You’re landlubbers.” Everyone knew they were worse off. “Besides, you’re a princess. You don’t need money.”

“I’m She-Ra.”

“Who is a princess.” Seacat grinned. Basic logic!

“I don’t have a country to rule. Or to tax,” Adora told her. “Bright Moon pays for my… well, for everything I need.”

“You don’t have money of your own?” Not even now, after all the time spent fighting for the Alliance?

“No.” Adora shook her head. “I don’t need money, though.”

Seacat gasped. “Don’t say that! Everyone needs money. Clothes cost money!”

“Bright Moon pays the tailor.” Adora shrugged.

“But what if you want something that Bright Moon won’t pay for?” Seacat asked.

“That’s never happened so far.”

Damn, Adora was too naive. If someone controlled your money, they controlled you. What if Bright Moon ever decided to demand Adora pay them back? Or just exploited the obligation Adora might feel towards them? “What about loot?”

“Loot?” Adora stared at her again. “We’re not bandits! Or… pirates!”

“Soldiers loot stuff!” Seacat protested. “Everyone knows that.”

“But… that’s against regulations!”

“Horde regulations,” Seacat reminded her.

“Yes! And the Horde is evil, so if they don’t do it, why should the Alliance do it?” Adora huffed again.

“Because that’s what soldiers do? You beat the enemy, you find something shiny, you keep it.” Seacat patted her cutlass again. “That belonged to a Horde sailor.”

Adora shook her head. “But… we’re liberating Etheria. We’re taking it *back* from the Horde. We’re not taking it for us.”

“Most of the stuff in the Fright Zone belongs to the Horde. So, it’s fine as loot!” Seacat grinned. “You don’t want to ask the shrimp every time you want something, do you?” She didn’t add ‘like with Shadow Weaver’, but felt guilty anyway.

“Ah…” Adora trailed off, then bit her lower lip. “No, I don’t.”

“Then you’ll have to take some loot next time you take some Horde fortress.” After a moment, Seacat added: “Or you become a sailor and capture a Horde cargo ship. A full one.”

Adora laughed. “Me, a sailor?”

“Well, you look like one.” Seacat made a point of leering as she looked Adora over.

And she was rewarded with a slight blush. “I’m She-Ra; I’m needed to save Etheria.”

“And after the war?” Seacat kept a smile on her face. They were just chatting. Flirting.

“Uh… I don’t know, actually. I never really thought about it, I guess.”

Well, that was something. Better than nothing. She could still hope.

Seacat smiled.

“But still… you sneaked out of our planning session,” Adora repeated herself. “Don’t you want to know our strategy?”

“I already know our strategy,” Seacat replied. It was obvious, anyway. “All I missed was the posturing.”

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again, pouting. “It wasn’t that bad.”

Seacat grinned and raised her eyebrows.

Her lover sighed. “Alright, it was that bad. I don’t know how Glimmer and Mermista can stand it - those officers were such…” She huffed, shaking her head.

“Such shellfish-brained idiots?” Seacat suggested. “That’s what Mermista calls them in private.”

“Yes, exactly!” Adora blinked. “She does?”

“Oh, yes.” Seacat nodded. “Heard it myself.”

Adora leaned against the table and slumped a little. “Why doesn’t she replace them, then? If anyone annoyed Hordak like that, or…” She trailed off, pressing her lips together.

Seacat knew whose name Adora had been about to say. And ignored the slip. “If Mermista got rid of everyone who annoyed her, she’d soon have no one left who’d dare to annoy her. Or tell her when she’s wrong.” That was how Sea Hawk had explained it to her. And that was what was expected from your crew as well.

“Oh. But how can she tell if someone’s right or wrong when they annoy her?” Adora frowned. “It’s hard to tell, especially with some of the more annoying officers.”

Seacat shrugged. “I don’t know. It’s probably a princess thing.”

“Right. I’ll ask Glimmer about it.” Adora nodded with a determined expression.

Seacat hid her smirk. She had been joking, but if Adora took her seriously… “Anyway, we’re set now, aren’t we? For the offensive, I mean.”

“Uh, yes.”

“Which means we’ll sail soon. Tomorrow or the day after, at the latest,” Seacat said.

“What? Loading the supply ships will take almost a week!” Adora protested. “That’s what Admiral Isabel said!”

“The supply ships, yes. But the Dragon’s Daughter V isn’t a supply ship - we’re a courier. We’ll be off to scout the coast for Horde frigates.” Sea Hawk wouldn’t sit around and wait for the admirals to sort things out.

“Oh. That means…” Adora pouted again.

“It means we’ll have to make this night count!” Seacat grinned, though she wasn’t too happy, either. Leaving your lover was a fact of life as a sailor. If Sea Hawk and Mermista could bear it, then she couldn’t do any less.

And Adora smiled at her. “Right! Uh, carousing?”

Now her lover’s smile felt a little forced, but if Adora was offering without Seacat having to call in her marker from the bet…

“There you are! Come, dinner’s almost ready!” The shrimp was there, with Brain Boy, standing in the door. “What are you doing there?”

“Err, Glimmer, perhaps they wanted a little privacy?” Brain Boy asked.

“What? No! They’d have gone to their room in that case!”

Well, she wasn’t entirely wrong there. And yet… that sounded like a challenge. Seacat flashed her fangs in a toothy grin and stepped up to Adora, wrapping her arms around the other woman’s waist. “We don’t need privacy. You’ve barged in on us before when we were in bed, haven’t you?”

The shrimp actually blushed. “But.. but…”

“That wasn’t…mph!”

Seacat silenced Adora with a kiss. A proper kiss. And ignored the shrimp clearing her throat a few times.

Adora was blushing again when they broke their kiss. "Uh…"

"So, someone mentioned dinner?" Seacat smiled as innocently as she could manage while she turned to face Adora's friends.

"Oh, yes. In the dining room," Brain Boy managed to reply.

"Alright! Let's go!"

*****

"...and the new sword should be ten per cent more efficient and have the same cutting power. I'm still ironing out a few small problems, but it's not going to explode unless you want it to!" Entrapta gushed while, somehow, managing to eat as well.

"That's reassuring," Seacat said before she could stop herself.

Fortunately, Entrapta didn't seem to catch the sarcasm. "I know, right? It would be quite bad if it exploded without you wanting it to!"

"Yes."

"Very bad," Adora added with a deep frown.

"Unless we managed to sabotage the Horde armoury with a few such swords." Sea Hawk rubbed his moustache. "That would be a tale for the ages."

"If we can sneak into their armoury, we can just leave a bomb there and blow it up," Seacat replied. "Also, I don't think Hordak or Shadow Weaver use swords."

"But their guards might use one!" Mermista said. "Exactly like in 'Double Dolphin Death', where the murderer went after the bodyguard of the actual target and poisoned them both!"

“The Horde armoury doesn’t distribute unconventional weapons,” Adora said. “Only standard issue.”

It was a little different in the field, actually - or at least at sea, in Seacat’s experience. But she didn’t correct Adora. If she sneaked into the Fright Zone, she wouldn’t stop at trapping swords. “Also, what if they are fighting our troops when the sword explodes?”

Sea Hawk frowned. “Right! I see I have to consider this a little longer.”

“Yes, please,” Adora said.

“So, when do we sail?” Seacat asked. She had to know if she could sleep in or had to be ready on the Dragon’s Daughter V in the morning. Well, she could take Adora to the ship, that would save her some time she could spend with her lover. Perhaps have her sleep in and only wake her up when they were already at sea… She dismissed that fancy with a snort. They both had their duties, after all - and Adora would probably swim back rather than neglect hers and leave her friends hanging.

“Oh… I think… When will the sword be ready?” Sea Hawk asked.

“I should be able to finish it tomorrow,” Entrapta replied. “Probably. The fine-tuning can be a little delicate. But it won’t take more than two days!”

“Then we’ll sail in two days,” the Captain told them. “With the tide, since other ships will be leaving port as well. We’ll confuse the spies that way.”

That would be… closer to noon. Good. More time with Adora. Seacat nodded with a smile. Mermista smiled as well, she noticed.

“The main fleet will set sail in a week, according to my admirals,” Mermista said. “But we’ll send out a squadron of frigates to patrol the coast in three days.”

“And two frigates with engines!” Entrapta added, nodding enthusiastically. “They’ll be ready for their sea trials by then!”

“Do you have the time to be working on my sword, then?” Seacat asked. If the princess neglected the Salinean ships for a mere sword...

“Oh, it’s mostly the sailors getting familiar with the engines - I finished the work on them. And Emily and the others are still assembling the next engine,” Entrapta replied. “And you need your new sword - you’ll be fighting again, soon, right?”

“That depends entirely on the Horde,” Sea Hawk told her. “If we find a transport on the way, we’ll board it, but if the craven scumbags are hiding in port, we won’t see action until the campaign up the river starts.”

And the fighting in the river would be nasty. All those forests hiding artillery, close-range battles with gunboats… “What about our swivel gun?” Seacat asked.

“I’ve ordered one to be sent to the Dragon’s Daughter V,” Mermista said.

“We can exercise the crew on it on the way.” Sea Hawk nodded.

And install it on the way, should they have set sail tomorrow? Well, it was only a swivel gun; easy to set up. “Good.”

“I still can’t believe you were sailing into war without guns;” the shrimp said.

Seacat snorted. “The Dragon’s Daughter V is a courier ship. The kind of guns we could mount wouldn’t do anything in a naval battle - the only ships they could hurt would be so small, we could easily board them instead.”

“What about other courier ships?” Adora asked.

“They couldn’t carry enough guns to keep us from boarding them,” Seacat replied.

“Indeed! Doubly so now that we have Entrapa’s marvellous engine!” Sea Haw added. “Oh, I wish I had seen the faces of the Horde scum when we rushed at that frigate! Hoisted by their own petard!”

Seacat chuckled at the memory. It had been dangerous - but they had pulled it off. Saved the Ice Spear and took down a frigate.

“Well, no need for such heroics,” Mermista said. “Not with our frigates now being able to match the Horde frigate’s engines.”

“Surpass, actually,” Entrapta piped up. “By my calculations, they are twenty per cent faster than Horde ships at the least. More if they can use their sails as well.”

That was good news. “Great!” Seacat beamed at the princess. With such ships, the Horde would soon be driven from the seas. Again.

*****

“Alright!” Seacat pushed the empty dessert bowl away to make a point. It wasn’t as if she felt a serious urge to lick it clean - she hadn’t done that in years, at least not at a dinner that wasn’t served on deck. But now it was time to start carousing! “Time to get some air! See you all!” she announced, then grabbed Adora’s hand and led her out of the room.

But before they even reached the stairs, the shrimp and Brain Boy appeared in a shower of sparkles in front of them. “There you are!” the shrimp spoke up “Let’s talk!”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. The grin on the princess’s face would’ve fit a Horde propaganda poster about evil princesses.

Adora must have felt the same since she looked flustered. “Talk? About what?”

“You two, of course!” The shrimp pointed at Adora, then at Seacat. “You’ve finally done the deed! Now I want details!”

“What? Details?” Adora was blushing again. “I mean…”

“Glimmer!” Brain Boy cut in with a frown at the shrimp. “We’re just curious how you worked out your, ah… issues.”

“Worked out?” Adora sounded like Entrapta’s recorder. “Issues?”

“How you overcame your differences and found love in each other’s arms!” the shrimp explained. “Though a few details wouldn’t go amiss,” she added with a toothy grin.

Seacat glared at Adora. Those were *her* friends and *her* responsibility.

“Glimmer! I’m not - we’re not - going to tell you about *that*!” Adora gasped.

The princess giggled in return. “Relax, I was joking about that.” She waved her hand and stepped up to them. “But, seriously, are you a couple now? Officially? This isn’t some sailor fling, is it?” she added with a frown at Seacat.

Adora blinked. “Uh…”

“Yes, we’re a couple,” Seacat told the princess, returning the frown. With interest. What did the shrimp think she was? Some sailor with a lover in every port? Adora was… *Adora*.

Adora nodded, beaming. “Yes!” She looked a little too relieved. They might have to talk about that.

“What Glimmer meant to ask,” Brain Boy cut in, sounding a little sterner than usual, “is: How do you plan to handle it when you have to separate for the offensive?”

Right. They probably had to talk about that, too. Seacat didn’t want to, though.

“Uh…”

The shrimp sighed and hung her head for a moment. “You haven’t talked about that, have you?”

“We discussed it. Briefly,” Adora told her.

“Very briefly.” Technically. “Why do you want to know?” Seacat asked.

“Because Adora is my friend, and she was moping for weeks over you!” The shrimp glared at her.

“You were?” Seacat grinned at her lover.

“I wasn’t moping!” Adora still couldn’t lie. “Well… I was…” She twiddled her thumbs. “...concerned. Missing you,” she added with a sigh and a sappy smile.

Seacat found herself smiling as well. It felt good to know this.

“And now you’ll be moping when we’re on campaign. Again.” the shrimp grumbled.

“I won’t!”

“You won’t miss me?” Seacat asked, raising her eyebrows?

“Well, yes, of course… But I won’t mope!” Adora nodded with a determined expression.

The shrimp and Brain Boy sighed. “And have you given any thought to the future?” the princess asked.

“Uh…”

“We need to win the war, first,” Seacat told them. “We can sort things out afterwards.”

“Things?” Adora asked.

“Us.” Seacat clenched her teeth. They didn’t need to discuss this right now. Not with so little time left to be together. And Sea Hawk and Mermista proved that you could have a relationship without working out everything. Granted, they had a very stormy relationship for years, before finally settling down, but… She sighed. “We’ll work something out.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed.

“But now it’s time for carousing!” Seacat announced.

“Great!” The shrimp said. “This will be fun, Bow!”

Wait! She hadn’t meant it like that!

*****

The light hurt. It burned straight into her eyes. Trying to fry her brain. And her head hurt. As she had taken part in a headbutting competition wth a goatman. She tried to close her eyes, then realised she was already squeezing them closed. “Damn, what happened?” she mumbled, shielding her face with her arm.

“A drinking competition happened.”

“Can’t be. I can drink anyone under the table.” She started to shake her head, then stopped, groaning at the pain that this caused.

“Well, you beat Glimmer, but… the ‘celebration beer’ you had afterwards sent you to join her.” Adora sounded amused.

Seacat risked opening one eye, safely behind her arm, and squinted. There was Adora, sitting on the bed - lounging, actually - and watching her. She didn’t look as if she had a hangover, but then, She-Ra cheated. “Well, I won!” That was what counted. Seacat couldn’t let the shrimp outdrink her. Or out-carouse. She had a reputation to maintain.

“You did.” Adora gently shook her head.

“What happened afterwards? Did I sleep until now?”

“You don’t rem…” Adora bit her lower lip. “Sorry.”

Once more, Seacat started to shake her head and stopped, wincing, before waving her hand instead. The one not shielding her eyes. “No, no, it’s not a problem. Drinking too much isn’t, you know, the same as…” She pressed her lips together. She had recovered her memory, her past, but she still remembered the years spent without knowing, wondering who she was, what family she had had.

“Yes.” Adora smiled. “Anyway, you weren’t really asleep, just… drunk. Very drunk.”

“Ah.” No nodding, that hurt. She grinned. “So, we caroused, and then…?” She raised her eyebrows.

“Then you fell asleep,” Adora replied with a slight frown.

Ah. So much for a passionate night. “Sorry,” Seacat told her lover. “I guess I… it’s the shrimp’s fault.” Seacat wouldn’t have entered a drinking competition with the princess if the princess hadn’t insisted on tagging along.

“I bet that’s what Glimmer’s saying, just with your roles reversed.”

“Well, if she is, she’s wrong.” Seacat slowly, oh so slowly, got up. “Ow.”

“Do you want me to heal you? Healing a hangover wouldn’t take much out of me…”

“What? No, no! Save your, ah, magic, for people who need it.” Seacat could stand a little hangover. Easily. Any sailor worth their salt could.

She just needed a little time for her head to adjust to its new lofty position above the rest of her body, instead of buried into the pillow.

“Well, let me help you!”

Seacat squeaked when she felt strong arms pick her up - and hold her. “Hey! Let me down! I can walk!” Eventually.

“No.”

“Of course I can’t if you’re holding me!” They were at the bathroom. “Hey! What do you think you’re doing?” Seacat protested as she was set down in the tub.

“If I leave you to yourself, you’ll probably take the whole morning. And I want to spend more time with you before you have to set sails.” Adora smiled at her again.

And Seacat’s next protest died on her lips.

Until the cold water hit her. Then it was back with a vengeance.

*****

Seacat was still a little mad at Adora for the whole cold shower thing - you used cold water to sober sailors up when they were drunk! You didn’t use it to help with hangovers! Her lover should’ve known that! - but seeing the shrimp all but comatose at breakfast, her head resting on the table with her face down, quickly got her over that. “Hey, you two!” she greeted the princess and Brain Boy, a little louder than necessary.

The shrimp just groaned. “I’m never drinking again,” Seacat heard her mumble into the table.

Brain Boy winced a little. “Good morning.”

“Glimmer? Are you alright?” Adora asked.

“Leave me in peace. I’m dying here.”

“Well, you should’ve known better than to challenge me,” Seacat told her. “Especially as a landlubber.”

“Landlubber?” the princess raised her head to glare at her, but her expression turned into a wince. “Ow!”

Seacat shook her head, ignoring the slight pain that caused her. “Well, you aren’t a sailor, are you? Then you’re a landlubber.” She grabbed some bread and eggs - one of the treats she missed at sea. Unless you wanted to share your deck with a chicken coop - and what self-respecting sailor would do that? - you couldn’t get fresh eggs at sea.

“I’m a commander!”

“A landlubber commander, yes.”

“Are you really arguing over that?” Brain Boy asked.

“Yes.”

“Please…” Adora smiled at both of them. “Let’s just enjoy the meal!”

“I’m enjoying my meal,” Seacat pointed out. “It’s the shrimp who’s dying.”

“I’m not dying!” the princess protested.

“You just said you were,” Seacat told her, grinning. “Was that a lie?”

“Oh, you!” Now the shrimp was glaring at her. “This is all your fault!”

“Who challenged me to a drinking contest?” Seacat raised her eyebrows.

“You claimed you could drink anyone under the table!”

“And I proved it, didn’t I?”

“As I was told, you only beat me by a single glass!”

Seacat chuckled. “But I beat you. And that...”

“...is enough of that,” Adora cut in. Her hand, which was somehow on Seacat’s thigh, squeezed. A little harder than Seacat liked. “We’ve got a day to enjoy before you set sails again, and we go back to Bright Moon to launch the offensive, and I will enjoy it to the fullest!”

Her lover looked slightly manic as she stated that, Seacat couldn’t help noticing. And, judging by the expressions on her friends’ faces, they had noticed as well.

Best to agree. Besides, Adora had the right idea. They needed to enjoy the time they had. Who knew what the future would bring?

*****

“Come on! Hurry!” Seacat not-quite-yelled as she pulled on Adora’s hand. They had to run.

“Why are we running?” Adora asked as they rounded the corner of the narrow back alley. “We’ve lost Glimmer and Bow - Ew!!” she complained as they ran past a midden heap in the middle of the alley.

That was why they were running, of course. Seacat had no intention to spend another evening and night with Adora’s friends. Not when this was the last night for them before they had to part. And Seacat knew exactly where to go this evening. Without the shrimp or Brain Boy.

“Don’t worry about them. The shrimp can teleport, right?” Seacat asked as she dragged Adora down an even narrower alley - more like a tunnel, as at least half the buildings on either side touched each other above the alley.

“But she doesn’t know where we’re going!”

“What an unfortunate oversight!” Seacat didn’t bother to hide her grin.

“Yes, so… Oh! You wanted to lose them!”

She flashed her fangs at her lover in response.

“But we could’ve just told them so!”

“This way, it’s all my fault, and they won’t be angry with you,” Seacat told her.

“But…”

“No ‘but’! Besides, we’re here!” They had just left the tunnel and stood in another, slightly wider side alley.

“We are?” Adora looked around.

“That’s the back entrance,” Seacat explained as she knocked on the closest door.

“The back entrance to what?” Adora asked.

Seacat grinned at her. “The best place to dance in Seaworthy.”

“Dancing? I’m not dressed to dance!” Adora complained.

“Oh, you’re perfectly dressed,” Seacat told her. Indeed - with her top and leggings, matching Seacat’s, Adora would fit in perfectly.

The door opened, and a grey-haired female minotaur peered at them. “What do you want?”

Seacat flicked a coin to the woman. “We don’t want to take the front entrance.”

“We don’t? Why not?” Adora asked as the woman let them in.

So her friends would have a harder time finding them, of course. But Seacat didn’t tell Adora that. She led her lover through the corridor, past the kitchen, towards the music she could hear.

Pushing the curtain separating the corridor leading to the kitchen aside, she beamed at Adora. “The Dancing Swordfish!”

Her friend stared at the sight in front of her: There was a small stage, with a few musicians on it and a singer. A siren, actually - Ludmilly Love, straight from the Enchanted Grotto. Or so the festhall claimed. Seacat didn’t care - the singer was good enough either way. Her voice sent shivers down your spine and made your body *move*.

The people on the dancing floor in front of the stage were proof of that. They were dancing like they were born to it, with the kind of attitude you usually needed a decent amount of booze to achieve. The kind of attitude when nothing but dancing - with your lover - mattered. No one was wearing fancy clothes or a lot of jewellery, but there weren’t any ragged clothes either.

“Oh.” Adora was still staring. And swallowing.

“The food and drink aren’t that good here,” Seacat told her as she took her hand, “but the music is always the best in Seaworthy.” She started pulling Adora along. “Let’s dance, shall we?” She was already feeling the urge.

As did Adora - before they had crossed the half a dozen yards to the dance floor, her friend was pulling her along.

And then they were dancing, in step with the rhythm. Moving without a care in the middle of a crowd, yet dancing together. Seacat raised her hands above her head and shook her hips, stepping up to Adora, pushing her chest towards the other woman. Her lover mirrored her. Fleeting touches followed as they twirled and turned. Her ponytail had come undone at some point, and her mane was falling around her shoulders.

It fit.

When the song changed, the drums featuring more prominently - the musicians had a fishwoman with tentacles playing the drums -

Seacat tuned her back to Adora, then leaned in, pressing her back into her lover's front, grinding against her.

She felt strong hands grab hers, still swaying above her head, and they started to move in sync. Seacat closed her eyes, focusing on the music - and on feeling Adora behind her. Against her.

Her heart was pounding, and she was panting, she realised. But they weren't dancing that fast. Or that wild.

Oh.

Yes.

This was perfect.

Then the song ended, and the singer started another. A slow piece. Very slow. And the lights dimmed further.

Adora's hands released hers, and before Seacat could protest, Adora grabbed her shoulders and turned her around - then pulled her close.

Oh.

They were swaying gently, slowly turning around themselves - together. So close, Adora's breath tickled her right ear.

Seacat moaned, softly, and leaned in, once more closing her eyes, taking deep breaths. Smelling Adora's scent. Pressing her face against Adora's shoulder. Yes. This was perfect. She ran her hands over Adora's back, then grabbed, lightly poking her with her claws, and felt Adora's body tense.

Just like back at the Prom. No, better than that. Adora's own hands caressed her back, one going up to cup the back of her head, fingers entangling themselves in Seacat's hair. Pulling her back.

She opened her eyes, opened her mouth to protest - she wanted to dance like before, to be so close - but Adora's lips met hers and silenced her before she could find the words.

Perfect.

*****

Seacat was flushed when, after a few more songs, they finally looked for a table. They hadn't done anything too untoward, as a princess other than the shrimp would probably call it, but she felt as if they had.

They found a table without anyone sitting at it - and the jacket on the bench was easily kicked away without Adora noticing - and took a seat. Well, Adora did - Seacat crawled into her lap and shifted around so she could lean against Adora's front.

"So?"

"So?"

"What do you think?"

"It's… great," Adora said.

Seacat didn't have to turn around to know that her lover was both beaming and blushing. She did it anyway, to plant a kiss on her. "Mhh."

"I didn't know about this place," Adora said afterwards. "Why didn't we visit before?"

"It's got the best music - you heard the singer. But the food and drink are expensive, and I told you that they aren't that good," Seacat explained.

"But the dancing! That's…"

“It’s perfect if you’re not alone,” Seacat told her. “Or if you’re looking for someone.”

“Oh. Is that why you didn’t want Glimmer and Bow to come with us? So they wouldn’t feel, ah, left out?”

Seacat chose to answer that with a humming noise and let Adora draw her own conclusion. Whether or not the shrimp and Brain Boy hooked up with each other or spent the night with someone else after flirting on the dance floor wasn’t her business.

All she wanted was to spend this night with her lover.

She sighed and leaned into Adora again, craning her head to look at her. She felt Adora’s arms tighten around her waist and smiled.

Perfect.

*****

Seacat sighed happily as they left the festhall - through the main door, this time. She was holding Adora’s hand, and the cooler air of the evening - the night, actually - felt nice on her fur after the time spent inside. Refreshing.

“That was…” Adora trailed off.

Seacat turned to smile at her. “Of course it was! My idea, remember?”

“You don’t even know what I was about to say!” Adora protested.

“Of course I do. You wanted to say ‘That was great, Seacat! Thank you for taking me here and for showing me a good time’!”

“I didn’t want to say that!” Adora shook her head.

“You didn’t know what you wanted to say. That’s why you didn’t say anything,” Seacat told her with a laugh. “Luckily, I know what you should’ve said.”

“Oh, you…” Adora shook her head, chuckling. “Well, it was very nice.”

“Of course it was!” Seacat pulled on her hand. “Come on!”

“Where are we going now?”

“Back to the inn.” Seacat flashed her fangs in a wide grin at her

“Oh.” Adora was blushing a little.

“Unless you want to go to a tavern and drink some better ale.”

“What? No, no. The inn is fine, perfect, actually. Really!” Adora replied.

“Can’t wait, huh?” Seacat leered at her lover.

“Oh, you!” Adora was blushing fiercely now, visible even in the dim light of the night. Then she suddenly frowned, narrowing her eyes at Seacat. And her grip on Seacat’s hand tightened.

“What?” This was… not according to plan. If she had a plan, of course.

A smirk replaced the frown on Adora’s face, and she reached for Seacat. With her hand trapped, Seacat couldn’t dodge - and didn’t know if she wanted to, anyway - and she found herself picked up and held, bridal carry.

“Hey!” she protested.

Adora ignored her.

She tried to wriggle out of the other woman’s hold, but Adora’s grip was too strong - even without turning into She-Ra - for that. Well, she could easily break the hold if she wanted to hurt Adora but… that was out of the question. “Put me down!”

“No!”

“I can walk!”

“So?”

“You’re not going to let me down, are you?”

“No.”

“We’ll see about that.” The way Adora carried her, she had to use both hands. Which left both of Seacat’s hands free. And her tail. And Adora was ticklish.

“Hey! What are you doing? Stop that!”

“No!”

*****

Seacat took a deep breath as she slid off Adora. That had been… well, perfect. A perfect end to a perfect evening. She shifted around in the bed, stretching out next to her lover, one arm draped over Adora’s chest, her head resting in the crook of Adora’s elbow.

She could feel Adora breathing. Felt her lover’s hand settle on her own body. Smelt her. “Love you,” she whispered under her breath.

“Love you, too,” Adora answered in a whisper - after a moment’s hesitation, though. And Seacat had felt her tense up.

“What’s wrong?” she asked.

“Nothing;” Adora replied at once.

Seacat rolled her eyes and waited.

“It’s just…” Adora sighed. “You’ll be sailing off tomorrow. And we’ll soon return to Bright Moon.”

“Yes.” They had discussed that, hadn’t they? It was well-known. Hell, a few Horde spies might already have picked it up just based

on the supplies being loaded on the ships. Not much you could do about that in a port as rife with scoundrels as Seaworthy. Unless you expelled everyone, of course. Which would be what the Horde would do.

“And we won’t see each other for a long time.”

“Yes.” Seacat frowned. She also knew that already. And she didn’t want to think about it. Not now. But Adora was obviously working through or up to something. Seacat’s eyes widened. She wouldn’t try to break off, would she? Not after everything they had done! Not after what they had just done! “We’ll see each other soon enough!” she snapped, turning her head to glare at her.

“Ah…” Adora blinked. “Uh… I mean…”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Don’t give me that!” Seacat snapped. “We just had a perfect evening and night! It’s a miracle the bed’s still intact! We’re not going to break up over the war!”

“What? No!”

No? “Good!” Seacat nodded firmly.

“Uh, good.”

That was settled then. Seacat still frowned at her lover. “So, what is bothering you? And don’t say ‘nothing’!”

“I was just…” Adora sighed. “I was wondering about… after the war, I mean.”

Again? “Didn’t we decide to tackle that once we actually won the war?”

“Well… I was just… wondering, you know.”

“About us after the war.” Like the shrimp had told them to.

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

Seacat sighed again. “And what did you come up with?”

“Nothing.”

That was a little too fast. “Really?” Seacat raised both eyebrows at her.

Adora caved. “I was… well, I was wondering what Sea Hawk and Mermista’s plans were.”

“Huh?” Seacat blinked. How did the plans of the Captain and Mermista affect… Oh. “You want to know how they plan to, ah, have a relationship?”

“No. I mean, well, yes. But mostly I wonder…” Adora took a deep breath. “Do you want to have a ship of your own?”

A ship of her own? Without the Captain? Seacat didn’t know what to say. What to think.

Adora kept talking. “I mean, Glimmer told me about her father, how when he married her mother, Queen Angella, he lived in the palace. As King. I mean, he did leave, of course - he wasn’t stuck there - but… he mostly lived there.”

Where was she going with that? Oh! “The Captain would never give up his ship!” Seacat blurted out.

“I didn’t mean that. I just thought… he wouldn’t travel as much, what with being married to Mermista. And what if they have children?”

Oh. Little children. A ship wasn’t a good place to raise children. Well, they would be fine in calm waters, but in a storm? Or when you had to outrun a pirate ship? Seacat doubted that Mermista would let Sea Hawk raise any of her children on a ship. At least

not until they were grown up a little, and could learn how to sail. And she doubted that Sea Hawk would want to see his children only every few months or so. “I see what you mean.”

“You do? I mean, yes.” Adora fidgeted a little. “I was thinking, if you had a ship of your own, you needed a crew.”

“Yes.” Of course she’d need a crew. That was obvious. Unless she settled for a rowboat.

“So… I was wondering if I could become a sailor. I mean, I already dressed like one, didn’t I? And I’ve been at sea. I slew a sea monster! And I am a good student. And She-Ra is really strong, and I can heal, and…”

Seacat silenced her with a kiss. “You idiot,” she told Adora when the broke the kiss.

“Hey!”

Seacat kissed her again.

“So… what, uh, do you think?”

After the third kiss, Adora got the message.

Idiot.

*****

The Vanguard

"...And that's the switch for the locator function. I placed it on the scabbard here. The small arrow will point at your sword. If you flick it and this switch on the other side at the same time, it also acts as a detonator switch and the sword will explode as long as it's in range," Entrapta explained, gesturing at the switches, then at the sword.

Which Seacat was holding. She tried not to show any reaction to the realisation that she was holding a bomb that would wreck the entire room and reduce her to smear on its remains.

"You mean it's armed?" Adora, obviously, didn't have such restraint. She was staring at the blade with wide eyes, then gaped at Entrapta.

"Well, yes, it's armed," the princess replied. "How could I demonstrate its functions if it weren't working?"

"Demonstrate its functions?"

"Not the bomb," Seacat cut in.

"Of course not - that would destroy the sword," Entrapta agreed. She blinked, then added: "And most of the inn, I think. It depends on whether the walls withstand the shockwave - if they do, they'll channel it upwards and the effects on the rest of the rooms shouldn't be too bad. If they don't, and if they are load-bearing walls, then the entire inn should collapse into the crater blown into the ground. Because the floor isn't actually that strong, you know? It's mostly a few solid beams and lots of wood, and that won't resist the blast very well."

"Ah." Seacat nodded. "Hide behind walls, not below floors. Got it." Well, it wasn't as if she was planning to blow up her room here.

Adora nodded with a slightly sickly expression.

“Unless the floor’s solid stone, but that would probably be too heavy for most buildings,” Entrapta told them. “I had to study that when I was rebuilding my workshop!”

“Ah.” *That* wasn’t a surprise. “And the sword otherwise works like the first one?”

“Yes, exactly! That’s what you wanted, right?”

“Yes.” Seacat smiled at the princess. “Thank you very much. This is great!”

“OK! And don’t forget to gather data if you use the bomb function!”

“Will do!” Seacat suddenly frowned. “Oh, what’s the blast radius of the sword-bomb?”

“Well, initial testing showed that the power of the explosion was roughly equal to a heavy shell.”

“Ah.” Enough to easily sink a courier ship.

Adora took a half-step away from the sword. “And how likely is it that that thing can blow up if you hit it hard enough?”

“Oh, not very likely. There’s a tiny chance that it might explode if the pressure on the power unit is strong enough to force a chain reaction even without the catalyst, but so much pressure would probably kill the wielder anyway before the bomb goes off.” Entrapta beamed at them.

Seacat smiled. “A last surprise? I like that.”

Adora frowned at her. “Don’t talk like you’re planning to use it. In that capacity, I mean.” In a lower voice, she added: “I’m worrying enough already.”

Seacat smiled at her. But she didn’t tell her not to worry - she was worrying about Adora, too, after all.

*****

“Ah, First Mate! Right on time!” Sea Hawk yelled as soon as Seacat stepped off the gangway onto the deck of the Dragon’s Daughter V.

“Captain.” She nodded at him.

“Got your new sword?”

She patted the hilt on her hip. “Yes. And it’s also a bomb.”

“Great!” He beamed at her. “That might come in handy!”

She hoped she wouldn’t have to blow up her sword - but he wasn’t wrong. They had a war to fight, anyway. She glanced at the gun mounted on the bow, then at Alcy and Licy - she still didn’t know their real names - and at Horas. The three were lined up next to the mast, smiling. She nodded at them.

“The entire crew’s assembled, then!” the Captain declared. “We’re ready to set sail!”

They had a bigger crew now. That would take some time getting used to, even though Seacat had known they would have to recruit more if only to man the gun. And the three former scoundrels had proven their mettle. Still... it wouldn’t be just her and the Captain any more. She would miss the closeness.

“Did you already say goodbye to Adora?” Sea Hawk asked in a lower voice as she passed him to check on the engine and hold.

“She’s coming to see us off,” she replied, opening the hatch. “She just had to clear some things with the shrimp.”

“Ah. I think I see her.”

Seacat dropped the hatch and looked at the pier, then cursed herself for her reaction. She was better than that. But she was already missing Adora, too.

“Seacat!” Adora waved all the way to the gangway. “Great, I made it!”

“We’re not yet setting sails,” Sea Hawk told her. “We need to wait for the tide - well, we wouldn’t have to wait, but we wouldn’t want to give our secrets away.

Adora didn’t seem to be listening to him, though. And Seacat wasn’t really listening either.

They were kissing.

*****

“Locked!”

“Loaded!”

“Aimed!”

Seacat pressed her hands over her ears and yelled: “Fire!”

Alcy pulled the cord, and the swivel gun fired. A moment later, the water erupted near the floating piece of wood they were using as a target. The sailor cursed under her breath.

Seacat shook her head. “Close. If it had been a ship, you’d have hit it.”

“But I missed the target.”

“Not by much. And if we’d have loaded a shell…” Licy wiped the sweat from her brows - the sailor had served as a loader for this drill, and while a swivel gun’s shells and shot were far lighter than those of a frigate’s guns, constantly reloading was exhausting.

But you needed to drill that so you could keep it up in battle. ‘The more you sweat, the less you bleed’ was a quote from a Horde Instructor, but true anyway. Seacat just wished the gun wasn’t so loud. Her ears hurt if she stood too close to it.

Well, she'd have to get used to it. Or get used to having Adora heal her ears every time they met. Or ask Entrapta for some earplugs that only worked against gunshots.

"Well, the cadence was good!" Sea Hawk commented. "You threw a lot of weight at the enemy."

"At the water," Alcy corrected him.

"We've got the entire journey's length to learn how to hit," Sea Hawk replied. He slapped her on the shoulder. "You'll get the hang of it in time for duelling gunboats on the river!"

"So you think we won't face any Horde ships at sea?" Licy asked.

"I didn't say that." The Captain grinned. "But if we encounter any Horde ships, they are bound to be frigates - and we won't fight a gun duel with a frigate."

That would be pointless, indeed. The swivel gun's shells probably wouldn't even blow holes into a frigate's hull. And landing a shot on the enemy's bridge… the enemy outranged them, and Seacat didn't want to brave enemy broadsides for some chancy shot.

"Keep drilling," she told them, pointing ahead. "There's another piece of driftwood coming up." So far out? Remnants from the storm that almost sank them, no doubt.

The two scoundrels jumped to handle the gun and point it at the new target. If they hurried, they'd get three, maybe four shots off before they were past it.

"I'll check the engine," Seacat said and then went down into the hold.

The engine wasn't running - with the wind at their back, they didn't need to waste the fuel crystals. She still stayed for a little while, watching it. Checking the switches and levers. And sighing. Usually, she'd be busy with the sails during such a voyage. But

with their crew having more than doubled, Seacat had more free time. More free time to think. And miss Adora.

She sighed again, then went back on deck. “Everything’s fine,” she reported. “The power chamber’s full.”

“Good, good! You never know when you might need them.” Sea Hawk smiled at her, then went back to the helm, where Horas was. The wheel looked tiny in the hands of the big minotaur, Seacat noted. He wouldn’t be a regular helmsman, of course - that would be a waste of his strength - but every member of the crew needed to be able to handle every essential task on board. You never knew when you’d lose someone, to a storm or battle.

And she didn’t have an essential task right now. She leaned against the railing and looked out at the sea while Alcy and Licy drilled without powder.

“Missing Adora?” Sea Hawk joined her at the railing, leaning against it while facing her.

“Is it obvious?”

He cocked his head. “Well, to me at least. But who wouldn’t miss their lover if they had to part ways so soon after coming together?”

“Don’t remind me,” she muttered, closing her eyes.

“I won’t.”

He didn’t have to, of course. Seacat was thinking about Adora all the time now. She sighed. “How do you handle it?”

“Ah.” Sea Hawk turned to look at the sea as well. “I tell myself we’ll meet again. And I do my best to enjoy the sea until then.”

“It’s not really working for me,” Seacat muttered.

“Oh, I know. But it will.”

She grunted. “When?”

“Someday.”

That wasn’t very promising. She took a deep breath. “Have you ever… thought about not leaving her?”

“Stop sailing all the seas?” He gasped, but she could tell he wasn’t really shocked.

“Stay with her.”

“Of course I thought about it.” It was his turn to sigh. “My love is a woman of the sea. And yet the same power that makes her so perfect a partner for any sailor also means she’ll be duty-bound to Salineas.”

“Oh.” Seacat hadn’t considered that, but it made sense. “You could still sail, though. Just not…”

“...as free as before.” The Captain nodded. “I know. But to take such a step… it’s hard for any sailor.”

She nodded.

*****

“Ship ahead!” Seacat heard Licy call out from the lookout. She quickly scaled the rigging to check with her telescope. “Looks like a merchant,” Licy told her.

The woman was correct, as Seacat could see herself. It was a transport ship. An older ship, too - broader in the beam than a cog and likely to roll a lot in heavier seas. Probably built in a yard on the Northern Coast, not in the Kingdom of Snows - the lines didn’t fit a cog like the Ice Spear. Though the flag claimed it was from Seaworthy. That was possible - many independent merchants, both honest ones and those who got their cargo at the point of a blade, picked Seaworthy as their homeport.

But… “There’s some damage to the bow,” she said. “Patched up, but not perfectly.”

“Oh?”

“And they’re headed towards the part of the coast occupied by the Horde.”

“That could be a navigation error,” Licy pointed out.

It could be. Not every ship had a decent navigator. And even those who should stick to the coasts to avoid getting lost at sea might decide to sail the open seas to avoid the Horde.

But Seacat didn’t think this was such a case. Or it had been a navigation error, but then the ship had been captured by a Horde raider.

“They’re changing course. Northwards,” Licy said.

“To cover up, probably.” Seacat couldn‘t make out the crew of the ship, not yet, but her gut feeling was clear.

“Suspicious transport ahead, Captain!” she yelled down. “Might’ve been captured by the Horde.”

“We shall check it out, then!” Sea Hawk replied. “Ready the engine, but don’t accelerate yet!”

“Aye aye, Captain!” Seacat narrowed her eyes as she went belowdecks. If it was a transport with a prize crew, then they could handle it. A Horde captain wouldn’t want to lose more than the absolute minimum of his crew to sail a prize home. But if the ship was transporting soldiers for a raid or hunting other transports, things would get a little tricky. At least the other ship had no engine, which meant the Dragon’s Daughter V could easily outsail it, should they have to retreat quickly.

She started the engine, checked that it was working properly, then rejoined the others on deck. The Dragon’s Daughter V was cutting

through the waves, towards the slower transport. Alcy was waving the signal flags, telling the other ship to stop and prepare for inspection.

“I don’t see any gun ports!” Licy reported.

That didn’t mean the ship was unarmed - but Seacat didn’t see any guns on deck, either. Although if the transport was a concealed raider, they would’ve hidden their guns. And the additional troops.

“They’re slowing down!”

Seacat could see the cog turn into the wind and come to a stop. The sailors on deck weren’t running around or grabbing weapons - but they weren’t lining the railing and watching the Dragon’s Daughter V’s approach, either.

“What do you think? Hidden gun ports? Or just a force hiding belowdecks to board us?” Sea Hawk asked.

“If they aren’t a prize crew, then it’ll be boarders. They wouldn’t have been able to install hidden gun ports while at sea, nor would the Horde ships have had guns to spare,” Seacat replied. They could’ve done that in port - but the transport would have had to sail during the storm to escape the blockade, and Seacat didn’t think the ship would’ve survived. Not as low as it was lying in the water.

“Yes. So… this will be interesting.” Sea Hawk grinned. “Horas! I think we’ll have to test out my idea!”

The minotaur grunted his agreement and went to man the swivel gun while Alcy replaced him at the helm and Seacat handled the sails.

They quickly closed in - from the rear. No need to find out the hard way that there were hidden gun ports. The closer they got, the more convinced Seacat was that this was a Horde prize crew.

The sailors were a little too tense, a little too young. Most ships had a few old sailors with experience amongst a crew that large.

"Ahoi!" Sea Hawk yelled as they came into speaking range. "Stand by to receive an inspection party!"

"Aye aye!" the other captain replied.

Seacat was already preparing the grapple hooks to lash the ship together. This was it - once they were alongside each other, it would be do or die.

She grinned, baring her fangs, as she let the hook fly.

A minute later, the ships were lashed together - Horas had almost single-handedly pulled them alongside the other ship - and Seacat scrambled up the line. She vaulted over the larger ship's railing and landed on deck with a grin. Half a dozen sailors on the deck, all armed, and the captain and helmsman on the bridge. Heh, she could fight them all by herself if she had to.

And, judging by how nervous they were, they knew it as well.

They didn't attack, but the transport's captain was moving towards her even as Sea Hawk joined her on deck. He was young, too. That wasn't proof that he was a young officer assigned to command a prize taken - there were young captains, mostly from families owning transport ships - but it fit the picture.

"Ah, well met, Captain!" Sea Hawk said, loudly. "I'm Admiral Sea Hawk."

That sent a shock through the crew - Seacat saw them pale.

"Ah… I'm Captain Storm." The Captain was obviously lying. "Say… we're in a hurry - perishable cargo, you know - so is there any way we could, uh, speed things up?" He patted his purse as if the offer hadn't been obvious enough.

“Are you trying to bribe me, good man?” Sea Haw replied, faking a shocked gasp.

“No, no!” The man - Storm wasn’t his real name, Seacat was sure - shook his head, almost dislodging his hat. “I was merely… uh, trying to save us time. We’re both busy men, aren’t we?”

“Indeed we are!” Sea Hawk pushed his chest out. “And I’m busy inspecting your ship!” he yelled.

“Of course, Admiral…”

The fake transport captain was interrupted by yelling from belowdecks. And screaming.

Prisoners. The cog was transporting prisoners, Seacat realised. That meant a bigger crew to guard them. “Horas!” she yelled, drawing her cutlass.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk’s sword flashed, and the captain’s sabre, barely out of its scabbard, went overboard.

“At them, men!” the Horde captain yelled, even as he backed up a few steps, holding his bleeding hand. “Hold them off!”

The sailors on deck made a ragged charge, and Seacat met half of them with a hiss. She batted the cutlass of the closest sailor away with a flick of her wrist, then hacked through the woman’s arm. While the Horde scum collapsed, screaming at the blood gushing from the stump, Seacat parried another blow from a burly fishman, then ducked below a wild swing with a boathook from a third sailor.

Then the hatch to the hold flew open and Horde soldiers started to pour out on deck - and forming up in lines. Marines, then - and disciplined ones. Half a dozen, one dozen... Seacat had to duck under another wild swing, then stabbed the sailor’s foot in retaliation. When the man collapsed, she slashed him across the chest, almost cutting him in half.

But the fishman attacked her with wild swings of his battleaxe. He wasn't trying to kill her, just keeping her off-balance, she realised - until the marines were ready. And it was working. She tried twice to cut the axe's handle, but he swept it out of the way- and forced her back with the next swing.

And the marines were now ready, three rows, pikes and shock rods. She clenched her teeth and counter-attacked the fishman, pushing him back a few feet - she needed room to fight…

Movement to her side drew her attention. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Horas climbing over the railing - and carrying the swivel gun. "Fire!" she yelled.

The marines started to charge as soon as they realised what was happening, but the minotaur was faster. He slammed the barrel of the gun into his left palm, braced himself against the railing, and fired.

And the charge of the Horde marines was shredded by canister shot at close range. The centre just disappeared - turned into chunks of flesh and blood. The ones at the edges of the formation dropped, their bodies pierced and torn by the shot, most of them dead, but a few screaming in growing pools of blood.

One Horde soldier, a young woman, had survived in the middle of the back rank, shielded by the ones in front of her. She seemed untouched - but she was shaking, and a moment later, she dropped her shock rod and raised her arms. "Please spare me! I surrender!"

Seacat glanced at the fishman, who had backed up a few more steps. He was trembling as well.

*Surrender!" Sea Hawk yelled - he had killed two of his enemies, wounded the third and was advancing towards the wounded captain.

The fishman dropped his blade and fell to his knees, sobbing.

A moment later, the Horde captain surrendered as well.

*****

“Thank you!” the recently freed original captain of the cog told Sea Hawk for the third time.

“Oh, it was the least we could do!” the Captain replied with a beaming smile, stroking his moustache. “We knew from the start that the ship looked suspicious. The damage to the rigging, and their heading...” He shrugged. “The outcome, of course, was inevitable.”

Mira, the other captain, nodded, then winced a little, touching the bruise on her face. “When we realised what was happening and saw the Horde soldiers line up at the stairs, we decided to warn you.”

And the scum had beaten her for it. Well, at least the marines left in the hold hadn’t put up a fight after the blood of the marines Horas had turned into mincemeat had started dripping down the hatch. And after the surviving marine on deck had explained the situation.

“Brave of you!” Sea Hawk nodded. “And very much appreciated. I assume you’ll sail to Seaworthy now?”

“Yes. We were headed to Salineas, originally, but with the damage taken…” Mira shrugged. “It’s a shorter trip - and safer.”

“Oh, yes!” Sea Hawk smiled again. “We’ve found no sign of a Horde raider between here and Seaworthy. You should be fine.”

And, though he didn’t say so, Seacat knew that the rest of the force would soon set sail from Seaworthy as well. The cog would be safe, indeed. And carrying half a dozen Horde prisoners guarded by their former captives. Fortunately, the freed sailors - the crews of three transports that the Horde frigate had captured since it had run the blockade during the storm - outnumbered the surviving Horde soldiers easily.

“And don’t worry- the Salinean fleet will soon bring up this raider, mark my words!” Sea Hawk announced. “We already captured two frigates!”

That caused a cheer to erupt amongst the freed sailors. Probably mostly those who had lost their ships, Seacat thought.

“But we must depart now - we have an important mission for the war!” the Captain declared, raising his fist to the sky. “The Horde will rue the day they laid claim to the seas! Huzzah!”

“Huzzah!”

Seacat dutifully cheered as well, though she was already thinking of their chances to encounter the frigate which had captured the cog. Her captain seemed to be either skilled or lucky - and either quality would make them a dangerous enemy.

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“And there goes our prize,” Alcy said to Licy as they watched the cog sail northwards.

“Yeah,” the other scoundrel agreed. “We took it, yet we won’t see any reward for it.”

You could argue that, technically, the ship would’ve been theirs - the Horde had pressed her into service already. In the past, there had been cases where a ship had been kept by whoever captured it. On the other hand, the Alliance forces weren’t supposed to keep the property liberated from the Horde for themselves. Especially if said property originally belonged to a member or ally of the Alliance. That made for angry allies.

“Now, now!” Sea Hawk said, patting both women on the shoulders. “We returned a ship that was stolen to her rightful crew! We’re following the sacred code of the sea!”

“We’re better than the Horde,” Seacat reminded them.

The two had the grace to blush.

“And like this, we didn’t need a prize crew,” she added.

“Right,” Alcy said. “I guess the sailors we freed wouldn’t have liked taking the ship to the prize court for us…”

Seacat snorted. The crew would probably have changed the name and claimed to be a different ship as soon as they were out of sight of the Dragon’s Daughter V.

“Besides, we’ll still get our share of the frigate and barge we took!” Sea Hawk reminded them.

“Once the prize court gets around to rule the case,” Seacat added.

“Right.” Licy and Alcy sighed in unison. “And that will take some time.”

“We won’t have many opportunities to spend any money, anyway,” Seacat pointed out. “Not until this campaign will be finished.”

“I only need one chance!” Licy told her with a wide grin. “And we’ll stop in Fortress Freedom, won’t we?”

“Oh, yes - a fortress full of marines? The taverns will be rocking!” Alcy agreed.

Well, they weren’t wrong. On the other hand, Adora wouldn’t be there.

Seacat hid her sigh. No need to bring down the mood. Especially not after they had just won a victory at sea. “Just don’t overdo it,” she told them. “The campaign up the river will be hard.”

“But we won’t be alone this time,” Alcy replied. “We’ll have at least two regiments with us! And gunboats!”

“One or two, at most,” Licy said. “Former Horde boats that we took.”

"It's still better than what we had before. And the infantry will advance along the river, screening us."

"That's the plan," Seacat confirmed. Though plans could change. The Horde leadership wasn't stupid, so they would be expecting such an attack. And a prepared foe was far more dangerous than a surprised one.

Seacat had a feeling that this would be a bloody affair.

*****

Fortress Freedom looked the same as when they had left it. More or less. A few repairs had been done, but Seacat could still see some damage from shells. Holes and craters in the piers and mole, mostly. It figured - a few raiders at sea didn't change the fact that the Horde lacked the strength for a landing operation; any Horde attacks would be coming overland.

At least the port facilities had been repaired - she could see a new crane at the waterfront. And lots of soldiers serving as stevedores, unloading cargo from a Kingdom of Snows transport. "Looks like they were reinforced already," she commented. There were too many marines in the port for just the Seahorses.

"Mermista mentioned that the fourth regiment was sent straight from Salineas, but she didn't know if the ships would arrive in time."

Seacat nodded. The winds made calculating travel times difficult. Another thing that would change with engines becoming wide-spread - at least for military transports. For most cargo, it didn't matter if it arrived a few weeks sooner or later.

"The more soldiers in the fortress, the better!" Alcy said, joining them at the railing.

Seacat didn't know if she meant that they would be safer - or that there would be more soldiers to carouse with. She didn't care, either. If any attack happened, she'd have ample time to get on

board the Dragon's Daughter V, and they'd fight at sea. And there was only one person she wanted to carouse with. And Adora wasn't in the Fortress.

She blinked. Damn. She got it bad. A sailor was supposed to live it up in port - any port. Hell, that was on which all those lurid novels Adora had read were based. And yet…

"Something wrong, Seacat?" The Captain asked.

"Nothing," she told him without looking away from the fortress. They were on an important mission. Any distractions would be stupid.

"Really?" He leaned forward, over the railing, to look at her with wide eyes. "You look a little down."

She sighed. Of course he'd notice. "Just thinking of Adora," she replied. Who wasn't there.

"Ah." He straightened. "She'll be alright. She's She-Ra, remember? And she knows what she's doing."

She rolled her eyes in return. That wasn't what she was worried about - though now that he mentioned it, she was worrying. A little. Shadow Weaver did know Adora. And she would be making plans to deal with She-Ra. Sure, the witch had messed up and underestimated Seacat, but she had known Adora for a much longer time - and had more experience fighting her, too.

Seacat shook her head. "It's not that." Not just. "I'm just…"

"You're missing her. And you don't feel like enjoying your shore leave without her."

How…? "How do you know that?"

"I felt the same at the start of my relationship with my dear Mermista." He patted her shoulder.

“I never noticed,” she told him. He had never moped around, not even after their breakups.

“Oh, it was before your time. Almost back before I realised that no matter what Mermista might say during a row, she loved me as much as I loved her.” He nodded. “I, too, felt like shore leave was pointless without the woman I loved. But I was wrong.”

She narrowed her eyes at him. “Really?”

“Wrong, indeed. At first, I didn’t want to enjoy my time on shore. And then, fearing for my reputation, I, ah..” He coughed into his fist. “I overcompensated, as Mermista calls it.”

“‘Overcompensated’.”

He nodded as if she had said something profound. “Yes. I decided - correctly - that I could enjoy shore leave even without my love. Yet I went a little overboard.”

She narrowed her eyes at him.

“So, do enjoy your time on shore! Raise a glass in honour of your lover! Dance and gamble and fight to your heart’s content. But don’t try to prove that you’re still the same sailor you were before you met the love of your life.”

“I wouldn’t do that!” That would be betraying Adora’s trust!

“Good.” He nodded again, with a smile that seemed proud rather than sad. “Then you’re already wiser than I was!”

“‘Already’?” She raised her eyebrows at him.

“At least in the ways of love,” he amended his words. “But mark my words - we’ll enjoy our time on shore leave! In honour of our two loves!”

“Yes!” Alcy chimed in, beaming at them.

Damn. Seacat had completely forgotten that the scoundrel was listening to them.

*****

“Set sail! Cast off!”

The crew threw themselves into it with a vengeance. The sail practically flew up as Horas pulled on the lines, and Alcy and Licy threw the mooring lines to the pier with enough force to almost dumping them in the water on the other side. The Dragon’s Daughter V was leaving port for a scouting cruise south. A short one - they would have to be back in time for the transports to arrive with the troops - but they needed to know if the Horde was preparing anything south of the fortress.

“And there we go!” Sea Hawk announced as the ship turned and started to pick up speed, the tide carrying it out.

“By the time we’re back, things should’ve calmed down,” Seacat said as they were halfway to the sea.

“Exactly!” the Captain agreed.

“We didn’t break too much, anyway,” Licy added.

“And they started it. Stupid marines.” Alcy scoffed. “Not the Seahorses, the others.”

“The Fourth,” Seacat told her. “The Iron Crabs.”

Both scoundrel and even Horas snorted at that. “Fits them,” the minotaur commented.

Seacat shrugged. She could imagine the jokes the marines had to suffer through. Well, she remembered making some, last night. But then, that was to be expected, what with the Fourth being new arrivals. The brawl that broke out had been started by the Crabs, in any case.

It had been fun, though. The Captain had been correct about that. And they hadn't overdone it. She still remembered everything and the taverns they had visited still stood. Slightly battered, in one case, but that hardly counted on the waterfront.

Still, sailing early meant they wouldn't have to explain any details. And the Captain wouldn't have to pull rank. By the time they got back, Kilian would've straightened out things anyway. At least Sea Hawk claimed so.

*****

"That's a whole day we spent patrolling the area without spotting anything," Seacat said as she joined Sea Hawk at the helm in time to see the sun set. "I would've expected them to at least use cutters and courier ships to keep an eye on us." The Horde hadn't lost most of their couriers, after all. And the smaller ships could evade the blockade by the Salinean Fleet. Not always, not by far - but often enough to make the attempt worth it.

"It might just be bad luck," the Captain replied. "However… if they are holding back their scouts, then they are not only preparing something, but they either have other means to keep an eye on the area - or they are ignoring us."

"They can't ignore the fortress," Seacat said. "It's the perfect staging point for an offensive."

"But that is obvious - they know we'll mass our troops there," he countered.

"They still need to know how many troops we're gathering," she pointed out.

"That depends on how far away their main line is. If they withdraw far enough, they have plenty of time to use scouts on skiffs to track and observe us." He rubbed his moustache. "I think they're up to something. That witch of theirs…" He looked at her. "Can she use magic to watch us from afar?"

“Probably,” Seacat replied. Sorceresses could do that, or so she’d heard. “I’ve never seen her do it.” Shadow Weaver never showed her anything. Although Adora didn’t know much about the witch’s capabilities, either.

“It cannot be sustainable - otherwise, the Horde wouldn’t have suffered defeats.” Sea Hawk nodded to her own words. “And it might be pointless at sea; without a reference point, you’d never know a ship’s position.”

“Good enough for keeping an eye on the coast, though,” Seacat told him.

“Infantry on foot would be enough for that,” he retorted. “So, we’re already sailing out of sight of land.”

She acknowledged the point with a slight hiss. “What are they doing, then? They can’t gather a fleet in a blockaded port without the Salineans noticing.”

“I agree. And yet, they have to keep us from landing more troops in the fortress. Once we’re ready, they’ll lose all the troops cut off in the north, at the very least,” Sea Hawk said. He suddenly smiled. “I think I know what they have their couriers doing.”

Sometimes, the Captain’s flair for dramatic scenes was very annoying. “What are they doing?” Seacat asked.

“Seeking the raiding frigates with new orders.”

Oh. That made sense. She should’ve thought of it herself. “And what will those orders say?”

“Either an all-out attack on the fortress - or a diversionary attack on another port,” Sea Hawk explained.

“Four frigates won’t be able to take the port. Engines or not - the Salineans will have double their number of ships screening the port, and the guns on the mole.”

Sea Hawk's expression grew serious, and Seacat tensed up. "But their engines will let them break through the Salinean battleline and into the harbour."

She hissed. "Fires ships?"

"Or bomb ships."

Damn. "We don't know if they would do that." The Horde hadn't been keen on such attacks before.

"They've got a lot to lose," Sea Hawk said. "If they lose the troops north of us and the river…" He shrugged. "We need to prepare for it, even if I'm wrong." Louder, he added: "Turn about! And start the engine!"

"Let's hope they haven't figured out how to turn their engines into bombs," Seacat muttered as she started to walk towards the hatch leading belowdecks. Four frigates blowing up like that… there wouldn't be much left of any ship in the vicinity.

*****

Nothing. Perched on top of the mast, Seacat sighed as she kept scanning the horizon. She was sure that the Horde ships were out there. And their scouts - or spies - would have noticed that the troop transports had arrived in the fortress.

But she didn't know how long it would take for the Horde ships to get word of that. They would have to send a courier to the coast - either south or north of the fortress, at a location the Horde still controlled. Probably at night, too, to make it harder to spot the ship.

The patrols of the Salinean Navy hadn't caught any such attempts, but that didn't mean anything. Smugglers routinely managed to evade the fleet, and any Horde captain who had managed to sneak out of a blockaded port would be skilled enough to make the coast at night as well.

Perhaps they had misjudged the time it would take for the transports to arrive? They would have meeting times pre-arranged, which was a tricky business. No. She shook her head. She couldn't count on that. And even if the Horde attack was late, they could still wreck the transports unloading the supplies.

And if the Horde ships had been turned into bombs… She shuddered.

On the other hand, finding any ship, much less four frigates doing their best to hide, was not easy. What were the odds that the Horde had managed to contact all four frigates and gather them for this attack?

She snorted. The Horde didn't have too many skilled officers. And…

...there was something on the horizon. She narrowed her eyes and picked up her telescope.

Then she cursed. It seemed that the odds of the Horde gathering all four missing frigates hadn't been as impossible as she had hoped.

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The Horde Gambit

“Captain! Four Horde frigates and three courier ships ahead!” Seacat reported, yelling down from the top of the mast without taking her eyes off the ships that had appeared on the horizon. None of them looked damaged, as far as she could tell from here.

She shifted her weight and adjusted her grip when Sea Hawk turned the Dragon’s Daughter V around. The fleet at the fortress needed to be informed at once so they could prepare for the attack.

“Full speed ahead!” Sea Hawk yelled below her, and Seacat braced for the slight kick that went through the ship when the engine started up. Alcy still hadn’t figured out how to accelerate gently.

There it came - she clenched her teeth as the mast briefly swayed back and forth while the ship picked up speed. The wind at their back, and the engine running full throttle - they were setting a new record. Or would be, if anyone kept count.

She focused on the enemy. The horde ships were falling back - and the frigates were outpacing the couriers. Which were a little low in the water. Ah - probably fire ships. Or bombs.

Damn. “Captain! The Horde couriers are weighed down! Possibly fire ships.”

“How tricky of them!” Sea Hawk yelled back. “But I can’t fault them for such an effective tactic! They must have learned from us!”

Probably long ago - but the Horde hadn’t been desperate enough to set their own ships on fire until now. But it meant that they had to stop seven, not merely four ships - and the Alliance fleet, meaning the Salinean Navy, was a little stretched right now. The six frigates at the fortress could stop the Horde frigates, but not if they also had to stop the couriers. And even with the Horde ships

weighed down, she doubted that the gunners on the mole could hit all of them before they entered the harbour.

Which left the task up to the Dragon's Daughter V, and the Flying Seagull. But that courier was covering the southern approaches and was unlikely to return in time to engage the enemy - the Dragon's Daughter V couldn't sail south to fetch them, and Captain Gren wouldn't leave her station until she found Horde ships or got relieved.

Damn.

Seacat gave the Horde ships another look, then slid down the mast to fetch the signal flags to inform the Salinean frigates as soon as they were in sight.

This was going to be a tricky battle.

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"Ships ahead!" Licy yelled. "Seven - four frigates, three couriers, under sail!"

As expected, then. There had been a small chance that at least one of the couriers would be sent away, but... Seacat studied the ships through the telescope. "They'll be slower than normal, loaded down with whatever." Something flammable, probably. Or explosive.

"But they'll break off before the frigates engage, to draw us out," Sea Hawk replied. He shook his head. "It can't be helped. They'll split south and north. We'll have one frigate cut off the single courier and go after the two others."

And hope the Horde courtier didn't manage to outsail the Salinean frigate.

"That leaves five to take on their four frigates. Good odds to sink them all without taking too much damage. The marines we took on from the frigate will board the first courier we catch and we'll

chase the other while they secure the courier," the captain went on.

They'd be lighter, then, and with the engine… It was doable. Barely, she corrected herself as she looked back at the Fortress. "It'll be close."

"Oh, yes. A harrowing adventure, in other words!" He smiled, flashing his teeth at her. "We'll have another shanty to sing after this!"

She smiled at him and nodded.

Provided they survived this, of course.

"Signal the Mermaid's Pride that she's to fall back and prepare to intercept a lone courier."

"Aye aye, Captain."

Seacat quickly did so, waited for the frigate to acknowledge the order, then returned to her spot near Sea Hawk. Alcy was at the bow with a marine as loader, and Horas was ready to handle the sails. And the other marines were getting ready as well. Probably looking forward to the prize money.

She snorted. Well, the odds were in their favour - couriers didn't have big crews. Of course, if the Horde had loaded the couriers down with soldiers… but they would've had to strip down the frigates for such a force, and whatever soldiers managed to get into the fortress would be quickly dealt with by the marines there; couriers simply couldn't carry enough troops for a landing or even a large raid against a port.

"They're breaking up! Two couriers northward, one southward!" Licy yelled.

Seacat confirmed it with her telescope a moment later.

"As expected," she muttered.

She signalled the Mermaid's Pride to intercept the courier heading south even though they already knew their orders - in a battle at sea, it paid to be thorough. But the Dragon's Daughter V was already turning northward, into an intercept course. They had two couriers to stop or sink.

"They're slow," Sea Hawk commented. "They wouldn't escape a normal courier - and they know we have them."

"It's a trap, then," Seacat said. "What are they carrying? Explosives or boarders?"

"Either would work, but they won't have too many of the latter." The captain studied the ships racing northwards through his telescope. "Too low in the water for troops. They wouldn't have so many soldiers to fill the hold. I bet they're fireships."

"Or bombs," Seacat pointed out.

"No. They would be using the engines by now, to get past us and into the port. And they would be lighter than that. And they can't have enough powder to fill the hold to be so low in the water - that would leave the Horde guns dry." Sea Hawk grinned.

"They could've enough powder stored there to ruin our day, should we close," Seacat retorted. "Fill the rest of the hold with scrap metal or ballast, to turn into shrapnel."

"That they could - but I don't think the crew would blow themselves up like that." The Captain shook his head. "One or two, maybe, but an entire crew? I don't think so."

"But they're carrying something!" Seacat insisted. And she was sure it wasn't any good.

"They are. And we'll soon be finding out what!" Sea Hawk grinned. "I'll bet it'll be a harrowing adventure!" He yelled the last word and raised his blade to the sky.

"The closer courier is turning towards us!" Lucy yelled.

Seacat could see it as well, of course - everyone could. While the slightly faster courier continued to run northwards, trying to get around the main Salinean fleet and escape the Dragon's Daughter V, the second had turned about and was now sailing straight for them. And…

"I see a raft on the deck," Seacat said, clenching her teeth. "They're prepared to abandon ship."

"They'll try to ram us." Sea Hawk turned to the helm. "I'll take the helm! Horas, sails!"

"Sergeant! Stand ready but don't try to board them until my command!"

The distance was shrinking fast - the Horde courier had the wind at her back and the Dragon's Daughter V was pushed forward by an engine. Seacat kept a telescope trained on the enemy courier. The Horde sailors were pulling on the sails, but… no smoke yet. But there! They were untying the raft! "They're getting the raft ready!"

"Let's give them something to worry about! Fire!" Sea Hawk yelled.

A moment later, Alcy fired the swivel gun. The shot went wide, though, at this distance. The second shot hit the enemy's bow, but the small explosion didn't do any damage.

Then the raft was flung into the water, half a dozen sailors jumping after it. The enemy helmsman - helmswoman - and captain stayed, though. "They're trying to ram us!" Seacat yelled.

"Not on my watch!"

But for all his claim, Sea Hawk kept the ship pointed straight at the oncoming courier. Alcy fired again - another hit. Bits of planks blew up, but above the waterline. One more shot, then they'd crash...

Then the Dragon's Daughter V swung around, to the North. The enemy courier changed course as well, but slower, pushed by the wind - and hampered by the lack of crew to adjust the sails. It was still rushing towards them, though.

And Sea Hawk turned the Dragon's Daughter V again, southwards. And this time, the enemy couldn't match him - they sailed past the Horde bow with a few yards to spare, then turned northwards again. And Alcy's next shot sent a load of canister across the enemy bridge, shredding both helmswoman and captain.

"Sergeant, board her and stop her!" Sea Hawk yelled, steering the ship towards the enemy's aft.

"Aye aye, Admiral!"

The first grapple hooks were thrown at the Horde courier, and the marines got ready to scramble up the lines.

And Seacat smelt something weird. There was the smoke from the gun, the smell of the sea, but… "Oil!" she yelled. "I'm smelling oil!" She bent over the railing and looked down. The sea was covered in oil. They were sailing in a giant slick of oil!

Sea Hawk cursed. "Cut the lines!" he yelled as he turned the wheel and the Dragon's Daughter V turned northwards again.

And even as the marines were cutting the lines tethering the ship to the enemy courier, Seacat saw a flame appear on the enemy deck - and leap across the deck.

The enemy ship had been soaked in oil, she realised. And the fire was racing down the hull, towards the oil in the water… "Cut those lines!" she yelled, jumping down and raking her claws across the closest line.

That left one, and a marine was already there, raiding his axe to cut it. But the line was taut - they were already dragging the burning ship behind them. "Watch out!" she yelled.

She was too late, though - the marine brought down the axe, not on the knot where the line was tied to the mast, but on the railing, and when the rope snapped, it whipped back - and into the marine.

The man was thrown around and into the mast with a sickening crack at the same time the Dragon's Daughter V all but jumped when she lost the weight of the Horde courier, shooting ahead.

But the oil on the water had caught fire, and the flames were chasing after them - faster than the ship was sailing. How big was the oil slick?

Sea Hawk turned the wheel, and the Dragon's Daughter V changed course, turning north again. Away from the oil slick. But the fire was faster. "Buckets! Grab buckets!" Seacat screamed.

Then the fire reached the ship, licking at the hull. Seacat jumped back when splashes of oil on the planks ignited. "Get those buckets!" If the ship caught fire, they were done for.

Alcy, Licy and the marines raced to the railing at the stern, pouring water down the hull. Seacat checked the rigging - it wasn't burning. Yet.

But they were now clear of the burning oil. Seacat briefly checked on the wounded marine - dead, damn it - then grabbed a bucket herself. She pulled up water from the sea, then emptied it on the railing and rigging at the stern. There were some burned spots on the hull, but no more fire. "We've made it," she reported to the Captain.

Behind them, the courier was ablaze like a bonfire soaked in alcohol.

"Thank you," he replied. "Now let's catch the fleeing courier. We can't let her enter the…" he trailed off.

Seacat looked up. The third Horde Courier had changed course. She wasn't headed towards the harbour any more - she was

headed towards the frigates battling it out.

Seacat cursed. There were five frigates against the Horde's four, but if the courier reached the Salinean ships, she might be able to disrupt their formation just enough for the Horde frigates to break through. Provided the Horde ships were prepared to sail through fire.

Which they probably were - this didn't look like an improvised desperate gamble, but a plan. That Horde admiral commanding the fleet was good. "Alcy! Licy! Man the gun!"

The two women rushed to the bow.

"Warn the fleet!" Sea Hawk yelled.

Seacat grabbed the signal flags and climbed up the rigging. She started signalling, hoping that the frigates had lookouts who paid attention. The courier they were chasing was still racing towards the Salinean fleet. The wind hadn't changed, so as long as she was running southwards, she was slower than before. And the Dragon's Daughter V was eating up the distance, thanks to sails and the engine.

But the courier was also closing in on the frigates. And at least the closest had caught her warning - she was suddenly disengaging from the Horde frigate she was fighting. Or tried to - the Horde frigate manoeuvred as well, to exploit the sudden opportunity.

The swivel gun fired, the shot throwing up water behind the enemy courier. They were in range now. But it would be close. Very close.

The Salinean frigate was signalling as well, passing on the warning - and turning to present her broadside to the enemy courier. But that meant she was also exposing her stern to the Horde frigate. If the Horde had timed her reloading cycles… Seacat winced when the Horde broadside struck the frigate in the stern. Such a volley could rip through the entire ship, stern to bow.

And, even worse, it could damage the engine - the struck frigate suddenly slowed down. At least she hadn't blown up. But dead in the water, crew scrambling to put up sails, she was easy prey for the Horde frigate.

And the courier was still running. Alcy fired again. This time, she hit - Seacat saw parts fly from the impact, but the shell didn't explode. A dud. Damn.

And the Horde frigate fired another volley into the Salinean ship. Seacat hissed when the ship started listing.

Even worse - the other frigates were now frantically manoeuvring as well. Two Horde frigates were already trying to break through.

And… "The courier's leaking oil!" she yelled. If they continued their course, they would sail straight into it.

Sea Hawk turned the Dragon's Daughter V away, to avoid the oil slick. He cut it close - closer than Seacat liked - the Horde courier still managed to open the distance again.

Alcy shot, missing once more - the angle had changed. But they were closing in again - running on a parallel course. Seacat could see the crew on the courier's deck handle barrels. *Shoot the deck!" she yelled!

"What do you think I'm trying to do?" Alcy yelled back. Her next shot went high, ripping through the Horde courier's sail but missing the deck. "Get us closer!"

Suddenly, shells hit the water around the courier - and around the Dragon's Daughter V. Seacat almost lost her balance and was drenched by saltwater when one shell blew up a little too close for comfort, shaking the whole ship. Who was… Oh. She saw the smoke blowing away from the side of the listing Salinean frigate.

"Checking the hull!" she yelled, already going for the hatch leading to the hold. Such close misses could easily break or shake loose a plank.

And as she had feared - there was a leak in the hold. Water was already collecting on the deck. Snarling, she went to the bilge pumps. “Pumps!” she yelled. “We need people on the pumps!”

She heard the sergeant yell above her, and two marines all but jumped down into the hold.

“This brings back memories,” she muttered as they started to pump. She climbed back on deck and took stock of their situation. The frigate had fired her last broadside - she was slowly turning turtle. The Horde frigate which had sunk her was engaged with another Salinean frigate and the enemy courier… Seacat snarled. The Horde ship was headed towards the two frigates.

“Shoot the damn courier!” she yelled, hissing with frustration.

Alcy didn’t answer this time. Instead, she fired again. And she landed a hit straight on the enemy bridge. Seacat saw the Horde Captain vanish in the explosion and the sailor at the helm slump over. “Yes!” she cheered - and she wasn’t the only one. The marines yelled when the Horde ship started to veer off.

Another sailor jumped to the helm, grabbing the wheel to force the courier back on course, but the short disruption had cost them - the Dragon’s Daughter V caught up half a minute later. Seacat saw Alcy and Licy turn the swivel gun, aiming it at the deck instead of the bridge. And from this angle, the deck was a much bigger target. At that range, Alcy couldn’t miss.

She didn’t. The shell hit the deck and burst. Right next to a barrel of oil two Horde sailors were trying to throw over the railing.

The explosion bowled them over and split the barrel open. A moment later, the oil lit up.

Seacat clenched her teeth at the screams from the burning Horde sailors. She saw one of them jump overboard - and land in an oil slick, which ignited as well.

Sea Hawk turned the Dragon's Daughter V away as more Horde sailors jumped overboard and the courier, burning from bow to stern now, swung around, driven away by the wind.

Then the fire reached the hold, and the courier disintegrated as the stored oil lit up and flames shot up in the sky.

"Hell!" Seacat blurted out before she could stop herself. The first one hadn't been as bad. Must have poured more oil out into the sea before it lit up, she realised.

"A nasty way to go," the sergeant commented next to her. The entire patch of the sea was burning - even those Horde sailors who had jumped overboard wouldn't make it out of that inferno.

She nodded. But they couldn't stop to pick survivors - if there were any survivors; she didn't spot anyone in the water.

"There goes the Horde frigate!" Lucy yelled.

Seacat turned her head. Indeed, the sunk Salinean frigate had been avenged; the Horde frigate was a wreck, dead in the water, with only a few guns firing back at the frigate that was raking her with broadsides.

She quickly climbed the rigging - the Captain needed more information about the battle. It didn't look as bad as she had feared. The third courier sunk, one Horde frigate burning, the second listing, the last one still fighting hard, but with the frigate which had sunk the courier now in range…

She yelled down: "One Horde frigate burning, the others getting sunk! No other Salinean ships sunk!"

She kept watching the battle. There wasn't much they could do, anyway - the Dragon's Daughter V was a courier ship; she had no place in a battle between frigates. Well, not unless things were desperate.

And things weren't desperate. Without the threat from fireships disrupting their formation, and the fifth frigate returning to the battle, the remaining Horde frigates, all of them damaged already, were clearly outgunned.

"Signal them to keep their distance - the frigates might be carrying oil as well!" Sea Hawk yelled.

Seacat scrambled up the rigging. The Captain was right - the Horde frigates weren't loaded down with oil as the couriers had been or they would have lit up after the first exchange of broadsides, but the way one of them was burning...

The Salienan frigates took a little longer than expected to acknowledge and follow the order, but they did obey. And the Horde frigates lasted a little longer, that way. But in the end, the outcome didn't change. All three remaining frigates were set aflame and sunk by the Salineans.

*****

Recovering the surviving Horde sailors from the sea took some time as well. No captain wanted to risk their ships by sailing too close to a burning hulk - a magazine explosion might splatter burning oil on anything nearby. So, longboats navigated the waters, slipping between still burning slicks of oil and drifting wreckage to pick up survivors.

There were more of them than Seacat would have expected, between the bloody fighting and the burning oil.

"What a waste," Alcy commented as they sailed towards the raft the first courier had dropped. "If we'd taken a frigate as a prize…"

"We'd have to share it with the Salinean frigates," Seacat pointed out.

"Still…"

Seacat shook her head. You could take the scoundrel off a pirate ship, but curbing some of the habits might take a little longer. Though… "Those were the raiding frigates that had slipped the blockade," she said. "If they had kept raiding, the Salineans would have had to use a big part of their fleet hunting them down and guarding transports. Sacrificing them like this..." It was stupid.

"Indeed!" Sea Hawk said. "Even if they had managed to reach the fortress and burn the transport ships and the supplies still on them, it wouldn't have been worth it - without the threat of those raiding frigates, the Alliance can easily shop more supplies down the coast. And the ships currently on escort duty are free to return to blockade and raiding stations."

"Probably a landlubber in command. Doesn't get how important the ships are." Shadow Weaver must not have a grasp on the naval side of the war. Seacat smiled at the thought.

Sea Hawk didn't look convinced. "That's possible, but the Horde hasn't struck me as particularly ignorant of naval matters. They came up with engines for frigates, didn't they?"

And there went their good mood. "Yes," she said with a frown. "But why else would they do this? They had a plan, but even if it had worked, they would've been hard-pressed to do enough damage to the port before getting sunk."

The Captain beamed at her. "They might be desperate. If this offensive succeeds, they'll lose a lot of troops, territory and resources."

"Desperate enough to send four of their best ships to be sunk?" That would fit Shadow Weaver. The witch considered anyone expendable, didn't she?

"Perhaps. We'll need more information to find out for sure."

"Lots of sailors and officers to interrogate," Seacat pointed out.

“And they will be interrogated, but I doubt that they know much about the state of the war on land. No, if we want to know about the Horde situation on land, we’ll have to catch an officer in command on land.”

“A raid on their lines?” Seacat asked. It would have to be the southern lines - the troops cut off in the northern part of the coast wouldn’t know much, either - they’d probably be fed lies so they didn’t realise how hopeless their situation was and wouldn’t surrender at the first opportunity.

“That’s dangerous - we’d have to make landfall somewhere without getting spotted,” Alcy said.

Seacat nodded. At least a small group could be landed quickly - and picked up as quickly. It was still dangerous, but not quite as dangerous as landing a sizeable raid force. If you had to make several trips with a long boat to land all soldiers, the enemy had a lot more time to gather their own. And if you had to make a hasty retreat, you had to hope you were first in line for the boats - or could swim.

“We don’t have the time for that, I’m afraid. But we should have a few opportunities once we strike out along the river,” Sea Hawk told them. “Now let’s invite some shipwrecked Horde sailors on board,” he added, pointing at the raft off the bow.

“Let’s hope they’ll be reasonable,” Alcy said.

“Yes.” Usually, you didn’t have to worry about that with shipwrecked sailors, but with people who were willing to run a fireship into a guarded port… “Let’s check them thoroughly for weapons,” she said.

*****

If the Horde sailors had been willing to fight to the death before, then the fight had gone out of them by the time the Dragon’s Daughter V picked them up from the raft. But then, seeing your

ship sink, finding yourself adrift in the sea… it took something out of every sailor.

Almost every sailor, she corrected herself with a glance at the Captain. And if it happened a few times, you got used to it.

But the Horde sailors they fished out of the water hadn't grown used to losing a ship. They were huddled together, shivering and not meeting the crew's eyes. Half a dozen - Seacat wasn't sure, but she thought the courier might have had a bigger crew than that. Well, that was war.

She looked them over. They were wearing their uniforms, but none of them sported rank insignia. "Who was in charge of this fleet?" she asked.

None of the Horde scum answered. They didn't look defiant - just beaten.

She picked a burly sailor in the front row. "You. Who was in command of your fleet?"

He looked at her. "Force Captain Maris."

Seacat frowned. "That's not a naval rank." Catra had learned the horde ranks quickly - she had to know who could order whom around.

"No." The sailor showed some emotion for the first time, clenching his teeth.

"They put a landlubber in charge of a fleet?" She snorted. The Horde must be getting desperate.

He shrugged.

The others didn't look like they cared, either. They didn't even seem to care much that they had survived.

She returned to Sea Hawk and reported what she had found out.

He rubbed his moustache. “Force Captain Maris… That name…”

Seacat pressed her lips together. If this was another old lover the Captain…

“...doesn’t ring any bell at all!” He shook his head. “Perhaps Adora might know them - she was a Force Captain.”

“For all of a day,” Seacat pointed out. “But she might know them.” Wasn’t there some training program where cadets on the officer track served as aides? Adora had mentioned something about it, a bit before the field exercise, but Catra hadn’t listened since she wasn’t being considered for command.

“Well, let’s signal the fleet and ask if they recovered the Force Captain,” Sea Hawk said. “First-hand information is always the best kind of information.”

*****

“No, Maris didn’t survive the battle. Splinter from a shell killed him.” The officer - a scorpionman who was almost as huge as the woman Seacat had fought in the Fright Zone - shrugged. “Bad luck. The sailor next to him didn’t get a scratch.”

Such things happened. But the officer seemed to be a little too uncaring about it. “Was he behind the plan to attack the Fortress?” she asked, ignoring how the Salinean officers who were present for the interrogation stiffened at her butting in.

“He said the plan came from Horde High Command,” the officer replied.

“And do you believe that?” Sea Hawk asked.

Another shrug. “The captains believed. And if he had been lying, well… It doesn’t matter any more, does it?”

“Weren’t you supposed to work in concert with a land attack?” Seacat studied the man to gauge his reaction, but he merely

blinked. “That would’ve been a good idea, I guess. But we weren’t told anything.”

And since any officer had to be ready to take command, should the enemy land a lucky shot, they needed to know the entire plan. That meant they hadn’t meant to strike in support of an attack by land. That made the attack even more reckless. Daring - Sea Hawk would’ve approved - but reckless.

“Did you actually think you would succeed?” Captain Borda, who was commanding the Mermaid’s Pride, blurted out. She must have come to the same conclusion.

This time, the officer scoffed. “We managed to sink one of your frigates while being outnumbered and outgunned. And if you hadn’t copied our engines, we would’ve broken through.”

“Did you even know that we got engines in our ships as well?” Borda shot back.

“It was unconfirmed intelligence. We prepared for it, but…” Once more the man shrugged.

“You’re awfully blasé about losing the entire fleet that had managed to slip through the blockade,” Sea Hawk commented.

“As the Force Captain told us: The war will be decided on land.”

Seacat snorted. “And you believed it?”

The Scorpionman sneered at her. “That’s how it worked last time. The Rebellion fell apart after defeats on land.”

“Too bad for you that the Horde hasn’t won any battle on land in a while,” Seacat spat.

“And Salineas will fight on even if our allies are defeated! You’ll never conquer us!” Borda added.

And yet another shrug. “We’ll see. For me, the war’s over either way.”

“That is correct,” Sea Hawk said with a smile before turning to the two marine guards in the room - two minotaurs just a little smaller than Horas. “Take him away.”

As soon as the door closed behind the prisoner and the guards, Borda shook her head. “With such an officer corps, it’s a wonder they have won any battles.”

“They only won when they had overwhelming advantages. At sea, at least,” one of the officers - Seacat didn’t know the man’s name - added.”

“Now, now,” Sea Hawk said, frowning. “The man has just suffered a complete defeat and saw many of his comrades die. He must be still under shock, so we cannot take his attitude at face value. However, I think we can say that the Horde didn’t put much faith in this attack.”

“The officers didn’t,” Seacat agreed. “They still fought hard, though.”

“And they still lost,” another Salinean officer said. “If the rest of the Alliance did half as well as the Navy, we’d have won the war already.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. She was a sailor, and she knew better than to dismiss the naval war like the Horde scum had done, but… “The Horde focuses on the land war.”

“Certainly not!” the idiot protested. “That would be foolish!”

“You’ve heard the prisoner, haven’t you?” Sea Hawk cut in. “And they aren’t entirely wrong. Should they beat the Rebel Alliance on the continent, the remaining kingdoms would be hard-pressed to defeat them.”

“They would have the resources of the entire continent and interior lines,” another officer added. “And they could block trade. How long could we, much less the Kingdom of Snows, last without trade?”

“We could always trade directly with the West!” the fool replied. “We control the seas!”

“How long will you be in control when you depend on fuel crystals from the continent to keep your shiny new frigates running?” Seacat shot back. “And how long until the Horde conquers the West?”

“The logistical challenges of launching an offensive against the west are considerable. Without control of the sea, I doubt that they could supply their troops in the field,” an older officer - Captain Kunis - pointed out. “However, you are correct: Without the resources of the continent, Salineas cannot maintain a competitive navy. That isn’t a new development, though - we had to rely on imported timber for our shipyards for decades.”

“So, in essence, nothing has changed,” Sea Hawk said. “The Alliance needs every member to defeat the Horde. Fortunately, My dear Mermista is well aware of that and on good terms with the other princesses.”

The Captain ignored the frowns that briefly appeared on various officers’ faces when he reminded them of his relationship with their princess.

Seacat didn’t.

“Now, let’s return to port - we have a number of prisoners to deliver, and prepare our offensive. Dismissed, gentlemen.”

*****

Seacat didn’t bother with the rope ladder hanging down from the frigate. She vaulted over the railing and pushed off of the hull, launching herself across the grab and grabbing the mast of the

Dragon's Daughter V. A moment later, she slid down the mast and landed on the hull. "Get ready to return to port," she told the crew.

Behind her, the Captain arrived, jumping off the ladder halfway on the way down and landing next to her. "Huzzah! Another victory for the Alliance!"

"No prizes, though," Alcy complained.

"But fame, which often begets fortune! Why the number of drinks we'll be paid for telling our story…" Sea Hawk shook his head. "My old friends will be so jealous!"

Seacat sighed. Sea Hawk's old lovers were already jealous enough in her opinion. But then, as an admiral, the Captain's reputation would spread with every victory anyway - and defeat wasn't an option, of course. And it was impressive - all the raiding frigates sunk, three couriers sunk, at the cost of one frigate. Not the perfect victory, but a victory nevertheless, and one that meant the sea lanes were safe again from Horde raiders. As were the supplies in the harbour.

She narrowed her eyes as they turned towards the port - Fortress Freedom, Seacat reminded herself with a frown. The shrimp didn't have a good hand with naming things. Was that… "Smoke?"

"It looks like smoke," Lucy confirmed. "From the harbour."

Seacat rushed to the top of the mast with her telescope. And cursed. She couldn't see everything in the harbour from her position - the mast was tall enough and the angle not ideal - but what she saw… one transport was on fire. But how? She couldn't see any enemy ship. Saboteurs amongst the soldiers or dockworkers?

Wait. There was something in the water - a drifting body. And a swimmer wrestling with… tentacles? And the ship was listing…

She had thought there were a bit too few fishmen and fishwomen amongst the enemy crew.

“Captain!” she yelled down. “Looks like they slipped fishfolk into the harbour.”

“What?” Sea Hawk replied. “What about our patrols?”

*****

“They swarmed our pickets. They must have sneaked close or something, took them before they could release the warning buoys,” Colonel Kilian told them an hour later, standing on the mole. “And with the lookouts distracted by the battle at sea…” He bared his clenched teeth. “Damn saboteurs slipped through, and…” He shrugged, wiping some soot stain from the back of his hand. “You know the rest.”

“We do,” Sea Hawk said.

“One transport sunk with half the supplies,” Seacat added. “That’ll set the offensive back a few weeks, at the least.” She looked at the wreck blocking one pier. That would have to be cleared as well before another transport could use the pier. Which meant the port’s capacity would be reduced.

What a mess.

“Hmm.” Sea Hawk rubbed his chin. “If we set sail at once with the Dragon’s Daughter V, we should be able to cut down on that. Still, we need to get back to Seaworthy, first, and grab supplies there.”

And that would cost time. Damn. One link of a chain broke and everything was held up.

Seacat blinked. A chain link. Oh. “We don’t need to sail all the way to Seaworthy!” she blurted out.

“Oh?” Sea Hawk looked at her with a smile. Even Kilian raised his eyebrows.

"We just need to reach the closest port to the north," she explained. "We'll take their supplies and ship them here, they'll send for the supplies from the port further north, and that port will have to get new supplies from Seaworthy."

"Oh, I see. Yes, that should work!" Sea Hawk beamed at her and hit the palm of his hand with his fist. "Good idea, First Mate!"

"That'll disrupt their buildup, though," Kilian said.

"But not as seriously as this disrupted our schedule," the Captain replied, pointing at the sunken ship and the listing second transport. "They have shorter supply lines and quicker communication with Seaworthy."

"And they should have a stock of supplies already," Seacat added. "They've been fighting for months already." And they wouldn't keep their supplies on a transport, anyway.

"Indeed! Let us rush north and secure us a transport!" Sea Hawk declared, pointing to the north. "The Horde might have gained a stay of execution, but not for long!"

"And I'll start a limited offensive with the supplies we have," Kilian added. "Keep the bastards busy and make them worry they failed."

"Good idea!"

Seacat nodded. But Adora and her friends would start their offensive on schedule. They'd bear the brunt of the Horde's reaction.

Damn.

*****

The Requisition

“Wow. We’re really faster than a skiff!” Alcy said, leaning over the railing to peer ahead. Her long, dark hair was blown back, almost hitting Seacat in the face.

With a scowl, she took a step towards the aft. “You should tie your hair up,” she said.

“Why?”

“It could get entangled in something,” Seacat told her.

“Like what?”

“My claws.” She raised her hand.

“Oh!” Alcy giggled for a moment. “Sorry, I didn’t realise.” She made an attempt to gather her hair in a braid, but with the wind blowing from the north and the engine running at full power, it was doomed to failure.

Seacat shook her head. “It’s nothing.” Just a minor annoyance compared to having to rush up the coast to secure supplies for the offensive. And worrying about Adora. And her friends.

But the former pirate - Alcy and Licy still hadn’t admitted their past, but Seacat was sure - frowned. “You should be enjoying the trip. There aren’t any Horde ships left to bother us, and this is great - we’re setting new records!”

“We’re only here because we made a mistake,” Seacat retorted. “A mistake which might cost us.”

“It wasn’t our mistake - we sank the Horde ships facing us. It was the marine patrols who failed,” Alcy told her, turning to lean with her back against the railing. “We’re rectifying their mistake. And that was your idea, wasn’t it?”

“Yes. But we’re all in this together,” Seacat pointed out. “If the offensive fails, claiming that we did our part won’t help us.”

“But would it fail? Even if we were delayed two weeks, all the marines I talked to, especially Lt Grenam, were convinced we would still win.” Alcy grinned and pointed at the coast. “They’ve been cut off from supplies and reinforcements. They won’t be able to do much with a few more weeks.”

“The northern Horde forces still receive some supplies overland,” Seacat countered.

“But is that enough to keep fighting? They can’t ship enough supplies with the coast and river blockaded.” Alcy frowned a little. “A delay might actually help the army. Starve the Horde a little longer.”

“There’s also the Horde forces in the Fright Zone,” Seacat said. “They will have more time to prepare as well. And their supply lines are in better shape.”

“But they’re not our problem,” Alcy replied. “We just have to secure the river. And strike northwards. Bright Moon will attack the Fright Zone, won’t they?”

That was the plan. And Seacat was sure that the Bright Moon attack would happen on schedule - and draw the brunt of the Horde forces. “Yes.”

“So, no worries.” Alcy smiled and reached out to clap Seacat on the shoulder. “We’ll be safe.”

Probably. But Adora…

“Oh!” Alcy gasped, then smiled again. “And don’t worry about Adora. She’s She-Ra, isn’t she? She’ll be fine!”

Seacat pressed her lips together. She better be fine. Or she’d have words with the shrimp and Brain Boy. They were Adora’s friends, weren’t they? They had to protect her. From herself, if needed.

*****

“I can’t just hand over my supplies to you! Those are earmarked for us! We depend on them!” Colonel Fores glared at them, his broad chest making him look like he was puffing himself up behind his desk.

“Of course you can!” Sea Hawk retorted. “You’ve got a much closer supply line - and you should have your magazines and stores full already while the forces in Fortress Freedom have had much less time to prepare. And we’ve suffered attacks by the Horde.”

“It’s not my problem if you can’t protect your supplies! My troops need them!”

“Actually, it *is* your problem,” Seacat snapped. “If we can’t launch the strike from the south, you’ll be facing much stiffer opposition. If part of your troops lost their supplies, you’d send them more anyway, wouldn’t you?”

“That’s not the same - they’re all under my command!”

“And we’re all under the command of the Princess Alliance,” Sea Hawk countered. “Of which my dear Mermista is a prominent member.”

“I only answer to Princess Frosta!” Fores spat. “And I won’t give out my supplies to… to some dressed-up smuggler! Not without an order from the Alliance!”

Sea Hawk glared at the idiot, shaking his head. “I see.” He turned to Seacat. “Let’s go, First Mate.”

As soon as they had left the lavish field headquarters, Seacat leaned a little closer to the Captain. “What do we do? Race to Seaworthy?”

“That would take too long even with our engine and favourable winds. And we don’t know how long it’ll take to secure supplies

and a transport there. No," Sea Hawk said with a grin, "I think we should look for a different solution."

"A different solution?" Seacat blinked before she gasped. "You don't mean…?"

He beamed at her. "They haven't unloaded the latest transport, yet. And I think it's time for you to take a command of your own."

He was serious. They were going to steal a transport.

Great.

*****

"We're going to capture a transport?" For a moment, Licy's grin seemed to reach her ears.

"Really?" Alcy, too, perked up. And she was usually the more even-headed of the two!

"Oh, yes!" Sea Hawk said. "I'm afraid it's the only solution for saving the Princess Alliance."

While the two scoundrels nodded eagerly, Horas grunted.

"We're not going to keep or sell the cargo or the transport," Seacat said before the two women could get the wrong idea. "We're going to sail her south to Fortress Freedom."

"Of course." Licy kept nodding so much, her blonde ponytail bopped up and down behind her like a buoy in a storm.

"Indeed!" Sea Hawk pushed his chest out. "The lives of our brothers and sisters in arms depend on this! We won't see them fight hungry and cold, bereft of weapons and supplies!"

"Because that would leave us without the needed support to take on the Horde," Seacat added. "And that wouldn't go well for us."

"Right," Alcy said, seemingly sobering a little.

Licy, though, was still beaming. “So, how do we do this? Board them at night and hold them at sabre-point?”

“Not quite,” Sea Hawk said. “That would be kidnapping. And a crime.”

“More like press-ganging,” Alcy said. “And the Salinean Navy does that all the time.”

“Only to merchant sailors,” Seacat corrected her. And with the war needing all the transports available to supply the troops, they had stopped that as well. “But we’re not going to hold our own at sword point.”

“Then how are we going to steal the ship?” Alcy asked. “They’re not going to simply let us take it.”

“Unless we make a show of force,” her friend added, “but then that usually involves pointing a sword at them.”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “We have a plan to get them to leave the ship without using violence.”

“You’re going to order them off the ship?” Alcy asked.

“In a manner of speaking, yes. A much more dramatic and suitable manner that won’t let anyone accuse me of abusing my rank,” he told her.

For the first time, the two women looked apprehensive. Even Horas looked slightly concerned. Well, they had been sailing with the Captain for weeks.

Sea Hawk grinned and pulled a small box out of his pocket. “We’ll be using this!”

“Tobacco?” Alcy asked, cocking her head to read the letters on the lid.

“No, I’m just using it for storage,” Sea Hawk told her. He flipped the lid open. “This is smoke powder.”

“Oh!” Alcy’s eyes lit up. “You’re going to fake a fire!”

“Exactly!” Sea Hawk beamed at them. “And we’ll be the daring and selfless heroes who will tow the burning ship out of the harbour before it sets another vessel aflame!”

“Ah!”

Seacat shared a grin with the crew. As far as plans went, this was simple and still sneaky. “We’ll start as soon as the sun has set.”

*****

Usually, Seacat would have preferred to approach the transport by swimming and diving. She could easily climb the hull at any point thanks to her claws. But after the news about fishmen saboteurs hitting Fortress Freedom had arrived, Colonel Fores had doubled the fishmen patrols in the harbour. So, that way was blocked to her.

Which was why she was currently crouching on the roof of a small guardpost at the waterfront, studying the pier ahead. There were no dockworkers - they had stopped their work after barely having started upon the transport’s arrival in the afternoon. Obviously, Fores didn’t need the supplies in the ship’s hold so urgently as he had claimed.

But that left the patrols - and Fores had increased them as well. On the other hand, the soldiers Seacat saw didn’t look very attentive. It wouldn’t be too hard to sneak past them even without the distraction she had arranged. A distraction that should be starting any minute now…

Then she heard the singing. Alcy was many things - a former pirate, a scoundrel, a good sailor and a fair gunner, but she wasn’t a singer. That didn’t stop her, of course, when she had a few ales. Or was pretending to be drunk.

Arm in arm with Licy, waving half-empty mugs around, she sang as they stumbled down the waterfront. As soon as they spotted the patrol, they walked towards them.

“Hey, soldier!” Licy yelled out. “Whatcha doin’?”

“We’re on patrol!” the leader, a hard-faced woman almost as tall as Adora said.

“Oh! Whatcha patrollin’ for?” Alcy cocked her head and pretended to lose her balance, stumbling into the arms of the second soldier, a young man. “Oops!”

“Watch it, you drunkard!” the woman spat. “Kuro, what are you doing?”

Seacat grinned and slid down from the roof, dashing across the waterfront and towards the pier as the soldier tried to explain that he wasn’t fondling Alcy - she was fondling him.

By the time she reached the transport, this Kuro was still talking.

Hiding behind a crate on the pier, she studied the transport. The gangway was down - well, that was standard - but illuminated. The deck watch didn’t seem to be the most attentive but still… better not take that risk. Especially since Alcy and Licy’s act was distracting the patrol but attracting the attention of the man on deck.

Well, a watch had been expected after the scare about Horde fishmen infiltrators. Even though the watch wasn’t actually paying attention to the sea. If they were, Seacat could’ve strolled up the gangway easily.

As it was, she had other means. The transport was tied down at the pier, after all. And the lines were sturdy, with some slack, but not enough so climbing them would be particularly difficult.

Seacat checked the patrol - not looking in her direction - and then the watch before dashing to the edge of the pier and grabbing the

line. She scaled it upside down, then slid over the railing at the bow of the transport, past the carved likeness of a dolphin. According to what they had seen, the ship - named ‘Leaping Dolphin’, even though it was as likely to leap across the waves as a particularly large tub - had a crew of six people. One was serving as the watch, which left five sleeping below at most - some would be carousing. And the captain in their cabin. Unless they were carousing as well.

In any case, it didn’t matter. She reached into the pack she had strapped on her back and pulled out the first burner, placing it in a nook next to the anchor chain’s windlass. She didn’t lit it. Not yet. The ‘fire’ had to break out in the hold - on the deck, the crew might attempt to put it out.

She sneaked forward, keeping to the shadows cast by the mast. The watch was on the bridge, leaning against the railing. Watching Alcy and Licy make a fool out of the patrol. Taking a deep breath, Seacat dashed forward, to the hatch leading into the hold. It wasn’t locked - sloppy, but a good thing for her - and she heaved, opening it far enough to slide through without getting squished.

She clenched her teeth as she struggled a little to keep the hatch from making a noise when she lowered it down again. Waking up the crew would be bad.

The hold was full of crates and bags. Food, mostly. Just what they needed for the offensive. And no one was sleeping here - perhaps the captain had been worried about his crew stealing some of the cargo. Or… No, the hold didn’t smell; some cargo, especially spices, could render a hold quite unattractive as a sleeping spot.

But she wouldn’t complain about anything that made her task easier. She planted two burners in the corners, towards the bow, then lit the fuses they had patched together from the swivel gun’s fuses. About two minutes left until the ‘fire’ would break out.

She scrambled up the stairs and put her back against the hatch, lifting it slowly until she could peek through the gap at the bridge. Where the watch wasn't standing any more. Damn.

She suppressed a hiss. Where was the damn watch? Did the idiot pick just now to make their rounds? The fuses were burning! She held her breath and listened. No footsteps. Had the watch gone to sleep or what?

She looked around. She couldn't spot anyone. And the clock was ticking. No time to wait. She pushed the hatch up some more, then squeezed through the gap, rolling over the deck towards the shadow cast by the railing.

Still no sign of the watch. If the idiot wasn't on their post, they would have to 'discover' the fire and alert the crew themselves. And she needed to be off the ship.

She dashed towards the bow, lit the burner she hid there, then climbed over the railing and slid down the line to the pier. Alcy and Licy were still keeping up their act, but they couldn't stretch it out forever before the patrol would arrest them. Or try to arrest them.

Seacat rushed back, checked if the patrol was looking at the wrong spot, then passed behind the soldiers, winking at the two scoundrels, and ducked into a side alley. Whew!

Grinning, she straightened and checked her appearance. No suspicious smears or stains on her clothes. She ran her hands through her mane, then retired her ponytail. Showtime.

She sauntered out of the side alley, then pretended to be surprised by Alcy and Licy's presence. "Hey! What are you doing? You should be back on the ship!" she yelled.

"First Mate!"

"Seacat!"

The patrol leader grinned nastily, obviously imagining what punishment the two women would suffer. Well, she would be disappointed - Seacat could already see the smoke starting to waft through the gaps in the hatch of the transport.

“Hell!” she gasped. “Something’s burning!” She pointed at the ship

The soldiers whirled, then gasped as well. “That’s the Leaping Dolphin! It’s full of supplies!”

“Forget the supplies!” Seacat yelled. “We need to warn the crew!” She didn’t wait for the others to reply and dashed towards the transport. “Hey! Hey! Fire!”

Where was the watch? The soldiers started yelling as well as Seacat rushed up the gangway. “Fire!” she screamed. “Fire in the hold!”

“What?” Ah, there was the watch, They must have fallen asleep on deck.

“Fire!” she repeated herself, pointing at the smoke emerging from the gaps in the hatch.

Kuro actually pulled on the hatch, lifting it up - and was instantly engulfed in a cloud of thick smoke billowing out from the hold.

“What?”

“Oh, no! The ship’s on fire!”

“Captain!”

The rest of the transport’s crew had finally arrived on deck. Where was the captain?

“No!” A burly man wearing breeches and not much else stared at the smoke. “Get some buckets!”

“Buckets? Are you mad?” Seacat snapped. “That much smoke… the fire’s too big already!”

“The bow’s catching fire, too!” Alcy added, staring at the bow, where Seacat’s third burner had started smoking.

“The ship’s going to lit up like a fireship!” Seacat yelled. “Get off her before the deck collapses!”

Confused and barely awake, the sailors were halfway down the gangway before their captain could react. “No!” he screamed. “Fetch some buckets! We need to save the Dolphin!”

“Save yourself!” Seacat told him. “We can’t do anything here - we have to save the others!”

“What? Others?” he complained as she pushed him down the gangway.

“The ship’s going to rip free once the lines catch fire,” she said. “And it might drift into the other ships.”

The soldiers - on the pier already - cursed at that and even the Dolphin’s captain paled. “No…”

“We’ll have to drag it out of the harbour,” Seacat continued. “Before it burns down to the waterline and sinks, blocking the entire pier.”

“But… how?”

Seacat bared her fangs and pointed at the Dragon’s Daughter V, which was approaching the Leaping Dolphin, Sea Hawk at the helm. “With her!”

She raced back up on board, followed by Alcy and Licy, who kicked the gangway off once all were aboard, and ran to the bow. “Cut the lines!”

As the two scoundrels started hacking at the mooring lines, Seacat waved towards Horas, who was already swinging the tow line to throw it over to her.

The minotaur let fly, and the weighted line shot across the narrowing gap between the two ships, landing on the deck of the Leaping Dolphin with a crack. Seacat grabbed it, held her breath and ran into the smoke cloud covering the bow of the transport.

She followed the railing through the thick smoke until she bumped into the base of the bowsprit. Squeezing her eyes shut - the smoke made them burn anyway - she felt around for the opening there, quickly pushing the line through, then looped it around itself and tied it off.

Then she felt her way back out of the cloud - only to discover that the smoke from the hold had started to engulf the deck. She took a deep, smoky breath, then yelled “She’s tied up, Captain!” before quickly making her way to the bridge, where Alcy and Licy were at the helm.

“Shouldn’t we extinguish the burners?” Alcy asked, coughing.

“Not yet, “Seacat replied. “They would notice something amiss.”

“They should’ve noticed the lack of actual flames already,” Alcy commented.

Then the ship jerked - the Dragon’s Daughter V had pulled away and was now towing the Leaping Dolphin behind her. And the air current that was causing blew the smoke straight towards the bridge.

Seacat cursed - she should’ve anticipated that. “I’ll extinguish the burner at the bow,” she said - the people left at the pier wouldn’t see much, anyway, once they were a little further away. Not at night and from behind. And the smoke was worse than she had expected.

She took a deep breath, left the two scoundrels behind and slid down the stairs to the deck, then grabbed the railing and made her way to the bow. She had to struggle to avoid coughing - the smoke in her lungs felt terrible - but reached the bow. And the burner would be… She knelt and felt around. There! She grabbed the burner and felt around for the lid. It wasn't there. Had it slid around?

Damn! She was running out of air. She snarled and threw the burner overboard, then waited until the air currents cleared the bow and finally took another breath.

And coughed.

Damn. And she still needed to put out the burners in the hold. That had to wait until they were past the mole, though.

Which they were just reaching. Great. And Alcy and Licy were still in the - fortunately thinner - smoke cloud from the hold.

Cursing under her breath, she approached the hatch leading to the hold. "Hold your breath!" she yelled.

Then she opened the hatch, and thick, black smoke rose, covering half the ship in a few seconds.

A deep breath later, she went down the stairs. She couldn't see anything at first, but then, the airflow started to draw most of the smoke out - going prone, she could see somewhat. There was the first burner!

She crawled towards it - its lid was next to it! - and closed it. That left the other. She went prone again and crawled towards the other corner. Her lungs were starting to burn. And the lid had disappeared here!

Silently cursing, she felt around. No lid.

Damn it. Had some rats taken it? Or had it slid beneath one of the crates?

It didn’t matter. She had to get rid of that burner. She grabbed it and dashed back to the stairs, then up on deck, and heaved.

It still took a few minutes for the smoke to clear, and her clothes would stink until she washed them, but they wouldn’t suffocate any more.

Though the supplies would smell and probably taste a little smoked.

*****

“And?” Seacat asked an hour later, standing on the main deck of the Leaping Dolphin.

“It’s a little smoky, yes,” Licy told her after swallowing the rest of the bread. “But it’s not too bad. I’ve had worse.”

Seacat nodded. She’d had a taste herself, but it was good to have confirmation - tastes differed, after all. If both Seacat and Licy could eat it, odds were the majority of the marines could eat it. They’d complain, of course, but soldiers always complained about the food anyway. Most of the food was canned and not affected by smoke anyway.

She looked back. She couldn’t see the lighthouse of the port behind them any more. By now, the selfish Colonel would have realised what they had done - but the man wouldn’t be able to chase after them. The only ship able to catch them would be a Salinean frigate with an engine - or a courier with an engine - and none of either had been in the harbour. Granted, a fast courier might catch up with them with a little bit of luck and favourable winds, but Fores couldn’t order around a Salinean courier. At least not for such a thing.

She smiled. They had gotten away clean. The plan had worked.

“It feels a little weird, you know,” Licy commented. “Being towed like that, I mean.”

“Hmm?” Seacat cocked her head to look at the woman.

“We’re three here - more than on the Dragon’s Daughter V,” Licy explained, “But we don’t have to do anything. Alcy’s on the helm, but we could probably rig something so the rudder stays stuck.”

“We’re here in case something comes up,” Seacat told her. “The Captain and Horas can handle the Dragon’s Daughter V, but if we need to sail this transport, we’ll have our hands full.” More than full - three crew was pushing it for a ship this size.

“Right. But what are the odds of that? We’ll be back in Fortress Freedom in no time, with our ship pulling us.”

“Don’t jinx it!”

“Sorry!”

*****

Dawn. Seacat stifled a yawn. She’d taken the last watch of the night, letting Alcy and Licy sleep a little, but she hadn’t been able to rest much before that - which was why she had to make an effort to stay awake right now. At least she didn’t have to do too much - the Leaping Dolphin was still being towed behind the Dragon’s Daughter V. Slower than before - the Captain didn’t want to overstress the engine or, how Entrapta called it, ‘weaken the containment fields’. Which was a quite disturbing expression for anyone who had seen the tests in Salineas. Such as Seacat.

And it wasn’t as if they had to rush - they would arrive soon at the fortress anyway. Seacat expected to see a picket or patrol appear at the horizon any moment now.

Suddenly, she heard a crack, and the ship started to fight her, rolling in the sea and trying to turn left or right. The cable had snapped, she realised as she struggled to keep the ship going straight. Of course, that shouldn’t be a surprise - the cable had been meant to tow a courier, not a transport, much less one almost fully loaded.

But she couldn't worry about that right now. Not with a ship in peril - light peril. "Alcy! Licy! Up and about! Set sails!" she yelled. "Get up! The line broke!"

The two women quickly appeared on deck. "What the hell?" Alcy yelled.

"The line snapped," Seacat repeated herself. "Set sails! We need to get underway!" Otherwise, she wouldn't be able to steer the transport. And that would be dangerous in this sea.

Alcy and Licy threw themselves into it, pulling the mainsail up, and even before the sail's tip reached the top, Seacat could feel the ship starting to pick up speed and the rudder having an effect again.

Whew. "Good work! Reel in the snapped line!" she yelled. "And prepare to turn about!" They needed to get back on course.

Slowly - far too slowly for Seacat's taste - the ship started to turn, with Alcy adjusting the mainsail and Licy reeling in the line dragging in the water. After a few tense minutes, they were finally on the right course again, and the two women could set the foresail.

And there was the Dragons' Daughter V. "Ahoy! Do you need assistance?" the Captain yelled.

"No!" she yelled back. "We've got things under control!"

"Want us to tow you again?"

And risk the line snapping closer to the ship, and injuring someone as it whipped over the deck? "No," she replied. "We can sail the rest of the way."

"Alright! Follow us!"

Seacat frowned as the Dragon's Daughter nimbly overtook them. If she ever got a ship of her own, then it wouldn't be a slow

transport.

*****

“Land Ahoy!”

Finally! She had expected to see the fortress around this time - they had met a picket ship, after all, and had been able to confirm their position after sailing out of sight of the coast to avoid entering a bay - but you never knew when a stronger current than normal might have pushed them further south than expected. Or delayed them.

Not this time. She could see the fortress ahead. Two frigates were just leaving the port, but there were more ships in the harbour; she could see the tops of many masts. More than expected. And the flags… Oh. “Mermista’s in port,” she said.

“What? The princess?” Licy gasped next to her.

“Yes. That’s her personal flag there in the centre. Crown over Mermaid.” Sea Hawk had spent a day trying to write a poem about it, once.

“Oh.” Licy sounded surprised. “That’s a good thing, right?”

“Normally, yes,” Seacat replied.

“Normally?” Licy’s voice hit a slighter higher pitch than normal.

“Normally, we don’t have a transport with us which we requisition under slightly hasty conditions,” Seacat explained.

“Oh.” Licy seemed to think for a moment. “But the Captain’s her lover.”

“Yes.”

“And it was his decision. So, we’re going to be OK, right?”

“Yes.” If there was any blame to be dealt out, Sea Hawk would take it. That was a captain’s duty, as he liked to say.

*****

“My dear Mermista!” Sea Hawk turned away from where he had been telling the dockworkers to unload the transport and beamed at the approaching princess.

“Sea Hawk.” Mermista nodded, but she was smiling. Good news, then.

Or not - she couldn’t have heard from Colonel Fores, yet, Seacat remembered as the two embraced. And kissed.

Seacat caught the admiral behind the princess openly frowning at the display. No surprise there.

“Seacat! How did the sword work? I can see that you didn’t use its explosive function, but how did it perform otherwise?”

Entrapta was here? That was a surprise - Seacat would’ve expected her to be in Salineas. “I didn’t get to test it in battle, yet,” she told the princess. “There was no boarding action. It did cut lines very well, though,” she added.

“Alright. Tests inconclusive, need more data,” Entrapta told her recorder. “Oh. And how do *you* do?”

“I’m good,” Seacat replied. “How about you? I thought you would be going back to your workshop in Salineas.”

“Oh, I planned to - and we were - but Mermista then told me that I could analyse any Horde technology that we captured on the offensive! I’ve already examined the weapons left in the fortress, though they were standard issue. However, I’ve seen a new skiff variant that was caught during a skirmish, and it’s fascinating - they improved performance by five per cent! Of course, that was at the cost of reliability and range, but still - they aren’t any more explosive than before, either. If I can isolate the improvements

and compensate for the loss in performance, I should be able to improve the latest mark of my engines as well!”

Now that was good news! Especially the bit about not exploding. “That sounds great,” Seacat told her. “Do you think…”

A shout interrupted her. “You *stole* the transport?”

Seacat winced. That was Mermista being angry.

“We didn’t steal it - we merely requisition supplies in a pragmatic manner,” Sea Hawk defended himself. With a wide smile, he added: “Colonel Fores was most uncooperative and hoarding supplies. Going through the chain of command would have taken too long, so we solved the problem with decisive action!”

“We really needed those supplies,” Seacat cut in. “And Fores can resupply much quicker than we can from Seaworthy. If he even needs to - he strikes me as the type of officer who only cares about his own troops and will hoard supplies for them.”

Now the princess was frowning at her and at Sea Hawk. “You didn’t check, though.”

“No, we didn’t,” Sea Hawk admitted cheerfully. “But it’s very likely. And even if he needed the supplies he can get them faster than we could, and we’re the crucial part of the offensive - we need to strike west and take the river to cut off the Horde forces and strike north against the trapped troops; the northern front just has to hold.”

“A week or two on half-rations won’t kill anyone,” Licy added, then grimaced and paled when that earned her a princessly glare as well. “Sorry…”

Alcy grabbed her friend’s arm, probably pinching her, and dragged her a step back - and behind Horas. “We have to watch the cargo being unloaded, Admiral.” Without waiting for an answer, they retreated up the gangway.

Well, Seacat couldn't blame them - Mermista could be terrifying if she lost her temper.

The princess turned back to glare at Sea Hawk. "You still stole the ship from her crew!"

"We temporarily borrowed it," he corrected her. "They'll get her back once we've unloaded the supplies."

Mermista pinched the bridge of her nose. "And they'll complain to Frosta, who will complain to me about you. Fores will complain to her as well. And probably to Bright Moon."

Seacat snorted. "The Queen won't hear him. Her daughter's going to be on the other front for this, and if we'd been late attacking along the river, her troops would have taken the brunt of the Horde's response." As would have Adora.

"It's still a breach of etiquette and of the chain of command."

Sea Hawk shrugged. "Sometimes, you have to break the rules."

"You do?" Entrapta piped up. "When is that time? I'm always wondering that when I hear this."

Uh-oh. Seacat suppressed a wince. Mermista didn't, as she could tell. Sea Hawk, though, beamed at the princess. "You'll know when it's time, trust me."

"Oh." Entrapta blinked.

"Yes. If you aren't sure, then it's not the time to break the rules," Seacat quickly added.

"Unless they are minor rules," Sea Hawk said.

Mermista's glare could've melted a cannon, in Seacat's opinion. "Rules are there for a reason. Especially when they concern experiments, data gathering and prototype testing."

“So, those aren’t minor rules?” Entrapta asked, pouting.

“No, those are very important rules,” Mermista replied.

“And what are minor rules?”

“They’re rare,” Mermista said. Shutting up Sea Hawk with a glance. “We’ll tell you once we encounter one.”

Seacat hesitated a moment, then spoke - this was too important. “It’s also, well, mostly, a question of why you want to break a rule. If you need to break a rule to save someone, it’s different from breaking a rule to make something easier. The more important the reason, the less important the rule becomes.”

“Oh.” Entrapta nodded. “That makes sense! So, if I needed to save the world, I could break all the rules!”

“Basically, yes,” Sea Hawk said.

“But that’s a hypothetical example,” Mermista said. “The world isn’t in danger of ending.”

“Yes,” Entrapta agreed. “The chance of a seismic event that would trigger enough tidal waves and volcano eruption to destroy most of the habitable surface of Etheria is very, very low.” She beamed at them, her hair bobbing as she nodded.

Seacat felt like her stomach was dropping. ‘Very, very low’ didn’t mean that there was no chance at all. Anyone who ever sailed with Sea Hawk would be very aware of that difference.

“You mean the world could end?” Mermista blurted out.

“Theoretically, yes,” Entrapta replied. “After a landslide near my city, I looked into seismic events and started investigating, and my sensor readings showed that there’s a potentially unstable element - as in an unstable part, not the element in a scientific sense - in the planet’s core that could, if stimulated correctly,

cause seismic shockwaves of an unprecedented power and scope.”

Even Sea Hawk paled at hearing that. Seacat felt her fur bristle and her ears got flat against her head. “And… what’s that... trigger?” she asked.

Entrapta shrugged. “I don’t know. Nothing seismic, at least - it’s not affected by shockwaves.”

“Did… did you test that?” She wouldn’t have done that, right?

“On a micro-scale,” Entrapta told her. “I saw no reaction.”

“You… you risked triggering this… this catastrophe?” Mermista all but shrieked.

Entrapta blinked. “What? Technically, yes, I suppose - but the energy carried by my micro-shockwaves was much lower than those by regular earthquakes.”

Whew. Seacat sighed with relief.

“Although there was the possibility that the wave frequency could be the key to triggering the unknown element. I didn’t test for that.”

“And you shouldn’t. Never. New rule: No poking the core of Etheria!” Mermista stated.

“That’s an important rule, right?” Entrapta asked with a guileless face.

“Ugh… Yes!” Mermista snapped, then turned around and walked - stomped - away.

“My dear Mermista, wait!” Sea Hawk ran after her.

“Did I do something wrong?” Entrapta asked after a few seconds. “She sounded mad.”

Ugh. “She was just shocked to hear that the world isn’t as stable as she thought it was,” Seacat explained. Not quite truthful - or, not completely truthful.

“But she seemed mad at me, even though that’s not my fault. The world is like it is. I just shared my data,” Entrapta said, frowning again. “Should I have lied instead?”

“No,” Seacat told her. “Sometimes, people get angry. She’ll calm down.”

“But… it wasn’t my fault.”

“And she knows it. She’s just a little… It’s just been a little too much, what with the war, our transport, the upcoming offensive, and now this.”

“Oh.”

They watched the princess and the Captain disappear in the crowd at the waterfront in silence. “Say… where’s Emily?” Seacat asked, as much to change the subject and cheer the princess up as to find out what the bot was doing.

“Oh, she’s doing a patrol of the perimeter! I’ve enhanced her sensors, so she can spot skiffs at a longer distance than she can be spotted. And she doesn’t need food or light so she can cover a lot of terrain without breaks. I also rigged some signal rockets to her so she can inform us if she encounters any Horde troops - I’ve made up a small code so she can tell us if she’s seeing scouts, a skirmishing party, or a larger force of the Horde,” Entrapta explained.

That sounded useful. And the Horde could mistake the bot for one of their own. Then again, so could Salinean soldiers. “Did you mark her as on our side?”

“Yes. I had to - she was almost attacked by some soldiers when we arrived, even though she didn’t do anything!” Entrapta pouted.

“Now she’s got some Princess Alliance symbol painted on her hull, and it’s weird.”

“Ah. Well…” Seacat trailed off when she spotted three signal rockets arc through the sky in the distance. “Uh… what’s the code for three red signal rockets?”

“That would be ‘too many to count’, why do you… Oh.”

‘Oh’ fit the situation very well, Seacat thought.

*****

The Counterattack

The bot had spotted ‘too many enemies to count’. Seacat didn’t know if that meant Emily couldn’t see all of the Horde troops or if the bot actually couldn’t count that high, but either way, this wasn’t just a scouting party. “Sound the alert!” she yelled. “Horde incoming.”

The marines unloading the cargo from the Leaping Dolphin looked at her, blinking.

She clenched her teeth. “That was a warning from a scout! The Horde’s attacking!”

“What about our pickets?” a woman asked. “They can’t have missed that!”

“Then they’re dead,” Seacat snapped. “Alcy, Licy, Horas! Prepare the ship!”

“What are you doing?” Entrapta asked.

“Alerting the Captain and Mermista!” Seacat took off towards the waterfront.

“Oh, OK!”

A quick glance over her shoulder showed Seacat that the princess was following her, using her hair to take giant steps.

Seacat almost ran into a particularly slow and blind soldier, but slid around the man, then dashed towards the citadel. Mermista would be quartered there, not in the lower part of the fortress.

As she turned onto the ramp leading up to the citadel gates, she finally heard the alert being raised in the port. Took them long enough!

That would alert Mermista, too. But she wouldn't know what was happening right away. Seacat drew a hissing breath through clenched teeth and pushed herself to run faster. There! That was the princess's party! They had stopped just in front of the gate! "Sea Hawk! Mermista!" she yelled.

"Hey!" Entrapta chimed in.

Seacat reached the group first, but she was too short of breath to say anything other than "Horde attack! Bot spotted them!" before Entrapta arrived.

"Emily alerted us of a large Horde attack," the princess announced - a little too cheerful for the occasion. Seacat, still catching her breath, noted that a few of the marines seemed taken aback. And everyone seemed to know who Entrapta was talking about.

"How many?" Colonel Kilian - he hadn't been on the pier - asked.

"Too many to count, for Emily - though she can count rather well," Entrapta replied.

"Where are they? They can't have sneaked a large force past my pickets!" Kilian protested, echoing his marine's words.

"Unless they took out the pickets," Sea Hawk said.

"We've got roaming patrols, too."

"Emily was patrolling south of the river," Entrapta said, "when the rockets went up. That's about…" She poured her lips and wrinkled her nose. "...five miles out!" she finished with a bright smile.

The Colonel noticeably calmed down. "That's far out of the pickets' positions. They must have caught the patrols, but we've got enough time to deploy and prepare."

"Are you going to face them in the field?" Mermista asked.

“We can’t let them set up fortified positions on the river bank; they’ll bring up siege guns, and it’ll be a bloody affair to throw them out again. Best to finish them in the field - with support from the frigates,” the Colonel replied.

“They have to expect that,” Seacat pointed out.

“That never stopped the Horde before,” the officer retorted with a humourless chuckle. “It’ll be a massacre when we catch them in the field with a few broadsides.

Seacat didn’t agree. The Horde leaders weren’t military geniuses, but they weren’t stupid, either. Unfortunately. And if Shadow Weaver was behind this, she’d have some plan other than ‘throw bodies at the enemy until one side runs out’. And yet, the river would block an attack on the fortress from the south, and this close to the sea, the river was very wide, so the frigates could sail upriver and decimate any enemy forces on the riverbanks.

“We need to scout the river, Captain,” she said, more quietly, while Kilian bellowed orders to his troops.

“Indeed,” Sea Hawk agreed. “The Horde has shown cunning lately; it wouldn’t do to underestimate them.”

“The Dragon’s Daughter V is ready,” Seacat told him - she trusted the others to have prepared the ship for combat by now.

“Then let us depart post-haste!” Sea Hawk declared before turning to Mermista. “We have to be off, my love!”

“Be careful.”

“Always!”

The kiss that followed was neither careful nor hasty. But a few minutes later, the Captain and Seacat were back on their ship.

“We beat the Navy again!” Seacat said as they were casting off, looking at the frigates still in the process to get under sail.

“Technically, we’re part of the fleet,” Sea Hawk told her.

She frowned. “You know what I mean.”

“I do.” He smiled. “Although I wish I knew what our enemy is up to. They must have a plan to deal with the frigates.”

“Mobile artillery? Skiff-deployed guns could shell the ships,” Seacat suggested.

“I doubt that they have enough of them to match a frigate, much less several,” Sea Hawk replied. “But I could be mistaken.”

Great. If the Horde had enough guns to contest control of the river, the Dragon’s Daughter V would be the first to find out.

They left the harbour and turned towards the river. A quick check with the telescope confirmed that the frigates patrolling were just turning around - they would take a while to return. Well, the two frigates in the harbour would be enough to wreck a Horde attack. Usually.

“Alcy, Licy - to the bow! Man the gun and keep an eye on the river!” Sea Hawk yelled.

Good. Usually, that wouldn’t be needed so close to the sea - here, the river was deep enough for frigates. But if the Horde was planning something… Seacat braced herself on top of the mast and studied the southern shore.

She couldn’t see anything out of place there. Two guardposts, manned - but they were evacuating already, boarding longboats to get back to the fortress. No, there was no Horde here, yet. That left the coast and the river. And they were going upriver.

Seacat turned and studied the water and shore ahead. Some driftwood, nothing unusual… She blinked. That was a lot of driftwood coming down. Had a Horde ship been blown up? She hadn’t heard about any combat, but… accidents happened, and

Adora might've sent some soldiers to the upper part of the river to protect her flanks.

Though… that would still be quite fast to reach the sea just now. Just when a Horde attack was about to take place…

She clenched her teeth and focused on the drifting wood. It looked… not like planks. More like pieces of tree trunks. Quite even pieces. Spread out, too. Wait… was that a line between two pieces? Or what?

"Alcy!" she yelled. "Shoot the driftwood, canister!"

"Which one?" Alcy yelled back while Licy started loading canister.

"The closest one!"

Sea Hawk was already slowing down. Good. Seacat really didn't like the looks of this. Dozens of those pieces were being carried with the river's current, towards them.

Alcy fired. A moment later, the wood exploded in a cloud of splinters and water. "That was canister, right?" Seacat yelled down.

"Yes!"

Damn. "The trunks are rigged to blow! They're bombs!" she screamed. "Keep shooting them!"

A moment later, the ship jerked as Sea Hawk put in reverse. Seacat kept her balance with ease, though - she was used to worse in a gale or even a storm. But those drifting bombs… The frigates wouldn't be able to enter the mouth of the river - hell, they would have to stay away from the coast since those things would spread out in the sea.

The Horde had just neutralised the Navy.

She slid down the mast to grab the signal flags.

“Warn the fortress!” Sea Hawk told her.

Alcy fired again, and another trunk blew up while Seacat scaled the rigging once more. She hoped the explosions had already attracted attention. Then she started signalling. The distance wasn’t too far, so… Yes! On the closest tower, a marine was acknowledging her warning.

Another explosion - quite close this time. How many bombs had the Horde manufactured? Wait… the powdermills were in the heart of the fright zone, and they didn’t require anything exotic like crystals. Damn. Shadow Weaver would have been able to get all the powder she wanted.

She studied the southern shore again as they reached the mouth of the river. The two longboats were clear - or should be. One was lagging a little, but they would be able to outrace any of the trunks.

Yes, they were evading the bombs. Good. She looked further inland. Still no sign of the Horde - but then, moving a few miles took time for an army. Though she would expect their scouts to show up - a skiff could cover the distance in a fraction of the time an infantry force took.

There! Smoke was rising in the light forest in the distance. She took a closer look with her telescope, just in time to see a small tree fall, uprooted by… a bot? A bot with those colours… Emily!

“There’s Emily!” she yelled. The bot hadn’t evaded the enemy forces by heading west - the dumb thing had gone straight towards the fortress. And now it was trapped on the southern shore, pursued by… Skiffs. Skiffs with guns.

A shell blew up next to the bot, making it stumble. Seacat held her breath. If the bot fell… but it recovered and kept going. And returned fire with its own gun - though at that range, and with a gun that made the Dragon’s Daughter V’s swivel gun look big, it wouldn’t do much to the enemy.

Damn.

"First Mate! Signal Emily to head to the cliff! We're going to sail there and pick her up!"

What?

That was a cliff - they couldn't land there. If they wanted to pick up Emily, they would have to find a spot on the river's shore. Which would put them at risk of getting blown up by the bombs drifting in the river.

But Sea Hawk was the Captain. She signalled to the running bot, which promptly changed course.

Great. Now the Horde also knew where they were going. Well, they were hard to miss, anyway, so close to the shore, but still!

At least once they were alongside the cliff, they would be safe from the bombs - the river's current was dragging the things out to sea, not along the coast. Hell - Seacat realised that the bombs would render the entire area unsafe until they were disposed of. Sailing at night would probably be too dangerous. And they would never get all of the bombs. Any ship, friend or foe, would be at risk. No wonder the Horde had been willing to sacrifice their frigates if they had planned this!

And once the offensive along the river started, they would have to deal with more of those.

Seacat clenched her teeth, hissing with frustration, as she kept an eye out for bombs while the Dragon's Daughter V swung around, now going in the correct direction again, and headed towards the cliffside.

What a mess! But she had to focus on the task at hand: Saving a bot. She shuddered briefly when she spotted Emily leaping a small ravine - it looked similar too… Seacat wasn't going there. "How are we taking it on board?" she yelled down. The cliff was as tall as their mast. If the bot leapt, it would damage the deck, at least

- and probably damage itself. And if it leapt into the sea, well… bots weren't boats.

"We'll rig a line!" Sea Hawk replied. "Horas!"

The burly minotaur was already swinging a line with a grappling hook at the end. But that wouldn't hold a bot - someone would have to climb the cliff and fasten the lines properly.

And the best sailor for that job was Seacat.

She watched the cliff again, gauging the time she had left before Emily - and then the Horde pursuit - reached the top. And she didn't like what she came up with. This would be close. Damn close.

Alcy fired the swivel gun, and Seacat jerked - just in time to catch a bomb exploding at sea. Ah. Good.

She slid down the mast, landing lightly on her feet, and grabbed the other line next to Horas. "Is the line secure?"

The minotaur pulled on it, then nodded.

"Good." She slung the other line over her shoulder like a sash, then gripped the grapple line. "Hold it tight until I reach the cliff, then give me some slack!"

Without waiting for an answer, she quickly made her way towards the cliff, hand over hand, upside down. Horas, as ordered, let the line go slack as soon as she touched the rock, and Seacat scaled the cliffside with the help of the rope and the claws in her feet.

She arrived on top just in time to see Emily appear about a hundred yards away. Damn - the grapple hook would never hold the bot's weight. Where to fix it… ah!

She ripped the hook out of the soil, then sprinted to the closest rocks on top of the cliff, wrapping the line around it and tying it up. A few tugs - that should hold.

She ran the other line through the loop, then dashed back to the edge of the cliff and threw it down. Horas caught it. “Hold on to it! We’ll use it to lower Emily down!” The minotaur should be able to hold the bot - but he’d have to brace himself.

And speaking of… Emily arrived, beeping at her while her turret swivelled back and forth. She wasn’t shooting - had she ran out of ammunition?

“Get over here! I need to tie this line to you!” Seacat yelled.

The bot beeped again. Then the earth a few yards behind it blew up - the Horde was shooting at them with guns.

“Hurry!” Seacat screamed.

The bot finally obeyed, scrambling over to her on its stubby legs - one of them not working, she noticed. Whatever. She grabbed the end of the line and jumped on top of the bot. There had to be a ring or something to run the line through… If she had to run the line around the bot, that would take far too long…

Next to her, a hatch opened and a ring appeared. “Ah.”

Seacat knelt to fix the line to the ring when another shell hit - almost directly underneath Emily. The explosion sent the bot stumbling - towards the cliffside. Seacat gasped, then rushed to tie the line off before the frantically beeping bot - and her with it - tumbled over the edge.

“Horas!” she screamed, holding on to the line as Emily started to fall. “Pull!”

They fell for a second that felt like an eternity, the water below - and the rocks beneath it - seemingly to rush at them, until the line went taut, and their fall was stopped. Seacat almost lost her grip on the line, scrambling with her feet for purchase on Emily’s shell, while the bot swung back and forth.

“Lower us! Quickly!” she yelled again. “Before they blow up the rope!”

They started to descend, and Seacat got ready to jump into the rigging - she didn’t know how long the rope would hold both her and Emily’s weight. Not after the abrupt stop before.

When Emily swung towards the Dragon’s Daughter again, Seacat jumped off, launching herself towards the ship’s rigging, then pushed off again and grabbed the other end of Emily’s line, adding her weight to Horas’s while she dangled above him.

“Come on!” she screamed. “Just a few yards more!”

Suddenly, the line went slack again. And both Seacat and the bot dropped.

Seacat fell onto Horas, barely managing to twist her body so she didn’t end up gored by his horns, then slid off and landed on the deck. Not quite on her feet.

Emily hit the deck with a resounding crack, cracking the planks and smashing part of the railing. The force of the impact caused the Dragon’s Daughter V to roll starboard, and Seacat dug in her claws to avoid sliding into the railing.

Emily warbled when the ship rolled back, the bot tethering on the edge. But Horas grabbed one of its flailing legs and heaved, pulling it back from the edge.

“Tie it down!” Seacat yelled as she grabbed the line that had fallen down - they couldn’t have the bot roll around on deck; it’d smash half the ship to cinders.

“Skiffs on the cliff!” Licy yelled.

Seacat briefly looked up. Yes, there were skiffs. And they were deploying guns. Damn. They couldn’t fire that far down, the angle was too steep and they were too close, but if the Dragon’s Daughter V left the cliff for the open sea…

The Captain wasn't about to expose the ship like that, though - he steered it alongside the cliff as Horas and Seacat quickly lashed Emily to the deck. And they were picking up speed - just in time; some bright Horde scum had started dropping rocks from the cliff.

But there were rocks in the water, too, so close to the shore - and if they hit anything at the speed they were going… Seacat clenched her teeth and rushed to the bow; they needed all the eyes on the water to spot rocks and other obstacles below the water.

A shell went overhead - were they firing at the top of the mast? It didn't matter; no one was up there.

"We can't return fire," Alcy told her when Seacat climbed past the woman onto the bowsprit. "The angle's too steep, and we'd have to shoot through our own rigging."

"Just watch for rocks!" she snapped. "We need to gain enough distance to safely turn towards the sea.

Alcy muttered a curse, but leaned over the railing as well, followed by Licy.

The sea looked clear - no, there was a shadow in the water. "Port!" Seacat yelled.

"Port!" Sea Hawk repeated as the ship swung away from the cliff.

"Steady!" Seacat yelled. They just needed to stay the course now until they were past the rock.

Further out to the sea, a column of water up, followed by the sound of a gun. The Horde was firing on them. And they couldn't turn back towards the cliff with the rocks in the way.

"Steady!" she yelled. "Steady!"

The next shell hit closer - close enough to splash the deck with water. "Check the hold for leaks!" she yelled.

The ship swung around, towards the open sea. After a few seconds, it turned back towards the cliff. Sea Hawk was trying to evade the shells. But they were sailing straight towards a reef!

“Port!” Seacat yelled.

The Dragon’s Daughter V started to turn, but it was still getting too close - there was a current pushing them towards the cliff. “Port!” she yelled.

Any second she expected to hear the sound of planks getting crushed and rocks slicing open the ship.

But it didn’t come. Another shell hit the sea further out, and one ahead of them - but to the side.

They were back in the shadow of the cliff, where the Horde’s guns couldn’t hit them. At least with direct fire. If they had howitzers...

“Rock ahead!”

“Port!”

Once more they left the shadow of the cliff, and the shells landed closer. They were still not out of the range of the enemy. Sea Hawk steered the ship more erratically - waving back and forth. But at that distance, that was just rolling dice and hoping you got lucky.

More shells flew, landing behind them and to the side. None were ahead of them - they had to be close to out of range, then.

Close but not yet there. “Steady!” she yelled - the course back to the cliff was still blocked by rocks that would gut the ship.

How much longer?

“More rocks! Steady!”

They kept going. Another close shell doused them in water. Seacat heard the pumps starting - Horas was pumping. They must have sprung a leak. Or more. Probably a loose plank.

And they still couldn't sail closer to the cliff.

But the shells were falling behind them, now. No longer to the side.

"We're out of their range!" Alcy yelled.

They were. They had recovered Emily and escaped. But they had sprung a leak or two. And the waters were still rife with bombs. And…. Hell! More skiffs were setting up guns above them! They must have chased along the cliffside to cut them off!

"Someone must really hate us," she muttered. Well, that was to be expected when sailing with Sea Hawk. "Captain!" she yelled. "Guns on the cliff!"

"I see them. This will be a little tricky!"

Uh oh. Was he going to make a break for the open sea? That would be very dangerous… but they couldn't keep sailing along the cliff; it was slowly turning eastward, which meant they'd be exposed to the guns behind them. They'd be in full view of two batteries, with nowhere to hide.

Oh!

"Watch out for rocks!" she told Alcy and Licy, then dashed to the bridge. "Captain! Do you have more smoke powder?"

His eyes lit up. "Great idea! Yes, the tin is in my cabin, in my desk! Hurry!"

She jumped over the railing, landing on the main deck, then dashed into Sea Hawk's cabin. Tin. Tin. Where was the tin? She ransacked the drawer of his desk. There!

She grabbed the tin, then grabbed a pot from the galley and rushed back on deck - just as another close shell sent a wave of water across it. She kept the tin pressed to her chest as the water rushed over her. They couldn't take much more of that, even if they weren't hit directly, the Dragon's Daughter V might break up from the shockwaves of near misses.

She dashed up the stairs to the bridge, past Sea Hawk, and put the pot down at the stern before she emptied the entire contents of the tin into it.

"Tie it down!"

"Aye aye, Captain," she replied. She would do it after igniting the powder, though. Every moment counted now.

She struck a match and dropped it inside the pot, leaning away from the initial flame, then looked for some rope to tie the pot down as dark smoke started to blow out from it.

"Huzzah! Brace yourself - we're making a break for it!"

Clenching her teeth and holding her breath, she quickly wrapped the line around the pot, threading through the handles, then tied it to the railing. Coughing, she withdrew. "Pot secured!"

"Full speed ahead!"

The Dragon's Daughter V turned towards the open sea and almost seemed to jump when Horas pushed the engine's throttle all the way up.

Sea Hawk started weaving back and worth, spreading the thick smoke trailing behind into a veritable wall. Shells continued to fall, some quite close, but… they were spread out more, Seacat realised after a few minutes.

It was working. The Horde scum was firing blindly. They still could land a lucky shot, of course. But the odds were now in the Dragon's Daughter V's favour.

Though there were an awful lot of shells falling into the sea, she noticed. Not just behind them and to the sides, but some also ahead of them - those had to be from the guns that had just set up.

“How’s the hold?” she yelled to Horas.

“Holding!” came the reply.

She snorted against her will - it couldn’t be too bad if the minotaur could joke, but she’d have preferred a more precise report.

So she moved to the hold, keeping her balance by digging her claws into the deck when Sea Hawk took a tighter turn than normal, and took a look for herself.

There was some water in the hold - about an inch high - but the pumps could keep up. Mostly thanks to Horas working them. She really needed to ask Entrapta about a pump with an engine.

Provided they survived this, of course, she added to herself when another close shell shook the entire ship, and she saw more water enter through a crack in the hull.

“Keep it up!” she yelled, then went to the captain.

“We’re holding up, but it’s getting worse,” she reported on the bridge.

“She’ll get us out of that, no worry! The Dragon’s Daughter V is a brave ship!” Sea Hawk replied. “Huzzah!”

Another close shell seemed to lift the ship up a little - and pushed her further ahead. For a moment, Seacat feared that the engine had been damaged, but they didn’t lose any speed.

And, finally, the shells were falling behind. Just when the smoke powder started to run out.

“That was close,” she said. “We’ve got several leaks in the hull.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk nodded, flashing his teeth. “The floating bombs, now the mobile artillery - the Horde is determined to negate our naval power. This will be a hard battle, I fear.”

“Yes.” The frigates would be needed to throw back the Horde assault - but between the floating bombs and the guns, this could become very costly for the Salinean Navy.

“Let’s return to the Fortress. And keep an eye out for floating bombs!” the Captain ordered. “We’ve got news to deliver. And Horde scum to defeat!”

*****

They had to give the cliff a wide berth - and keep an eye out for floating bombs - on the way back to the fortress. Wider than the apparent range of the Horde guns - Seacat wouldn’t put it past them to try and lure them closer by firing deliberately short shots.

At least the frigates had been warned - the two picket frigates hadn’t sailed closer to the shore, and the frigates in the harbour hadn’t left. And longboats were at the entrance of the port, probably looking for floating bombs. Or fishmen infiltrators.

The Dragon’s Daughter V slid past them, Licy waving at them, and headed straight to the closest pier.

“Tie her up, then start plugging the leaks!” Sea Hawk yelled. “Seacat, with me!”

Seacat frowned. Leaving the ship when they needed everyone to fix the damage as soon as possible? But the Captain’s orders were, well, orders. “Do what you can, focus on the smaller leaks you can completely fix,” she told the others and went to cut loose Emily. The bot warbled some more, then awkwardly got up and headed towards the gangway.

“Wait! We’ll have to lift you to the pier with a crane!” she told it. “The gangway is too narrow and too weak for you!”

Fortunately, the bot stopped, and Seacat went down the gangway and addressed the closest soldier on the pier. “Get a crane over here and get the bot on the pier!”

The man stared at her, then glanced at Sea Hawk coming down the gangway before he nodded. “Yes, ma’am!”

She clenched her teeth. Sea Hawk couldn’t be expected to handle everything; that was what he had his crew for. The soldiers should know that she spoke for him.

But they had more important problems than the chain of command. More urgent ones, too. “What’s the plan?” she asked as they walked down the pier at a brisk pace. What she meant was: Why do you need me here?

“We need to talk to Mermista. And to Entrapta. We need a way to deal with those floating bombs.”

“Ah.” That was it - she should’ve known. Mermista would be busy being in command, so Seacat as the next best woman would be the one to talk to Entrapta. And check the princess’s ideas for practicability. And for safety. That made sense.

“Now, where would my dear love be?” Sea Hawk mused as they reached the waterfront. “If she saw us entering the harbour, she would have sent word already, so she must be in the citadel.” He nodded at his own words, rubbing his moustache. “Onward, then!”

Seacat shrugged as she followed him. It was as good as any other guess.

But the Captain turned out to be correct - they were met by a runner halfway to the gate of the citadel. A few minutes later, they entered the planning room at the top of the main tower.

“Sea Hawk.” Mermista nodded at him, Seacat saw, but she was far tenser than normal. Well, a battle was starting. Or had started - the first shots had definitely been fired.

“My dear Mermista!” Sea Hawk hugged her anyway. “We’ve returned bearing a rescued comrade of the mechanical variety, and dire news.”

“Emily! You’ve brought Emily!” Entrapta blurted out. “Where is she? How is she?”

“Emily’s on the ship, about to get unloaded, and apart from being a little banged up, looked fine,” Seacat replied.

“Oh, no! I’ve got to check on her - it’s thanks to her that we received advance warning of this attack!”

“Emily’s fine,” Seacat told the princess, holding up her hand. “But before you go, we need to talk about the bombs.”

“Oh, right. The bombs. Those are bad, right?”

“Yes,” Seacat said. “Probably as much powder as a shell. They’ll hole any ship and might sink a smaller one right away.”

She saw the admiral in the room wince at that, and Colonel Kilian nodded with a grim expression.

“And they’re floating in the sea, hidden amidst driftwood,” Mermista said. “We need to destroy them before they sink any of our ships. Their mere presence - the mere possibility of their use - will affect our entire fleet and supply lines.”

“Can you use your powers to gather them all in one place?” Seacat asked.

“I need to see them for that,” Mermista told her. “I could create a wave that cleared a path, but it wouldn’t stop them from coming down the river.”

“We could use nets to gather them up, as long as they don’t sink underwater,” Entrapta said. “Though they might explode when touching each other, so the nets would be quite large, so the explosion won’t damage the towing ship, and they’d need to be frequently replaced.”

“Courier ships with swivel guns can more or less reliably destroy the bombs from a distance,” Seacat pointed out.

“But we’re short on courier ships,” the admiral said. “We’ve got two here, three if we count the gunboat. And we’re short on swivel guns, too.”

“What about bots?” Seacat asked. “Emily had a cannon large enough to trigger such bombs.”

“Oh, that would work, but… we would need a ship for her, and for the other bots,” Entrapta said. “Longboats aren’t large enough. I could design a smaller bot, but they wouldn’t be as effective since the cannon would be smaller as well, and the ammunition would be limited…”

“Then we’ll build rafts,” Sea Hawk said, grinning. “We’ve got the materials and men for that. “They won’t be going to sea, but they’re enough for coastal work - or on the river.”

“And they’ll be easy prey for the Horde guns,” Kilian pointed out. “And without the frigates, we won’t be able to push the Horde guns away from the cliff.”

From where the guns would be able to bombard the fortress - and the harbour. That would soon render the port unusable.

“And without the rafts, we won’t be able to get the frigates close enough to shell the gun emplacements,” Mermista added.

“Mobile gun emplacements,” Seacat said. “They can move them pretty quickly with skiffs.

“Ugh.” The princess pressed her lips together in a deep frown.

Seacat looked at the others. They all knew what this meant - someone would have to deal with the guns, and they would likely take heavy casualties doing so.

Damn, she was thinking like an officer. She had to think like Seacat. There had to be a way to avoid sacrificing people in a bloody suicide charge. If only… Her eyes widened. "Entrapta! I've got an idea!"

*****

"How's the ship?" Seacat asked as soon as she stepped on the Dragon's Daughter V's deck.

"We've patched up most of the smaller leaks, but the big one… is still leaking," Licy replied from the hold.

"Keep at it. We'll sail soon," Seacat told her. If Horas could keep up - and he had kept up with more leaks - then they would do fine.

"What?" she heard Licy exclaim, followed by Alcy shushing her.

"We need to move the Horde from the cliffside," she told them, peering down into the hold.

"Who's 'we'?" Alcy asked.

"The Salinean Navy," Seacat replied. "But someone needs to clear the floating bombs for them."

"And that'll be us?"

"Us and the other courier ship. And what rafts they manage to build for Entrapta's bots." Seacat flashed her fangs. "But at the start, it'll be just us."

Even Horas seemed to wince at that.

“We’ll be working at the mouth of the river, though,” she told them, “under cover of the fortress’s guns.”

Alcy nodded, but looked grim still - with good reason, of course. The artillery was already duelling, and the Horde had more guns, and more mobile ones, too.

A few shells had landed inside the port already - fortunately, not too close to them. Still, staying in port wouldn’t be a good idea either.

Well, the frigates would add their fire to the fortress’s guns once they moved to the cliffside. A few broadsides would make the Horde gunners take notice. Or so Seacat hoped.

As much as it was logical to risk a few small ships and boats instead of the frigates - or longboats packed with marines crossing the river - it would still be hard on the small ships. Such as the Dragon’s Daughter V.

But they would do what they had to to defeat the Horde. “This is their big push,” Seacat told the others as she climbed down into the hold to help them plug the last leak. “They’ve sacrificed their fleet to gain time. They must have used most of their powder supplies for the floating bombs. And this must be most of their artillery skiffs and their best troops. If we defeat them here, the war’s as good as won!”

She wasn’t quite lying - the Horde had more troops and more guns - but the Horde didn’t have too many good troops. And they couldn’t just move all of them around nily-wily. Just sending so many to the fortress would have strained their supply lines.

But if they won, they would regain the initiative. Hook up with the trapped troops up north. And start pushing towards Seaworthy again.

They had to stop them here. Stop them and defeat them.

*****

By the time Sea Hawk arrived a quarter-hour later, they had managed to plug most of the biggest leak by hammering the planks back in place and sealing the gaps with tar. It wouldn't hold up for too long, but it would last long enough to fight the battle, or so Seacat hoped. Odds were, after a few hours, it wouldn't matter one way or the other.

Right when they cast off, an explosion shook the southern wall - a Horde shell had landed directly on a gun emplacement, the powder charges going off and wrecking a part of the wall. The marine gunners shot back, but they were outnumbered - and the Horde gunners could move quickly to disperse themselves - or focus on either end of the southern wall.

Another shell landed in the middle of the harbour, close enough for a small wave to hit the Dragon's Daughter V on the way out.

"Steady!" Sea Hawk yelled as they passed the line of longboats. "Signal the frigates on station that we'll be clearing the way to the cliff!"

Seacat scrambled up the mast. The frigates were a long way off due to the floating bombs - just about close enough so one could pick out signals without a telescope - but she saw water erupt close to one frigate as they shot at bombs. Or driftwood - no ship could take a chance here, even though the frigates could manoeuvre much more easily thanks to their engines.

Seacat used the flags to inform the frigates of the plan, clinging to the top of the mast with her legs, the claws on her feet digging into the wood. Usually, she'd cling to the rigging, but for this, she needed to be as visible as possible. Timing would be everything.

Alcy fired the swivel gun, and an explosion threw up a column of water right at the edge of the mole - a floating bomb had come so close? Things were worse than Seacat had feared.

As they sailed alongside the mole, shells flew overhead, hitting the harbour - but soon, they began to fall next to the Dragon's

Daughter V. Quite close, too.

Sea Hawk started to weave through the waves, which threw off the Horde gunners's aim for now, but they would soon adjust. And if every gun fired on them, a shell was bound to hit them by sheer chance.

She shook her head and focused on her task. "The frigates are on the way!" she yelled. Not as fast as she'd like, but the ships were moving, following longboats looking for bombs.

"Huzzah!"

The cheering from Alcy and Licy was interrupted by another shot, which didn't blow up a bomb, though.

"Port!" Alcy yelled. "We missed!"

"'We'? I'm just the loader!" Lucy added.

Seacat would have snorted if she hadn't spotted the floating bomb drifting closer and closer to them, despite Sea Hawk turning the ship away.

"Steady, crew!" the Captain yelled. "Just a little longer!"

Seacat clenched her teeth and hissed with frustration. They were a target out there, hemmed in and slowed down by bombs and shot at by all the Horde artillery on the southern shore. This wouldn't go well if the princesses didn't act soon!

As if they had heard her, the cliffside and southern shore was suddenly starting to be covered in thick smoke - Entrapta must have finally finished building the special shells Seacat had asked for! A few minutes later, the entire area was covered in black clouds.

Seacat turned to look at the mole. Yes, with the Horde gunners blinded and their guns having been aimed at the Dragon's

Daughter V, Mermista had climbed on top of the battered mole and raised her trident.

A moment later, a huge wave rose in front of the princess, shooting out towards the southern shore.

*****

The Gunboat

The wave Mermista had conjured swept over the water. Even though the Dragon's Daughter V wasn't in its path, she was pushed away as well, and Seacat had to grab the mast with both hands to keep from getting thrown off as it tilted to the side. She heard Alcy and Licy curse and Sea Hawk yell with glee as the ship righted herself.

But her attention was focused on the wave approaching the cliffside and southern shore. The closer the wave came, the higher it rose - and it carried driftwood and floating bombs with it. Almost… almost… The wave hit, smashing into the cliffside - and washing over the lower parts of the southern river shore. And the bombs it carried with it went off as they hit the rocks and soil. About a dozen explosions in short order - or more. She cheered at the sight.

"Signal the frigates to head in! We're moving to cover the river!" Sea Hawk yelled

"Aye aye, Captain!"

She turned to signal the frigates, quickly repeating the message twice, then grabbed her telescope from where she had stuffed it into her top to check for acknowledgement - she couldn't make out the signals with her bare eye.

For a moment, she feared the frigate's signal officer had missed her message, but then the ensign in the crow's nest started waving the signal flags. Yes!

"They're coming!" she yelled down.

"Huzzah! Into harm's way we go, then!"

The Dragon's Daughter V turned and headed upriver.

"Keep an eye out for bombs!" Seacat yelled.

They were on the southern side of the river, too - the northern side, as Seacat could see, was covered by a bot and a few guns setting up near the fortress. As she watched, a floating bomb was blown up by a well-aimed shot of Entrapta's bot.

Alcy soon followed with a hit of their own. Seacat cheered - though she knew it was a bad sign that the Horde still had so many bombs to send downriver.

And, worse, the smoke cover would soon be gone - Entrapta hadn't been able to create too many smoke rounds, and what she was now constructing wouldn't be enough to keep the enemy covered.

Now everything depended on whether the frigates could rush in quickly enough to silence the Horde guns before they blew the Dragon's Daughter V out of the water.

"Yes!" Alcy hit another one.

But Seacat was glancing at the shore. The smoke was thinning rapidly now. She could already spot the first Horde soldiers waving - at them.

"The Horde's recovering!" she informed the captain.

"As expected!"

Alcy fired again, but nothing blew up. Either she missed - or the target wasn't a bomb. Hard to say. The woman fired again - still no explosion.

"Try again!" Seacat yelled, studying the target through her telescope. "It looks like a bomb!"

The next shot hit it - she could see the wood splintering - but it didn't blow up. "Next!" she yelled. "That's a dud!"

Then the water blew up near them, and Seacat had to grab the mast to keep from falling - the first Horde gun had started to fire

on them.

She swung around and glanced back towards the sea. The Salinean battleline had formed and was approaching, but not fast enough.

The Salinean guns in the fortress were firing normal shells again, but that hadn't stopped the Horde guns before.

Another gun fired. A second later, the shell passed over the deck of the Dragon's Daughter V. "Captain!" she yelled, "Half a dozen guns are about to open up on us!"

"Understood!" Sea Hawk sounded tense now. A moment later, the Dragon's Daughter V swung around and started weaving through the water. "Use the burner!" the Captain yelled.

"That'll obscure the bombs!" Alcy yelled.

"We can't blow them up if we're blown up!" Sea Hawk yelled.

Licy was already dashing to the bridge, though. She slid to a stop at the stern and grabbed the burner there.

But as she lit it, two guns on the shore fired. One shell fell short, another hit the stern - and didn't explode. A dud? Seacat felt relief.

Then a third gun fired, and, a moment later, the port half of the Dragon's Daughter V's rigging was sliced apart.

Chain shot. The Horde guns were using chain shot, Seacat realised as the mast started to topple to starboard.

Then she clenched her teeth and jumped into the river before the mast smashed into the water.

The current stopped her dive quickly - and then started to push her back, towards the ship. She resurfaced, then swam to the side

as fast as she could - if she got entangled in the rigging floating in the water, that would be bad.

The Dragon's Daughter V had stopped, the toppled mast acting like an anchor - and the river's current was slowly turning the ship around. Even with the burner still producing smoke, the Horde gunners wouldn't keep missing a stationary target like that for long.

"Cut the rigging!" she heard Sea Hawk yell.

"There's Seacat!" Licy had spotted her.

"Forget about me! Get the ship clear!" Seacat screamed as she passed in front of the Dragon's Daughter V. She could climb back onto the ship easily, once she was clear of...

"Bomb! Coming at us!"

"Don't shoot it! Seacat's too close!"

Damn it. Seacat clenched her teeth and redoubled her efforts. She had to get on board - if the bomb exploded with her in the water…

Something hit the river to her side, and she caught it trailing below her. Chain shot - the Horde was still firing chain shot. Not as bad as a shell detonating in the river, but if that had hit her, she would've been sliced in half…

She reached the ship's hull and dug her claws into it, then pulled herself up. "Shoot!" she yelled.

A moment later, Alcy fired. And a column of water rose. Close. Damn close.

"Hit!"

Yes! Seacat scaled the hull, reaching for the top of the railing - and the Horde guns' barrage arrived.

To starboard and port, the river erupted, throwing up water. Explosive shells, Seacat realised while she struggled to hold on to the railing. More explosions shook the ship - and she heard the groaning of wood being torn apart.

Then the ship jerked once more, suddenly shooting forward, and Seacat was slammed into the hull. Grunting with pain - her cutlass had been slammed into her thigh - she slipped, sliding back, her claws carving gouges into the wood as she barely kept from falling into the water.

Screaming with rage, she pulled herself back up, then slid over the railing, panting. A quick glance showed that she hadn't lost her sword this time - but she was missing her telescope. Damn. And her signal flags.

"First Mate! Are you wounded?"

"No, Captain!" she replied, forcing herself to stand. She could worry about herself later - they had to save the ship.

"Bomb ahead!" Licy yelled.

And they still had to screen the frigates. Seacat glanced to starboard. The Salinean battleline had formed and was now almost in range. They were sailing towards the cliffside - straight south. Not ideal for sweeping the riverbanks clear of the Horde guns, but they could hammer the cliffside without being hemmed in by the river and risking the floating bombs.

The bomb exploded - too close for Seacat's taste. They would have more leaks in the hull - Horas was already belowdecks, keeping the pumps going. Alcy and Licy had the bow. That left her… she climbed the stairs to the bridge. The burner was about to run out and needed to be refilled.

Before she reached it, another volley from the Horde guns arrived. More shells exploded to the portside - and one starboard, close enough to push the Dragon's Daughter V off-course.

“We’ve sprung a leak!” Horas yelled. “I can’t keep up!”

Seacat cursed and jumped down onto the main deck, then leapt through the open hatch into the hold.

She landed in knee-deep water - a whole plank had been pushed in, broken, and the water was streaming in. Snarling, she grabbed the edge of the plank and pushed back, digging her feet’s claws into the deck. She had to plug the leak, or the ship was lost!

But the force of the water was too strong - she barely made any headway. And the water kept rising. It was hopeless.

“No!” She clenched her teeth and screamed with frustration. Not like this! “Damn it!”

Then Horas was there, pushing as well - and they managed to plug most of the leak.

“Hold it in place!” she snapped, quickly looking for spare planks to nail over it.

“The pumps…”

“Hold it!” she cut him off. There! She grabbed a plank and the hammer and nails from their mounts and started nailing the plank into place.

By the time she had finished - and the thing was holding - they were standing hip-deep in the water. Horas started pumping again, but… he had barely kept up before, and now?

She climbed to the deck. “We’re not gonna last, Captain!” she yelled. “We’re taking too much water!”

“Can we reach the port?” Sea Hawk yelled back.

“Maybe!” she yelled back.

“The Dragon’s Daughter V is a good ship! She’ll bring us home!”

Seacat could only hope that the Captain was right.

They were headed straight towards the port - mostly; the ship was still weaving to throw off the Horde gunner's aim and spread the remaining smoke - towards the port. Seacat grabbed new signal flags to inform the frigates that they couldn't screen them from bombs any more.

The smoke… She rushed up to the bridge again. She needed to refill the burner. "Captain! The burner!"

He threw a tin can to her. She grabbed it with one hand as she passed him, then slid to a stop at the stern, grabbing the burner. Refilling it extinguished the fire, but she relit it without any problem.

More shells flew, but fell short this time - they Horde gunners had miscalculated their speed. Where were the smoke rounds from the fortress? And what was the battle line doing?

Wait. She had to inform the Salineans about the change of plans. She went and grabbed two more signal flags. With the mast gone, the bridge was now the highest spot on the ship, so she returned to Sea Hawk's side and started signalling as more shells hit the river near them. More leaks as well, probably - the Dragon's Daughter V was now as low in the water as if she'd had her hold stuffed full of ore. And they were still only halfway to the port.

She didn't wait for the acknowledgement - the sailors could see the Dragon's Daughter V sailing back anyway, and they'd have to be blind to miss that she'd lost her mast.

Another volley. One shell hit close enough to spray them with water. Seacat snarled. Just a little longer - just a little more luck…

Suddenly, thunder sounded in the distance, and she gasped - the Salinean ships were firing! Four broadsides' worth of shells hit the cliffside as they briefly turned away to bring their guns to bear. For a moment, the entire top of the cliffs vanished in smoke.

She cheered. “Take that, Horde scum!”

“Huzzah!”

“Yes!”

“Yay!”

“We’ve got another leak!”

Damn!

She jumped down to the main deck and then into the hold. Yes, there was another leak - smaller than the other, but in their current state… She hissed and started plugging it with what was at hand.

But the water kept rising - it was now reaching her chest. And Horas’s waist. And each time the ship turned, the water sloshed around, making the list worse - and doing its best to sweep them off their feet.

They wouldn’t make it. She shook her head, wiping water and tears from her face, and stopped hammering the loose plank. If they kept going, they’d roll over with so much water in the hold.

“Get out, Horas!” she snapped. “It’s hopeless.”

“I can keep pumping!”

“Not for long! Out! On deck!” She snapped. “Move!”

The minotaur gave the pump another turn, then started towards the stairs. Seacat followed him - swimming while he waded.

But they reached the stairs and made it to the deck. “Captain!” she yelled.

He looked at her.

She shook her head.

He nodded. “Abandon ship!”

Alcy and Licy jumped overboard, followed by Horas ripping off part of the railing and joining them. Seacat was about to jump as well, but then noticed that Sea Hawk hadn’t left the con. “Captain!”

“I’m fixing the wheel - the closer she’s getting to the fortress, the better to raise her afterwards!”

“Captain!”

“And she’ll serve as a distraction to draw fire away from us!”

That was a good argument. But not good enough. She scaled the stairs to the ridge. “Captain!”

He finished tying down the wheel. “All done!”

She grabbed him and threw him overboard, following a moment later. They were about in the middle of the river - the current was strong, but they could make it to the shore if they swam for it.

“Hey!”

Or they could swim to the longboat coming towards them. Someone must have noticed their distress on the shore.

The Dragon’s Daughter V was staying her course - headed straight towards the northern shore. But she was sinking - the bow was almost dipping into the waves now.

Halfway to the longboat, she felt herself being pulled upriver. What the…?

Oh. Another big wave smashed its wave upriver. At an angle - Mermista was covering for them. But why would…? Seacat turned in the water. Ah. The Salinean battle line had turned and was now sailing straight up the river, parallel to the southern riverbank. And shelling the Horde positions with broadside after broadside.

Good.

A few strokes brought her to the bow of the longboat - marines were in it, she noticed - and a lizardman pulled her out of the water. “Are you hurt?” someone asked.

“No,” she replied. She wasn’t looking at them. She was looking at the Dragon’s Daughter V. The bow had slipped beneath the waves now, but the engine was still working - and driving the ship down to the bottom of the river mouth.

She watched the ship disappear as more broadsides were fired in the background and hoped that this had been worth it.

*****

The longboat took them back to the fortress, but the marines had to fight the river for it - or, rather, they had to fight the waves Mermista kept sending upriver to sweep the river mouth clear of bombs so the frigates could keep decimating the Horde troops on the riverbank.

And, as Seacat could see, the frigates were doing a decent job - the Horde artillery had fallen silent. Although she didn’t know how many Horde guns had been destroyed and how many had fled the riverbank and were now setting up for indirect fire in or near the forest. She saw a number of smoking gun emplacements, wrecked by shells, though - the Dragon’s Daughter V’s sacrifice hadn’t been in vain.

Alcy and Licy were cheering anyway at each broadside. Horas wasn’t, though, and neither was the Captain.

“They still have their army,” Seacat pointed out. “If they keep it away from the coast, they can move against our forces when we start going upriver.”

“Oh.” Licy looked crestfallen.

The marine sergeant in command of the longboat nodded. “We’ll have to defeat them in the field.” She was grinning, though. “But with their artillery wrecked like that, we won’t have too much trouble.”

“Don’t underestimate them,” Seacat told him. “They already got us with the underwater infiltrators and now those bombs.”

He shrugged. “That won’t help them in the field. We’ve beaten them whenever we faced them.”

If the Horde gave battle. If they were smart, they’d just retreat, only offering battle in good positions where they had the advantage and the fleet couldn’t help. Of course, the Horde wasn’t always smart. But they had come up with a lot of ideas lately.

Seacat clenched her teeth. They had still lost, but it had cost the Alliance. She had a feeling that defeating this army would cost a lot more, too.

As they finally rounded the mole and entered the port, they saw several rafts being towed out, each with a bot on it.

Good. That meant Mermista wouldn’t have to keep sending huge waves upriver.

*****

“Mermista! My Love!”

“Sea Hawk.” Mermista was smiling, but she looked exhausted - using her powers for so long had taken a lot out of her. Adora didn’t have that problem, Seacat knew. Then again, she was She-Ra, not just a princess.

“That was great! Those waves… you saved us all!” the Captain exclaimed as the two embraced.

Seacat frowned. Sea Hawk wasn't wrong, of course - but it made it sound as if they had lost the Dragon's Daughter V for nothing. Then she noticed the admiral nearby frowning at the couple and glared at the woman. What did the admiral think she was, Mermista's mother? She was Mermista's subordinate, not her keeper!

"She saved the fleet," the admiral commented with a sneer. "After your ship got sunk."

"We knew that this could happen," Seacat retorted. "And someone had to draw fire so Mermista could do her thing."

"As did our frigates. But they didn't get sunk."

Seacat hissed. She wanted to claw the sneer off of the woman's face.

"Enough!" Mermista snapped. "Sea Hawk and his crew risked their lives for us; I won't tolerate any disrespect!"

The admiral had the grace to blush in embarrassment. Or anger. Or both. Seacat didn't care - she was fed up with those snobby officers. She looked at the battle on the other side of the river mouth. The frigates were turning around, which meant their fire lessened as they blocked each other's broadsides during the manoeuvre. But there didn't seem to be much left on the Horde side that could shoot back. All four frigates were still sailing, seemingly untouched, but without her telescope, she couldn't check if they had suffered more damage.

"What now?" she asked. "Send the marines over the river?"

"Colonel Kilian is in favour of that," Mermista said. "But I fear that would be what the Horde wants us to do." She turned to look at the distant shore herself. "They knew we'd have to respond to their artillery. And they know we can't let them stay so close, ready to attack or flank our force once we push upriver."

“Yet when we attack, they’ll retreat from the shore, rendering our fleet ineffective and fix us in place. Like a fleet in being,” the admiral pointed out. So she wasn’t entirely useless.

“Well, we need to trap their forces, then, and prevent them from retreating,” Sea Hawk said. “I have an idea!” He beamed. “It’ll be dangerous, but if it works out, we’ll completely defeat the enemy!”

*****

They were going slow. Too slow, for Seacat’s taste. And not just because the gunboat she was on couldn’t go nearly as fast as the Dragon’s Daughter V, lacking an engine - they were going slow because someone upriver was still dropping floating bombs into the river and they had to deal with them.

And it didn’t help that most of the bombs were now duds or decoys. Quite the contrary, in fact - now the swivel guns mounted on the bow needed to take a few shots to be sure they had hit a dud. If she ever found out who among the Horde scum had come up with this…

She hissed in frustration.

“Patience, First Mate!”

She turned to scowl at the Captain.

As usual, he wasn’t fazed. “We’re doing well - exactly according to plan!”

“We’re not doing anything,” she corrected him. “We’re just passengers.”

“We’re in charge of the operation,” he told her. “That makes us staff.”

Staff, but not crew. This wasn’t her ship. And she hated it. If only they hadn’t lost the Dragon’s Daughter V! “Mermista’s in

command," she retorted.

"And my love's a great commander, but she can't do everything. Which is where we come in. And this was my idea, of course!" He grinned. "Cheer up - we'll be in the thick of it soon enough."

Well, at least they weren't at the fortress. Waiting to land at the southern shore, not knowing if they would be needed, would be worse than being passengers on a gunboat. She huffed, and Sea Hawk put his hand on her shoulder, squeezing gently.

"I just want to do something," she muttered. To get back at the Horde for sinking their ship. Her ship.

"I know. And we will. Soon, I think."

Seacat sighed.

"Guns on the riverbank!"

She whirled and grabbed her new telescope. Yes - there, between two patches of trees, Skiffs were unloading guns. They had drawn the Horde's attention, as expected.

"Signal the Fortress!" Sea Hawk yelled. "We're engaging Horde guns!"

Seacat clenched her teeth, flexing her claws. Now she would be even more useless, watching while the ship fought.

In front of her, the bow gun emplacement turned, gunners struggling to aim the large piece at the shore while the swivel gun crews ducked.

The two main guns of the gunboat fired before the Horde had finished setting up their four guns, but both shots went wide, bracketing the enemy's position.

Seacat longed to yell at the gunners to correct their mistake but held her tongue. With some difficulty.

Then the first gun of the Horde fired. Second from the right, Seacat noted - likely the best crew, and that meant one of the primary targets. The shell fell short, hitting the water and blowing up a column of it without coming close enough to shake the ship.

The gunboat's guns fired again before the rest of the Horde guns were ready, and this time, the stern gun landed a direct hit. Seacat saw the enemy gun flip through the air after the shell exploded, followed by secondary explosions as the powder stored there went up. Unfortunately, that hadn't been the fast gun - which fired together with the remaining two. Two shots fell short - one going wide as well, but the third went long - the gunboat had been straddled. The Horde gunners wouldn't take long to find the range, then.

It was all up to their own gunners, now. And Seacat hated that. Those weren't her crew. She didn't know them. She couldn't trust them. Hell, this was a prize crew - and everyone knew that the Salinean captains didn't staff prizes with their best sailors and officers.

The gunboat's two guns fire once more. Another hit and miss - and once more, the stern gun had hit while the bow gun had missed. Against a stationary target! This time, the third gun from the right vanished in a fireball. That left two guns to return fire. Among them the best gun crew of the enemy. They fired quickly - and hit. Seacat ducked when the shell exploded against the bow, sending shrapnel and splinters across it.

Screams sounded, and Seacat jumped up, then dashed towards the wrecked bow. "Alcy! Licy! Help me!" she yelled as she passed the bow gun.

She winced when she reached the bow - the swivel gun crews had been cut down. She saw one goatman holding the stumps of his legs, screaming as he tried to stop the bleeding, and a mothwoman staring at her bleeding belly without even trying to do anything. The rest… well, ripped to pieces described them well.

“Check for bombs!” she told the two women behind her as she knelt, ripping the belt off a dead lizardman and then grabbing the goatman’s belt. “We need to tie this off!”

He didn’t listen and kept screaming. Useless.

She pushed his hands away and started to tie the belts around his legs. He still tried to interfere. Snarling, she hit his arms away. “Stop!” She had another wounded to take care of.

Alcy fired when Seacat finally knocked the goatman out so he’d stop untying the belts, then went to check on the mothwoman.

Who was slumped over and not breathing anymore. Damn.

Behind her, the guns fired again. She looked to the shore and bared her teeth when the good Horde gun was hit, vanishing in a fireball. That was enough - the remaining gunners fled, not bothering to pack up their gun.

By the time she had gotten the wounded goatman to the hold, the guns had fallen silent, and the boat was turning towards the southern riverbank.

She dropped the wounded off in the hold - the gunboat was much too small to have a healer there, but they had someone taking care of the wounded.

When she returned on deck, they had resumed their course upriver. And the crews at the swivel guns had been replaced. “Going to be a bloody affair,” she muttered as she rejoined the Captain at the railing.

“I fear so. It should help sell the whole plan to the Horde, though,” he replied.

“It better do so,” she said through clenched teeth. If all this was for nothing…

“Can you check if the frigate is entering the river mouth now?”

“Aye aye.” She climbed the stairs to the bridge - which was in the middle of the ship, not at her stern, where the second gun was housed - and peered back, downriver. The frigate was indeed sailing upriver already - using her engine.

And she could see the rafts it was towing. “They’re underway!” she yelled back.

“Good! Press on, captain!” Sea Hawk yelled to the gunboat’s captain. “We need to find where they drop those bombs in the river!”

It was an obvious target - and Horde would be aware of this. Which meant they would be prepared for an attack. Seacat wasn’t a fan of making obvious attacks, no matter how necessary they might be. On the other hand, the Horde’s forces covering the river wouldn’t be able to stand up to the frigate and the troops on the rafts she was towing.

Which meant the Horde would have to either fall back - or move the bulk of their forces in. And, seeing as the Alliance didn’t have the bulk of their own forces on the river, that would allow the Horde to defeat them in detail, as Kilian had called it.

But for that, they needed to move their forces out of the forest where they were hiding and to the river - or they would miss the opportunity to fight under favourable conditions. Seacat hissed. She couldn’t see if the Horde was moving.

“I’m taking a look,” she said, then jumped into the rigging and scaled it. Taking out her borrowed telescope - Mermista could get another one easily if she needed one - she studied the shore. The riverbank wasn’t very steep here, so she could see the forests behind it - small patches dotting the fields before they merged into a denser wood following the river. Was that movement? A skiff!

“I see a skiff going upriver!” she yelled down. It would be a courier or scout. A courier sent upriver to get the bomb droppers

to evacuate… or a scout to secure the route for the army following them. Or, Catra remembered her lessons, a strike skiff, full of soldiers for rapid deployment.

She kept watching the forests. More movement. Another skiff. That was carrying a gun. Damn. “Skiff artillery!” she yelled. “Not deploying yet!”

How much further upriver were the Horde forces? They couldn’t be too far - they would lose too many bombs in the river. At most two turns or so. And they would have to have boats - or a ship - to drop the bombs in the middle of the river so they wouldn’t get dragged to the riverbank right away.

They were in the first turn now - Seacat recognised the area from their raid upriver. Another, wide one, followed.

“Ship ahead!” the lookout yelled from the crow’s nest.

Seacat turned and took a look herself. A gunboat. Damn. Same class as the one they had - and they were dropping trunks into the river. “Get that boat!” she yelled.

The gunners in the bow were already moving the gun, but the swivel gun crews were in the way - and they were firing as well since a lot of trunks and bombs were coming towards the ship. They needed to change course so they could bring both main guns to bear - and let the swivel guns keep firing. What was the damn gunboat captain doing?

“Clear!” the gun commander yelled.

The swivel gun crews dropped to the floor.

A moment later, the bow gun fired - and the shell went wide.

The Horde gunboat was turning, and first the stern gun, then the bow gun fired. The stern gun missed, as did the bow gun - but they came closer.

“Turn so we can match their guns!” she yelled as the swivel gun crews returned to their guns, firing quickly and blowing up another bomb while the main gun reloaded.

They were still not turning. Sea Hawk was going to the bridge now. Finally!

Once more, their own gun fired - and missed again! Seacat wanted to jump down and throw the gunners into the river and take over. What kind of incompetents had been assigned to this boat? She would gut the captain who had used this to get rid of the officer!

The Horde ship fired now - they matched the Alliance gunners in speed, too! - and one near miss threw water all over the deck while the other exploded further behind them. It had missed the hull by inches; Seacat had seen the shell pass by.

This couldn’t go on!

Another bomb exploded - Seacat could see that the Horde sailors were still dropping the things into the water. What the hell…

A scream drew her attention - Sea Hawk was holding the gunboat captain at sword point! Seacat quickly grabbed a line, then jumped, swinging over to the bridge.

She let go of the line at the right moment and landed on all four on the bridge, hissing. If anyone went after the Captain…

But the gunboat was already turning - finally! The bow gun shot again, missing, but a moment later, the stern gun fired - and hit the afterdeck of the horde ship! That should at least throw off the stern gun’s crew…

The enter afterdeck of the Horde gunboat blew up. They must have hit some of the bombs stacked there! The boat stopped moving at once, the mast already swaying - but the Horde’s bow gun fired one last time - and hit.

Seacat ducked, clenching her teeth,when the shell hit the already damaged bow of their ship. The crew of the main gun there, as well as the swivel gunners, were thrown around by the explosion, and the bowsprit was blown off - Seacat saw it fly through the air for a moment before it hit the water.

But she also felt the ship slow down with a jerk - despite the sails still catching the wind.

She knew what that meant: They had been holed under the waterline, and the water was pouring inside, slowing the ship down.

“Keep going!” Sea Hawk yelled. “Beach her on the Horde side.”

“What? No!” the gunboat captain protested.

“Do it, or I’ll cut you down and do it myself!” Sea Hawk snapped.

Shaking, the helmswoman stayed the course.

Upriver, the Horde gunboat’s remains slipped under the waves leaving a field of wooden debris.

The enemy shore was closer - Seacat didn’t think they would manage to turn around before sinking, certainly not with the wind blowing from the rear like now - but they would be stranded on the enemy riverbank.

She clenched her teeth. That was what the Captain wanted - a tempting target for the Horde to make them commit their forces.

It was a good plan, but they would have to hold out long enough for the frigate to reach them with the reinforcements for it to work without getting them killed. And they would have to reach the shore without sinking. If they couldn’t beach the gunboat and save the guns, they wouldn’t stand a chance to fend off even a small Horde force. “I’m checking the hold,” she spat, then grabbed the railing and jumped over it, landing on the deck below.

A few quick steps took her to the hatch leading down. Alcy, Lucy and Horas joined her. “We’re going to beach her,” she told them. “I’m checking the damage below.”

“We’re going to beach her?” Licy gasped.

“We’re going to be bait.” Alcy looked grim, as did Horas - they understood Sea Hawk’s plan.

“Oh.”

Seacat ignored the byplay and climbed down into the hold. The water was already knee-deep, streaming past a bulwark that wasn’t quite working. Shoddy Horde craftsmanship. And there were people down here. People who couldn’t move. People who were unconscious. “Get the wounded on deck!” Seacat yelled to the sailor treating the wounded as she reached for the legless goatman. “Horas! Alcy! Licy! Help!”

She carried the moaning but unconscious goatman up on deck, laying him down at the railing. If the ship didn’t make it to shore… but they were close, and if the wind held, they would make it. Probably.

Behind her, Horas reappeared, carrying two more wounded, followed by Alcy and Licy, carrying a third. That left… One more.

The sailor who had been treating the wounded was already on the stairs, but he was struggling to carry the last wounded - and the bulwark could break at any moment. “Horas!” Seacat snapped, moving towards the wrecked bow.

The minotaur reached down and lifted both the sailor and the wounded gunner up with one hand as Seacat passed them. Good. She climbed over the wreckage of the bow gun. One swivel gun was still - again - manned, and fired as she reached it, blowing another bomb up. So, they had decent sailors who knew their duties in this crew as well.

Good. “Prepare for beaching!” she told them. “We’re going to hit the riverbank there.” She pointed at a sandy slope ahead.

“Right.” The woman manning the swivel gun nodded at her while her comrade reloaded the gun.

“And be ready to fend off Horde attackers,” Seacat added. “We’ll have to hold until the relief arrives.”

The frigate would have to go slow, too, what with the bombs still floating in the river. If the Horde was quick enough…

Seacat clenched her teeth and grabbed the piece of the railing still standing as the riverbank rushed up in front. “Brace!” she yelled.

Then the ship hit the shore. The already wrecked bow crumbled under the impact, wood splinters and broken planks flying everywhere. Instead of sliding up the riverbank, the gunboat turned and hit the riverbank sideways, the sudden stop and the wind still driving the sail almost toppling the ship as it rolled to starboard, then swung back to port.

Most of the crew were sent sprawling on the deck, but Seacat managed to keep her balance by digging her claws into the planks and grabbing the railing. Sea Hawk, likewise, held on to the steering wheel, though the helmswoman herself lost her grip and was sent over the side, landing on the riverbank with a scream.

And the wind was still blowing against the sails, rocking the ship back and forth.

“Cut the lines! Get that sail down!” Seacat yelled. A moment later, she jumped down on to the main deck and slashed the lines herself with her claws - the gunboat’s crew was too slow to get their act together. They had been sent on a critical mission with the dregs of the service! When Mermista heard of this, heads would roll among the captains and admirals!

Or Seacat would make them roll literally.

With most of the lines cut, the mainsail finally was torn loose, burying the helmswoman underneath it as it was blown on to the riverbank.

“Get those guns ready! We will have Horde scum attacking any moment!” Seacat yelled. The skiffs she had seen… if they carried scouts, then those would easily match them. And the force stationed upriver, with the gunboat dropping floating bombs into the water, would have troops to spare as well, with the boat sunk.

They were on their own until the frigate arrived. And with the blown-up remains of the Horde gunboat carried downriver by the current, hiding any left-over bombs, the frigate couldn’t risk rushing ahead.

She clenched her teeth as she joined the Captain on the bridge, looking at the shore. She could already hear the engines of several skiffs drawing closer. If they managed to get guns in place...

This would be a bloody affair, as she had predicted.

*****

The Beachhead

Stuck on a gunboat beached on an enemy shore, half the ship's guns wrecked already, half the crew wounded or dead, reinforcements delayed and the better part of a Horde army bearing down on them... Seacat forced herself to appear calm. Like the Captain. Even though she wanted to kick the crew still struggling to get the bow gun back up overboard and do it herself.

"Horas! Help them!" she snapped.

The Minotaur grunted in acknowledgement and went to help them lift the cannon on the repaired carriage. Seacat doubted that the gun would be of much use for precise shooting, but every gun able to shoot at the Horde would help. At the very least, it would provide the Horde gunners with another target so the stern gun crew, which was decently skilled, would get off another shot.

She sighed.

"No worry, First Mate!" Sea Hawk told her - in a lower voice, but with his best smile. "We won't have to hold out for too long - relief is on the way!"

Yes, she could even see the top of the frigate's mainmast. If she used a telescope. They would take a while to reach them. Of course, so would the Horde's main force. But the Horde troops upriver, which had been handling the floating bombs? And the scout or strike force on skiffs which had been on the way to reinforce them?

They would be here any minute.

She looked at the bow. Horas had laid the gun barrel down, and Alcy was directing Licy in fixing it to the carriage. Good. They knew their business.

Which couldn't be said about the swivel gun crews. Those were obviously barely trained to handle the guns. Then again, most of the trained gun crews had been killed in the duel with the Horde gunboat. And she couldn't train them up in the time they had left - not that she was an expert gunner, anyway.

She clenched her teeth. She couldn't just stay here. She had to do something. Something productive. She eyed the crow's nest. The mothwoman up there was looking at the shore, but… Seacat knew she had the best eyes on the ship. "I'll go take a look," she told the Captain. "See if I can spot the scum." She turned away.

"Careful, Seacat."

That had been barely more than a whisper. And yet it made her stop and look over her shoulder at Sea Hawk. He was smiling, but… She had rarely seen that look in his eyes.

She nodded, then jumped into the rigging near the bridge and scrambled to the crow's nest.

The mothwoman jerked when she arrived there. "Uh… it's a bit..."

Seacat ignored her attempt to point out the obvious lack of space for two people there and climbed higher, to the top of the mast. The riverbank had a gentle slope here, but it was still rising quite high - here was where the river started to cut into the cliff - so the higher she was, the better.

She wrapped her legs around the mast, gripped the top with one hand and pulled out her telescope. First, west. No sign of the enemy post which had to be there, but… there was something moving in the forest at the foot of the hill blocking her view of the next part of the river, at least according to the birds flying around there. Unless the things were still shocked by the gun duel on the river.

Somehow, Seacat didn't think that was the case.

She turned to look south and south-east. More flocks of birds were barely visible in the distance, where the Horde's main force was supposed to be. On the march, then. At least enough to counter the landing force coming from the fortress. But they wouldn't reach the beached ship before the frigate arrived.

Then movement much closer caught her eye. A skiff turning around a patch of trees. She adjusted the telescope and hissed - that was a strike skiff, carrying half a dozen soldiers. And more were coming behind it. Two, three, four… six. About thirty soldiers. Almost double the remaining crew with them.

But they could take those soldiers. Even without the guns, they could take them - Seacat would give her own crew decent odds against thirty Horde soldiers, even if they were strike teams, which were generally a cut above the rest, as Catra had learned.

Then she saw the skiff with guns on them. And cursed under her breath.

"Artillery skiffs!" she yelled down to the Captain. "Four of them! And about thirty soldiers!"

"Get the swivel guns ready to repel boarders!" Sea Hawk's voice rang out. "Prepare the guns to return fire - we need to sweep them off the slope as soon as they appear!"

The skiffs stopped well behind the top of the riverbank, outside the sight of anyone but Seacat and the mothwoman below her, and the soldiers quickly dismounted. The gun-carrying skiffs stopped as well and started to set up. They weren't going to deploy on top of the slope, then - they would be shooting indirectly. Like mortars. Damn. A ship generally didn't have to worry about mortars - hitting a ship on sails with direct fire was hard enough. But a beached ship? The gunboat couldn't move.

"They're not charging!" she told the others. "They'll bombard us!"

"Ready for counterfire!" Sea Hawk yelled.

The gun crews started to raise the barrels of the guns - the bow gun, once again, being far slower.

And the strike skiffs departed. They would be fetching more soldiers. Seacat hissed with frustration. That would delay the Horde attack - but it would also mean they would attack with at least double the numbers.

She glanced upriver. Or more - she still couldn't see the soldiers in the forest, but the birds getting disturbed showed they were closing in as well.

And soon, the guns would start shelling the ship. They had to take the guns out, and quickly, or the gunboat's remains would be scattered all over the riverbank before the frigate arrived.

"Where's the enemy?" the officer commanding the stern gun yelled.

Uh… Seacat lowered the telescope and narrowed her eyes. "About half a mile from our position," she yelled down. "Sought-southeast of us!"

"Elevation four!" the officer yelled, down on the deck. "One charge!"

"Elevation four, one charge!" the loader replied.

The Horde gunners were still setting up. Seacat could see them shovelling frantically to set up the guns so the recoil wouldn't launch them across the countryside.

"Ready!"

"Fire!"

The stern gun fired. Seacat kept her eyes trained on the enemy position. So close, it wouldn't take long… An explosion erupted on the field, about a hundred yards to the east of the enemy

position. “You missed by a hundred yards, to the east!” she yelled. “Shoot more to the west!”

“I’m a trained artillery observer,” the mothwoman in the crow’s nest below her said.

Oh. Seacat clenched her teeth. She should’ve asked before assuming everyone was inept. “Call them out, then!” she told the woman. “I’ll keep an eye on the Horde!”

The Horde soldiers had dropped to the ground right after the shell had exploded, but they were getting up now and running towards the top of the riverbank.

“Incoming soldiers!” Seacat yelled.

“Prepare to receive them!” Sea Hawk yelled, and a quick glance told Seacat that the two working swivel guns were trained on the top of the slope.

But the Horde soldiers stopped before reaching the top and dropped to the ground again. Out of sight of the swivel guns, and too close to be shelled indirectly by the main guns. Great.

“They’re gathering right behind the top!”

The stern gun fired again. Seacat glanced upriver - no change - then looked at the enemy guns again. The shell exploded quite close to the eastmost gun.

“West fifty!” the mothwoman called out.

“West fifty!”

“Bow gun ready!”

“Fire!”

The bow gun fired, at last. But the shot went wide and long.

“West two hundred! Short two hundred!” The mothwoman yelled.

The gunners struggled again to move the barrels. And the Horde guns were now ready - Seacat saw them loading… chain shot?

She cursed. “They’re using chain shot! They’re shooting at *us*!” she told the mothwoman. Glancing down, she saw the sailor pale.

But the stern gun fired again. A moment later, the shell landed exactly on the eastmost Horde gun, which vanished in a fireball.

“West thirty!” The mothwoman yelled out - she was walking the fire.

And she wasn’t leaving the crow’s nest, Seacat realised. Damn. She hesitated. What could she do here? She wasn’t a trained observer. She should get down and do something more useful. But that would look… that would be cowardly.

The Horde guns shot and Seacat tensed. One shot hit the top of the riverbank, cutting through grass and soil, and spinning off to the side. Another went long and wide. And one came so close, Seacat heard the chain and balls cutting through the air.

“Get down; you can’t do anything here,” the mothwoman told her. “I’ll handle this.” Her voice hitched a little - she knew what this meant.

As did Seacat. And she hated it.

“First Mate, come down!” Sea Hawk yelled.

Damn.

“Go,” the mothwoman hissed. “You can’t do anything here I can’t do.”

Hating herself, Seacat nodded at the woman and slid down the rigging. “Captain.”

“First Mate.”

The stern gun fired again.

“South thirty!”

So, no hit. Damn.

The bow gun fired next, but Seacat didn’t expect them to hit anything anyway.

“South hundred. West fifty.”

And they didn’t. Seacat kept looking up.

Then the Horde guns fired. One chain shot wrecked the rigging below the crow’s nest. Another smashed into it. Seacat didn’t see a third. She didn’t hear a scream, either - but she saw an arm sticking out over the railing.

Cursing, she scrambled up the rigging. The Horde guns were reloading, so she had some time. Then she saw the blood dripping from smashed crow’s nest. Damn.

When she reached the top, a glance was enough to confirm that the mothwoman was dead - she had been cut in two by the chain shot. Seacat snarled, then turned to look at the Horde guns. Two were reloading, one was doing something with the muzzle.

The bow gun fired again. She counted the seconds until the shot hit. Yes! The middle gun - one of the faster ones - was hit, its crew cut down by shrapnel. “Hit! West thirty!” she yelled down. Before the bow gun could fire, she saw the third gun finish reloading and quickly grabbed the closest line, then pushed off.

She was halfway down to the deck when the next chain shot arrived, cutting the line and most of the remaining rigging. Seacat it the deck on all fours, turning to scale the mast again when she saw it was listing even more than before.

“The mainmast’s going!” Sea Hawk yelled. “Cover!”

Seacat dashed across the deck, to the bridge, as the mast slowly started to topple. The beaching must have damaged it before - masts didn't break that easily!

They easily broke things when they fell, though - it smashed the portside railing and half the hold before crashing into the water.

The bow gun fired now, but without anyone observing the shot, they were shooting blindly.

Well, it wasn't as if they were shooting any better before.

"They'll have the soldiers at the top of the riverbank spot for them," Seacat told the Captain. She could already see the grass there move a little weird.

"Then we need to encourage them to keep their heads down," he replied. "Swivel guns! Rake the top of the riverbank with canister!"

That might delay them, but it wouldn't keep the Horde from getting someone to spot them - the riverbank was long, and they only had so many guns. Two, to be exact.

The stern gun fired.

They'd have to hope for a lucky shot. Two lucky shots, actually. Or they would have to get an observer of their own on top of the bank. Or take the guns out in another way - but they didn't have enough forces to rush the guns. Not through thirty Horde soldiers. They could probably break through them, but not fast enough to keep the guns from loading canister and shoot them to pieces before they reached the guns.

She ducked as she heard the faint sound of a Horde gun firing. A moment later, there was a splash in the river, about a hundred yards behind the beached gunboat. Then a shell exploded on the beach. A hundred and fifty yards to the east.

The bow gun replied, followed by the stern gun. Were they shooting faster than before? Well, they were effectively shooting

blind, so they probably didn't have to adjust their aim quite as carefully any more.

The stern gun, closely followed by the bow gun fired again. Still no Horde shot. Ah - the observers would have to relay the corrections to the guns by a runner; it was too far to yell. Seacat snorted - a sailor worth their salt would be using signal flags. But Horde soldiers rarely cross-trained. Someone didn't consider that when sending out troops.

Or they hadn't had any signal officers available - the Horde artillery had been pounded by the Salinean fleet, after all.

She looked upriver. The bird swarms were closer now. Damn. "I need to check what's coming up on us from upriver," she told the Captain.

"Wait until the next volley arrives, then go," Sea Hawk told her. "I've got a feeling they'll hit a lot of the riverbank before they hit us."

She snorted. They weren't better off either - with the mast down, their only hope was getting a lucky shot in before the Horde got the range and angle to shell the ship.

Another shell hit the water, closer, though also wider, followed by a shot that almost hit the top of the riverbank. Either the Horde gunners were much worse than the bow gun crew, or they had some defective weapons. Either way, it looked as if the Captain was correct about the enemy artillery.

"I'll swim to the underbrush there," she told him, nodding at the closest patch of forest on the riverbank. It wouldn't be a good idea to let the soldiers on the top of the slope see her run upriver.

Unless she wanted to lure them into an ambush, of course. But they needed information about the approaching enemy more than a few dead scouts.

So she slid over the railing at the port side of the ship, shielded by the wrecked rigging and the bridge from the Horde eyes, and then dived.

The current wasn't too strong here - the river was wide - but she still had to struggle to swim upriver. If she surfaced halfway to her goal, that would ruin her plan. And probably get her killed. And if she was in the water when the next shell hit…

She clenched her teeth and kept swimming as fast as she could until she couldn't hold her breath any longer and came up for air. Gasping, she glanced around - she was pretty much where she had been going, the area where the trees reached the water. Shielded from view by most of the riverbank, too.

She dived anyway, swimming further upriver. Better safe than sorry. When she came up for air again, she couldn't see the riverbank. Which meant the Horde soldiers there couldn't see her either.

Panting, she climbed on shore, pushing wet hair out of her face - her ponytail had lost a few strands. But she had her cutlass, and her borrowed telescope was still safely strapped to her belt.

Time to get to work. She moved through the forest, ears perked. Soldiers moving through dense trees were loud. Hell, soldiers moving as a group were loud, period. Catra remembered enough marches to know. Soldiers would be complaining about everything as they walked, too.

Most of them, at least - the scouts would know better. And even the dumbest Horde scum would shut up when getting close to the enemy, if only because they were too busy being afraid.

Seacat, though, wasn't Horde scum. She was a sailor, but she knew how to move without alerting everyone! She stuck to the shore, never letting the river out of her sight, and made her way west. Behind her the artillery duel continued - she could hear the shots being fired.

About ten minutes later, she suddenly heard something. She froze, ears twitching. Twigs cracking, leaves rustling…. Close, too.

She slowly rose and stepped behind a large tree, drawing her cutlass without making a sound. That had to be the Horde vanguard!

Pressed against the trunk, she gripped the hilt of her blade tightly. The Horde scout or skirmisher was getting even closer - and she didn't hear anyone else. Good! Now she heard footsteps. Almost on the other side of the tree. Left or right? Left.

She drew back her arm, with the cutlass pointed at the ground, and waited, holding her breath.

The leaves next to her parted, a face appearing - a Horde helmet.

Seacat lunged, her cutlass coming up, then down, slicing into the helmet - and through it into the soldier's shoulder. She pushed her foot into the man's chest and pulled the blade out as half his head fell to the ground.

One scout down. She quickly checked the body, ignoring the blood still flowing out of the wrecked head and throat. The markings on the armour weren't familiar to Catra, but that didn't mean anything. The armour was infantry, though. Regular. That explained why the man hadn't noticed her before he had lost half his head. But did the Horde force coming down the river lack scouts and had used infantry instead? Or had they sent their scouts elsewhere?

She didn't know. But she knew that she couldn't stay here. Even regular Horde infantry would sooner or later notice one of their vanguard missing. And she needed to know what kind of force was on the way.

She listened again - another shot from the gunboat. So they were still shooting, good. Then she heard birds screeching - close. Frowning, she crouched, then carefully followed the dead soldier's trail upriver. Soon, she heard the sounds of a larger number of

people making their way through the forest - and the expected cursing. Damn. They were already far too close. And even from just the sounds, she could tell there were at least a few dozen on the march.

Clenching her teeth, she looked for a suitable tree. There!

A quick dash brought her to the tree, and she easily scaled the trunk. Up in the canopy, she sat down on the thickest branch, staring at the forest ahead of her.

There was the Horde force. They were moving in a ragged formation, soldiers stumbling over roots as they tried to keep pace, others slipping on mud or pushing through the underbrush. At least fifty. Whoever was leading them wasn't a good commander, in her opinion - this kind of march would tire the soldiers, and they ran the danger of being defeated while strung out. Whatever advantage moving under cover of the trees might provide, it still wasn't a good trade.

But her friends lacked the numbers to take advantage of this. And with about thirty more soldiers on the top of the riverbank, they were in danger of being rushed. Not even canister shot would put down all of the soldiers of a charge, and the gunners wouldn't have time to reload…

She had to do something! Kill the commander? That might stall the advance. Or help the Horde in the long run, if the second in command was actually capable. And she'd have to get into the formation to do it - few Horde commanders led from the front - and then escape, which would be difficult...

Or she could kill a few more scouts and lead them on a chase. That would distract them for a little while at least. But she'd have to let them close enough to spot her and give chase before escaping.

What would Sea Hawk do? Set the forest on fire, of course! But without some oil, that would be difficult so close to the water. And

the wind was blowing from the east, which wouldn't be ideal for spreading any fire she could get going northwards.

If she had some smoke powder, she could use it and make the Horde think that the forest was on fire, though. Or that the fire was much bigger than it appeared.

That sounded like a plan. The best she could come up with, in any case, on such short notice. She turned and started to jump from branch to branch, quickly making her way back to the beached gunboat. She had to hurry if she wanted to keep the Horde from leaving the forest.

Halfway to the gunboat, she heard yelling behind her - they must have found the dead vanguard. She bared her teeth - with a little luck, this would make the Horde slow down and look for ambushes now.

Then she reached the edge of the forest and gasped. The gunboat was on fire, covered in thick black smoke… Oh. Sea Hawk was using the smoke powder to make it harder for the enemy to correct their shots. With the gunboat's guns firing blindly anyway, it wouldn't impact them. And the wind was blowing the smoke up the slope, to blind the infantry there.

But it would also hide a Horde charge, should the scum have the guts to charge into the smoke. The Captain was gambling on the frigate arriving before the Horde got their act together.

And, as a glance told Seacat, the frigate had only covered about half the distance since they had beached the ship.

Well, she didn't have time to dwell on that. "Captain!" she yelled, dashing across the shore towards the boat, "I'm coming in! Don't Shoot! It's me, Seacat!"

She kept yelling as she dashed along the shore, towards the stern of the gunboat. No canister shot ripped her to shreds - they would have moved one swivel gun to the stern by now - and no shell blew her to bits. Even better, as she reached the beached hull,

she saw the unmistakable form of Horas standing there, next to Alcy and Licy manning, as expected, a swivel gun.

“Horas!” She jumped up, dug her claws into the wood and quickly scaled the hull to the deck. “I need smoke powder and oil! And watch the treeline - we’ve got soldiers incoming if my plan fails.”

Horas didn’t ask or argue, merely turned and started towards the hold. Alcy and Licy swung the gun around, looking grim, and Seacat rushed to the bridge, past the sweating gunners struggling to load the next shell into the stern gun. The smoke she breathed hurt, but she ignored the pain. If she wasn’t quick enough, smoke inhalation would be the least of her troubles.

“At least fifty soldiers are on the way to flank us!” she snapped as she reached the bridge. “They’ll be here in ten minutes, or sooner.”

“I see. Things will get even busier, then.”

“I’ve got a plan to delay them - setting the woods on fire, and add some smoke.” She was about to explain further, but a sudden whistling noise interrupted her, and she dropped to the floor before she realised what she was hearing - an incoming shell.

Sea Hawk had taken cover as well, and a few moments later, the entire ship shook as a shell exploded a few yards from the hull, sending wooden shards and splinters, as well as soil and sand, into the air.

“They’re getting better - or luckier - with their shots,” Sea Hawk said.”The smoke helped, but…”

She nodded, getting up. “I’ll be back as soon as possible.”

“If you get cut off, swim to the other shore,” he told her.

She knew what he meant. If the ship got destroyed while she was away, he wanted her to abandon them and save herself. She snorted - as if she’d do that.

Judging by his smile, he knew that.

Then Horas arrived, with a barrel of oil and a pot of smoke powder. She slung a piece of rope through the pot's handles and tied it across her chest, then grabbed the small barrel and attached another piece of rope to it.

She couldn't carry it - she'd be too slow to do any good - but she could throw it into the river and drag it along the shore.

Once down on the shore, it ended up more rolling than throwing, and she had to wade through the water herself, but it was doable. But would she be quick enough to reach the treeline before the Horde forces did? Clenching her teeth, she pushed herself. She had to, or her friends would be flanked by the Horde troops.

But the barrel was damn heavy, and the current, even though it wasn't very strong at the shore, was working against her. Wading slowed her down as well, and her feet slipped on the pebbles and mud of the shore and shallows. She might not…

"Let me carry it."

Horas! He must have jumped down and followed her. She wanted to send him back - the Captain might need him - but…

A shell exploded on the riverbank, quite close to them, and she heard a splinter whiz past her. "Take it and follow me!" she spat, rushing out of the water and sprinting towards the trees. Another shell hit the river nearby, the water slowing down the shrapnel enough to render it harmless. Mostly.

She pressed on - the Horde wouldn't shoot the forest, not when their own troops were approaching. Unless the Horde gunners weren't aware of that, which was possible. Damn.

Then she was at the forest's edge, panting. Where were the Horde forces? She could hear them, but she didn't see a glimpse of their uniforms, yet. Good enough. She put down the smoke powder pot and opened it, then lit it.

Horas, panting as well, arrived. And he was bleeding from a cut on his arm - not all the shrapnel had been harmless, then.

“It’s nothing,” he grunted.

She took him at his word. “Splash the oil on the trees along the shore,” she snapped. “Don’t go too far.” That would let the wind blowing from the north drive the flames into the rest of the forest. Too bad it wasn’t blowing from the east - that would drive the flames towards the approaching Horde force.

Horas did so, grunting again. And Seacat could hear the cursing Horde soldiers now - and was that someone moving in a bush? The smoke was already hampering her view. Best not take a risk. “Horas!” she yelled. “Come back!”

He started towards her, trampling a few bushes, as she moved to the edge of the oil-soaked treeline. As soon as he was clear, she lit the oil, watched the fire spread for a moment, then followed Horas. “Back to the ship!”

He didn’t reply, just started to run - and she could see another wound on his back. That wasn’t a scratch. Damn. Clenching her teeth, she rushed after him. “You idiot!” she hissed as she passed him.

He grunted in return. At least he didn’t seem to be slowed down - even though he was leaving a trail of blood drops. Damn the idiot!

She threw herself to the ground, sliding down the riverbank and almost rolling into the water, when another shell exploded near the ship. Behind her, Horas did slip into the water but quickly recovered, and they ran on.

Seacat reached the ship, scaling the hull with her claws. “Licy! Get a rope! Horas’s wounded! Alcy, keep the gun pointed at the forest!”

“Oh, no!” The woman gasped but grabbed the closest rope.

They tied one end to the railing, avoiding a ragged edge left by a shell, and Seacat jumped down with the other end. Horas arrived, staggering. “Just a scratch!” she hissed at him. “Can you climb?”

“Yes.”

“You better.”

She climbed up before him, grabbing the rope. “Help me pull him up!” she told Licy.

Together, they managed to drag the flagging minotaur over the railing and laid him out on the deck. “We need a Healer!” Lucy yelled.

They didn’t have one. “Get a bandage!” Seacat yelled, pushing to roll Horas on his stomach so she could check the wound in his back. It was deep, but it should have missed his lungs - he could breathe without blood foaming at his mouth. But he was bleeding still…

“Horas?” That was the Captain. He should be on the bridge!

“Shrapnel in his back,” Seacat told him. “Too deep to pull it out.”

Sea Hawk cursed, then reached into a pocket, pulling out a flask. “This should help.” He poured the concoction into the wound just as Licy arrived with a bandage.

“He needs a Healer,” Seacat spat. If he hadn’t come with her…

“There’ll be one with the frigate,” Sea Hawk told her. “We just have to…”

Behind them, the bridge vanished in a fireball - a shell had hit it directly.

Seacat dropped to the floor, clenching her teeth, as bits and pieces rained down on them. Had anyone been on the bridge? She hadn’t seen anyone, but with the ship mostly hidden in the

smoke… She pressed her lips together as she got up. If anyone had been there, they were dead.

“They’re getting better with their fire,” Sea Hawk said. “Or luckier.”

Which worked out the same. Seacat hoped that no Horde soldier had watched the hit in the smoke - if the enemy guns kept firing at the same spot they’d quickly wreck the gunboat. Well, wreck it further. A quick glance told her that the forest she had set ablaze was burning nicely now - the Horde wouldn’t be charging through that!

Horas groaned - softly, but she heard it easily. “Horas?”

“It’s nothing,” he lied.

“We need to get you belowdecks,” she spat.

“No!” he protested.

“We could evacuate him - if we make a raft, he can float towards the frigate,” Licy suggested.

“A good idea. We need to be ready to evacuate our wounded,” Sea Hawk replied. “Start building a raft. I’ll see to the guns.”

“I don’t need…” the stupid minotaur started.

“You need to shut up,” Seacat told him. “Stay here. Licy, come with me - we’ll start building a raft at the shore.” She jumped over the railing and landed on all four in the mud at the bottom.

“Huzzah! Return fire, lads!” she heard Sea Hawk yell. “Help is almost here!”

The two guns fired again - not that they had been waiting for the command, anyway - but Seacat didn’t think much of their chances to hit anything. She shook her head - she had to focus on her task.

Licy joined her on the ground, stumbling a few steps after landing. “Where do we get the wood?” she asked.

Seacat pointed to the bow, which must have been further wrecked by enemy fire in the time she had been in the forest. “Plenty of wood there.”

“Right!”

They hurried towards the bow, ducking when a shell flew over the ship to hit the water - almost in the middle of the river. That was one inept gun crew. Or a worn-out barrel.

When a gust of wind thinned the smoke cloud for a moment, Seacat looked downriver. The frigate was closer now. But it would still take her fifteen to twenty minutes to be in position to fire her guns at the Horde. And the barges would take even longer to reach the sore.

It would take them almost as long to create a raft, but it would mean they wouldn’t have to wait for the frigate’s longboat.

She grabbed the closest plank - broken in the middle, but that wasn’t too bad - and then looked for more. They’d have to lash together a large raft if it was supposed to carry Horas and the other wounded.

Another shell hit the riverbank on the other side of the ship, close enough so the whole boat shook and a few broken parts fell down on them from the deck above. Licy yelped when one of the pieces bounced off her head.

“They must have made some corrections to their aim,” Seacat spat as she grabbed another plank.

“Took them long enough,” Licy agreed, tying down the next part. “Do… do you think the Salineans will arrive in time?”

Seacat hesitated. She didn’t want to lie to the woman. But it didn’t look good.

But before she could reply with something at least half honest but not discouraging, Licy muttered a curse. “We need to get Horas out, then.”

“We will.”

Seacat heard another shell coming down. Down!” she yelled, dropping prone and holding her hands over her head.

Licy joined her, landing across Seacat’s legs with a shriek.

Then the shell detonated right above them, on the already wrecked bow, and Seacat felt as if she had been punched when the shockwave hit her right before a cloud of dust and smoke descended on them.

She coughed, blinking and feeling around. Her ears were ringing. Someone was on top of her - Licy! Seacat wriggled out from under the other woman and fumbled around until she felt Licy’s head under her hands. “Licy?”

She sounded off, somehow. The smoke and dust thinned, and she blinked, coughing a few times. Lucy didn’t look hurt - she wasn’t bleeding. But she had her eyes closed, and her lips were moving, but there was no sound. Wait. There was no sound at all - the explosion must have deafened her! Temporarily, or so Seacat hoped with a sinking feeling in her stomach. “Licy?”

The other woman finally stirred, shaking her head. Her lips were still moving, twisting in a smile when she noticed Seacat, but whatever the woman was saying, Seacat couldn’t hear it.

She pointed at her ears then shook her head, and Licy’s eyes widened. She must have understood. Yes, judging by the way Licy grabbed her own ears, then slapped a hand on her mouth, she was suffering from the same problem.

Seacat pointed at the half-finished raft and looked for another plank. The shell would have sent a lot of broken wood down, which should make finishing the raft easier.

She had been right - there were lots of broken planks and other pieces. But she also saw three broken, bleeding bodies: The shell hadn’t hit just the bow, but the bow gun, ripping the crew to pieces.

And the gun - she saw the bent barrel sticking out of the mud a few yards away. If it had landed on them...

She shook her head. There was no time to think about such things - she had a task to do. Captain’s orders.

She clenched her teeth and grabbed as many planks as she could. “Hurry!” she yelled - and heard her own voice, if faintly. Temporary deafness, then.

Licy grabbed two planks and started tying them to the rest of the raft. “...ot enough…”

“What?”

“It’s not enough!” Licy repeated herself. “There’ll be more wounded!”

More dead, too. They were lucky that the gun hadn’t had much powder left. Seacat dragged more wood to the raft. “We need to push it into the river!” she yelled. Before they wouldn’t be able to move it anymore.

Together, they managed to push the raft into the river until it was halfway in the water.

Seacat turned, looking for more wood. Lucy was hammering a stake into the riverbank to tie up the raft.

There was a plank. And there… Seacat froze, staring at the top of the riverbank.

The Horde soldiers were charging down the slope. And they were far more than thirty - the western force Seacat had stalled in the forest must have joined them!

*****

The Holding Action

Dozens of Horde soldiers - almost a hundred! - were charging down the riverbank. “They’re attacking!” Seacat yelled. “They’re coming!”

At the stern, the swivel gun Alcy had been manning fired. A couple soldiers were mowed down by the canister shot, but the rest kept running. The swivel gun left at the bow fired as well, and a few more Horde soldiers went down, but not enough. Not nearly enough. And they were already too far down the slope for the stern gun to hit them.

Damn.

“We have to get Horas!” Seacat yelled to Licy.

“But…” The other woman stared at her.

“We can’t stop them! We need to save the wounded!” And the Captain. And themselves. “Come on!” Seacat scaled the hull - at the wrecked bow, she didn’t need her claws. Which meant the Horde wouldn’t have much trouble boarding them, either.

On the deck, she saw that Sea Hawk was handling the lone swivel gun, pushing a charge down its barrel as bolts rained down near him. “Captain!”

“Get the wounded!” he snapped without looking at her.

Damn. But he was right. “Help him load!” she told Licy, who was just reaching the deck herself. “We need to hold this part to use the raft!”

Without waiting for an answer, she dashed towards the hatch to the hold. Two jumps took her over the remains of the bow gun. A quick sprint carried her past the wrecked bridge, and she was on the main deck. A sailor was holding a spear in his hands and staring at the railing, ducking whenever a bolt flew by.

“Drop that and help me evacuate the wounded!” she screamed at him.

He jerked, whirling to face her, and she kicked the spear out of his hands. “We’re leaving. Come with me!”

The bow swivel gun fired again, and she heard screaming. Good. The stern swivel gun hadn’t fired, though. What was Alcy doing?

But she had a task to do. She climbed down into the hold. She saw a figure on the floor, next to the minotaur. “Horas!”

A groan answered her.

She quickly checked the other wounded. Dead. And one who could walk. That left Horas. “Get to the bow and on the raft there!” she told the wounded sailor. Then she turned to the sailor she had ordered to come down and pointed at the minotaur. “Help me carry him!”

“What?” the sailor gasped.

“Leave me, I’m done for. Save yourself!” Horas said.

“Shut up!” she yelled at both. “Grab his arm. Now!”

She was already crouching at the wounded minotaur’s side. “We’re not leaving anyone behind!”

The other sailor was just standing there, though.

She hissed at him. “Help me, or I’ll cut you in half and feed you to the fish!”

Paling, he hurried over to them.

“Grab his arm, you idiot!”

Once more, he jerked, but this time, he grabbed Horas’s right arm.

“Heave!” she screamed, pulling with all her strength. “Heave!”

Horas was heavy. Damn heavy. But she could carry him with a little help. Very little help - Licy or Alcy would’ve done better.

She managed to get Horas to the stairs leading up to the main deck. Baring her teeth, she looked up. That was steep. But she had to do it.

“It’s too much!”

“Shut your mouth, or I’ll shut it for you!” she yelled at the sailor. “Push him! I’ll carry him!”

She bent down and grabbed both of Horas’s arms, dragging them over her shoulders. Taking a deep breath, she pulled the minotaur on her back.

And started to climb the stairs, panting with every step. She clenched her teeth so hard, she feared they might crack. Her fangs cut her own lips when she teetered on the fifth step and almost fell down.

“Push, you sorry excuse for a sailor!”

“I am pushing!” came the weak reply.

Idiot. She dragged Horas forward, ignoring the pain in her back, and took another step. And another. Sweat drenched her fur, and her legs felt as if they would fall off. And her back…

Another step. And another. And another. And…

She stumbled as she reached the deck. She heard more screaming. And another shot from the swivel gun at the bow. “Alcy!” she yelled. “Help me!”

She heard the swivel gun at the stern fire, then she saw Alcy run towards her. And behind the woman, grapple hooks flew over the railing. The Horde scum was boarding. Too late.

Together with Alcy and the sailor, she dragged Horas to the bow. On the way, she saw the other wounded - dead with a crossbow bolt in his chest. Damn.

“Huzzah! Keep them down, lads! And lasses!” The captain was standing there, blade flashing, as he battled the oncoming Horde forces. Licy was helping him, but only three more sailors were present - the survivors of the stern gun crew.

“We need to get him down to the raft!” she said, looking around for a rope.

There was no way she would be able to carry Horas down through the wreckage of the bow. Especially not with Horde scum hot on their heels and swarming around the hull.

“Alcy! Cover our backs!” she snapped. “You!” She glared at the sailor. “Grab that rope there!” She turned to Horas, who was leaning against the railing facing the river. “Horas!”

“Leave me. I can…”

“You can shut up and grab the rope!”

She threw the rope at his head, and he grabbed it out of reflex. “Help him tie it around his chest!”

Holding the other end, she looked up at the remains of the mast. No. Too far. But…

She dropped the rope and dashed back to the main deck, past Alcy, drawing her blade. The first Horde soldiers were climbing over the railing. She cut down the first, then screamed as she dashed towards the others. Most of them jumped back down. The one who didn’t got her skull cleaved for her stupidity.

Then she whirled, eyed the broken mast still stuck to the ship and cut.

Entrapata's blade cut through the mast with ease, and, after a moment, the thing started to roll, towards the bow, smashing more of the railing before coming to a rest - pointed forward and to the side, sticking out over the river.

Yes!

She jumped, grabbing hold of the end of the mast with one hand and pulled herself up, just in time to dodge a crossbow bolt. More bolts flew at her, missing, as she ran on top of the fallen mast towards the bow. "Licy! The rope!" she yelled from the fallen mast as soon as she reached the wrecked bow section.

The other woman turned, grabbed the rope and threw it up to her. Only the sailor who had 'helped' her carry Horas was left on deck; the other sailors had already gone down to the raft. She hoped for their sake they had done so on orders!

Seacat caught it and ran it around the mast, then jumped down. "Hold it!" she told the sailor. "Licy, you too!"

"Uh-uh…" The woman looked a little queasy.

"Just hold it!" Seacat was already at Horas's side. "And you - over the side you go!"

She heaved, screaming, pushing him up with trembling legs, draping his arm and chest over her shoulders. She paused for a moment, taking a deep breath, then screamed as she leaned forward and pushed him over the railing.

Then she whirled, grabbing the rope together with the sailor and Licy, just in time to stop Horas from crashing down.

"This is too heavy!" the sailor complained,

"Shut up," Seacat snarled. A mainsail was heavier, anyway. "Lower him down slowly!" They couldn't let the rope slip - that would doom Horas. And rip off the skin on their hands. Or a limb. "Slowly!"

She guessed that Horas was about halfway down to the raft. They'd know when he reached it since the rope would go slack.

The sailor whimpered.

"Hold fast!" she snapped.

"It's so…" Licy groaned.

"Hold!" Hand over hand, she let the rope go - slowly.

"They're scrambling up the stern!"

That was Alcy. Seacat looked to the side and saw the woman fall back towards them, cutlass flashing as she fought against a Horde soldier with a shock rod. And more soldiers were climbing over the wrecked bridge. They'd be swarmed in a moment.

Seacat cursed. "Licy! Hold them off!"

"What?"

"Hold them off!"

"But…"

Seacat glared at her as she dug in her claws.

Licy let go of the rope and drew her sabre.

And Seacat strained to keep from getting pulled along with the rope. She didn't have the leverage. It didn't matter - only about a yard more...

The sailor let go of the rope with a scream, and Seacat was pulled off her feet and slammed into the mainmast. She screamed with pain, but didn't let go of the rope, she had to… She realised that the rope had gone slack and quickly moved on top of the fallen mast, then looked down. Horas was in the water, making feeble attempts to reach the raft.

Damn.

She whirled, then raced on top of the mast towards Alcy. A Horde soldier was climbing on the mast as well, back at the middle of the ship. She bared her teeth as she drew her cutlass, slashing at Alcy's opponent as she passed them. The Horde soldier fell with a bleeding throat, and Alcy finished him off.

"Go help Horas! Take Licy too!" Seacat snapped. "I'll hold them off."

"Aye aye!" Alcy didn't question her but turned at once and dashed towards the bow.

Seacat charged at the soldier balancing on the mast - the mainmast wasn't that thick - and grinned. She had claws and the better balance! He managed to parry her first strike - and even kept his sword from getting cut in two - but it cost him. Unbalanced, he couldn't parry her next slash, and with his belly slit open, he fell off the mast.

Seacat jumped off the mast, landing on the deck next to the wrecked bridge, then ducked as a soldier fired a crossbow at her. The bolt went wide, and she fell back, then turned. A jump carried her up to the top of the remains of the bridge, at the back of the three Horde soldiers about to descend on the bow. She cut the first in half before they realised she was there, then kicked the next so she fell down onto the mess of rigging and broken wood. Judging by the screams that followed, the Horde soldier wouldn't get up again.

That left the third soldier - a lizardman. The Horde scum hissed at her but didn't charge her. And he held his spear as if he knew how to use it.

Damn. She couldn't stay here. She had to take the scumbag out and secure the bow before it was swarmed. And the lizard looked like he knew how to balance as well.

She blinked, glanced down, then grinned - and slashed into the wreckage.

She saw the lizardman's eyes widen a moment before the part he was standing on broke off after she'd cut its support, and he was sent over the side, crashing into the riverbank.

Seacat jumped off as well, landing on a clear patch of the deck, and raced to the Captain. Alcy and Licy were already off the boat, as was the damn coward. That left just the two of them.

And about two dozen Horde soldiers.

"We need to go, Captain!" she yelled as she cut down a Horde soldier climbing over the railing.

"We have to buy the raft more time - they won't be fast."

Damn. He was right.

"Alcy! Lucy! Once you have Horas, push off and get away!"

"But…" she heard Licy starting to complain.

"Aye aye!" Alcy cut her friend off.

Seacat nodded and turned to face the Horde soldiers charging from the stern while Sea Hawk kept facing the soldiers scrambling up the wrecked bow.

The bridge's wreckage blocking most of the deck and the bow's height were the only things that saved them from being swarmed by Horde scum. Seacat could block the small passage left open by herself.

Not forever, though - soldiers were already climbing over the remains of the bridge, and one particularly daring scumbag was balancing on the fallen mast. Seacat feinted at the first soldier on the deck, driving the tall man back for a moment, then jumped up

and slashed to her right, cutting through the ankle of the soldier on the mast. Screaming, he fell into the river.

She had to take a few steps back as the first soldier charged, rapidly thrusting his spear at her, but she managed to step to the side and into his reach, cutting off the spearhead with another blow of her blade.

The Horde soldier tried to use the wrecked spear as a staff, but he had clearly not been trained as well in that as Catra had been. She ducked under his swing and ran him through with her cutlass. He collapsed, blood streaming out of his helmet, and the Horde soldiers lined up behind him didn't seem willing to share his fate.

That left the three Horde soldiers about to flank her through the bridge's wreckage. The foremost of them was almost through the jagged mess of splintered wood. Almost, but not quite.

She dashed back, rounding the wreckage, and jumped up. The lizardwoman swung her shock rod, but Seacat batted it aside with the flat of her blade and caught the woman with the tip of her blade on the backswing before she could recover. The Horde soldier hissed with pain, dropping her weapon to hold her bleeding thigh, and Seacat jumped on the remains of the steering wheel, then pushed off, flipped in mid-air and came down on the Horde soldier climbing over the corpse of the spear-wielder.

He saw her coming and raised his blade to skewer her, but he was crouching on the bleeding body of his fellow Horde scum, stumbling when he tried to whirl. Seacat batted his sword aside and hit him feet first. Her claws dug into his chest and sword arm, gouging both. She kicked out, pushing him over the remains of the railing, and jumped back, landed in a crouch in the middle of the deck. "Who's next?" she yelled, baring her fangs.

She could see the Horde soldiers falter, looking at each other. The one trying to reach the wounded lizardwoman in the wreckage paused.

“Huh? Who wants to die next?” She added, flashing her blade. “Come on!”

Then she noticed that the smoke was all but gone - and there was a line of Horde crossbowmen on the top of the riverbank, ready to shoot *down* on her and the Captain.

“Captain!”

She whirled and jumped, tackling Sea Hawk to the deck. A moment later, A dozen crossbow bolts hit the wreck. And Seacat.

She screamed when she felt a bolt graze her shoulder and another pierce her thigh. Damn!

“Seacat?”

“Hit,” she hissed. “We have to leave.”

She rolled off him, screaming some more at the pain that caused, but she managed to keep her blade. The Horde soldiers were about to surround them. Cutting them off from the water. “Go!” she told the Captain. “I’ll hold them off!”

“No! You’ll just get killed by the crossbowmen!” he replied.

Before she could protest, she felt his arms around her, lifting her up. “And off we go, Horde scum!”

One of the Horde soldiers on deck tried to intercept them, but Seacat cut him down with her blade. And then they were above the railing, plunging down into the river.

She barely managed to close her mouth when they hit the water - in the shallows. Sea Hawk hadn’t managed to jump far enough to avoid crashing into the muddy ground underwater. She felt him let go of her, and she twisted around coughing and sputtering as she resurfaced. The first Horde soldiers were rounding the ship and entering the water themselves. No, stopping to line up their crossbows!

Groaning, she dived, Sea Hawk at her side. A bolt passed through the water next to her, and she dived even deeper - not that the water was deep. Her leg hurt like hell, and her lungs started burning while she kept swimming.

She had to resurface too soon, though - far too close to the shore. At least the raft was almost to safety. Where was the Captain?

She gasped when she saw him - a bolt was sticking out of his back. “Sea Hawk!”

“It’s just a scratch! Swim on, I’ll be right behind you!”

She’d kill him for that. But… a dozen crossbowmen were taking aim at her. More were reloading. Damn.

She swung her blade in a circle, once, twice, then slung it towards the wrecked hull with all her remaining strength. It clattered against the wood and fell to the ground.

Seacat saw a Horde soldier run towards it as the first bolts started to plunge into the river next to her.

But her hands were already on the scabbard. “Captain! Dive!” she yelled, before flipping the switch.

She caught a glimpse of the gunboat and most of the shoreline vanishing in the explosion just before she ducked her head and dived. She had barely gone under when the shockwave hit, but compared to the Horde bomb vessel exploding at the Battle of Salineas, this was nothing. Just a strong push - punch - to the back.

She still hit the ground - the river was not deep here - but quickly recovered and swam back to the surface. Bits and pieces started hitting the water, hurled this far by the bomb, and a smoke cloud was rising above the riverbank. Where was the Captain? She couldn’t see him. No!

She dived again. He had to be underwater… hurt… maybe even knocked out… if her bomb had killed him… No!

She looked around. The water wasn't very clear, and the sand and mud and dirt falling down didn't help. She had to find him! He had to be around here. She had the best eyes in the Alliance - where was he?

She surfaced again and looked around. Sea Hawk had been… downstream. He must have been carried away by the current.

Cursing her own stupidity, she dived again, ignoring the pain in her leg and shoulder. Sea Hawk needed her! Where was he? He would… if the shock knocked the air out of his lungs, he would… sink.

She dived to the ground, looking around in the dimly lit, muddy water. Where was he? There! Something big, in the mud!

She swam, she raced to it, then wanted to cry - it was a rock. Not Sea Hawk. No! She shook her head - and caught a glimpse of something else. A shadow in the water.

A few strokes - her leg hurt even more now - got her close. A body! Sea Hawk! She grabbed him with one hand and started to swim to the surface, kicking with her legs, clenching her teeth at the pain, until she broke the surface.

She quickly pulled Sea Hawk up, holding his head over the water. Was he breathing? She couldn't tell. She needed to… she needed to get him out of the water so she could help him. But she was in the middle of the river. No, closer to the shore. The raft… was too far downstream.

No choice. She swam as fast as she could manage, with her wounds and dragging Sea Hawk, to the shore. If the Horde soldiers spotted her… But the entire riverbank was engulfed by the smoke cloud from the explosion. And the crater she could see beneath it… she doubted anyone on the riverbank had survived the explosion.

She could only hope she was correct.

She reached the shore, covered with bushes and a few trees, panting and exhausted, and dragged Sea Hawk out of the water.

He wasn't breathing!

She knelt down, stifling a scream of pain - there was a bolt in her thigh, still - by clenching her teeth and pushing a fist against her mouth, and started to breathe into him. Then she turned him around - blood started running down her thigh as the bolt twisted - and tried her best to get the water out of him. Sea Hawk had taught her how to save a drowning sailor, but…

She wiped tears from her eyes and breathed into his nose and mouth again. Almost afraid, she checked for a pulse. Weak, but still there, but he still wasn't breathing.

She kept it up, breathing into him, then pushing on his chest, flipping him over, ignoring the wound in his back, trying anything to make him breathe. Breathe. He had to breathe! She couldn't keep this up forever…

Panting and shivering - it was getting cold - she did it anyway. Finally, he coughed. And kept coughing, spitting out water. Then he drew in a choking breath. And he opened his eyes.

She managed to smile. "Captain!"

She hugged him, not letting go.

He groaned, then hissed. "Ugh… Where are we?"

"Shore. Had to blow up the boat," she replied, not looking up. He was warmer than her. "Sorry." She took a deep breath. "Horde shore."

"Ah." She felt him breathe, raggedly. Felt him cough. "Not the safest spot."

“No.”

“Can you swim?” he asked.

“Yes,” she replied.

“Good. I see the frigate - it’s not too far.” He groaned again. “Let’s get up.”

Seacat nodded and released him before pushing herself.

Only she didn’t. Her legs refused to work. And… and… She blinked. Was it getting dark? It wasn’t that late, was it?

“Seacat!”

“Yes, Captain?”

It was really dark now. And she was tired. So tired. And with the Captain safe, she could rest.

“Seacat!”

She blinked. “Wha...?”

“Stay awake!”

“Aye aye, sir.” Staying awake. She could do that. After a little rest.

“First Mate!”

She gasped. “Yes?”

“Stay awake. This is going to hurt.”

“What?” Then she screamed. Her leg…

She stared at the bolt. Sea Hawk had cut the protruding bit off. It was bleeding. A lot.

Until Sea Hawk tied his belt around her thigh - above the wound. That was… a tourniquet. But… Had she been bleeding out without noticing? In the water?

"We'll have to swim to the frigate."

Right. She shook her head. Focus. She needed to focus. "Aye aye, Captain."

"Good."

Wait… "What about your wound?" He was wounded too!

"I'm not about to... fall asleep," he replied. "Into the water! Now!"

She tried to stand, but he had to help her up - and then lowered her into the water.

She gasped - the water was cold. She was cold already. But…

"Swim!"

She swam. The current quickly dragged her downriver, but she kept swimming towards the other shore. Towards the frigate.

"Come on!" Sea Hawk encouraged her. "We're almost there!"

She almost laughed - they weren't even near. But she kept swimming, as well as she could with a numb, bleeding leg.

"Hey! Ahoy! Huzzah! We're here!"

Sea Hawk was yelling. And waving.

She blinked. Oh. There was a longboat. Headed towards them.

Seacat changed course, slightly. The current was still dragging her downriver, but the longboat was moving to intercept her. Them.

Just a few more strokes. Her shoulder didn't hurt any more. And she couldn't feel her leg, either, apart from some dull pain. A few

more strokes. She could spot the ensign in the bow, yelling something.

The river's current did the rest of her work, and then she was grabbed and dragged out of the water.

Then she screamed when something or someone bumped against the bolt in her leg.

People cursed.

"Treat her gently, you idiots, or I'll cashier you and then feed you to the sharks!"

That was the Captain. Seacat managed to laugh. She turned her head, saw him sitting on a bench in the boat, then looked at the sky again.

"Sorry, sir!"

"Let's get back to the ship! Hurry!"

"Setan! Call ahead - we've got wounded!"

"Aye aye, sir!"

A moment later, Seacat heard someone bellow: "Two wounded! Call the Healer!"

Would the frigate's Healer be busy with Horas already? Wait… She tried to push up, but failed. "Did you get Horas and the others? They were on a raft!"

"We did. Don't move."

"Rest, Seacat."

She felt Sea Hawk's hand on her good shoulder and sighed. "Aye aye, Captain." She was cold. Damn cold.

Suddenly, she was lifted up - and someone jostled her wounded leg. Again. Once more, she hissed with pain as she was placed on a gurney. And then raised. She caught glimpses of the frigate's hull, but too quickly, she was on the deck, and someone was poking her wound - more pain - before ordering her belowdecks.

"The Captain's wounded, too!" she managed to say before she was carried off. "Don't let him walk off!"

A quick trot through narrow corridors followed, until she was in the sickbay.

"Two wounded!"

"Put them on the table, I'll take a look." That was the Healer. Seacat recognised the robes.

"I was shot in…" she started to say, but she was cut off.

"I can see it. And you're in shock. Just lie there and let us handle this."

But… She clenched her teeth. This wasn't… OW! "That hurt!"

"Good. You'll keep the leg, then."

What? She gasped. Then she sighed. She didn't know what exactly the Healer did. But the pain stopped after the woman had poured something over her leg. Same that… Oh. Horas! She forced herself up. "Where's Horas?"

"Please calm down, we're healing you," someone else told her.

She bared her teeth as someone tried to push her back down on the table. "Where's Horas? Big, burly minotaur, he was wounded. Splinter in the back."

"He's sleeping. He's not trying to make his wounds worse by being an idiot!" the Healer snapped. "If you don't behave, I'll put you under!"

Under? Underwater? Or what?

But Horas was alive. She let them push her back down and sighed. Damn. That had been a bloody mess.

“Rest now. That’s an order. You lost a lot of blood. Stupid idiot.”

Seacat wanted to protest, but she felt too tired. Much too tired.

She’d yell at the woman later.

“And now to you idiot.”

“That’s Admiral idiot for you, Healer!”

“Very funny. Down!”

Seacat chuckled as she closed her eyes. A bit of rest, a short nap, would be good.

Then the frigate fired her broadside, and Seacat knew she wouldn’t be able to sleep.

*****

“So, what’s the verdict?” Seacat asked when Sea Hawk entered the sickbay, glaring at him and baring her fangs. While she had, of course, obeyed the order to rest, she really didn’t like that he hadn’t done the same, but had pulled rank instead as soon as he was able to stand. And she also wasn’t happy about the fact that the frigate’s guns had fallen silent some time ago and she hadn’t heard anything until now.

He didn’t flinch - he sighed and sat down on her cot. “Well, we beat the Horde troops back and established a beachhead.”

That had never been in doubt. The Horde hadn’t had enough troops, much less enough guns, in the area to contest the landing. They had barely managed to overwhelm a wrecked gunboat, after all. “But?” She cocked her head.

“They didn’t bite. The main force of the Horde withdrew into the forest.” He sighed again. “My plan failed.”

“Ah.” Well, it had been a gamble anyway. Land just enough troops to draw the main force out to destroy them, then land the rest south of the river mouth, moving to cut them off from retreating into the forest while the first landing force held out with frigate support… “The Horde commander isn’t an idiot.”

“I hoped that they were aggressive enough to attack - they’ve been quite daring with their ships, after all,” Sea Hawk replied.

Seacat snorted. “That’s because whoever commands the force isn’t a naval commander, but infantry. Or artillery, perhaps - they used their guns quite effectively. Anyway, they sacrificed the ships because they considered them expendable.” The ships wouldn’t have been put permanently under their command, but just for this operation. And Catra knew very well that the Horde’s navy wasn’t popular among the rest of the Horde - as stupid as that was.

“That would be remarkably short-sighted - and I say this as a Captain willing to sacrifice my own ship for the cause.” He shook his head.

She shrugged, then winced - her shoulder hurt.

“Are you alright?”

“Yes, yes. Just felt a pinch.”

“Let me see!”

She hesitated a moment, but he was the Captain, and so she turned on her side. “See? It’s not soaked with blood. The Healer knows her business.” Even though the woman was about as friendly to her patients as a drunk bandit from the Crimson Wastes.

He poked the skin near the wound, gently, but it still hurt. She didn’t make a sound, but he didn’t miss how she tensed at the

pain. “More bed rest,” he said. “That’s an order.”

“In here?” she asked.

“We’re headed back to the fortress,” he told her. “You’ll be able to rest there in safety - and more comfortable than here.”

She slowly nodded. “What about you?”

“I’m fine,” he said, flashing his teeth at her.

“Can I poke your back?”

He coughed into his fist. “I don’t want you to strain your body.”

“I’ll tell Mermista.” And the princess would visit Seacat.

He glared at her. “Perhaps I’ll rest myself.”

She snorted. “It wasn’t your fault,” she said.

“My plan, my fault,” he replied. “I should’ve insisted on a better crew as well,” he added, after a glance to check if anyone was listening. “We had one good gun crew; if we’d had two of them…”

She nodded. They might’ve silenced the enemy guns in that case, but… “Maybe. Or we might’ve caught a shot to the magazine.”

“Yes.” He sighed once more. “Overall, our losses were light. One gunboat, but we destroyed one of theirs, and a fourth of our crew made it out. And after your sword blew up, our marines had no trouble establishing a beachhead.” He grinned. “A little more powerful, and there would be a neat little bay now, perfect for landing boats.”

Seacat smiled, though she had to force herself to do so. If the explosion had been that powerful… That had been very close, then, closer than she had thought. “So, what do we do now? There wasn’t supposed to be a force around threatening our lines when we secure the river.”

“Ah.” He took a deep breath - and she didn’t miss how he winced a little when he did so. ‘Fine’? Hah! “We’ll have to take the river,” he said. “But it’ll be more difficult.”

And more costly. Another bloody mess, Seacat would bet on it. “Do we have enough troops for that?” If they had to secure the whole river against attacks… “We’ll need more ships - more gunboats.”

“Yes. We’ll have to see what we can do about that. And we need a new ship ourselves, of course.”

She narrowed her eyes at him. “A proper ship. Not a gunboat.” She didn’t want to sail on another of those boats again.

“Of course!”

*****

“You used the bomb function!”

Seacat suppressed a wince when Entrapta entered her room at the fortress - in the citadel, not on the waterfront, close to the harbour, where she had hoped to be quartered - and squealed like a kid receiving gifts. “Yes, I had to,” she replied. “The Horde was about to shoot us full of crossbow bolts.”

“Oh! And the bomb took them out? At what range?” The princess, carried by her hair, climbed on Seacat’s bed - which was, to be fair, big enough for a minotaur to sleep in comfortably - and pulled out her ‘recorder’. “Tell me everything!”

“Uh…” Seacat pulled her head back, but Entrapta just pushed her recorder even closer into her face.

“I need the data! What was the range? Was there a delay? If so, how long? What was the area of effect? Was there any standard object affected to measure the force of the explosion?”

“Uh… I was in the water, and I had thrown it on the shore, so…”

“You had thrown it? Did that affect the effect? How long did you wait until you used the bomb function after throwing? Was it an air-blast?”

“No, I waited until it was stuck in the mud there, close to the gunboat.”

“Oh! A gunboat! A Horde one?”

Were there any others? “Yes.”

“So we have a standardised object to measure the damage against! All we need is another Horde gunboat, and we can determine the force of the explosion by comparing it to a powder charge!” Entrapta blinked. “Although we should better use at least two gunboats, in case there’s some threshold to overcome to pinpoint the damage. Or three. Do you think we can get three gunboats for science?”

Seacat smiled wryly. “I don’t think we can get even one for such a test. We need every single boat to secure the river as long as that enemy army is hiding south of us.”

Entrapta pouted. “Oh, damn, I forgot about that. Yes, Mermista told me something about that - she asked if I could build a gunboat.”

“Ah.” Seacat nodded - carefully; her shoulder still hurt. “And can you?”

“Well, I could. If we had a yard. Or if I built a yard, first. But it would take as long as having the ships built in Salineas and transported to here.”

“But gunboats aren’t ocean-going vessels,” Seacat pointed out. “If there’s rough weather, most of them will sink on the way.”

“Oh.” Entrapta frowned again. “Well, we could capture the Horde yards upriver so we can build the gunboats there!”

“We probably need the gunboats to secure the river up to there.” Seacat resisted the urge to rub her twinging shoulder.

“Oh. That’s a dilemma.” Entrapta scrunched her nose. “I guess I should build one or two then.” She sighed. Her hair flitted around like the tentacles of a drunk octopusman.

“You don’t want to?” Seacat asked

“It’s bo-ring,” the princess said, pouting. “Not as bad as building dozens of smoke rounds for cannons, but still… there’s no challenge in building gunboats.”

“Not even if you add an engine?” That would greatly improve on the design.

“I thought about that, but…” Entrapta sighed again, slumping over - and almost sitting down on Seacat’s wounded leg.

Seacat subtly pushed the princess’s leg back a little. “But?”

“I’d rather work on your new ship, to be honest,” Entrapta said. “Or on a new gun!”

“New gun?” That sounded… dangerous. For everyone.

“Yes! That’s why I’m here! I need the data for the new project. If it works out, we won’t need any boring gunboats!”

Why would… Seacat drew a sharp breath. “You want to build a gun that shoots something like my old sword?”

“Yes!” The princess beamed at her. “And which doesn’t use powder, by an engine-derived method of propulsion!” Her hair formed a… well, it looked like a barrel. Sort of. “Imagine a gun big enough to fire at the horizon! Firing not a shell with powder, but an enhanced bomb device! Boom - and then BOOM!” Entrapta made an explosive noise and opened her hands in a typical ‘blow up’ gesture. She nodded. “The Horde would have to surrender since they couldn’t fight against that!”

This time, Seacat didn't hide her wince. "They'd still fight," she said.

"What? But they wouldn't be able to do anything - we could blow them up before they even know we're around! The army hiding in the forest? Boom!" Entrapta shook her head. "It would make no sense to keep fighting if you will only get killed."

"That won't stop Shadow Weaver or Hordak," Seacat spat. "They would fight to the bitter end, trying to win." She shook her head. "Faced with such a gun? They'd grab hostages so we'd be killing innocents alongside Horde scum whenever we use it."

Entrapta was looking at her with such obvious horror that Seacat felt a spike of guilt in her stomach. "But… that's…"

"That's the Horde for you," Seacat told her. "Trust me, I know how they think." Catra knew Shadow Weaver very, very well.

"But… That means no supergun."

"Not yet," Seacat told her. "But it would be very useful when we're attacking the fright zone." If they could take out both Shadow Weaver and Hordak in a minute by blowing up their headquarters… that might make the rest of the Horde surrender.

"Really?"

Seacat nodded. "Really. We might not need it anyway, but better to have something and not need it but to need something and not have it."

"Good!" Entrapta nodded firmly. "Now, that means I need your data even more. Tell me everything!"

"Uh… OK." Seacat smiled weakly. She didn't really want to remember everything - Sea Hawk and she had almost died, after all. But Entrapta… Well, she wouldn't understand that. And her sword had saved Seacat's life. Several times. She nodded and

took a deep breath. “Now, I just had thrown the sword, so I was about…”

*****

The Recovery

“There’s one!” Licy exclaimed, almost jumping over the rampart behind which she was standing.

“Where?” Alcy asked

“At the top of the cliff, next to the small, round bush!”

“The top of the cliff is covered in small bushes.”

“But this is a round bush! Perfectly round!” Licy replied.

“Those are bushes; none of them is… right! There they are!”

“See? I told you!” Licy lowered her telescope and grinned.

Watching the two’s antics, Seacat sighed and shook her head. Slowly, of course - even after a few days of recovering, her shoulder still hurt. Not as much as her leg would hurt, should she try to stand at the rampart, as Alcy and Licy were, instead of sitting in a wheelchair Entrapta had cobbled together in ten minutes. “We already know that the Horde has scouts on top of the cliff,” she said.

“But now we know exactly where they are!” Licy protested.

“And what can we do about it?” Seacat asked.

“We can send a patrol over to catch them,” the other woman told her.

“And have them ambushed by the Horde forces,” Seacat retorted.

“Then we need to send more troops over!” Licy wouldn’t easily give up on her idea. Or on any idea, Seacat knew. At least she wasn’t chasing Sea Hawk any more.

“The Horde scouts would see them approach, and withdraw,” Alcy said.

“Exactly - and that would mean they’d stop spying on us!” Licy smiled widely.

“Or they would be more careful next time, so we wouldn’t be able to find them as easily,” Alcy replied.

“It wasn’t easy to find them!”

“If you can spot a scout from across the river, then they are easy to find,” Seacat pointed out. If she had been as sloppy, she would’ve been caught several times by the enemy.

“Perhaps they want us to think they’re easy to spot,” Licy suggested.

“And why would they do that?” Alcy asked.

“So we’ll underestimate them!”

“No one’s underestimating them any more,” Seacat countered. Not after they had managed to thoroughly delay the planned offensive twice.

“Yeah…” Licy looked dejected, and Seacat caught her glancing towards the hospital of the citadel. Where Horas was still healing up.

She clenched her teeth - she hadn’t meant to dampen their spirit like that. “He’ll be up in a few more days; he’s tough.” If the minotaur had been a little less tough, he would’ve died; Seacat had asked the Healer in charge. Once more, she clenched her teeth. Stupid dumb brute, too proud to tell her about his wounds.

“Yes,” Alcy said, with obviously forced cheer. “Then we’ll get a new ship, and be off again!”

“Yes,” Licy agreed.

Seacat had no doubt that they would get a new ship - Sea Hawk had always been quick to replace a lost ship - but it wouldn't be a courier with an engine of Entrapta, like the Dragon's Daughter V. They'd probably get the next Horde courier brought up by the Salinean Navy while trying to run their blockade. Or they'd get another gunboat for the river campaign. Though those would have to be built, and they had no yard, and Entrapta was busy building her 'supergun'. In top-secret, so as not to alert the Horde spies who were undoubtedly all over the place.

"Provided Mermista ever lets him go again," Alcy added.

Seacat chuckled with the others; the princess hadn't taken well to their narrow, very narrow escape from death. Nor to Sea Hawk directing the battle on the frigate while wounded. While Seacat had been allowed out of the hospital after two days, the Captain was still confined to his bed.

She sighed. It wasn't really funny, anyway.

"Are you alright? Do your wounds hurt?" Licy asked, looking at her with a concerned expression.

"No, no, I'm alright. Just thinking," Seacat replied.

"Ah."

"There's another ship coming," Alcy reported, lowering her telescope. "Looks like a transport. Salinean, not Kingdom of Snows. They're coming from the east."

That meant they were coming from Salineas. Well, most transports would travel through the Seagate.

"She's riding low in the water. Must be stuffed with supplies," Licy commented.

That wasn't new, either. The fortress was full of supplies. They'd launch the offensive upriver any day now - but without a gunboat

or two, things would get sticky as soon as the river wasn't navigable by a frigate any more.

They really needed a gunboat. Seacat wondered why Mermista hadn't told Entrapta to cobble one together. Was that because she didn't want Sea Hawk to take command of it?

She had to talk to the princess, Seacat decided. Finding Mermista was easier said than done, though. Especially with Seacat limited to her wheelchair. At this time of the day, Mermista should be either in the planning room, or in the office - well, what passed for an office in her quarters.

Seacat grabbed the wheels of her chair and started to roll towards the ramp at the end of the wall; it was built to push cannons up to the ramparts but it handled her chair as well.

"Seacat! What are you doing?" Alcy asked before Seacat had managed to travel a few yards.

"Looking for Mermista."

"You're supposed to rest, not work!" Licy protested.

"I'm not running around, am I?" Seacat pointed out. "I'm resting."

Alcy snorted. "You're not resting your shoulder."

"Exercise is good for recovering from bed rest," Seacat replied.

"Once your wounds have healed," Alcy retorted. "Not when they're still open."

The two women had caught up to Seacat, and Alcy had grabbed the back of the wheelchair. "Don't exert yourself."

Seacat sighed. If only she wasn't so… Ah well. "Alright, then start pushing. I need to talk to Mermista. She should be in her quarters. Unless you saw her walking around down in the harbour?" She turned her head to look at the two women.

"No, she isn't. I would've noticed when the soldiers and workers started running instead of walking and lollygagging," Licy told her, grinning.

"You need to talk to her?" Alcy asked. She was frowning a little, Seacat noticed.

"About gunboats," Seacat explained. "They should be setting up a yard or something. They aren't, though."

"Ah." Alcy nodded. "I haven't heard anything about it, either. But this sounds like you want to start working again."

Seacat clenched her teeth. She didn't want to sit around being useless when the war was going on, and everyone else was fighting. Any day she wasted here, any day the offensive wasn't launched upriver, meant another day the Horde could focus on Bright Moon's forces. On Adora. "I just want to know what's going on," she said.

Alcy still looked as if she doubted her, but Licy nodded. "So do we! Let's go!"

They went down the ramp - which was a little more concerning than going up, Seacat realised. If Alcy let go and the wheelchair's brakes broke… that would be hard on her hands.

But they reached the yard, where marines were drilling, without trouble and followed the wall to the entrance to the main part of the citadel. Double the normal guards were there - another sign that Mermista was here.

"We're looking for the princess," Seacat told the marines standing guard. "Is she in her quarters or the planning room?"

"We don't know," the corporal in charge told her. "I'd try the planning room," he added, glancing at her wheelchair.

The planning room was on the ground floor. Mermista's quarters were higher up. And there were no ramps leading upstairs. "The

planning room it is," Seacat agreed.

"I hope she's in a good mood," Alcy said as they went on.

"She spent her fury," Seacat said. At least she hoped that was the case - Mermista had been cursing Sea Hawk for quite some time. After hugging him, of course. "We'll be fine."

As they approached the planning room - two more marines were guarding it - the door was opened, and Mermista stepped out. The princess frowned as soon as she saw them. "Seacat? Shouldn't you be resting?"

Oh. "I'm resting," Seacat claimed. "Entrapta made this for me so I can still go around without exerting myself." She patted the armrests of the chair.

"As long as she's not pushing the wheels herself," Licy added - very unhelpfully.

Seacat heard Alcy groan for a moment while Mermista glared at them. At Seacat. "You need rest! You almost died from blood loss according to healer Kirsten!"

"But I didn't," Seacat blurted out before she could help herself. "And I can't stay in bed all day!"

"Oh, you can, trust me," Mermista replied. She glared at Alcy and Licy as well. "Didn't I order her to rest?"

"Yes, Princess!" Alcy said, nodding.

Licy tried to make up for her earlier mistake. "But she's resting - Entrpata said the chair would let her rest while being, uh, mobile." She nodded a few times.

"Entrapta did?" Mermista frowned again.

"Speaking of her," Seacat cut in, "I was wondering about gunboats. Namely, where are we getting more of them?"

“Do you honestly want to discuss strategy and logistics in the middle of a hallway?” Mermista shook her head.

“We can discuss it inside,” Seacat suggested.

“No. We’ll get you back to your room to rest, and I might answer a question or two - if you’re being good and staying in bed.” Mermista nodded at Alcy and Licy.

The two women jumped to grab Seacat’s wheelchair and turn her around.

“Yes, Ma’am!”

“Of course, Princess!”

Traitors. But there wasn’t anything Seacat could do. Not with her leg still useless. And with Mermista in a bad mood.

“We considered building gunboats, but we don’t have the facilities,” Mermista explained as they crossed the courtyard again. “Building them would take too long.”

“Even with Entrapta’s help?” Seacat asked.

“Yes.”

They entered the building where Seacat was quartered.

“Entrapta suggested to build the parts in the yards in Salineas, ship them here and put them together,” the Princess went on. “But we’d need a yard here anyway.”

“So, what can we do?” Seacat asked, trying not to groan when Alcy and Licy lifted her out of the chair and onto the bed.

“You can rest. We’re going to take the Horde yards upriver. The frigates should be able to reach the base there.” Mermista smiled tightly. “We’re expecting more landing boats from Salineas - the

transport that arrived should carry them with the rest of the supplies."

"So, we're launching a limited offensive?" Seacat bit her lower lip. And then they would have to build gunboats? Provided the yards were taken intact? That sounded like a tall order.

"Yes."

"What about Bright Moon's forces?" And Adora.

"We've sent a skiff upriver the day you almost died. They know we can't move to link up with them yet.

Seacat smiled. That meant they wouldn't overextend themselves, expecting support when none was coming. Adora would be safe.

*****

Seacat grunted as she manoeuvred her chair through the door. Her shoulder still hurt a little when she strained her arm - and moving in her wheelchair without someone pushing her was straining after a while, though good training as well. Oh. Horas was awake. "Hey!" she said.

He grunted in return. He was sitting in his bed - which was much bigger than hers - and while most of his chest was covered in bandages, it was still a good sign.

"How are you doing?" she asked. "Alcy and Licy send their regard; they're busy looking at barges."

He grunted again.

"That bad, huh?" She grinned. "Cheer up! We'll soon be out of here. Probably before Mermista lets the Captain out of his room." She rolled over to the side of his bed. "I'd offer you my chair - I'm getting crutches - but I fear you wouldn't fit. But I can ask Entrapta to make a bigger one for you if you want."

“I’ll manage without,” he said. “I wouldn’t want anyone to break something trying to push me around,” he added.

She flashed her fangs in a grin. “Hey! I managed to carry you!” she reminded him.

“And I thank you for that.” He nodded somberly, and she suppressed a wince - she shouldn’t have mentioned that.

“That’s what crew does for each other,” she told him. “The sacred laws of the sea bind us together,” she quoted the Captain.

Once more, Horas nodded with a sombre expression. He seemed to be taking this far too seriously. It wasn’t as if she’d done anything special - she’d have done that for anyone.

“Anyway, you’ve probably heard already, but we’re launching an offensive upriver, to capture the Horde base with the shipyards,” she said. News had spread in the day since she’d heard of it.

“Yes.” He took a deep breath - she could almost hear the bandages straining. “That will be bloody.”

“A frigate can reach up there. And the troops will move overland, following the river.” She shrugged.

“The bombs will be dangerous.”

“We don’t know how many they’ve left,” she pointed out. “And they can clear a path.” They certainly had had enough practice. “And we’ve got more barges to ferry the soldiers over the river.”

“It’ll be bloody anyway.”

“Of course it’ll be bloody.” She grimaced. In theory, the frigate would suppress and wipe out the Horde guns covering the river, allowing the troops to cross the river and land on both sides of the base. Then they would shell the fortifications and take the base. But things never went as smoothly as that. The river was navigable for a frigate - but only barely. They might not be able to

get close enough due to bombs. “But, hey - what else can we do?”

Not that *they* could do anything, what with being laid up while they recovered.

He nodded again.

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The Captain was frowning at her when she entered his room. He had his arms crossed over the chest and was sitting in his bed. She could see the hint of bandages through his open shirt as well, but he looked better than Horas.

“Captain.” She raised her eyebrows. “What’s wrong?”

“I’m still confined to the bed,” he told her.

That explained the two guards outside. And the bars on the window, which hadn’t been there during her first visit. Yet… The Captain had gotten out of tighter spots, and he looked quite healthy. Well, healthy enough to stand and walk, which meant he would climb and jump. So, why…? “You’ve broken out of more solid cells,” she said.

“Err, yes…” He grimaced.

“You’re not chained to the bed, are you?”

“What? No!”

“So?” She rolled to his side.

“Mermista made me promise not to leave the bed until I was healed,” he said, pouting. “And a man of the sea is a man of his word!”

“Especially if you gave your word to Mermista,” she told him.

“Well, yes.” He sighed. “But she’s being really unreasonable about this. I’m almost healed up.”

“Ah.” The princess must’ve been more struck by their close brush with death than Seacat had thought. She shrugged. “It’s not as if we could do much, anyway - we’re still missing a ship. Right?”

“Ah, right.” He sighed. “Mermista said she’s ordered a new courier for us, but that’ll take some time. Our new ship has to be built first, then sailed to us. And then Entrapta will have to install an engine.”

So, at least a month, if the yard pulled double-shifts or Mermista commandeered a courier already on the slip. Yes, everyone would be healthy once the new ship was ready. She sighed as well. She didn’t like waiting and doing nothing while others risked their lives. Like Adora.

At least she’d be able to ditch the chair soon - her leg didn’t hurt as much any more, and crutches would be fine. At the very least, she’d be able to stand on the leg without ripping the wound open. Hell, if Entrpata hadn’t taken time out of her busy schedule to build the chair for her, Seacat would’ve ditched it already.

“What are you thinking about?” Sea Hawk suddenly asked, and Seacat realised that she’d fallen silent for a few moments.

“Adora,” she replied.

“Ah.” He smiled. “I should’ve known.”

Seacat felt a pang of guilt. Even healing up, she wouldn’t be able to help with the offensive. The curtailed offensive. “We’ve let Bright Moon down,” she muttered.

“Huh? What brought this on?”

She frowned at the Captain. As if he didn’t know! “We should’ve taken the entire river by now and finished off the encircled

portions of the enemy army. But instead, we've got Horde forces threatening our lines, and Bright Moon has to fight alone."

"I'm sure Bright Moon suffered setbacks as well. They didn't take the mines on schedule, either."

And Seacat was sure that Adora would fight even harder to make up for any setback. She wouldn't sit around doing nothing while others fought. And died.

"Hey! It wasn't your fault at all," Sea Hawk told her. "If anything, the fault belongs with me - I should've expected such an underhanded move as the Horde pulled with the harbour!"

She snorted at that. "That's the fault of the Salinean officer corps."

"Oh, don't be too hard on them. If I didn't think of it, then they couldn't even imagine it." He flashed her smile.

"But they could imagine listening to you," she shot back with a scowl.

"Ah, that." He shrugged. "They'll come around."

Her scowl deepened. They had been 'coming around' for a long while now, and she still couldn't see the port of that journey. "They are a bunch of…"

A knock on the door interrupted her, and before Sea Hawk could answer, the door was opened, and Mermista walked in. "There you are!" she snapped.

"Where else would I be, since you've confined me to my quarters?" Sea Hawk retorted with a pout.

"For your own good. If you want to run off and risk your life again, you'll have to be fully healed at least," she shot back. "But enough of that. How are you doing, Seacat?"

“Me?” Seacat’s blinked. “I’m doing fine,” she replied. She didn’t want to end up confined to a bed as well, after all. “The leg doesn’t hurt too much any more. And the shoulder’s down to some twinging.” She patted her shoulder to demonstrate. And didn’t wince.

“Ugh,” Mermista replied. “You’re almost as bad as he is.” She glared at Sea Hawk. “That means you can barely stand, I guess. And crutches would still strain your shoulder.”

Seacat glared at her. “I’m not an invalid. I’m almost back to normal,” she lied. Well, almost lied - compared to being crippled or dead, she was much closer to healthy.

“Sure you are.” Mermista, damn her, wasn’t fooled, though, and shook her head. “That’s your fault.” She turned to Sea Hawk. “She’s got that from you.”

He smiled in response. “She learned from the best!”

“Oh, you!” Mermista wasn’t amused.

Sea Hawk, though, didn’t double down - he held up his hand. “My love, my dear Mermista, we’re at war. With the Horde. To win, we have to take some risks. Playing it safe will only let the Horde recover from the defeats they’ve suffered. And how could we not share the risks of our soldiers and sailors?”

Seacat bit her tongue to keep from telling Mermista that the princess had fought and risked her life as well. Mermista was aware of that. And she hated being poked like that. She still winced a little when the princess glared at them.

“I’m very much aware of that,” Mermista admitted. “But there is a slight - no, a huge! - difference between fighting in the war, and risking your life with reckless abandon.”

“It was a calculated risk,” Sea Hawk replied.

“Then you miscalculated.”

“Hey! Bad luck happens,” Seacat cut in. She raised her chin when Mermista glared at her. “The plan was sound. A little dangerous, but sound.”

“We’ve gone over that before,” Mermista told her. Well, she must have done that in private with Sea Hawk.

“Oh, yes, we did.” Sea Hawk confirmed with a wince.

“In any case, you won’t leave the bed until you’re whole again,” Mermista said. “And the same goes…”

Another knock at the door interrupted the princess.

“Enter!” Sea Hawk said quickly.

A Salinean marine stood there. “Princess! There’s a skiff approaching - it bears the colours of Bright Moon.”

Seacat blinked. “A courier?” Bright Moon’s forces didn’t have many skiffs - most of them were captured Horde skiffs if she recalled correctly. Too few to use them to transport troops, as the Horde did. But they did great work as couriers - on land, of course.

“News from the Western front,” Mermista said, frowning. “Probably asking for a new estimate for when we’ll start our offensive.”

Seacat winced. Having to tell your allies you couldn’t do your part was embarrassing. She didn’t envy Mermista for that. And… if this was a courier, they probably carried letters as well. Adora!

She almost jumped up in her haste but managed to turn it into sitting straighter. “Let’s go welcome them!” she said, grabbing the wheels of her chair.

“Ah, wondering if there will be news from your lover?” Sea Hawk asked.

She glanced at him and huffed. That was obvious, wasn't it? And perfectly natural. Seeing as he was working directly with Mermista, he shouldn't be teasing her about wishing for a letter.

She frowned when she rolled out of the room. She'd have to write to Adora anyway. Inform her about the latest events. And… tell her she'd been wounded again. Though she could truthfully say it wasn't anything serious. Not any more.

Mermista caught up to her, and, a moment later, the guard who had informed her about the skiff's arrival started pushing Seacat's chair down the corridor. She almost protested that she didn't need the help but relented. Mermista would call her a fool, and Seacat didn't really need to prove anything.

They reached the courtyard right after the skiff set down. It was a former Horde skiff, too - a scout model. And… her eyes widened, and her heart seemed to skip a beat when she saw the pilot. "Adora?" she yelled out.

"Cat-Seacat!" Adora turned, smiling. But as soon as she saw Seacat, she gasped. "No!"

Seacat winced. "I'm fine!" she protested - but Adora had already jumped down from the skiff and was rushing towards her.

"Seacat! You're wounded! Oh, no! And it's serious!" Adora reached out for her, hugging Seacat to her chest, then released her as if she'd touched hot coal. "Ack! Sorry! I almost hurt you… what happened? How did you get hurt?"

"The usual way. We fought the Horde," Seacat blurted out before she could help herself. That was about the stupidest thing she could've said.

"They almost got killed when they beached their gunboat on the Horde's side of the river," Mermista said. "That was after their ship got sunk."

Adora gasped again, then stared at Seacat. "What did you do?"

“Adora!” The shrimp’s arrival in a wave of sparkles, together with Brain Boy, kept Seacat from answering. “Hello, Mermista! Hi, Seacat.” The princess waved at them both.

“Hello, Mermista, Seacat.” Brain Boy, as usual, was less outspoken, and took a short bow.

“The Horde crippled Ca-Seacat!” Adora blurted out.

“I’m not crippled!” Seacat protested. “I’m just using this to heal up more quickly.” She tapoped the armrest of her chair.

“But you’re still hurt!”

“Well, heal her, then, Adora!” the shrimp said with a frown.

“Oh… right!” Adora nodded with a determined expression.

“I’m fine - I’m just…” Seacat started to explain, but Adora wasn’t listening.

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

And there was She-Ra. She took a step back, then levelled her sword at Seacat. And glowing energy shot out of the blade’s tip at Seacat.

Seacat clenched her teeth and held her breath as the energy - the magic - hit her. Then she shivered when she felt her body heal. For a moment, she felt weird. Then she sighed - her leg wasn’t hurting any more.

“Did it work? Are you healed?” Adora asked, gripping her sword with both hands as she leaned in. “Can you walk again?”

Seacat flashed her fangs in a grin. “Let me get up and find out.”

“Uh, of course!” Adora blushed in that cute manner of hers and took a step back. The shrimp snickered, and Brain Boy shook his head with a wry grin. And Mermista would be rolling her eyes -

Seacat didn’t need to turn her head and look at the princess to know that.

She smiled at Adora instead, then slowly got up from the chair. Her leg still didn’t hurt, and she stood, then carefully started to shift her weight on her healed leg. It held. Not even a hint of pain. Nodding, she took a few steps. No pain either. “Yes, It’s good,” she said. She rolled her left shoulder, then gripped it with her hand, squeezing. “That’s good as well. Thank you.”

“Your shoulder was wounded as well?”

Seacat frowned. Adora needed to calm down. She took one more step forward and hugged her, sighing into She-Ra’s chest. She was fine. Everything was fine. Well, almost. Seacat raised her head to look up. “You should heal Sea Hawk too. And Horas,” she said.

“Sea Hawk is also wounded?”

“Confined to bed,” Seacat confirmed.

Adora gasped once more.

“That’s just to keep him from running off and hopping on the next ship to fight the Horde,” Seacat said.

“Oh. But he’s still wounded?”

“Yes. As is Horas,” Seacat told her.

The shrimp cleared her throat. “We also need to discuss the actual reason we’ve travelled here.”

“One of the reasons,” Brain Boy added.

The shrimp briefly frowned at him, then nodded at Mermista. “We need to coordinate our forces. And I think we can help you out.”

Mermista looked like she wasn't sure if she should be happy or annoyed at the offer, in Seacat's opinion. But she nodded. "Let's talk in the planning room."

Right. Any Horde spy would now be aware that the She-Ra and the Princess of Bright Moon had arrived. And it wouldn't take a genius to figure out that they weren't here to sightsee.

Great.

"Let me!" Adora said to the guard next to Seacat. A moment later, she had gripped the chair and turned it around. "Back to where you've come from?"

"Uh, yes." Seacat told her.

At least it's not as embarrassing as being carried like an invalid, she thought.

*****

"Marvellous! The difference between your magic and the Healer's arts is astonishing!" Sea Hawk flexed and struck several poses. "I feel no pain whatsoever any more!"

"Yeah, yeah, whatever," Mermista said. "Can we focus on the planning now?" She rolled her eyes and pointed at the map table. But Seacat didn't miss that the princess's cheeks had flushed a little.

And, judging by his wide smile, neither had Sea Hawk. "Of course, my love! Now that I have been freed from my prison, the Horde's defeat is merely a question of time!"

"Let's not be too hasty," Brain Boy pointed out. "The Horde has surprised us several times lately. We cannot underestimate them."

"That's right!" the shrimp agreed. "Not only did they stall your offensive from Fortress Freedom, but they also resisted our own."

Oh? So the forces of Bright Moon had encountered trouble as well? More than the expected resistance? “What did they do?” Seacat asked.

Adoira winced and glanced at the shrimp. Seacat’s eyes narrowed. Adora was too honest for her own good. When she didn’t want to answer a question, something was wrong.

“What did they do?”

“We attacked as usual, to break through their lines,” Brain Boy told her. “Princesses in the front to overwhelm the local defences, regular troops behind them to exploit the breakthrough. A classic strategy. But they were ready for us - they retreated quickly, and when we pursued, they blew up their own lines.”

Seacat gasped and looked at Adora. She knew her friend - Adora would’ve been leading the charge. “They blew you up?”

“They tried. But I was too fast for them!” Adora defended herself.

“They mistimed the explosion,” the shrimp corrected her. “Adora was already closing in with the retreating Horde forces when the bombs went off. But the company following her was decimated, and she was cut off and surrounded.”

Adora looked down at the floor, pressing her lips together. She felt guilty, Seacat realised. She took a step towards her lover and put a hand on her shoulder, squeezing gently. “It wasn’t your fault,” she whispered.

“It was. I shouldn’t have charged ahead. A leader stays with their troops. I should’ve known better.”

“If you had stayed with the company, you’d have been caught in the explosion and you’d be left wounded for the Headhunters,” Brain Boy told her.

“Headhunters?” Seacat narrowed her eyes. Catra didn’t remember any such unit amongst the Horde.

“A new force that the Horde’s fielding,” Brain Boy said. “Soldiers specially trained to fight princesses, as far as we know.”

“What?” Mermista blurted out.

“Yes. they’ve got better weapons and training than the regular Hode soldiers - better than the scouts and strike units, too!” Adora said.

“Could they hurt She-Ra?” Seacat asked, squeezing a little harder.

“Not really…” Adora trailed off. “Just scratches. Mostly. They didn’t hit with their cannons.”

“Cannons? Artillery?” Sea Hawk asked.

“No. I would’ve wrecked them before they could’ve gotten a shot off. They mounted small cannons on skiffs.” Adora rubbed her shoulder. “They shoot while moving, so they don’t hit very often.”

“Swivel guns. They mounted swivel guns on skiffs.” Seacat cursed. “That’ll… we need to adjust our tactics. Small units will be cut to pieces in the open by such skiffs.”

“Yeah, that’s what kinda happened afterwards,” Brain Boy said. “Turns out that soldiers trained to fight princesses are good to fight other soldiers.”

“I beat them,” Adora told them, with a rather mulish expression.

“In your sector. But Spinnerella and Netossa almost died. If they hadn’t managed to catch the skiffs in the nets - if the Horde soldiers had been a little farther away…” The shrimp shook her head. “We had to fortify our positions and dig in while Adora healed them. And herself.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes again. Aha - Adora had been hurt more seriously than she had said!

“Anyway!” Adora spoke up, looking anywhere but at Seacat. “We’re here to plan how to deal with those new tactics. I’ve got some ideas!”

“They better be good,” the shrimp said. “The old ideas didn’t work.”

Seacat looked at Brain Boy as Adora hunched her shoulders again and the shrimp suddenly looked guilty.

“Concentration of force. Instead of following up with a company per princess team, we gathered all princesses, and then Glimmer transported us behind the enemy lines,” he told her.

That sounded like a decent plan. Unless… “They were prepared for that?”

“They detonated another bomb in their own camp as soon as we were spotted,” Adora said through clenched teeth, “They killed a company of their own to kill us. Glimmer got us all out just before the explosion.”

“Because Bow had detected the fuse they were using,” the shrimp said.

“But… if they were so close and so quick… whoever lit the fuse would’ve been caught in the explosion as well, wouldn’t they?” Mermista asked.

Adora wasn’t the only one who looked grim as she nodded. “We don’t know if they were told the explosion would be smaller - or if they were ready to die…”

Seacat cursed again.

Mermista shook her head. “Horde soldiers aren’t fanatical enough to sacrifice themselves. They break far too easily.”

“You’ve mainly fought the Horde fleet,” Adora retorted. “They are the dregs of the Horde forces. They have much more fanatical

troops.” She grimaced. “I should know; I was raised as one.”

“But you turned to the light as soon as you were aware!” the shrimp told Adora with a smile.

“You’ve been naive,” Seacat added. “And Shadow Weaver did a number on you.” She managed not to hiss at the name, but she tensed a little anyway. That was in the past. She was Seacat, not Catra. She had beaten the witch.

Adora took a step towards her, then hesitated. “Yes, but… many wouldn’t have known better.”

“And once they’ve lost a few friends in battle, many will harden their resolve and fight to avenge them,” Sea Hawk said. “They might not believe in the Horde - but they hate us.”

Adora flinched again. Seacat sighed and went to hug her. Her friend was probably once again blaming herself for Catra’s ‘disappearance’.

Seacat felt her relax some, leaning into her hug. She wanted to let go of her again, but Adora wrapped her arms around her.

“Anyway…” Mermista cleared her throat. “If they keep doing this, they’ll run out of loyal soldiers.”

“Yes!” Sea Hawk nodded. “Many crews - not mine, of course - would be lost without a good captain and first mate. Any loyal officer lost like this will have repercussions.”

“Well, for the longest time, you two were your crew,” the shrimp said. “But, yes - that’s also our prediction. The Horde won’t be able to sustain these tactics for long, and it’ll significantly reduce the effectiveness of their forces overall.”

“Even the ‘Headhunters’ are having such an effect,” Brain Boy added. “They’re their best soldiers - and they’re missing from the regular forces. That means the average troop quality of any unit

other than the Headhunters goes down amongst the Horde forces. We can exploit that."

Seacat almost snorted. The boy sounded like he was giving a lecture.

"Yes." Adora nodded, her chin touching Seacat's shoulder. "Change of tactics - we use the princesses as a decoy to draw off their best troops, and then hit them with our regular forces."

"Though it'll be harder to move enough troops for that," the shrimp went on. "I can't transport enough soldiers to make a difference."

Seacat's eyes widened. "But ships can. Or barges."

"Exactly!" The princess beamed at her. "The Headhunters use skiffs to move around rapidly. We don't have enough skiffs to match them - but if we fight along a river, we can use ships instead."

"We already planned to secure the river," Mermista pointed out. "And we need to remove the Horde from its shores for that."

"Yes," Sea Hawk said, "But moving more troops with ships will allow us to move along the coast and strike deeper from any point of the river without a big obvious buildup." He grinned." We'll be able to trap the enemy army across the river."

"That's the plan, yes," the shrimp said. "Lure them into attacking the river, and cut them off."

"Like we are supposed to cut off the Horde forces north of us?" Seacat asked. "Just pointing out that we haven't done that, yet," she added when the shrimp frowned at her. But Mermista was frowning at her as well. Damn.

"We're working on that. But the recent setback has further delayed our offensive," Mermista said.

“Well, according to our scouts, the Horde forces in the north are mostly cut off already - they are only receiving a trickle of supplies overland,” Brain Boy said.

“But they are holding in place, instead of trying to break through our lines and retreat over the river,” the shrimp added.

“Trying to get an army across a river as big as this one requires a lot of boats and time,” Mermista told her. “My frigates would cut them to pieces, and they might not have the time or supplies to move west of the Horde base on the river to cross outside our range.”

“They would be in our range,” Adora said, releasing Seacat. “We’d sweep around them and encircle them. Waiting for a relief force might be their best bet.”

Seacat wasn’t convinced. In their place, she’d have thrown everything south - even if the attack failed, it would’ve done something. And if they had attacked together with the southern army… Could the Horde really lack enough carts and skiffs to move their army? “I don’t like it,” she said. “The Horde must be up to something. Shadow Weaver must have a reason for letting the Horde forces north of us die in place.”

And it was probably going to be very bad for the Alliance.

“Well, whatever her reason, she won’t stop us from taking the Horde yards!” Adora announced. “That’s why we’re here - we want to launch a pincer attack on it!”

“As soon as possible,” the shrimp added.

“Let’s strike in the morning! Huzzah!” Sea Hawk, of course, was all for it.

But Seacat wasn’t quite as enthusiastic.

*****

The River Offensive Part 1

"We can't strike at the Horde yards in the morning," Mermista pointed out, leaning over the map table. She tapped the bend of the river where the Horde base was located. "If we want to hit the base from both sides, we need to coordinate, and Princess Glimmer and She-Ra need a day to return to their forces."

"And a day to get ready for the march - or to send word back to you that something delayed us," the shrimp said, nodding.

"Ah, logistics and topography!" Sea Hawk hit his palm with his fist. "Many a good plan was wrecked by those fiends!"

Adora, the shrimp and Brain Boy were staring at him. Seacat rolled her eyes - the Captain was joking. Mostly. He was very much aware of both logistics and topography - no sailor worth their salt could ignore either.

"Yeah…" Mermista frowned at him. "Let's be, like, serious about it."

"Of course, my love!" Sea Hawk straightened and coughed into his fist. "I believe that even with the threat of more floating bombs, we can move our forces upriver and into position within a day. And, supported by one or two frigates, we shouldn't have much trouble landing them on the southern shores."

"Yes. The trouble we'll have will be breaking out of a beachhead." Mermista frowned. "If the Horde forces at the yard are as mobile as the ones facing us here, then we'll be handicapped. They can reposition faster than we can, and we will have inferior numbers of guns as soon as we leave the shore. And a direct attack on the base with frigates will be dangerous. They'll be prepared for that."

"But you can land your forces on the Horde side of the river without trouble. We can't do that as easily. And we can't fight our way east through the Horde lines on the southern side of the river

- it would take far too long. So, we'll need assistance to cross the river on our side of the base," the shrimp said.

Seacat noticed Adora wincing during the exchange. Brain Boy also looked uncomfortable. "I take it you tried it before."

The shrimp nodded. "We performed a pincer attack on the Horde force blocking our way down from the crystal mines. It worked, but… we lost a lot of soldiers in the river."

"I wasn't fast enough to take out the enemy guns, once they revealed themselves," Adora said. "They were pre-sighted on the river and the shore."

"Indirect fire - our own guns couldn't reach them until we had eyes on them," Brain Boy added.

Seacat winced. So did Sea Hawk and Mermista. Crossing a river - even a small one, like the river close to the mines - under fire from several enemy guns, and without fast boats…

"We can send some of our transports upriver - but they will have to run the guns of the Horde base," Mermista said.

"And doing that, the Horde forces will be aware of your presence," Seacat added. "Though I don't know if you can hide moving so many troops downriver anyway."

"If we land farther away from the base, we should be able to establish a beachhead without much resistance," the shrimp said. "But we won't be able to attack the base right away in that case. And the Horde might be able to evacuate before we encircle the base."

"Or call in reinforcements," Brain Boy pointed out. "Those skiffs allow them to move strike forces quickly."

Like the Headhunters. Seacat pressed her lips together. "We haven't seen the Headhunters here, yet. They probably didn't

expect Mermista to fight on the frontlines. But now that they know...”

Mermista nodded with a grim expression. “They’ll send some down here - if they can spare them.”

“Which means we could fool them to deploy Headhunters here while you travel upriver,” Seacat went on. “If Entrapta can create artificial waves, and we find a body double…”

“Even without artificial waves, a body double might be enough for the Horde to send Headhunters to this front and keep them around,” Sea Hawk said. “If only to be ready to react to landing attempts.”

“But they’ll have Headhunters in the yard as well,” Adora said. “They’ll know that we’ll be striking at it - it’s the last stronghold they have on the river. If they lose it, they are reduced to raiding. And, even with their new mobile forces, they aren’t as effective when raiding as we are.”

Seacat nodded. The Horde was focused on massed soldiers and guns. “They know we are coming. And they’ve had time to prepare for our attack.” Not good odds for an offensive.

“That means we’ll have to be creative and surprise them!” Sea Hawk said. “I might have an idea.”

*****

“Glad that’s over!” the shrimp announced, stretching her arms over her head as they left the planning room.

“It’s not quite over,” Adora protested. “We only have an overall plan - we haven’t hashed out the time tables and the marching order, final lines and unit disposition!”

Seacat snorted. “That’s not our job,” she said.

“What?” Adora stared at her with her mouth slightly open.

“That’s the job of the Salinean and Kingdom of Snow officer corps,” Seacat explained. “They are responsible for sorting out how to accomplish what Mermista decided.” Which was why Mermista and Sea Hawk were still in the room, dealing with the pricks.

“But…” Adora blinked.

“And it’s not your job to decide those things for the forces here, either.” Seacat grinned. “Not that you’d be able to since it involves ships.”

“Hey! I’ve read up on ships! And I helped out when we travelled on the Dragon’s Daughter… III?”

Adora pouted in that way that made Seacat want to kiss her right then and there. So she did, putting her hands on Adora’s cheeks and pressing their lips together.

“Aw!” The shrimp apparently approved.

Brain Boy cleared his throat - as if that would make Seacat stop. She was a sailor, not some prissy princess. She wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck, digging her fingers into her lover’s blond hair, and moaned loudly.

Brain Boy cleared his throat again, but by now, Adora was getting into it as well. Seacat felt her hands wander down her back, brushing over the strip of bare skin between her shirt and breeches, and grabbing… Yes! Damn, it had been way too long!

“Uh… perhaps you want to, uh, go to your room?” Brain Boy said.

“Oh, come on, Bow! They haven’t seen each other in a long time!” the shrimp told him.

“I’m not objecting to their display of affection. I’m just… we’re in a hallway outside the planning room.”

He was right, of course. Mermista would be mad if they went any further here. Seacat broke the kiss, panting, and smiled at Adora - whose face was flushed. “Yes, let’s go to my room!”

“But…” Adora looked at her friends.

“Go on!” the shrimp told her with a smile. “We’ll see you at dinner.”

“We’re not going to head back until tomorrow,” Brain Boy added, “when we have detailed operation plans to take back.”

It was the first time Seacat was glad for the Salinean Navy’s love of paperwork. “OK!” she said. “We’ll be…”

Adora interrupted her by sweeping her up into a bridal carry. “Let’s go!” her lover said, starting to walk without waiting for an answer.

Seacat blinked, then leaned her head on Adora’s shoulder. This once, she’ll let it go - she had been wounded until a few hours ago, after all.

*****

Later, Seacat, in her bed, with her head on Adora’s chest, sighed with a smile. It had been too long. Far too long. She didn’t want Adora to leave again. Ever. But she couldn’t ask that of Adora. The Alliance needed her. Needed She-Ra. She sighed again.

“What’s wrong? Are you hurt? I mean, we, ah, we…” Adora trailed off.

Seacat didn’t have to look at Adora’s face to know the other woman was biting her lower lip. “No, no, I’m fine.” As if she’d be hurt by what they had done. Really! “I’m just… You’re leaving tomorrow.”

“Oh.” Adora’s chest rose as she took a deep breath. “I’m needed at the front - the western front, I mean.”

“I know.”

“Ah.”

“That doesn’t make it any easier to see you leave,” Seacat went on, looking at the ceiling.

“I don’t want to leave.”

She smiled at that. “I would be hurt if you wanted to leave,” she said.

“You could come with us,” Adora suddenly said after a few moments of silence. “We need help with the crossing. And with the boats on the river. You’re the best sailor I know.”

Seacat took a deep breath. Going with Adora? Upriver? Leaving the Captain and the crew? Mermista and Entrapta? She wet her lips. They didn’t have a ship. Wouldn’t have one before the attack would start. Not even a gunboat. It was either a barge or a frigate. Neither appealed to her. And Adora was right - the Bright Moon forces needed people who knew their way around ships, not just boats. As large as the river was, having sailed some boats on Bright Moons shallow lake wasn’t enough to handle the crossing. Although… Seacat alone would have her work cut out for her.

She grinned. “I think you need more than myself for that. Fortunately, I know a crew who’s currently waiting for a ship.”

*****

“You want to return with Princess Glimmer?” Sea Hawk asked at dinner. Which was held in Mermista’s dining room, making it both fancy and private. Good food but you had to watch your manners more than usual.

“We need help with ferrying soldiers over the river,” Adora said before Seacat could answer.

“And with shipping supplies downriver,” Brain Boy added.

Seacat frowned at him, then cleared her throat. “We’re still waiting for a new ship, and we aren’t exactly needed on barges or frigates here.” The marines could handle the barges, and the Salinean frigates had decent crew, if not always good officers. But neither Seacat nor the rest of the crew would be accepted as officers.

“We were planning to send a selected group of marines with experience in such things upriver,” Mermista said. She wasn’t frowning, though.

“That’s a good idea. We can tag along,” Seacat said. “Or rather, we can travel with Adora and her friends and start preparing before the marines arrive.” She frowned. “How are you planning to get them around the Horde base, anyway?” They couldn’t exactly carry their boats and barges overland, and the Horde fortress’s guns commanded the river there. “Run under the guns at night?”

“That, or send a couple of our skiffs to ferry them around the base overland,” Mermista replied.

That would take most of their skiffs - neither the Salinean forces nor soldiers from the Kingdom of Snows had many skiffs, what with the things not working over water. It would work, though, so Seacat nodded.

“We’d need one skiff carrying us upriver, too,” Seacat said.

“I think that can be spared. We’ll need a courier anyway.”

That sounded good. Mermista was on board. But the Captain hadn’t said anything yet. Seacat glanced at him - he looked happy. She frowned for a moment. He wasn’t happy to see her leave, or his crew. She knew better than that. Still…

“I think that’s a good idea,” Sea Hawk said. “You need the experience, and my dear crew will make a difference with your forces.”

Which probably meant that they wouldn't be making much of a difference with the Salinean forces. Well, it wasn't really wrong - Seacat and the others were great at handling smaller ships, not frigates, and barges were, well… they didn't need a sailor.

"Have you asked the others yet?" Sea Hawk interrupted Seacat's thoughts.

"No." She shook her head. "I wanted to clear it with you first."

"Well, you did, First Mate!" He beamed at her. "And I'm sure they'll jump at the chance as well!"

Well, probably.

"Do you want to come as well?" Adora asked him.

Seacat winced - Mermista's scowl was one of the worst she'd seen lately. Fortunately, Sea Hawk was quick to reply: "My place is at my love's side!" as he reached over and wrapped his arm around Mermista's waist for a moment, and the princess smiled again.

"Oh, of course! Sorry!" Adora was blushing with embarrassment, Seacat noticed. And the shrimp was whispering into her ear.

Seacat's ears twitched, but she only caught the tail end of the shrimp's line: "...ly, Adora!"

"Sorry," Adora mouthed in return.

Seacat placed her hand on her friend's thigh and gently squeezed. She'd meant well, after all.

*****

"So, what do we do now?" Adora asked, stretching, once dinner was over. "Carousing?"

"I'd love to," Sea Hawk told her, "but I've found that my and my dear Mermista's presence tends to, ah, inhibit the soldiers and

sailors enjoying their leave."

Mermista rolled her eyes. "Duh. No one wants to get drunk under the eyes of their princess or commander."

"Really? Even if it's not against regulations?" Adora asked.

Seacat sighed with a smile as the shrimp and Brain Boy exchanged a glance. "Most people don't like to have their superiors know about the side of themselves they show while drinking," Brain Boy said.

Adora frowned. "Why not?"

"Uh, it's embarrassing?" the shrimp told her.

"Not everyone's as honest as you are," Seacat explained. "Some get rowdy and insulting when they're drunk. They wouldn't want their officers or Captain's to be present.

"So they wouldn't drink as much, which would impact the business of the tavern we'd visit," Sea Hawk added.

"Oh." Adora nodded. "We'd have to make up for the lost business."

"Or we'd have to punish people if they do something we can't overlook," the shrimp said.

"But… if they're breaking regulations, shouldn't they be punished?" Adora obviously wasn't quite familiar with how regulations were enforced, or not enforced, in practice.

"I'll explain it to you over a beer," Seacat told her with a smile.

"But…" Adora started.

Seacat ran a finger over her lips, interrupting her. "Shh. We can talk over a beer." She also ran her tail up the back of Adora's thigh.

"Uh… right!"

Adora blushed quite cutely, too.

*****

"...and that's why the officers overlook such things on leave, but never on board." Seacat downed her ale.

"But if sailors - and soldiers - need this, this…" Adora gestured at the rest of the tavern, which was packed with sailors and marines. "...this 'winding down', why not adjust the regulations?"

"Because you don't want them bitching and complaining all the time. If it's officially allowed, then they'll do it at sea as well." Seacat told her friend. "Even if you say that they can only complain on leave or without insults, people will still do it."

"Would that be so bad? Soldiers curse all the time," Adora said.

"They do, as do sailors. But that's not the same as complaining about their officers." Seacat shook her head. "A frigate isn't like our own ship. She has a much bigger crew - hundreds of sailors. They need discipline to function. If you don't keep a lid on complaining and making fun of officers, they'll mutiny. And if you keep them from winding down, they'll mutiny as well. Or you'll end up with a system where the crew elects the officers and captain. Like pirates."

"Would that be bad?"

Adora was really naive. Seacat smiled at her. "You want the most capable leading you, not the most popular."

"Ah." Adora took a swallow from her ale. "But you said that the Salinean officers aren't the best."

She frowned. "They could be better, but they could be a lot worse, too. And overall, they have done decently well. It's mostly the admirals who are idiots. Well, about Sea Hawk - some of them know their business well enough."

Adora snorted, shaking her head "To hear you argue for discipline…"

Seacat forced herself to smile back. She wasn't Catra any more. "I grew up. I still don't like it myself - which is why I could never be a sailor in the navy." Following the orders of some prick officer? Hah!

"That was very interesting, but I think we've had enough lectures," the shrimp cut in. Brain Boy looked a little disappointed, but the princess wasn't looking at him. "We're here to have fun! Drink and dance and…"

"...be merry?" Brain Boy added with a smile.

"Bow!" The shrimp shook her head. "That is having fun! We need a third thing to do. It's a rule."

Seacat narrowed her eyes. Perhaps the shrimp hadn't been quiet during the explanations because Seacat had been a good teacher, but because the princess had had a few ales already.

"Singing! Drinking, dancing, singing!" Adora declared.

She'd had a few ales as well, Seacat realised. And she hadn't yet changed into She-Ra.

Uh oh. Seacat winced when her friend stood up and raised her mug as if it was her sword.

"Off to war we go, we go, for the glory of the…" Adora trailed off with a grimace. "No, not that one."

Seacat nodded. A Horde marching song wasn't a good choice here - or anywhere. Then she winced again when Adora accidentally emptied the remains of her ale on herself, yelping: "Eeek!"

The shrimp snickered - no, laughed, a full belly laugh complete with pounding the table with her fist. And Brain Bow's grin was threatening to reach his ears.

They had drunk far more than Seacat had realised while she had been explaining naval discipline and customs during leave to them. Far more than Seacat had drunk as well.

“Seacat!”

She turned her head while Adora was still trying to find a song that she hadn’t learned as a Horde cadet, ticking off her failures on her fingers. There were Alcy, Licy and Horas, Lucy waving enthusiastically at them.

“Come, sit down,” Seacat yelled to them. “And fetch me a couple ales on the way! We need to show those landlubbers that they can’t outdrink a sailor!”

Not without cheating and transforming into a seven feet tall buff princess.

“I can so outdrink you!” Adora protested at once.

Seacat snorted. “Let me catch up to you, and we’ll see!”

“Well, I doubt that anyone amongst us can outdrink Horas,” Brain Bow commented.

“What?” The shrimp sneered. “Is that a challenge?”

“Drinking contest?” Licy beamed at them. “Bartender! As much ale as the table can handle!”

Loud cheering, not just from Seacat’s friends, but from half the tavern, answered her. And Seacat could see the tavern owner’s eyes light up at the thought of all the coin he’d make tonight.

Ah well, they had come here to carouse, hadn’t they?

Seacat grinned. It wasn’t her fault that Adora and her friends had drunk more than she had during her explanation. “We need a prize, too!” she said.

More cheering answered her.

The night was off to a good start!

*****

Seacat blinked as she stared at the mug in front of her. That was… she had lost count. Too many mugs.

“Are you giving up?” Licy asked from across the table, brushing a strand of her blonde hair out of her face. Or trying to - she had a little trouble coordinating, or so it seemed.

Seacat scoffed. “You wish!” Even with the ales she’d already drunk, she could drink the woman under the table. She lifted the mug. “To Princess Mermista!” Then she raised the mug to her lips and tilted her head back.

The ale flew down her throat. She almost gagged, but managed to keep it under control - spitting out any beer would’ve made her lose.

Licy had copied her. Or was trying to. But she was swaying a little - and Seacat could see that she was struggling. Good.

And Licy started coughing. She was stubborn, though, and didn’t pull the mug away from her mouth.

Which resulted in all the remaining ale splashing on her face and chest. And that meant...

“Yes!” Seacat cheered. “Another victory!” She stood, raising her hand in triumph, then had to sit down rapidly when her legs started to wobble. “Uh…”

Alcy patted her friend’s back, then helped her wipe the ale off. Since Alcy had dropped out earlier, she wasn’t actually helping. At least, it didn’t look like she was helping.

And that only left… Seacat looked around the table. Horas was there, already refilling his mug. Adora was also sitting there, but she seemed to be not quite there - she was looking at a patch of the wall with a silly grin. With the shrimp and Brain Boy out already, that meant second place would be Seacat's - it wasn't as if she would be able to outdrink a minotaur. Though trying was fun.

Someone had refilled her mug while she had been pondering that, and she gripped it with her right hand. "Alright!" She could do this. She could beat Adora. And, maybe, if Horas had some… no, Adora had healed him. He wouldn't have some lingering weakness. Probably.

She shook her head and repeated herself: "Alright!"

"Wait!"

Seacat glanced to her side. Adora was struggling to hold the mug. "Giving up?"

"You wish." The blonde beamed at her. "Just getting my second wind." And her sword, apparently. Wait! "For the honour of Grayskull!"

Seacat winced when her lover changed, the sudden light briefly blinding her.

"Hah! Now I'm ready!" She-Ra announced.

"Foul!" Seacat protested. "No magic use!"

"Yeah," Horas agreed. "No magic!"

"That's the sacred law of the sailor's tavern!" Seacat went on. "You use magic, you're dis… dish… you're out!"

"What? I didn't know that! And Glimmer used magic before!" Adora gaped at her.

“She teleported to fetch more ale,” Seacat said. “Not the shame.”

“I think Queen Angella might disagree about there being no shame,” Adora replied.

Seacat blinked. “Shame.”

“Exactly.”

“No, not…” Seacat shook her head, then regretted it at once when the tavern started spinning. “Anyway, you’re out!”

“Yes!” a sailor standing near them yelled. “No magic!”

“That’s the rule!” another agreed.

“Yes!”

She-Ra pouted. “That’s unfair!”

Seacat giggled, raised her mug, and started drinking. She managed to empty the mug into her mouth and not onto her chest - though it was a near thing - and slammed it down. “Yeah!”

Horas, of course, had already finished his. “Refill!”

Seacat blinked, then raised her hand. “No need, I give,” she said. “I mean, I give up. You get the mug!” The mug Brain Boy had engraved or something - she hadn’t paid too much attention. Seacat nodded firmly, which sent the whole tavern into a spin again.

“Seacat!”

Oh. She had her head on the table. How had that happened? And Adora looked worried. Ah well! Seacat pushed herself up, then slid to the side, resting her head in Adora’s lap. Yes! “Perfect!”

“Hey!”

She groaned in return and closed her eyes.

“Seacat?”

“Just a little nap,” she told her friend. Her lover. Yes. Perfect.

“Seacat! Glimmer! Uh… Bow?

“Yesh?”

“What do we do now?”

“We drank, sho we… danshe!”

“You want to dance?”

“Yesh!”

“Glimmer?”

“Glimmer! Where did she go?”

“To she danshe floor!”

“Yes! Come on, Alshy!”

“Lishy!”

That sounded like a good idea. “Lesh danshe!” Seacat said and got up.

“Seacat! Wait!”

Oops. She almost fell down if not for Adora’s arm getting in the way.

“How do you want to dance when you’re like that?”

“With you!” She beamed at Adora. That was a silly question, anyway.

She could do anything with Adora.

*****

Seacat didn't hurt when she woke up. That was a nice surprise. Usually, she had at least a slight headache after a drinking contest - unless she won quickly - but today? No, she felt fine. No headache. And the sunlight shining on her bed didn't feel like someone was stabbing daggers into her eyes, either.

And she was warm too - sprawled on top of Adora, basking in the sunlight warming her back, and her lover's body warming her front. A perfect way to wake up.

She rubbed her cheek on Adora's chest, then raised her head and rolled her shoulders. She was a little stuff, though. Stretching would do her good, and…

"Oh, good, you're finally awake! Good morning!"

That was… Seacat froze, then turned her head. Entrapta was standing next to the bed, smiling at her. How had the princess…? Ah. She had used her hair to walk, which meant she hadn't made any noise. "'Morning," she mumbled. "What are you doing here?"

"Waiting for you to wake up, of course!" The princess nodded. "They said I couldn't wake you but had to let you sleep in, so I waited until you woke up."

"Oh." That made… some warped sort of sense. Or would. "I don't think they meant waiting in our room."

"But how would I know when you're awake? I could listen on the door, I guess..."

"When we're leaving the room." Now she was developing a headache. Sort of.

"Ah." Entrapta nodded. "I'll make a note for next time. But now, since you're awake and all: We can talk!"

"About the barges and gunboats?"

“About the rafts for shipping the Bright Moon forces downriver! I’ve made and tested a prototype for a raft that can be constructed quickly and operated safely - Sea Hawk and Mermista insisted on that quality even though that will reduce performance some. But, apparently, they won’t be sending sailors upriver to steer them. Something I don’t get, actually - it would make the raft much more efficient.”

Seacat felt Adora move underneath here. She looked back just in time to see Adora open her eyes.

“Huh? Whatsgoinon?” Adora blinked. “Seacat!”

“Good morning, Adora!”

The smile turned into a gasp as Adora’s eyes widened. “Entrapta? What are you doing here? You didn’t… we didn’t, did we?”

“She came in in the morning to talk to us,” Seacat told her.

“Oh.” Seacat felt and saw Adora relax. “That’s good.”

“Yes, it is!” Entrapta agreed. “And I can ask about your sexual activities as well.”

Adora wasn’t the only one who blinked at that. “What?” Seacat asked.

“Yes. Remember when you told me that Mermista would tell me about this subject?”

Seacat did Vaguely. That had been in Seaworthy. Some time ago. “Yes?”

“Well, she didn’t tell me much. Not much I didn’t know yet, anyway.” Entrapta nodded. “But she told me to ask you two for the details.”

Of course Mermista would do that. Great. And Adora was blushing and mumbling. Useless. “Rafts,” Seacat said. “We need to talk

about rafts first. The war takes priority."

"Right! Rafts, then sex. Actually, they're more like barges - just more square. I wanted to make them modular, but field engineers can't match the tolerances for that. Still, you can expand on the designs and make them larger." Entrapta showed them some blueprints. It looked like a normal raft, other than…

"Getting so many planks will be difficult," Adora said. Of course, as soon as the talk was about war, she was all business.

"No, it won't!" Entrapta beamed at them. "I made a portable sawmill with an enhanced cutting blade!"

Oh! "You adapted my old blade?" Seacat asked.

"Yes! And I've built it so you can easily cut all planks to specs! You'll be able to construct rafts aplenty as long as you have wood - and you can cut wood easily with my blades!" The princess nodded. "But the real trick is the glue!"

"Glue?"

"Yes! Normally, you'd use nails and ropes and stuff to construct the rafts. That takes time and is a structural weakness if you lash the planks together. It also means you need more parts if you use rope and nails. But my glue will keep the planks together easily! And it's much easier to transport, too. Just…." She winced. "Don't fall into it. Really don't. I'm still trying to get Ophelia her legs back."

"Ophelia? Legs?" Adora sounded shocked.

"My new bot. She helped to test my design. I could make new ones, but that wouldn't work for people who got their legs stuck, so I am working on finding a solvent to counter the glue."

Ah. That was a relief. A small one - seacat didn't want to imagine what would happen if she managed to get her legs or any other

limbs glued together. On the other hand, that might be a good weapon for special occasions...

"So… let me show you how to build a raft in seventeen easy steps! Then we can test the designs in the harbour!"

*****

The portable sawmill was pretty much only portable if you were Horas or She-Ra. But it worked very well - they had the planks needed for the construction ready in no time. On the other hand, the sawmill would also cut any sloppy soldier handling it to pieces in record time.

And the glue… Seacat kept her distance from it. Normal glue and fur didn't go well together. Special glue made to build a raft and hold it together? She shuddered at the thought.

Entrapta, of course, was handling a barrel of it as she demonstrated how to assemble the raft. "And that's the basic body. Now for steering and propulsion, we'll be using simple technology as well!"

"You mean paddles," Seacat said.

"Yes! They can be made with the sawmill as well, but you'll need some leather wrappings to protect your hands. Easy!" Her hair moved and dragged some rough paddles over. "I made a few already! And this is the setup to steer it in the current!"

That was a more complicated setup - double rudders, to be exact, linked with rope.

"You can just use paddles to steer, but that's not too efficient. But the important thing is this!" She pointed at the openings left in the raft. "You can use rope to tie them together, forming a bridge!"

"Could we use the glue, too?" Adora asked.

“Err…” Entrapta winced. “You could, I guess - but handling it in water is not advised. It’s kind of easier to glue yourself in the water. You could stay upriver of the glue, of course, but… if you get stuck to the raft, the raft will be unusable.”

“And it would be painful as well,” Seacat pointed out.

“That, too, yes.” Entrapta nodded and hair-walked over to the assembled raft. “So! Let’s test the raft in the harbour!”

She reached out to the raft with her hair, but Adora stepped in front of her. “Let me! For the Honour of Grayskull!”

She-Ra could carry the entire raft without breaking a sweat, as she demonstrated by lifting it over her head.

Seacat couldn’t resist. She pushed off the wall that she was leaning against, jumped on Entrpata’s design table, flipped and landed on the raft in a crouch.

“Hey!”

The raft wobbled a bit while Adora adjusted, but it was nothing a sailor used to heavy seas couldn’t handle - Seacat didn’t even lose her balance. She smirked. “What? Am I too much for you?”

“What? No!” She-Ra announced and started to move towards the door.

“Uh… not the door; it won’t fit. We have a gate here!” Entrapta called out. “For ships. Well, they were meant for ships, but I didn’t build one yet.”

Seacat didn’t have to see She-Ra’s face to know what she was thinking when the princess pointed at the canal inside her workshop and jumped off before She-Ra threw the raft into the water. Then she smirked at She-Ra - she wasn’t born yesterday, after all.

She-Ra huffed, then pointed at the raft. “Come on, sail it outside!”

Seacat grinned and jumped off, landing on the raft. It was pushed a bit lower into the water, but she heard no creaks and saw no give - the glue held as promised.

But, as she soon found out, the raft handled as expected - like a slab of wood in the water. Fine for a calm river, but not for the sea. And she wouldn't trust it on a river or a lake during a storm, either.

But it would do what it was meant to do: Transport soldiers down and across a river. Provided they managed to build enough of the things. And if the soldiers could actually steer those things.

"So, it works, right?" Entrapta said.

"Yes," Seacat said. "Easy enough for even Adora to make and steer."

"Hey!" her friend protested.

Seacat laughed. Just teasing you. But you are a landlubber - so you're a good test subject.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded. "So, since the raft has been tested…" She smiled widely and pulled her recorder out. "It's time for the sex talk!"

Seacat grimaced.

*****

"We'll need another skiff," Seacat said as she looked at the Bright Moon skiff. "Maybe two."

"Two?" The shrimp frowned at her.

Seacat pointed at the portable sawmill, the supplies, and then at Horas. "Unless you've got one of the Horde skiffs carrying a gun, those scout models won't carry us all and the gear."

“Uh, yes,” Adora agreed. “We’re already be pushing it with seven people in two skiffs. With the supplies…” She shook her head. “We need another.”

“Or a carrier skiff,” Seacat said. “But I don’t think we captured one of those. Not a functional one, at least.”

“So… three skiffs.” Adora looked disappointed for some reason.

“I’ll ask Mermista for one,” the shrimp said. “Start loading the stuff!” She walked off instead of teleporting.

“‘Start loading’?” Adora smirked.

Seacat sighed. “Go on, show off!” Adora pouted at her, and she smiled. “I’m teasing you, dummy.”

“Ah! For the Honour of Grayskull!”

While She-Ra grabbed the sawmill and heaved, Seacat leaned over to Brain Boy and asked, in a low voice: “How often does she transform like that?”

“Actually, only when we need her,” he told her.

“She doesn’t stay She-Ra in the field?”

“Not always.”

Seacat couldn’t believe that. That was… if the Horde sent assassins or those Headhunters after her… She shook her head. “Damn. That has to change.”

“What has to change?” Licy asked as she and Alcy joined them while Horas finished loading the supplies on the skiff.

“Adora needs to stay as She-Ra in the field,” Seacat explained. That was safer.

“I do?” She-Ra asked.

“Yes. With the Horde going after you and the other princesses specifically, you have to be more cautious,” Seacat said.

She-Ra blinked, then smiled. “Don’t worry, I can handle them.”

“Don’t underestimate Shadow Weaver.”

“I won’t, don’t worry.”

Seacat clenched her teeth and refrained from making a scene. She-Ra was overconfident. She’d bring this up once they had a bit more privacy.

And there was the shrimp. “Mermista’s sending a skiff over,” the princess announced. “Who here has steered a skiff before?”

She-Ra, Brain Boy, Seacat and both Licy and Alcy raised their hands. Horas shook his head.

“Alright.” The shrimp nodded at Brain Boy. “We’ll take our skiff. Adora, you and Seacat take the cargo skiff.”

“It’s not actually a cargo skiff,” She-Ra said. “It’s a scout skiff; we’re just using it to transport cargo.”

The shrimp waved her comment away. “It’s carrying our cargo, so it’s our cargo skiff. And we need you two to pilot it since the cargo is crucial for our offensive, and you are the best to protect it.”

She-Ra nodded with a serious expression. Seacat wasn’t quite convinced that the shrimp was entirely honest. It would make more sense to have She-Ra ride on another skiff so she could fight without endangering the cargo, but if it meant Seacat could ride with her friend for the trip, she wouldn’t complain. So she nodded as well.

The shrimp pointed at Licy, Alcy and Horas. “And you three are on the third skiff. Which should arrive any minute now.”

Seacat doubted that. Mermista was the princess, but unless the fortress was under attack, the bureaucracy wouldn't be so easily moved. Not that she cared; after setting Entrapta on them, Mermista deserved some trouble with the bureaucracy. "So, we're following the river?"

"Yes. It should be safe enough, and we can do reconnaissance at the same time," She-Ra said. "We used the same route coming down."

"The Horde might have an ambush prepared, then." That's what Seacat would do in their place - send smaller parties over the river to scout and ambush - and to keep in contact with the trapped Horde forces to the north. And the Horde had been acting very sneaky lately.

"If they do, we'll smash them!" She-Ra said.

Yes, her friend was overconfident. Damn. She really had to talk to her about this. Preferably before they ran into a Horde ambush.

*****

The River Offensive Part 2

Mermista managed to get a skiff assigned to them before noon, and they set out after a light meal. The shrimp and Brain Boy led the formation, Adora and Seacat were in the middle with the cargo, and Alcy, Licy and Horas as the ones least experienced with overland travel in a warzone brought up the rear.

They made good time at the start, too - but then, they were still in the area occupied by the Salinean (and Kingdom of Snows) forces in Fortress Freedom. And the sun was shining, making it pleasantly warm.

Seacat squeezed past the sawmill tied down in the middle of the skiff and went to the stern, where Adora was controlling the skiff. She leaned against the railing there, smiling at Adora. "I still can't believe that you wanted us to eat rations on the way."

"It would have saved us an hour," Adora replied with a quick pouty glare at her before she focused her attention on the skiff and terrain ahead of them again.

"It also would have damaged our morale. Probably irreparably," Seacat told her. "Really, you should know best that you don't eat rations until it's an emergency."

"They're standard food in the field!"

"For the Horde. If we have to eat them, it's an emergency," Seacat said with a smile. She craned her head and enjoyed the wind for a bit. "So, you've travelled this route before."

"Yes. We know the terrain. We'll spot an ambush in advance," Adora said. "Bow is really good at it."

Of course, she knew what Seacat was trying to work towards. "Well, he better be good," she grumbled. "But there's always someone better."

“In the Horde?” Adora snorted.

“They’ve got good scouts, too.”

“Compared to Bright Moon’s rangers and Plumeria’s irregulars? No.” Adora shook her head. “Trust me, we’ve been beating them every time we faced them - and they didn’t even manage to get through the Whispering Woods.”

“But the Horde did collect their best soldiers for those Headhunters, didn’t they?”

“Yes. But their scouts were bad before.”

Seacat clenched her teeth for a moment. It sounded promising. And Adora did have more experience - both in the Horde and at fighting them on land. But… “I don’t like this,” she said. “Why aren’t they even trying to save their encircled forces?”

“They don’t have the supplies to move them through the wilderness and across the river. By staying put north of us, they at least tie up our own forces. You know the Horde leaders - they’d rather have everyone die fighting than running.”

“I know.” Seacat did know that. And it sounded logical - for the likes of Shadow Weaver. But… “I can’t help feeling that we’re running into a trap.”

“If there’s a trap, we’ll spot it. Don’t worry!” Her friend beamed at Seacat. “We’re good at that.” She raised her balled fist for a moment.

“Does running into a trap and fighting your way out count?” Seacat shot back, raising her eyebrows.

“Uh…” Adora suddenly found the horizon very fascinating.

Seacat smirked but soon sighed again. She had a bad feeling about this.

*****

By the time they struck camp for the night - not even Adora wanted to travel at night and sleep in shifts on the skiffs - they hadn't encountered any Horde troops. Nor were there any nearby - Brain Boy had scouted the surrounding area with the shrimp's help and they were widening the net, so to speak.

That left everyone else to put up camp. Which meant Adora and Seacat, relying on Catra's memories from her Horde training, were doing it while Alcy, Licy and Horas were helping as best as they could - a sailor hadn't much use for tents and campfires.

"You know, the Horde had better tents. Tents which were easier to put up, at least," Seacat commented while she struggled with the poles for the second tent.

"That's because the dumbest Horde soldiers were expected to be able to do this," Adora replied.

"Well, that's not a bad rule," Seacat said.

"We're not dumb!" Licy protested.

"You aren't," Seacat told her. "But this could be easier."

"Well, that's Bright Moon's standard tent." Adora shrugged. "You get used to it."

"We should loot some Horde tents, then," Alcy suggested.

Adora grinned. "Well, we could… but the Horde tents aren't as comfortable as Bright Moon's tents."

"Never mind then!" Licy quickly said. "I'd rather spend a little more time putting those things up and be more comfortable! We can plunder Horde camps for other stuff."

"Most of the Horde gear and supplies are like that," Adora said. "Easy to use, cheap to make, but not as good as what the Alliance

uses. They use crossbows a lot but few bows, for example."

"Well, their ships are the same," Alcy pointed out. "Not as good as Salinean ships, but they'll do the job."

"But taking a ship is far more profitable than taking some cheap tents," Licy added. "And we'd need a transport to grab stuff in bulk."

"If we can make additional rafts, we could ship a lot downriver," Horas said.

"You sound as if you're only here to loot the Horde base," Adora complained.

The three scoundrels grinned at her while Seacat chuckled. "Don't forget that while Sea Hawk's an admiral in the Salinean Navy, we haven't joined the Alliance. We're just sailors working for Sea Hawk," she told Adora. "And as such, we like prizes and loot."

"But…" Her friend gaped at her.

"We're not just here to loot, of course," she went on before her lover could find the words to complain. "But we won't dismiss the possibility, either."

"And the officers loot anyway," Alcy added. "The soldiers too - though they call it foraging."

"That's not the same!" Adora protested.

"It works out the same for those who have their farm plundered," Horas said, putting down a log meant for the fireplace.

"But the Alliance doesn't need to forage! We've got good supplies!" Adora shook her head. "And there aren't any farms left in the Fright Zone."

"Well, that's because the Horde razed them all and replaced them with factories and stuff," Seacat said.

“How do they get food, then?” Horas asked.

“Food? They raid for actual food. But they produce rations somehow,” Seacat replied. Catra knew that, but not how they were made. Only that they made hardtack taste good in comparison.

“Rations are made from plants cultivated in controlled environments. I’ve seen them - huge tanks with green and grey stuff floating in it,” Adora said.

“The Horde eats algae?” Licy looked shocked.

“I don’t know what it is, but it floats and grows in huge tanks,” Adora said.

“Sounds like algae.” Alcy grimaced. “I’m almost pitying them.”

“Well, Horde rations really don’t taste well,” Seacat said. “That’s why they are so eager to raid.”

“They could hunt and fish instead,” Horas told them.

“That’s harder. You need to have a reason to be in the woods, or at the shore of a lake or river, or you’ll get punished. Raiding and plundering is part of the war,” Adora explained.

“And if you hunt or fish, your squad will expect their share. If you raid, they’ll have loot themselves,” Seacat added.

“What a screwed-up system!” Licy scowled.

Coming from a former pirate, that was a condemnation indeed.

“That’s why we’re fighting the Horde,” Adora said. “Well, one of the reasons.”

“And we’ll beat them!” Licy agreed. “First this base, then we finish off the Horde army in the North, then we cut into the Fright Zone!”

That sounded a good plan, Seacat knew. But the Horde wouldn't just sit there and take it. That she knew as well.

*****

After the meal - some hardtack and dried meat, but also fresh fruits Brain Boy had gathered, and some roots they had boiled - Seacat sat down closer to Adora. "Hey, Adora."

"Yes?" Adora tilted her head and looked at her.

"We're soon in the territory contested by the Horde." Technically, they were in the contested territory already, but still closer to the Alliance lines.

"Yes?"

"Won't we have to expect those Headhunters to attack us?"

"If they do, we'll beat them. With the skiffs, we can outmanoeuvre them," Adora said.

"Yes. But what if they surprise us?"

"Uh…"

"What if they get a volley off before we're ready - or know that they are there?" They would only need to set up a battery for indirect fire and have someone spot for them.

"That would be bad. But we're looking for ambushes."

"Yes, but… She-Ra can shrug off explosions, right?" Seacat watched her lover's face as she asked.

"Yes, as long as they aren't too powerful, I can… Oh." Adora scowled. "You can't shrug off explosions."

"No, I can't - but you can." This was about Adora, not Seacat.

"But you'd still be dead." Adora shook her head.

Seacat blinked. What the…? Oh. Oh, no! She scowled. “Adora. If you had to sacrifice yourself to save me, would you do it?”

“Of course!” Her lover looked shocked at the question.

“Even though you’d die, leaving me alone?”

“Yes, though you would…” Adora trailed off, then set her jaw. “It’s not the same!”

“It is the same!” Seacat insisted. “I don’t want you to take unnecessary risks. You’re a princess - the Horde is gunning for you. The Headhunters were created to fight you and the other princesses. If you’re She-Ra, you’re safer.”

Adora pressed her lips together and didn’t answer.

Damn. Seacat shook her head again. “Adora, you can’t expect me to accept that you can sacrifice yourself for me, but I can’t do the same. Sort of.”

“If anyone has to die, it should be me,” Adora said, looking away from Seacat.

“What? No!” Seacat reached out and grabbed Adora’s cheeks, turning her lover’s head to face her. “That’s wrong!”

“I’m She-Ra. I’m supposed to protect everyone.”

“But not like that!” How could her friend be so…” Did you talk to that ghost again?”

Adora looked away and flushed a little.

“You did!”

“She helped me figure out my powers a little better,” Adora said. “Like healing.”

“And she told you that you had to die for us?” If Seacat ever found the bunker again, she’d wreck it and Light Hope!

“She said I had a duty. I was chosen for this. She-Ra is the protector of the whole world. I can’t let others die to save myself.”

“That’s not the same! What you’re talking about is killing yourself pointlessly!” Seacat exclaimed.

Adora frowned at her. “I’m not going to let you die while I live.”

“But I want you to live even if I die!” Seacat retorted.

They stared at each other. Why couldn’t Adora see how stupid she was? Dying like that didn’t help anyone!

“And I’m going to kill both of you if you continue this!”

“Huh?” Seacat turned her head and saw that the shrimp was glaring at them.

“Glimmer…”

“Don’t you ‘Glimmer’ me, Adora!” the shrimp cut her off. “You’re not going to kill yourself, understood? We’re entering Horde territory soon; be She-Ra for the rest of the trip.”

Seacat nodded in agreement. The shrimp knew what she was talking about.

“And you!” The shrimp turned to her with a scowl. “Show a little more understanding! Adora doesn’t want to live without you! That’s not smart, but it says a lot about her love for you!”

“But…” Seacat started to say.

“No buts!” the princess cut her off. “You’re both stupid. Now kiss and make up or I’ll teleport you into the river and keep you there until you do!”

Seacat blinked. “Can she do that?” she asked Adora.

“Uh… probably.”

“She can, and she can hear you just fine,” the shrimp added. “Now stop being stupid.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. She wasn’t stupid! She-Ra was the stupid one here! She looked at her friend.

Adra looked mulish - but also guilty. They really had to do something about Light Hope.

“Besides,” Licy added - right, everyone was listening - “Have you done it as She-Ra and Seacat yet?” She giggled.

Adora blushed like a wildfire before Seacat could tell off the woman with a suitably lurid comment.

“You have?” Licy asked.

“No! I’m so strong as She-Ra, I might hurt Seacat.”

Seacat closed her eyes for a moment and groaned. Really! “I’m not so flimsy,” she told Adora.

“Uh…”

“Well, if you need some tips, we’ve done it with strong people,” Licy offered. “And I’m sure Horas has experience with smaller partners, too!”

“I think that’s a little too much information!” Brain Boy blurted out.

Seacat ignored them both. “Really, you aren’t that strong as She-Ra,” she told Adora.

Her friend frowned. “Are you sure?”

They had fooled around with Adora as She-Ra, hadn’t they? Seacat remembered a little of that, at least. She nodded. “Yes! Besides, my claws can cut through armour - did you see me being worried about hurting you accidentally?”

“Too much information!” Brain Boy protested again.

“It’s not the same,” Adora insisted.

“Just try it out - you can heal her, can’t you?” Licy wasn’t really helping.

And the shrimp looked baffled - no, angry, now. Seacat wondered if they’d end up in the river anyway. “Ugh!” The princess shook her head. “That’s enough of that! Sort it out in private!”

“But…” Adora started again.

“No buts!” The princess held her index finger up and almost stuck it into Adora’s face. “You staying She-Ra in the field is a sound military decision. And Seacat’s right that you can’t expect us to live on should anything happen to you unless you accept the same for yourself!”

“B… I’m She-Ra.” Now the girl was pouting. Really!

Seacat shook her head with a sigh.

“And you’re our friend - and Seacat’s lover,” the princess added with a glance at Seacat. “We’re all in this together. We share the risks and dangers, but only as much as we must; not as much as we could.” She blinked. “Did that make sense?”

Seacat nodded. As did Brain Boy. And Alcy, Licy and Horas nodded as well, though Seacat wasn’t quite sure if Licy was just nodding along with everyone else.

Adora still looked mulish. Sometimes, she was far too stubborn for her own good. Such as the time she had wanted to defeat a bot in training even though they hadn’t had the weapons to do so. She had ended up in the infirmary - and Catra had been blamed for it by Shadow Weaver.

She didn’t want to think about that. The shrimp was right - they had to sort this out. But not at the campfire. The tent didn’t grant

them a lot of privacy, but it was better than nothing. It wasn't as if you had much privacy on a ship either. "Tent. Now," she told Adora.

To her surprise, Adora nodded and followed her into the tent. "That won't keep anyone from hearing us," she said.

Seacat sighed. "But it'll help - if we keep our voices down."

Adora frowned but nodded.

Kneeling on their sleeping bags, they stared at each other for a moment without saying anything.

"I'm sorry," Adora said. "I just…" She looked away.

"I know. I'm sorry, too," Seacat replied.

"I don't want to lose you."

"I don't want to lose you either." Seacat sighed. "But we're at war. And the Horde's after us - they know us."

"They're after me specifically," Adora pointed out.

"Who was kidnapped?" Seacat retorted. "You or me?"

"You, but because of me."

Damn. "No, because Shadow Weaver is an evil bitch," Seacat spat. "That's not your fault."

Adora obviously disagreed, but she didn't contradict Seacat.

"Anyway. I don't want you to take unnecessary risks," Seacat told her. "You don't want me to do that, either, do you?"

Adora pressed her lips together. She couldn't really argue against that. But Seacat could tell that she wanted to. "I don't like it," she finally said, pouting.

Seacat shrugged. “No one does. But it’s war. Until the Horde is defeated, we’ll have to deal with this.” And even afterwards… the sea wasn’t safe. A sailor took a risk every time they set out on a voyage. But this wasn’t the time to mention that.

Adora smiled - weakly - for the first time in this talk. “I guess we’ll have to hurry up beating the Horde, huh?”

Seacat nodded. “I guess so.”

Once more, the two of them stared at each other in silence for a moment. Then Adora cleared her throat. “They, uh, can hear everything, right?” she whispered.

Seacat nodded. And, judging by the lack of any sound from outside, they all were listening.

“So, even if we, uh…” Adora blushed again.

Ah. Seacat smirked. “So?”

“So?” The blush got worse.

Seacat pointed at her ears. “I can hear people even through doors.” Thin doors, unless she was actively trying to listen in, but still.

“Oh.”

“And I believe we need to test your claim about being too strong for me.”

“Uh…” Adora was wringing her hands nervously now.

Perfect. Seacat leaned forward and then crawled towards her friend. Her lover. “Transform,” she whispered into her ear.

*****

She woke up with arms wrapped around her, held in the crook of She-Ra’s arm. The princess was warm, like Adora. But she smelt a

little differently. And she was much stronger. Much tougher, too, as Seacat had found out. Her claws could still hurt her, though - not that she had tried. Not seriously. Just a scratch or two.

She shifted a little. Through the hole in the fabric above her - raising your sword to transform wasn't a good idea inside a tent - she could see the reddish sky. Dawn, then. Time to get up. Even though she didn't want to. She wanted to lay there a little longer. Bask in She-Ra's presence.

But they had a mission. Sighing, she wriggled out of She-Ra's arms. "Wake up," she whispered into her lover's ear.

A groan was her answer. And this was the woman who had wanted to skip lunch yesterday to gain an hour. Sighing, she started poking She-Ra's face. That didn't do the job, either, so she unsheathed her claws and pricked her.

"Ow!" She-Ra's eyes flew open, and she sat up so quickly, Seacat had to jerk back to avoid getting clipped by her lover's head, then had to put her hands on She-Ra's shoulders to keep her from standing up.

"Don't wreck the tent… any more than you already have," she said.

She-Ra blinked, then pouted. "That was an accident. And your fault!"

Seacat raised her eyebrows. "My fault? How was it my fault?"

"You distracted me when I was about to transform, so I didn't think about the tent."

"Ah." She grinned widely. That was good to know. And very flattering.

She-Ra was still pouting, but, after a moment, she started to smile. Then she grinned.

Seacat's eyes widened. She knew that grin. When Adora grinned like that…

Too late. Faster than such a strong woman had any right to be, She-Ra pounced, and Seacat found herself on her back, with She-Ra's hands on her shoulders. "Gotcha back!"

"That's not how it works," Seacat protested.

"Really?" She-Ra kept smiling, then bent down to kiss her.

Seacat closed her eyes and sighed, then moaned into the kiss. Perhaps this was how it worked…

"We're leaving in half an hour! Get ready! Breakfast will be ready soon!"

She-Ra pulled back at once, gasping - and blushing.

Seacat wanted to claw the shrimp. "We heard you!" she snapped.

"So did we!" the princess shot back.

She-Ra's blush intensified.

Seacat sighed. "Alright, let's go get something to eat." She arched her back for a moment, stretched on the ground, then rolled over and crawled out of the ten.

The princess was up, as were Brain Boy and Horas. Alcy and Licy were… groaning in their tent. Awake, but not up.

"You know we've heard everything," the princess told her.

"Of course you did; you aren't deaf." Seacat snorted.

Both the shrimp and She-Ra gasped at her comment. She ignored that and looked at the pot of water hanging above the campfire - recently revived with a few more logs. "Do you have tea? Or chocolate?"

“Both.” Brain Boy smiled at her. “Pick what you prefer.”

“Tea then.”

The tea was passable. She’d had worse. She’d had better, too.

“It’s the standard Bright Moon tea,” Brain Boy told her - he must have caught her reaction.

“For everyone in the army?”

“Yes, of course,” the shrimp butted in.

“It’s good then.”

“‘Then’?” the princess asked.

“If this was a special royal tea, it wouldn’t be good,” she told them.

“Well, I like it!” She-Ra declared.

“You grew up on rations. Of course you’d like it,” Seacat told her.

“So did you!” She-Ra shot back.

“But only one of us never traded for better food,” Seacat shot back. Adora had been too straight-laced for that.

Another pout was her reward. Adora remained Adora, even if she grew a foot in a moment. Seacat grabbed a sausage from the open pack next to the campfire and started munching.

“I wanted to make a hot meal, but…”

“We don’t have time for it,” the shrimp said. “This is the most dangerous part of our trip. We don’t know if we have to make a detour, and Mermista is counting on us to arrive in time to move the forces downriver.”

“And the Horde knows we’re using couriers along the river,” She-Ra added.

Seacat mumbled in response and took another bite out of her meal. As long as it was tasty, she didn’t need a hot meal. Not when it was pretty warm outside. “Say… are there special royal tea brands?”

The shrimp frowned. “Uh… Mom got some special tea brands. I was punished once when I… Uh…”

Seacat grinned. “Raided the pantry?”

“I wanted to make tea.”

“It came out more like some… soup?” Brain Boy said.

“I was four, damn it!”

Seacat laughed and finished her sausage.

*****

“So, everything sorted out?” the shrimp asked a little later while Adora ran a check on their skiff. Seacat would’ve done it, but her lover was a little more familiar with the things than her.

“I thought you heard everything,” Seacat told the princess with a smirk.

“We heard everything that you did in the tent. We didn’t hear everything you said before that.” The shrimp pouted slightly.

Seacat shrugged. “She’s She-Ra now.”

“Kind of obvious.” Princesses could roll their eyes with the best of them.

“Why are you asking, then?” Seacat shot back.

“Adora’s my friend,” the shrimp told her. “And while being She-Ra in the field keeps her safe and is good for her, I’m not just worried about the Horde hurting her.”

Oh. Seacat narrowed her eyes at the princess. “I won’t hurt her!” she hissed.

“You know how devastated she was when you were kidnapped? She blamed herself for that.”

So, she already hurt Adora? Seacat clenched her teeth. That hadn’t been her fault. Not just her fault, then - if she had been more cautious about poison…

“Look, it wasn’t your fault. And it’s over and done, anyway. I’m just saying…” The shrimp sighed and glanced around.

“No one’s listening,” Seacat told her. “Or no one can hear us at this distance. Unless you start yelling.”

“Ah.” Another sigh. “Anyway… She-Ra might be nigh-invulnerable, but Adora’s inexperienced in those things. Relationships.”

“I know. We grew up together, remember?” Seacat suppressed a scoff.

“Yes. But… “ The shrimp wet her lips. “You’ve been living a normal life for years. As normal as it gets with Sea Hawk, anyway.”

“Hey!” She glared at the princess. Sea Hawk was the best Captain anyone could wish for!

“Adora, though… she’s vulnerable. She’s putting up a brave front, but she’s… not as confident as she appears.”

Seacat sighed. “I know.” Adora was her oldest friend, after all. “She’s no carousing sailor. But we’re working on it.”

“I didn’t mean that!” the shrimp hissed. “I mean… Oh, damn it! Look, Adora’s insecure. She thinks she has to protect us all.”

“We’ve been talking about that.”

“Good. Make her see that she doesn’t have to sacrifice everything for others.”

“I’m trying.”

“Good.”

They looked at each other for a moment. Then the shrimp nodded and turned to walk over to her skiff.

And Seacat went to join Adora.

*****

“It looks safe,” Brain Boy said.

“That doesn’t mean it is safe,” the shrimp replied. “The Horde could be hiding inside the forest there.”

“It’s a bad position. Too easy to flank, and since it’s at the bottom of the valley, they wouldn’t have any way to detect approaching enemies,” Adora told them.

“Can’t we just give it a wide berth?” Licy had joined them on the ridge, looking down at the valley crossing their route.

“We could. But if there are Horde forces there, it’d be better to know before we send our troops down there,” the shrimp told her.

“Even if there aren’t any now, there could be when we return,” Seacat pointed out. “Best just go around them. Or around the empty forest.”

“But while they don’t have a good view of us, they can see up the valley just fine,” Adora retorted. “If they have scouts in the woods, they’d spot us.”

“So? They know we’re using couriers on this route,” Brain Boy said.

“We aren’t a courier. We’re a convoy,” Adora told him.

“A small convoy,” Licy added. “One transport, two escorts.”

Seacat chuckled at that. “A tiny transport.”

“Yes!”

“Ha ha ha.” Obviously, the shrimp didn’t like making fun of their mighty skiffs. “We should still check if there are Horde troops there. If there are, that’s valuable intel.”

“Use a skiff as bait?” Adora suggested. “Draw them out, and if they give chase, we hit them.”

“And if they don’t give chase, we’d be split up. And they’d still notice us,” Seacat said. “Have they attacked any couriers so far?”

“No. Which is why I think they will soon,” the shrimp retorted. “The Horde has been much more active lately. What with the damn Headhunters attacking us.”

“Would they send Headhunters against couriers?” Seacat asked.

“If they don’t have princesses to attack, probably. It would be wasteful not to use the troops,” Adora said. “But they might keep them in reserve instead, in case we’re about to attack them.”

“All that doesn’t help us. Do we try to get around them? Or just drive past them? The clock’s ticking!” the shrimp blurted out as if she, too, hadn’t kept them discussing things.

“I say let’s drive past. Our main mission is to reach your forces,” Seacat said. “Anything else is a distraction.”

“Alright,” Adora said. “Perhaps we should… Look!”

A skiff was racing out of the forest. A Horde skiff. And behind it were two more Horde skiffs. Firing at it.

Seacat trained her telescope on the skiff. It was a little tricky- the skiff was swerving wildly to avoid the shots from the swivel guns - but… She cursed.

“That’s Lonnie! And Kyle and Rogelio!” Adora blurted out. “They’re fleeing from the Horde!”

Or trying to appear like they’re fleeing, Seacat thought.

“And those are Headhunters behind them,” Brain Boy said.

“Damn!” Seacat muttered. That meant there were a lot of Horde troops down there. And if the Horde scum noticed them…

“We need to save them!” Adora said.

Change that to ‘when’, not ‘if’. Adora would never give up on their squadmates. Former squadmates. Seacat sighed.

“It could be a trap,” the shrimp said.

“They don’t know we’re here,” Adora retorted. “We have to save them!”

There weren’t any more skiffs chasing the trio, Seacat noticed. They could take two skiffs. Even if the skiffs had guns on them. “Can you teleport us on the chasing skiffs?” she asked.

“Yes, but not on both at the same time,” the princess replied. “And not more than two people.”

“Drop me and Brain Boy on the first skiff, then get Adora for the second,” Seacat said.

“But…” Adora started to protest.

Seacat cut her off. “The second skiff will be expecting you.”

“...right!” Adora nodded firmly. “Let’s do it!”

“It’s going very fast,” the princess pointed out. “I can’t match its speed.”

Oh. That would be like getting hit by the skiff. “New plan. You drop me on the first skiff, then get Adora for the second.” They could handle it. Brain Boy? Probably not.

“But…”

“Do it!” Seacat snapped when the leading Horde skiff fired again, and the upper part of the steering sail of the trio’s skiff was ripped off. She drew her new blade - a replacement that hadn’t been enhanced by Entrapta - a moment before she felt the shrimp grab her shoulder.

The next moment, she dropped on the deck of the leading skiff - and crashed into the pilot, almost impaling herself on the steering gear. The skiff was going so fast, she barely managed to hit him with her feet first, raking her claws over his chestplate and smashing the Horde soldier off the skiff, then had to grab and dig her claws into the steering sail to avoid getting thrown off.

But she did it and swung around, then clawed her way back to the deck just as the two gunners in the front noticed her. Snarling, she charged them, swatting the loader’s staff away with her blade and raking her claws over his faceplate, down his chest.

He dropped, throat and chest shredded, with blood running down his armour, and she whirled, parrying the shock rod from the second Horde scum. The woman was good, she noticed quickly as she had to deflect, dodge and parry a flurry of blows. The Headhunters must be almost as good as their reputation.

But she wasn’t good enough. Seacat leaned away from the next blow, then dropped, sliding over the deck, and slashed at the woman’s ankles. Her blade didn’t quite cut her legs off, but it cut through her armoured boots, and the Horde soldier dropped with a scream as her leg gave out.

Seacat brought her sabre down on the Horde scum's neck, decapitating her, then rushed back to take control of the skiff.

By the time she managed to bring it to a halt, Adora had finished off the second skiff - by cutting it in half or something; Seacat saw her jump off before the whole thing crashed into a boulder at the bottom of the slope.

"So much for a second prize," she muttered before remembering that Adora wouldn't claim the skiff as a prize in the first place.

The skiff the Horde scum had been chasing was slowing down, too, she noticed. Good - trying to stop the idiots would've been difficult. Or messy. Seacat brought her new skiff around - it handled decently well even with a slashed steering sail - and went towards her lover.

"Hey, Adora!"

"Seacat!" Adora jumped and landed on the skiff, and Seacat had to struggle for a moment to keep control of the vehicle.

"Watch it!" she snapped.

Adora laughed. "I thought you could pilot anything?"

Seacat huffed in return. "It's damaged." She glanced to the side and saw that their own skiffs were now cresting the ridge. "Well, the cat's out of the bag," she said.

Adora laughed again. "Let's go meet them."

"Right." Seacat brought the skiff around and headed towards their former squadmates.

They drew up next to the Horde skiff, and Seacat saw that the Headhunters hadn't just hit the steering sail. The hull was peppered with small holes, and Kyle was bandaging Lonnie's arm and leg. Canister shot - the woman had been lucky that the Horde

skiffs mounted small guns. If that had been a frigate's gun, she'd lost a limb or two. Or her life.

"Lonnie?" Adora called out.

Seacat saw the other woman frown and clench her teeth, though Kyle beamed at them. Rogelio… well, he wasn't hissing at them.

"Adora! You saved us!" Kyle said.

"She didn't save us. We were outrunning them," Lonnie said.

"Sure, sure. And you'd have magically stopped bleeding out while steering the skiff," Seacat said as she released the controls. Lonnie glared at her in return, which made Seacat grin.

"What are you doing?" Adora asked.

Seacat didn't roll her eyes.

Lonnie had no such restraint. "What does it look like? We are deserting!" she spat through clenched teeth.

"And why are you deserting? I don't remember you questioning the Horde's goals last time we met," Seacat said.

Lonnie hissed and glared some more. Kyle, though, as expected, nodded and replied: "We didn't know any better, back then. But after we got back to the Fright Zone and healed up, we were sent to the Headhunters. Special units."

"We're familiar with them," Adora said.

Behind them, the shrimp and the others arrived. Lonnie tensed, Seacat saw. As if it mattered - Adora could've taken all of the deserters by herself. Blindfolded and with one arm tied behind her back. Seacat could've done the same, too.

But Rogelio stepped closer to the other two. Between them and the rest of Seacat and Adora's group.

Oh, of course! They didn't know the others, Seacat realised. And didn't trust them.

"Hello!" Brain Boy waved. He was the only one, though. Horas glared at Rogelio, Alcy and Licy stared at Lonnie, and the shrimp… jumped over to Seacat's new skiff.

"So, those your old friends," she said, cocking her head.

"Yes," Adora said.

"Old squadmates," Seacat corrected them. "The wounded is Lonnie, that's Kyle and he's Rogelio."

"And you're Princess Glimmer!" Kyle replied. The shrimp started to preen when he went on: "We were trained to recognise you on sight when we joined the Headhunters."

The shrimp frowned in return. "I see."

"Uh… but we deserted!" Kyle hastily added.

"And why did you desert?" Seacat repeated her question.

"Uh… the Headhunters weren't what we expected," Kyle said. "They were good, I mean, not the dregs of the Horde, but, they, ah…"

"They kill our own troops to get the enemy," Lonnie spat. "Use them as bait for their traps. And the Force Captain in charge doesn't care how many of the Headhunters die, either, as long as he achieves his goals."

Ah. Seacat nodded. That made sense.

"Oh, no!" Adora looked shocked. "We knew they were using bombs to trap us, and that they had killed their own, but we didn't know they planned to do so!"

Lonnie didn't look like she believed Adora, but Lonnie had always been like that. Kyle, though, nodded. "Yes. Once we realised that, we decided to desert at the first opportunity. And when we were sent to the outpost here, we had that opportunity."

"An outpost? How many Horde soldiers are there?" the shrimp snapped.

"Uh...we were ten with three skiffs, and… one left?" Kyle said.

"One was left in the outpost," Lonnie said. "The rest chased us."

"We wanted to sabotage their skiffs, first," Kyle explained, "but they caught, uh, me, and…" He hunched over. Rogelio patted his back.

"Should've escaped at night," Seacat said.

Lonnie glared at her. "We can't see in the dark."

Seacat grinned. "I know. But the Horde wouldn't have been able to see in the dark, either."

Adora cleared her throat. "Anyway, you did desert, and we saved you."

"Yes," Kyle said. "Thank you!"

"It was our pleasure," she replied. "We don't like the Headhunters."

"So… you want to join the Alliance?" the shrimp asked.

"Actually…" Kyle started, but Lonnie elbowed him in the stomach.

"Yes," she said, still glaring at them.

If that was an attempt to infiltrate the Alliance, it was the most inept one Seacat had ever seen.

"Are you sure?" Adora asked.

“What else can we do? Three Horde soldiers with a damaged skiff? By now, Murkin will have informed the base about us.” Lonnie scoffed. “Alone, we won’t cut it.”

“Caught between the Horde base, the horde troops up north-east, and the Alliance,” the shrimp said. “Not the best position.”

“And the mountain passes are closed,” Lonnie said. “We’d be stuck to the plains. And hunted by the Horde and the Alliance.”

The shrimp looked at Adora and Seacat. “What do you think?”

“They’d be the worst choice for Horde spies,” Seacat said. Her grin widened when Lonnie gritted her teeth at that. “And that’s another skiff for our troops.”

“They’re our squadmates! We grew up together,” Adora said. “I’m sure they’ll help us.”

Well, Kyle had been more hindrance than help, Catra remembered, but Seacat was sure the boy had outgrown his clumsiness. He wouldn’t have survived years in the Horde otherwise.

The shrimp nodded. “Welcome to the Alliance.”

*****

The River Offensive Part 3

Now five skiffs instead of three - Seacat piloted her new prize, Adora their old one and the three deserters stuck with their stolen one - the convoy left the valley before any Horde reinforcements could arrive. They drove west, keeping the river in sight but not following too closely - with a damaged skiff, it was better not to tempt fate. Or something.

Seacat didn't really care. Piloting a skiff all by herself wasn't much fun. Fortunately, they reached the Alliance camp later in the afternoon. It didn't look like Seacat had expected. There were earthen fortifications, like those that the Salinean marines put up in the field. But theirs weren't covered in wooden spikes and thorny hedges like the ones here. How old was… Oh. That must be Princess Perfuma's work.

She also didn't see as many gun emplacements as the Salineans would have as they drove up close to the massive wooden gate - another creation of the Plant Princess, no doubt.

"Open the gate!" the shrimp yelled - she was leading the convoy for the last leg. With their captured Horde skiffs, they didn't want to risk fatal misunderstandings.

"Open the gate! Princess Glimmer is back!"

"We've got Horde deserters!" the shrimp added as the gate swung open. She jumped off the skiff as soon as they were inside the camp and addressed the officer at the gate. "Gather every commander for a meeting! And get the skiffs looked after!" She turned. "Bow! Come with me! Everyone - park the skiffs and join us in the main tent!"

Brain Boy dutifully trotted after the shrimp. Seacat looked at Adora. "Pushy little princess, isn't she?"

Judging by the scowls from the closest guards, the soldiers had overheard her as well. Well, it wasn't as if Seacat cared too much.

"Uh… she's the commander," Adora replied.

"As I said." Seacat flashed her a grin, then turned to the scowling guard. "Where do we put the skiffs down?"

The woman pointed her spear at the back of the camp. "Skiff park's there."

Seacat nodded and drove the skiff off.

The skiff park was rather small - the Horde usually had far more skiffs in a base of similar size. But that was no skin off Seacat's butt. She set the skiff down in a corner, aligned with the closest skiffs, tied it down - you always tied your vessel down, no matter how small it was - and headed towards Adora.

Who was headed towards the deserters. Well, Seacat had expected that. Or should have. She followed her lover and yelled to her three crewmates: "Come on, no lollygagging!"

Alcy scoffed good-naturally in return, Licy stuck out her tongue, and Horas merely kept working. Morale was good, then.

"So, come with us!" Adora told the deserters. "You heard Glimmer."

"Lonnie needs a Healer!" Kyle protested.

"No problem!" Adora beamed, pointed her sword at Lonnie, and a beam of magic struck the woman before she could react. "See? All healed!" Adora announced before frowning. "Well, you should be healed. Are you?"

"Watch where you point that sword!" Lonnie replied, gingerly touching her bandaged limbs. Then she blinked. "It doesn't hurt any more."

Seacat sighed. “Check if it’s healed, duh!”

Lonnie scowled at her - she was being pretty ungrateful, in Seacat’s opinion - but started to unwrap the bandages.

Kyle jumped to help. “Wow! Not even a scar!” he gushed.

“Good!” Adora beamed again.

“That’s She-Ra - the best fighter and Healer in Etheria!” Licy said - the rest of their group had finished securing their skiff, then.

“Uh… anyway,” Adora said, coughing, “we should go. Glimmer is waiting for us.”

Lonnie cursed under her breath before speaking up. “I don’t think we’re expected at the staff meeting of the princesses.”

“What? No, you heard Glimmer: She wants us to join them! Come on!” Adora insisted.

“Yeah,” Seacat added. “Better don’t start your service in the Alliance with insubordination. Do you know what they do with mutineers in Bright Moon?”

Lonnie’s scowl deepened, but Kyle gasped and leaned towards Seacat. “No! What do they do?”

“They tie them down under their magical crystal lens, then let the moonlight focus on them. It drains them of every bit of moisture in their bodies - slowly. Most live three nights.”

Kyle looked horrified, and even Lonnie and Rogelio seemed uneasy.

“Ca-Seacat!” Adora scowled. “That’s not true!” Then she blinked and added: “I think. I don’t remember Bright Moon having a deserter.”

Seacat grinned. “Of course not - who would dare to desert with such a penalty?”

“If things were as bad as in the Headhunters, a lot of soldiers would,” Lonnie said.

“Oh.” Adora nodded. “I’m sorry. I wasn’t…”

Seacat shrugged. “That’s probably why the princess wants you at the meeting - first-hand information about the Horde forces.”

The three deserters exchanged a few glances, then Lonnie nodded. “Let’s go then!”

They walked over to the biggest tent in the centre of the camp. “Too obvious,” Seacat muttered.

“It has to be big so they can hold meetings in it,” Adora told her. “And by being in the centre, an enemy has to go through half the camp to reach it.”

That was true. But… “Would that stop the Headhunters?” she asked Lonnie and the others.

“Uh…” Kyle grimaced.

“Tents won’t stop shells,” Lonnie said. “But the walls will stop an assault, even in a skiff, and they can’t set up guns behind a ridge here.”

That wouldn’t keep them from blowing up the wall in a suicide run, followed by another. Though that was harder than it sounded - Seacat knew all about using a vessel to ram a target. And they’d need a huge bomb to blow up this wall. Or an enhanced engine bomb. And either was vulnerable to shells. Especially if placed on a skiff. “What about assassins?” she asked. They passed some guards who scowled at the Horde uniforms but didn’t say anything.

“We weren’t trained for that,” Lonnie told them as they approached the tent’s entrance. “Ambushes and scouting, rapid deployment. Massed attacks. Assassinations? No.”

That made sense, of course - princesses were hard to kill without numbers or bombs. And an assassin strong enough to carry a bomb powerful enough to kill She-Ra wouldn’t be able to sneak anywhere. She remembered the bug princess from the Fright Zone and snorted.

“What’s so funny?” Lonnie asked.

“Just remembered a funny story,” Seacat replied as they entered the tent. The shrimp was there, Brain Boy, several Bright Moon officers, a few people who looked like they had lived in the wilderness for years, and...

“Adora!” A blonde woman rushed at them. “You’re back!” The Plant Princess.

“Hi, Perfuma. Didn’t Glimmer tell you we were back?”

“I did,” the shrimp said.

“Glimmer did,” the princess confirmed. “But it’s good to see you myself.”

“Ah.”

She didn’t have to hug Adora for so long, Seacat thought. She didn’t say anything, though. She noticed two women - two princesses - standing in the rear. “I’m Seacat. These are my crew, Alcy, Licy and Horas. And they are…”

“...they are our old squad. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio,” Adora cut in. “Sorry!” She blushed. “Perfuma, Netossa and Spinnerella,” she presented the other princesses. “General Juliet, Colonel Kris and, uh, Headranger Loran and his deputy, Ranger Nesta.”

“Plumeria didn’t have a standing army, so we had to improvise,” the Plant Princess explained. “Rangers were our guards, and so they’re our officers.”

“Ah.” Seacat didn’t really care about landlubber ranks. Not that she’d tell the person who supplied the entire Alliance with most of their food that.

“But we’re adapting. And I think it makes us stand out a little, so people won’t think all Plumeria does is provide food for the Alliance.”

Seacat nodded, trying not to look as guilty as she felt. Even if Plumeria’s food production was much, much more important than whatever soldiers they might send to fight.

The shrimp cleared her throat. “Anyway! Now that everyone’s here, let’s start.” She didn’t wait for a response and pointed at the map on the table in front of her. “This is our goal. The last base the Horde has on the river. We take it, and the river is ours - and their troops north-east of us are completely cut off. We’ve planned this with Mermista; we’ll attack from both sides at the same time. We’ll ship troops downriver on rafts that we’ll construct thanks to the machine we brought.”

“A machine?” the Plant Princess frowned. “I could grow rafts.”

“That would tire you out,” Adora told her. “And we can’t risk you being too tired to fight should we get attacked. They definitely have Headhunters at the base.”

And the rafts probably wouldn’t swim very well, in Seacat’s opinion. She doubted that the princess had any experience with ships and other vessels. “But you can grow some trees to be cut,” she told the Princess. “If that’s not too exhausting.”

“Oh, no, no - I can do that.”

“But as soon as we start constructing the rafts, the Horde will know what we’re up to,” the shrimp said.

“We’ll have to prepare the wood in advance before we start assembling the rafts,” Adora said. “Make them think we’re, uh, going to turn this into a fort?”

Brain Boy nodded. “That sounds like a good plan.”

Seacat nodded. “It won’t fool them for long, but any delay will help us. They have no gunboat, but they’ll place guns on the river as soon as they realise that we’re coming.”

“That will force us to either detour overland, run the guns or take them out,” Adora said. “We can’t detour; even a single battery could delay us long enough to jeopardise the entire operation.”

That made sense as well.

“But can we take them out quickly enough? We’d have to screen the whole southern shore of the river as we travel downriver - on land,” Brain Boy pointed out.

“Then we’ll have to gather a force on rafts to land under fire and take out any guns setting up,” Seacat said. “Or have them on skiffs following the river - on the southern shore. But that would keep them from retreating across the river if they are attacked by stronger forces.”

“Or a combination of both,” Adora said. “If we have our main screening forces on skiffs, we can quickly react. Reinforcements on rafts in case we need more forces.”

Seacat hid her scowl. That was a good plan - as expected from Adora. But it also meant She-Ra would be on point the whole time; everyone knew who would be on the skiffs: Princesses and select other outstanding soldiers. Such as Brain Boy.

And Seacat.

“So, we have experienced sailors here to handle the rafts,” Adora went on, nodding at Seacat, Alcy, Licy and Horas.

What? Oh, no, she couldn't! Seacat glared at her lover. She wouldn't be stuck on a raft while Adora was on the frontlines!

"Yes. Only four of them, but it'll have to do until we link up with the Salinean forces," the shrimp said.

Seacat swallowed her retort. The princess was, damn her, correct - they were here to help with shipping the troops downriver.

"You'll have to handle both the rafts transporting the bulk of our troops and the rafts with the reinforcements for the screening forces," the princess went on.

"I'll handle that. The reinforcement rafts," Seacat blurted out, glancing at everyone.

No one contradicted her. Adora frowned but didn't say anything. She'd better not say anything when she was going to travel by skiff - on the Horde side of the river! With other princesses!

"The Headhunters are ready for a raid," Lonnie spoke up. "They'll be ready for a small force on skiffs."

"Yes, we've trained for that," Kyle added. Then he blinked and ducked his head. "I mean, back when we were in the Horde."

"How many Headhunters are there?" Adora asked with a stern expression.

"There is supposed to be a company of Headhunters per regiment," Lonnie replied, "but you know that we - the Horde - never had their full complement in the field. So, it's usually half that. Multiply that with the number of regiments..."

"Unless they mass all companies," Kyle piped up. "Force Captain Crusher wanted all under his command to defend the river yards. He thinks the rest of the Horde is just cannon fodder."

"Yes," Lonnie confirmed. "Last we heard, they were gathering all Headhunters at the yards."

“That would mean the river’s only covered by regular Horde sc… soldiers.”

“The dregs of the service,” Seacat said.

“We can’t underestimate them,” Adora told everyone. “And it also means that when we reach the yards, we’ll be facing... “ She frowned for a moment. “...a regiment full of their best.”

“Unless more of them desert,” Lonnie said. “Not everyone in the Headhunters is ready to die for the Horde.”

That was only logical, Seacat knew. The best soldiers were often the brightest ones as well - and many of them would see the writing on the wall. Although… She narrowed her eyes. “All the Headhunters are being gathered at the yards?”

“Yes,” Lonnie scoffed. “I already said that.”

“But that means that they won’t be defending the approaches,” Seacat pointed out. “The Salineans could push through the rest on land, even without support by their frigates.”

“And the same goes for us,” Adora added, nodding.

“So why are they doing this? Headhunters are very mobile; they could harass the Alliance all the way to the yards,” Seacat asked. “They would gain more time for reinforcements that way.” It was as if they wanted the Alliance to hit the yards. “It’s a trap!”

“Mass your best forces in a good defensive position and let the enemy smash themselves to pieces attacking you, then counterattack them.” Adora nodded. “But we won’t be smashed or smash ourselves. Even if they have an entire regiment of Headhunters, we can beat them.”

“Yes. But they know that - they’ve lost enough battles,” the shrimp said. “I agree with Seacat: This is suspicious. Very suspicious.”

“They might not want to risk losing their best forces piecemeal,” the general pointed out. “Either of your columns could overwhelm a smaller force. And even on skiffs, they risk being cut off or crippled, then mopped up.”

“And they’ll have shorter and less vulnerable supply lines at the yards. Until we cut them off, of course,” Adora added.

“Well, if they don’t oppose us, we’ll be at the yards in a day,” Brain Boy said. “And then we’ll find out what they are planning.”

“And we’ll defeat them!” Adora added.

Everyone nodded. But none cheered, Seacat noted.

*****

“...and we were told to - taught to - stop to shoot, for added precision,” Lonnie explained while pointing at the swivel gun mounted on the skiff. “Three people per skiff, plus shells and powder.”

Seacat suppressed a yawn. That was pretty obvious. Unlike ships, skiffs could quickly stop and didn’t have to deal with waves or the currents of a river.

“We noticed that, yes,” Adora said. “But it’s good to have confirmation.”

“You can shoot on the move,” Kyle added, “as you’ve seen.” He pointed at the damaged steering sail of the skiff. “Canister shot is preferred, too.”

“We’ve also noticed that,” the shrimp said, rubbing her arm.

Kyle blushed. “Uh, sorry.” He tried to push back a box of canister shots back, slipped and almost fell off the skiff, but Rogelio caught him in time. “Sorry!”

“And what’s the supply situation?” the Plant Princess asked.

“We’ve got enough rations, but we’ve been short on powder,” Lonnie replied. “Too much went into the bombs floated down the river, they say. And into the bombs that wrecked our own lines.” She snorted. “There were even rumours that they were building catapults!”

“I’ve heard them myself!” Kyle protested. “And I saw the materials drawn from the depot!”

“Catapults?” General Juliet looked surprised. “They haven’t been used in years! If they’re building catapults, the Horde must be really short on powder.”

That would be good news.

“But how would they use catapults?” Adora asked. “Their ballistic arc makes them not very useful as field artillery - especially not against a mobile enemy. Are they planning a siege?”

“Or they plan to use them against us when we lay siege to their yards,” the shrimp said. “They could save on powder and still have some artillery for indirect fire. Not very precise, but they could target ships and a beachhead.”

“And when we charge, they have their guns,” Adora said.

Seacat shrugged. “They would have to be desperate. Entrapta thought of using catapults to shoot her anti-engine solution, but no one in Salinea had the needed expertise to use them effectively - as effectively as the design could be, anyway.”

“The Horde hasn’t been using catapults since the earliest part of the war,” Adora said. “They would have to train their crews just for this.”

“We’ve also heard rumours that the Horde called back the best artillerymen to the Fright Zone for ‘new training’,” Kyle told them.

“Their best?” The Shrimp shook her head. “They wouldn’t call their best back; they need them for the real guns. They could as

well take anyone and teach them how to use a catapult."

"Well, they did call them back!" Kyle protested. "Or so I've heard," he added, ducking his head at the shrimp's glare. "But the Force Captain was pretty angry about losing one of his best artillery crews."

"He recruited from the Headhunters?" Seacat asked.

"Yes." Kyle nodded, almost hitting his head against the beam of the sail behind him.

"Only one crew? That could be meant for training catapult crews from scratch," Seacat said. "Teach them indirect fire and how to call the shots."

"Or that's a disinformation ploy," Adora said. "They know that Horde soldiers have been deserting and switching sides for a while. They might want us to underestimate them."

"Yes," Brain Boy agreed. "If they have cannons in reserve, and we think they are out of powder..."

Seacat winced. That would wreck the operation. "Were there any other rumours?"

All three former Horde soldiers shook their heads. "Nothing out of the ordinary. Just the usual gossip," Lonnie said.

"Nothing?" Seacat frowned. Adora was looking worried now.

"Did you hear anything about new frigates being built?" Seacat asked. "Gunboats?"

"Who cares about the navy?" Lonnie shot back. "But, no, we didn't. Not since you took the crystal mines."

"But they're building gunboats!" Kyle piped up. "At the yards."

"Ah."

“That means we need to hurry so we can catch them before they use the gunboats against us,” Adora said.

“The Salinean ships can sink them, and we can board them,” Seacat said.

“And almost get killed by a shell,” Adora said with a frown.

Seacat frowned back. That had been one time. And bad luck. She wouldn’t make the same mistake again.

“Anyway, we should get a move on,” Brain Boy said. “We need as many rafts finished as possible by tomorrow.”

“We can save on the numbers needed if I carry seeds and grow our supplies in place,” the Plant Princess offered.

“That’s a good idea!” Adora agreed.

“As long as you don’t get taken out by the Headhunters,” Seacat pointed out. “Or we’ll be stranded without food.”

“Oh.” The princess hunched over a little. “I didn’t think of that.”

“It’s still very useful,” Adora said. “We’ll carry emergency rations and can save them for such an emergency. Enough to get back to this base, at least.”

“Right!” The princess was smiling again.

“Then let’s get started!” Adora said.

This time, there was cheering.

*****

The soldiers from Bright Moon and Plumeria weren’t sailors, but they knew their forest - and they knew how to cut and use wood. Coupled with Entrapta’s sawmill and the Plant Princess growing trees right into the mill, planks were quickly piling up.

“Looks like the glue’s going to be the bottleneck,” Seacat commented.

“We’re creating more of the stuff, but the Princess’ instructions were a little…” Alcy shrugged.

Seacat nodded. The princess was a genius. Unfortunately, she had a little trouble realising that not everyone was as smart as she was. Or knew as much about alchemy. “So, we might have to use ropes? Do we have enough?”

“Licy and Horas are checking the supplies.” Alcy hesitated a moment, then added: “I think we’ll actually be faster using ropes - the glue’s too dangerous for most.”

It wouldn’t be dangerous if those idiots would listen, of course. But what could you expect from landlubbers? “As long as the rafts don’t fall apart on the way, anything goes,” Seacat told Alcy. “And I want all-glued for my force.” She didn’t need a raft falling apart in the middle of a landing operation just because shrapnel sliced a rope. “Remind me to check how many of them know how to swim,” she added.

Alcy groaned. “I hope more of them know how to swim than the soldiers from the Kingdom of Snows.”

Seacat chuckled. Sure, it got so cold up north, odds were most sailors would freeze to death in the water before they could reach land or a boat, but that was no excuse for not learning how to swim. She blinked. “Oh. If ropes are a problem, see if the princess can grow some rope-like plants or something.”

Alcy nodded. “That’s a very good idea.” She glanced at the Plant Princess, who was conjuring up more trees.

“Provided she doesn’t exhaust herself,” Seacat said. She sighed. “I’ll talk to her.”

Alcy nodded, appearing to be relieved. The woman was still a little shy around the princesses, Seacat realised.

She walked the few dozen yards over to the sawmill. “Hey!”

“Seacat!” The princess beamed at her. “Is everything OK?”

“Plenty of planks, yes. We might run out of glue,” Seacat told her. “Or of people trained to use the glue.” They hadn’t had a serious glue accident yet, but it was probably just a question of time.”

“Oh.” The princess blinked. “Am I overdoing it?”

“No, no - we’re looking for ropes. They’ll do in a pinch, though we’ll be slower.”

“Oh! I can grow ropes!” She beamed at Seacat. “No problem!”

“Will they hold up in water?”

“Oh, yes. Plants love water!”

Ah. The princess meant living ropes… “As long as they don’t suddenly ensnare the passengers.”

“Oh, no, they won’t! But wouldn’t that be useful for cargo?”

“It would - but you’d be needed to unload every raft,” Seacat pointed out.

“Right.” The princess’s face fell. “That would be a bad thing if anything happened to me.”

“Anything happening to you would be a bad thing anyway,” Seacat told her.

“Of course. But letting down the Alliance would be worse. We need to help each other to win this terrible war.”

“Yes. But you’re already doing so much,” Seacat told her.

“I could do more, though.”

She suppressed a groan. The Plant Princess was as bad as Adora, it seemed. “No one’s being helped if you hurt or exhaust yourself.”

“I know! It’s just…” The princess sighed and wriggled her fingers, and a tree grew into the sawmill. “I want to do more.”

“Well, don’t overdo it. Please,” Seacat added. “We need you healthy and in good form.”

“I’ll do my best!”

That was what Seacat was afraid of. But she nodded. “Thank you.”

“How many ropes do you need?”

“We’ll see that when Licy and Horas are back and we’ll start assembling the rafts.”

“Alright!”

Seacat smiled, nodded, and returned to Alcy. “We should be good,” she told her. “Keep an eye on things - I’ll check up on Adora.”

Alcy smiled widely as she nodded. “Aye aye, First Mate!”

Seacat sighed. “Not like that.” But she was smiling as well. Everyone needed a break, and she was sure she could convince Adora to take one with her.

*****

Adora was, unsurprisingly, busy. Very busy - Seacat’s lover was bent over the planning table in the command tent and sketching on a map. A map of the Fright Zone, Seacat noticed when she cocked her head and took a closer look. “Hey, Adora! What are you doing?” she asked.

“What?” Adora looked up, blinking. “Oh.” A smile appeared on her face that managed to make even She-Ra look cute. “Uh... I’m making plans.”

“For an assault on the Fright Zone?” Seacat raised her eyebrows. That was quite the forethought. Although it was also very optimistic - they hadn’t even taken the yards yet, much less finished off the northern forces Horde.

“They’re contingency plans, you know,” Adora went on. “Just in case.” She nodded firmly with her jaw set.

“In case…?” Seacat tilted her head.

“In case we should end up invading the Fright Zone.”

Seacat sat down on the table - it was massive; her weight wouldn’t budge it at all - and took another look. “An invasion from the Whispering Woods.”

“Yes.”

“We’re east of them. And we’ll be far more east once we take the yards.”

“Yes. They are contingency plans.” Adora nodded even more firmly.

“In case we abandon our current operation?”

“Yes.”

“And withdraw to the Whispering Woods.”

“Yes.” Adora smiled. It looked more than a little forced.

“Should you plan our retreat to the Whispering Woods, first, in case the operation fails, and we cannot hold the river?” Seacat asked.

“I already made those plans.” Adora pointed at a few rolled-up maps on the side. More than a few, Seacat realised.

“How many contingency plans did you make?” Seacat counted half a dozen maps or scrolls.

“I like to be prepared,” Adora replied. “For everything. We can’t afford to be taken by surprise again.”

“Well, I say we need to be well-rested, or all the plans in Etheria won’t help us. That means you and I are taking a break, now!” It wasn’t as if most plans survived in the field, anyway.

“I can’t take a break! I need to prepare our operation!”

“Adora, you’ve been planning an offensive in case we scuttle the operation, abandon the river and attack - somehow - through the Whispering Woods. You can’t know what kind of forces we’ll have available for such a strike. You don’t know what the rest of the Horde will be doing.” Seacat leaned forward, her hands brushing some of Adora’s notes away, and faced her friend. “We’re taking a break.”

Adora opened her mouth to protest, but Seacat cut her off. “I can call the shrimp and make it an order.” Wait a minute. She frowned. “Where is the princess, anyway?”

“Uh… she’s inspecting the troops.”

“Ah. And she said you should keep making plans?” Seacat narrowed her eyes. If the shrimp had ordered this...

“Uh… She didn’t say I shouldn’t.”

Adora was a terrible liar. “She told you to take a break, didn’t she?”

“Uh… I took a break. Really.”

“For a few minutes?” Seacat shook her head. “We’re taking a real break. Get some food. We can look for something useful to do when you’re no longer trying to plan imaginary battles.”

“They aren’t imaginary!”

“Sure they aren’t.”

They walked over to the mess tent to grab some food. Seacat couldn’t help but whistle at the sight. So many fruits - fresh fruits! And fresh bread. No hardtack and lemon juice. Although… no fresh fish, either. And not as much meat, salted or not, as she was used to.

“Isn’t it great? And we owe it all to Perfuma!” Adora said, smiling as she loaded a plate with fruits and sweet bread.

“Yes. I knew she was more or less supplying the entire army, but to see it in action…” Seacat nodded and filled a plate with as many different dishes as she could manage. “This looks almost as good as the buffet at the Princess Prom.”

“Oh, no - there’s not much dessert, really,” Adora corrected her. “And not as much fish, either.”

“I noticed,” Seacat said. She also noticed that Adora must have been used to living with a princess if she was missing dessert in the field. “I hope Perfuma’s bodyguards are on the task.” If the Plant Princess was killed, the logistics of the Alliance would collapse.

Adora nodded. “Oh, yes. Perfuma doesn’t like it, but we have an entire company looking out for her in the field.”

Seacat snorted. “Let me guess: She wants to fight.”

“Uh… yes and no. Perfuma doesn’t like to fight, actually,” Adira explained between eating her snack. “But she doesn’t like not fighting when we’re fighting even more so.” She blinked. “Did I say that right?”

“I got what you mean,” Seacat told her. No fish, but the fruits were good. And the bread was good as well.

“Ah… good.” Adora kept eating, but she was fidgeting.

Seacat sighed. “Relax, Adora.”

“I can’t relax while everyone else is working so hard!”

“I’m relaxing here,” Seacat told her.

That earned her a glare. And a pout. “Everyone but you, then.”

“People take breaks. People need breaks. If you’re exhausted, you make mistakes.” And that could sink a ship, as the Captain had taught her.

“I’m She-Ra. I don’t get easily exhausted.”

Seacat leaned over the table and tapped her index finger on Adora’s forehead. “Your body might be tougher, but your brain? That’s pure Adora.”

“Hey!” More cute pouting.

Seacat suppressed the urge to grab Adora’s face and pull her in for a kiss. That wouldn’t have worked anyway - not when Adora was She-Ra. Too heavy. Too strong. Seacat grinned anyway. “If you can’t relax here, we might have to go take a nap.”

And now Adora was blushing. But her pout turned into a frown and then into a smirk. “I doubt that we would actually nap.”

“But we would relax,” Seacat countered.

And the blush returned. “I only have a tent here. Everyone would hear us.”

“You didn’t care about that last night.”

“That was… we weren’t in the middle of a camp, then!”

"Actually, we were in the middle of a camp. Just a small one," Seacat pointed out.

"That's… that's not the same! And we were surrounded by our friends! Not by… everyone!"

She was right, of course. Seacat didn't really give the entire army a show. But teasing Adora was fun - and helped relax her friend. Or at least distract her.

And Adora needed a distraction before she ran herself into exhaustion with busy work. As the Captain always said: A good sailor knew when to sleep. "Come on," Seacat told her, finishing her snack. "Let's find the princess and see what needs to be done."

*****

"Alright you scallywags! Get those rafts into the river, but tie them up first! I don't want to see anyone drifting downriver! If you lose a raft, I'll throw you in myself so you can swim after it and drag it back!" Seacat put both hands on her hips and yelled at the landlubbers lining up on the shore. She heard a few scattered laughs from the assembled soldiers, but they quickly died down when she glared at them. "Move it!"

"Seacat's in a bad mood today," she heard Alcy comment as the woman waved towards the first row of soldiers.

"She had to sleep in a tent in the middle of the camp," Licy replied.

"Ah. That would do it."

Seacat rolled her eyes. No, the fact that last night, she had only cuddled with Adora hadn't put her in a bad mood. Or shouldn't have.

But the delay in getting the rafts ready because some idiots glued themselves to the glue reserves? *That* had annoyed her. They had

to get a move on to reach the Horde yards on schedule or they would open themselves to defeat in detail. Fortunately, Perfuma had managed to compensate. As long as her living ropes held up in the river, they could still make it.

“You there!” she bellowed at a soldier in the second row, loud enough to carry through a storm. “Don’t fiddle with the ropes!”

Alcy and Licy had the first rafts in the water now, tied up to the improvised pier they had built. There, soldiers would board it. Seacat would’ve preferred if those who built the raft boarded it, so they would be motivated to take extra care, but that would’ve meant more instructions and more delays.

“Seacat!”

She turned. The shrimp had arrived, followed by Brain Boy. “We’ve started loading troops on the rafts,” she told them.

“I can see that,” the princess replied.

Of course she could see it. But you still reported. That was the way things were done on a good ship.

“Any problems so far?” Brain Boy asked.

“No one managed to drown yet,” she told him. “Not for lack of effort, though.”

The two others chuckled. Seacat snorted - she had only been half-joking.

“What about your force?” the shrimp looked around.

“We need the rafts to carry Adora’s force across the river, first,” she told them. “Those are our most stable rafts.” She had checked them personally.

“Ah.” The princess nodded.

Seacat suppressed a scowl. She should be with Adora, not on the river.

"How long until we're ready to move?"

"An hour, by my guess," Seacat replied. "And even then, we'll still be loading people on rafts. But the first rafts will have to move then."

"Ah."

"We've only been using ships for supplies so far, so we're not used to this," Brain Boy told her.

"I know." He didn't have to state the obvious. Anyone would know this after a glance at the pier. If those were her crew, she'd keelhaul the lot of them. "Form orderly lines, you misbegotten sons of squids!" she yelled.

Brain Boy looked surprised, but the princess giggled. "I'll have to remember that."

She snorted. Soldiers were like sailors. Some only moved when you cursed. "Any news from the east?" she asked.

"Nothing. So, we'll proceed according to schedule. As close to schedule as we can manage," the shrimp replied.

"We'll manage," Seacat told them. "Even if I have to personally drown anyone who's lagging, we'll be there on time."

Once more, the two laughed, but this time, she had been joking. Mostly.

If anything happened to Adora because of some idiot soldier not following orders… What was that noise? She turned and saw three skiffs driving towards them. Adora, Spinnerella and Netossa in the leading skiff, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle in their liberated gun-armed skiff, and behind them, bringing up the rear… a skiff with just a single pilot? That would be the shrimp and Brain Boy's skiff.

“Not going to comment about the commander of the entire force riding in the skiff on the enemy’s side?”

Seacat blinked. “Why would I? Admirals are on the bridge of their flagships, sailing straight at the enemy. Plus, you can teleport.” And she could save Adora if she had to.

“That’s refreshing,” the shrimp told her with a smirk aimed at Brain Boy. “Some people didn’t want me near the frontlines at all.”

“I just mentioned that it’s more difficult to command an army if you’re fighting a skirmish,” the boy told her.

“General Juliet has my full trust.” The shrimp scoffed and crossed her arms. “Seacat understands!”

“We’re not at sea.”

“We’re on a river running a convoy. That’s almost the same,” the princess retorted.

“Hey, Seacat!”

“Hey, Adora!”

Adora jumped off the skiff and quickly joined them. “So, how’s it going?”

“We’re going to be on schedule,” Seacat told her.

“Mostly,” Brain Boy butted in.

“We’re going to be on schedule,” she repeated herself with a glare. “So get on your skiff and get going! We have an army to ship downriver!”

“Uh, right.” Brain Boy climbed onto their skiff.

“So…” Adora shifted her feet.

Seacat sighed, then grabbed her for a hug. “Don’t do anything foolish,” she whispered.

“Same for you,” Adora told her. And squeezed.

Very tightly. “Bit… tight…” Seacat managed to say.

“Oh, sorry!” Adora released her. “I didn’t…”

“I know. Just… don’t die.”

“I’m She-Ra!”

She narrowed her eyes at her friend.

Adora caved. “I won’t die.”

“You better not.”

“So, can we get a move on? We need to ship those skiffs over to the other side!” the shrimp butted in.

“Glimmer!” Brain Boy blurted out.

“What? It’s true! We’re on a schedule.”

“Right.” Seacat laughed. “Let’s get you over the river.”

And then they would be on their way to the Horde yards. The next step to winning this war.

*****

The River Offensive Part 4

"Watch it!" Seacat yelled. "There's rougher water ahead! Make sure you won't fall overboard! Don't stand up!"

She looked over her shoulder to check if the landlubbers with her were obeying. Their 'ship' was just three rafts tied together, so you would have to be a damned fool to treat it as a real ship - but as she found out while loading half an army on rafts, there was no shortage of such fools among the soldiers of Bright Moon and Plumeria. Unlike Salinean marines, they had no experience with ships and tended to see rivers as larger brooks, which meant they severely underestimated the dangers when they were travelling on water.

At least the few dozen soldiers with her were supposed to be the best of the bunch, but that often came with arrogance, which was about as dangerous as foolishness for a soldier. Or for the people relying on them.

She glanced to the southern shore. She couldn't see Adora, nor any sign of the three skiffs of the screening force, but she hadn't heard any shots being fired, either. That meant they weren't fighting. Unless… a catapult was silent compared to a cannon. The sound of its release wouldn't carry far. But would they manage to hit a moving skiff? Much less three of them?

No. Seacat firmly shook her head, but she couldn't help worrying a little anyway.

Then they reached the rougher waters, and she was busy keeping the raft on course. It wasn't an actual challenge, of course - if it were, the army following them was doomed. But still… keeping the raft stable so the idiots with her wouldn't panic required some care and attention. Some.

But they cleared the spot quickly, and the river slowed down and smoothed out. If not for the danger of a Horde ambush, it would

be a pleasant trip. Sunny weather, a light breeze, fresh food… Seacat had had worse trips.

She looked back. The main convoy - if a bunch of rafts could be called that - would be hitting the spot any time now. Yes, there they came. Alcy was handling the first raft, and she had things under control. And the soldiers were sitting and holding on to the ropes and other handhelds on the rafts. As they should be.

But just as Seacat was about to turn away, she spotted some fool standing up and going after… something rolling the raft. She squinted as the thing fell into the water. What idiot would…?

"Sit down!" Alcy yelled, but it was too late - the man stumbled, the raft wobbled, and he went overboard, his scream cut short as soon as he hit the water. Seacat hissed and kicked the rudder, slowing down her raft. "Look out for the idiot in the water," she snapped. He would be surfacing any moment now…

But the man didn't come up. Damn.

"Where is he?" the sergeant in charge of the Bright Moon forces with her asked.

"I don't see him," Seacat told her. "He wasn't wearing armour, so he shouldn't sink. Unless he hit his head somewhere. Or came up under a raft and was pushed underwater again."

"Maybe he couldn't swim."

Right. Some of those landlubbers couldn't swim. She clenched her teeth. There wasn't much they could do. Not much she could do. She could slow the raft, but to paddle upriver? No chance. And the current would've dragged the idiot away by now.

Damn. "Let's hope that'll teach the rest not to stand up when they're in rough water," she muttered. "Damn fool."

The soldiers nearby glared at her, but she ignored them. The man had been a fool. Alcy had given strict commands, and the idiot

hadn’t listened.

What a waste.

“If we only lose one soldier, we’re lucky,” she told the soldiers. “The idiot could’ve caused the raft to capsize, throwing everyone on it into the water.”

“What?” Even the sergeant was now looking at their raft as if it might sink any moment.”

“Well, it wouldn’t have been easy - but if he had resurfaced, screaming, and the entire load had gone to one side to pull him in…” She shook her head. “That might do it.”

And the landlubbers definitely were stupid enough for such a thing to happen. That was why she had sent Horas with Perfuma. He was massive enough to rebalance a raft by himself - and he could throw a fool or three overboard if he had to.

Perfuma would disagree, but the princess was worth dozens of those fools.

*****

Around noon, Seacat heard shots. Swivel guns. Horde ones or captured ones used by Lonnie and the others. “Look sharp!” she yelled. “We’ve got company!”

She couldn’t see whoever was shooting, though - as had happened often, Adora and the others were hidden behind the forest that lined the riverbank at this point. But the shots had been fired ahead of them.

She scoffed and guided her raft closer to the shore. “Sergeant!” she snapped. “Take five soldiers and scour the riverbank ahead of us. I don’t want to run into an ambush.”

“Yes, ma’am! Bonetti, Greo, Lars, Kepel, Anna - with me!” the woman bellowed.

The five the sergeant had named groaned but were ready to jump on the shore as soon as Seacat manoeuvred close enough. They weren't Salinean marines, but close enough.

She pressed her lips together as the soldiers started moving through the forest. She should be leading them, not staying on the raft. But no one else could steer the vessel as well as she could. And if they came under fire, an inexperienced helmsman could doom the entire force.

She still hated it. "Brad!" she yelled. "Stick the pole in at the stern! We need to hold back a little so we won't overtake the others!"

"Aye aye, ma'am!"

She swallowed the rebuke - the man wasn't a sailor. "Reta! Signal the main force to slow down! Combat ahead!"

"Yes, ma'am!" The goatwoman quickly started waving her flags. Again, not quite as deft as a signals ensign in the Navy - or Seacat herself - would have been, but good enough. Seacat had certainly seen worse on some frigates.

One she saw that Alcy had slowed down, she gave the go-ahead to go on. They couldn't let the landing party get too far ahead either, or they would be left without support.

They entered the next turn of the river - a northward one, the river snaking around a hill on its route eastward. That was an ideal ambush spot - forest to conceal a gun, and the turn meant they could be sailing right into the firing arc of a gun but be too far away to rush it.

And the swivel guns ahead hadn't stopped firing. That wasn't a mere scouting force - Adora could have crushed such a force by herself. That was a skirmishing group; if it were a larger force, Adora would've sent the shrimp to inform them.

They advanced slowly, Seacat pushing a pole into the riverbed to counteract the current. She could catch glimpses of the advance

party as they approached the turn. Was that movement ahead of them?

Her eyes widened as something reflected the sun in the middle of a bush. “Hold on!” she yelled and pushed the raft to the side, away from the shore.

A moment later, a gun fired and a shell ploughed into the river next to the raft - then detonated underwater. “Hold on!” Seacat yelled, digging her claws into the raft’s deck as the shockwave pushed them up. She heard screams from the soldiers as the raft tilted before falling back, then even more screams followed by splashes.

Snarling, she steered the raft back towards the riverbank. “Everyone off!” she yelled.

“We’ve got people in the water!”

“And we’ll be dead if we don’t get on land!” she bellowed. “Off the raft! And charge that position! Brad! Tie it off!”

Everyone in her force could swim, anyway. Or should be able to. They hit the shore, and she grabbed a line, then jumped off and secured the line to the next tree. Unfortunately, Brad wasn’t fast enough - he didn’t manage to tie up the raft’s stern before it swung out, dragging him into the water.

The slower soldiers, those who hadn’t been able to jump on land, cried out, and two more fell into the water. “Hold on!” Seacat yelled. “The raft’ll hit the shore again!”

But before the raft could turn around fully, the gun fired again.

And half a dozen soldiers on the raft were blasted to pieces by shrapnel.

Seacat turned to look at the gun. At that distance, with this reloading rate… “Get them out of the water! Get the wounded!” she screamed.

And started to sprint through the woods. If she pushed herself, she could reach the gun before they could reload.

She dashed between the trees, jumping on and to branches at a particularly thick spot, and quickly overtook the landing party. “Follow me!” she yelled, rushing past the sergeant, jumping and clearing a dense patch of underbrush before scrambling up a tree leaning over the water, launching herself towards another tree.

Her claws found purchase on a thick branch, and she used her momentum to swing around it and land on her feet on top of it. Almost. She could see the gun from this spot - they were just ramming the powder charge into it.

Too close. She clenched her teeth and launched herself towards the next tree. And the next. And the next.

One of the Horde scum manning the gun spotted her and cried out in alarm. But she was too close. Too fast. One more tree, then she pounced, claws extended, down on the gun captain.

The woman raised her shock rod, but Seacat batted it aside with a kick before slamming into the officer and smashing her into the ground - away from the gun. She rolled with the impact, tumbling over the ground, and came up in a crouch, baring her fangs at the Horde scum.

The gun crew was turning towards her, one of them reaching for the gun, but Seacat was still faster. She dashed forward, one foot hitting the groaning officer’s head before the woman could react. She shattered the faceplate and raked her with the other foot, then brought her blade down on the sailor’s arm before he could fire the cannon.

He screamed, clutching his ruined arm, and collapsed on his knees as she whirled. She parried a strike from a burly man with a ramrod, then gutted the scum with a swipe of her free hand. Another came at her, screaming like a madwoman, but Seacat

ducked away from the first wild blow and slid around her, then slashed at her knees from behind.

One more Horde scum down. That left two of the gun crew. And...Damn! There were more Horde scum coming at her through the woods. Seacat jumped on top of the gun, kicking out to knock the second loader down and into the water, before whirling and slashing her sword across the face of the lizardman trying to catch her from behind. If she could turn the gun around and face the oncoming Horde… No. It was too heavy. And the sergeant's party wouldn't reach her in time.

But there was the ammo dump! All those shells and powder bags! She grinned as she grabbed a fuse and a match.

She lit the fuse, dropped it, and jumped into the water, past the groggy loader dragging herself out of the river. Seacat dived, scraping over the ground, the pebbles scratching her skin as she pushed herself further. The fuse wouldn't burn long… and she needed to be as deep under the water as possible before…

Something hit the water next to her, slamming into the ground and throwing up a cloud of mud. She looked over her shoulder and up and saw dozens of pieces splashing into the water. Wooden splinters. And metal ones. And body parts. The powder had gone up, then.

She kicked her feet, swimming deeper, as more and more pieces hit the river and sank - or shot - into the water around her. None touched her - and the water would slow them down anyway.

But she couldn't hold her breath much longer. She pulled her legs under her, brought the feet down into the mud covering the riverbed, then pushed and shot towards the surface.

She broke it and inhaled deeply, looking around. Smoke still covered the spot where she had set off the powder charges, but she could see more Horde soldiers moving in the woods nearby.

More than enough to overwhelm the marines in the advance party.

And the river's current was dragging her away, around the turn. Had the Horde scum seen her? She couldn't tell. But she had to return to the shore.

She took a deep breath and dived again, swimming underwater towards the riverbank. She didn't surface until she could see the riverbed rising in front of her - she was almost at the shore. If anyone had seen her… She resurfaced again to breathe and take a look.

No one shot at her - no bolts or arrows flew towards her. No one yelled, either. They must have missed her.

Or they were waiting in ambush for her to expose herself by coming out of the water.

She scoffed. The soldiers she had killed hadn't been good enough to think of something, much less pull it off. Not with reinforcements bearing down on them from upriver. She dived again, swam forward, then climbed out of the water behind an overhanging tree.

Still no one - but she heard yells and commands ahead of her. Unless her men had been far slower than they should've been, they would be hitting the enemy right now.

Once more, she climbed the closest tree, her claws quickly taking her up into the canopy. Hidden by the foliage, she could see more people moving alongside the shore - both Horde scum as well as Alliance soldiers - and clashing near the former gun emplacement.

Perfect.

She turned, then ran down the angled trunk, jumping off in the middle of it. She hit the ground running and weaved through the forest towards the battle ahead of her, drawing her blade.

The Horde scum were still trying to form lines but the underbrush hampered their movement. She caught a straggler from behind, slashing her neck and left her bleeding out while she ran past. There was a lizardman stuck in a denser bush - his uniform had gotten entangled with a thicker branch. He turned towards her and snapped. “Help me, damn it…”

She saw his eyes widen when he realised that she wasn’t another Horde soldier. He opened his mouth, gasping, about to scream, and she stuck her blade through his mouth, turning his attempt to warn the others into a short gagging noise before he fell over, blood gushing out of his mouth.

She was already running forward again when she heard someone yelling: “Stand! Stand and hold!”

That sounded like an officer. She bared her fangs in a feral grin and changed direction towards the man. Dodging behind a tree, she almost ran over a Horde straggler hiding there. The woman gasped, staring at her with wide-open eyes.

Seacat cut her down before she could warn the others. And kept going. She jumped over a fallen trunk, then scaled a tree - and saw the officer still screaming at his troops, many of them apparently giving ground under the assault of the Bright Moon and Plumerian soldiers.

For a moment, she hesitated. The man was surrounded by half a dozen soldiers, one of them holding a flag. Attacking him would be dangerous. But the Alliance forces were obviously advancing, and if the Horde soldiers lost their leader at this point, when they were falling back under pressure…

She hissed and dashed forward on the thickest branch of the tree, then jumped off, gripping her blade with both hands - and brought it down on the officer with all her weight behind it.

Her sword bit into the man’s shoulder - he had moved at the last moment - but it didn’t matter; the force behind the blow was

enough to drive it through most of his chest. He jerked, then started to fall in a shower of blood. And Seacat found her sword stuck. Caught on the chest plate, or a rib or whatever.

And the soldiers around her were reacting. She ducked under a wild swing with a shock rod and kicked the soldier in the stomach, pushing him into the way of another who stumbled over him. But before she could exploit that or free her sword, she had to jump back to avoid a spear thrust, then drop when a goatman tried to decapitate her.

She rolled over the ground, slashing his ankles with her claws, and came up… to drop down again and scramble to the side to avoid two shock rods and another spear. She cut the spear shaft with her claws, then jumped, pouncing on the suddenly disarmed soldier. One swipe with her claws shattered his faceplate and left him clutching his slashed face, and she jumped off his falling body, launching herself towards the closest tree...

...and was hit in the side and smashed to the ground by the Minotaur wielding the flagpole. She tried to roll with the impact, but her ribs burned with pain, and she gasped, freezing for a moment.

Three soldiers were charging her, howling like madmen. She hissed at them - and counter-charged. Two faltered; the third pressed on, and his spear traced a bloody line across her already wounded side when she was a little too slow to dodge.

But now she was inside his reach, and before he could react, she lashed out with both arms and raked her claws across his arm and throat. She grabbed the spear and whirled - and barely managed to bring it up to parry a sword strike. The blade cut deep into the shaft, but not through it, and she twisted the spear, wrenching the stuck sword out of the Horde soldier’s hands.

But more were pressing her. She threw the spear and sword at the legs of the closest soldier, making him jump back and collide

with another, then lunged to bury her claws into the side of the disarmed soldier.

He screamed like a stuck pig and stumbled back, and she whirled again. “Who’s next?” she snapped, baring her fangs.

For a moment, the Horde soldiers were frozen. Looking at each other, not at her. They were breaking…

Then something hit her left shoulder, forcing her back and almost sending her falling. Crossbow bolt. Stuck in her. Rendering her left arm useless. The sheer pain made her hiss.

Worse: Her getting hit had rallied the Horde soldiers. They were charging her.

The tree was too far away. Her arm was useless. She was bleeding.

She charged them, hissing and screaming. One of them gasped, slowing down. Another stumbled over a root. The other two kept coming at her. She ran on, eyes on the man with the shock rod. He lifted his rod, ready to strike, and she dropped, sliding over the torn ground, into his legs.

Her shoulder made her scream with pain, but she reached up with her good hand, claws extended, and ripped through the inside of his thigh and into his groin.

He collapsed with a shriek that was heard through the forest - and was cut off when the other Horde soldier hit him instead of Seacat with her sword.

Seacat pushed the wounded scum off and launched herself at the woman, her right arm reaching for the Horde scum’s sword arm before the woman could raise her blade again. Grabbing the wrist, she twisted and rammed her hip into the enemy, then pulled - and slammed her into the ground.

Another crossbow bolt flew past her, and she ducked, then dropped on her back and rolled over her good shoulder to avoid the clumsy Horde soldier who had managed to get up. The one who had hesitated was gone, his weapon on the ground.

She jumped up, kicked the woman she had thrown in the face, then charged the crossbow shooter. His eyes widened, and he fumbled his weapon, then dropped it to draw his sword.

But he only managed to get his hand on its hilt before she reached him, raking her claws against his sword arm, then ramming him with her good shoulder and smashing him against the tree behind her.

His head was thrown back, and she ripped his throat out on the backswing while she whirled to face the last Horde scum.

Who was fleeing.

For a moment, Seacat stood there, chest heaving, blood from her and others running down her front. The bolt was still stuck in her shoulder. The pain was terrible, but if she pulled it out, she'd bleed. A lot. Damn.

Looking around, she saw more Horde scum running - away. Past her. And the yelling and sounds of combat were coming closer. Good. But if she got caught in the melee when the Alliance soldiers arrived… She looked at the tree. She could climb it. Even without one arm.

Then she heard screams and yelling from the other side. And saw Horde scum running back towards her. Gritting her teeth, she dug her claws into the trunk and started scaling it, trying to ignore the pain every movement caused in her shoulder. But she had to clear the ground or she'd be caught between… well, everyone.

She reached the lowest branch and groaned as she pulled herself up on it to rest. Just a moment. Her shoulder… She hissed as she touched the shaft of the bolt and felt the blood dripping down.

And she had to climb higher - anyone with a crossbow could pick her off where she was. She just had to…

Below her, the Horde scum retreating from the Alliance soldiers clashed with the others running from whoever had gotten into their rear. Oh. That's where Adora and the others had gone. She should've realised that.

Scoffing at her slow mind, she started to climb higher. Just another branch. Then she could rest and hide and wait.

By the time she was sprawled out on the next branch, limbs pulled up, the fighting had reached the tree. She turned her head and glanced down. The Horde soldiers were getting massacred. They were trying to escape into the river now, but their armour wasn't good for swimming. And Seacat doubted that they would have the time to strip out of it.

"Stand! Hold! Damn you!"

Oh. One officer - no, a squad leader - tried to rally the Horde. To make a stand. But an arrow hit her head before she could say anything else. Then Adora appeared, throwing a Horde lizardman at a clump of soldiers hiding near a tree.

"For the Alliance!" she yelled as the Horde scattered, raising her sword. "Forward!"

Damn, she looked hot like that! Really hot. For a moment, even Seacat's shoulder didn't seem to hurt as much.

Then she shifted a little and gasped with pain. Damn. At least the tree below was now surrounded by Alliance soldiers.

"Hey, Adora!"

"Ca-Seacat?" Adora looked around.

"Up here, you dummy!" Seacat giggled, then winced.

“Seacat!” Adora’s smile only lasted a moment before turning into a horrified expression. “You’re wounded!”

“Yes. Crossbow got me in the shoulder,” Seacat told her. “I got him and the commander of this lot but had to hide afterwards. Give me a moment to climb down.”

But Adora was already climbing - or jumping - up the tree. “Seacat!”

“It’s not that…” Seacat stopped trying to defend herself in favour of holding on to the branch when Adora, all seven feet of her, landed on it and sent it shaking so much, it almost threw Seacat off.

“Oh, no! I’m so stupid!”

“Well, no argument from me,” Seacat said, flashing her fangs in a grin.

Adora shook her head and didn’t answer. Instead, she bent down and picked her up.

Seacat tried and failed not to wince when she was lifted off the branch into bridal carry.

“You’re badly hurt!”

Well, yes, that should’ve been obvious. “And you’re going to jump down with me?” Seacat clenched her teeth. That would hurt.

“Of course not! Glimmer! Glimmer!”

The shrimp appeared a few moments later next to them in a shower of sparkles. “Oh, no!”

Seacat closed her eyes and sighed. She wasn’t *that* hurt. “I beat half a dozen Horde soldiers like that,” she snapped at the princess. “And then climbed the tree.”

But no one was listening to her. The shrimp reached out and grabbed her hand, and a moment later, all three of them were on the ground.

"I'm going to heal you!" Adora declared. "Just a second!" She looked around.

"Just drop me on the ground. I'll live," Seacat mumbled. "The battle's still going on." She could hear the sounds of people fighting. And dying.

Once more, no one listened to her. Adora kicked a corpse out of the way and set her down on some moss at the foot of a tree, then took a step back. "Uh… I need to get the bolt out, or it might… mess up the healing."

"Just do it," Seacat told her. She could take it.

Adora grimaced. "Glimmer? Can you pull it out? So I can heal her right away?" She levelled her sword at Seacat.

The shrimp grimaced but nodded. "Sure."

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Just Do iAAAGH!" The bloody shrimp had done it!

But the pain vanished at once. Seacat closed her eyes, relieved.

"Now stay here - we'll finish the fight! You!" Adora bellowed as she pointed at a soldier nearby. "Watch her! Don't let her engage anyone! And protect her with your life!"

The Alliance soldier - a Plumerian ranger, Seacat noticed - nodded a little shakily. Seacat snorted - when Adora was like that, there was no arguing.

Then Adora left, followed by the princess - on foot, not teleporting. Saving her magic for essential tasks since she wouldn't be able to recharge until she returned to Bright Moon.

And the princess had teleported once - no, twice - for Seacat.

She sighed. If she hadn't climbed the tree, that wouldn't have been necessary. But if she hadn't climbed the tree, she might've been killed. She wouldn't have had to climb the tree if she hadn't been wounded, of course. But they were fighting a war - you couldn't play it safe. Not too safe, at least.

She turned to face her freshly appointed guard. "How was the fighting going before…" She shrugged. "...before all this?"

"We had them on the run," he replied. "They were trying to flee through the river or overland, but we had them encircled, so all that left was the river."

She nodded. That fit with her observations.

"We've beat their blocking force! They couldn't stop us!" the ranger added with a smile as if this was a great victory.

"We were facing the dregs of the Horde," she corrected him. "They broke easily. When we're facing their best, things will be much harder." Soldiers trained to fight princesses wouldn't break easily - or at all.

He didn't like that. "But we have She-ra and the Princesses with us!"

"And the Horde is prepared for them." She snorted again. "Don't underestimate them."

"But they weren't prepared for us, not here."

She shrugged, half-wincing when the expected pain didn't come. "Their leaders didn't expect them to win; at best, they were meant to delay us. They had a single gun on the river and not enough troops to hold our forces, much less the entire army."

"But why sacrifice them like that?"

"To gain time for more training and preparations. To make us feel overconfident." She shrugged again. "Perhaps their commander wanted to get rid of a rival?"

He looked shocked at the last suggestion. "But… their own troops?"

"They blow them up for a chance to get a princess," she reminded him. "In the Horde, soldiers are expendable. Everyone is. With the exception of Hordak."

He shook his head. "That's…"

"That's why we're fighting them." She leaned against the tree and crossed her arms.

"*We* aren't fighting them right now." He sounded mulish.

"We've got our orders." She grinned. "You'll get your fill of fighting soon enough." And then some. For a Plumerian, he was rather eager to fight - but that could just be the effect of running into battle with your friends and driving the enemy off.

"I suppose so."

And Seacat would get her lecture from Adora. She wasn't looking forward to it. And she still needed to recover her sword.

*****

"...and what were you thinking, attacking the enemy by yourself?" Adora shook her head, hands on her hip.

"I didn't attack the enemy on my own," Seacat defended herself. "I attacked a single gun and its crew to save the rest of my soldiers, and then I took out an enemy commander and a few of his guards."

"The enemy commander, surrounded by his best soldiers!" Adora shook her head. "That was… That was reckless!"

“And necessary,” she retorted. “He was rallying the troops.”

“And you were alone and almost died! Ca-Seacat!”

Being snippy and telling her lover that almost only counted with artillery shells wouldn’t be a good idea. Seacat bit her lower lip. “That was bad luck. But I had to take out the gun, and then I saw the leader before they saw me. And I saw the opportunity to decapitate the enemy forces, as Mermista would call it.”

“You almost died!”

“Sorry.”

“You better be sorry!”

But others had actually died. Soldiers Adora hadn’t been able to heal.

Neither of them mentioned that.

“Well, we need to continue our trip,” Seacat said instead. “We need to make landfall by nightfall.” Otherwise, the operation would be delayed at best. Ruined at worst.

Adora slowly nodded, then reached out and grabbed her. Hugged her.

“Never do this again,” Seacat heard her whisper. “Promise me.”

She hugged her back, but she didn’t promise. She couldn’t. And Adora knew it.

*****

Getting the convoy going again in a semblance of order took longer than the battle had lasted, even including the time spent looking for wounded and prisoners. And there were a lot of empty spots on Seacat’s rafts, even with Adora healing the wounded. A few of them were soldiers who hadn’t been able to swim as well

as they had claimed. But most had been killed by the gun ambush.

Morale was high, though - most soldiers didn't seem to realise that the Horde troops had been pushovers. Seacat wondered, privately, if this was the result of the Horde concentrating their best troops in a few elite companies. If there had been a few more officers and sergeants rallying the others, a few more soldiers holding the line instead of panicking...

"I don't know if the Horde's new strategy is working for them," she muttered.

"Pardon?" the sergeant - she had been wounded, but healed - asked from behind her as their raft drifted down the river.

"They pulled out their best troops from the line companies to form the Headhunters," Seacat explained. "That left the regulars without their best soldiers and officers. Easy to break."

"Ah." The sergeant shrugged. "They were easy to break before as well - at least when the princesses took to the field."

Seacat nodded. Of course, Horde scum wouldn't last long when facing Adora and her friends. And if you were losing the soldiers anyway, then pulling out their best troops and forming the Headhunters was a sensible if cold tactic. Better to concentrate their best troops and have a chance of killing princesses than losing both their regular and their veteran soldiers for no gain.

It was hard on the regulars, of course. But then, if they were doomed either way… She shook her head and muttered a curse. She had almost been killed by those 'easily broken' troops, after all. Numbers did count, and if soldiers thought there was no way out anyway… "In any case, our next battle will be hard," she said.

"The Headhunters?"

She nodded. "They'll be waiting for us at the yards."

“They’re going for the princesses first,” one of the soldiers on her raft said. “Not for us.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes at the mothwoman. “We’ll be right next to the princesses. We’re the vanguard.”

The sergeant frowned. “You think they’ll send Headhunters to stop us?”

Seacat nodded. “If they want to stop us from linking up with the Sallinean forces, they have to send their best.”

“They could stop the Salineans instead!” the mouthy soldier added.

Seacat snorted. “Good luck stopping one or two frigates.”

“But the Salineans only have two princesses, and one of them doesn’t fight,” the mothwoman retorted. “We have five! They’re the easier target!”

Seacat scoffed. “Have you ever seen a Salinean frigate? Twenty guns per broadside, and swivel guns and carronades on top of that! The Horde would need dozens of field guns to equal them - and the Salineans have the better gunners.”

The mothwoman looked stubborn. “But they have only one princess, and she’s limited to water.”

“We’re on a river,” Seacat told the dumbass. “That’s ideal for Mermista’s powers. And Entrapta is a genius. Her bots fight for her.”

“We’ve dealt with bots before. They’re worse than the regular Horde soldiers.”

The mothwoman was starting to piss her off. “You haven’t dealt with her bots.” Seacat glared at the woman. “I’ve fought at the sides of Princess Glimmer and She-Ra as well as Mermista and

Entrapta. And I've fought at sea. The Salineans aren't the easy target you think they are."

"Shut your mouth, you fool," the sergeant growled. "And don't try to lecture veterans."

"Yes, sergeant," the mothwoman replied, ducking her head. But Seacat's ears picked up her muttered "dumb cat", and she had to suppress the urge to kick the woman into the river.

This trip couldn't end soon enough.

*****

They reached their destination with a few hours delay. Instead of late in the afternoon, they arrived at the area surrounding the Horde yards early in the evening. "Signal the convoy to hold!" Seacat ordered.

"If we wait too long, it'll be night before we can disembark the troops," the sergeant said.

"We're close to the yards. If we start disembarking troops and the Horde hits us with fast troops and artillery…" Seacat shook her head.

"We've got the princesses protecting our flanks!" dumbass chimed in.

"They won't be able to keep us safe if the Horde sends their Headhunters after us," Seacat replied. The Headhunters would have their best guns and gunners, too. They could spread out and set up to shell whatever beachhead the troops established - from too far to be easily dislodged. And Seacat would bet half her pay that the Headhunters would be lying in ambush for any force trying to go after the guns.

"If we're fast enough, we can push them back!" the idiot added.

"Are you faster than a skiff?" Seacat retorted.

“We have skiffs ourselves.”

“We can’t spend the night on the rafts,” the sergeant pointed out.

“We need to scout the area before we can land troops,” Seacat said. “Let’s get closer to the…”

Shots interrupted her order. Horde guns.

“Not again,” she muttered. What had Adora blundered into now?

“Signal to the convoy to disembark the troops on the northern shores!” she snapped. “We’ll land on the southern shore and see how we can support the princesses!”

Cheers answered her - first and foremost, and closest to her, the dumbass’s.

“And signal to Alcy to prepare three rafts to evacuate skiffs and send them over!” Seacat added.

“Do you think we’ll have to retreat?” the Sergeant asked.

“If we’re facing the entire force of the Headhunters?” Seacat scoffed. They would be lucky to escape.

Then they reached the shore, and she jumped off. “Tie them up and form a perimeter!” she yelled. “I’m going to take a look up top.”

She didn’t wait for anyone to acknowledge her order and ran up the slope of the riverbank. She had to check on Adora. And the others.

*****

The River Offensive Part 5

Seacat reached the top of the slope and immediately dropped to the ground, then crawled up the last yard. She could see a dozen skiffs racing across the small plain between two hills and a forest, swivel guns barking as they spread out. Headhunters. And they were chasing three skiffs which were trying to avoid being surrounded and cut off.

Cursing under her breath, she considered the situation. The forces with her had no guns, not even a swivel gun - an oversight, but they were meant to be a landing force to charge enemy positions at the river, not a siege force, so artillery wouldn't have been of much use. And charging on foot against mobile skiffs? That would be a massacre.

On the other hand, if the skiffs set up on top of the slope, they could shoot at the rafts below - and once they set up actual field artillery, things would turn into a massacre as well. So, she couldn't help Adora and the others. She couldn't even signal them - and if she could, odds were that the enemy would spot her waving flags first. Adora might not even notice, what with the Horde skiffs harassing her. That left…

She bared her fangs and yelled down to the beach: "I need oil up here! We need smoke!"

A minute later, the sergeant led five soldiers up the slope carrying casks of oil. The dumbass was among them, alas. "Set the top of the slope on fire!" she snapped. "We need cover for the evacuation!"

She glanced at the river. Three rafts were making their way over to their shore. But they were still several minutes out. Damn.

"Greo! Spread the oil on the eastern side! Lars, western side! The rest, fill the area between! Leave this spot clear!" the sergeant barked before moving to Seacat's side. "What're we going to do?"

“We need to evacuate the princesses,” Seacat told her. “And they need to know where we are.”

“Ah. Set it on fire!” the woman yelled.

The wind would push the smoke over the river. That was good for hiding them but bad for embarking troops, especially skiffs. “We might have to leave the skiffs,” she said.

“If they even make it to us,” the sergeant commented as shots struck one of the skiffs - not Adora’s - and it veered off, slowing down. Damn.

Two Horde skiffs closed in, but one was driven off - no, toppled - by a hurricane, and the other suddenly veered off, a net entangled around its steering sail. But more Horde skiffs were appearing on the hill to the east, racing towards the battle. And Adora’s skiff was turning, as was Lonnie’s.

Seacat cursed again. Had they missed the smoke? No, the damaged skiff was slowing down - probably a hit to the hull had damaged it too much. Yes. The two princesses and the pilot were jumping on board Adora’s skiff. But six people on a single skiff was too much. Even four was pushing it. They would be too slow, and there were more Horde skiffs closing in… No! She wouldn’t…

She would! Adora jumped off and charged the closest skiff!

“That bloody idiot! I’m going to kill her!” Seacat yelled.

At least the two skiffs were now headed towards the river - straight towards them.

But so were half a dozen Horde skiffs.

“Everyone up here!” Seacat yelled. “Be ready along the slope! We need to jump them once they reach the top of the slope!”

The soldiers with her, even dumbass, obeyed. The others down at the shore were slower, but started running up the slope after a

moment.

But would they be in time? Three Horde skiffs were moving to intercept the others. One of them was seen off by a well-placed canister shot from Lonnie, but the other two… One fired, a shell, blowing a hole into Lonnie's steering sail, the other… crashed into the first thanks to a net and hurricane combination.

That opened a hole for the two skiffs to drive through and reach the riverbank, but more than a dozen skiffs were in hot pursuit. And Adora was… poised on the wreckage of a skiff, seemingly fending off shells with her sword while several skiffs drove in circles around her and fired their swivel guns. She was tough, but those were guns, and if they used canister…

As the Alliance skiffs drew close, Seacat stood. "Over here!" she yelled.

They changed course and drove towards her.

"Move to the side!" Seacat yelled to the soldiers as she waved the skiffs on.

A moment later, the skiffs cleared the riverbank and drove down towards the shore.

And the shrimp jumped off and landed next to Seacat. "We need to get Adora!"

"How could you let her do this?" Seacat spat. "Go fetch her!"

"She said she'd hold them off until the rest are on the rafts!"

And the idiot would know they weren't ready yet. Seacat cursed once more.

Then the Horde skiffs arrived at the riverbank.

The main part of Seacat's force was still charging up the slope when the first skiff reached the top of it, but Seacat and the

vanguard were already in position. She jumped up, pushing her claws into the hull of the skiff, and quickly scrambled up to the deck. A Horde soldier tried to fend her off with a spear, but she dodged to the side, hanging from one hand, then grabbed the shaft right behind its head and pulled.

The Horde soldier was smart enough to let go of the spear instead of letting himself be pulled down, but it didn't help him - she was up on deck in the time he needed to draw his cutlass and rammed the spear into his belly before he could get his guard up.

The gunner at the swivel gun glanced over her shoulder, gasping even as she fired the gun, shooting a load of canister down the slope. Seacat snarled and raked the back of the soldiers' neck with her claws before she could turn to face her. The woman died before she hit the deck.

That left the pilot. Who was trying to turn the skiff around but only succeeded in sliding down the slope towards the river. Seacat charged him across the tilted deck, her claws leaving gouges in the wood. He managed to parry her first blow with her blade but had to release the controls of the skiff for that, and the vehicle took an even sharper turn, almost toppling over.

He lost his balance and when he grabbed for the steering again, he left himself wide open. She lunged, thrusting the blade into his chest - no, into his armour; the sword didn't cut through the chest plate. New design, she realised as she stepped back, avoiding the man's wild swing with his cutlass.

By now, the skiff had almost completed its turn, the bow pointing up the slope. Seacat snarled and rushed the man, batting his blade away with her own, then raked her claws across his faceplate. He fell back and off the skiff, screaming as he reached for his ruined face.

She really needed a better sword when fighting Headhunters.

She grabbed the controls and looked at the top of the slope. Two skiffs were filling the gap in the smoke - with their guns aimed down the slope. Soldiers were trying to board them from the side, but they were firing down - at the rafts. And at the soldiers charging up the slope.

Two more skiffs had broken through the smoke east of them, but the princesses were pushing them back - as Seacat glanced at the Horde vehicles, the gunner of the closer one fell off it with an arrow sticking out of their head, and a hurricane pushed the other skiff into it.

But the ones in the gap… Seacat clenched her teeth and drove her freshly taken skiff up the slope, as fast as the thing would go. The Horde scum at the bows saw her coming and swung the guns towards her, but it was too late - she jumped off before the guns fired, and the double-load of canister hitting the skiff couldn't stop it.

Seacat tumbled down the slope but managed to stop her slide and look back in time to see her skiff ramming the first Horde vehicle from the side, pushing it into the other with enough force to break their hulls. The three skiffs slid to the side, stuck together, and the remaining soldiers scrambled up their hulls before they came to a stop.

By the time Seacat was halfway up the slope, the skiffs had been taken. She saw the mothwoman cheer at the helm of the middle one.

And she saw the dumbass get torn apart by a load of canister from behind - the rest of the Horde skiffs were in range. But that meant… Where was the shrimp, damn it? Where was Adora?

The three rafts were still on the way, but the raft that had transported her force should be able to handle two skiffs. And they could take the other rafts to evacuate the shore.

“Get the two skiffs on the raft!” she yelled back at the shore, then sprinted up the slope, running as fast as she could, past torn and bleeding bodies. And trying not to think about the fact that the mud her feet were running through was a little too reddish in places. Too many were dead already - if things continued like this, they wouldn’t need more than one raft.

She reached the top of the slope - and saw three more skiffs moving towards them. No, they had stopped and were shooting at them. Covering fire - but that required another force to charge. And where was Adora?

She crawled forward a little, past the wrecked skiffs, until she saw the first skiff they had lost. Adora was still there, hacking at a skiff that had come too close.

Where was the shrimp? She should be teleporting Adora back now!

Seacat glanced around, but she couldn’t spot the princess. Had she been wounded? Or killed? On Seacat’s watch? No. She would appear in a cloud of sparkles soon enough… Sparkles the Headhunters were trained to spot and fire upon. Damn.

She looked back at Adora. Her lover was jumping on a skiff that had driven too close. A swing of her sword cut both gun and gunner in half, then she threw the loader at the pilot, knocking both off the skiff.

“Come on, Adora! Take the skiff and join us!” Seacat hissed. It would take longer, but…

There was the shrimp! Landing on the skiff’s deck! Adora was headed to the controls, but the shrimp reached out to her.

A moment later, both disappeared.

Right before a volley of shells wrecked the skiff. The Horde’s field artillery had set up. And they were on target. Bad news!

Seacat hastily crawled back. “Everyone - on the raft now! We’ve got artillery incoming!” she yelled as she slid rather than ran down the slope.

Spinerella and Netossa took out another skiff that had driven through the smoke - which was thinning, Seacat noticed - but the rest of the force started to head back to the shore. Where they were just loading the second skiff on Seacat’s raft.

“No time!” Seacat yelled at the soldiers. “Drop it overboard - we need to evacuate everyone right now!” Before artillery shells killed the entire force.

“But…” one of the soldiers trying to tie the skiff down protested.

“Do it, or I’ll throw you overboard!” she screamed at him, slashing the ropes that had already been slung over the stern of the skiff.

“Do it!” Bran yelled.

“But… we need to drive it… and it doesn’t work on water!”

But it would work on the raft. Was the idiot afraid of getting wet? Before Seacat could throw him overboard, the skiff lurched - and toppled over, almost capsizing the raft as it slid overboard.

“Hah!” Adora stood there, teeth clenched in a tight smile. She had just pushed the skiff into the river by herself!

Seacat wanted to kiss her right here and now. But they had troops to command - to save. So she flashed her a smile, then yelled. “Everyone on the raft! Now! Move it, you landlubbers!”

Yet, there were still troops fighting on the slope. Familiar soldiers. The sergeant was leading them, she realised. What was the idiot doing? “Sergeant! Fall back!”

The woman didn’t react. But she had heard Seacat - Seacat knew how to make her voice carry through a battle at sea or in a storm. Had she been rendered deaf in the fighting?

No.

Yet, the sergeant was charging the closest skiff. And the rest of her men weren't falling back, either.

The damn idiots were holding the Horde back so the rest could evacuate! Even though they couldn't teleport or fight from the shore, like the princesses. They wouldn't escape.

Snarling, Seacat jumped off the raft. Her feet sank into the mud at the shore - the results of dozens of soldiers trampling over the grass and sand - and she cursed. "Fall back!" she yelled, both hands forming a cone around her mouth. "I'll keelhaul you if you don't!"

"Cat-Seacat!"

Adora? She glanced over her shoulder just in time to see Adora grabbing her shoulder and pulling her back. On the raft one-handed.

Seacat was about to curse her, but… a shell hit the river, sending up a plume of water and causing the raft to rock slightly. They had no time any more. Clenching her teeth, she yelled: "Cast off - we're leaving!"

She kept looking at the riverbank as the raft drew away, dragged by the current as much or more as the paddles and poles the soldiers used. One soldier was blown apart by canister trying to board a skiff. Another fell, taken from behind by infantry. She couldn't see anyone else still standing except for the sergeant. The woman was on the deck of a skiff, fighting with two Horde soldiers. An arrow from Brain Boy took out one of them, the woman gutted the other…

And the skiff blew up as a shell landed straight on it a moment before the rest of the volley struck the shore.

Seacat closed her eyes and didn't resist when Adora pulled her in for a hug from behind. "Idiots," she mumbled.

Adora didn’t contradict her.

Neither said anything until they, trailed by the rafts that Alcy had sent over and which had turned around as well, reached the northern shore.

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“Half of our screening force lost, together with two skiffs.” The shrimp wasn’t happy as she looked up from the map in the command tent and at the rest of them in the tent. “We managed to inflict higher casualties on the Horde troops, but that’s pretty much the only good news.”

“We also know more about their forces and their rules of engagement,” Brain Boy added. “And they did lose at least a dozen skiffs.”

“They’ll be able to recover most of them,” Adora corrected him. “We didn’t do too much damage.”

That was the problem with fighting on land - skiffs didn’t sink like ships. If this had been a battle at sea, the Horde would’ve lost most of their skiffs. Seacat shook her head. “We also know that they can deploy field artillery very quickly. Any landing operation will have to deal with that.”

“Can we?” the shrimp asked. “Can we land our forces in the face of that?”

“Not without a lot of casualties,” Seacat told her. “Once they have the range, they’ll be able to shell a beachhead. And they’ll see us coming.”

“And if we rush the artillery, their skiffs will hit us,” Adora said.

And delay them until the artillery could target their positions. And if they tried to ignore the skiffs… well, that wouldn’t end well.

“Deploying our own artillery will take time, and we won’t have spotters on their position, so taking the Horde guns out will be difficult,” Adora went on.

“The problem is the rafts,” Seacat took over. “They’re slow and hard to manoeuvre when crossing the river. The Horde will see them coming and have a lot of time to get ready to receive us.”

“Can the Salienans help us out?” Juliet asked. “They have faster boats.”

“They don’t have too many of them - they need barges for most of their troops. And they’re faced with the same problem,” Seacat replied.

“So we might need to cross the river at such distances that they cannot react,” the shrimp said.

“They have their best troops on skiffs - they can shadow us and react rapidly,” Adora corrected her.

“We can hide our movement - we control this side of the river,” Brain Boy said. “Leave some decoy force, make it appear that we’re still here…”

“That could work,” Adora said. “But if they see through our decoy… And even if we establish beachheads further away on both sides of the yards, we won’t be able to coordinate with each other. We might do better to just unite all troops and form one force. Land and then move to the yards to encircle them there.”

“They’ll be prepared for that,” Seacat pointed out. “That’s the obvious response.” And you should never do the obvious, the Captain had taught her that. Unless the enemy expected you not to do the obvious, of course.

“Do you have an alternative?” the shrimp asked.

Seacat didn’t. But before she could admit that, the tent flap was pushed back, and a guard peered in. “Commander! The Salineans

have arrived! They've sent two officers."

The shrimp all but jumped. "Send them in!"

"See? I told you we were expected!"

Seacat's eyes widened. She knew that voice - the Captain!

And there he was. Sea Hawk stepped into the tent, then held the flap back for Mermista. Both of them were wearing regular Salinean uniforms, not their regular clothes.

"Merm…mghlrm."

Seacat glared at Adora while she strained to keep her lover's mouth shut. "They're in disguise!" she hissed. "Don't blurt their names out!"

Sea Hawk smiled, but Mermista rolled her eyes. "Whatever."

Seacat nodded at them. "Good evening."

"Good evening! You're hale and whole, I hope?" the Captain boomed.

"Of course," she replied.

"Really." Mermista somehow didn't seem to believe her.

"She was hurt badly in a battle on the way here," Adora, the traitor, told them as soon as Seacat released her mouth. "I healed her."

"I am hale and whole," Seacat insisted. Now.

"Now." Mermista shook her head. "And you will do your worst to change that, I suppose."

Seacat wasn't going to answer that - she was doing her part in the war, like everyone else. If the princesses could risk their lives, then she couldn't do any less. But a change of subject would be

good. “I thought you were staying in Fortress Freedom?” she asked in a low voice.

“Officially, we are!” Sea Hawk said. “To fool the Horde into thinking we were still at the fortress. But when we were informed that the Horde had changed tactics and wrecked a scouting force of our troops, we decided to travel upriver with the Salinean contingent. My dear Mermista, the cunning Entrapta, and my glorious self!”

“You’ve had trouble as well?” Adora asked.

“Yes. Their Headhunters ambushed our screening force,” Mermista said. “Mauled them - few of them got away.”

“We faced the same problem. Crossing the river will be a challenge,” the shrimp told them.

“Oh, we’ve got a plan about that.” Sea Hawk smiled widely. “It’s why we’re here.”

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“Are you sure Mermista can do it?” Adora asked, looking at the river down below.

Seacat rolled her eyes. “She said she could.” And Mermista was many things, but not a liar.

“But it’s an awfully long distance.” Adora was biting her lower lip - Seacat knew it without needing to look at her lover.

“She can do it - she’s experienced,” Seacat told her. More experienced than Adora by far.

“But we don’t exactly know what the riverbed looks like,” Adora went on. “Mud and worse…”

“That doesn’t matter. Mermista commands the water.”

“Yes, but… what if she, uh, gets tired? Exhausted?” Adora looked at her.

“Then we’ll still have the structure Entrapta and Perfuma came up with,” Seacat retorted.

“Entrapta said she couldn’t guarantee that it would hold up under the water’s pressure,” Adora said.

“She said she couldn’t guarantee that it would hold up for longer than a quarter of an hour,” Seacat corrected her. That was if Perfuma grew the wood to specs, of course.

“Yes. But the river’s quite wide. That’s an awfully short time to cross the river on foot. In mud.”

“Yes.” Seacat shrugged.

“I’m just saying… it’ll be dangerous. So much can go wrong, and if it does…”

“It’s still not as dangerous as trying to cross the river in the face of enemy artillery,” Seacat said. She looked at Adora. Her friend was… still biting her lower lip. “Are you… worried?” she asked. She wouldn’t say ‘afraid’. She-Ra wasn’t afraid - quite the contrary.

“No!” Adora blurted out. A moment later, she sighed. “Yes. We’ll be down there. At the front. All of us.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. “We talked about that. Mermista, Entrapta and Perfuma need to be at the front, or the tunnel won’t go anywhere.”

“Yes.” Adora hissed.

“And they need protection to keep the tunnel up until we’ve established a beachhead and took their artillery positions.” At which point they would be able to move barges across the river without trouble. Without much trouble.

“Yes.” Adora pouted.

“And the rest of us are the best choice to protect them.” And charge ahead once they were on the other shore. They had talked about this at length the day before when hashing out the plan.

“It’s just… all of us will be concentrated in one location. If the Horde has hidden a bomb at the riverbank…” Adora trailed off.

“Entrapta has some thingie that can detect the bombs,” Seacat reminded her.

“Yes.”

Seacat sighed. “Adora… We went over all of this yesterday. What’s really bugging you?”

“I…”

“Yes?” She was growing impatient. Everyone was getting into position for the surprise assault. Decoy forces had been sent upriver and downriver so the Horde would assume they were about to cross the river as expected. And here, Adora was...

“I can’t protect you from the river!” Adora blurted out. “I can’t cut the water down! I can’t smash it to pieces before it can hurt you. And if I throw myself in front of you, you’ll still drown!”

Oh. That. Seacat considered telling Adora that she could swim, but that would be a lie. Sort of - should the river flood the tunnel, swimming wouldn’t save anyone. Not at that depth. Not inside the tunnel. Not with the force of the river and the water pressure bearing down on them. Sure, there was a chance that she could escape the tunnel and reach the river’s surface. But the odds were really, really low.

“I wanted to tell Glimmer to get you out, should anything happen…”

“You didn’t!” Seacat gasped. That would… No. Just no. To ask the shrimp to save her and let the others die…

“I didn’t.”

“Good.”

“But I wanted to. I could probably survive, but…” Adora took a shivering breath.

Seacat took a step and hugged her. As tightly as she could, given their current size differences.

Neither of them said anything for a while.

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When they reached the small cove, hidden from the Horde’s view thanks to dense trees, and pushed their way past the assembled volunteer forces to the shore, Entrapta all but jumped on them. “There you are! Everything is ready! We were just waiting for you! This is so exciting! We’ll be combining technology and magic! In a new and daring way, I mean! This could revolutionise travel, too! Come, come! You have to see this!” The princess grabbed Seacat’s hand and started to pull her towards Emily, which was standing at the shore.

Well, Entrapta wasn’t apprehensive in the least. Mermista, though, Seacat saw, was very stern and serious. And holding Sea Hawk’s hand as she stared at the water, her trident in her other hand. She looked confident, but Seacat knew her too well to be fooled - the princess was nervous. Nervous but determined, of course - she would see this through.

Perfuma, on the other hand… The princess of Plumeria was obviously nervous. Her smile looked fake, and she was fidgeting. The shrimp and Brain Boy looked similar to Mermista, as did the other two princesses.

If this failed, then the Alliance was done for, Seacat suddenly realised. With the exception of Frosta and Queen Angella, the entire leadership of the Alliance was present.

Damn. But they had to do this. They had to take this fortress and finish the Horde forces in the entire area. Otherwise, the Horde would recover, and any offensive would be even more costly.

“Alright!” Entrapta yelled. “Let’s get going! Emily’s ready with the scanner and the sealing agent!”

Indeed, the bot had a huge tank with clear liquid in it fixed to its rear.

“Yes, yes, no need to shout,” Mermista grumbled, then stepped into the water and raised her trident.

At once, the water retreated in a circle in front of her - forming a tunnel leading into the river.

“Perfuma, now!” Entrapta was smiling widely.

Plants started to shoot out of the ground and into the tunnel, lining the invisible walls and covering them with a thick weave.

“Emily!”

The bot moved forward and started spraying the liquid onto the plants. It quickly hardened, sealing the gaps. In theory, at least - Seacat had no wish to find out how long it would resist the river in practice.

“It’s working!” Entrapta cheered, holding what looked like her recorder but was the size of her head in her hair. “Just as designed - the solution is hardening on schedule. Let’s go deeper; I need pressure values to estimate! It’s too bad Frosta’s not here - she could freeze the water for additional stability.”

The tunnel quickly lengthened, and Seacat took her first step into it soon after Entrpata led Mermista and Perfuma further down.

The mud felt… oddly dry under her feet. Not dry, but more like wet sand than mud. And she could see the waterline - the sealing stuff was transparent enough, and the plants left some gaps. Which meant she knew exactly when she was underwater. Which was a weird feeling.

"Brrr."

She glanced to her side. Adora looked like she had just shivered. Her lover caught her looking at her and flashed a fake smile at her. "Amazing, right?"

Seacat nodded, even though she felt ill at ease herself. "Yes. Amazing." It was, of course - the Horde wouldn't see this coming. Or so they hoped. But walking underwater, the entire river above them, the immense pressure only held back by Mermista's power… She shivered and barely resisted the urge to run her hands over her arms. This might be a little more… challenging than she had expected.

Then she felt a hand grip her own, and Adora smiled at her.

Seacat took a deep breath and kept walking. Forward. And down. A bot was planting sticks with some glowing substance on top that Entrapta had brought every few yards, but the tunnel was still rather dim - for most people; Seacat could see just fine, of course.

But she could also hear the water running over the surface of the tunnel much better than others. Not deafening, but she couldn't ignore it, either - it was too loud. And too dangerous. She hoped the landlubber soldiers wouldn't realise just how dangerous water was. If they panicked in the tunnel, the Horde wouldn't have to lift a finger to defeat them.

She looked up a little when Emily moved to the side to spray the next part. Mermista looked… well, Mermista was tough and liked to act even tougher, but she had some tells, though Seacat didn't

think she was about to collapse. On the other hand, they weren't even halfway to the other side.

"Everything's fine!" Entrapta's voice rang in the tunnel. "The pressure is within expected parameters, albeit barely, and we're on course according to my compass!"

Good. Seacat nodded to herself.

Adora looked over her shoulder. Seacat did the same - she couldn't see the exit but she could make out the start of the riverbank.

"No one's following us," Seacat commented. No one should be, of course - the soldiers weren't supposed to enter the tunnel until Seacat and the others had reached the Horde's shore - something about the airflow, Entrapta had said. They needed some wind blowing through the tunnel to keep the air breathable for the army. Another thing to worry about. Or not - their group was small enough to not need more air.

"Shouldn't we start to go up by now?" Adora asked in a low voice.

"Not really," Seacat replied. "They'll have the riverbed dredged in this area for their yards. Gunboats don't have much of a draft, but they'll want some safety margin." She pointed at the ground. "See there? The stone with the scratches? That's from dredging, I think."

"Ah. So we're close?"

"Probably," Seacat replied. She wasn't really certain - it was hard to estimate the distance underwater. But they had to be close. Unless she was completely mistaken.

"So…" Entrapta suddenly said. "This is pretty steep, I think. Rather hard to go up."

Oh. Seacat moved ahead and took a look. Indeed, the riverbank was rising quite steeply here. Too steep for a charge. If the

soldiers had to scramble up this slope, they would spend too long in the tunnel. “Go sideways?”

“I guess so,” Entrapta said. “But that will affect the airflow.”

“I… I can make stairs or a ramp,” Perfuma offered. She looked quite tired, though.

But it wasn’t as if they had a choice.

“Alright!” Entrapta nodded with a smile. “Then we can go straight, and my calculations will still hold true! Everyone: Back up a little; we’ll build a ramp!”

They backed up - well, Adora stated to help move mud around to stabilise the plant ramp. Seacat watched, feeling both guilty for not helping, even though there wasn’t enough room anyway, and more and more anxious. Was the air growing stale? Adora would need lots of air to work so hard, and they were basically staying in place…

She took a deep breath to calm down, but the air *was* smelling stale. And the river’s roar was louder here, somehow.

But then they were moving ahead again. And up. And a few minutes later, Seacat could see light - Mermista had broken the surface.

Seacat bared her fangs as she drew her sword.

It was time to charge.

Adora was, as expected, the first out of the tunnel, but Seacat was right behind her - even though she had to jump over the shrimp to keep pace. The tunnel had reached the Horde shore almost on top of the planned spot,- a little beach right outside the first fortifications protecting the yards.

She heard shouting and yelling, followed by sirens as the Horde scum raised the alert, but Adora was already charging the

fortress. A running jump carried her to the top of the earthen ramparts, and she started cutting down the troops there while they tried to rally.

Seacat couldn't quite match that, but the earthen walls provided easy hand- and footholds, and she quickly cleared the top as well, intercepting a guard running towards Adora with a quick slash that caught the man in the throat, between helmet and chest plate.

Adora was handling an entire squad on her side, so Seacat cut down another Horde soldier who was too brave for his own good, then rushed towards the gun emplacement at the corner - the crew was moving the gun to aim it at the tunnel, where Entrapta was giving the signal to the troops on the other side.

Two guards with spears were trying to bar her way, but Seacat batted one spear away, jumped over the other, then landed between them. Her left foot lashed out, claws slicing through the man's calf while she swung her blade and slashed the back of the other guard.

Both collapsed, dropping their weapons, and Seacat dashed forward, into the middle of the gun crew. The officer in charge had his blade out and faced her, trying to buy time for his men to fire. He had a solid stance, sabre pointed at her. Quite different from the scum she had fought before.

But Seacat wasn't about to duel the man while she had a gun to destroy. She flashed her fangs at him in a toothy grin, then jumped on the rampart, landing in a crouch.

The Horde scum couldn't help it - they turned to face her, and she launched herself over their heads to land next to the powder bags stacked near the gun. A quick cut with her blade cut three of them open before she was moving again - charging the gunner who was holding the rope match to fire the gun.

The woman dropped the rope and backed off, drawing her cutlass - but once again, Seacat ignored her. She slid under the wild swing of the woman, picked up the rope match and somersaulted back to the powder charges.

She saw the Horde scum pale and gape as she jumped on top of the wall, holding the lit match above the spilt powder, and grinned at them before she dropped it and jumped off.

The explosion a moment later sent stone and body parts over the ramparts - from which she was hanging by her claws. As soon as the powder had gone off, she pulled herself up and on top of the rampart again

The gun had been thrown halfway across the gun pit, and only two Horde soldiers were still alive - and one of them was on the ground, clutching at the broken ramrod stuck in her chest.

Seacat glanced around. Adora had cleared the rampart on her side and was rushing towards the gate tower. Spinnerella and Netossa had dealt with a sally from said gate and were holding it against the soldiers trying to charge them. And the shrimp, Brain Boy and Sea Hawk were guarding the tunnel and the princesses keeping it from collapsing with half the army inside.

And Entrapta was coming towards her - she was climbing the wall as well; her hair tendrils were slung already reaching the top of the ramparts. A moment later, she arrived next to Seacat. "Whoo! Let me check for hidden bombs!" she announced while pointing a gadget at the courtyard below.

Seacat clenched her teeth. This base was manned by Headhunters - they would've mined the yards, at least. Although… was that a catapult in the citadel? Yes, it was. A huge one, too - and placed so you couldn't spot it from the river. Was it true that the Horde was running out of powder?

"Oh… there's no bomb in this part," Entrpata told her. "But there's lots of powder in there!" she pointed at the citadel of the fortress.

“Is it a bomb, or just a magazine?” Seacat asked, moving to block a squad of Horde soldiers rushing up the stairs nearby.

“Magazine. Of course, a magazine is a bomb if you have the means to set it off.” Entrapta grinned. “But that’s it - all the other stuff is just dispersed powder.”

Seacat frowned, but before she could ask another question, the squad reached the top of the ramparts, and she had to fight them. They were good - their leader was a grizzled veteran with long, grey hair and scar crossing her face who really knew how to wield a blade. But they were on the stairs, and they weren’t able to gang up on Seacat, who was holding the top of the stairs. And as good as the veteran was, Seacat was better. Faster and stronger - and more skilled. She knew it after a few thrusts and parries.

And so did the Horde soldier - Seacat could see how she set her jaw and fought on despite the odds, wielding her sword expertly - until she misjudged a swing, and Seacat got inside her guard, ramming her blade into the woman’s throat, then kicking her corpse into the rest of the squad and sending them tumbling down the stairs.

“No bombs in the yard?” she asked, glancing over her shoulder.

“None!” Entrapta replied, fiddling with her gadget. “Although… there’s a crystal engine there, big enough for a frigate. And a few smaller ones according to my sensor arrangement.”

Had the Horde been planning to build a frigate here? Seacat shook her head. “We need to get moving!” she snapped. “Before a crossbowman nails us.”

The first bolts were hitting the rampart - and coming quite a bit too close to hitting them for Seacat’s comfort; the Horde forces were rallying across the courtyard.

They dashed towards the gate, more bolts flying after them, but they reached the shelter of the gate tower - cleared by Adora

without getting hit.

“Seacat! It looks like our plan worked - they are understaffed; they must have deployed the bulk of their troops against our decoy landing operations!” Adora told them with a wide smile as she finished off the apparently last defender of the gate.

“Good.” Seacat smiled - briefly. Something felt off, though.

Then she heard yelling from outside: “For the Alliance! Bright Moon! Plumeria!”

The vanguard of their army had arrived and was leaving the tunnel, charging towards the fortress. Seacat looked through one of the slits in the walls and saw the first soldiers reach Netossa and Spinnerella, who directed her towards the gate.

Which Adora was opening for them.

The guns disabled, the army storming the gates - all that was left was taking the citadel and the yards.

“Oh. The big engine’s moving,” Entrapta announced. Slowly, but it’s moving.

“They’ve installed it in a ship?” Seacat dashed to the top of the tower. There hadn’t been a ship ready on the slips. She peered at the yards while the soldiers streamed through the open gate, rolling over the Horde troops trying to face them. There was no gunboat moving - and she couldn’t see any gunboat in a state ready for an engine, either. So, where was that…

Then she saw Horde troops pushing a huge engine towards the citadel. Why would… She cursed. “Entrapta, is that an enhanced engine? Can it blow up?”

“Uh… my sensors aren’t good enough to catch the fluctuating changes that would cause, but… I’ll take a look!”

Hair tendrils latched onto the roof's railing, and, a moment later, Entrapta swung up from below and peered through her goggles at the engine moving towards the citadel.

And she gasped. "Uh… yes. There are some modifications on the engine. Not as elegant as mine, but…

The Horde had enhanced engine bombs. That was what they needed the catapults for!

"Adora! That engine is a bomb!" Seacat yelled down.

Adora looked up at her, then turned. "Bow! Nail it down!"

Brain Boy jumped on a low wall, took aim, and an arrow splashed glue all over the crew pushing the engine's cart.

Seacat pulled her telescope out and took a closer look. They were… they were… "Cover! Take cover!" she yelled. "Stop and take cover!"

The soldiers started to react - stopping their charge, then moving towards the ramparts and courtyards of the fortress.

"Adora! Take cover!"

But Seacat's friend wasn't listening - she was charging towards the bomb.

Seacat cursed and jumped over the railing, landing on the ramparts below, then jumped down to the courtyard. "Adora!"

"Cut the rear part! The controls are there!" Entrapta yelled. "It can't explode without the controls!"

Seacat clenched her teeth, running after Adora. But she knew she wouldn't make it.

Then Adora yelled and threw her sword. Seacat saw it flip over while it flew through the air before it hit the engine - right on the

controls.

“Charge!” Seacat yelled as she rushed forward. “Charge!”

And the soldiers charged. Adora was the first to reach the bomb, recovering her sword and cutting down the Horde scum around the bomb, but the soldiers quickly passed her, storming the citadel. The first were placing charges on the gate when Seacat reached Adora.

“You…” She shook her head. “That was too close.”

Adora smiled grimly. “Yes.”

The charges at the gate went off, blowing the entrance open.

“Let’s finish them off!” Seacat told her.

“Yes. let’s…”

A bright flash, followed by an explosion that sent a smoke cloud so high, it dwarfed the clouds, interrupted her.

“That was…” Adora trailed off.

“...the decoy force to the west,” Seacat finished for her.

Another flash, another explosion and more smoke rose into the sky to the east of them.

Seacat couldn’t tell, but she was sure that the Salinean decoy force, including the frigate, had just been wiped out.

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The River Offensive Part 6

Seacat stared, frozen, at the smoke cloud rising over the river in the east. The frigate would be gone as well as anyone in the decoy landing force. So many dead in a moment… And if not for Adora, they would've shared their fate here.

"Keep going!" Adora yelled. "Secure the citadel and the yards! And secure any and all skiffs - and gather them at the gate! Move it!"

The soldiers, who had faltered, charged again.

Seacat shook her head. She couldn't… she had to do something. Think! "We'll need to have bigger screening forces - so we can detect and intercept any catapults before they are in range," she muttered.

"Yes," Adora agreed. "That's why we need every skiff we can get. If they manage to throw such a bomb at the yards while we're here…"

Almost the entire leadership of the Alliance would be gone. And their best troops. Seacat gasped. "We need to warn Fortress Freedom - the river's probably too wide for a catapult there, but if they manage to lure the frigates in port closer…"

"Yes." Adora nodded. "Let's meet the others. We need to act swiftly."

"Yes." Seacat pressed her lips together. If they were caught by surprise again, they would be lost.

They quickly returned to the gate. Netossa and Spinnerella were there but looked shocked still - the two princesses were glancing around as if they were expecting assassins to drop down on them. "What was that?" Netossa asked as soon as she spotted Adora and Seacat.

“Planning meeting,” Adora snapped instead of answering. “Inside the gate tower.” She marched towards the stairs leading up, Seacat on her heels.

As the soldiers before, the two princesses straightened and nodded and quickly followed them.

Inside the gate turret, Entrapta was mumbling and tapping on her device. “...frigate scale engines… crystal density… area of effect… boosting effect… delayed acceleration…”

“Entrapta!” Seacat spoke up.

She looked up, blinking. “Oh. I was just… calculating the bomb blast. I don’t have it precisely down, so I need more calculations to get a good average range…”

Seacat sighed. “Just take the worst estimate.”

“But…”

“Entrapta, we need to plan how to react to this,” Adora told her. “Where’s Glimmer? Glimmer!”

“Probably still at the tunnel, keeping guard - soldiers are still travelling through it,” Netossa said.

“Ah, right.” Adora nodded. “But we can’t wait for too long. Alright.” She nodded again. “Send out scouts with any skiffs they can get ahold of, downriver and upriver - we need to know as soon as the Horde tries to get close enough so they can use their catapults. What’s the range?” she asked, looking at Entrapta.

“Uh…” Entrapta bit her lower lip. “I need to look at the catapult and the bomb.”

“Do that,” Adora told her. “Netossa, Spinnerella - help to secure the skiffs. Seacat…”

Seacat nodded. “We’ll need to get the boats here, so we can move the soldiers back to our shore.” She doubted that Mermista and Perfuma would be able to hold the tunnel together long enough to evacuate everyone back to the northern shore. Or construct another tunnel.

“Exactly.” Adora flashed her a weary smile. “We can’t keep them concentrated here; it’s too dangerous.”

Seacat nodded again, then cursed. “Even if we evacuate everyone back over the river, we’ll have to keep a close watch on the entire river to know as soon as the Horde tries to cross.” Hell, with those bombs, the Horde finally had something that didn’t take a huge army to move and could still do as much or more damage as a princess or two. And if they used it against Bright Moon or Plumeria… or in a battle at sea… “A smuggler could get such an engine into any port, leave the ship and have it blow up, wrecking the entire harbour. We need to spread the word about this!”

“Go and signal to Alcy and the others to start taking the soldiers back!”

“Aye aye!”

Seacat dashed to the top of the tower. The Horde would… there! Signal flags!

She checked with her telescope that the signal ensign on the other shore was watching, then started signalling to transmit Adora’s orders. It still took two tries - the ensign must be shaken by the bombs. She should’ve had Alcy do this part, but then things would’ve fallen apart as soon as the woman left with the rafts.

Then she peered down at the end of the tunnel. The last soldiers seemed to have left. Mermista, Sea Hawk and Perfuma, were looking into it, then hurriedly moved to the side.

A moment later, water shot out of the tunnel and almost reached the top of the riverbank. Seacat could also see some perturbance

in the river - the tunnel must have collapsed and was now being torn apart by the current.

So much for the tunnel lasting long enough to reach the exit even after Mermista stopped - or failed - to control the water.

Seacat could also see that Mermista and Perfuma were close to collapsing as well - Sea Hawk was all but carrying Mermista to the gate, and Perfuma was propped up by Brain Boy. Damn.

She looked at the rest of the fortress. Someone had set the gunboat on the slip in the yard on fire. Probably another Horde scum trying to deny them their prize. Not that it mattered much - right now, the skiffs were far more important. They needed to get screening forces out. And that looked good - she could see Alliance soldiers in the skiff park, going over the dozen vehicles there. And the Horde banner on top of the citadel was getting torn down - the fortress had fallen.

She climbed down into the main room of the tower again, just in time to see the rest arrive.

"This is horrible… so many dead," Perfuma muttered as she all but collapsed in a seat.

Mermista held up better, though she was clenching her teeth when Sea Hawk helped her sit down. "We're buggered, aren't we?" she spat.

Despite the situation, Seacat almost laughed at the profanity - of course the Princess of Salineas would have picked up cursing from her sailors.

"I wouldn't say that," Adora replied, all tense and serious. "We're sending out screening forces so we have advance warning once the remaining Horde forces move toward us. But we need to move the soldiers - most of them - back over the river so they'll be safe for the time being. Any concentration of force in range of the Horde catapults will be inviting one of the enhanced bombs."

“We need to take out their catapults,” the shrimp cut in. “They can’t bomb us without them.”

“How mobile are they?” Brain Boy asked.

“Oh.” Entrapta blinked. “The one in the fortress isn’t very mobile. They are too big to be moved easily - since they need to launch frigate-sized engines. Engines sized for frigates.”

“They can’t use smaller engines?” Adora asked, staring at the princess.

“Wellllll…” Entrapta pouted. “I haven’t personally checked, but… if they had been able to use smaller engines to induce an enhanced explosion, they probably would’ve used the gunboat-rated engines in the yards.” She perked up, even smiled at them. “So… they need a big catapult, which will be structurally unsound to move quickly or far. Probably has to be moved disassembled and reassembled in place - that’s how siege catapults were used before siege guns were developed, you know?”

“Some good news, at least,” the shrimp muttered.

“More like: not quite as bad as it could’ve been,” Seacat corrected her. “They managed to build the catapults in time to attack our decoy landings, so they must have been able to put them up quite quickly.”

Mermista shook her head, then groaned. “No. We weren’t pushing the landings in order to draw more Horde forces. They would’ve had enough time.”

“More not so bad news, then.” Adora nodded. “That means we’re safe enough for now - but we need to verify this.”

“And we need to plan for suicide attacks with such a bomb on a ship,” Seacat added. “It’s too heavy for a skiff, at least.”

Everyone winced at that thought. Then Entrapta nodded. “Oh, yes. I could build an enhanced bomb that is small enough to be

carried with a skiff - actually, I have such a prototype at the fortress - but the Horde probably isn't there yet."

'Yet'. Seacat muttered a curse.

"We still need to evacuate the bulk of our army and hold the fortress - but be ready to destroy it," Adora said. "And we need to make contact with the decoy forces and find out what happened - and how many survived."

"We'll be sending boats upriver and downriver," Sea Hawk said. "The surviving soldiers should also be sending couriers to us already - though they'll be heading to the camp across the river, I suppose."

"Alright. Let's comb the yards for holdouts and start securing the engines and whatever else we can use," the shrimp said. "And get ready to take out the catapults. If they are not very mobile, taking them out will be easier."

"The Horde probably has an enhanced bomb ready to be detonated as soon as we break through to the catapult," Brain Boy pointed out.

"Or as soon as you're sighted, depending on the blast radius," Seacat added.

The shrimp didn't like that. "But we need to take the catapults out."

"Then we need a plan," Adora said. "But first, we need more information. And rest," she added with a glance at Perfuma and Mermista.

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Word from the Salineans arrived at the same time Alcy started moving soldiers back across the river - Seacat saw the longboat approach the fortress from the east while she was overseeing the collection of the gunboat engines.

“Pack them up and lash them down on the raft,” she yelled at the soldiers working at the pier. “And don’t mess up! If those engines end up in the water, I’ll send you after them, and you’ll get them back or drown!”

“Yes, ma’am!” the sergeant in charge of the squad told her.

She glared at them for a moment, just to impress the importance of this, then went to see Adora and the others.

The mood of the soldiers in the fortress was pretty bad, she noted as she walked to the citadel, where the shrimp had relocated the command room to. None of the bragging and cheering soldiers would do after a victory, even or especially if it had been a bloody affair. They weren’t even looting as much as they could.

She couldn’t blame them, of course. Not after the shock of seeing those explosions.

The guards at the citadel were alert, at least, glaring at everyone and everything as Seacat entered. Adora and the others would be in the main building, but Entrapta was studying the catapult in the courtyard, so she took a slight detour. “Hey!”

The princess looked up, then smiled. “Oh, hi! Did you load up the engines?”

“They were tying them down on the rafts when I left. Courier arrived,” she replied. Nodding at the catapult, she added: “Did you find anything?”

“It’s a standard siege catapult with a counterweight,” she told Seacat. “According to a captured soldier who helped build it, they used old blueprints. For the mobile ones, too.” She smiled. “That means we know the capabilities of the catapults as soon as we get those blueprints!”

That was good news. Seacat smiled back at the princess.

“Although the range is a little bit longer than I expected given the weight of the engines,” Entrapta added.

And that wasn’t good news. “Bigger than a standard Horde field gun?”

“Almost but not quite. But the arc’s much better.”

Field guns could set up faster than a catapult. That meant if you saw the horde coming, you could shell them before they were ready. As long as the Horde guns didn’t shell you first. But since the catapult threw its load in a higher arc, they could hide behind field fortifications and weather a bombardment. “We’ll need bigger guns,” she said.

Entrapta tensed. “I can modify the engines we recovered.”

“But they would be too big for your gun project?”

“Yes.”

“We’ll have to discuss this with the others.” Seacat nodded towards the main building. “Let’s go.”

“Alright!”

*****

“...and the frigate was… sunk in the explosion. The blast destroyed or capsized all the barges on the river, too. Many drowned.” The courier’s voice wavered a little as she gave her report.

Seacat pressed her lips together. She could imagine it. The blast’s shockwave knocking people out, the waves tossing barges around, people ending in the river, hurt or unconscious, panicking marines struggling for anything that was afloat…

Mermista looked even worse. “How many survived?”

“One in ten,” the courier said, “from the forces on the river.”

Seacat closed her eyes and clenched her teeth. She had expected that, but she had hoped...

Mermista looked like her face was made of stone. “And the forces on the shore? How many are left in total?”

“About two in ten,” the man replied.

“I see.” Mermista didn’t show any emotion, but when Sea Hawk wrapped his arm around her shoulders, she didn’t push him away or frown at that breach of decorum or something in a planning session.

And that made Seacat want to go over and hug her as well.

“Any word from the western forces?” Adora asked.

The shrimp shook her head. “They might not have a raft ready to travel downstream,” she said. “We’re sending a skiff upriver as soon as we can spare one.”

Which wouldn’t be any time soon, Seacat knew.

But the princess took a deep breath and went on: “This is a heavy blow, but we’ve weathered worse. We still have the bulk of our forces, and in a few hours, they’ll be safe from another such attack.”

“But this is a threat to all our bases - and harbours,” Seacat pointed out. “One small ship carrying such a bomb is enough to wipe out a port.”

“I’m aware of that,” the princess retorted. “Defensive measures will be taken. However, we’ll need enhanced bombs of our own. Direly.” She looked at Entrapta.

“I can modify the engines we took here in a day or so,” the princess replied. “But I’ll have to head back to Fortress Freedom

to make more - and to work on a delivery system."

"What about a catapult?" Brain Boy asked.

"That's slow to set up," Adora said. "They could swarm it with skiffs and guns."

"Exactly! We need a gun that shoots enhanced engine bombs!" Entrapta nodded. "Or, we need an alternative propelling system that is faster to set up than a catapult. And I have something in mind!"

"An alternative propelling system?" Seacat asked.

"Yes! Guns put too much stress on an enhanced engine bomb - the pressure from the propellant is too big, the acceleration too much for the mechanism. Catapults do better - no pressure - but they, too, have trouble with the acceleration, if not as much as a cannon. Both limit the range of such bombs. So, I'm thinking: rockets!" Entrapta beamed at them.

"Rockets?" Adora asked.

"Yes! Steady acceleration - more or less, actually - and controlled flight. The ideal propulsion system for enhanced engine bombs."

"And how long will it take you to develop and build such a rocket?" Brain Boy asked. "And how many can you build?"

"Uh…" Entrapta bit her lower lip. "Maybe… Err… It depends on how many resources I have. If working in the fortress, probably… a month? And I think I can build… Uh… about one per day, once I have bots set up, though that will take a while as well, and I also would need to build the bombs..."

"In a month, the Horde will be in Bright Moon," Mermista said.

"Bright Moon is protected by a magical barrier!" the shrimp replied.

“Against enhanced engine bombs?” Mermista snorted. “They can lob a lot of them at the barrier. Salinas’ Sea Gate was almost destroyed, remember?”

“But it had decayed - Bright Moon’s protections are constantly maintained,” the shrimp retorted.

“If they attempt to set up catapults near Bright Moon - or anywhere - we can hit them before they’re ready,” Adora said. “As long as we can detect them soon enough.”

“Which would be a problem on the sea,” Mermista said. “They can set up a catapult on a ship and have it ready to bombard a port - they don’t need to be very precise with such bombs.”

“But they still need to get in range,” Sea Hawk pointed out. “And it’s far more difficult to hide a ship at sea than a force on land.”

“Unless they have some fishpeople tow the bomb underwater,” Seacat said. “Or they attack at night.”

No one said anything for a few seconds, though the shrimp muttered some curses under her breath.

“We’ll need to extend the patrol routes of our own fishfolk,” Sea Hawk said.

“Perhaps we’ll have to abandon some of the lesser-used ports,” Mermista added. “But even so… they can simply detonate such a bomb near the port, wipe out the patrols, possible damage the port already, and come back later…”

“I can build a detection system for the bombs,” Entrapta said. “Like mine, here.” She held up her device.

“That’ll have to be your priority,” Adora said. “We need a way to detect such bombs from as far away as possible.”

“But we also need bombs of our own to strike back,” the shrimp cut in. “We can’t face their armies in the field until we do.”

“Even after we have such bombs, any army is a target,” Brain Boy pointed out. “And every princess,” he added with a grim expression.

Everyone in the room tensed.

“We need to ensure that the Horde can’t make more of those bombs,” Seacat said. “Guard the crystal mines at any cost - and be ready to destroy them.” That would hamper their navy, but there was no other way.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “How many such bombs can they make? And how fast?”

“That depends on how much fuel crystals and other materials they had stockpiled,” Entrapta replied.

“We’ve taken a lot of their resources, and we secured more in the yards here,” Brain Boy said. “But the fact that they left the gunboat engines here means the Horde wasn’t too pressed for more bomb material.”

“Or they messed up,” Adora said. “The Horde’s logistics aren’t perfect.”

“I’d rather not assume they made a mistake,” Seacat said. “But we control the fuel crystals at least.”

“Yes.” The Shrimp nodded, then growled slightly through clenched teeth. “We need to withdraw and disperse our troops until we’ve got those detectors. We can’t risk losing more people to those bombs.”

“If we withdraw the soldiers, the Horde will go after villages and towns,” Adora countered. “And we can’t let the Horde forces trapped in the north escape.”

“We might not have a choice,” Sea Hawk pointed out. “Until we know how many bombs the Horde has, any concentration of force is at risk.”

“If we can’t face them at all, we lose the war,” Adora told him.

“Alright, then let’s find out if the two Horde forces to the east and west have more bombs - and how many,” Seacat said. “Entrapta? I’m going to need your detector.”

“Oh. I’ll have to teach you how to use it, then.”

“You want to spy on them?” Adora said. “They’ll blow you up!”

“Only if they spot me,” Seacat replied. “And I’m no princess; I doubt that they would waste a bomb on me.” She smiled at Adora to take the sting out of her next words. “And unlike everyone else here, I’m not a leader needed to keep the army together.”

Adora glared at her.

*****

“Alright,” Seacat said as the skiff approached the forest ahead of them. “Drop me off there, then continue the patrol.”

“Shouldn’t we wait to pick you up?” the Bright Moon soldier manning the swivel gun on the skiff asked.

She almost groaned at the question. “No, that would tell the Horde that I’m in the forest.” And she hadn’t spent the entire trip hiding in a fake ammunition crate only to have the soldiers tip off the Horde by not continuing their patrol.

“Ah.” At least the soldier had the grace to sound embarrassed. “Sorry.”

“No worry. Drive close to the forest’s edge. I’ll drop off there.” She peered through the slits in the crate. She couldn’t see much - she had to trust that the soldiers’ ability to spot hidden Horde scouts was better than their ability to think things through - but she could see the trees growing larger.

Then they reached the edge of the forest. She took a deep breath, closed her eyes for a moment, and flipped the latch on the side.

A moment later, the crate's side fell open, and she rolled off the skiff, twisting in mid-air to land on her feet in a crouch and dash into the closest bush. If anyone had spotted her…

She held her breath and listened as the engine noise of the skiff started to fade. Nothing. Then again, no scout worth their salt - and the Headhunters would have such scouts - would reveal their presence by moving around if they knew that an enemy was nearby. Or they'd move too silently even for her ears to pick up.

Which she needed to do. She couldn't just stay here and wait. She crawled forward, peeking through the foliage, checking the area around her. It looked clear. But this was an obvious place for the Horde to place scouts. So, where would they be? At the corners where they would have the best field of view? No, that was too obvious, and the patrols flew too close. They would be further inside the forest - and above ground. She should've waited until nightfall - she could see in the dark, and most Horde soldiers couldn't. Then again, they would use those who could as scouts and guards at night.

She crawled further ahead, looking around - and up - as she moved. Still no sign of a Horde lookout. But there had to be one. Perhaps she should get up in a tree herself. The big one ahead seemed to… Oh. She looked up. Squinted. The foliage was moving, but only in a certain spot. Not the wind. Perhaps an animal.

But she wouldn't bet on that.

Grinning, she crawled through the underbrush until she reached the tree in question, where she listened again, holding her breath.

The creaking of wood. Some scratching noise. And a muttered curse.

There they were! She grinned, baring her fangs, as she peered up the tree. If the Horde scout was on that branch, then they wouldn't be able to see the back of the trunk right… there!

Seacat quickly crawled around the tree, checked for anyone nearby, then scaled up the trunk. Halfway to her goal, she heard cursing - the Horde soldier must have heard her claws ripping into the tree's bark. Snarling, she sped up, climbing around the tree trunk, then pushing off as soon as she caught a glimpse of a Horde uniform.

A crossbow bolt slammed into the tree a moment later, missing her by inches. "You're done for!" she snapped as she grabbed the branch with both hands, claws out, swung around it and landed on top of it.

The Horde soldier dropped his crossbow, but he wasn't quick enough to draw his short sword before she was on him. She raked one set of her claws across his sword arm and drove her other into his belly, below his chest plate - and twisted.

He stared at her with his open, then started choking, blood running from his lips. She ripped his throat out before his sword hit the bottom, then grabbed his twitching body and jumped down. Once more, she twisted in mid-air, landing with both feet on his chest as they hit the ground.

He was dead before he could say or do anything.

She dragged him under a dense bush nearby - nothing to be done about the blood - and continued westwards, upriver, towards the Horde forces that had wrecked the Bright Moon's decoy forces - when their courier had finally arrived, the numbers had been better than feared, but still gruesome. All the rafts were destroyed and most of the force gone.

She pushed the thought away as she reached the edge of the forest. She hadn't spotted any more Horde scouts, but there had to be… Oh.

This wasn't a force on the move - they were fortifying their camp. She could see a huge catapult - not as big as the one in the yards, but bigger than expected. Couldn't be very mobile. Now where were the bombs? She pulled Entrapta's 'scanner' out of her backpack and pushed the button to activate it.

The thing blinked and she saw the symbols of a bomb light up. Only one - but that was still more than enough to wreck an attack. And it meant that the Horde had some reserves.

Damn.

She pulled out her telescope and studied the Horde camp - or growing base. Where was the bomb? It would have to be close to the catapult, to be used at a moment's notice. There were several tents nearby, but only one was guarded. And surrounded by earthen walls. Those wouldn't stop an enhanced engine bomb, of course, but that was standard procedure for Horde powder magazines in the field. And Seacat would bet that the Horde would store their enhanced bombs the same.

So… she had accomplished her mission and confirmed the likely location of a bomb. She could already withdraw, but if she was here, she might as well gather more information. The camp was quite large and quite well-organised. She quickly counted the troop tents, then the officer tents. Then she made a quick calculation. The number she came up with would fit, mostly, with what they knew about the Horde strength in the area. Not quite up to Alliance numbers, even after the losses they had taken. But with a single bomb, that could change.

Her eyes widened. Indeed, a single bomb could change the equations - both ways. If they sneaked into the camp and set the bomb off… or teleported into the magazine, set a timer and ported out… She slowly smirked. Hoisted by their own petard, as the Captain would say.

On the other hand… the Headhunters would expect that. They knew about the shrimp's powers - Lonnie had told them about the

Horde training. Only an idiot would miss the obvious threat of the princess teleporting into a camp and setting off an enhanced engine bomb. So, this was a trap. Damn. If only the shrimp could teleport a bomb… Although… Seacat cocked her head and looked at the camp, then up. Well, that might be a way to deal with it.

She studied the defences, especially the guards and patrols, then stashed her detector and telescope and started to crawl back into the forest until she was out of sight.

Then she stood and quickly made her way to the riverbank. The Horde would have posted another guard here to give advance warning should the Alliance push upriver. Now where… there!

A silent crawl, a quick jump and another Horde soldier bled out from a slashed throat. Seacat dragged the body to the shore, then dropped it and pulled out the snorkel Entrapta had built for her. Insisted to build it, actually - Seacat could've fabricated one herself, if not quite as elegant.

But whatever worked. She bit down on the mouthpiece, tasting rubber, then grabbed the dead guard and slid into the water. The river's current would drag her back to the yards more safely than making the trip on foot would be. Faster too, overall.

And the Horde wouldn't find the body as quickly as the other guard's.

*****

"So… this is likely a trap." Adora nodded, looking at the map Seacat had drawn. "You think that they'll be ready for us to try and grab the bomb."

Seacat shrugged. "It's the obvious thing to do - for them and for us."

"Exactly! Blowing the Horde up with their own weapons would be poetic justice! Hoisted by their own petard! Or Petards," Sea Hawk exclaimed.

“Which is why the Horde is ready for such an attack,” Mermista said with a snort - she was looking better after her rest, Seacat noticed.

“And they are digging in,” Brain Boy added. “The other camp is the same - one bomb left, and they’re fortifying like crazy.”

Well, he would know - the boy had scouted the eastern force.

“Quite. And we can’t let them. We need to take them out - or, at least, drive them off,” the shrimp said. “They can’t be allowed to threaten the crystal mines.”

“And how do we do that?” Mermista asked.

“I’ve got a plan,” Seacat told them. Adora wouldn’t like it, of course.

*****

“I don’t like this plan,” Adora said a little later, after the group had taken a break to grab something to eat.

“I know,” Seacat told her, grabbing a second grilled fish. And ignoring the frowns from the soldiers at the chow line. She hadn’t had decent fish in a while. And, she added after taking a bite on the way back to the command tent, she wouldn’t have any today. Damn. How could you mess up grilled fish?

“It’s dangerous.” Adora, of course, hadn’t taken a bite from her own food - she was far too fussy about things. And rules.

“More dangerous than charging the camp?” Seacat asked. “Or staying near Horde forces with enhanced engine bombs?” She smirked at the glare Adora aimed at her. That was Adora’s own fault - who would think about trying to bait the Horde into using their remaining bomb by showing herself, and hoping the shrimp could get them away after the bomb was launched? The Horde had taken their best gunners for this; they wouldn’t use a bomb if

they thought the princesses could escape. Not when they could send Headhunters after them.

But then Adora looked down at the ground, crestfallen, and Seacat felt guilt filling her. “Sorry…” She whispered.

“It’s not your fault. It’s the Horde’s.”

And wasn’t that the truth?

*****

“Alright. Everybody knows the plan?” Adora asked.

“Yes,” Seacat replied, nodding emphatically. It was her plan, after all.

Adora narrowed her eyes at her. Maybe Seacat had overdone it a little. But this was the third time her lover had asked the same question.

“Yes,” the shrimp replied. She looked determined and firm - though Seacat could tell that she was a little nervous since she was fidgeting a little when she thought no one was looking. And glancing to Brain Boy.

Brain Boy himself nodded as well. He didn’t look happy, but he wouldn’t say anything. The boy was smart, after all. Though it probably helped that he was part of the plan as well. Unlike Adora, who would have to watch from the rear.

“Good.” Adora nodded. She took a deep breath, then looked south-east, towards the location of the Horde camp across the river. “And be careful,” she added in a low voice.

Seacat nodded. She knew as well as her lover that this was dangerous. She would’ve preferred to do it at night, but the princess couldn’t see in the dark - not as well as Seacat could. Not even with the moonlight helping. So, it had to be daylight. Or close to.

She turned her head. The sun was starting to rise. Just a little longer...

She crossed her arms and leaned against the skiff that had brought the four of them here. A few yards away, the shrimp was looking over Brain Boy's shoulders as he fiddled with their cargo. "Just hold and kiss him," she muttered, shaking her head. Stupid princesses!

Adora walked over and joined her with a sigh. "I still don't like the plan," she said.

"I know. But we don't have a better one," Seacat replied. "Besides - this way, we don't risk the troops."

She could see Adora clenching her teeth - her jaw muscles twitched - just so she wouldn't say that she'd rather risk troops than Seacat. And yet, the idiot would happily risk herself rather than anyone else. "Turnabout is fair play," she said.

"Fairness has no place in war," Adora replied with a quote from one of their old instructors - Seacat couldn't actually remember who,

"I don't think they meant our situation," she told Adora.

Adora huffed, and Seacat pushed off the skiff's hull and moved to hug her. And kiss her.

*****

Once the sun was almost up, they moved to the shore. Adora handled the cargo by herself and set it down at the riverbank. While Seacat and the shrimp stripped to their underwear and Adora looked for enemies - though this far upriver, the Horde didn't have any sentries - Brain Boy conducted a last inspection.

"It's fine," he said after a minute.

“Good. Let’s get going,” the shrimp said, then stepped into the water. And shivered at the cold.

Seacat joined her a moment later, carrying the small raft they had constructed. She held it steady while Adora and Brain Boy lowered the bomb into the hole in the middle of it, then pushed it a little to check that it wouldn’t move too much. “Alright.”

“Alright.”

She looked at Adora, then turned and grabbed the handles mounted on one side, together with the shrimp. Together, they started pushing the raft towards the middle of the river while the current dragged them eastward. Towards the Horde camp.

For the first minute, neither of them said anything as they kicked their legs to propel the raft - styled to look like a piece of driftwood from one side - onward.

“I really hope this works,” the shrimp whispered when they were dragged around the last turn of the river before the Horde camp.

“It will.” Seacat didn’t tell her that it all rested on her magic. The princess was under enough pressure already. Well, so was Seacat - she had no doubt that Queen Angella wouldn’t be pleased at all if Seacat’s plan got her daughter hurt or killed. Well, any wounds, Adora could heal, but still…

“What if I miss?”

“You won’t.”

They were now almost at the camp - or, rather, at the part of the shore closest to the camp; the camp hadn’t been built directly at the river, but so far away that the Horde soldiers would be able to use an enhanced bomb without endangering themselves.

“Alright,” Seacat said. “Ready?”

“Yes.” The shrimp took a deep breath and pulled herself on to the raft, on top of the bomb. A moment later, she and the bomb vanished in a sparkling cloud.

Seacat immediately looked up in the sky. The princess should appear… there! She caught the flash of sparkles and saw a figure appear in mid-air, starting to fall - and disappear a moment later, to reappear nearby.

Then she saw the figure split - and half of it vanish again while the other half kept falling.

She whirled, scanning the river. Where…

A splash sounded to her right. She caught the water sprout collapsing - the shrimp had landed in the river, as planned. Now they just had to…

Behind her, the bomb went off. Seacat turned to look in the direction of the camp. That hadn’t been…

Then she heard another, louder explosion, and a cloud of smoke appeared above the riverbank, followed by more explosions.

The princess had dropped the bomb on the Horde’s powder magazine. As planned. “Great work!” she muttered, turning to look for the shrimp. If the impact had knocked her out...

Just in time for the princess to resurface, spluttering and gasping, about twenty yards off. Seacat grinned, relieved, and started to pull the now empty raft towards the princess.

“This was…” The princess shook her head as she managed to grab the handles of the raft again.

“...great?” Seacat asked.

“Terrifying!” The princess took a deep breath. “I had to adjust my position, and I was falling the whole time…”

“But you did it,” Seacat told her as the river dragged them around another bend. “The Horde’s camp is wrecked.”

“Yes.” Glimmer smiled, showing her teeth. “And now we can mop up the remains.”

Seacat grinned in return. “One down, one to go.”

*****

The Counter-Attack

By the time the Alliance's vanguard arrived at the camp Glimmer had bombed, the Horde had barely managed to get organised enough to sift through the rubble and shredded tents the explosions had left. And Seacat and Glimmer had barely managed to get out of the river at the rally spot where Adora and Brain Boy were waiting with the skiff.

"We should be on the other side," Adora said. "Leading the charge."

"Well, then someone else would've had to drive us upriver," Seacat told her. She grinned at the glare Adora sent her way.

"So that was your plan!" Adora pouted.

She shrugged. "It was obvious, wasn't it?" Skiffs couldn't go over water. Well, not water deeper than a puddle or some shallow creek, at least. Basically, anything deep enough to sink a skiff would stop it. "I thought you'd have realised it."

Adora scowled, but Glimmer and Brain Boy giggled.

"Adora was far too concerned about you to think about attacking the Horde afterwards," Brain Boy said. "Besides, they don't need us. Netossa and Spinnerella are veterans; they'll deal with any organised resistance."

"But there are still Headhunters in the camp…" Adora clenched her teeth.

"And they'll handle them," Seacat said as she pulled her clothes on. If two princesses backed by troops of their own didn't manage to handle a disoriented bunch of Horde soldiers woken up by their camp blowing up, then that would be their own fault.

"I can teleport us over," Glimmer said.

“No. We need you with as much magic left for emergencies as possible,” Seacat told her. “We can take the raft back to the yards.” She cocked her head. “I don’t hear guns, anyway.” Which meant the Horde wouldn’t have been able to deploy their guns. And the catapult wouldn’t have survived the explosions intact.

“Alright.” Adora’s tone told Seacat that it wasn’t alright, but there was nothing she could do about it. By the time they would reach the shore opposite the former Horde yards, where their raft was waiting for them, the battle would be over.

*****

Seacat had been right. The Horde troops hadn’t been able to put up much resistance in the wake of the explosions ripping through their camp.

“...and then I ripped the gate off, Netossa took out the two guns with her nets, and we stormed in. Organised resistance ceased right afterwards,” Spinnerella said.

“Their leader had died in the explosions,” Netossa added.

“Their leader? The leader of the Headhunters?” Adora asked.

Netossa shook her head. “No. That one is in the eastern camp.”

“Too bad. We should’ve hit that one first,” Spinnerella said.

“This one’s closer to the crystal mines,” Netossa reminded her wife. “We had to take out this force first.”

The Horde could circumvent the yards, fall back towards the south, then move up north to the river - and the mines - but they would have to supply their soldiers overland, and after the loss of the yards and now the western camp, that would strain their logistics. But the Alliance still had Horde forces to the east. And with at least one working enhanced engine bomb, they couldn’t use the Salinean fleet to secure the river.

“So, we do the same to the eastern camp?” Glimmer asked, looking eager.

Adora, though, winced. “Repeating the same tactic isn’t a good idea,” she said. “They will be prepared for that.”

“How would they know what we did?” Brain Boy asked. “I doubt there were any witnesses.”

“They will know that there were explosions, and then the camp was stormed,” Seacat said. “Their screening forces will have escaped.”

“Yes, but they won’t know how we did it,” Glimmer said. “I can just teleport above them, as before, and - boom!”

Netossa shook her head. “They will expect us to have either sneaked in saboteurs or launched a bomb with a hidden catapult or mortar. That means they’ll reinforce their powder magazines enough to withstand a shell.”

And that meant the magazines would withstand the sort of bomb Glimmer could teleport as well.

“I can still destroy the catapult,” Glimmer said.

“Yes, you can. But that would leave them with an enhanced engine bomb in the camp - ready to be used should we storm it,” Seacat pointed out. Glimmer could scowl almost as well as Adora, she noted.

“And they would use it,” Brain Boy said.

“Yes,” Lonnie spoke up. “They’re ready to sacrifice themselves to get us. And even if there aren’t any princesses around - if they’re about to lose the camp and the bomb anyway…?” She shrugged.

“Well, we do need to find a way to deal with the camp,” Adora said. “We can’t leave them - and their bomb - to threaten our lines.”

“Well…” Entrapta spoke up with a slight grimace. “I could probably construct a firebomb. If their magazines are burning, then they can’t use them, can they?”

“That might block their use of the enhanced engine bomb,” Seacat said. “But won’t they put the fire out before we can reach them?” And Glimmer would have to hit the exact spot.

“Well, if I use a concoction I discovered looking for alternative fuel for engines, they won’t be able to put it out unless they can smother it - and that would take some time given the heat of the burning fuel.” Entrapta still looked queasy. “But it would be, well… it would burn everything. And everyone. And it’s kinda dangerous when exposed to air.”

“Ah.” If Entrapta was hesitant - and called something ‘dangerous’ - then Seacat was sure that the thing was too dangerous to be used at all. Perhaps…

A courier entering the command room interrupted them. “Commander!” She saluted Glimmer. “We’ve got word from our patrols. The Horde force to the east is moving!”

“Moving?” Adora asked.

“They’re packing up their tents and supplies,” the courier replied.

“And the catapult?” Entrapta asked.

“That, too,” the courier told her.

“Oh. So if we time it, we can judge how mobile they are - sort of,” Entrapta said. “We would still need to check how quickly they can set up a catapult, but it would be a start and give us an estimate.”

“Where are they going?” Seacat asked

“We don’t know yet - they’ve sent scouting forces everywhere,” the courier told her. “Except for across the river, of course.”

“They won’t be moving towards us,” Mermista said. “And they can’t cross the river. It’s either south or east.”

“Linking up with the forces in the forest south of Fortress Freedom, or heading south and possibly west to threaten the crystal mines.” Adora shook her head. “Hard to say.”

“If they try to go around us, we can shadow them all the way,” Brain Boy said. “They might as well retreat into the Fright Zone to replenish and push from there. The force across the river’s mouth would still block us from moving south from Fortress Freedom.”

“The bombs would do that,” Adora said. “If they hide a bomb in a choke point or a mountain pass…” She shook her head. “We’ll need your detectors for every scout,” she told Entrapta.

“Uh… I’ll have to get back to the fortress for that - I don’t have enough tools or materials here. Sorry.” Entrapta shrugged, but she looked rather dejected.

“We have to move to the fortress anyway,” Seacat said. “With the threat from the Horde, we can’t use the river as a supply route until they’ve been pushed back to the Fright Zone.”

“I can keep us supplied,” Perfuma pointed out. “At least with produce.”

“Yes,” Adora chimed in. “But we need a larger force at the crystal mines - and they need supplies as well. And we need to crush the pocket of Horde forces to the North of us.”

“And for that, we have to strike from the fortress. It’s the anchor point of our control of the coast.” Mermista nodded. “We also must keep up our picket lines and blockade. If they manage to slip out some enhanced bombs… All the inspections at sea we’ll have to do will add delays to our supply lines as well.”

Seacat nodded. You couldn’t inspect the cargo as it was unloaded - you had to do it at sea. And that meant you had to check the entire hold for anything big enough to hide an engine. That would

take some time - almost as long as unloading a ship took. They would have delays of up to a week or so for the bigger ships.

And all without the Horde even trying to slip a bomb past the Salinean lines… The threat of the bombs was almost as dangerous and effective as the bombs themselves. She muttered a curse under her breath.

"Alright. Let's send out our screening forces - part of them - to shadow the Horde so we know where they're moving to," Adora said. "And we'll split our troops here - half march back to the crystal mines, half to the fortress. We'll leave a garrison, half here half across the river in a permanent camp, with the yards rigged to blow."

"And we'll need patrols along the whole river to know if the Horde tries to cross it," Seacat added.

"Yes." Glimmer nodded. "And I'll have to go back to Bright Moon to recharge - and talk to Mom."

Seacat noticed Adora glancing at her. Ah. They'd have to split up, then - Adora would have to go back with Glimmer and Brain Boy. Mermista and the captain were needed at the coast, but Adora was needed at Bright Moon. Especially if the Horde threatened the city as well.

"You'll have to go back as well." She nodded at her lover, who winced in return.

"And we'll need Netossa and Spinnerella with Perfuma at the crystal mine," Glimmer added.

The three princesses nodded in agreement, though a little reluctantly, or so Seacat thought. Well, tough for them - the crystal mines were essential; now more than ever. Without them, the Horde would eventually run out of bombs. Probably.

"I'll send Colonel Kilian up here to take command of the yards," Mermista said.

Adora nodded. So did Seacat - the Colonel was a marine; he would understand best how to cover the river.

"So… I think we've settled everything," Adora said. "For now."

"Yes, I…"

Once more, they were interrupted by a courier rushing into the room. But this man looked frightened. "Ma'am! Sir! The Horde destroyed Fortress Freedom!"

*****

The fortress hadn't been completely destroyed. The citadel was still standing, Seacat saw as they approached on their skiff. And the earthen fortifications looked more or less intact - at least from this side. Perhaps the report had been exaggerated. Sent in the heat of the moment, without waiting for a proper assessment of the damage.

But when they passed through the northern gate of the fortress, it was instantly obvious that the reports hadn't been exaggerated. The harbour was gone. Moles and piers and walls were so much rubble - or missing entirely. The waterfront was gone as well. Warehouses and alehouses swept away or caved in. And the smell… The explosion must have sent a wave through most of the fortress, leaving puddles and flooded cellars.

And, Seacat added to herself after another sniff, corpses that were starting to stink.

"All the supplies in the port are gone," Adora said.

"As are most of the ships which were in port," Mermista added, looking grim. "That's the main mast of the 'Salinean Pride' there.

Which had been the flagship of the squadron stationed in the fortress. Now all that was left of it was the top of the mast visible above the water, still flying her colours. Seacat could see the remains of two cargo ships, Kingdom of Snows cogs, spread over

the waterfront. And a courier ship that had been thrown into a gun emplacement. She could see two frigates and two cutters cruising about a mile out and quickly ran through the list of the other ships stationed at the port in her head.

"So the Shark's Tooth and Pride of the Gate survived," the Captain beat her to the point.

"Enough to stop any attempt to cross the river - unless they have another bomb ready," Mermista said.

'Unless they have a bomb' would be added to a lot of sentences from now on.

"If they had the means to cross the river, they would've done so," Adora pointed out. "This would've been the perfect opportunity - blast the port, then land before the soldiers can recover."

Seacat glanced around as they walked up towards the citadel. Judging by the looks of the soldiers digging through rubble and other debris, most of the soldiers hadn't recovered yet. They looked either still shocked or dejected. "They could've built rafts in the forest," she said. "The shore isn't ideal for a landing operation, but they could've tried." And probably succeeded.

"They would've lost a lot of troops, though," Adora retorted. "As long as any Salienan ship would've been in range."

"They don't need to take the fortress," Mermista replied. "With all the supplies here gone, we only have the citadel's stocks left. That won't be enough for our forces in the area. We need to either pull the troops out and move them to another port or rush more supplies in."

And the only way to rush in supplies would be to call on Perfuma. Who was needed at the crystal mines. Or to create a fleet of rafts and ship supplies downriver, which would take a lot of soldiers, and make them vulnerable to raids.

Damn. “How did they manage it, anyway?” Seacat exclaimed. “It looks like the bomb exploded right inside the port.”

“They must have smuggled it inside underwater,” Mermista replied. “I gave strict orders to inspect every cargo ship.”

Damn fishpeople.

“My workshop is gone.” Entrapta spoke for the first time since they had entered the city. “All my prototypes. My materials. My bots…” She sniffed.

Seacat reached over and wrapped the princess in a hug. “We’ll rebuild.” Probably not here, though, but somewhere safer. “And Emily survived.” Because the bot had been with Entrapta.

Entrapta nodded with a weak smile. “Yes.” Then she sighed again. “But my other workshops are in Dryl or Salineas - that’s quite far away.”

That would make them safer. Probably; Salinas was a priority target for the Horde since it controlled the sea lanes on this coast. And every frigate defending Salineas wasn’t blockading Horde ports. And Dryl was far in the mountains. But they needed Entrapta’s bombs quickly; the shorter the route to the front, the better.

They reached the citadel. Colonel Kilian met them there. The man had a bandage wrapped around his head, covering one eye, and his uniform looked dusty and had some fresh tears, but otherwise, he looked as usual. “Princess!” He saluted.

“Colonel.” Mermista returned the greeting. “What’s the situation?”

“Bad,” the man snapped as they entered the courtyard. “We’ve lost the harbour and most of the troops outside the citadel. The stockpiled rations will last for two months, at best - with the current troop strength in the fortress.” He looked at Mermista.

“We planned to send the landing forces back from the yard,” the princess told him. “But given the new situation…”

“We do need more troops to hold the fortress. And to repair the most crucial fortifications and docks.”

“Yes,” Adora chimed in. “We can’t abandon the fortress - that would give the Horde access to the forces trapped in the northern area and control of the river.”

“Can we afford to rebuild an entire fortress?” Seacat asked. Silently, she added: And can we keep it safe from more bombs?”

“We have to. We lose all our gains if we lose it.” Glimmer looked all grim and determined.

But it was good that she understood how important the fortress was.

*****

“How are things?”

Adora! Seacat turned away from the piece of rubble she had been inspecting in the remains of the waterfront and smiled at her lover. “Do you want the good news or the bad news first?”

“Bad news first,” Adora said.

Seacat snorted - she had expected that. Adora was always the sort of girl to pick work before pleasure. “The supplies are an almost total loss. The food’s rotting as we speak - it was covered in seawater. From the port.” And every sailor knew how filthy that water was. “Some barrels with pickled vegetables and cured meat might still be useful, but most of them were broken when the shockwave hit.” The rats were having a feast, too - and that wouldn’t be pretty once they bred. Seacat shuddered at the thought. “We’re still finding bodies, too.” Some of them gnawed-upon as well. Filthy vermin!

“And the good news?”

“Mermista can recover the guns of the sunken frigate. Which means we can rebuild the fortifications and convert the rest to field guns. Or put them on merchantmen.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded but didn’t look very happy about the good news. Well, they weren’t really good news. Just… not as bad as they could’ve been.

“What about the citadel?” Seacat asked.

“It’s in good shape. But…”

“We need more than a citadel. We need a port to supply the troops here and up the coast,” Seacat said.

“That, too,” Adora agreed. She looked around - they were alone for the moment - and sat down on a broken column of the warehouse that had been standing here before. “Entrapta’s working on a new workshop in the citadel.”

“That’s good.” Seacat smiled - the princess wasn’t happy unless she could work on her inventions.

“It is, but…” Adora sighed again. “She can’t do everything. And we need so much from her…”

“Oh.” Right. Entrapta was the Alliance’s only source of engines and enhanced engine bombs. And bots and other inventions. Like the rockets she was planning to make. Seacat muttered a curse. “It’s like with Perfuma. If we lose her, we lose the war.”

“Yes. But even if nothing happens to her - and nothing will happen to her! - it might not be enough.” Adora looked grim. “She just can’t build everything we need. And she can’t teach others. Not quickly enough to have them take over.”

Damn. Seacat should’ve seen this. Unlike Perfuma, Entrapta couldn’t just use magic and make things grow - she had to make

everything by hand. And by hair. “And she lost most of her bots. Those helped her.”

“Yes. She can repair and rebuild them, but that will take time as well,” Adora told her.

“Time we don’t have,” Seacat said. She closed her eyes and clenched her teeth. Damn. This was worse than she had feared. “And if we fall back, abandon our gains, we won’t be facing the old Horde, but a Horde with enhanced engine bombs.” And Headhunters.

“Yes. Advancing against them will be much harder than it was before.”

And much more dangerous. Headhunters would adapt to the bombs very quickly. And strike at the Princesses. “We need a new plan, then,” Seacat said.

“Yes.” Adora looked at her. “Do you have any ideas?”

Her lover looked so hopeful, despite the situation… Seacat closed her eyes again. “I’ve got an idea. But it’s very, very dangerous,” she said, glancing at her friend.

Adora nodded with a determined expression.

*****

“A decapitation strike?” Mermista sounded, well… not as angry as Seacat had feared. But the princess wasn’t happy. “Into the heart of the Fright Zone?”

“Yes.” Seacat stood a little straighter.

“That’s a suicide mission.” Mermista crossed her arms over her chest. “You’ve managed once, but they’ll be ready for another attempt - they won’t be fooled again. They’ll have shored up their weaknesses and changed procedures.”

“And it was a rescue mission,” Brain Boy added. “Not an attempt to take out Hordak.”

“And Shadow Weaver,” Seacat said.

“Shadow Weaver isn’t a priority. She doesn’t build the bombs and engines,” Adora said.

Seacat clenched her teeth. Adora was correct. But still… Seacat wanted that witch dead. “She’s his second in command. If we take her out as well, the Horde will collapse. We don’t have to hunt for her, but if the opportunity presents itself...”

Mermista looked, if anything, even more dubious, but Sea Hawk nodded. “Indeed - a daring strike into the heart of the enemy! That’s the spirit! They think we will retreat, they think they have us on the ropes, but we will turn the tables on them!”

“It’s a suicide mission,” Mermista repeated herself.

“It’s not,” Glimmer said. “If we plan it right, prepare and with a little luck…”

“That’s not exactly encouraging,” Mermista commented as the other princess trailed off.

“It’s not as if we have a choice,” Seacat said.

“The Horde can’t make unlimited numbers of bombs. Not as long as we hold the crystal mines,” Brain Boy pointed out.

“They don’t need to make many bombs. Just the threat of them being used is crippling us,” Seacat retorted. “They can pick their targets - we need to treat every attack as a lethal threat.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed. “We need to strike at them now. And finish this, once and for all.”

Seacat nodded. One way or the other.

It was do or die, as the Captain would say. “So, we do need to… kill Hordak.” Seacat didn’t like her slight hesitation there, but she didn’t want to mince words. Even if Entrapta winced a little. “He’s not just the leader of the Horde; he’s also responsible for their technology.”

“So, he’s like my counterpart,” Entrapta said with a frown.

“If you were a homicidal monster, yes,” Mermista told her. “Did you ever feel the urge to crush and enslave your neighbours? Or your own people?”

Entrapta blinked and wrinkled her nose. “I don’t think so, no.”

Seacat glared at Mermista - the princess should’ve known that Entrpata didn’t deal well with rhetorical questions. At least Mermista looked like she regretted her quip. “So, you’re not his counterpart any more than Scorpia is Adora’s counterpart just because she’s a Force Captain and one of the Horde’s best fighters,” Seacat told Entrapta.

“And a princess,” Entrapta pointed out.

“Technically a princess,” Mermista retorted. “They only claimed that to meddle with our alliance at the Princess Prom,” she added with a scowl.

“Indeed. They abused the terms and customs of the event,” Sea Hawk said, nodding several times. “Instead of celebrating and partying, they pursued their own plans.”

“That’s actually what the Princess Prom evolved from,” Brain Boy told them. “It was originally a meeting of royalty to discuss politics and settle disputes. The ball was added some time afterwards. It only started to be known as the Princess Prom when most kingdoms started to use the occasion to debut their heirs.”

“Fascinating!” Entrapta piped up. “The social dynamics that would lead to the ball part usurping the original function must be very interesting.”

Mermista pressed her lips together. “Yeah, yeah, I’m sure. But we were talking assassinations, not ballroom dancing.”

“That can be the same thing,” Glimmer said.

“Really?” Entrapta leaned forward. “I wasn’t aware of that.”

“Well, you could hide quite a number of weapons under a ballgown…” Adora started to say.

Seacat cleared her throat. Loudly. “I don’t think Hordak will be found dancing any time soon. Can we focus on assassinating him and Shadow Weaver?”

“Of course!” Sea Hawk replied. He coughed into his fist. “As was pointed out before, the Horde will surely have changed procedures and plugged the holes in their perimeter that we exploited during our last foray into the Fright Zone. But given the sheer length of their borders, I have no doubt that we can slip through the enemy lines without being detected.”

“That’s the enemy lines. But the core areas of the Fright Zone?” Adora shook her head. “They’ll have them locked down tightly since they can’t afford to lose the factories.”

“And Hordak himself will be even better protected in his throne room,” Mermista said.

“Uh. He’s usually in his, uh, laboratory?” Adora said. “He doesn’t really do the throne room thing much. Only for some ceremonies, like my promotion to, ah, Force Captain.” She looked away, and Seacat reached up to pat her shoulder.

“So, you could make whoever is his assistant get him out of his workshop and into the throne room?” Entrapta asked.

Seacat was sure that Entrapta was projecting, but it was a valid suggestion - if you weren’t aware of how the Horde leadership worked. “That would be Shadow Weaver,” she said.

“Oh.”

“But we’re putting the cart before the horse,” Glimmer cut in. “First, we need a way to infiltrate the core of the Fright Zone. And we’ll have to be able to study the area before we can strike - we can’t just drop in and fight our way through.”

“We can’t be seen,” Seacat added. “If Hordak or Shadow Weaver realise most of the princesses fighting the Horde are in the Fright Zone, they might blow the entire area up to get them.” She would at least consider it, in their place - kill the princesses, even just the ones present here, and the alliance would fall apart. Without Mermista, the admirals would try to rule Salineas, and she didn’t trust them to rule their own ships, much less a kingdom. Bright Moon might keep fighting if Glimmer were killed, but they wouldn’t be doing any better than they had done before Adora became She-Ra. And without Adora… well, not that anything would matter any more if Adora were dead.

“Great,” Mermista said, scoffing. “We can’t even be seen. And we have to be seen at the frontlines, or nearby, or they’ll suspect something is up.”

“And we need to keep up the Alliance’s morale,” Glimmer said.

“So, we’ll need disguises,” Seacat said. “We need to pass as Horde soldiers.”

“That won’t work for long - they’ll notice we’re not with a unit there,” Adora told her.

“Did they tighten security? Used to be, you could pass almost anywhere if you claimed to have orders,” Seacat replied. “So, we could slip some fake orders into the administration offices.”

“There are ways to spot that, but… would they expect that?” Glimmer said.

“Not if we replace an existing force,” Seacat, grinning. “We’ll have to take out some soldiers on the way back and take their place.”

“Passing as Horde soldiers?” Brain Boy still looked sceptical. “We don’t know their regulations and customs…” He trailed off.

Adora smiled. “Don’t worry! I can teach you! And train you! When we’re done, you’ll be able to pass as Horde soldiers anywhere!”

Seacat grimaced. Adora was her best friend. Her lover. Her partner. But she had a thing about training. And regulations. A very unreasonable thing.

Damn.

“We still need to plan our insertion,” Seacat said. “And how we kill Hordak.” And Shadow Weaver.

Adora raised her sword. “This should work. It can cut anything.”

“I didn’t mean that,” Seacat explained. “And Entrapta’s blades can cut anything as well. I meant, how do we keep them, him, from fleeing as soon as we get close.”

“Indeed. Such a fiend will have escape plans - multiple ones. At the very least, he’ll have an escape tunnel or two. And a fast vehicle ready to take him away,” Sea Hawk added.

“And body doubles,” Mermista said. “He must know that he’s the key to the Horde’s survival and success, so he’ll have decoys.”

“Shadow Weaver is his second in command,” Seacat agreed. “Of course he’ll have body doubles, if only so she won’t kill him to take his place.”

“Shadow Weaver wouldn’t do that,” Adora protested. “Or she would have done it already,” she added before Seacat could chew her out. “He must have safeguards, too, to control her.”

Seacat nodded. “She was willing to murder me and any witnesses just to get rid of a… ‘distraction’,” she spat. “She’d have killed him if she thought she could get away with it.”

“That just means we’ll need to study the situation very carefully before we strike,” Glimmer said. Brain Boy, unsurprisingly, nodded in agreement.

“But we can’t spend too much time, or the Horde will realise that the princesses aren’t at the frontlines,” Seacat objected. “And body doubles won’t cut it for most of you. We need a cover story or something.” You couldn’t fake magic, after all.

“I know!” Adora piped up with a wide smile. “We’re searching for a super-weapon to win the war in… uh…” She chewed her lower lip. “...the Whispering woods?”

“Too close to the frontlines,” Glimmer said, shaking her head.

“And if the Horde wanted to, and didn’t care about casualties, they could push into the forest,” Brain Boy pointed out.

“The Crimson Waste!” Sea Hawk said. “A vast, mysterious desert full of rumours and myths! The Horde’s entire army could search for us there and wouldn’t be able to find us in a year or more!”

“And how do we lure the Horde into the desert?” Glimmer asked. “And keep them from launching an offensive at us while they think we’re away?”

Seacat winced. That was a very good point - if the Horde thought most of the princesses were gone for weeks, they would launch an offensive. And despite the losses the Horde took, they still outnumbered the Alliance. “We need to keep them guessing,” she said. “Make them think it might be a ruse to lure them into overextending themselves or attacking before they are ready or something.”

“That would work. Neither Hordak nor Shadow Weaver likes to attack without intel.” Adora nodded.

“But they have spies in our ranks,” Brain Boy said. “They could quickly find out the truth if we’re unlucky.”

“Then we fool our own people as well,” Seacat retorted. “Tell some that we’re looking for a super-weapon, others we tell to be ready to ambush the Horde attacks…”

“That would be a good thing anyway,” Glimmer said. “They need to be ready to receive attacks.”

“But then that might not help us convince the Horde that we aren’t actually in the Crimson Waste.” Mermista shook her head.

Seacat clenched her teeth. She hated such mind games. Unless she was winning, of course.

“We have to take the risk,” Adora said. She looked firm and determined. “Even if the Horde attacks our troops while we’re away, even if they advance and take more territory - it’s worth it if we can take out Hordak.”

“And Shadow Weaver,” Seacat added.

Adora didn’t react. “If we don’t stop Hordak, we’ll be beaten by his bombs - and by the threat of his bombs. We can’t outlast him like that.”

“I can build bombs,” Entrapta said. “A lot of bombs.”

“You can - but then you couldn’t do anything else. Hordak has factories and manufactories,” Adora told the princess.

“But we were winning before the bombs,” Entrapta protested.

“Yes. But the bombs changed everything,” Seacat told her. “We can’t risk more bomb attacks. That means we need more people securing ports. More scouts. Moving troops to safety. Spreading out. Better perimeters. And we need to secure the passes and more. Before, if a dozen Horde soldiers sneaked into Bright Moon territory, they couldn’t do much. Now?” She clenched her teeth and shook her head.

“Yes,” Adora went on. “Before, we had the advantage that a few of us could do a lot of damage, which meant the Horde had to deploy lots of troops to react to us and put up guards. Now, we’re in the same situation - but we don’t have enough troops to cover everything and attack them.”

“We might not have enough troops to cover everything, period,” Glimmer said. She sighed. “Mom will hate it - for a variety of reasons - but this is the best chance we have.”

“Then let’s make sure we have the best chance for success.” Seacat grinned.

*****

“Alright, you maggots! Another lap! And run as if your life depended on it! The last to arrive will serve as target dummy for your close quarter combat training! Run! And no cheating!”

Adora was channelling their old instructors perfectly, in Seacat’s opinion. Then again, her lover had had four years more experience with them, so Adora was bound to remember them better.

She didn’t run as fast as she could, of course. That got you singled out. And the only one she knew about who hadn’t been hurt for getting singled out by the instructors was Adora because Adora had been the perfect cadet. And Shadow Weaver’s pet cadet.

“Faster! I’ll have your guts or breakfast if you don’t run faster! I’ll drag you behind a skiff!”

“This… Adora’s really overdoing it!” Glimmer huffed as she tried to keep pace.

“She’s not overdoing it,” Seacat corrected her. “She hasn’t even used a shock rod to motivate us.”

“What?” Glimmer stumbled as she turned her head to stare at Seacat.

“On the lowest setting, of course,” Seacat added. You couldn’t run faster if your muscles locked up, after all.

“That’s… that’s…”

“No talking! If you can talk, you’re not running fast enough!” Adora bellowed.

Damn. Seacat had forgotten about that bit. She urged herself to run a little faster. Mostly to keep Glimmer running fast enough. Brain Boy was sprinting ahead - he should’ve known better. No, he wouldn’t have known better. The boy had never gone through basic training, hadn’t he?

“No cheating, Entrapta! Use your legs, not your hair!”

“But I’m faster using my hair!”

“I don’t care, you maggot! Run!”

“But that’s inefficient!”

“I’ll give you inefficient if you use your hair for another step!”

“That doesn’t make any sense…”

Perhaps Adora was getting a little too much into her role…

*****

“If... every… Horde… soldier… gets… through... this…” Glimmer managed to say between gulping down air. She hadn’t even bothered to move from where she had collapsed after Adora had finally called the exercise.

“Every cadet does,” Seacat told her.

“It’s inefficient,” Entrapta complained. “And illogical. People should train according to an exercise regime tailored for their state of health.”

Seacat looked at the princess. She didn’t seem to be as out of breath as the others. Then again, she had been arguing with Adora for quite some time while running. Mermista, though, was pretty much asleep in Sea Hawk’s arms. “Well, that’s not how the Horde does it. One size fits all,” she told Entrapta.

“But that doesn’t make any sense!”

Seacat suppressed a sigh. “But that’s what they do.”

“They don’t want to get the most out of every soldier - they want troops that act, think and fight the same,” Adora said. “It’s about control.”

“Oh.”

Seacat glanced at Adora. Was that what she had learned as a cadet or realised after deserting? Judging by the reactions of the rest of the group, who were listening to their talk, this was news to them as well. “Yes. If you weren’t a good little soldier, you got punished - even if you got results.”

Adora winced at that but nodded. “Yes. The Horde’s entire strategy is based upon that. They need soldiers who follow orders without thinking.”

“But you can’t win a war like that,” Brain Boy protested. “You need to be able to adapt and change plans - exploit opportunities and counter enemy actions.”

“That’s the duty of the officers,” Adora said.

“And they’re trained differently?” Glimmer asked, sitting up and leaning against Brain Boy.

“They receive additional training after basic training,” Adora told them. “But everyone goes through basic training.”

“And that explains why the Horde is so bad at reacting to surprises,” Seacat said with a grin. “Most of the officers never really unlearn their training.”

“Enough of them do,” Adora corrected her. “And the Headhunters are proof that the Horde’s changing as well.”

“Wait…” Glimmer narrowed her eyes at them. “You mean we could skip this torture and pass for Headhunters?”

“We want to pass as harmless rear echelon troops,” Adora reminded the princess. “Headhunters draw attention. No one wonders what regular troops are doing.”

“Great…” Glimmer closed her eyes. “I can already feel my brain shrinking.”

“Good!” Adora beamed at her. “That means we can now start on standing at attention and saluting properly, Horde-stye.”

Seacat joined the others in groaning. She didn’t need flashbacks to that part of her training.

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The Whispering Woods

Lying on her stomach, hiding in the bushes at the edge of the Whispering Woods, Seacat studied the hills across the creek through her telescope. “I don’t see any Horde lookouts,” she said.

“Neither do I,” Brain Boy, lying on the ground at her side, replied.

“Don’t they have the entire Whispering Woods picketed?” Seacat asked. That was what they had been told, after all. And it made good sense - the Whispering Woods were the easiest route for Alliance forces to raid the Fright Zone. They allowed small groups to sneak up onto enemy territory undetected and offered a quick retreat.

“They usually have,” Brain Boy confirmed. “But the Horde has been shifting troops around lately.”

So she had heard as well. “But to abandon the entire frontline here…” That felt wrong.

“It’s not exactly a frontline,” Brain Boy said. “They only have a few bases covering this part.”

“Which rely on scouts and lookouts to allow them to counter any intrusions.” She scoffed. There should be a skiff or two patrolling the area. Or some hidden lookout. “Let’s take a look at their closest base once night has fallen.”

Brain Boy made an agreeing noise.

They crawled back deeper into the woods, until they were out of sight of any hidden watcher, then made their way back to their camp. It wasn’t long - ten minutes later, they stepped into their camp, hidden beneath the hanging branches of a Willow.

Adora beamed at them as soon as she saw them, then coughed and schooled her features. “Report?”

Seacat shrugged. “We didn’t spot the Horde lookouts.”

“They might’ve been withdrawn,” Brain Boy added. “I don’t know where they could be hidden unless they dug into the hills. We wouldn’t be able to spot them from here, not at that distance.”

Or any distance, Seacat silently added.

“Our scouts didn’t report any such activity,” Glimmer said. “And you can’t dig tunnels without having to dump all the excavated earth.”

“We can’t underestimate them,” Seacat told them. “If they worked at night…”

“They couldn’t have done this quickly enough to avoid being noticed - our scouts routinely cross the frontlines,” Glimmer retorted.

“And we know the Horde is shifting troops around for an offensive up north - or against the crystal mines,” Adora said.

“But this is their most vulnerable flank,” Seacat insisted. “They can’t afford to leave it open.” It felt like a trap.

“And we can’t afford to focus so many princesses for a decapitation raid,” Adora shot back. “But we’re taking the risk.”

She was right, damn it. But assuming the enemy was making a mistake generally wasn’t a good way to plan an attack. Wishful thinking didn’t win battles, as the Captain had taught her.

“While we shouldn’t underestimate the enemy, neither can we afford to waste time worrying about potential dangers,” Sea Hawk spoke up as if prompted while Mermista scowled for some reason. “We have to find a suitable unit moving towards the Fright Zone heartlands to intercept and replace.”

“Then we move into the Fright Zone at night, when the Horde guards won’t see us from afar,” Adora said. “We check out the

closest base, then follow their supply lines southwards."

"You still planning to have us shuttle any prisoners back?" Lonnie asked from where she was sitting with Kyle and Rogelio. "We know the Fright Zone best of us all."

"Yes." Adora nodded.

"That's why you'll be seen by enemy spies," Seacat added. "The Horde won't expect us to infiltrate their heartlands without you along."

"Sounds a bit too complicated to me," Lonnie shot back with a frown.

Well, that was why Lonnie had never been considered as officer material. That and the fact that for all their guts, none of the three recent deserters was particularly powerful in battle. They weren't princesses, for one. Rogelio was strong - but his claws couldn't cut through armour, and he wasn't particularly quick, either. Lonnie was tough and skilled, but not exceptionally so, nor was she as smart as the Captain. And Kyle was… Kyle. Taking them into the heart of the Fright Zone was as good as sending them to their deaths. Of course, Lonnie knew that and still asked to come along, which said a lot about her.

"That's settled, then," Adora said.

Seacat snorted. It had been settled days ago when they had finished planning the mission on the way to Bright Moon.

Adora glanced at her with a slight frown, then went on: "So… while we wait, I'll go check if there's more information to be had from a local."

Seacat stiffened and pressed her lips together so she wouldn't curse. She knew what Adora meant. "I'll come with you."

Adora looked at her, then nodded after a moment's hesitation.

Seacat grinned. She wouldn't let her lover visit that damn broken bot by herself.

Then Entrapta piped up with a wide smile. "Oh! Can I come as well?"

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"So… this is, like, a relic from the First Ones. A stationary bot with an interface that allows it to talk to you. Wow!" Entrapta shook her head. Which, since she was travelling by hair through the woods, made her body jerk around a little.

"Yes." Adora looked a little strained. That wasn't surprising since Entrapta had peppered her with questions for the whole trip - and this was about the third time Adora repeated herself.

"It's so exciting!" Entrapta squeed. "The First Ones were far more advanced than we are, technologically, at least! I don't know if they were as advanced where magic is concerned - the records I managed to examine were spotty - but their technology! They were supposed to have been able to fly! True flight, not hovering using the Earth magic effect, like skiffs do."

"Earth magic effect?" Adora asked. "Like… the soil? That's what Perfuma uses?"

"No, no, she uses a Runestone, the Heart-Blossom, which gives her powers over plant life. Earth Magic is magic related to the earth part of the planet, conceptually. It's like a big field, and sorcerers tap into it to work magic. And princesses without a runestone, which I think are actually only specialised sorcerers. That's my hypothesis, at least - I'm not a sorceress, you know. But I've read some books about it. I wanted to visit Mystacor, but, well, I never got around to it. Always something coming up - new find, new experiment, rebuilding the lab, and the war happened."

"And I tap into the Earth magic… field… as well?" Adora asked.

“I don’t know.” Entrapta shrugged. “You have a runestone fragment in your sword, right?”

“So Glimmer and Queen Angella told me,” Adora said.

“Well, it’s not big enough for a proper Runestone. Those are BIG.” Entrapta spread her hands as far as her arms would reach.

“I’ve seen Bright Moon’s Runestone, Plumeria’s and Salineas’s.” Adora looked at her sword with a weird expression.

“So, there are two classes of princesses?” Seacat asked.

“Probably? I don’t know.” Entrapta shrugged. “Does their magic define them? I’m a princess, but I don’t do magic.”

“Except for your hair,” Seacat reminded her.

“Right! That’s true!” The princess smiled at her. “Though I don’t think it’s really important. She-Ra only has shards of a Runestone, and she’s the most powerful princess in Etheria.”

“So… how many Runestones exist?” Seacat asked.

“Five. The Moonstone, the Heart-Blossom, the Pearl, the Fractal Flake - and that’s a really cool name! - and the Black Garnet.” That’s Bright Moon, Plumeria, Kingdom of Snows and the Fright Zone.”

“The Horde has a Runestone?” Seacat asked.

“I guess so,” Entrapta replied. “They also might have destroyed it when they conquered the Kingdom that was where the Fright Zone is now.”

“It’s not destroyed,” Adora told them. “Shadow Weaver uses it.”

“Oh.” Entrapta perked up. “Did she bond to it?”

“I don’t know.”

“How does she use it?”

“I don’t know.” Adora was clenching her teeth.

“Have you ever tried to use it?”

“No.”

“Do you know if anyone else tried to use it?”

“No.” And now Adora’s forehead showed a throbbing vein. She was getting annoyed.

“So, what about the First Ones? Didn’t they make Adora’s sword?” Seacat asked.

“Right! That’s what we - well, Adora - was told, wasn’t it? Although we don’t know if that’s true and whether or not they did more than just using the runestone parts as fuel or catalyst. Which wouldn’t be magic, but technology. On the other hand, if you use it to transform, it would mean it’s magic. Not just power.” Entrapta rubbed her chin. “So I guess the First Ones used magic as well. Probably.” She turned to Adora. “I could verify it if you let me run a few experiments with the sword!”

Adora all but cradled the sword in her arms and turned away. Seacat smirked at the sight. “No! I need it to battle the Horde and protect Etheria!”

“So, does that mean I can examine it once we have beaten the Horde?”

“N… maybe,” Adora told her.

“Is that a real maybe, or just another word for no?” Entrapta asked. “People use it for both, you know, and it’s kind of hard to tell. Which, I think, is the idea, but makes it hard to plan ahead.”

“It’s a maybe - we don’t know how things will be once we’ve beaten the Horde,” Adora told her with a smile.

“Ah, ok!” Entrapta beamed at her. “So, can I examine Light Hope?”

“Uh…”

“You said she was damaged - I could try to repair her! ‘I’ve repaired bots before!”

“Err…”

“And if I find out how she was made, I could make bots that can talk! And I could upgrade Emily so she can talk! Wouldn’t that be nice?”

“Ah…” Adora looked at Seacat with a helpless expression.

Seacat was torn about it herself. Repairing the broken bot? Who knew what it would do once it was repaired. On the other hand, if there was something wrong with it, and Entrapta found it… “I don’t think taking a look will do us harm.”

“Yay!”

*****

Light Hope’s place hadn’t changed since her last visit. At least as far as Seacat could tell. Still some half-overgrown ruin with a tall door leading into a bunker. “I don’t like this,” she muttered.

“Fascinating!” Entrapta, of course, was gushing and looking every which way, her head turning back and forth so fast, Seacat almost feared it would break off.

“Light Hope? I’m bringing guests! Friends! Not intruders.”

“Oh! Does she have anti-intruder protocols? How does she identify intruders? That was always a sticky point for me. It’s easy to program the Horde uniforms as foes - or friends; that’s what the Horde does and why they all wear the same uniforms - but that can be fooled easily by changing clothes. And it would be bad if

you lose your clothes. Or have an idea that can't wait and rush to your workshop right from your shower!"

Seacat wondered if the princess was speaking from experience. But she wouldn't ask here. Not where the bot would overhear.

They entered the big chamber where they had met the bot before. The transparent image floated there. "Hello, She-Ra," it said in its weird, cold voice.

"Oh! You look great!" Entrapta squealed.

"Who are you?" the bot asked.

"Light Hope? Entrapta. Entrapta? Light Hope. You already know Seacat."

"Hi!" Entrapta waved.

Seacat nodded - and kept an eye on the room. She wouldn't be surprised by another attempt to kill her.

"What are they doing here?"

"They're my friends!" Adora told it.

"They're a distraction from your training. You need to balance Etheria, as is She-Ra's duty."

Seacat clenched her teeth. Stupid bot!

"Balance Etheria? What do you mean?" Entrapta asked, looking up from where she was examining the walls of the room and the weird devices there.

"The planet is out of balance. She-Ra needs to restore its balance to gain enough power to protect it."

"Oh? Power? Do you mean the planetary Runestone network?" Entrapta asked. "She-Ra's a part of it? Even though she only has that small Runestone in her sword? Oh… fascinating!"

“She-Ra’s sword is the key to winning the war,” Light Hope said. “Once the balance is restored, you can use the power of the whole planet through your sword.”

Adora blinked, staring at her sword. “You mean… I could… end the war.”

“Yes, She-Ra.” The bot smiled, but it was cold and fake.

“And how can she do this?” Entrapta asked. “Because, you know, if it’s just blasting stuff, we already could do it - in theory. We just need enough enhanced bombs and - boom!”

“She will have the power to end the war,” the bot repeated itself.

“But what kind of power? Power is only useful if you can apply it. And control it. What kind of power will she have? Will her magic just be stronger?” The princess wasn’t letting this go, Seacat noted. And the bot didn’t seem to have an answer.

“Is your memory still damaged?” Adora asked.

“My data banks are in need of maintenance, but I am functional. No essential data is missing.”

“But how could you tell that nothing essential is missing if you don’t have access to your memory? You wouldn’t know if you’re missing something! Well, some missing memory you might be able to detect, but not everything.” Entrapta shook her head. “This is not logical.”

“Entrapta can repair you,” Adora said. “She’s good with bots and technology. Even First One technology.”

“This is unlikely. My technology was secret. No one but my creators would’ve known about it.” Did the bot look… off?

“The First Ones, right! I studied their technology!” Entrapta beamed at the bot. “I don’t know everything, but I can repair

some of the First One's technology! Can I take a look at your core?"

"Only She-Ra can access my core, and only if it's necessary."

"But you're damaged! It's necessary!" Adora protested.

"I am functional. As long as you can balance Etheria, I will be able to support you adequately."

"Only adequately? We can do better than that!" Entrapta nodded eagerly.

"What exactly do you want Adora to do? How does she restore balance or whatever?" Seacat asked.

"The Horde has disconnected a Runestone from the others. It isn't attuned to its wielder," the bot explained after a moment. "Once this has been fixed, the balance will be restored, and you will have the power to end the war."

Seacat felt her fur bristle. She didn't know what the bot was hiding, but she was certain that they couldn't trust it.

"We need to attune to the Runestone? The missing Runestone? The Black Garnet? Wait. No, they're keyed to their princesses. We need to find the princess and have her attune to the Runestone?" Entrapta asked.

"We know the princess. It's Scorpia," Adora said.

Seacat hissed. That was the Force Captain who almost killed her in the Fright Zone! "We can't let her attune to the Runestone!" she snapped. "She'll use it against us!"

"Etheria must be balanced," the stupid bot retorted, like a broken… well, bot. If bots could talk.

"That isn't an answer to our question," Entrapta said. "Do we need to let Scorpia attune to the Runestone?"

“That will be a little difficult,” Adora added. “She’s the enemy, after all.”

“She’s a Force Captain. If she gains magic powers from the Runestone, that would only help the Horde against us,” Seacat pointed out. Then she frowned. “And why hasn’t she attuned to the Runestone already?”

“Hordak mustn’t trust her,” Adora said. “He let Shadow Weaver have the Runestone, after all.”

“Or Shadow Weaver doesn’t want to share or lose the Runestone,” Seacat poined out.

“That’s selfish!” Entrapta chimed in. “Imagine all the data you could get from observing how a princess attunes to a Runestone!”

“That’s not exactly the point,” Seacat told her.

“It is the point! We need data to make informed decisions!” Entrapta retorted.

“But letting the Horde Princess attune to the Runestone to decide whether or not we should let her attune to it is kind of pointless.” Seacat cocked her head.

Entrapta blinked. “Oh…. right. That would defeat the purpose of gathering that data. Hm.” She looked at the flickering image of the bot again. “We need access to your data banks.”

“My data banks cannot be shared with outsiders. Only She-Ra has access to them.”

“I’m She-Ra, and I need access to them.” Adora nodded firmly.

“They’re currently inaccessible due to lack of maintenance.”

“I can repair that! Them!” Entrapta blurted out.

“You aren’t permitted access to my data storage.”

“I’ll grant her access!” Adora said. “I’ll, uh… formally allow her to repair you.”

“Negative. You do not have the clearance to do so.”

“But I’m She-Ra!”

The damn bot was more broken than Seacat had suspected. But she wasn’t sure any more if having Entrapta repair it would be a good idea. The thing had tried to kill her, after all. And this sounded… well, if the bot were a sailor, Seacat wouldn’t let it on her ship. On the other hand… “Perhaps just let Entrapta take a look at the data banks without doing anything?”

“Oh! I can do that!” The princess beamed at Seacat before looking at Adora. “Can I?”

“Uh…”

“You aren’t permitted access to my memories. That would be a breach of security and secrecy and endanger my mission.”

“What is your mission?” Entrapta asked.

“To support She-Ra in balancing Etheria and gaining the power to end the war.”

“Wait…” Adora raised a hand. Seacat looked at her and noticed that her lover was pensive. Thinking something through. “Who gave you that mission?”

“The First Ones - my creators.”

“But that was long before the war against the Horde. Which war should I end?”

That was a very good question, Seacat thought.

“There is only one war.”

Entrapta frowned. “That doesn’t make sense.”

“Well,” Seacat said. “I think it’s clear that we can’t just follow those orders without more, ah, data.” She looked at Adora.

Her friend hesitated a moment, then nodded. “We have a plan to end the war. If it works, we won’t need to have Scorpia attune to the Runestone.”

“That is the only way to gain the power to end the war,” the bot protested.

But Adora shook her head. “You’re damaged. We’ll have to repair you.”

“Yes!” Entrapta cheered.

Adora frowned at her. “After we’ve ended the war.”

“Oh.”

Seacat nodded. But she couldn’t help feeling that it would be best to destroy the bot instead.

*****

“I don’t trust the bot,” Seacat said as soon as they had left the bunker. “It’s hiding something.”

“Yes, her data,” Entrapta agreed. “She told us that.”

Well, that was correct. But not what Seacat wanted to say. “I mean, it’s hiding something important. It wants Adora to ‘balance Etheria’, but it’s really vague about the goal of that.”

“She wants me to gain more power,” Adora said. “Light Hope was clear about that.”

“But it didn’t want to explain anything,” Seacat retorted. “That’s suspicious.”

“Her data banks are damaged,” Entrapta said. “She might not know anything more than that.”

“I think it knows more than it is willing to tell us. Come on - those were cheap excuses. First, the data banks are damaged, and once Entrapta offers to repair them, the data banks are restricted? Yeah, right!” Seacat shook her head. “That’s not how honest people talk.”

“If she can lie, then that would mean she’s even more advanced than I thought!” Entrapta beamed. “Her architecture must be so advanced!”

“I don’t think Light Hope is lying,” Adora said. Seacat scowled at her, and she shrugged. “She might be under orders not to reveal anything to anyone except She-Ra.”

“Or not even to She-Ra,” Seacat said.

“Well…”

“Mara dearie!”

Seacat whirled and gasped. How had the old woman managed to sneak up on them? Seacat hadn’t heard even a footstep!

“Who’s Mara?” Entrapta asked.

“That was my predecessor as She-Ra,” Adora replied. “Madame Razz is…”

“What are you doing here?” the old woman asked.

“Looking for mushrooms,” Seacat told the obviously senile old woman - before Adora could reveal secret information that couldn’t be blapped to anyone. She glared at her lover behind the old woman’s back and made shushing gestures until Adora nodded.

“Oh! Making mushroom pies? I love mushroom pies! Although I love berry pies more. My Mara loves them as well, she does!”

“Well, we haven’t found any mushrooms, so we probably should…”

“Oh, I know all about the best mushroom spots! Come with me!” The old woman grabbed Adora’s hand and started pulling.

Seacat saw her lover grimace at her before she was pulled away - hah! As if Adora couldn’t easily resist anyone, least of all an old senile woman - around the next bush. Seacat sighed, shook her head and followed the two. “Can’t leave her alone for a moment…” she muttered.

“Well, you didn’t so far, did you?” Entrapta asked as she fell into step next to Seacat.

“And I’m not planning to, either,” Seacat told her.

“How will you do that when you’re going back to sea after the war?”

Seacat clenched her teeth, then ford herself to smile. “We’re working on that.”

“Ah!” Entrapta nodded several times, but Seacat didn’t ask what the princess had thought of.

“So, where are you planning to bake the pie?” the old woman asked when Seacat and Entrapta caught up with her and Adora.

“Uh… at the camp?” Adora said.

“You have an oven there? That’s a great camp!”

“Ah… no?” Adora shook her head, her smile now looking frozen.

“No? Then you need to use my oven! Come, come!”

And they changed direction.

“Where are we going? I thought we were gathering mushrooms!” Entrapta asked.

“To my house. The oven’s there.”

And a few steps later, they were in front of a house. Or, rather, a hut. Seacat looked around, wondering how they had missed the clearing on the way to Light Hope.

“Here’s the oven!”

And it was a big oven - much bigger than Seacat would have expected.

“I’m making pie for you, Mara. You need it, I think.”

“Ah…” Adora trailed off - apparently at a loss for words.

“Have you been visiting the ghost?” the old woman asked as she puttered with a plate of what looked like cookies.

“‘The ghost’?” Seacat asked.

Adora frowned at her, then smiled at the woman. “Light Hope isn’t a ghost.”

“She looks like a ghost, and she’s mean. She hurt you so much, Mara dearie!”

“She hurt Mara?” Adora looked surprised, so this was news to her.

Seacat leaned forward, ears twitching, and even Entrapta had stopped examining the oven. “How did she hurt Mara?” If the bot tried doing the same to Adora…

“She had a plan for her… a plan my dear Mara didn’t know. Couldn’t know. Until she did. Oh - hand me the berries, will you?”

A plan? Seacat glanced at the others. Adora had the expression she always had when she didn’t want to accept something. And Entrapta… was frowning.

“What kind of plan?” Seacat asked.

“What plan? You don’t need a plan to bake; you need a recipe, my dear.”

“No, I mean: what plan does the ghost have?” Seacat pressed her lips together. Patience - as much as she wanted to shake the truth out of the woman, that wouldn’t be a good idea. Probably.

“The ghost?”

“Mara’s ghost,” Seacat replied.

“Oh. She was mean. Mara didn’t know.”

“How was she mean?” Adora blurted out.

“You didn’t know, Mara dearie. It wasn’t your fault. And you saved everyone. Oh, flour! We need flour!”

“This doesn’t sound good,” Seacat muttered.

“Her data is very confusing and unorganised. I’m not sure if it can be trusted,” Entrapta added.

“But…” Adora trailed off, then took a deep breath. “Can Light Hope be trusted?”

The old woman stopped pouring flour into a bowl and turned to look at Adora. “Can you trust her again, Mara dearie?” She walked to Adora and reached up to caress her cheek, leaving a smear of flour on Adora’s skin. “You were so brave, saving everyone even after you found out.”

“Found out what?” Adora all but spat as she brushed flour from her cheek, missing a trace next to her ear.

“The plan.”

“What plan?”

Seacat blinked - she had asked at the same time as everyone else.

“It’s a recipe, Mara dearie!”

“But…”

They didn’t get anything else out of the confused old woman. The pie was delicious, at least.

*****

“So… the old woman thinks you’re your predecessor,” Seacat said a little later, glancing over her shoulder to check that the hut they had left wasn’t visible any more - she didn’t trust the woods here. Or the woman.

“Yes.” Adora sounded rather curt.

“She’s nice,” Entrapta said. “Much nicer than the bot.”

“But as confused,” Seacat said, stretching her arms over her head. “Although she seems honest in her confusion.” Unlike the bot. Seacat was sure that the bot was lying.

“And she thinks Light Hope is planning to hurt you,” Entrapta added.

“Yes.” Adora apparently wasn’t feeling very chatty right now.

Well, Seacat wouldn’t shut up. This was important. “So, what do you plan to do?”

“I’m planning to kill Hordak. And take out Shadow Weaver,” Adora replied.

“And what about the Runestone?” Entrapta asked. The princess was walking backwards with her hair in front of Adora, peering at her. “Light Hope is very insistent that this will end the war, and Madame Razz seems sure that this will hurt you.”

Oh, for Ocean’s sake! “You’re not going to sacrifice yourself for this, you hear me?” Seacat told her. She caught Adora twitching -

her lover was planning to do exactly that! “No, you aren’t!” she hissed.

“I said I’m going to kill Hordak and end the war,” Adora raised her chin.

“And what if ending the war takes some time? The Horde will splinter, and mopping up all of them won’t be quick or easy.” At least some soldiers would turn to banditry or piracy.

Adora hesitated a moment.

Seacat didn’t. “It won’t be a war, though. More like hunting down bandits,” she told her. “That’s not worth hurting yourself over.”

“I’m not planning to hurt myself!” Adora insisted.

“That doesn’t mean you won’t do it if you think you have to,” Seacat replied. “You don’t plan everything.” And some of Adora’s bad ideas weren’t planned at all - just spur of the moment decisions.

Adora frowned at her. “I’m not going to sacrifice others.”

“Well, it would be fascinating to see the Runestone network restored,” Entrapta said. “Though I would prefer to calculate the effects beforehand. It doesn’t always avoid explosions, but it helps.”

Adora blinked, as did Seacat. “Explosions?” they asked at the same time.

“Well… the Runestone network has been ‘out of balance’ for at least twenty years; since the Horde took over the Runestone, actually, I’d say - I lack exact data,” Entrapta, still walking backwards on her hair, explained. “But the magic didn’t simply vanish - energy doesn’t do that. And you can’t shut down Runestones like machines. So… that energy is either being siphoned off or accumulating. And if it’s the latter, then reconnecting it to the network could overload the network.”

“And that would mean…” Adora trailed off.

Entrapta nodded. “Boom!” she said, spreading her hands.

“But what if Shadow Weaver is using that power?” Adora said.

“Well… even so… suddenly connecting another power source to a network can have disastrous consequences. Overloading capacitors, melting powerlines, starting fires…” Entrapta shrugged. “It could blow up as well. I’m not a sorceress, and magic might not act like power, but… you can use magic in place of power pretty well, so I think there are some parallels.”

“Light Hope mentioned that Adora would have the power of Etheria. The planet,” Seacat pointed out.

“Yes. If that’s meant literally - or if she meant the power of all five Runestones - then that would be a big explosion.” The princess nodded with a smile. Then she blinked. “And that would kinda be bad, I guess. For the planet.”

“A big underwater explosion could cause a huge wave,” Seacat said.

“And underground, it could cause earthquakes,” Entrapta added. “Although I can’t calculate how bad those would be without more data.”

Adora looked stricken. “But… You said you don’t know. It could just work out, couldn’t it?”

“And hurt you anyway?” Seacat glared at her.

“Well, there’s always the chance that the First Ones implemented ways to compensate for that,” Entrapta said.

“Light Hope is damaged. I don’t think we can trust in the First One’s craftsmanship,” Seacat commented. “I’d rather not risk such wide-spread destruction just for a chance to stop the war a little sooner.”

“That’s a good thought,” Entrapta agreed. “Even though the data would be fascinating!”

Adora gritted her teeth. “Alright. We’re not going to let Scorpia attune to the Runestone unless we’re sure it won’t cause a catastrophe.”

“Or hurt you,” Seacat added with a glare.

Adora sighed. “Or hurt me badly - if we still need it.”

They glared at each other. Seacat huffed. “But we all decide whether or not it’s needed. Not you alone.”

Adora opened her mouth, but Seacat leaned in. “Or I’ll follow you and hurt myself as well.”

Adora closed her mouth. Then she sighed again. “Fine.”

Seacat hugged her. No need to rub her victory in - she would smile widely at Adora’s back.

*****

“We should’ve had Swiftwind drop us down behind the enemy lines one by one,” Mermista complained when they were approaching the small river separating the Whispering Woods from the Horde-controlled - loosely, but still - plains bordering it to the south.

“Swiftwind isn’t just a convenient transport,” Adora objected.

“And he’s vital as a courier,” Glimmer added. “He’s been keeping the Alliance leadership connected all over the continent.” At Adora’s frown, she pouted. “He volunteered. And we haven’t been sending him over the sea or Horde territory.”

“The Horde’s been expecting such airdrops,” Lonnie cut in. “We’ve been ordered to keep a lookout for the horse - and for suspicious lights at night.”

Lights which would be needed to let the horse know where the rest of the group to be transported was. And where they would be dropped off. Seacat nodded.

“He’s not a transport device,” Adora said with a scowl. “And horses are far too fragile to be used in war! Did you know that they die if they break a leg? Or when they drink too much cold water?”

This probably wasn’t a good time to remind Adora that she could heal such wounds - and worse wounds, actually. Besides, the real challenge wasn’t getting through the Horde lines but to ambush a troop going to the Fright Zone’s heartlands and replace them. And the horse wouldn’t be able to help them with that. Although… “He could drop bombs on the enemy.”

“He can’t carry much,” Adora replied, turning her frown on Seacat. “And if he carries one rider, he can’t carry much of a bomb.”

“I could rig a harness he could operate with his mouth, carrying two bombs… we could get some decent blasts out of, say… two half-human-sized bombs?” Entrapta suggested.

“His value is greater as a courier - and a diversion. With a blonde soldier from Mom’s guard, we can have the Horde chase ‘She-Ra on her flying horse’ wherever we want,” Glimmer pointed out.

“He helps us out of his free will, and we shouldn’t abuse that,” Adora protested. “He’s my friend, not some… bot!”

“My bots are my friends as well!” Entrapta told her, pouting as well.

It was Seacat’s turn to frown at her friend, and Adora grimaced. “That’s not what I meant - I meant the Horde’s bot; those which they use without care.”

“But all bots have the potential to be like Emily - if you use sufficiently sophisticated technology!”

“Which they don’t have right now,” Glimmer cut in. “For which we are all very grateful.”

“Yes, yes - can we hug and then get on with this?” Mermista said, rolling her eyes. “The night won’t last forever.”

“Unless the Horde wins this war. Then, the night will truly last forever - or until the flame of freedom and heroism once more extinguishes the darkness!” the Captain declared.

Seacat snorted, then noticed that Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle looked almost shocked. Grinning, she wandered over to them and whispered: “Yes, that’s normal for the Alliance.”

“How the hell did you manage to beat the Horde?” Kyle asked, but it was clear the others were thinking it as well.

“We’re just that good,” Seacat told them before snorting. “No. Talking like that lets us find flaws in plans before we’re committed. Sometimes, at least.”

“We’re pretty committed right now - we’re very close to the border,” Lonnie pointed out.

Seacat shrugged. “If we find a flaw so late, we can always improvise.” She flashed her fangs at the trio. “Another thing the Horde isn’t really good at.”

“Hey! We’ve been trying to, ah, improvise,” Kyle said. “We don’t have to react according to standard procedure if another procedure would be better.”

So the Horde was adapting. It wasn’t true freedom, but being able to pick a tactic from a selection of approved ones was quite important. And if soldiers were drilled in all of them, sometimes more effective in the heat of combat than an original plan. Especially with the average Horde soldiers having to carry out the plan.

Well, they were on this risky mission because it was their best shot, so the long-term consequences of this change shouldn't be too bad. Or so Seacat hoped.

"Quiet now," Brain Boy spoke up. "We're too close."

And that shut up the discussion.

They approached the edge of the forest very carefully - the Horde didn't like entering the Whispering Woods, but any commander worth their salt would want to have scouts in it anyway. But Seacat couldn't spot any scout around them - and her eyes were good in the dark. And Brain Boy didn't find any trace of Horde scouts either. Which, of course, didn't mean there wasn't anyone watching, but they couldn't exactly search the entire front.

"Alright," Brain Boy whispered. "Over the stream, through the ravine, and then all ahead until the ravine ends. We gather there to pick the next leg of our trip."

"Just follow us," Seacat added with a grin.

"You can't ever expect not to lose a soldier on a night march," Adora said.

Seacat snorted. Not even Kyle could get lost following a ravine. She blinked. "Lonnie, put Kyle in the middle!"

"Of course," the woman replied, and Seacat could hear the annoyance in her voice. Well, better safe than sorry - after all, the trio had been Horde soldiers until a short time ago, so you couldn't always trust them to do the right thing without orders.

Adora sighed, then shook her head. "Let's go."

Seacat nodded, then dropped on her stomach and started crawling towards the shallow stream ahead of them. It didn't take her very long - though Brain Boy managed to beat her there somehow. Damn landlubber was in his element!

She glanced over her shoulder and saw that the others were close. Good. She slid into the water and quickly crossed it, then slipped into the ravine. This time, she beat Brain Boy but had to wait for the others. Well, not for Memista, who slid through the water like a fish. And arrived perfectly dry.

Seacat acted as if she didn't see the smug smirk on her friend's face. They would be mainly working on land, so Mermista's magic would be hampered. Though she would be quite useful once they were in the Fright Zone's centre, where the plants needed a very robust sewer system for their cooling water - or so Entrapta claimed.

Kyle arrived, shivering already - and covered in mud somehow. Adora arrived last. She was wet but otherwise fine. "Alright," she whispered. "Get a move on. We need to find cover before day breaks."

And then they had to find a suitable force to ambush and replace.

And all that was the easy part of their mission.

*****

The Fright Zone

"There they are!" Adora's excited whisper carried through the small cave in which the group was hiding.

Seacat got up from the blanket on which she had been napping and joined her lover at the cave exit. If this was a trap… Brain Boy had told them that there were no tracks or any other signs that anyone else had been using the cave, but it was too conveniently placed for her taste. Sure, it wasn't too close to the Whispering Woods, and it was facing the wrong way to watch the front, and there was no reason that the Horde would be using a cave with a base relatively close by, but…

She peered through her telescope. Yes, there was a Horde convoy coming their way. One skiff, as escort, and two heavy wagons pulled by lizards. Three soldiers in the skiff, two each on the wagons. Seven. Same number as their group. "Almost too perfect," she whispered.

"We were bound to have a bit of good luck," Adora replied, whispering as well, "after all the bad luck we got. And I can't see any ambushing force."

"Let's check for a catapult in range, anyway. And for bombs in the wagons," Seacat said. She turned her head. "Entrapta?"

"Yes?"

"Can you scan for bombs?"

"Sure!" The princess almost bounded out of the cave before she managed to stop and crouch down next to them, brandishing her device. "Let's see…" She pushed a few buttons and twisted a knob. "Nope! No enhanced engine bombs in the area - which is bigger than the range of the catapults. Unless the Horde has learned how to shield the bombs from my instruments or how to build rockets, we should be safe!"

Seacat hoped that the Horde wouldn't figure out either before it was too late for them. Even so, they would be as safe as they could be attacking a Horde convoy. Granted, even if all seven soldiers coming their way were Headhunters, Seacat wouldn't give them many chances to hurt her friends. Hell, even if they were traitor princesses, Seacat would bet on Adora.

But those were regular Horde scum. The ones on the skiff were in decent shape, but the ones with the wagons… Glimmer would be able to fit twice into the uniform of the apparent leader.

"Let's get into position," Adora whispered. "Everyone! Move!"

Brain Boy had already packed up what gear they had laid out, and Lonnie and the others were rolling up their remaining blankets. They waited until the convoy vanished behind a rock before dashing out of the cave, into the light woods below. To the ambush location they had determined.

Adora dashed across the road - if you could call a dirt strip that - and into the dense bushes there. Seacat followed her. As did Glimmer and Brain Boy. And not too soon - Seacat could already hear the engine noise of the skiff. And the chatter from the Horde scum.

They had to get the skiff. Without wasting Glimmer's magic on teleporting on it - they would need every little bit of that in the Fright Zone. Which meant… she grinned as she looked up. Yes, that would do nicely.

The skiff turned the corner, entering the passage leading through the forest, the wagons close behind it. Perhaps too close. Not that it mattered - the wagons wouldn't escape either way.

"Ready?" Adora whispered.

"Yes," Glimmer replied.

"I'm going high," Seacat said.

“High? What…? Oh.”

Then the skiff was almost upon them, and Seacat jumped up and at the tree trunk. Her claws dug into the bark, and she launched herself further up, onto the thick branch overhead. The Horde scum had noticed and looked up, one of them shouting in alarm, but she was too fast for them. She jumped onto the steering sail, then vaulted over it and dropped down next to the skiff’s pilot. He tried to draw a shock rod, but she grabbed his helmet and buried her knee in his stomach.

She heard him vomit into his helmet - that wouldn’t be the one she would be wearing afterwards - and hit his unarmoured neck with a chop.

A glance over her shoulder showed that the others were already on the skiff’s deck. Adora simply grabbed the two remaining Horde soldiers and smashed their heads together.

“Huzzah! Onward!”

And Sea Hawk was at the wagons, followed by Mermista and Lonnie’s crew. The fat leader tried to run, but a net-arrow from Brain Boy stopped him. The rest quickly surrendered.

Perfect.

“Now strip!” Adora ordered.

“What?” one of the scum who was still conscious asked.

“I said strip! Get naked!”

“No!”

“What? Not that! We need your clothes!”

Seacat couldn’t help it - she snickered. Adora pouted at her, of course, but it really was funny.

And it might be the last time she got to laugh on this mission.

*****

“This uniform stinks!” Glimmer complained as soon as they made camp for the evening.

Well, doh - that was on the scum who had worn it. Couldn’t do anything about it except for washing it, and they had done that. It wasn’t Seacat’s fault that Glimmer hadn’t washed her new uniform enough.

“This uniform chafes.” Mermista, who had washed her uniform enough, commented.

“Yeah, they all do,” Adora said. “Except for the officer’s uniform. We used to use some powder to prevent that, but...” She grimaced. “I kind of forgot about that? It’s been a long time since I wore the standard uniform.”

Seacat added: “I never wore it - I was a cadet before I, well…” She shrugged.

Mermista huffed.

“This uniform doesn’t fit my manly physique!” Sea Hawk pouted. “How can I look dashing and heroic wearing this?”

Seacat rolled her eyes. That comment didn’t deserve a response.

“We can adjust them! I can craft some tools to cut and sew!” Entrapta gave one anyway.

“Great!” Brain Boy smiled as well. “Can you adjust mine as well?”

Seacat frowned and narrowed her eyes. The boy’s uniform fit almost perfectly. So why would he...? Oh. “You’re not going to walk around with your midriff bare,” she snapped. “That would attract attention we can’t afford!” Both kinds.

“But it feels so wrong!”

She scoffed. “Tough shit. Deal with it.”

“This is great! I’ve got so many ideas about modifying the fabric and the armour!” Entrapta had hers almost dismantled.

Oh, for…! “You can’t modify it like that,” Seacat told her. “Any uniform that’s not standard will stick out.”

“Well, in the Fright Zone, at least,” Adora added. “At the front, it’s a little different.”

“We should attack Hordak at the front, then!”

“He almost never visits the front, and we wouldn’t be able to predict where he would visit,” Seacat pointed out.

“Oh, right.” Entrapta nodded. “I guess I’ll have to stick to modifying the weapons.”

“As long as they look like ordinary Horde weapons.”

“That will make it more difficult to improve them.” Entrapta pouted as she wrinkled her nose.

“And easier to hide.” Seacat looked at Adora and grimaced.

Her lover smiled back at her. Typical.

“Alright.” Seacat leaned against the skiff and briefly wished that she’d gone back with Lonnie’s squad and the prisoners. “We know from the prisoners that the Horde has been withdrawing troops from this front. And we have ‘our’ orders. We’ll deliver the goods, then vanish - we’ll have to meddle with the records, but that shouldn’t be a problem.”

“We can fake the perfect orders for us!” Adora nodded.

“As long as they aren’t perfect,” Seacat told her with a grin. “Paperwork usually has mistakes in it. Except for Adora’s, of

course.”

She was rewarded with a cute pout from her lover. Good.

“So, act like the usual rear-echelon scum: Be happy that you’re back in the safe Fright Zone and boast about your duty at the front,” Seacat went on.

“I’ve never heard them boast,” Adora said.

“You never mingled with them off-duty,” Seacat told her. And that was why Adora had rarely if ever eaten anything but rations except for when Catra split her haul with her.

Adora huffed and mumbled something about slackers.

“Anyway - keep your head down and be ready to cite orders - our fake orders - whenever someone asks what you are doing. We’ll have the orders ready in the files. That will be our priority.” Seacat nodded.

“And the Horde’s paperwork will be their undoing!” Sea Hawk raised his fist. “What fitting fate for our foes!”

Seacat hoped the Captain wasn’t already composing a shanty. “Also, don’t mess with the Headhunters. Even if they push or order you around. Rear-echelon supply troops don’t stand up to them. And if they suddenly disappear, the Horde will investigate, so don’t think of killing them in secret.”

“We can handle some bullying,” Glimmer said. “Unless they go too far.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “Though that shouldn’t be a problem - in the Fright Zone, regulations are enforced much more than at the front.”

Which would restrain the scum. Hordak was an evil leader, but he enforced discipline. And Shadow Weaver would consider rule-

breaking as a challenge of her authority. Either way, the Headhunters should mostly behave.

And if they didn't… Well, a disappearance would cause problems, but an accident? People got hurt or killed in accidents every day in the Fright Zone. The plants weren't too safe, and the scum working there or driving the big wagons often didn't pay as much attention to bystanders as they should.

Something the group was counting on, of course.

*****

"Welcome to the Fright Zone," Seacat muttered as they approached the last checkpoint - or the first, depending on how you counted. "Home sweet home." She wrinkled her nose - the stench was growing worse and worse. All those plants burning… stuff. And bodies."

Mermista, sitting next to her, snorted. "I can't imagine living here. So far from the sea."

"It's not as if anyone is living here out of their free will," Seacat said. "Well, except for Hordak, I guess." At least he could've moved to a better place.

"He won't be living here much longer," Mermista replied. "Or living, period."

Seacat made a noncommittal sound. She wasn't quite as optimistic as the others - this was the Fright Zone. The heartlands of the Horde. So to speak. Hordak ran a tight ship here - and Shadow Weaver had her eyes everywhere; she had caught Catra so often…

"Halt!" A lizardman manning the checkpoint raised his hand. The two men at the cannon next to him straightened, but they didn't aim the gun.

“Supply convoy from the Northwest,” Seacat told him as she brought the skiff to a stop near the lizardman. “Adriana there is in command.” She pointed at Adora, who was sitting on the first wagon.

“Right. Wait here.” The officer walked towards Adora. No parade ground step, and he was slouching slightly.

“It seems standards slipped since I left,” she whispered.

“Really?” Mermista looked around. “Could just be this checkpoint.”

“It’s the gate to the heartlands,” Seacat corrected her friend. “Most visitors will pass through here, so this is the first impression they get.” And ‘slacker’ wasn’t the impression she thought Hordak would want them to have.

“If this is the checkpoint, where’s the rest of the traffic? Bright Moon has more traffic than this,” Mermista commented in a low voice.

That was a good question. “We’ll have to find out,” Seacat replied.

The lizardman walked back, giving the lone mothman at the barrier a lazy wave. “Let them through.” He didn’t even look at them before he sat down behind a desk in a small shelter.

They slowly drove past the checkpoint, and past three soldiers lying in the grass. There was another shelter which would be the quarters of the troops stationed here, but it didn’t look like it was bursting at the seams. Not much laundry drying in the air, either. Of course, any laundry drying here would stink like the Fright Zone. On the other hand, the Horde scum here must be used to it.

“I think they’re understaffed,” she said once they were past the checkpoint. “But I’ll have to ask Adora if she had the same impression.” Things could’ve changed since she was a cadet, after all.

Mermista didn’t answer for a moment - she was studying the first plant that came into view. “No wall. I imagined there would be a giant wall here.”

“It wouldn’t stop a princess - or not many princesses - and would cost a lot to build and maintain,” Seacat said. “And unlike skiffs and bots, you can’t move a wall to attack someone or guard another spot.”

“And until recently, the Horde was always attacking instead of defending.” Mermista nodded. “Then we turned the tables, and the Horde had to scramble to adjust.

“Yes.” Seacat grinned. And wasn’t that a pity for Hordak?

She slowed the skiff down and guided it to the side, letting Adora catch up. “Where to, commander?” she called out.

“Uh…” Her lover looked around. “It’s been a while since I was here. I think we should go… that way!” She pointed ahead.

Seacat hoped that Adora was merely acting. Fortunately, the road did lead to the supply depot, where they could unload their cargo. Unfortunately, they had to unload the cargo all by themselves - it didn’t seem that the warehouse nearby had much staff.

After putting down a particularly heavy crate, she wiped her forehead with her sleeve and muttered a curse; even pirate ports were better organised than this. The Horde must be really hurting for soldiers right now.

On the other hand, it meant that it should be easier to sneak into the administration centre and manipulate orders. But first, they had to finish unloading. And hope that Glimmer or Mermista didn’t complain too loudly - and that Entrapta didn’t dismantle the door controls she had been eyeing for a minute now. Or forgot that she couldn’t use her hair here.

Seacat sighed and went over to her friend. She had better keep an eye on the princess so their mission wouldn’t be over before it

had really started.

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“That’s the administrative centre,” Adora announced in a whisper, pointing at the big, ugly building ahead of them.

It looked as if it had been a plant before - Seacat could see lots of pipes and vents covering its walls and probably roof. “I remember it differently,” she said.

“That was the training administration. This is supply,” Adora explained.

“Oh.”

“It looks nice!” Entrapta said. “Do they use the pipes to send messages to other buildings? You could use pressurized air to propel small containers with paper and crystals!”

“Uh… I don’t know?” Adora shrugged. “I wasn’t often in there, and I never worked for the centre. I mostly dropped off paperwork.”

“That’s not very helpful. We need to know where the files are,” Mermista commented.

“I know that! The files archive, I mean,” Adora retorted. “I, uh….” She blushed a little. “I looked up Ca-Seacat’s file.”

“I was a cadet,” Seacat pointed out.

“But you were in the field when you, ah, went missing, so your records were filed with those of the other soldiers,” her lover replied. “Anyway, I know where the files are stored. Both, uh, active and passive.”

“Oh! They keep an archive?” Entrapta beamed at them. “That is a treasure trove of data! Imagine what we could learn about the Horde if we have access to their entire data!”

“We’re here to destroy them, not study them,” Mermista said.

“But the more we study them, the better we can plan! Think of the data - we could probably find guard schedules, too!” Entrapta’s helmet was twitching - her hair was probably moving again. Seacat didn’t want to know how the princess had managed to stuff her hair inside her helmet, even though she was wearing an oversized piece meant for a lizardman.

“But the longer we stay inside the centre, the higher the chances that we’ll get detected,” Adora cut in. “We need to get in, file out orders, and get out. That is, only a few of us need to get in.” She eyed the pipes. “And we can get in through the vents.”

“So, you and me?” Seacat asked. They were the ones raised in the Horde, after all. And Seacat was the best climber and the most limber - she could fit through any vent.

“Yes.” Adora smiled. “We’ll best go in through the roof.”

Seacat nodded and looked at the building again. Yes, that would be easy to climb. She sighed - climbing Horde buildings. Just like before…

“Don’t you want to wait until it’s night?” Glimmer asked.

“They’re actually more active at night,” Adora explained. “Most officers file their reports in the evening, and Hordak expects the results in the morning.”

“Oh. So, they have to work all night?”

“Yeah,” Seacat agreed. “That’s the Horde for you.” They didn’t care about the soldiers as long as the orders were obeyed and the objectives achieved. “Let’s go.”

“Yes.”

Seacat led the way - to the adjacent building. That was a warehouse, which made it far easier to climb without people

watching. She quickly scaled the side, then looked down. Adora was slightly struggling - she didn't have claws, nor Seacat's balance - but smiling when their eyes met.

"Come on, slow-poke," Seacat whispered, offering Adora a hand when she reached the top. "We don't have all day."

Adora snorted. "Right behind you."

Right. A large pipe connected the two buildings - some shared cooling system, maybe? The metal felt cold under Seacat's feet - and it was wide enough to shield them from view from anyone on the ground.

Seacat dashed across it, then hid behind a water tank on the roof of the administrative centre. Adora followed a little more slowly. Not quite as agile as Seacat was, nor as at home in such heights, Seacat noted. Which was as it should be, of course

They moved to the biggest air vent, and Seacat's ears twitched as she listened.

"You think there's something inside the vents?" Adora asked.

"You never know when they send someone into the ducts to fix a leak," Seacat replied. "But I don't hear anyone. Or anything." Other than the usual sounds of the Fright Zone, of course. "Let's go in!"

She grabbed the edge of the vent, pulled herself up in a smooth motion, and started to slowly slide down the vent.

"Don't wreck it with your claws!" Adora cautioned her - as if Seacat still were seven years old! Catra hadn't made such a mistake since that day, anyway.

Scoffing softly, she dropped onto the bottom part of the duct, then cocked her head. Still nothing moving through the ducts - other than air. "Where are the files?" she asked as soon as Adora joined her.

“Uh…” Adora looked back and forth between the two vents.

“North is this way,” Seacat told her.

“Thanks! This way, then!”

Seacat took the lead again. They crawled through a narrower pipe - still large enough so neither of them would get stuck - and finally reached a large room filled with shelves. Seacat peered through the narrow grating closing off the vent and saw several Horde soldiers moving around.

Damn.

Then she felt Adora trying to crawl past her - then over her. Seacat hissed in displeasure.

“Sorry,” Adora whispered but kept crawling forward, ending up lying on top of Seacat, her chest pressing into Seacat’s back, and rested her chin on Seacat’s shoulder. “Yes, that’s our objective!” she whispered into Seacat’s ear.

“I’ve guessed so as well,” Seacat replied in a whisper, then suppressed a snicker at Adora’s silent huff. “Now, let’s see how we can sneak into the room.”

“We’ll just act as if we belong here,” Adora said. “As long as we can get down on the floor without being seen, we’re OK.”

“What?” Seacat hissed.

“They only check at the door, not inside the building.”

That was… well, good for the Alliance, but… Such a lax regime went against everything a good sailor did. No wonder the Horde fleet was, except for a few good crews, so bad.

“Don’t growl.”

“I’m not growling!”

“Yes, you are.” Adora rubbed the top of Seacat’s head.

She huffed. “So, let’s get down here and fix our orders and records. Be quiet so I can listen!”

She felt Adora tense up - even holding her breath. As usual, she was overdoing it. But Seacat couldn’t hear anyone else. “It’s clear, let’s go,” she whispered.

“Need to deal with the grating here,” Adora replied. Seacat could hear her fumbling around.

“Let me do it,” she hissed - she knew how to handle the vents. Her claws were perfect for it. A few scratches and they could push the grating out, then slip out as well. And poised on Adora’s shoulder, she could easily push the grating back into its proper place. “Done!”

“Good.” Adora took a deep breath and straightened. Seacat could almost feel the change as Adora gripped her papers more tightly and started walking towards the middle section of the room they had entered. “Come on, we don’t have all day!”

“Yes, ma’am.” Seacat rolled her eyes. Just as the hapless soldier under the command of a tight-ass officer would have - behind their back, of course. Adora was a little too good at playing the Horde officer.

But it worked - the paper-pusher they encountered on the way gave them a wide berth without looking at them. Just another pair of soldiers handling paperwork.

Adora led them to a huge shelf crammed full of sheets and folders. “Now, where are those records?” she mumbled, loud enough for the soldier not quite working at the desk nearby to suddenly feel the urge to make herself scarce before Adora found a task for her.

As soon as the layabout was gone, they started sifting through the supply troop orders. Fortunately, they knew when they had been

expected, so it only took them ten minutes to find the files. And five minutes to replace the 'send back for more supplies' order with 'assigned to reactivated warehouse in preparation of new supplies'.

"Don't be too perfect," Seacat told Adora at the end. "You've seen how many mistakes were in the original."

"Yes." Adora sounded annoyed, though, and she hesitated before adding a spelling mistake.

Seacat shook her head. "Let's go."

"Alright. We can…"

Seacat turned. When Adora trailed off like that, it was usually a bad thing. And it was. Her lover was looking at another stuffed shelf.

"That's new."

"Judging by the amount of paperwork the Horde generates, it's no surprise that they expand their archives," Seacat retorted.

"We're not in the archives; this is the active data centre," Adora replied. "And that's… that's a huge shelf. They lost territory, and we know they've got problems replacing losses, so what is behind this new mountain of data?"

Adora had obviously been hanging out with Entrapta. Perhaps a little too much. But she was right. "Let's check it out, then," Seacat said, walking towards it.

"Wait!" Adora hissed.

But Seacat didn't stop. They were already long enough in here - they needed to get done and get gone. She reached the suspicious shelf and pulled a sheet out of a stack at random.

“What are you doing?” Adora hissed. “We need to put it back as it was!”

“Why?” Seacat whispered back. “The more confusion, the better!”

“Uh… Right!” Adora looked around, then grabbed two stacks and started redistributing them.

Seacat snorted and read her sheet. And then drew a hissing breath. “It’s a new project,” she whispered. “A huge construction project, or so it seems. Project Omega.”

And didn’t that sound ominous?

“What? I’ve never heard of that.”

“You’ve been out of the Horde for a long time,” Seacat told her, sifting through more forms. “Nothing about what the project is about,” she muttered.

“There was an entire power plant built for it.” Adora held up a stack of reports.

“And look at those supply reports,” Seacat held up hers. “They must have half an army assigned to the project.”

“We didn’t see any new construction on that scale”, Adora said. She frowned, then quickly sifted through several transport reports. “So much earth being moved… They’re underground.”

“What?” Why would anyone build anything underground? Why would the Horde? This had started before Glimmer’s bombing attack, anyway. This… Seacat pressed her lips together. Barges on transport reports. “The Horde must be building something huge there.”

“And we need to find out what it is,” Adora said.

Seacat agreed - whatever project the Horde was using so much manpower on would be important. Especially when they were

hurting for soldiers and supplies. But on the other hand… "We're here to kill Hordak," she whispered.

"He might be involved in the project," Adora retorted.

Seacat clenched her teeth. "We can't discuss this here," she shot back, looking around. "Let's go back to the others."

"But…" Adora looked at the shelf. "There must be more information there!"

"We can return later," Seacat told her. "Let's go back."

"But…"

"Or the others will start to worry about us." And who knew what Glimmer would do if she thought they had been captured. Or Sea Hawk and Mermista.

Adora sighed. "Alright."

They returned to the corner with the vent leading into the air ducts.

"We could just walk out," Adora said. "They don't check people who walk out."

"Safer this way," Seacat said. "Lift me up."

Adora glanced around, then held out her hand. Seacat climbed up and put a foot on it, then let her lover lift her up. Adora was so strong when she was She-Ra - she didn't show any strain at all lifting her up one-handed.

Seacat shook her head. She could dwell on that later. She had a vent to open.

Which didn't take much time. Seacat climbed into the vent, then was about to turn around with some contortions to help Adora up - but her lover had already jumped up and was pulling herself up.

Seacat still had to squeeze past her to put the grate back on the vent, though.

*****

"They have a new, secret project?" Entrapta sounded as if they had told her that they had found a First One library or something. She was also not very quiet. They were in the warehouse, in makeshift quarters, but still… you never knew.

"Yes. And a huge number of workers - soldiers - are assigned to it. It generates more paperwork than the rest of this area together," Adora explained.

"That's very suspicious," Glimmer said. "Could that be where the Horde is making their enhanced engine bombs?"

"Well…" Entrapta chewed her lower lip. "That would mean they're making many more than I thought."

"We'll have to find out what they are doing," Adora said. "If this is where they build their bombs, then we have to take it out as well."

"Yes," Mermista agreed. "Otherwise, the Horde will still continue to fight - whoever controls so many bombs will be in charge."

"And too dangerous," Glimmer added.

"That will complicate our mission," Brain Boy pointed out.

"Unless we use this to kill Hordak," Seacat said. She ignored Adora's triumphant expression; this wasn't the time to be petty. "I doubt he'd survive one of those bombs going off."

"I doubt we would survive it, either," Mermista said. "Especially if a bunch of them go off at once."

"Oh, that shouldn't happen," Entrapta said. "Unless the bombs are kept so close that the initial impulse sets off the crystals in the

others. Then there would be a chain reaction." She blinked. "I would need to study the bombs to determine the safe distance at which the bombs would be destroyed without being set off."

Seacat had a sudden vision of a massive crater where the Fright Zone used to be.

"And what if that destroyed the Runestone?" Adora asked.

"Oh." Entrapta blinked again, then cocked her head to the side. "I don't know, actually. Runestones are supposed to be very hard to destroy, but the shards we've found prove it's possible to destroy them, but those probably weren't tied to Etheria like the five linked Runestones. On the other hand, the Black garnet isn't attuned to the network, so it might be easier to destroy - although an enhanced engine bomb might be enough to destroy it anyway."

"And what would happen to Etheria if that happened?" Brain Boy asked.

"I don't know." Entrapta sounded far too cheerful about it. "We'll have to find out!"

"Without blowing up the Runestone," Adora said.

"Right." Entrapta nodded. "Though that will be harder."

"But also safer," Seacat said.

"We don't know that, actually," Mermista pointed out. "If this secret project is so important, the Horde will guard it with everything they have. Did you find the records for the guards assigned to it?"

Adora shook her head. "No. We didn't stay long enough to search the records."

"Probably wise," Glimmer said. "You might've been detected otherwise. But we need to know what they are doing there - and how to stop it." She stood from where she had been sitting on one

of the beds they had requisitioned. “We need to observe it and find a way inside!” She put her hands on her hips and raised her chin. “This is crucial for the Alliance!”

“We need to find out first where it is,” Brain Boy said, and she deflated a little.

“And we need to find out how to get into Hordak’s laboratory and quarters,” Seacat reminded them.

“And Shadow Weaver’s,” Adora added.

“I know how to get into her quarters,” Seacat said.

“She will have changed her security after my defection. Certainly after you escaped her,” Adora retorted.

Her lover had a point, Seacat had to admit. She nodded. “So… who scouts which area?”

“We shouldn’t split up too much,” Adora said. “If one of us gets caught and we aren’t close to save them…”

“Yes!” Sea Hawk stood up as well. “We need to fight side by side. A last stand is only advisable when we have accomplished our mission, to cover our retreat - not when we are still working on reaching our target.” He shook his head. “That would be a sad shanty indeed.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes at him, as did Mermista. She wouldn’t let the captain sacrifice himself for them.

Then she glanced at Adora, who nodded a little too readily. And neither would she let her lover sacrifice herself.

*****

“I think we’ve found the project,” Brain Boy whispered.

"We've found a possible entrance," Seacat corrected him. "And you don't have to whisper," she added. "We're on the roof of a factory; no one can hear us over the noise from the machines." If not for her ears, she'd have trouble hearing the boy herself.

"Sorry."

She made a noncommittal noise. The boy was just too… nice, probably. Always apologising, even though he was rarely at fault. Well, perhaps that's what you were like, growing up with a princess. Would Seacat have turned out like him if she had grown up with an Adora who had been raised as a princess from birth? Something to ponder another time, she reminded herself. They were on a mission.

"Although the number of supplies carried down that entrance seems pretty indicative that the secret project is there. Beneath us."

"Yes." That was a lot of supplies. "The river must be crammed full of barges." They needed to take control of the river running through the fright zone as well. But they couldn't do it with the threat of bombs.

"That should open it for sabotage," Brain Boy said. "Sink a few of them at narrow spots of the river…"

Seacat grinned. "I like that idea." A few saboteurs wouldn't risk getting a bomb thrown at them - and wouldn't be as easy to spot as a frigate or gunboat. "But we need to confirm that this is the project, first. And not a - what did Entrapta call it? A feeder?"

"A feeder plant, yes," he said, nodding. "Though those would be part of the project as well. And I think the material transported through the entrance here is too varied for a feeder plant."

Well, he was the 'Techmaster'. Seacat shrugged. "Whatever it is, we need to get in there." If only to find out if Hordak visited the place regularly. Hordak's laboratory was a little too well-protected

- at least that had been their first impression upon scouting its perimeter. “But not today. Let’s go back to the others.”

Perhaps Adora and the others had found a weakness that let them get into Hordak’s laboratory or his personal quarters while they were taking a second look today.

Seacat could hope, at least.

*****

“Whoever placed the guards and set their rotation knew what they were doing,” Adora told them. “Entrapta, Glimmer and I did a full tour around the entire area - it’s locked down tightly.”

“Yes! And not just with soldiers, but also with bots!” Entrapta chimed in. “Double-double patrols - two bots and two soldiers. Though I think that the bots are ordered around by the soldiers, so that’s one weakness, unless they have backup orders or there were significant improvements to their control systems. Still, we can handle bots since we look like Horde soldiers, and if there are crystals that are attuned to the bots to indicate who is allowed in, we can take those from guards and fool the bots. Probably. Unless they improved the pattern recognition matrix and made all bots remember all guards. Which is possible, but they would be quite hard to maintain. One mistake and - boom! You lose one of your guards!”

“Great,” Glimmer commented. “We’d have to worry about being shot at by bots who *don’t* recognise us.”

“A novel experience, I’ll say,” Sea Hawk added with a grin.

Mermista growled and glared at him.

“Well, we don’t know if the bots are so… advanced?” Adora looked at Entrapta.

“No, we don’t. Unless we observe some of the bots attacking Horde soldiers. Or…” She beamed at them. “We take a bot and

examine its controls!”

“I think the Horde would notice a missing bot,” Seacat pointed out.

“Not if we pick one that’s being sent away for maintenance or repairs!” Entrapta countered.

Seacat blinked. “Oh. I think we just found a weakness. A possible weakness. If the bots on guard aren’t maintained inside the guarded area…”

“...then we can sabotage them outside the area!” Adora and Seacat exchanged a smile.

“At the very least, the bots going after the soldiers would be a distraction. But if they patrol inside the area, close to where Hordak is working, then we could use one as a bomb carrier,” Brain Boy said.

Seacat nodded with a wide smile. That would mean none of them would have to risk fighting Hordak in his laboratory. “We’d need an enhanced engine bomb, though,” she cautioned.

“I could, if I had the materials, make a bomb,” Entrapta offered.

“I’m sure the materials are heavily guarded,” Adora said. “After we cut off their fuel crystal supplies.”

“Oh. Then I can’t make a bomb.” Entrapta hung her head, and her hair drooped for a moment.

“Well, they might have assigned the materials to the secret project,” Brain Boy suggested.

“Or they’ll have their bombs there - then we just needed to grab one,” Mermista said.

“That wouldn’t work,” Entrapta told her. “The standard Horde bomb is too big to fit into, or be carried by, a Horde bot. I would

have to build an adapted bomb variant to fit into a bot as it is - and I would have to take out most of the gun. The space is just too limited. The bots are a pretty mature design - not much wasted space, if any at all. Impressive, for the short time - relatively - that they've been around. Although now that I've met Light Hope, I think bots have been around far longer than we thought. Hordak could've been using First One technology for his bots."

That was a likely explanation, in Seacat's admittedly inexperienced opinion - it wasn't as if Catra had ever cared much about where the Horde technology came from.

"So… next task: We need to find out where the bots are maintained. And we need to find out where the materials for an enhanced engine bomb are stored," Adora said.

"Or where they are used," Glimmer added. "Also, if we don't find a weakness, I can teleport us inside." She flexed her arm. "I've got enough magic to get us in and around."

"Let's save that as an alternative," Adora said.

Seacat nodded. Glimmer was their best shot at escaping, after all. "And we have to find out what this secret project is about."

She had a feeling this was more important than finding out how to get into Hordak's laboratory.

*****

The Secret Project

"I still say we should've just faked orders that send us down there."

Seacat rolled her eyes. Couldn't Brain Boy shut up for a change? "Too much of a risk - we wouldn't have a clue what awaited us, and that might catch attention. If this is the Horde's top-secret project, then security will be very tight there," she whispered as she, once more, studied the entrance below them.

"That's not exactly reassuring, you know. We are planning to sneak in, after all."

Perhaps she should've taken Entrapta with her. Or rather, should have asked the others to allow Entrapta to come with her. The princess would've been all fired up about sneaking in. Which, to be fair, was why she hadn't been allowed to come - despite her experiences sneaking through air ducts in her own castle. But Brain Boy was a little too cautious. Sometimes, you had to roll the dice and trust your luck. And your wits and claws, if your luck wasn't enough.

"And we *will* sneak in. We just have to find out their procedures," she told him. Guards always had a routine. Even though they weren't supposed to have one, sooner or later, they developed habits. Good officers were supposed to prevent that - but breaking up shifts and changing orders tended to slow things down. And Seacat was sure that when guarding such an important project, few officers would risk slowing the work down by doing things by the book. Not in the heart of the Fright Zone. Well, Adora would've, of course.

But Seacat's lover wasn't down there. The officer commanding the entrance guards was a snot-faced mothwoman. A good choice for the night shift, of course - she would see well in the dark. Unfortunately, or fortunately for Seacat and Brain Boy, few Horde soldiers could see in the dark, and so the guard post was lit up

brightly. Seacat snorted - the mothwoman was probably lucky if she wasn't blinded all the time by all the lights.

"And how long will that take?"

"An hour or two," she told him. "Patience!" she added, baring her fangs at him.

He sighed. "I'm just…"

"You're worried about the others, I know." She suppressed a sigh herself. "But worrying about them won't help them - or us. And they're not trying to sneak into Hordak's laboratory," she reminded him. "They should be worrying about us." She blinked. "I mean, not that there is anything to worry about. We'll be doing this, easily."

Judging by the glance he sent her, perfectly visible since she could see in the dark as well, he wasn't quite convinced. Rats.

Ah, well… "Look, see how the guards never really leave the light? And how they sit down or lean against the wall, instead of waiting in the guardhouse?"

"Yes?"

"That's because they're too lazy to keep going back and forth whenever a supply transport arrives," she explained. "Give them another hour or so, and they won't notice anything but the transport."

"And then we… sneak past them?"

She grinned. "No. We'll sneak in *above* them."

*****

"...and then I told her: 'I don't think you've fooled your mother.'"

Seacat snorted. "How old were you?"

“Ten.”

When Seacat had been ten years old, she’d also been sneaking out of her room at night to fetch food. But not to get the second serving of dessert she hadn’t been allowed to have, but to get something to eat for her and Adora when her friend had split her ration with Catra after Shadow Weaver’s punishment.

And there went her good mood.

“Sorry.”

She gritted her teeth. “Don’t say sorry. It’s not your fault.”

“Well…”

“Do you even know what isn’t your fault?”

“Uh.” He coughed, then rallied. “I made you sad.”

“No. You didn’t make me sad. I did that by remembering what Shadow Weaver did.”

“But that’s not your fault, either!”

She grinned at him. “See? Now you get it!”

He blinked, his mouth half-open, then pouted while she snorted again.

“And now you’ve restored my good mood at the cost of your… dignity?” she went on.

He sighed. “A small price to pay.”

“I was joking,” she told him. “Though… was that how it was, growing up with a princess as your best friend?”

“Actually, no,” he said. “Glimmer was always the one who, well, got punished for what we did.”

“Oh.”

“Yes. She said she was taking responsibility since she was the princess. Noblesse oblige.”

“Noblesse?”

“It means that as a princess - or anyone of high rank or power - you’re supposed to be more responsible and more honourable than others.”

She scoffed. “Well, no one taught Shadow Weaver that.” Adora hadn’t been taught that, either - but she still lived it. Lived it a little too much, at times.

“Well, that’s the Horde - they’re evil for a reason.”

She nodded. “And we’re about to put an end to that.” She looked down. “About an hour before the shift changes. Let’s go!”

“Alright.” Brain Boy pulled his bow out.

“Don’t miss!” she told him.

He narrowed his eyes and glared at her for a moment, and she grinned. So, he had a spine. She just had to find the right things to poke him about.

He grabbed one of his trick arrows, took a deep breath, and drew the bow. She refrained from telling him again where to aim - he knew it.

A moment later, he released the arrow. Seacat held her breath while it flew across the road, towards the massive building on the other side. It flew true, as the archers would say, and hit the arc above the gate. It stuck there, and the line it had been trailing went taut.

Brain Boy flashed her a smile.

She nodded in return. His trick arrows were very versatile. That arrow could be used to hit enemies with glue, too. "Tie it up here! Let's go!"

He quickly tied the line to the wall behind them, then pulled out two triangles. "Friction brakes," he explained. "Hook them over the line, and you can slow your descent by squeezing the handles here."

Ah. Clever. Sea Hawk would complain about such an invention removing all the pleasure from swashbuckling entrances, but Seacat was glad they wouldn't hit the other building hard. Not that it would hurt her, but the impact might be noticed by the guards below.

She still went first, of course - she was strong enough, and quick enough, to stop Brain Boy, should something go wrong with the gimmick.

But it worked as advertised, allowing her to control her speed as she sailed over the heads of the scum below and touched down on top of the gate's arc, light as a feather. Yes.

Brain Boy followed her, not quite as graceful but easily good enough to avoid being overheard by the Horde scum. And he withdrew the line with another gimmick - some mechanical spinning disc that would be very useful if it were twenty times the size and able to weigh anchors.

Once both were crouched on the ledge here, shielded from view from below, she slowly peered over the edge. The guards were, as expected, acting as if they were already done with their task, barely paying attention to anything but the most obvious tasks. Even the officer looked like she was half-asleep - another sign that Hodak was pushing his soldiers harder than before.

And there was the next transport. Right on time!

"Get ready!" she hissed.

“Ready,” he replied.

Seacat wet her lips as the wagon approached the gate below them, and the soldiers started to check the cargo - without the zeal and care they had displayed hours ago. Any moment… Yes! The soldiers withdrew, and the officer gave the signal to open the gate.

As the massive gate started to open, Seacat grabbed the edge and dropped down, swimming around and latching upon the right side of the gate as it slowly slid to the side. She rode it for a moment, approaching the wall, then jumped and gripped a pipe on the wall.

She pulled herself up on top of it in a second, then looked to the other side. Brain Boy was just pulling himself up - with the help of a line.

Cheater, she thought with a grin, then waited until he made eye contact and pointed at a huge air vent in front of them.

Brain Boy nodded at her, and they quickly crawled and climbed to the great vent. It was big enough to almost fit a skiff inside - and she could feel the vibrations from the air being sucked down through it. This wasn’t a feeder plant.

“Should we go through the air vents?” Brain Boy asked. “They’re big, but…”

“...the air flow’s strong there. Better not. We’ll travel with them, though,” she replied.

Whatever the Horde was doing here, the air vent would lead straight to it, Seacat was sure.

But it led straight down, first. Fortunately, Brain Boy could use his line again, and so Seacat didn’t have to cut hand- and footholds into the metal vent as they descended alongside it. They had to squeeze through the narrow free space between the pipe and the

shaft it was run through for a dozen yards until they finally reached the lower level - the basement.

And Seacat gaped. The basement was huge. Large enough to fit the biggest ship in the Salinean fleet into it twice - without cutting down the masts. And it was half-full with the Project Omega. Dozens, hundreds of people were all working here. All working on...

“What are they building?” Brain Boy asked. “This can’t be a ship, can it?”

Seacat stared. There was a hull, and the size… twice the length of a frigate. But it was wrong - even the Horde frigates had better hulls. This hull wouldn’t really cut well through water. And the lower gunports were much too low - they were far too close to the keel… She pulled her telescope out and took a closer look.

Damn.

“It’s a ship, yes. But not one meant for water,” she muttered.

“What? Where else would you… No!”

She looked up. The ceiling was higher than she had expected as well - and were those hinges? She took a closer look with the telescope. Yes. Massive, huge, giant hinges. And that was a closed gap, not a painted line going from one end of the ceiling to the other. “Look at the ceiling,” she whispered.

He did. And cursed. “This… A *flying* ship?”

“Yes. Look at the gunports - the lower line is set so they can fire *down*,” she pointed out.

“But… how could it fly?” Brain Boy shook his head. “The power needed to lift anything… the magic…”

“Perhaps some variant of the skiff’s magic?” Seacat speculated. “Though those can’t fly in the sky, and this ship looks like she’s

meant to fly high above us." And drop bombs on them.

"I've studied that. Earth Magic doesn't work that way," he replied.

She wasn't a scholar, much less a sorceress, but she was willing to take his word for it. But… "Earth Magic doesn't. But what about another kind of magic?"

"The Black Garnet? That's lightning magic, last I knew."

She shrugged. "If it's powerful enough? And lightning comes from the sky."

"Actually, lightning is…" He sighed. "No, it might work. Magic works as often with themes as with technology. And if the Horde manages to tap into Etheria's magic network, they probably have enough power to do anything they want."

She scoffed. "They don't need much more than enough power to let this ship fly. Once they are aloft, they can drop bombs on us wherever they please, and we can't do a thing against them." Neither Glimmer nor Swift Wind would be able to carry enough bombs to scratch that ship - and the horse would be blown out of the sky by those broadsides, anyway, before it reached the ship. Unless the Horde scum was only packing shells and solid shot. But they wouldn't be so stupid.

"We have to stop it. Even if we take Hordak out - with this, the Horde could still win the war. If they can maintain the ship."

"Well, they're building it," Seacat told him. "I think they can keep it flying for some time even if Hordak keeps the details to himself."

"Right. Let's gather as much information we can before we have to leave," he whispered.

"Yes." She took her telescope and studied the hull and guns again.

Fairly standard, once you took the placement into account. Though the gun mountings would have to be modified to be able to shoot down at a steep angle. The hull was, apart from the weird-ish shape, standard. Full steel, not too thick, though. "Weight must be a limitation," she said.

"Yes. And I wonder how they are planning to move it - no sails."

"No mast, anyway," she replied. "Nor any base to mount one in." Well, if a ship could fly, they could simply fly higher to see farther - if they even needed to, in the air. "The bridge would likely be where the lookouts are." Close to the captain - that would make reacting easier. Less chance of information being delayed or lost in the middle of a battle. On the other hand, if you hit the bridge…

Brain Boy interrupted her with a hand on her shoulder. "There! See that round chamber in the part close to the stern?"

She looked over. Yes, there was a gap in the deck, and she saw a round chamber underneath. "Yes."

"That must be where the Black Garnet will be placed. All the power lines lead to this room, and it's empty so far."

"What about the engines?" she asked.

"They're in the middle. See those openings? Air intakes."

"Ah." That made sense. "Are the engines already installed?"

"Yes. The ship seems almost finished."

Seacat cursed. "But if it's so close to being finished… Hordak must be visiting often, then." Shortly before setting out for their shakedown cruise, things were the most hectic - the Captain had bought enough new ships with her assisting him to know this. "I bet he has a special office here!"

"If he does, I'm not seeing it," Brain Boy replied.

“It would have to be high up, so he can look down on everyone and observe the progress with a single glance,” she said, looking around, then up. “There. On the other side, at the bow of the ship.”

Brain Boy looked up. “An observation bubble.”

“Probably armoured,” Seacat said. “But I think we’ve found his office.”

“His office when he visits - it doesn’t look like anyone’s in there right now,” Brain Boy said.

“Yes,” Seacat agreed. “The soldiers probably would be working harder if Hordak was present.” And the guards would be more attentive. Like sailors when the Captain was on deck. “Do you see any entrance to the office?” she asked.

“One of the doors at the bottom should lead to a stair,” he replied. “But I don’t see any guards in front of any door.”

“That could be by design,” she said. “Keep the guards hidden so spies don’t know which door’s the important one.” Although the Horde usually wasn’t so sneaky. Shadow Weaver, on the other hand…

“Perhaps. He might also have a separate entrance from above,” Brain Boy said.

That would fit. But would the Horde be slacking like they did if they couldn’t know when Hordak was watching and when he wasn’t? Or were they exhausted? She took a closer look at the workers. They seemed to be rather tired. She saw one minotaur almost dropping a plate of steel when his grip slipped, and he took several tries to readjust his hands. And a woman painting part of the hull was doing so while sitting - even though it would take her longer to move that way. “He’s running them ragged,” she said.

“Well, we already suspected that there was a manpower shortage in the Horde,” Brain Boy said. “If they’re throwing everything at this - and Project Omega sounds like they are - then it would make sense that the soldiers are overworked. But overworked people make mistakes. They might spend more time fixing problems than they gain by hurrying the work.”

“That’s the Horde for you. Hurry up and wait.” She snorted. “But we can’t hope that they make so many mistakes that the ship will fall from the sky.”

“Technically, we can hope - but we shouldn’t depend on it.”

“Smartass,” she told him, flashing her fangs at him.

He grinned back at her but quickly grew serious again. “A few bombs would damage the entire ship. Enough to keep anyone from using it after Hordak’s out of the picture.”

“Or one enhanced bomb,” she pointed out. “But they aren’t making the bombs here. At least I can’t see anyone working on bombs.”

“It would be very dangerous to work on bombs so close to the ship, wouldn’t it?”

“Yes.” Not that that stopped the Horde before. “They might’ve a separate workshop for the bombs nearby. But I think they don’t - that would be guarded.”

“We should’ve taken Entrapta’s detector with us,” he said.

“Yes. But she might need it looking for other ways to get to Hordak.”

“True. We’ll have to return here, then.”

“Definitely,” she agreed. “And we need to find out where the Runestone is.”

That was the key to the ship, after all. And to the bot's plan.

*****

"A flying ship?" The Captain looked both horrified and intrigued as he lounged on the crate serving as a chair in the warehouse they had taken over.

"The size of two Horde frigates," Seacat confirmed. Not something he could sail by himself.

"A flying ship… that would dominate Etheria." Mermista shook her head. "We can't let the Horde finish this!"

"We won't," Adora said. "But we can't abandon our primary objective for this. We need to kill Hordak. Once he's dead, the ensuing chaos should allow us to strike at the ship as well."

"If we're lucky, we can strike at Hordak and the… airship… at the same time," Brain Boy said. "He's got an office in the yard. At least, we assume that it's his office since it has the best view of the entire yard and isn't being used as far as we could tell."

"That sounds like a logical deduction," Entrapta said. "Even though it's not logical not to use such a good office when Hordak isn't around."

"That's the Horde for you," Glimmer said. "It's all about Hordak's ego." She shook her head. "But we can't count on getting both the ship and Hordak at the same time. And Hordak takes priority. He's behind all this new technology."

"We assume that," Adora said. "But he certainly is the uncontested leader of the Horde. And he's holed up in his laboratory. Our only way in seems to be using the bots that guard him."

"We've found the maintenance section for the bots!" Entrapta chimed in. "It's all new and shiny!"

"New? The Horde's been using bots for years," Seacat said.

“Yes.” Adora nodded to her. “But we’ve found out that they recently moved the maintenance sections together - including the one in Hordak’s laboratory.”

“That might be a simple way to make maintenance more efficient. Consolidate and centralise it,” Brain Boy said.

“Or it was needed to make room for something else in his laboratory,” Adora retorted.

Seacat nodded. That sounded like a valid theory. She certainly didn’t think Hordak would move the maintenance of his bodyguard bots outside his laboratory to merely make it more efficient.

“Alright. Let’s get Hordak first. Before the ship is ready to fly,” Mermista said.

“We need proper reconnaissance of the laboratory,” Adora pointed out. “Entrapta, you can place a device into a bot that lets us see their memory?”

“Well, more like copy their data, which we can then display. But it works out the same,” Entrpata confirmed.

“We can’t wait too long - every day we stay here, we risk being discovered. Or our ruse at the front being exposed,” Mermista said. “We need to hurry.”

Well, she wasn’t wrong. Time would run out sooner rather than later.

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“There!”

“Yes.” Seacat, crouching behind a cooling unit on the roof of a factory, nodded. “Just as you said.” There was the bot maintenance building.

“Right. So, they send the bots that can walk through this door, and they walk out through that door there,” Entrapta explained.

“How many soldiers inside?”

“About two dozen at any time,” Adora said. “And half a dozen guards.”

“Guards?” Why would they have guards inside the building?

“In case the bot in question acts up.” Entrapta shrugged. “If you change their control unit or their sensors and make a mistake, they can go, uh…”

“Out of control?” Seacat suggested.

“Kind of,” Entrapta nodded. “Although they’re still in control, kind of - they just don’t listen any more. At least that’s what happened to mine.”

And wasn’t that worrying!

“We’ve never seen them lose control like that in the field,” Glimmer added.

“Well, they usually don’t do maintenance in the field, I believe. Or not when fighting, at least.” Entrapta’s hair spread out. “And it’s almost impossible to damage the control unit of a bot just so that it still works but loses its friend/foe programming. Usually, they just stop working if their control unit is damaged.” She perked up. “Though if you repair it and forget to disconnect it, they can regain control in a second - isn’t that fascinating? It’s like returning from death.”

“Fascinating, yes,” Glimmer mumbled. Seacat saw Brain Boy frown at her.

“Anyway, we’ll have to avoid all of them,” Adora said. “That will require precise planning and execution. We need to time our distraction perfectly so Entrapta and Bow can sneak inside and

manipulate a guard bot's control unit. And we have to make a distraction that won't raise suspicion and cause the Horde to investigate."

"Make a bot go out of control outside?" Seacat suggested.

"That is, as I just explained, quite difficult," Entrapta objected.

"Poison their rations so they get the runs?" Glimmer cocked her head.

"Do we have such poison?" Adora shot back.

"I could make poison, but it would be quite lethal," Entrapta said.

"And that would certainly be investigated," Seacat said. "Not to mention it would be hard to poison any rations - those things are as durable as a brick."

"What's your plan?" Glimmer asked Adora.

"Have Mermista cause a leak in a water pipe. While everyone is trying to find it and plug it, we drop Entrapta and Bow from the ceiling and have them sabotage the guard bot," Adora answered.

"Drop us?" Brain Boy asked.

"Lower you down with a line," Seacat told him. "But what if they notice the changes when they return? We'd have to target a finished bot."

"And those walk out on their own as soon as they are finished," Entrapta added.

"That's why the timing is critical: We need to have the water leak when they are about to close and secure the bot's cover before they reactivate them, so you can open them up again and replace the thingie without anyone noticing," Adora retorted.

"The control unit," Entrapta corrected her.

“Yes.” Adora nodded with a slight frown. “That’s also why we need Mermista - she can control the water, so it is seen by the Horde at the exact moment we want.”

“That sounds a little like Operation Locker Room,” Seacat said.

Adora blushed as everyone else looked at them.

“Operation Locker room?” Glimmer asked.

“Adora’s plan to get back at a rival squad who had taken our locker room,” Seacat told them.

“We were ten, and it’s really not important right now,” Adora said.

“But it relied on precise timing as well. And failed,” Seacat reminded her.

“Right. But this is different. We couldn’t control when the shower would go off.” Adora shook her head. “Totally different.”

“Should we really plan this on the roof of a Horde factory?” Brain Boy asked.

“It’s one of the safest spots.” Seacat shrugged. “The noise from the machines means no one will hear us, and the steam from the pipes hides us from casual view from the air. And if anyone comes looking, we’re just taking a break.”

“Anyway, the timing shouldn’t be an issue as long as we can maintain contact with each other,” Adora said. “Which shouldn’t be a problem since Mermistra can use her powers from the rafters as well.”

“And you’ll lower us down?” Brain Boy seemed a little concerned with that. As if Adora would drop him.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “Well, you’ll descend by yourself. But I’ll pull you up again.”

“If I could build a stronger auto-retriever, I could ascend by myself,” the boy said.

“Oh, yes!” Entrapta perked up. “We could build a remote-controlled harness, too!”

“We don’t have the time,” Glimmer cut in. “We need to do this now. Well, soon.”

Great. But Glimmer wasn’t wrong - and Adora could lift Entrapta and Brain Boy at the same time without breaking sweat. They didn’t need all the gimmicks the two wanted to build. “Let’s hit them an hour after midnight,” Seacat said. Shift change would be too late - it would early morning by then. And for this, she preferred the cover of darkness.

“Let’s get Mermista.” And the Captain, of course - he wouldn’t leave her side.

*****

“I can do that, yes - the pipes aren’t the newest, nor are they built well,” Mermista said a few hours later. “They’re already leaking in places.”

“Perfect,” Adora said. “Then we can move into position.”

They climbed down to the ground, dashed across the road when no one was looking and were soon climbing the mix of pipes and nooks and crannies forming the back wall of the maintenance building. It was easy for Seacat, of course. Adora didn’t have any trouble either - they used to race each other years ago in the Fright Zone - and Mermista and Seahawk were used to climbing the rigging of a ship. Entrapta’s hair had her up the wall faster than a monkey would have managed, but Brain Boy had to lend Glimmer a helping hand. Probably too used to teleport.

In any case, they all made it up on the roof without the Horde sounding the alarm. And Brain Boy managed to open a skylight without breaking it - or alerting anyone.

“Can you control the water from here?” Adora asked in a whisper.

“Yes,” Mermista replied. “It would be better if I could see the pipes, though.”

“No problem.” Adora dropped down on the rafters, then waved at the princess.

Seacat saw Mermista wince for a moment before setting her jaw and following Adora. Sea Hawk was right behind her, of course, then the rest of the group climbed through the open window as well.

Seacat brought up the rear - after a quick sweep to ensure there was no one watching - and pulled the skylight close.

“Alright. We’re in position. We’ll prepare the harnesses and the ropes, then we’re ready. After we move directly above the end of the maintenance line.” Adora was, once again, talking too much, but it couldn’t hurt - the noise from below was too loud to let anyone overhear them; it was so loud, Seacat’s ears were actually hurting a little.

They made their way through the rafters, glancing down. “Are those Hordak’s guard bots?” Adora whispered.

“Different markings,” Brain replied.

“Yes. Those are regular bots but of a later series,” Entrapta added. “But those there, at the entrance, are the guard bots we’re looking for - see the numbers on the armour plating?”

Seacat did, even without her telescope, but the numbers didn’t tell her anything.

“Those indicate the series and model number, and they are quite distinct. The big “I”, for example, indicates the first special mark. And the number afterwards means...”

Adora cleared her throat. “Yes, yes. But important is: Once that bot is ready to be closed up, we’ll need the water to make a big splash… I mean draw attention.”

Seacat grinned while Adora blushed. Then she helped Brain Boy and Entrapta to put on their harnesses and checked the lines. Twice. A fall from this height would be worse than dropping from the mainmast of a Courier even if the floor weren’t covered with metal tools, spare parts and bots.

“Everything’s ready,” she reported.

“More or less,” Brain Boy added. “Don’t let us fall!”

“I could build a device to soften our impact - if I had a bit more time. And a workshop,” Entrapta said.

“I won’t let you fall,” Adora told them, smiling earnestly at them.

“Good.” Entrapta seemed reassured. Brain Boy… well, he didn’t complain.

Then they had to wait while the workers below went over every bot. Seacat sighed and hoped she didn’t fall asleep with boredom.

“...Oh. That’s a new tool. It allows them to access and alter the memory at once. Oh! I need that! It would make upgrading bots so much faster.”

At least Entrapta wasn’t bored. The princess was studying the workers below and taking notes on her device. Not that Seacat understood anything of it.

Brain Boy would, but he was talking in whispers to Glimmer, and Seacat tied not to overhear what they were talking about.

Same for Mermista and Sea Hawk - Seacat knew all too well what they were talking about; a ship’s cabins had thin walls, after all.

She glanced at Adora, who was trying to keep an eye on the entire hall at once. Just as Seacat had known she would. Smiling, she moved at Adora's side, sitting down on the beam so their legs touched.

Adora gave her a glance, which Seacat met with a wider smile, then went back to keeping an eye on the Horde.

But she wasn't as tense as she had been any more.

Then the guard bot they had spotted moved to the line, and everyone got ready.

Seacat watched as the Horde soldiers - Horde workers - below opened the armoured hull of the bot, then used a crane to lift it up. "Not exactly friendly for repairs in the field," she commented in a low voice.

"I know, yes!" Entrapta replied. "I've got plans for a field repair bot for that! Based on the standard bot chassis, they could travel everywhere bots could, keeping up and providing repairs. Well, assistance for repairing the bots - I haven't yet found a way to make bots that can actually repair bots."

And wasn't that a scary thought? "Don't let the Horde hear about your plans," she said.

Entrapta blinked. "Well, I wasn't planning to, but they would probably notice once we deploy them… Oh. Is this about our lack of bots in the Alliance?"

"Yes." The Horde would copy such an idea and benefit far more from it than the Alliance, where only Entrapta used bots - and a handful at most of them.

"Oh."

"Cheer up," Seacat mumbled as the Horde scum below started plugging some tools into the exposed innards of the bot. "Once we have the Horde beaten, you can build whatever bot you want."

“Yay! And I’ll have so many resources!”

Seacat blinked, then shook her head. She had to focus on the task at hand. This was essential for taking out Hordak.

Below them, the workers finished doing whatever they did to the bot and moved it further ahead in the line, to the crane where they’d lower the armour plate over the bot’s body. Almost. The crane was moving now, the Horde soldier controlling it doing some adjusting… and the plate slid in place.

“Mermista, now!” Adora hissed.

“Alright.”

For a second, nothing seemed to happen. Then a siren sounded - and the workers below jerked or froze. And a stream of water appeared in the back of the hall, quickly forming a growing pool on the ground.

Someone - probably a non-commissioned officer - screaming their lungs off got the workers moving, some scrambling to grab tools, others rushing towards the water.

“Direct some to the furnace there,” Adora ordered. “We need the cover of the steam.”

“Good thinking!” Sea Hawk said. Mermista grunted - but steam started filling the hall, causing more confusion.

“Bow, Entrapta - go!” Adora barked. “I’ve got you!”

At least Brain Boy looked a little sceptical, but both nodded and dropped their lines, then started descending. Seacat clenched her teeth. She’d prefer Brain Boy in the rafters, covering them with his bow, but he was the second-best tech expert they had. And they needed all of them for this.

Entrapta was the first to reach the abandoned bot, and her hair quickly reached for the crane control levers. Shortly afterwards,

the armour plate was rising again. Without hesitation, Brain Boy stuck his head and shoulders through the gap, followed by Entrapta.

Seacat held her breath, splitting her attention between the Horde scum frantically trying to stem the tide, or as much as she could see of their efforts through the steam cloud, and her two friends working below her. And tried not to think of the fact they were working underneath an armour plate heavy enough to crush either, should the crane fail.

Damn. It just took one Horde scum going back for some tools to wreck this. Who had approved of this plan, anyway? This had been a stupid idea.

But none came through the steam cloud. And no alert sounded. Other than the one still going on about the water.

Yet Entrapta and Brain Boy were still working. What was taking them so long? The longer they took, the higher the chance that someone would sound an alert if only to kick the mess up the chain of command so they wouldn't be blamed for this.

And Mermista couldn't keep it up forever, either, or it would become apparent that this was not a normal accident. Once the Horde managed to shut down the water lines, this would be over one way or the other.

Still no Horde soldier walking through the steam cloud - well, the steam was hot, which would keep them wary. But it wasn't hot enough to actually boil anyone.

What was taking the two so long? Couldn't they…?

As if they had read her mind, they finally pulled back out. Entrapta's visor was covered in oil, Seacat noted - and waved.

Adora immediately started pulling them up. Seacat moved to help them. Almost...

“They’ve shut down the water,” Mermista snapped.

Time was running out. Seacat gritted her teeth and heaved harder than if she were setting sails to escape a coming storm. Grip, pull, grip, pull, grip…

Entapta’s hair reached the beam first, and Adora almost lost her balance when the princess suddenly swung up by herself. Brain Boy was close behind her - he had climbed a fair part of the line himself.

Still no alert. Now all that was left was pulling up the remaining lines, getting out on the roof - and finding a way off the roof while everyone was busy repairing the pipes.

Easy.

*****

They made it back to the warehouse shortly before the sunrise - after all the additional Horde soldiers ordered to assist the maintenance building had finally finished getting into each other’s way and were sent back to their posts. Or barracks.

“Next time we need a distraction, we need to find something that won’t attract half the Horde,” Mermista muttered.

“Unless, of course, we want to attract half of the Horde!” the Captain said. “We now know how important coolant lines are for the Fright Zone, too - they should be a primary target for sabotage from now on! And, my dear Mermista, you’re perfect for exploiting this glaring weakness!”

That cheered her up. It cheered up Seacat as well. All in all, this mission had gone decently well - they had planted their device in the guard bot and got away clean. And apparently did a lot of damage to the Horde war machine.

Seacat grinned and stretched her arms over her head as she entered the warehouse. “I’m going to sleep past noon,” she

announced, “All this waiting tired…” She trailed off and blinked. This scent… this trace of… she knew it! This was… She hissed, her claws unsheathing, as a tall figure stepped out of the shadows near the stairs in the warehouse.

“Shadow Weaver.”

*****

The Traitor

Shadow Weaver! Seacat hissed and unsheathed her claws. There was the witch, standing barely out of the shadows, looking at them! Seacat could see her eyes behind the mask, but nothing else of her face. As always, her body seemed to fray at the bottom, floating and turning to shadows. An illusion, Seacat thought. Or hoped.

“Ambush!” Mermista snapped, water shooting up from the ground and forming a whirlwind around her.

Ambush? Seacat gasped. This was a trap! They must be surrounded!

Brain Boy raised his bow, arrow notched, and the Captain drew his sword, igniting it. Entrapta was fiddling with her device.

“No. Shadow Weaver wouldn’t be here if this were a trap,” Adora said, raising her free hand. “That’s not your style,” she added, facing the witch.

The witch inclined her head in return. “Very perceptive, Adora,” she said in a voice so low, it was barely above a whisper, yet carried through the hall. “As was to be expected, of course, of my star pupil.”

“Why are you here?” Adora replied. She hadn’t lowered or sheathed her sword, Seacat noted.

Shadow Weaver tilted her head slightly to the side. “There aren’t any bots outside,” Entrapta announced. “And the scanners I’ve placed show no movement, either.”

“Yeah, well - she obviously got past them,” Mermista commented.

“Yes. How did you manage that?” Entrapta asked. “My security scanners should have detected you. How did you bypass them? Did you freeze their sensors?” She beamed at the witch!

Who, Seacat noticed, actually seemed surprised. “Do you honestly expect me to reveal this?” she asked.

“Yes, of course!” Entrapta nodded, her hair swinging back and forth. “You’re here to talk to us, right? This would be a good subject!”

“It would certainly help with any claim that you’re not here to trap us,” Seacat added, baring her teeth at the witch.

Shadow Weaver chuckled, once, in that infuriating manner of hers that made Seacat want to rip her throat out. “I’m here because our interests overlap,” she said. “And the fact that I didn’t call the Horde guards down on you as soon as I noticed you sneaking over the border - or sabotaging the bot maintenance building - should be proof enough of my intentions.”

Seacat clenched her teeth and claws. The witch was lying, but she couldn’t yet tell what she was lying about. She knew their plans - which meant either there was a traitor amongst them, or the witch’s magic had let her discover this. She was betting on the latter - none of her friends with them was a traitor; Seacat would bet her life on it. Was betting her life on it, actually.

“What do you want?” Adora took a step forward.

“The same thing you want - Hordak’s death. At least I assume you’re not merely sabotaging his bot guards to sneak into his laboratory to copy his plans, or anything similarly ridiculous,” Shadow Weaver replied. Seacat could almost smell the arrogance dripping from her words.

“You want to stab your leader in the back?” Glimmer sounded very doubtful. “Typical Horde behaviour, I guess.”

“I prefer to think of it as defending myself against his betrayal,” the witch replied.

“‘His betrayal’?” Adora looked confused for a moment.

“You’re still alive, aren’t you?” Mermista added. “If he wanted to betray you, he could just order you arrested - and executed.”

Wait. There was something… “Your gem. It’s gone,” Seacat blurted out.

And the witch froze for a moment, glaring at her.

Seacat grinned in response. Flashing her fangs. “He took the gem away, didn’t he?”

“Oh, right. The gem in your mask,” Adora belatedly said. “What did it do?”

“It kept me alive,” Shadow Weaver told her. “Years ago, before your birth, a failed magical experiment left me… cursed. Slowly dying, I managed to find a way to stave off my demise using a magical gem. But Hordak decreed that he needed it for his *experiments*, and I was forced to hand it over. He told me that I would get it back once he was done, before the renewed curse would kill me - but I don’t trust him to keep his word.”

“With good reason,” Glimmer agreed.

“Nor do we trust you,” Seacat spat. The witch had to be lying. Besides, dying from a curse would be a fitting fate for her.

“So, unless you get this gem back, you’ll die.” Adora sounded… Seacat glanced at her lover and suppressed a hiss. Adora sounded as if he believed the witch!

“Painfully, yes.” Shadow Weaver nodded. “So, you see - we both have a very urgent interest in killing Hordak. You want to stop him before he completes his airship and starts raining death on your lands. I want my gem back before I die.”

“We want to end the war!” Glimmer butted in. “Not just to kill Hordak.”

“Killing him will end the war. I don’t have any interest in waging war - I only worked for Hordak so I could stay alive thanks to his help and find a way to remove the curse on me. I have no interest in leading the Horde.”

Yeah, right. Seacat hissed under her breath.

But Adora was nodding.

Seacat shook her head and scoffed. “As if! You’re already planning to stab us in the back!”

The witch turned her head towards her, tilting it a little. As she used to when scolding Catra. Which was always followed by a punishment. “Do you have so little trust in your… allies?” Shadow Weaver scoffed, but so silently, only Seacat heard it as the witch took a step forward. “Four princesses. Two accomplished warriors of renown. And you.” She made that almost laughing sound. “You fear such a formidable group wouldn’t be able to foil whatever plan I might come up with? And you think me as stupid as to risk my life on such a throw of the dice?”

Seacat clenched her teeth. “You’re already risking your life. And you don’t have much to lose, do you? This isn’t just about survival - it’s about power. You never liked even the slightest challenge of your authority!” she spat.

“Not from those beneath me,” Shadow Weaver replied. “But I’m not facing a mouthy cadet who couldn’t understand discipline and obedience - I’m talking to the leaders of the Princess Alliance.”

“Technically, you’re only talking to a few members of the Alliance,” Entrapta pointed out with a wide smile. “Only two sovereigns are present. That would be Mermista and I. Glimmer’s the commander of the forces, and Adora is She-Ra, but Queen Angella outranks both. I think, at least - Glimmer was promoted by the queen, so that’s clear, but I actually don’t know who promoted She-Ra.”

Seacat grinned as the witch seemed to be confused by Entrapta’s explanation.

“That doesn’t matter right now. We need to decide what we do now.” Adora, unfortunately, stepped in.

“Indeed.” Shadow Weaver was smiling under her mask; Seacat knew it. “As perceptive and decisive as ever, Adora,” the witch went on.

“We can’t trust her,” Seacat snapped, looking at Adora. Her lover had to see it!

“You don’t have to trust my word - but you should trust my intelligence,” Shadow Weaver said, looking at Adora. “You don’t honestly expect me to have come to meet you like this - alone - without having taken certain precautions, do you?”

“What did you do?” Adora asked.

Seacat hissed. “She left a note with a subordinate.”

“Indeed.” The witch tilted her head to the side as if she were surprised.

“A classic move!” Sea Hawk blurted out, pounding his palm.

“And one that means we can’t just kill her and make the body disappear.” Mermista, as expected, didn’t trust the witch either.

But Adora… Seacat’s lover shook her head. “So we either work together, or we all die.”

Shadow Weaver nodded. “And with my help, your chances of successfully killing Hordak and ending the war have just increased significantly.”

As did their chances to be stabbed in the back afterwards. But as much as she hated to admit it, Seacat knew that if Shadow Weaver had left a note, then Hordak would have them hunted down in short order.

Damn it.

“We’re in agreement then.” The witch held out her hand to Adora.

After a moment’s hesitation, Adora shook it.

“I’ll return this evening with more information,” Shadow Weaver announced.

“Why not share your information now?” Glimmer asked with a deep frown.

“I didn’t take the plans with me, of course.” Shadow Weaver shook her head. “I wanted to avoid tempting you to kill me, take the plans and rush your plans.”

Seacat scoffed through clenched teeth. That damn smug tone!

The witch nodded at Adora, looked at the others, and stepped back into the shadows. Seacat lost sight of her a moment later, and another moment later, she could hear the witch breathing or moving any more.

She stepped forward, closer to the shadows - but they were empty.

“She’s gone.” Seacat glared at Adora.

Her lover had the grace to blush - but still frowned. “What did you expect me to do? She had it all planned out so we had no choice but to accept working with her.”

But Adora didn’t have to shake the witch’s hand!

“Whatever,” Mermista cut in. “We now have to decide what we’re doing.”

“And we have to assume that she can observe us - listen to us - with her magic,” Glimmer pointed out.

Right. Shadow Weaver had revealed that she had been tracking them. Damn the witch and her magic!

“Can you block her… whatever she uses?” Adora asked.

Brain Boy shook his head. “I don’t even know how she’d do this. Perhaps a scrying spell?” He shrugged.

“She didn’t have any sensors placed here,” Entrapta announced. “But my detector doesn’t work on pure magic. I’m working on another version, but it has been harder than expected to calibrate the device since magic isn’t as logical as it should be.”

“Let’s assume she’s looking over our shoulder,” Seacat said.

And wasn’t that creepy?

“So, we need a way to communicate securely?” Entrapta beamed. “Give me a few minutes! And those pipes over there! And the tarps there! And some… Oh, I got it.”

Seacat watched as the princess grabbed the material - she practically ripped the pipes out of Adora’s hands with her hair - and bent down, pulling tools and some concoctions from her belt.

“What’s she doing?” Adora asked after stepping closer to Seacat.

“No idea,” she replied. “But it’s bound to be good.”

“Ah.”

Brain Boy looked confused, but after a few minutes, he perked up and started nodding. Obviously, he had realised what the princess was building. Seacat hadn’t, not yet, but she wasn’t about to ask him.

Glimmer showed no such restraint - Seacat could hear her ask in a low voice: “What’s she doing, Bow?”

“She’s making speech tubes,” Brain Bow replied.

Speech tubes? Ah. That meant the pipes would be used as...

“What did Bow say?” Adora asked in a whisper, interrupting Seacat’s thoughts.

“She’s making speech tubes,” Seacat replied.

“What?” Mermista was there as well.

“Speech tubes,” Seacat muttered.

“Speech tubes? How clever!” Sea Hawk exclaimed.

“Right?” Entrapta beamed at them. “I use them to order tiny food at my castle. And I think I can rig up a network so we can communicate safely!”

And she did. In about half an hour. The end result looked a lot like… well, some of those masks people wore to protect their noses and mouths against sand in the Crimson Wastes. If they also wore a mask over one ear. And all of the masks were connected to a central… thing.

“Everyone, grab one mouth and one ear part!” Entrapta announced. “Only one each - I didn’t have enough material for two ear parts. And, I guess, that means we’d hear anyone coming or something.”

Seacat reached for one mask, but a strand of hair swiped it away. “Not you, Seacat! Your ears are different, so I had to improvise!”

Seacat looked up and stared at the thing another strand of hair was holding out to her. “That’s… a bowl?”

Entrapta nodded. “Your ears are very expressive, so you can put the bowl over your head, and we can still see your ears move! That should help with understanding you!”

Seacat blinked. Adora giggled, and Seacat really wanted to kick her in the shin, but Entrapta was watching with that wide smile of hers that made you feel like the worst Horde scum if you made it

disappear. “Thank you,” she said, taking the transparent bowl in her hands.

“No problem! It was a nice engineering challenge! And my notes on social interaction came in very handy, or I wouldn’t have realised that you used your ears so much to convey meanings.”

Seacat hadn’t been aware of that, either. Well, she certainly used the ears to fool people when gambling, but she hadn’t realised that her friends had picked up on it as well. And speaking of friends… As soon as the princess turned away, Seacat did kick the still giggling Adora. Then she put the bowl over her head. It smelt like leather and some chemical that made her nose itch.

“Hello? Can you hear me?”

“Yes!”

“It seems to work.”

“So neat!”

“Ingenious!”

“Your ears are twitching, Ca-Seacat.”

And it worked. Maybe a little too well - the noise from the Fright Zone was gone, so the voices felt a little louder than normal. As long as no one screamed, it should work. “Alright,” she said, her voice echoing a little. “How do we keep Shadow Weaver from stabbing us in the back?”

“I’ll stick with her,” Adora said at once. “If she betrays us, I’ll put her down.” The tubes attached to her masks bobbed a little when she nodded.

“We’ll stick with her,” Seacat corrected her. Adora meant well, but she might hesitate a little too long to strike Shadow Weaver. “But we need more than that.” The witch was far too clever, after all.

“And we need something she won’t see coming.” Literally see, in this case.

“I think I have an idea,” Brain Boy said. “It depends on Entrapta.”

“Yay!”

Seacat winced - that cry had hurt her ears a little. But that was a small price to pay for foiling Shadow Weaver’s plan.

And, she thought as Brain Boy explained his idea, the boy had a very nice idea indeed. Seacat almost wished that Shadow Weaver tried to betray them.

“So… I’ll need more materials for this!” Entrapta declared. “The stuff here will do for some, but I need more bot maintenance supplies!” She gestured to the scrapheap in the corner of the warehouse.

“No, what we all need,” Seacat cut her off, “is rest. We’ve been up the whole night.”

“Technically, we didn’t do much for most of the night,” the princess objected. “We waited, which counts as resting time, last I checked.”

“Not when you’re hiding from the Horde and aren’t actually resting,” Adora said. She yawned. “We really need to rest.”

“One has to keep watch, though!” Entrapta said. “I can do that!”

“And work on your devices?” Brain Boy asked.

“Yes!”

“No,” Seacat said. “You need to rest. I’ll take the first watch.” She didn’t yawn. “And once we’ve rested, we can get the materials for you.”

“Oh… alright.”

Seacat knew she'd have to watch the princess as much as she had to watch their surroundings.

*****

Eight hours later, Entrapta was tinkering with scraps from the warehouse - and from a few 'rediverted' supply crates. And Seacat stretched out on her cot. She'd slept a few hours already, but a little more never went amiss.

"Ca-Seacat?"

Adora was standing at the foot of her cot. Seacat sighed. "Yes?"

"We have to work with Shadow Weaver."

"I know." She didn't look at her lover - she looked at the ceiling.

"But you're still angry with me."

Seacat pressed her lips together. Yes, she was. It was stupid, but she couldn't help it.

"I'm sorry," Adora said.

"It's not your fault." Seacat sighed again and turned her head to look at her. "I just…"

"You hate it." Adora sat down on the cot, then had to quickly jump up when her weight came close to toppling it. "Sorry!"

Seacat snorted, even though she had to grab the edges of the cot to keep from getting thrown off. "You're too heavy."

"Hey!"

"We're not kids any more - we don't fit on one cot any more." She grinned. Adora pouted in return, and Seacat reached out to pat her thigh. And her butt.

"We really don't have a choice," Adora repeated herself.

“I know. And I hate it.”

“I don’t like it either,” Adora said. She was eyeing the cot, Seacat noticed.

“Come on, sit down,” Seacat told her, sitting up and swinging her legs to the side.

Adora sat down next to her, and Seacat wrapped her arm around her shoulder. The cot creaked a little but held. “I’m sorry.”

Seacat rolled her eyes and used her free arm to reach over and flick the idiot’s nose. “It’s not your fault.”

“That doesn’t mean I’m not sorry.”

“You shouldn’t be.”

“Well, I am.”

“Then stop being sorry.” Really, it was simple.

“I can’t. Not when you’re so…”

Ah. “I’ll get over it. I’m almost over it already.” Leaning into Adora’s shoulder helped with that. Though… She slid into Adora’s lap and rested her cheek against her chest. Better. Much better, she thought when she felt Adora shifting beneath her and one arm wrap around her waist.

“I know she’s got a plan. I’m not dumb,” Adora said. She would be pouting, Seacat knew.

“I don’t think you’re dumb. Just an idiot at times.”

“Hey!”

“And we shouldn’t talk like this.” Seacat glanced at the ceiling. “She could be watching us.”

“I can get the masks for us.”

“No.” Seacat grinned and tilted her head back so she could look at Adora’s face. She touched her lover’s nose with a finger, then ran it down and over her lips. “We don’t have to talk about this. Not right now.”

“Oh.” Seacat felt Adora’s arm tighten around her waist and saw her lick her lips, then swallow while she blushed a little and glanced around them. “But the cot won’t, uh…” Her blush grew stronger.

“We don’t need a cot,” Seacat whispered. “Just a few blankets.”

“And privacy! We, uh, wouldn’t want to distract anyone from their work. Their important work!”

Seacat giggled. “We can move behind the crate there. I’ll hang up a sign so we won’t be disturbed.”

“But… they’ll hear us!” Adora sounded scandalised. But she was intrigued, Seacat could tell. And feel.

She smiled and licked her own lips, slowly. “You’ll have to be quiet, then.”

“Oh. But...”

“I’ll help you with that.” Seacat shifted, reaching up, and kissed her. That did silence Adora for a while.

Then she grabbed the blankets and led her lover behind the crate in the corner.

*****

The witch returned in the evening. Hidden on the roof, Seacat spotted her approaching the warehouse. Although that didn’t mean anything - Shadow Weaver wouldn’t show off if she had a way to approach them unseen. And Seacat assumed that the witch had seen them take up a guard position on the roof.

That was the thing she really hated: She had to assume the worst just so they wouldn't be surprised. Shadow Weaver wasn't perfect. She made mistakes - Catra was the best example of that - but they couldn't plan for that.

But even so, with Shadow Weaver approaching, it was time to swap. Seacat was one of two people in their group who knew Shadow Weaver; she needed to be down in the warehouse when the witch started talking, not up on the roof.

So while the witch crossed the road below, she moved back to the trapdoor in the ceiling and whistled.

Half a minute later, she heard someone climbing through the opening. "Seacat."

"Captain." She smiled wearily at him.

He beamed at her in return. "Take heart! We'll see this through to victory!"

She nodded, and he clapped her on the shoulder as she passed him on the way down.

The witch was already in the warehouse when Seacat slid down the ladder they had installed, landing on the floor in a crouch. She didn't greet Shadow Weaver, and the witch didn't acknowledge her either.

Another mistake, in Seacat's opinion. Adora might have mixed feelings towards Shadow Weaver, but not to the extent that she'd forget that the witch had tried to get Catra killed. Trying to ignore Seacat wouldn't help there, either.

She moved next to Adora, her tail briefly rubbing against her lover's calves and thighs, and grinned when she heard Adora inhale sharply in response. And she hoped that Shadow Weaver was frowning behind her mask.

"Have you recovered your… spying device?" the witch asked.

“No. The bot hasn’t been sent to maintenance yet,” Entrapta replied. “Another day, I think, if they keep the same intervals.”

“Project Omega approaches completion. The longer you wait, the greater the chance that Hordak will be out of your reach - literally,” Shadow Weaver told them.

“One more day shouldn’t hurt,” Seacat said.

“One more day of waiting, followed by how much time spent planning?” The witch sniffed. “By my estimate, the airship will be able to launch, operational, yet not completed, in a week at most. Perhaps earlier.

Ah. She was trying to hurry them along. To make them depend on Shadow Weaver’s information - and plans. Typical. “That’s plenty of time to make sound plans,” Seacat said.

“*You* would think so,” the witch replied.

“Yes, I would,” Seacat hissed. She felt Adora’s hand on her shoulder just as she realised that she had taken a step forward.

“One more day won’t hurt,” Adora said.

The witch stared at her for a moment, then nodded. “As you wish. I will return tomorrow evening, then.”

“Why don’t you stay?” Glimmer asked. “We can start making plans and adjust them once we know more.”

“I cannot stay here for too long without drawing suspicion. I will not risk discovery for a mere pre-planning session. I will return when you’re ready to finalise our plans.” The witch turned and walked into the shadows.

Seacat cocked her head, but she couldn’t hear Shadow Weaver’s steps. She might be gliding over the floor. After a bit, Seacat sighed. “Well, that was to be expected.”

“She has a point - if she’s under surveillance, she can’t just disappear repeatedly,” Brain Boy said. Seacat glared at him, and he raised his hands. “I’m not saying she’s right - just saying she has a point.”

That was the same! Seacat hissed under her breath. “She just wants us to depend on her.”

Adora nodded. “She wants to lead.”

“That’s probably part of the reason she is willing to stab Hordak in the back,” Glimmer said. The princess looked at the tarp under which Entrapata’s ‘communication network’ rested. “We shouldn’t discuss this in the open, though.”

“Right.” Seacat went and grabbed her bowl. At least she wouldn’t have to wonder who else had worn it before since it was unique. Her friends, though, spent a little time sniffing and swapping. She grinned when Glimmer took Brain Boy’s mask, thinking it was hers.

She didn’t grin when Adora was about to pick Entrapta’s helmet, and vice versa. “That’s yours,” she said, grabbing the mask before the princess could take it.

“Thank you!”

Of course, since the others saw it, she had to identify the masks for everyone. At least Entrapta marked them afterwards.

*****

“Hey!”

Seacat slowly raised her head at the guard’s call. “Yes?” She was just a grumpy, lazy Horde scumbag.

“What are you doing here? We don’t expect a delivery?” The sergeant in charge of the Bot Maintenance’s gate had come over.

She shrugged. “Administration is missing some paperwork, and I have to check the inventory here.” She presented her fake orders. And ignored the urge to pull off the helmet that was squishing her sensitive ears flat.

“What?”

“Someone misfiled the latest requisition forms, and now we need to redo them.”

“We haven’t used any requisition forms in weeks! Everything’s set!” the sergeant exclaimed.

She nodded. “That’s why I said - but the officer wasn’t listening. You know how it goes. ‘I want everything checked! No magazine left un-inventoried!’,” she added in a fake squeaky voice.

The guard chuckled, but the sergeant merely grinned. “You need to do an inventory?”

“Yes. So I can tell my dear superior that no, there aren’t any forms missing from this branch.” Seacat nodded with a sigh.

“Not your first inventory today, right?”

She shook her head. “Third.”

This time, both Horde soldiers winced. “Well, we won’t delay you. Just tell us when you’re done.”

“Will do,” she said and stepped inside the hall. She walked - not quickly, shuffling, like a soldier who had spent the day doing stupid jobs for stupid scum - past the line of bots waiting there, tapping on their legs. The bots from Hordak’s laboratory area weren’t amongst them. Not yet. Plenty of time for her mission.

She had to present her orders to another scumbag waiting at the office area in the hall before she could start her supposed task. But afterwards, it was smooth sailing. She could wander around everywhere in the hall without anyone bothering her. Other than

her tail, stuck wrapped around her waist. The things she suffered for the Alliance…

She shoved the thought away. Until the guard bots arrived, she had to kill time. Fortunately, killing time was something any Horde soldier learned quickly - you had to look busy at all times, or some officer would give you more work. So she faked counting the bots, the bot legs, the bot cannons, and then the bots again until she saw the first of the special guard bots arrive, quickly followed by the rest of them.

Then it was time to act her part. She pulled the special sheet of paper Entrapta had given her out from where she had had it stuck between forms and clipped it to her board as she wandered over to the start of the line. Once she was close enough, she faked having to fix her boots and knelt down, putting the board - paper side up - down next to her. Even squished, her ears picked up the sound of the bot's top moving in response.

Then all hell broke loose when the symbol on the paper triggered the changes Entrapta had placed in the bot. It froze for a moment, then started shooting wildly.

"Bot gone crazy! Watch out!"

"Run!"

The maintenance soldiers scattered like a school of fish when a shark attacked, some running screaming outside. Seacat resisted the urge to run as well. Entrapta had assured you that the bot's 'no shooting Horde uniforms' rule was still in effect. And she trusted the princess.

She still clenched her teeth when a shell hit the ground close to her and held her breath when she dashed towards the bot. But she reached its legs without being shot at, and a few quick jumps had her on top of it.

While the bot continued its rampage, she pulled out Entrapta's recording device and stuck it in the… where was the 'port'

Entrapta called it? Ah, there!

The shaky movement almost threw her off the bot, but she managed to keep her balance and stuck the device into the opening, then pushed the button Entrapata had told her to push. And held on to the bot as the hall filled with smoke and fire. Finally, the device lit up. She pushed the other button, then grabbed it and jumped off the bot.

And ran as fast as she could towards the exit.

She had barely made it out when the bot exploded behind her.

The area was full of panting, screaming soldiers and officers, none of them aware of what was going on. And it was already night time. Seacat had no trouble at all to tell the sergeant she was done for the night, and the officer could send someone else tomorrow, then slip away before anyone could stop her and return with Brain Boy, who had been watching from the closest roof, to the warehouse where the others waited.

And where Entrapta would check the bot's memories on her device.

*****

"So?" Seacat asked.

"Just a second!" Entrapta replied without looking up. "I'm sorting through the memories."

She'd been sorting through the memories for some time now.

"This won't take the entire night?" Brain Boy asked. "I mean, the bot recorded for almost a day…"

"Oh, no, I can compress the replay, no worry. Oh! That's fascinating!"

“Yes?” Adora leaned forward, trying to catch a glimpse of whatever Entrapta was looking at on her device.

“The bots have standard patterns, switching through them based on mathematical formulas!” Entrapta looked up and beamed at them. “It’s so elegant!” She blinked. “Predictable, but still elegant!”

Adora looked puzzled for a moment, then nodded. “So we could anticipate their positions based on the formula?”

“I guess so. It’s mostly elegant.” And she was back to looking at her device.

Seacat shook her head and sighed - silently.

“We shouldn’t have used a bot going out of control. They’ll look into the incident,” Mermista complained.

“The charge should have destroyed all traces,” Seacat retorted.

“And it also destroyed most of the maintenance building!” Sea Hawk added.

“Which means we’ll have to find the new one - and find a way in if we want to use the bots again,” Mermista said.

“Well, we shouldn’t use the same trick again.” Sea Hawk grinned. “We’ll find a new trick!”

“You mean we’ll listen to the witch and trust her plan?” Mermista was grumpier than usual, Seacat noted. With good reason, of course - Shadow Weaver had pretty much ruined their plans. Even if they found a way to get to Hordak thanks to the bot’s memories, they would have to account for the witch’s meddling.

“Oh! That’s how they get inside!”

“Yes?” Adora looked like she wanted to rip the device out of Entrpata’s hair.

“There’s a side gate for bots.”

“Can we use it? What are the codes?”

“Uh… they just walk up, and the door opens. I think. There’s no memory of the bot giving a sign or code.” Entrapta shrugged. “It’s probably safer that way.”

“If we find out who is on guard there…”

“Could be another bot. Or an automated system. Which, kinda, is a bot, of course,” Entrapta explained. “Hordak doesn’t seem to have many non-bot guards, does he?”

“He doesn’t trust his soldiers very far,” Adora said.

“Oh. He must be lonely.”

The leader of the Horde, lonely? And mostly talking to Shadow Weaver? Seacat snorted. “Don’t pity him - he’s responsible for the war.”

“Right!” Entrapta nodded. “Anyway, now here are the records of his lab. “Oh! That’s gorgeous! Such power!” She held up the device. “Look at that power plant! It uses crystals! His lab must be completely self-sufficient!”

Seacat suppressed a sigh. “Could we blow that plant up? Like an enhanced engine?”

The princess blinked. “Uh… in theory. But I can’t tell from this memory how exactly it works, so modifying would take some time.”

Damn. Time was in short supply.

“Oh! Here are the enhanced engine bombs!”

What?

“He’s got bombs there?” Adora said. “Where?”

“Well, they’re built here… let me check the map and compare it to the log of the inertial guidance system…” Entrapta trailed off and started muttering under her breath.

Seacat didn’t bother following her words - she barely understood the princess when she got into technical details. Unless it was about ships, of course.

Entrapta pointed at a section of their crude map. “Here! That’s where he builds or has built the enhanced engine bombs. Now let’s see if I can get any details…” She went back to staring at a panel of her device. “Oh! He has bots building them! Or he might be controlling the pincers remotely. But I think they’re automated.”

“He’s got bots manufacturing enhanced engine bombs?” Mermista asked. “Then he could have them build engines, too, couldn’t he?”

“Yes,” Entrapta replied without looking up. “They seem to be standard bots, just modified. I wonder why - my bots are all customised. Most of them. Does using standard bots add greater flexibility? Although… he still has to modify them for their individual tasks. On the other hand, it might improve their morale if they know they won’t be discarded if they become outdated - not that I would discard my bots, ever!”

Mermista looked grim. “If he can automate this, then he can scale up production easily once he has enough raw materials.”

“We already knew that we had to take him out,” Seacat said. “This changes nothing.”

“But others could use those bots,” Mermista objected.

“We’ll destroy them as well, then!” Sea Hawk said.

Between Hordak, his laboratory, this new manufactory and the airship, they would have to destroy quite a lot of the heart of the Fright Zone, Seacat thought. Not to mention that she was sure that they would have to deal with Shadow Weaver as well…

"So… that's a very interesting setup. Efficient, too! I think I'll build my next workshop like this," Entrapta said.

"You found his workshop?" Adora asked.

"What? No. I just studied the assembly line there. But you're right - Hordak's actual workshop, where he does his research and builds his prototypes, must be even more impressive! Let's hope B-Five took a stroll through it as well!"

"B-Five?" Brain Boy asked.

"That's the bot's name," Entrapta replied.

"*Was* its name," Mermista added.

"Oh, no - I got its memory saved in my recorder, too!" Entrapta beamed at them. "So, once we're done here, I can give it a new body!"

Seacat winced. Give a new body to one of Hordak's guard bots? She had seen first hand what such a bot could do if they went out of control - even worse, the bot hadn't really gone out of control. It seemed Entrapta was a little *too* impressed with all this Horde tech…

"But not without, ah, changing its allegiance, right?" Adora asked.

"Oh, that's unnecessary," Entrapta explained. "The bots don't really have an allegiance - they just have parameters according to which they act. I just need to edit out all the 'shoot this' orders."

"Is that the same with your bots?" Seacat asked.

"Oh, no! My bots are learning - they have an improving control and guidance centre. The bots here have the same, but they regularly get their memory wiped, so they can't exactly grow and improve. It's really wasteful and cruel. Well, it would be cruel, but the bots can't develop much, if at all, in a few days doing the

same things. But it's wasteful - if they were allowed to learn, they could do so much more!"

"I doubt Hordak wants more underlings that can think for themselves," Seacat commented. Especially if he mostly talked to Shadow Weaver.

"Why? He must be really lonely," Entrapta said. "Bots are great, but they're not good at talking."

"Because he doesn't trust anyone," Adora said. "But it's good that he's lonely - so we won't hurt anyone else when we take him out."

"Except for his guards and guard bots," Memista pointed out.

"Yes, except for them." Adora frowned a little.

"Oh, there's Hordak!"

Now Seacat wanted to take a look herself. But the device was too small. "What's he doing? And where is he?"

Without tearing her eyes off the device, Entrapta grabbed a pen with her hair and marked a door close to the centre of the restricted area. "Here. Oh, there's a glimpse into his lab… but not enough to see what he's working on. But that's great armour he's wearing. Very sleek, and… Oh. He turned and the back… it's technological armour! Look at the pipes and pistons!"

"Can you sketch his armour?" Brain Boy asked.

"Oh, good idea! I could try to reverse engineer it!"

"Or we can look for vulnerabilities," Brain Boy said in a dry voice.

"That too, I guess. I wouldn't want to build a flawed armour. Fascinating!"

Entrapta was halfway through a complicated sketch when Glimmer's voice sounded from above, where she was standing

guard on the roof:

“Shadow Weaver’s coming.”

Great. Seacat clenched her teeth as Sea Hawk scaled the ladder to relieve Glimmer.

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The Horde Leader Part 1

Shadow Weaver entered the warehouse with as much arrogance as before. Or even more. The others might not realise it, what with the mask covering the witch's face, but Seacat knew her well enough to tell from the way Shadow Weaver held herself as she glided over the floor.

"Adora." A brief nod. "Princess Glimmer. Princess Mermista. Princess Entrapta."

So, she had decided to be a little more diplomatic? Seacat snorted, which caused the witch to briefly tilt her head towards her. Seacat grinned in return. As before, the show of greeting the princesses wouldn't fool anyone who knew her. And both Adora and Seacat did.

"Shadow Weaver." Adora's answering nod was barely noticeable.

"I trust you've finished your 'scouting' efforts," the witch said. "At least I assume the bot rampage was an attempt to obfuscate what you did."

Seacat clenched her teeth. Yes, arrogant even though she wanted their help.

And Glimmer was bristling. "We did get good intel about Hordak."

"Oh, yes! Fascinating insight into his technology!" Entrapta nodded several times.

"We know that he's building pretty much all of the Horde technology," Brain Boy added. "And that he has tech armour."

Seacat didn't quite roll her eyes, but she wanted to. 'Tech armour' was Brain Boy's invention. The word, not the armour.

"Tech armour?" Shadow Weaver scoffed. "It's what's keeping him alive."

“Oh?” Entrapta perked up. “It has healing properties? It keeps him alive when wounded? He must have found a way to harness magic for that!”

“No. It’s not healing him - it’s keeping him alive despite his crippling wounds,” the witch corrected the princess. “The state of his health is so bad, he cannot live without his armour. I assume he can barely move without his armour. Destroy it, and he’s doomed.”

“Yeah.” Adora frowned. “But how good can he fight and move *with* his armour?”

Shadow Weaver inclined her head, just as she had done whenever Adora had asked a good question as a cadet. “Formidably. He’s a terrifying opponent. At least he was when he still took the field - but I doubt he has let the capabilities of his armour atrophy. However, I am certain he cannot stand up to you all - provided you face him together.”

“And take casualties doing so.” Mermista scoffed.

“This is war - the final battle of the war. Hordak must die. If you shy away from doing what needs to be done because you fear the price it may cost you, you will pay a much higher price later. You and your lands.”

“Our people,” Glimmer corrected the witch.

“I’m She-Ra; I can take him,” Adora said.

Seacat wanted to kick her shin. No, this wasn’t her fight. Not just her fight, at least. They were all in this together.

“You might be able to - but your power might not be enough to defeat Hordak before he can rally his guards and other reinforcements. Your friends would be in danger either way - but the outcome you need, Hordak’s death, would be much less secure.” Shadow Weaver shook her head. “No matter the risk, all of you need to attack him - and overwhelm him quickly.”

“Some of us are more suited to other tasks than fighting,” Brain Boy pointed out. “Especially in a research lab.”

“And an assembly line!” Entrapta added.

“You’re a master archer,” Shadow Weaver said. “And your trick arrows offer ways to severely hamper Hordak. What do you think you could accomplish in his laboratory that would compare to that?”

“You might not be aware of it, seeing as you never fought at the side of friends, but if you try to attack one man with too many people, they’ll only get into each other’s way,” Seacat told her.

“That might be - but in the end, the goal is achieved. Hordak will be dead.”

Yeah, that was just how the Horde worked. Drown your enemy in blood as long as it works.

“We’re not the Horde,” Adora said. “We’ll fight Hordak, but we’ll do on our terms. But we could use your help to get to him - it would make things easier.”

Seacat wanted to protest, but her friend was right. Probably. They would have a much easier time entering Hordak’s personal laboratory if Shadow Weaver opened the doors. “Not that we need your help,” she said anyway, sneering at the witch.

Shadow Weaver sniffed, then turned to Adora. “As you wish. But I hope you will remember my counsel before it is too late - all our lives are in danger, after all.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded with a firm expression.

“We know what we’re doing,” Glimmer added. “We’ve been fighting the Horde for years.”

“Fighting and defeating them,” Mermista added.

“And yet, for all your bravado, it’s all coming down to a covert strike against Hordak himself.” Shadow Weaver scoffed. “A strike that would’ve failed already if not for me covering up your entrance. Please try to remember this before you ruin everything for your pride.”

Seacat really wanted to hurt the witch.

“This isn’t about pride,” Glimmer protested.

“It isn’t? What about power? We both know that if your group defeats Hordak without my help, it will boost your reputation and influence amongst the Alliance much more than if you needed my support. A group of princesses bravely attacking the enemy leader is much more appealing than winning through treachery, isn’t it?”

“That doesn’t matter to us!” The princess shook her head. “All that counts is defeating Hordak!”

“Then it shouldn’t be a problem for you at all to accept my help.”

“There’s the matter of trust,” Seacat cut in. “Mainly our lack of trust in you.”

“If I wanted to lure you into a trap, I could have done so easily already,” the witch replied.

“You need us - until Hordak is dead,” Adora pointed out.

“And what would I gain by betraying you afterwards? Control of the Horde? It would collapse without Hordak’s technology. He took care to ensure that he was irreplaceable.” Shadow Weaver shook her head.

“If he hadn’t, you’d have made a move against him long ago,” Seacat spat.

The witch tilted her head at her, and Seacat could see the condescension in her eyes. “You would think so, of course. But I was well-aware of my means and my chances to succeed him.”

“But even without Hordak, you’d have his bombs and the airship!” Glimmer narrowed her eyes. “Even if you would run out of them and lose the airship to maintenance, you could do a lot of harm before that happens.”

“You’re planning to destroy the airship, aren’t you?”

“Yes. That still leaves the bombs,” Glimmer said.

“And they don’t need much maintenance, at least not for the next several months,” Entrapta added.

“But they require an army to use. The Horde is already teetering on the brink of disaster. If Hordak falls - and the airship is destroyed - morale will plummet. Horde soldiers will desert in droves - doubly so since the heartlands of the Fright Zone were attacked. You are aware of just how fragile the Horde is at the moment, aren’t you?”

“The Horde’s drilled to obey. As long as you can step in and give orders, most of them will continue the war,” Seacat pointed out.

“I will be too busy restoring my failing health,” the witch replied. “What would I gain if I kept the Horde running but died in the process?”

“You, too weak to do both?” Seacat scoffed. This was the witch’s plan: Have them kill Hordak and then kill them before taking over the Horde to lead them against the Alliance, which would be reeling from the losses.

“You are too ignorant and naive to understand.” The witch turned her head. “Adora. Do you believe the Horde would survive the loss of Hordak?”

Adora took a deep breath - she didn’t look like she wanted to be put on the spot like this. “If the chain of command is still intact, then… I believe it’s possible to keep the Horde running.”

“Even without the airship? Project Omega, which was touted as the Horde’s ultimate weapon?” Shadow Weaver shook her head. “You overestimate your enemy.”

“That’s called being cautious,” Mermista snapped.

“If you overestimate your enemy, you’ll risk losing a war to a beaten foe because you are too afraid to fight.”

“We’re here, in the heart of the Fright Zone. We can see how hard everyone’s working,” Glimmer said.

“As long as Hordak is alive. My own standing isn’t high enough to engineer the same kind of loyalty.”

“Well, then we need to dispose of the bombs and the airship!” Entrapta said. “Without either, the Horde can’t fight on. Well, not with a significant chance of winning the war.”

“Or we use the bombs to destroy the airship,” Seacat said. And a big part of the Fright Zone.

“That would be possible, but…” Entrapta bit her lower lip. “We would have to get the bombs into the yard.”

“The more people you divert to this, the lower your chance to kill Hordak becomes,” Shadow Weaver said.

Seacat scoffed again. The witch was showing her cards.

“We can take both. All three,” Adora said, nodding firmly - and meeting Shadow Weaver’s eyes with a stern expression. Unwavering.

Seacat sighed softly at the sight.

The witch held Adora’s gaze for a long moment, then nodded. “So be it. I hope you’re right, Adora. For all our sakes.”

“So do we,” Brain Boy added.

The witch seemed to ignore him. “I can slip in Hordak’s sanctum tomorrow evening - I will ask for an audience with him. As long as you follow me without being seen, you’ll be able to attack him by surprise and overwhelm him.”

“We need the route in advance, so we won’t get lost if we lose sight of you,” Adora said.

“I’ll mark it on your… map.” The witch nodded at their sketch on the crate serving as a table. “But smuggling a bomb out of the laboratory and into the hangar… I can’t help you there.”

“You don’t need to,” Entrapta told her. “We can handle it!”

“And can you avoid Hordak’s spies on your own?” the witch asked.

“His spies?” Adora frowned.

Shadow Weaver cocked her head. “He has spies in the Fright Zone. I have managed to avoid them to meet with you thanks to my long experience, but I dare say that trying to steal an enhanced bomb would run afoul of them - Hordak is aware that such a bomb represents a grave threat to him.”

Of course the witch would say this to keep them following her plan! On the other hand, it made a lot of sense that Hordak wouldn’t leave such bombs unguarded. “I assume you will tell us to get the bombs after we kill Hordak, right?” Seacat said.

Shadow Weaver glanced at her. “That would be the obvious solution. Once Hordak’s dead, his spies will be useless. They might find other masters, but since they have exclusively reported to Hordak, Horde officers wouldn’t trust them. Hordak’s death would provide you with a window of opportunity to further wreck the Horde.”

“And you with an opportunity to betray us!” Glimmer retorted.

“I will be busy saving my life,” the witch replied. “I’ve explained that before. I would not risk my life for the dubious privilege of

controlling a doomed army."

"Unless you think you could save them," Adora said, hands on her hips.

"Even if I thought so, do you honestly think I would take such a risk? You should know me better than that, Adora."

Seacat gritted her teeth. The witch was manipulating Adora. "We know that you're a liar," she spat.

Adora nodded.

"I've lied before, yes. But I'm not lying now." Shadow Weaver tilted her head again. "All I want is to cure the curse on me. What happens to the Horde afterwards is of no concern to me any more."

"Was it ever a concern?" Adora asked. "Or was the Horde just a means to an end?"

"It was a means to save my life," the witch replied after a moment. "That doesn't mean every member of the Horde was merely a means to an end." She looked at Adora.

Seacat scoffed. "We know you! You treat everyone as a tool!"

"Not everyone. I've cared for Adora since she was a baby."

And she hadn't cared for Catra. "And you've tried to murder me," Seacat spat.

"A mistake, in hindsight."

Seacat wanted to hurt the witch. Kill her. She could just pounce on her. Shred her with her claws before she could react. At this distance, she wouldn't be able to use her magic. And if she truly was dying, she might be weakened enough to…

Seacat drew a deep breath. No. She couldn't kill Shadow Weaver. Not now, when they were so close to defeating the Horde.

"Enough!" Mermista spoke up. "We don't trust you. Tell us how those spies operate, and we'll find a way to deal with them. Get us to Hordak, and we'll kill him. But if you try to betray us, you'll regret it."

Shadow Weaver looked at the princess, then nodded. "Very well."

Seacat didn't relax or sheathed her claws until the witch had left the warehouse. "She's... "

Adora put her hand on her shoulder, then pulled her in for a hug. "I know."

She didn't know, though. But she tried her best. Seacat closed her eyes and hugged her lover.

"So…" Entrapta held up the speaking tubes again. "Planning session?"

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Hordak's laboratory wasn't visible from the roof of the warehouse - a wall of big furnaces blocked the view - but Seacat still looked towards it. Today was the day. Today Hordak would die. And the war would end.

And Shadow Weaver would betray them. Seacat was certain. The witch was too focused on them killing Hordak and ignoring everything else. She had to have a plan to stab them in the back as soon as Hordak fell.

Well, they had a plan for that as well. They weren't as naive as the witch thought.

She bared her teeth. Oh, yes - Shadow Weaver would rue this day!

“Don’t stab her before we kill Hordak.”

Seacat turned. Adora had climbed up on the roof as well. “If you tried to surprise me, then you failed. I heard you on the ladder.”

“I wasn’t trying to surprise you!” Adora protested as she walked up to Seacat. “I just wanted to…”

“I’m fine,” Seacat said at once.

Adora didn’t say anything, just watched her.

“I don’t like waiting,” Seacat said.

Adora still didn’t say anything.

Seacat sighed. “I’m not going to stab her. Not until she betrays us.”

“You think she will betray us.”

Seacat tilted her head at her. “You think she won’t?”

“I don’t know,” Adora said. “I don’t know what she’s planning. She says she doesn’t want the Horde, and…”

“You believe her?” Seacat snapped.

“I do believe her that she doesn’t want the Horde just to rule the Horde. She’s not the type. But she wants something, and if commanding the Horde will help her get it, she’ll try to take over the Horde.”

Seacat nodded. “And she’ll betray us for it.”

“If we get into her way. Or she thinks we’ll stop her,” Adora said.

Seacat looked at her with a frown. “Whatever she’s planning, it can’t be good.”

Her lover sighed. “I know. But… part of me hopes that she is telling the truth and only wants to cure herself.” She looked down at the ground - well, the roof. “We’ll be hard-pressed enough with Hordak and then the Horde.”

Seacat waited a moment, then spoke up: “I hope she tries to betray us.” She clenched her fists. “I want to kill her.” The witch had tried to kill her. Had wiped out an entire village and her own troops for it. And she was trying to manipulate Adora. “She’s fixated on you. Even if we let her go, she’ll return and try something.”

“I know!” Adora replied. “But we made a deal. Breaking it…” Seacat could see her jaw muscles moving as Adora clenched her teeth. “It wouldn’t be right.”

Adora would be worried about that, Seacat knew. She’d been a stickler for rules and regulations. Not that there was anything wrong with having a code - as long as it was flexible enough.

“If I, if we break our word and stab her in the back - what does that mean for us? How can people trust us if we do that?” Adora asked.

Seacat pressed her lips together. The Captain had taught her that a sailor’s reputation was, well, their livelihood, if not their life. Even pirates knew that if they had a reputation for breaking their word, they would have to fight harder to capture a ship since no one would surrender. And she wasn’t a pirate.

And the enemies and rivals of Seacat’s friends would use this against them. Mermista would have more trouble with the admirals. And her relationship with the Captain would be more difficult - Seacat knew the officers would blame him for this. The other princesses would probably be affected as well. Glimmer had the queen to cover for her, but Entrapta? She scoffed. “I hate it.”

“I know.”

Seacat closed her eyes and leaned against her. “The moment she turns against us, I’ll finish her.”

“We’ll finish her.”

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The message arrived while they were eating dinner. Horde rations, so it wasn’t a big loss - Seacat tossed hers as soon as the shadows in the corner started to move and formed letters. A word.

Come

She took a deep breath and stood. This was it. Shadow Weaver would be waiting at the side entrance to let them in and guide them to Hordak.

“Alright! Does everyone know the plan?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Mermista rolled her eyes.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times.

“Yes.” Glimmer looked ready and determined.

“Yes.” Brain Boy nodded.

“Huzzah!”

Seacat grinned. It was finally time. “Let’s go!”

They left the warehouse. It was dark outside already - Seacat wasn’t sure if that was a good thing. It meant fewer Horde scum on the roads to stumble into them or ask questions about their orders, but it also meant it would be easier for Horde troops to hide or move unseen, if this was a trap. Of course, if this was a trap, the warehouse would’ve been surrounded already, but…

She shook her head and focused on watching their surroundings as they marched, disguised as a troop of guards, towards

Hordak's laboratory.

They passed a patrol of regular bots without issue - other than Entrapta looking a little too long at the slight limp one bot had developed, but Seacat didn't have to drag her with them - and reached the side entrance in question.

It was supposed to open automatically if you approached and were expected, so they kept going. Seacat held her breath. If this was a trap, then this would be the perfect moment to attack them - caught in the open, with a massive wall blocking their path.

But no troops rushed in to surround them, and when the entrance slid open, Shadow Weaver stood there.

And the witch wasn't happy. "Hordak's not in his laboratory," she announced before anyone could say anything. "He's in the airship yard."

Seacat hissed. That… complicated things.

"Are you still meeting him?" Adora asked.

"Yes. But you'll have to find your own way in," the witch said. "And quickly. Before he grows suspicious - and notices that his spies have been dealt with already."

Great. "What about the laboratory's guards?" Seacat asked.

"What about them?"

"We need to sabotage the bombs," Seacat explained. That was the agreed-upon plan!

"Disabling the security to the bomb storage would alert Hordak. We can't risk that until we have faced him," Shadow Weaver replied.

Seacat clenched her teeth. She hated it, but the witch was right. But…

“Then we’ll sneak in without alerting the guards!” Sea Hawk announced. “Well, some of us.”

“That’s too dangerous!” Shadow Weaver hissed.

“It’s a risk we have to take,” Adora spoke. “We trust our friends.”

“Huzzah!”

That meant Adora, Seacat, Glimmer, Mermista and Sea Hawk would attack Hordak, with Brain Boy and Entrapta going after the bombs. More or less like they planned to split up anyway - but they wouldn’t be close enough to support and reinforce each other now.

And Shadow Weaver was angry. “I won’t take responsibility if this leads to a disaster.”

As if the witch ever did! Seacat snorted as she bared her fangs to her.

“Alright. This doesn’t really change much,” Adora said. “We talked about this before, so we’ll stick with our plan.”

“But…” Entrapta started to protest.

Adra shook her head. “We stick to our plan. I trust you.”

The princess nodded, though reluctantly. “Alright then. I guess.”

Adora turned to Shadow Weaver. “Go. We’ll sneak into the yard ourselves and get to his office.”

“Or wherever he’s at the moment,” Glimmer added. “As long as we can see him, we can reach him.”

Seacat nodded. This was why Glimmer hadn’t been using any magic so far during the mission. She could get them into the airship yard and into Hordak’s office without trouble.

“I see.” Shadow Weaver nodded, then turned and started to leave. “Don’t start until I’m inside,” she said over her shoulder.

Seacat bit her lower lip to keep from snapping at the witch. Shadow Weaver wasn’t in command.

“Alright,” Adora said as soon as they were alone. “Bow, Entrapta - go and get the bombs and do your thing.”

Seacat snorted again - Adora had such a way with words sometimes.

“Everyone else - come!”

Seacat smiled at Entrapta, then followed Adora.

“Alright.” Adora walked quickly. “Glimmer can teleport us inside past the guards - once she catches a glimpse of the inside.”

“The air ducts up on top; if she drops us there, we’ll be fine,” Seacat said. She made a quick mental calculation. “But that might be a little hard to spot - unless you’re at the gate.”

“Then I do two teleports,” Glimmer said. “One into the air, then on the duct. Then I can fetch the rest of you.”

That would be an additional two teleports. Nothing too difficult, but… “If the gate’s open when we arrive. We might have to wait for a delivery,” Seacat said. “Can’t do anything about that,” she added. “We could take out the guards easily, but that wouldn’t let us open the gate.”

“Let’s hope that there’s a delivery,” Adora said. “Soon.”

Seacat nodded. She hated depending on others like this. First Shadow Weaver, and now they had to hope some Horde supply sergeant was going to do their job when they arrived.

She suppressed a sigh. Perhaps they should’ve asked Shadow Weaver to take them with them… No. Hordak would’ve been

suspicious if he saw them arrive together. They'd have to improvise if needed.

She grinned. Hell, if everything failed, Adora could probably cut a hole in the gate. Or push them open.

They reached the shipyard. Airship yard, Seacat reminded herself. And wasn't that something? How long until ships would be replaced by airships? Or would airships be too costly to produce in large numbers and remain limited to the military?

She scoffed silently at herself and focused on the building ahead of them. This wasn't the time to wonder about the future. They had a Horde leader to kill.

Two of them.

The gate was closed, and the guards were alert - much more alert than before, she noted. So, it was true that Hordak was in the yard. But there was no wagon approaching with supplies.

And no sign of Shadow Weaver.

"So, how do we do this? Tell them we're expected by Shadow Weaver?" Mermista asked.

"Charge the gate and blow it up?" Sea Hawk suggested. "We would be inside before they could recover and gather enough troops to stop us."

"But we would alert them before we strike at Hordak, who might use the opportunity to escape," Seacat pointed out.

"Do we have an alternative?" Adora asked. "Glimmer can't teleport if she can't see the destination."

"Welll…"

Seacat looked at the princess. That wasn't the face of someone agreeing with Adora.

“Glimmer?”

“I *can* teleport without knowing or seeing the destination,” she said. “But it’s taking more out of me. And… I can miss.”

“Miss?” Adora asked.

“I could land somewhere else.”

“Like next to a guard? Or in another building?”

“Yes.”

“Let’s shelf that for now,” Adora said.

Seacat agreed.

“The water pipes!” Mermista broke the sudden silence. “We can enter through them!”

“The pipes?” Adora asked.

“They’ve got cooling lines. We can enter through them - and then we cut the line and break out. Cause a disruption and distraction,” Mermista explained. “I can feel the pipes from here.”

Seacat bit her lower lip. That sounded good. Dangerous but doable.

And they wouldn’t have to depend on anyone else.

“But we need to cut the pipes, right? To get into them,” Adora asked.

“I like that,” Glimmer said. “I don’t fancy drowning.”

“The valves are inside the building - or farther away,” Mermista said. “It would delay us if we headed there, and we might have to deal with guards.”

“And we might trigger an alert. Which would screw up the whole plan.” Adora sighed.

“And we would have to hold our breath while we get pushed through a pipe full of water, hoping that we don’t miss our exit - which we will have to make by cutting our way out anyway,” Glimmer said. “I can’t believe anyone would suggest that.”

Adora pouted, “I was just trying to find a way to preserve our surprise.”

“Well, it doesn’t seem like it would work - but if we cut the pipes, it might serve as a distraction,” Seacat said. “Cause the area to flood.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk smiled. “The sea shall be our ally even this far inland!”

“You mean the river water they are using,” Mermista said.

“Which shall create a new sea here. Small, and not very deep, but… it’s the thought that counts. Huzzah!”

“Whatever. Let’s go!”

They hurried over to the back of the building, where the cooling pipes entered. And where the ground was flat - and hid the giant trapdoor underneath through which the airship would fly out. If Seacat hadn’t known the underground layout, she wouldn’t have suspected a thing, but now… It did look suspicious to have such a vast area without anything built on it. And while the Horde was apparently using it for drills, it was too far from the actual infantry and cadet barracks to be practical.

Someone had been sloppy, she thought. A new barrack nearby would have helped - and allowed the Horde to train the ship’s crew as well. Then again, that might have attracted attention as well.

“Alright! Everyone ready?” Adora’s question interrupted Seacat’s thoughts. Her lover was standing at the biggest pipe, sword ready.

“Yes.”

Seacat hurried to Mermista. “Yes.”

Adora took a deep breath, raised her sword with both hands and struck. The magic blade cut through the metal with ease, and the whole pipe came apart, water shooting out of the gap - and curving away from Adora.

“Thanks, Mermista!” Adora smiled over her shoulder at the princess.

“Let’s hurry - this is a lot of pressure.”

Seacat dashed forward and jumped into the pipe, her bare feet landing in a puddle on the bottom. The whole pipe smelt like the river, too - not the cleanest water. But not as muddy as the river proper.

“Onward!”

The rest climbed into the pipe, Sea Hawk carrying Mermista despite her protests, and they hurried towards the yard.

Seacat could already hear alarmed shouts outside. She hoped that the Horde scum wouldn’t hear them running inside the pipe - the water at the bottom did dampen the sound of their steps a little, but to Seacat’s ears, it still rang rather loud.

She took the lead then glanced over her shoulder - they were still outside the building. She kept running. A few more yards, and they were inside the building. “Almost,” Adora said next to her.

Then they reached the part of the pipe that went straight down - to the actual slip on which the airship was being built. Seacat stared down. About ten yards, maybe a bit more. Too much to

jump - there was no water left below. In fact, steam was rising through the pipe.

Right, this pipe was used to transport cooling water. Without water, things would get hot. But to descend into that…

"Alright!" Adora said and raised her sword again.

"What are you…" Seacat started to say, but her lover drove the sword into the wall ahead of them, then leaned into it - and jumped.

Seacat stared as Adora slid down the pipe, cutting it open lengthwise, until she landed on the bottom. "Jump! I'll catch you!"

Seacat snorted, then grinned and jumped herself, descending with a series of quick jumps from one side to the other until she reached the bottom.

Adora frowned at her, then grinned herself. Had she expected anything else from Seacat?

Sea Hawk jumped as well, landing harder than Seacat but not too hard. Mermista slid down on a pillar of water - which caused more steam to rise - and Glimmer actually let herself be caught by Adora.

But the metal under Seacat's feet was growing hotter by the second. And the air was turning to steam. "We need to get out!" she snapped.

"Yes!" Adora swung her sword - and cut the pipe wide open. As the slab of metal fell down, Seacat looked into the huge hall, at the airship under construction - and at the window across the hall.

Hordak's office.

"Glimmer!" she snapped, pointing at it.

Glimmer whipped her head around and stared at the window, narrowing her eyes. “Got it!” She grabbed Adora’s and Seacat’s hands as the first shouts of alarm rang through the hall - the Horde scum had seen them.

Then everything went sparkly for a moment, and they appeared in a large room with a desk and lots of weird devices. And Hordak. Glaring at them.

“Get the others!” Adora yelled, already charging the Horde leader.

Seacat dashed to the side, jumping over a chair. If she flanked Hordak…

“You dare!” Hordak raised his right arm, and something launched from it, hitting Adora and blasting her back. Seacat gasped as her lover hit the window, then fell down, leaving cracks in the thick glass.

“You dare to attack me in my home?”

For a moment, Seacat was frozen. If Adora was… But her lover groaned and got up. Seacat hissed and charged the scum who had hurt her. As soon as he turned to face her, she dived to the side, and his next blast wave thing missed her and wrecked the chair behind her.

She jumped on his desk while he was still turning to shoot at her again, then lashed out with her foot in a spinning kick.

He blocked it with his armoured bracer, and her eyes widened as she felt her claws slide off. What kind of armour did he have?

She quickly flipped back, off the table, avoiding the next blast, but mistimed the landing and rolled over her shoulder, coming up in a crouch and staring down the cannon mounted on Hordak’s bracer. That was…

“No!” Adora slammed into the Horde leader, and his shot went wide, blowing a hole into the ceiling as she rammed him into the

wall behind him. Seacat moved to help, but before she could reach them, Hordak managed to swing his arm around, and Adora was blown back again, but this time, she managed to keep standing. Mostly.

Seacat ducked behind the desk when the Horde leader turned. Where was Shadow Weaver? And where was Glimmer?

Sirens started blaring. Something moved at the back of the wall, stepping out of the shadows - Shadow Weaver! The witch raised her hand, and lighting leapt towards Hordak, crackling all over his armour.

"Traitor!" he turned and fired at her. Her magical shield stopped the blast, but she was pushed back anyway. "This is how you repay me for saving your worthless life?"

"You betrayed me!" the witch snarled. She sent more lighting towards the Horde leader, but it didn't seem to affect him.

"Rah!" Adora jumped and brought her sword down on Hordak with both hands. The Horde leader dodged to the side, though - moving far faster than he had any right to! - and the sword carved a deep gap into the floor.

Hordak turned and fired at Adora. She took the blast on her sword, deflecting it into the ceiling. Splinters flew, and dust and smoke covered Adora as Hordak fired again - and Seacat pounced, coming at him from behind. Her blade struck his chest plate - and slid off. She let go of it and jumped on his back, claws scrambling for purchase, as she reached for his uncovered head. Close quarters were her strength. He whirled, almost throwing her off, and instead of tearing his throat out, she tore half an ear off.

He screamed, and she bit his neck, raising one arm to slice his throat…

...and her whole body went stiff with pain as lightning ran over her.

“Stupid child!” she heard Shadow Weaver curse before Hordak rammed his back - and Seacat - into the wall behind him.

The impact drove the breath out of her chest, and she fell down, head reeling from the blow.

“You pest!”

Hordak turned. He would shoot her. She had to move! But her body wasn’t responding. Her legs were shaking and twitching, not pushing. This was…

“Leave her alone!”

Hordak screamed. And something hit Seacat. Liquid. Warm liquid. Blood, her nose told her.

She blinked.

Hordak’s blood.

He was screaming still, wildly firing at Adora, who was driven back, as more lighting leapt over his armour without doing anything.

And he was bleeding from his side. Adora’s magic sword could cut through his armour - at least the weaker parts.

Unfair, Seacat thought as she got up, still on trembling legs. But if her claws didn’t work… She grabbed part of the wrecked desk and struck at the Horde leader’s legs from behind.

He fell to the ground, unbalanced by the blow. “You!”

Seacat was already moving, running towards the other side of the room, dodging behind the wrecked desk. A blast missed her - and hit the window in front, shattering it and blowing the pieces out, to fall down to main hall of the yard. She jumped and rolled - clumsily, she almost stepped on her own tail - over the floor,

keeping low. More screaming filled her ears. And more sirens. Familiar sirens.

Adora was attacking again, swinging her blade, though Hordak somehow managed to fend her off, using his bracers to parry. He kept firing as well, but Adora struck his hand away before he could line up a shot.

Seacat grinned and started towards the fighting, still keeping low. The wild blasts struck the ceiling and walls, filling the room with smoke and dust.

Lots of smoke.

Seacat was about to flank Hordak again - at least the stupid witch had stopped throwing lightning around, though whatever she was doing wasn't doing anything to Hordak either - when she realised why the sirens sounded so familiar.

"Fire!" she spat. That was the fire alarm of the Horde. She glanced to the hall and saw it was filling with smoke as well.

The yard was burning.

"You stupid useless creature!" Shadow Weaver spat. "Did you set fire to the entire building?"

"No!" Seacat blinked. "The cooling pipes!" They had cut the cooling water - the plants would be overheating. And if no one turned them off…

And Shadow Weaver was gone. Glimmer hadn't returned - something must have happened. That left…

Adora flew back, crashing into the wall with a grunt of pain, then slid down, crumpled.

"Hah!" Hordak stepped out of the smoke cloud. Grinning. He swayed, still bleeding - but his arm cannon rose.

Seacat rushed him. Hordak snarled, and his arm swung around.

Seacat dropped to the floor and felt the heat of the shot was over her as the scum fired a moment later. The wall behind her exploded, but she didn't care - she hit Hordak's legs, sending him sprawling, then grabbed his cannon arm, biting and clawing at the softer parts of his armour. She had to disarm him. No matter how.

Before he…

Something hit her head, and she saw stars.

*****

The Horde Leader Part 2

Her head ringing, Seacat clung to Hordak's arm, trying to fend off the next blow with her free arm. If she let go, she was dead - he'd blow her to pieces with his cannon.

He hit her arm, and she hissed at the pain. But it also allowed her to focus. She deflected his next blow, jerking at the shock when he fired his gun in an attempt to shake her off. In response, she clenched her legs around the barrel despite the heat and bit down harder, chewing at the fabric between the armour plates and the gun mount.

He had hurt Adora. She'd kill him!

His next blow hit her shoulder, and she yelped - but didn't let go. Her claws found a spot at his elbow, and she dug in, wriggling her fingers, slicing into his sleeve, then into his flesh.

He grunted. "You pest!"

And he shamed her into the wall. But he had no leverage - she could weather those blows. Warm blood was running over her hand, now. And her fangs finally pierced his suit. His blood tasted awful. But she kept biting. And clawing.

Hordak would die!

He grabbed her flailing arm instead of trying to hit her. And started pulling. She screeched and tried to resist - but he was too strong. A little more, and he'd pull her arm out of its socket!

No choice. She let go - and used the momentum as he overbalanced to swing around and rake the claws on her feet across his face before he managed to fling her off.

He tumbled back, howling with pain, as more blood ran down his face. "You…. I'll kill you!"

Holding one hand to his ruined face, he moved the cannon to point at her.

She dodged to the side, rolled over her shoulder and charged him again, jumping right when he lined up the barrel, and twisted her body in the air.

But he didn't shoot - he pulled his arm back instead!

Her eyes widened, and she lashed out with her foot, connecting with the cannon and kicking it up right before it fired.

It missed her, blasting another hole in the ceiling.

Then the pain hit her, right when she was about to hit him. Her foot… the blast must have burned it.

Instead of clawing his face off, she smashed into his chest plate, driving the breath out of her lungs, and slid down.

Despite the pain, she moved forward, between his legs, as his cannon swung around again.

And she punched up, slicing the inside of his thighs and smashing into his groin.

Blood splattered over her, and he howled again even though her claws slid off the groin protection. She tried to cut his tendons, but the armoured boots stopped her.

Then he kicked her, in her wounded leg, and she was pushed to the side, rolling over the torn floor until she hit the remains of the window in the front.

Hordak was reeling, his bleeding legs wobbling - but he was aiming at her. Seacat rolled to the side, into the thickening cloud of smoke entering through the smashed window. The next blast missed her, tearing out more of the front wall.

She scrambled away on all fours - on her hands and knees, trying to hold her burned foot in the air. Where was Glimmer? What had happened? Adora was… No!

Snarling, she changed direction, moving towards Hordak again. She had to keep him distracted, or he would…

She left the smoke and gasped - Hordak was gone. Coughing, she whipped her head around. Adora! Her lover was still lying where she had fallen.

Seacat crawled towards her as smoke filled most of the office. "A..." She coughed again, "Adora!"

She reached her. And reached out for her face. Her throat. Adora was breathing. But… they couldn't stay in the office. Not with smoke filling it. They'd suffocate. Damn.

"Wake up, Adora!" she yelled, then coughed some more.

But Adora didn't stir. Blinking through her tears, Seacat grabbed her lover's arms and started pulling her towards the door. They had to get out. Get away. Before the smoke killed them.

Her wounded foot hit something, and she screamed. Oh. Adora's sword. For a moment, Seacat hesitated. Then she grabbed it, bit down on the grip and continued pulling Adora towards the door.

Everything hurt. And Adora was heavy. But Seacat wouldn't give up. Not now. Not ever.

She just had to reach the door. And close it. To keep the smoke out. Then she could rest. A little. Until…

There was the door. She pulled Adora through, pushing her the last yard, then pulled the door closed behind her.

And collapsed over her lover.

*****

“Catra! Seacat! Wake up! Oh, no! Please!”

Seacat opened her eyes and blinked. Everything was… blurry. And hazy. But her foot didn’t hurt any more. And breathing didn’t hurt any more, either. “Wha…?” she started to say, then coughed.

“Ca-Seacat!”

And someone crushed her ribs. Someone? “Adora!”

“Oh, I was so worried!”

“Can’t… breathe…” Seacat managed to say.

“Oh, no! Did I mess up the healing? Wait!”

Before Seacat could protest, Adora released her, and a beam of light hit her.

“Are you feeling better?”

“You were crushing me,” she explained. Though she did feel better - her lungs didn’t hurt any more. But the smoke would quickly change that. And… “Hordak! He ran!” Seacat jumped up. “We need to catch him!”

“Wait!”

But Seacat wasn’t waiting. “Come!” She took a few steps towards the stairs, then stopped and turned. Adora looked… well, she looked hurt. “Oh, no!”

As Seacat should’ve expected, Adora frowned, then raised her chin. “I’m fine. Let’s go!” She dashed past Seacat.

“You were knocked out when I dragged you out of the office!” Seacat yelled as she went after her lover.

“And you were knocked out when I woke up.”

“But you healed me!”

“I’m She-Ra; I heal fast.”

“But…” Seacat jumped over the handrail and landed next to Adora on the lower stairs. “Not that fast!”

“We can’t let him escape! Run!”

Was she deliberately misunderstanding her? Seacat couldn’t tell. But she chased after Adora. They couldn’t get split up. Not more than they already were. Damn! “Something must have happened to Glimmer! She never returned!”

Adora didn’t answer - but she ran faster.

Seacat cursed and started jumping over the handrails rather than trying to keep up running. That way, she could even pass Adora, and…

She gasped as she almost jumped straight into a gaping hole where the next flight of stairs should’ve been but managed to keep her grip on the handrails.

“Catra!”

“I’m fine,” she replied, pulling herself up. “But Hordak must have blown up the stairs.”

“We aren’t too high up any more,” Adora said. “We can make the jump.”

“And what if that’s a trap?” Seacat told her. That would be like the Horde scum!

“Let’s check!” Adora raised her sword and pointed it at the platform below them. A beam shot out of it and hit the concrete.

And the whole flight blew up. Seacat dived to the floor, then was almost crushed as Adora threw herself on top of her. Smoke filled the staircase when they got up.

“How did he have time to place a trap?” Adora asked.

“Probably already in place,” Seacat replied. She looked at the platform, but smoke blocked her view. “We’ll have to jump blindly,” she said. “Or…” She eyed the walls of the staircase, covered with dents and cracks from the bomb. “Yes.” She moved over the broken remains of the stairs to the wall, then drove her claws into it. “I’ll climb down and you follow me once I clear the way.”

“Wait!”

Seacat wasn’t waiting. And she wasn’t going to let Adora sacrifice herself.

She held her breath as long as she managed as she made her way through the smoke, driving her claws into the wall to keep from falling down.

Twice her foot, trying to touch the floor, only hit air before she finally reached the remains of the platform. Yes!

“I’m down!” she yelled as she went prone. “But half the platform is gone. You’ll have to jump all the way to the back!”

“Coming!”

A moment later, a white blur parted the smoke, and Seact dived to the side as Adora shot across the concrete and smashed into the door at the back.

“Ow!”

“Oh for…” Seacat rushed to her lover’s side.

“You told me to jump all the way! And I’m fine!”

Seacat suppressed the curses she wanted to spit and nodded. Curtly. “Let’s open the door.”

A slash from Adora's magic blade later, the door fell open, cut in two.

And the two stared at the main floor of the airship yard. And at the burning ship. Smoke billowed up from the hull as a few dozen Horde soldiers were trying to fight the flames with what looked like water pumps.

"Where's Glimmer? And the others?" Adora yelled over the roar of the flames and the yelling from the soldiers.

"Must be at the other end," Seacat yelled back. The end hidden in more smoke and fire. And where was Hordak? And Shadow Weaver?

As if someone had read her mind, a whole section of the wall to their left blew apart. Through the thin smoke there, Seacat could see lightning arc through the air. "Shadow Weaver!" she spat. And she would be fighting Hordak, based on that blast.

But their friends… She glanced at Adora.

Her lover looked grim. "That's Hordak."

Seacat nodded. The main objective of the entire mission.

"We have to kill him," Adora went on.

"And the traitor." Seacat nodded again.

Even though she felt like a traitor herself for abandoning her friends.

But they had to end this war. And that meant dealing with Hordak. And Shadow Weaver.

Before everything went up in flames.

Seacat moved forward to the gap in the wall. The smoke wasn't as thick there as it had seemed, and she could make out two

figures inside, but they were moving rapidly. She heard more lightning crackle in the middle of it.

Another blast hit the wall next to her, and she ducked as cracks appeared in it.

"Watch out!" Adora snapped, hefting her sword. "I'm going in."

Before Seacat could protest, Adora had jumped through the breach and into the smoke.

Cursing under her breath, Seacat followed her lover.

She bent over as she entered the smoke cloud herself - the air should be better at the bottom. The room, as far as she could tell, was much larger than she had expected. Not as large as the actual slip, but it was close to a warehouse's size. And filled with a lot of machinery and what looked like crystals and… water tanks? Some liquid, at least. Not quite a labyrinth, but they looked sturdy enough to block quite a few shots from Hordak.

Before she realised it, she had left the smoke cloud and found herself next to Adora, staring at a floating black rock or crystal bigger than herself. Dozens of cables and lines connected it to huge fuel crystals and other devices nearby. And it was surrounded by lightning - countless sparks lit up around it.

"That… that's the Black Garnet!" Adora stated the obvious.

"It's certainly not the white diamond," Seacat replied. "But where are…?"

One of the crystals blew apart in a shower of sparks and shards, and Seacat ducked behind the closest device to avoid getting clipped by splinters. Another blast followed as she peered around its corner, revealing Hordak's position. The Horde leader was running past two broken furnaces or something, firing his arm cannon at…

...a floating, lightning-hurling Shadow Weaver.

As Seacat watched, Hordak fired at the witch, but the blast was stopped by a huge spark.

"I've reconnected to the garnet. Your toys cannot hurt me any more!" the witch gloated, striking back with two lightning bolts.

But as before, they washed over Hordak without doing much. "All that power, and you are throwing useless lightning? That is why you will fail!"

"You cannot stop me!"

But they could. Probably. Though Hordak was first. Probably.

Adora wasn't showing any doubts or hesitation - she was charging at the Horde leader, sword held high.

The scumbag noticed her before she reached him, though, and a blast from his cannon flew towards her. She swatted it away with her sword and pressed the attack. "You won't hurt anyone any more!" she yelled, swinging her blade.

Hordak dived to the side, but the sword cut into his shoulder, causing him to cry out as he tumbled to the ground. Adora whirled to strike at him again, but lightning hit Hordak - or, rather, his armour - and Adora had to retreat.

"Stop hitting him with lightning!" Seacat yelled. Couldn't Shadow Weaver see that it wasn't doing anything?

Then the floating, sparkling witch turned into her direction, and Seacat felt a cold shudder run down her spine.

There were sparks crackling behind Shadow Weaver's mask. What had the witch done? Reconnected to the garnet? Was she tapping into Etheria's magic or something?

"You!" Shadow Weaver spat out the word, showing more emotions than she'd ever displayed before, as far as Catra remembered.

“Yes, me! Don’t get into Adora’s way!” Seacat spat as she moved to flank the Horde leader - who was quickly retreating behind the closest piece of machinery.

Adora charged straight at him, though, cutting the machine apart with one blow. But as the pieces fell to the side, Hordak fired through the gap. Seacat gasped when Adora barely managed to deflect the blast into one of the fuel crystals.

And more lightning arced towards Hordak, only to slide off his armour and hit the broken machine next to him.

“Are you deaf? Leave him to us if you can’t cast anything but lightning!” Seacat yelled, then had to dive behind a console or something as Hordak took a shot at her.

“You’ve failed!”

Seacat peered around the corner - and stared straight at Hordak’s cannon. She threw herself back, but a moment later, the entire corner was blown up, and several pieces hit her. She rolled with the blast, over her shoulder, and… cried at the pain that caused. Panting, she tore the splinter from her upper arm and clenched her teeth.

Adora charged at the Horde leader again, but he disappeared in the smoke cloud between two crystals before she reached him.

“Incompetence! I was a fool to trust you!” the witch ranted.

More lightning filled the smoke cloud, and Seacat, holding one hand against her bleeding arm, fell back from it.

“Shadow Weaver!” Adora yelled. “Stop throwing lightning around. It doesn’t hurt Hordak! But it hinders us!”

The witch laughed in return. More and more sparks were surrounding her, Seacat noticed. It looked as if she was wrapped in lightning. What had happened? Something was very, very wrong.

A fuel crystal suddenly detonated nearby, and Seacat threw herself to the ground as more splinters filled the air.

She was lucky this time and quickly got up again. “Adora!”

But her lover had already entered the smoke, looking for Hordak. And Shadow Weaver…

The witch was floating above them all, lightning gathering in her outstretched hand. Seacat glanced at the Black Garnet. It was crackling with lightning as well. Shadow Weaver definitely was connected to it.

But she wasn’t handling it very well. As Seacat watched, the witch threw the ball of lightning at a corner of the room, blasting the smoke there. Two machines were revealed a moment before they exploded, but neither Hordak nor Adora was there.

A blast slid off the bubble of lightning that surrounded Shadow Weaver, exploding against the wall. Another followed as the witch turned. “You cannot hurt me!”

But neither could she hurt the Horde leader. Not when his armour protected him against lightning. So, why were those two still fighting each other? Seacat bandaged her arm before she lost more blood and ducked behind a broken crystal.

It made no sense. Shadow Weaver was obviously affected by the garnet and not thinking clearly any more. But Hordak… why wasn’t he running? He had run from his office, hadn’t he? This was… He must have a plan. A plan for which he needed something in this room, or he would’ve left already.

That meant the garnet. And something else. Something that the Horde leader thought offered him better chances than simply running and rallying his troops.

She slowly rose and peered around. The smoke made it harder to see much, but she was close to the centre of the room, where the garnet rested in its cradle made of lines and…

Seacat followed the lines. Most led to fuel crystals arranged around the runestone. Most. But one led to a particular… thingie… in the back. Where Shadow Weaver was floating. Six red crystals, arranged in a circle, set in a metal plate and topped with a metal grid.

If only Entrapta were here!

More blasts tore through the room, one blowing up a machine and another shattering wreckage. But the machines near the red circle were all undamaged. Hordak was shooting at Shadow Weaver in the air but didn't fire at the ground there?

Whatever the thing was, it must be the key to his plans! Now how to wreck it and his plans?

She caught a glimpse of Adora jumping in the smoke, swinging her sword, and gasped. She wanted to help her lover. Adora couldn't keep this up forever. Not with Shadow Weaver throwing lighting around like that and Hordak blasting away.

So, Hordak or his machine?

Seacat clenched her teeth. Hordak needed to die. But Adora was on that. She had to trust her. And this whole Black Garnet thing made her fur rise - and not from the electricity.

She glanced around, ducking her head when another blast tore through the smoke and hit the closest machine - but came not even close to the garnet, or the other corner. That did it.

She got up, ignored the pain in her arm and dashed towards the biggest machine between her and the garnet. That would block a blast or three.

No blast hit her - though she heard two strike the walls or ceiling - until she reached the machine. And then it was only a short dash to the Black Garnet itself. Relatively short. She bit her lower lip, took a deep breath, and ran as fast as she could across the open space.

She reached the huge runestone, sliding to a stop at its base, and smiled - she'd made it. Now she just had to check that thick powerline…

"Get away from there!"

And dodge Shadow Weaver. Damn.

Before Seacat could say anything, the witch went on. "Go kill Hordak! Don't hide here, you coward!"

She hissed under her breath. Coward? She had to bite her tongue to keep from lashing out at the witch. Who, she noticed, was now covered with sparks racing up and down her body. And her eyes… all Seacat could see behind the mask was a shining, glaring light.

"Get away!" the witch shrieked. "I know what you're planning!"

Then she raised her arm towards Seacat.

Seacat jumped up and threw herself behind the closest machine a moment before lightning struck the base of the garnet.

"IT'S MINE!"

Another lighting ball flew at her, but Seacat was already running. The ball slammed into the machine next to her. She kept running. More lighting rained down on her, shattering fuel crystals and devices. She turned, circling the garnet. If the witch was so bent on killing her… She slid under the large powerline, jumped up and…

...screamed with pain when every part of her body felt as if it was on fire, and she couldn't move at all.

When she could move again, she was on the ground, bleeding. And still screaming. Everything hurt.

She tried to get up, but her legs didn't work - she fell down again. Spitting blood - she'd bitten her lips and tongue - she dug her

claws into the pedestal of the Black Garnet and pulled herself up on shaking legs. Shadow Weaver. The witch had tried to kill her again.

Seacat managed to turn her head and saw the witch floating towards her, hands extended, holding glowing balls of lightning. And Seacat was too weak to run. Adora…

No. Adora was fighting Hordak. Seacat drew a shuddering breath, which hurt even more, and looked around. No cover nearby. Only a few power lines stuck to the garnet. Which wouldn't stop the lightning.

She blinked. Oh. Then she hissed and unsheathed her claws, turning to the largest powerline. She slid her claws beneath and through the ropes tying the line to the stone. They snapped at once, and the line started to slide off. As did other, smaller ones.

Seacat ignored them and grabbed the big line, then swung it around as hard as she could manage, towards the floating witch. Shadow Weaver launched the lightning at her, but hit the line first - and the lightning raced along the line. Away from Seacat. Into the crystal circle.

A moment later, it blew up. Seacat dropped to the floor as splinters cut through the air. She heard someone - Shadow Weaver - cry out and grinned despite the pain. Then she started to get up. She still had to…

"You! This is ALL YOUR FAULT!"

Seacat raised her head. The witch was floating above her. Screeching Covered in sparks, shining so brightly, Seacat had to squint to be able to see anything.

So this was it. Nowhere to run. No way to hide. No powerline left.

She hissed at the witch as Shadow Weaver raised her arms, sparks forming an arc between her hands.

“DIE!”

Seacat closed her eyes and clenched her teeth. She would…

Screaming. Seacat opened her eyes. Shadow Weaver was screaming. Flailing. Sparks flew from her to the closest crystals and machinery. But she was glowing. Brighter and brighter. And the arc between her hands… was now between her hands and the top of the Black Garnet. And shining bright enough to hurt. So much power…

Oh. Seacat started to run. To limp away. Towards the big machine. She didn’t know what exactly was happening, but it wouldn’t be good. Shadow Weaver had tied herself to the runestone, and without the lines, the crystals and machines weren’t absorbing power any more.

And Shadow Weaver couldn’t handle it. If she had ever been able to.

Seacat stumbled behind the machine as Shadow Weaver’s screams grew hoarse and the blinding light grew even stronger.

Then everything went white. Seacat bent down, covered her head with her arms, and squeezed her eyes shut.

A crack, louder than a bomb, followed. Her ears were ringing. Hurting. She rolled on her back and squinted. The crystals nearby had shattered. The machine she was next to was smoking. As were others she could see. And Shadow Weaver…

She didn’t see the witch. Not in the air. Not on the ground. No.

There was something. Something that looked…

Seacat coughed, blood drops splattering the ground, and forced herself to get on her knees, then started to crawl towards the… towards the…

It was the witch's mask. Cracked, but clearly hers. And blackened on the inside. Covered with burned… Seacat felt like retching. The stench of burned flesh filled her nose. She shook her head, then looked around. There was something burning on the ground, near the runestone. Blackening robes covering…

Ah.

Her lips twisted into a smile. "Failed to kill me again, huh?" She coughed and spat out a bit more blood - her tongue hurt - before looking around. The smoke was worse, now. And where was Adora? She couldn't hear any blasts any more, but her ears were ringing anyway.

"A...Adora?" she croaked more than she yelled.

"Adora!"

Her throat hurt, and she coughed again.

"ADORA!"

Steps. Something. Someone. Someone was walking towards her, out of the thick smoke cloud hiding half the room.

Seacat started to smile. Then she recognised the figure.

Hordak.

He was hurt and bleeding - his left arm was hanging at his side, swinging back and forth with each step. He was hunched over, blood running down his battered armour from several cuts. But he still had his cannon mounted on his bracer. And he was walking. Towards Seacat.

She couldn't run. Her legs were still not working properly. But she wouldn't die like this. She started to force herself up. Both hands on the ground, she pulled her shaking knees underneath her. Panting, she tried to lift one leg, put one foot on the floor, but failed. No. She hissed - not on her knees. Not like this.

And there was Hordak. Five yards away. Staring at her.

No, she realised. Staring at the runestone. At the Black Garnet.

He wheezed, and she saw his bloodied head slowly turn. Towards the remains of the red crystals. “No…” he whispered, so low, she almost missed it with her ringing ears and the sounds of fire and breaking machinery. And screams in the distance.

“No,” he said again. Then he sobbed, shaking his head. “No.”

Seacat stared at him. What was wrong with him?

“No.” Hordak kept shaking his head, his whole body shuddering.

Then he slowly sank to his knees, both arms hanging at his sides, the muzzle of the cannon striking the floor with a metallic sound.

And he started to laugh.

He craned his neck, lifting his face towards the ceiling.

Laughing like a madman.

Seacat blinked. He was bleeding - he was kneeling in a growing pool of his blood. And he was laughing.

He must have gone mad, she realised.

And he kept laughing, his chest shaking, until a cough interrupted him.

“All for nothing,” he mumbled. “All for nothing.”

A few chuckles followed.

Then a sob. And another.

“Brother…” he whispered, tears and blood running down his face as he cried.

Until he took a shuddering, wheezing breath and stopped.

Seacat waited a few seconds. If this was… But he wasn't moving. Not at all. She couldn't see his chest moving, not with the broken chestplate covering him, but she couldn't hear him breathing either.

Slowly, she leaned forward, crawling towards the Horde leader on hand and knees. He didn't move. She reached him, crawling through his blood until she could touch him. Check his throat for a pulse.

And saw his back, which had been torn open from shoulder to hip, covered in blood.

He was dead. Only his armour was holding him up.

Adora had killed him.

But Seacat's smile vanished. Adora! She was… No!

She crawled towards the smoke cloud, following the blood trail Hordak had left. Halfway to the cloud, she had to sop, coughing and gasping for air - the smoke was getting worse, even when crawling.

Not that she could run, anyway. Or walk.

But she had to get to Adora. Save her friend. No matter what.

She pushed on, putting one hand before the other, breathing hot air and smoke. There was the smoke cloud - moving towards her. She couldn't see anything in it. Couldn't hear much, not with her ringing ears and the fire roaring in the main hall.

But she could see the blood on the ground and followed it. Adora would have landed the lethal blow. She had to… she couldn't…

Seacat sobbed, felt tears run down her cheeks. She didn't care. Didn't stop to wipe her eyes. She kept crawling forward, towards

Adora.

After what seemed like an eternity, she reached the remains of a crystal. Broken. Covered in blood. But where was…

She looked around. “Adora!”

Her voice cracked, wheezed. All the smoke… “Adora!”

She took a deep breath, felt her lungs hurt. Coughed. “ADORAAAAA!”

Shuddering, she fell forward, catching herself with her hands on the floor.

“Adora…”

“...”

She blinked. “Adora?” She had heard something! She turned her head, ears twitching.

“...”

To her left. She crawled, uncaring about the crystal shards that cut into her palms and knees. After several yards, she saw a figure in the smoke. Adora!

She forced herself on, as fast as she could. “Adora!”

A weak groan was her answer.

Then she saw her friend. Her lover. Her Adora. On the ground. In front of a crumpled machine. But she was breathing. Moving, or trying to.

“Ca-catra?” She was lifting her head.

“Adora!”

She reached her, bloodied hands grabbing Adora's shoulders, checking her back for wounds.

"Catra."

"Adora. Are you hurt?" A cough wracked her just after her stupid question.

"I'm…"

"Don't talk!" Seacat tried to turn her on her back, to check her front for wounds.

"Hordak…"

"He's dead. You killed him." She heaved, wincing at the pain this caused, but Adora turned on her back.

"Oof."

She had been hit in the chest - there was a huge scorched stain. The magic armour must have protected her, but if she had internal wounds… "Where's your sword?" She could heal herself with it, couldn't she? Seacat couldn't remember.

"Thataway."

Adora's right arm rose then flopped to her side, pointing towards the right.

"I'll be right back," Seacat whispered, then crawled off.

"Catra…"

She bit her lips until they bled. Adora needed her sword. But where was it? Where was the stupid sword?

There! Stuck in a crystal! She reached it, but it was stuck. Seacat snarled and put her bleeding, hurting feet against the crystal, then pulled, yelling with pain and need.

The sword slid out, the crystal crumbled, and Seacat fell to the ground. She ignored the pain, rolled on her stomach and grabbed the sword. And started to crawl back to Adora. Who needed her magic sword.

It took her longer than she thought. “Adora?”

“Ca-Catra?”

“Your sword!” She pulled it forward, then pushed the hilt into Adora’s hand. “Your sword.”

“Good…”

“Now heal yourself!”

Adora laughed, ending in a cough. But she raised her sword - and, still lying on the ground, pointed it at Seacat.

“NO!”

But it was too late - the magic energy hit her. And Adora collapsed.

“ADORA!” She rushed forward. The stupid idiot was smiling. She shook her, but Adora didn’t react.

She put her head on her chest, then sighed when she heard her breathing. Still alive.

“You idiot!” she spat, shaking her head and sending tears flying. “You should’ve healed yourself!”

Wiping her eyes, she forced herself to stop shaking. She had to get Adora out of the building. Yard. Whatever.

Groaning, she knelt, then grabbed Adora’s arm and shoulder, draping it over her own shoulders. She picked up her sword with her free hand, then strained and stood. On shaking legs, but she

stood. Adora was heavy as She-Ra. But Seacat would die before dropping her.

They had to get out. Through the smoke. In… that direction.

She started walking, putting one foot before the other, trying to breathe shallowly as she stumbled through the smoke.

And tried not to remember how Hordak had stumbled.

But she managed to leave the smoke cloud and reorient herself. There, behind this smoke, was the entrance. Exit. Whatever.

She walked on, dragging Adora along. "Stupid fool," she muttered. "Should've healed yourself."

"Never," she heard a whisper next to her ear.

"Adora!"

A faint chuckle followed, but no answer.

"Adora!" She turned her head, but her lover's eyes were closed, and she was hanging limp on her.

But she was still breathing - Seacat could feel her.

And there was the entrance - the breach in the wall. Seacat managed to climb the broken bits of the wall cluttering the area before the breach proper and then slid down the other side, with Adora in her lap.

But the yard… The airship was burning from bow to stern. And so were most of the cranes and other machines. And the pits below, where the workers had been installing the lower rows of guns, were filled with flames. No wonder smoke was everywhere.

She couldn't see any Horde soldiers fighting the fires any more. And the exit was on the other side of the hall. With flames in the way…

No matter. Adora needed her. Needed her to save her. Even if she had to walk through fire.

She clenched her teeth and walked on. Would there be just the one exit? That would be safer to keep spies out, but… would Hordak have built this without at least another exit? For emergencies?

She stopped. He wouldn't. He had been far too paranoid for that. There had to be another exit. And near his office. But she hadn't seen any sign of it.

Walk through the fire in the hope that she could survive to reach the stairs with Adora or abandon that and bet on finding the second exit before the smoke and heat killed them?

She took a look at the burning airship. She couldn't see through the flames, nor through the smoke, and the stairs on the other side would be full of smoke.

Seacat turned and started walking towards the stairs leading to Hordak's office. The second exit would be there, somewhere. She just had to find it.

She turned around a broken counterweight from a burning crane, ignored the limbs sticking out from underneath the stones, and dragged Adora on, towards the door she could see there. Just a little more…

"Come on! We're almost out… well, almost… don't give up! Come on! Don't die on me!"

Seacat froze. She knew that voice. That was…

Before she could react, a huge figure walked out of the smoke to her right. "See? There's the bow, and…"

The Horde princess froze as soon as she noticed Seacat. She was carrying two Horde soldiers under her arms, Seacat saw. A third

was dangling from her stinger. All of them were unconscious. And her uniform was scorched.

They stared at each other for several seconds without doing anything. Seacat could take the princess. Probably. If the magic sword could cut through the bug armour, definitely. But she couldn't take her and protect Adora at the same time. And she probably couldn't take her quickly enough to escape.

Seacat scoffed and motioned to the door with her head. "Looking for the second exit?"

The princess blinked. "Second exit?"

Seacat suppressed a groan. Horde soldiers! "Hordak wouldn't have had an office here if he didn't have a second way to come and go."

"Oh, right!" The princess smiled for a moment. "That would explain how he kept surprising us with his inspections!" Then she frowned at her.

Seacat's opinion of the princess's brain took another dive. "Let's get out of here before we suffocate or burn."

"You set fire to the yard!" She took a step towards Seacat, raising her pincers, then had to quickly grab her unconscious charges again before they fell to the ground.

She was technically correct. But Seacat didn't think admitting that would be smart. "The fire broke out when the plants overheated."

"You were spying on us! Attacking us!"

"Shadow Weaver betrayed Hordak," Seacat retorted. "They fought each other over the runestone. Both are dead - the witch was killed by the stone."

The princess gaped at her. "Hordak is dead? Shadow Weaver is dead as well?"

“And we’ll die here if we don’t get out at once,” Seacat told her. “So, you want to save your friends?”

The princess blinked. For a moment, Seacat wasn’t sure if the Horde scum would see reason. But then the huge woman slumped. “With both dead…” She shook her head.

“Come!” Seacat snapped. “We need to find the exit!” She turned and walked towards the door.

“I thought you knew where it was!”

Seacat glanced over her shoulder. “I know where it should be. That’ll be enough to find it.”

“And where is it?”

“Near Hordak’s office.”

“That makes sense.”

Of course it did!

Seacat kicked the door’s remains away and entered the smaller room behind it.

The princess followed her. “So, where… Oh, no!”

She was staring at the remains of the stairs ahead of them.

Seacat clenched her teeth. This would complicate things a little.

*****

The Horde Leader Part 3

They had to find the second exit. Or second entrance. Whatever. Hordak would have placed it close to his office so he could flee in an emergency. And for convenience. But would it have been in his office? The Horde leader had trapped the stairs after fleeing his office, blowing the entire lower floor away. Would he have done that if his secret exit was in the office? Would he have cut off his own escape route?

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Seacat didn't think so. On the other hand, he had been focused on whatever had been going on with the runestone.

"Is the second exit upstairs?" the Horde princess asked.

"Was this area usually under guard?" Seacat asked instead of answering.

"Uh… there were always two guards outside the room. In the hall."

"That means Hordak could've slipped in here and reached his office without being noticed by guards," Seacat thought out loud. She looked around.

A loud crash made her jerk. She turned her head, but the princess was closer to the remains of the door. "The bow of the airship collapsed. The fire's spreading."

Well, Seacat had known they didn't have much time. But where would the exit be? Hordak had charges prepared here. Would he have done that if he had an emergency exit here? It would've led to him being stuck in the office.

She couldn't tell. "Knock on the walls, see if anything rings hollow."

“You don’t know?”

Seacat hissed: “Just do it! If it’s not here, we’ll have to climb up to the office.”

The princess looked at the two Horde soldiers she carried, then put them down and started knocking on the walls. Seacat turned her head to listen, but she didn’t catch any different sound.

And the fire was now almost to the room. Damn. That left the staircase or the office. The staircase…

She went to the stairs and looked at the hole left by the explosion. It didn’t look like there was anything below - no hidden tunnel. That left…

“We’ll have to climb.”

“With the wounded?” The princess sounded shocked.

“I’ll get up. You hand me the wounded,” Seacat said. She hesitated a moment, then lowered Adora on the ground. This was their only chance to escape. If the princess tried to stab them in the back, they’d all die anyway.

She pressed a kiss on Adora’s forehead, grabbed her sword, then jumped. Her claws sank into the back of the staircase, and she quickly scaled the wall to the undamaged portion of the staircase.

“Alright. Throw me the wounded.”

“My guys first!”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Yes.”

“Catch!”

She caught the first wounded and put him down on the floor. “Next!”

The two others followed. She resisted the urge to stack them.

Then the princess lifted Adora. And groaned. “She’s heavier than I expected!”

“Not too heavy for you,” Seacat spat. “Throw her.”

The princess threw Adora. Seacat caught her with both arms, then stumbled back a few steps to compensate without dropping her. “Oof!”

A moment later, two pincers latched on the edge of the stairs - and the concrete started crumbling under the pressure.

Seacat froze for a moment. If she let the Horde princess drop… But she was already moving, cursing herself.

Despite the princess’s frantic efforts, her pincers couldn’t get a grip - they crushed the concrete to powder instead, and she started to fall.

Seacat jumped, reaching for the pincers, but missed.

Then she saw the tail whip by. And her hand shot out, the other going for the remains of the handrail.

She screamed as the full mass of the princess threatened to pull her arm out of its socket, and the railing groaned under their combined weight, but she managed to hold on to the Horde scum.

“Ah… Oh. Thanks.”

“Don’t talk!” Seacat spat. “Climb!”

“I’m trying! I’m a hugger, not a climber!”

“I don’t care. Get your fat ass up here!” Seacat clenched her teeth and tried to find purchase with her feet to pull the idiot up. She scrambled, her claws piercing but wrecking the concrete until she finally got a grip on it and could use her leg muscles to help pulling.

Groaning, she heaved and pushed and pulled until the princess could grab onto the handrail.

Then it was over in a second - the dolt was far too strong and easily pulled herself and Seacat up on the stairs with a smooth movement. “Thanks, Cat! I thought I was a goner.”

Seacat wheezed in response. Before she could give the princess a piece of her mind, she heard another crash from below, and a moment later, flames shot into the room they had just left.

Damn. “Grab your soldiers and follow me!” she yelled, already lifting up Adora.

If the secret exit wasn’t in Hordak’s office, all of them would die.

But the staircase was filling with smoke - they didn’t have much time. Unless… No. Even trying to seal off the stairs wouldn’t work. Not with the office’s windows smashed and broken.

She hurried up the stairs, banging on the walls as she passed them. Solid. Solid. Solid. Solid.

On the top of the stairs, she whirled and knocked on the walls there. If there was an exit… No, Nothing here either.

“So, where’s the exit?” The Horde princess sounded anxious.

“Has to be in the office. Hordak would’ve liked appearing in there without anyone noticing.” Seacat entered the office and looked around - as much as she could, with smoke filling half of it.

Half?

“I have to say, I don’t see any entrance or exit here - and wow! Who wrecked this?”

“Quiet!” Seacat hissed.

“What?”

Seacat growled and looked around. The smoke should’ve filled the entire office by now. So, it had to escape somehow. But where?

She walked around, checking the ceiling. There! There was a gap through which the smoke went out. Air ducts, at the least. Hidden ones. And how better to hide an exit than to build it together with air ducts? “Here!” she yelled before coughing. “Smash the ceiling here!”

“The ceiling?”

“Just do it!” Another cough made her double over.

“Are you alright?”

She glared at the moron. Why wasn’t the princess affected by the smoke? Some bug thing? “Smash. The. Ceiling. Here!”

“Alright, alright!”

The princess put the soldiers down and smashed her pincers into the ceiling. Concrete dust fell down, and pieces of the ceiling flew every which way.

And the gap turned into a hole that attracted even more smoke.

Without being told to, the princess widened the hole, then stepped back when a steel platform fell down, missing her by inches. “Ow.”

That must have been the mechanism Hordak used to come and go.

“We could’ve used that.”

“It probably broke in the battle.” Seacat jumped, dug her claws into the concrete and pulled herself up. Yes, there was a tunnel.

Which was filling with smoke now that it was open. “Hand me the others. Hurry!” She coughed again. Damn.

And the princess took her sweet time handing her the wounded - Adora was last. Seacat muttered a curse under her breath and turned before the princess climbed up after her. “Hurry!”

And she was off, running down the tunnel. After twenty yards, she reached a door. Locked. She slashed her claws against the lock. Open. “Come on!” She waved the princess through, then pulled the door closed. That should stop the smoke. A little.

The stairs led up. And up. The yard hadn’t been that deep below the surface - they had to be in a building. At least the air was better. But hauling Adora that high up… Seacat’s legs were tiring. Her body was tiring.

She gritted her teeth and forced herself to keep running. The air was getting worse with each step. Even the princess was now coughing.

There! The top of the stairs! And another door. Seacat didn’t bother with testing the lock - she slashed the door to pieces and kicked the remains away. “Finally!”

They were in another corridor. Empty. But if Hordak arrived through this, there would be… ah. More stairs. Leading up to the roof and down to the ground. Seacat went down. The air would be better there. The princess followed her.

“Where are we?”

Seacat rolled her eyes instead of answering. This was Horde territory.

“Oh, I know! This is the spare warehouse! In case the yard couldn’t store all supplies!”

Seacat clenched her teeth. Who cared any more? Another flight of stairs - she stumbled and almost lost Adora but managed to keep

her balance.

“Careful!”

What was with the Horde princess? They were enemies, damn it! Not that Seacat would complain about not having to fight the bug princess. Once had been enough.

She huffed and took a few deep breaths after reaching the ground floor. “We’ve made it.”

“I guess so. Now, where was the infirmary?”

“Barracks,” she told the princess.

“Thank you! So I…” She trailed off. “Ah.”

Seacat glared at her. “The Horde’s finished. Hordak is dead. Shadow Weaver is dead. Your airship is destroyed. You don’t have enough enhanced engine bombs left and can’t make new ones.”

The princess stared at her. “But…”

“How long do you think you’ll last if you keep this up? And who’s going to lead the Horde now?”

“Uh… the most senior Force Captain, I think. That would be… no, he’s dead. Or… no, she’s been demoted. And… no, deserted. That leaves…” She blinked again. “Me? In this area?”

“Are you asking me?”

“No, no. I guess it is me.” The princess looked, well, almost shocked.

“And you want to fight on? Lose more people?” Seacat scoffed.

“No, but…”

“What ‘but’?”

“I only have your word that Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead!”

Great.

“Well, then best start looking for them. After you got your friends to the infirmary, I think.”

“Uh…”

Seacat turned and opened the door to the road outside. She had to head to their warehouse - that was the first rally spot. The most obvious. On the other hand, the last location she had seen the others was the airship yard. Which also was the last location the others had seen Adora and herself.

And she was sure they wouldn’t leave without them. But Adora was helpless. And she could see a lot of Horde soldiers gathered around the spot. And her friends would’ve sent someone back to the warehouse. That was just common sense.

Clenching her teeth, she started walking towards their former base.

“The infirmary is the other way.”

She rolled her eyes at the comment and turned to stare at the Horde princess. “That’s the Horde infirmary.”

“There’s another one? I mean, yes. And you aren’t Horde… Right.”

Seacat nodded sharply and started walking again.

“Uh…”

“What?”

“How many of you are here?”

She gritted her teeth. “Why should I tell you?”

“Good question. I was just curious.”

Yeah, right. “Goodbye.”

Seacat kept walking this time. The air was bad, though not as bad as inside the yard. And it wasn’t as if the Fright Zone had good, clean air, anyway. She ran into a troop of Horde soldiers but they didn’t pay her any mind - just another Horde soldier dragging a wounded away.

She still held her breath until the scum had turned the corner. It wasn’t too far to the warehouse - but it wasn’t a short trip, either. And she was already tired. Maybe she should take a break...

No! Adora needed help - she was breathing evenly, but she was still hurting. Seacat could bear this. For as long as she needed to!

She kept going, ignoring the roaring fire behind her or the screams that occasionally reached her. All that counted was Adora. And reaching the warehouse.

Which she did. She kicked the door open and entered. “Hello?”

“Seacat?”

That was Entrapta! “Yes?”

The princess appeared on the catwalk above her, then lowered herself down with her hair. “And Adora! We were so worried!”

Seacat found herself picked up in a hair-hug. “Uh…” And squeezed. “Ack.”

“Oh, sorry! But I was worried as well. The others told me you had vanished in a fire. I was here, working on modifying my speaker bots into search bots.” She blinked as she set Seacat down. “Should I reverse that? We still need to counter orders Shadow Weaver could give, right? If she betrays us, I mean.”

“Shadow Weaver and Hordak are dead,” Seacat told her.

“Oh.”

Seacat gently laid Adora down and checked her wounds. Still the same. But she was breathing and not bleeding out. Or otherwise… “Where are the others? At the yard?”

“Looking for you. But the fire was too dangerous, so they couldn’t enter the yard. Oh, and Glimmer was hurt! She’s here!”

“Hurt?” Seacat clenched her teeth. Hurt was better than dead, but… what kind of wound would keep Glimmer from coming for Adora? Seacat was quite sure that the princess would teleport into fire for her friends.

“She caught a blow to the head,” Entrapta explained. “Nothing broken, but she’s sleeping.”

Or unconscious. “Alright. Take care of Adora. I’ll fetch the others,” Seacat said.

“I could use the speaker bots!” Entrapta said. “Instead of broadcasting Shadow Weaver’s talk with us about killing Hordak, I could just tell the others that they can return!”

And alert everyone to their presence? But the Horde princess was already aware of them. And finding anyone, especially their friends in disguise, in this chaos… Seacat smiled. “Yes. But we’ll be sneaky.”

“Sneaky?” Entrapta stared at her.

“Sneaky.” Seacat nodded. “We’ll have to make the bots say something only our friends will understand.”

“Oh!” The princess smiled then frowned. “And what would that be? We didn’t agree on a code phrase or encryption.”

Seacat wasn’t quite sure what encryption meant, but she understood the gist of it. “I know,” she said. “But we can be creative. Where can we record a message?”

“Oh! Bert! Come here!”

One of Entrapta’s new bots waddled over. It looked like a barrel on legs, about as tall as Entrapta.

“Just talk into the opening here,” Entrapta explained. “I can handle the rest.”

Seacat nodded. “Alright.” She took a deep breath. “Team Archer and Team Marine, relocate to the assigned warehouse to handle the bots and the wounded. We have new orders to deploy.”

“And they’ll understand that?” Entrapta frowned. “Oh. Team Archer is Bow. And Marine is Mermista!”

“Yes.” Seacat nodded.

As the bot waddled outside, on its way to the closest roof, Seacat hoped that their friends were listening.

Then all she could do was wait. And stare at two unconscious friends.

“They’re alright, I think. Just need to rest. At least my prototype scanner doesn’t show anything serious, though it’s a prototype, and I haven’t gotten nearly enough data to properly calibrate it.”

And listen to Entrapta explain her technology.

“Though I’ve got the basics down - I think so, at least. When you get down to the basics, people are just like animals or machines; just different sorts of mechanics.”

Seacat frowned. “But both have magic.” Hell, Adora was magic when she was She-Ra. Or should be.

“Right. That might complicate matters.” Entrapta nodded. Then her eyes widened. “Which means they could actually be hurt!”

Damn. “They look OK,” Seacat quickly said. “Adora healed me, but that exhausted her.” Not that the various wounds and bruises would have helped with that…

“But Glimmer took a blow to the head before she could exhaust herself!” Entrapta’s hair started poking and prodding the unconscious princess. “Glimmer?”

The princess groaned and turned her head away.

“She did that before,” Entrapta said.

Seacat couldn’t tell if that was a good or bad sign. But it made her worry all the same. She didn’t know anything about magic powers and injuries. Though Mermista and Brian Boy should know about that, having grown up with magic and Glimmer, respectively.

They wouldn’t have left Glimmer with Entrapta if she was in real danger, would they?

Seacat clenched her teeth. Of course they would have done that if they thought they had to save Adora and Seacat.

She stood. “I’m going to take a look. See if I can find them.”

“Oh.” Entrapta looked at her. “You think they need help. Help we can’t give them.”

Yes. Seacat would have said so, if Entrapta didn’t look like she blamed herself for this. “I just want to get out of the Fright Zone as soon as we can. I ran into the Horde princess on the way out of the yard.”

“Oh? Did you kill her?”

“We didn’t fight. But we’re surrounded by Horde troops. Sooner or later, she’ll tell someone, and they’ll start looking for us.”

“Oh. Do we need better disguises?”

Seacat shrugged. “Our disguises should be fine. But I’d prefer to leave while everyone is still distracted by the burning yard.”

Entrapta nodded. “That’s a good idea. Do we take the bombs with us?”

Seacat froze on the way to the door. “The bombs?”

“The bombs Bow and I took from Hordak’s workshop,” Entrapta explained. “We put them on the cart there.”

Seacat hadn’t paid much attention to the cart covered with a tarp. Obviously, that had been a mistake. “How many bombs did you take?”

“Just two - we couldn’t handle more with one cart.” Entrapta beamed at her. “But we took the two most advanced!”

Most advanced? “How powerful are those bombs?”

“We took them because one of them should’ve been enough to destroy the shipyard. We didn’t know you’d set it on fire.”

“And you have two of them.”

“I wanted to study the other. The advancements Hordak made are fascinating!”

Seacat felt the fur on her neck bristle. Right. Another reason to get the rest of their group and get the hell out of the Fright Zone.

Preferably without any bomb.

“Alright,” she said. “I’ll go look for the others.”

Of course, that was the moment the door was opened, and Brain Boy entered, followed by the Captain and Mermista.

“Seacat! What happened?” The captain blurted out as he rushed towards her.

“Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead. But Adora got hurt and exhausted herself healing me,” Seacat reported, as professionally as she could. “And the Horde princess is aware that we’re in the Fright Zone. We should leave at once. Before they rally.”

“Yes,” Mermista agreed while she looked Seacat over.

“I’m fine,” Seacat told her. “Adora healed me.” She winced at the frown that appeared on Mermista’s face. “It wasn’t too bad,” she added, but it was clear neither the Captain nor Mermista believed her.

Brain Boy was already checking Adora. Seacat bit her lower lip. She had checked her lover already. Several times. But she wasn’t a trained Healer. Neither was Brain Boy, though he should have some training with magic, as Glimmer’s childhood friend.

“Looks like exhaustion,” he said. “The rest seem to be non-life-threatening wounds and bruises.”

“And what about Glimmer?”

He looked grimmer for a moment. “Concussion. I hoped Adora would be able to heal her, but…”

“She needs to recover first,” Seacat finished for him. None of them mentioned that being unconscious from a blow to the head wasn’t a good thing.

“And Glimmer’s responsive. Sort of,” Entrapta said with a smile. “She groans if you poke her.”

“Good.” Brain Boy nodded, but anyone except for Entrapta would’ve been able to tell that he wasn’t entirely honest.

“We need to leave,” Seacat said. “Before the Horde gets their act together. And I’ve got a distraction in mind already.”

“Oh?” Brain Boy looked at her.

“But we might need to sacrifice some of your loot for it.”

She saw his eyes widen when he got what she was planning.

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“This is the Princess Alliance speaking,” Mermista’s voice rang out over the Fright Zone again as the cart carrying Seacat and her friends approached the gate leading out of the core area. “Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead. We’ve taken control of the enhanced engine bombs and will be detonating them in an hour!”

“Ugh.” Mermista herself scowled. “I sound like an idiot.”

“You sound marvellous, my love,” Sea Hawk told her. “Magnificent! Determined! Impressive!”

“I sound like an idiot because we’re giving the Horde advance warning. We could’ve just set the bombs to blow up the laboratory and most of the plants.”

“But then we wouldn’t have had this distraction.” Brain Boy pointed at the road ahead - filled with Horde soldiers fleeing the area. “The guards would’ve tried to stop us.”

“We would’ve killed more Horde soldiers, though,” Mermista retorted. “And we wouldn’t have almost got stuck behind some wagon with a broken axle.”

Well, they had cleared that obstacle quickly enough, but if there had been a serious blockade… That was the trouble with timed explosions: Once you set the timer, you better hope that you can get clear in time.

“But aren’t the Horde soldiers beaten already?” Entrapta asked.

“This is the Princess Alliance speaking. Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead. We’ve taken control of the enhanced engine bombs and will be detonating them in an hour!”

“As an army, probably. But they’ll turn to banditry and piracy,” Mermista said. “We’ll have a lot of trouble keeping them out of our lands.”

“The Fright Zone might turn into another lawless land like the Crimson Waste,” Brain Boy said. “Though it’s better than an organised army trying to conquer everything.”

They had reached the gate now. The guards there had fled already, or so it seemed. Or they had gone looting whatever they could while every Horde scum was trying to flee. There was always an idiot who tried to get into the hold of a sinking ship, thinking they’d get out in time with some treasure.

“Make way for the wounded! Get out of the way! Don’t make me push you out of the way!”

Damn. That was a familiar voice Seacat could’ve done without hearing again for a great long while. “That’s the Horde princess!” she hissed. Glancing over her shoulder, she could see the massive woman clearing a path for what looked like a giant covered wagon.

“Get out of the way!”

“We’re kinda in the way,” Brain Boy commented.

“But we’re carrying wounded as well,” Entrapta pointed out.

“I doubt she’ll care,” Seacat said. “We’re the enemy, after all.”

“Let’s get out of the way, then,” Brain Boy said, guiding the cart to the side.

“And hide your faces!” Seacat added in a hiss. “We don’t want her to recognise us!”

The last thing they needed was a fight in the middle of the fleeing Horde.

But the big woman parted the crowd and led the large wagon - the sides sported the badge of the Horde Infirmary - through.

Seacat relaxed. One volley dodged.

“Hey!”

Or not. She clenched her teeth as the Horde princess left the wagon and turned back towards them.

“You’ve got wounded on your cart? Do you need help? Are there others who need to be evacuated?”

Before anyone could reply, the Horde woman was at their cart, peering at Adora and Glimmer. “I can help you…” She trailed off, staring at the two, then at the rest of the group.

“Hi?” Entrapta said, waving at her.

“You!” The princess stared at Seacat.

“Me, yes,” Seacat replied. “We’re evacuating the wounded.”

“You did this! You’re trying to kill us all!”

Oh, no! “If we wanted to kill you, would we have given you a warning?” Seacat retorted, looking around if anyone was paying attention. Fortunately, it seemed as if the Horde scum were too busy trying to escape.

“This is the Princess Alliance speaking. Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead. We’ve taken control of the enhanced engine bombs and will be detonating them in an hour!”

Entrapta’s bots had remarkably bad timing, Seacat realised, as the Horde princess’s scowl grew even deeper.

“We wouldn’t have warned you if we wanted to kill you all,” Brain boy quickly said. “And we didn’t plant bombs in your infirmaries. Or your barracks. Just the plants and Hordak’s laboratory.”

They'd had to prioritise, of course. And they didn't have unlimited bombs, either. But that wasn't something the Horde princess needed to know.

"That will still destroy the Horde!"

Seacat wasn't the only one staring at the bug princess.

"That's, uh, kind of the point," Brain Boy said. "We want to ensure that whoever is replacing Hordak can't keep waging war on the Alliance."

"Oh. I guess you would."

Seacat revised her estimate of the princess's intelligence a little further downwards, even accounting for the fact that she was currently very stressed. "So… do you want to start a fight here?" She cocked her head. "In the middle of the road, with all the wounded around? Against princesses?"

That earned her a glare from the Horde scum. "Are you threatening to hurt the wounded?"

Seacat held her ground. "We're not the ones who blow up their own soldiers to hurt the enemy."

"No, you're blowing up my home!"

"Only parts of it," Brain Boy said. "And we warned you."

"And you tried to blow up our homes," Mermista added with a deep scowl.

Seacat glanced around. A few soldiers were watching them, but the vast majority of the Horde scum were still streaming past, fleeing the area.

The Horde princess stared at them. Seacat stared back.

But after a few more seconds, the princess backed down and stepped to the side.

Brain Boy sighed audibly and urged their wagon on.

Seacat didn't relax until they had gained enough distance to lose sight of the bug princess.

*****

They were still on the road filled with Horde scum when the enhanced engine bombs went off. Even from so far away, they could hear the explosions and see the smoke clouds, illuminated by the fire below, rise over the Fright Zone like a giant mushroom.

Seacat hissed through her teeth at the sight. That was… she had seen enhanced engine bomb explosions before, but nothing like this.

"So, my theories were correct," Entrapta said. "The bombs were advanced models, so the force of the blast was much bigger than a normal enhanced engine bomb detonating. The shape of the smoke cloud is distinctive - I think."

Seacat glanced around, but no one was paying attention to them. Everyone was staring at the cloud.

"This is fascinating. I wish we had taken one of the bombs with us!"

"This is horrible," Brai Boy said. "That blast must have destroyed most of the zone there."

"Yes? Wasn't that the point?" Entrapta looked confused.

"Imagine someone using such a bomb in a town!"

"Well, it would destroy the town - the average town is much smaller than the urban areas of the Fright Zone," Entrapta said.

Then she blinked. “Oh. You mean without warning the population.”

“Yes.”

Seacat padded the shoulder of the princess. “We’re not going to do that. No one is going to do that.” She hoped she wasn’t lying.

“We’ll have to control fuel crystals very, very tightly,” Mermista said. “If someone else manages to build such a bomb…”

Seacat shuddered at the thought.

*****

Adora started to stir about an hour later, when they were on a smaller road leading north, without Horde scum nearby. Seacat heard her groan softly. She immediately left Sea Hawk to steer the cart and scrambled to Adora’s side. “Adora!”

“Ngh?” Her lover was blinking, her mouth half-open.

“Adora!”

Her eyes focused on Seacat. “Ca-Seacat?”

“Yes.” Seacat beamed at her. She was awake. Back. Alive.

“What… where are we?”

“We’ve left the Fright Zone’s core lands and we’re on the way back to Alliance lands,” Seacat told her.

“Did… did we win?”

“Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead.”

“Oh.” More blinking.

“And we blew up Hordak’s laboratory, his plants, and most of the Fright Zone’s buildings,” Seacat told her.

"We did?"

"We warned the Horde beforehand, so they evacuated," Bow added.

"Ah." Adora looked relieved. A little bit. "Is everyone alright?"

Seacat pressed her lips together. "Ah…"

"Glimmer got hurt. She's stable, but…" Bow said.

"Oh, no!" Adora sat up. "Glimmer! Where is my sword?"

"Adora, wait!"

But Seacat's lover had grabbed her magic sword already - who had left it at her side? - and pointed it at Glimmer. A moment later, magic energy shot out of the tip and hit the princess.

And Adora collapsed. Seacat barely managed to grab her before she hit her head on the cart and glared at her unconscious lover.

"You bloody idiot!" she screeched.

"Huh? What happened? Bow!"

And Glimmer jumped up in the cart, looking around like a cornered seal for a moment.

"It's alright, Glimmer!" Bow blurted out. "We're out of the Fright Zone. Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead. And the airship's been destroyed."

"With most of the Fright Zone," Mermista added.

"We won?" Glimmer started to smile. Then she saw Adora. "Adora!"

"Don't bother," Seacat told her. "The idiot woke up and exhausted herself straight away healing you. She won't wake up for hours now."

And then Seacat would kill her! So Adora wouldn't do something so incredibly stupid again! Really! To wake up, just to knock herself out again!

"Oh." Glimmer still looked confused. Then she frowned. "I missed the whole fight?"

"All of us missed it except for Adora and Seacat," Bow said. "You got knocked out before you could teleport the rest of us, so we couldn't join them in Hordak's office - and we had to fight our way out when the airship started burning."

"Burning?" Glimmer gasped.

"The whole yard went up in flames while we fought," Seacat explained. "Shadow Weaver left us with Hordak, and Hordak fled as well. We found them at the runestone, fighting each other. Adora killed Hordak but got knocked out herself, and Shadow Weaver…" She hesitated.

"Did you kill her?" Glimmer asked.

"She killed herself when she linked herself to the Black Garnet. The magic was too much - the lightning turned her to ash," Seacat said.

"Ah." Glimmer and Bow exchanged glances.

As did Seacat and Mermista, who had joined Sea Hawk at the front of the cart.

"Did she ground herself?" Entrapta asked.

"I don't think so," Seacat replied. "It looked like magical lightning."

"Oh. That's different."

"Hordak's armour was immune to it," Seacat added, trying to change the topic. "No matter what she threw at him, it didn't hurt him."

“Oh! Lightning-proof armour?” Entrapta cheered up. “I’ll have to look into that!”

Well, it was safer than creating more powerful bombs.

Seacat sighed as she cradled Adora’s head in her lap and leaned back, ignoring Glimmer and Bow all but crawling into each other’s lap and how they whispered.

At least it was over.

Mostly.

*****

“Seacat?”

Seacat blinked and looked around as she sat up. That was… “Adora!”

“Good morning,” her stupid lover said, smiling at her from where she was sitting on her blanket.

“Morning?” Seacat looked up. It was barely noon.

“Technically. I think,” Adora said. “So, we made camp?”

Seacat rolled her eyes. That much should’ve been obvious. “What clued you in? The tents we pitched?” Her lover pouted, and Seacat scoffed. “We’re on the way to the Whispering Woods.”

“As planned.”

“Yes. And speaking of planned…” Seacat gathered her thoughts to give her lover a piece of her mind about reckless healing. But then, Adora stretched, and Seacat kind of got distracted. That was… “...unfair,” she muttered.

“Hm?” Adora smiled innocently, but she wasn’t good enough to fool Seacat.

“I know what you’re trying to do, and it won’t work,” she whispered.

“Oh?”

“You’re trying to distract me so I won’t yell at you.”

“Most of the others are sleeping,” Adora pointed out. “Yelling at me would wake them up.”

“Then they can also yell at you.”

Adora flinched. “I’m sorry for… worrying you.”

“For exhausting yourself while you’re wounded?” Seacat crossed her arms over her chest.

“That, too.” Adora shook her head. “But I couldn’t let Glimmer keep suffering!”

“You could’ve waited a moment, at least,” Seacat pointed out. “We might’ve needed you being able to walk.” If the bug princess had attacked them or ordered Horde troops to attack… well, the troops on the road hadn’t looked as if they would attack anyone, least of all a group of princesses.

“Sorry.”

Seacat sighed. “Just don’t do it again.”

“Healing?”

“Recklessly endangering yourself without checking what’s going on, first,” Seacat corrected her.

“Ah.” Adora bit her lower lip. “I think I can do that.”

“Of course you can!” It wasn’t a question of ability!

“I’ll try, then.”

That was probably the best Seacat could get. At least now. She didn't like it, though. Sighing again, she reached out and hugged her lover. "You really worried me," she whispered.

"So did you," Adora told her.

Seacat ignored that. They hadn't had any choice. Unlike Adora's latest stunt.

"So, how's Glimmer?"

"She's fine. And with Bow."

"Oh, right." Adora smiled. "So… we've won."

"Pretty much, yes." Seacat shrugged. The war wasn't over, but the Horde was done for. The Horde wouldn't last much longer, not after losing their leaders, their bombs and their airship. The Horde scum, though? Dealing with them might take longer. Many of them would become pirates and bandits.

"So…" Adora bit her lower lip again. "What are you planning to do now?"

Oh, that question. Seacat blinked. "The war's not over," she said. "There's still the Horde armies to deal with. And the Horde ships."

"Ah." Adora nodded. "So, that'll take a while."

"Yes."

Her lover nodded again.

Damn, this was awkward. Seacat was supposed to scold Adora, not… avoid talking to her about their future.

But this probably wasn't the time nor the place to discuss this.

Seacat sighed and hugged Adora again, then slid in her lap. Her lover was back. Everything else could wait.

*****

“News of Hordak’s death must have travelled fast,” Bow commented as they looked at the deserted remains of a Horde checkpoint they had passed on their way to the Fright Zone. Back then, it had been manned by a squad. Now...

Now, it was not just deserted but looted to the bedrock. So to speak - everything that had been portable had disappeared, and the rest had been set on fire. That wasn’t a good sign.

“Something wrong?” Entrapta asked. “Isn’t it a good thing that the Horde soldiers stationed here deserted?”

“Where did they go?” Seacat asked. “And why did they burn down the post?”

“That’s standard Horde tactics,” Adora explained. “You aren’t supposed to leave anything useful to the enemy.”

“Scorched earth,” Bow added. “The Alliance did the same in some campaigns.”

Seacat frowned. “In any case, if they continue such habits, then there’ll be a huge problem with bandits and raiders. And pirates, but those can be dealt with more easily.”

“The Salinean Navy will sweep them from the seas!” Sea Hawk announced. “Huzzah!”

“And hang them,” Mermista added.

“Won’t that drive them to fight to the death?” Entrapta asked. “That’s why we take prisoners, isn’t it?”

“Pirates aren’t soldiers; they’re criminal scum,” Mermista said.

“As opposed to Horde scum,” Seacat added. “But rooting out the bandits - bandits with military training, experience and supplies - will be harder.” Though not impossible.

“We’ll manage,” Glimmer said. “We still have an army. If we can beat the Horde, we can beat its remnants.”

“But the Alliance might dissolve, with the Horde gone,” Bow retorted.

“Salineas will stay in the Alliance,” Mermista announced. “No matter what the other kingdoms might decide.”

Though they would be busy hunting down pirates, Seacat knew. That couldn’t be helped.

“I don’t think Perfuma will quit, either,” Adora said.

“She was pretty isolationist before the Horde attacked Plumeria,” Glimmer pointed out.

“But now she knows what is at stake,” Adora retorted. “And she’s a friend.”

“I’ll stay as well!” Entrapta announced. “And my bots! If they want to.”

That would help a lot with patrolling some areas. But Etheria would still be quite a lot more dangerous for the next few years. Especially the areas near the Crimson Waste.

Then Seacat realised that Adora hadn’t said anything about fighting on herself. And was staring at her.

Oh.

They probably needed to have that talk sooner than Seacat had expected.

But not right now.

“Let’s go on.” She pointed north. “Let’s go home.”

*****

The Negotiations

Fireworks lit up the night sky, bright flashes and sparks going off above, the faint explosions drowned out by the reaction of the crowd below - the courtyard of Bright Moon's palace had been filled to capacity, or so it seemed, by everyone in the country who wasn't serving at the frontlines.

Leaning against the railing of the balcony, Seacat sighed and took another sip from the fruity drink she'd pilfered from the banquet.

"Is something wrong?"

Seacat turned. Adora stood in the doorway leading to the main ballroom of the palace, two glasses in one hand and a plate with snacks - dessert - in the other. "I noticed you had sneaked out," she said with a shy smile.

"I told you I was getting some fresh air." Seacat snorted, emptied her glass and put it on the stone railing.

"When I was talking to Queen Angella and couldn't follow you."

She shrugged. "I'm not much for royalty."

It was Adora's turn to snort as she joined Seacat at the railing, the white dress she wore billowing out a little - Seacat's lover had never learned to, or didn't bother with, walking more demurely. It wouldn't fit her, anyway - even untransformed, Adora was She-Ra. Grace, power and strength. And beauty. So much…

"Seacat?"

She blinked.

"You were, uh, kind of…"

"You distracted me," Seacat cut her off with a grin, emptied her fruity drink and grabbed a glass from Adora.

"I distracted you?"

"You and your dress," Seacat replied.

Adora blushed. "Oh. Glimmer picked it out."

"I know. You wanted to attend in uniform." Seacat shook her head. A Horde uniform, merely slightly altered, too!

"It is a victory celebration, not an… uh, another kind of celebration," Adora defended herself.

A premature celebration, in Seacat's opinion. The Horde hadn't surrendered. Not officially, at least. The army trapped north of Fortress Freedom had surrendered, at last, and the forces facing Bright Moon and Plumeria had disintegrated, but whoever was in charge of the remnants in the Fright Zone hadn't replied to the demand for parley the Alliance had sent. If they had received the demand in the first place.

"And you're in uniform!" Adora went on with a pout.

"I'm a dashing naval officer," Seacat replied, pointing at her chest. "But this isn't a uniform."

Adora blinked. "Of course it is! It has all the buttons, the epaulettes, even the golden cord!"

Seacat's grin widened. "Oh, it looks like a uniform, but it isn't a uniform of any navy known to Etheria." She'd had it custom made, after all.

"It looks like one of the Salinean uniforms, just in dark red," Adora protested.

"It's similar to them, but no Salinean would mistake it for one of theirs." Seacat ran a hand down her chest, drawing attention to the generous amount of cleavage shown.

Adora's blush grew stronger. "That's because you didn't close it!"

“It’s not meant to be closed,” Seacat explained. She pulled on the jacket to emphasise her point. And her bust.

“Oh.” Adora slowly nodded. “So, Sea Hawk’s uniform is the same, then?

She shook her head. “No. Sea Hawk’s wearing the uniform of an admiral in the Salinean Navy.”

“What?”

“Well, he is an admiral, and there aren’t actually any rules about the colours of the uniform at his rank, other than the epaulettes and stripes, so…” Seacat shrugged with a sly grin. “Besides, Mermista didn’t object, so that makes it official.” She grabbed a small cake from Adora’s plate while her lover gaped.

“Oh, you!” Adora pouted at her. “You just made that up!”

“No, I didn’t. That’s how it works.” She ate the cake in two bites. “Oh, that’s good!”

“Really?”

“Yes. Try one!”

Adora rolled her eyes. “I meant about the uniforms.”

“The Alliance isn’t the Horde.” Seacat stole another of the cakes.

“And soon, the Horde will be gone.”

“Yes. As soon as the bug princess finally remembers that she’s in charge and surrenders.”

“We don’t actually know if she’s in charge,” Adora pointed out.

“Who else would be? She’s a princess. With Hordak and Shadow Weaver gone, whoever is left will turn to her.” Seacat shrugged again.

“Remember what we were taught about princesses?”

“Of course.” She frowned a little. That had been years ago, after all. In another life. “But those who bought into this will have deserted already, I think.”

“Or banded together to resist to the end.” Adora sighed. “Angella said we need more information.”

“Just invade, crush whoever is resisting, and finish the war for good.” Seacat finished her drink.

“It’s not quite as simple.” Adora leaned against the railing, and Seacat was once again briefly distracted by the way her lover’s dress clung to her figure. “And there’s another thing.”

“Yes?” Seacat looked up at Adora’s face.

“Light Hope.”

“Oh.” Seacat needed another drink for that. “You didn’t go visit her, did you?” She didn’t think so; Adora had been way too busy with all the briefings, planning sessions and celebrations - many of which Seacat had had to attend as well - but it wasn’t as if the broken bot’s bunker was too far away.

“What? No. But I need to. We need to.” Adora said with a firm expression. “We need to find out if she knows what Shadow Weaver did to the runestone and what it might have done to Etheria’s magic.”

Seacat owned her mouth to protest that they didn’t need to talk to the broken bot but closed it again and scowled instead. Adora was right - if Shadow Weaver could kill herself like she had done, then they needed to find out if something was wrong with the Horde’s runestone. And if that could happen to others. “I guess so.”

Adora nodded. “This is important. It’s what Mara was doing. Before…” She trailed off.

Seacat clenched her teeth. Adora's predecessor had died trying to 'bring back balance to Etheria' or whatever the bot called it. And now Adora wanted to do the same? "I don't trust the bot." It had tried to kill her, no matter what it claimed.

"I know. And I understand. But… she's the only one who knows about She-Ra's duties."

"And she's broken. And doesn't want us to fix her."

"Yes. Though I think I can convince her to let Entrapta repair her damaged memories."

Seacat snorted. "If her memory is actually damaged."

"What? She wouldn't lie to me!"

"Really?" Seacat shook her head.

"She's… she's a friend."

"And she's been lying to you. She is supposed to help and obey you, but when you told her to let Entrapta repair her, she changed her lines, remember?"

Adora's expression showed that she did. "I know. But…" She slumped a little.

Seacat sighed and moved to hug her lover. "I know." Adora thought the bot was a friend. And she'd do anything for a friend. Even if they hurt her.

Seacat would have to make sure this wouldn't happen.

*****

"We need to send someone to make contact with Princess Scorpia," the queen said, leaning over the table in the planning room of Bright Moon.

She was really tall, Seacat thought, not for the first time. It was weird that Glimmer was so short - her father must have been quite short as well. Or it was just the way magic worked.

“She hasn’t answered our first request for parley,” Mermista pointed out.

“To be fair, we blew up the Fright Zone’s core,” Bow said. “And it’s not clear whether she’s in charge of the Horde’s remnants or not.”

“Or whether the message was even received by her,” Seacat said.

Glimmer frowned. “Our courier handed it over to the officer in charge of the Horde troops.”

“Of some Horde troops,” Seacat told her. “The princess might not be in charge of them.”

“We could wait until they settle their differences, and we have a leader to talk to,” Entrapta suggested.

“I would rather deal with Princess Scorpia,” Angella said. “Of all the Horde leaders we know of, she seems to be one of the least aggressive.”

Seacat snorted. The bug princess had been very aggressive when she had tried to stop Seacat from escaping the Fright Zone’s prison.

The queen looked at her. “Twice you’ve talked to her without a fight.”

“Yes.” Seacat pressed her lips together. She didn’t like the sound of this.

“Would you volunteer to meet her a third time? You seem to have developed a rapport.”

And Catra had been a Horde cadet. Angella didn’t mention that, but everyone knew it.

“It’s our best chance to end the war without further bloodshed,” the queen went on.

Seacat slowly drew a deep breath. Angella was right. But… “It’ll take some time going back to the Fright Zone,” she said. “The frontlines are disintegrating, but Horde troops and Horde deserters will still be present in the area.”

“I can ask Swift Wind to fly us to the Fright Zone to meet with her,” Adora said, smiling. “And return quickly.”

“Just the two of you?” Glimmer asked.

“Swift Wind can’t carry more than us two over such a distance. And even then only if I’m not She-Ra,” Adora explained.

“I was thinking of sending a delegation with an escort,” Angella said. “But time is of the essence.”

“And I can keep us safe,” Adora added. “Safer than an escort - unless we’re all going.”

“You’re not going, Glimmer,” Angella said. “The commander is needed here.”

Glimmer closed her mouth. She glared at her mother but didn’t protest.

Seacat snorted. “Well, riding the horsey is probably safer than travelling overland.” At least with the airship destroyed.

“Great!” Adora beamed at her.

“Good. Now, next point: We took a lot of prisoners when the Horde forces trapped between Fortress Freedom and Seaworthy surrendered,” Angella went on. “They need to be supplied for the foreseeable future.”

“I can help there!” Perfuma said.

“You’re also needed to supply our own forces in the field,” Angella told her.

“Move the prisoners to the coast, and we can ship the supplies from Perfuma to them,” Mermista said.

“Do we have the shipping?” Glimmer asked. “After the losses we took?”

“We should - we’ve been building more transport ships,” Mermista explained.

“Good. Next point: Deserters…”

*****

“Oh, what a great day! Boon companions, we’re on our way to end the war of wars! A crucial mission, entrusted to us by everyone! As we soar in shining wings through the sky, the hopes of Etheria rest upon us - a burden we are glad to bear!”

Seacat resisted the urge to stick her claws into Swift Wind’s flank and scratch for all she was worth. If they weren’t flying far too high in the sky, she might have done it. If they were on a ship, she certainly would’ve thrown the horse overboard. After tying his wings together so he couldn’t fly off. Or at least gagged him - as a horse, he couldn’t remove a gag, could he? Seacat was no stranger to bombastic speeches - the Captain was very fond of them, and of shanties - but everyone had a limit, and she had reached hers.

Too bad Adora hadn’t reached hers. “That’s the Fright Zone ahead!” She moved her arm to point downwards.

“Finally!” Seacat blurted out.

“The heart of darkness! The core of the evil Horde! We shall pierce it like a sword from heaven!”

“We shall land there and look for the Horde princess,” Seacat corrected the horse.

“Yes. This is a diplomatic mission,” Adora agreed.

“War is but the consequences of diplomacy failing, and we should be prepared for such an outcome,” the horse retorted.

That sounded like a quote. “Did you read the entire library of Bright Moon?” Seacat asked. And how would the horse have managed to turn the pages?

“I’ve had many books read to me,” Swift Wind replied.

“You have?” Adora asked.

“Well, between courier missions,” Swift Wind said. “I requested stable boys who knew their letters and had them read books to me while they groomed me. We both profited from the arrangement.”

“Ah.”

That was smart. Seacat had to admit. But if she ever met whoever had introduced the horse to that particular manner of speech…

“I think they’ve seen us,” Adora said. “The soldiers at the checkpoint there are signalling.”

Seacat leaned around her lover to take a look with her telescope. “They’re signalling the Fright Zone’s core area. Whoever is in command there will know about us approaching.”

“Good.” Adora nodded. “Then they will be prepared.”

“And that’s good?” Swift Wind asked.

“It means that when we don’t rush in but approach openly - under a flag of truce - they’ll be unlikely to mistake this for an attack,” Adora explained.

And the Horde scum would have an easier time to ambush them. "We should wait until we see the princess," Seacat said. "She shouldn't attack us on sight." Unless she had taken the destruction of most of the core area of the Fright Zone personally.

"She did seem reasonable last time we met her," Adora said.

"She's still a Horde leader," Swift Wind pointed out.

"So was I," Adora retorted.

"For all of… half a day?" Seacat asked.

"It still counts!" Adora was blushing a little. "We'll have common ground, at least."

"We still should be ready to take off at once. And you should transform before we land," Seacat told her.

"Swift Wind can't carry both of us when I'm She-Ra!"

"I only need to land; I'll manage."

But he wouldn't be able to take off with them. Which meant that Adora would need to transform back if they had to flee. And that would be… tricky. Seacat leaned forward, resting her chin on Adora's shoulder. And whispered: "Don't even think of staying She-Ra to cover our retreat or something. I've told you before: I won't mount Swift Wind unless it's with you."

Adora gasped. "That wasn't what you meant!"

"But you know I mean it now," Seacat replied. She knew Adora, after all.

"But…"

"No buts."

Adora tensed, then sighed. "Alright," she said, pouting.

Seacat smiled as she withdrew a little. One potential problem taken care of. One of many, alas.

*****

A little later, they were circling above the heart of the Fright Zone. What was left of it, anyway, next to two huge, overlapping craters.

"I didn't think it would be that bad," Adora mumbled.

"I don't think anyone expected this," Seacat replied. "Except for Entrapta. Maybe." She whistled. "Hordak's laboratory is completely gone."

"Yes. And so are the main bot and weapon plants." Adora nodded. "And the shipyard's just ashes and rubble any more. Do you think that the runestone was destroyed as well?"

"I don't think so." Seacat wasn't an expert, but she doubted that mere fire could destroy a runestone. They would have to ask Entrapta once they returned to Bright Moon. "Do you see the bug princess anywhere?" She started looking over the area with her telescope.

"No, just a few guns and… troops scattering."

They were out of range of any gun in the Horde arsenal. Not that Seacat thought they would manage to elevate the barrel that high, anyway. Or hit Swift Wind.

She still gave the guns a look. You could tell a lot about an army by checking their artillery. And… "There is the princess!"

Below them, the Horde princess was hefting a gun all by herself, pointing it at them.

"If she fires that piece, the recoil will paste her," Seacat muttered.

"She won't," Adora said, but Seacat's lover sounded unsure.

“Well, let’s find out how dumb she is,” Seacat said. “Take us down.”

“If I fly down, they can shoot their cannons at me,” Swift Wind replied.

“Just land somewhere near, but not too close. We have a flag of truce,” Adora told him.

“Alright.” The flying horse started their descent.

And Seacat really hoped that she was right about the princess. There were about a hundred Horde scum down there - half of them manning the five guns they were setting up, the other half aiming crossbows.

But they weren’t firing. And the princess dropped the gun once they touched the ground.

Adora dismounted and grabbed the flag. Seacat slid down herself, restraining from drawing her sword. She put a hand on the hilt, though.

“Alright, fly up and circle above us,” Adora said.

“If anything happens, I’ll come save you!”

“Only after we’ve disabled the guns,” Seacat told him. “You can’t save us if you’re shredded by canister shot.”

“That’s barbaric!”

“But effective.”

With a huff, the horse took to the air again. And Adora and Seacat started walking towards the princess. And tried to ignore how they aimed their guns and crossbows at them. Seacat still looked for cover - but the open field they had landed in didn’t provide much if any cover.

“We should’ve landed in the crater,” she mumbled. “Plenty of cover there. And you should’ve transformed.”

“That would’ve made it look like an attack,” Adora retorted.

“Well… aiming cannons and crossbows at us also looks like an attack is about to happen.”

“They’re just cautious,” Adora said.

Seacat snorted.

But once they closed to about a hundred yards, the bug princess raised her arm, and the crossbows were lowered. Then the princess climbed over the small wall that covered the central gun and started walking towards them.

Adora stopped walking as well. Smart, in Seacat’s opinion - if things took a turn for the worse, they could run out of range before the princess made it back to her troops - or moved out of the line of fire. Probably.

Though standing still and waiting felt even worse than walking. Seacat wanted to fidget with something, but pulling her sword would provoke an attack for sure. Hell, even taking out her telescope would probably be mistaken for an attack if the trembling Horde scum on the left part of the Horde line was any indication.

But the princess reached them, stopping five yards away, without the guns firing. “So…” The princess cleared her throat. “Flag of truce?”

“Yes. Are you the new Horde leader?” Adora asked.

“Yes. You already knew that,” the princess said, frowning at Seacat.

“We suspected. We didn’t know,” Seacat corrected her.

“And we’re here to negotiate an end to the war,” Adora said.

“Who are you?” the princess asked. “I know her” - she nodded at Seacat - “but I don’t know… wait! I’ve seen you before - at the Princess Prom! You’re She-Ra!” She took a step back.

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

“Ah.” The princess grimaced but didn’t say anything else.

“As I said, we’re here to negotiate an end to the war. I represent the Princess Alliance,” Adora said with a nod. “And you represent the Horde.”

“You want… First, you murder our leaders, then you blow up our plants and supplies, and now you want to end the war?” The princess scowled at them. “You know what you did to us!”

“Ending the war was the point of doing all of this,” Seacat told her. “Without Hordak and Shadow Weaver and with your airship gone, you’ve got no chance to win this war any more.”

“So, we’ve come to end the war without further bloodshed,” Adora added, with a glance at Seacat.

Seacat glared at her for a moment. She was just telling it like it was!

“We’ve still got an army and a navy,” the princess replied. “And we can rebuild.”

Seacat made a point of looking at the craters, or at least into the direction where they would be, mostly hidden behind some intact warehouses.

Adora shook her head. “Even if you had the time to rebuild, you won’t be able to build enhanced engine bombs. And you were losing the war before you built them.”

“Your navy was just clogging up the ports you still controlled,” Seacat added. “And your army is deserting.”

Judging by the scowl on the princess’s face, she was aware of that but didn’t want to admit it. “We can still put up a fight!”

“Yes, you could,” Adora said, smiling slightly. “But why would you? You can’t win.”

“We can die on our feet instead of on our knees.”

Was that pride or just a front? Or desperation?

“You don’t need to die at all,” Adora said.

Seacat pressed her lips together. She could think of a few Horde scumbags that needed to die. The ones who blew up their own troops, for starters.

“We offer terms,” Adora went on.

“What terms?”

Adora reached into her uniform and pulled out a sealed letter. “Here’s the proposal.”

The princess took it, opened it - which was impressive for someone with pincers for hands - and started to read it.

“You want us to surrender!” she said after she finished reading.

Seacat rolled her eyes. Anyone with half a brain could see that the Horde had lost the war.

“Surrender, but not unconditionally.” Adora smiled. “You can keep your core lands - as you’re the heir to the kingdom, whether you restore your kingdom or keep the Horde going in the Fright Zone is your business, as long as you don’t attack others.”

“And as long as you don’t raise children to turn them into soldiers,” Seacat added, baring her fangs.

“What?” The princess looked at the letter again. “You want us to abandon orphans?”

Seacat felt her claws slide out and clenched her teeth. What was this…

A hand on her shoulder stopped her. “No,” Adora said. “We want you to stop taking orphans and turning them into soldiers. No more cadets - your soldiers will have to start training as adults.”

“Oh.”

“And you’ll return all orphans taken from other countries,” Seacat spat.

“As long as they want to return,” Adora added. “We’re aware that some might not.”

Thanks to having been brainwashed, Seacat thought. But taking in hardened Horde soldiers wouldn’t be smart - that would only cause more trouble. She cursed Hordak and Shadow Weaver again for doing this.

“The Horde’s our home,” the princess replied.

“The soldiers deserting from the frontlines might disagree,” Seacat told her. When the huge woman glared at her, she flashed her a toothy smile. The idiot probably needed a reminder that they were losing the war.

“We still have an army,” the princess repeated herself.

“And you won’t have it for long if you keep fighting,” Seacat retorted.

“We’re here to avoid further fighting. That’s why the Alliance offers you these terms,” Adora said. “You can make a counteroffer, if you like.”

“That will take time.” The princess looked at the offer once more.

“Take your time. We’ll start rolling up the front,” Seacat told her.

“What? We don’t have a truce while we negotiate?”

“That would only benefit you,” Adora said, glancing at Seacat. “We won’t launch an all-out offensive or strike at your homeland, but we won’t let you reinforce and reorganise the front, either.”

“Or let your frigates roam the sea. Those you have left, anyway,” Seacat added. “Besides, what do you have to offer? We’re not going to let you keep the conquered territory.”

“This offer seems to benefit mostly myself,” the princess said after a moment.

“You’re the princess of the Fright Zone. It’s yours by birthright,” Adora said.

“I’m the leader of the Horde. Well, the leader of the remains,” the princess said. “This makes it look as if I’m selling the rest out.”

Adora shook her head. “You’re their leader. They’re your responsibility. And you have to decide whether they are better off fighting to death or surrendering.”

Which was why many Horde soldiers were voting with their feet. Or their ships.

“They didn’t cover that in Force Captain orientation.” The bug princess sighed. “The closest would be the stuff about preserving your troops.”

Adora nodded. “Hordak wanted obedient tools. Force Captains who were more loyal to their soldiers than to him were unacceptable. But you’re a leader now. You have to make decisions.”

Seacat nodded. That was how it worked.

“I… I have to think about this.” The princess glanced over her shoulder.

“How long will you need?” Adora asked.

“I don’t know…” The huge woman sighed. “A day?”

“A day it is.” Adora nodded. “We’ll…”

“We’ll meet you tomorrow, on the plains between the Fright Zone and the Whispering Woods,” Seacat interrupted her, ignoring her frown.

“Alright. Until tomorrow, then.” The princess nodded.

Adora nodded in return.

Seacat stretched her arms over her head. “Good. Let’s go then.”

“Right.” The princess nodded again, then turned away and started to walk back to her troops.

“What was that about?” Adora whispered.

“We aren’t going to meet them here,” Seacat told her. “If the Horde scum decides to fight to the death, they could easily blast us to shreds here as soon as we land. Taking out She-Ra would be a coup for them - and they won’t have anything to lose. But such an ambush won’t be possible on the plains.”

“Unless they bury explosives at the meeting spot.”

“We’ll land a little away and have her come to us,” Seacat replied. “I doubt that they have enough powder left to mine the entire area.” And on the pains, scouts could keep an eye on the Horde until the meeting.

“Do you really think Scorpia would do that?”

Seacat shrugged. “Better safe than sorry.”

Adora sighed, then waved at Swift Wind to come pick them up.

*****

"...and then we left and flew back to Bright Moon," Adora finished her report, then sat down at the planning table.

Seacat patted her thigh under the table - her lover had worried a little too much about this, even though everyone knew she'd deliver a perfect report. Which she had done.

"Thank you, Adora." Queen Angella smiled at her - and at Seacat. "Do you think the Horde will accept our terms?"

"Ah…" Adora nibbled on her lower lip. "I don't know? It's the rational choice, but… Princess Scorpia seemed concerned with the, ah, appearances of it."

"'Appearances'?" Now the queen was frowning.

"She said it would look like she was selling out the Horde to take over," Seacat explained.

"But she is the leader of the Horde, isn't she?" Glimmer asked. "She's in charge."

"Yes." Seacat nodded.

"So we assume," Adora added. "We haven't seen any sign that would contradict our assumption."

Seacat rolled her eyes. "The princess is about as subtle as a frigate's broadside. If she wasn't in charge, she would have let it slip."

"That was my impression at the Princess Prom as well," Bow said.

Queen Angella nodded. "We will assume that it's true, then."

"So, why would she think she's selling her troops out?" Glimmer asked.

“Horde propaganda,” Seacat replied. “They demonise princesses.” Catra remembered the lessons about princesses in the Horde.

“It’s a little more complicated than that,” Adora said. “The Horde taught us - the older cadets - that everyone could become a Force Captain if they worked hard enough. And that was contrasted against the Alliance, where your birth decided your position.”

“That’s not true!” Glimmer protested. “Look at Bow! Or Sea Hawk! Or Seacat!”

“They aren’t princesses,” Queen Angella explained. “In order to bond with a runestone, you do have to be a member of the right family. This talent is hereditary.”

“Most princesses don’t bond with runestones, though,” Entrapta cut in. Of course, they don’t have runestones in the first place. “I don’t, for example. And neither do Spinerella and Nettossa. There are actually only five such runestones - six if you count She-Ra’s sword. And I can’t say yet if it should count. It’s far smaller than the five other runestones, but it’s connected to them.”

Seacat frowned. That seemed… Well, she wasn’t a sorceress, but it seemed weird. Suspicious, too. Five huge runestones, and then one tiny runestone set in a sword? All connected?

“There are a lot more princesses who don’t have ties to a runestone than five - or six,” Nettossa pointed out. “All of them have magical talents, though.”

“As opposed to a talent for magic,” Entrapta said, nodding. “I don’t think there’s ever been a princess that was also a sorceress, but I didn’t check with Mystacore’s archives.” She frowned. “I should, actually. That’s an interesting question about hereditary talents.”

“Can we focus on the Horde’s claims for now?” Glimmer asked. “It’s not as if the Horde was set up any differently than most kingdoms. Hordak and Shadow Weaver ran it, and the rest could’ve reached at most the rank of Force Captain.”

“Exactly like Salineas,” Sea Hawk said, nodding. “Any sailor can reach the rank of admiral - under my love!”

“We don’t raise soldiers from childbirth like the Horde does!” Mermista protested with a glare. “And we don’t invade our neighbours.”

“So,” Seacat summed up, “the Horde lied about the Alliance. As usual.”

“They did,” Adora agreed. “But lies or not, what is important is what the Horde soldiers believe. And if they think Scorpia received our offer because she’s the rightful princess of the Fright Zone, they might not follow her.”

Glimmer sighed and slumped. “And I thought it was a good thing that the highest-ranking Horde scum was also a princess! Now it’s making things more difficult?”

Bow patted her back.

“Princess Scorpia is the leader of the remaining Horde forces - at least of the biggest and most organised part of the Horde that’s left,” Queen Angella said. “That is what matters. If she cannot secure the loyalty and obedience of her troops, then any agreement with the Horde wouldn’t have worked anyway.”

“Well,” Adora said, “she was promoted to Force Captain - she’s the senior Force Captain, actually. So, she should have lots of experience leading the Horde.”

Unless the idiot had only been promoted because she was a princess. Then again, Seacat knew first-hand how dangerous and powerful the bug princess was. “If that fails, then I think she’s got good chances to beat everyone into obeying her orders,” Seacat said with a chuckle.

“What we need is an agreement to end the war on our terms that will last,” Queen Angella reminded them. “If Princess Scorpia needs some minor concessions to ensure that, then we will grant

them. If she cannot provide this, we shall look for someone who can do it while we advance towards the Fright Zone." She frowned. "One way or the other, this war will end."

Seacat agreed with that. Very much.

She was a sailor, not a soldier.

*****

The next day, they were on Swift Wind's back again, circling above the plains separating the Fright Zone from the Whispering Woods.

"We should've been more specific about the meeting spot," Adora complained.

She was correct, but that didn't mean Seacat had to admit it. "I thought it was clear that it would be near the entrance to the Fright Zone. Well, let's follow the road towards the frontlines," she said, leaning to the side to peer through her telescope.

"Well, apparently, it wasn't clear," Adora said.

"Or the Horde Princess isn't smart enough to realise what should be obvious," Seacat shot back.

"I could've followed the road on our way in. We would've spotted them that way." The stupid horse had to add their own unwanted comment.

"They probably expected that," she told them. "And we're still at war, so we can't do the expected thing if we can help it."

"But we want to end the war!" Adora complained again.

"Yes. we want it to end, but it hasn't ended yet," Seacat said. "Oh! There they are!" The hulking figure of the bug princess was unmistakable. "There, about two miles ahead."

“Alright. Here we go!” Swift Wind started to descend in a glide.

Seacat pressed her lips together. The moment of truth, as Sea Hawk would call it, was upon them. “Land a little away and to the east of them.”

“Not to the north? Closer to the Whispering Woods?” Adora asked.

Seacat grinned. “They would expect that.”

“Oh, you!”

Seacat was still chuckling when they landed and she slid off the horse. In front of them, the Horde delegation - about fifty soldiers, though they hadn’t brought any guns this time - had turned to face them. “Hah! Caught them on the wrong foot!”

“I’m sure that this will make them more likely to accept our terms,” Adora commented.

Seacat snorted. “They’ll have made their decision already. This is just…”

“Posturing?” Adora asked.

“...being cautious.” Seacat turned to Swift Wind. “And, speaking of being cautious…”

The horse sighed. “Wave if you need me.” He took off again.

Seacat watched him go, then turned to look at the princess approaching them. She was in the company of another Horde scum this time. “Anyone you know?” Seacat asked in a low voice.

Adora shook her head. “No. At least we know she isn’t the leader of the Headhunters.”

“Right.” That didn’t mean much, of course.

Like yesterday, the princess stopped about five yards away. “Princess She-Ra. Seacat.”

While the princess nodded at them, Seacat studied the other woman. Average size. Fit, but not obviously armed. Green hair. About thirty years old. Not a sailor - the skin was too pale for that. And the uniform didn't match the Horde navy. But… she was wearing a Force Captain badge.

"Force Captain Scorpia." Adora returned the greeting, then looked pointedly at the other officer.

"This is Force Captain Emeralda. She's the ranking Healer of the Horde."

Oh? A Healer? Seacat wondered why the woman was present while she nodded at the Horde scum. Perhaps she was the only other Force Captain left with the princess?

"Pleased to meet you," Adora said with a smile.

"The pleasure's all yours, I assure you," Emeralda said with a thin smile.

Oh, one of *those*. Seacat flashed her fangs at her but refrained from commenting about sore losers.

"So…" The princess cleared her throat. "I… we've discussed the proposal you brought to us."

"And you've got a counterproposal." Adora nodded again.

"Yes." The princess cleared her throat again. The Healer's expression didn't change - she kept smiling politely. "As they are, the terms are unacceptable."

"What?" Seacat glared at the princess. "They're very generous! We could crush you!"

"But it would cost you!" the princess shot back. "If you didn't care about your casualties, you wouldn't have proposed terms in the first place!"

The scum was right, of course. But Seacat was sure that in a pinch, the Alliance would gladly crush the Horde, casualties be damned. The war had been going on for over two decades, after all.

“And what is your counterproposal?” Adora asked with her own polite smile.

“Here.” The princess reached into her uniform and pulled out a sheet. She held it out to Adora.

Seacat tensed up, glancing at the stinger looming above them as Adora stepped forward to take the proposal. If the thing so much as twitched...

But it didn’t, and Adora returned to her side before unfolding the sheet. Seacat wanted to read it with her, but someone had to keep an eye on the Horde.

“Ah.” Adora handed the proposal over to her.

“You’ll want to discuss it with the Alliance leadership, I guess,” the princess said.

“That won’t be necessary,” Adora replied.

And now both Horde officers tensed up.

Seacat glanced at the sheet and skimmed it. Same terms as the Alliance offered. Same territory. Pretty much the same, so… Ah. She blinked. “You’re demanding supplies for ten years?” she blurted out. What were they thinking?

“If we don’t get them, we’ll starve,” Emeralda replied. “The Fright Zone cannot sustain our current population. Not for years - most of our agricultural lands were repurposed. We depend on the outer territories for food.”

“Half your troops have already defected,” Seacat shot back.

“I didn’t count them in our *current* population,” the officer retorted.

“So, yeah,” the princess cut in. “If we don’t get supplies, then we’ll fight on. Even if we get killed, it’s better than starving to death.”

She looked serious, Seacat noted. Too serious to be an act for the dumb princess. But that didn’t mean they should feed the Hode for years. “Don’t you have rations for years stockpiled?”

“We did have rations stockpiled, yes,” the princess replied. “Enough to last for years in case of a siege. But *someone* blew them up.”

Oh. Seacat hadn’t been aware of that. Who placed food storage houses next to weapon manufactories, anyway? The Horde, of course.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “We accept your proposal.”

Seacat blinked. So did the princess and the Healer.

“You do?” The princess sounded surprised. “Just like that?”

Seacat wanted to ask the same question. Supplies for ten years for an entire kingdom wasn’t a minor concession.

“Yes.” Adora smiled. “Princess Perfuma will be able to supply you with produce. She might even help with converting your land back to fields.”

Oh.

“And you can speak for her?” the healer asked.

Adora smiled. “I know her. She won’t let anyone starve if she can help them.”

“We’ve invaded her kingdom,” the princess pointed out.

“Yes. But she won’t let you starve,” Adora reassured them.

Seacat nodded. Yes, she couldn’t see the plant princess watch and do nothing while people starved in the neighbourhood. And the other members of the Alliance might not be unhappy if Perfuma was busy helping the Fright Zone instead of driving all other farms out of business.

“So, let’s sign it?” Adora asked, beaming at the other two.

“Err, right.” The Horde princess nodded. “Right now?”

“Yes.”

Seacat watched as a soldier fetched a folding table and both Adora and the princess signed the agreement.

The war was over. At least officially.

It felt weird to see it end like this, with the stroke of a pen, not a blow of a sword. Or a captain surrendering at sword point.

But Seacat wouldn’t complain. She was sick of the war.

*****

The Mission

"Of course I'll help them!" Princess Perfuma nodded enthusiasticall, then shook her head. "We should've anticipated this - in hindsight, it's obvious that the original Horde territory cannot sustain their numbers! I will contact Princess Scorpia at once to ensure that this will be handled!"

Seacat smiled - Adora had been right; Perfuma was willing to help the Horde. Although not everyone shared the princess's enthusiasm, as a quick glance at the others seated around the planning table in Bright Moon showed.

Glimmer was scowling, even though she didn't say anything aloud. But Seacat's ears did pick up the "Horde scum" comment she muttered under her breath. As did Bow, who frowned at the princess. Mermista scoffed and rolled her eyes, clearly showing her opinion. The Captain didn't comment, only nodding at Perfuma's words. Netossa was scowling, Spinnerella shaking her head - tough at her wife, not at Perfuma or Adora. Entrapta...well, she was checking something on her recording device. Princess Frosta tried not to show any reaction, but Seacat didn't miss how she took her cues from Adora and Queen Angella.

And the queen… was showing her usual serious face. "Good," she said. "The bandit problem will be bad enough with all the deserters without adding more to their numbers."

"Exactly, your majesty," Adora said. "If we can keep the Horde remnants fed and contained in the Fright Zone, dealing with the bandits should be much easier. Especially if Scorpia can keep control over the weapon supplies."

Seacat nodded. Bandits with cannon to protect their camps or attack towns with would be harder to root out - or drive into the Crimson Waste, which was more likely.

“That won’t affect their fleet,” Mermista said. “We need to take control over all remaining Horde ships before they turn to piracy. Many of them already have done so in all but name.”

“Won’t they surrender on Scorpia’s orders?” Perfuma asked. “As soon as they hear of the end of the war, that is.”

“They’re already striking at our transport ships whenever they can,” Seacat explained.

“Which, fortunately, isn’t often thanks to our convoys,” Sea Hawk cut in.

Seacat nodded. “But with their home ports blockaded, they will resort to ‘neutral’ and pirate ports anyway. And since they’ve been doing this for some time, I doubt they want to return to the Fright Zone and hire on with a transport.”

“They won’t,” Memrista said. “The Horde sailors are the dregs of the service. Those who survived until now are the exceptions, and they’re basically pirates in uniform already. They will continue to prey on our merchantmen until we can hunt them down and sink them all.”

“Well, without the Horde, they won’t be able to keep their engines going,” Entrapta pointed out. “That should limit them.”

“Pirates don’t need engines to attack transports,” Mermista retorted. “But it means they will have a more difficult time escaping from one of our own frigates,” she conceded. “Still, we’ll probably have to keep convoys going for a while.”

Frosta nodded. “That’s what my naval officers tell me as well.”

Seacat sighed. There would be enough independent merchants who would rather risk a pirate attack than wait for a convoy to be assembled. The lure of the profits if you could beat the competition to port was just too great. “Well, that will be sorted out sooner or later,” she said. “There were pirates around before the war as well.”

“Indeed there were - and some still operate to this day!” Sea Hawk exclaimed. “And compared to the likes of Admiral Scurvy, whom I know well, the Horde sailors shouldn’t prove much of a challenge!”

“That’s not exactly reassuring,” Adora commented with a glance at Seacat.

Seacat shrugged. “It won’t be very different compared to the war. We had to deal with pirates and Horde vessels anyway.”

“But…” Adora trailed off.

Queen Angella cleared her throat. “I think this point has been addressed. The increase in banditry is a more pressing concern since the war kept that under control. Few of the denizens of the Crimson Waste dared to venture into the neighbouring lands when they would risk facing our soldiers or the Horde’s.”

“So keep the soldiers in the field, at least in that area,” Mermista said.

“Many of our allies will want to withdraw their soldiers now that the threat of the Horde has vanished,” Queen Angella replied. “We cannot expect our allies to make the same efforts to deal with bandits threatening our borders as they made to deal with an existential threat to all our countries. Especially if they have problems of their own to deal with.”

“Well, we should!” Glimmer protested. “This is a consequence of the war.”

The queen glanced at her daughter with a slight frown. “It is, but it is limited to our borders, and those of the Fright Zone, mostly.”

And the bandits would know that the Fright Zone didn’t have much to raid.

“It’ll be costly, though,” Bow pointed out.

“Without a doubt, but it’s a cost we can bear. Our soldiers will serve a little longer than planned - but not as long as we feared but a while ago, when we were facing the full might of the Horde.”

Seacat glanced at Adora. This sounded like a mission up her alley, so to speak. Hunting down criminals to protect the innocent. But her lover hadn’t spoken up so far.

Something was up.

*****

Wearing a large shirt and not much else and sprawled on the bed in their quarters - well, Adora’s room, technically - in Bright Moon’s palace, Seacat listened to the cheers and other sounds of celebration outside. The festivities, as Queen Angella called it, hadn’t been officially sanctioned - the official celebration of the peace treaty had been set for a week after the signing of the terms. But the queen hadn’t forbidden her people from partying, either.

Seacat snorted. The queen knew better than to give an order that wouldn’t be obeyed. After decades of war, everyone wanted to celebrate however they could. Hell, most of the princesses present for the formalities of the peace treaty had been celebrating outside earlier. Sea Hawk and Mermista would still be celebrating. Seacat was sure of that.

The only reason Seacat and Adora weren’t out there carousing was that they had a different celebration in mind.

And, Seacat added silently with a frown, she also needed to talk with Adora in private. And without being drunk. Hearing Adora take a shower in the bathroom, humming to herself, Seacat felt a little guilty for the deception. But this needed to be done.

The door to the bathroom swung open, and Adora stepped into the room. Wearing only a very thin, very transparent and very short night shift. Seacat swallowed and felt much more guilty at

the sight. She hadn't known Adora owned something like this. And she was tempted - very tempted - to skip the talk and go straight to the 'ravishing', as Adora called it thanks to those lurid novels she had read. Very, very tempted.

"So… do you need to take a shower too?" Adora asked with a teasing smile as she walked towards Seacat.

When had she learned to sway her hips like that? Seacat swallowed again. "Ah… I'm good. I already took one, remember?"

Adora hummed. "I do." She licked her lips and leaned forward, putting both her hands on the bed and. "So…"

Seacat licked her lips and swallowed. Well, she could always talk to Adora afterwards. Planning to talk instead of celebrating had been a stupid idea, anyway.

*****

Seacat sighed and stared at the ceiling. Well, the canopy above their bed. She was sweaty and exhausted, and she had lost another shirt, but she didn't regret anything. Still… She turned so she was on her belly, on top of her lover, looking at her face. "Hey, Adora."

"Huh?" Adora shifted underneath her and blinked. "Yes?"

"Why didn't you volunteer to hunt down bandits?" Seacat asked.

"Oh."

"Unlike the others, you don't have a realm to rule. And securing the borders against raiders… That sounds like a mission for She-Ra," Seacat went on.

"I guess so?" Adora tried to shrug, which didn't work well since she was lying on her back.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Protecting Etheria, remember?"

“Well, Bandits aren’t the only problem left after the Horde,” Adora said. She looked to the side. “There are also pirates, aren’t there?”

Seacat raised her eyebrows. “You want to go pirate hunting?”

“Well…” Adora but her lower lip. “It seems a pressing problem, what with all the ships we need to, uh, ship stuff around.”

Seacat cocked her head to the side and frowned. That didn’t sound like the Adora she knew. She would’ve expected her lover to have plans ready, with charts and maps. Like she had done for the Princess Prom. So, what was she hiding? “You know, you’ll need a ship to hunt pirates,” she pointed out.

“I know!” Adora pouted, but she was looking at Seacat again. “I, uh, thought, kind of, that, you know, you’d get a ship.”

Oh. Seacat’s eyes widened. OH! She couldn’t help smiling. “You want to hunt pirates with me?”

“Well, if you’re hunting pirates…” Adora looked away. “I mean, it’s just an idea.”

“And what if I don’t want to hunt pirates? If I just want to sail the seas?” Seacat kept looking at Adora and saw her starting to blush.

“Well… that sounds… I haven’t just sailed the seas myself. It sounds… interesting.” Adora was still looking away.

Seacat shifted a little and reached out, cupping her lover’s chin. She felt Adora tense at the touch, then gently turned her lover’s head back until their eyes met again. “Sailing the seas, together? With me?”

Adora swallowed, and her blush grew stronger. “If you want. I mean, you’re Sea Hawk’s first mate, and you have a crew, but…” She bit her lip again. “If there’s a spot free on board…”

Seacat smiled. “There will be. Though I might not be the first mate.”

Adora blinked. “You might not…? But Sea Hawk said you were the best first mate he knew. How could he pick someone else?” She started to scowl. “I will have words with him!”

Seacat laughed. “It’s not that. I was thinking of getting my own ship.”

“Your own ship?”

Seacat nodded. “I don’t think Sea Hawk will return to sail the seas like he did before we got involved in the war.”

“Oh. You think he’ll stay with Mermista?”

“He has been staying with her for a long time by now.”

“Right.” Adora nodded.

“But would you like to leave Glimmer and Bow?” Seacat asked.

“Well, it wouldn’t be forever. We’d visit, wouldn’t we?”

“Of course,” Seacat told her.

“And they… well, they’ve been together for a while. And, well, Glimmer’s the princess. She’s supposed to have kids.”

“Ah.” Seacat didn’t ask if Adora felt like the fifth wheel with her best friends becoming a couple. She didn’t care for the reasons as long as Adora was with her. Would be with her.

*****

“This is great!” Entrapta gushed as they walked through the Whispering Woods. “I’m going to investigate *two* sites with First One’s tech! And with the war ending, I have the time to do research instead of building bombs!”

“Two sites?” Seacat asked, looking around just in case the route wasn’t as safe as they thought. Adora had said she had cleared

the worst monsters a while ago, and they would take time to get replaced, and Bow was scouting ahead, but better safe than sorry.

"Light Hope's bunker, then the Fright Zone!" Entrapta was almost skipping over the forest floor.

"We're going to Light Hope to fix her," Adora said, looking concerned. "Not to, uh, dismantle her."

"Usually, to fix a bot, you have to dismantle them - at least partially," Entrapta retorted. "But don't worry! I can put everything back together. Usually. Sometimes, things are too broken for that."

"Uh…"

"But since Light Hope can communicate and all, I doubt that. The worst that could happen is that she loses some memory banks. Though, in a way, she already lost them, so that's not really making things worse."

Seacat snorted. The bot *claimed* that it had lost parts of its memories.

"And I've learned a lot from Hordak's special bots, too!" Entrapta went on. "It's not First One's tech, but pretty good. So, I'm positive that we can fix your friend."

Seacat suppressed a scowl. The bot wasn't really Adora's friend - not if it was manipulating her.

"You know, I haven't actually thought about what I'll be doing once the war's over," Glimmer said after a moment.

"You didn't?" Adora asked.

"Not really. I grew up with the war. It wasn't as… intense… as it was during the last few years, but it was always present, you know? Ever since Dad…" Glimmer trailed off, and Seacat could see how she set her jaw. "Anyway, there was always some skirmishing

going on, at least. Or raids. People got wounded or killed. And now… It's over."

"But for the bandits," Seacat pointed out.

Glimmer scoffed. "That's not the same. Bandits aren't an army."

"We've heard that many Headhunters refuse to surrender," Adora said.

"Yes. But without support and supplies, they're not a great threat. The people who maintained their skiffs and supplied them with powder, shells and food seem to be sticking with Princess Scorpia for the most part," Glimmer retorted.

"They'll raid for supplies," Adora said.

"That doesn't work well," Seacat countered. "Unless you leave a lot of shells and powder only lightly guarded, they'll start to lose more than they gain if they attack soldiers." And unlike merchantmen and transport ships, trade caravans didn't carry cannons and ammunition.

"They'll raid farms and towns for food, though."

"The border to the Crimson Waste is used to such raids," Glimmer said. "We'll keep a stronger presence there for a year or two, hunt down the worst of the bandits…" She turned and started walking backwards, facing Adora, Seacat and Entrapta. "If we work together, we can take out any bandit group, even former Headhunters. They won't be willing to kill themselves to get us, not any more."

"Ah…" Adora grimaced. "I, ah, wasn't… I was planning to, ah, hunt pirates. kinda."

"Oh." Glimmer blinked. "Ah." To Seacat's surprise, she smiled. "I see."

"You do?" Adora asked. "And you don't mind? I mean…"

Glimmer made a dismissive gesture with her hand. “No, no. It’s OK. As long as you visit regularly.”

“Ah. Of course!” Adora smiled.

Seacat didn’t think that Glimmer was completely fine with Adora’s decision - her smile felt a little forced, and she was too cheery - but as long as Glimmer wouldn’t say anything, Seacat wouldn’t bring it up, either.

“Besides, you won’t leave right away, right? There’s still Light Hope to fix, probably a trip into the Fright Zone to check how the disarming goes - you’re our best expert for the Horde - and Seacat doesn’t have a ship yet.” Glimmer smiled and turned to walk normally, hands behind her head. “It’ll be a while until you’re off to hunt pirates.”

Adora nodded. “Yes. There’s still lots to do!”

Seacat forced herself to keep smiling. Glimmer was correct, after all. They had to ensure that the Horde wasn’t trying to stab them in the back. And Adora - and Seacat - were the most familiar with the Horde. Not counting Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio. The trio knew the Horde as well, but they weren’t She-Ra - if any disgruntled Horde scum took a stab at them, they wouldn’t be able to stomp the attacker into the ground as easily as Adora could. Or Seacat.

And if the bug princess tried anything, Adora and Seacat had better chances to escape if they didn’t have to drag the trio with them.

*****

“Unauthorised intruders detected.”

Seacat tensed and looked at the various entrances into the room as she heard the voice of the bot. If it sent those spider-things in again… She gripped her sword - she really should ask Entrapta for an enhanced one, but it felt like exploiting the princess.

“They’re my friend, and I authorise their presence!” Adora retorted.

Light Hope’s projection appeared before them. “This facility was made for the exclusive use of She-Ra.”

“That means I own it, right? And I say I want my friends here!” Adora huffed.

“They are distractions and potential dangers.”

Seacat shook her head. The bot should’ve known better. Would’ve known better, if it knew Adora at all - Seacat’s lover was too loyal to take such accusations well.

“They are my friends! And they aren’t a danger - they were crucial for defeating the Horde!” Adora protested, as expected.

“Yes!” Glimmer chimed in. “I’m Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon! This is our best friend, Bow! And Princess Entrapta of Dryl! We’re all members of the Princess Alliance!”

“Irrelevant.”

“Irrelevant? You… you…” Glimmer sputtered.

“I think your memory banks are not working properly. And not just because your memory is missing. Are you getting new data?” Entrapta asked.

“My memory is working sufficiently.”

“But you aren’t reacting to new data,” Entrapta protested. “You cannot make any decisions without sufficient data. And how can you gain sufficient data if you aren’t accumulating new data?”

“I have sufficient data.”

“No, you haven’t. You didn’t even know that the war is over.”

“Irrelevant. Etheria remains unbalanced. She-Ra’s duty hasn’t been fulfilled yet.”

“The Horde is defeated,” Adora said. “The war is over. What remains to do? Do you want me to hunt down the bandits and pirates left?”

After a moment, the bot replied: “You need to restore Etheria’s balance. Reconnect the last runestone to re-establish the runestone network to grant you the power of the Heart of Etheria. With that power, you will be able to fulfil your duty and end the war.”

That was new. And Seacat didn’t like it.

“The Heart of Etheria?” Apparently, Adora hadn’t heard that yet, either. “And what war do you mean? We defeated the Horde!”

“Without the power of the Heart of Etheria, you cannot defeat the Horde.”

“But we have defeated them!” Adora blurted out.

“Incorrect. You lack the power to defeat the Horde. That means the war isn’t over.”

“You aren’t listening!” Adra shook her head.

“She’s broken,” Glimmer added with a scowl.

Seacat nodded. And a broken bot couldn’t be trusted. If the bot sent more of its bugs after her…

“We need to fix her. And we need to find out what the Heart of Etheria is,” Entrapta said. “And what it is supposed to do.”

“And what this war Light Hope is talking about is,” Bow chimed in. “This bunker is far older than the Horde. At least a thousand years since its First Ones’ tech.”

“Preferably before the Horde Princess digs out the Black Garnet and connects to it,” Seacat said.

“We need to secure the runestone!” Glimmer said. “We should’ve written that into the treaty!”

Seacat shrugged. “What can they do if we go and take it?”

“We would be going back on our word,” Adora pointed out.

Glimmer sighed. “And the diplomatic consequences wouldn’t be pretty. Some of the smaller kingdoms already claim Bright Moon wants to rule them.”

Politics! Seacat shook her head.

“Then we need to access Light Hope’s memory banks!” Entrapta said, nodding several times. “We need that data to make an informed decision!”

“My memory banks are classified,” Light Hope spoke up. “Such a breach of security would endanger my and She-Ra’s mission.”

“And what is your mission?” Adora tried again.

“To restore balance to Etheria.”

Seacat put her hand on Adora’s arm. “The bot’s useless. Let’s go and check its memories.”

Adora bit her lower lip. “But… those are her memories. It feels… wrong to just take them.”

“We won’t take them - we’ll copy them!” Entrapta wasn’t helping.

“I cannot allow you to threaten my mission by accessing classified information.”

“Light Hope! We’re trying to help you!” Adora exclaimed.

“You can’t accomplish your mission if you lack the data to make any informed decision,” Entrapta chimed in. “You might not even know your actual mission if your memories are incomplete. That’s logical!”

“Irrelevant. My systems are classified.”

“But I’m She-Ra! I have a right to know about my mission.”

“You do not have the authorisation to access my memories.”

“Well, guess we’ll have to do this the hard way,” Seacat said.

“Unauthorised intruders detected.”

“They’re authorised!” Adora repeated herself. “They’re with me.”

“Authorisation overridden by security protocols. Present beings classified as threats to the mission. Counter-measures initiated.”

“We’re trying to help you!” Adora pleaded.

But the hidden entrances were already opening, and the first of the bot’s spider-guards or whatever they were started to charge in.

“She doesn’t want the help - or us around. Or alive!” Seacat spat, drawing her sword.

“Oh, great,” Bow muttered as he let loose one of his trick arrows that exploded in a splash of glue, sticking three of the attackers in place.

“You’ve got to be kidding me!” Glimmer spat, brandishing her staff and moving to cover Bow’s side.

“Oh, those bots are new!”

Seacat muttered a curse of her own and rushed to cover Entrapta. She cut the legs off of the spider-bot charging at Bow, making it fall to the side. Before it hit the ground she used it as a

springboard to jump over two more and land on the bot about to swipe at Entrapta with her sword planted in the bot's brain.

"Light Hope! Stop this!" Adora yelled - but she was wielding her sword, taking out several of the bots with each swing. "This is wrong!"

"The mission has to be protected at all costs."

"What mission?"

Seacat snarled as she stabbed another bot, then grabbed Entrapta's arm. "We need to move to the wall - we can't let them encircle and swarm us!"

"They're already swarming us!" Bow retorted as he fell back towards Seacat and Entrapta, freezing three bots with an ice arrow.

"Die! Die! Die, you bastards!"

Glimmer was smashing bots with her staff - which had to be magic. No normal staff would do so much damage to the armoured bots.

"Glimmer!" Bow yelled.

"I'll be right with you!" she yelled back. "I'll hold them back!"

Seacat had reached the closest wall and pushed Entrapta behind her, brandishing her blade at the half a dozen bots about to attack them.

Here they came! She met the first with a stab through its eye-things, causing it to spark and collapse, then pulled her blade back, turning with the movement, and slashed at the second bot trying to get past her at Entrapta. She swung at its forelimbs, then cut off its head on the backswing as it pulled its legs back. She kept turning, sliding to the side, and stuck her blade into the side of the third bot.

As it screeched to a halt, she twisted the blade, then jumped, dragging the blade up and over the bot, cutting it apart before she landed on another bot, straddling its body. A straight downward cut later, the bot's head was split in two.

Two bots were climbing over the destroyed ones' bodies, though, reaching for Entrapta, who was fending them off with blows from a wrench wielded by her hair while…

"What are you doing?" Seacat yelled as she cut down the first and then the second bot. Entrapta wasn't even looking at the bots - she was staring at her recorder thing.

"I'm trying to find the frequency that Light Hope uses to command the bots. She isn't using verbal commands, so it has to be a signal of sorts."

Seacat didn't quite know what that meant, but she got the gist of it. "You think you can shut them down?"

"Possibly, yes!"

"Do it!" Seacat spat and faced the next wave of bots. She kicked the leading bot back, split the next trying to reach Entrapta… She gasped. "They want to get Entrapta because she can stop them!" she yelled.

Glimmer appeared at her side, staff smashing into another bot, and a net tangled up two more. "Bow!"

"Coming!" Bow hit a bot in the head with his bow, then slid under it - all the way to Glimmer and Seacat.

How the… Oh! He had used one of his ice arrows on the ground. Clever.

But dozens of bots were now swarming them - and… Seacat looked up and cursed again. "They're climbing the walls and ceiling!" This was bad. Very bad. "Entrapta?"

"I'm working, I'm working. This is First One tech, no doubt!"

The first bot dropped from the ceiling, Glimmer swatting it away with a two-handed swing from her staff, but more and more climbed into position.

And Seacat was busy cutting down the ones attacking on the ground while more were circling around them climbing the walls.

Then a lance of light or magic smashed into the bots in front of them, sending them into the wall to Seacat's left and shattering their bodies and limbs.

Another lance swept across the ceiling, cutting through the bots there, and Seacat ducked, hunching over Entrapta, as parts and pieces fell down.

"Almost!" the princess said, her hair forming a shield over them.

"Glimmer!"

"I'm OK!"

"No, you aren't!"

Seacat whirled, stabbing another bot as Bow pulled a bleeding Glimmer back to the wall, before she kicked half of a bot into the way of another. The bot stumbled, and she dispatched it with a cut across the 'eyes'.

"STOP THIS!" And there came Adora, literally cutting her way through the swarm, smashing the bots left and right. "Stop this!"

A moment later, the bots froze, then collapsed.

"Light Hope?" Adora asked, a smile starting to appear on her face.

"Alright!" Entrapta chirped. "I've blocked the signal!"

Seeing Adora's face all as she realised that Light Hope hadn't stopped attacking them but had been stopped made Seacat hate

the broken bot even more.

“Alright. I think I disabled all defence options,” Entrapta announced as she stood and slid her goggles back up so they rested on her forehead. “Now we can examine Light Hope’s memory banks!”

“Good.” Adora nodded, though she still looked hurt. And not in the physical sense.

Seacat reached out and squeezed Adora’s hand. In return, she saw her lover smile for a moment. Good.

“So… where are the memory banks?” Entrapta looked around.

“I don’t…” Adora started to say, but the princess took off before she could finish.

“I think they have to be in this direction - the power lines in the walls are all wrong for another room!” Entrapta announced. “Let’s see…” She flipped her visor down and connected her recorder to it.

“What are you doing?” Bow asked after he finished bandaging Glimmer’s side.

“Scanning the walls. I linked my detector to my mask, see?” She pulled it off and held it out to Bow.

All Seacat saw from her position were a few glowing crystals around the slit, but Bow nodded, whistling under his breath. So, it must be impressive - if you were a princess or Bow.

Though since Adora and Glimmer looked more lost than impressed, it was probably just Bow who found it impressive.

Entrapta pulled the visor on again, then started pointing her device at the walls and the consoles in the room. “Oh.” She moved around a little, then bent down next to the wreck of a guard bot thing and touched it with her device. “It seems that the

residual power - or some alloy used in the construction of the guard bots - affects my detector. First One Tech is great! She beamed, then frowned. “Although it’s not so great for finding the memory banks…”

“Don’t worry!” Adora said. “I’ll have the room cleared in a moment!”

She proceeded to push, kick and carry the bots’ remains into the chamber from which they had come.

“Should we help?” Glimmer asked.

“She’s much stronger than both of us together,” Seacat replied. And Glimmer was wounded, damn it! She should be resting! “And doing something makes waiting easier for her.” And would keep her mind off the fact that the bot had betrayed her. Speaking of… “Where’s Light Hope?” She hadn’t seen the bot’s projection since the guard bots had swarmed them.

“Did you turn her off?” Adora asked.

“What?” Entrapta turned towards them. “No. She must have switched off the projection display. Although she’s still here - well, here somewhere.” She turned around, gesturing at everything. “Probably not there, though,” she added, pointing at the hallway stuffed full of broken bots.

Seacat clenched her teeth. She would’ve expected the bot to try its best to talk Adora around, not… disappear like this. “Are there more of those guards around?” she asked.

“Not according to my detector, but I didn’t notice the other guards until they activated,” the princess replied, already focusing on her device again.

That wasn’t very reassuring, and Seacat wasn’t the only one looking over her shoulder as she walked over to Entrapta.

“I don’t like this,” Glimmer mumbled.

“We’ve got it under control,” Bow told her. “Light Hope lost her bots. If she had more, she would’ve sent them against us.”

“But she might have traps left,” Seacat reminded him.

“First One traps!” Entrapta sounded as if she would love walking into one.

Seacat exchanged a glance with Adora, and both moved to Entrapta’s side. Just in case.

“I think Light Hope’s core is behind this wall,” Entrapta said, pointing ahead. “But I don’t know yet how to get to her. The First Ones could build excellent secret passages. Much better than the secret passages in my home.”

Seacat scowled. Life would probably be much easier if the First Ones hadn’t been so good at building stuff. Or everything. Though if they hadn’t been, then Adora would probably not be She-Ra. And that meant she probably wouldn’t… Seacat shook her head. No! Adora would’ve left the Horde, She-Ra or not She-Ra.

She nodded firmly and ignored the glance from Adora. “So… we can either look for a secret passage… or we can make a door.”

“Good idea!” Glimmer, predictably, was all in favour of the quick solution.

Adora nodded as well, drawing her sword. “I should be able to cut through the wall.”

“Uh, guys?” Bow shook his head. “We don’t want to blindly cut a hole in the wall. What if Light Hope’s memory banks and control units are right at the wall?

Adora gasped. “You’re right! We can’t just cut a hole!”

“Yes, we totally can!” Entrapta disagreed. “We just need to check beforehand!”

“And how do we do that?” Adora asked?

“We drill a hole in the wall at the ceiling!” Entrapta replied. “That should be safe. At worst, we’ll hit some cooling pipe or something. But the First Ones didn’t really use such a system - they were too advanced for that!”

“And their bot still broke down,” Seacat said.

“After a thousand years! Although she could’ve been turned off to save power for most of the time and only activated when Adora entered.” Entrapta pouted. “It’s hard to say without examining the control unit. But the First Ones definitely had the sturdiness to last so long!”

Adora cleared her throat. “Uh, so what about checking for Light Hope’s memories?”

“Right! Let me get my special drill!” Entrapa pulled another device out of her tool belt, then looked up. “Hm. I need a lift…”

“Hop on my shoulders,” Adora offered at once.

“Alright!”

Seacat frowned - just a little - as she watched Entrapta climb on Adora’s shoulders and have her hair hold the drill to the wall.

And she winced, holding her hands over her ears when the drill started turning and a horrible noise filled the room. “What the…?”

“My ears!” Glimmer followed her example, though her ears were easier to cover.

Adora was clenching her teeth but didn’t move her hands from Entrpata’s legs, holding the princess stable on her shoulders. And Bow…

...was digging some clay out of his pocket?

“Use that for your ears!” he said, offering some to Glimmer.

“Good idea!” Glimmer smiled and stuffed some in her ears. Bow moved towards Seacat, but she glared at him. Putting clay into her ears? “First, you don’t have enough clay. Second, you know what this does to fur?”

Bow winced and went to help Adora out.

Entrapta had some gimmick protecting her ears, as it turned out. Or she was deaf to the noise.

After a few very, very nasty minutes, the noise finally ended, and Entrapta used some mirrors to check the hole, then some more mirrors and her hair to check the room on the other side. “Alright! It looks clear about… two and one-third yards to my left!”

Bow moved to the wall. “Here?”

“One step to the right… yes!” Entrapta retracted her mirrors and jumped off Adora’s shoulders, her hair cushioning her landing. “Let’s cut our way into Light Hope’s control room!”

Adora drew her sword again and eyed the wall, which Bow had marked. “OK… I can do this!”

With a yell, she slashed at the wall, quickly cutting a hole into it, which she then widened with her sword.

In the light from Entrapta’s lamps, they could see a room full of consoles and what looked like shelves full of crystals. No, dividers made of crystals. And lots of lines.

Entrapta tried to rush in, but Seacat held her back, and Adora entered first. Seacat clenched her teeth. If there was a trap, she would personally wreck Light Hope’s control unit with a hammer. Or her claws.

But there was no trap.

“Looks safe,” Adora said, using her sword to shine more light on the room’s interior.

Then a new light appeared in the middle, forming Light Hope’s projection. “Adora! Stop! You’re endangering the mission! You’re endangering me! This room is off-limits to everyone except for certified workers!”

“I can repair you! Don’t worry!” Entrapta exclaimed as she wriggled out of Seacat’s grip and entered. “You’ll be as good as new in no time! Oh! Look at the crystal matrices!”

“Adora! Please, don’t do this! Mara died for this!”

Seacat scoffed as she followed Entrapta and joined Adora. “You don’t even remember.”

“I remember. I remember that this will endanger your mission. Please, Adora!”

Adora clenched her teeth, Seacat noticed. The damn bot was getting to her. She hugged her lover. “She’s talking like this because she’s broken. Let Entrapta fix her.”

Adora nodded - although slowly. And she was still tense.

Seacat sighed. This was all Light Hope’s fault.

“Oh, look, Bow! These must be the memory banks!”

“How do you know this?”

“Look at the array here!”

“Oh, yes. That would be…”

“...linked to the sensors in every room.”

“Adora! Please! Stop them!”

“Shut up, Light Hope!” Glimmer blurted out. “You had your chance to let us do this peacefully and with your cooperation.”

“Adora, please!”

“It’s for your own good,” Adora said, turning away.

Seacat glared at the bot, then followed Adora.

*****

“It’ll be OK,” Seacat, sitting in Adora’ lap, said in the main room, where, apparently, a stray shot or blow had wrecked Light Hope’s projector earlier.

“I know,” Adora replied - but she was still tense.

Glimmer grunted - she was lying on a console, apparently trying to take a nap. Well, she was wounded!

That was actually a good idea, in Seacat’s opinion. Bow and Entrapta were still working in the control room or whatever it was called. And it had been hours! A nap in Adora’s lap sounded great.

But just as she was moving to a more comfortable position, Entrapta appeared in the hole in the wall.

“So… I have good news and bad news.”

Entrapta looked… nervous. Concerned. She was biting her lower lip and not looking at them. Seacat hadn’t seen her like this since… She’d never seen her like this. The princess was looking almost… desperate. And guilty.

“What is the good news?” Adora said, jumping up with Seacat in her arms.

“Hey!” Seacat protested as she wriggled out of her lover’s arms and jumped down to the floor.

“The good news is that I managed to decrypt the memory system!” Entrapta announced. “We now have full access to Light Hope’s memories!”

“And… and the bad news?” Adora asked.

Entrapta grimaced. “We looked at the memories to test our access. And how to search them. And…” She trailed off and took a deep breath. “And, apparently, your duty is to destroy Etheria.”

Adora froze.

“What?”

*****

The Horde's Remains

"My duty is… to destroy Etheria?" Standing before the hole leading to Light Hope's control unit room, Adora sounded shocked. No, she was shocked, Seacat knew. "But… She-Ra's duty is to protect the planet. Protect, not destroy!" Adora shook her head slowly, her lips moving without making a sound for a second. "This makes no sense!"

"Uh, well… that's what the memory says," Bow said, glancing at Entrapta before focusing on Adora. "But that only means that this is what Light Hope thinks, not that it is, ah, true."

"But Light Hope taught me everything about being She-Ra!" Adora protested. "This can't be true! Someone must have manipulated her!"

Seacat pressed her lips together. The bot was the one manipulating Adora. But saying that right now… Adora wouldn't take it well.

"Well, I can check if the memories were manipulated… I think," Entrapta said. Adora stared at her. "And I'm going to get right on it! Come on, Bow!" Her hair grabbed the yelping Bow, and the two disappeared into the control unit room again.

"Wait…" Glimmer blinked, then looked at Adora. "Adora?"

"This can't be true!" Adora said. "She-Ra is the protector of Etheria!"

"Yes, she is," Seacat told her, reaching out to grab her hand. "And we'll find out the truth, trust me." She smiled, even though she feared that the truth wouldn't be… comforting.

"If She-Ra's duty was to destroy Ehteria, why hasn't it happened already?" Glimmer said.

“Mara died,” Adora said. “My predecessor. A thousand years ago. She died before she could fulfil her duty.” She blinked. “That’s what… Light Hope told me…”

“That was your predecessor,” Glimmer said. “But there were She-Ras before her. Seacat looked at her with a frown, and she went on: “I read up on the legends. The details vary, but there were at least a dozen She-Ra’s we know of. If She-Ra’s duty was to destroy Etheria, why didn’t they do it?”

“And how are you supposed to destroy Etheria, anyway?” Seacat asked. “You’re powerful, but you could cut the ground all day and you wouldn’t make much headway.”

“The runestones,” Adora said. “Light Hope said she wanted me to restore the balance. That would give me the power to end the war. It has to be the runestone network.”

“Or this Heart of Etheria,” Seacat added.

Bow reappeared in the hole in the wall, shaking off a tendril of Entrapta’s hair. “Yes, that’s it!” he said.

More tendrils reached for him. “Bow! Adora said to look for signs of manipulation!”

“We haven’t even told her everything that we’ve found out yet!” Bow protested. “That’s how She-Ra is supposed to destroy the planet: By harnessing the magic of Etheria through the runestone network. It would destroy the planet, but it would grant her immense power - a whole planet’s magic’s worth.”

Seacat gasped. That was… insane! “But what could she do with all the power if it destroys the planet?”

“Ah… that, we haven’t yet found out,” Bow said.

“Adora said to look for signs of manipulation,” Entrapta said. “So, we’re doing that.”

“Uh… I think I was a little hasty,” Adora admitted. “Best find out what exactly the plan… this plan… is.” She shook her head.

“Yes. We need all the information we can get,” Seacat said. “And we need to make sure that the Horde princess doesn’t connect to the Black Garnet.” If this runestone network was restored before they knew what it could do and how it worked… The whole planet could be destroyed! “And I thought enhanced engine bombs were bad,” she muttered.

“Someone has to travel to the Fright Zone. To secure the runestone,” Glimmer said. “And make sure that Princess Scorpia doesn’t connect to it.”

Seacat nodded. It sounded harsh, but if the whole planet was at stake…

“Uh… do you mean… killing her?” Entrapta asked. “She seemed nice. Kind of.”

“No, not killing,” Glimmer said. “Not unless there’s no other way. But we can bring her here. Show her the memories.” She looked around. “And we need to call my aunt, Castaspella. She’s a sorceress from Mystacor. She can help us analyse this… this whole thing.”

“Right!” Adora nodded. “Swift Wind can fly me to the Fright Zone. I’ll take Scorpia back with me.”

“No,” Seacat said, shaking her head. “You are the only one Light Hope listens to - partially, at least. And you can handle the guard bots here. What if you leave, and Light Hope sends more of those after Entrapta and Bow?”

“But…” Adora deflated. “Right.”

“Exactly,” Glimmer agreed. “You, Entrapta and Bow stay here. I go and get my aunt. And you…” She looked at Seacat.

“I’ll go and get the princess,” Seacat said.

Even though she hadn't any idea how she'd manage that.

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"And yet again, we swoop down onto the Fright Zone, on a mission of utmost importance! Hold on tightly!"

Seacat clenched her teeth and grabbed Swift Wind's mane. She definitely felt less safe than when riding with Adora - though knowing that Adora probably held onto the horse with just her legs might make her reevaluate that.

But that could wait.

They glided in, over the guard post at the entrance to the heart of the Fright Zone, over the… craters filled with plants?

Seacat blinked. Plants didn't grow that… Oh. "Perfuma must have arrived already," she said.

"Really? I didn't fly her down here," Swift Wind replied.

"If she left right after the meeting, she could've made it easily." Seacat frowned. She should've heard about this. Or was that the first sign of the Alliance growing apart?

Someone below them was waving. And pointing at them. "Land near the officer there," she told Swift Wind.

"Alright! Remember: Just call for me, and I shall come for you! Swift as the Wind!"

"Yes," Seacat managed to say while she grimaced. The horse grew worse with every trip.

But they set down next to the Horde officer - no, a sergeant; up close Seacat made out the rank tabs - and she dismounted.

"Halt! What do you want here?"

“I’m Seacat, here to speak to Force Commander Scorpia. It’s urgent,” she told the goatman, ignoring his squad, which started to fan out.

“I wasn’t informed of this,” he replied.

“That’s because it’s urgent,” she told him. “I’m here on a mission for She-Ra and Bright Moon.”

“But…” He trailed off as one of his soldiers, a mothwoman, whispered into his ear. Seacat couldn’t quite make out what the woman said, but the sergeant straightened. “I’ll inform the Force Captain.”

He turned away and started walking. Seacat sighed and looked around for a decent spot to sit down. “Really missing a decent waiting room here,” she muttered.

Fortunately, it didn’t take the bug princess long to arrive - after ten minutes, Seacat could hear her talk. To Perfuma.

A minute later, they rounded the corner, and Seacat stood to greet them. “Force Captain. Perfuma.”

“Seacat! How nice to see you!” Perfuma hugged her before Seacat could decide whether or not she wanted to get hugged.

“Seacat.” The Horde princess’s greeting was much more... curt.

“We’ve been turning the craters into fields. The plants there will be protected from the wind. Drainage is an issue - or would be, if this weren’t a dry region, although more plants could change that, so we had some preliminary work planned. I hoped for some irrigation canals, but that’s for the future. Of course, we still need more produce to secure the food supply, but it’s a very good start!” Perfuma positively gushed.

“Good, good,” Seacat managed to say. A glance at the bug princess told her that she was, apparently, the only one weirded out by this enthusiasm; the Horde leader was beaming. “But I’m

here on an important mission - and I think we should best discuss it in private."

"Oh! Should I leave?" Perfuma asked.

Seacat shook her head. "It concerns you as well." The end of the world concerned everyone, of course, but as a princess connected to a runestone, Perfuma was more directly involved.

"Oh? Is it because I went ahead and travelled to the Fright Zone? We're at peace now, and I couldn't stand the thought of people trusting us going hungry. I did leave enough produce to cover the Alliance's needs, didn't I?"

Seacat didn't know if that was true but nodded anyway. "It's not about, no. We've unearthed a matter of…" She grimaced. "Utmost importance."

"We can talk here. I don't keep secrets from my troops," the bug princess told her.

Seacat pressed her lips together for a moment. "But I do," she told the princess. "And this is about others' secrets as well. So, can we talk without others listening in?"

The bug princess glared at her, but Perfuma nodded. "If it's not our secret to share, then of course. Right?" She smiled at the hulking horde woman.

After a moment, the princess sighed. "I guess so. Let's talk in the field then."

That was fine by Seacat - less chance of an ambush, and Swift Wind could reach her more easily that way. Just in case.

Though she didn't think that was why the bug princess had picked the location. Perhaps the Horde was doing worse than expected, and their meeting rooms were used for quarters?

At least Perfuma was happy - she was caressing the leaves of the plants near the path they walked, and the foliage seemed to double as they passed.

After a short time, the bug princess stopped and turned towards Seacat. “That’s far enough. Talk.”

“Alright,” Seacat said. “We’ve found out a thing about the runestones.” Best tell it straight - neither Perfuma nor the bug princess would appreciate talking around the bush. And she really needed to stop making plant puns in her head. “The runestones form a network that can be used to destroy Etheria if it’s completed.”

“What?” The bug princess was staring at her while Perfuma gasped.

“If you connect with the Black Garnet, it could mean the end of the world,” Seacat explained. “The runestones are connected but incomplete, missing your runestone. But if you complete the network, the gathered power can rip the planet apart.” Or so Entrapta claimed, and Seacat trusted her friend - if anything, Entrapta had a tendency to underestimate explosions.

“That’s impossible!” Perfuma exclaimed. “The runestones are the source of our magic! They aren’t destructive - only what we do with the magic can be destructive!”

“Well, yeah, and it seems that She-Ra can use the entire network,” Seacat retorted. “Or should. But she has no idea how - or how to prevent this from happening. We’re still looking into this. Entrapta and Bow,” she added.

“Oh.” Perfuma blinked. “Are you sure?”

“Entrapta’s sure that the power gathered is enough to wipe out the planet.”

“Oh.”

“How convenient for you that I’m the only princess who can’t connect to her runestone, huh? Everyone else can use their magic.”

Seacat suppressed a wince. The hulking princess was glaring at her. Seacat could take her, even with a normal sword, but it would be a close fight and probably take long enough for reinforcements to arrive. Unless Perfuma intervened. “I know how it looks. But it wasn’t as if you were using the magic, anyway, right? And it’s not as if it’s going to be of any use rebuilding the kingdom, is it?”

The princess’s glare grew worse. Damn. “Do you even know what the runestone grants me?”

“You can throw around lightning bolts, big deal.” Seacat had read up on that, And she had faced Shadow Weaver when the sorceress had been connected to the Black Garnet. “What were you going to do, shock plants into growing faster?” Not her best effort at diplomacy. But the Horde princess had almost killed her once.

“Of course you’d think that,” the princess spat. “But lightning is power - I could replace several of the power plants you destroyed myself!”

“Until they are rebuilt,” Perfuma added. “You can’t really allow yourself to become stuck as a power plant.”

The princess glanced at Perfuma, nodding slowly. “Yes, of course.”

Seacat frowned. Time to switch tactics before this got worse. Adora and the others were counting on her. “Perfuma,” she spoke up. “You know us - you know Adora, Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta. They wouldn’t lie about this.” She shook her head. “This isn’t a trick; the danger is real. Until we’ve solved this, we can’t risk Scorpia connecting to the runestone.”

Perfuma nodded, although a little slowly. But she turned to the bug princess. “Seacat’s right, Scorpia. They wouldn’t lie about this.”

The bug princess's expression softened, but when she glanced at Seacat, the scowl returned in force. "It still sounds very convenient to me that I'm the one who isn't allowed to connect to my runestone."

"That's because you're the only princess who wasn't connected to the network. You're the missing link here," Seacat told her. "If Frosta hadn't connected to her runestone, we would be talking to her."

"Please," Perfuma added. "It's not as if you can connect to it right now anyway, isn't it?"

"We were about to start digging it out," the princess replied.

"Well, have the soldiers dig somewhere else," Seacat muttered, earning her another glare. "There's plenty to do."

"Thanks to you!"

"We were at war!" Seacat shot back.

"But now we're at peace, and we need to trust and work together," Perfuma cut in.

"And how long will this take? Months? Years?" the Horde princess asked with a suspicious expression.

"We're working on it," Seacat replied. "And we'll do everything to solve this - no one wants that hanging over our head." Except for Light Hope, apparently.

The princess stared at her, then glanced at the smiling Perfuma. After a long moment, she scoffed. "Alright - but I want to see proof of this danger. I'm not going to do this on the word of a deserter."

Deserter? Seacat snarled. "Shadow Weaver tried to have me killed!"

“Adora was a Force Captain and deserted.”

Oh. Seacat scowled at the bug princess. “And with good reasons!”

“Please!” Perfuma stepped between them, hands out. “We need to work together!”

The Horde princess hesitated a moment, then nodded - with obvious reluctance.

As did Seacat. What did the Horde scum think she was to attack Adora like that?

*****

“You want me to carry you back to Bright Moon?” Swift Wind, for the first time Seacat had met him, sounded less than confident.

“Yes,” Seacat nodded.

“I can’t carry you all.” The horse nodded towards the bug princess, who was staring at him as if she had never seen a talking, flying horse before. “I’d struggle to carry her alone!”

“Don’t be mean,” Perfuma scolded him.

“I’m not mean - I’m telling it like it is,” Swift Wind retorted. “I can only carry so much weight, and she looks like she weighs as much as I do. Or more.”

The bug princess chuckled, scratching the back of her head with one pincer. “I’m a bit on the large side, but that’s normal for my family.”

“Yes,” Perfuma agreed. “And it’s all muscle.”

“And armour.” The princess banged her two pincers together.

Very durable armour, as Seacat knew from experience. “But can you carry at least her?” she asked to get things back on track. The fate of Etheria might depend on this, after all.

Swift Wind eyed the princess. “Probably.”

“Probably?” both the bug princess and Perfuma asked.

“If he can’t, he won’t be able to take off,” Seacat told them. “Scorpia here needs to talk to Entrapta and Adora, so she doesn’t blow up the planet.”

“What?” Swift Wind blurted out.

“Hey! This isn’t my fault! Don’t blame me for this!”

“I’m just reminding you what’s at stake,” Seacat told them. “And if you can carry her then we can defuse this quickly.” And taking the bug princess out of the Fright Zone would keep her away from the runestone as well.

But the bug princess eyed the horse with obvious doubts. “And what if you drop me?”

“I haven’t dropped anyone, ever!” Swift Wind frowned. Or at least it looked like that - horses had weird expressions.

“There’s always a first time.”

Was the princess afraid of heights?

“Can you fly closer to the ground?” Perfuma asked.

Swift Wind hesitated. “Uh. I could. Probably.” There was that word again. “But without using thermals, I’ll have to fly all the way on my own.”

“So, you will be too tired to come fetch us, them,” Seacat said.

“Yes.”

“That’s no problem. I won’t leave anyway,” Perfuma said. “It would look like we kidnapped you, otherwise!”

The bug princess chuckled. “Ah, didn’t think of that, but you’re right. Wait - then you’d look like a hostage!”

Perfuma frowned. “I guess so? But that’s OK. I have a lot to do here, anyway.”

“I don’t like people thinking you’re a hostage.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “And I don’t like Etheria blowing up. Can we get a move on?”

“I need to tell Emeralda about this,” the princess replied. “So she knows what’s going on.”

“Don’t tell her about the runestone,” Seacat said. “Just say we had news about Shadow Weaver, and you want to check in person.”

“I don’t keep secrets from my people,” the princess said with a deep scowl.

“Well, start doing it, then,” Seacat retorted. “This is too dangerous to spread.”

“Please, Scorpia?” Perfuma laid her hands on the princess’s pincer. “Some secrets have to be kept for everyone’s sake.”

After a moment, the huge woman slowly nodded. “I don’t like it, but you’re right.”

Seacat rolled her eyes again. She’d been saying that all along!

*****

Fortunately, it didn’t take the Horde princess long to settle things with her subordinate Force Captain, and less than half an hour later, Seacat watched Swift Wind fly away with the princess on his back. The horse had even stopped complaining about the weight once Perfuma had asked him to.

But seeing the horse struggle to fly, Seacat had a feeling that Swift Wind might walk part of the way to Bright Moon. Or to Adora.

Well, everyone had to make some sacrifices. She hadn't been on a decent ship in far too long.

"If this is a trap…" Emeralda said next to her.

"It's no trap!" Perfuma blurted out.

"So you say."

Seacat sighed. "If we wanted to kidnap Scorpia, we wouldn't need a trap. We could just take her." Really, that should be obvious.

"But we won't since we're no longer at war!" Perfuma frowned at both Seacat and the Horde scum.

"Yes, since we won the war," Seacat agreed. That earned her a scowl from the princess and a scoff from the scum. She shrugged in response. "Just telling it how it is. So, can we stop with the threats now?"

The Force Captain scoffed again and walked off.

"She's really nice if you get to know her," Perfuma said after a moment.

"Who? The Healer or the princess?" Seacat asked.

"Emeralda. But Scorpia is nice too, of course," Perfuma replied. "I've met a number of nice Horde members. It's a tragedy that we were forced to fight a war against them."

Seacat snorted. "A war they started."

"Hordak did that!" Perfuma was frowning again. "His soldiers just did what they were told."

“Some liked doing what they were told,” Seacat corrected her. “And others enthusiastically went beyond that.” Catra had known that, too.

Perfuma looked taken aback. “That’s... “ She shook her head. “What matters is that we’re not at war any more. And that means we need to build trust and friendships to live together.”

Seacat shrugged. As long as the Horde scum didn’t bother her, she would be OK. She didn’t have to visit the Fright Zone. Well, she wouldn’t have to any more once this was settled.

She looked around. Even after the explosions that left huge craters, the scenery still felt familiar. In some warped way. The cadet quarters - barracks - had survived. She could see them from here. Well, the top of the building next to them. Adora and Catra used to climb up there to watch the Fright Zone.

“What are you doing now?” the Horde scum asked.

“Waiting,” Seacat said. Dumb question, really.

“I’m going to be working on converting more fields,” Perfuma said. “They won’t grow by themselves - well, not until we’ve planted the seeds, and a little magic will do them good.”

“More fields? Here?” Seacat asked. That sounded a little… “Are you going to raze more buildings?”

“What?” The Force Captain scoffed. “Of course not. We lack amenities as it is.”

“How so? Half your troops have deserted, and you’ve got tons of buildings left here,” Seacat pointed out.

“Half our troops will be moving back to the Fright Zone, and even before you blew up our headquarters, we didn’t have enough barracks for all of them. We weren’t supposed to house so many troops here - they were meant to be stationed in the outer territories.

What a shame! Seacat suppressed a snigger - they wouldn't have that problem if they hadn't tried to conquer the world and hadn't raised so many troops to begin with. They caused their own problems.

"That's horrible!" Apparently, Perfuma disagreed. "How can we help you? Convert warehouses?"

"We can put up tents in a pinch. It's mostly the food and sanitation that's the problem."

"I can help with the food, at least."

"Only if you can grow pre-cooked produce." The Force Captain snorted.

"Oh. I didn't think of that."

"Your troops can't cook?" Seacat asked.

"We don't have the facilities for so many people. And you don't want the soldiers doing their own cooking - there would be uncontrolled fires everywhere, and the hygiene situation would be terrible. That's why we used so many rations - they were easy to store, distribute and could be eaten without the need to cook anything. But with our stocks almost completely gone..."

"Oh, no!"

"You had us eat those damn rations because you skimped on kitchens?" Seacat blurted out.

The Force Captain stared at her. "Of course. We would never have managed to feed the army through traditional means."

"This is…" Seacat shook her head. "The Alliance manages just fine."

"The Alliance has magic," the Horde scum shot back. "We don't."

Well, not since Shadow Weaver had killed herself trying to hijack the runestone. But Seacat didn't think the witch would have helped anyone with her magic except herself. The mere thought of Shadow Weaver using magic to feed people….

"So, you need more fruits, then. Those can be eaten raw." Perfuma nodded. "I can do that. But I need more space."

"We can convert two of the drill fields," the Horde scum said. "It won't be enough, but it'll help."

"What about storage?" Perfuma asked. "And harvesting?"

"We've got that handled. We have more than enough idle hands."

Seacat shook her head again. "You've got most of your supply troops here. What are they doing if you're still just scraping by?"

"Their organisation was gutted," the Force Captain replied. "They're still rebuilding."

"Bet they are focusing on recreating all the forms:" This time, Seacat chuckled.

But the Horde scum didn't like her joke. "They're working as hard as they can."

Seacat shrugged. "Good for them:"

"Seacat." Perfuma put a hand on her arm. "I know it's hard to forgive, but we must if we want to have a lasting peace."

Seacat snorted in response. That was her business. But Perfuma looked so earnest… She sighed. "Too many memories here."

Perfuma gasped. "Oh, of course! I should've thought of that! I'm so sorry."

"It's not your fault," Seacat told her. "You didn't kidnap me and tried to turn me into a Horde soldier."

“We didn’t kidnap children,” the Force Captain protested with a glare. “We took in orphans. Mostly. Should we have left them to die?”

“Children orphaned in a war you started!” Seacat shot back. “And you could’ve sent them to the Alliance.”

“As if they cared for foreign children.”

“We would’ve cared for them!” Perfuma pointed out.

“Well, you would’ve,” the Horde scum admitted. “But the others?”

“Don’t tell me you did it out of the goodness of your hearts. You needed as many troops as possible,” Seacat cut in. “And we paid the price.” She sneered. “I was a cadet here for a decade - I know how we were raised.”

“We all suffered due to the war. But we need to leave it behind. Not forgotten, never - but we can’t live shackled to our past,” Perfuma said.

Seacat pressed her lips together. “I’ll go take a look around the area,” she said and turned away.

*****

Even after two enhanced engine bombs had gone off and turned a big part of the core area into craters, which Perfuma then turned into lush fields of green somethings, and after the war had ended, the Fright Zone hadn’t changed that much. At least Seacat thought so after a brief walk.

It still felt the same. The buildings, the lighting, the Horde uniforms. The air smelt better, but the stench from the plants and manufactories still lingered. The stench of the Horde that Catra remembered.

Even the landmarks were the same. Mostly. She recognised most of the buildings Catra used to scale. Both the ones she had

climbed with Adora and the ones that had been exclusively Catra's - spaces she had used to get away from everything, even from Adora. That ledge, barely wide enough for a nap, with that perfect view of the canyon. The sunsets had looked...

Seacat scoffed. This wasn't… She wasn't Catra any more. She wasn't a Horde cadet any more. Hadn't been for years. And her time in the Horde hadn't been a happy time. Except for spending time with Adora, of course, things had sucked. Or worse. Shadow Weaver…

She hissed under her breath. Shadow Weaver was dead. And Seacat had seen her die. Killed by her own greed. The Horde was defeated. The war was over. Seacat was free.

She closed her eyes and took a few deep breaths, then coughed. She was Seacat, the best first mate on all the seas. And she would be the best damn captain on all the seas, soon enough.

"Hey! What are you doing here?"

She looked around. So far, the Horde scum had ignored her. But now… a burly… deerman? In Horde uniform - an officer - was glaring at her.

She sneered. "I'm walking around. Duh."

He didn't take that well. He marched towards her. "Who are you? And how did you get here?"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "The name's Seacat. I'm an envoy from the Alliance."

He stopped, taken aback - but only for a moment. "Anyone could claim that!"

She shrugged. "Feel free to ask Force Captain Emeralda."

"I'm not going to bother the Force Captain for every vagabond strolling around!"

“Well, you should,” she told him with a smirk. “If I’m not an envoy, then I managed to walk past all your guards, and that’s a serious security issue.”

“Or you’re a deserter!”

Seacat rolled her eyes in return. “Please. If I were a deserter, I wouldn’t have changed out of my uniform until I was far away. That’s pretty much common sense.” Not that common sense was common amongst junior officers like that one.

“That sounds like you did it before!”

Oh for… “When I left the Horde, years ago, it was after Shadow Weaver massacred my entire company.” And she only shed her uniform after it had gotten soaked in the sea. Probably - Seacat still didn’t remember that very well.

“What?” Once more, the deerman looked confused but rallied. “So, you *are* a deserter!”

“Technically, yes.” She snorted. “And I’m also an envoy from the Alliance. Are you going to try to do something about it?” She grinned at him. If the idiot tried something, she’d… well, she would tear his uniform to shreds and send him off in his underwear. And scratch him up a bit, as a reminder not to bother her.

She glanced around. They had attracted the attention of a gaggle of Horde scum, but the soldiers didn’t look eager to intervene. Or risk their necks.

“You’re a suspicious… a spy!”

“Attacking an envoy from the Alliance? You really want to die, do you?” She shook her head. “If I don’t kill you, your Force Captain will. Or Scorpia.” She took a step forward. “But it won’t come to that.” She flashed her fangs. “I’ve fought Scorpia barehanded and won. Do you really think you’ve got a chance?” Well, she had

gotten away, which was a victory. And barehanded was a little stretch, but who cared?

“Sir! I recognise her!” one of the troopers suddenly yelled.

“What?” the deerman whirled, and Seacat sighed. Turning your back to an enemy? Just how green was this officer? Had he been a cadet until yesterday?

“I saw her tear through my unit,” the man said. “She’s a princess!”

What? “What?” Seacat glared at the Horde scum. “I’m no princess! I’m a sailor!”

But the soldiers had already started to move away - some outright fled. She turned to the deerman, but the officer was also backing away.

Great.

The Horde scum thought she was a princess.

Seacat shook her head and started to go back to the craters, where Perfuma was probably still growing food for the scum.

*****

“You’re back!” Perfuma put down the plant she had been holding and beamed.

Seacat snorted. “I never left; I just took a tour.”

“Ah.” The princess bit her lower lip. “Did you…” She swallowed. “Did you meet people you knew?”

Seacat shook her head. “It’s been years since I… left. And I didn’t really know many except for Adora, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio.” And all of them had left the Horde.

“Oh. You didn’t know anyone else?”

Seacat didn't roll her eyes; Perfuma meant well. "We didn't meet many other cadets long enough to form friendships. We were Shadow Weaver's pet squad, too - and that didn't make us popular." Not that she'd tell Adora that - her lover would feel guilty.

"Oh." Perfuma wasn't smiling any more. "That sounds lonely."

Seacat shrugged as carelessly as she managed. "We all survived." And that was more, much more, than most other Horde soldiers could say about their training squad.

"But…"

Seacat sighed and put her hand on Perfuma's hand. "It's in the past." She wasn't Catra; she was Seacat. She was past this… past all of this.

Perfuma nodded, but Seacat had the impression that she wasn't convinced. Well, that was her problem. Not Seacat's. Seacat was doing fine. Well, she would be doing fine once they had dealt with this threat to the planet. And speaking of… "Did you hear anything about when Scorpia would be back?"

"Oh, no, I didn't. Swift Wind didn't visit, though he must be tired after carrying Scorpia so far. She's a great person, but she's a little heavy."

"Just a little," Seacat agreed with a cynical smile. The Horde princess was a brute. She could probably throw longboats around as others could throw chairs. Although she'd be great in a bar fight - provided she wouldn't pound everyone into thin paste. The city guards or watch generally didn't like that. "You know," she said. "I would've expected her to serve in the Headhunters." Or lead them - she was a princess, after all.

"Oh, Scorpia wouldn't have fit in," Perfuma said, waving her hand. "She cares too much about others."

Seacat snorted. The bug princess cared so much, she had almost killed Seacat.

“Really! She was shocked when I told her about the bombings of their own troops!” Perfuma insisted.

“Well, that might be true.” The bug princess never struck Seacat as very cunning or a good liar. But it would mean she was very naive. Not a good quality for a leader. Perfuma was similar, but she wasn’t trying to lead the Horde remnants.

“It is true!” Perfuma blurted out, then looked surprised at her own reaction. “I mean, I’ve been working with her. And talking with her.”

For all of two days or so. But Seacat didn’t say that out loud. She would have to ask Glimmer about this, though - if Scorpia turned Perfuma, that would have consequences for the Alliance. It might even break up if the other princesses reacted badly. Or tried to push Perfuma into abandoning the Fright Zone. Seacat wasn’t very close to Perfuma, but she knew that the princess was more stubborn than she seemed at first glance. She might be naive, but she wasn’t a pushover. “But that means some of her subordinates might try to exploit that.”

Perfuma stared at her. Yes, definitely naive.

Seacat shook her head. “I grew up here. I know how many of the Horde think.”

“But Adora would never do that! And Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio seem nice.”

“Yes.” Seacat nodded. “And all of them defected to us, didn’t they?”

“Oh. But Emeralda is also nice.”

Or a good actress. Seacat grunted in response.

“She wouldn’t betray Scorpia!”

“No, she wouldn’t,” Seacat agreed. “She would lose you as well if she did.”

“But…”

“You don’t get promoted to Force Captain for being nice,” Seacat explained. “Scorpia’s a princess. Even without a connection to the Black Garnet, she can fight very, very well.” And she would never have betrayed Hordak. “Adora’s…” Seacat smiled. “Well, you know her.”

“She’s nice!”

“And she’s also the best damn officer the Horde ever had.” Even if she had deserted before her first mission after stumbling upon Glimmer and Bow while doing reconnaissance herself.

Perfuma sighed. “The war’s over. We shouldn’t have to deal with this kind of…” She shook her head.

Seacat shrugged. “It’s still better than being at war. By far.”

The princess perked up. “That is true!”

“Also, did you know the Horde thinks I’m a princess?” Seacat said, grinning.

“Really?”

“Yes.” She chuckled.

“Well… I can understand how they came to that conclusion,” Perfuma said. “You are very…”

“Effective?” Seacat snorted. “Sea Hawk is as good.” Or better, depending on the enemy.

“Do they think he’s a princess as well?”

Seacat blinked. “I didn’t ask. Maybe I should.”

Perfuma nodded.

*****

“And so they’ve been calling me a princess, but not Sea Hawk or Bow?” Seacat stared at Emeralda.

“They obviously aren’t princesses,” the Force Captain replied. “And they don’t have magic powers.”

“I don’t have magic powers, either,” Seacat pointed out.

“Are you sure?” Emeralda narrowed her eyes. “According to what we know, you’ve survived where anyone else would’ve been killed. And you escaped from our special prison.”

“Yes, I’m sure,” Seacat told her. Really, as if she needed magic to defeat the Horde! All she needed was a trusty blade and a ship. Preferably both made by Entrapta.

“And what do they call them?” Perfuma asked. “Bow and Sea Hawk, I mean.”

“We don’t have a special category for them,” Emeralda replied. “Why would we?”

“What about princes?” Perfuma suggested.

“We’ve never had any trouble with princes,” Emeralda told her.

Seacat shook her head. “What about sorcerers?”

“That was Shadow Weaver’s area of expertise. But Mystacor didn’t intervene in the war.”

Perfuma nodded. “They preferred to avoid it.”

“Bloody cowards,” Seacat said. “If we had their support early on…”

“You won anyway,” Emeralda told her with a scoff.

“We lost a lot of people,” Seacat told her.

“So did we.” The woman shrugged. “It’s over now. Beating yourself up over what could’ve been won’t help anyone.”

Perfuma nodded. “Exactly. We have to build trust and understanding to preserve the peace.”

“But we can’t just blindly trust everyone,” Seacat retorted. She certainly wouldn’t trust any sorcerer easily.

“Someone has to start trusting the other.” Perfuma looked firm.

As long as it wasn’t her, Seacat could accept that. “I guess so. Anyway - unless Swiftwind broke a wing carrying Scorpia, he should be back with a message soon.”

“Or with Scorpia,” Emeralda said.

Seacat doubted that the princess would be easily or quickly convinced. Adora was honest to a fault but not the smoothest talker. Glimmer was a little too forceful and stubborn. Bow was too gentle. And Entrapta… She shook her head. No, this would take a while. Probably… She narrowed her eyes, then pulled her telescope out.

“Did you see something?”

Seacat gazed through it, then nodded. “It’s Swift Wind. With Scorpia.”

“Oh.”

They waited in silence as the horse approached. He was visibly straining by the time he touched the ground, Seacat noted. Not collapsing, but… his fur was shiny with sweat.

“Can I get some water?” he asked. “And some oats?”

“Of course!” Perfuma gestured, and a plant grew out of the soil, opening up and presenting water to the horse, followed by a small tree dropping oats.

Seacat was staring at Scorpia, though. The princess looked grim.

“Emeralda. We need guards around the location of the Black Garnet. No one is allowed to touch it until we can move it to the Whispering Forest.”

Oh. Apparently, she had underestimated her friends. And the Horde princess.

*****

The First Ones

"Ca-Seacat!"

"Hey, Adora."

Seacat slid from Swift Wind's back before the horse had touched the ground, jumping a yard down to face her lover.

"You're back!"

And she found herself lifted off her feet and hugged tightly. She-Ra tightly, even though Adora hadn't transformed. Not tight enough so she had trouble breathing, but… "Missed me?"

Her only answer was a deep breath as Adora buried her face in Seacat's mane, which had been freed from her usual ponytail during the flight.

"Bad day?" Seacat whispered.

"The worst. Kind of. No one died, but…" Another sigh.

Damn. Seacat closed her eyes and held on to her lover.

"And I'm back as well. Me, Swift Wind!"

"Welcome back, Swift Wind."

That was Glimmer, standing in the entrance to Light Hope's bunker.

Adora put Seacat down and smiled at Swift Wind. "Thank you. I know we've asked a lot of you…"

"We have a special bond, Adora! I'd do anything for you!"

"And you did. You carried Scorpia from the Fright Zone and back!"

"I would carry the weight of the world for you! Although the princess *was* quite heavy."

The horse looked… well, if he were a normal horse in the Horde, the quartermasters would size him up for dinner.

"Oh, no!" Adora drew her sword, then hesitated for a moment. Seacat saw her clench her teeth before her lover pointed the sword at Swift Wind, and healing magic shot out of the blade's tip.

"Thank you!" Swift Wind pranced a little.

"We've got some oats Bow gathered," Glimmer said, raising a small bucket.

"Oh, you shouldn't have!" Swift Wind claimed - but he was already sticking his mouth into the bucket even before Glimmer managed to set it down.

Seacat shook her head. "So, what's got you so shaken?"

Adora's faint smile faded. "Light Hope's memories."

"Oh?" Were they so bad? Worse than Seacat had thought?

"Yes," Glimmer replied. "We've looked at more of them, and they were…" She shrugged.

"I saw Mara's death," Adora said, brushing a hand over her eyes.

Mara had been the She-Ra before Adora. Seacat cocked her head, silently waiting for her lover to continue.

"She… she sacrificed herself to save Etheria."

"Ah." That didn't sound good. Not at all. That sounded like… Seacat tried to ignore the lump of ice in her stomach and glared at Adora. "I won't let you do that."

"What?" Adora looked confused.

“I won’t let you sacrifice yourself.” Seacat scowled at her.

“Oh, for…! Adora doesn’t have to sacrifice herself!” Glimmer blurted out.

“She doesn’t? Good.” Seacat smiled, relieved.

“As long as we keep Scorpia from connecting to the runestone, we should be safe,” Glimmer explained.

“She’s sending the runestone to you - well, to here,” Seacat told them.

“We know. We showed her the memories,” Adora said. “It was…” She bit her lower lip. “It was bad.”

Seacat hugged her again.

“The First Ones wanted to sacrifice Etheria to win a war against the Horde.”

“The Horde? But wasn’t that a thousand years ago?” Seacat remembered that part.

“Yes. Not our Horde. Well, in a way, it was. They all looked like Hordak - those we saw, at least. In the memories,” Adora went on.

“I’ve never heard of such a Horde,” Seacat said.

“It was on another world. Worlds,” Adora told her. “The First Ones and the Horde’s. They had wrecked their worlds in the war but still fought on. The destruction wrought…” She shook her head. “Anyway, the First Ones were losing. They made their last stand on Eternia.”

“Eternia?”

“A world like Etheria,” Glimmer said.

“But the Horde was pressing them. That was when the First Ones apparently discovered Etheria. And the runestone network. And She-Ra.” Adora pressed her lips together. “And decided to use all that to defeat the Horde. Even if they had to destroy Etheria to do it.”

“They sound worse than the Horde,” Seacat commented. To be willing to murder so many people, destroy a world…

Adora flinched, and Glimmer glared at Seacat.

“What?” Seacat asked. They wouldn’t disagree, would they?

“They were desperate,” Glimmer said. “And…”

“I’m a First One!” Adora blurted out. “I’m from Eternia, not Etheria.”

Oh! Seacat felt like a scumbag. “I’m…”

“Mara sacrificed herself to stop the First Ones, and she was a First One herself,” Glimmer said, interrupting Seacat with a scowl.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “But this…” She raised her sword. “This is a tool of the First Ones. It’s the key to controlling the Heart of Etheria. With this, you can destroy the world. I wasn’t chosen to save Etheria - I was chosen to destroy it. To win a thousand-years-old war.”

Damn. Adora looked like… well, she looked like she had some stupid idea she thought was all noble and necessary. “So?” Seacat shrugged.

Adora blinked. “What, ‘so’? I was chosen to destroy Etheria! I’m a danger to the world!”

“As you were chosen to command the Horde and conquer Etheria for Hordak?” Seacat retorted.

Adora frowned. “That’s… that’s not the same!”

Seacat stepped forward until she was standing right in front of her lover, staring at her. “It’s exactly the same!” she said, crossing her arms. “Someone telling you to do something doesn’t mean you have to do it!”

“But…” Adora started to say something dumb, so Seacat cut her off.

“No buts! You didn’t obey Shadow Weaver, so why should you obey those First Ones?” She scoffed. “You didn’t even know about this, so it’s not your fault, either!”

“I’ve been telling her that,” Glimmer said, scowling as well. “She doesn’t listen to me.”

“She’s stubborn,” Seacat said, nodding.

“Hey!” Adora frowned at both of them.

“Very stubborn,” Glimmer agreed with a sigh. “I hope you can knock some sense into her.”

“I’ll try my best.”

“Hey!”

Seacat shook her head. “It’s not your fault! And do you think that the First Ones can force you to do anything? They haven’t been seen in a thousand years!”

“I’m a First One! I was summoned here!”

Right. She’d said that. “So?” Seacat repeated herself. “Mara was a First One, too, wasn’t she?”

“Yes!”

“And she didn’t obey the First Ones, either, right?” Seacat smiled.

“She sacrificed herself to stop them,” Adora said, looking grim.

Seacat winced and tried to ignore how Glimmer glared at her. “Right. And she stopped it. And the runestone network is broken. So, even if you wanted to, you couldn’t destroy Etheria.”

“But I’m a constant danger! All it takes is one princess connecting to the Black Garnet, and I’m destroying the planet!”

“And that’s why Scorpia agreed that we’ll seal off her runestone so that no one, ever, can connect to it again,” Glimmer cut in. “You’re safe, Adora,” she added in a softer tone.

Seacat nodded in agreement.

Adora shook her head. “I’m not safe. As long as I have the sword, I’m a danger.”

Seacat resisted the urge to hit her. Her lover was being really stupid. “We’re all a danger,” she said. “Entrapta could probably blow up every town on Etheria if she wanted to and had some time to construct her enhanced engine bombs shooting cannon.”

“Rockets,” Glimmer told them. “She said rockets were a better method for delivering bombs, remember?”

Seacat glared at her. So not the point! She turned back to Adora, reaching out to cup her cheek. “Please… it’s not your fault. You’re no danger. You’re safe. We’ll solve this.”

“I don’t feel safe,” Adora replied. But Seacat could feel her leaning into her hand. A little.

“That’s why Castapella is here. We’ll work this out,” Glimmer said. “Together.”

Seacat nodded, even though she didn’t think she could help with all the magic. But someone had to keep Adora from doing something stupid. “Yes.”

And the way Adora smiled, all watery, but still, Seacat felt that she was helping. A little, at least.

“Let’s go inside,” Glimmer said.

“Is it safe?” Seacat asked. She should’ve asked that earlier, actually, now that she thought of it.

“Ah… we’ve, kind of, taken Light Hope apart,” Glimmer said.

And Adora looked guilty again. Why would…

“It’s not your fault,” Seacat told her for the third or fourth time. “The First Ones built her.”

“But she was… is a friend. She taught me so much, and now I hear it was all a lie…”

Seacat wondered, briefly, if she could accidentally step on some of Light Hope’s parts. “Maybe Entrapta can fix her,” she said, forcing herself to smile convincingly.

Adora nodded with another sad smile, though Glimmer rolled her eyes at Seacat behind Adora’s back. Couldn’t fool them all.

“So, Mystacore finally decided to help us save Etheria?” Seacat asked.

“My aunt came as soon as I asked her for help,” Glimmer replied with a frown.

Seacat wanted to ask why Glimmer hadn’t asked sooner for help, say at the start of the war, but they had bigger problems than Mystacore’s cowardice to solve. “And she can help fix the runestones?”

“She’s one of the most skilled sorceresses,” Glimmer said. “At least for the magic part, she’ll be a big help.”

“But this is First One technology,” Adora said. “And not even Entrapta understands it very well.”

And they were dealing with a magic bomb powerful enough to destroy the planet.

Great.

They reached the main room of the bunker. “There you are! We were starting to worry.” A woman in robes with a very faint resemblance to Glimmer greeted them.

“We had to set Adora straight,” Glimmer said. “She was being stupid again.”

“Hey!” Adora protested, but everyone ignored her.

“Castaspella - this is Seacat. Seacat - this is Castaspella, my aunt.”

“The sorceress,” Seacat said, nodding at her.

“The sailor,” the woman replied with a grin.

“You’ve heard of me?” Seacat cocked her head to the side.

“Adora told us a lot about you,” Castaspella said.

“Ah.” Seacat nodded.

“She was worried about you.”

Adora looked down. “You were alone in Horde territory.”

“With Perfuma,” Seacat corrected her.

“I didn’t mean like…” Adora bit her lower lip. “I mean, I wasn’t worried about some betrayal.” Glimmer coughed, and Adora added: “Not much.”

Why would she…? Ah! “I was fine,” Seacat told her. “Not many dared to bother me.”

“‘Not many’? Who bothered you?” Adora asked at once.

“Some fresh officer without experience thought I was a deserter or spy. He ran with his tail between his legs when he was told who I am. Did you know they think I’m a princess?” Seacat snorted.

“A princess? You?” Glimmer blinked. “How could they think that?”

Seacat felt a little irked at the obvious surprise. “I impressed them in the war.”

“Oh! Of course they would think you’re a princess!” Adora said, nodding. “You’re a dangerous woman.”

“Exactly,” Seacat agreed.

“But… you aren’t a princess. You don’t have magic powers or a country,” Glimmer protested.

“The Horde apparently doesn’t care about that, only about how many of them you can kill,” Seacat explained with a shrug.

“That’s actually how the first princesses came to be.” Bow stood in the opening to the control room. “Hi, Seacat.”

“Hi, Bow.” Seacat greeted him. “What was that?”

“Bow!” Glimmer pouted.

He smiled at her but then looked at Seacat. “My dads told me. That’s how princesses got started: They had magic powers and could fight better than anyone else. So, they emerged as leaders, collecting followers. And since such powers were hereditary, they established dynasties. This was in the Archaic Period of Etheria.”

“Not every princess gathered followers like that,” Glimmer objected. “Some built cities for their people. And She-Ra didn’t attract followers.”

“Why not?” Adora asked.

“She was a roaming princess, righting wrongs and protecting everyone,” Glimmer told her.

“And her magic wasn’t hereditary,” Bow added. “After her death, someone else was chosen by her power as She-Ra. So, she couldn’t found a dynasty.”

That made sense. Not many would blindly follow a princess just because she had the same power as her predecessor. Although… Seacat blinked. “Wait. When was that?”

“The first tales of princesses date back to about… five thousand years ago,” Bow said. “Back in the Archaic Period.

“Were the First Ones around already?”

“No, they came later. At the end of the Age of Starlight.” Bow smiled.

“The mythical Age of Starlight.” Seacat snorted. “Back when you supposedly could navigate at night as well as you could during the day since the sky was lit by countless small lights.” Well, before they figured out the moons’ rotations.

“It’s a well-established fact.” Bow sounded a little vexed. “All the old documents that survived agree that it was real.”

“And then someone… extinguished the light?” Seacat was more than a little sceptical.

“Well…” Bow hesitated, then glanced at Adora. Why would he…? Oh, no. “The Age of Starlight ended at the same time, approximately, that Mara died,” Bow said. “We’re still looking for more information in Light Hope’s memory.”

“It’s fascinating to find first-hand knowledge like this about a period shrouded in myth and mystery.” Castaspella smiled. “We might have to rewrite history after this.”

“My dads will be both annoyed and ecstatic,” Bow smiled as well. “They’re historians and have a great collection of First One artefacts.”

“They have? Why didn’t you mention them before? Hi, Seacat!” Entrapta appeared in the hole in the wall. “We might need their knowledge and collection!”

“It’s just murals, broken stuff, and such,” Bow said.

“Those could still hold power,” Entrpata retorted. “First Ones built things to last!”

“Or they could be magical,” Castaspella added. “Many powerful items look harmless or even useless.

“Well, I can see what I can do,” Bow said. He was looking quite… not shifty, but uncomfortable.

“Bow? Is something wrong with your family?” Glimmer asked.

“What? No, nothing’s wrong,” Bow replied. “My dads just have different views of a few things.”

“‘Different views’?” Adora looked interested.

“Nothing important right now,” Bow deflected, “We need to focus on Light Hope and the Heart of Etheria.”

“Yes,” Castaspella agreed. “This takes priority.”

*****

“So… these are Light Hope’s memories?” Seacat asked, looking at a shelf full of crystals in the control room.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times. “Well, they are recordings - which are sort of memories, only we can copy them and watch them, which we can’t with memories. A few are damaged, actually - I haven’t figured out yet how, they don’t seem to have suffered

physical damage, but these crystals are different from the ones I am used to, so… perhaps they decay with age, and Light Hope had no backups, or those decayed as well." She shrugged. "We've got so many things to research!"

Seacat grimaced. "Like the Heart of Etheria threatening to blow up the planet?"

"Yes, that too." Entrapta smiled. "Once we have the Black Garnet here, we'll be able to compare it to runestones with a working connection. That should give us more data!"

"Uh…" Seacat bit her lower lip - lightly. "Shouldn't we bury the Black Garnet as deep as possible so no one will be able to find it and bond with it?" At least that seemed obvious to her.

"Wellllll…." Entrapta pouted. "I guess we could do that, but we wouldn't be able to examine it in that case. And we can't solve a problem without the right data. And we can't get data without doing research - examining things. Like the runestone."

"I offered to seal off my sword," Adora cut in. "But Entrapta and Castaspella said that that wouldn't help."

"Don't you need it to transform?" Seacat asked.

"The war's over. It wouldn't be a big loss." Adora shrugged, but Seacat could tell that she was faking it.

"And people will still get hurt in peacetime," Seacat pointed out.

"I can still fight," Adora said. "Like you, I don't need magic to fight."

Seacat nodded. Adora didn't have claws, though she was a little stronger even when she wasn't a head taller than Seacat. "But magic helps. And you can heal with the sword."

Adora pressed her lips together. "Yes." She looked away.

Seacat cocked her head to the side. “What’s wrong?”

“It feels wrong to use the sword.”

“Oh?” Entrapta moved to Adora’s side, peering at the sword’s scabbard on her back. “How so? Does the magic feel different? Do you feel nauseous? Or is the magic harder to control?”

Adora took a step back. “No! I mean… it works like before. I just…” She sighed. “Knowing that this was meant to control a weapon that will destroy Etheria… It feels bad.”

“Oh.” Entrapta nodded. Then she closed her mouth and shook her head. “I don’t get it!”

“What?” Adora looked confused. Seacat felt confused as well.

“The sword is just a tool,” Entrapta told them. “Like a wrench. Or my recorder. Sure, I could hit someone on the head with my wrench, but that’s on me.”

“But a wrench wasn’t made to kill people,” Seacat pointed out.

“No. A sword was, though - and you can use a sword to cut trees, as you told me!” Entrapta beamed at her. “Actually, that’s a great example. The sword I made for you was made to kill, and could even explode if you pushed the right buttons, but you could use it to cut wood and repair things!” She nodded enthusiastically at Adora. “Like your sword can be used to blow up the planet, stab people - or heal them! See?”

Adora blinked. “Oh. I didn’t think of it like that.” She smiled. “Thank you, Entrapta!”

“No problem!” The princess beamed. “Now we just need to figure out whether or not the sword has a failsafe mechanism that will detonate the planet if it’s not countered.”

Adora froze.

“What?”

*****

Seacat found her outside, sitting on a rock, chin resting on one knee. “Hey, Adora.”

Her lover sighed and looked over her shoulder. “Ca-Seacat.”

She walked over. “I didn’t think I would be of much use in there,” Seacat explained. “I’m not a Techmaster.” Or a princess, like Glimmer.

“Me neither,” Adora said, sighing again.

“Scoot over,” Seacat told her. “I want to sit down as well.”

Adora glanced at her. “But… the rock’s barely big enough for me!”

“So?”

Her lover blinked, then suddenly grinned and reached out to Seacat. A moment later, she was sitting in Adora’s lap.

Seacat snorted as she shifted around to get more comfortable. “Feeling better?”

Adora hesitated. Which told Seacat enough. “It’s not your fault. And you won’t destroy Etheria.”

“I know!” Adora replied. “But I could. If Scorpia connected to her runestone, at least.” She shook her head. “And I don’t know if I could stop it. They’re still examining the whole thing.”

“Well, we stopped the whole plan,” Seacat said. “With the garnet secure, Scorpia can’t connect to it.”

“We think we stopped it. We don’t know anything about the network.”

“We’ll find out. Entrapta is good at that stuff.”

“Yes.” Adora closed her eyes. “I still feel bad.”

“Don’t.”

“I can’t help it.”

Seacat clenched her teeth for a moment, then forced herself to relax. “Well, I can do something about that.”

“What?” Adora looked down at her. Perfect.

Seacat grabbed her head and pulled her in for a kiss.

*****

“Did you have to throw my undershirt away?” Adora complained a little later.

“It was in the way,” Seacat told her as she was putting her own shirt back on. “Be glad I didn’t just rip it off.” Which she would’ve done if they had been in their quarters, where getting a replacement shirt was easy, instead of outside of Light Hope’s bunker.

Adora huffed but kept looking for her top. Which, Seacat knew, had landed on a branch. But her lover didn’t seem to think of looking up. Smirking, she asked: “You forgot all about jungle and forest patrol training, did you?”

Adora stopped and turned towards her. “Patrol training? Oh!” She pouted, then looked up. “Why did you throw it so high?”

“I wasn’t really looking or caring,” Seacat replied as she pulled her leggings on.

Adora sighed, then looked up again. “Can you get it down?”

“It’s your top,” Seacat said.

“You put it up there!”

“Which means you should get it down,” Seacat told her. Adora pouted in response, and she snorted. “Alright, I’ll get it.”

Scaling the tree wasn’t a big deal. Or any deal at all. Her claws easily carried her up, and she grabbed the top and jumped down, landing lightly next to her lover. “Here!” she held it out to Adora. “Though I think I like how you look with just your jacket on.”

That had Adora blushing nicely. “Well, I…”

“Mara dearie?”

“Madame Razz?”

There was the old woman, smiling at them. No, at Adora. “Mara dearie! Did you visit the ghost?”

“The ghost?” Adora didn’t seem to know what Razz was talking about.

“The mean ghost,” the old woman said.

“Light Hope? The bot?” Seacat cocked her head.

“The ghost, yes. She’s mean, Mara dearie.”

“She’s currently… asleep,” Seacat said. Cut off from power, Entrapta had explained, but she would be back if anyone reconnected the power.

“Ghosts don’t sleep. They wait.”

“Well, she can’t talk right now. She’s… Her memories were damaged, and we’re fixing her. My friends, that is,” Adora explained.

“Why would you repair her? You broke her,” the woman told them.

“I did?” Adora blinked.

“Yes, Mara. Did you forget? You broke her before you left.”

“Not you, Mara,” Seacat whispered.

“Mara broke Light Hope?”

“You did, yes. When you found out about the magic.” The old woman nodded, her head almost hitting the shaft of her broom.

“The magic?”

“Of course the magic! Everything is magic, Mara dearie. I told you that the magic’s in you, didn’t I?”

“What magic?”

“Etheria’s magic. I told you when I found you; don’t you remember?”

“Uh…”

“Mara dearie, are you confused?”

If anyone was confused, then it was the old woman, in Seacat’s opinion.

“I’ll bake you a pie. You will remember.” The woman walked past them. “I just need berries…” She walked around a tree.

“Madame Razz!” Adora went after her, then stopped. “Madame Razz?”

Seacat joined her. The old woman had disappeared. No trace of her.

She cursed under her breath. “Did you understand any of that?”

“Uh….”

Seacat snorted. “That’s what I thought.”

“Hey! Did you understand her?”

“She’s your friend, not mine,” Seacat told her.

“But…” Adora trailed off and sighed. “Let’s go tell the others.”

“Tell them what?”

“That my predecessor broke Light Hope before she left.”

“And that’s important how?” Seacat asked.

*****

“The damage was done deliberately? By She-Ra? Fascinating!” Entrapta smiled at them.

“That’s what the old woman said,” Seacat told her. “We don’t know if it’s true. She isn’t fully… you know.”

“She isn’t fully what?” Entrapta asked.

Seacat bit her lower lip. “She is often confused about Mara and Adora.”

“Oh. So, her memory is faulty, too?”

“I don’t think it’s faulty,” Adora retorted. “It’s more like… She mixes up the time. Times.”

“And you think she actually met Mara a thousand years ago?” Glimmer didn’t try to hide that she doubted that claim.

“Madame Razz is one of the oldest people of Etheria,” Castaspella told her. “Though she is…”

“Yes,” Seacat said, nodding.

“Well, it would fit with what we found out - the control unit was sabotaged,” Entrapta said. “That affected her memory banks. But there are signs of repair attempts. Light Hope had limited self-repair capacity, but she couldn’t quite repair the damage. And she was cannibalising herself to get the parts.”

“Cannibalising?” Adora looked a little sick.

“She used parts of her other parts to repair her core parts,” Entrapta explained. “There probably is a priority list, what can be sacrificed to keep the unit able to pursue her prime objective.”

“Which is Etheria’s destruction,” Seacat reminded the others.

“They actually want to destroy another planet; Etheria’s destruction is mostly a side effect,” Entrapta corrected her. “Oh! We also found out more about the Heart of Etheria. It’s the central node for the network.”

“It has long been speculated that there is another runestone, lost or hidden. It seems this isn’t the case,” Castaspella added. “But there is something in this place.”

“And we’re going to find it!” Entrapta cheered.

*****

A little later, Entrapta, Bow and Castaspella were back trying to make sense of the bot’s parts, and Glimmer had teleported back to Bright Moon to inform Queen Angella of the recent developments. Hopefully before she heard the news about the latest agreement with the Horde from someone else.

Well, that was Glimmer’s problem, not Seacat’s. Her problem was Adora, who was standing next to her, leaning against the wall and staring at the others. And probably feeling guilty that she wasn’t some tech expert who could help them.

“So… Mara foiled the First One’s plot,” Seacat said, glancing at Adora.

“Yes.” Adora nodded without taking her eyes off Entrapta.

Seacat pressed her lips together for a moment. Sometimes, Adora really was an idiot. “So, she wasn’t a tool of the First Ones.”

“But…” Adora trailed off and pouted at her.

Seacat grinned in return. “It wasn’t her destiny. She deserted - like you did from the Horde.”

“And she died,” Adora retorted.

Damn. “We don’t know how she died,” Seacat pointed out. Not yet, at least. “But we already have Light Hope dismantled. And we have the runestone network… missing a runestone.”

Adora snorted but at once grew serious again. “We don’t know if that’s enough.”

“Nothing happened for a thousand years,” Seacat said.

“There was no She-Ra for a thousand years.” Adora glanced at the heft of her sword. “The sword wasn’t… being used.”

“But the runestone network was together,” Seacat countered.

“Was it?”

“Hordak arrived what, twenty years ago? I don’t think Scorpia’s family left the Black Garnet untouched since Mara.” Although, now that she thought of it, maybe they should’ve asked the bug princess about that.

“They didn’t,” Adora confirmed. So, they had talked about it. “But…” She shook her head. “We can’t rely on assumptions. This is too dangerous.”

“That’s why we’re going through everything in Light Hope’s memory,” Seacat reminded her. After a moment, she sighed. “And none expects you to help with that.”

“I should’ve studied more.”

She suppressed another sigh. “Do you really think the Horde or Shadow Weaver would’ve let you study First One technology? You

were on the command track."

"I could've insisted. Or studied in my free time."

Seacat blinked. Then scowled and reached over to hit Adora on the back of her head.

"Ouch! Hey!"

"Stop being an idiot!" Seacat spat. "Not everything is your fault - or your duty! No one expects you to do everything and know everything. Other than you, you idiot, and you don't count since you're an idiot."

"Hey!"

"Do you see me feeling guilty that I'm the best sailor around and can't make heads or tails of a bot? No! Because that's fine - others can do it. Much better than I could. Or you."

"I'm fluent in the First One language," Adora told her.

"Then you can translate when needed. Perfect!"

"But I should…"

"No!" Seacat shook her head and stepped into Adora's face. "You shouldn't - you just want to do more."

"Etheria's at stake!"

Were those tears in her eyes? Seacat suppressed the sudden guilt she felt. "Yes. And that's why we're letting the experts work on it. You're an officer! Didn't you learn that in a storm, you have to command, not do everything on deck?"

"Yes, but… I'm also She-Ra."

"She-Ra, who fights better than anyone else and can heal wounds that would kill people."

“Yes!”

Seacat inclined her head and waited.

“I mean… Yes, She-Ra can do that, but that doesn’t mean it’s all I can do. I learned how to command, after all, before I became She-Ra.”

“Yes, you did. And how long did it take you?” Seacat shook her head again.

“That depends on what you consider the first lesson - but I wasn’t working full-time on it. We also had basic training and all sorts of other lessons!” Adora protested.

“And you want to spend all your time on this now?” Seacat glared at her, and Adora tried to take a step back but hit the wall.

“Ah… I mean… not all my time!”

That wasn’t good enough. “So you say. And what if someone needs healing? Or someone makes a mistake, and bandits escape?” Seacat took a half-step forward, looking at Adora while their chests touched. “What about me?”

“Of course I’d heal you!”

Seacat closed her eyes. “Not the point. You can’t sacrifice your entire life serving others. You deserve to live your life, too. You deserve to be happy without feeling guilty for not working every damn day as She-Ra!”

Adora stared at her with her mouth half-open. “But…”

“No buts or I drag you out on a voyage without stopping until we’ve rounded Westcape!” Seacat put her hands on her hips. “You’re a free woman, Adora, not a slave. You deserve to be Adora, not just She-Ra!” Why couldn’t she see that?

“I know!” Adora protested. “But…”

“I said ‘no buts’!” She glared at her lover. “You deserve to love and be loved - no matter if you’re She-Ra or Adora or an idiot.”

“Hey!”

Seacat lowered her head and glared at her.

Adora fidgeted. “I just… it feels… I don’t know.”

“Well, I know. And since you don’t know, listen to someone who does!”

They stared at each other for a moment. Then Seacat reached out, grabbed Adora’s head with both hands and kissed her. Hard. “You deserve this,” she whispered. “And I’ll keep repeating it until you accept it.”

*****

Glimmer appeared in a shower of sparkles in the middle of the main room. Seacat didn’t startle. But she glared at the princess barging in like that.

“Oh, stop it!” Glimmer told her. “You should’ve known better than to do things in the forest next to the bunker!”

“That’s not the point,” Seacat retorted. And the forest had been perfectly fine for that - Seacat could’ve heard anyone approaching before they stumbled upon them. Unless, of course, they teleported in.

“Glimmer?” Adora appeared in the hole leading to the control room. “You’re back!”

“Yes. And I’ve got news. Scorpia’s arriving with the runestone.”

“Already?” Adora cocked her head sideways. “It’s only been three days.”

“Well, if the entire world is in danger, people, even Horde scum, tend to move fast,” Glimmer told her.

Seacat nodded. “It’s still impressive for overland travel of such a huge cargo - digging it out would have taken a while, too.”

“They rigged together a sort of platform on two skiffs,” Glimmer explained.

Seacat blinked. “That worked?”

“Apparently, barely.” Glimmer shrugged. “Didn’t look like they could manage to carry anything else other than the pilot, though.”

“Still impressive,” Seacat said. Entrapta might be interested in improving the idea.

“So, how are things going here?” Glimmer asked.

“I’ve just finished translating a document,” Adora said. “But it was a bust. Unless the Heart of Etheria is related to cooking recipes. Bow liked them, though.”

*Cooking recipes?” Glimmer blinked.

“Apparently, Light Hope also served as some sort of… archive.” Adora shrugged. “There’s lots of stuff there that’s perfectly normal. Clothes, music.”

“Why would they do that?” Seacat asked.

“Perhaps Mara felt homesick?” Glimmer suggested.

“Bow thinks it might’ve been an attempt to preserve their culture, should everything else fail,” Adora said. “Before they realised Etheria had the power to destroy their enemy.”

She didn’t seem to care much about it, Seacat realised.

“That’s great!” Glimmer said, beaming at her. “You can learn all about your home!”

Adora frowned instead of being pleased, though. “I don’t want to! The First Ones wanted to destroy Etheria!”

Seacat pressed lips together. It wasn’t as if it mattered - she was Seacat, and she was happy - but Adora shouldn’t dismiss the opportunity to learn about her home like that. Seacat knew what wondering about our past felt like. Though she also knew what finding out that you were raised in the Horde felt like. “Well, recipes won’t be making anyone destroy the world,” she said.

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “They could be great.”

Adora still looked unconvinced. “We might not even have the ingredients - I can read the names, but I don’t know what they mean.”

“Oh.” Glimmer actually looked disappointed.

Seacat shook her head. “Anyway, where do we store the Black Garnet?”

“In Bright Moon,” Glimmer replied. “It’s safer there than here.”

And no matter how dismantled Light Hope was, Seacat didn’t want the runestone near it. Nor did she want more people to know about this bunker. And they would have to tell more people if they had to transport the runestone here.

“Entrapta and Castaspella might need to examine it,” Adora pointed out.

“I can teleport them back and forth as needed,” Glimmer replied. “And we can always move the runestone here if we have to.” She frowned. “Though the political implications are… divided.”

“Oh?” Seacat raised her eyebrows at the princess.

“Some - Frosta and Mermista, for example - like that we took the runestone from the Horde,” Glimmer explained. “Others are a little

concerned about what seems to be, in their eyes, at least, a grab for more power by Bright Moon."

"Really?" Adora shook her head.

"Well, we can't tell them the real reason we need the runestone secured," Glimmer told her. "Imagine the panic!"

Adora winced, and Seacat nodded. People would go crazy.

"So, we have to ride this out. Mom's on it, anyway."

"And we can work in peace," Adora said.

Seacat nodded in agreement.

*****

"So… we have good news and bad news," Entrapta said.

"Oh?" Seacat looked up from yet another picture of First One architecture. Too bad they hadn't found ship designs so far - she had seen more pictures of food and clothes and buildings than she liked over the last few days. Then she frowned. Entrapta looked… like she had to announce that her calculations had been wrong. And Bow and Castaspella were with her, both looking serious.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded. "So, the good news first: We are pretty sure that we've found a way to disarm the Heart of Etheria."

"You have?" Adora gasped.

"Yes. And without destroying the sword. I think. Not sure about that, but I don't see a reason to destroy the trigger if we can disarm the chamber, so to speak." Entrapta shrugged.

Seacat could see a reason - when your entire world was in danger, you better be thorough in dismantling the threat. Then again, sacrificing the sword might do more harm than good.

“Anyway, that’s the good news. The bad news is that, uh, we might not have as much time to do this as we thought,” Entrapta went on.

Castaspella nodded. “We’ve analysed the runestone network. The magic has been building up over hundreds of years, and unless it’s safely discharged under controlled conditions, it might overload the network. With catastrophic results.”

“Boom!” Entrapta mimed an explosion while Bow nodded.

Seacat stared at them. This was… this was…

“How much time do we have?” Adora asked in a clipped tone.

“Oh… we don’t know exactly,” Entrapta said. “It’s hard to estimate since our data is incomplete, and magic is kinda fuzzy.”

“We merely lack the arcane theories to precisely judge the build-up.” Castaspella frowned at Entrapta. “Magic isn’t fuzzy.”

“Compared to technology, it is!”

“Can we focus on the fact that we’re about to be blown up?” Glimmer asked. “Instead of magical theories?”

“How do we stop this?” Adora stood. “We can stop it, you said.”

“Yes. That’s the good and maybe not so good news,” Entrapta replied. “We kind of need to reach the Heart of Etheria directly.”

“I thought it’s in the middle of the planet,” Seacat said.

“It is - but the First Ones built a control station to access it.”

“Access it?” Adora stared at the princess. “You mean we have to climb down a stairway?”

“No. Well, perhaps there are stairs, but it’s not a physical access to the planet’s core - the control unit for the Heart of Etheria is in that station,” Entrapta explained.

“Why isn’t it here?” Adora asked. “Light Hope is here.”

“I don’t know. Security?” Entrapta shrugged. “But the control unit is there. Probably guarded by another bot. Unless Mara managed to destroy those before she died.”

“That’s where Mara died?” Seacat asked, glancing at Adora.

“As far as we know,” Bow said.

And Adora was straightening. No doubt, she was imagining a noble sacrifice. “I’m going with you all the way,” Seacat whispered. “Wherever that is.”

Adora gaped at her, but before her lover could say anything, Entrapta went on: “So… we have the location of the access point. But it doesn’t match anything on our maps.”

“Where is it?” Seacat asked.

“In the middle of the Southern Sea,” Entrapta told her. “It’s supposed to be an island, but there’s no island on the map.”

The middle of the Southern Sea? Seacat blinked. That sounded like… but that was just a sailor’s tale, wasn’t it?

Adora shook her head. “That has to be... Beast Island.”

*****

Fitting Out

"Beast Island?" Seacat shook her head at Adora. "Beast Island is a myth! A scary story told to Horde cadets so they won't break the rules!" She would know - Catra had lived in fear of being banished to Beast Island by Shadow Weaver for years!

"It's not!" Adora protested.

"I've been sailing the seas for years; I've never heard of anyone discovering the island," Seacat retorted. And she had asked around after Sea Hawk had taken her in.

"But I've heard about it! And Entrapta showed us that there is an island in the Southern Sea!"

"That doesn't mean that it is Beast Island!"

"Excuse me?" Glimmer stepped between them with a frown on her face and her hands on her hips. "What is Beast Island?"

"It's an imaginary island where the worst Horde criminals are sent to die," Seacat told her. "It's populated by giant beasts which will eat them alive - or so the story goes."

"It's real," Adora insisted. "I've seen the records."

"Why would the Horde send anyone to an island to get eaten? They could just kill them! Hang the bodies from a wall as an example!" Seacat shook her head. "That makes no sense."

"You've never heard of an island in the Southern Sea?" Bow asked. "Did anyone explore it fully?"

"There's a part full of reefs and currents strong enough to smash ships on said reefs," Seacat told him. "Ships which venture there don't return."

“Or they don’t return because they end up on Beast Island,” Adora said with a frown. “And the crews get eaten.”

“If the island would cause every ship to get wrecked or sunk, how would the Horde transports return?” Seacat countered.

“Because they know the secret route through the reefs?” Adora tilted her head. “That would allow them to travel to and from the island safely, wouldn’t it?”

Her lover was correct, Seacat had to admit. But she was wrong as well. The Horde sailors weren’t good enough to find such a route. If they were, Salinas would’ve fallen long ago. “And how did they know the safe route?”

“Probably from Fright Zone sailors before the Horde took over,” Castaspella said.

Seacat clenched her teeth. “But why didn’t any sailor know about this island?” She shook her head. “That doesn’t make any sense; if there was a safe path and a hidden island, sailors would’ve known. Stories travel.”

“Unless it was a state secret of the Fright Zone,” Glimmer pointed out. “If the kingdom kept it a secret, then no one but a few, probably the royal family, would’ve known. After Hordak’s takeover, he could’ve just kept it a secret and nothing would’ve changed.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. “That sounds as if you’re talking from experience.”

Glimmer met her eyes. “You don’t expect me to tell you if Bright Moon had a similar secret, do you?”

Seacat glanced at Bow; she wouldn’t expect the princess to tell her, but to Bow? Yet, the man looked surprised - and pensive. So Seacat shook her head. “No, I don’t.”

“That doesn’t mean that there is a secret,” Glimmer was quick to add.

Adora nodded with a stern expression. “Yes. Need to know. The Horde did the same.”

The way Glimmer’s lips twisted, she didn’t like what Adora had just said no matter that Adora had tried to be supportive.

“So… we need to ask Scorpia about the route to this island. After we verify if the island is our destination,” Entrapta spoke up.

“And if it isn’t the same? If they don’t know about an island there?” Seacat asked.

“Uh…” Entrapta pursed her lips. “Then we’ll need to find a way through those reefs!”

“That’s going to be very dangerous,” Seacat reminded her.

“Even with an improved engine? How strong are the currents?” Entrapta asked.

That was a good argument. The engines were brand new - the ships which had been lost had been sailing ships. They couldn’t manoeuvre as well as a ship with an engine. Seacat nodded. “I think that might work.”

“And if it doesn’t work?” Bow asked.

“Then we need a way to survive a sinking,” Seacat said.

“Oh, that shouldn’t be hard! I’ve got an idea!” Entrapta beamed at them.

Seacat had a bad feeling about this. But with the planet at stake, they had no choice - they had to reach this… island. No matter what. “Then we need to go and question Scorpia,” she said.

“We’ll ask her,” Glimmer corrected her. “I doubt that she’ll refuse us - this affects us all.”

Seacat hoped that Glimmer was correct. The Horde princess had handed over her runestone far more easily than Seacat had expected, even though she hadn’t been connected to it, so she hadn’t been using it, anyway. But state secrets? Some people got very weird about secrets. Depending on the secret, of course.

*****

“Beast Island?” The bug princess asked with a big frown on her face.

“Yes,” Adora said.

“No,” Seacat said at the same time. She ignored the eye-rolling from Glimmer. “What we need to know is if you have records about an island hidden in the Southern Sea, amongst reefs and currents.”

“Yes, Beast Island.” The Horde Princess nodded.

Seacat ignored the gloating looks from Glimmer and Adora. “And you know the route there?”

“I think there are records, yes. We didn’t cover that in-depth during Force Captain orientation.”

Ah. Seacat turned her head to look at Adora, whose gloating smile had been replaced by a pout.

“I didn’t go to Force Captain orientation,” she said. “I defected on my first day.”

“Well, you didn’t miss much.” The bug princess shrugged. “It’s supposed to be a secret base, but we lost contact with it long ago. A few ships were sent there to check up on the island, but they were attacked by monsters. Hordak decided it wasn’t worth the troops to retake the island and wrote it off.”

“He wrote off a secret base?” Adora shook her head.

“A secret port in the middle of the Southern Sea!” Seacat shared her lover’s surprise. That could’ve changed the outcome of the naval war - well, not the outcome, but it would’ve probably prolonged the conflict. And if pirates had secured the island… “Who knew the safe route? Are they accounted for?”

“I think so? I didn’t really care about it; I’m shock infantry, not navy,” the bug princess said, touching her pincers together. “And when I got promoted to leader, the whole war was all but over.”

“And we’re all happy about that,” Glimmer cut in. “But abandoning an entire base…”

“It’s not as if there was anything important on it. The island was mainly used as a prison by the Horde. At least that’s what I heard.”

“You had special prisons in the Fright Zone,” Seacat pointed out. She had been held in one, after all.

“Those were built afterwards, I think.”

“Can we go back to talk about the monsters?” Adora asked. “What kind of monsters would drive a Horde garrison from an island? And repel attempts to retake it?”

“Large ones with armour. Sounded like some of the monsters Mom told me about that used to roam the Fright Zone.” The Horde princess frowned. “They kept the borders secure, or so I heard.”

“Great. We’re gonna have to fight guard beasts that beat the Horde,” Seacat commented.

“That’s why it’s called Beast Island,” Adora said, a little smugly.

“But the Horde never sent prisoners there to be eaten,” Seacat countered.

“No. Unless you count the ones sent there before the monsters overran the island,” the bug princess just had to point out.

“Fascinating. Where do you think those beasts came from? Sea monsters?” Entrapta asked. “Perhaps attracted to the island by experiments with the prisoners?”

“There were no experiments on the island,” the bug princess replied. “Not with prisoners or otherwise. Hordak did all the experimenting himself in the Fright Zone.”

“That also means we have no idea what awaits us. Unless we find a survivor from the Horde expeditions,” Seacat said. “Preferably one who can take us through the reefs and currents.” A ship with an engine shouldn’t have too much trouble with the currents - this wasn’t the Maelstrom - but a safe route would be better.

“Well, I’ll ask around. And look in the archives - those that survived you - before we set sail.”

Seacat stared at the Horde princess. “‘We’?”

“It’s part of the Fright Zone - my kingdom.” The princess smiled at her. “Of course I’m going to check.”

Seacat was just finding the words to tell the brute off when Adora nodded. “That’s a good idea. And it was your family’s island.”

“A prison island,” Seacat muttered.

“Beast Island,” Glimmer said.

“The location of the First One’s control station!” Entrapta beamed at them. “This will be great!”

“We’ll need a ship, though,” Seacat pointed out. “A real ship, none of the Horde boats left.”

“With a great engine!” Entrapta agreed.

“So… Fright Zone, then Salineas for a new ship?” Adora asked.

“Bright Moon first,” Glimmer cut in. “Mom needs to know. And the other princesses or they’ll wonder what we’re up to.”

“Of course we’d go first to Bright Moon,” Adora was quick to agree.

“Wow, you don’t trust your allies?” the bug princess shook her head. “That’s a problem the Horde never had.”

“Because you didn’t have any allies,” Glimmer retorted.

“And the Horde lost because Shadow Weave and Hordak fought each other,” Seacat added.

She smiled at the Horde woman’s frown.

*****

Back again in the Fright Zone. Seacat sighed as she looked around. Nothing had changed since her last visit. Well, except for the whole area being much greener than she remembered. And not the kind of green used to paint steel and concrete - there were plants everywhere between the buildings.

“Things changed,” Adora commented next to her.

“Yes,” Seacat agreed.

“Scorpia!” And there came the culprit. Of sorts.

“Perfuma! Is this your work?” The bug princess jumped off the skiff and landed in front of the other princess.

“Yes. Do you like it? I thought it would be a good idea to add more plants, not just crops. They should help cool the area as well, and clean the air! Although if you think it’s a bad thing, then I can make them wither…”

“No, no - it looks nice. And a cooler summer would be nice as well. I can stand the heat, but we have a lot of soldiers who can’t.” The bug princess beamed at Perfuma.

Seacat rolled her eyes.

“Oh! Adora! Seacat! Glimmer! Bow! Entrapta! I’m so sorry I didn’t notice you - I didn’t expect you.”

“It’s OK!” Entrapta told her. “You can’t greet everyone at once!” Nodding, she jumped off the skiff as well, her hair cushioning her landing. “It looks neat! And those plants filter the air?”

Seacat swallowed the sarcastic remark she had been about to make to Perfuma about priorities.

“And the ground - the soil isn’t the best; a lot has been contaminated,” Perfuma explained.

“Oh! Oil? And metal?”

“Yes. You’re familiar with that?”

“Oh, yes. I had the same problem at home when I tried some outdoor experiments.”

“I could give you some saplings which should grow in your country,” Perfuma suggested.

“Oh, I had the whole area sealed off so it wouldn’t leach into the water supply - I would have to remove that, first, and I can’t take the time since we need to get to Beast Island first, to save the planet!”

Seacat pressed her lips together. So much for secrecy. At least none of the Horde soldiers was around, and Perfuma was cleared for this…

“Beast Island?”

“It’s a secret Island with creatures so dangerous, they defeated the Horde and ate everyone present - and a First One installation that will allow us to access the runestone network!”

“The beasts didn’t defeat us - we just didn’t think the island was worth the casualties we’d take,” the bug princess cut in.

“And you’re going to visit the island?” Perfuma sounded shocked.

“Yes!” Entrapta didn’t.

“Once we find out if there are records left in the Horde archives,” Seacat told them. “Which is why we’re here.”

“Oh.” Perfuma looked at them with her mouth half-open, then nodded firmly. “Then I’m coming with you!”

“A-Alright!” the bug princess replied before anyone else could say anything.

“Aren’t you needed here?” Glimmer asked.

“The fields are planted and growing. I could make them grow faster, but that would not help the soil. Though I could spread more plants over the country, that’s not as important as saving the planet, is it?”

Well, if she put it like that… Seacat certainly wouldn’t mind her coming with them. Control over plants might save their lives if those monsters were as bad as they seemed. And Perfuma might also help her keep Adora from doing something stupid.

“To the archives, then!” Entrapta pointed ahead, towards the larger buildings visible.

“Uh, the archives are this way,” the bug princess corrected her, pointing towards a collection of smaller, shabbier buildings.

“To the archives there, then!”

*****

“So… we’ve got a chart for the island, but it’s missing half the information we need because you thought keeping the other half separate was a good idea. And then lost that half.” Seacat sighed.

“Hey! It was Hordak’s order,” the Horde princess tried to defend herself. “And you burned down that part of the archives.”

“You could’ve stopped the fire,” Seacat retorted.

“Half the country was on fire after your bombs,” the princess shot back. “Protecting the archives wasn’t as important as protecting the barracks.”

“Or so it seemed. In hindsight, protecting the archives would’ve been more important.” Entrapta looked up from the blueprints she was studying.

“You couldn’t have known,” Perfuma said, putting her hand on the bug princess’s arm. “And prioritising people over paper is never wrong.”

Except for when it was. But Seacat didn’t say that out loud. “In any case, we need to find out if a sailor from the expeditions survived.”

“Those records were in that half of the archives as well.”

Well, damn.

“We can ask around?” Perfuma suggested.

“That would reveal our destination,” Adora objected. “And a group of princesses travelling together to an island will draw a lot of attention. We don’t exactly want everyone to be aware of the island’s importance.”

“No, we don’t,” Glimmer agreed. “We need a permanent garrison there to protect the First One’s installation.”

"If the monsters are gone, then the Fright Zone will take over the island, as before," the bug princess said.

"Yeah, right," Glimmer blurted out.

As the two princesses glared at each other, Bow spoke up: "Uh… it seems to be too important for any single country."

Perfuma nodded. "And too dangerous."

After a moment, the bug princess sighed. "We lost the war, didn't we?" She shook her head.

Seacat didn't comment. But it was hard not to.

*****

"Salineas ahead!"

Finally! Seacat had to restrain herself from scaling the rigging of the courier that they had commandeered to take them to Salineas. She was only a passenger on this ship, she reminded herself for the umpteenth time. She had to let the crew work. Even though she could do so much better.

Sighing, she leaned against the railing. If the lookout spotted the island, it would soon appear on the horizon.

"You know, it could've been worse," Adora, next to her, said.

Seacat frowned at her lover. "How?"

"We could've taken a Horde ship, as Scorpia had offered."

Seacat glared at her. Sailing on a Horde ship? And one they hadn't taken as a prize? With Horde sailors as crew? "I'd swim before accepting that," she growled.

Adora laughed, reached over and pulled her into a hug. "We know. I don't think anyone in the Fright Zone doesn't know."

Seacat huffed. The Horde princess hadn't been amused, but that was her own fault. Everyone knew the Horde sailors were the dregs of the service. And really, showing up in a Horde ship in Salineas? They would've been escorted anyway, so why bother travelling on a Horde ship? The courier was much faster, anyway.

Adora ruffled her hair, which made Seacat frown even more. "Hey!"

"Sorry."

Adora didn't sound sorry. Nor did she look sorry. But that was a good thing - she had been so sad for most of the trip, despite everything Seacat had tried. She'd let her lover ruffle her hair anytime if it cheered Adora up. "It'll be good to see Sea Hawk and Mermista again," she said, leaning into Adora's side.

"Yes."

And there was the island, a speck on the horizon, quickly growing as the courier raced atop the waves, a favourable wind pushing them on.

*****

"Seacat!" Sea Hawk spread his arms and beamed at her.

"Captain." Seacat managed to nod before she was swept up in a hug and twirled around as if she were still fourteen years old. But it felt good.

Even if Mermista was shaking her head. Well, she was smiling as well before she turned to address the others. "Welcome to Salineas. I assume you didn't just decide to visit us to enjoy the sea," she said, with a pointed look at the bug princess.

"Ah… no." Adora winced. "We kinda have a problem. A big problem. Urgent, too. And secret." She looked around as Sea Hawk set Seacat down.

Mermista frowned, looking at her guards, then back at the others. "Ugh, fine. Guards, leave us!"

The guards filed out of the throne room. "So, what's the latest crisis?" Mermista stared at the bug princess.

"Well…" Adora trailed off.

"We need to stop an old First One device from using the runestone network to blow up Etheria," Entrapta announced.

"What?" Mermista gaped. As did Sea Hawk.

"Yes. And that's why we need a new courier ship with an improved engine so we can travel to Beast Island and stop the whole thing," Seacat added. She flashed Mermista a grin when the princess turned towards her with a scowl.

"I believe I need a bit more of an explanation," the princess said.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. "It all started a thousand years ago when the First Ones created She-Ra's sword for Mara, the She-Ra of the time - and a First One. Because they were fighting a war at the time against the Horde. Only, not our Horde, but a Horde made up of many people like Hordak, and…"

*****

"...and that's why we're here now. Can we get a ship?" Entrapta beamed as she finished her explanation.

Mermista blinked. "So… You plan to use half of a chart to navigate the Southern Sea's reefs to find a safe route to Beast Island, then disable a First One's device to save the planet."

"Yes!" Entrapta said. Seacat nodded, as did the others.

"It's not the best plan," Seacat said, "but our options are kind of limited. We didn't find any survivors from the Horde expeditions. And the other half of the chart was lost."

“When you burned down our archives,” the Horde princess added.

“In retaliation to your aggression,” Mermista retorted.

“Please!” Perfuma stepped up. “Blaming each other won’t help anyone - we need to work together to save the world!”

“Blaming the Horde certainly makes me feel better,” Seacat heard Mermista mumble under her breath, but the princess nodded - with obvious reluctance.

“Indeed! A gallant expedition into the jaws of danger to save the world!” Sea Hawk jumped on the table and raised his fist towards the ceiling. “Huzzah!”

Seacat nodded, then realised the others were staring. “Did you really expect the Captain to stay back?” she asked.

“We’re both coming,” Mermista declared with a scowl that made sure that disagreement wouldn’t be tolerated.

Well, Seacat had expected that as well - she knew the couple, after all. And they would need them - Seacat was a good sailor, one of the best, but the Captain was the best, period. And Mermista… well, she controlled water. That could save their lives and their ship if the current turned out to be too strong. Though, as far as Seacat knew, the Southern Seas didn’t have a Maelstrom.

“Good,” Glimmer said. “But no burning down the ship!”

“Unless it’s needed to save the world!” Sea Hawk retorted.

Well, there wasn’t much anyone could say against that.

“Could we take a frigate?” Adora asked. “You have enough of them, don’t you?”

“I doubt that a frigate can safely travel through the reefs,” Seacat pointed out. “The chart is incomplete, but even so, I can see that

the draft of a frigate would be too deep. Back when the island was first occupied, ships were smaller in general."

"Indeed! What we consider a courier these days would've been a flagship for the fleets of the Ancient Age!" Sea Hawk added. "And our current frigates will, no doubt, one day be outclassed by ships of even greater size!"

"Or airships," the bug princess added. "If someone hadn't wrecked our airship, we could easily travel to the island."

"If you had your airship, you'd be threatening to bomb our lands," Glimmer countered.

"Please!" Perfuma held her hands up again. "I know that the threat of Etheria being destroyed by the runestone network makes us all anxious, but we have to work together. Accusing each other won't help anyone!"

Seacat swallowed her retort - the princess was right, after all. But it was the Horde princess's fault, being a sore loser. "Yeah, yeah," she said. "Let's focus on getting this expedition going. Do you have a fast courier Entrapta could add a new engine to?"

"We actually have a ship being built that would be perfect for this," Mermista said with a grin.

*****

She was a beauty. Slim, sleek lines, a mast that was the highest Seacat had seen for that class of ships… everything about her screamed 'speed'. And she was elegant - Seacat had to take a second look to see the intakes for the engine. They hadn't been tacked on, like with so many other ships, but designed to be part of the ship from the start. And the bridge… the steering wheel was smaller than she was used to but moved the rudder easily, and there were controls for the engine built into a small pedestal next to it - you could run the entire ship by yourself if you had to

“Look, Captain!” she exclaimed, showing the foldable sun covers. “No more sunburn!”

“You get sunburn?” Adora asked, looking up from where she had studied the stairs leading to the main deck.

“Me? Rarely. But the Captain doesn’t have fur covering his skin,” Seacat told her. Neither did Adora, of course.

“Oh.” Adora looked at her arm. “I could heal that, I think.”

Of course she could. Still… “This is a great ship!”

“The latest design.” Mermista sounded smug.

“It’s perfect! Well, mostly!” Entrapta stuck her head through the opening leading to the hold. “It still needs an engine, but I can fit my latest mark in there. I think.”

“We designed the hold with room for expansion,” Mermista explained.

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk beamed at them. “This is a ship built to last - to grow with her captain!”

Seacat nodded. She shouldn’t have expected any less from the Salineans, of course - they did build the best ships in Etheria. Although she couldn’t help wondering - privately, of course - how long Sea Hawk would take to sink the ship.

“Does that even matter?” Glimmer asked. “How long do your ships generally last?”

“Oh, they last as long as they need,” Sea Hawk told her. “But why do you ask? This isn’t my ship.”

“No?”

“It isn’t?” Then a new courier ship for the Navy? Some Salinean captain would be disappointed for losing their ship before it even

was finished, she guessed.

“No, she’s Seacat’s,” Mermista said.

Seacat blinked. That… this… “Mine?” This ship was for her? She was to be her captain?

“Oh, that’s great!” Adora cheered and grabbed Seacat, lifting her up. “Just the kind of ship you wanted, right?”

Seacat nodded, almost absentmindedly. Her own ship. She had expected to get one, of course, but so soon? And such a ship? She had to have cost a fortune, an all-new design, not even counting the new engine…

“You deserve it,” Mermista said with a wide smile. “Consider it compensation for stealing your captain.”

Oh. She had expected that as well, but she hadn’t expected it so soon - or in this manner. To have it confirmed - and with such a beauty! - was… Seacat nodded as Adora set her down. Then she swallowed. “Thank you. Thank you!”

She had a ship. She’d be captain of her own ship!

*****

“So, should I be jealous?”

Seacat looked up from where she had been pouring over the charts in the captain’s locker. Adora was smiling at her, but she seemed a little on edge, too. “What?” Seacat asked.

“Well…” Adora laughed, rubbing the back of her head. “Just wondering if I’m being replaced by a ship.”

Seacat blinked. “What? No!” She chuckled. “How could you think that?”

“Well, you’ve been busy with the ship for hours now.”

She had, hadn't she? "There's a lot of things to be done before we can sail," she said.

"Entrapta is still working on the new engine," Adora pointed out.

"Yes. But the fitting out isn't done yet, anyway - it wouldn't do to set sail and then discover halfway that we're missing an anchor or spare sails and lines."

"Ah." Adora sat down on the bunk. "I didn't realise ships took so much… work."

Seacat snorted. "Landlubbers rarely do. But don't worry, we'll make a sailor out of you yet."

Adora nodded, her smile widening a little.

Seacat frowned. "Was that what you were concerned about?"

"No!" Adora blinked. "Well, a little…" She sighed and ran her hand over the sheets. "I just… I don't get half the stuff you're doing, and it all sounds so important."

"It is important," Seacat told her. "But no one learns everything in a day or two. It takes time to learn how to run a ship. That's why the Horde had so much trouble on the sea - they rushed things."

"You mean it takes years?"

"To become a captain or first mate? Yes." Seacat smiled. "It took me three years until Sea Hawk promoted me."

"Oh." Adora hunched over a little.

"But it doesn't take as long to become a decent sailor," Seacat pointed out. "And it's fun to learn - you're doing it while you're at sea. Not on a field or in the training hall."

"Hey! The exercises were fun. Kinda," Adora protested.

“Sometimes,” Seacat said. “But I could’ve done without all the tests and forms.” And without the ‘debriefings’ by Shadow Weaver.

“Paperwork moves an army,” Adora quoted one of their instructors

Seacat didn’t remember who had said it. “Or slows it down.” She shrugged. “Anyway, the Salineans know how to build and outfit ships. I’m mostly checking that everything’s in order.” She wouldn’t allow the first ship of her own to be anything but perfect when setting sails. The embarrassment in front of the Captain would be too much!

“And is it?”

She snorted. “We’re working on it. The charts seem up to date and in order, though we’re still missing the cannons.”

“Cannons?”

“Two swivel guns. One at the bow, one aft.” Double the guns of an average courier vessel. Not enough to threaten a sloop, much less a frigate, but they would come in handy if they encountered anything smaller. And they could outrun any sloop or frigate.

“Oh.”

“Then there’s the food to be stored, spare lines, spare parts - both for the ship and the engine - and hammocks for the crew and passengers…”

“We’re sleeping in hammocks?”

“Most sailors do,” Seacat said. Adora should know that.

Adora pointedly looked at the bunk upon which she was sitting.

Seacat laughed. “Well, that’s for the captain - and her lover.”

Adora blushed in return. “So, no hammock for me?”

“Nope!”

“Glimmer will be jealous.”

“We can probably rig some makeshift cabins in the hold,” Seacat said. “Unless they want to sleep on deck - which many sailors do when sailing the Southern Seas.”

“Oh?”

“It’s going to be hot,” Seacat explained. “So, most want fresh air and a breeze instead of sticking to the hold.”

“Most?” Adora raised her eyebrows.

“Some prefer the privacy the hold might offer.”

And the blush grew worse. Seacat grinned.

“Uh… we’ll be crowded, won’t we be? You, me, Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, Scorpia, Perfuma, Mermista and Sea Hawk…” Adora ticked off finger after finger.

“And Alcy, Licy and Horas. My crew,” Seacat added.

“Right. Eleven people.” Adora frowned. “We’ll be really crowded!”

Seacat laughed again. “A frigate is worse. Much worse. Hundreds of people on a single ship.” Sure, a frigate was larger, but not that much larger. “And in a pinch, we’ll be glad about having so many people with us.”

They were sailing for Beast Island, after all.

“Ah. Still…” Adora knocked on the cabin’s wall. “The walls aren’t too thick.”

Seacat laughed once more. “Oh, you learn to ignore that, at sea.” She stepped over to Adora. “Besides, the walls are thicker than a tent’s, aren’t they?”

Adora’s blush returned, even stronger, as she was reminded of that trip. “Uh…”

Seacat slid into her lap, then pushed her down on the bunk, straddling her while Adora ended up on her back, staring up at her.

“Ah. Aren’t you busy preparing the ship?” Adora asked, though her tongue was wetting her lips.

“I’m about to test if the captain’s bunk is adequately constructed,” Seacat said. “And I need your help with that important task.”

Adora was, as expected, good at that task. Very good.

*****

“Licy! Alcy! Horas!” Seacat beamed at the crew - her crew! - when they approached the ship and came onboard.

“Seacat! I mean, Captain!” Licy saluted - a little sloppily, but it was an earnest attempt; Seacat could tell.

“Captain.” Alcy nodded at her.

Horas grumbled something that passed for a greeting.

“So you’ve heard the news,” Seacat said.

“That Mermista gave you a ship as a reward for your services during the war? Yes,” Alcy said.

“And as a wedding gift for you and Adora!” Licy added with a wide smile.

Alcy rolled her eyes at that. “That’s a silly rumour. We would’ve heard about a royal wedding being prepared. Sea Hawk wouldn’t have been able to keep it a secret.”

“It’s still a nice rumour,” Licy retorted, looking around. “Where is she, by the way?”

“She’s fetching some supplies. Putting that great strength of hers to use,” Seacat said with a grin. Though privately, she wondered -

a wedding? Adora and her? That was… She hadn't considered that. She hadn't even considered whether Sea Hawk and Mermista would marry. The Captain had never talked about marriage. But wouldn't they have to marry, so the children would be legitimate? Or would the magic powers prove that?

She pushed the thoughts away; there was no need to worry about that when the world's fate was in danger. "She's not a wedding gift," she told them. "But she would be a worthy gift. Look around - isn't she a beauty!"

Licy nodded eagerly. "Oh, yes! I bet she's the fastest ship on all the seas."

"She will be - once Entrapta delivers and installs the engine," Seacat replied.

"Oh! Is it true that all the princesses came here to attend the ship's maiden voyage?" Licy asked.

Seacat pressed her lips together and looked around. No yard worker was around. "In a manner of speaking," she told them.

Alcy sighed. "I guess this isn't a shakedown cruise with royal guests."

Seacat shook her head. "Not exactly. Don't tell anyone, but we're on a mission to save Etheria."

"Etheria? I thought the war was over! Isn't the Horde princess now an ally?" Licy blurted out.

"She's an ally of sorts, yes," Seacat confirmed. "The threat to Etheria isn't the Horde's fault." Well, not directly. "It dates back to the First Ones. And their magic experiments."

Alcy looked even grimmer. "I take it that 'saving Etheria' isn't hyperbole.

Seacat shook her head. “No. We’re literally going on a mission to save the entire world from blowing up.”

Alcy cursed under her breath, Horas growled, and Licy gaped at her, her mouth opening and closing without making a sound.

Perhaps Seacat should’ve said this a little less bluntly.

*****

“Say, Ca-Seacat,” Adora said as the sun was setting and a stevedore delivered another bag of powder for the still missing swivel guns.

“Yes?” Seacat replied, leaning with her back against the railing and watching Alcy, Licy and Horas check the mainsail.

“What are you going to name her?”

Oh. Seacat smiled. “Victory’s Daughter!” It was the perfect name!

“Oh. That’s… a nice name.”

But Adora didn’t sound very enthusiastic. “What’s wrong with it?” Seacat asked with a frown. It honoured both the Captain and the outcome of the war.

“Well… it reminds me of the Dragon’s Daughter,” Adora said, fidgeting with her hands.

“That’s the point,” Seacat told her.

“But isn’t that unlucky?” Adora cocked her head sideways. “I’ve been reading those sailor stories again…”

“You have?” Seacat grinned, showing her teeth, as Adora blushed.

“Yes. And they said picking names of sunken ships was unlucky. Well, one of the characters said that.”

Seacat scoffed. “Those books were written by landlubbers. Would Sea Hawk have named his ships Dragon’s Daughter if that was attracting bad luck?”

Adora winced. “Well, they all sank…”

Seacat frowned at her. “They were sunk, which is a difference. Victory’s Daughter won’t sink!” She wouldn’t let her. And she wouldn’t let the Captain sink her.

Unless, a voice whispered in the back of her mind, it was needed to save the world. Or Adora.

“Are you sure?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Seacat nodded firmly. “She won’t sink.”

“And she won’t burn down, blow up, get stuck on a reef?”

She narrowed her eyes at her lover. “Just how many of those stories did you read?”

“Uh…” Adora bit her lower lip in that cute manner of hers and twirled her fingers. “All of them? I mean, all of them that I could find? I wanted to learn more about sailing!”

“Didn’t we get you real sailing books?” Seacat asked.

Adora hunched her shoulders a little. “I also was… well…” She blushed again.

Seacat smiled as she shook her head. Her lover was too cute like that.

She hesitated a moment, then took a step and leaned into Adora’s side with a contented sigh. “Did you know that there’s a rumour that she’s a wedding gift for us?”

“What?” Adora pulled away. “A wedding gift? For us?” she blurted out.

Seacat nodded. “That’s what some people say. It’s a good cover, I think, for our mission.”

“Really? But…” Adora swallowed. “A wedding?”

“A wedding gift.” Seacat snorted. “Don’t worry, we don’t have to marry for our cover.”

“Oh.”

Did Adora sound disappointed? It seemed so. At least to Seacat. She licked her lips, then added in a lower voice: “If we marry, it won’t be for a mission or because others say we have to. It’ll be for us.”

Adora made a strange sound, and Seacat found herself lifted up and hugged.

It was entirely unfitting for a captain on board her own ship.

Seacat didn’t mind.

*****

“Give it another try!” Entrapta’s voice sounded up through the small pipe leading from the bridge down to the hold - a speaking tube, she called it. “I think I’ve worked out all the problems now!”

Seacat took a deep breath. She trusted the princess, she really did, but… hearing about things like ‘this should prevent the engine from tearing up the ship, now’ wasn’t really comforting. And yet… No. Entrapta knew what was at stake. She pushed the lever next to the steering wheel forward.

And she heard the engine in the hold starting to hum as the ship - Victory’s Daughter - began to move.

Licy cheered. As did Adora.

“Working nicely!” Entrapta reported through the speaking tube. “Push her further!”

They had to leave the port first, so they wouldn’t ram the mole or another ship - Salinas was the busiest port in all the Seas, especially now with the war over. But that was easily accomplished with a few turns.

And then they were on the open sea, and Seacat was pushing the lever as far ahead as she could.

And Victory’s Daughter, her ship, raced on the waves.

*****

The Voyage South

“Full speed ahead!” Seacat yelled into the speaking tube.

“Copy, full speed ahead!” Entrapta’s tinny voice sounded through the tube - and through the open hatch leading down to the hold.

A moment later, the Victory’s Daughter seemed to jump forward as the engine propelled it through the waves at ever-increasing speed. Seacat bared her teeth in a wide grin at the wind hitting her face - this was great! Perfect!

“Shouldn’t we save some fuel?” Adora asked.

“We aren’t going to sprint the whole trip,” Seacat told her. “But we need to put her through her paces to test the engine.”

“Are you talking about Entrapta or the ship?”

Seacat frowned at her lover. Adora’s humour was sometimes lacking. “The ship.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded with a serious expression. “And why did you use the speaky-tube instead of the controls here?” She pointed at the levers next to the steering wheel.

“To test them,” Seacat told her. “I’ll test the controls later.”

“Ah. Didn’t we test the ship yesterday?”

“We did. But this is her maiden voyage. We have to test her endurance now.” You never caught everything that needed fixing when fitting out. Entrapta would have to teach the crew about running the engine, too, Seacat reminded herself. Well, running it wasn’t really difficult - Seacat could do it already. Unless the new engine was markedly more complex than the others Entrapta had made. The princess hadn’t said so, though. But repairing it? Learning that would be difficult. And finding someone who knew

more about engines wouldn't be easy, either. Fortunately, they had sails if they ever lost the engine on a voyage.

And for this, they had the best person for the job with them. Entrapta could probably whip up a new engine out of some scraps and some spare parts from Emily. Not that the princess would ever do that to Emily, though, Seacat added to herself as she looked at the bot standing in the middle of the deck, just before the swivel gun in the bow.

"So…"

Seacat looked at Adora. "What?"

"How long will we run at full speed?"

"An hour, I'd say. Enough to test it thoroughly." Seacat looked behind - Salineas was already growing smaller. How fast the ship was! Her ship. Faster than anything she had ever sailed.

"Huzzah!" The Captain seemed to share her impression. "This is like riding the lightning!" He grabbed a line and jumped, swinging around the mast and landing in the rigging.

"He didn't actually ride the lightning, did he?" Adora asked.

Seacat glanced at her. She should know better than to ask such a silly question. Then again, it was the Captain… "No. But he'd do it if he ever had the opportunity."

Her lover laughed at that.

"We're burning a lot of crystals." Mermista had climbed the stairs to the bridge.

"We need to put her through her paces," Seacat repeated herself.

"Yes. I'm just wondering about the availability of crystals," Mermista said, leaning against the railing. "With all frigates getting

engines installed, and couriers as well… It's not going to be cheap to keep them supplied. And mines run out. Eventually."

Right. Seacat hadn't considered that. Transports could just sail, but warships and couriers needed engines once everyone else had them. "Did anyone check how large the crystal supply is?" she asked.

"I've sent Admiral Barton to investigate," Mermista said.

Seacat frowned - the name didn't ring a bell.

"She was recently promoted for her actions during the war," the princess explained. "She's good at administration and logistics."

A good choice, then. "Well, if the crystals run out, we'll have to see if we find alternatives. Wasn't Entrapta looking into engines using wood?"

"She was, yes. But they are very inefficient," Mermista replied. "I don't have the exact numbers, but we would need a lot of wood to fuel an engine for a frigate. We would have to sacrifice firepower - or restrict the engine to combat and emergencies. And wood takes time to grow. We can't sacrifice our forests for fuel; we need them for building ships."

"Perfuma might be able to help out," Adora said with a smile. "I bet she can grow wood with a thought."

"Yes." Mermista didn't sound very happy about it.

Even Adora noticed it. "What's the problem?"

"We would depend entirely on her. That's not a good idea," the princess explained. "And what if she retires? Or dies?"

"Oh." Adora blinked. "I didn't think about that.

Seacat nodded. "The Horde didn't really train long-term planning."

“No, they didn’t.” Adora frowned. “Hey!”

Seacat chuckled. But she was a little concerned about their future. Although that was a problem they could - and had to - tackle after saving Etheria. How to fuel your fleet wasn’t really important if everyone died when the planet blew up.

*****

Later that day, they were running under sail, with the engine turned off, and everyone was on deck, relaxing in the warm afternoon sun.

Well, Entrapta was going through a stack of notes double her height, but that was relaxing for her. Seacat wasn’t quite sure that Bow, who was helping her, felt the same, but he was a grown man; he could decide for himself whether or not he’d take a break. And Perfuma and the Horde princess were making plans about ‘revitalising’ more of the Fright Zone. Castaspella, who had made it to Salienas after her detour to Mystacore in time to join them, was leaning over the railing and puking her guts out.

But everyone else except for Horas, who was manning the bridge, was relaxing. Seacat was leaning against Adora’s legs on the main deck. Well away from Emily, in case a wave hit the ship and made the bot slide around despite the lines lashing it to the deck. And watching Glimmer trying to avoid showing how unhappy she was that Bow was busy.

Seacat hid her grin when the princess turned towards them. “So! How much longer until we reach the island?”

“About a week or a little longer, depending on the wind,” Seacat told her. “That hasn’t changed since we’ve left port.”

Glimmer frowned for a moment. “Can’t we go faster with the engine?”

“We might run out of fuel if we do that,” Seacat replied.

“Don’t we have a hold full of fuel crystals? There’s barely room for everyone to hang a hammock.”

“If we run into trouble, we might need all that,” Mermista cut in - probably annoyed at the implied criticism of the supplies provided by the Salinean Navy.

“Trouble?” Glimmer snorted. “In a pinch, I can drop bombs on a ship. Or She-Ra,” she added with a grin.

Seacat frowned, but Adora laughed. “Oh, yes! Drop me on an enemy ship, and I start slicing and dicing!” After a moment, she added: “Well, they wouldn’t blow themselves up, would they?”

“I haven’t heard of any Headhunters deserting with a ship,” Mermista said. “Hey, Princess Scorpia! Do you know of any Headhunters in your navy?”

“What?”

“We’re wondering if we might encounter people who are willing to blow up their ship to get us,” Adora explained.

“Who would do that?” the Horde princess gasped.

“Your Headhunters?” Seacat replied with a frown.

“Who wouldn’t?” Sea Hawk spoke up. “It’s a tried and true way to sink an enemy ship! I’ve done it myself; I can vouch for its efficacy!”

“No, I don’t know of any such people,” the bug princess said. “Most Headhunters who deserted went into the Crimson Waste.

“We’re not going to blow up my ship,” Seacat said with a slight growl. She’d gut anyone suggesting that! Unless it was absolutely necessary. “We can outrun anything big enough to threaten us. Provided we have enough fuel.”She flashed her fangs at Glimmer. Just a little.

Glimmer pouted. “Well, what other threats are out there? Sea Monsters?”

“I can deal with them!” Adora said at once.

“We know,” Seacat commented, remembering that particular trip. Her first voyage with Adora. So long ago… She sighed at the memories.

“Something wrong?” Adora asked.

“No. Just remembering how you jumped into the water to kill a sea monster,” Seacat told her.

“Oh.” Adora chuckled, though it sounded a little forced.” Well, that wasn’t my finest moment. I so wanted to show off.”

“Well, you did - and it was impressive,” Seacat said, turning her head to smile at her.

“Thanks.”

They stared at each other. Seacat licked her lips. If she shifted a little - well, a lot - she could…

“You’re so sweet!” Licy blurted out.

Alcy’s sigh was heard across the entire deck. “Licy!”

“What? It’s true!”

“You just interrupted them!”

“Oh! Sorry! Please continue! Just ignore me, Captain!”

Seacat stared at the other sailor. Licy was beaming at her as if this was normal. She glanced at Sea Hawk, who was openly smirking. Great.

That part of being a captain she could’ve done without.

Then Adora pulled her into her lap.

“Hey!” Seacat squirmed, but Adora held her tightly. And trying to force the issue would make her look even more ridiculous than sitting in her lover’s lap already did. So she sighed and leaned back. “Any trouble with the ship?” she asked.

“No. Everything’s shipshape!” Licy replied.

“We’ve adjusted the rigging a little, but that was it,” Alcy added.

“My yards do good work,” Mermista stated with a grin.

“Still, this is a new design…” Seacat lightly bit her lower lip.

“But I’ve built it upon tested designs!” Entrapta announced. “And I ran the calculations three times! So far, everything’s coming out correctly!”

“Let’s hope it stays that way,” Seacat said, leaning into Adora. Just a nice, peaceful trip, and then they could deal with the First One’s mess.

*****

A few days later, they were deep in the Southern Sea, and the temperature told. Seacat, standing on the bridge, shook her head at the sight of Glimmer, who was lying spread-eagled on the main deck under a sunscreen. The princess hadn’t stopped complaining about the heat for the last hour. Which was kind of impressive, actually.

Entrapta was in the hold, working on some ‘fan-system’ that should help with the temperature. Or so she claimed - she’d been down there since the morning. Seacat hoped that Horas, who was sleeping after his watch on the bridge at night, wouldn’t be disturbed by whatever the princess was building.

She didn’t think, really didn’t think, about Sea Hawk and Mermista ‘resting’ in the captain’s cabin. As if Mermista truly had felt faint!

And she ignored Castaspella, who still hadn't gotten over her sea sickness. Or over the railing.

"Ah! This feels nice!"

Seacat turned her head to look at the Horde princess stomping over the deck. The big woman spread her arms. "It's almost like home!"

"A little too warm," Perfuma, who seemed to be glued to the Horde princess's side for the trip, said.

"Oh. I forgot you grew up in colder forests. I'm sorry."

"No, no! It's OK. I can handle it. You shouldn't feel sorry for being happy about the weather."

"But if you're suffering…"

"I'm not suffering! I'm merely… unused to the temperature," Perfuma retorted.

"Still, perhaps we should get into the shade. I've seen soldiers collapse in the heat."

"I'm no soldier."

"That doesn't mean you can't catch a sunburn. Or a heatstroke." The big woman picked the princess up and carried her to the sunscreen.

Seacat shook her head at their antics. It wasn't that hot. And the heat had some good parts, too.

She looked behind her, where Adora and Bow were working on the swivel gun, and smiled. Her lover was wearing the sailor's outfit Seacat had picked for her - which almost matched her own - and it showed off her body much better than her usual uniform.

"We're ready for gunnery practice!" Licy yelled from the bow.

Right. Gunnery practice. Horas better had slept enough. “Fetch a target!” Seacat yelled. “And call Horas to throw it.”

“No need!” Licy yelled back. “There’s a driftwood ahead!”

Driftwood? In the middle of the sea? Not unheard of, of course - driftwood could travel far in the currents of the sea - but… “Belay that! Let’s first take a look at the wood!” she called out.

“Do you think it might be a floating bomb?” Adora asked.

“Here? No.” And if it was, it would probably be inert anyway; after so much time in the water, the seals would have failed, and the powder would’ve been ruined. At least Seacat hoped so. There had been incidents with transport ships encountering floating bombs near the coast, even after the war had officially ended.

“So, why are we taking a look at it?”

Seacat grinned. “So we know where it’s from. You can find out a lot from driftwood.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “Another thing I need to learn.” She nibbled on her lower lip, which made her look very cute but also showed that she wasn’t feeling completely happy about this.

“It’s not that important,” Seacat assured her. “And most of it is common sense. Hey, Perfuma might be able to tell us much more about the wood thanks to her own knowledge about plants.”

“Right.” Adora smiled.

Seacat turned the ship a little - the wind’s direction hadn’t changed, so it was easy to sail closer to the piece of wood - and they approached it. Cautiously, of course - driftwood didn’t need to contain a bomb to damage a ship’s hull.

Adora all but jumped into the sea, so eager was she to recover the piece of wood. She speared it with a harpoon, then pulled it

out of the water with the ship's crane. "Doesn't look like a bomb," she said.

Seacat frowned. It really didn't look like a bomb - it looked like a piece of a ship's hull. "Pull it in!" she ordered.

As soon as the wood was on the deck, she took a closer look. "That's a piece of a plank," she said. She sniffed the edge. "Tar."

"Quite thick for a plank," Adora commented.

"Frigate's hull," Alcy told them.

"There aren't any Salinean frigates in this area," Seacat said. Mermista would've told them. "Which means this is a Horde frigate."

"Are you sure? It could have drifted down from the coast, couldn't it?" Adora asked.

"Yes." Seacat pointed at the edge. "This is too fresh to have spent weeks in the sea."

She didn't know what worried her more: That there might be a slightly damaged Horde frigate in the area or that something might be in the area that had sunk a Horde frigate.

*****

They didn't find any more parts of the mysterious frigate as they continued their voyage towards Beast Island. That didn't mean anything, of course - the ocean's currents could've dispersed a frigate's worth of parts all over the Southern Sea - but Seacat didn't like it anyway.

And she kept an eye out on the sea even when she took their position shortly before sundown. Still no drifting wreck.

"What do we do if there's a Horde frigate out there? Here, I mean," Adora asked from behind her.

Without taking her eyes off the sextant - she had to check their position before sundown - she replied: “We can outsail any frigate.” No Horde hulk would ever catch the Victory’s Daughter!

“But what if they’re blocking our way to Beast Island?”

She finished her task first before answering. They were on course. Then she turned to face Adora. “Then Glimmer drops you in the middle of the frigate’s deck or on bridge, and you sink it.”

“And what if they surrender?”

Then they’d have a prize. Wait - they didn’t have the numbers for a prize crew. Seacat clenched her teeth. “Then we drop their guns in the sea and send them on their way. Unless they’re pirates, in which case we sink the ship with them on it.”

“Really?” Adora looked shocked. “But…”

“Pirates are the scum of the Seas,” Seacat told her. “If we took them to Salineas, they’d hang anyway. And as the ruler of Salineas, Mermista can judge them.” The pirates would even have a fair trial!

Adora still looked queasy. “And how do we know that they’re pirates?”

“If they hoist the black flag,” Seacat replied. “Or if they refuse to answer to Scorpia.” The Horde princess could order Horde ships around, Seacat reminded herself. Although if they hadn’t heard about the end of the war, even legitimate Horde ships might be suspicious of a Horde leader travelling with the leadership of the Alliance. On the other hand, Scorpia didn’t know about any frigate dispatched to this area.

“They could just be deserters,” Adora argued.

“And what would they be doing here, in the Southern Seas?”

“Looking for a place to live?” Adora smiled weakly.

Seacat snorted. “On Beast Island?” She blinked. “They might be trying to reach Beast Island, actually.”

Adora frowned as she thought this over. “To hide?”

“Or to loot whatever is hidden on the island,” Seacat said. “Or to use it as a base for piracy.”

“Wouldn’t it be too far away from the coast and shipping lanes for that?”

Seacat shook her head. “No. The farther away, the better - the Salineans would find a base close to the coast easily.” Well, unless led by inept officers. But Mermista had been good about weeding out those during the latter parts of the war. She shook her head as she noted their position in the log.

Adora leaned against the railing and looked at the darkening sky. “I hope we don’t meet the frigate.”

“Then we will meet whoever or whatever sank it,” Seacat said. “There’s only one thing of interest in this area of the ocean, and that’s Beast Island.”

“I hoped this would be over, you know.”

“‘This’?” Seacat stowed the sextant and the log in the small chest she carried and looked at her lover.

“Killing the Horde.”

Oh. “Technically, we’d be killing pirates, not the Horde. Scorpia commands the Horde, and she can order Horde ships away,” she pointed out.

“It’s still killing,” Adora retorted. “I was just…”

“I know,” Seacat said. “But pirates are a fact of life on the sea. As are bandits on land,” she added - in case Adora had serious second thoughts about sailing with her.

“I know.” Adora huffed. “Just… I’m tired. After this is done, can we just sail for a while? Without killing anyone?”

That depended on the pirates being smart enough not to attack them. Or bother them. But Seacat nodded, touching Adora’s arm and squeezed. “We will.” She cocked her head, the chest under her left arm. “And what about monsters?”

“They don’t count!”

“Alright.” Seacat grinned. “Let me stow this, then we can join the others for dinner.” Once Alcy and Licy were done eating and could relieve them on the bridge. Technically, it only needed one person, but if they had so many people on board, two were better.

“What’s for dinner?”

“Look for yourself,” Seacat told her.

“You smelt it already, didn’t you?”

Seacat had, but why spoil the surprise? “Perfuma’s cooking.”

“That doesn’t narrow it down.”

That was true - the princess had a very wide range of dishes. And she could grow fresh fruit and vegetables on the ship! “Just be a little patient!” Seacat replied, grinning.

“Oh, you!”

They laughed as Adora mock-chased her to their cabin.

*****

“Ship ahead!”

Seacat jerked at Adora’s call and looked up at the crow’s nest. “What kind of ship!” she yelled. She couldn’t just scale the rigging and take a look herself - that would make it look like she didn’t trust Adora.

“Uh…” She saw Adora fiddle with the telescope. “It looks like… Horde!”

The Horde frigate! Just as she had feared. Seacat gritted her teeth. “Course?”

“North? Their sails aren’t… they don’t look right.”

Seacat moved to the bow. She couldn’t spot the enemy ship yet. “Stay the course!” she yelled at Alcy, who was at the helm of Victory’s Daughter. “Get ready to start the engine in case we need to run!”

“Run?” Glimmer was at her side. “We can take a frigate!”

“Not in a gun duel. I’d rather have my ship safely out of range of their guns while Adora goes through their crew,” Seacat replied. “Just in case they’re not as inept at gunnery as most Horde ships.”

“There shouldn’t be any Horde ships here.” The bug princess had joined her.

“Well, there is.” Seacat trusted Adora’s eyes more than the Horde’s records. And… was that a speck on the horizon? She used her own telescope. Yes! That was the sail - the sails of a Horde frigate.

But they looked tattered. And they weren’t… they weren’t properly secured. Not even a Horde crew would be so sloppy! Had they run into a storm and had had their sails torn to shreds before they could reef? She could see the hull now - it looked intact. At least as far as she could tell.

She couldn’t see any movement on board the frigate, though. No sailor on deck, none in the rigging, none on the bridge.

Seacat clenched her teeth as she felt the fur on her neck bristle. This wasn’t good. “Take us closer!”

“What?” Glimmer asked.

“I’ve got a bad feeling about this,” Seacat told her.

“And so we’re going to close with the frigate?” The bug princess sounded surprised. “What if it’s an ambush?”

“That would be good, actually,” Seacat replied. She flashed her fangs at the Horde princess. “We can deal with ambushes.” The enemy wouldn’t expect Adora. Or Glimmer. Or Mermista.

“What do you think it is, then?”

“I don’t know,” Seacat told her. “But I’ve got a feeling that it’s bad.”

As they closed with the frigate - but not too close; they wouldn’t enter gun range - more details became visible.

“The ship’s drifting,” Seacat said. “No one’s at the helm.”

“And the rudder doesn’t look as if it is stuck,” Sea Hawk added, looking through his telescope. “The ship wasn’t set adrift, then.”

“No, she wasn’t. And she’s got an engine,” Seacat said. She could see the air intakes.

“Why would the crew abandon the ship?” Entrapta asked.

Seacat could think of a few reasons, none of them good. “She doesn’t look too damaged. The sails are torn, but the hull looks to be in decent shape. For a Horde frigate,” she amended - they weren’t built well, after all. Or designed. “So, it wasn’t a fire that forced them off the ship.”

“Plague?” Mermista speculated. “They should’ve set her on fire in that case, but…” She shrugged. “Horde sailors.”

The bug princess muttered a curse under her breath at that. Seacat grinned at her. “You can’t deny that your sailors are the dregs of your army.”

“Not all of them are bad,” the princess retorted with a scowl.

“That’s not exactly a good defence,” Bow pointed out.

The Horde princess grumbled some more.

“If they caught the plague while they were at sea,” Seacat cut in, “they could’ve all died before reaching land. We can’t board the ship if this is the case.” She wouldn’t risk Adora. Even though her lover could heal with magic.

“We can’t just ignore it,” Glimmer retorted.

“We won’t ignore it,” Seacat told her. “Best set them on fire. If we don’t see any sign that she’s still got crew. Licy!”

“Yes?”

“Shoot the cannon. Let’s see if that gets us a reaction,” Seacat said.

“Aye aye, Captain!”

Licy started to aim the cannon in the bow, and Seacat protected her ears. A moment later, the swivel gun bellowed.

Seacat watched through her telescope again. No reaction. Perhaps the frigate was… Wait! “There’s someone on the deck!” she yelled. More than one - she could see sailors, Horde sailors, appearing on the deck. A lot of them.

And then the frigate started to turn towards them - someone had reached the helm.

And they were clearing the guns, Seacat saw.

Damn. “It must have been a trap.”

“A trap?” Glimmer asked.

“Alcy! Turn about!” They had to keep away from those broadsides. As the Victory’s Daughter turned into the wind, Seacat replied to Glimmer: “They probably tried to lure us in by making it look as if the ship was deserted.”

“Who would fall for that?” Glimmer asked.

“Most captains wouldn’t just ignore or sink a drifting frigate,” Seacat said. “We didn’t, did we?”

“But that’s…” Glimmer pouted.

Seacat snorted and studied the frigate again through her telescope. “They’re not using their engine,” she commented. “They’re trying to sail with those scraps…” She shook her head. “Keep on course!” she told Alcy as she reached the bridge.

Entrapta stuck her head out of the hold. “Do you want the engine?”

“No, not yet,” Seacat told her. “We can outsail a frigate easily.”

“Unless that’s the trap,” Glimmer said. “They want us to think that - and then when we’re running under sails, they start their engine and whoosh - they jump us.”

“That’s not how it works,” Seacat told her. “You’d have to be a Horde sailor to fall for that.”

“Hey!” Ah, the Horde princess had overheard her.

Seacat grinned but ignored her and studied the enemy ship again. “They’re not flying the Horde flag. Or any flag,” she said. The flag could’ve been torn away by whatever storm had torn up the sails - and wasn’t that typical for Horde sailors?

“You think they’re deserters?” The Horde Princess asked.

“You didn’t send a frigate down here. And no Alliance transports are going through this sea,” Seacat told her. “So, they can’t be a

frigate that managed to break out of their blockaded port and started raiding."

"Yeah, I guess so." The Horde princess frowned as she stared at the ship behind them. "So, I guess me telling them that the war's over won't help?"

"Worth a try," Seacat said. "But the only way to get you close enough so they can hear you without getting into range of their guns would be Glimmer teleporting you onto their deck."

"Alright then." The Horde Princess nodded. "You ready, Glimmer?"

"Ah… I can only teleport you - you're a bit too big to carry both you and Adora."

The princess was braver than Seacat had expected. And a little dumber as well. "If they're deserters, they'll probably attack you. At the very least, they'll try to take you hostage," she pointed out.

The Horde princess grinned and slammed her pincers together. "They can try. I'm pretty good in a brawl."

Seacat looked at Glimmer. "That won't exhaust you? We can sail a little closer."

"Naw, that distance won't make much of a difference." Glimmer smiled.

"Alright."

"Wait!" Perfuma raised her hand.

"What?" Glimmer cocked her head at the other princess.

But Perfuma stepped up to the Horde princess. "Be careful!"

"Don't worry! They're just sailors - nothing I can't handle!"

Seacat rolled her eyes. "Just *Horde* sailors, you mean. I remember one sailor you couldn't handle."

But the Horde princess didn’t take the bait - she kept smiling at Perfuma. Really!

Glimmer cleared her throat. “Alright. Ready?”

After a moment, the Horde princess nodded. “Ready.”

Glimmer grabbed her hand, and both disappeared.

“Hey!”

Seacat looked up.

“Scorpia just appeared on the frigate’s deck!” Adora yelled. “And Glimmer! Wait - Glimmer disappeared again!” Adora reported. “Wait! I thought I was the one we’d drop on the enemy deck!”

Seacat chuckled. “Scorpia’s trying to order them to surrender.”

“Oh. Well, she’s trying to beat them into surrender, as far as I can tell,” Adora replied.

Ah. Seacat checked with her telescope. Yes, there went two Horde scumbags into the sea. And another. “It seems she’s doing well.”

“She needs help!” Adora protested. “For the Honour of Grayskull! Glimmer! Take me over to the frigate!”

And Glimmer did. Without waiting for Seacat’s permission.

Seacat clenched her teeth as she watched Adora appear on the enemy frigate and tear through the Horde scum. Well, at least there was no way the Horde could hurt Adora. Still, to teleport without permission...

Well, technically, Seacat was the Captain of the Victory’s Daughter, but she wasn’t in command of the whole mission. On the other hand, they were in a naval engagement, which put the entire battle under Seacat’s command. Although Sea Hawk was an Admiral, and while Seacat’s ship wasn’t, officially or unofficially,

part of the Salinean Navy, this was at least an official Alliance mission, so he could order her around. And Glimmer was the Alliance commander, so, technically, she could order everyone around.

Seacat shook her head. They had to clear that up, but that could wait until the battle was over. Which, she noted, it was - the Horde sailors still standing were just standing there, and the ship started to turn into the wind to come to a stop. And the Horde Princess and Adora were on the frigate's bridge.

"Alcy, take us closer - but don't approach from the broadsides!" Seacat ordered.

"Aye aye, Captain!"

Seacat smiled at the reply - she wouldn't ever tire of hearing this! "Let's find out what the Horde frigate was doing here!"

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By the time they reached the frigate's stern, Adora had torn the guns facing aft from their carriages and was standing next to the helm. They were pretty much safe.

Seacat was still the first to climb over the Victory's Daughter's bow onto the frigate's bridge. "Hey, Adora!"

"Ca-Seacat! I mean, Captain!" She saluted with a beaming smile. "We've taken the ship!"

"And they were deserters," the Horde Princess added, carrying a man under her arm. "That's their captain, or so they claim." She dropped him onto the deck.

Seacat looked at the man. He didn't seem to be hurt, but he looked weak. Bedraggled. She crouched down. And his lips were… chapped, Dry. And, glancing around, she saw that the rest of the Horde deserters looked the same. Most couldn't even stand

properly. “Did you run out of water?” she asked. That would’ve been stupid even for the Horde.

“Yes.” The man groaned. “The water was cont...contaminated.”

“What? Where did you refill?” If there were contaminated water sources, Seacat had to know. She knew how bad it was to lose your water.

“We didn’t.” The Horde sailor coughed. “We wanted to refill on the island, but… reefs damaged the hull - our charts were wrong.”

So they had been trying to land on Beast Island. “And you wrecked your sails?”

“Thunderstorm.”

“Ah.” Seacat tilted her head to the side. “And how did your water get contaminated?”

“I don’t know. It just went bad. We only noticed when the people started dying.”

Now that was… disturbing. If it was true. It could be sabotage - she remembered Svetana, the Horde spy who had almost made them die from thirst on the Dragon’s Daughter V when they beached the ship for repairs. But who would do that to the Horde and not reveal themselves now? “Is anyone missing from the crew?” she asked.

The Horde captain looked at the broken railing next to him.

Seacat rolled her eyes. “I meant before She-Ra and Princess Scorpia boarded you.”

“What? No. Everyone was accounted for.”

So the saboteur would have been still on the ship. Why hadn’t they come forward now that the Horde ship had been taken? Could they have been killed in the fighting? It was possible, of

course, but… unless the bug princess was even dumber than Seacat thought, she would have opened with the fact that the war was over, which should have given any Alliance spy pause, at least. And once Adora joined the princess, it should've been clear; everyone knew She-Ra.

Seacat looked at the main deck. Unless the spy had been flattened by Adora's arrival. Or killed before they could say anything. That was possible, at least.

"Alright. So, we have a mysterious saboteur," she said.

"Or the barrels were defective," Mermista - who had joined them with Sea Hawk - pointed out. "If they had some defect that poisoned the water, like the early cans with their soldering…" She trailed off with a grim expression.

Seacat shuddered at the reminder. Sea Hawk had told her about ships' crews slowly poisoning themselves by eating canned food before everyone had realised that they couldn't use lead to seal the cans. Sailors had thought they could finally avoid getting scurvy for good but had made things far worse instead. Fortunately, that had been far before her time. "We'll have to inspect them, then. Examine them." And, of course, send someone to guard their own water supplies. Just in case there was a saboteur around who hated both the Horde and the Alliance. Like a pirate would.

"And… do you have some water to spare?" The Horde captain looked at her with a pitiful expression.

Seacat blinked. Spare water for close to two hundred sailors? And that was taking a lot of losses and casualties into account.

Damn. She hadn't considered that. And the Horde scum were prisoners.

*****

“We don’t need to waste water on them,” Mermista said a little later, back on the Victory’s Daughter. “They are deserters turned pirates.”

“We still can’t let them die of thirst!” Adora protested.

“Well, I guess we can hang them before that,” Mermista admitted.

Bow looked queasy at that comment. As did Glimmer, though the princess tried to hide it and nodded.

“What?” Perfuma, though, didn’t hide her reaction. “We can’t just… We can’t!”

“Piracy is a capital crime,” Sea Hawk explained. “The Law of the Sea is clear on that.”

“But…” Adora looked surprised. “We’ve had former pirates in the Alliance!”

Like Licy and Alcy, of course.

“Pardoned pirates,” Mermista said. “We captured those pirates in the act.” She crossed her arms. “And I don’t see them volunteering to fight the Horde.”

“They probably would, if we asked them, given the alternative,” Bow said.

“And did they even do any piracy?” Adora asked. “They deserted after the war ended and fled to this area. Before that, they were raiding, but that was OK, wasn’t it?”

Seacat frowned. Her lover was correct. Technically, the deserters hadn’t yet boarded any ships. They had been ready to attack the Victory’s Daughter, though. On the other hand, they had been dying of thirst...

“And they were desperate,” Perfuma argued. “We can’t just… kill them like this!”

“But can we save them?” Glimmer looked around. “We don’t have enough water for hundreds of people. Even if we gave them all our water, they wouldn’t make it back to a port or an island with water, would they?”

They wouldn’t. Seacat knew that. Without water, not even the Victory’s Daughter running under full sails and with the engine at maximum speed could reach land before they died from thirst. The former Horde tub? No chance at all. Hanging the scum would be a mercy. Hell, throwing them into the sea or sinking the ship with them tied to the rigging would be a mercy!

“Can you magic up some water?” Bow asked Mermista.

“I can’t turn saltwater to freshwater,” she replied.

“Don’t ask me,” Castaspella, still green in the face - the sorceress had the worst sealegs Seacat had ever seen - spoke up. “I don’t know any spell that would create water.”

“We just need salt removed from the seawater?” Entrapta asked.

“Yes?” Seacat cocked her head at the princess.

“I can do that!” Entrapta beamed at them. “Give me an hour, and I’ll whip up a machine to desalinate the water!”

“Enough water to save the Horde crew?” Adora checked.

“Yes! I might need to dismantle the Horde engine for parts, but it’s an easy principle. You just need to turn the seawater into steam and then condense it into liquid again. Easy!” Entrpata nodded enthusiastically.

That was easy? If this worked, it would revolutionise sailing as much as the engines did! Entrapta really was a genius. “Alright,” Seacat said, nodding. This was her decision as the captain. “Do that. We can figure out what to do with the prisoners once they aren’t dying of thirst any more.”

“Alright!”

Seacat looked at Adora.

“I’ll ensure no one bothers her,” Adora said.

“Good.” With the Horde crew crazy from thirst, they might get desperate. More desperate. “And we’ll take a look at the water barrels.”

*****

“The barrels look OK,” Mermista said later. “I can’t find any source for the contamination.”

“Nor can I,” Sea Hawk added.

Seacat couldn’t find any problem either. “So… poison?”

“Probably,” Mermista said. “But who would have carried poison with them on the frigate. They didn’t encounter any other ships on their trip down here.”

“It’s definitely poison,” Castaspella stated. She looked better on the bigger ship - less movement from the waves, Seacat noted. “And it was done by magic,” the sorceress went on. “The aura is unmistakable.”

Magic? Seacat clenched her teeth. They had a magical saboteur on board?

*****

The Reef

“Magic?” Seacat clenched her teeth as she looked at Castaspella. She gestured at the barrels in the Horde frigate’s hold. “You mean the water here has been poisoned by magic?”

The other woman nodded. “By a spell, as far as I can tell. A recent casting - I could make out some lingering magical residue.”

“A spell.” Seacat nodded.

“Which means we’re dealing with a sorcerer, not a princess,” Castaspella added.

“I’m aware of that,” Seacat told her. She had spent a lot of time with princesses, after all.

“Many aren’t aware of the differences between the two,” Castaspella replied. “They just think all magic is the same.”

Seacat tilted her head at the sorceress. “I’m quite familiar with the differences. We have been discussing runestones a lot, remember?” That came out a little sharper than she had wanted, but the sorceress’s attitude grated on her. “I’m more concerned with what this means. Do we have a sorceress hidden amongst the crew? And can they poison our water supplies? From how far away? And how noticeable is such a spell?”

“Those are very good questions.” Castaspella smiled as if she were in a lesson. “Unfortunately, I haven’t identified the spell, so I cannot answer them. Neither can I tell if the poison was created by magic, or merely transported by magic. It’s been too long since it was cast.”

Great.

Mermista groaned and rolled her eyes but, fortunately, didn’t comment on that.

“So, our water supply could be poisoned already.” Seacat shook her head. “You need to test for magic regularly. And we’ll need one of those water-makers for the Victory’s Daughter.”

Castaspella nodded - to Seacat’s surprise without adding anything.

She huffed. “And now we need to find a way to deal with a ship full of Horde prisoners. We’ll discuss this on our ship.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk agreed.

She climbed up the ladder to the main deck. The bug princess was talking to the assembled prisoners - well, most of them. Two were dripping wet, so they were probably amongst those who had been thrown overboard during the fighting and had managed to stay afloat long enough to get rescued.

“...and the Fright Zone has changed! It’s full of fields and plants now - and cooler than before. Not by much, it’s still warm, but it’s not the same as you have known!” the princess said, gesticulating with her massive pincers. “And we’re at peace! You don’t have to worry about war any more!”

“How is that possible?” one Horde sailor asked. A few more muttered various curses about the princess lying, though Seacat didn’t think anyone except for her could hear those.

“That’s my work,” Perfuma said, smiling at them. “I’m Princess Perfuma of Plumeria.”

The front rank of the prisoners backed away a little at Perfuma’s declaration. Obviously, her reputation had preceded her - if they had known her, they wouldn’t be afraid, in Seacat’s opinion. Even though they probably should be afraid; Seacat could imagine what an angry Perfuma could do.

But here and now, Perfuma wasn’t angry. She beamed at the scum and held up her hand. “I can make plants grow,” she said. “Look!”

From the seed in her hand, a sapling grew in seconds, turning into a small plant - a small tree - and bearing fruits. Everyone stared, and the curses turned into exclamations of surprise.

“Tiny fruits!” A purple strand of hair shot towards the small apple tree and grabbed a fruit. A moment later, Entrapta was munching on the apple. “Oh, delicious!”

The Horde scum had retreated some more. Apparently, magical hair tentacles were scarier than magically growing plants. At least to those who didn’t know better.

“Entrapta? Did you finish the water-maker?”

“Yes! I told you it would be easy, didn’t I?” Entrapta laughed. “It’s already working in the hold.” She frowned. “But I might need more barrels. I only had a bucket, and the water might start to overflow. Actually, it might be overflowing already - it was a small bucket.”

Seacat resisted the urge to slap her forehead. “Alright. Castaspella, can you clean the water barrels so they can hold freshwater?”

“I should be able to, yes.”

“Do so. Entrapta, please help her set up the barrels.”

“Water!”

“They’re making water!”

“Water!”

“Water!”

Anyone with ears could hear those mutterings. Seacat grimaced. “Scorpia, please ensure that the barrels are brought up as soon as they are full. And keep the prisoners from accidentally wrecking the machine.”

“Uh… right.” The bug princess nodded, smashed her pincers together and smiled - with teeth - at the Horde sailors. “You heard her! Water’s coming! Behave until then, you hear?” her stinger twitched above her head.

Once more, the sailors tried to back off - but they were already pressing into the railing, so they only pushed into each other. At least they seemed cowed enough not to make trouble. As long as the water came quickly, at least.

Entrapta’s head appeared in the open hatch. “Uh… can someone run the pumps? I kind of underestimated my machine’s efficiency…” She smiled widely and forcedly.

Seacat closed her eyes. Right. She should’ve expected that.

*****

“They’re pirates. They should hang.” Mermista didn’t quite sneer, but she came close, Seacat saw - even in the dimmer light of the hold of the Victoria’s Daughter. If only the captain’s cabin were big enough to fit everyone but Alcy, Lucy, Horas and Entrapta, who were over on the frigate!

“But they haven’t done any pirating yet!” Adora protested.

“The important word is ‘yet’,” Mermista retorted. “They deserted to become pirates.”

“But they didn’t do any pirating,” the bug princess cut in with a deep frown.

“They tried to take over Beast Island,” Glimmer pointed out.

“They didn’t succeed,” Adora said.

“So? If they had tried to board us and failed, wouldn’t it count as piracy either?” Mermista sniffed. “In fact, they did try to fight us.”

“After we fired a warning shot. And they were mad with thirst,” Perfuma said. “We can’t blame them for overreacting in those circumstances.”

Of course they could, in Seacat’s opinion. They were Horde scum and pirates. Still...

“Beast Island is ours - mine - so I should be able to decide whether or not that counts, shouldn’t I?” the bug princess asked. “And, ah, I say it doesn’t count. So there!” She crossed her arms and huffed.

“Beast Island isn’t yours! You lost it years ago when you abandoned it to whatever had taken over,” Glimmer said.

“What? That was a temporary setback. And it wasn’t my decision!” the bug princess protested. “You didn’t think the territory we conquered was ours, either, did you?”

“We beat you,” Glimmer told her. “That’s not the same.”

“Uh… It’s not about the island,” Bow said. “It’s about what we’re going to do with the prisoners.”

“According to the law of the sea, we took their ship in battle, and so she’s ours. We can send her back to Salineas with a prize crew,” the Captain said.

“We can’t actually spare a prize crew,” Seacat pointed out. “We need everyone for the mission. And even if we could spare a crew, we couldn’t spare enough to keep the prisoners in line and crew the ship.”

Sea Hawk coughed into his fist. “Well, yes, but that’s just the reality of our circumstances, not the law.”

“And the law also says that pirates hang,” Mermista added.

“They haven’t actually done any piracy,” Adora tried again.

“Only because they didn’t have the opportunity,” Mermista said.

“They might have abandoned their plans anyway once they heard about the changes to the Fright Zone,” the bug princess retorted.

Unsurprisingly, Perfuma agreed. “Yes! We can’t just assume the worst and kill people for something they might or might not have done!”

“And what are our alternatives?” Glimmer asked. “We can’t just set them free and hope they won’t turn to piracy anyway; that would make us responsible for everyone they kill.”

“And for every ship they sink,” Mermista added.

“We can’t just kill them without a trial,” Bow retorted, frowning at Glimmer. “They surrendered, and we accepted their surrender.”

“We’re not at war any more, anyway,” Adora said.

“But we’re at sea, and we fought them.” Seacat shook her head. “That’s different from fighting bandits. I think.”

“It’s actually not very different,” Glimmer said. “We just have fewer rules for looting their stuff.”

“We’re not talking about loot,” Bow spoke up again. “We are discussing what to do with two hundred Horde sailors!”

“Former Horde sailors.” Mermista scoffed.

“I can take them all back into service - I think I said something about that,” the Horde princess said.

Perfuma nodded twice. “You did at least imply that there was a place for them in the new Fright Zone. It would be unjust to turn around and kill them for something they didn’t do.”

“At least without a trial,” Bow repeated himself.

“We can hold a trial,” Mermista said. “Try them for piracy. Attempted piracy.”

“We would need a defender for them,” Bow countered. “And the defender would need time to prepare the case.”

“Yes. The trial has to be fair,” Sea Hawk said, then cringed at Mermista’s glare. “It’s the law of the sea.”

“So, we can’t hold a trial here. And we can’t keep them prisoners.” Adora nodded. “Which means we have to let them go.”

“We can’t keep their ship? It’s much nicer than ours,” Castaspella said.

“What?” Seacat glared at her. “It’s a tub! A swimming hulk! The Victory’s Daughter beats her on all counts!”

“I get much less sick over there,” the sorceress replied. She did look a little green in the face, Seacat noted.

“Anyway - no, we don’t have room for the Horde crew. We can’t keep the ship. And we can’t count on being able to drop them off at Beast Island,” Seacat said.

“And we can’t kill them without trial,” Bow repeated himself again.

“We can’t expect them to show up for a trial, though. If we set them free, they’ll get away,” Mermista said.

“So?” Adora replied. “They didn’t actually do anything yet. And we can dump their guns in the ocean so they can’t attack another ship.”

That seemed to be a decent compromise. They couldn’t waste too much time on this, anyway - not with Etheria still in danger.

Seacat nodded. “Who’s in favour of disarming the ship and sending them to the Fright Zone?”

Adora raised her hand, as did the bug princess, Perfuma and Bow. After a moment, Seacat raised her hand as well. And that sealed it.

*****

Adora was quite enthusiastic about throwing the guns overboard. Seacat, standing on the bridge of the Victory's Daughter, shook her head with a smile as she watched her lover on the Horde frigate heave and launch a carronade over the railing. The splash the gun made as it hit the water almost reached the deck. Thanks to her strength, the Horde ship would be disarmed in no time - before all of the Horde sailors had gotten their first drink of fresh water, Seacat guessed. Not that it mattered - the Horde sailors hadn't any fight left in them. Certainly not after that demonstration. And if they had, they wouldn't have any weapons - the bug princess and Perfuma were throwing the crossbows and swords overboard.

"That was a good decision."

She turned. Sea Hawk had joined her on the bridge and he was smiling brightly at her. She couldn't see Mermista.

"My dear Mermista is resting," Sea Hawk said.

That probably meant sulking in the cabin - Seacat's cabin. Mermista hadn't taken the decision to let the Horde sailors go gracefully. Seacat glanced down to the door leading belowdecks.

The Captain leaned against the railing next to her. "She's not mad. Well, not really."

Seacat snorted.

"She just needs a little time to come around," Sea Hawk insisted. "You know her - she likes to have her way, but she won't hold it against you."

“You think it was a good decision?” Seacat asked. He hadn’t voted for it, after all. Then again, Mermista might have taken that badly. If Seacat had voted against Adora… No, Adora would’ve understood. Eventually.

“Yes.” Sea Hawk blinked. “Well, it was good to see you make the decision, I mean. You’ve come a long way from the little girl I found so long ago. Well, not so long ago, actually.”

She snorted at his comment so she wouldn’t sniffle. “It’s been a few years.”

“And you’ve become a great sailor - and now a captain.” He nodded at her. “It’s a big step, becoming captain of your own ship. I remember my first ship and my first crew. I was older than you were but much less prepared. I think. And I think my crew would agree.”

“You taught me well,” Seacat said.

“As well as I could, at least, though one always wonders what one could’ve done better.” He sighed. “But you handled the decisions well. You know your ship and the sea. You have your crew in hand. And your heart’s in the right place. A sailor can’t ask for more from a captain.”

Seacat nodded, pressing her lips together for a moment so she wouldn’t blurt out something embarrassing or stupid. “You’ll still be my captain.” She clenched her teeth right afterwards. So much for not saying something stupid.

He laughed, though. “That’s normal. I still remember my first captain - well, the first I liked. My actual first captain wasn’t… Anyway, I’m proud of you. Very proud. And I wanted to let you know. I know you’ll be a great captain. The greatest.”

“After you,” Seacat replied.

“Greater.” He twirled his moustache. “A child is supposed to eclipse their parents, after all.”

She stiffened. That was… well, they hadn't really talked about that. And she wasn't sure if she wanted to touch that. It was a little much to handle. Not that she had ever doubted that he loved her. Not after she had gotten to know him. But to hear it like that… "Does that make Mermista my mother?" she asked, forcing herself to grin.

"In a sense, yes," he replied at once. "She certainly feels protective of you. Always has, actually, even if she tried to hide it."

"Don't let her hear that," Seacat told him. "She'll think you called her old."

He laughed at that. "Probably. But she'll know what I mean." He looked at the sea. "She's a formidable woman. But so are you. I'm proud of you both."

"I'm proud of you," Seacat replied. She sniffled. Once. "You taught me all I know."

"Oh, hardly. I tried my best, but some things you have to find out for yourself." He laughed again, though it sounded a little forced. Was he feeling embarrassed as well? He rarely was and never showed it, in her experience.

She nodded. Ahead of them, another gun hit the ocean.

"Anyway." He reached out and grabbed her shoulder. "You'll do fine. I just wanted to let you know."

Before they continued to Beast Island. To save the world. "Thank you." She hesitated a moment, then turned to hug him. She didn't let go of him for a while. And ignored his sniffles like he ignored hers.

*****

"Reef ahead!" Licy, who was serving as lookout, called from above.

“Just where it’s supposed to be,” Seacat commented after a glance at the charts, which they had updated with the charts taken from the Horde ship, before sending the scum on their way. At least their water hadn’t been poisoned, so the odds of the sorcerer hiding amongst the Horde crew were low.

“Island ahead!”

“That, too,” Seacat said. “Stay the course but slow down,” she told Horas, who was at the helm. “Alcy, go to the bow, check for underwater reefs.”

“Aye aye, Captain!” The woman saluted, which earned her a snort from Seacat.

Horas merely grunted, which was good enough - they weren’t in the Navy.

Seacat moved to the railing overlooking the main deck, then vaulted over it, landing on the deck. Another jump and she was in the rigging, scaling up to the crow’s nest.

She wanted to see the island with her own eyes.

“It’s straight ahead,” Licy said.

“I see it,” Seacat replied, wrapped her arm around the rigging’s lines and pulled out her telescope.

Beast Island looked like any other jungle island to her. At least at first glance. Some beaches, then the jungle, covering the entire island including the central hill. Big enough to have its own water source - they knew that from the Horde records. But…

“I see no buildings. Or ruins,” she said. “There should be a small harbour with a pier.” She quickly ran a calculation through her head. Yes, they were on a course that should show the harbour. “No ships or their remains, either. Wait!”

She focused on the beaches. There - that stone formation was too even. Too straight. And in the water… "There was a port there," she said. "But it's gone except for the foundations."

Someone must have razed it.

*****

"The harbour is gone?" Mermista looked taken aback. "Who would've done such a thing?"

"Someone who wants to discourage visitors?" Adora suggested. "No harbour, no ships?"

"You don't need a harbour to make landfall," Seacat pointed out. "Razing the port facilities makes the island less attractive, but since it's the only island in the area, it's still the only option for a base. Or to get freshwater."

"Yes." Sea Hawk nodded. "Though it also makes it less obvious that the island is or was inhabited."

"Which makes it easier to surprise an unsuspecting crew." Seacat nodded.

"You mean it's a trap?" Glimmer asked.

Seacat shrugged. "Wouldn't be the first island or peninsula that serves as a trap for ships. Though usually, they lure them into reefs with fake lighthouses, then plunder the cargo." And kill any survivors. She'd heard tales of such bottom feeders. Entire villages working together… Worse than pirates.

"Do you think that whoever is behind this was behind the poisoning of the Horde frigate's water?" Bow asked. "But they let them go, didn't they?"

"They would need a ship to collect a drifting frigate," Mermista said, "though she wouldn't have to be a large one. A boat would suffice to carry enough crew to take the ship to the island."

“But where would they take the ship?” Adora asked. “If there’s no port.”

“Good question.” Seacat smiled at her. “We don’t know anything concrete - this is just speculation.”

“Yes.” Bow nodded. “The island could’ve been razed by someone who left already.”

“I doubt that,” Castaspella spoke up. She shook her head, then grimaced and closed her eyes. “Sorry.”

Seacat made an agreeing noise. The woman really had no sea legs at all.

“This is the location of the First One’s base,” Castaspella went on. “If they razed the Horde facilities, then that was likely done to make the island look uninhabited - to hide the actual base.”

“We didn’t know about the First One’s base, so it was already hidden,” the bug princess pointed out.

“Someone wanted to hide it better?” Adora shrugged. “No people on the island means no chance the base can be found.”

“Other than the people who did the razing,” Seacat said. “We have to assume that they are still there.”

“Scavengers. Looters. Tomb raiders.” Mermista scowled. “And well-organised ones, if they could raze a port.”

“We might be dealing with a kingdom,” Glimmer said. “They would have the resources for such an expedition. But which kingdom? Few have the ships for this.”

“They can find ships with experienced crews for hire,” Sea Hawk told them. “But where would the ship be?”

“So… we might have to deal with a princess?” Adora asked.

“It’s a possibility,” Glimmer said. “Unless this is the work of the Horde.”

Seacat nodded. Shadow Weaver would’ve loved plundering a First One’s base. And she might have sent a secret expedition behind Hordak’s back. “Right. We have to be prepared for anything. And we need to find a way through the reefs.” Before they could find out who was on the island, they needed to reach the island first.

“How do we do that?” Adora asked. “Go diving?”

“No,” Seacat told her. “We’ll use the longboat. Mermista can keep the currents from smashing it against a reef, and we can find the safe channel like that.”

“It’ll be tiring, but I can’t think of a better way,” Mermista agreed.

While underwater reefs would slice open the hull of any ship, even a small courier like the Victory’s Daughter, a longboat would be able to pass safely over all but the most shallow ones. But the visible reefs...

“Fret not! We shall find the safe passage in no time!” Sea Hawk announced. “My dear Mermista rules the oceans as their queen! No depths hold any secrets from her, nor does any current resist her command! Other than the Maelstrom, of course.”

“And the rest of us wait on the ship?” Glimmer asked, apparently ignoring the Captain’s declaration.

“Yes,” Seacat told her. “Most of you wouldn’t be able to help.” Well, Entrapta might be able to whip up a device, but she would probably have to use the engine for parts.

Both Glimmer and Adora frowned. “And you’re going too?” Adora asked.

“Yes.”

“No. As the captain of the Victory’s Daughter, your place is here!” Sea Hawk contradicted her.

Seacat opened her mouth to set him straight - if she was the captain, then her word was law, and the longboat belonged to her ship - but closed it again. He was right, damn it!

“Good!” Adora nodded. Rather sharply, Seacat noted. “And we’ll be ready to come to your aid, should anything happen. Glimmer can fetch you in the blink of an eye.”

“Excellent! Let’s go!” Sea Hawk raised his fist to the sky. “We shall brave the reefs and pave the way for the island! Adventure!”

Mermista shook her head and dragged him towards the longboat before he could say anything more.

*****

“They’ll be alright,” Seacat said as the longboat pulled away from the Victory’s Daughter. Sea Hawk was standing in the bow, ready with the sounding line to measure the depth of the water, and Mermista was using her magic to guide the boat through the waves.

“Of course they’ll be,” Glimmer said. “I’m keeping an eye on them.”

“It’s an awfully strong current, though,” Adora pointed out. “We have to run the engine just to stay in place.”

“You should see the Maelstrom one of those days,” Seacat told her with a grin. “It makes this current look like a gentle wave on the beach.”

“Really?”

“Yes. It’s suicide to enter it, but we can safely sail close to it,” she explained. “Any sailor should’ve seen the Maelstrom at least once

to understand how mighty the ocean is." That's what the Captain had taught her, and he was correct.

"I should be able to build an engine stronger than that!" Entrapta piped up.

"And a hull that can withstand it as well, without getting crushed?" Seacat asked.

"It's just applied physics," Entrapta replied. "Measure the force that you need to be able to withstand, then build a ship that can do so!"

"It's not so simple," Horas, standing at the helm, retorted. "The Maelstrom is more than just a current."

Seacat nodded in agreement with him. Adora and Glimmer seemed surprised that Horas had spoken up - the big minotaur rarely said many words.

Entrapta, of course, looked intrigued. "Really? We need to go there, then! And explore it!"

"Maybe after we save Etheria?" Seacat suggested. "We're not exactly ready for an expedition to the Maelstrom, either." And she didn't want to head there without a lot more preparation. Showing Adora the Maelstrom was easy. Keeping Entrapta from getting herself and everyone else killed in her enthusiasm? That would be harder.

"Right. Beast Island first, then the Maelstrom!" Entrapta nodded.

Seacat returned the nod, then looked at the longboat. Sea Hawk and Mermista were already changing course, leaving a small buoy to mark a reef. "This might take a while," she said. At least they knew the direction from which to approach, or this would take even longer.

Adora didn't reply right away, so Seacat glanced at her. Her lover was staring at the island, dimly visible in what seemed to be mist.

“Adora?”

“What?” Adora blinked, then shook her head. “Sorry. Got lost in thoughts.”

“What about?” Seacat asked.

“Nothing. Just… stuff. The First Ones, and their plans, you know?

Seacat narrowed her eyes at her but slowly nodded. Adora was still hung up on the revelation that she was a First One, and that the First Ones had been planning to destroy Etheria to defeat their enemies.

She had to do something about that. This wasn’t Adora’s fault. Not at all.

It was that stupid bot’s fault.

*****

Waiting was the worst duty as a captain. Seacat paced the bridge, resisting the urge to keep her eyes peeled on the longboat in the middle of the reefs. She wanted to do something - anything! Not wait for others to finish their task - and stop putting themselves in danger while Seacat stayed safely behind.

“They’re OK,” Adora told her.

“For now,” Seacat replied before she could help herself.

“What?” Adora frowned.

Sighing, Seacat explained. “The only thing that keeps the current from wrecking the longboat on the overwater reefs is Mermista’s power. If she stopped, they’d be shipwrecked at once. And without Glimmer, we couldn’t save them - the current’s too strong for swimmers. Even fishpeople would have trouble, I think.”

“Oh. But we do have Glimmer.”

“Yes.” But that didn’t really help much. “And the island is called ‘Beast Island’. What if there are sea monsters lurking in the reef?” Adora perked up, and Seacat glared at her. “Don’t you dare! I just said the currents were too strong even for fishpeople!”

“But…”

“No!” Seacat shook her head so wildly, her ponytail whipped her into the face. She ignored it. “You’d be battered against underwater reefs and dragged around and underwater until you’re dead. You won’t jump into the sea here!”

“What if I stay on the sea monster?”

Oh for… Seacat growled and grabbed Adora’s shoulders. “No!” she hissed, her nose almost touching Adora’s. “Stay out of the water! Got it?””

Adora nodded with a grimace.

Seacat released her with a scoff and resumed pacing. She trusted the Captain and Mermista, but they were in the middle of a reef that had broken ships since ancient times if the Fright Zone’s records were correct. And they were trying to find a path to an island overrun with monsters where an ancient base was hidden that threatened the world.

And she had to stay back and wait until they were done.

She hated that part of being a Captain.

Waiting.

Scoffing again, she went down the hold. “How are we doing on crystals?” she asked.

“Oh, enough to keep this up for a week!” Entrapta replied. “We don’t need much power. Though we could save the crystals entirely if we pulled back a little more, I think.”

“No,” Seacat told her. “The seabed’s too deep for an anchor, and if we lower the anchor closer to the reef, in the shallow water, the currents will drive us against the reef anyway.”

“Oh. Perhaps we could build a better anchor?” Entrapta cocked her head.

“It’s the length and weight of the anchor chain that’s the issue,” Seacat explained. “And the anchor needs to hold and yet be able to be weighed.”

“Oh! Perhaps a retractable claw? Controlled by a line that’s run parallel to the chain?” Entrapta beamed at her.

“As long as a fish pulling on it can’t release the anchor?” Sent drifting by such an event wouldn’t be a good thing - especially at night.

“Oh. That might be tricky. Though if I construct a lock that only opens after a specific sequence of tugs, with some delay and resetting mechanism… although that would struggle with the pressure from the depths…”

Well, it seemed Entrapta would be busy for a while. And the rest of the hold was in perfect order. Nothing amiss, nothing in need of being tended to.

Sighing, she climbed back on deck. Castaspella was resting on a chair near the railing, under a sunscreen. She still looked sickly, of course, but it didn’t look as if Adora would have to heal her a few times so she could eat. Progress, of sorts.

“Anything happen?” she asked, walking up to Glimmer.

“No. They’re doing the same thing they’ve done since they left.” The princess sounded bored.

“But they haven’t left the area as quickly as the others,” Adora added. “They’ve gone deeper into the reef, too.”

That meant they were following a possible passage. Or a trap. Well, they'd find out soon - the longboat was closer to the shore than ever before if Seacat wasn't mistaken. And headed straight to the harbour. Perhaps…

The boat stopped. Seacat grabbed her telescope. Sea Hawk had turned in the bow to talk to Mermista. He still held the sounding line, though. And he… looked excited.

Then he turned away and the boat… continued. Into the harbour. Yes!

Seacat balled a hand into a fist. Sea Hawk and Mermista had found the passage to the island! Now they just had to return, and they could sail Victory's Daughter straight to the shore!

She studied the passage the two had marked with buoys. It wasn't straight - of course not - and twisted and narrow enough so any ship larger than a courier wouldn't make it without running aground - and tear her hull open on the reefs on both sides.

That would make using the island as a base for a squadron more difficult. No safe harbour for frigates, and any supplies would have to be shuttled back and forth with smaller ships. Well, that wasn't Seacat's problem. All she had to do was help save the world.

She snorted at her own joke, drawing frowns from Glimmer and Adora, which she ignored. Sea Hawk and Mermista were on the way back. That was all that counted.

Though Seacat wouldn't be able to relax until both were safe aboard the Victory's Daughter again.

She really didn't like this part of being a captain.

*****

"So, in hindsight, the passage should've been easier to find," Mermista explained. "If I had studied the currents instead of the

reefs. The safe passage wouldn't be safe if the currents could drive you on a reef when you try to pass through."

"It was an easy mistake to make," Sea Hawk added. "I made the same mistake, after all!" He beamed at her. "And one has to note that the tides make the difference - we wouldn't have noticed the passage by checking the current if the tides weren't right."

Seacat nodded. That made sense. Without an engine, the ships would've had to use sails, and that would've required the winds to blow just right - you couldn't tack in the narrow passage Mermista and Sea Hawk had marked. And if you had a longboat pull your ship out to the open sea with rowers, well… they wouldn't beat even a weak current. Indeed, it should've been obvious. The half of the chart they had hadn't covered the tides. Sloppy to overlook that. And having grown used to an engine that allowed you to ignore tides when leaving a port wasn't an excuse, either. Seacat should've known better.

"So, we can now land?" Adora asked, beaming at them. She couldn't have known better, of course, being a landlubber.

"We'll have to wait for high tide," Mermista told her. "Another hour."

"Ah."

"Yes. But I think a little rest will do you good," Seacat told the Captain and Mermista. "Actual rest," she added - both of them looked weary indeed.

"Ah, but I can hardly rest with our goal so close!" Sea Hawk said, raising his fist. "I can hear it calling out to me! It says…"

"It says: Come to bed for a while," Mermista interrupted him by grabbing his arm and dragging him off to the captain's cabin.

Seacat hoped they would actually sleep for an hour.

“So,” she turned to address the rest. “Get ready for landfall. I want the guns loaded with standard shells and ready to fire on anything that threatens us. And everything tied down, in case we need to leave quickly.”

“Aye aye, Captain!” Licy saluted.

“Well, I’m ready!” Adora announced.

“As are we,” Glimmer added.

“I’ll check the engine!”

Castaspella didn’t say anything. She was still breathing very carefully.

“I’m ready to punch and sting anything that threatens us,” the bug princess said, once more smashing her pincers together. Seacat briefly wondered if she would accidentally crack them one day.

“I’ll make sure there’s no growth on the ship’s hull,” Perfuma said. “No plants, at least.”

It wouldn’t matter too much, not with a new ship, but every little bit of drag might count in a chase.

Seacat looked around. Everything was either being prepared or ready. Which meant more waiting. Great.

She sighed and leaned against the railing, looking at the island.

Adora joined her. “So… what do you think we’ll discover on the island?” she asked after a moment.

“Monsters, of course.”

“We already know that they are there,” Adora retorted.

“That’s why I expect them,” Seacat said.

Adora huffed. “Apart from monsters?”

“Someone who used magic to poison the Horde frigate’s water,” Seacat replied. “Someone’s on that island.”

“But who?”

“I don’t know. An expedition from another kingdom? Perhaps from the west?” Seacat shrugged. “We’ll find out.” And if whoever was on the island got in the way of saving the world, they would smash them.

“I guess so.”

Adora seemed a little… concerned. “What’s bothering you?” Seacat cocked her head as she looked at her lover, her ears twitching.

“I don’t know. Beating up monsters is one thing. Dealing with magic poison?”

“They used magic to poison the water. It doesn’t have to be magic poison,” Seacat pointed out. Castaspella had said so, and she was the expert.

“Right, right. Semantics.” Adora clenched her teeth for a moment - Seacat could tell from the way her jaw muscles tensed. “I just… I can’t do much against magic.”

“Other than healing?” Seacat grinned.

“Right. But that doesn’t stop them from trying again.”

“Beating them up does, though.”

“Yes. But… I haven’t exactly fought against a princess or a sorceress,” Adora admitted.

“You were trained to do so, though,” Seacat replied - and bit her lower lip. Reminding Adora of her time as a Horde cadet was…

Seacat didn't like to be reminded of Catra's training, either.

"Yes, but not as She-Ra." Adora turned around, showing her back to the island and resting her elbows on the railing. "It's just…"

"You're nervous," Seacat told her.

"I'm not… I guess I am?" Adora admitted with a sheepish expression.

"Everyone is," Seacat said. "They just hide it better than you do." She nodded at Glimmer and Bow, who were on the main deck, standing very close together but not hugging. "See?"

"Right." Adora nodded. She should know - she knew the couple better than Seacat.

And the bug princess and Perfuma were talking as well, in the bow. Seacat saw how the stinger of the Horde princess twitched - which showed how nervous she was. Probably. She might also be ready to stab someone, but that was unlikely.

"The engine's running perfectly!" Entrapta suddenly announced, popping up from the ship's hold. Her hair tendrils propelled her on deck a moment later.

"Well, she's not nervous," Seacat commented.

"Why not?"

"She's looking forward to exploring the island," Seacat explained. The princess didn't really see the dangers the island posed like everyone else did. "We'll have to keep her safe."

"Of course we will!" Adora said. "I'll keep everyone safe."

"And I'll keep you safe. Whether you like it or not." Seacat narrowed her eyes at Adora for a moment, then smiled. At least, she'd try her best.

Adora nodded.

Neither of them mentioned what they would do if Adora couldn't keep herself safe and everyone else. Seacat knew that Adora would pick everyone else over herself. And she wouldn't let Adora do that alone.

Which, Seacat was sure, Adora knew as well. And she didn't like it.

But they didn't talk about that. Instead, they wrapped their arms around each other and watched the island together. And enjoyed each other's closeness for a little while longer.

And Seacat found that waiting wasn't so bad any more. Not with Adora at her side.

*****

The Swarm

The tide had finally come in, and they were on the way to Beast Island's port. What was left of it, anyway. Victory's Daughter cut through the waves as Seacat turned the ship just a little more towards the north to align it perfectly with the buoys marking the passage. She licked her lips and took a deep breath - it wouldn't do to make a stupid mistake so close to their goal.

But the courier ship, propelled by Entrapta's new engine, slowly slid through the treacherous waters without coming too close to the deadly reefs on either side. It was a tighter fit than Seacat liked, but not an impossible one. A frigate would've wrecked herself on those jagged rocks already, though.

Whoever had settled this island had been crazy. Or desperate.

Sea Hawk was in the bow, sounding the water's depth. And Mermista was ready to use her magic to push the ship back if the engine wasn't strong enough. But they wouldn't need either. Seacat wouldn't make a mistake.

There came the first bend. It wasn't a tight curve, but still a little tricky. Seacat turned the wheel slowly and carefully, watching as the ship turned her bow. Almost… almost… now!

She steadied the course, and the Victory's Daughter sailed on towards the second bend. That one, too, she took with a careful turn. And then it was mostly straight sailing towards the harbour.

Seacat still didn't relax until her ship was safely past the reefs and they dropped anchor in the harbour.

Then she closed her eyes and sighed with relief. This had been… taxing.

"You know, I think we could use bombs to blow a safer passage through the reefs," Entrapta suddenly said. "An enhanced engine bomb could probably clear a passage for a frigate!"

Seacat looked at her. “That would probably change the currents with all the underwater reefs being destroyed.”

“Yes?”

“That might lead to more silt being swept into the harbour, and the need to dredge it up regularly,” she explained. “And the currents might grow even stronger.”

“Nothing a better engine couldn’t handle! And I could build a bot to dredge the harbour!” Entrapta beamed at her.

“But then, everyone could reach the island,” Seacat retorted. “That might not be a good idea, depending on what we find here.”

“Oh, right. I forgot about that. Although I could build bots that protect the harbour and the rest of the island!” Entrapta nodded. “We probably should do that anyway - even if we don’t clear the passage, someone else might do it.”

And wasn’t that a frightening prospect? Others with enhanced engine bombs? “Only the Horde and the Alliance have those bombs,” Seacat pointed out. “And the Horde lost the knowledge of how to build them with Hordak.”

“Yes, but it’s science! Now that people know it’s possible, they’ll find ways to duplicate it! That’s how science works!” Entrapta smiled, then frowned. “Which is usually a good thing but miiiight not be a good thing in this case. I think.”

Seacat nodded. More people with enhanced engine bombs… Well, perhaps the Alliance would hold in this case. And they would need closer ties to the Horde - the Fright Zone. Their soldiers would have some headstart for building such bombs thanks to their prior knowledge. At least Perfuma seemed to be getting along well with the Horde princess. “Well, that’s a problem we can solve once we have solved this problem.” She pointed at the island’s shore, about a hundred yards away.

She wasn't going to tie her ship to the pier. Not with monsters around. And they still didn't know who or what had razed the port's buildings. "Prepare the longboat!" she yelled. "We're going to the shore!"

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta jumped over the railing and landed on her hair on the deck below. "Finally!"

Seacat would've preferred to keep her safe on board, but they would need her should they encounter First One's tech. And Castaspella… well, the sorceress looked as if not even a giant monster would keep her from finally stepping on dry land again. Seacat wouldn't even try to make her stay on the ship.

Sea Hawk and Mermista, on the other hand, were still tired from sounding out the passage. And if things turned bad, they could save the ship with Alcy, Licy and Horas.

Which meant the longboat was still a little crowded but not too much when they finally cast off and headed to the shore. After a quick detour to let Adora and the Horde princess figure out how to row together.

Then they quickly sailed towards the sandy part of the shore. Seacat jumped off the bow and into the surf, sword drawn, and looked around. It looked, smelt and felt like any other tropical island she had seen, and yet… She felt the fur on her neck rise.

Beast Island.

"Something's out there," she whispered.

"Huh? What?" Adora joined her, her head turning as she looked around as well. "I don't see anything."

"I know," Seacat replied. "But I know it's there."

"Ah."

“Well, we suspect that whoever poisoned the frigate’s water is on this island,” Bow said.

“Finally, land!” Castaspella sighed with obvious relief as she climbed out of the boat, which the Horde princess had driven up on the beach.

“The plants…” Perfuma trailed off.

“What about them?” Seacat asked.

“They feel… different.” The princess knelt down in the sand and touched it with her hands. A sapling appeared, growing quickly as usual - but it grew crooked. Warped. And the fruits it bore…

Seacat grimaced and held her nose.

“Tiny frui…ew!” Entrapta let the fruits she had grabbed drop into the sand.

Seacat stared at them. They were rotten.

“This isn’t natural,” Perfuma shook her head. “I would have to use my power to keep the plans from growing… wrong.”

“The jungle looks normal, though,” Bow commented.

“Yes,” she agreed. “Which means this might be a new development that is limited, so far, to new seeds.”

“A new development?” Seacat clenched her teeth. “How new?”

“I can’t say. A few weeks? A few months? I don’t know what would be natural growth rates on this island. No longer than two or three months, though.”

“About the time we killed Hordak?” Adora asked.

“More or less,” Seacat agreed. “And about the time Shadow Weaver tapped into the Black Garnet.”

“Great.” Glimmer scoffed. “As if she hadn’t done enough vile things!”

“It’s just a hypothesis, though,” Entrapta said. “We need more data to verify or falsify it! So… can you identify what’s causing the changes in the plants? Is it a curse? Is it a princess’s power?”

Seacat really hoped that they weren’t facing another princess who could manipulate plants.

“It’s a sort of magic spell,” Castaspella said. “Not a power. But I can’t identify the spell.”

That was a relief. Seacat turned towards her. “Is it too old?” Like she hadn’t been able to identify the spell that poisoned the water?

“No. I’ve never encountered such a spell - it seems to cover the entire area,” the sorceress replied.

“Oh! Interesting!” Entrapta beamed. “That must be related to the First One’s base!”

“Or it’s related to something after the base,” Seacat said.

“Either way, it’s interesting! Something we haven’t encountered before!”

“Well, let’s stay out of the jungle for now and examine the ruins of the port.”

“Yes!” The Horde princess nodded sharply. “Someone destroyed our outpost.”

Glimmer glared at the princess’s back but held her tongue for a change, and they walked down the beach towards the remains of the Horde waterfront. The stone remains had already been overgrown with plants.

“More signs of this… corruption,” Perfuma said after touching a few leaves. “This was recently grown. Same time period as the

curse."

"Great. Something triggered evil plants," Glimmer said.

"And something definitely not plant-based razed the port," Entrapta chimed in. "Look at this!" she pointed at some stonework half-buried in the sand. "That was done by explosives!"

"And someone must have moved all the rubble. Either they carried it away, or they pushed it into the sea," Adora said.

Seacat took a look at the water. "It's down here. The seabed should be far deeper here. They ruined the port." If she had steered the Victory's Daughter towards the pier, they'd have run aground - well, not really, since Sea Hawk would've been sounding out the harbour, but still…. Someone really didn't want visitors. "Port razed, harbour filled with rubble… I don't think this was done by someone visiting the island to take it over," she said.

"They wouldn't have tried to wreck the port," Glimmer agreed. "They either wanted to keep anyone else from using it as a base… or they are on the island and don't want anyone else coming by."

Seacat knew on what possibility she would bet.

"Well, we're here anyway," Adora said. "And we won't leave! Not until we've done what we came for!"

"So… jungle expedition? The base is supposed to be located inside the crater in the middle of the island," Bow asked.

"Let's check the rest of the ruins here, first," Seacat replied. "We might get some more clues."

"Yes," Adora agreed.

They started to walk down the waterfront's remains, Perfuma clearing the plants with her power.

“Found one!” Entrapta announced after a few minutes. “Oh! It’s a bot part!” She was looking into the harbour’s water.

Seacat walked to her and looked at where the princess was pointing. Indeed, a segmented leg was poking out from under a heap of rubble, half-buried in the water.

It looked a little familiar. As if… Seacat frowned and tilted her head sideways. From this angle… The water wasn’t deep, not with all the rubble on the bottom, but there was a danger of getting stuck in the loose debris.

“Let me get it!” Adora jumped into the water.

“Adora!” Seacat yelled.

But her friend was already underwater, grabbing the leg. If she got stuck…

She didn’t. Adora ripped the leg out, then resurfaced. “Look!”

Seacat looked. And recognised it.

It was the same sort of leg that...

“Oh! Those are the same parts Light Hope’s bots use!” Entrapta said what Seacat was thinking. “I wasn’t sure. Let me check something…” She pulled her device out and ran it over the leg as soon as Adora climbed back on the pier. “Oh! It’s as old as Light Hope’s. Same generation.”

“So, that means the port was razed by First One’s guard bots?” Bow asked.

“It’s possible,” Entrapta replied. “Though they could also have been defending it against the attackers and gotten caught in the rubble.”

“It was supposed to be deserted. If they lost a bot razing empty buildings, then they can’t be too dangerous,” Glimmer

commented.

“I wouldn’t go that far,” Seacat cautioned her. “Accidents do happen.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times. “Especially when experimenting with bots. Like, say, giving them new orders to do something they haven’t done before.”

“Like razing buildings instead of killing people,” Seacat agreed.

Adora looked pensive. “If those are the same bots Light Hope uses… does that mean there’s another, ah, Light Hope here?”

“Oh! That would be great! More memory banks!” Entrapta beamed.

“I think that depends on the purpose of this base. Light Hope was meant to support She-Ra, wasn’t she? Train and help her,” Bow said.

Seacat scoffed. Manipulate Adora, more likely. And try to kill Adora’s friends.

“So,” Bow went on, “it depends on whether or not they wanted another such bot for this base.”

“Like for controlling the whole weapon,” Entrapta said. “Just tell her what to do, and she does it. That makes sense. Automated targeting and firing. Like my bots, but with a much larger weapon.”

“A weapon that will destroy Etheria if used,” Seacat reminded her.

“Right. That would be bad. But it’s a great idea, anyway. Imagine self-aiming cannons! Or rockets!” Entrapta beamed. “It’s a logical step from using bots - even a step backwards since they wouldn’t have to be mobile.”

A ship crewed by bots… Seacat didn't know if she should laugh at the idea or fear it. "In any case," she said, "we must prepare to face such bots. Hordes of them."

"Hey!" The Horde princess frowned at her.

Seacat ignored her.

"And we won't be able to hit the bot controlling them, not when we haven't found the base yet," Glimmer said.

"Too bad we didn't find the control box of the bot," Entrapta said. "I might have been able to find the path it took to arrive here in its memory. Or the path back. Unless they use a homing signal, of course."

"*I can go down and look for the rest of it," Adora offered.

"It's too dangerous to just go diving," Seacat objected. "If a bot got stuck in the rubble, so can you."

"Glimmer can teleport me back," Adora pointed out.

Seacat pressed her lips together. Her lover was right. She still hated the idea. But it might save them a lot of time combing the jungle for a stupid base. So she sighed and nodded.

And Adora stripped down to go diving.

*****

It took Adora almost an hour to sift through the rubble until she found the crushed remains of the bot the leg had belonged to. An hour of diving, moving some debris, coming back and waiting for the mud she had stirred to settle, and diving down again. She was obviously tired by the time she lifted the bot's body out of the water but she was still smiling widely.

"There!"

“Great!” Entrapta beamed at her. “Let’s hope the memory banks survived the water. And the crushing.”

“Oh.” Adora looked disappointed.

“But this is First One’s tech,” Entrapta assured her. “It’s built to last! I should be able to find something…” Her hair tendrils flexed, and the broken shell was torn off. “Oh, the communication crystal’s busted. But the control box is OK!”

Bow knelt down next to her, and Seacat took a step back, offering a towel to Adora. “Good work,” she said.

“Thank you,” Adora replied, drying herself off. With a little bit of help from Seacat. “I liked doing it, you know?”

“I know.”

“Using She-Ra’s strength not for fighting, but…” She trailed off.

“...for moving rubble?” Seacat grinned.

Adora pouted. “You know what I mean.”

“I know.” Seacat stepped up to her, rose on the tips of her toes and kissed her. Adora was dried off now but hadn’t dressed yet, and this was a great opportunity...

“Oh, here it is! I found it!”

Seacat sighed as Adora pulled back and started to dress again. Entrapta was a great friend and a genius, but her timing sometimes needed a little help.

She ignored the snickers from Glimmer as she walked back to the broken bot.

*****

“Alright! The home base of the bot is in the centre of the island - in the middle of the caldera. Well, the entrance is. It’s almost the

exact centre, too. I wonder if the First Ones liked the precision - or, maybe, they created the island in the first place? It's theoretically possible to create an island if you can control, say, a volcano. How long did your kingdom have control of the island?" Entrapta turned around and started walking backwards while talking.

"Uh… A few hundred years?" the Horde princess replied. "I would need to check the detailed records."

"So, less than a thousand years. This could be the work of the First Ones!"

Making an island? In the middle of the ocean? That sounded… Well, the First Ones could destroy an entire planet, so creating an island might not be too impressive in comparison. "If they made the island, does that mean they could've created the reefs as well?"

"In theory, yes." Entrapta nodded. "Although we might need to take samples from the reefs to determine their origin. A volcanic origin might support my theory."

"Does whether or not we're on an artificial island affect our mission?" Glimmer asked.

"Well…" Entrapta scrunched her nose. "Not really? They could've tunnelled under the entire island either way."

"Then we should focus on finding the base," Glimmer said. "Priorities."

"Yes," Castaspella agreed, looking around. "I don't like this jungle. It's steeped in strange magic."

Seacat wouldn't have liked the jungle even without knowing that. Too many plants to hide behind, too many ambushes. Too many sounds from animals to mask an enemy's approach.

“Well, it’s not enough to stop us!” Adora was at the head of their group, literally cutting a path through the jungle.

“But the bots could,” Bow pointed out. “And whoever poisoned the water. They must be aware of our presence.”

Seacat nodded. They couldn’t exactly hide the Victory’s Daughter.

“They are hiding. Or gathering their forces,” Adora said. “Probably both.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. They were one hour into the jungle, halfway up to the caldera, and hadn’t encountered anything larger or more dangerous than a dog. What was the enemy doing? Why didn’t they try to stop them?

“Or waiting in ambush,” Entrapa added. “If they have created tunnels, they could wait until we’re surrounded.”

And wasn’t that a lovely picture?

“So, stay alert!” Adora said. “Be ready for anything!”

Seacat wiped some sweat from her face and suppressed the urge to reply with something snarky.

“I’m ready for anything!” the Horde princess boasted.

A moment later, she yelped when the earth suddenly rose around her, then crashed down on her.

“Ambush!” Adora yelled, jumping back and landing in a crouch, sword ready.

“Scorpia!” Perfuma shouted, running towards the giant molehill that was all that was left of the Horde Princess. She knelt down and stuck her hand into the hill. A moment later, plants shot out of it, breaking it up - and revealing a coughing Horde princess covered with dirt.

“OK, I wasn’t prepared for the earth to swallow me,” she said, coughing and spitting out dirt.

“Are you hurt?” Perfuma asked.

If the Horde princess could joke, then she wasn’t seriously hurt. Seacat, blade drawn, looked for whoever had done this.

“That was… a spell,” Castaspella said. “They must be close!”

“No shit, Auntie,” Glimmer snapped.

“No follow-up attack.” Adora looked around, “Hit and run tactics. They’ll try to pick us off one by one or tire us out for the main attack.”

Smart. And annoying. Seacat hissed under her breath. Why couldn’t they face some dumb bots?

“Hello? We’re not here to fight! We’re not the Horde. We’re the Princess Alliance, here to save the planet!” Perfuma called out.

“Yes!” Entrapta yelled. “We’re here to fix the First One’s base! Can you show us the way?”

Right. If whoever was hiding here had driven off the Horde, then they might be allies. They didn’t have to fight them. Seacat nodded. “We can…”

A huge tree fell towards her, cutting off her words as she jumped to the side. “Hey!”

But more trees were already falling, some tearing other trees with them as they crashed to the ground, forcing the group to split up to avoid being crushed. And it left the ground covered with crisscrossing tree trunks and a dense tangle of branches and foliage. They were split up and isolated.

And the footing was worse than a deck covered in fallen and torn rigging. Seacat scoffed as she jumped on the biggest tree trunk

near her. “Rally!” she yelled. “We need to stick together!” This was almost the perfect setup for…

...a swarming attack, she finished her thought when her ears picked up the sound of hundreds of legs hitting the ground. “Incoming bot swarm!” she yelled, as loud as she could. “Get ready!”

Before she could say anything else, the trunk below her blew up.

The force of the explosion threw her through the air, and she barely managed to flip in time to avoid crashing head-first into a still-standing tree. As it was, the claws on her feet deeply dug into the bark as she absorbed the impact.

And she hissed as the pain from a few splinters in her legs and side registered - she was hurt. But not out of the fight. She quickly swung up on a branch, then looked for the others. Adora was standing in a small clearing of her own making. No, she was moving towards the explosion.

“I’m fine!” Seacat yelled.

“Cat-Seacat!” Adora whipped her head around, and their eyes met.

“Watch out! Swarming bots!” Seacat screamed - by now, everyone had to hear the sounds of moving bots.

She saw Adora’s eyes widen, then her lover gritted her teeth and nodded with that firm expression Seacat liked so much. “Bow, get up on a tree and start shooting as soon as you see them. Perfuma, clear the space and make some barriers! Everyone else, rally around me!”

Seacat pulled the largest splinter out of her leg, then jumped down. She hissed again when her leg hurt more than she expected but didn’t let that stop her from rushing towards Adora.

Just in time to see the wave of bots flood through the jungle and towards them.

Plants rose to deflect and entrap them, but there were too many. For every bot caught or stopped, two more swarmed over their bodies and continued towards the group.

“I can’t control the plants quickly enough!” Perfuma cried out. “Something is blocking me!” She stretched her hands out, more vines shooting from the ground, but that didn’t stop the onrushing bots, either.

Seacat was about to jump over Perfuma’s head to cover her - if they lost the princess, they’d die in the jungle - but the Horde princess was there already, in front of Perfuma, her pincers grabbing the first two bots. “Take that!” she roared, throwing the two machines back and into the next bot. All three exploded, taking two more with them.

A yellow bolt flew towards her from somewhere in front of them, but it ricocheted off the pincer she threw up to deflect it. Someone was shooting at them. But he was behind a wave of bots. No way to get them. Unless…

“Bow! Take out the sorcerer!” Seacat yelled.

“Hyah!” Adora swung her sword, and the first two ranks of the bots charging at her were sliced in half, exploding as well.

Seacat looked at the others. Castaspella had created a sort of glowing shield for herself and Glimmer, who was using it to smash the bots trying to get through it with her staff. Entrapta was behind them, fiddling with her device.

“It’s… I can’t find the frequency they’re using! It keeps changing!” Entrapta exclaimed. “Fascinating!”

Seacat blinked, shook her head, and went to back up Glimmer and Castaspella. They weren’t as tough as the bug princess or Adora, and if the shield broke…

Arrows flew past, towards the jungle in front of them. Seacat couldn't tell if they hit anything. A few yellow bolts came back, so Bow had probably missed.

Seacat leapt - or limped - forward and cut down a few stragglers trying to sneak up behind them, then started on the flank of the bots still trying to get at Glimmer and Castaspella. Her sword easily cut through their shells - they seemed weaker than Light Hope's bots. But there were so many of them…

Still, between Adora and the bug princess, they had the raw power to handle them, as long as they could hold off the swarm.

"Seacat! You're hurt!" Adora blurted out.

"I'm fine!" she yelled back. "It's just a few scratches!"

"I can see your blood!"

Oh. Seacat looked down. Her leggings were covered in blood. Damn. She cut down another bot, then scrambled back behind Castaspella's shield. Perhaps she needed to bandage that before Adora got even more distracted.

She hadn't even taken out some bandages before a wave of magic hit her. Healing her. Adora!

She turned, glaring at her lover, who was smiling as she lowered her sword - and was promptly buried under a wave of bots.

"Adora!" Seacat cursed and rushed the monsters. "You idiot!"

She cleaved one apart, cut the legs off the next, then stuck her blade through the head of a third, but a dozen more were on top of Adora, legs and pincers striking…

With a guttural scream, Adora rose, throwing the bots off her, then grabbed her sword and swung it in a wide arc, cutting more of them apart.

“You’re hurt!” Seacat yelled as she joined her, stabbing at two twitching bots on the ground trying to get up.

“I’m fine!” Adora replied.

Seacat almost hit her for that. “Don’t take your eyes off the enemy!” she snapped instead as she cut another bot in half. Above her, arrows and spells flew past each other - it seemed their enemy was focusing on Bow.

“Don’t let yourself bleed out!” Adora snapped back, smashing three with one sweep.

“I wasn’t!”

“You were covered with blood!”

“You were covered with bots!”

“I’m not any more!”

“I know how bleeding out feels, and I wasn’t!” Seacat insisted. Another bot took a swing at her, and she ducked beneath it, then stabbed its underbelly. It collapsed with lightning crackling over its shell.

“You were seriously hurt!”

“And you were seriously in danger!” What if the bots had been bombs?

“I’m not any more!”

“Save the lover’s quarrel for later!” Glimmer spat. “Focus on fighting!”

She could fight and quarrel at the same time, but Glimmer was right.

More arrows flew above them, disappearing in the jungle. Bow still hadn’t nailed the enemy sorceress. But he was still drawing

their attention - yellow bolts of magic shot out of the jungle in rapid succession, blowing up the trees behind them.

“Bow!” Glimmer yelled.

“I’m OK!” Bow yelled back. “But that enemy is good.”

Well, that was obvious. Seacat wanted to go hunt the bastard down herself, but there were too many bots still attacking them - and they couldn’t close ranks or they would get blown up by a single spell. Like…

“Watch out!” she yelled, throwing herself to the ground as another spell hit the ground near them.

Instead of exploding, though, or rising to bury them under a wave of dirt and rocks, the whole area started to glow instead. And Adora was closest. “Move!” Seacat screamed. “Move, Adora!”

Adora turned, but a bot jumped at her, and she had to duck to avoid it. And before she could recover, the area behind her started to collapse as if the earth itself were vanishing.

No, Seacat realised with sudden horror, it was as if someone was compressing the entire area in the centre; she saw a bot getting caught up in it get dragged towards the centre and squeezed like a lemon. “Adora!”

Adora’s leg was caught in the area. She was tugging against it, but she was getting dragged back. She stabbed the sword into the ground to stop it, but Seacat could see how she was straining.

And then Castaspella stepped up, hands flashing - literally - and the area suddenly stopped collapsing. The sorceress was panting. “This was… whoever is doing this is very skilled. I haven’t seen such spells before.”

“And he’s very slippery!” Bow added, landing next to them with a roll. “I keep missing him.”

Which was very rare, Seacat knew - Bow was a master archer.

“Then we need to take the fight to them!” Glimmer announced. “Auntie, cover us with a shield while we advance. Adora, Scorpia - keep the bots off us. Perfuma, keep the plants at bay. And pave us a way. Bow, Seacat - as soon as you spot the bastard, go and get him!”

It was a better plan than just staying here. And Seacat liked the thought of cutting down the enemy who had almost killed Adora. So she stuck with Bow as they gathered under Castaspella’s magical shield and advanced towards the other edge of the jungle, bots and spells smashing against the shield.

Adora and the Horde princess lunged, stabbing and crushing the bots who scrambled against the shield, but they couldn’t do anything against the spells hitting the shield - and Castaspella already looked exhausted. Sweat was running down her face, and her feet trembled while she moved forward.

But they were close to the enemy’s position now. Judging by the locations from which the spells were cast, they were jumping back and forth from tree to tree.

Well, Seacat could copy that! “I’m coming for you, you scumbag!” she yelled, dashing forward.

“Cat-Seacat!”

But she was already passing through the magic shield - which made her fur stand up - and launching herself at the closest tree. A green bolt of energy flew at her, and she twisted her body, making it miss by inches. Then she was at the tree, claws ripping into the trunk, and scaled it in seconds.

“To your right!” Bow yelled.

She turned her head, still scrambling up the tree, and saw an arrow hit foliage two trees away. Snarling, she pushed off, jumping towards the next branch. She grabbed it and swung up,

landing on her feet on top of the branch. Where was the enemy? There! Something moved behind that tree.

She dashed forward, on top of the branch, then jumped off again, claws digging into the next tree. Almost…

Something appeared in front of her, and she gasped, throwing herself back a moment before a bolt of fire passed through the space she'd been in.

Bow moved up, sending two arrows at the bastard, but one missed, and the other broke against a shield.

And then the entire tree Bow was perched on suddenly fell. He tried to jump off, firing a grapple arrow at the next tree, but another bolt struck him. Screaming, he fell and crashed into the ground.

Seacat cursed and moved towards his dazed form, but she knew she couldn't reach him in time - the tip of a staff sticking out from between the leaves was already glowing. No! She couldn't...

And Glimmer appeared between Bow and the enemy.

"Glimmer!" Seacat yelled as the princess reached for Bow. The stupid princess! She was too slow - the enemy was… Seacat blinked. No Spell. No crying. No death.

A moment later, Glimmer and Bow disappeared in a burst of sparkles. The enemy hadn't sent a spell at her back.

Seacat gritted her teeth and kept running towards the enemy's hiding spot. She jumped from branch to branch, cleaving through some foliage in her way. There was the enemy!

Only they weren't there. Seacat whirled, jumping around the trunk, looking and listening. The chittering of the bots, Adora scolding Glimmer, with Castaspella chiming in, but… no sign of the enemy sorceress. Or sorcerer - she had never caught a clear

glimpse of them, only some dark figure hidden by leaves and branches.

Cursing under her breath, she jumped off the branch, returning to the ground with a few leaps.

She reached the others just as the bug princess wrecked the last bot, and Adora healed Bow. “They got away,” she told them.

“They fled?” Adora asked.

Seacat shrugged. “Perhaps their magic ran out or something. They had Glimmer and Bow at their mercy.”

“Magic doesn’t ‘run out’,” Castaspella told her. “The caster might become exhausted, but that’s not the same.” The sorceress certainly looked exhausted.

Seacat shrugged. “It works out the same. And Glimmer runs out of magic.”

“She’s a princess; that’s different.”

She also ran out of lives, but Seacat didn’t say that. She knew better than anyone that Glimmer wouldn’t have let Bow die.

“So… we won?” Perfuma asked.

“The enemy withdrew,” Adora corrected her. “That can be a victory, but could also mean that the enemy completed their objective.”

“They tried to kill us, and we drove them away,” the bug princess said. “But this might have just been a probing attack to gauge our strength.”

If they could get such a number of bots for a scouting attack, Seacat wasn’t looking forward to facing a real attack.

“But as they know how we fight, we know how they fight.” Glimmer had stopped trying to crush Bow’s chest through hugging and stood up. “Next time, we will get them.”

“Unless they change tactics,” Seacat pointed out. “They were pushing us hard.”

“They are good,” Bow said, getting up as well. “I never got a clear shot at them. Almost never. And they have magic shields, like you.” He nodded at Castaspella.

“They used spells I knew, but also spells I never saw before,” the sorceress added.

“And the tactics?” Seacat asked.

Castaspella shook her head. “Nothing special, just common sense when facing superior numbers. They’ll probably focus on taking out Bow and myself next time. To remove Bow as a threat and me as our protection.”

She sounded rather matter of factly about the whole thing. Bow grimaced, and Glimmer grabbed his hand and whispered something in his ear, but the sorceress just laid out things. Perhaps she was too tired to care.

“Well, then we need a plan to counter them!” Adora stated with a grim expression. “I’m not going to let them kill any of us!”

“And what do we do?” the bug princess asked. “This feels like fighting in that weird wood of yours - monsters in every bush, magic working against you, and some shadowy enemies peppering you with arrows without ever facing you in open combat.”

“And you never found a counter?” Seacat asked.

The princess shook her head. “Flooding the forest with soldiers didn’t work because of all the magic. There were talks about cutting down the whole forest, but they never amounted to

anything - too much of an effort, and without magic of our own probably impossible anyway. Wouldn't have surprised me if the trees regrew faster than we could cut them down," she added with a grin at Perfuma.

The other princess blushed a little. "We'd have done what we could."

"Well, we do have magic of our own," Glimmer said. "Plenty of it."

"But so does the enemy," Perfuma pointed out. "It was all I could do to keep the plants in check. So much bad magic…"

Then things had been even more dangerous than Seacat had realised. "That means we need to stick together," she said. "No chasing after obvious bait," she added with a brown at Adora.

"Hey!" her lover protested, then pouted. "If we bunch up, we'll be vulnerable to attacks with magic. Like that crushing air thing." She shuddered, and Seacat reached out to grip and squeeze her shoulder.

"That was, as far as I can tell, gravity manipulation. A very complex magic - at least at Mystacore," Castaspella replied. "I wouldn't have thought it was possible to create such a strong gravitational draw, though."

"That's because they use First One's technology and magic together!" Entrapta piped up.

Seacat looked at the princess - she was kneeling in front of a gutted bot, one hand still stuck in its head. "See? The control crystals are First One, but the runes carved on it, and the smaller crystals… that's the work of a sorceress."

Castaspella quickly joined her. "You are right. That's Etherian rune magic."

"That's why I couldn't control their network: They're using magic for it!" Entrapta sounded happy about that. "They might even be

powered by the magic in the jungle! No need to return to refill their crystal reserves that way. The bots could patrol the forest forever! This is so fascinating!”

And very, very dangerous. Seacat pressed her lips together. Entrapta meant well and was a good friend. “Is there a way to use this against them?”

“Only if we manage to combine First One Technology with magic as well.” Entrapta beamed at Castaspella. “And since we’re here to do that anyway, since that’s probably needed to deal with the runestone network buildup, we might as well start early!”

And hope that the enemy didn’t attack them in the meantime. Great.

“We should move to a safer location for that, though,” Adora said.

“But we’ve got all the bots here!” Entrapta pointed out. “Enough parts to build dozens of them!”

“And we’re surrounded by magic trees that might crush us if the magic controlling them isn’t kept in check,” Seacat told her. “Just grab a few and let’s return to the ship. I’m getting thirsty, and I don’t trust the water in the jungle. Or the water we had on us. The enemy had plenty of time to poison it.”

“Ew.” The bug princess looked at her bottle. “That’s something we didn’t have to deal with in your wood.”

Seacat nodded. But it was something they had to take into account here. Well, no one had claimed that saving the world would be easy.

*****

The Sorcerer

"Are you sure the water's safe?" Glimmer asked, wiping sweat from her brows.

"I didn't detect any magic on the bottle," Castaspella replied.

The princess eyed her water bottle, then frowned. "I can manage until we reach the ship."

"I assure you, it's safe."

"I'm just…" Glimmer shook her head. "What if the enemy sorceress cast a spell on my bottle that no one noticed? They had a clear shot at me and didn't take it."

Seacat shook her head. "If we can't trust your own aunt, then we'll have trouble reaching the First One base without water to drink."

"I could build a machine that extracts water from the air!" Entrapta piped up. "With those bots, I should have enough parts."

Seacat shifted the bot head she was carrying from one shoulder to another. "And how heavy would that machine be?"

"Uh…" Entrapta briefly nibbled on her lower lip, then smiled. "I can build a bot to carry it! A water bot!"

"Wouldn't that be the first target in an ambush?" Adora asked. She hadn't any trouble carrying a complete bot. Well, complete except for the split head.

Seacat gritted her teeth and took a deep breath before continuing her walk. The faster they were out of this jungle, the better.

Even though she knew they would have to return to it as soon as Entrapta had analysed the bots and found a way to stop them or control them.

“So… should I build a water-bot?” Entrapta asked.

“I can’t hurt,” Glimmer replied. “And even if it draws fire, better a bot than one of us.”

Well, you couldn’t argue with that. And Seacat would be lying if she claimed that she wasn’t concerned about their drinking water getting poisoned by magic. She had once almost died from thirst; she didn’t want to repeat the experience. “Yes, but do it after you analyse the bots,” she told the princess.

“Great! And if I have parts left, I can build a carrier-bot!”

“A carrier-bot?” Seacat asked before she could help herself.

“A bot to carry cargo and supplies. If we had one, we could’ve taken a lot more parts with us!”

Oh. That sounded… actually like a good idea. “And we could use it to transport any wounded.”

“Oh, right.” Entrapta scrunched her nose and hummed something. “I might need armour, then, to protect the wounded. That means the overall carrying capacity would be less than planned unless I upgrade the legs and engine…”

Seacat sighed and prodded the princess to keep her on the path Adora was cutting - they weren’t taking the same path back to the ship to avoid another ambush. If this continued, they’d have their own bot army. Well, not with the number of parts they were carrying.

*****

A little later, back on her ship, Seacat finally allowed herself to relax. The water hadn’t been poisoned. But it could’ve been. If someone could poison the water supplies of a frigate outside the reef, they certainly could do the same to a courier anchored right off the island’s beach.

She tuned out the sounds of Entrapta and Bow working on the bot parts strewn across the hold and stared at the island off the Victory's Daughter's bow. The crater - the caldera - was so close. Two hours, tops, on foot. Three if you had to drag Castaspella with you - the woman wasn't fit enough to keep pace with the rest.

"So…" Adora joined her at the railing, rolling her neck and stretching her arms over her head. "What do you think?"

"Huh?" Seacat blinked. Adora's stretching had had interesting effects on her chest and shirt. "About?"

"The enemy."

"Oh. You mean, why did they withdraw?" Seacat tilted her head.

"Yes."

"Perhaps they ran out of power?" Seacat shrugged. "If they needed some First One crystal to power themselves…"

"Wouldn't they have retreated earlier? Withdrawing when you're out of supplies is a recipe for disaster."

"Force Captain orientation?" Seacat asked.

"You know I never had that," Adora replied, pouting. "No, officer school."

"Perhaps they weren't trained like you were?" Seacat suggested.

"They had good tactics, though."

"Right." Seacat shrugged again. "Then I'm out of ideas."

"Me too," Adora said. "And I don't like it. I hate it when I can't figure out the enemy."

"Well, you had an advantage before, having had Horde training," Seacat told her with a grin. "Welcome to how everyone else has

to deal with enemies."

Adora laughed at that. But both knew this wasn't a good thing. It would be much, much easier if they were fighting Horde deserters instead of whoever was facing them.

*****

"Alright! We've finished analysing the bot network!" Entrapta announced the next morning as she climbed out of the hold. "And I think we found - with Castaspella's help - a way to disrupt the network." She beamed. "We can test that next time we go into the jungle."

"I'd rather test it before our next trip into the jungle," Mermista commented.

"But then the enemy could adapt to our plan," Glimmer retorted. "We'd lose the advantage of surprise."

"And if it doesn't work?" Mermista asked, putting her hands on her hips.

"Then we're no worse off - better, actually, since we won't count on it working," Glimmer explained. "We need to reach the First One's base."

Seacat nodded. The fate of Etheria depended on it. And, she added with a glance at her lover, Adora's fate. Seacat knew Adora blamed herself for this. If they couldn't solve this… "So," she spoke up, "how long until we're ready for the next expedition?"

"Uh… I think Castaspella and Bow need to rest," Entrapta said.

Come to think, the two hadn't left the hold yet. Seacat took a step ahead and peered through the hatch. Bow was slumped over some bot, snoring, and Castaspella was sprawled on a mattress, asleep despite the slight motions from the waves. "Yes," Seacat said in a dry tone, "I think they need to rest. Did you work through the night?"

“Yes? It was important, wasn’t it?” Entrapta looked bewildered.

“It was,” Seacat assured her. “But… aren’t you tired as well?”

“I was, but my enhanced tiny tea solved that!” The princess beamed at her.

Seacat knew she shouldn’t ask, but she had to know. “‘Enhanced tiny tea’?”

“I distilled a whole pot of tea into a tiny pot of tea! Several times!”

“Ah.” Seacat forced herself to smile. They’d have to wait until Entrapta fell asleep and then woke up again before they could start their next attempt to reach the caldera. Well, there wasn’t much they could do about that.

“So, I’ll start on the water-bot now!”

Not much except for keeping an eye on Entrapta and hoping she wouldn’t break the ship or herself when she collapsed.

*****

Seacat sighed as she looked at the dark night sky. Entrapta had finally collapsed in the afternoon, falling asleep while trying to dismantle another bot. Just about the time Castaspella and Bow woke up. But without Entrapta being rested, they couldn’t go to the caldera. And Seacat preferred to reach the First Ones’ base with daylight to spare, anyway.

But it meant another night standing watch on deck. And with more people than normal, too - so close to the island, anything else would be too dangerous. She looked at the bow, where Alcy was checking the hull on her round. And at Emily - the bot was covering the entire main deck with her turret. Seacat grimaced at the thought of what a shot would do to the deck or rigging, but as long as the bot used canister shot, it shouldn’t sink the ship. A few small holes were a small price to pay to catch an intruder, anyway.

The carrier-bot and the water-bot Entrapta had managed to build before she collapsed were still in the hold - Seacat didn't trust them to behave on deck. Not without seeing them in the field.

She turned to watch the shore again. Even in the dim light, she could clearly see the sand and rocks. But that didn't mean she would be able to spot an enemy sorceress or sorcerer - not when they were using spells Castaspella had never encountered. And had been able to poison the water of a Horde frigate. At least they should be out of the range of most spells. But she had no doubt that they were being watched. A smart enemy would keep their eyes on the Victory's Daughter - and their unknown enemy was smart. Too smart for Seacat's taste.

Ah well. Another hour, then Sea Hawk would relieve her, and she could return to her bunk and sleep on top of Adora. Just… She froze. That series of splashes… it could've been a school of fish jumping out of the water, but...

She quickly scanned the sea. All was calm… no. The waves were different - there were ripples in the water. Fading quickly while the waves kept on, but she could see them. And the line they formed from shore to the ship. As if someone had skipped a stone on a lake…

Cursing, she jumped down on the main deck, then sped to the hatch leading down to the hold. "Alcy! Check the hull!" If that had been an attack on the hull…

She reached the hatch and stared down. Nothing… wait! Something was moving there in the shadows. Someone! She jumped down the hatch, drawing her blade a moment before she landed in a crouch. "Alarm! Boarders!" she yelled as she charged a figure dressed in a ragged cloak.

The figure whirled, and a light flashed. Seacat dived to the side, but she wasn't quick enough. Something hit her shoulder, and she was thrown back by the blast.

She kept her grip on her sword, though, and rolled with the punch, her claws digging into the deck to stop her before she hit the ladder leading up on deck. And the others were waking up.

The man - she saw a beard poke out from underneath their hood - moved his staff, and Seacat rolled to the side, evading another spell that blew up a barrel behind her. She rolled over her shoulder, tucked her legs in, then pushed off and launched herself forward, blade flashing.

Her sword stuck a glowing barrier, sliding off, and she barely managed to raise her left arm to keep from crashing head-first into it. Even so, the impact hurt her already struck shoulder, and she screamed with pain as she fell down, her blade skidding over the deck.

Once more, the man moved his staff. Too close to dodge. She saw his eyes flash and glow as the barrier faded. Seacat clenched her teeth and rolled forward, hitting the man's legs and making him stumble. She lashed out with her claws, but he jumped back, and she only ripped a strip off his cloak.

"Captain!" Alcy was there, jumping down into the hold as well.

"Watch out!" Seacat snapped - but Alcy was already dodging to the side as the man sent another spell at her.

"Seacat!"

"Ca-Seacat!"

"Captain!"

The others were coming! Seacat flashed her fangs. They had the bastard cornered now! She dashed forward, trying to ignore her hurting shoulder, but another barrier stopped her.

Then Glimmer, Bow and Castaspella appeared in a cloud of sparkles in the middle of the hold, and the man seemed to freeze. His lips moved, but Seacat couldn't hear any words - she couldn't

hear him at all, she realised. He didn't make any sound. But she saw glowing symbols on his exposed skin.

Castaspella waved her hands, and red spells splashed against the man's barrier. In return, the intruder slammed his staff on the deck, and smoke filled the hold. "Watch out!" Seacat yelled, rolling to the side. She had to get around those barriers!

She heard Castaspella mutter a word, and the hold cleared at once - just in time for Seacat to see the cloaked boarder *fade through the hull*. She gasped, turned - and raced up the ladder to the main deck.

"What's going on?" Sea Hawk asked as she dashed past him to the railing.

"There!" Another line of ripples showed the man's flight back to the shore. Seacat whirled. If she was quick enough… But by the time she reached the swivel gun, the man had already disappeared into the jungle.

She muttered a curse under her breath.

"Seacat! Are you alright?"

"What?" Seacat turned to face Adora. Why would she…? Oh. Seacat's shirt was torn. And she was bleeding. She hadn't even realised that.

"You're hurt!"

"Yes," she agreed.

Adora was already pointing her sword at her. A moment later, magic washed over Seacat's body, and the pain vanished. The shirt was still ruined, though.

"Check our water supply!" she bellowed. "The bastard managed to sneak on board by going through the hull, like a ghost!"

“A ghost?” Licy, standing there in her underwear and with a sword in hand, gasped.

“Like a ghost,” Seacat repeated herself. “Some spell.”

“It’s not teleportation,” Castaspella said. “The intruder must have found a way to render themselves intangible.”

“Himself. I saw his beard,” Seacat said.

“You did?”

She grinned, pointing at her eyes. “I can see better than you, remember?”

But not well enough to spot the boarder before he got into the ship.

“Well, I guess we know now how he managed to reach the frigate,” Adora said. “At least he can’t turn himself invisible.”

“He might be able to do that as well,” Castaspella said. “There are several illusions which allow such a feat, though most limit your movement.”

Seacat frowned. More bad news. “What about the water?”

The sorceress frowned. “I’ll go check.”

Seacat turned to Alcy and Licy. “Check the hull! If the boarder sabotaged us, we need to know. Entrapta, check the engine.” She looked at Horas. “Stand guard. Keep an eye on the water - the bastard leaves ripples when he skids over the water.” Oh. “Mermista! Can you feel if someone skips over the water?”

The princess, also in her underwear, like Sea Hawk, frowned. “It’s harder with the waves, but I can do it. It’ll tire me out, though.”

Seacat thought for a moment. “Do it. We are vulnerable. We can relieve you once we know the ship’s OK. We need to know what

the bastard wanted on the ship. And whether or not he managed it."

But even if they had prevented him from doing whatever he wanted, the sorcerer had already managed to ruin their sleep. Entrapta's use of enhanced tiny tea had let everyone rest during the day while they waited for her to catch up, but it would still affect them.

Seacat really hated smart enemies.

*****

In the morning, Seacat felt better. The water hadn't been poisoned - she must have caught the intruder before he managed to do whatever he did to the Horde frigate's water. The hull hadn't been damaged, either - not even where the bastard had faded through it; Castaspella and Entrapta had thoroughly examined the entire area. According to both, the 'structural integrity' of the ship wasn't affected. They were back on track - so to speak - for the expedition. And they did have a carrier-bot and a water-bot.

But the bastard was waiting for them in the jungle. Seacat knew it - she felt it in her guts. Somewhere in that corrupted forest, he was waiting for them with his spells and bots.

She gripped the railing harder and bared her fangs as she looked at the treeline at the shore, then at the upper edge of the caldera. He wouldn't stop them. They could counter his bots, and Castaspella could counter his spells. Otherwise, the bastard wouldn't have retreated when he was caught in the Victory's Daughter's hold.

"This will work, Seacat."

Seacat turned. Sea Hawk joined her at the railing. "Of course it will," she said.

"I mean it. You've driven off the enemy twice, and third time's the charm, isn't it?" He beamed at her.

“And what if that means the third time he’ll win?” Seacat raised her eyebrows at him.

“Oh.” The Captain blinked, then laughed. “I think you’re too skilled for that to happen. He ran from you.”

“He ran from all of us,” Seacat retorted.

“Well, we could all go on this expedition…”

“No.” That would leave the ship - her ship! - unguarded. “We’ve got a plan, and we’ll stick to it. We just have to reach the caldera and find the base.” She snorted. “And if we have to wreck more bots, we’ll let Entrapta build more bots from it until we outnumber them.”

Sea Hawk grabbed her shoulders and laughed. “That’s the spirit!” In a lower voice, he added: “But be careful. Please”

“Of course. Who was the voice of reason amongst our crew, huh?” Seacat cocked her head to the side as she smiled at him. And blinked twice.

“Good.” Sea Hawk nodded and released her.

She nodded in return, then bellowed: “Alright! Get the longboat into the water!” they would have to take two trips with all the bots to ferry to the shore. And they were wasting daylight already.

*****

“We could’ve taken the same path we took the first time,” Glimmer commented half an hour later, halfway to the ridge of the caldera.

“The enemy would’ve expected that,” Seacat retorted.

“They would’ve expected us to pick a new route, so picking the same route would’ve fooled them,” Glimmer objected.

"They would've covered the old route anyway," Adora cut in without looking back from where she was cutting down the underbrush. "They have enough bots. And they'll wait closer to the top, so they have more time to react to our movements."

"We haven't spotted any bot so far," Bow pointed out - the man was standing close to Adora, keeping an eye on the jungle ahead.

"That doesn't mean that there weren't any," Adora pointed out.

"Actually," Entrapta commented from behind them, where she sat on top of Emily, "my detector hasn't pinged on any networked bot yet. So… they could've sent some non-networked bot to scout us, but that would mean they had to walk back to report, which would make their reports late and leave tracks. So…. they might not have spotted us."

That was encouraging. Seacat smiled and wiped some sweat from her face.

"Unless, of course, they are watching from above us," Entrapta went on. "They could be tracking us through vibrations, too, as we walk - and seismic detectors would likely be common in any base inside an old volcano. Or use magic, I guess."

"I haven't detected any spells so far," Castaspella, who was 'resting' on the carrier-bot, said. "But if they know spells that I don't know…"

"The forest will be telling them where we are," Perfuma pointed out. "The plants can sense us and relay that."

"I guess there's no need to try and sneak up on them, then." Seacat forced herself to smile. She had been expecting that - this was the enemy's home base, after all. They had had months to prepare. And anyone who'd raze a port would do worse to drive off intruders from their island.

"Good. I'm not good at sneaking, anyway," Adora said. She briefly turned to Seacat and smiled. "And we know we can beat them in

an open fight."

They expected to beat the enemy, at least. And they would soon find out if they were right.

Only, no attack came as they climbed the slopes of the old volcano. Soon, the jungle grew less dense. Less suitable for an ambush. And then they saw the ridge above them, a few hundred yards away, with only scraggly bushes and some thin trees covering the steep slopes.

"Yes!" Adora exclaimed and stepped forward, sheathing her sword. "Look, guys! We've made it! Just a little..."

"Uh-oh," Entrapta interrupted her, "I just got a ping on the network."

Seacat clenched her teeth. "Where?" she snapped.

"Uh… lemme check… ahead of us. Lots of messages - commands. But… climbing? They're just saying 'Up!', nothing more."

'Up!'? "Are they on the other side of the ridge?" That would keep them out of sight. But wouldn't they hear them approach? Bots weren't exactly stealthy when they moved. Especially in large numbers. Seacat's ears twitched. There was something…

"Let's charge up the ridge!" Glimmer said. "Get the high ground before them!"

"Wait!" Seacat held up a hand. "I hear something!"

But it wasn't the sound of countless legs striking the ground. This was… more a grinding sound. Like…

Her eyes widened. "They're burrowing! They're in the ground!"

"What?"

Seacat dropped to the ground and pressed her ear against it, clenching her teeth at the sensation of wet earth. Yes. “They’re beneath us!”

“And around us!” Perfuma added. “They are ripping through the roots!”

A moment later, bots were appearing all around them, shaking off dirt and small rocks as they broke the ground from below. Roots followed them, trying to grab and restrain the bots, but they were too slow to catch most of the bots.

“I’m going to start the override!” Entrapta announced, perched on Emily.

“Protect Entrapta!” Seacat yelled and rushed towards the closest bot. “And keep an eye out for the enemy sorcerer!” she added as she dodged a swipe from the bot’s legs and cut its head off. Rolling over her shoulder, she jumped up, tucking her legs in to avoid another bot, and landed between three of them.

Whirling, her blade flashed, cutting legs all around her, but one connected with the back of her thigh before she could jump away. Hissing at the pain, she threw herself forward, below another bot that was climbing over a crippled one. She rolled to the side and stabbed up, her sword piercing the underbelly of the bot, then rolled on, just managing to get away before the collapsing bot fell on her.

Jumping up, she stumbled - her leg was hurt worse than she’d thought. A quick check with her free hand confirmed that she was bleeding pretty badly. Adora wouldn’t be happy.

She snorted at her thought and slashed at two more bots, then glanced around. Plants had tied up a dozen bots, and between the Horde princess and Adora, the bots attacking them from the front were being dealt with.

But the ones hidden in the jungle… She clenched her teeth and moved to intercept a pair of them trying to cut Emily’s legs. The

large bot was firing its gun, blowing apart another bot, but it couldn't be everywhere. At least Castaspella was shielding the carrier-bot, but the water-bot… well, Entrapta would have to fix it after this.

Another bot charged Seacat and ended with steel through its ugly head for its attempt. Two more tried to flank her, but she slashed at one with her claws while she parried the attack from the other with her sword, then whirled to finish it.

And more were coming! Where was Bow? She couldn't see him. She slashed at two bots, driving them back, and looked up. Ah, he was in the canopy, looking for the sorcerer. Good. The two bots were joined by a third and attacked again. She beheaded the first and fell back. Her leg was slowing her down now - and was she leaving a trail of blood? She needed to bandage that leg. But she couldn't. Not with the bots attacking her.

She cut the forelegs off the next, but the second caught her blade, and she had to let it go before she was trampled. Hissing, she swiped her claws at it, cutting through legs, pincers and then its shell with her claws until it collapsed.

She bent to retrieve her sword and almost fell. This was… Really not good. She had to fall back. Have Emily guard her back.

She glanced over her shoulder. She was further away than she had thought - or had Emily moved? No matter.

She started running. Limping. A jump turned into a stumble, and she got almost gored by a bot attacking her from the side. She managed to twist away, but its pincers still left a bloody line on her side.

In return, she stuck her blade through the thing's head, then pushed off and dropped into a roll that carried her to the legs of Emily. Almost…

She pulled the rest of her shirt off and wrapped it around her leg while she hid beneath Emily. That helped. She wouldn't bleed out

now. Not before this battle was over one way or the other, anyway.

“We need some help in the back!” she yelled.

“I’m on it!” Glimmer replied, jumping down on a bot nearby and smashing its head with her staff. “You’re hurt!” the princess blurted out when she saw Seacat.

“I’m fine,” Seacat replied, forcing herself to walk normally towards the next wave of bots. They must be coming from further away - the enemy couldn’t have buried so many close by. They were still more than she had expected. Who had built all of them?

“Got it!” Entrapta yelled. “And… Done!”

A moment later, all the bots suddenly stopped moving.

“Turned them off!” the princess cheered. “And now I can command them!”

“Seacat’s wounded!” Glimmer snapped. “Adora!”

“What? Coming!” Adora rushed towards them.

“Look, I’m…” Seacat started to say, but her lover didn’t listen - she was already waving her sword at her.

A moment later, the pain in her thigh faded.

“See, that’s…” Adora trailed off.

“What?”

“Your shirt!”

Oh. Seacat grinned. “Well, I had to…”

“Oh, no!” Entrapta interrupted her. “There’s one bot not listening!”

“What?” Seacat whirled. They could take one bot. “Where?”

“Straight ahead!” Entrapta replied. “It’s headed to the ridge! From the other side!”

Seacat turned. And froze for a moment.

The bot’s head cresting the ridge was as big as Emily’s entire body!

“Oh! That’s a new model!” Entrapta said. “I wonder…”

Then the entire ridge crumbled under the bot’s weight and started to slide down - towards their position.

“No!”

“Watch it!”

“Everyone, rally!”

Seacat cursed as she watched the avalanche of dirt and rocks race towards them, uprooting and smashing the trees in the way. This was…

Castaspella screamed a word Seacat didn’t understand, and a yellow shield appeared in front of them. “Everyone behind it!” she yelled.

Except for Bow and the Horde princess, everyone was already behind the shield. And Bow was just jumping down from the tree he had been hiding in. The Horde princess, on the other hand, had been caught out in the open, too far from the shield. She was running, but there was no way she would make it. Seacat saw the woman’s face - she knew it as well.

Next to her, Perfuma screamed: “Scorpia!”

Then Glimmer appeared next to the Horde princess, almost getting trampled, and a moment later, both disappeared in a flash of sparks - moments before the mass of dirt and rocks arrived where they had been.

The two princesses reappeared in a tangle of limbs in the middle of the group. “Ow!”

“Thanks, Glimmer!”

“Scorpia!”

“Everyone, get close to the shield! We need to stay together!” Castaspella snapped.

Racing towards the avalanche felt wrong, but the sorceress was right - if they were too far back, they would still be swept away and crushed. Seacat reached the shield and hunkered down, staring at the approaching wave of dirt, rocks and mud. If the shield broke…

Strong arms encircled her. Adora.

Seacat turned, grabbed her lover’s head and kissed her a second before the avalanche hit the shield.

The wave of earth and stone smashed into it, then broke, flowing around it - and over it.

“Brace yourself!”

“Emily!”

“Stay down!”

Clumps of mud and dirt rained down on them, and everything went dark. Seacat held onto Adora even as her lover pushed her down and shielded her with her own body. She felt mud covering her leg, something hard hitting her foot, and a rock digging in her side as the avalanche swept over them, only the magic shield keeping them from being crushed and swept away.

But they were still buried. Someone had a light - Entrapta! She was using her device. Seacat panted as she looked around. At the shield, there was a small, a very small space that hadn’t been

filled by the mud and rocks, barely enough for everyone - Seacat wasn't the only one half-buried in the avalanche. But the air would run out soon.

Someone sobbed. Seacat couldn't tell who. Her ears were still ringing from the terrifying sound the avalanche had made.

"We need to get out!" Adora yelled.

"Just let me…"

Perfuma cut Glimmer off. "I'll handle it!"

And plants started to shoot out of the earth, pushing against the dirt and rocks above and around them. Forming webs and digging into the mass that had buried them.

"Hurry!" Castaspella said. "I don't know how much longer I can keep the shield!"

"I am hurrying," Perfuma replied with a tense expression. "We aren't buried deeply!"

And they weren't - the first rays of light started to appear as the plants burrowed through the ceiling. More dirt fell down on them, but Seacat didn't mind. They were saved. They wouldn't die buried alive.

Adora rose, pushing away the last parts of the shell of earth and mud that had tried to kill them, and raised her sword. "Yes!"

Seacat followed her, pulling her leg free - getting the mud out of her fur would be murder - and looked around. "No!"

The huge bot was coming at them, climbing down the ridge.

"Damn it!" Adora yelled. "Incoming!"

She was already charging the bot. Seacat cursed and followed her. They had to buy time for the others to rally.

The bot's head swung around to face them, and it opened its maw. Something glowed inside. Seacat's eyes widened. "Dodge!" she screamed, jumping to the side.

A lance of red light reached out, and the ground near her exploded. What the hell was that?

She rolled over the smashed ground, scrambled up and dashed forward again.

"Over here, you dumb bot!" she heard Adora yell. Her lover was waving her sword at the bot as she charged towards it, drawing its attention.

Seacat cursed under her breath. That idiot! She jumped over a jagged rock, landed on a slippery patch of dirt that almost sent her sprawling, and reached the bot's huge foreleg. She swung her sword, but the blade barely cut the thing's armoured shell.

Adora, on the other side, had more luck - but not much more. The leg showed a gap with sparks covering the edges, but it was still working.

"We need to strike at its vulnerable spots!" Adora yelled.

"Tell me something I don't know!" Seacat yelled back.

An arrow hit the thing's shell, splashing green ooze over it. Acid, Seacat realised - Bow's trick arrows. But the shell held.

"Rahhhh!" The Horde princess smashed into the thing's leg, pincers sliding off the metal. She tried to grab it but was swept away.

And the thing shot more red light at them, blowing up the ground and showering everyone with dirt and fragments of rocks. It was focusing on Adora - and missing so far.

It wouldn't miss forever, though. Seacat snarled and jumped, digging her claws into the bot's shell.

And she started to climb.

The armour of the giant bot was hard, much harder than usual Horde stuff. And much thicker than the armour on the smaller bots. But her claws still cut it, and all that the thicker armour meant was that climbing was easier. Not easy, though - the thing tried to shake her, then scrape her off with another leg, and Seacat had to jump and scramble around the leg to avoid getting squished.

"Seacat!"

"I'm OK!" she yelled back.

"What are you doing?"

"Killing a damn bot!"

She hissed as she reached the body of the bot, jumping off the twitching leg joint and landing on the bot's side. More explosions followed - she saw smoke and dust get thrown up from below, but none reached her. On the bot's back, she was pretty much out of its reach.

Kind of sloppy, actually, to design it like that. "I guess the First Ones weren't perfect," she mumbled as she approached the bot's head. All she had to do was open up the armour and then start cutting and slicing the stuff inside. Like a brainworm from the stories sailors spun to scare each other.

She was about to start cutting the head armour when she heard something behind her. Whirling, she saw two smaller bots charge her - and more coming up behind through an opening in the bot's back.

Cursing her own overconfidence, she cut the first apart with her claws, then kicked the second off the giant bot's back. That left… half a dozen coming at her.

No problem. She grinned and charged them, the claws on her feet ripping into the armour beneath her. The next bot lunged at her, and she moved to the side, letting it skid past her and off the shell as she sliced her claws through the head of the one behind it.

A kick sent another bot off to join the rest on the ground but left her encircled by three. She dropped down, flattening herself against the armoured shell to avoid their first attacks, and kicked out, breaking legs - and sending herself sliding off the giant bot's back. Pushing her claws into the armour stopped her descent but left her pinned down - and another bot jumped at her!

She gasped and pulled her claws out, letting her slide, then fall down the shell, and the bot missed, bounced off and fell past her before she drove her claws into the armour again to catch her fall.

"Seacat!"

Oh. Adora must have caught that. "I'm OK!" she yelled as she started her climb back up.

The last bot was coming at her - and it was climbing over the shell. Its legs clung to the armour like a real spider's.

Seacat's eyes widened. That meant… she glanced to her side. Yes. The bots she had kicked off were climbing up the giant legs. Damn!

She pushed herself, scrambling up the slope, towards the charging bot. She had to time this perfectly.

Clenching her teeth and hissing, she tensed, then, a second before the bot reached her, she threw herself to the side, raking her claws over the smaller bot's sides as it went past her.

Her claws caught on something, and for a second, she was pulled along before she managed to rip them out and catch herself. This bot, at least, was done for - she saw it explode as it hit the bottom.

That left… two that she could see. She hurried to reach the top of the bot's back before them. One of them almost beat her to it, but she was faster and dug her claws in before raking its head. It froze, sparks covering the tears her claws had left, then tumbled down, blowing up before it hit the ground.

One left! She hissed, her ears flattening, as she faced off with the last bot. Easy!

The thing charged her - they never learned - and she crouched to block and then claw it.

Then she was flying through the air. What…? She looked back - a cloud of smoke, like from an explosion, covered the part of the bot's back she had been standing on. How…?

Pain filled her. She had been blasted off the thing's back, she realised - the sorcerer! And she was falling.

"Ca-Seacat!"

She was trying to twist her body. Land on her feet. But her body wasn't cooperating. Damn, this would…

"Gotcha, wildcat!"

Arms closed around her, catching her. Not Adora's - hard ones. Pincers.

As they hit the ground, Seacat cradled in the bug princess's arms, she gasped.

She had been saved by the Horde princess!

Damn!

"She needs help!" the woman yelled.

"Ca-Seacat!"

“Someone get the sorcerer!” Seacat screamed. She could deal with the pain, but if that bastard struck again…

“He’s on top of the ridge!” Bow yelled. At least one of them was on the job!

“Hold still!” Adora snapped, kneeling down next to her. When had the bug princess dropped her to the ground?

Then the now far too familiar feeling of magical healing filled her.

“There!” Adora beamed at her.

A moment later, Seacat’s dumb lover was flung away by a giant leg.

“Adora!” Seacat screamed as she whirled. The giant bot was facing her, mouth cannon already glowing.

She dived to the side, rolling over her shoulder, and was showered with dirt as the ground blew up again behind her. Something struck her back, right into her kidneys, and she screamed with pain - but kept going. Caught between the sorcerer and the giant bot, they had to beat both or die.

“Glimmer!” she yelled. “Get me up to the bot’s back!”

“What?”

There was the princess, ducking behind tree trunks. Seacat ran towards her, weaving to make herself a harder target. Another explosion, to the side. She flinched as she entered a dust cloud, almost stumbling on the uneven ground.

There! Glimmer was in front of her. “Teleport! Now!” Seacat blurted out. Behind her, the bot was already aiming again.

Glimmer grabbed her hand, and they disappeared.

And reappeared on the bot's back just as it shot at the ground where they had been before. Snarling, Seacat rammed her claws into the back of the bot's head, slicing through the armour.

"What do I do?" Glimmer asked.

"Keep the sorcerer from hitting me!" Seacat snapped back as she tore a fist-sized piece of armour out. She needed more to reach the bot's control unit.

"But… I can't stop a spell!"

"Be ready to get us out of the way, then!" Seacat replied, widening the hoe. She could already see the first crystals shining inside.

Any moment, the sorcerer would attack. She had to hurry - they couldn't last much longer. Even with Bow and Castaspella keeping the enemy busy. And Adora…

Seacat clenched her teeth. Adora was fine. She had taken worse than a kick. She killed sea monsters for fun.

Snarling, she stuck her arm through the hole and started shredding the crystals she could reach. The bot faltered but didn't fall. Not enough.

She pulled back and ripped into the armour again until she had torn a hole big enough to slip through.

"Let me!" Glimmer said, pushing against her side.

"What?"

But the princess had already stuck the tip of her shaft through the hole, baring her teeth.

A moment later, something blew up inside, and smoke started to escape through the hole.

And the giant bot stopped moving. For a second. Then it started to topple over.

Glimmer screamed, struggling with the staff, but Seacat grabbed her and jumped off the bot before it crashed to the ground.

One down. One to go. She dropped Glimmer to the ground and whirled, looking at the sorcerer.

The man was fighting both Bow and Castaspella, who looked exhausted. And Bow's arrows kept hitting magic shields. But now, with Scorpia no longer having to distract the bot from attacking Entrapta and Perfuma, they could focus on the sorcerer.

"Rahhh!"

And there was Adora, charging up the slope. Yes!

The sorcerer turned, stumbled for a moment - and an arrow slipped past his shield, hitting him.

No, ripping his cowl off - the man seemed unhurt. So close!

Then Castaspella gasped and sank to her knees. "Micah?"

"Micah?" Glimmer echoed, gasping as well.

Seacat knew she was missing something.

*****

The Missing King

“Micah? Who’s Micah?” Seacat blurted as she stared at the sorcerer on top of the ridge. He seemed to have frozen in the act of casting a spell with his staff or something. She was sure she hadn’t seen him before - she would remember such a pale face and those jagged black tattoos covering his skin.

“Micah’s…” Glimmer trailed off.

“My brother,” Castaspella said.

“Dad,” Glimmer added.

What? Seacat blinked. Wasn’t Glimmer’s father dead?

“Rahhh!” Adora yelled as she raced up the last few yards to the top of the ridge.

The sorcerer - Micah - jerked, looked at Adora, then vanished down the other side of the ridge.

“Adora! No!” Glimmer yelled - more than a little belatedly.

And Adora stopped, sword held high, right on top of the ridge, glancing over her shoulder. “What?”

“Don’t kill him!” Glimmer yelled, starting to run up the slope as well.

“What?” Adora turned, then turned back. “He’s gone! What’s going on?” she yelled after a moment.

That was a good question, Seacat thought. A very good question. “Let’s get up the ridge and secure it before the enemies return!” she snapped.

“No! We need to recover Emily!” Entrapta objected. “She was carried away in the landslide! As were Water-Bot and Carrier-Bot!”

Seacat blinked. Right. The bots.

“We don’t have…” Castaspella started to say.

Seacat interrupted her with a raised hand. “Alright. “Scorpia, Perfuma, can you help Entrapta? We’ll secure the ridge.” Those two should be enough to keep her safe and help dig out whatever remained of the three bots.

“Alright,” Perfuma said, smiling at Entrapta. “Don’t worry, we’ll find them!”

Scorpia nodded, though she glanced back at the ridge.

“We won’t leave without you,” Seacat told her.

“I don’t think you would,” she replied. “But something’s...”

“We’ll find out what’s going on,” Seacat said as she started to climb the slope herself. After taking her shirt off her thigh and wrapping it around her chest. Then she had to wait and help Castaspella, who was too exhausted to easily make the climb. But they made it without Seacat having to carry her.

“So…” she asked as soon as she reached the ridge. “What’s going on?”

“I don’t know!” Glimmer said, sniffling.

“We were fighting Glimmer’s dad,” Adora said.

“I thought he was dead,” Seacat said.

“So did I!” Glimmer replied, shaking her head.

“Why would your dad fight us? He had to realise that we’re from the Alliance!” Adora shook her head.

“Did we tell him?” Bow asked.

“Yes, we did,” Seacat told her. “Perfuma shouted it out in the first battle.”

“But…” Bow started to object.

“He must be possessed,” Castaspella said. She wasn’t looking at them, Seacat noted - she was staring down the slope, into the crater, which was covered in jungle, with a lake in the middle. “Or cursed. The pale skin, the black lines… That’s not normal!”

“Uh…” Adora grimaced. “Are you sure that’s him? And not some… monster that looks like him?”

“He looks like Micah,” Castaspella said. “Just with different skin. And some of his spells… Micah used them when we sparred.”

“Yes,” Glimmer quickly agreed. “And he didn’t attack me when he saw me!”

Seacat frowned. That was true - the sorcerer had shown some hesitation, at least at directly attacking Glimmer. But he had also sent hordes of bots against them.

“He still attacked us, though,” Bow said. “And with an army of bots. And that monster.” He pointed at the wreck of the giant bot below them.

“He must be magically controlled,” Glimmer said.

Castaspella was still not looking at them. “Or he’s…” She trailed off, biting her lower lip.

“What?” Glimmer scowled and walked up to her aunt, almost slipping on a loose patch of earth. “What do you think happened?”

“I’ve seen those sorts of marks before,” Castaspella said.

“What? Where?” Glimmer

“When Light Spinner became Shadow Weaver,” Castaspella said.

Seacat gasped. Shadow Weaver? That monster? But…

“She did have dark marks on her skin,” Adora said in a small voice. “I saw them once when I entered her room and surprised her. But they didn’t quite look like those, I think.”

“Really?” Glimmer turned. “So, it’s not the same!”

“Shadow Weaver fought differently, too,” Adora added.

“Because she was changed. But she was Micah’s teacher,” Castaspella told them. “Before she was turned into… what she was.”

“No!” Glimmer shook her head. “Dad’s not like Shadow Weaver!”

“But why is he attacking us, then?” Seacat asked.

“He’s under a spell! We just have to break that spell!” Glimmer replied.

Seacat looked at Castaspella. She was glancing at Glimmer, but the sorceress didn’t look as confident - or desperate - as the princess.

“You can break the spell, Auntie!” Glimmer told her, gripping her hands.

“I’ll try,” Castaspella said. “But…”

“No ‘but’! We’ll save Dad!” Glimmer clenched her teeth. “We’ll save him, and then we kill whatever Horde scum did this to him!”

“If they’re still alive,” Seacat pointed out.

“What do you mean?” Glimmer turned to her.

“He was captured by the Horde and sent here instead of having been killed,” Seacat explained. “That probably was done on the orders or with the knowledge of Shadow Weaver.”

“Do you think she did this to him?” Glimmer gasped.

Seacat shrugged. “I wouldn’t put it past her.”

“Uh… I think it’s possible,” Adora added unprompted. “She did try to kill Ca-Seacat, after all.”

“But if she used the same spell she tried on Micah…” Castaspella said.

“What?” Glimmer asked. “Tell us!”

The sorceress took a deep breath. “If she did… then there might be no way to save him.”

“No!” Glimmer screamed. “We can save him! Adora can heal him!”

“Uh… I don’t know if I can heal… possession?” Adora grimaced.

Glimmer turned and glared at her. “Yes. You. Can.”

“Uh… right!” Adora’s smile wouldn’t have fooled a drunk, blind sailor, but Glimmer nodded. “We need to capture him.”

Well, Seacat could get behind that. Whatever was up with Glimmer’s dad, he was trying to keep them from reaching the First One’s base here.

“And how do we do that?” Bow asked. “He can fade through solid material with his magic. And I have trouble hitting him with my trick arrows.”

“I knock him out?” Adora suggested.

“As long as you don’t accidentally kill him…” Seacat said. Though she couldn’t help wondering - privately - if the sorcerer might have died already, and something was animating his corpse. He was so pale, and those lines on his body… She knew those tales about ghost ships and walking corpses she knew were just scary stories sailors told in taverns, but she also knew magic could do

the impossible. A dead body, possessed by magic… She suppressed a shudder.

“Yes. Don’t kill dad,” Glimmer said.

Bow wrapped his arms around her shoulders - he must have noticed as well that she was pressing her lips together and standing far too straight to be OK - and she took a few shivering breaths when she turned to hug him.

Everyone else looked away. Seacat checked on Entrapta and the others down the slope. They were digging out… She narrowed her eyes. Ah, that looked like Emily. Emily after having been keelhauled a few dozen times. But there didn’t seem to be any danger around - Perfuma’s plants had already pushed the bot’s remains to the surface.

When she turned back to the others, Glimmer had recovered her composure. And Adora looked as determined as ever. “I could just blast him with magic healing,” she said, raising her sword.

“He might dodge it,” Bow pointed out. “He dodged most of our attacks.”

“It’s not an attack,” Adora objected.

“It looks like one - you point the sword at him, energy shoots out of it…” Seacat shrugged. “If you don’t know better, it looks pretty much like an attack,”

“But… it’s not!” Adora pouted.

“We know that, but he doesn’t,” Bow told her.

“Yes. Healing magic is very rare - the kind of healing magic that works as fast as yours,” Castaspella said. “And speaking of healing…”

Adora gasped, pressing a hand in front of her mouth. “Oh, no! I totally forgot!”

A moment later, Castaspella was bathed in the magic and sighed with relief. “Ah… thank you.”

“So, you can recharge her?” Glimmer asked Adora.

“She can relieve my physical exhaustion,” Castaspella corrected her. “It’s not replenishing magic - that’s not how a sorceress’s magic works.”

“Ah.” Glimmer nodded. “Didn’t Dad see you heal Seacat in the battle?”

“I’m not sure if he paid attention to that,” Adora replied.

“Well, he kept an eye on all of us - I tried making him split his attention and focus on me, but he still was able to avoid you,” Bow said.

“Micah was one of the brightest, most talented students at Mystacore,” Castaspella said with a sigh and a wry smile. “That’s why Shadow Weaver set her eyes on him.”

“Ew!” Glimmer grimaced.

“Not like that. She tutored him - in order to exploit his talents for her own plans. She used him to cast a very dangerous restricted spell.” The sorceress shook her head. “It changed her when it backfired, but Micah escaped unscathed. Or so we thought.”

“You think this might be the result of the spell?” Glimmer asked.

“I wouldn’t exclude the possibility,” her aunt replied. “But we won’t be able to find out for certain before we can capture Micah.”

Or his body, Seacat silently added. Out loud, she said: “Well, keep an eye on the jungle below us. I’ll go check up on Entrapta. And use the mirror to signal to the Victory’s Daughter that we’re delayed.”

Adora frowned before nodding. She understood that she needed to protect the others.

And Seacat needed to check up on Entrapta. If Emily was destroyed…

*****

"And her control unit and memory banks are OK!" Entrapta announced with a tired but wide smile. "Emily's OK. Well, she will be, once I fix her legs, and her cannon, and her power supply…"

"How long will that take?" Seacat asked, looking at the broken shell of the bot. A few lights were blinking, but nothing else seemed to be working - the avalanche had smashed the bot like an empty bottle.

"Uh… a few hours - I've got lots of spare parts here!" Entrapta nodded while her hair kept meddling with the bot's innards.

A few hours? That was a little too long, Seacat knew. On the other hand, she couldn't ask Entrapta to leave Emily behind. And they had no way to take the bot with them. Looking at the princess's smiling face - she could still see tracks of tears - there was only one answer. "Alright, I'll tell the others." She nodded at Scorpia and Perfuma. "We'll be working on ways to capture King Micah without killing him."

"I only need to sting him once, and he'll be out like a light," Scorpia reminded her - her tail wriggled above the princess's head.

Seacat smiled. "Then we just need Glimmer to teleport you next to him once he shows up."

"Exactly!"

*****

“How much longer will this take?” Glimmer asked. Not for the first time. “We need to press on!”

Seacat sighed as she looked at the princess. Glimmer was staring at the jungle below them, in the caldera. Where her father had vanished. “We can’t abandon Emily,” Seacat told her.

“Yes, we…” Glimmer pressed her lips together, glancing over her shoulder down the slope, where Entrapta was still working on the big bot.

“We’re not leaving anyone behind,” Adora said.

“Of course not,” Glimmer quickly agreed.

Though Seacat had a feeling that if Glimmer didn’t know that leaving the bot behind would mean leaving Entrapta behind, she probably would urge them to move on. Well, Seacat understood the feeling. If someone had cursed Sea Hawk like that, and he was hiding in the jungle somewhere… She pushed the thought away. They wouldn’t leave Entrapta behind. Certainly not in this jungle, where bots could swarm you. And possessed or cursed sorcerers could blast you from ambush.

Seacat didn’t think Micah would hesitate to attack anyone except for Glimmer and Castaspella. If he would hesitate at all. He might have done so - or they might have misinterpreted his actions. Or he had done so, but not because they were his family and he wanted to spare them. Perhaps he was looking for more victims for whatever had taken control of him? And Castaspella would fit the bill. And Glimmer had a staff, like Micah.

“Hey!”

Seacat looked up. Adora was sitting down next to her, stretching her legs. How had she missed that? “Hey,” she replied to cover up her reaction.

“Are you OK?” Adora asked in a low voice.

“Me? I’m fine. You healed me, remember?” Seacat smiled and elbowed her.

“I didn’t mean that,” Adora replied. “I mean… you looked pretty, uh, pensive.”

“Just thinking about our mission,” Seacat replied.

“Ah. The Heart of Etheria, or Micah?”

“Micah,” Seacat replied, glancing at Glimmer. The princess was busy talking to Bow. Probably planning their descent into the crater - again.

“Ah.” Adora swallowed. “Well, if I can heal him… Do you think I can?”

“I don’t know,” Seacat told her. “I’m not a sorceress.”

“But do you think I could?”

“I hope so,” Seacat replied.

“Oh.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. Now Adora looked sad. That wasn’t what she had meant to do. “The important thing is to capture him. We can sort out how to cure him once we’ve saved the world.”

“Right. We’re here to save the world.” Adora nodded firmly, then slumped a little. “From me.”

Seacat hissed and slapped her lover on the back of her head. “No, you idiot! We’re here to save the world from some thousand-years-old plot by people long dead. Not from you.”

“But…”

“No buts!” Seacat moved over, into Adora’s lap, facing her, then leaned in until Adora leaned back. “You’re not responsible for this.

Mara stopped it, anyway."

"But I'm a First One!"

"So? We both were Horde. And we left!" Seacat huffed.

"But…"

"No 'but'!" Seacat leaned in further until Adora was on her back, and she was straddling the taller woman. "You're not to blame for this. Not for the First Ones, nor for Micah - whatever happened to him. Probably Shadow Weaver."

"Yeah," Adora agreed. "That would fit her."

And she was sad again. Damn it! "And that wasn't your fault, either!" Seacat hissed.

"But…"

Seacat kissed her. That, at last, shut her up.

"No 'but'!" she said once they broke the kiss.

"Uh, alright…" Adora trailed off, biting her lower lip. "I'll try."

"Good. We're here to save the world. And blaming yourself isn't helping!"

"OK." Adora licked her lips, then blinked. "Uh… your shirt."

And Seacat noticed that her battered shirt, which was still sporting some blood stains from when she had used it as a makeshift bandage, had somehow fallen off during their kiss. "Oh." She blinked, then grinned. "What did you do?"

"What? I didn't do anything!"

"Really? You didn't want to strip me?"

"No! I mean… I didn't do it!"

“But you wanted to.”

“Well…" Adora looked away. And froze. Seacat frowned and glanced to the side. And froze as well.

Glimmer, Bow and the others were staring at them. Or glaring.

Oops.

*****

“Come on, Emily! I know you can do it! That’s it! One step after the other! Yes!”

Seacat clenched her teeth as she watched the repaired bot slowly make its way up the slope while Entrapta cheered it on. It was now noon - the sun was shining straight down on them - and the remains of the avalanche had dried out, so every step Emily took threw up a small dust cloud. But the bot, despite looking like a steel bucket someone took a few hammers to, ignored that and kept steadily advancing towards them. Entrapta had done it.

A few minutes later, the bit reached the ridge and settled down on all four legs. And Entrapta patted its battered shell. “Perfect! Well done!”

Emily beeped and blinked something in return which cheered up the princess even more.

“Great!” Entrapta turned towards them. “Emily’s fixed. Now I just have to fix Water-Bot and Carrier-Bot.”

Seacat winced. “How long will that take?”

“Uh…” Entrapta fidgetted. “They weren’t as durable as Emily since they weren’t meant for combat, so… Their memory banks are intact!”

But the rest probably not. Seacat shook her head. “Let’s take their memory banks and repair them later when we’ve done what we

came here for."

"But…" Entrapta sighed. "I guess that's for the best. I'm not sure I have all the parts for both. We have lots of broken bots, but a few specialised parts I took from my stash on the ship."

Good. Seacat really didn't want to wait any longer. And Glimmer wouldn't wait any longer, she was certain.

They had to reach the Heart of Etheria today.

"Let's go!" she said.

"Yes!" Glimmer jumped up so quickly, Seacat almost thought she had teleported. "Let's save Dad!"

"And the world," Seacat reminded her.

"Yes, that too."

"So..." Adora cleared her throat. "Is the plan still that Scorpia stings him?"

"Unless we find a better plan, yes," Bow said. "We need to keep him from escaping once we spot him - I have a few trick arrows left that might do the job. But the problem will be holding him once we have him. If he can fade through solid wood and metal, he can probably fade through what rope we could use to tie him up."

"Or through the hands we hold him with," Seacat pointed out.

"I'll keep him sedated," Castaspella said. "But it means I won't be able to do much else - keeping someone as strong as my brother asleep will take most of my attention. Unless you can sting him again without endangering his health," she added, looking at Scorpia.

"Uh…" The big woman scratched the back of her head. "I haven't actually done that. One sting generally takes out anyone, and, ah

- we had prisons for that."

Prisons designed by Shadow Weaver. Seacat clenched her teeth. Well, the witch was dead. And they didn't know if the poison in Scorpia's stinger would work in the first place - whatever controlled him might make him immune to such an attack. But they had gone over that before. "Let's go!" Seacat repeated herself and started climbing down the slope into the caldera.

Adora overtook her at once, as she had expected. As did Glimmer, which meant Bow did as well. Seacat would've preferred keeping the princess in the back, but Glimmer would never agree to that. And if Micah really hesitated to hurt her, she would be pretty safe up front. Hopefully, at least.

The giant bot had left huge tracks in this part of the slope, which made climbing a little harder than it would've been, she noticed.

"Eeep!"

Seacat whirled and froze. Emily was stumbling, legs failing to find purchase in the softer earth! If the bot lost its balance, it would roll down the slope. And Entrapta was balanced on top of it - if she didn't get thrown clear, she'd be crushed!

Seacat started towards them, but vines erupted from the earth, wrapping themselves around the bot's legs and stopping it from falling over.

"Thanks, Perfuma!" Entrapta cheered. "Emily's ground pressure is a little too high for this terrain, I think. I need to make climbing claws for her!"

Seacat had a brief vision of a bot with claws on its legs. It wasn't a nice image. Not at all. "Can you ease Emily down the slope?" she asked.

"Yes," Perfuma said. "It'll be slow, though."

“That’s no problem,” Seacat assured her. Anything was better than risking another landslide here.

She turned and saw that Adora, Glimmer and Bow hadn’t stopped - they were almost at the treeline already. Frowning, she set out to follow them. They could’ve waited for her, at least!

But they stopped at the jungle, and she caught up with them shortly afterwards. “Did you see anything?”

“No,” Adora replied. “But anything could be hiding in there.”

Seacat agreed - the underbrush was denser than in the jungle on the other side of the ridge. And their enemy, Micah or whoever had done it, had already proven that they could hide an army of bots in the jungle.

“So, we agreed to wait for Entrapta and Perfuma,” Bow went on.

Seacat glanced at Glimmer. Judging by the way the princess was scowling, she had disagreed with that decision. But as long as she went along with it, that was fine.

Seacat cocked her head, her ears twitching. “I don’t hear anything suspicious,” she told the other. Then she blinked. “And *that* is suspicious.”

“What?” Adora asked.

“I don’t hear any animals. Not even birds,” Seacat explained. “Either they are all in hiding and staying silent because something scared them, or… there aren’t any animals in the jungle.”

Bow winced. “Either explanation is bad.” He looked at the jungle with narrowed eyes.

Seacat nodded. “Yes.” She listened again, but she could only hear a few insects buzzing nearby. No sound of anything larger.

She really hoped that the animals had been scared away - she didn't want to enter a jungle where animals disappeared.

"Whee!" Entrapta arrived on Emily, which slid the last few yards to them, and the princess jumped off, letting her hair catch her fall. "That was fun!"

The bot beeped, and the princess frowned. "You were perfectly safe!"

Seacat wondered - privately - if bots could get scared. After surviving - sort of - a landslide, Emily might not be too keen on risking another. Seacat certainly wasn't.

Then Castaspella, Scorpia and Perfuma arrived. Perfuma looked a little tired - same as Castaspella.

"Something's wrong with the jungle," Bow told them. "Seacat can't hear any animals."

"Oh! Let me check my scanner!" Entrapta said.

Perfuma bent down and touched the ground, plants growing under her hand. After a while, she frowned.

"I don't detect any higher animals near us!" Entrapta announced.

"And I don't detect the usual signs of animals eating plants, other than insects," Perfuma added.

"So… something is keeping animals out of this jungle," Bow said.

"Or wipes them out if they enter," Seacat pointed out. "What could it be?"

"Something is controlling the plants, but that was the same on the other side," Perfuma said. "So, that can't be it."

Seacat tilted her head. Still, only the buzzing of insects. A lot of buzzing, actually.

Oh, no! She gasped. “Bugs!” she blurted out. “There’re lots of bugs coming!”

“Bugs?” Adora asked.

“A huge swarm!” Seacat explained, looking around. They couldn’t... They had to… How did you fight a swarm of bugs? With fire! “We need fire!”

“What?” Glimmer asked.

“Uh-oh!” Bow paled. “Do you hear this?”

“Yes,” Seacat snapped. “We need to prepare fire to keep them away.”

“Bugs? A swarm of them?” Entrapta asked.

And there they came - Seacat could hear the swarm fly towards them. And crawl.

Then she saw them. A cloud of flying insects and a wave made up of crawling bugs coming at them. They swept through the underbrush like a freak wave.

Emily’s gun bellowed. A second later, a bush blew up in the middle of the swarm. It didn’t seem to affect them at all - they kept coming.

Castaspella raised her hands, and a shining yellow shield appeared - just in time to have the swarm crash into it.

Seacat hissed as she saw the bugs cover it, blotting out the sun as they tried to find a way through it. And those were just the flying bugs. More were on the way. And the noise they made - it hurt her ears!

“I can’t keep this up forever - their weight is adding up!” the sorceress snapped.

“We need fire!” Seacat repeated herself, yelling loudly. “Something to burn them. Oil!”

“I’ve got one flask, but I need it to lubricate Emily!” Entrapta said.

“You can repair her!” Glimmer turned towards the princess. “We can’t be repaired if we get buried under bugs. “Dad!” she yelled. “Call them back!”

“I don’t think he’s hearing us over all the noise from the bugs,” Bow yelled.

“This is bad,” Scorpia said, loud enough to be heard. “I know those bugs. Flying Stone Wasps! They paralyse their prey. A swarm can even take down a minotaur!”

“I can construct a zapper!” Entrapta said. “Just give me an hour or two!”

Damn. Seacat growled. “We need to burn them!” But a flask of oil wouldn’t be enough.

“Wait!” Perfuma held her hands out. Vines shot up from the earth, winding themselves around the magic shield. Forming a wall. But…

“That won’t stop the bugs!” Glimmer yelled.

“Not yet!” Perfuma shot back. “But… Once the walls are ready, set them on fire!”

“What?”

“Set them on fire!” the princess repeated herself.

Adora looked at her for confirmation. Seacat nodded. They didn’t have a better plan, anyway.

Adora grabbed the flask from Entrapta, Soaked a rag with it, then wrapped the rag around a stone. “So… how do I get it through

the shield?”

“Drop it, then set the vines on fire and redo the shield!” Perfuma replied. “Hurry!”

That sounded like suicide. But they had no choice now - the rest of the bugs had arrived. “Do it!” Seacat snapped, taking a deep breath

A moment later, the shield disappeared. And a burning rag flew towards the closest vine.

And a new shield appeared around them - a fairly smaller one. And one that hadn’t kept all bugs out. Seacat swiped at the bugs trying to sting her while she heard shrieks and grunts from the others. “Keep them off of Castaspella!” she snapped, standing next to the sorceress. If Castaspella’s concentration broke...

Adora was there, swinging her sword - broadside - and splattering bugs around. But it wouldn’t be enough once the shield broke.

Seacat glanced at the burning vines. The fire was spreading all along the vines. And so was thick, dark smoke. Smoke… She narrowed her eyes. The bugs were… dropping in the smoke. And the scent… “What are you burning?” she yelled.

“The vines have aromatic oils in them. People use them to deal with bees to get the honey from bee hives!” Perfuma explained. “I thought of them after my first visit to Scorpia.”

“Oh.” Seacat smiled. “Good thinking! This will…” She coughed. The smoke was inside the shield, now.

“Uh… They usually wear masks,” Perfuma said before she coughed as well.

Damn, that smoke was nasty! Seacat had another coughing fit.

“Cover your noses with a piece of cloth! Soak it in water!” Adora yelled.

By the time they had managed to soak their rags, Seacat was constantly coughing and could barely see anything inside the shield.

But the bugs were dropping like flies. Or something.

“I don’t… feel… so good!” Entrapta managed to say between coughing,

“Get to the ground!” Perfuma yelled, then coughed, “The.. air… is better here.”

Seacat was already crouching and simply dropped down. The air was better, if not by much, but it helped.

And slowly, the buzzing noise disappeared, followed by the chittering noise of the ground-bound swarm. After a few minutes and more coughing, Seacat spoke up in the sudden silence: “I think you can drop the shield now.”

Castaspella didn’t say anything, but a gust of wind hit Seacat’s face, and the smoke started to clear.

Damn. She turned on her back and drew deep, coughing breaths. That had been close. Too damn close.

“We really need to capture Micah,” she said.

If he had worse tricks of his sleeve, they might not survive.

“We have to find him first,” she heard Adora whisper.

Well, that was the problem, wasn’t it? Although… “I have an idea!” Seacat said, grinning.

Adora would hate it, but it was their best chance.

“We need you to play bait,” she told Glimmer. “Lure him out so we can capture him.”

“What?” “What?” “No!” Glimmer, Bow and Castaspella blurted out.

“It’s too dangerous!” Adora protested.

“We know Micah hesitated to attack you,” Seacat explained. “We don’t know why, but he attacked others like Bow. So you’ve got the best chance here to avoid a fight.”

“Yes. He attacked me quite stubbornly,” Bow said. “But we don’t know if he’d spare Glimmer - if he *can* spare her.”

“Yes. And he also hesitated to attack me,” Castaspella added. “I should play bait!”

“No!” Glimmer shook her head. “You’re the only one who can deal with whatever spells he can cast. And I can teleport to safety if something goes wrong. And he didn’t attack me.”

“He sent his bots against you,” Adora said. “I should play bait. You can teleport Scorpia to him and strike him as soon as you see him!”

“We didn’t see him most of the time when we fought him before,” Seacat pointed out. “That’s why we need a bait who can make him hesitate.”

“Like I did before,” Glimmer said. She slowly nodded with a firm expression. “I need to do this. For Dad!”

“No, you don’t!” her aunt objected. “I can do it as well. And I can stand up to him, giving you more time to catch him. I’ve countered his attacks before. And we need you to teleport to him.”

“And we need you to deal with magic,” Seacat told Castaspella. “He might not hesitate to attack you.”

“Glimmer’s not expendable.” Bow frowned.

“If anyone is risking their life as bait, it should be me. I can withstand most attacks,” Adora insisted.

Seacat rolled her eyes. “And we need you to heal anyone hurt in the fighting.”

Adora frowned at her. “But I’m She-Ra. It’s my duty to protect you!”

“And that means not sacrificing yourself pointlessly,” Seacat shot back.

“What? You think this is going to be a sacrifice?” Bow looked shocked.

“No!” Seacat trend to face him. “There is a risk, but Glimmer can teleport. And Adora can heal her - if she’s not trying to sacrifice herself.”

“I’m not!” Adora claimed. “But I am the toughest. I will be fine.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “And Dad won’t hesitate to attack you. He doesn’t know you. You can’t be bait. It has to be me.”

Seacat nodded in agreement. “And we have to be ready to capture him.”

“And how do we do that if he’s too far away and Glimmer is the only one who can reach him?” Adora asked.

“Simple,” Glimmer replied. “I teleport to Scorpia, then to him.”

That was probably their best shot. It might be better to have Adora play bait, but they hadn’t been often able to spot Micah in the fights so far, and Glimmer couldn’t teleport blindly. She had to lure the sorcerer out. Even though that would also be much more dangerous for Glimmer. Not that Seacat would think that Glimmer would let that stop her.

She glanced at Adora, who was frowning as well. So, her lover probably shared her take on this.

“Glimmer…” Bow started, stepping towards her.

“Bow! I have to do this! I have to save Dad!” Glimmer shook her head.

“But… you don’t have to do it like that!”

“I’m the best choice for this.” She gripped his hand. “Please.”

Bow pressed his lips together, then took a deep breath. “I hate it.”

“But…?” Glimmer faintly smiled, and her eyes looked a little wet.

Another sigh. “I don’t see a better alternative. I really don’t.”

That pretty much summed it up. The two embraced, and Seacat sighed as well.

“Alright,” she said after a while when none of the two seemed to be ready to break their embrace any time soon. “Let’s get this organised. Before we have to fight even more bugs.”

“Oh, I think I’ve cracked that,” Entrapta spoke up.

“What?” Seacat turned to face her. As did everyone else.

“They had to control the bugs somehow, didn’t they?” Entrapta asked.

“Magic,” Castaspella replied at once.

“Well, that was one possibility. But I noticed some weird readings - there was a sound too low to hear by anyone of us. And it was directed at us. I think that was how Micah controlled the bugs. Or whoever controlled them,” Entrapta explained.

“A sound we can’t hear? Huh?” Adora asked. “How would that work?”

“We can’t hear it, but bugs can sense it,” Entrapta told her.

“Ah.”

“Like a whistle that only some people can hear,” Scorpia said. “We - the Horde - experimented with that a while ago, or so I’d heard. It was never fielded because concentrating so many people in the same unit, so they could listen to commands no one else heard, was not worth the effort or something.”

“Whatever,” Adora said. “You can stop another such attack?”

“Emily can! Once I modify her audio and speaker system!”

The bot beeped.

That sounded reassuring, in Seacat’s opinion. “Do that. And we’ll be looking for a good spot to ambush a king,” she told the princess.

“We can’t just walk around in the jungle with Glimmer in the lead,” Adora protested.

“Why not?” Glimmer asked.

“Micah would be suspicious of such a change in our usual tactics,” Adora explained.

“If he’s fully in control of himself,” Bow pointed out. “He’s been on the island for over a decade, at the least,” he said.

“We don’t know that,” Castaspella disagreed. “Shadow Weaver might not have sent him to the island right after he got captured.”

Seacat winced. She had been held by Shadow Weaver; she knew what that meant. And if Shadow Weaver had experimented on Micah or was responsible for his situation… “He might not be stable at all,” she said.

“He didn’t attack me,” Glimmer retorted.

“He did attack us,” Bow told her.

“He doesn’t know you. He knows me. And Auntie.”

“Anyway,” Adora cut in, “if he expects me and Bow to take point, we should do that. For a while, at least. Then we take a rest, and Glimmer plays bait. Close by.”

“How do we know when he notices her?” Bow asked. “If Glimmer yells, then he’ll realise we’ll attack him.”

Another good question.

“If we rest, I can surround us with a network of plants that detect footsteps,” Perfuma said. “I can’t do it while we walk, but give me some time, and I should be able to sense him near us.”

“What if he travels in the canopies?” Bow asked.

“That’s trickier. Trees don’t sense people climbing on them. And if I cover them with vines which could sense someone touching them, he might notice,” the princess replied.

“I can cover the canopies,” Bow said.

“But can you spot him in time for us to react?” Adora asked. “I mean, for us to send out Glimmer?”

Bow frowned. “I have to try.”

“Oh, we could plant sensors around us!” Entrapta said. Apparently, she had finished working on Emily. “I can use some of the sensors from the bots we destroyed. If you place them around our campsite, we’ll have ample warning of his approach. I think. Unless there’s magic that fools sensors.”

“There are ways to hide your presence,” Castaspella said. “But they mostly fool sight, not sound. There are spells to mask the sound of you as well.”

“And ground- and tree-based vibrations?” Entrapta asked.

“I…” Castaspella frowned. “I don’t believe so?”

“Great! Seismic detectors, it is! This will be fun!”

“Yes, fun,” Seacat muttered. “Well, then we rest here while Entrapta works on her sensors and Perfuma grows some plants.” And Seacat would try not to worry too much over the time they were losing - or the possibility of this ambush being turned into a counter-ambush.

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Seacat sighed. Entrapta was happily dismantling more bot parts. Perfuma had her hand on the soil again, eyes closed. Listening to plants. While she sat in Scorpia’s lap. “I missed that,” she said.

“Huh?” Adora stopped looking at the jungle around them, hand twitching over the hilt of her sword, and turned to face her. “What did you miss?”

“That they are a couple,” she explained.

“They?”

Seacat nodded at the two princesses.

“Oh! You didn’t notice?” Adora smiled.

Seacat narrowed her eyes at her lover. “And when did you?”

“Uh…” Adora blushed. “When Scorpia asked me for advice about courting. On the ship.”

Seacat blinked. “She asked *you* for advice?”

“Hey!” Adora frowned. And pouted. “I courted you, didn’t I?”

“I seduced you,” Seacat countered.

“I started it!”

Seacat chuckled. “Well, you weren’t very good at it, but I’ll grant you that.”

“Hey!” More pouting.

Seacat grinned, leaned over and kissed her. “And it was cute!”

“Mh.” Adora sighed. “Anyway, I just told her to be honest and ask. And it worked!”

Well, Seacat couldn’t argue with that.

“So, I do give good advice about love!”

Seacat snorted. “Are you trying to claim you helped Glimmer and Bow out as well?”

“Well…” Adora twirled her fingers. “I did nudge them. A little.”

Seacat shook her head. “Adora the matchmaker. Who would’ve thought?”

“Hey!”

More pouting and more kissing. Perhaps, Seacat thought as Adora held her in her arms, they could look for a little more privacy…

“And I’m done with the first batch!”

And there was Entrapta, beaming at them while she held up half a dozen metal boxes with red lights in them. “Here are the first sensors! They’ll detect people moving in a radius of ten yards, so think of that while placing them!”

“Thank you.” Seacat smiled at her as she took a step back from Adora, then looked up at the jungle’s canopy above them and did a quick calculation.

They were going to need a lot more sensors if this was supposed to work.

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The Crater Fight

“And here are a few more!”

“Thank you.” Seacat smiled at Entrapta. And felt guilty about having the princess work so hard on creating sensors when the rest of them weren’t doing anything in particular. Except for keeping their eyes open for Micah. On the other hand, Entrapta was having fun making sensors.

She walked over to the trunk of a particularly large tree under which Glimmer was sitting and waiting.

As soon as the princess saw her approach, she asked: “More sensors for Bow?”

Seacat nodded and dropped the metal cubes into Glimmers’s lap.

“Thanks.”

“No problem.” Carrying the sensors from Entrpata’s ‘open-air workshop’ to Glimmer wasn’t really much, but it was better than doing nothing.

Seacat turned to walk away. Perhaps she’d do another perimeter check - she clenched her teeth at Catra’s training resurfacing. Or she would…

“Seacat?”

Seacat stopped and turned back, cocking her head at Glimmer. “Yes?”

Glimmer wet her lips. “Shouldn’t… shouldn’t Dad have… found us by now? It’s been what, one hour?”

Seacat shrugged. “Your dad probably needs more time to come up with his next attack.” After a moment, she added: “And it

might be an attack like the swarm or the landslide. An attack that doesn't care about individual targets."

"I know," Glimmer replied. "But he tried that twice. He might try something else this time. And I have to try and stop him."

Seacat nodded. She didn't entirely agree, but there was no stopping Glimmer. She didn't know what she would do if Sea Hawk were possessed or something, but she wouldn't let anyone stop her either. No matter the risks. "We'll get him," she said.

"Yes."

Seacat didn't let her smile slip until she was walking away with her back to Glimmer. With every minute that passed, Micah would have more time to prepare. All the sensors of the world wouldn't help if he just set the jungle on fire or something. Not that a fire would be a great threat - they could outrun any fire thanks to Glimmer, and Adora could probably mow down half the forest to stop it from spreading.

As usual, it wasn't the things you could think of that you had to worry about. It was the things you didn't think of. And you couldn't really prepare for those. So, they'd faced swarms of bots, swarms of bots hidden under the ground, a landslide, a giant bot, and a swarm - two swarms - of killer bugs. And an attempt to poison their drinking water.

What else could a possessed sorcerer and a First One's bot come up with?

"Ca-Seacat!"

Seacat turned. Adora was walking towards her. "Yes?"

"I've finished a patrol. No sign of the enemy." Adora nodded, though Seacat had half-expected her to salute.

"We've been putting up more sensors," Seacat replied.

“I’ve met Bow on the way.” Adora sighed. “I don’t like waiting.”

“We can’t do much else,” Seacat said.

“What if he’s holed up in the First One’s base?” Adora asked. “Waiting for us to enter his kill zone?”

“We’ll send in bots first,” Seacat told her.

“I mean…” Adora looked around. “How long do we wait here for Micah to attack us?”

“Even after losing Carrier-Bot, we’ve got enough supplies left to spend a day or two here,” Seacat told her. A few dents didn’t mean a can couldn’t be used any more, after all.

“And what if those two days are what we would’ve needed to stop the whole thing?”

Telling her that that would be bad luck wouldn’t cut it. “I doubt that that’s the case,” Seacat said instead.

Adora stared at her for a moment, then sighed and slumped a little. “I hate waiting.”

“Who doesn’t?” Seacat asked. “But it’s either waiting or just pressing on and force our way to the base. I’d rather fight Micah on our terms.” That would make capturing him easier. She looked around. “But yes, we can’t wait forever.”

“No, we can’t.”

“But Micah’s been attacking us pretty regularly,” Seacat pointed out. “I don’t think he’ll wait too long, either. I think he’s just building up his forces.”

“Maybe literally,” Adora agreed. “He has to replace his bots.”

“How long does that take?”

“Light Hope never told me,” Adora said. “But I never asked, either. I should’ve.”

“We don’t know if this base has the same, worse or better resources as Light Hope had,” Seacat told her.

“I think it has more resources.” Adora shook her head. “Light Hope was just… one bunker for She-Ra. This is a base controlling the Heart of Etheria. They have to protect it better.”

“But She-Ra’s controlling the network. Or supposed to,” Seacat objected. “She needs protection as well.”

Adora frowned at her. “She-Ra is a protector.”

“Everyone needs protection sometimes,” Seacat frowned at her. “Even you.” Especially Adora.

“But…” Adora’s frown turned into a pout as she trailed off, and Seacat grinned.

“No one is invincible,” she told her lover.

“But some are harder to hurt than others,” Adora retorted.

Seacat shrugged. “That may be true, but…”

“I’ve got a signal!” Entrapta yelled.

Damn.

Seacat turned. “Where?”

“Uh… west by southwest, forty-five yards,” Entrapta replied. Then her hair moved, pointing. “That way!”

Glimmer was already moving. As was Scorpia. And Adora, of course - she was rushing forward.

“The plants…” Perfuma gasped.

“What?” Seacat turned to the princess.

“They’re dying! They’re… withering! All of them!”

What? “Stop!” Seacat screamed. “Fall back!”

Scorpia stopped, Adora almost crashing into her. “What?”

“Fall back!” Seacat repeated herself. “Something’s killing the plants!”

A moment later, a loud crash sounded from the jungle, Followed by another. And another.

“The trees are toppling!” Bow yelled, scrambling down from the canopy.

“How?” Perfuma asked. “How is this happening? I can’t help them!”

Scorpia picked her up and carried her with her as she fell back.

“Up the slope!” Adora yelled. “There aren’t any plants there! Everyone, up the slope!”

“Go, Emily! Go!”

Seacat clenched her teeth. Everyone was following Adora, except for...

“I don’t see Dad!” Glimmer yelled.

“Glimmer!” Bow grabbed her hand. “Come!”

“Run!” Seacat yelled at them. She was running herself, now. Along the path that Adora had hacked through the jungle before.

Behind her, more trees fell. She pushed on, claws digging into the soil as she jumped over roots and rushed forward towards the slope.

In front of her, Emily was struggling with some denser underbrush. Seacat slashed with her claws, cutting branches as fast as she could until the bot could barrel through the remaining foliage and continue. But that had cost her - she glanced over her shoulder as she dashed past the bot and saw a tree behind her topple - and turning grey as it fell. As did the entire jungle.

What the hell was happening?

"Something's… disintegrating the plants!" Entrapta gasped. "Down to the molecular bonds!"

Seacat didn't know what that meant, but she knew that it wasn't a good thing. And that letting whatever did it catch up with her wouldn't be good either.

But the thing was spreading quickly - and the edge of the jungle was still a while away.

And Emily's legs had trouble with the soft soil.

Seacat shook her head. This wouldn't do.

She sped up, then jumped, landing on top of the bot. "Entrapta!"

"What?"

"Hold on!" Seacat grabbed the princess, then jumped off again.

"Wait!"

Seacat didn't listen - she kept running. Even with Entrapta's weight, she was faster than the bot.

"Emily! Run!"

Seacat didn't look back. There was the edge of the forest!

"Emily!"

"Seacat! Entrapta!"

They crossed the treeline, and Adora was there, grabbing them both - and turning around, scrambling up the slope.

Seacat struggled for a moment - she could scale the slope faster than that - but relented halfway up the slope. Glimmer and Bow were there - they must have teleported - next to the others. And behind them…

Seacat drew a hissing breath. A whole section of the jungle had turned into a grey wasteland, all the trees and bushes gone. Even the grass had withered.

"Emily!"

The bot appeared at the edge of the trees, but too late - the trees next to it crumbled, and Emily vanished in a cloud of dust as they disintegrated.

"Emily!" Entrapta wailed.

Then the bot broke out of the dust cloud and kept going. Apparently none the worse for wear.

"Oh!" Entrapta fumbled with her device. "Stop, Emily!"

The bot stopped halfway up the slope.

"What happened?"

"Oh. It's organic matter that's affected," Entrapta explained. "Doesn't affect inorganic matter." She looked at them. "Like stone, metal - or bots. Which are made of metal and crystals."

"Ah." Seacat nodded.

"But what did this? And how?" Adora asked.

"Magic," Castaspella whispered. "It's a life-draining spell. But the scale of it…"

The jungle looked as if someone had burned a swath of it down to the ground. A gap leading straight to the lake in the centre of the crater.

The sorceress sank to her knees. “The power to do that… And the power it would grant someone…”

“Someone?” Adora asked.

“Like a sorcerer?” Seacat added, narrowing her eyes.

“If Micah cast this…”

Suddenly, a bright light appeared in the lake. Underwater. And it rapidly grew stronger.

“Look!” Bow snapped.

Something rose through the water, breaking the surface. A platform, shining bright enough to make Seacat’s eyes hurt a little even at this distance.

No, the platform wasn’t shining - that was the man standing on it.

“Micah…” Castaspella gasped.

“Dad!”

Seacat had trouble making out anything - the man was shining so brightly, it looked as if he was on fire. Blazing. She could see the staff, though, as it moved. Rose.

Pointed towards them.

“Take cover!” she yelled as the staff started to glow brighter as well.

“Emily! Run!” Entrapta managed to yell before Seacat grabbed her and dragged her over the ridge. They rolled down the other side, followed by the rest of the group.

A moment later, the top of the ridge vanished in a blaze of light, and more mud splattered over Seacat's fur.

She rolled over and got up just in time to see a cloud of dust rolling down the slope. "Cover your noses!"

The dust cloud engulfed them, and Seacat tried to breathe shallowly until it settled.

Then she looked up. The ridge… whatever spell Micah had used had carved a crescent out of it. Whatever had been there was gone.

If they had been just a little slower…

Seacat shivered.

"How can we fight *that*?" Scorpia blurted out as she got up, pulling Perfuma with her.

"We…" Glimmer shook her head. She was pale but raised her chin and clenched her teeth. "It's still Dad. I'll face him!"

"He just tried to vaporise all of us!" Bow protested.

Glimmer turned to stare at him, blinking away some tears. "What else can we do? He'll blast the entire crater apart! We have to try it, or we'll die anyway!"

Seacat cursed under her breath. The princess wasn't wrong. So much firepower… "He can't hide that glow. Once you see him, teleport Scorpia and Adora to him."

Glimmer nodded. Good. That was their best shot.

"Entrapta, Perfuma - fall back and hide! Not in the jungle!" Seacat told her. "Castaspella, you and Bow need to be ready to take your shot if you get an opportunity. Go find a good spot on the ridge."

"And what will you be doing?" Adora asked.

“I’ll serve as a distraction,” Seacat told her.

“No!” Adora shook her head. “You can’t teleport!”

“I’m the fastest runner,” Seacat retorted. “And we don’t have time to discuss this.” She turned to Entrapta. “I need some signal rockets.”

“Uh… let me check… I have some with me. I think.”

“Ca-Seacat!” Adora shook her head again.

“We don’t have a choice,” Seacat told her while she grabbed the half a dozen rockets Entrapta handed over. “Glimmer can’t teleport more than you and Scorpia - and you two have the best chance to capture Micah.” Or kill him, but she wouldn’t say that out loud.

Adora stared at her for a moment, lips trembling, without saying anything. Then she hugged Seacat. Hard. Seacat closed her eyes and hugged her back.

Then she pulled back and started running up the slope to their right. Castaspella and Bow went up to their left.

And Glimmer, Adora and Scorpia waited below the edge of destruction.

Seacat reached the top of the ridge, crouching to peek over it. Micah was still in the centre, glowing like the sun. But another path had been cut through the jungle - the gap was now double its width. Why would he…? Her eyes widened. Castaspella had called it a life-draining spell. Was that where the power for the giant blast came from?

If so, then they had an opportunity. If they could make him fire another blast, they could attack before he could recharge.

Seacat swallowed, then wet her lips. She glanced down to where Adora and the others were. They couldn’t do this. And letting

Glimmer play bait was too dangerous now.

Time to roll the dice.

She quickly laid out the rockets, roughly aiming at Micah. Then she lit them, one after another.

And ran like hell down the slope.

She was barely down the slope when the first rocket went off. Halfway when the fourth fired.

Then the entire slope trembled, and she was thrown down moments before everything disappeared in a cloud of dust. Coughing and sputtering, she tumbled down the slope, rocks and roots hitting her before she came to a stop at the trunk of a tree.

Panting, she got up and stared - half the ridge had disappeared. Again. If she had lingered a little longer… Shaking her head, and cursing the dirt on her fur, she scrambled back up the slope. Glimmer had already teleported with the others. Seacat had no way to reach the centre of the crater before the fight would be over. She should just take cover and wait.

She knew that, yet she ran up the slope. At the very least, she wanted to see Adora fight. See how…

She reached the remains of the ridge and gasped.

Micah, glowing a little dimmer, was *flying* towards her! And behind him, more jungle turned to dust. Where was Adora? She saw something move in the lake in the centre. Adora! But where was Glimmer? And Scorpia?

And what was Micah doing? He was flying over the ridge! And he was pointing his staff at… Seacat's ship! No!

"Hey! Bastard!" Seacat screamed, waving her sword at him. When he looked down at her, she threw the blade at him, wishing she had a bomb blade.

Her blade met a glowing shield and fell down again - but a yellow spell hit Micah from behind a moment later - Castaspella's work! And as Micah turned, a net arrow exploded in his face. Yes!

Seacat scrambled up the slope again. If she could climb high enough… no, Micah was too far away for a jump.

And he shredded the net with a wave from his staff before firing smaller blasts at Castaspella and Bow. The explosions were still large enough to cover that part of the ridge in smoke and dust. And Seacat was stuck here, unable to do anything! She grabbed a rock and threw it, but Micah didn't even bother moving away. Didn't even notice, she bet - he was focused on bombarding the ridge on the other side of the gap. And neither spells nor arrows flew back at him.

Seacat cursed again. She couldn't stop Micah from killing her friends! "Fight me, you Maelstrom-cursed bastard!" she screamed.

And Micah turned towards her. So close, and with the light around him having dimmed, Seacat could finally see his face. He didn't look angry. He didn't look smug, either - his unnaturally pale face covered with jagged dark lines didn't show any expression as he pointed his staff at her.

She tensed, preparing to leap to the side. If she could dodge behind the rock there, she might evade his first blast. The next, though...

The tip of his staff lit up, glowing brighter and brighter. This was it. Seacat started to move.

And a cloud of sparkles appeared above the bastard.

"NOOO!" Adora screamed as she dropped down on Micah, her sword slashing at his staff.

Seacat saw the staff being cut into two pieces, saw the light suddenly shine so bright, it almost blinded her. The next moment, both Micah and Adora vanished in an explosion.

Seacat threw herself to the side, behind the rock, then rolled over her shoulder, jumping up. Above her, Micah and Adora were falling. As were two more bodies - Glimmer and Scorpia!

“Adora!” Seacat yelled, dashing across the rubble and torn earth.

Adora hit the ground, bounced, and started to roll down the slope. Seacat jumped, sliding and scrambling down the slope. “Adora!”

She reached her a few seconds later. “Adora!”

Adora groaned. “What…?”

She was alive! Seacat hugged her. “You dummy!”

Adora tried to laugh. “You’re OK…”

“Of course I am!” Seacat hadn’t been the one who blew herself up by slashing at a sorcerer’s staff!

“Good.” Adora smiled, then groaned.

“You’re hurt!” Her leg was bent the wrong way. And she was bleeding from several cuts.

And yet, the idiot tried to get up. “Have to… stop Micah!”

Right. “Stay here! I’ll fight him!” Seacat yelled, standing to look for the king.

“No!”

“Stay here!” Seacat snapped. Where was the bastard? There was Scorpia, slowly getting up - and trying to dig herself out from the crater she had formed in the soft ground. Glimmer… Seacat couldn’t see Glimmer. And Micah….

She spotted a glow above her, close to what was now the top of the ridge. Seacat scoffed and started to run - on all fours, hands and feet digging into the soil as she raced up the steep slope. The bastard would pay for what he had done to Adora!

“Ca-Seacat!”

She ignored Adora’s shout. They had to stop Micah. A large rock blocked her way, but she jumped, legs propelling her over the rock.

And there was the bastard! Standing in a small round crater. His clothes were torn, but Seacat couldn’t spot any wounds - or any sign that getting blown out of the sky had hurt the sorcerer in any way.

But he had lost his staff! Seacat bared her teeth and pounced on him, claws out.

He didn’t even turn to face her - he moved his hand, and she crashed into a glowing shield, hard enough to hurt. Seacat lashed out with her claws, but they couldn’t dent the thing, and she slid down, landing on the ground.

She rolled over her shoulder, jumping up - then had to throw herself to the side to avoid the spell shooting from Micah’s hand.

Behind her, part of the jungle blew up, but Seacat circled around Micah, her claws digging into the soil, and launched herself at him again.

Once more, a shield stopped her, but she was prepared this time - and jumped up and over it, pushing off and lashing out with her claws.

She raked his outstretched arms, feeling her claws slice through flesh - but Micah didn’t cry. Instead of staggering back and holding his bleeding limbs, he stood his ground - and light flared up between his hands.

Seacat twisted away, but she was too close. Not fast enough. The spell missed her but struck the ground next to her, and she was sent flying in a cloud of mud and rocks, then slammed into the slope above the two before she could recover.

Her breath knocked out of her, she rolled on her belly, fingers digging into the earth to get up.

Micah was turning towards her now - slower than before, but she was too far to… She hissed, closed her hands around the soft earth, ripped and let loose.

The mud hit Micah in the face, and this time, he staggered back. Seacat rolled to the side, avoiding the next blast, then got up and charged him again. If she could reach him before he recovered…

And one of those damned shields stopped her again. She changed direction, circling Micah, but he was readying another of his blasts - she could tell from the glow around his hands, and the next piece of cover was...

Before the sorcerer could finish his spell, though, a hulking figure appeared behind him, pincers raised, and struck. Scorpia smashed Micah into the ground, foiling the spell. While Seacat stopped, sliding a little in the soft soil, the princess's stinger stabbed down, piercing the man's skin in his back. "Hah! Got you!"

Micah stopped moving.

Seacat gasped. They had… had they done it? "Let's tie him up!"

"Uh… do you have any rope?"

No, Seacat didn't have any. But they could break the bastard's arms until they could fetch some. That would… She saw Micah's arm move. "Scorpia! Watch ou…"

Too late. A yellow spell blasted the princess in the face and away from Micah. As Scorpia flew through the air to land on a patch of rubble, Seacat pounced on Micah, slashing at his arm. Once more, her claws cut into the man's flesh and foiled his aim. A second spell flew over her head, and a third narrowly missed her when she threw herself off Micah. But despite his wounds, Micah seemed none the worse for wear as he rolled to his side, then got

up, a few more blasts forcing Seacat to dodge rather than close with him.

Then an arrow struck the sorcerer in the side, exploding into a big glop of glue. Seacat hissed and darted forward, then had to jump to the side when Micah managed to free his left arm - which was healing - and sent another spell at her.

Red chains appeared over his head and fell down, wrapping themselves around his upper body, pinning his arms to his side.

For the first time, his expression changed - he showed his teeth while he grunted and strained his arms.

Seacat was already jumping at him, but just before she reached him, the magic chains were shattered, and she had to shield herself with crossed arms to avoid getting brained by the fragments. Even so, her stomach, arms and legs got hit, and she missed Micah, hitting the ground instead and rolling down the slope before she could stop.

She got up and charged upwards again, angling her approach to strike from Micah's back while he was busy sending a barrage of spells at Bow and Castaspella. If she could hit him in his blind spot…

He didn't turn, but his arm moved right before she reached him, and a yellow blast clipped her shoulder, sending her flying and spinning around herself.

She hit a rock when she crashed to the ground and heard her lower arm crack before the pain hit her. Panting, she rolled over on her stomach, then dug her claws in to get up. Before Micah could focus on her.

As she rose, she saw he wasn't focusing on her at all - he was busy bombarding the ridge above him, where Bow and Castaspella had been. Seacat started up the slope, but she was too slow. She knew it.

Micah turned and raised his right arm when roots shot out from the ground and wrapped themselves around him. Seacat bared her teeth and pressed on, sprinting over torn earth and rubble.

But before she was halfway to the sorcerer, the vines withered and died - and Micah started to glow again. As did the jagged black runes on his skin. A shield appeared, catching canister shot from below - Emily was firing.

Almost lazily, he turned and shot a spell back.

Seacat didn't see if he hit anything - she was focused on Micah. She was almost upon him, too. Just a few more yards.

Her foot slipped on a softer patch, and she stumbled - and Micah turned to face her. His hand glowed, and Seacat knew this time, she wouldn't be able to dodge. Vines rose in front of her at the last moment, and the spell hit them. Seacat was pelted with shredded vines and thrown back again from the blast wave. She barely managed to cradle her broken arm before she hit the ground.

A solid shot from Emily was deflected by Micah's shields. An arrow bounced off them as well. Scorpia charged from the side but ate another blast into the face, sending her tumbling down the slope. And more explosions followed on the other side.

How could they defeat that monster? Seacat shook her head, tried to ignore the pain, and started to scramble up the slope - at an angle. If she got to the higher ground, she might cause a landslide to bury the bastard.

But he had spotted her again. She started to weave back and forth as she ran, trying to present a harder target. One spell missed her, blowing up a rock behind her. But she was still in the middle of the slope, and there was no cover left. She could see him take aim with his next spell.

Then Glimmer and Adora appeared in front of him, and Micah faltered. Seacat saw his mouth open and his eyes widen as he

stared at the princess, seemingly frozen for a moment.

Before he could recover, Adora moved her sword and hit him… with healing magic?

And Micah began to scream as the magic hit him. All the marks on his skin glowed while he jerked.

Seacat slowed down, blinking at the man. Instead of glowing, he was now covered in smoke that… that flowed out of the marks. Thick, black smoke.

And Adora kept it up, kept the sword pointed at him, kept the magic pouring at him. Into him.

Until Micah toppled over, ending up face-down on the ground.

Seacat felt like collapsing herself. She accidentally moved her broken arm, wincing at the pain, as she changed direction and started walking directly towards the fallen sorcerer. And Adora and Glimmer.

"Dad!"

"Watch out, Glimmer!" Adora snapped.

But the princess didn't listen - she rushed forward and knelt down next to her father. "Dad!"

Adora joined her, limping, and they turned Micah over. "Watch out!" Seacat yelled. "He faked it once before!"

But this time, the sorcerer didn't send a spell at either of the two - he didn't move at all. He actually looked dead to Seacat. Pale and stiff.

"Dad! No!"

And to Glimmer, apparently.

But Adora bent down and touched the man's throat. "He's breathing."

"Dad! Wake up!" Glimmer gripped his shoulder and started shaking him.

"Glimmer!" Adora grabbed her hand. "I don't know what is wrong with him!"

Seacat finally reached them. "Watch out!" she repeated herself. "If he wakes up he can blast us all away!"

"He won't! He didn't attack us when I teleported next to him!" Gimmer protested.

"He blasted Scorpia across the slope," Seacat retorted.

"Ca-Seacat! You're hurt!"

"I'm…" Seacat broke off. A broken arm wasn't fine. "Others might need more help," she said. "Your leg. Bow and Castaspella…" She looked at the cratered remains of the other side of the gap.

"Bow!" Glimmer gasped. "Auntie!" She started to get up, then hesitated.

"I'll look for them," Adora told her, standing up. "My leg's healed enough. You two stay here with him."

Seacat looked around. Down near the jungle, she could see someone moving - more than one. She narrowed her eyes, wishing she still had her telescope. But... those would be Perfuma and Entrapta.

"Ow."

And there came Scorpia, limping up the slope from the other side. The princess looked battered, but if she could walk without leaving a tail of blood, she probably was OK. Sort of.

“Glimmer!” And there were Bow and Castaspella. They looked singed and Castaspella was limping, Bow dragging her more than carrying her, but they were alive.

Adora limped to them, then grabbed them both and started helping them walk... back to Glimmer and Seacat?

Well, given the powers Micah had demonstrated, it was probably as safe here as in the jungle.

“Bow!” Glimmer left Micah’s side as Adora lowered first Bow then Castaspella to the ground. “Are you hurt?”

“Banged up a bit,” he replied. “Castaspella is worse off.”

“I…” The sorceress groaned. “I got caught by a blast at the end. Micah’s aim is better than I remember.”

“How did we ever capture that guy?” Scorpia blurted out as she sat down in the rubble near them. “He could’ve wiped out the Horde by himself!”

“He couldn’t do this!” Castaspella said. “This power… no sorcerer could do this.”

“It wasn’t something Shadow Weaver did, either,” Seacat pointed out. “If she could’ve done this, she’d have done it to herself. And wiped out the Alliance and Hordak.”

Castaspella nodded. “Draining so much life… and turning it into such powerful spells…” She trailed off.

“But who did this to Dad?” Glimmer asked. “All those marks on his skin…”

Seacat squinted. The marks had faded, but they were still visible. And they looked a little like…”

“That’s First Ones’ writing,” Adora said. “I can’t read those symbols, strangely, but I know that much.”

“First Ones runes!” Castaspella nodded. “That would fit with the bots he controlled.”

“And that he was inside the First Ones base,” Bow added. “The question is: Did he control the base - or did the base control him?”

“What?” Adora stared at them. “Do you think… that the base turned him into this?”

Seacat clenched her teeth. She didn’t want to say it, but… “If they had a bot like Light Hope, but one connected to the runestone network? Is that possible?”

“In theory… perhaps?”

“Is what possible?” Entrapta asked as she arrived with Perfuma. “He destroyed Emily’s shell - I saved her command and memory module, but the shell’s gone.”

“Could the First Ones’ base have taken control of Micah and gave him his power? This power,” Seacat explained.

“Oh. Well… we can’t say it’s impossible,” Entrapta replied.

“The power to drain life itself?” Perfuma shuddered. “I felt the forest die - all the plants withered and died. This is unnatural!”

“It is,” Castaspella agreed. “It’s why such spells are forbidden at Mystacore. Shadow Weaver broke that law, and she got cursed.”

“Dad’s cursed?” Glimmer, arm around Bow, blurted out.

“I fear so,” Castaspella said. “And I have no idea how to cure him.”

“My healing magic did help him,” Adora said. “The runes faded.”

“It also knocked him out,” Seacat told her. “And he hasn’t woken up yet. We need to secure him before he wakes up.”

“Did you find the pieces of his staff? I think that was how he controlled the power he had,” Entrapta said. “Kind of like Adora’s sword.”

Adora stared at her sword as it was about to cut her.

“Not exactly like your sword,” Seacat said, frowning.

“Right.” Adora nodded but she didn’t seem to be convinced.

And, given what Micah had been able to do, Seacat wasn’t sure her lover was wrong. Not when the First Ones had picked her sword to control the Heart of Etheria.

“Let me heal you now,” Adora said.

“No!” Seacat shook her head. Adora looked like she was about to fall over if she used more magic. “Rest first.”

“But you’re wounded!”

“I can wait,” Seacat retorted. “We can’t exactly push on to the base like this.”

“But the bots might recover!” Adora protested.

“We need you there, as we need Entrapta and Castaspella,” Seacat told her. “If you’re out, what can we do?” Adora was She-Ra, and she was a First One. If anyone had a chance to take over the First Ones’ base, it was her.

“But…”

“And we need to get Dad to the ship,” Glimmer spoke up. “And heal him.”

That, too, of course. And that would take time.

“And I need to repair Emily. And Water-Bot and Carrier-Bot!”

“We all need to rest,” Bow said. “You can heal us in the evening. After you heal your leg.”

Adora glanced up at the ridge, pressing her lips together. Seacat refrained from pushing her further. Her lover was stubborn and a dummy when it came to her own health, but she wasn’t a complete idiot.

“Ok.” Adora sighed. “Let’s get the staff - the two pieces - and then go back to the ship and rest so I can heal you.”

*****

It was dark when Seacat woke up. She must have slept for far longer than she had planned, she realised - when they had reached the Victory’s Daughter, she had told the others to wake her up after an hour.

She sat up, wincing at the pain from her broken and splinted arm, and looked around. At least they hadn’t moved her from the spot on deck to her cabin.

“You needed the rest.”

She turned her head to scowl at Sea Hawk. He smiled at her, leaning against the railing.

“I’m the Captain,” she spat. “I can’t sleep at a time like this.”

“Your ship’s doing fine. And you’re hurt,” Sea Hawk tilted his head and twisted his moustache. “And you can’t help treat the king, can you? So, it was best to let you sleep.”

She scoffed. Her crew was busy on the other side of the ship. They hadn’t woken her up as ordered, but if Sea Hawk had given her that order, she probably wouldn’t have followed it either.

Sighing, she leaned back. “How’re things, then?”

“The king’s still unconscious. Castaspella and Glimmer are watching him.”

“Adora?”

“Still sleeping.” Sea Hawk shook his head. “She must have exhausted herself.”

“Yes,” Seacat agreed. And didn’t that tell them a lot about how bad Micah’s condition was? She-Ra’s magic had been enough to repair the Seagate, and trying to fix Micah had exhausted Adora?

“Everyone else is resting. Well, Entrapta is building a new bot shell for Emily, but she took another tiny teacup of tiny tea, so she wouldn’t be able to rest anyway,” Sea Hawk went on. “And my dear Mermista is keeping an eye on the sea.”

Seacat got up. “Good. Let’s check up on Micah, then.”

“After you.” Sea Hawk stepped aside and walked beside her.

She entered her cabin and suppressed a wince. They had put Micah into her bed. “So, what can we do about him?” she asked.

“I’m still working on that,” Castaspella said. “She-Ra’s magic did a lot, but he’s still affected by whatever changed him. This is unnatural.” She pointed at the markings on Micah’s pale skin.

“I don’t suppose cutting them off would help?” Seacat asked.

Glimmer and Castaspella gasped.

“NO!”

“How can you even suggest that?”

Seacat shrugged. “I’m no expert.” And you cut off rotting body parts to save someone, didn’t you?

“This is a curse. And while it’s focused on him, it’s not anchored on him,” Castaspella said. “I think it’s linked to a sort of collector.

Which would explain how he could use so much power without killing himself."

Like Shadow Weaver did when she connected to the Black Garnet. "And that would be in the base."

"Yes. Entrapta said the same after examining the remains of his staff." Glimmer nodded.

"Great." So, they had to enter the base and hope that Micah wouldn't wake up and lay waste to the ship while they were away. If he hurt or even killed the rest of their group…

"So far, there haven't been any sightings of bots or anything else," Sea Hawk said.

"That probably just means they are gathering in the base," Seacat pointed out. Perhaps they should've pressed on. Letting your enemy recover wasn't a good idea. Then again, it was also stupid to press on when you were exhausted.

"If they are, we shall cut a path through them!" Sea Hawk declared.

"You need to stay on the ship," she told him. "With Mermista."

He frowned at her. "Isn't the base underwater?"

Damn. Seacat could only handle so many stubborn people who were too brave for their own good. "I'm sure it has an entrance that's not underwater."

"Ca-Seacat! Let me heal you now!"

Case in point. Seacat turned in time to see the sword levelled at her and the point of it starting to glow.

*****

The First Ones' Base

"And you thought I should stay on the ship!"

Mermista didn't have to sound so smug, in Seacat's opinion. "I didn't expect the entrance to the First Ones' base to be underwater," she said with a scowl.

"Didn't you see Micah rise out of the water on a submersible platform?" the princess asked as they walked up to the shore of the central lake.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "I didn't expect that to be the only entrance."

"We don't know whether or not there's another entrance - or an emergency exit we could use as an entrance," Entrapta chimed in from where she was watching a row of devices she had put up along the shore. "We didn't find one, but that doesn't prove that there isn't any."

That was true, but they didn't have enough time to look more thoroughly for an alternative entrance. Not with Glimmer's dad still tied to whatever magic the First Ones used, ready to lay waste to the island again should he wake up. And not with the fate of Etheria at stake. She sighed. "So, can you open a path to wherever is down there?"

"Of course I can!" Mermista grinned, then raised her trident.

And the lake started to part in front of her, the water recoiling, forming a gap that quickly widened, all the way down to the ground - and to the centre of the lake.

"Even more impressive than the tunnel you created during the River Campaign, my love!" Sea Hawk told her.

"Thank you!"

It was more impressive. And more terrifying as well. This time, there would be no vines and sealing agents holding back the water. Should Mermista lose control, tons of water would crash down on anyone caught between the walls.

Seacat suppressed a shudder. They couldn't take long down below. Just enough to figure out how the regular entrance worked. She looked forward, where the water was still parting, revealing mud and confused crabs.

And a structure encrusted with shellfish and covered with algae and other water plants.

"Oh! There it is!" cheered Entrapta. "Let's go!" She was already climbing up on Emily.

"Wait!" Adora said. "Let me check it first!" She stepped into the gap and started walking through the mud.

"Wait!" Seacat sprinted after her.

"Wait on the shore!" Adora told her. "I'm looking for traps."

Seacat clenched her teeth. As much as she hated it, Adora was right - she wouldn't help much and only be a liability. If the water walls crumbled, Adora was about the only one who'd have a chance to survive it. Other than Glimmer, and the princess had nearly exhausted her teleport magic. "Be careful," she whispered, quickly hugging her lover.

"Of course!"

And Adora turned away and continued her trek down the lakebed towards the First Ones' base.

Seacat stepped back on the shore and forced herself to watch.

"You know, if Mermista loses control over all that water, we'll be swept away by a wave anyway," Entrapta said. "I think the entire shore would be swept away."

“I won’t lose control,” Mermista hissed.

“Of course not, my love!”

“I’m just pointing out the consequences should you lose control,” Entrapta told her. “There’s no reason I couldn’t go with Adora.”

“It’s easier to survive being swept away on the shore and carried inland than being crushed at the bottom of the lake,” Seacat pointed out.

“Really?”

“Yes.” Not much easier, of course.

“I’m growing a wall,” Perfuma announced.

A moment later, plants started to grow at the shore in front of them, forming a thick wall.

“Will that withstand the water?” Entrapta asked. “Hypothetically, I mean,” she added with a side glance to Mermista.

“It’ll reduce the power of a wave,” Perfuma claimed.

And it was blocking her sight. Seacat climbed on the growing wall to keep Adora insight. “Make sure Mermista has a line of sight to the lake,” she snapped.

“Oh, right, sorry.”

“I don’t need to see the water to control it!” Mermista yelled.

Whatever. Seacat wasn’t going to take any risk when Adora’s life was at stake. Her lover had almost reached the base by now. “Why would they have built a base underwater, anyway?”

“To hide it, I suppose,” Scorpia replied. “We never even suspected that there was anything here. We wouldn’t have deported prisoners to the island if we had known of this. I wonder how Micah discovered the place, anyway.”

“He’s a very good swimmer. He might have tried to escape through the lake,” Castaspella said. ”Or he sensed the magic,”

Seacat turned to glance at the sorceress. “Can you sense any magic?”

“It’s more that I can’t sense much magic where the base is.”

“Yes, Perfuma agreed. “It feels the same to my powers.”

“Oh! A base that blocks magic? Interesting!” Entrapta piped up. “Then again, if they built the base to manipulate and collect the runestone network, it would make sense to be able to block the magic as well. You can’t collect what you cannot contain, after all.”

Well, wasn’t that good news? Their magic powers might be useless inside the base. Seacat pressed her lips together.

Then Adora reached the walls of the base, and Seacat held her breath. If this was some magic trap…

But nothing happened. Adora touched the walls, first with her sword, then with her hand, before she scraped off some shellfish and plants. Yet all that she did was reveal some of the metal underneath.

“Looks like the outside isn’t guarded or trapped,” Glimmer stated the obvious.

“She hasn’t reached the entrance yet,” Seacat retorted.

“One of the entrances,” Entrapta told them. “Since the platform that Micah used is on the top, there should be an entrance on ground level. If we assume that the base was constructed before it was flooded. Unless they sealed that entrance up after finishing construction like some ancient tombs. Though that would make later changes to the complex more difficult without noticeably increasing security. Provided they have proper security at the entrances.”

“I don’t think the First Ones were planning to change much after finishing the base, seeing as they planned to destroy Etheria to destroy their enemies,” Seacat pointed out.

“I’m not sure we can judge how the First Ones thought,” Bow said. “We don’t have enough information - practically everything we know is from Light Hope, which is a biased source.”

Right, Bow’s dads were historians. He had mentioned that once, Seacat remembered.

“And Adora was taken from her family before she could actually learn her own culture,” Glimmer added.

Which was a very good thing, in Seacat’s opinion. And not just because she would have never met Adora otherwise. Any people willing to destroy a world to fight a war weren’t good people.

“Well, we’ll find out soon enough!” Entrapta said. “Too bad I couldn’t make Emily waterproof. If I had the parts, I could have made her able to swim!”

Emily beeped, probably in agreement. Seacat wasn’t quite sure - the bot only looked vaguely the same as before, having been cobbled together from parts from various sources.

“I’m widening the gap around the base,” Mermista announced, “so Adora can walk around it.”

Seacat clenched her teeth. That would take Adora out of her sight. If anything happened to her...

But Adora quickly returned and waved at them before she climbed on the roof of the base - where Seacat could see the lines of the platform Micah had used.

“We should go join her!” Entrapta said. “So Mermista doesn’t have to keep the water at bay for too long.”

“I’m fine,” Mermista snapped. “Don’t rush into a trap.”

“But Adora’s there!”

“And she’s looking for traps,” Seacat said, scowling - Adora was poking the apparent hatch with her sword.

“Perhaps it’s a hidden transponder that needs to be activated,” Entrapta speculated. Or a voice command - no, that wouldn’t work underwater.

“Magic. If Micah managed to get into the base, it must react to magic,” Castaspella said.

“Unless he was caught by bots in the jungle and carried into the base,” Sea Hawk countered.

“We never saw any sign of bots,” Scorpia said. “If they had been roaming the jungle, we would’ve noticed. So, it’s probably magic.”

“But if this was a First Ones’ base and meant to let Adora control the weapon, shouldn’t she be able to use magic to enter? And how would she do that if the entrance was closed and underwater?” Entrapta asked.

“Easily,” Seacat told her. “Hey, Adora!” she yelled. “Heal the door!”

“What?” she heard Adroa faintly reply. Rats.

“It’s too far. I’m going to join her,” Seacat told the others.

“*We /em> are going to join her,” Glimmer said.*

Everyone nodded. Even Mermista. And Entrapta was already gathering up her gadgets.

Damn. Seacat scowled. But she knew she wouldn’t be able to convince the others to stay back. She looked at Sea Hawk, then at Mermista. He nodded - he wouldn’t let any harm come to her. At least not if he could prevent it.

Seacat could only hope that they weren't about to trigger a trap that would make Mermista lose control.

She quickly took the lead, ignoring the way her feet sank into the muddy ground beneath the lake, and hastened to the base. Adora had spotted them and was waiting on the roof, waving at them. "Seacat! It's not safe yet!" she yelled, just loud enough for Seacat's ears to pick it up.

"Tell that to them!" Seacat yelled back.

"It's not safe yet!" Adora yelled, louder than before

"It's safe enough!" Glimmer screamed.

"You don't know that!"

Seacat rolled her eyes and sped up. As she reached the building, she shook her head. "You should try to heal the door with your sword."

"Oh!" Adora frowned. "I should've thought of that."

"I could try a spell myself," Castaspella said, "but that might trigger an attempt to capture me if whatever is controlling this base is looking for sorcerers and sorceresses to control."

Seacat felt the fur on her neck raise and her ears flatten. No, they didn't need a second pale and marked, almost invincible, monster to fight!

"Ok, I'll try to heal the door." Adora raised her sword, then pointed it at the roof just as Seacat climbed up.

A moment later, the magic energy hit the roof - the platform - and the lines forming a circle lit up, as did a symbol in the middle of it.

"Entrance," Adora read.

The light shone brightly for a moment, then faded - and the platform started to descend.

“Oh! They must have sensors checking for water!” Entrapta, stepping from Emily’s back straight to the roof, gushed. “Fascinating!”

Seacat nodded, almost absentmindedly. She was staring down the dimly lit shaft that had been revealed.

Entrapta also peered down. “It’s not very deep. Too deep to jump, though. We could wait and see if the platform returns without any more input, so to speak. An automated system like that would make sense. Perhaps it’s a proximity thing? If you’re close to it, it descends, and if you’re far above it, it ascends?”

“We can’t check that,” Seacat said, looking up. Mermista might create a water bridge, but Seacat didn’t want to strain her even more - holding the entire lake at bay had to be exhausting.

“Oh, look, there comes the platform!” Entrapta beamed, then took a step back as the platform rose again until it was level with the rest of the roof. “Like I thought.”

“So, we could use this elevator,” Adora said. “I just need to use magic on the platform.”

“Let’s test it before we end up floating above the lake,” Glimmer told her.

“Alright.” Adora stepped on the platform and used her sword again.

As before, the platform started to descend again, and Adora jumped onto the roof.

“It works,” she announced. “Once it returns, let’s all step on it.”

“I’m not sure that’s a good idea,” Castaspella said. “We don’t know what awaits us inside. What if it’s a trap? That might have

captured Micah before?"

"I'm She-Ra," Adora said. "This was made for me."

"And we can deal with any trap," Glimmer added. "We did so before!"

"Yes," Scorpia slammed her pincers against each other. "Whatever is waiting for us down there, we can beat it!"

Perfuma, standing next to her, nodded. "If we work together, we can do it!"

"We barely beat Micah," Bow pointed out. "And he came from this base."

"Bow!" Glimmer shook her head. "That's why we need to go down there: To stop whatever is possessing him!"

"And to save the world," Mermista commented.

Glimmer blushed and scowled at her. "Yes, of course."

"And courage and love will see us through the worst this base has to offer! Huzzah!" Sea Hawk declared, raising his sword to the sky.

"Not to mention that you can't keep the water back forever," Seacat said. "If we enter the base, you can release the lake. And I don't see what else we can do out here."

"But what if She-Ra's presence triggers a trap?" Castaspella said. "Or mine?"

"This base was made for me," Adora told her. "Well, for She-Ra. Why would they create a trap for me?"

"Light Hope betrayed you, didn't she? If she informed this base…" Seacat trailed off and pressed her lips together when she saw Adora flinch at the reminder.

"They captured Dad well before all that," Glimmer said.

“If he and the base were responsible for the monsters that razed the Horde port,” Bow added.

“Who else could’ve been it?” Glimmer asked. “And we came here to stop this runestone network from destroying the world, and we can’t do that if we stay here!”

Well, the princess was right about that. Still… Seacat had a bad feeling about this. She glanced at Entrapta, but her friend was already in the centre of the platform, smiling widely as she sat on Emily. Sighing, Seacat joined her. “Let’s go then!”

“Yes!”

“Should we leave Emily back here? On the shore, I mean,” Glimmer said as she ducked under the bot. “It’s a little crowded with her.”

“But I need her! She’s carrying a lot of tools and materials!” Entrapta retorted.

“Better take her with us,” Seacat said. The bot had proven her worth a few times already, and if they had to deal with another bot like Light Hope, Seacat didn’t want to find out that Entrpata needed a tool that was outside the base. And Emily would help keep Entrapta safe.

She jumped up, grabbed the top of Emily’s leg and swung herself up to the top of the bot’s shell, next to the princess.

Adora smirked at her, then stood in front of the bot. “Everyone ready?”

The group stepped a little closer to the bot - Scorpia almost hugged it - and Entrapta nodded. “Everyone’s inside the circle!”

Adora raised her sword, then pointed it at the circle, letting magic healing energy shoot out of the tip of the blade.

Seacat felt the platform beneath her feet jerk. A moment later, they started to descend.

There were no markings on the shaft's walls. No lights. Nothing but dark metal. Seacat reached out and drew a claw over the wall. She smiled when she saw the scratches she left. Good to know that she could cut the walls in a pinch.

Then they stopped, and a section of the wall parted, revealing a long hallway that could've been taken straight out of Light Hope's bunker. Seacat sniffed the air - it smelt… not stale, but not like the jungle or the lake. A hint of something she couldn't identify. Something she had smelt before, though… Her eyes widened. The air smelt like the air in the Horde's yard when Shadow Weaver had started to throw lightning around like crazy.

"This could be a trap," she said. "A lightning trap."

"You smell ozone?" Entrapta asked. "Fascinating! They must have huge power plants, then. Or unsafe ones."

That wasn't reassuring at all - Seacat still remembered how Shadow Weaver had died. And how Hordak would've died if not for his special armour. Armour none of them was wearing.

But Adora was already stepping into the hallway, sword raised. "I am She-Ra!" she announced.

Everyone waited, but seconds passed without any answer.

"Uh… we probably should step off the platform before it ascends again," Entrapta suggested.

"Right." Seacat joined Adora in the hallway, half-expecting an 'Intruder Alert' alarm going off.

But nothing happened.

"Perhaps the base is dead?" Perfuma looked around. "It feels dead to me - no plants at all are nearby. And I can still feel the plants in

the lake outside, even though it's harder than usual."

"The entrance works," Adora pointed out the obvious as the door closed behind them. It had door controls on this side, Seacat noted with some relief.

"Perhaps it doesn't work without Micah," Bow said.

"Unlikely," Entrapta said. "My sensors are picking up a huge amount of power! This place is bristling with energy!"

"That doesn't mean that there's anyone to direct that power," Castaspella said.

"Why would they install Light Hope but no bot here?" Seacat asked.

"We don't know much about the First Ones or their technology," Bow replied. "Light Hope might be a unique bot, or she was needed for her task - liaising with She-Ra - while this base doesn't need a bot."

"Someone captured and possessed Dad," Glimmer said. "He didn't do that to himself."

Seacat pressed her lips together. People changed in prison - especially Horde prisons. But this wasn't the right moment to point that out. "Let's go on," she told the others.

"Yes." Adora took the lead at a brisk pace.

Seacat rushed to catch up, meeting her lover's annoyed glare with a flat stare. No way was she letting Adora alone in the front.

"I'm releasing the water," Mermista announced with a sigh just before they reached another door.

This, too, had controls set in the wall next to it, and Adora touched them before Seacat could say anything.

And a bot's voice sounded through the hallway: "Scanning."

Seacat tensed.

"It might be a recording," Entrapta said. "Not a bot itself."

Then a line of light ran over Adora, then over them all before returning to Adora.

"What…?"

"Oh! An active sensor! But why are they using visible light?" Entrapta frowned. "Is that meant to show the subject of the scan the progress? Or does using such a frequency grant an advantage?"

"What is this?" Adora asked through clenched teeth.

"A scanner!" Entrapta replied. "It's scanning you. Analysing you. Gathering data!"

Adora didn't seem to be reassured - and neither was Seacat. They were in a base whose puppet sorcerer had tried to kill them multiple times already. She didn't trust anything here.

"She-Ra identified, but vitals differ from saved data. You are not Mara."

"I'm Adora!"

"Please transform back so your unenhanced vitals can be detected," the bot - it had to be a bot; it sounded like Light Hope - told her.

"Uh…"

"Fascinating! Your transformation must hide your vitals and other data! So, not even the First Ones can scan or extrapolate your natural body's data when you're She-Ra!"

"Uh… should I transform back?" Adora asked.

Hell, no! Seacat shook her head. “No. That might be a trap.”

“It might be what we need to take over the station - proof that you are a First One,” Entrapta retorted. “It would make sense that they restricted the base to First Ones, you know, since they wanted to blow the planet up.”

And wasn’t that reassuring. “We can cut our way in,” Seacat said. Her claws would shred the door.

“That might trigger a hostile reaction,” Bow pointed out. “It would be easier to handle this if we had control over the station and any bots it might have.”

That was correct, but… Seacat had a bad feeling about this. She could feel her fur rising.

“The base that captured Dad,” Glimmer cut in.

“We still don’t know that,” Scorpia told her. “But we know how dangerous the base can be if it considers us enemies. And we’re in a narrow hallway.”

That was also true. Seacat still didn’t like it.

“I can always transform back,” Adora said. Seacat glared at her, and she shrugged. “And I’m not helpless either way. If this is a chance to take over without having to fight an army of bots and traps, then I think we should do it.”

Seacat huffed and took a step closer to Adora.

Her lover smiled at her, then raised her sword again in a brief blaze of light, transforming back.

“Scanning.”

Once more, that infernal light beam ran over Adora - and over Seacat. She resisted the sudden urge to bat at it. That would be pointless - you couldn’t touch it.

“First Ones physiology identified. She-Ra’s status updated. Welcome to Power Station One, She-Ra. The Heart of Etheria is at your command.”

“Yes!” Bow whispered.

“Uh, thanks,” Adora replied. “So… can you open this door?”

“Opening the Door,” the voice replied as the door slid open.

“Thank you.” Adora entered a room that looked very similar to the one in Light Hope’s bunker with all the consoles.

Seacat looked around, ears twitching, as she tried to spot the hidden passages containing bots.

“Control Unit detected. Weapon system charging.”

“What?” Adora blurted out as Seacat held her breath.

“‘Weapon system charging’?” Bow repeated in a slightly higher voice than usual.

“Are we under attack?” Scorpia asked, looking around.

“Uh…” Entrapta grimaced. “I think the weapon system the base means is the Heart of Etheria. All the magic power it has gathered. The thing we are here to stop and dismantle.”

“What?” Seacat yelled - together with pretty much everyone else.

“The weapon is charging? How? We didn’t connect the last Runestone!” Glimmer exclaimed. “It shouldn’t work!”

“It shouldn’t work according to Light Hope’s data, even with Adora’s sword present - the Heart of Etheria can only activate if the network is complete!” Entrapta looked around. “Console! I need to check the readings!”

“What’s happening?” Adora asked. “And how do we stop it, whatever it is?”

“I’m going to find out!” Entrapta yelled as she dashed into the room.

“Warning! Intruder detected. Physiology doesn’t match approved personnel. Countermeasures initiated!”

“Stop! Stop! She’s authorised! By me, She-Ra!” Adora yelled. “I’ve got the sword and everything! After a moment, she raised the sword. “For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Adora transformed into She-Ra again, but the bot’s voice didn’t react. And Seacat heard the sound of doors opening - sliding into walls. Now would come the… She frowned, cocking her head. She didn’t hear any bots scrambling over metal.

“Stop it!” Adora yelled again. “I’m ordering you!”

“Please state the override code,” the bot finally replied.

“Override code? What override code?” Adora asked.

“I don’t know,” Entrapta yelled. “There wasn’t anything in Light Hope’s memories!”

And now Seacat heard the sound of metal legs approaching them. “Here they come!” she yelled, drawing her sword and moving to block one of the passages.

“Base! Stop this! Stop… ah, damn it!” Adora joined her, sword drawn.

Sea Hawk and Mermista followed their example, as did Glimmer and Scorpia, while Bow, as Seacat saw with a glance over her shoulder, moved to cover Entrapta with Perfuma.

A moment later, the first bots appeared in the hidden passages. Seacat hissed. “There they are!”

“I don’t see...oh. There they are!” Adora yelled.

And the bots attacked. About half a dozen of them. Seacat moved to intercept them, but Adora charged ahead, and one swipe of her sword cleaved all but one bot in two, and she got that one with the backswing.

The half a dozen bots coming through the door on the other side were dispatched by Scorpia and Sea Hawk before Seacat reached their position.

“Countermeasures insufficient. Please hold.”

“What?” Mermista said. “Did the bot just ask us to wait until it can make more bots?”

“A novel approach to fighting, I’m sure,” Sea Hawk commented with a grin.

“We must have depleted their stocks of bots,” Glimmer said.

Seacat moved back to Entrapta and Bow, nodding at Perfuma. “What’s going on?”

“The weapon is charging,” Entrapta replied, pointing at a number of blinking lights on the console. “It must be reacting to the control unit - Adora’s sword! But it shouldn’t do that!”

“What?” Adora yelled, staring at her sword as if it was about to attack her. “This is my fault?”

“No!” Seacat snapped. “None of us thought this was possible!”

“It shouldn’t work,” Entrapta said, hands and hair pushing button after button. “The network isn’t completed. The energy readings are far too low for the intended purpose, and it shouldn’t activate without that. The danger was overloading the Heart, not activating it!”

“Well, it seems we were wrong,” Bow said.

“No, no, no!” Entrapta retorted. “The Heart of Etheria is still dormant. But another system is charging in the base here. And… the power readings are much lower than the Heart’s.”

“That’s good, right?” Perfuma asked.

“If this blows up, it won’t destroy the planet,” Entrapta replied without looking up. Seacat was about to smile when the princess continued. “But if the power storage overloads and loses containment, the explosion will destroy the island for sure.”

“What?” Seacat paled. “Isn’t this supposed to hold enough power to destroy the planet?”

“That’s the Heart of Etheria, in the centre of the network. This is the, uh, it’s an auxiliary system… targeting system? Something to be fired before the Heart fires, in any case. It’s not meant to handle even the vastly reduced power it’s using now!”

“We need to evacuate!” Seacat snapped. “How long until it blows up? We need to get back to the ship!”

“Wait!” Mermista held up her hand. “If the island blows up, will it sink?”

“Uh…” Mire tapping of buttons and keys from Entrapta followed. “It’ll vaporise the island. Basically. There might be some larger remains, but it’ll be mostly gone.”

Mermista went pale. Seacat felt her stomach drop to her knees. “That will cause a giant wave,” the princess said, shaking her head. “It’ll lay waste to the entire South Coast - and probably Salineas as well.”

“What?” Glimmer gasped.

“There have been similar catastrophes in the past,” Mermista explained.

“Yes,” Bow agreed. “The Crimson Flood that created the Crimson Waste, for example.

“We can’t let that happen!” Adora looked grim - as if she was ready to… Damn!

“Yes, we can’t,” Entrapta agreed. “Because if the island gets blown up, we lose the control unit the First Ones installed here - and we need that to safely discharge the power gathered in the Heart of Etheria!”

Seacat muttered a curse under her breath.

“If we lose the station… the heart of Etheria will continue to collect magic energy until it can’t contain it any more.” Castaspella sounded shocked. “And then it’ll…”

“...destroy the planet,” Glimmer finished for her. “It might take a while, but Etheria would be doomed.”

“Stop it!” Adora yelled. “We have to stop it!”

“I’m trying! But the console isn’t accepting my commands! It requires an override code!” Entrapta yelled without looking up from where she was hitting buttons all over the place.

She sounded desperate, Seacat noticed. And that made her stomach plummet again. If Entrapta was desperate, their situation had to be even worse than Seacat thought.

“She-Ra must have the override code,” Bow said. “I can’t imagine the First Ones being so negligent as to leave the intended user without a way to stop this!”

“Mara might have known it - and taken the knowledge into the grave.” Mermista shook her head.

“And after a thousand years, the system might not be working correctly any more,” Castaspella added. “Like Light Hope, this bot might be damaged.”

“It doesn’t matter if it’s broken - we have to try anyway,” Adora stated. “I’ve got the control unit here.” She raised her sword. “Just tell me where to go.”

“And what will you do? Point the sword at it and heal the thing?” Mermista asked.

Adora firmly nodded. “Yes. And if that doesn’t work, I’ll cleave it into two parts!”

Mermista gasped in surprise - she should’ve known better than to ask Adora that kind of question, in Seacat’s opinion. Her lover always preferred the direct, simple solution.

“But that will likely cause an explosion!” Entrapta said. “If you breach the containment shell…”

Adora drew in a sharp breath. “What? You mean that will cause the explosion?”

“Well… an explosion. If you’re quick enough, it’ll be limited in power,” Entrapta explained. “But it’ll still vaporise the station.”

Damn. “And if we drain this chamber of the power?” Seacat asked.

“That would work - if we had a receptacle to vent the power into,” Entrapta replied. “But it’s magic, and the crystals we’d need for that…” She shook her head, tentacled hair flying back and forth. “I don’t have the crystals to construct such a storing device, and I don’t have the time for it, either.”

No way to drain the magic safely, then. And this was just an auxiliary storage - not even the Heart of Etheria itself, which held far more magic… Seacat blinked. That might… “Can you vent it into the Heart of Etheria?” she asked.

“That would overload it!” Glimmer gasped.

“Not necessarily!” Entrapta retorted. “The Heart can hold magnitudes more power - it’s already doing so, actually. It should be able to safely contain the additional power currently held in the subsystem.”

‘Should’. Not the most encouraging words. But better than certain failure. “Then let’s do this!” Seacat said.

“But we’d need a direct link to the Heart of Etheria. And according to the console, there isn’t any such link,” Bow said, shaking his head.

“But we can build one!” Entrapta exclaimed. “If we can repurpose the parts in the consoles here, and… I’m sorry, Emily, but we’ll need parts of you again!”

Seacat had no idea what the beeping from the bot meant, but Entrapta patted its shell and smiled, so it was probably agreement.

“But the bot here will try to stop us!” Perfuma cut in.

“With what?” Glimmer asked. “If it had anything left, we’d have been fighting it already.”

“We can’t know that. There might be traps,” Seacat said.

“I don’t care. We need to stop this, and I’ll do it. Traps or no traps.” Adora straightened. “Where is this subsystem?”

“It’s two floors down according to the map here,” Bow said. “Let me see if I can… yes!”

A crystal set on a pedestal started to glow. Seacat took a step back and prepared to jump away, but it stopped growing brighter, and in the middle of it, lines appeared. Lines that glowed, and… Oh. They formed a sort of map. No, a sort of transparent model of the base.

Seacat tilted her head. “Just how far down goes this shaft?” she asked, pointing at the model.

“Deeper than the deepest mine shaft I’ve heard of,” Bow said.

“But still within a safe distance from the molten core of Etheria,” Entrapta added.

“How much time do we have left?” Adora asked.

“Uh…” Entrapta cocked her head. “If we hurry, we’ll make it. But we need a powerline and a connection to the crystal storage to drain the magic. And an adapter to the main line leading to the Heart of Etheria.”

“Hurry!” Adora spat.

“I’m hurrying!” Entrapta’s hands and hair were constantly moving, ripping lines out of consoles and gathering other, weird materials.

“We should clear the way to the subsystem…” Seacat started to say,

“Storage crystal!” Entraota interrupted her,

“… whatever.” Seacat clenched her teeth. “We don’t want to be held up when we descend with the power line.”

Adora nodded. “Good idea. Let’s clear the way.” She turned to Scorpia. “Keep them safe.”

Scorpia straightened, then nodded, touching her chest with one pincer in a Horde salute. “I will!”

Adora turned and left the room. Seacat followed her. “This way to the shaft.” The one leading to the storage crystal. Not the one leading down to the bowels of the planet.

They reached it quickly and peered down. “I don’t see a platform,” Seacat said.

“Let me check the controls.” Adora aimed her sword at them, and magic shot out of its tip.

Nothing happened.

“We’ll have to climb,” Seacat muttered.

“Yes,” Adora agreed.

Just like in the Horde airship yard, Seacat thought. Hopefully, this would work better.

She bent down, then stuck her claws into the wall. “I’ll create handholds for you,” she told Adora before scrambling down the shaft.

“Ca-Seacat! Wait for a rope!”

“It’s not too deep,” she replied - this wasn’t the main shaft, after all. And she had only two floors to climb. Half a minute later, she was busy slashing at the door barring her way. The material the First Ones used for the door was, annoyingly, tougher than the one they had used for the wall. But it wasn’t tough enough.

“Watch out!”

Seacat jerked, looking over her shoulder - and kicked her feet against the door, propelling herself away from it. She swung to the side while holding on with one set of claws as a metal arm smashed into the door where she had been a moment ago.

“What is that?” she yelled, scrambling up the wall as the arm - with grasping claws as big as her arms - withdrew to take another swing at her.

This time she was ready - and jumped onto it as it once more missed her. Her claws sliced into the metal, but the arm kept moving - now trying to crush her against the shaft’s wall.

She cursed and jumped off again. But the jerking arm made her lose her footing, and instead of hitting the wall with all four sets of claws, she only managed to drive one set into it, then dangled from it before she managed to regain her footing.

“Watch out!” Adora screamed - and Seacat saw something move from above her. Too fast to dodge.

She tried anyway - but before the arm crushed her, Adora fell onto it and cleaved it into two with her sword. And continued falling.

“Adora!” Seacat screamed.

Adora managed to jump off the broken metal arm and ram her blade into the wall, then hung onto it as it sliced downwards for half a floor before it stopped. “I’m OK!”

“You idiot!” Seacat cursed her and started to scramble down towards her.

“Says you!”

“Damn right I do!” Seacat quickly reached Adora and started creating more hand- and footholds for her reckless lover. “You jumped down a shaft!”

“It wasn’t too deep!”

Seacat hissed in annoyance at hearing her own words. “That’s different!”

“How so?”

“I’m lighter - and I have four sets of claws to stop my fall, not just one sword.”

“It worked, didn’t it?” Adora shot back as she started to climb after Seacat.

“That’s not the point!”

Seacat reached the floor they needed again and vented some of her frustration on the wall there. If Adora had fallen all the way down…

By the time the idiot joined her, she had made a hole wide enough for her to slip through. Which she did.

“Wait!” Adora yelled.

Seacat looked around. She was in a hallway - no dust, no sign of a trap. And the next door was ten yards away. “Looks safe!” she told Adora and started to widen the hole from the inside. That was easier - she didn’t have to hang to the wall while working.

Soon, the hole was wide enough for Adora to enter, and she used her sword to cut the rest of the door down. “The others need to be able to enter.”

“They better bring some rope,” Seacat said. “Let’s clear the way.”

But apart from a single bot trying to kill them with a broom - Adora cut it in two without stopping - they didn’t encounter more traps or defenders and soon reached the storage area Entrapta had found.

And the huge, brightly glowing crystal it housed. The light was so bright, it hurt looking directly at it.

“Wow,” Adora whispered.

“I think we’ll need a bigger line,” Seacat mumbled. She sniffed the air. “It smells like lightning.”

“And it’s getting warm,” Adora added. She reached out with her hand but pulled it back before she touched the crystal. “Yes, it’s growing hot.”

“That’s not a good sign.” Seacat clenched her teeth and felt her ears flatten themselves against her head.

“No, it isn’t.” Adora took a deep breath. “Look…” she started to say.

“I’m staying with you,” Seacat told her with a glare.

And Adora proved that she wasn’t a complete idiot by shutting up.

*****

“Alright! That’s the line… I’ve connected it to the main shaft!” Entrapta announced. “Now, all we need is to connect it to the crystal and activate it with your sword!”

“Good.” Adora took a deep breath. “Take a step back.”

“Better, leave the room,” Entrapta said. “The adapter could be leaking.”

“‘Leaking’?” Seacat turned towards her.

“I had to improvise. The main part of the magic should be channelled through it, but some part might, uh, leak,” the princess explained. And that could be bad.”

They moved out of the room. All except for… “Adora!” Seacat yelled.

“I have to activate it!” Adora yelled back. “With my sword.”

“Does she know how?” Glimmer asked.

“It should be automated. Or instinctual,” Entrapta told them. “I repurposed the trigger mechanism to start the discharge.”

“What?” Seacat turned back towards the door, but the light from the crystal inside suddenly grew much, much brighter.

And Adora started screaming.

*****

The Dark Crystal

Adora! Seacat rushed towards the door. Her lover was screaming as if… as if…

“Wait!” Entrapta yelled.

Seacat ignored her. She reached the door - and froze.

The storage crystal was glowing brighter than the sun, sending sparks of magic out into every direction like a lightning storm - and Adora was standing next to it. Her hair was floating, and there was a shining halo around her as magic - like lightning - ran over her body. She had her eyes closed and was still holding her sword which was blazing like the crystal.

“Adora!” Seacat yelled, stepping into the room.

A spark of magic hit her, and she collapsed, spasming on the floor. The pain was… the pain… damn, the pain!

Something grabbed her, dragging her out of the room - away from Adora. She tried to resist, to crawl towards her love, but her body wasn’t working.

“Seacat! What were you thinking?”

Entrapta was yelling at her. And Castaspella was doing something with magic.

“Adora,” Seacat spat, trying to get out of Entrapta’s hair.

“You can’t help her!” Bow yelled.

So what? She would try anyway! Seacat rolled over on her belly and got up. Or tried to. Her limbs were still twitching.

“Don’t be stupid!” Glimmer told her. “Stay down!”

She wouldn't. Not when Adora was suffering.

"Scorpia, do it."

"No!" Seacat gasped. She couldn't! She wouldn't!

She felt a sting, and everything went dark.

*****

Seacat woke up groaning. Her whole body hurt. And she was… on the ground?

"Seacat! You're awake!" Entrapta ran a device over her. "You didn't suffer any permanent damage," she said. "You're going to be OK!"

Seacat didn't feel like she was going to be OK. This had been… one of the most painful experiences of her life. Almost as bad as getting interrogated by Shadow Weaver in prison. And…

She gasped. "Adora!"

Entrapta winced. "She's alive."

Seacat forced herself to get up. "Adora!" Where was she? She was in a hallway, but where was Adora?

"We couldn't stop her until the power had been completely drained," the princess went on. "The leaking was worse than anticipated - and she absorbed most of it. I'm sorry!"

"Where is she?"

"In the storage room, but…"

Seacat wasn't listening any more. She walked, stumbled towards the storage room. Towards Adora!

This time, no hair or stinger held her back. She reached the door, leaning against the frame - and saw her.

Adora was on the ground, as if… No! She was alive! She was breathing!

But she looked terrible. Pale, trembling, shivering, eyes closed… "Adora!"

"She's alive," Castaspella said from Adora's side. "But so much magic ran through her…"

"What happened to her?" Seacat asked, snarling, as she stumbled towards her lover.

"We don't know," Castaspella said. "Her body's fine - no worse than yours, according to Entrapta. But what the magic did to her…" She shook her head. "I don't know of anyone who survived such a thing."

"Shadow Weaver…" Seacat whispered, reaching out to touch Adora's cheek. "That's how she died. Connected to a runestone."

"Yes. But this wasn't a runestone. And she's She-Ra - this whole base was made for her. So…" Entrapta shrugged. "We don't know what it did to her. We won't know until she wakes up. But the storage crystal is now empty."

Seacat didn't care about that. What good was that if Adora wouldn't… was… She shook her head, sending tears flying. "Adora! You idiot!" She bent down and rested her head on Adora's chest. "You stupid idiot!"

Someone coughed. "Not… an… idiot."

Her ears twitched. That was… "Adora!"

Seacat sat up. Adora was awake! Her eyes were open. And she was smiling at her! "You dummy!"

"Had to… do it." Adora whispered.

"No!"

“Yes.”

“I think they’re going to be fine,” Glimmer commented.

Seacat ignored her. She hugged Adora. “You idiot!”

Adora chuckled, And Seacat felt an arm on her back, weakly patting it.

She hugged Adora harder.

“So… how do you feel? Any lingering pain?” Entrapta asked. “Hallucinations? Loss of memory? Taste? Sense of touch?”

“Everything hurts,” Adora replied. “Exhausted.”

“That is normal. I wouldn’t recommend transforming back,” Castaspella said. “Your normal body might not be able to survive this.”

“What?” Seacat gasped. “Adora might be stuck like this?”

“Only until she recovers,” Castaspella explained. “And it’s just a security precaution. We don’t know what happened to her.”

“But so far, it looks good. You can talk, you understand us. You aren’t leaking blood or brain fluid, and your nerves haven’t been damaged as far as I can tell. Not permanently, at least.”

That was as comforting as it was terrifying. Adora could’ve died!

“So could’ve you,” Glimmer said. “Stepping into the room!”

Had she said that out loud? Without realising it? She must be hurt worse than she’d thought.

“Idiot,” Adora mumbled.

Seacat scoffed and hugged her lover again.

“Adora, you need to rest. We’ve dismantled the bot controlling the station, and the storage was drained, so we’re good. You don’t need to push yourself. Just get well,” Glimmer said.

“But…”

“No buts.”

Seacat nodded in agreement. “I won’t let you get up anyway,” she said. “I’ll sit on you if I have to.”

“You’re already straddling her,” Glimmer told her.

Seacat ignored her.

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After about an hour, Adora was strong enough to push Seacat away and get up, despite Seacat’s protests. And Seacat was well enough, so the pain was merely an annoyance, not something to worry about.

“Let me heal you!” Adora, predictably, said anyway.

“No! Save your strength for others,” Seacat retorted. “And for yourself.”

“I’m fine. Entrapta and Castaspella said so.”

“They didn’t say that - we don’t know what the magic did to you!”

“*Might* have done,” Entrapta corrected them. “I think trying to heal someone would be a good test if your magic was influenced by all the other magic!” She smiled at them and raised her device. “Tell me when you’re ready to heal!”

“Uh…” Adora grimaced. “I don’t want to use Seacat for a test? What if I hurt her?”

That was a good question, in Seacat’s opinion.

“Well, you can try it on me!” Entrapta suggested. “Although I’m not hurt.”

“Try it on me,” Seacat told her lover. If anything had changed, it was better to find out now instead of in the middle of a battle.

“But…”

“I trust you.” She smiled at Adora. And hid her tension. If this did go wrong…

Adora took a deep breath - her chest heaved - and nodded. “Alright then.”

“Ready!” Entrapta said.

And Seacat stared at the point of Adora’s sword as it rose. As soon as it pointed at her, magic flowed into Seacat.

She gasped. This… this felt… “Incredible!”

“What?”

Seacat blinked. “I feel… perfect. Better than perfect.” She felt as if she could arm wrestle Adora and everyone else together!

“So... it looks like your healing ability is more effective,” Entrapta said. “Castaspella! Come!”

“What?” The sorceress appeared in the doorway a few seconds later. “Adora! You’re up!”

“And she healed Seacat!” Entrapta beamed at her. “And it was more effective than usual. Can you check them?”

“Why didn’t you call me before they tried this?” Castaspella complained.

“Uh… I forgot.”

“Perhaps you should heal Entrapta next,” Seacat suggested. Her friend did look a little tired. “Once we are sure it’s safe.”

“Let me examine you two.” Castaspella shook her head, and Seacat heard her mutter “Idiots!” under her breath. Soon, both of them were bathed in the light from Castaspella’s magic as she ran her hands over them. “It doesn’t seem to be corrupting you,” she said after a few minutes.

“Good! Do me now!” Entrapta said.

“Wait!” Castaspella raised a hand. “Let’s see if Seacat is actually better - and not just feeling as if she is. If this is a magical stimulant then we don’t want to find out when you exhaust yourself and collapse. Or die.”

Seacat grimaced. “I do feel fine, but… I wouldn’t be able to tell if I was fine, would I?”

“Let’s test it!” Entrapta said.

“Shouldn’t we stop the Heart of Etheria?” Adora asked. “Before we do anything else?”

“I would prefer it if you wouldn’t try to manipulate the Heart of Etheria before we’re sure that you or your magic aren’t negatively affected by what you went through,” Castaspella told her.

“That’s a good point,” Adora agreed.

“So, let’s test Seacat!” Entrapta beamed again.

“Alright. You test her - I’ll continue looking for whatever turned my brother into a monster,” Castaspella said. She nodded at them and left again.

“You didn’t find it yet?” Adora asked.

“It’s not on the blueprints,” Entrapta replied with a pout. “It must have been a later addition, and the system didn’t update the data.

That is really sloppy.”

Oh. “So… we can’t trust the magic plans we got?” Seacat asked.

“So it seems. That’s why we’ve been checking the known areas - very carefully! - while you were resting. But enough of that! Let’s see if you are actually better and not just feeling better!” Entrapta smiled. “If you were actually healed, your endurance and fine motor skills should have been restored.”

Seacat had the impression that this testing would be exhausting.

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“That’s it! Your fingers - and claws - are starting to tremble. And you are taking longer now to assemble a sensor!” Entrapta announced. “And all the data I gathered fits your normal profile,” she added.

Seacat set the last set of parts she had been given down and sighed.

“You have a profile of her body?” Adora sounded both surprised and intrigued.

“Yes. I have data on all of my friends!” Entrapta smiled. “On both your forms, too! You have to know your friends, after all, so you don’t hurt them by mistake.”

Adora blinked, but Seacat nodded. Entrapta might have misunderstood the advice, but she didn’t mean them any harm. “Alright. So… we know now that Adora’s magic healing powers weren’t affected.”

“Not negatively!” Entrapta nodded. “So, heal me - us - now!”

Adora did so, and Seacat sighed with relief. The testing had been literally exhausting. “Alright,” she said as she got up, “Let’s get back to actual work!”

“The Heart of Etheria!” Adora nodded with a determined expression.

“Actually,” Entrapta piped up, “We need to map the base out, first. We can’t really plan anything without correct data - and if we make a tiny mistake with the magic in the Heart of Etheria…”

Seacat winced. “Let’s find whatever trap got Micah, then.”

*****

Finding the hidden parts was easier said than done, though. Whoever had built the base hadn’t kept it simple at all. And whoever had expanded it… “Was the architect drunk?” Mermista complained an hour later as they discovered another winding tunnel in the base. “Couldn’t they build straight corridors?”

“No,” Entrapta replied, smiling as she pointed her device at the wall. “This isn’t a corridor - this is a mine tunnel! Or was one; the base bot must have used this to gather raw materials and then repurposed the tunnel once the ore ran out. How efficient!”

“We’re in a mine?” Gimmer asked.

“Yes, but don’t worry - it’s stable. The First Ones knew about mining in volcanic areas,” Entrapta explained.

“‘Volcanic areas’?” Adora asked.

“They usually have more tectonic activity,” Entrapta told her. “Earthquakes and such,” she added after a moment.

Seacat couldn’t help but worry even more now. “Well, the base lasted a thousand years already,” she said.

“That’s not much of a timespan for earthquakes,” Bow said. “And they probably didn’t plan for the base to last that long, seeing, ah, as it was supposed to be destroyed with the entire planet a thousand years ago.”

“Bow!” Glimmer glared at him. “Don’t scare people!”

“But it’s the truth!”

“Yes. How can that be scary?” Entrapta asked.

“The thought that we could end up buried alive might be scary for some people,” Glimmer replied. The way she was looking at the ceiling probably meant she was included in that number.

Bow must have noticed as well since he gathered her in a hug.

“Bow! I’m fine!” Glimmer protested, as expected.

“Of course.”

“I really am!”

“So, can we, like, get on with this?” Mermista asked. “I would prefer to get out of this as soon as possible.”

“Right!” Entrapta took the lead, visor down and staring at her device. “There’s a large room ahead of us. “No power lines in the walls, though. Probably a raw material storage facility.”

She turned the next corner and stopped. “Or… it’s a magic storage facility.”

“Another one?” Seacat groaned and moved forward. And stopped.

“That’s not a storage crystal,” Castaspella said behind her, looking at a floating, crackling dark crystal. “Not just a storage crystal, at least.”

“Is that… Is that what changed Dad?” Glimmer asked in a small voice.

“It’s active,” Entrapta stated the obvious. “But it’s purely magical.”

“How could a bot have installed a purely magical device after the First Ones had left and Mara and her friends had died?” Bow

wondered aloud. “It wasn’t any different than Light Hope.”

“It’s theoretically possible,” Entrapta replied. “First Ones’ technology was very advanced, and they had sophisticated interfaces for magic. We have them as well - Emily could use magic. Theoretically, with the right interface. Which I would have to craft. But to construct something like this… I don’t think the base bot had the capacity for this. This would require… creativity.”

“Something’s here,” Castaspella whispered. “I can feel it.”

Seacat felt the fur on her neck bristle. “I can hear something. Like… a whisper.” Her ears lay flat on her head. A creepy whisper. And she could feel a cold breeze.

“What is it?” Adora asked, looking around.

“Whatever it is, it’s not natural,” Perfuma said. “My magic… I can’t feel anything here. Not even the seeds in my pockets.”

“That’s not good!” Scorpia cut in. “Let’s back off!”

But the whispers were all around them - and behind them.

“We’re surrounded,” Seacat spat. She heard the hint of cackling. “It’s… it’s playing with us!”

“It took Dad! We’ll make it pay!” Glimmer announced. “We can… Eeek!” She jumped, whirling around. “Something touched me. Something cold!”

Perfuma yelped as well. “My seeds! They died!”

Scorpia lashed out with her stinger but only met air as far as Seacat could tell.

“Stop this!” Adora yelled. “Whatever you are, stop this!”

More cackling. Seacat’s entire fur bristled. And her tail was poofing out. She hated this. “It must be the crystal’s doing!”

“Let’s smash it!” Adora blurted out. “Wait - is it safe?”

“I can’t tell,” Entrapta replied. “Castaspella?”

Seacat turned to look at the sorceress and cursed - Castaspella was standing still, eyes staring at the crackling crystal. “Castaspella!”

“Auntie!”

But she wasn’t reacting at all. Instead, she was slowly walking towards the crystal.

But Adora stepped in her way and pointed her sword at her. “Stop!”

Castaspella didn’t stop, but before she could impale herself on Adora’s blade, magic energy hit her, and she collapsed.

“Auntie!”

“Forgotten Stars!” Castaspella shook her head as she got up on all fours. “I was… it possessed me.” She raised her head and stared at the crystal. “We have to destroy it.”

Before anyone could say anything in response, the whispering turned into screeching, and a wave of cold hit them. As they staggered back, transparent figures appeared between them and the crystal, and the floor and walls started to get covered with ice.

Adora swung her sword at the closest figure, but the blade went right through it - and Adora jerked back, staring at the ice covering half the weapon. “Don’t let them touch you!” she yelled.

But they were surrounded. And the damned things were closing in.

“Uh… my sensors don’t show anything!” Entrapta yelled. “Except for cold spots. They’re draining thermal energy!”

Magic. Evil magic.

Scorpia lashed out again with her singer, then hissed and pulled it back, rubbing the frozen tip. “Yikes!”

“Don’t let them touch you!” Adora yelled again, levelling her sword at the closest thing. Magic energy shot at it but passed harmlessly through it. The thing seemed to cackle in their eerie way.

“Did you just try to *heal* it?” Glimmer asked.

“I thought it might help, like with Micah,” Adora replied.

They were bunched up and surrounded. Caught between the things and the walls. Seacat hissed. “We need to get past them.”

“I’ve got an idea!” Bow drew an arrow out of his quiver and shot it at the closest thing - no, at the floor. Fire erupted from the impact, flames reaching for the ceiling. Seacat could feel the heat from where she stood.

And the things recoiled with a hissing noise - for a moment. Seacat’s hope of beating them with fire died quickly when they swarmed the flames and snuffed them out in moments. But they had reacted. “They’re going after fire! Use it to lure them away so we can escape!”

“No! Open a path to the crystal!” Adora yelled. “Quickly.” She was swimming her sword at two more of the things advancing towards her.

But there were an awful lot of the things between them and the crystal.

“I’ve only got two more fire arrows!” Bow yelled.

“Use them!” Adora snapped. Lure them away!”

“But if the crystal explodes - or if the things don’t die with it…” Glimmer trailed off.

“We have to risk it!” Adora insisted. “Bow! Now!”

Bow grimaced but did as told and fired one arrow to the right, setting up another fire, followed by the second further away.

The ice ghosts or whatever they were drawn to the flames, and Adora charged the crystal, sword held high. A few of the ghosts attempted to intercept her, but she jumped over the first pair, went around the next and *ran through* the third.

I’m going to kill her for this! Seacat thought as she followed Adora. She wasn’t going to run through the ghosts, of course - she jumped and then slid under one before darting around the rest.

The things were all converging on Adora now, shrieking like stuck pigs, but she was too close to the crystal to be stopped. With a roar, she raised the sword, jumped and brought her blade down on the crystal.

For a horrible moment, caught between two more ghosts, Seacat thought Adora had missed. Or the crystal resisted the force of her blow somehow.

Then, like a burst seam, something seemed to open in the crystal, a gap where Adora’s sword had struck, and energy shot out of it. Two of the things were caught in the stream and ripped apart. And the metal walls started to buckle under the stream as it bounced off them. But the other ghosts were fine.

“We need to flee!” Glimmer yelled. “They’re still attacking!”

But there were too many of the things between them and the exit. And they had nothing to hurt the ghosts with… Seacat’s eyes widened. “Get ready to run!” she yelled - and jumped to the wall. Slashing quickly with her claws, she cut out a sheet of metal, then ripped it off.

“Ca-Seacat! What are you doing?” Adora yelled.

“Clearing a path!” Seacat replied - and dashed towards the steam of magic energy coming from the broken crystal.

A ghost tried to intercept her, but she dived to the ground and slid past it, then jumped up and rushed forward. Straight at the stream.

“Ca-Seacat! No!”

Seacat clenched her teeth and raised the metal plate before stepping into the stream. The impact almost ripped the plate out of her hands, but she held on - and twisted the plate, directing the stream across the room. Two more of the things coming her way were caught in it and dissolved.

She had to dig in her claws to keep from getting bowled over. The plate was starting to bend and buckle, but Seacat managed to move the reflected stream of magic, sweeping it over the room, towards the hallway, ripping the ghosts caught by it to shreds. “Go!” she yelled as soon as the path was clear. “I don’t know how long I can hold this!”

The stream was growing - both in power and width. She was now getting pushed back, the claws on her feet leaving deep gouges on the floor. And her hands were starting to hurt - the beam was almost wider than the plate now.

She couldn’t stop, though. Not when the others were still running away. Not when there were still dozens of the things to keep at bay. Hissing with pain, she held on.

“Ca-Seacat!”

Until strong arms wrapped around her waist, and she was yanked away, the freed stream narrowly missing her tail.

“You idiot!” Adora snapped, squeezing Seacat under her arm and running towards the exit.

“What?” Seacat let the mangled plate drop. “Let me down! I can run!”

Adora didn’t listen. Her friend carried her out of the room and around the corner.

Right before an explosion shook the floor.

Seacat felt a shockwave hit them just before a cloud of dust and smoke engulfed them. Adora was still carrying her, though, and not letting her go even as they stumbled through the smoke. “Put me down!” Seacat yelled, then coughed when she inhaled too much smoke.

And then they were in the old mine tunnel, with the smoke thinning somewhat. She could see others ahead, running as well.

“Put me down!”

Adora finally did, and Seacat whirled, facing the corridor behind them. If they had missed any ghosts…

“Are we still alive?” Bow asked.

“What do you think?” Glimmer shot back.

“After seeing ghosts, I’m not sure what to think,” he said.

“Were those creatures actually ghosts? That would be the find of the century! The existence of ghosts was proposed but never proven!” Entrapta chimed in.

“Can anyone see any ghosts?” Seacat snapped.

“In this smoke?” Glimmer complained.

“My sensors don’t detect any cold patches in the smoke,” Entrapta replied. “Do you think we destroyed them all? So briefly after discovering them?”

“I sure hope so,” Adora said. “They almost killed us.” She shuddered. “And you!” She turned towards Seacat. “What were you thinking?”

“I was thinking we needed to destroy them,” Seacat replied, scowling. “And I saw the beam being reflected by the metal on the walls.”

“You almost died!” Adora yelled.

“You charged the entire horde of ghosts!” Seacat yelled back. “I had a plan!”

“So had I! And it worked!”

“So did mine!”

“Adora! Seacat!” Mermista interrupted them. “Stop it! You both took serious risks, but it worked out!”

“Exactly!” Sea Hawk beamed at them. “A brave and desperate plan - two plans - that worked out into a harrowing but victorious adventure!”

Seacat closed her mouth. She still glared at Adora, who should’ve known better. If she had managed to slice the crystal in half, instead of creating a small gap, then the explosion would’ve killed her! Probably.

Adora was pouting at her.

“I still don’t detect any colder zones. I think all of the ghosts - if those were ghosts - are destroyed,” Entrapta said.

“Those weren’t ghosts.” Castaspella shook her head. “Probably ethereal constructs. There was some work on such things in Mystacor a few decades ago, but nothing ever came of it.”

“Well, someone managed,” Glimmer said. “Or something.”

“Let’s check the crystal’s remains!” Entrapta cheered. “The smoke’s settling.”

“Carefully,” Perfuma cautioned them.

They quickly made their way back to the chamber with the crystal and the ghosts. The entire room had been torn up - shards of the crystal were stuck in the walls, ceiling and floor. Parts of the walls and ceiling had been caved in as well.

She glanced at Adora and frowned once more. Her friend looked a little shaken, at least - but seemed to glare at her!

“I don’t sense any magic any more, except for a fading impression,” Castaspella stated.

“Does that mean Dad’s safe?” Glimmer asked, biting her lower lip. Bow hugged her.

The sorceress shrugged. “I can’t tell until I check Micah. It’s possible that this is enough to cure him. Or he might need further treatment - this is an unprecedented development.”

“In any case,” Scorpia said, grinning, “this danger’s dealt with!”

“Yes.” Perfuma nodded. “And the area feels… better, now.”

“I wonder who built this,” Entrapta said as she waved her device around. “It wasn’t on the original plans, so it must have been added later. After the First Ones had left, since the mines aren’t on the plans and would’ve taken some time to dig. So, who was here?”

“Well, if they left any clue, it’s probably destroyed by now,” Mermista said, looking pointedly at the wrecked room. “And good riddance, I say!”

“As long as we all survive, I don’t care!” Glimmer shook her head. “This was… we almost all died. Several times.”

“Let’s hope the Heart of Etheria is not as dangerous to get to,” Bow said.

Seacat glared at him. He just had to say it!

*****

“Sorry.”

Seacat tensed, then turned. Adora was standing behind her in the winding tunnel Seacat had entered to cool off. And she was wincing.

“Sorry for what?” Seacat asked.

“Sorry for dragging you around like that,” Adora replied. She took a deep breath. “And for acting without thinking, I guess.”

“Risking your life at the drop of a hat, you mean,” Seacat shot back.

That earned her a scowl. “I didn’t grab a shield and jumped into the path of a deadly magic beam!”

Seacat clenched her teeth. It wasn’t the same - she hadn’t had any choice. Although… “Sorry,” she mumbled.

They stared at each other for a moment. “I guess we’re both sorry,” Adora said.

Seacat slowly nodded. Her lover was still too quick to risk herself.

“But… I couldn’t do nothing. And... “ Adora sighed, “I’m sorry.”

Seacat nodded, sighing as well. “Yes. It’s just…” She trailed off. How to explain that she couldn’t stand Adora risking herself like that, even though she was fine with risking herself? Without looking like a hypocrite? “I’m the captain of our ship,” she said.

“That doesn’t mean that you get to risk yourself and I can’t,” Adora shot back. “I’m She-Ra.”

"But…" Seacat started.

"No buts. This is my duty - this base was made for me."

"I'm not going to let you do this alone," Seacat said.

They stared at each other again. Seacat bit her lower lip, then took a step towards Adora.

And felt herself engulfed in her love's arms.

*****

"So, you two good now?" Glimmer asked when they rejoined the others. "Did you kiss and make up?"

"Glimmer!" Adora gasped. "That's…"

"...an entirely valid question when we are planning to save the world and need you," the princess went on. "We can't stop the Heart of Etheria if you're not fully with us."

Bow nodded. "This was just one trap. What if the path to the Heart is protected by other, more dangerous traps?"

Seacat winced, then forced herself to grin. "Then we deal with them like we dealt with this."

"By almost dying and only winning through luck?" Mermista narrowed her eyes at her while she elbowed Sea Hawk. "That was a rhetorical question."

"Ow!"

"Well, what do we know about the path to the Heart of Etheria?" Seacat asked.

Entrapta smiled. "Well, it's not a path to the Heart of Etheria. It's a path to a failsafe of sorts - a way to stop the weapon from being fired in an emergency, as far as I can tell. The data in the bot's memory was a little corrupted, and I'm not sure if it was complete

to begin with; some of the sectors seemed empty but not damaged, although that could be a normal reaction of the crystals used by the First Ones - we don't have enough experience with them to determine this. Although I think there are a few experiments we could do..."

Seacat smiled and interrupted her: "A failsafe?"

"Oh, right. It's basically a vent - a vent for magic energy. Instead of channelling it into the weapon's firing mechanism, which is actually a construct of pure magic, not unlike the Runestone Network, and anchored to this base, the power would be vented into the lake. Probably boiling the water, so we shouldn't be near it, just in case."

"Uh…" Adora grimaced. "Enough energy to blow up the planet, vented into a lake? Wouldn't that, uh, boil the ocean?"

"Glad you asked!" Entrapta beamed at them. "Bow, the diagram!"

Bow sighed and held up a crudely drawn sketch of the world and the island.

"The weapon construct serves to amplify and focus the energy. Like a gun. Only that it blows up in the process of firing since it can't contain the explosion. Actually, that's like a badly built gun." Entrapta nodded to her own explanation. "So… without the amplification and focus, the energy would still be enough to blow the entire island and part of the ocean into space or something. But the failsafe can vent the energy slowly enough so it can, well, disperse into the general magic field, which surrounds us all. The lake serves as a sort of cooling device for the spillover since the process isn't perfect."

"And we're in the lake," Mermista said.

"Technically, we're under the lake," Entrapta said. "Which is a good thing since the facility will be protected - and it's shielded against magic, which you have noticed, of course; my hair's not as

strong as it usually is because the magic field that is everywhere on Etheria isn't quite completely here. If you know what I mean."

Seacat thought she did. "So… we need to activate this thing and hope that whatever the First Ones planned will work?"

Entrapta nodded with a wide smile. "Exactly! Isn't it exciting?"

That was one word for it. "And how do we do this?"

Entrapta's smile slipped a little. "Well… we're not entirely sure…"

"Based on our experiences, Adora using magic on the controls in the failsafe chamber should be enough," Castaspella said.

Seacat hissed. "And what if the entire energy goes through her - again?"

Entrapta stopped smiling entirely. Castaspella looked away.

Damn. Seacat muttered every curse she knew under her breath. "Adora..."

"I'll do it anyway." Adora nodded. "If we don't stop this weapon, all of us will die anyway."

Including Adora. Seacat clenched her teeth and managed not to blurt out what she really wanted to say. "I'm coming with you," she said instead.

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again as their eyes met. She slowly nodded.

Seacat ignored how everyone else seemed to have held their breaths. And how Sea Hawk was squeezing Mermista's shoulder and whispering to her, shaking his head. This was how it should be. She wouldn't let Adora do this alone. Even if she couldn't actually do anything. But she would be with Adora. Whatever happened, she wouldn't leave.

“Alright,” Adora said, taking a deep breath. “How do we get to this failsafe?”

“And how is it protected?” Seacat asked.

“Well, the chamber is at the bottom of the main shaft,” Entrapta said. “But that’s all we know.” She smiled. “We’ll see when we go down there, I guess, if anything was added that is not on the models we have.”

“Everyone in the shaft? On the same lift?” Seacat shook her head. You didn’t put everything on a single ship if you expected trouble.

“There’s just one lift - one platform - leading down,” Entrapta said. “We would have to wait until it reaches the chamber and returns if we split up.”

“Yes,” Adora said.

“But…” Entrapta blinked. “Oh.”

Adora nodded. As did Seacat. They wouldn’t drag anyone else down with them.

*****

“Are you sure it doesn’t go down to the centre of Etheria?” Adora asked, peering down the shaft.

“Yes,” Entrapta replied. “Well, pretty sure - in theory, they could’ve dug deeper after the models in the memory banks were finished, just as they added mines and stuff. But it’s pretty hard to reach the core of the planet - it’s all molten magma, mostly. So, you can’t just keep digging; you’d have to find a way to keep the heat at bay, stabilise the shaft, compensate for the movements of the molten parts - they are a liquid, after all, and the planet’s turning… It’s not impossible, but it’s very difficult, I guess, even for the First Ones. Just the lift to the failsafe chamber is an engineering challenge. Or it would be if they didn’t just use the

same magic to make the platform float that they use to blow up the planet. But a proper lift would be a challenge!”

Seacat narrowed her eye at the shaft as well. She couldn’t see the bottom, which was… well, not a good feeling. “It must be at least a mile,” she muttered.

“A bit more,” Entrapta confirmed. “Impressive. I wonder how they dug the shaft. Did they just vanish the earth and stone? Or actually transported the material out of the shaft? And where did they put it?”

Those were interesting questions. Probably - if you were an engineer. Or Entrapta. But Seacat didn’t care about them right now. “So, does the lift work?”

“It should. We haven’t been able to get it to work, but we didn’t have She-Ra’s sword. Or her magic.”

“It didn’t react to my spells,” Castaspella said.

“So I just zap the controls. As usual.” Adora nodded.

“Yes.” Bow nodded. “The controls are the standard ones. There should be no reason why it wouldn’t work.”

Unless someone changed them. Or trapped them. Seacat shook her head. The others would have looked for signs of either. She had to trust them. “Let’s do it.”

“Wait!” Entrapta walked up to her and Adora. “Take this with you!” She handed them a few signal rockets. “They will fly a mile high, so we’ll see them if you fire them. Standard signal colours!”

“Good idea.” Seacat smiled at her as she took them. “Thank you!”

“It’s the least I could do. I wish there was a way to extend speaking tubes, but… they don’t work that way.” Entrapta pouted. “If we had a way to speak to you while you were far away, things would be so much easier.”

Definitely. But they hadn't and had to make do. And Seacat had something else to do other than just coming along with Adora. "Thank you," she repeated herself, then hugged Entrapta - and was wrapped in limbs and hair in turn.

"Be safe," Entrapta whispered, just loud enough for Seacat's ears. Then she released her and took a step back. "I'll recheck the controls!" she announced, turning away.

Seacat acted as if she didn't see the princess wipe her eyes. She exchanged a nod with Castapsella, who turned to join Entrapta.

"Seacat."

She straightened. Sea Hawk was smiling at her. "Captain."

"I'm proud of you. Come back safe!"

She hugged him as well. This time, she wiped her eyes when they broke the hug.

"You better come back safe," Mermista told her. "You hear?" The princess glared at her.

"I will." Seacat smiled back and hoped she wasn't lying as she hugged her friend.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia hugged her - and lifted her up - without asking or warning. "Give 'em hell!"

"Sure." Seacat swallowed the rest of her remark as Perfuma joined them. The princess didn't say anything, which was a surprise.

Adora had been hugging Bow and Glimmer, and both had tears in their eyes when they finally released her. While the others turned to Adora, Bow and Glimmer came over to Seacat. "Keep her safe, you hear?" Glimmer whispered. "You know how she is."

Seacat nodded. "I won't leave her," she said.

“Good.” Glimmer gave her a firm nod. “I’ll hold you to that.”

They stared at each other for a moment.

“Group hug!” Bow blurted out, and once more, Seacat felt arms wrap around her.

It felt good.

But then everyone took a step back, and Adora raised her sword at the lift controls.

And Seacat swallowed the lump in her throat. She reached out to Adora and took her lover’s hand, then squeezed gently.

It was time to face whatever was waiting for them down below.

*****

The Heart of Etheria

Seacat took a deep breath as the lift kept descending. This was it. They were about to enter the Heart of Etheria. Well, the failsafe chamber for the Heart of Etheria. But it was the closest they could get to the actual heart, according to Entrapta. She looked up, but the top of the shaft was just a slightly brighter spot above them by now, even for her sharp eyes.

And even in the dim eerie light in the shaft, it was hard to make out how fast they were going since the walls hardly had any markings on them. On the whole, it was a very unnerving descent. Like disappearing into a dark emptiness. Or something. She shuddered.

Adora squeezed her hand. Gently, of course - Seacat didn't want to find out what would happen if her love used her actual strength in She-Ra's form.

"We should've asked how long this will take," Seacat muttered.

"Why?" Adora cocked her head. "Do you want to know if we have time for a nap before we arrive?"

Seacat chuckled. Adora, joking at this moment? That was a good sign. "Well… I have some ideas about what we could do to pass the time," she said with a wide grin.

"Our friends would never let us forget it if we have to scramble into the failsafe chamber with our pants down because we misjudged the time," Adora pointed out.

"They would never know," Seacat shot back. She bared her fangs. "We would never tell them. Well, I would never tell them. You'd give it all away by blushing and stuttering as soon as they asked how it went."

Adora gasped. "I would not!"

“Really?” Seacat narrowed her eyes and leaned towards her. “You’re blushing right now!”

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it and pouted. “That’s your fault!”

“Damn well it is!” Seacat smirked and pushed herself on her tiptoes, pressing a quick kiss on Adora’s lips.

Adora gasped again but quickly rallied - when Seacat was about to drop down, Adora’s arms wrapped around her waist, pulling her closer, and the kiss turned into a proper kiss.

Seacat closed her eyes and pressed herself into Adora’s front. She didn’t want this to end. She didn’t want to face whatever trap the First Ones had built into the chamber. She didn’t want to deal with this at all.

She wanted to be with Adora and sail the seas. Enjoy life, have adventures without having to save the planet. She let her hands roam over Adora’s back, her claws gently pricking her lover’s skin through the fabric of her top.

She felt Adora tense in return, then tighten her arms around Seacat’s body, one hand grabbing her ponytail and using it to pull her head back. Then she was kissing Seacat’s throat.

“Yes…” Seacat hissed, running her own hands over and through Adora’s hair. Her lover’s lips were trailing kisses over her collarbone, moving lower…

And Adora pulled back, releasing her.

Seacat growled, panting.

Adora was breathing heavily as well. “We can’t risk a trap catching us… like this.” She bit her lower lip, a blush colouring her cheeks.

Seacat wanted to argue, but Adora was right. She closed her eyes and sighed. Then leaned against Adora again, this time resting

her forehead against Adora's upper chest. "I'm not going to lose you or leave you," she whispered.

"Me neither. Uh, lose you, that is, or leave you," Adora replied. "I mean…" She trailed off.

"I know," Seacat whispered. "You better not," she added after a moment.

"I won't."

"And don't you dare to sacrifice yourself," Seacat whispered.

"And what if there's no other way?"

"Then we both do it." She opened her eyes and looked up at Adora. "That's why I'm here."

"I know." Adora clenched her teeth - Seacat could see her jaw muscles twitch. But then her lover sighed. "I know," she repeated herself and hugged Seacat.

They stayed like that while the lift kept descending.

"Did you ever think," Adora whispered after a while, "that we'd end up here when we met in Seaworthy?"

"No," Seacat said. "I thought you were a weirdo."

"Really?"

"Yes, I did. Of course, calling me a Horde cadet didn't help you with making a good impression." Seacat snorted at the memory - it was funny in hindsight.

"But… nothing other than that?"

"Well, I noticed how attractive you were." Only a blind idiot would've missed that. "And I had some weird dreams."

"Oh."

“Not that kind of dreams! Well, not just that kind,” she added, turning her head away.

“Oh.”

Seacat didn’t have to look up to know Adora was smirking.

“So, your subconsciousness knew.”

“My subconsciousness isn’t the best or trusted source,” Seacat retorted.

“And then came the Princess Prom.”

“When I took you carousing, yes.” The dreams had gotten… steamier afterwards.

Adora squeezed her tighter again. “I liked that.”

“So did I.” Seacat sighed again. They had come a long way since that first meeting. And this stupid trap wouldn’t stop them.

She closed her eyes and hugged Adora.

This time, they stayed like that until the lift stopped.

Seacat took a deep breath and put a hand on the hilt of her blade as she stared at the faintly visible door in front of them. It didn’t move. “Heal it?” she asked without taking her eyes off the wall.

Adora did so, but the magical energy seemed to hit the wall - the door - without any effect. “I guess we have to cut our way through it?”

Seacat looked around but couldn’t see any controls. Not even a hint of controls. It wasn’t a good sign. “Yes, let’s do it,” she said, stepping forward and lashing out with her claws. The material parted, as it had above. “Doesn’t look any sturdier.”

“Good.” Adora took a deep breath, then slashed at the door with her sword, quickly cutting it to pieces that fell to the ground.

Behind the door, a straight corridor awaited them. Same lighting, too.

"I'd have expected something a little bit more special for a failsafe chamber," Adora commented.

"Doesn't seem to be the First Ones' style," Seacat replied. "They seem big on everything looking the same."

Adora nodded and took a step into the corridor. Seacat followed her. Both stopped. "I doubt that they left the corridor unguarded," she said. "This is the one room where their plans can be stopped. They wouldn't let just anyone enter."

"It might've recognised me as She-Ra - and as a First One," Adora said.

"That didn't stop Light Hope," Seacat pointed out. She couldn't see anything out of the ordinary in the corridor. It was unnerving.

"Light Hope couldn't stop me, though," Adora replied.

"But this is the core of the First One's base." Seacat shook her head. "There have to be defences."

"But they would want the failsafe to work when needed," Adora countered.

"We had to cut our way in," Seacat replied.

"So… I guess there's only one way to find out." Adora took a deep breath, then started walking, sword held in a guard position. "Stay behind me!"

Seacat clenched her teeth. She didn't want to hide behind Adora, but… there was a chance that Adora would be able to enter without triggering the defences. Which Seacat was sure were present.

Nothing happened. Maybe the defences were only triggered at the door on the other end? It was possible. Trap intruders in the corridor… This was harrowing. And not in the good, adventuring way.

Just about halfway to the door, Seacat heard something. A hissing sound. Like… not like a snake. More like… "Hold!" She muttered a curse under her breath and looked around.

"What did you see?" Adora asked.

"Nothing," she replied. "But I'm hearing something…" She sniffed, her nostrils flaring. "Gas!"

"Gas?"

Adora looked around. "I don't see anything. I don't smell anything!"

"Hold your breath!" Seacat shook her head. "We need to get out of here." She looked back - the platform was rising. No way back - the gas would fill the corridor before the lift was back. "Forward!"

They rushed towards the door.

"Open it without destroying it!" Seacat hissed.

"What if the room on the other side is full of gas as well?"

Seacat didn't answer that. The answer was obvious - they would die.

Adora reached the door before her, swinging her sword - and shooting magical energy at the controls. The doors started to slide open in three directions.

Adora climbed through, then turned towards Seacat.

"Close them!" Seacat yelled with her last breath, preparing to jump.

Adora gasped but turned away, and Seacat saw the flash from her sword light up the room a moment before she jumped, clearing the gap moments before it closed again.

She rolled over her shoulder, then went into a crouch, looking around.

“You’re crazy!” Adora complained. “If you had been a little slower…”

Seacat sniffed the air, her ears twitching. “No gas.” She sighed. “We’re safe here.”

“As safe as we can be in a base designed to blow the entire planet,” Adora replied. “I see no other door.”

Seacat didn’t either. “This must be the failsafe, then.” She looked around. There was a glowing triangle set in the floor, matching the walls of the room - and the ceiling. “How do we activate it?”

“I guess… heal the floor? Or the walls?” Adora didn’t quite shrug as she turned around herself, studying the room. “I don’t see any controls. I guess healing the walls it is, then!” Adora said. “Or the floor?” She looked unsure.

Seacat snorted. “I’m not an expert on First Ones’ tech.”

“What if a mistake triggers the whole thing?” Adora shook her head.

“Let’s think this through,” Seacat said - as much to calm down her lover as to try and solve this puzzle. “Triangle on the floor.”

“And on the walls!”

“But they don’t match each other,” Seacat said. “The ceiling, though - it mirrors the floor.”

“So, I stand on the triangle in the floor and heal the ceiling? Or the floor?”

“Either would work,” Seacat said. She took a deep breath. This was it. This was why they were here.

“But which one?” Adora asked.

“None.”

Who…? Seacat whirled, drawing her blade - and froze. A glowing figure floated above the floor. Like Light Hope.

“Light Hope?” Adora asked but shook her head right afterwards. “No, you aren’t Light Hope.”

“No, I’m not,” the bot confirmed. “I’m the guardian of this installation. The last hope of our people.”

“You’re Last Hope?” Adora cocked her head.

“No.”

“We already dismantled the bot of this base,” Seacat pointed out.

“The bot?” The figure frowned. “You mean the crystal computer of the installation?”

“Yes.” It figured that the First Ones would have fancy names for bots. Their bots had an attitude, after all.

“So, who’re you? Another bot like Light Hope?” Adora asked again.

“I’m not a bot at all - although I am using the form of a crystal computer’s interface, which might be a little misleading.”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “Can you be a little clearer?”

The bot frowned at her, then looked at Adora again. “Light Hope is an artificial sentience.”

“A bot,” Seacat cut in. When the bot frowned, she grinned, baring her fangs.

“I, on the other hand, am the same as you - or I was.” The figure nodded at Adora.

“What? You’re a First One like me?” Adora gasped.

“My consciousness and memories, yes.”

“You’re a copy?” Seacat blurted out. The First Ones could copy memories? That was… quite frightening.

“I’m not a copy. I’m like you.” The bot nodded at Adora again. “But my mind inhabits a crystal computer array instead of a flesh and blood body. My natural body has long since turned to dust.”

“You’re a ghost!” Adora replied.

Once more, the figure frowned. “There’s nothing superstitious about this - it’s a perfectly scientific procedure.”

A very creepy procedure, Seacat thought.

“But why would you do this?” Adora asked.

“To save our people, of course.” The bot floated closer to Adora. “This installation is our people’s last hope of salvation. A last, desperate plan to win a war of annihilation. How could I not do everything I could to help with it?”

“Because doing so would doom this world?” Seacat cut in. “Kill everyone?”

“If the enemy wins, this planet is doomed anyway. Our enemy knows no mercy.”

“But that was a thousand years ago!” Adora protested. “If our people’s situation was so desperate, then the war is long over at this point!”

“It isn’t - you are proof of that.”

“What?” Adora blinked.

“Your existence proves that our people are still alive. Your parents. Your siblings. Still fighting desperately against a relentless enemy.”

“You know my family?” Adora sounded… vulnerable. Unsure.

Seacat clenched her teeth.

“I was the one who arranged for you to be transported to his world.”

Both of them gasped at that. “But… it was Hordak…” Adora trailed off. Seacat reached out and squeezed her hand.

“Hordak was trying to open a portal to his wretched home. It was easy to manipulate his supposed right hand and arrange an experiment that managed to pierce the barrier that kept us sealed away from the real universe. After all, this is part of this installation’s purpose.” The bot sounded… proud. But not like Entrapta when she showed off a new invention. Seacat could almost hear the sneer in its voice even though the bot’s expression remained polite. “And I had it aimed at our people, knowing that only one of us could be our saviour.” It nodded at Adora’s sword. “And I was vindicated - you became She-Ra. Ready to fulfil your destiny.”

“No!” Adora yelled. “She-Ra is the protector of Etheria! Not its executor!” She shook her head. “My duty is to protect everyone!”

“She-Ra is the sword of *our* people,” the bot retorted.

“No!” Adora shook her head again. “She-Ra is older than that. There was a She-Ra before the First Ones… before our people arrived on Etheria.”

“That was then. Now, She-Ra is ours.”

Seacat’s eyes widened. The bot couldn’t mean… “You stole her power?” She blurted out, then wanted to hit herself at the expression on Adora’s face.

“Stole it?” The bot scoffed. “It was there for the taking. So much power, with practically no guidance. It was a terrible waste of potential. Now, the Heart of Etheria is ours. None but those of our people can wield its power. And its power is bound to you.”

“To… to my sword.” Adora looked at her blade.

“Exactly. You are our protector. Our saviour. Your destiny is to end this war and bring peace to our people - and the universe.”

“And doom Etheria?” Adora shook her head almost violently. Seacat saw some tears flying.

“It is already doomed. The enemy will not stop. Will not falter. Will never be satisfied until our people have been purged, our resources taken, our world subjugated to his will. And then he will reach out further.” The bot sneered openly. “You think he won’t reach Etheria? He already has! Hordak was just the first soldier of his. Others will follow! And only you can stop them!”

“What? Hordak… the Horde….?” Adora trailed off.

“The Horde is our enemy. Hordak, for all his power, was but one soldier. Barely more than a mindless drone. The true enemy is his leader. And you are the only one who can defeat him. Only you can destroy his base - his homeworld - where he sits and sends his drone armies through portals to our world.” The bot shook her head. “*This* is your destiny, Adora.”

“No! Sacrificing - murdering - all of Etheria isn’t my destiny!”

“The people of this planet are already dead. They cannot withstand the Horde.”

“We did it already!” Seacat yelled.

“You beat a pathetic imitation, natives armed with primitive weapons. You cannot stand against the real Horde. The only way to beat them is to destroy their leader - and his world.” The bot

stared at Adora. “Sacrifices have to be made. For our people. For your family.”

Seacat narrowed her eyes. “Do you even know Adora’s family? Do you know if they’re still alive?” The bot hadn’t mentioned any details. Her ears twitched, easily picking up Adora’s soft gasp. Damn - the bot was exploiting this!

“Does it matter? If they should’ve fallen fighting the enemy, you can still avenge them. But if they’re alive, then you are the only one who can save them,” the bot replied.

“By murdering all of Etheria,” Adora spat. “What kind of monster would do that?”

“I told you: If our people lose the war, Etheria will be attacked next anyway. The creatures of this world are already doomed.”

“We’ve stood fine for a thousand years,” Seacat countered.

“And a single Horde drone almost conquered the planet.”

She clenched her teeth. As much as she hated to admit it, that was true. “But we beat him in the end.”

“Thanks to us.”

“Thanks to Adora!” Seacat hissed. “You didn’t do anything!”

“I brought her to this world.”

“To destroy it!” Seacat wanted to lash out, shred the bot with her claws, but the figure wasn’t real. And she didn’t know where the bot’s control unit was located. Though it probably was around here since Entrapta hadn’t found it upstairs.

“To fulfil her destiny.”

“Stop!” Adora yelled. “I’m not going to… to destroy Etheria just to win a war. We don’t even know if the war’s still going on!”

“It is. Hordak’s presence and actions are proof of that,” the bot told them.

“Because he tried to conquer Etheria?” Seacat sneered.

“Because he was still alive. If our people had won, none of the enemy’s drones would have been left alive.”

Seacat felt her fur bristle. Even though she already knew that the First Ones were willing to destroy Etheria to win their war, this somehow made it worse.

“You’d kill them all?” Adora asked, shaking her head with apparent shock.

“They are the enemy. And they are just drones. Parts of a hive mind. Not people like our people.”

“And we’re not people either, I guess,” Seacat cut in with a sneer.

“You are doomed either way.”

“How convenient!” Seacat spat.

“I am merely stating the facts. Adora needs to realise her destiny and save our people. Her family.”

“I’ve got my family here!” Adora snapped. “I’m not going to sacrifice them for some people I’ve never met! You don’t even know if they are still alive!”

“If they have been killed, then you can avenge them.”

“And kill even more people?” Adora kept shaking her head. Seacat saw tears run down her cheeks.

“The enemy is a threat to every world. Left alone, he’ll conquer the next world. And another after that. As long as he’s alive, no one is safe.”

Seacat scoffed. “And why do you care about other worlds? You’re willing to sacrifice Etheria for your plans.”

“Etheria is doomed either way. The enemy is aware of its existence.”

“Really?” Seacat sneered. “And why hasn’t this enemy invaded already? Sent more soldiers with Hordak?” This didn’t add up. “It’s been a thousand years, and he hasn’t done anything!”

“Because our people are still fighting him.”

“And he is so hard-pressed, he can’t spare a few more soldiers to conquer Etheria, yet you need to destroy a planet to win the war? This makes no sense!”

Adora nodded, squeezing Seacat’s hand. “You’re just saying anything you think will make me destroy Etheria for you. You’re like Light Hope!”

“No, I’m like you!”

Seacat shook her head. “You sound like a bot. You look like a bot. But most important: You act like a bot. Just following orders without thinking.”

“I am no bot!” the figure spat, finally showing emotion. “I am a First One! I sacrificed everything for our people! I built this installation! I kept it going! I brought things back on track after Mara’s treason!”

“‘Mara’s treason’?” Adora glared at the bot. “She didn’t want to destroy the planet, and you call that treason?”

“It was treason. She betrayed our people. She was made She-Ra to fulfil her destiny, yet betrayed it.”

“She was chosen to be She-Ra by Etheria!” Adora spat.

“We control Etheria!”

“No! You just want to destroy it!” Adora wiped some tears from her eyes.

“To save our people!”

Adora shook her head again and turned to Seacat. “She’s just repeating herself. Like Light Hope.”

“I am not like Light Hope!”

“And it tried to kill us with gas,” Seacat pointed out. “It only started talking after we beat that trap:”

“Oh, right!” Adora glared at the glowing figure. “This is just you trying to stop us with words since you have nothing left, right?”

The bot froze for a moment, then shook its head. “No. I’m telling you about your destiny. That this world is doomed either way.”

“No! Etheria isn’t doomed! We’ll save it! That’s why we came here!” Adora turned away and stepped on the triangle set in the floor, raising her sword.

“No! Think of our people! Your family! Your destiny!”

Seacat scoffed and joined Adora, once more gripping her love’s hand.

“No! Stop!”

Adora sent a wave of magic into the ceiling.

And the bot’s projection rushed towards them. “No!”

Seacat lashed out with her free hand, but her claws harmlessly passed through the figure a moment before it reached them.

Then everything went white.

*****

Seacat blinked, rubbing her eyes. She was standing in a clearing in a forest. Unfamiliar trees, though. She sniffed the air. Unfamiliar smells, too. Not near the sea, in any case.

"Where are we?" Adora, standing next to her, asked.

"I don't know," Seacat replied. "I've never seen this place before."

"Where we… were we transported here?" Adora looked around.

Seacat knelt down and touched the grass. Or tried to - her fingers passed through it. "It's not real. Or… or we're not real."

"A dream?"

"A dream we share?" Seacat cocked her head.

"One of us could be dreaming," Adora replied.

"Well, it's not me," Seacat told her. "Or we wouldn't be wearing clothes, and we'd be in a place with a bed."

Adora blushed. "Well… let's assume that we aren't drawing, then."

"Oh!" Seacat grinned at her lover. "That means if this was your dream, we'd be naked too!"

Adora coughed. "Let's find out where we are. And what happened."

Right. They still had a world to save. Seacat hissed. "The bot! It rushed us at the last moment!"

"So, this could be Last Hope's doing?" Adora frowned.

Seacat bared her fangs. 'Last Hope' - the bot didn't like that name, so that made it perfect. "Probably. We should…" She trailed off, her ears twitching. "I hear shouting. And yelling."

"What? Where?" Adora whirled.

Seacat pointed to her right. “This way.”

“Let’s go!”

They rushed through the forest. Literally - neither trees nor any other plant was real. And the shouting turned into screaming. Finally, they entered another clearing - no, a field - and saw a village covered in smoke. And… “Hordak!” Seacat hissed.

Hordak was there, reloading a crossbow. A figure came running at him from the village, wielding a pike, but before they reached Hordak, he finished reloading, aimed and fired a glowing bolt.

The figure collapsed with a fist-sized hole in their chest. Another smaller figure rushed out of the village towards the fallen one. A child.

And Hordak was reloading his crossbow again.

Adora charged him, but her sword passed through him. He didn’t even react. Just kept reloading, then aimed, and…

Seacat looked away as Adora screamed. Then she walked over to her flailing lover and grabbed her arm. “It’s not real. It’s just… a ghost. Or some projection. Like Last Hope.”

Adora shook her head but stopped trying to kill Hordak. “But…” She took a few deep breaths, her chest heaving, before she continued: “It looked so…” She blinked. “This isn’t Hordak.”

“What? But…” Seacat narrowed her eyes. It wasn’t Hordak. Different armour. Different hair colours. “Oh. This must be one of the ‘drones’.”

“Yes. That means…” Adora looked around. “This is either the First One’s home or the Horde’s home.”

“Well, since they are attacking a village, it’s probably the First One’s home,” Seacat pointed out. The two dead people had

blonde hair. Like Adora. It didn't have to mean anything, but it was another possible clue.

"You mean… this is where I was born?" Adora looked around.

"Well, the same planet, probably." Seacat shrugged. "I doubt that this is your home village." Not that they would be able to tell.

"And they're at war. Like we were," Adora said.

"As Last Hope claimed." Seacat nodded.

"Eternia."

Seacat whirled, hissing. The bot stood behind them. Only, it didn't look like a bot, all glowing and transparent. It looked like… a person.

"Eternia. Our people's home," they said. "Under attack by the Horde." They stepped past the two of them and watched the village. More Hordaks were walking out of the village, driving blond people before them. "Such scenes are repeated across the entire world. Brutal invaders stepping out of portals to attack and slaughter us."

"But…" Adora shook her head.

"That's your memory, isn't it?" Seacat said.

"One of my memories. It was the same all over the world. We fought back desperately, but…"

The village blew up, both Hordaks and their captives screaming moments before they vanished in a fireball.

Adora gasped. "But… they blew up their own people?"

Why would the Horde do that? They had taken the village. Resistance had been broken, so…

Seacat hissed and looked around. On a hill in the distance, she saw a skiff and two people packing up a… thing. “You blew up your own village!”

“It had fallen to the enemy.”

“You blew up your own people!” Adora yelled.

“They were already doomed. We couldn’t spare the troops to save everyone.”

“But you could spare the troops to blow up the village?” Seacat shook her head.

“Bombards can be fired by two people. One, in a pinch.” Last Hope shrugged. “Taking down Horde drones herding prisoners? That would’ve taken a squad or a platoon. And risked more casualties.”

“You… you sacrificed your own people! Just to hurt the enemy!” Adora spat.

Seacat scoffed. “Like the Headhunters. But even they didn’t sacrifice civilians.”

“We didn’t sacrifice anyone. If we could save our people, we did. But those we couldn’t save… better to die quickly than to suffer in slavery.”

“That’s monstrous!” Adora protested.

“That’s the war you need to win.”

“No!”

“That’s the war you remember,” Seacat cut in. “That’s how it was a thousand years ago.”

“Yes.”

“It… can’t be the same any more,” Adora said. “Things will have changed. You can’t just act as if it were still a thousand years ago!”

“Hordak’s presence, and yours, proves that the war goes on.”

“They might have made peace!” Adora blurted out.

Seacat had her doubts, though Hordak certainly hadn’t acted as if he came from a realm at peace.

Last Hope scoffed. “Peace with the enemy? After all he did to us? Impossible!”

“We’ve made peace with the Horde,” Adora retorted. “After all that they did to us.”

Seacat nodded in agreement. “And it didn’t take us a thousand years.” Granted, they had made peace after killing off Hordak and Shadow Weaver, but still!

“You were never hurt as much as our people! We were peacefully colonising new worlds, spreading civilisation and advanced knowledge to less fortunate indigenous tribes, when we encountered the Horde. And they weren’t interested in peaceful exchange of goods and ideas - the enemy demanded our subjugation. Unlike other civilisations, we were able to resist him, and we fought on all the worlds we had explored,” the bot said. “Countless villages such as this one were wiped out in the war as we slowly lost ground until we were forced back to Eternia, our home, the Horde following us over the burnt and broken remains of the worlds we had abandoned. Nothing could stop them. No number of dead drones gave them pause.”

Seacat frowned. Something was off. “Wait! You lost how many worlds before you had just your homeworld left?”

“We had colonised over a dozen before we ran into the Horde. All were lost as we had to abandon them.”

“And yet you think Eternia held out for a thousand years?” Seacat shook her head. She wasn’t a general, but she knew enough about war to know that this didn’t add up.

“Of course! We might have had to abandon the worlds, but we didn’t let the enemy exploit their resources. We sent everything we could to Eternia to prepare for the final battle.”

“Everything?” Adora asked.

“Their magic and what people we could save.”

“Their magic?” Seacat stared. Had they evacuated the other worlds’ sorcerers? Or… She gasped. “You mean the worlds’ magic? Like the Heart of Etheria?”

Adora gasped as well.

“They weren’t like Eternia or Etheria. But what magic they had, we drained before the enemy could use it. They would have to advance over dead worlds, draining their own planet’s resources to reach us.”

That was monstrous. This… this…

“The Heart of Etheria wasn’t your first attempt, was it? You did this before,” Adora whispered.

“Do you think we would risk our fate on an untested weapon? An experiment? Etheria was the only planet we found which possessed enough magic to make this feasible. Enough magic to wipe out the enemy’s homeworld and save Eternia. Fortunately, the enemy never found it before we completed the Heart of Etheria. But then the traitor struck.”

“Mara and her friends didn’t want to wipe out the entire world just to save yours,” Adora said.

Wait! Seacat scoffed. “I bet she didn’t know what you had been doing either. How many knew who was draining the planets you

abandoned?”

The bot sneered. “You cannot wage a war by spreading crucial information to those who had no need to know.”

“You are a monster!” Adora yelled. “You wiped out those worlds!”

“I am not a monster! I’m trying to save our people! All those worlds were doomed anyway - they would be conquered and exploited, their magic and other resources fueling the enemy’s army. It was no worse than burning supplies before they fell into the hands of an advancing enemy.”

Adora fell to her knees. “You… my family…” She sobbed. “All of them…”

Seacat umed to her side. “We don’t know that. We don’t know anything about what happened to them. We only have a bot with memories that are a thousand years old.”

“I am not a bot!”

“But…” Adora shook her head, sniffling.

“We can’t trust Last Hope,” Seacat went on. “It would do anything to manipulate you. It tried to kill us, remember?”

“That was an automated defence. It started before I could stop it.”

Seacat scoffed through clenched teeth. As if anyone would believe that!

“You’re right.” Adora smiled at her, still sniffling, and wiped the tears from her eyes. “But… I don’t know what happened.”

And she would worry and wonder. Seacat hissed under her breath. “It’s not your fault,” she said. “None of this is your fault. And remember Mara and her friends? They did the right thing, too! They didn’t go along with this… this plan!”

Adora nodded. “And neither will we.”

“What a touching gesture. But it’s futile. You cannot save Etheria! Once Eternia falls, the enemy will turn his sight on Etheria. And you know that he can reach you - your own arrival, and Hordak’s, prove it. How many of our people will you sacrifice merely to prolong this planet’s life a few more years?”

“You don’t know what’s happening out there!” Adora snapped.

“I know enough! The war’s still going on!”

“You don’t know that!” Seacat said.

“Then check yourself!” the bot screamed. “Use the power of Etheria to open a portal! Look upon our homeworld! Meet our people!”

Adora froze. “What?”

The bot drew back, seemingly surprised for a moment, then glared at her. “Use the power you are about to drain to open a portal and see for yourself!”

It was desperate, Seacat realised. Or it truly thought it was right. But no matter what, Adora would never sacrifice Etheria.

But, Seacat realised with a sinking feeling in her gut, Adora might very well follow the bot’s suggestion and take a look for herself.

“You want to trick me into releasing the weapon!” Adora snapped.

“Just open a portal and see for yourself!”

“As if I could!”

“Of course you could; it’s really simple with the power at your disposal.” The bot scoffed.

Seacat scoffed back at it. “So simple, it was only achieved once in a thousand years?”

“I had to be careful in choosing my…” The bot trailed off.

“Your tool?” Seacat finished for him.

“Few have the talent to wield magic. Fewer still have the talent to wield magic on such a scale. Most natives are limited to a few tricks, and even those who widen their horizons, not content with their inborn power, rarely stretch their powers. The individuals who can connect to the Heart of Etheria, even only indirectly, are far and few.”

Individuals like Shadow Weaver, Seacat thought. She fit the description perfectly. And… Her eyes widened. “Micah! That’s how you trapped him!”

“What?” Adora stared at her, then at the bot.

“The bot manipulated Shadow Weaver to get you to Etheria,” Seacat explained. “He must have manipulated Micah to become… whatever he became.”

“The guardian?” The bot cocked its head to the side. “He stumbled upon the installation, fleeing his Horde captors. A lucky coincidence but, ultimately, a failure.”

“A lucky coincidence?” Seacat narrowed her eyes at the bot. “Shadow Weaver sending her former pupil to this island? And he managed to escape and ‘stumbled’ upon your base?”

“You manipulated her to get him!” Adora blurted out. “And then you trapped him and controlled him!”

“A necessary move to keep this base safe,” the bot said. “Shadow Weaver was becoming… tiresome. With Micah as my guardian, backed by the installation’s power, I could easily drive the Horde scum from the island.”

“And you tried to kill us with him!” Adora spat.

“That wasn’t my intention. I was… not paying as much attention as I should’ve,” the bot replied. “I would have kept him from trying to kill you, had I known what he was doing.”

“You couldn’t control him. Not outside the base,” Seacat said, slowly shaking her head. “You have no idea what’s happening outside, do you? Your memory banks must be struggling or something.”

The bot didn’t answer.

“And you want to trick me into using the weapon!”

“Just open a portal and see for yourself what you are sacrificing. Don’t you owe your people that much before you abandon them?”

Adora bit her lower lip, Seacat saw. “But…”

“It’s too dangerous!” Seacat interjected. “We can’t trust the bot!” It would lie and cheat to achieve its goal.

“I’m not a bot,” the bot insisted again.

“So you say,” Seacat shot back. “I don’t believe you.”

But Adora still looked torn. Damn it! “Just drain the magic, as we planned,” Seacat told her. “Once Etheria is safe, we can deal with the rest.”

Her love slowly nodded. “Yes.”

“Waste all that power? Risk your life for nothing?” The bot scoffed. “Channelling so much power might kill you - it will kill your friend. If you used it to open a portal, though, the strain would be much less.”

Seacat felt her stomach drop. She hadn’t considered this. Not really. She could die here.

“Ca-Seacat…”

And Adora was staring at her with tears in her eyes.

“I won’t die,” Seacat spat. “You can do this!”

“Maybe you should return to the others…”

“We’ve already started the failsafe,” Seacat reminded her.

“You’ve already started this. You can only continue - or divert the power,” the bot said, gesturing at the land around them. “Open a portal. See the world you are about to doom! Save your friend!”

“You want me to kill everyone! Kill Ca-Seacat!”

The bot smiled. “But you could use a portal to save her. Send her to Eternia. No matter your decision, she would be safe here. I’ll show you how to do it!”

“No!” Seacat spat. “Don’t listen to him, Adora!”

She heard Adora gasp, then sigh. “I see.” A heartbeat later, she whispered: “I’m sorry, Seacat.”

“No!” Seacat yelled.

And everything went dark.

*****

Everything was dark. Like the night. Seacat was floating in… the sky? Not quite - there was no moon, but small lights dotted it. And… was that the sun? At night?

“No. No. This can’t be!”

That was the bot, screaming.

“I did everything right. I see everything. I have the power. This is…”

“Adora!” Seacat whirled. Her lover - the idiot - was floating behind her, surrounded by a golden glow. Like herself, she realised.

“This can’t be! You must have made a mistake!” It looked like a bot again, like Light Hope. All transparent.

“What did you do?” Seacat asked.

“I opened a portal to Eternia. The First One’s homeworld,” Adora said with a sad smile.

“This doesn’t look like a world,” Seacat pointed out.

“The coordinates match… but the magical signature. Where are the anchors?” the bot rambled. “It’s gone. It can’t be gone!”

“Eternia is gone?” Seacat asked. “A whole world, gone?”

Adora nodded. “There’s no planet to portal to. Just…” She tilted her head. “...pieces. Many, many pieces floating in space.”

“It can’t be! They wouldn’t! No!”

“There’s no magic, either,” Adora went on.

How would she know? What had happened to her? Seacat looked around. “So… we’re where the planet would be?”

“Yes.”

“No! No! No!”

“But how…” Seacat drew a hissing breath. “Did their enemy destroy the entire planet?”

“He couldn’t have!” the bot screamed hysterically. “He couldn’t have! Only we… only we… NOOOOO!”

The First Ones had done this, Seacat realised with a gasp. “They… they used Eternia instead of Etheria. They destroyed their own world. To destroy their enemy.” She shook her head. This was…

this was exactly what a people who would destroy their villages rather than let the enemy take them would do.

“The war’s over,” Adora said. “Everyone lost.”

*****

The Cure

“No! No! They can’t have done this! Not Eternia!”

The bot was losing it. Or had lost it. Seacat shook her head. “So… Eternia is destroyed. And the Horde?”

“They must have lost their leader and homeworld,” Adora told her. “I don’t think the First Ones would’ve sacrificed their world for anything less. But there might be more soldiers left on other planets.”

Seacat nodded. She hoped that the First Ones had managed to kill their enemy. That would make everyone safe. Safer. She shook her head. “It’s… sick.”

“Yes.”

The bot was wailing. “How could they do this? How? This is… this is…”

Seacat rolled her eyes. “This is what you wanted to do to us,” she reminded it.

“Not like this! Not Eternia!”

“When did this happen?” Seacat asked. “Did Hordak know about this?”

“If he didn’t, then it must have happened after he arrived on Etheria,” Adora said. “But I don’t think there’s a way to tell.”

“Unless you can check the debris out there.” Seacat nodded towards the empty space.

Adora frowned. “I…” She blinked. “I actually could…”

“What?” Seacat stared at her.

“The power - the magic - from the Heart of Etheria. I can use it,” Adora explained. She was staring at nothing - or at something.

“To check how long ago the planet exploded?” That was… incredible. And creepy. Creepier than floating in empty space, with just some magic protecting them.

“I could pull the planet together…”

“What?”

“You could restore Eternia?” The bot gasped.

“I could pull the parts together,” Adora told it - still looking at empty space.

“Do it! Save Eternia!” The bot’s arms reached out for Adora, then passed through her. “Restore it!”

“Adora…” Seacat trailed off.

“It’s a safer way to use the stored magic,” Adora whispered. “Better than draining it into the sea.”

“Do it! Do it!”

Seacat hissed under her breath. The bot was more annoying than ever. “Is it safe?”

“It’s safer.” Adora slowly tilted her head. “I can see the parts. They’re still… connected. With fading magic.”

“The Heart of Eternia. The source of our power. Restore our homeworld!”

“Don’t kill yourself!” Seacat snapped.

Adora smiled for the first time since they had arrived here. “I won’t,” she breathed. She jerked, then floated towards Seacat, smiling.

Seacat licked her lips. “Don’t… don’t die!”

“I won’t,” Adora repeated herself, then gathered Seacat in a one-armed hug. Their auras melded, and Adora kissed her.

Seacat kissed back, squeezing her love with all her strength.

After a much too brief time, Adora broke the kiss, smiled, and floated away. Then she closed her eyes and craned her neck.

And her glowing aura flared. The shining portal behind them flared as well. Power - Magic - poured out of it. Into Adora.

And her aura grew.

She raised her sword over her head, and its tip started to glow, brighter than the sun!

Seacat squeezed her eyes shut, but the light grew so bright, she still had to shield her eyes with her arms to avoid getting blinded. And she felt warm, warmer than before. What was happening?

“Yes! Yes!” The bot apparently didn’t have eyes that could be blinded. Or didn’t care.

Seacat clenched her teeth as she started to sweat. This was… For a moment, she was afraid that the raw power might kill her. Boil her alive.

But things settled - she was still sweating, but the heat was getting worse. The light didn’t grow weaker, though.

And the bot kept chanting: “Yes! Yes! Yes!”

After some time, the heat finally started to fade, and the light grew dim. Seacat took a deep breath and opened her eyes.

Adora looked exhausted - her aura was dim, almost gone. But she was smiling as she lowered her sword. “It’s done.”

Seacat looked around.

“Where? Where is Eternia?” the bot screamed.

“Around us,” Adora replied, reaching out to Seacat. “Its parts are coming together.”

“That’s… finish it! Restore Eternia!”

Adora squeezed Seacat’s hand and pulled her towards the portal.

“Finish it!”

In front of the portal, Adora turned.

“I said I could pull the parts together. That’s happening now - Eternia will be restored. But it won’t happen at once. It’ll take a long time. And even longer before there’s life on it again. The Heart of Eternia is much too weak for anything.”

“Use the Heart of Etheria! Restore our world! Save our people!”

Adora shook her head. “I did what I could. Etheria is safe. Eternia will reform.”

“But our people! Restore them!”

“Magic can’t restore the dead!” Seacat spat. “The world you knew is gone!” At least she hoped so. If those First Ones returned...

“Magic can do everything!”

“No, it can’t,” Adora said. “I don’t remember everything from, well, just now. But I remember that. And even if I could restore the First Ones, I wouldn’t. Not at the cost of Etheria. No one deserves to die so others can live again.”

“And certainly not people who were willing to sacrifice our world for them!” Seacat asked.

“No! Do it! You can do it! You have to do it!”

Adora shook her head, then flew through the portal, pulling Seacat along.

They were back in the failsafe room. With a sigh, Adora moved her sword, and the portal vanished.

The bot appeared in the room. “No! No! No! Go back!”

“Did you also find out where its control unit is hidden?” Seacat asked. They better took care of the damn bot before it restarted the end of the world or something.

Adora blinked. “I didn’t look for that, but…” She turned. “There was a.. thing connected to everything behind *this* wall.”

Seacat grinned.

“Let’s shred it,” she said.

“But…” Adora trailed off.

“No! No! You can’t!”

“We can’t kill Last Hope.” Adora swallowed. “They might be the last of us - of the First Ones.”

Together with Adora. But Seacat didn’t say that. Learning your people and your homeworld had been destroyed wasn’t something you just shrugged off - no matter whether or not that might have saved this world. “It’s trying to kill us all,” she pointed out instead.

“But…”

“Let’s just, ah, disconnect the things. Like Entrapta did,” Seacat suggested.

“No! Go back! Restore Eternia!”

“Should we fetch her instead?”

“And risk that Last Hope here finds another trap to trigger? Or redoes the gas? Which is probably still blocking the corridor.” Seacat muttered a curse under her breath.

“Oh. But…”

“No! No! No!”

“Let’s at least take a look at it.” Maybe they would trigger something that took out the bot - Seacat was getting really tired of the wailing.

“Alright, I guess…” Adora didn’t seem to be too enthusiastic, but she didn’t hesitate either, and a few slashes with her sword opened a door into the next room.

The consoles and crystal shelves there looked almost like Light Hope’s. Seacat entered just as the bot’s projection appeared in the room.

“Stop! Don’t! Stop!”

She ignored the stupid thing and looked around. “The crystals… those are the memories there. And that’s the central control unit.” She pointed at the main consoles.

“So, what do we do?”

“We cut off those things over there,” Seacat said. Entrapta had done the same for Light Hope.

“No!” The bot moved to hover over the flatter and darker crystals to the side. “You can’t do that!”

“Of course we can!” Seacat retorted as she moved towards them.

“Please!”

Seacat stopped and cocked her head. “You’ve tried to kill us several times. You enslaved Glimmer’s dad. You want Adora to

destroy this world."

The bot turned to face Adora. "Stop her! You're like me! We're the last of our people! You can't let her do this!"

Adora gasped, then straightened. "I'm… I'm not like you!" she snapped.

Seacat smiled, then lashed out with her foot, opening a gap in the console next to her. Lines and cables spilt out.

"No!"

She crouched down, looked at the bot as she extended the claws on her hand - and cut the lines with a smile on her face.

The bot's projection flickered a few times, its wailings fading, and disappeared.

Seacat stood and sighed. "Finally!"

Adora slowly nodded. "So… what do we do now?"

Seacat smiled at her and walked over to her. "First, we check if the gas's still there. If it is, we wait for our friends to come down. If it isn't, we join the others."

"But… won't they run into the gas?"

"Entrapta has her device to detect this. And Castaspella can do magic. They're better prepared to handle this than we are," Seacat said. "I trust them."

"Still…"

"What else can we do?"

Adora bit her lower lip and didn't answer.

Seacat wrapped her arm around her waist, and they went back to the failsafe room. "Let's open the door for a moment; let me sniff

the air," she said.

"Isn't that dangerous?"

"We've been in there," Seacat pointed out. "And you can heal me."

"Right…"

Seacat sighed. "Adora… I'm not going to die from this. Our friends aren't going to die, either. We're staying with you."

"I… I know, It's just…" Adora sighed as well and looked away. "I saw Eternia die. When I held the power of the Heart of Etheria. I saw a glimpse of how the world had been. And how it had blown up. The life, the magic snuffed out in the blink of an eye."

Damn. Seacat wrapped her love in a hug. To see such a thing… "I'm here," she whispered.

Adora hugged her back, not saying anything. But Seacat felt her cry and felt the tears hit her back.

And she wanted to storm back into the control room and smash the bot to dust for doing this to her love.

*****

Sometime later, Adora had recovered some. And was ready to open the door - and heal Seacat.

Seacat nodded at her and crouched down. As soon as the door's three parts started to slide back, she sniffed the air. No gas. She took another sniff. Still no gas. "Keep it open," she said, moving forward. Again, no whiff of the gas.

"I think it's gone."

"You think?"

"I don't smell it. Only way to find out if I'm wrong…" She gestured towards the corridor.

“Right!” Adora took a step forward.

“I actually meant I enter. You wait here in case you need to fetch me. You can hold your breath longer.” As much as it irked her to admit that a landlubber was better at holding her breath.

“Oh!”

Seacat grinned and, before Adora could say anything, entered the corridor. She walked down its whole length without catching a whiff of the gas.

It was safe. They could call the lift down and rejoin their friends.

It was over.

It was finally over.

*****

“They blew up their own world?” Glimmer sounded shocked. Well, the princess was shocked, as far as Seacat could tell. As were the others. Bow was still shaking his head. And Scorpia was hugging Perfuma, who had taken the news really badly.

“Yes,” Adora said. “They were about to lose the war and decided to take their enemy with them.”

“So, they inflicted the fate they had planned for Etheria on their own homeworld?” Sea Hawk shook his head. “How… I actually lack the words to describe this. That’s new.”

“It fits them,” Mermista said. “If they scorched and drained worlds to deny them to their enemy, then this was just the logical consequence of losing the war. Deny the enemy victory.”

“And kill him in the process,” Seacat added.

“But…” Scorpia spoke up. “They destroyed the enemy’s - the Horde’s - homeworld. Not the entire Horde.”

“They got, or so it looks like, the enemy leader,” Seacat said. “They claim that his soldiers were just mindless drones.”

“Soldiers like Hordak? He wasn’t mindless!” Entrapta objected. “I mean, he could’ve just been recreating technology he was taught, but… he was a leader. Wasn’t he?”

“He was,” Scorpia confirmed. “So… there might be more soldiers like him, left on the other worlds. Unless those worlds were destroyed as well. And we don’t know if the enemy leader is actually dead.”

“He is,” Adora said in a soft voice. “They aimed at him. They used the magic, their own world, their own lives, to utterly erase him. The world he was on was merely…” She trailed off.

Seacat bit her lower lip with a frown. So, there had been more to the whole magic draining thing than Adora had admitted so far.

“Collateral damage?” Entrapta suggested. “Anyway, Last Hope claimed they had a hive mind? That’s fascinating. There are a few species of insects that have hive minds, but not on the level of actually being sentient. But Hordak didn’t act like he was part of a hive mind, either.”

“Could’ve been propaganda,” Seacat pointed out. “Last Hope was trying everything to make Adora destroy Etheria.”

“And they claimed that they were a First One?” Entrapta asked.

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

“A copy,” Seacat corrected her. “A bot with the memories of a person - if that was true in the first place.”

“They broke down like a person,” Adora retorted.

That didn’t rule out a bot, in Seacat’s opinion.

“Fascinating! We have to check it out! Imagine if we could duplicate the feat!”

“We should focus on freeing Micah first,” Castaspella said. “And this bot might be the key to undoing what was done to him.”

“Yes! We’ll have to examine their memories anyway!” Entrapta nodded.

Seacat sighed. She really didn’t like the bot. Or the base here. But Adora was needed to operate the lift, and Seacat wouldn’t leave her love. Not after what she had just gone through.

“Just to be sure,” Mermista spoke up. “The planet’s safe, right? You, like, drained the magic in the Heart to restore the other planet? We won’t blow up a few years down the line?”

“Yes,” Adora said, nodding firmly. “The Heart of Etheria still exists, but it won’t blow up. And Eternia will reform, but it’ll take a long time. And there won’t be any life on it unless someone seeds it.”

“How long will that take?” Perfuma asked.

“Uh… thousands of years? Or longer?” Adora smiled a little weakly. “I’m no expert, and I was just… feeling around as I did it. I know it’ll happen, but not when.”

“We could probably calculate that if we can track the debris left and how it moves,” Entrapta suggested.

“If we want to open another portal,” Seacat said. “And if we can do that.”

“Uh…” Adora pressed her lips together for a moment. “That would require a lot of magic. I had to drain the failsafe for it.”

“Oh.” Perfuma looked disappointed.

As did Entrapta. “I was hoping we could create portals. Imagine the possibilities!”

“Well, we can… if we find a way to gather enough magic,” Adora said.

“Which is incredibly dangerous,” Castaspella said. “You would need to access the runestones. And that could kill you if you aren’t properly attuned.”

Like it killed Shadow Weaver, Seacat remembered with a shudder.

“Let’s not start opening portals into empty space, OK?” Glimmer said. “Focus on finding out how to heal Dad for now!”

“Yes.” Castaspella nodded firmly. “Save anything else until we have saved Micah.”

“Alright.” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically, her hair bopping. “Let’s go down!”

*****

“So…” Entrapta stepped back from where she had been fiddling with crystals. “I’ve got good news and bad news.”

*Yes?” Seacat tilted her head. She didn’t like bad news.

“The good news is that I found the memories of what was done to Micah. The bad news is that I don’t know what it is.”

“Let me check,” Castaspella said.

“Right. It’s this one.”

The two women bent down over a slightly glowing crystal. Glimmer moved over to hover over them, followed by Bow, who hovered over her.

Seacat shook her head.

“I feel so useless,” Adora whispered next to her.

“Same,” Seacat replied. “I’m a sailor - a captain now - not a sorceress.” She turned to smile at her love. “But our friends know what they are doing. Trust your crew.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk beamed at them. “You can’t and shouldn’t do everything yourself!”

Adora slowly nodded with a shy smile.

She obviously hadn’t fully accepted that, Seacat knew. But she was getting there. Or Seacat would drag her there, kicking and screaming.

She looked around. “So… What else is there to do now, except for waiting?” On a ship, there was always something to do. Lines to splice, rigging and sails to fix, decks to swab in a pinch. But in this base?

“Stand guard, I believe,” Sea Hawk told her. “A noble yet not particularly adventurous task.”

“We wait,” Mermista said. “I think we’ve explored the entire base, and we can’t help the others. Well, Adora, you’re needed to transport us up and down the hole, but the rest of us?” She shrugged.

“Should we… should we head back to the island?” Perfuma asked. “With the base secured, we could work on restoring the forest. Well, I could.” She rubbed her shoulders.

“Still feeling bad?” Scorpia asked, wrapping her arms around her.

“No.” Perfuma bit her lower lip. “A little. I’m still… There are no plants around, and I feel weak, weaker, here.”

Seacat nodded. She would feel better up top - and even better back on her ship. But Adora was the only one who could operate the lifts here, and she’d stay with her. That didn’t mean the others had to stay, though. “Well, we could get you out,” she said.

“Though you probably need Mermista to get you to the shore, even if the lift goes to the surface of the lake this time.”

“It should,” Adora said. “That’s how it worked for Micah.”

“We can swim,” Perfuma said. “It’s no bother.” Scorpia nodded after a moment.

“And we should inform the others of our mission’s success,” Mermista added. “And check on Micah.”

Seacat winced. If Micah had woken up on her ship...

“We’ve destroyed the crystal that manipulated him,” Adora said.

“And we don’t know what that might’ve done to him.” Mermista glanced at the others studying the bot’s memories. “We should check before getting too invested here…”

Check whether or not the sorcerer was still alive, Seacat realised. She nodded and turned to Adora. “Time to do your job and get us up.”

Adora laughed and picked up her sword. “It feels better to only use this to move us up and down,” she said. “And not…”

“...to cut people in half?” Seacat suggested before she could dwell on what the First Ones had done with it.

“...to blow up planets?” Mermista shrugged at Seacat’s glare. “Pretending it’s not the key to Etheria’s magic won’t help. You have to deal with this, sooner or later.”

Later, much later, if Seacat had anything to say about it. And she did. This wasn’t the time to hash out everything. Not so soon after what they had gone through.

“I could throw it away…” Adora shook her head. “But we need it if we find more First Ones’ bases. And I can heal with it.”

Seacat would be fine with giving up healing to ensure Adora wouldn't carry that weight around with her. But she knew Adora wouldn't see things her way in this.

"I guess we won't be destroying the bot either, then," Mermista said, looking at the others working on the crystal."

"I…" Adora pressed her lips together as she trailed off. "We don't know if this is actually a First One or not. I don't want to kill them if that's the case," she went on. "They were a monster, trying to get me to destroy Etheria, but they were also…" She shrugged. "They were here for a thousand years. Like Light Hope."

Which, in Seacat's opinion, should be destroyed as well. But too many wanted to study the bot. Or 'fix it' in Adora's case. She sighed. "I guess we'll have to look into taking the bot with us."

"Great idea!" Adora beamed at her. "We can put them with Light Hope; they might help each other!"

Help each other to destroy the planet, probably.

"As long as they're kept away from any other bots," Mermista said. "Or anything else that they could use to do anything." She scowled. "I don't want to do this again." She gestured at the room.

"You won't have to," Adora told her. "If they… if they try anything, I'll destroy them myself."

"Good." Seacat nodded. Entrapta would hate it, of course. As would Bow, probably - he must hoped to extract everything the bot knew about Etheria's history that was lost in time.

But Seacat would rather be safe than sorry. Those damned bots had had too many second chances for her taste already. "Well, let's go upstairs, then," she said.

*****

The second lift did take them to the surface of the lake, the water held back by some glowing magic shield. Seacat took a deep breath as soon as they were on the surface. It wasn't the sea, but close enough. Fresh air, after so long!

"So… I guess we swim?" Scorpia said.

"Unless you can build a raft here, yes," Seacat told her. "That wouldn't be a bad idea, actually," she went on. "You could build a ferry while we wait for the others to find out how to cure Micah."

"We still need to swim to shore, though," Scorpia said.

"So?" Mermista grinned, then stepped to the edge of the platform. "The water's warm." A moment later, she jumped in.

Seacat shook her head as she watched Mermista slice through the water, then jump out of it, flipping over. She was sporting her mermaid's tail, obviously showing off.

"Ah, my love!" Sea Hawk, of course, completely approved.

"Well, it seems safe," Scorpia said.

"Then let's swim to the shore." Perfuma nodded

The two entered the water as well, followed by Sea Hawk, leaving Seacat with Adora.

"Want to go for a swim as well?" Adora asked.

Seacat cocked her head. The water looked great, and she felt more than a little sweaty and dusty, but… "Maybe later. Let's go back and check that the others haven't caused trouble or something." Adora held the key to the whole base, after all, and if the others were in trouble, she'd be needed. Seacat still wished they were already gone.

"Alright." Adora looked at the lake again, then used her word to send the platform down.

“So… how do you feel?” Seacat asked as they made their way back to the failsafe chamber.

“I’m fine,” Adora replied.

Seacat raised her eyebrows.

“Alright, I’m… unsure,” Adora admitted. “Seeing Eternia - my homeworld according to Last Hope - destroyed like that…” She shook her head.

“Your family.” Seacat wrapped her arm around Adora’s waist and leaned onto the taller woman.

“My family’s here. You, my friends,” Adora replied at once. “I don’t even remember anything from before. Or anyone.”

“Still, they were your relatives. And they missed you.”

Adora didn’t look convinced. “But what if they went along with all of this? The plan to blow up Etheria? What if they… were like Last Hope?”

Seacat bit her lip for a moment. After a thousand years of war? Odds were, they would have been desperate like Last Hope. Or worse. “We don’t know if they knew about it. Mara didn’t until she was told to do it, after all.”

“Yes. But…” Adora shrugged. “I don’t want to know, and yet I do.”

And she’d never know. “It’s not your fault,” Seacat told her.

“I know.”

But did she believe it? “You couldn’t have done anything.”

“I know.” Adora sighed. “I did what I could for Eternia, but… it won’t be Eternia even once it’s been restored. It’ll be a new planet.”

“Which isn’t a bad thing,” Seacat said. “A new beginning, of sorts.” Like a new ship.

“Yes. But without some help, it’ll be a really long time before life returns to the planet,” Adora told her. “Maybe I should’ve used the power to restore the scorched and drained planets.”

“You would have had to find them, first. And what if they were occupied by soldiers like Hordak? You’d only help the Horde,” Seacat pointed out.

“I know.”

“Good.”

Adora huffed, but Seacat squeezed her waist. Well, pressed herself into Adora’s waist - Adora was taller and weighed more, after all.

“And I wonder about my sword,” Adora went on.

“It’s just a tool,” Seacat replied.

“A tool made to destroy a world. Worlds.”

“Which you used to save people and restore a world,” Seacat countered.

“Yes. But I could do so much harm with it…”

“And so much good.”

“Yes. But…” Adora sighed once again. “I don’t want to depend on it, either.”

“Then don’t.”

“It’s not that easy.”

“Have it sealed in the vaults of Bright Moon or wherever,” Seacat suggested. “Only to be taken out if you need it.”

“But what if I need to heal you? Or anyone?”

That was a problem. “I guess you’ll have to carry it, then.”

“I guess so.”

“And you’ll manage. I trust you.”

“Thanks.” Adora smiled at her.

Seacat hesitated a moment, then shifted around until she was in front of her love.

Then she grinned - she knew how long the trip down to the failsafe chamber took, after all.

*****

“So… we’ve finished dismantling the core unit of Last Hope. And their memory banks,” Entrapta announced when they entered the failsafe chamber. “Oh, and Castaspella found the data on Micah.”

“That’s good, right?” Adora asked.

“Yes! More data’s always good!”

Seacat held her tongue. Sometimes, ignorance was bliss.

“We think we can help my brother,” the sorceress spoke up. “But we need your help.”

“Anything you need!” Adora offered at once.

“We need you to tap into the Heart of Etheria again,” Castaspella said.

“Oh.” Adora looked surprised. And apprehensive.

“With the, ah, dark crystal destroyed, we need more magic to heal Dad,” Glimmer explained. “We know your normal healing won’t be enough. But if you tapped into the runestone network…”

“I could blow up the planet!”

“There’s not enough magic left for that - but still enough for some island sinking, I think,” Entrapta said. “But if you go through the failsafe system, you can safely drain some more magic. It’s still gathering, after all, until we manage to dismantle it.”

“Oh. But…” Adora bit her lower lip.

“Please.” Glimmer took her hand. “It’s my dad. I know you can do it!”

Well, she had restored a planet. Restoring a king should be easy, in Seacat’s opinion.

Adora looked determined. “Alright. Let’s do it.” She blinked again. “Uh, how do we do it? We’re here, and Micah is on the ship…”

“We fetch him, of course,” Glimmer said. “I can teleport to the ship and back. Once I’m outside,” she added.

None of the others seemed to object, so this was probably their best course of action. Seacat suppressed a sigh. The sooner they were done, the sooner they could leave this island.

*****

It didn’t take Glimmer long - she returned about twenty minutes later with Adora, who was carrying a still unconscious Micah. Seacat and the others had used the time to pack up Last Hope’s parts to transport them, or most of them. And Seacat hadn’t given in to the sudden urge to lose a few key parts or ‘accidentally’ break them.

Still, if this was the last she saw of Last Hope, she wouldn’t complain. Light Hope or Last Hope, actually. On the other hand, Adora probably didn’t want to lose her last link to her family.

“So, where do I put him? Just put him down on the floor?” Adora asked.

“Gently,” Glimmer said.

“Of course.”

Seacat suppressed a snort. It wasn’t funny. Even though the sorcerer had come very close to killing them all. And probably could take a little drop like that.

But Adora lowered him to the floor, and Glimmer laid him out on his back, arms crossed over his chest. It looked like he was dead. Glimmer quickly moved his arms to his side - she must have realised the same.

This time, Seacat snorted. Softly.

Adora didn’t hear it - her love was staring at her sword and mumbling about being able to do this under her breath. Seacat nodded and walked over. “You’ll do fine,” she told her, doing her best to sound utterly convinced.

“I’ll try my best.”

“We know.”

Glimmer nodded. “Yes. You can do it, Adora.”

“Without blowing up the island!”

Seacat winced. Entrapta meant well, but reminding Adora of the possible consequences wasn’t helping. She reached out and squeezed Adora’s hand. “You can do it.”

Adora nodded, then pulled her in for a hug.

“Group hug!” Bow exclaimed.

Seacat managed not to hiss when she was suddenly pushed into Adora by someone on her back, and felt more arms around her and Adora.

She did sneeze, however, when she felt hair in her face - Entrapta had joined them. And the princess must have dragged Castaspella along, judging by the sorceress's protests.

Still, as gestures went, this was nice. And Adora looked less stressed when they separated. Her love took a deep breath, then raised her sword. "Better stay back."

Seacat hesitated a moment - she had been with Adora the last time - but stepped back. This was about healing Micah, not saving the planet. There wasn't a danger of Adora burning out or something, according to Entrapta.

She still held her breath when Adora pointed the tip of her sword at the ceiling, and magic shot out of it. The magic energy hit the triangle, which started to glow. As did the triangle on the floor.

"She's made contact," Entrapta mumbled, watching her device. "Magic reservoir… standing by. Flow within expected parameters. All systems nominal."

"She's touched the Heart of Etheria," Castaspella whispered with wide eyes.

Seacat was already squinting - Adora was glowing with power. With magic. No - she was standing in a glowing field of magic. Seacat felt the hairs on her neck stand up. Followed by the rest of her fur. She would look all poofy after this, she knew it.

But Adora… Her love opened her mouth without saying anything, craning her neck to stare at the ceiling. It looked like magic was pouring into her mouth. Or out of it.

Then she straightened and pointed her sword at Micah. The light grew even brighter around her blade - and then around Micah's body.

Once again, Seacat had to shield her eyes.

“Fascinating! The readings are off the charts! Note to myself: Expand charts.”

“Dad! Dad!”

“Don’t look, Glimmer!”

“The power… it’s unbelievable.

Seacat felt the air grow warmer as well. And there was a tension in the air, like at sea before a storm. As if the air itself was gathering lightning. She clenched her teeth and turned away, one arm pressed against her face. How much longer would this take?

Suddenly, the light dimmed - even through her closed eyes, she could tell. She turned, blinking. Adora was still standing. Still holding her sword. Seacat could see that much with stars flaring in front of her eyes.

“Dad! Dad!” And someone - Glimmer - rushed forward. “Dad!”

Seacat shook her head, then joined Adora. By the time she reached her love, her eyes had adjusted. Adora looked... exhausted. But she was smiling.

And Micah looked… healthy. There weren’t any dark marks on his skin any more. And he wasn’t pale any more - he looked more like Glimmer. She must have inherited his complexion. But… “Did it work?” Seacat whispered.

Adora nodded. How did she know?

A groan answered that - Micah was moving. Opening his eyes.

“Dad!”

“Wha… what?”

And Glimmer dropped on his chest, hugging him. “Dad!”

“Brother!”

“Huh?”

“Your highness.”

“What…?”

“Dad! You’re healed!” Glimmer was sobbing. Micah was holding her, but he still seemed confused.

“I don’t read any lingering contamination,” Entrapta commented.

“I’ve healed you,” Adora said.

But Micah was staring at Glimmer. “Glimmer?”

“Dad!” Glimmer raised her head, and Seacat saw tears running down her cheeks.

She clenched her teeth and started to drag Adora away.

This was a private moment. Or it should be.

*****

“Thank you! Not just for healing me, but also for defeating me when I was… possessed. I don’t know what I would have done if I had harmed Glimmer! Thank you from the bottom of my heart!”

It is clear where Glimmer got her own temper from, Seacat thought as Micah shook Adora’s hands once again while they slowly ascended in the lift to the main part of the base.

Adora, despite knowing Glimmer for years, still looked flustered. “Well, I just did what I could, and we all fought you, I mean… you know what I mean.”

“Dad! Don’t scare my friend!”

“Oh! Sorry!” Micah released Adora and all but jumped back. “I’m still… adjusting. I’m so sorry! Also, for attacking you. I wasn’t myself.”

“We know, Micah,” Castaspella said. “No one is blaming you for it.”

Micah nodded, although a little hesitantly. “I’m just glad I didn’t sink your ship or poison your water. I did that to the Horde, you know?” He grinned. “The only good thing that came off being…” He trailed off. “Ah, speaking of the Horde. How goes the war?”

“We beat them, Dad,” Glimmer said, baring her teeth in an almost feral grin.

“We did?” Micah looked surprised. “But… I remember attacking a Horde ship. And razing their port.”

“It’s a recent development,” Bow cut in.

“Well, not so recent,” Seacat corrected him. “The frigate you attacked were stragglers who went pirate after the war.”

“Oh. So the war’s over. The Alliance won.” Micah started to smile.

Adora grimaced. “Uh, yes. And, uh, we like… We’re working with the Horde remnants. Their princess is with us.”

“So please don’t attack her,” Seacat added.

“We’re working with the Horde?” Now Micah looked shocked.

“Yeah, Dad.” Glimmer nodded. “But we have them under our thumb. We’ve crippled their military.”

“Technically, they’re no longer the Horde,” Bow pointed out. “What with Hordak dead.”

“They’ve kept the name,” Glimmer retorted.

“I’m sure they’ll change it sooner or later. It’s just inertia,” Bow told her.

“And stubbornness,” Seacat added. Scorpia was quite friendly, but she had her pride.

“Yes,” Adora said. “But the important thing is that we’re at peace.”

“After we beat them.” Glimmer grinned again. “We pushed them back on all fronts, Dad. And then we sneaked into the heart of the Fright Zone and took out Hordak, Shadow Weaver and their airship.”

Micah stiffened. “Shadow Weaver is dead?”

Glimmer pressed her lips together, Seacat noticed. Probably realised that this was a sore point.

“Yes, Dad.”

“She tried to connect directly to the Black Garnet, and it killed her,” Seacat explained.

“Ah.” Micah slowly nodded. “She was always… too ambitious for her own good.”

Castaspella muttered a curse under her breath. “She handed you over to this base. She’s responsible for what was done to you.”

“I know,” Micah said.

But he didn’t seem overly happy about hearing of her death, Seacat noticed.

“Anyway,” Adora spoke up. “You’ll probably like Scorpia. She’s nice.”

“When she’s not trying to kill you,” Seacat couldn’t help adding. She grinned at Adora’s frown.

“And she’s with Princess Perfuma, of Plumeria,” Adora went on.

“Little Perfuma…”

“Yes. Not so little any more.” Seacat grinned.

“Princess Mermista is also here.” Adora nodded.

“And Admiral Sea Hawk.”

“So much has changed. Who’s Admiral Sea Hawk?” Micah asked.

“The best sailor on all the seas!” Seacat informed him.

“Mermista’s lover,” Glimmer said a moment later. She ignored Seacat’s glare - the Captain was much more than Mermista’s lover!

“Ah.”

“So… you all came to rescue me?” Micah asked.

Oh. “You didn’t tell him?” Adora looked at Glimmer.

“When? We were busy just..:” Glimmer trailed off.

“There wasn’t time,” Bow said.

“Tell me what?” Micah asked.

Adora sighed. “We didn’t know you were here. We were told that you had been killed.”

“Shadow Weaver.”

“Yes,” Seacat confirmed. “She probably didn’t want any records left of handing you over to Last Hope. Hordak probably wasn’t aware of her plans.”

“She did betray him, after all,” Adora said.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “Anyway, we came here to stop Etheria from being destroyed to fuel the First Ones’ ultimate planetary destruction device.”

“WHAT?”

Seacat sighed. That would take some time to explain.

It did. And Micah was quite pale at the end.

*****

"Weigh anchor!" Seacat yelled.

"Aye, aye, Captain!" Horas threw himself against the winch and started turning it. Licy and Alcy helped.

Seacat waited until the anchor had left the water, then used the speaking tube. "Half power forward!"

"Aye, aye, Captain!" she heard Entrapta's tinny voice.

A moment later, the Victory's Daughter started picking up speed, and Seacat turned the wheel to point her bow towards the open sea.

"Clear!" Sounded from Mermista, who was at the bow.

Seacat smiled. They still had to navigate the reefs and then travel back to the continent, but they were finally leaving this cursed island.

She took a deep breath, smelling the fresh air of the sea, the wind picking up. Felt the sun on her fur.

Yes! She was a sailor, not a soldier. She wasn't meant to crawl through tunnels and mines.

She was meant to sail the seas.

With Adora, she added, glancing at her love.

*****

New Horizons

They had barely entered Bright Moon when Queen Angella appeared, headed straight towards them.

“Mum, look who we…” Glimmer trailed off when the queen rushed past her towards Micah.

“Micah!”

“Angella!”

Seacat shook her head and leaned towards the princess. “Did you really think you could surprise her?” she whispered. The queen would have heard the news before they reached Seaworthy.

“I expected her to receive us in the throne room,” Glimmer whispered back while they watched the royal couple embrace each other. Which they managed very well despite the height difference - Seacat took a few notes.

“Well, it’s good to know even the Queen won’t stand for formality at all times,” Seacat replied.

“Glimmer!”

“Yes, Mum? I can...”

Glimmer once more failed to finish her sentence as the Queen dragged her into the embrace. And the people around them cheered. Loudly. Well, it wasn’t every day that a king thought dead returned.

“A moment for the ages!” Sea Hawk commented, beaming. “The lost lover returns!”

“The lost king returns,” Mermista corrected him.

“I doubt that the Queen’s thinking about his position right now,” Sea Hawk retorted. “Unless she is thinking of…” He, too, was cut off when Mermista elbowed him.

Scorpia and Perfuma were holding hands and crying. They weren’t the only ones. Adora was sniffling. Seacat was merely blinking because Bright Moon was so bright.

Entrapta was… recording. Seacat’s ears twitched. “...it seems a romantic couple’s reunion is enough for the Queen to ignore protocol. Fascinating. My data wouldn’t have let me extrapolate this result. I need more data.”

Perhaps Seacat should talk to Entrapta? Tell her to grant the royal family their privacy? Or, maybe… She felt strong arms close around her, followed by a blonde mop of hair pressing into her face as Adora embraced her. Right. She’d do that later.

For now, enjoying the moment would do. They’d probably delve into politics soon enough. There were a couple of issues to settle, after all. Such as the fate of the Heart of Etheria.

But that could wait until after the celebration feast.

*****

The bed in Adora’s room was a little too soft, in Seacat’s opinion. Just a smidge. She frowned as she squirmed on it, trying to find the perfect position for a little nap. She had a few hours to while away until the celebration, after all, and with the Queen indisposed, there wouldn’t be anything to do, anyway. Not that she minded. So… given the sun’s position, she had to move a bit to the right to catch its rays for another...

“It still doesn’t feel like home.”

“Huh?” Seacat blinked and sat up, looking at Adora. “What do you mean?”

“This room.” Adora sighed. “I’ve been staying here whenever I was in Bright Moon since I, ah, left the Horde. But it doesn’t feel like home.”

“Really?” Seacat cocked her head to the side, then glanced around. “It feels like your room. Weapon rack. Huge pinboard for planning attacks and defences. Snacks hidden in the trunk under your uniform…”

Adora gasped. “How did you know that?”

She rolled her eyes in response and tapped her nose.

“Oh.”

“And you did the same when we were cadets. Only with ration bars.” Seacat grimaced.

“Oh,” Adora repeated herself, though with a smile.

“So, what’s wrong with the room?”

Her love sighed and came to sit down on the bed, next to her. Seacat used the opportunity to undo Adora’s ponytail and start braiding it. “It’s just… it’s too big. Too…” Adora raised her head, and Seacat grabbed it to prevent her from moving. “Hey!”

“Don’t move.”

“But…” Another sigh. “It’s too luxurious. You could fit an entire platoon in here.”

“You haven’t gotten used to having a room for yourself?” Seacat snorted. She had taken a room of her own in Mermista’s palace every time they visited.

“I didn’t actually stay here for very long. I was usually out, campaigning.”

“Ah.” Seacat made a point of sighing. “That shows that you aren’t a sailor.”

“What? Your cabin in the Victory’s Daughter is a tenth this size!”

“Yes. And that’s why a sailor will pick the largest, most luxurious room they can afford once they are on land.” Seacat grinned behind Adora’s back.

“Oh. So...”

“I’m joking. Mostly,” Seacat interrupted her.

“Hey!” Adora glared at her.

Seacat giggled and finished the braid. “All done!”

“Let me see.” Adora stood and went over to the large mirror on the wall. “Oh.”

That was about the fifth time or so.

“So, you don’t feel at home here.”

“The room doesn’t feel like home,” Adora corrected her. “Bright Moon… is different.”

Seacat nodded. Adora’s best friends lived here.

“But it’s still not home. Not…” Adora shrugged. “It’s just…”

“You feel as if you don’t fit in.”

“Yes!”

Seacat nodded again. She knew that feeling. Very well. Perhaps a little too well. “Because you don’t feel like a princess.”

“I’m not really a princess.” Adora sighed and sat down again. “I’m just… a fraud. Picked by people willing to destroy the planet. Raised by a monster.”

“Oh, for Maelstrom’s sake!” Seacat rapped her on the head.

“Ow!”

“Be serious, will you? You are a princess. You are She-Ra. You’ve proven that you deserve the title and the power. Many times over!”

“But it’s based on a lie!” Adora protested.

“Are you sure? We only have the word of Light Hope and Last Hope for that. And they are liars.”

“We also have their memories.”

Seacat shrugged. “And we have our memories. You saved the Alliance. You saved Etheria. It doesn’t matter why and how you were chosen - you *are* She-Ra.”

“But…” Adora leaned back. “I feel out of place. I wasn’t raised as a princess. I was raised a Horde soldier.”

“So?”

“I can’t be all like… like Angella!”

“And you don’t have to. Does Mermista act like Angella?” Seacat asked.

“If she wants to, she can be very stern.”

Drat. Seacat hid her frown. “What about Perfuma? Or Entrapta?”

“Well…” Adora trailed off. “It’s not the same.”

“Yes, it is!” Seacat yanked on her lover’s braid and pulled her down on the bed.

“Hey!”

But she was already straddling Adora. “Enough moping. Captain’s orders!”

“But we’re not on your ship! We’re...”

Seacat shut her up with a kiss.

*****

The celebration was almost as big as the one after the victory over the Horde, Seacat noted as she looked down at Bright Moon’s street from the balcony near the Palace’s hall. Well, there was no reason not to party hard if you were given the chance - any sailor worth their salt would agree. Even if it was a little too loud for her taste.

“Hiding from the party?”

She didn’t bother turning around at the sound of Adora’s voice. “I could ask you the same.”

“I came to look for you,” Adora said as she leaned against the railing next to Seacat.

“Well, you found me. And I wasn’t hiding. Just taking a break from being the life of the party.”

“The great carouser.”

Seacat snorted. “We didn’t get to carouse in Seaworthy. We’ll have to do that once we return.” Her ship was there, and she didn’t like being too far away for too long. It wasn’t that she expected anyone to steal it, but… she didn’t really trust the local garrison that far. And Horas, Licy and Alcy were great, but they were no princesses; a determined group of thugs could beat them.

“Right. But that’ll be a few days. We still have things to discuss and settle. And…”

And she didn't want to leave her friends right away, probably. Seacat didn't ask. But she turned and faced her love. "And people will have to get over their hangovers. You could make a killing selling cures."

Adora blinked. "I would never do that! Charge for healing?"

"Healing hangovers," Seacat corrected her. "That's just a convenience." She shrugged. "It would pay nicely in the palace, I bet - everyone wants to look their best."

"But still…"

"And with the war over, you can use the money."

"I actually got a life-long stipend from Bright Moon," Adora told her.

"Ah." Seacat nodded. That made sense.

"Angella insisted that it wasn't for saving Micah when I asked. It's for She-Ra."

"And you feel guilty about it?" Seacat shook her head. Adora was an idiot. "Don't be. It's a bribe."

"A bribe?" Her love blinked.

"You aren't just She-Ra; you also control the Heart of Etheria. You can heal, you can cut your way through an army, people love you, you saved everyone's life at least once - you saved the planet, though that's secret." Seacat ticked off her points on her fingers.

"Yes, but… I didn't do it for money!"

"No. But making sure that you have enough money, so you don't need to find a source of money ensures that you'll be unlikely to make trouble for Bright Moon."

"I would never cause trouble for Bright Moon!" Adora insisted.

“Yes, I know that. And Angella, Glimmer and the others know it as well. But not everyone knows you that well. The others in the Alliance will feel safer with you receiving a stipend from Bright Moon.” Seacat hesitated a moment. “And the other countries will be more cautious about causing trouble for the Alliance.”

“Oh.”

Seacat shrugged. “It’s politics.” She chuckled. “Hell, I’m sure that Mermista has used my relationship with you to silence some of the idiots amongst her officers and nobles who still oppose her relationship with Sea Hawk.”

“What?” Adora stared at her.

“Yeah, some nobles still don’t like Mermista picking the best damn captain on all the seas over some idiot admiral.” Seacat nodded with a feral grin. “But since they know how close I am to him, and that we are a couple, and because those scumbags see everything as having or not having power, Sea Hawk is suddenly tied to She-Ra, Princess of Power, Protector of Etheria. And for the snobs, that makes him more acceptable.”

“That’s… weird.”

“It’s stupid.” She shrugged again. “But that’s what Mermista has to deal with. You saved a relationship!”

Adora didn’t laugh. “It’s… I don’t like this.”

“I know. But that’s how things are. You’re She-Ra. You’re a princess - and the most powerful princess by far.” Only Entrapta and Perfuma could equal her, in Seacat’s opinion, and not in combat.

“I wish I wasn’t!”

“Really? You wish someone else were She-Ra?” Seacat shook her head. “And could you trust her to be as responsible with her

power as you are? Could you trust a stranger with the Heart of Etheria?"

Adora opened her mouth but closed it again without saying anything. Then she pouted. "That's not fair."

"Life's not fair," Seacat told her. "Although we can't really complain, can we? We made it out of the Horde and through this war pretty well, didn't we? And Glimmer got her dad back."

"Yes." Adora smiled again.

"So, all in all, it's a very good thing you're She-Ra and not someone else." Seacat grinned at her.

"I guess so…"

"You know it. You just don't like it because you don't want to brag." Seacat pointed out. "Something we'll have to solve, by the way."

"What?" Adora gaped at her again.

"A proper sailor has to know how to brag, of course! Can't have you with me on the Victory's Daughter if you can't fit in!" Seacat smiled widely at her love.

For a horrible moment, Adora looked confused before she smiled. "Right! That would make you look bad!"

"Exactly!" Seacat hid her relief that Adora was still on board with coming with her by leaning closer and kissing her. It was silly, but she couldn't help worrying that Adora would suddenly decide she shouldn't or couldn't be a sailor.

Seacat didn't know what she would do in that case. Never ask a sailor to choose between you and the sea, as the saying went. But what if the sailor had to choose? Well, she could dwell on this another time. The celebration was still going on, and the food was

great. “Let’s get back to the hall,” she whispered. “Before Glimmer sends out a search party.”

They walked through the wide hallways, past two guards - poor sods, having to stand guard while everyone was celebrating, but someone had to. Just as her own crew had to guard the ship back at Seaworthy.

Even if she wasn’t familiar with the palace by now, Seacat could’ve followed the sound of music and laughter to find the hall. The musicians were giving their all. They sounded better, at least to her, than the musicians at the Princess Prom. And, Seacat added to herself as they entered, and a slightly drunk Glimmer rushed towards them with a loud “There you are!”, the party was also much less formal than the prom.

“Glimmer!” Bow protested as he followed her.

“Ah, shut up, Bow! Not even Mom’s complaining! They’re acting like newlyweds,” Glimmer stage-whispered.

“We can see that,” Seacat told her as she glanced at the main table. Indeed - the usually stern Queen Angella was… feeding King Micah some dessert?

“Uh… Was the Queen like that before, you know…?” Adora asked.

“Before the war? I don’t know,” Glimmer replied. “I’ve only ever known her while the war was on, and I don’t remember too much of the time before Dad… disappeared.” She grinned. “But this is great! Fantastic!”

Bow smiled wryly and shook his head. “It’s also a special occasion,” he pointed out. “I doubt this will be the norm.”

“Aw!” Glimmer pouted. “Don’t destroy my dreams!”

“Dreams?” Adora cocked her head.

“Mom’s not nagging me about duty this and duty that any more!” Glimmer said.

“Ah.” Adora nodded.

“Didn’t that stop when we won the war?” Seacat asked.

“No. She just shifted from nagging me about military matters to diplomacy,” Glimmer explained. “And I so don’t want to deal with that right now! I just want to enjoy having a complete family again!” She blinked. “Ah… I mean… sorry!”

Adora smiled, though it looked a little forced. “Don’t worry on my behalf,” she said. “I never had a family. Other than my friends. Can’t miss what you never had, right?”

“Of course you can,” Seacat told her. “But you have a family. You said so yourself.” She wrapped her arm around her love’s waist.

Adora’s smile shifted, growing more honest. “Right! And I was right!”

“Group hug!” Bow announced.

Adora still had a way to go, Seacat thought as they embraced, but she was getting there.

*****

They returned to their table, where the rest of the princesses present had finished dessert for the most time. Scorpia was still eating cake, and Entrapta had half a stack of tiny desserts in front of her, her hair tendrils picking up one after another while she argued about something magical with Castaspella, but the others were pretty much done and drinking tea.

“The hero of the hour returns!” Netossa announced, a little too loudly - Glimmer wasn’t the only one who had drunk a little too much wine, Seacat thought. Well, a little too much for such a party - it would be too little for proper carousing.

“Love…” Spinnerella shook her head.

“What? It’s a celebration! And She-Ra’s the hero!”

Seacat glared at the drunk fool.

“I’m really not,” Adora insisted. “We all worked together.”

“So you’re all heroes!”

“Indeed we are!” Sea Hawk used the opportunity to place a boot on the table. “We are…”

Mermista interrupted him by dragging him back down. “Behave!”

“But I am!”

“No, you aren’t!”

Seacat shook her head and smiled.

“So, stop moping!” Glimmer said, sitting down next to them. “It’s a celebration!”

“Sorry,” Adora sighed. “It’s just… It’s been a little much. I thought I was fine after the voyage back, but… with everyone fawning over me, it’s kind of back.”

“Ah, right!” Glimmer nodded. “You’ll get used to it. It’s part of being a princess. At least in Bright Moon,” she added.

Which was one of the reasons Seacat preferred Salineas. That, and the sea, of course. Although… she hadn’t visited with Adora in a while. Perhaps this had changed? She’d have to ask Mermista.

But not now. Now she wanted to enjoy the party. Or what remained of it. She grabbed a piece of cake and turned to Adora. “Open up!”

“What?”

Seacat held the piece in front of Adora's face. "Open up. You need cake!" And booze, but that could wait as well.

Adora finally did as she was told, and Seacat fed her the cake. Piece by piece. By the time she was done, Adora was giggling past a load of sweet dessert. And reaching for some caramel confections.

Seacat opened her mouth wide and managed to nip at Adora's fingers when she fed her in return, then grinned at her expression as she licked her lips.

Bright Moon might not have the best grilled fish, Seacat had to admit, but they were hard to beat when it came to dessert.

Though all that wasn't nearly as important as the company, of course.

*****

"Welcome, everyone, to this meeting of the Alliance leadership and selected guests." Queen Angella sounded as she usually did - quite formal and very stern - Seacat noticed. Although… Was that a hint of a smile when the queen glanced towards Micah? Well, they probably had spent the night the same way Seacat and Adora had. And, unlike Netossa, who was staring at the tabletop and gripping a pitcher of juice with both hands while Spinerella shook her head, they didn't have a hangover, either.

Neither did Seacat, but that was only thanks to Adora. Sea Hawk, of course, had a hangover but didn't let it affect him, while Mermista was grumpier than usual. As expected, in other words.

"Thank you." If Frosta was angry that her ship had arrived too late to take part in the celebration, the kid didn't show it. The youngest amongst them was alert and serious. Or tried to be. She was more focused than Entrapta, at least, who was reading some of her notes. Or Perfuma and Scorpia, who were whispering to each other.

“Thank you.” Glimmer definitely had a hangover and tried not to let it show.

“We’ve gathered here to settle a few crucial issues,” the queen went on. “We have peace with the Horde and no war looming on the horizon, yet we face unprecedented challenges. Etheria itself was almost destroyed. The runestone network was twisted and abused - and is still unbalanced. While She-Ra has dealt with the immediate threat, the fundamental issues remain unresolved. If we do nothing, we risk a repeat of the situation in the future.”

“The far future,” Entrapta piped up. “It should, according to my calculations, take at least decades, close to a hundred years, before the build-up of magic, if left alone, will reach a level usable for the weapon. Much longer until the storage grows critical again.”

“Thank you,” the queen said, nodding at her.

“But it will happen if we do nothing,” Frosta pointed out. “So, we have to do something.”

“First, we need to ensure that the base that is connected to the Heart of Etheria is safe,” Netossa said after downing half the pitcher. “We can’t allow anyone to explore it or take it over. The risk is too high.”

“Yes.” Queen Angella nodded.

“Beast Island has been a part of my kingdom for generations,” Scorpia spoke up. “We’ve had a base there before the bot took over.”

“A prison, you mean,” Glimmer said as Micah winced.

Scorpia shrugged. “In any case, it’s our territory. We can keep it safe.”

“If you think we’ll let the Horde keep such a crucial island, you’re gravely mistaken,” Frosta told her with a glare. It would’ve

sounded and looked more impressive if she wasn't a kid, though.

Perfuma put her hand on Scorpia's pincer. "But we're at peace now, and we're all in this together."

"We're at peace because we beat the Horde, and they had to surrender," Netossa said. "If they have access to the Heart of Etheria, who knows what they'll do."

"I gave up control over my own runestone to save Etheria," Scorpia retorted.

"It's not as if you'd had a choice," Netossa told her with a deep frown. "If Etheria had blown up, you'd have died as well." She crossed her arms over her chest. "Only a fool would hand you control over the Heart of Etheria."

"Technically, the island - or the base - isn't the Heart of Etheria, nor does the base grant you control over it. Not without the control tool," Entrapta said, nodding at Adora.

Who winced and fingered her sword. "Sorry," she muttered under her breath. Seacat patted her hand.

"The Heart of Etheria concerns all of Etheria. Regardless of past history, the island is too important to be left to any one kingdom," Angella stated.

"If you wish to take the island, then I need some compensation. The situation in my kingdom is still dicey. If people get the impression that you're running roughshod over us, they might decide to take matters into their own hands," Scorpia said.

"So?" Frosta sneered. "We beat you before; we can beat you again. More easily this time."

"You would attack people for the actions of others?" Perfuma asked.

"A princess is responsible for her kingdom," Frosta replied.

“For everyone in it? What about bandits?” Perfuma retorted.

“If you can’t police your kingdom, why are you a princess?” The kid scoffed.

“It’s not as simple,” Mermista spoke up. “Our navy patrols the seas, but pirates still manage to slip through our waters. That doesn’t make us pirates.”

“But you make efforts to hunt them down. You aren’t letting them go and rob others’ merchantmen,” Netossa said.

“I wouldn’t let anyone start a war, either,” Scorpia exclaimed. “But you can’t control everyone!”

“You tried very hard for decades!” Netossa shot back.

“Please!” Perfuma stood. “This bickering helps no one! We need to find a solution for our problems that is accepted by everyone.”

Which was the crux of the issue. Seacat clenched her teeth. She hated politics. At least during the war, people had had a common enemy to unite them. Now? She shook her head.

“I am guarding the key to the Heart of Etheria,” Adora spoke up. “That is my responsibility.”

“And you deserve our trust,” Queen Angella said. “But you are not immortal.”

No, as Mara had proved, even She-Ra could be killed. Seacat clenched her teeth. Adora wouldn’t die on her watch!

“But we can trust the Heart of Etheria to choose a worthy successor,” Perfuma said. “As worthy as Mara was, despite the First Ones’ plans.”

“We haven’t figured out how She-Ra gets chosen,” Entrapta pointed out. “So, scientifically speaking, we cannot assume that

the process involves a test for worthiness. It could be random choice or according to a set of criteria we don't know."

Seacat sighed, but the princess was correct.

"Indeed." Queen Angella nodded. "Which is why we need to secure the island and the base on it to prevent any single kingdom from controlling it."

"And to prevent She-Ra from accessing the base?" Mermista asked.

"If it's needed."

"Good luck stopping She-Ra." Mermista snorted.

"I could destroy the sword. Remove the possibility of it being abused," Adora offered.

"No!" Perfuma gasped. She wasn't the only one. Even Angella looked taken aback.

"That wouldn't be a good idea," Entrapta spoke up. "What if we need the failsafe again because we can't figure out how to fix the Heart of Etheria?"

"Oh." Adora sighed and hunched over a little. Seacat patted her thigh.

"Our priority should be to fix the Heart of Etheria," Castaspella said. "She-Ra should be the protector of Etheria - not the guardian of a weapon that can destroy a world to destroy another world."

"To fix it, we need to secure it first," Angella replied.

"If you control access to the Heart of Etheria, you control the Heart!" Scorpia objected.

“Not quite,” Entrapta retorted. “Without the key, the entire base is useless. For controlling the Heart, at least. It’s still a fascinating place for the study of First Ones technology and magic.”

“Can you fix the runestone network without the sword?” Seacat asked.

“Well, we don’t know until we try,” Entrapta told her.

“And we won’t try until we know more,” Castaspella added.

“And we won’t let either of you start until we are certain that the base is secure.” Angella nodded. “That’s why I propose to let the Alliance handle it.”

“The Alliance against the Horde?” Scorpia asked. “We have a stake in the island as well - and in the runestone network.”

“You started this war!” Frosta exclaimed.

“The war is over,” Perfuma shook her head. “What we need now is trust and cooperation.”

“Well, I don’t trust the Horde! Or their friends!” Frosta blurted out.

Perfuma gasped. “But…”

“Oh for…!” Glimmer shook her head. “Perfuma is our friend. Without her, we would have lost the war!”

Mermista nodded, although she was still frowning. Netossa nodded almost reluctantly. And Perfuma grabbed Scorpia’s pincer.

And Seacat started to get a headache. “This is stupid!” she mumbled.

Adora nodded. “Scorpia’s right that they got a stake in this as well - all of us do. We need to work together to deal with this. I can’t do this alone. Nor can anyone else.”

“So, we form a coalition force to garrison the island?” Bow asked.

“Or we accept the Horde into the Alliance,” Perfuma proposed.

Frosta scowled at that, but so did Netossa. And Micah… looked quite wary. At the least. He cleared his throat. “Princess Scorpia has fought at your side against, well, the enemies on the island.” He looked down at the table.

“Dad! You were possessed!” Gimmer said.

“Perhaps you should change the name of your… faction,” Queen Angella suggested. “The Horde’s name carries a certain reputation.”

“The Fright Zone Kingdom doesn’t exactly sound very nice, either,” Scorpia retorted.

“No. But it’s better than The Horde,” Angella told her.

“Does that mean the Fright Zone Kingdom could enter the Alliance?” Perfuma asked. She was narrowing her eyes. And she was still holding Scorpia’s pincer.

Seacat had the feeling that Plumeria might not stay in the Alliance, depending on the answer.

Angella exchanged a glance with Mermista. No doubt, they, too, were worried about that. “It would solve a number of issues,” Angella said.

Mermista nodded.

“It would let the Horde enter the Alliance,” Frosta said.

“The Horde’s dead,” Seacat spoke up. “We killed it when we killed Hordak and Shadow Weaver. Without them, you just have a bunch of former Horde soldiers.” And their weapons.

“The same soldiers that fought us for years.”

“I am a former Horde soldier as well,” Adora said.

“You’re She-Ra.”

“Yes. A former Horde soldier. Like Scorpia.” Adora stared at Frosta until the princess looked away. Then she switched to Netossa. The other princess looked away more quickly.

“It would be the logical choice,” Entrapta said. “We’re already working together to solve this problem. Or we were.” She frowned. “I don’t understand why we can’t just continue like that.”

“Yes,” Angella said. “We are facing a new threat, and we must adapt as a result.”

“So… welcome to the new Alliance, I guess?” Mermista commented.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk stood.

“No shanties and no posing!”

Sea Hawk sat down again.

But Perfuma and Scorpia were smiling, and it looked like the Alliance would hold together.

They hadn’t solved everything, but it was a good start. At least Seacat thought so.

*****

Of course, just working out - roughly - how the Alliance would change took another few hours. And they debated whether or not it would be better to have two Alliances, the original defensive alliance one and one focused on guarding the Heart of Etheria, twice before dropping the idea. As if making things even more complicated would be a good thing!

By the time they took a break for dinner, they were still trying to work out how to rotate command of the garrison. And whether or not they should rotate command. Given that the garrison force would be formed from detachments from every member of the Alliance, Seacat didn't think rotating command would be a good idea. She said so, repeatedly and without mincing words, but people didn't really listen.

"We should just let Emily take command," she muttered as they left the meeting room to freshen up before dinner.

Adora chuckled. "She can't talk, or she'd be an ideal commander."

"Yes," Seacat agreed. "She could blow up anyone who didn't follow her orders."

"I could work on building her a voicebox!" Seacat glanced over her shoulder. Entrapta was beaming at her. "I was thinking about it - bots usually use a series of beeps to communicate, but that was apparently a relic of Hordak's designs. As Light Hope and Last Hope prove, bots can talk with the right equipment. So, I should work on that." She nodded. "That way, my troops will be able to talk to the rest of the garrison, too!"

"You're planning to send bots?" Adora asked.

"Yes, of course," Entrapta confirmed. "Emily, Water-Bot and Carrier-Bot have experience on the island and prove bots can handle the terrain. And they can be repaired if something happens. Plus, a number of bots don't feel very welcome in the Alliance. Probably because most of them used to fight for the Horde."

Seacat didn't know if those bots felt anything. But… "As long as it's safe to keep them near the base."

"Oh, it should be, with Last Hope gone from there. The odds of the base managing to reprogram the bots are very low."

That wasn't as comforting as Entrapta meant it.

“And there won’t be any soldiers from Dryl?” Adora asked.

“Unless they volunteer, I don’t think so,” Entrapta said. “We don’t have too many to spare, anyway.”

“But you’ll be working on the Heart of Etheria,” Adora pointed out. “At least part-time. Won’t it be lonely with just bots from your kingdom?”

Seacat bit her lower lip, but Entrapta shook her head. “Oh, no. There’ll be Castaspella. And you, when we need the sword! And that means Seacat will be there as well. And Bow, probably. And his Dads. So I won’t be lonely.”

“Good.” Adora nodded.

“And working on the Heart will be fascinating. Though I probably should build a workshop there to maintain bots. And to do repairs on ships. We might need a yard. Or a small dry dock,” Entrapta went on. “Mermista said something about assigning a squadron to the island, and the engines for the frigates will require maintenance, too. Plus testing grounds for First Ones tech. I’ll be so busy!”

And happy, or so Seacat hoped. She certainly deserved it.

*****

“So, you’re still set on sailing the seas?” Glimmer asked later, at dinner.

“Yes,” Adora asked while Seacat swallowed the grilled fish - it was still not up to Kingdom of Snows or Salinean standards, but getting better at least.

“Yes,” Seacat said.

“You’ll always have a room here, you know,” Glimmer went on.

“And you can always take a berth on my ship if you get sick of all the politics,” Seacat offered in return with a smile that showed her fangs. Try to make Adora second-guess her decision, will you?

Glimmer sighed. “I might take you up on that. I’m not looking forward to more politics. I thought Mum would handle it, but even though Dad’s back, she’s still talking about letting me take over some of the work.”

“Well, at least you have something to do now that the war’s over?” Adora suggested. “I think you worried about that before we won.”

“I didn’t!” Glimmer replied. Bow sitting at her side, coughed and covered it up by taking a sip from his water when she glared at him. “I wasn’t really worried. Just… speculating about what I’d be doing now.”

“And what were you planning to do?” Seacat asked.

“Helping out with the hunt for the bandits. And research First Ones history and technology,” Glimmer said.

Seacat snorted. Three guesses how that combination had been chosen.

“You can still do that,” Bow said. “Queen Angella just wants you to help out a bit more.”

“I know.” Glimmer pouted. “I’m just… I love Mom and Dad, but I wanted to… to roam a little.”

Seacat nodded - she could understand that.

“Well, talk to your parents?” Adora suggested.

“What? No! I’m not so selfish as to ruin their time together just because I don’t like dealing with trade delegations trying to swindle us out of our peace dividend.”

"'Peace dividend'?" Adora asked.

"Bow's term for the savings in our budget, now that we don't have to fight a war any more," Glimmer explained.

"Well, it's a term my Dads have discovered. They're historians," Bow explained. "And it fits."

"Makes sense," Seacat agreed, filling her plate with more fish. "So, you'll be mostly here and in the Whispering Woods, studying Light Hopes's bunker?"

It was Bow's turn to sigh. "My dads are coming to 'help'. I just know they'll take over the whole research."

"They're historians; you still have the technology to study," Glimmer told him, quickly patting his hand.

"I know. Just… I wanted to strike out on my own, you know?"

Glimmer nodded.

Seacat glanced at Adora and frowned. The two should be glad they had a family to complain about. "Well, Sea Hawk's going to stay most of the time in Salineas," she said. "But we'll visit often." The kingdom was at the centre of the sea trade in this part of the world, after all. "And my offer stands."

"Thanks."

"We'll visit often," Adora said. "We'll also have to visit Beast Island, the Whispering Woods, and the Fright Zone."

"And explore the seas!" Seacat added. Visiting friends was good, but any sailor worth their salt couldn't be stuck on the same routes forever."

"Look at us, already planning our lives," Glimmer said, leaning back. "Where did we go wrong?"

Everyone laughed at that. But Seacat couldn't help feeling that Glimmer wasn't completely wrong. Their lives - all their lives - were changing a lot.

*****

"Glimmer's not happy," Adora said later, back in their room.

"She'll get over it," Seacat replied, sitting down on the bed. "It's her duty as a princess, after all. And the Queen won't be, ah, *busy*, forever."

Adora blushed a little. "I didn't mean that," she said, removing her tunic. "She doesn't like 'everyone splitting up', as she calls it.

Seacat snorted. "Does she expect everyone to live in Bright Moon? One Big Happy Alliance? Imagine Scorpia moving in. And Entrapta filling the halls with bots!" Or doing destructive tests in the courtyard.

Adora smiled for a moment, then sighed.

Seacat rolled her eyes. "She thinks she's losing you."

"Well… She didn't say that…" Adora shrugged. "But she did mention a few times that I'd always have a room here."

Seacat snorted again. Predictable. "Well, she could come sail with us as well."

"And leave Micah and Angella?" Adora started to remove her shirt.

"Not forever. I'm not going to leave Sea Hawk and Mermista forever, either."

"You're used to being separated from your family," Adora pointed out. "You're a sailor."

"We left and split up during the war as well," Seacat opened her shirt, then stretched. Adora was staring, she noted with a grin.

“Ah… I mean, that’s not the same. That was war. Glimmer, well, she thought things would change when the war was over.”

“Things did change. A lot.” Seacat slipped out of the shirt and threw it to the floor.

Adora blinked at her, then went to pick up the shirt and draped it over a chair. Seacat grinned and pondered throwing her leggings on the floor as well. But that would be a bit too much.

“Things changed, yes. Glimmer just expected things to change more, like…” Adora trailed off as soon as she saw Seacat squirming on the bed.

“Yes?” Seacat smiled as if she didn’t know what she was doing.

Her love shook her head with a sigh.

Seacat pouted at her for a moment. “She wants things her way. And things aren’t going her way.” She started pulling her leggings off.

“Uh… yes, I guess so.”

“She’ll get over it. As long as Bow doesn’t go on a tech excavation tour with Entrapta or something.” Seacat threw her leggings at Adora, who caught them.

“He will go back to Beast Island,” Adora said as she put the leggings on the chair. “Once everything’s set up.”

“And Glimmer will come with him.” Seacat watched her undressing. “Either to represent Bright Moon, command the garrison or to protect them, or whatever excuse she can think of.”

“Probably.” Adra sat down to remove her boots.

“And she’ll be fine,” Seacat said. “Eventually.”

“Eventually.” Adora sighed again.

Seacat frowned. “Do you… do you want to stay a little longer than planned?” She didn’t bite her lower lip, though she wanted to. But that would make her look…

“No!” Adora shook her head. “It’s… I like Angella, and Glimmer and Bow are my best friends, but... “ She sighed once more. “It’s all politics. If I stay, people will think I’m with Bright Moon. Which I am, but not in the sense they’ll be thinking. I’m not…”

“You’re not Angella’s princess to order around. You’re She-Ra.”

“Yes! I’m supposed to protect Etheria, not fight for a single kingdom or even the Alliance.” Adora finished stripping and joined her on the bed. “I won’t let my friends down, but… I can’t only be their friend.”

She sounded a little too… worked up... just for that, though. “They’ll understand. But what else is bothering you?” Seacat asked, propping her head up with one hand while she shifted so she was lying on her side, facing her lover.

“I’m guarding the key to the Heart of Etheria. And everyone knows it.”

“Yes?”

“What if people, ah, resent me for it? I’m holding their life in my hands. If I wanted to, I could end the planet.”

Oh. “You won’t. And we’re working on making it so you can’t. And you can’t right now, even if you wanted, since you drained the magic reforming Eternia,” Seacat said.

“I know.” Adora rolled on her back and stared at the ceiling. “I know.”

But she didn’t really believe it. Seacat shook her head. “You idiot.”

“What?”

“You can handle this. You were…” Seacat trailed off. She couldn’t say ‘born for this’. That would make Adora think of the First Ones again. “You proved it during the war. You are She-Ra. Chosen by Etheria itself.”

“But…”

“No buts. You saved us all. All the time.”

“You saved me. Several times.”

“So? Everyone needs help sometimes,” Seacat pointed out.

“Yes. But…”

“I said ‘no buts’.” Seacat slid over, straddling Adora and staring at her face. “You are going to be just fine. You can do this. You will do this. And I’ll help you. Everyone will help you. Do you understand?”

Adora looked at her. Seacat could see her mouth open, lips parting, then closing again. She could see the corners of Adora’s mouth twist a little, pulling up into a slight, almost shy smile. “Yes, Captain.”

Seacat grinned. “That’s ‘aye aye, Captain.” They would be leaving soon to sail the seas, after all.

“Aye aye, Captain!”

“Better.” Seacat nodded. “Now, no more…” She gasped when Adora grabbed her shoulders and pulled her down into a kiss.

And there was no more need for talking. Or doubting. Or worrying.

They were at peace.

*****

Epilogue

“Sail ahead!” Licy yelled from the top of the mast.

“Is it the Red Reaper?” Adora moved to the railing before Seacat could answer.

“Maybe.” Seacat turned to Horas. “Take the wheel.”

“Aye aye, Captain!”

She pulled her telescope out and jumped on the railing.

“Cat-Seacat!”

Seacat flashed her lover a grin. Adora had turned her stumbling over Seacat’s name into a nickname. “I’m just checking if we’ve found our prey,” she told her love. Then she jumped, grabbing a line with her free hand and swung over to the rigging. Scaling to the top of the mast was as easy as walking across the deck, and she quickly took up a spot next to Licy.

“She’s not flying any colours,” the sailor told her. “But the ship’s the right size. The rigging doesn’t fit, though.”

Which didn’t mean anything - the Victory’s Daughter was currently rigged to look like a ship from the Kingdom of Snows. Seacat took a look through her telescope. The ship sailing towards them was indeed the right size for the Red Reaper, a particularly slippery pirate who had been prowling the Southern Seas for a while now. She belonged to one of the last former Horde Captains who knew their trade, Duncan Daring. Under his leadership, the scum had managed to avoid the Salinean Patrols time and again.

But their luck was about to run out. Seacat grinned as the ship tacked and she could see more of her hull. “Definitely a Seaworthy ship,” she said, which fit the description they had. “And… yes. There’s the air intake midships. They didn’t manage to disguise that.”

“Hah!” Licy grinned.

“It’s the Reaper!” Seacat yelled down. “Get ready!”

“We could just run her down,” Licy said. “We’ve got Entrapta’s latest engine, and they have to make do with an old Horde one.”

An old Horde engine, which they had somehow managed to salvage from their sunk frigate and put into a smaller and better-built ship. Still, the Victory’s Daughter would catch up - as the official testing vessel for Entrapta’s engines, she was and would remain the fastest ship on all the seas.

But even so… “Chasing them would mean we’d have to dodge their stern guns.” And Seacat knew better than most that while the Victory’s Daughter running at full speed and weaving back and forth between the waves was *almost* impossible to hit at range, even a Horde gunner could get lucky and land a shot - a shot that could cripple or sink them. And the closer she sailed, the easier she would be to hit.

“Letting them close in means hoping that they won’t just sink us,” Licy retorted.

They had been over that. “The risk is minimal - as long as we play our roles.” Seacat was the Captain, and she had made the decision, after all. The pirates would want their cargo - and her ship. They wouldn’t blow them out of the water just to amuse themselves.

As long as they didn’t suspect anything.

Seacat grabbed a line and slid down, landing lightly on the deck. Two jumps saw her back on the bridge. “Alright! Horas, belowdecks!” The big Minotaur was a little too noticeable in such a small crew. He had to get out of sight as long as he was still hidden by their sails.

She took over while Horas climbed down the stairs. “And no transforming!” she told Adora, who was already gripping the hilt

of her sword.

Her love huffed but released the sword. “I don’t like this.”

“I know. But it won’t be long until you can board them.”

Her ship still was terribly undergunned compared to the average pirate ship, never mind a frigate, but with She-Ra in their crew, they only needed to get close enough to an enemy so Adora could board and the outcome was decided.

Which was why Adora wasn’t allowed to transform until the pirates were too close to escape. Daring was a pirate scumbag but no fool.

“Just act natural,” Seacat told Adora. “And keep your hat on.”

“I don’t think they would recognise me,” Adora protested. “You’re much more well-known.”

Seacat snorted. She was famous, she had to admit, but she wasn’t nearly as famous as She-Ra. “I’m wearing a bandana,” she retorted. It was a little uncomfortable - her ears were getting squished - but it served as a decent disguise.

“Your tail’s visible.”

“Lots of people have tails.” More than there were minotaur sailors. Or blonde women almost as tall as a minotaur with huge swords.

Adora huffed again. “I don’t like it.”

“You always say that,” Seacat shot back.

“Well, it’s true!”

“A week ago, you were complaining that we haven’t had a decent fight in months,” Seacat pointed out as she checked their course. Still holding steady. And the Reaper hadn’t changed tack again, closing in without appearing to be in a hurry. Good.

“Well, yes. But I didn’t want to do it like this.”

“What would you have done?” Seacat asked. Not much longer now until the pirates would show their true colours. “Try to find them on the back of Swift Wind?” The flying horse wouldn’t last more than a few hours and neither he nor Adora could navigate well enough to find their way back to shore, much less a ship.

“Something that doesn’t have us hoping they won’t see through our disguise.”

“We’ll be fine.” Or so Seacat hoped. The pirate tacked again - too soon for a normal merchant. They wouldn’t tire their crew with unnecessary manoeuvres like that. But a regular merchant might not notice. Still, they couldn’t play too dumb, or Daring might smell the trap.

Seacat changed course herself in an apparent attempt to give the other ship a wider berth.

Not much longer now.

“She’s going to tack again,” Adora said. “Trying to surprise us by using their engine once we’re closer. They don’t want to sink us.”

“Yes.” Seacat agreed. The pirates would expect them to try to run as soon as they saw through the Reaper’s disguise. And if Seacat were the captain of a merchantman, she would expect to be able to outrun the pirates - as long as she could pass them without getting sunk. The pirates would have to turn hard and would still take more time to pick up speed - and the way they were rigged, they wouldn’t match a fast courier.

The engine on the Reaper changed the equations, though. But so did the engine of the Victory’s Daughter. The only question was: Would the pirates see through the deception before it was too late?

“If they grow suspicious, then we’re in trouble at this range,” Adora muttered, echoing Seacat’s thoughts.

“Yes. But they won’t,” Seacat retorted. “They’re seeing what they want - a dumb courier.”

“But if we’re acting too dumb…”

“We won’t.” Seacat adjusted the course again. “Trim the sails!” she yelled!

Adora jumped down to the deck and grabbed the closest line, pulling. Alcy quickly joined her. A moment late, the ship was running as fast as she could at that angle to the wind.

Seacat smiled. She loved how fast their engine was, but there was something to sailing that an engine would never beat: the feeling of handling your ship, edging out the last bit of additional speed, reacting to the slightest changes of the wind...

But they weren’t here to sail. They were here to hunt down pirate scum. Seacat glanced at the Reaper. She was tacking again. Heading almost straight to cut them off. Damn. Even a dumb merchant captain would grow suspicious now. Ah, well - they should be close enough.

She turned further into the wind. As if she had just realised that the pirates were after her.

Adora and Licy pulled on the lines, and the sail caught the wind perfectly as the Victory’s Daughter turned away from the pirates.

Who now started their engine - Seacat saw how the ship suddenly picked up speed without changing sails or course. And the black flag went up.

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Adora transformed. Seacat grinned and yelled into the speaking tube: “Start the engine!” Then she turned the wheel, letting the ship turn towards the pirates.

She could see the pirates on the deck of the Reaper acting confused for a moment when the Victory's Daughter swung around.

Seacat clenched her teeth. This would be tricky. If the pirates suspected something… Yes. The Reaper's bow started to turn away - they wanted to present their broadside.

"Full speed ahead!" Seacat yelled.

A moment later, Entrapta's latest engine kicked in, and the Victory's Daughter flew towards the pirates, eating the distance up faster than the pirates could turn. A hundred yards. Eighty. Sixty. They were skirting the edge of the pirate's field of fire now. Forty. She saw the first pirates rushing from starboard to port, to man the guns there.

But they were too late. Twenty yards. She turned the wheel and sailed straight at the pirates. Ten yards.

With a howl, Adora jumped off the bowsprit and landed on the foredeck of the Reaper. Seacat spun the steering wheel, and the Victory's Daughter turned away, narrowly avoiding a collision - and sailing along the enemy's port side, directly under their guns.

But Adora was already cutting a bloody swath through the pirate gun crews, bodies and limbs flying as she swung her sword. One gun was sent overboard by a kick, barely missing the bowsprit of the Victory's Daughter. Horas was coming up on deck to board the pirate ship as well.

And Alcy was at the bow now, turning the swivel gun towards the enemy bridge.

"Fire!" Seacat ordered.

A load of grapeshot turned half the pirate ship's bridge into an abattoir.

By the time the Victory's Daughter swung away and turned around to approach the pirate ship again, the surviving scum had surrendered to Adora and Horas.

"You got Daring with the swivel gun," Adora explained as Seacat climbed aboard the larger ship. "They lost the will to fight after that."

Seacat looked around. A dozen bodies littered the deck, and blood was forming pools on the planks. She saw more than one pirate who had not just been cut down but cut in two. "Or they were too scared of you two," she suggested.

"Well…" Adora blushed a little. "We couldn't let them get a shot off."

Seacat nodded. "Let's get them tied up and see how we can tow the ship to Port Fright." That was the closest port, by Seacat's reckoning.

The pirates started muttering at that. Some of the fools might even expect to be shown mercy by their former comrades.

But Seacat knew better. Scorpia hated pirates as much as Mermista did ever since a pirate ship had attacked a cog carrying Perfuma. Not that the fools had stood a chance - Perfuma had wrapped up their entire ship in seaweed before they had realised what was happening - but Scorpia was a little overprotective with regards to her lover.

Entirely understandable, in Seacat's opinion.

*****

Port Fright - and who had thought this would be a good name, Seacat still didn't know; neither Scorpia nor Perfuma were telling her anything when she asked - was busy as usual when the Victory's Daughter approached. Several merchantmen from Salineas were moored at the piers, amongst a variety of other ships, including a frigate of the Fright Zone Kingdom's new navy.

“Not too shabby,” Adora commented as they sailed into the harbour, passing the frigate. “But they should’ve challenged us by now.”

“They’ve recognised us,” Seacat retorted. “But it’s sloppy, yes.” Friends of the princess or not, they should be challenged before entering the harbour. Then again, they were at peace, and there was no threat of someone sailing an enhanced engine bomb into the harbour - they had locked that down, at least.

And if someone were, Seacat doubted that the Fright Zone sailors would spot it, anyway. They weren’t as bad as the regular Horde Navy had been, but they could hardly be called good, either.

“Still no Kingdom of Snows ships.” Adora looked around as they sailed towards the piers reserved for the navy.

Seacat shrugged. “If Frosta wants to keep this up and pour gold into Salineas’ coffers, it’s on her.” The princess wasn’t officially blockading the Fright Zone, but her merchants didn’t trade with the Fright Zone as a rule. Not officially, at least - Salinas served as a go-between. And made a tidy profit, of course.

“She should grow up,” Adora muttered. “It’s been years.”

Seacat shrugged again. Not everyone forgave as easily as Perfuma. And Frosta was barely grown up. “Ah, the marines have finally noticed us.” She pointed towards a squad of soldiers marching on the pier.

“Took them long enough.” Adora shook her head.

Seacat snorted. “Do you want to hire on with Scorpia as their instructor? Instil some discipline and enforce better standards?”

Adora pouted at her. “I’m just commenting on their reaction time.”

“I know,” Seacat told her, reaching over and patting her love’s back. “I’m just teasing you.”

That earned her a huff, but then both were kept too busy getting the Victory's Daughter to stop. It would've been easy with the engine, but… It wasn't cheating, not really, but Seacat liked sailing under sails. And it wasn't as if they were in a hurry.

"Cast off the towing line!"

"Aye aye, Captain!"

Behind them, the Red Reaper veered off, Alcy guiding the ship to its own spot on the pier. She was using the engine, of course. The Victory's Daughter could be handled with two people if they were skilled sailors. The Red Reaper was a sloop, though, and three people weren't enough to handle her sails. Not in the port, at least.

And even so, Adora tied up the last line, securing the ship, before Alcy managed to touch the pier.

"Ahoy!" Seacat yelled to the soldiers there. "We've captured the Red Reaper! The surviving pirates are belowdecks!"

That finally got the marines moving - they must not have recognised the ship, Seacat realised. Maybe Adora was right and they needed a lot more training. It would be good to raise standards - the Fright Zone Kingdom was a member of the Alliance, after all.

"The Fright Zone garrison on Beast Island is much better than them," Adora mumbled as they prepared to meet the officer on duty.

"They're the best of the crop," Seacat agreed. Everyone sent their best to the island, both to ensure it was as safe as possible and to show off. "Victory's Daughter, Captain Seacat," she told the officer as soon as he stepped on deck.

"Captain!" The officer started to salute, then stopped, blushing a little. "Sorry, Captain." Then he glanced at Adora and blushed even more.

Well, even not in She-Ra form, Adora was famous amongst the former Horde soldiers.”So,” Seacat spoke up, “can you handle the prisoners? We have to report to Scorpia that we solved your pirate problem.”

“Of course, Captain!”

The paperwork didn’t take a minute; reminding people that the ruler of the kingdom was a personal friend - as was her lover - never hurt. Seacat smirked as they waited for Alcy to finish her paperwork.

“Shouldn’t we help them?” Adora asked.

“It’s good training,” Seacat replied. “Alcy can handle it.”

“Alright, But…” Adora trailed off as another officer, this one slightly out of breath, approached them.

She looked like she had run to the pier, Seacat realised. That wasn’t a good sign.

“Captain Seacat? First Mate Adora?” the woman asked, straightening.

“Yes?” As if they could be mistaken for anyone else - well, unless they were in disguise, of course!

“I have a message for you from Princess Scorpia.” The officer handed two scrolls over, one for each of them.

Frowning slightly - this was odd - Seacat opened hers. And blinked.

“Scorpia and Perfuma are getting married!” Adora gushed before Seacat could comment. “And we’re invited!”

Of course they were invited - they were their friends. But the marriage… that was a bit of a surprise. Two ruling princesses

marrying… Seacat grinned at the thought of how this would affect the Alliance.

“They’re holding the ceremony in the Whispering Woods,” Adora went on after dismissing the courier.

“I hope they mean the edge of the forest,” Seacat commented. “Or we’ll be busy fighting monsters.”

“I think so. After all, you can’t really place tents or pavilions inside the woods. Not the big ones,” Adora said. “And it has to be a big wedding.”

“Two ruling princesses. And not just any two ruling princesses, but two of the six Elemental Princesses?” Seacat snorted. “I wonder if such a marriage ever happened before.”

Adora scrunched her nose. “Well… I don’t know. I bet Angella knows. Or Netossa and Spinnerella. They married each other, after all.”

Seacat shrugged. “They aren’t Elemental Princesses.” They weren’t connected to a Runestone. Or had the potential to connect to a Runestone. “Although I bet the fact that Scorpia isn’t connected to the Black Garnet is making things a little easier.”

“Why so?”

“They won’t have to deal with the question of who gets to connect to which Runestone. If they have kids. Or what happens if someone can connect to both Runestones,” Seacat explained.

“Oh.” Adora slowly nodded. “Kids.”

Seacat blinked. She was thinking about that?

“They’ll have kids.”

“They’re ruling princesses,” Seacat said. Getting heirs was pretty much their duty, after all.

“Can you imagine their kids?” Adora smiled, though she looked a little…

Seacat cocked her head. “Are you thinking about kids?” No need to spell out which kids she was talking about.

Adora blushed. “Well… Not really. Not in a ‘pick names’ kind of thinking. Or even thinking very much, but…” She trailed off.

She was. Seacat forced herself to snort. “Do you want to have kids?” Kids. They were… Seacat didn’t know much about kids.

“I… I don’t know.” Adora sighed. “None of our friends has children, you know.”

Sea Hawk and Mermista supposedly were working on that, but so far without success. No need to mention that, though. Or ask for details. “I know,” Seacat said instead.

“So… I don’t really know. Anything. We didn’t have a normal childhood, did we?”

Seacat nodded. “Raised by the Horde.” No kid deserved that.

“So, I thought… let’s wait and see how our friends deal with kids. Before deciding… before really thinking about kids of, ah, our own.” Adora wasn’t looking at her but at the sea.

Seacat was glad for that. Kids… were terrifying. Or rather, the responsibility was daunting, Sea Hawk once said - without Mermista present - that a Captain was responsible for her crew, but sailors weren’t kids. Usually, they weren’t. It wasn’t the same as raising a kid. “Yeah,” she managed to say. “Let the others test the waters.”

Adora nodded.

“The politics will be murder,” Seacat said after a moment, changing the subject. “Plumeria and the Fright Zone Kingdom formally uniting?”

“They’re not, though,” Adora objected. “Or are they?”

“For all things that matter, they’ll be united. The kingdom made up of former Horde soldiers, and the kingdom that could feed them all if they wanted to form an army again.”

“But… Perfuma and Scorpia would never do that!” Adora protested. “And they already have been working together for years!”

“But they were just friends, as far as the other countries were concerned. This will be more formal. They’ll have heirs to both countries,” Seacat pointed out. “They will be forming a much tighter union, at least as far as some of their rivals are concerned.”

“Great.” Adora scowled. “Politics messing with friendships again.”

“I doubt that those who have issues with this marriage are our friends,” Seacat retorted.

“But they’ll cause trouble anyway. Over love.”

“Scorpia and Perfuma can handle that. And Angella will help.” Also to ensure they remained close friends. Mermista might help as well.

“I hope so.” Adora was scowling now. “I’m not going to let anyone ruin this for them!”

Seacat nodded.

“Captain?”

Alcy was approaching them. Seacat nodded at the sailor. “All done?”

“All done. They’re already moving the pirates to the local prison cells.”

They better keep an eye on that. Desperate pirates might attempt something, and the garrison hadn't impressed Seacat so far. "Did you hear the latest?" Seacat asked as they walked towards the moored sloop. "Perfuma and Scorpia are getting married."

"About time!" Alcy replied. "When and where? I've got coin riding on Bright Moon and in summer!"

"You've bet on this?" Adora blinked.

"Sailors bet on anything," Seacat told her with a laugh. "But don't worry, you'll get the hang of that in time." She had gotten the hang of almost everything already, after all.

"You don't bet!"

"I'm the Captain; I have to be responsible."

"Really? What about carousing?"

"That's different."

"How?"

"It's not betting." And carousing was carousing. "Now focus on guarding the pirates before they try to escape!"

"But…"

"No buts!"

*****

"Port ahead!" Licy announced.

They had arrived. Or would shortly.

Seacat moved to the bow and studied the port as Horas guided the Victory's Daughter through the last leg of their trip. It was a river port, of course, built mainly for transport barges and the odd gunboat. Frigates and cogs wouldn't make it so far inland, not

even with an engine, but it could handle couriers like their own ship.

“They’ve expanded it,” Adora said, squinting her eyes against the setting sun.

“Of course they did - this is the biggest wedding in a century or so,” Seacat replied. “They need bigger facilities to handle all the additional traffic.” Two gun boats were guarding the approaches.

“I didn’t think so many people would arrive by ship,” Adora said.

Seacat shrugged. It was the most comfortable way to travel, after all. Princesses and other important people would have their own cabin, and a ship sailed far more smoothly than any wagon - provided there was no storm, of course. And, Seacat added as she saw a yacht moored in the new area of the port, it allowed people to show off their wealth by adding stupid gilding to a perfectly fine ship. “Have you ever seen an uglier figurehead?” she asked as they passed it, pointing at the golden carving of an octopus-woman at the yacht’s bow.

“Does it remind you of Octavia?”

“Yes, but that’s not the point,” Seacat replied. “Sail us to the free spot next to the Barge!” she yelled back to Horas.

“Well, I think the seahorse we saw in Seaworthy was uglier,” Adora said.

“That wasn’t a seahorse but a sea monster,” Seacat corrected her.

“Captain Malk said it was a seahorse.”

“Malk’s a fool. Or he was trying to fool you.”

“Or he hired a carver who wasn’t very good at their craft.”

“As I said, Malk’s a fool.” Seacat smirked. “So…” She trailed off as she noticed Adora looking at the sky, then rolled her eyes.

“Swiftwind.”

“Yes!” Adora beamed at her. “I’ve sensed him for a while.”

The flying horse soon came into sight, then dived at them as they pulled up at the pier.

“Adora! It’s so good to see you again! It’s been far too long since we were reunited! And hello, Seacat.”

“Hello, Swiftwind.” Seacat nodded at him.

Adora wasn’t as restrained and jumped on the pier before the lines were tied to hug her ‘horsey’.

Seacat refrained from pointing out that they had seen each other in Port Freedom just before the Victory’s Daughter started her trip upriver. And before that in Seaworthy. Adora wouldn’t like it if they began bickering. And it wasn’t as if she was really jealous or felt threatened by a horse. Even though it could fly.

“So, did you see Glimmer, Bow and the others?” Adora asked.

“Yes. They’re all here. Except for Frosta, who should arrive in a day or two. And the delegation from the Crimson Waste.”

“I can’t believe they invited the bandits,” Seacat grumbled as she checked the lines.

“Perfuma wants to use this opportunity to mend fences,” Adora said.

“The Crimson Waste doesn’t need mended fences - those won’t keep the raiders in check,” Seacat retorted.

“But if their leaders agree to stop the raiding, then that would, well, stop the raiding.” Adora blinked.

“They won’t,” Seacat said, jumping off and landing on the pier as well. An official was headed their way, she noted.

“You said the same about the trading agreements.”

“I should’ve known that greed would overcome grudges.” She should have. But the Waste had nothing to trade to replace raiding.

“Let’s not talk politics on such a fine day!” Swiftwind said. “How about we go for a flight while Seacat handles the paperwork?”

Adora beamed, then glanced at Seacat.

Seacat snorted. “Go on. I know you love this.”

Adora leaned over for a quick kiss, then jumped on Swiftwind’s back, and the two were off.

And Seacat forced herself to smile at the gaping official. “Victory’s Daughter. No passengers, cargo of ale and wine.”

“Ah… of course.” The young woman nodded. “You’re expected elsewhere. I mean… we did expect you. We’ve got a berth at the main pier reserved for you. So...”

“Ah.” Seacat looked over to the old part of the port. “Is there any particular reason why we should move there since we’re already here?”

“Well, we had to, ah, tell a number of princesses and princes that the berth was reserved for you.” The woman smiled weakly.

Seacat sighed. “And if we don’t take it, people will feud over it. We’ll move.”

“Thank you, Captain!”

Politics! They tended to creep up on you when you least expected them. Though, to be fair, this kind of politics was expected at such an occasion.

Which was why Seacat loved to sail the seas. There were no politics to care about when it was just you, your crew and the ocean.

Then again, she was looking forward to seeing their friends again. You just had to take the bad with the good.

*****

“Adora! Seacat!”

“Hey!”

“Glimmer! Bow!” Adora dropped the jacket she had been pulling out of her sea chest and turned to beam at their friends standing in the doorway.

“We’ve heard you had arrived, so we came to see you,” Bow explained as they entered. “Glimmer was…” He was cut off by Adora hugging him and Glimmer at the same time.

“I’ve missed you guys!”

“Uh…” Glimmer rubbed her arms when Adora released her. “Have you grown even stronger?”

Adora grinned and squeezed her own biceps. “Pull on sails and lines every day, and see what happens.”

“She certainly is pulling her weight,” Seacat commented as she joined the others. “Though she’s still not as strong as Horas, not without cheating.”

Adora snorted. “It’s not cheating! You told me so yourself!”

“That was when I bet on you at the arm wrestling competition in Seaworthy,” Seacat explained. “This is different.” She turned back to Glimmer and Bow. “How are you two doing?” They looked good, at least - dressed in stylish clothes, vaguely similar to how they dressed during the war, but much more elegant. Bow was

still showing his midriff, of course. Then again, it was a very nicely built midriff.

Glimmer sighed. "Well, it could be better. I want to enjoy the wedding, not deal with more politics! If Countess Smoking Mountain bothers me one more time about the trade agreements and how we are supposed to subdue the Crimson Waste for her…" She bared her teeth. "I might teleport her into the river!"

Seacat chuckled. Then she saw Bow was wincing. "Don't tell me you actually did that to someone!"

"I didn't!" Glimmer protested. "But I know a lot of people who deserve it!"

"Things should improve, now that the actual wedding is about to happen," Bow said. "A lot of guests arrived early and used the opportunity to, well…"

"Politics," Adora said with a scowl. "It's a good thing we weren't early."

Glimmer pouted. "I hoped you'd be here early."

"We can stay a little longer. Or take you back to Bright Moon via Seaworthy," Seacat offered.

"But that would be a huge detour…" Bow blinked, then smiled sheepishly. "Never mind."

"Thanks, but Mom would never fall for that," Glimmer said. "Although if we could visit Salineas, then that would count as a diplomatic trip."

"We've spent days with Mermista already," Bow pointed out.

"Yes. And I'm sure I can get her to offer to show us the latest ship or something," Glimmer said. "Dad will support me."

"Is it really that bad?" Adora asked, obviously concerned.

Glimmer sighed again. “It’s not, actually. I’m just…” She shrugged.

“You want a vacation,” Bow said.

“Kind of, yes.” Glimmer sat down on their bed. “It’s been a long year and a half since the last one.”

“I don’t think many would consider a trip to Beast Island as a vacation,” Seacat pointed out.

“They don’t have to deal with politics,” Gimmer said in a flat voice.

“So you’d rather deal with monsters and magic?” Adora looked concerned.

Seacat was about to remind her that she had asked to go sea monster hunting a few times when Bow spoke up: “There’s not a lot of dangerous magic left. Except for the Heart of Etheria, I mean. We’ve made good progress dismantling the base’s defences.”

Good. Seacat nodded. The last thing they needed was more First Ones magic trouble.

“So, a trip to Beast Island means I get to inspect the garrison and enjoy the island while Bow gets to fiddle with First One technology. It’s like a vacation.” Glimmer grinned. “For both of us. And no one to prod us about our relationship.”

“Your parents want you to marry?” Adora asked.

“Not our parents!” Glimmer replied. “Well, not Mom and Dad. But there’s so many at court who either want me to marry Bow and ‘make it official’ or ‘reconsider the advantages of a dynastic marriage’.” She scowled. “And Scorpia and Perfuma made it worse!”

“What? How?” Adora echoed Seacat’s thoughts.

"With two of the Elemental Princesses marrying, and both with borders with Bright Moon, some idiots feel that Bright Moon needs to do something similar to 'keep the balance of power'," Glimmer spat.

Seacat blinked. What did they mean? Marrying another Elemental Princess? But Mermista was all but married to Sea Hawk, so… "They want you to marry Frosta?"

"They want me to consider courting her. I really should teleport the next one who suggests that into the river. Or the ocean."

"Or you could marry Bow and end the speculation," Adora suggested with a bright smile.

"We're going to marry when we're good and ready," Glimmer retorted. "I'm not going to marry for convenience or for power!"

Bow nodded, though his smile was a little wry, Seacat noticed. Well, as stubborn as Glimmer was, she probably wouldn't marry him for years as long as people kept prodding her.

Seacat grinned. You didn't need to be married to have a relationship. And if Glimmer let such a thing keep her from marrying Bow, then she probably wasn't ready for marriage yet. She cleared her throat. "So, we've got a few more days until the wedding, and you've been here a while. You must know the best taverns to carouse!"

Adora nodded enthusiastically. "Oh, yes!"

Glimmer and Bow blinked.

Seacat grinned. They should be used to that by now.

*****

"I do."

A moment ago, Scorpia had all but yelled her words, but Perfuma whispered hers as she clasped the other princess's pincers in her hands. A glow started where they touched each other and quickly spread, engulfing both of them and growing brighter.

Seacat had to squint as the light turned blindingly bright for an instant, and then she was looking at the two kissing under the huge blooming tree Perfuma had grown for the occasion. Small, white and pink petals were drifting down on them - and on the guests. They matched the couple's dresses. And the bots Entrapta had built for the ceremony changed their tune.

Sitting in the front row next to her, and holding Seacat's hand in a vice-like grip, Adora sighed. "It's so… so..."

"Yes," Seacat whispered. She glanced at Glimmer and Bow, seated next to Adora. Glimmer looked like she was reconsidering her decision not to marry right now. And on Seacat's other side, Mermista was holding on to Sea Hawk's arm as if he was in danger of being blown away by a gale. Not that he seemed to mind. Frosta was… ah, she appeared to be affected as well, though she tried to remain aloof and was failing. Entrapta, on the other hand, was beaming and recording the whole thing. To analyse it later, no doubt. And Netossa and Spinnerella were crying. And trying to hide it.

Well, weddings were supposed to have such an effect. Seacat could imagine her own and Adora's - on her ship, of course, joining each other on the bridge while the sun was setting on the open sea...

Then the cheering started as the guests stood, quickly forming two rows to let the freshly married couple pass through.

Scorpia was blushing like she had spent a day out under the sun in the Southern Sea, and Perfuma… if the woman's smile grew any wider, it would split her head. Seacat grinned as the couple passed her, and Adora grabbed her arm, falling in line behind the two.

Soon, everyone was following Scorpia and Perfuma in an orderly procession - like a line of battle - towards the clearing where the food had been prepared. A bunch of musicians were already playing soft music - Seacat's ears twitched when she heard them - and she could smell the roasted fish.

Servants bowed when the couple stepped into the clearing and faded back into the woods. Scorpia and Perfuma continued to the centre of the clearing while the guests split and started to form a circle around them.

"Now comes the wedding dance!" Adora whispered next to Seacat.

She smiled in return; she knew that, of course, but Adora was a perfectionist.

They ended up standing in front of the buffet while the last guests filed in, and Seacat was tempted to grab a bite - the roast fish was right behind her. No one would notice, not with Scorpia and Perfuma drawing everyone's attention.

*Don't," Adora hissed.

Almost everyone's attention, Seacat corrected herself. Of course Adora would not ignore her, not even now.

She stuck her tongue out at her love, just for an instant, and grinned. "I wasn't going to," she lied in a whisper.

"You're impossible!"

"Yes!" Her grin grew. She brushed a few petals off her sleeve - they stood out on the dark uniform picked for her by Mermista and Adora, after they had finally accepted that, as a Captain, she wouldn't wear a dress.

Scorpia and Perfuma were now doing their speech. Seacat tuned them out. She had heard it before, in all the versions. A new beginning, a new union, blah blah. Politics.

She wasn’t here for politics. She was here for her friends. And for her love. Who had tears in her eyes.

Seacat reached up and brushed them away with her free hand. She was so beautiful. And the dress she wore… Such a change from the far too modest one she had worn at the Princess Prom. This one was… Seacat sighed. “We’re really lucky, aren’t we?” she whispered.

Adora blinked, then slowly nodded. “Yes. Yes, we are.”

Then the speeches ended, and the dance began.

And the two stepped forward, holding hands, joining their friends on the dance floor.

Yes, they were really lucky indeed.

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The End.

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